Catra of Etheria

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24188830.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak, Kyle/Rogelio (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra), Grizzlor (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Flutterina (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Adoption, Happy Adoption, Teen Adoption, loving family, Family, Sisters, Mothers and Daughters, season 4, Alternate Universe, Alternate Universe - Catra is She-Ra, Alternate Universe - Adora Remains with the Horde (She-Ra), Queen Angella is doing her best, Glimmer isn't a bad person, Entrapta is getting really scary, the horde, The Evil Horde Rises!, Dragons, cat-ra, Horde Adora, Elberon is awesome, Flutterina is cool, Ambush, Flamethrowers, Fire, Lord Adora's Horde, Lord Adora, The Final Battles Begin, Magic-Wielding Glimmer, Bow the Tech Master, Flutterina's Backpack, Allied soldiers, Trolls, that was my favorite episode of old She-Ra, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Magicatra AU, Magicats (She-Ra), Magicat AU

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English

Series:
Part 4 of Catra of Brightmoon

Stats:
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by Runeless

Summary

The battle between the Horde and the Princess Alliance approaches climax, with Adora leading the Horde while Catra wields the Sword against her; but a third side has grown inside both like a cancer, and seeks to use a secret left behind by the First Ones, no matter the cost.

And unknown to everyone, an evil greater than any approaches, ready to stretch its hand out over the squabbling forces of the planet and crush them all.

(Catra and Adora, She-Ra's true purpose, and the face of evil.)

Notes

One day before Season 5, I present to you my work! Gonna add chapters as I finish them.

LET'S GO

Chapter 1: Princess Catra of Brightmoon

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Part I:

Princess Catra of Brightmoon

Hordak is dead- but not at the hands of the Princess Alliance. Hordak is dead because he chose, against all odds and all belief, to save the world. When the great portal opened and threatened to consume all Etheria in distorted dreams, Hordak sacrificed himself to pull out the Sword, sparing Angella the burden- and sparing Catra the burden of watching her surrogate mother die.

Hordak is dead, having saved the world, and warning them of his brother's coming, who will seek to crush their Great Rebellion. Adora now reigns in the Fright Zone... but Hordak, Hordak whom they have fought for over a decade, is dead, and one act of heroism does not a lifetime of tyranny overcome.

So a great celebration is planned in Brightmoon, a revel to be grateful that their great enemy is dead; and how bad can Adora be? Hordak was the true villain; Adora is just the inferior sequel, the lesser enemy, the thing that will take just one last push to topple over.

The party takes three months to get everyone's schedules to line up, but that works out; in that time, the party is advertised, and the Princess Alliance is going to have its greatest celebration and ceremony at Brightmoon, in a great outdoor festival on the very grounds where, once upon a time, Catra fought the entire Horde as She-Ra.

The Great Rebellion has succeeded; Hordak is dead. A sense of imminent triumph reigns; soon they will crush Adora's remnant Horde, and all will be well. The Princess Alliance shall have an Etheria at peace, for the first time in generations, and all look forward to that sacred time.

The vigil has been kept; freedom shall soon reign over all Etheria.

-

There's a celebration going on, and Catra has mixed feelings about it.

Most of the Alliance is having a party. Normally Catra loves parties- it is the greatest failing of her Horde upbringing that they have no parties- but this one is being held to celebrate Hordak's death, and Catra does not feel like she can participate.

It would be different, she thinks, had they fought one last great battle; it would be different, if the last image of Hordak in her mind was some snarling villain. Catra could have been delighted

with that kind of victory, she thinks, she could be at peace, and party with the others out before Brightmoon.

But the image she sees of Hordak now, when she thinks of him, is not him performing any of the cruelties he is responsible for; no, she sees Hordak with the Sword in his hands, dying so that the world would live. Her last image of Hordak is not of the man who caused so much harm... but of the man who spared Queen Angella from having to make that terrible choice.

It feels... wrong, to her, to be glad of the death of someone like that.

(Well, technically he was just trapped between dimensions, but it wasn't much different than death, as Bow put it.)

She was Horde once, too, and changed; and somewhere in the back of her skull, she wonders what kind of man Hordak could have been, if things were different. For love of Entrapta, for friendship with Scorpia, he had been willing to die; who knew what transformation that alchemy might have worked on him, in time? Maybe he could have changed, redeemed himself all his many sins, and the Horde's attack be stilled at last.

So she stays in Brightmoon's corridors, and bereft of its usual citizens, the great castle is surprisingly solemn, with only a token handful of guards left inside, the others outside keeping the peace during the celebrations. From outside drifts in the sounds of the party, and the music of the bands Glimmer hired- a rotating list of who's who, using the remains of one of Sea Hawk's many burned and wrecked boats as a stage. Sea Hawk planned to set it on fire at the party's climax; Glimmer had approved, but had also

threatened creative bodily harm if he burned it before it was time. Catra had been involved in those conversations, even as she had made her own plans to stay away.

She just... couldn't, not with Hordak's last sacrifice so fresh in her mind. So she is alone, now, walking these long halls, not really *going* anywhere, so much as moving to scratch the restless itch in her feet and in her skull. She pays no attention to her wanderings, simply drifts through the long halls; were anyone to see her, they might mistake her for a ghost princess, and Catra could fulfill all the horror stories of the Horde at last. Her face is pensive and gloomy; her nature sorrowful, as she muses over Hordak's death.

...She is alone in her thoughts, and not just because no one walks the halls with her. Queen Angella assured her in private that she would make sure everyone knew of his sacrifice, seeing how much that mattered to Catra... but she admitted to the warrior, too, that she was unable to forgive him, and that she planned to participate in the festivities wholeheartedly. Angella had not forgotten Micah, nor forgiven the Horde for his death; that Hordak died saving the world does not change the fact that Angella's world ended when he killed Micah.

Angella is still picking the pieces back up, she is *still* recovering from that hurt, and so she will celebrate his death alongside her daughter, whom she put in charge of organizing the festivities.

It's the first time Catra has ever seen Angella and Glimmer move in concert before, but she thinks it won't be the last; ever since the Battle for the Portal, the two have grown closer, more in harmony. The last three months have been good for them. They talk often, in private, and they both seem more at ease around

each other, if a little cautious. Glimmer confided in Catra that they have deliberately been avoiding deeper topics; they don't feel confident enough to tackle the big issues yet... but Glimmer's hoping to do so after the party.

She's got hope that they can heal, finally, after all this time.

Catra's delighted for that, all her emotions about Hordak aside, she's *stoked* that Angella and Catra can restore their relationship. It has hurt them so much; she's happy for them, without her melancholy weighing on her, she'd be all for it. Catra had grown aware- more aware, recently, with Shadow Weaver in the castle- that she was a bundle of mommy issues that walked like a woman, and she is glad Glimmer will have her own maternal troubles soothed, glad that Angella can come to an accord with her beloved daughter.

…And that... makes the other things she feels *worse.*

To Catra's eternal shame, she feels... a little bit... jealous.

There is some part of her that looks at Glimmer and Angella's family coming back together and wants to be part of it, and that is... that is a *betrayal* of her friend and her liege both, to feel this way. Angella and Glimmer have been apart for so long, and it hurt Angella so much... Catra shouldn't... she has no place in that family. They grow together, they are healing, and that is *good,* and Catra's jealous heart has no reason to feel this treasonous poison.

It's stupid of her to do so anyway. It's wrong, to be mad that Glimmer couldn't see the good mother she was given, to be angry that Catra herself is stuck with Shadow Weaver... who is now a guest of Brightmoon, so that Catra cannot get away from her even in her home.

(She still hasn't told anyone the truth, she *can't.* Can't talk of her childhood, not... not here, where she thought she'd gotten *away* from it. Somehow she feels so ashamed of what happened to her, it feels as it is *all her fault,* no matter how her mind knows that cannot be true; she cannot stop her heart from feeling envy and she cannot stop her heart from feeling shame. The most orderly Princess cannot order the chaos inside herself.)

It's a good thing that Glimmer and Angella are spending more time together. It doesn't matter that Catra has less time with the Queen these days, and that she feels hurt by it doesn't matter either. Catra... Catraa has no *right* to be mad that Angella chose her real daughter over... over someone who isn't. At day's end, Glimmer is her real child, and Catra is just... just a former Hordeswoman, if one who has done well in Brightmoon.

Catra was once Catra of the Horde, and now she is Catra of Brightmoon, *She-Ra* of Brightmoon, and that's enough, it has to be *enough.* It is good that they are getting along better now, though Catra did crack one joke, only a little bitter, that it had taken *the end of the world* to fix their relationship.

(Glimmer had not heard the bitter, had just laughed at the outrageousness of it all. Catra wasn't sure that she'd wanted her to hear the bitter, and for someone so used to manipulating others, it is a frightening feeling, to not be sure what you *want* another person to hear.)

Seeing the perfect world has prompted Angella and Glimmer to be better to each other. They were so happy in that world... maybe the memory of it warms them.

Angella remembers, as does Catra, and a few scattered others, though most people do not. Glimmer and Bow both do, as does Madame Razz, who seems to have decided to follow Catra, a strange, mumbling, weird-old-lady shadow that pops up around corners from time to time, and keeps talking about pie.

At least, Catra *thinks* Madame Razz remembers; it's kind of hard to tell. The old woman tests her nerves, but she also saved Catra's life in the false world of the portal; it had been her attempts to wake her up that first broke Catra free of the spell.

(Catra, fresh from the Horde, would have hated the old woman; Catra, three years into being the Princess of Power, finds she has the patience to handle her most of the time, and the wisdom to leave when she can't.)

Catra wonders what the pattern is, what separates those who remember from those who don't. Entrapta, who remembers, theorizes that the people Catra actually spoke with remember; she thinks it's some side effect of Catra being the Sword's proper owner, a theory that's better than anything Catra's come up with. Entrapta had also mentioned that she wasn't much interested in pursuing the topic; she had another project that was taking up all her time.

That was why she'd sent all these answers to Catra in the form of a letter. Catra hadn't seen Entrapta since their visit to Perfuma's garden; in fact, nobody had, as far as anyone could tell. Even her cooking staff, which had come to Brightmoon to become Catra's personal household, hadn't seen her for a full week, Dryll standing empty until Entrapta suddenly showed up, looking “off”, as the staff had said, and kicked them all out with incredibly generous severance packages.

They'd debated retiring, but had come to a group decision not to do so, enjoying their work too much to stop- and enjoying each other, if Catra wasn't wrong about some of their interactions, which she mostly found cute. They had wanted to stay together, and keep working, keep themselves busy.

So to Brightmoon had they come, looking to get hired, and since Catra didn't have any personal retainers, Glimmer had suggested they sign on with her, becoming her personal kitchen staff. Catra wasn't sure what she felt about that, but it *was* nice to have someone learn her favorite meals... and at least she didn't have to pay them, Angella was taking care of that.

It hadn't taken long before the cooks figured out what she mostly wanted, though force of habit from working for Entrapta left their food tiny for two weeks. Only the baker was dismayed; Catra had little taste for sugar, and much taste for hot spice, a side effect of her feline heritage. She *could* taste sugar, but she didn't much care for it.

...Thinking of them, Catra debates going to get food... the trio were helping with the party, but she could still raid the kitchen.

...No, no. No point. She wasn't hungry. The other thoughts crowd back in, her head is stuffed to burst; and so Catra retreats deeper into the castle, going up some stairs, hiding from the party so all her thoughts don't spill out of her too-full skull and ruin the mood for others.

The others had been told that she'd do this. Let them enjoy the day. Bow had protested; she'd waved him off. He's fought the Horde longer than she has, after all; they all have, they've battled the Horde all their lives. Catra is a convert to the cause, not a born believer, and a convert from the Horde itself at that; perhaps it is appropriate, that she is in something like... mourning, for the man who had been her leader once.

...She wonders, as she clambers up the steps, slowly, quietly, if, given time, Hordak might have become like her, atoned for his sins, and embraced a different way. She wonders if she is mourning the man who died- who she can see, and agree, deserved it- or if she is mourning the man he *might* have been, that he can never be now, the way Catra herself, once upon a time, was not worthy of what she now has, but became so.

Her wandering leads her to lonely areas of the castle, hiding from the shine of joy and the laughter of the living, until, eventually, she finds her feet taking her, almost against her will, to Shadow Weaver's garden.

As part of the perks she'd gained by helping them, Shadow Weaver had been given an old gardening terrace in a mostly disused wing of the castle, a place in which she could grow her

preferred plants, though she had complained twice that they wouldn't let her keep the more dangerous- and therefore more useful- herbs in that space. Just a little place for her, one watched closely... though Catra knows, in her heart of hearts, that it is not watched closely *enough*. Shadow Weaver was too dangerous to be given an inch, for fear she would conquer miles.

Still, she'd been overruled. Catra had only been here once, with Angella and the rest of the Best Friends Squad with her, after the Battle of the Portal- as the Alliance was calling it- mostly so Catra would know where it was, and thus avoid it. The terms of Shadow Weaver's... imprisonment, as such, required her to avoid seeking Catra out, which she had agreed to in return for Hordak's destruction, and Catra had never had an urge to violate those terms before.

(She didn't feel that urge *now*; she hangs back, down a long hallway before that garden, merely peeking out of the shadows into the light- and how strange that was, to seek safety in darkness from the light. That had never been her way, felt wrong...)

Shadow Weaver was out there, clipping the flowers off of a plant she'd raised, and the unintentional symbolism was so obvious and so sharp that each cut makes Catra jolt, she feels those shears at her own neck. Shadow Weaver had never been kind to any of the things under her control...

Catra couldn't understand it; why Shadow Weaver still here? It wasn't like Brightmoon had kept her out before, it was hard to imagine it could keep her *in*. Now that Hordak was dead... what did she seek here? Why stay?

...Down the hall, a vent is opened, and a person crawls out, nearly causing Catra to leap out of her skin. It is a novel way, to skin a cat with sheer terror; her hand goes to the bracelet she wears, the Sword transformed to make carrying it easier.

Her eyes take in the newcomer, and she stops, staring. They moved on their *hair*, which jerks strangely at times as if it is breaking loose from her control; a small figure sits inside that great serpentine mass, wearing what looks like the remnants of a pair of overalls, a heavy chain replacing one set of straps on the left side. Half a Horde symbol dangles down one arm, what had once been a red Horde banner repurposed into a sleeve with hasty stapling at top and bottom. The other arm left bare, the sleeve torn off in some lab accident or another; the skin underneath is pasty, and thin, from staying indoors and not eating well. A heavy boot on one foot, the other in an equally heavy, completely different style of boot, the thick purple gloves on both hands uniform but also burned and torn in a dozen places.

Finally, the mask- round, with great bulging eye windows, like an insect's face in caricature, surrounded by all that prehensile hair...

...Entrapta?!?

Too surprised by her ramshackle appearance to say anything, Catra simply stands there as Entrapta slithers away, to speak with Shadow Weaver in low tones. Her hair was no longer in two great tails, just one undifferentiated mass now, she was a great shaggy thing as she engages Shadow Weaver in conversation, her body frazzled and looking like she'd just had a major fight.

What is she up to?

After she speaks with Shadow Weaver, her questions and her answers both given in voices too low for even Catra's ears to make anything out, she takes her leave of the sorceress, returns to the long, dark hallway that Catra is hiding down- and the engineer's eyes, so used to seeing small details, pick Catra out of the dark, right as she is about to slip away into a vent again.

" Catra," Entrapta says, and her voice is a croak, dusty with disuse. She doesn't take off her mask, and her hair flares in a halo about it; with the rest of the mass trailing behind her, it makes her resemble a cobra with its hood out. " You... are not celebrating?"

The great warrior of Brightmoon shakes her head. " No," she says to Entrapta. " I... keep thinking of... well, I used to be Horde too, Entrapta."

Entrapta nods, then, awkward, stretches out a hand halfway, as though she wants to comfort but can't quite manage to complete the thought. " I... we both were. I miss him."

Catra cannot claim that, not precisely; Hordak was not a good man.

But he *might* have been, he might have *become* so, and that aches, that is what hurts her, when she thinks of him.

“ He could have been great,” Catra says, and that resonates with Entrapta; she withdraws the hand, clenches it as a fist at her side, and her next words are a sob.

“ Yes,” Entrapta chokes out, hair poofing out hard around her head again... but then she can say no more, and she retreats, her snaketail of hair following her into the vents.

Catra is left alone, with only Shadow Weaver before her; but she is not that desperate for company, not after speaking with the tech princess, and so she slips away too, back down the halls, seeking the comfort of her room, to wait the party out in peace.

(In the garden, Shadow Weaver- who heard and saw everything- chuckles as she clips a calico blossom.)

-

Some hours later, Glimmer sighed, laying back in her chair after a long, successful day. All around her in Brightmoon's great open field were the remnants of the party; tents and stalls and the great long table they ate at, as well as the merry embers of Sea Hawk's ship, still finishing its slow burn.

Servants were moving about, not just Brightmoon castle retainers but independent workers hired to deal with today's great event, all working on cleaning the party up. Glimmer reminded herself to

make sure they got a bonus; this couldn't be easy to handle. It seemed like everyone in the Alliance had been in here today.

Which, of course, meant the party was a *smashing* success. Glimmer couldn't stop grinning; she'd done it. Of course, rather ironically, she hadn't really gotten to enjoy it; she'd been too busy keeping it going smoothly.

Still, who cared? She didn't mind; knowing it had went so well was its own reward. Her mom... she'd be proud.

Wasn't that hard at day's end, either. Really, most of it was just... putting people in the right spots. When Catra spoke of the need for planning and forethought, she was right, for all that Glimmer and the other princesses made fun of their order-loving friend. Chaos had its advantages, but Order sure was safer- and much more of a sure bet.

Yes, Catra was right... she usually was. Mighty Catra, their great warrior, and also their great leader, who was right about... everything.

Usually that led to some grumbling in Glimmer's brain, her own private choir of complaints... but today, even those thoughts couldn't ruin her good mood. No, she felt good, and she could admit that Catra was right without the usual feelings that accompanied it, that feeling of... well, she didn't like thinking about it.

(Unworthiness, she is unworthy, she is unworthy; a thought that has haunted Glimmer since her childhood, since she saw how small her wings were and realized how poorly she measured up compared to her parents.)

So Glimmer, when her mom told her she was to plan today's celebrations, had tried to think like Catra. She hadn't quite managed it, wasn't as good as Catra would be... but she'd discovered that a little bit of planning went a *long* way.

The big thing was arranging her workers, a thing that had worked out *perfectly.* Frosta as her "personal guard" kept the ice princess out of trouble by having her accompany her- which had even been kind of fun, Frosta was like the little sister she'd never had. Huntara and Tung Lashor for bouncers and general guards had been brilliant; they hadn't even had to throw anyone out, they were just too intimidating for anyone to cross.

Mermista and Perfuma had worked together on decorations, making fountains and delicate floral arrangements that showcased various heroic moments in the struggle against Hordak- including one of Micah, to Glimmer's stunned surprise, a request Angella had made personally. It showed him fighting, and Glimmer's eyes wandered to it during the night, from time to time, this statue that depicted her father acting not like cool and calm Angella but instead acting like, well, *Glimmer*, striking out with his staff.

She didn't know why her mom had asked... but she was glad she had.

The feast had taken the longest to set up; it had to be perfect. Glimmer wasn't going to make Spinnerella's mistake of serving vegetable platters- no one liked those!

Instead, she'd had a bit of inspiration. This was for the Alliance, right? Well, she'd put together what she was calling a " Rebel's Feast"; she'd recruited people from every nation's royal staff, making a feast that had elements of every culture in it. Produce from Plumeria, fresh fish from Salineas Glimmer had teleported in personally yesterday (it had taken her all day and multiple recharges, but she'd done it), supplemented with frozen drinks native to the Kingdom of Snows, everything kept at the perfect temperature with a little magic from Mystacor.

(Huntara and Tung Lashor had suggested adding a plate of sand for the Waste, a suggestion they'd both managed to say completely straight-faced, bursting into laughter only when Glimmer glared at them.)

Brightmoon itself supplied most of the dessert, though Entrapta's kitchen staff had made some traditional desserts of Dryll for variety, the harsh, mountainous region producing surprisingly strong sweets. The baker had been excited to work with sugar again, claiming Catra didn't much care for the stuff. Probably explained why Catra had let Glimmer borrow the trio when she'd asked- though Catra had also said she didn't think she'd have much interest in food today.

(Poor Catra; she'd explained her conflicted spirit to them, and while Glimmer didn't really understand, she also didn't like seeing one of her best friends so down.)

Even the minor nations of the Alliance, the smaller citystates and principalities that had no Princess or legacy of magic, had their

place at the table; fruits from Alwyn, cakes from Elberon, spiced drinks from Seaworthy, a variety of excellent baked breads from Erelandia... and Glimmer's own personal favorite, a small scattering of food she'd bought from Thaymor, which had been burned to the ground by a Horde attack three years ago, and just this year finally reached sustainability again.

The contribution was minimal... but Glimmer felt it important to remember those who had lost everything, who had regained it with their help, and she had made sure she'd taken a bit of food from their contribution when time had come for her to eat. Thaymor was where they'd found Catra... and it had been Adora who had destroyed it, killed all those people who could not flee. Glimmer wanted to remember them.

As for the entertainment... well, Glimmer had put Bow to work on that. She'd wanted Entrpata to help him, but she'd disappeared into Dryll, had buried herself so deep in the Crypto Castle that no letters could dig her out; so it was up to Bow, and he'd done pretty well, though every single Princess had made suggestions to him at some point. They had an area for physical contests- mostly arm wrestling and other feats of strength- alongside the merchant's area, set aside for independent entrepeneurs to ply their trade.

A riddling contest had surprised Glimmer with how incredibly well it had went; it had been Bow's idea, and the crowd had loved it, the eventual winner being a Seaworthy sailor whose riddle about an egg was short, sweet, and had stumped his final opponent completely, earning him a fine cash prize.

But the greatest attractions were Glimmer's own personal idea; three sets of galleries, one for darts, oen for arrows, and one for thrown knives, all with boards with Hordak's face on them. Simple, effective, and a huge draw; everyone had loved them. Even her mother, after some initial, amused disapproval, had joined in, managing to nail Hordak in the nose with a knife.

Netossa had played all three types, and gotten her Hordak targets in the eyes, every time, to general acclaim. Spinnerella had sought Glimmer out personally to tell her how much she and her wife had enjoyed the celebration. Glimmer had blushed, and stammered a bit; she'd always looked up to the two mighty rebel Princesses, who owned no land and were connected to no Runestone, but who nonetheless used their inborn magic to fight for their people.

They weren't the only ones thrilled, either; everyone had a good time, as far as Glimemr could tell. Even her mom had liked it; she'd given a speech at the start that made a point of Hordak's death, that he had died better than he had lived... but then her mom had surprised Glimmer, by stating bluntly that Hordak had lived poorly, and encouraged everyone to enjoy themselves.

Really, it was a shame Entrapta and Catra were missing it. Shadow Weaver was banned, but the other two had standing invitations... still, Glimmer supposed it would have been weird for Entrapta to come. They were celebrating the death of her old employer and the guy whose side she'd *chosen* to be on, so her escaping the party wasn't a surprise.

(No one knew Entrapta *had* arrived... using the party as a cover to talk with Shadow Weaver in private.)

But Catra...

" Princess, Queen Angella wishes to speak with you," said a messenger, who had arrived during Glimmer's musings " She's in her private chambers."

" Thanks," Glimmer said, yawning. " Be there in a sec."

She teleported off, arriving outside her mom's room, knocking politely on the door, not noticeable as special amongst the hallway- her mom preferred a modest room, not the much larger, more official Queen's room she had used for centuries, that she and Micah had once shared- that Angella would not sleep in now.

" Come in!" came her mom's clear voice, and Glimmer popped inside. The place looked as it always had, a small, cozy room of quiet drapery and purple and pink imagery, with a bed, a dresser with mirror, and a small closet of clothes, alongside a single comfy chair for guests. Yes, indeed, the same as it had always been... save that a painting of Micah, once hidden in a closet, had been moved into the room, and hung proudly on the wall.

Seeing him again in the other world- talking to him- had made Angella less afraid of his representation, had not opened her old wound but, strangely, helped to close it; this was not the first piece of Micah that had been returned, dragged out of storage to be displayed once more.

Glimmer looked at it for a second before refocusing on her mom, who was sitting before her dresser, looking herself over in the mirror while adjusting her gloves, having changed into a more casual outfit with the party over.

" What's up?" daughter asked mother.

" First, I'd like to compliment you," Angella said. " You did marvelously with the celebrations. The Hordak targets were *inspired*."

" Thank you!" Glimmer said, grinning.

" Take a seat, would you?" Angella said, gesturing to the guest chair. Glimmer plopped down on it gratefully; running the party *had* been exhausting.

" Thanks," Glimmer said.

" You're welcome! Secondly, if you're up for it- and no pressure if you're not!" Angella said, just a *bit* too brightly, as she turned around to face her daughter. " Then... well, I suppose we should have that talk we both need to stop putting off. I... rather feel like this is a bit like a bandage, the faster we rip it off the better it'll go. I almost put it off, but I'm in a good mood right now, and so maybe... it will be easier?"

Her mom was as nervous about this as Glimmer was... which made this a bit easier, to know she wasn't the only one panicking a bit.

" Okay," Glimmer said. " How'd you know I wanted to talk after the celebrations?"

" Motherly intuition," Angella said- then sighed and laughed at Glimmer's skeptical expression. " Okay, you... are too much like your father, in that respect. He liked timing things for dramatic effect, too."

Your father, words she hears on her mother's lips more often these last three months, good words, that tell her of a father she has not had in too long.

" Alright," Glimmer said. " Though... how are we going to start?"

" I don't know," Angella said, chewing on her lip and her daughter's words both... this was hard, the things that needed saying were three years too old to be unsaid still...

Glimmer, sitting before her, a little wary. Always defensive around her, Glimmer was, and Angella had to admit it wasn't all on Glimmer's end, either.

Remember the things you haven't said, she forcefully reminded herself. She could have *died* with all those things unsaid, and knowing that stiffened her coward's spine.

...Maybe start there.

" So... do you want to know a secret? I... am... a coward," Angella admitted, out loud, for the third time in her long, eternal existence. First to Micah, explaining her terror of their marriage; then to Catra, flying over the world as it ended. Lastly now to Glimmer, whose eyes widened at the sudden revelation. " I am a coward, Glimmer. I always have been. Micah was the brave one, not me."

" Coward? But you've... fought the Horde longer than anybody..."

Angella's bitter laugh rocked Glimmer more than a dozen speeches; she did not associate *bitterness* with her mother, at least, not when she talked of subjects other than Glimmer, her unworthy daughter.

" Fought? In what way? Until they came to Brightmoon's very steps *I* did not fight. I ordered *others* to fight... and die. Like Micah. I..."

Angella sighed. " I am a coward, Glimmer. That's my secret."

They stood in silence for a minute, Glimmer finally speaking. " Why are you telling me this?"

" I was ready to die," Angella said, closing her eyes, seeing and hearing not Brightmoon at evening's rest around her but the world as it ended, the howl around the Sword and its ethereal glow. " The Sword had to be pulled out, but it was floating in the air, Glimmer. Catra couldn't reach it- and Entrapta had warned us that whoever pulled it out would be... lost."

Glimmer put her hand to her mouth. " But Hordak-"

" Hordak arrived later," Angella answered. " For a little while- it was just me, Glimmer, the task had to be mine. Catra... Catra panicked. Told me not to leave her, like Shadow Weaver always did, she wept at the idea... She stalled me until Hordak showed up. I was... I was going to die, Glimmer, and all I could think about was you, and how much I've screwed up with you. If it wasn't for Catra, I *would* have died."

Glimmer lowered her hand, leaned forward in her chair. " Mom..."

Angella nodded her head. " So... that's my secret. I am a coward. Glimmer... I want to talk. And I want to *listen.* You have my word that I will hear you out, if you will, in turn, hear me out, and I'll *listen*."

Glimmer's face turned sad. " That's an easy thing to say, and a hard thing to do. It's also *not* the first time you've said it."

Indeed, this wasn't even close to the first time Angella had *said* she'd listen... but unlike the times before, Angella did not get mad or yell when Glimmer pointed it out, but simply nodded her head sadly.

" True," she agreed.

Glimmer nodded.

" Okay," she said.

Angella smiled softly. " I... must admit I have no idea what to do now. I didn't really plan for what to say, I'm mostly just, err, 'winging it', I think, is the slang? Which is odd to me because I'm fairly certain it didn't originate with winged beings like us-"

" It's the slang," Glimmer said with some amusement.

" Good to know," Angella said with a smile, fluttering her wings for effect. " Still... I confess to having no idea for how to talk this out. Do you have any ideas?"

Dozens.

" I have one," Glimmer said aloud. " I... suppose... let's do it like this. We take turns asking questions. Answer them honestly and in full. One question, one answer, then the other one asks a question. You go first, since it's my idea."

" Okay," Angella said, chewing on her lip and her daughter's words before, finally, asking a relatively small question, one that was little but still poked at the bigger things between them. " Well, here's a question I should have asked... a long time ago. Why are you a soldier? First Ones know I gave you every opportunity to back away; and like I said, I am, at heart, a coward. You've got Micah's spine, not mine. Why did you join the military?"

Instinct and habit made Glimmer want to get defensive... but she had questions of her own to ask, and... and her mother didn't accuse her, she wasn't throwing this at her like she usually did... she seemed to just be, well, curious.

So Glimmer tamped down on the burst of fury that first accompanied that question, and pondered her answer, talking as she thought about how to answer.

" I... okay," Glimmer said, " Not what I expected... but yeah, you've never *actually* asked that, have you? Not in so many words."

“ No,” Angella said. “ And it's three years too late for me to ask that question in the right time... but I hope it's not too late to ask it at all?”

A gentle lilt upward made the last statement a nervous question, and that was new, seeing her perfect, immortal mother worried... different and new enough that it let Glimmer plunge ahead and reveal to her the answer, the truth she'd never told anyone except Bow and Catra before.

“ I love it,” she said. “ I know that's probably disappointing or kind of underwhelming to hear... but that's all there is to it. I love the excitement, the thrill- I don't... I don't deal with routine very well. Catra gets that, and Bow kinda does? He doesn't like combat, necessarily, but he understands the attraction in others. Bow joined the Rebellion because he wants to do something great with his life, because he believes in the cause. I do too, but really that's not why I joined. I could believe in the cause and do something else to support it- I picked battle because it's my passion. I love it. I love fighting, combat, adventure, violence- and I get it, it's dangerous, that's why it makes me feel *alive*.”

She struggled a moment, looking for the right words to say, the words that wouldn't mock her mother but would explain Glimmer's feelings. Her mother struggled too, struggled not to lash out or yell at her daughter for recklessness or do any of the things she usually did, the things that had prevented them from talking about this for three years.

To their credit, both won their struggles. Angella stayed silent, and Glimmer finally found her voice.

“ There's not a word for it, at least not one I know. It's not bloodlust, I'm not Perfuma... I like the rush. I... call me a danger-hunter, I guess? I don't... how'd Bow put it... I don't feel alive unless I can wave at Death.”

Angella nodded, clearly processing that. “ I... cannot pretend I understand that even a *little*. Death scares me.”

“ You?” Glimmer said in surprise, unable to help herself. “ You're immortal!”

“ You'd think that'd help,” Angella said. It was supposed to be a joke, but her low, terrified tone betrayed her. “ Immortal doesn't mean invincible. I can't die of old age, but I am vulnerable to death like anyone else... and it frightens me, Glimmer. I don't *have* to die, so the idea of doing so scares me... I'm not even sure death will treat me like it treats others. I have no standing invitation from it, there is no place in the clearing at the end of the path for me... I... no, death scares me.”

“ Well, we both know *I'm* not immortal,” Glimmer said. “ We don't talk about that- so I guess now's as good a time as any. Here's my first question. How long am I going to live?”

Angella sighed. “ I... Actually, I'm not sure you *aren't* immortal. Nobody's sure, Glimmer. Something like you has never been before. I'll give you the best answer I can. Castaspella did some

work when you were born- but you have to understand, Glimmer, I didn't even know I could *get* pregnant when I had you."

" Wait, really?" Glimmer said, and Angella nodded.

" I'm one of a kind, Glimmer, an elemental being born of the Moonstone's power. Over the years, I'd had, err, carnal relations before..."

" Well, that's a thought in my head now," Glimmer deadpanned, and Angella laughed, humor sailing over the awkward moment.

" My deepest apologies," Angella said with a smile. " But... well, despite that, I never got pregnant, so I just assumed I was barren. I'm an elemental thing, Glimmer, not made of mortal flesh... but it turns out that I can quicken like flesh. Me and Micah were together for some time before we had you, and we had no reason to use protection of any kind, though contraceptive spells *do* exist."

Angella smirked. " Micah was apparently exceptional in many ways; he got me pregnant, though that *terrified* me."

Glimmer tried not to think of her parents having sex, and with a titanic act of will, barely managed it. " Why'd it scare you?" she asked instead, though she thought she knew the answer already.

“ Time had never been my enemy before, Glimmer... and now... now it was. I had just reconciled myself to seeing Micah grow old and die, the way everyone I've ever loved does. I... I'm so *old,* Glimmer. I remember when the Fire Princess reigned in the East, before she set her nation ablaze seeking godhood. I remember things that are whispered myths to others. I...”

She shook her head. “ I'd accepted Micah's eventual death as the price for having the joy of him in my life for a little while... I've made that bargain before, and it was easy to come to. Happiness for a time, then mourning for a time, the way I've always done it. Micah was... I loved him *more* than the others, he's the only one I ever married, my way of acknowledging how strongly I felt... but then I got sick. Sick in the morning, and somehow I *knew*, the second it began; I'm a coward, so naturally I leapt to the scariest conclusion possible, and I was right. I was pregnant... pregnant with a baby I'd raise and love and get to watch *die*, either before its time or *at* its time. I... didn't deal with it very well, and some part of me has always been afraid that I have treated you poorly because... because maybe then it'll hurt less, when you are old and fading, and I am still here. Alone.”

Angella rubbed her eyes, and Glimmer, her heart breaking, got up and gave her mom a hug, wrapped herself up in her; her mom hugged her back, still sitting, arms around Glimmer's waist as her head nestled into her daughter's neck.

“ I didn't know,” Glimmer said softly, and Angella sighed.

“ It's something else we should have talked about before now,” she said. “ I apologize, Glimmer. We... *really* have a lot to work out between us.”

Glimmer nodded. " And... not all of it is from your end," the punching princess begrudgingly admitted as she let go, and stepped back. " But back to my question. What am I looking at?"

Angella let go too, a bit reluctantly; it had been a while since they'd hugged, and she found herself missing the contact.

" Castaspella wasn't sure. If my essence wins out- which she thought it would, given your connection to the Moonstone- then your aging will be greatly slowed down once you hit adulthood. Maybe it'd be only a few centuries, or maybe you'd be as immortal as I am. If Micah's won out... you'd age like he... would have. It's one reason I've always encouraged you to stay topped up on the Moonstone- the more of its magic you have inside you, the more of it you wield, the better the chances you'll live a long time... It's selfish, Glimmer, because you'll outlive all of your friends... but I don't want to lose my daughter, so soon after losing my husband."

Angella frowned, and for just a moment, Glimmer was aware of how *old* her mother was, the incredible lengths of time she had existed. It was a fact she didn't think about often... but now, it was hard *not* to think about it, how many friends Angella had made and lost over the centuries.

...Yeah, she could see how having a maybe immortal daughter... might sound pretty good, from her mom's perspective.

" I get it," she said. " I don't hold that against you, either. Nobody's really in your position but you; what choice do you have?"

Angella nodded, giving her a small, but honest, smile.

" Well, this is... kind of an overwhelming conversation, and I think I'm going to need a break soon... but there's one last thing to address, while we're on the subject of daughters. The other world, made up of dreams... in it, I had adopted Catra."

" I... oh," Glimmer said, looking away from her mom and trying not to make her thoughts obvious on her face. A bolt of that green, jealous thing in her heart, in her guts (in her eyes)... but also a kind of... genuine happiness? She'd just been thinking about how sad Catra was, how missing the party couldn't have been good for her...

" Why did I adopt her in that other world?" Angella asked. " I know a bit about how the other world worked... is that what Catra truly desires?"

...*Yes,* Glimmer thought, the only answer she could truthfully give. It was a thought that hurt, that made that green thing inside her shine. She has always been

(unworthy)

Of her mother and her father both, a truth her stupid, stunted wings reveal to everyone with eyes to see. Her mother is an Etherian angel, her father the greatest sorceror seen in generations; Glimmer is little more than a glittery brute.

And Catra makes her feel that way, too, not on purpose- Catra is her friend, she would never hurt her on purpose- but Catra... Catra was so *good* at everything, she was She-Ra and a hero and a legend. Glimmer wasn't sure how comfortable she was, adding another person to her family who she felt so... *inferior* too.

...But Catra *was* one of her best friends. Memories, warm and loving, poured through her mind, and they were good, even as tinged with Glimmer's self-doubt as they were. Catra trying to comfort her at the Prom, awkward but wanting to help. Catra saving her in the Fright Zone after Glimmer had thought all hope lost. Catra, complimenting her on dealing with Frosta well. Catra sitting with the other princesses after a successful attack, laughing with her, comrade in arms. Catra hugging her as she wept while Bow reconciled with his fathers.

Catra nearly dying to save her mother... and apparently, saving her again in the false world, stalling her long enough that Hordak could arrive.

And, of course, all the memories of Catra looking at her mother. Catra had never said it in so many words, but it was not hard, to look at a girl who had never had a mother, and see the way, over these last few years, that Catra looked at Angella, ready to do anything she asked, and not... not *know.* Not know what was the most secret thing of Catra's, the happy fantasy she kept inside.

Maybe we're already sisters, Glimmer thought. *I know her deepest secrets, as I'm sure she knows mine.*

Some part of her wanted to lie. It was the only victory Glimmer had over Catra; she was Angella's real daughter, and Catra wasn't. Catra wanted it, but what was she supposed to do? This was Glimmer's, Catra couldn't *take* it from her, she'd have *that* over her all her life...

...What a *shitty* fucking way to think.

Glimmer, tired of being second best to everyone in her life- tired of feeling so

(unworthy)

Nonetheless found the strength somewhere inside herself to push the green thing aside, and spoke the truth.

" She wants you to adopt her," Glimmer said, looking her mother in the face, as her better nature won out. " She loves you. And you love her too, I see the way you dote on her; she's a daughter to you in practice, if not on paper. And with all we've been through together, she might as *well* be my sister."

Angella nodded. " I... have noticed how much Catra seems to cling to me," she said. " I was surprised to have adopted her in

the other world- but not terribly so, if you understand.”

Glimmer nodded. “ You already kinda knew, huh?”

“ Yes,” Angella said, chewing on her lip again- bad habit when nervous. “ Glimmer, do you really think I should do this?”

“ Do you want to?” Glimmer asked. “ Won't be worth anything if you don't want to be her mother. She is damn near grown, it's kind of late to adopt her- but then again, you've had her for three years, and you've been more of a mom to her in that time than Shadow Weaver was in all the time before that. I don't know *what* Shadow Weaver did to Catra, but you can't call it parenting.”

The memory of Catra, shivering, nervous, between her and Bow, the Sword of Protection a security blanket in her hands- the girl who had fought all the Horde, reduced to a scared child by one witch's presence.

“ I... think I do,” Angella said, sounding a little surprised. “ I have cared for that girl since the moment she brought you back. I didn't expect that, Glimmer, I thought I was going to lose you... but then she came back, after all we did to her, she came back with you in her hands, safe and sound. And all these years since, I've done my best to be good to her, to make up for what we did to her at the start, even as she hasn't held it against us... Yes, I think I would like to adopt her.”

“ Good,” Glimmer said, and when the green thing in her heart tried to rise up, she knocked it back down. Not today. Today... today she was just going to be happy, for Catra, one of her two best friends... and soon to be her sister.

(Inside, she knew she'd be wrestling with that thing all her life, the way she'd wrestled with her feelings of inadequacy- and some days she'd win, some days she'd lose. Today, she wins, and that is enough.)

“ So, how... how do I approach it?” Angella asked, and Glimmer laughed at her nervous look.

“ Let me handle that. You just wait here.”

“ Glimmer!” Angella shouted, wings popping up in surprise as Glimmer teleported out. Her mom would dance around the issue if somebody didn't force it- and, well, Glimmer wanted to be happy for Catra when this happened, and right now seemed like the best time.

Two teleports later, she ended up in Catra's room.

“ Hey Catra!” she said, Catra surprised to see her from her position on the bed, just lying down. She lifted her head, differently colored eyes wide.

“ Hey,” she said, surprise fading as her cool, calm, collected facade restored itself, eyes shrinking. She yawned; apparently she'd drifted off at one point. “ How'd the party go?”

“ No time,” Glimmer said, grabbing her arm. “ Tell you later!”

“ Hey!” Catra squeaked, as Glimmer warped them back to her mother's room. Catra landed on her feet as they arrived, moving from horizontal to standing with grace and speed Glimmer could only dream of.

“ I- my Queen, is this an emergency?” Catra said, suddenly wide awake, tail stiff with fear and ears down. “ I didn't hear any alarms-”

“ It's no emergency,” Angella said, willing herself to be calm with an effort- though her wings remained frazzled, bunched up and ready to take off at a moment's notice. “ I just- Glimmer, I'm not ready!”

“ I think you're good,” Glimmer said, turning to Catra with a mischievous grin on her face. She might lack Angella's beauty and Catra's grace, but right now, she had the advantage of being the only straightforward person in the room. “ Catra, me and my mom talked it over. She wants to adopt you, and I'm all for it.”

“ I- *Glimmer*...” Angella despaired, while Catra gave Glimmer a sharp look.

“ You're... serious.”

“ Yes,” Glimmer said. “ I knew you two would either make a show of it or put it off, so I decided I'd intervene and just get it done. I mean, you're going to be my sister, what else are siblings for, right?”

Catra stared at her a moment, shook her head to clear it- then turned to Angella, her tail lashing just a little, her ears turned and focused on Angella.

“ I... my Queen, is she serious?”

“ Yes, Catra,” Angella said. “ I wanted to do this with more formality- I apologize for Glimmer's antics, and I understand if you want to delay.”

“ Don't you dare,” Glimmer told her mother sternly. “ Don't put this off another minute, either of you, you've spent three years dancing around it already. I mean, you already adopted her in the other world, so this isn't even the first time.”

The mention of the other world caused Catra's ears to droop, and her tail to go stiff again; her face fell, and she gave Angella a long, low bow, staying in that position, looking at the floor and not at Angella.

“ I... Queen Angella, that was born of my own selfish desire,” Catra said. “ You have a real daughter in Glimmer. Don't- don't add me to your family. You two are both coming back together again; you don't need me complicating things. I'm content to serve you.”

“ Catra, don't-” Glimmer started, but Angella raised a hand to her. Seeing Catra like this, hearing her care and concern, made her decision for her; Angella caught the spinning coin of choice, her decision made.

She got up out of her seat, approaching Catra.

“ Catra, you don't bow to me,” she said, putting a hand to Catra's shoulder, lifting her up to look her in the eyes- and there they are, unshed tears in Catra's eyes, the thing her bow had been hiding. “ Daughters shouldn't bow to their mothers.”

“ My Queen-”

“ Hush,” Angella said, squeezing Catra's shoulder. “ I've cared for you *as* a daughter for years now. Glimmer is bull-headed and direct, but she's entirely correct. I want you to be part of my family, Catra.”

“ I... I suppose it would be nice to have She-Ra as a daughter,” Catra said, even as the tears in her eyes threatened to overspill, trying to make a joke out of the situation, still not able to believe this was happening.

“ I don't care about She-Ra,” Angella said, shaking her head. “ I want *Catra* to be my daughter. She-Ra is just your job. It's *you* I want.”

Catra's breath hitched, and then with a sob she started to cry.

“ Come here, my daughter,” Angella said, opening her arms to hug her. Catra pressed into it, hugging her back, burying her face in her shoulder.

“ *Mom,*” Catra sobbed, a word that had waited to be said for years.

“ Family hug!” Glimmer yelled cheerfully, even with a few happy tears of her own, and the brutish princess threw her arms around her mother and her sister.

Catra wept in her family's arms.

Chapter 2: Glimmer of the Alliance

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer of the Alliance

Catra stares at her, eyes accusing, eyes *angry*.

Why did you do it?

Hordak, her leader, whom she has planned to overthrow and kill for so long now... dead, at her hand, but there is no peace. He stares at her, eyes accusing, eyes *angry*.

Why did you do it?

She has no answer; at least, none that stands up to their scrutiny. She opens her mouth and speaks and lies fall out of her mouth, little white lies that get up and dance like stars... but darkness pours out of their eyes and murders them, extinguishes each light that falls from her twisted lips.

The one thing no lie can defeat- the truth.

And in that starry darkness, the likes of which Adora has never seen, she sees *them*- the shadows of her people, of the First Ones- and they stare at her, eyes accusing, eyes *angry*.

Why did you do it?

Adora wakes up screaming and alone.

(In the morning, she heads out on the first transport to the Crimson Waste with her squad, and all notice the bags under her eyes- and the burn scars all down her arm.)

-

Out in the Crimson Waste, as the bad rubbed at her wounds, the good and the ugly were walking, though Tung Lashor would have informed any observers that he was considered *very* good-looking among his fellow lizardfolk, which was true, though it didn't affect the mammalian opinion of him much.

The Best Friend Squad, alongside Huntara, Perfuma, and Tung Lashor, were back after Mara's ship... but for the first time in forever, Catra could barely focus on the mission. She was quiet, walking behind the others, still in something like a trance.

Queen Angella had adopted her.

...Catra still couldn't believe it was real. She couldn't believe it when Angella (*mother*) told her, she couldn't believe it when Glimmer (*sister*) hugged her, she couldn't believe it when the paperwork was signed.

(Which was when Glimmer discovered she was superior to Catra in at least one department; Catra's handwriting was *atrocious*, a slow, uneven scrawl that looked as though she'd suffered a concussion and an epileptic fit both while writing. Penmanship was not high on the Horde's priority list.)

Even now, two days later... somehow, inside, Catra didn't truly believe it.

Glimmer had noticed; she had made a point of calling Catra her sister in the earshot of others, her way of trying to reassure Catra this was real, though it had only been two days, so most people didn't know.

Bow had been first to find out, and he'd been glad they had finally done it- *finally*, because Bow had always expected this would happen, the way that, when he was held captive in the Fright Zone, he'd simply known that Catra would save him. Hell, even *Catra* had not known she would do that, not until the moment came and she did, in fact, prove to be worthy of the Sword... but Bow had never doubted.

(Perhaps his greatest strength; Bow's faith in others is so strong that it makes the people around him *better*, for fear of disappointing him.)

Of the others, only Frosta, Sea Hawk and Mermista, who'd been hanging around after the party, knew. Mermista had been delighted at the news, really *understanding* what it meant to Catra; the water wielder had given her a genuine *smile,* almost strange to see on her face. Strange, and lovely, too, like the free ocean horizon. Mermista had squeezed her hand, told her that she was so *glad* for her, and Catra had just awkwardly smiled back, still reeling emotionally, a happy kind of punch-drunk.

Sea Hawk had given her a thumbs up, and offered to write an epic ballad for her, despite the protests of both herself and Mermista, and had even promised to have it done within a week, which was a threat hanging over her head Catra could have done without.

Frosta had taken the news rather... differently.

“ So can you teleport now?” she'd asked.

“ ...No?” Catra offered. Frosta shook her head.

“ Got the shit end of the deal,” the littlest Princess had opined, and walked away, because she was bored of the conversation. Catra had been stunned; Bow's mouth had fallen open at hearing her cuss.

“ You can't cuss, you're a baby!” Glimmer had yelled at the retreating Frosta.

Then they'd heard about Mara's ship getting stolen by the Horde, and everyone effectively remembered that, yes, Hordak was dead, but his army was still hanging around, and the Princess Alliance should probably do something about that.

Hence the mission, which Catra *should* be focusing on, and not the... the terrible sweetness inside her, that is eclipsing everything else.

Focus on the mission, Catra reminded herself.

It should have been easier, now, under the beautiful, burning sun, the light banishing all her shadows... but the sunlight that banished her darkest fears and all Shadow Weaver's memories cannot banish the gentle moonlight of Angella's regard, which lingered in the back of her mind, evoking a soft kind of wonder Catra had never felt before.

Still, with some effort, she managed to focus herself. Angella- her mother- needed her to get Mara's ship back, and Catra hadn't ever failed her yet... and she *certainly* wasn't going to fail her on her first mission as her daughter.

(Was this the pressure Glimmer felt on each mission? Normally Catra could just roll with it, but now the pressure seemed overwhelming, suddenly. Being Angella's daughter was terribly sweet... and sweetly terrifying. She couldn't *dare* fail her. Not now.)

They had a good group for the mission, and a large one. Glimmer and Bow, of course, her best friends (and her *sister),* alongside Huntara and Tung Lashor, curious to see how their home had developed in their absence and their resident experts on the Waste.

Perfuma was their surprise guest, the plant princess brought along so she could help ferry Mara's ship out of the Waste. Spinnerella would have worked, too, but Perfuma's power was more practical over long distances, and since she and Netossa refused to be separated, it had seemed like overkill to send *six* soldiers to the Waste.

(One of the bizarre traits of the Rebellion army was that, due to the unusually high individual combat prowess of most of their soldiers, a squad of a dozen was considered quite large; even the non-Princesses among them, like Bow, tended to be worth entire handfuls of normal troops.)

Mermista would have been better, but Catra's wish for her to tag along was shot down when Glimmer made the salient point that there was no *water* in the desert. Catra had conceded the issue with only mild grumbling, but a lot of hidden irritation; she hadn't had a chance to hang out with Mermista in forever.

...And maybe she wanted somebody to talk to. Her heart was too full, Catra had never expected to have her deepest wish fulfilled and now... now she wasn't sure how to handle it. An irony; she knew how to deal with pain, with loss, with fear, but when confronted with *happiness*, that terrible sweetness she first tasted in Brightmoon, she didn't know what to do. She wanted to cry when she thought of it, strange, hot, happy tears, and that was just... disconcerting.

...*Focus, Catra!*

-

Mara's ship was a treasure trove. Thank goodness that her gang- and that was still absurd to think about, that somehow she, Adora, had gotten in control of the Crimson Waste- had so many hands, and could pressgang so many *other* hands, into doing the work.

Here in the Valley of the Lost, the work proceeded apace, Horde soldiers and conscripted locals hauling boxes and boxes of technological goods out, and hauling explosive supplies in.

" So, uh, Adora," Lonnie asked, being the bravest of Adora's squad. " How come... ya know, we're just stealing stuff from this ship instead of just, uhh, taking it? We're putting a lot of bombs in it."

" Ship's useless," Adora opined, rubbing more anti-burn cream down her left arm. Whatever had happened in the false world, it had stayed with her; her arm was a mass of burns. She'd also lost some vision in her left eye, though that was barely noticeable compared to her arm. It still worked... but it *hurt*. " We can't fly it and don't have any use for the hull. We'll take the technological parts out and then the science team can get working on it."

The science team being a new thing Adora had come up with. Lonnie wasn't sure why Hordak hadn't done it beforehand; the idea was so simple and obvious that maybe he'd just overlooked it.

(Some part of her wondered if maybe Hordak hadn't wanted anyone *else* doing scientific research, for fear they'd eclipse him.)

The science team was the Horde's new research department. Adora had grabbed any Horde candidates and soldiers that were good at engineering and made them start studying what was left of Horde's lab, as well as getting them to work making robots and doing all the work Hordak would normally have done himself.

The science team wasn't precisely the pit of innovation and brilliance it had been when Entrapta and Hordak had been there... but it turned out that the work of one or two impossible shining stars of intelligence, while impressive, was not unreplicable by, say, fifty or so average people.

The Horde was badly behind in tech, but the longer the science team worked, the better they got; in three months, they'd made impressive leaps and bounds in understanding Hordak's technology; they'd finally gotten the automated systems that made more Entrapta-style bots working, quite a victory considering none of them could read her notes.

In another three months... who knew?

" How... how's the arm?" Lonnie asked.

“ It's fine,” Adora said, though her wince when she moved it put the lie to her words immediately.

“ If you say so,” Lonnie said, doubt in her words as, behind her, Kyle nearly tripped and died, Rogelio saving him from a self-inflicted fate at the last minute. “ Where'd you get burned, anyway? Far as I know, there's no such thing as a fire princess.”

“ Portal,” Adora said. “ Side-effect of activating it. Not... not sure why it's only hurt me.”

(Another lie. She remembered falling, remembered letting the light in, remembering **burning**)

“ Well, don't... don't strain yourself, okay? With Hordak dead, we need you now more than ever, Lady Adora,” Lonnie said. Adora laughed.

“ You guys just call me Adora,” she said. “ You're... you're my friends.”

Lonnie smiled at her, and punched her gently in the shoulder- in the good one, because Lonnie wasn't an asshole.

She got up and left, and Adora finished up medicating her arm, slipping back into her suit with ease.

She didn't look at Mara's ship.

(Soon, soon it'd be gone, and she wouldn't think about what she was, she wouldn't have a reminder that the First Ones would *hate* her for not living up to their legacy. Soon, soon, she could go back to pretending to be... anything else.)

-

One day into the trip, Huntara challenged her.

“ Hey, you getting soft on me, kitty cat?” she asked, in the friendly, spiteful way Huntara asked things of her friends. “ I think you are, all that living in Brightmoon.”

Catra laughed. “ Soft? I'll show you soft. Bet I can make it to the ship first.”

Then she tore off, Huntara laughing as she bounded off after her, Catra's mind on the race and not her own thoughts.

“ You're getting soft, kitty cat!” Huntara yelled as they ran, long legs catching up to her.

" Soft? Not as much as you, I saw you gorging on Brightmoon cake! Gonna be soft enough I could use you as a pillow!" Catra yelled back.

" Hah! Sorry, not my type, I like muscular girls, not skinny noodles! Got this bartender down here- wonder if she's still single..."

" I'm... okay, you got me there," Catra said, chuckling. " Skinny noodle outrunning you, though!"

She dropped to all fours, soon pulling ahead.

(She hadn't run like this since... since she was a kid, she'd cut off so much of her natural instincts to act like the others... but now, here under the sun... she felt comfortable in her own skin.)

" Four legs is cheating!" Huntara yelled with a laugh as she ran into the distance, trying to keep up.

" I don't understand any of that," Perfuma said to the others, as the rest of the group shook their heads at the distant figures of the two former-Horde. " I agree with Huntara about muscular girls, though. Something lovely about strong, feminine biceps. It's a bit shallow, I'm aware, and of course the person is always more important than their looks, but one likes what one likes."

“ I get that,” Bow said. “ My dad always jokes that Lance wasn't his type at first, because he hates long hair, so the person matters the most... but for what it's worth, I kinda like short girls, but I couldn't begin to pick apart why.”

“ We could also *not* discuss this,” Glimmer said, and Tung nodded his head vigorously.

“ Sorry, you mammals are super gross to me,” he said. “ I do *not* want to think about you guys in any context like that. All that flesh and hair is just... super weird. Ya'll look like walking hairy sausages.”

“ Dude, don't be racist,” Glimmer said.

“ It's not racist unless I hold it against you,” Tung argued, as the group finally began to catch up with their literal forerunners. “ I am an enlightened, civilized man, and therefore I do not care how incredibly, disturbingly ugly you are.”

“ I am going to shoot you,” Bow said, then stopped as the group topped the dune, and looked down on a whole lot of... nothing.

“ Uhh, the ship can't turn invisible, can it?” Huntara asked, as she and Catra panted with exertion.

“ No,” Catra said. “ I don't think so... Who would take it?”

“ I don't know,” Huntara said with salt in her voice, “ who *would* steal an ancient, incredibly valuable First One's ship loaded with tech?”

“ Sarcasm does not become you,” Catra said, turning her gaze on where the ship *should* be.

Dammit, Catra could not be sent on a mission without *something* going wrong.

(She hadn't even been able to visit Bow's *dads* without being attacked by a monster. What the hell?!?)

“ So, we gotta track it,” Huntara said. “ This'll take some doing. Bet I can find it before you, kitty cat.”

“ You're on!” Catra said, pointing at her nose. “ I can sniff out anything.”

“ Or we could follow the very obvious tracks,” Bow suggested as he slid down the hill, cutting short their next competition.

“ Don't be a smartass, Bow,” Catra said, and Glimmer cracked up behind her.

They follow the tracks while Tung asked the obvious question of why “smartass” was even a phrase- “ nobody thinks with their ass, that's not how it works!”- the long skid marks eventually leading them to...

“ The Valley of the Lost!” Huntara said with pride. “ A smuggler's haven. Used to do all kinds of business out here!”

“ Criminal business,” Tung Lashor added helpfully, and the two high-fived.

“ So Mara's ship is down there somewhere?” Glimmer said, ignoring the desert duo. “ We... probably don't want the Horde stealing anymore of it than they already have.”

“ Not sure what they're gonna do with it, though,” Bow said. “ Hordak's gone and so's Entrapta. Who's left to do tech work? Adora's not secretly a scientist, is she?”

“ No,” Catra said. “ She was pretty good at the basic stuff- the general engineering courses we were all taught- but that's just low-level maintenance stuff. Repairing tires, fixing wires, that kind of thing. All the *real* science was done by Hordak alone... unless he had that creepy imp thing helping. It wasn't until Entrapta showed up that he had any help, as far as I'm aware.”

“ Regardless, let's get the ship *back*,” Bow said. “ If Adora is a First One, then that means she might be able to use it regardless

of knowing much tech or not... and I don't want the Horde to use it as a new base.”

“ The last thing we need is the Horde to fly overhead and shoot us,” Glimmer agreed, and the group descended into the Valley, putting on some cloaks.

Above them, a figure watched, and blinked their doubled eyelids.

-

“ Hey, Adora,” Catra announced- but even as Adora was turning her hand towards her to cast a spell, she... shifted?

“ Apologies!” the new thing says. “ I wanted to play the starring role, just once, you understand the attraction dahling~.”

“ I... who *are* you?” Adora asked.

“ Name's Double Trouble,” the shapeshifter said with a smile. “ I am an actor, a thespian, a traveler of the stage! Also a spy. One must make a living and the acting arts fail us so often when it comes to making payment on time...”

“ What talents do you have?” Adora asked, as Double Trouble turned into Rogelio- and began speaking in Kyle's voice.

“ Why, I can do anything you need- for a price.”

Lonnie walked in, saw Rogelio talking like Kyle, and walked back out. Whatever her boss was doing with illusions was *not* her business.

“ What price?” Adora asked.

“ Knew I liked you!” they replied, all smiles and acting and... well, *lies*. This one was kin of hers....

Adora smiled. They might be useful.

-

The Valley of the Lost reminded Catra *way* too much of the Fright Zone, which was clearly not what it was supposed to do- Huntara and Tung Lashor, initially chatty, began to grow more and more concerned as they saw what had happened to their home.

The place was crawling with Horde soldiers and Horde bots- which looked *new*, which was a bit worrying, wasn't Hordak dead and

Entrapta in Dryll? Where were they getting *new* bots from?

Huntara in the lead, they made their way to what she told them was an old friend, a bearded warrior named Grox.

Grox hocked a loog of spit after hearing Huntara out, a spit that almost got Perfuma, who flailed out of the way.

The hair on the back of Catra's neck lifted of its own accord when Grox pulled out a horn, and midway through her speech about Huntara forgetting the one rule, Catra leaped forward and slapped the horn out of the woman's hand.

" Seriously?" Catra said, frowning. " Should have just blown the horn. Gonna betray somebody, gotta do it fast."

The bearded woman tried to attack with her metal claw, but Bow loosed a quick arrow that locked her gears up and stunned her.

" She tried to spit on you," Catra said to Perfuma, as the woman tried to fix her arm. " You want first punch?"

" Oh, I *shouldn't*," Perfuma said- then reared back with one skinny fist and, with a wild haymaker, laid the traitor out with one blow.

“ Oof!” the petal princess said, shaking her hand to get the sting out. “ Painful!”

“ Impressive,” Huntara said, nodding her head.

The mission proceeded apace after that, the group sneaking in. The Crimson Waste... Catra remembered it well from her first mission, from that strange vision of herself as Princess of this place...

But that was a different Crimson Waste and a different Catra. This Waste, and this Catra, suffered the Horde's attentions...

But not for long, if Catra had any say about it.

In an alley near the canyon holding Mara's ship, Catra and Huntara snuck close; when the time was right, they knocked out a pair of guards.

“ Not so soft, kittycat!” Huntara whispered to her, and Catra grinned. She liked Huntara, the big woman reminded her of Adora... before...

(the portal the light the terrible light)

Catra refocused herself as Glimmer teleported Tung Lashor behind a different squad, the duo laying them out quietly, sharing a quick

smile. They'd become fast friends over the desert walk, bonding over a mutual love of fisticuffs and violence, and they sent a thumbs-up to Catra with their job done.

" Okay, forward," Catra ordered, and Bow and Perfuma- who was rambling something about how much she hated cacti- went after the last group. Bow took his out quickly; Perfuma... exploded a cactus, which did no good but was *very* loud.

" Oh come on, flower girl!" Huntara yelled, as alarms rang over the camp.

-

Oh, this was going to be a *delightful* experience, Double Trouble could tell that already.

Catra- ferocious Catra, meow!- had stopped and stared when they first saw Double Trouble wearing Adora's skin, stared at the burned arm and the strange milkiness in her left eye. Oh, the *pain* on her face, the way love and rage and worry all warred with each other... ooh!

Double Trouble's delightfully triumphant decadent thrill when they saw that was almost payment enough for this job.

Almost.

They fought, and Double Trouble had to admit... watching the She-Ra transformation in person was fan-*tabulous!* It was a *little* overblown, but they supposed that if anything justified that outfit, being a superpowered Princess did.

Still, they weren't being paid to win... just to buy time for the bombs to go off.

-

Glimmer teleported inside Mara's ship as the fight raged on outside, mostly to make sure nobody from the Horde was inside. Perfuma and Huntara were beneath the ship, while Bow and Catra were busy fighting Adora- and oh, *First Ones*, Glimmer was *so sick* of fighting with her, she had spent three years battling the same person. They could at least switch it up, put Scorpia back on the frontlines or *something.*

(She wondered how sick *Catra* was, of fighting the girl she'd once loved- still loved, if Glimmer didn't miss her guess.)

She glanced around. No Horde... though a lot of boxes with Horde symbols on them.

Idly, she looked inside.

...Oh.

Glimmer was no tech expert, but the blinking and the ticking noises of these devices made their purpose... kind of clear.

Those were... a *lot* of explosives.

...Oh *shit.*

-

As Catra and Adora clashed, Glimmer began teleporting repeatedly, in and out of the ship, towards the canyon's end, throwing... boxes?

" Bombs!" she yelled. " Bombs on the ship, I'm clearing them out!"

" Ooh, ya caught me," Adora said, then winked at her with that milky, half-melted eye. " Shame... but maybe I'll still get one of you. The bombs are on a timer, and in just a few seconds-"

Catra turned, away from Adora, who took the opportunity to run away.

" Glimmer!" Catra yelled. " *Siste*r!"

But she was already gone in a blast of sparkles, back inside the ship.

-

Glimmer grabbed the last box of bombs, laughing. She was almost out of teleports, but she had two left- just two- one to toss this bomb box out and one to teleport away!

Simple enough.

She teleported out. She'd done it, she'd saved the ship!

" Hey guys!" she said as she popped out, holding up the last box. " I got the last-"

And then there was only pain and light.

-

" **Nooo!**" Catra screamed, as the bomb went off in Glimmer's hands.

Some reflex teleported the princess when the pain hit, but she was bleeding, torn, shrapnel in her- oh no, *Glimmer*, no-

(A lesson, she had healed once before, it worked on Shadow Weaver)

She put her hand to Glimmer's forehead, ragged with cuts, and she gleamed gold.

-

It was over after that. Double Trouble watched from a distance as the Princess of Power healed the sparkly one, large chunks of metal from the bomb blast pulling themselves out of her forehead, her ruined hands reknitting themselves, and a particularly fascinating chunk of metal was extracted from her neck- *that* would have been fatal, if DT didn't miss their guess, and given that they'd impersonated a healer for four years once, they were probably right.

Glimmer, hurt, lived, and there was a tearful reunion and blah blah, boring...

But the plant princess used the surge of golden energy to do something *incredible*. DT watched with interest as the flower girl, looking more like the soon-to-be-dead victim of a horror movie, herself became something horrifying- mother nature on a rampage, from desert walls she pulled green life. Great roots that

lifted the ship up, up, up, needing She-Ra only to wipe out a few stones, a task she accomplished with energy blasts generated by one-handed sword swings, while holding the sparkling girl in the other arm.

Fascinating. These princesses... every Etherian heard rumors, of course... but this was a *lot* of power, to see in person.

Hmm. Something to file away for later, perhaps.

DT crawled away, to speak to the woman who was their- current- boss.

-

Huntara couldn't help but be impressed by Perfuma. It was like standing in the presence of a goddess, to be near Perfuma when she was throwing so much power around. The idle thought occurs to Huntara that it was a good thing the floral fighter was so serene. In other hands, it would be horrifying to see; from the desert sand, green life, by Perfuma's will alone.

(Perfuma was the most terrifying of the Princesses, in her own way; some primal part in the back of every animal's brain knew it existed only at the suffering of the plantlife around it, and seeing Perfuma in action scared the hell out of it.)

Apparently she was even stronger because of She-Ra's presence, something the soft archer rambled on about as the group left with the ship. Something about unity, and working together, that made Princesses stronger. Bow had apparently been theorizing about it since they undid the freezing of the forest, an event Huntara knew nothing about but that he spoke of as something impressive; he talked further, something about how the First Ones had designed the system to be balanced out, greater than the sum of its parts.

Interesting stuff for others, Huntara supposed; meaningless to her. The mood is somber as the group returns, Glimmer not able to walk unassisted, Catra carrying her in her arms.

Huntara hated to add onto their burdens, but seeing the Horde treating her home like this... well.

She'd promised herself she'd stop running, back at Mara's ship the first time, when Tung had freed her. She didn't like breaking promises.

" Catra... I'm staying."

Catra turned to her, Glimmer in her arms. " I- what?"

" This is my home," Huntara said. " I know I joked about being the Princess of the Crimson Waste... but now, now I think maybe somebody *should* be. I think I've gone soft- not in Brightmoon, but long before, I think I've been soft in my spine for far too long.

I'm not running anymore. I'm going to kick the Horde out of the Waste, out of my home... and maybe I'll shape this place up a bit while I'm at it. Being betrayed by my goons, and then by Grox... we might be thieves and scoundrels, but there should be a code. You can have honor among thieves, and I'll punch anybody who disagrees with me.”

Tung chuckled. “ My thoughts exactly. Brightmoon... Brightmoon's got the right idea about some stuff. Not everything... but it's got gentleness and strength both. I want to live that way... teach others to live that way. 'll stay too. Every Princess needs a general.”

Huntara smirked. “ You sure you're okay taking orders from me? We were rivals, literally three months ago.”

Tung laughed. “ Been a long three months, I think I'm good.”

“ Well, if- if you're gonna be a princess,” Glimmer wavered, speaking up from Catra's arms, “ you got standards to uphold. Do your best, Huntara... and Tung? Watch over her for me. I'll be grading you harshly when you're done~”

She coughed, spat up a clot of blood from her throat; She-Ra's healing had pulled the shrapnel out, but some interior hurts still remained. Catra's ears flattened at the sound, her eyes following the spat of dark crimson as it slapped wetly on the burning sands.

The lizardman saluted with his whip. " You got it, spunky."

" Good luck," Bow said. " And whatever happens, don't hesitate to call on us. We'll be there when we can!"

" I am honored to acknowledge this fine desert rose as a fellow Princess!" Perfuma said with glee.

" Yeah," Catra said, subdued. " I... be careful. And thanks for everything, you two."

They nod and leave, and so too do the Best Friend Squad and Perfuma, heading home to Brightmoon.

-

That night, after a debriefing, Glimmer woke in her hospital bed to the feeling of something... shifting at her toes.

Groggily, she leaned her head up. In the soft glow of the moons in the dark, she saw only a large, lumpy furred thing, a silhouette she knew from long experience.

"...Catra?"

“ Hey,” said her sister, clumped at the foot of the bed. “ I... I was worried about you.”

Glimmer looked around herself- this was a private ward room, was in fact the original private ward Catra had stayed in, after she got so hurt in the Battle of Brightmoon. A gentle breeze blew in through a window Glimmer *knew* had been shut when she went to sleep.

“ Wait... did you climb in the window?”

“ Didn't want to bother the guards,” Catra whispered back. “ I... I didn't want anyone to think I was bothering you.”

“ You're not,” Glimmer said. “ How you feeling?”

“ Better than you,” Catra said. “ I didn't blow up.”

Glimmer chuffed a laugh, and immediately regretted it. “ My everything hurts,” she moaned.

Catra snuggled closer to her feet. “ Sleep. I'm watching over you.”

And that *was* comforting to know...

" Thank you," Glimmer said, and fell asleep with her sister at her feet, curled up.

(Angella would find them like that in the morning, Catra having fallen asleep during her self-appointed vigil, and the Queen would let her daughters rest.)

-

Adora looked over the robot before her, welding mask in place, carefully etching a glyph in its side with a small, handheld blowtorch. All around her were similar bots, most of which had glyphs carved on them already; Adora had been through what looked like four or five blowtorches already, working on this dozen or so robots in this Fright Zone warehouse.

" Want news on how it went?" said another Adora, standing nearby, wearing only a pair of shades for protection from the glare. That Adora looked at the bots the other Adora had worked on, saying nothing, but privately pondering if the Horde's new leader had even *slept* since she got back from the Crimson Waste. Judging by her work output, she hadn't...

" Yes, but please, be yourself," Adora replied, carefully putting a dot on the First One's sigil she was drawing. " I do love hearing myself talk, but if I didn't put a limit on it I'd drown in narcissism."

The other Adora laughed and shifted form, Double Trouble taking her place with their usual flair, even managing to keep the shades affixed.

" Ah, well, fun's fun and all- they got away with the ship, obviously."

" We stole most of what was in it," Adora said with a shrug. " The ship's just a hull. Only things we hadn't removed were the fuel crystals and food reserves- I was just going to leave those. The crystals were nearly melted into the engine room- not a lot of juice left- and the food... well, I'm assuming it went stale at *some* point in the last few centuries."

" Well, good to know that, because they've got the ship," DT said. " Your bombs went off, but they only got the shiny princess. She teleported most of them out but the last one... boom. Right in her hands."

" Oh, did she die?" Adora asked, flipping up her mask. " That would be incredibly helpful to us."

" No, she lived," the shapeshifter sighed. " She fell rather dramatically into Catra's arms- there was some yelling about, oh, what did she say..."

The shapeshifter turned into Catra. " *Sister!* Yes, that was the term she used."

“ Sister?...” Adora said, quirking an eyebrow. “ That's... odd. What happened after that?”

“ Some mystical magical glow, golden, and the princess with the tiny, useless, rather ugly angel wings lived. Honestly if I was her I'd get those cut off. Why advertise that the ugly duckling will never become a swan? Crippling self-doubt is so cliché. There are *much* more interesting psychological issues, don't you think?”

“ Wouldn't know,” Adora said, flipping her mask back down. “ Don't have any.”

(Unseen by her, the lizard-like changeling's grin grew terribly sharp, just for a second. This one... this one was going to be a *fun* role to learn.)

“ Well, at any rate, that's the scoop. Did I earn any *future* commissions, or are we a one-hit wonder, darling?”

“ Oh, you've earned it,” Adora said, as she finished up the last touches on the robot's sigil. “ You bought me time to come back home and work on an idea I had. If you're willing, we can continue this working relationship.”

“ Love to~, darling. Though... might I ask *why* you are busily tattooing a robot? Not that I'm judging, everyone needs a hobby.”

Adora laughed. " Okay, you're pretty funny. I'm not paying extra for amusement, but that's not bad. Tattooing a robot. Heh."

She stood up and backed away from the robot, lifting her mask. She drew a symbol of light in the air with her burned hand, aimed at the bot, concentrating through the slight blur that now marred her left eye.

" I don't know anything about tech- but I *do* know a lot about magic, these days. It's all symbols and language... and I wrote on the robot the word for *lie.* This is the word for *sight...*"

She whispered her spell, and the bot... disappeared.

Double Trouble cocked their head, and Adora grinned.

" Can't improve the bots the technological way... so I'm improving them in another. And I've got other ideas, too..."

Double Trouble looked around, a keen eye for detail telling them that not *all* the bots had the same glyphs. " What do these other symbols say?"

Adora held up her scarred arm.

" That one means *burn*."

The shapeshifter quirked an eyebrow as Adora broke out into a fit of strange laughter.

(*What in the world did I sign myself up for?* They thought, with excitement and trepidation both. This would need a delicate touch...)

-

Glimmer slept fitfully, feeling a bit bored when awake but not in any condition to *do* anything.

Catra and Bow had taken off that morning. Elberon had been attacked and all available forces were busy; Catra had volunteered though Angella knew she wanted to stay with Glimmer.

Glimmer had pushed her to go. She'd recover just fine, with Catra watching over her or not, though she had to admit it was comforting to have her around, or curled up at her feet. Like a living security blanket.

So Catra had taken off with Swift Wind and Bow, and left Glimmer a trackerpad so she could hassle them whenever she felt like it, which she was mostly determined *not* to do...

But she really *was* bored when she was awake. Thankfully, she was so tired that sleep came easy, and the sleep wasn't bad, though the painkiller they'd put her on gave her... odd dreams.

(The world of the portal... a world that never was, but Glimmer suspected that memories of it would be with her until the day she died.)

From one such odd dream, she awoke, to find someone looming over her bed, a familiar someone in a bug-eyed welding mask with Horde insignia wrapped around one arm.

" Greetings, Princess Glimmer," Entrapta said, lowering herself closer, entire body tucked away in a single long mass of her hair, her body raised up like a viper about to strike. " How would you like to destroy the Horde?"

...What?

" Shouldn't you be asking Catra or my mom about this?" Glimmer asked. " I... my entire body aches, Entrapta, I'm not really in the best of places right now."

" Oh, no, but you will be," Entrapta replied. " You'll heal. You'll recover. And then... then you will be in the perfect position to do what I need you to do. In the perfect position to do it in secret, so no one finds out."

“ Why would I do any of that, whatever it is?” Glimmer asked. Entrapta cocked her head to the side, and leaned down low, close to her.

“ Shadow Weaver told me to tell you, if you asked why... that you should help, because Micah's daughter deserved to be more than just Catra's sidekick. That you were worthy of being *more.*”

A surge of emotion through Glimmer, so strong even she couldn't parse everything those words made her feel.

(Give the old witch credit; give her a single button to push, and she could write you a symphony.)

“ Get out,” Glimmer growled at her.

“ She told me you'd say that, too,” Entrapta answered, almost... cheerfully. “ Bring tiny food to Dryll when you're ready to talk.”

And then she slithered out, and Glimmer was left alone with all *kinds* of thoughts flickering through her head.

Chapter End Notes

More changes, more and more...

Remember to leave a review!

Chapter 3: Adora of the Horde

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora of the Horde

Somewhere, in the deepest parts of space, a thing that bore many titles- and whose true name was *Monster*- saw the flash of a distress signal on his console, sent by one he had thought long-since dead.

The signal lasted only for a few seconds, then went silent. Almost a mechanical hiccup, the computer equivalent of a sneeze. Nothing important.

The thing's servants, though, they all hyperfocused on that little blip. After all, their master had considered it, was *still* considering it, and so his servants held their breath, and all the universe about him was silent.

The silence stretched, in that terrible place, none of his servants daring to be first to disturb the peace in the presence of their god, waiting for his judgment, the smartest among them wondering what the signal had been, to be worthy of his consideration for so many long moments.

After that period of quiet, the light of the universe dismissed it as a glitch; an electronic hallucination, and turned his attention to other matters. Reality let out its long-held breath, and the servants resumed their usual work.

But... idly, as a just-in-case measure... he put one of his many servants to the task of watching the area of space the signal had come from, to tell him if anything else should change.

And then the great and terrible lord sat back in his throne, and thought of it no more... for a time.

-

Adora tossed and turned in her bed.

Shadow Weaver's fingers, cold at her temple. Scrambling her mind. Couldn't trust her thoughts, couldn't trust anything cold and dark, it might be hers, it might be hers.

But the burning rage in her heart- the hot hellhound thing inside- her anger. She could trust that. Shadow Weaver was cold and dark, this was hot and bright; she would not have put it in Adora's heart.

So Adora wallowed in it, fed the beast inside, let her grow fat and strong. She gave it a meal of every hateful thing in her heart,

everything she hated, let it chew on those bitter bones.

Catra, proving she was so strong in Light Hope's castle, she didn't need Adora anymore, so she threw her away.

(Inside, from the dark, a cold voice whispering the truth: *you were the one who walked away, Adora*.)

Scorpia's smiling face and easy trust, Entrapta's manic brilliance, neither of them understanding her pain, neither caring to *try*.

(Still that voice inside, cold and dark and wise: *you never let them in, Adora.*)

Shadow Weaver, who had hurt her so much, who had made her into this, with her cold touches and colder training.

(*She has not been here in months*, whispered the thing that was kin of Shadow Weaver's... but wasn't *quite* her, lacked the sadism, and in turn had gained wisdom. Whatever this cold, dark thing was, it *wasn't* her adoptive mother. *She is in Brightmoon now; these are your own actions.*)

Catra, telling her the truth about herself, about... about what she *really* was.

(*And offering you a second chance, Adora.*)

The whispers of the cold, hard truth burned away in the crackle of fire, Adora turning to the blaze of her delusions and her hate and oh, of *course*, she could see it now. She turned in her dream and

there it was, the thing that drove her, it sat amidst a burst of flames hot and bright as the sun and she wept for joy to see it.

It was a great hellhound- of course it was, she was Catra's opposite, right?- dozens of feet tall, and around its neck was a spiked collar that bore the name *Revenge*- but both sides of the collar were spiked, outward *and* in, and the great beast bled lava from its terrible wounds.

Revenge for my hurts, Adora thought in the dream. *Revenge on Catra for abandoning me. Revenge on Shadow Weaver for lying to me, all these years. It hurts me, but everything hurts, who cared?*

Revenge on the universe, for making her a First One, and only telling her when it was too late.

(*I'm sorry*)

She looked up, past the collar, and the hellhound had not a dog's face, but her own, and its eyes were blazing pools of hellfire.

It smiled at her, and she smiled back, and when it opened its mouth fire burst out and burned her to ashes and dust.

Adora woke up with a start, to the cool touch of Lonnie's hand.

" Adora?" Lonnie asked. Adora struggled upward, the dream still on her, shedding it slowly as she came to full wakefulness.

" I... what time is it?" Adora asked, trying desperately to cover for her sweating face, her shivering hands, blinking three times before she remembered that the blurriness in her left eye was there to stay.

Why had some piece of that other place come with her? She didn't know anyone else who kept echoes of the portal world with them. Whatever spell she'd cast when she fell in... it had carried, her wounds had attached to her magic and hitched a ride back to reality on it.

If she had used no magic, it would not have come with her- so this was just punishment for her actions, for her sins. Why not? She belonged to a race of angels, after all- and now, she was marked, her status as a fallen angel and a demon has cursed her. Her wings are the broken cinders of the glorious things they should have been, burned up in the hellfire of her deeds.

" Adora!" Lonnie snapped. " Come on, snap out of it!"

Adora blinked. Had she drifted off again...? *Pull it together.*

" Sorry," she said, and threw on a jittery smile for one of the few people in the world she could still call friend... though she kept

turning her face away from her. " I... sorry. Been pulling too many late nights."

Usually that would let her pass without comment; but tonight, Lonnie turned hard and worried eyes on her.

" Adora," she said, quietly, " after all that's happened, morale's at an all-time low. Hordak's *dead*. The Horde was never built to deal with something like that happening. Desertions are skyrocketing, and I can't blame them."

" I... it has?" Adora asked. She... thought she'd seen a report about it, but she'd been focused on the next plan, on robots and Double Trouble and blowing up the fucking ship where her life was ruined.

(*You're a First One.* How can four words hurt her so much? No wonder she'd pulled the switch; the end of the world meant nothing to Adora. Her world had ended when those four words were said to her.)

Lonnie nodded. " You'd know if you'd read our reports. Me and Rogelio and, hell, *Kyle* are keeping it together- did you know Kyle's got a real dab hand at discipline? Apparently all that resentment built up over the years, we've been turning the deserters and rulebreakers we catch over to him and he's had some *creative* ideas. People are getting scared to be turned over to him now."

...What happened to Adora's life, that *Kyle* came to be regarded as a figure of fear? " I... am surprised," Adora admitted, and Lonnie chuckled.

" Fuck, me too," she admitted. " Almost as surprised as him confessing to Rogelio and them *finally* getting somewhere with that relationship of theirs..."

Adora found it in her to smile; that was good news. Kyle had danced around it for years, despite Rogelio's open affection for him. " Good."

Lonnie nodded, smiling back... but then it faded, replaced with grim seriousness. " Yeah. But even that was born of desperation; Kyle told him because he thought he wouldn't get another chance, Adora. It's all falling apart. Hordak's dead, we've got no Shadow Weaver, no princess- we're just ordinary people, Adora. We're the world's only hope of law and order, of a world that makes *sense,* where your average person isn't held to the whims of *children.* You see that ice princess? She's what, ten? Maybe? But she's a living ice age, she rules an entire Kingdom, all because she's got magic no one can match. It's not natural, it's not *right*."

Lonnie shook her head. " We're the common man, Adora. We're just people. We're fighting for our right to exist... and to free the planet from its tyrants. A nobel goal... but we're straining to strike at the unarmored heels of living gods. We're fighting war goddesses and freaks and monsters, tech geniuses and ancient hardware and mages... and we're just people, Adora. All we've got is numbers and whatever the science guys can come up with from all that tech crap we stole... and you. Faith in you is the only reason the whole thing's not already fallen apart."

It was a beautiful speech. If Adora didn't know the truth about the Horde- about this rapacious thing she was part of, if she didn't know it was Evil- she might have believed it. Lonnie, apparently, had never come to the realization Adora had... but then again, she'd never had a Catra, to throw it into such stark relief. Lonnie was giving the viewpoint of the average Hordesman...

But Adora knew what she was, and what the Horde was... so she focused on the last part of Lonnie's words.

" Faith... in me?" Adora said, turning to look at her friend fully.

" We all know your story," Lonnie said. " The guys you brought back from the Waste? They've been preaching to everyone who'll listen, and now some of the other Hordesmen are telling stories too."

Her tone shifted, quicker and faster, mimicking the storytellers she'd heard. " Did ya hear? Adora, who walked into the desert with four soldiers and came back at the head of an army! Adora, who was raised right here in the Fright Zone, just like any other Hordesman. Adora, she's got magic, she'll save us all!"

" That's how they talk about me?" Adora asked, and Lonnie nodded her head, returning to her normal voice.

“ It's why I came up here so early,” Lonnie admitted. “ I wanted to talk to you about this, early, before you did anything today. Sorry about coming in early- heard you having a nightmare, figured you'd want to be woken up.”

A nightmare?... but the dream had been so lovely.

Adora shook it off. “ Thank you.”

Lonnie shrugged. “ No problem. Back to the matter at hand... Adora... they're primed to follow you, and we need it. We need *you.* But what we *don't* need is you at half power, at ten percent, at... *whatever* this is, jumping at ghosts and drifting off. You... you keep losing yourself, and losing *time*, we've covered but you keep falling back into yourself... you... I don't know *what* you need. I'm just a soldier, Adora, and it's all I'll ever be.”

That's entirely wrong, Adora thought, as Lonnie built up steam, and Adora's heart was tugged along despite itself. It was incredible to watch; who knew Lonnie had it in her, to be so inspiring? *You're a good Force Captain, Lonnie.*

“ But you... you inspire the troops. I can be your second in command, I can keep the machine running... but we need a leader. You're in control of an army of teenagers and a few scattered adults, Adora. We've lost a lot of people, most of the older ones are gone, ran off when Hordak died- save the old guys in your new science lab. That's it. The Horde is getting reborn, or it's dying; your choice. Rise to the occasion, or fall.”

Lonnie sighed. " It's a shit situation you're in. It's just you and a youngster's mob... and us. We need you, Adora. Please, fight back whatever this is... we don't even have a title for you, Adora, but you're our new Hordak, for whatever that's worth. And we need you."

...They did, didn't they? The Horde suffered without order. Order seemed so... *endemic* to the efforts of abomination... the Alliance seemed to do well with its chaotic, devil-may-care attitude... but the Horde needed something else.

Adora didn't know if she could give it to them.

" Adora, fuck, you're doing it again!" Lonnie said. Adora blinked.

" I... Lonnie, I don't know if I *can*," she told her friend, finally turning her face to her fully.

" I've got suggestions, if you're willing to hear me out," Lonnie said.

Adora shrugged weakly. " Can't... can't be worse than nothing.

" Okay," Lonnie said... but she didn't immediately continue. She seemed... hesitant, clenched her hands a few times before

continuing. " Adora... I know you don't want anyone knowing, though I can't imagine *why*. I... what you found out on the ship. We were there, Adora."

Lonnie sighed, and said the thing Adora hoped she would not.

" I think you should tell them what you are."

Adora swallowed heavily.

" What do you mean?" Adora said, and the expert liar was caught out, her voice too high-pitched, Lonnie *couldn't* know...

" You and Catra weren't being quiet," Lonnie said. " Hell, you walked out and told everyone your people made the Sword. I've kept it tamped down, because it hurts you so much... but Adora, I know. You're a *First One.*"

Adora flinched. The four words that had ruined her. She'd heard, once, that for every person there existed a sentence that could destroy them- and she was one of the lucky few to *hear* that sentence, who got to know what exact sequence of words would ruin their lives.

" Adora, it's not something to be *ashamed* of," Lonnie said. " It's a gift! This is what we need! We can sell it- Hordak's hand-picked

successor, the last of the First Ones, raised right here in the Fright Zone. Adora, this could do *wonders* for morale!”

“ Lonnie...” Adora began... but now she was stuck. What was she supposed to say? She was a liar, and the truth was an unfamiliar thing in her mouth, it slipped off her tongue and fell right to the floor.

What was she supposed to say? *Lonnie, the Horde is evil, we're the bad guys. We've always been the bad guys. All that shit you just said was propaganda. We're monsters, and only Catra ever had the decency to figure it out... only Catra amongst us was ever good. Maybe that's why Shadow Weaver was so hard on her... the rest of us were evil, too, but Catra was good... Maybe the old wraith could sense it.*

If she did that... Lonnie would break. She could see it, now that she bothered to look at her; Lonnie wasn't trying to convince her just because the *Horde* needed it.

She was trying to convince Adora because *Lonnie* needed it.

Lonnie, raised all her life to be a soldier, was *proud* to be a soldier- she didn't even have the distractions of others, Lonnie had no interest in relationships. Her one goal in life had been to be a Horde officer, a Force Captain... and now the Horde was breaking. She *had* to save it. Her hands trembled, just the smallest bit, and her eyes were a bit too wide... *scared*.

Lonnie was scared.

What a thought. Lonnie had *never* been afraid. Even now, with the end of her world before her, Lonnie was showing only the smallest signs of fear...

Because she's putting all her faith in me, Adora thought. Lonnie was holding off a full-blown panic attack because she had Adora to hang all her hopes on.

Shifting sands to build a home on, Adora thought, with something like self-hating amusement... but...

These were her people. She... she owed them something... her Horde upbringing, a value instilled before all others, that some part of her still believed in.

The Horde demands you do your duty, whatever that is.

No one could give Adora orders... but that didn't mean she didn't have a *duty*. She had a duty to these people... and yes, they were monsters, but so was Adora, who was she to judge? These were her people.

She'd had that thought on Mara's ship, looking at the savages and thugs and bandits she'd allied herself with... but be they savages and thugs and bandits, they were still *hers*. And... and there were

others here, the more normal Hordesmen, like she had once been, lied to and manipulated- like Lonnie, who was looking at her and hoping against hope she'd pull it together.

...Adora was a monster. She had to accept that. There was no turning back after pulling the switch... there was no turning back after burning that village, and killing those innocents. She has been on a one-way street for a long, long time.

But... she had planned to be a *compassionate* monster once already, hadn't she? When they'd been in the cold, and they'd found those shards that drove Catra berserk. She'd planned to keep Catra as her hostage, as her... her...

Oh, for fuck's sake, admit it, Adora, she grumbled at herself. She was going to keep Catra as a lover, she could admit that, after kissing her, cutting herself on her, her tongue still had the scars. She was going to be good to her; not a prisoner, not a slave. A guest, honored, beloved, she would be... she would be taken *care* of, the first care anyone in the Horde had ever taken with Catra.

She was going to be good to Catra... before... before that dream fell apart in her own hands, because of Scorpia.

(At least she was on Beast Island, Adora thought with a wicked spark of joy. A fitting punishment, for stealing her happy ending from her... even if she *had* done it to save her life.)

...She could be good to the Horde, too, couldn't she? She was angry with so many people... but none of them were in the Horde

now. Shadow Weaver in Brightmoon, Catra in Brightmoon, the universe wasn't something she could revenge herself on in practical terms...

Not by herself, at any rate. The Horde, the Horde was her weapon; she'd known that, once. Before the ship. Before *you're a First One.* Before the words that seared the inside of her skull, that made her want to puke and apologize to the shadows in her head for all her sins, that made her realize just how *vile* she really was. She was meant to be a shining star, not this pit of blackness...

(*Some part of you knew beforehand*, came that cold, dark voice. *You love Catra still, Adora.*)

Adora shook off the dark and cold. She... she wanted a lot of things... but she needed the Horde to get them. She... she had to *focus.* She wanted *vengeance*... and only the Horde was a weapon big enough to kill all her enemies, to make them *hurt*. She wanted everyone to suffer for her pain, she wanted the fire inside her heart to set the world ablaze.

Once upon a time, she'd planned to be Catra's worst enemy; now, three years later, it was time to make good on that promise. The portal was an abberation; born of her sudden, terrible understanding, a *mistake* she'd made.

She... she could move past it. She *could*.

She clenched her unharmed fist.

“ You're doing it again, despite everything,” Lonnie said next to her, quiet and despairing, a tone she'd never heard out of Lonnie before. “ You just... went away, again.”

“ No,” Adora replied, letting this odd new feeling, this sense of... *responsibility*, settle on her skin. “ I was *thinking*.”

Lonnie's face lit up with something like hope, and inside Adora, some ember of *compassion* began to burn again.

Lonnie shouldn't look like that. Her friend, who *wanted* this, *needed* it, so badly, shouldn't hurt so much.

Adora had planned to be good to Catra, if no one else; maybe she could good to the Horde, if nothing else.

(She could not conceive of gray, her mind so set in binary paths that she could see things only in terms of purest Good and purest Evil... but she was approaching it, sideways, her empathy and friendship with Lonnie urging her to do something good despite her own beliefs.)

“ This is top priority now,” Adora growled. “ I'm leaving for the mission in Elberon, but the *second* I'm back, I want me, you, Kyle and Rogelio sitting down, and we're going to pull a *miracle* out of our collective asses. What's the point of being a First One if I can't do something amazing?”

“ That's right!” Lonnie said, and smiled, as Adora came back to herself. “ Damn right!”

Adora nodded. She... she could still feel the... *strangeness* inside, the place where four words had split her soul in half. The fracture points had been there already, but the sentence had been a sledgehammer that shattered her... and it was still there. Always would be.

But for now, she could slap a bandaid on the wound, and get her ass *moving*.

“ First, real quick- is the Elberon plan ready to go?”

Lonnie frowned.

“ That shapeshifter's ready,” Lonnie said, the straightforward soldier having not much liked Double Trouble. Rogelio, of all people, liked DT, but nobody else had.

“ Okay,” Adora said. “ Let's go tell Kyle and Rogelio that we need to meet later, then I'll take off to Elberon. Meeting starts as soon as I'm back.”

“ Glad to see you back, Adora,” Lonnie said, and her grin was almost infectious, so obvious was her relief.

As Adora got up out of the bed, she grinned back.

“ Thank you, Lonnie. It's good to *be* back. Now wait outside- I'll be right out.”

Lonnie nodded and headed out the door. Adora slipped from nightclothes into her white shirt, her red jacket... wincing as the burns on her left arm rubbed against the fabric. Sensitive today. She grabbed a bottle of ointment before she left, applying it even as she left her room.

“ Let's go find them,” she said to Lonnie, who saluted her with a smile.

They found the duo together, in more than the relationship sense; they were in one of the old barracks. Kyle was in the middle of disciplining a group of would-be runaways; with Rogelio standing next to him, he was having them take turns shoving each other into lockers, wielding a stun baton on anyone who hesitated.

“ Really?” Adora said when she saw it, and Lonnie shrugged.

“ He swears by it,” she replied.

“ Discipline will be maintained!” Kyle announced cheerfully as he whacked one of the slackers with the stun baton. “ I said shove your friend in the locker! Shove him!”

Rogelio sighed.

-

“ Well, that... was easy,” Bow said, as he finishing restringing his bow. “ Even by Horde standards, those were some *seriously* unfaithful troops.”

“ Morale's probably shit with Hordak dead,” Catra opined. “ I mean, he *built* the Horde, and now he's gone- the country wasn't designed to exist without him. The possibility wasn't even accounted for, I don't think.”

“ Which is great for us!” Swift Wind announced, right as the trackerpad beeped.

“ That'd be Glimmer,” Bow said, popping it out. “ Oh, hey, Glimmer!”

“ *Uhghghghghghghhgh*.”

“ That was impressive,” Catra noted, with some respect. “ You were reaching Mermista levels of disgusted, exhausted, *and* bored, all at once.”

“ I cannot *describe* how bored I am-”

“ Well, at least your friends left you this lovely trackerpad so you could call them!” came Angella's bright voice, the angel leaning down so she could be seen on the viewscreen. “ I do love these things. I was so sad when we lost the technology.”

“ Hello, your Majesty,” Bow said, while Catra grinned at the screen.

“ Hi, mom,” she said, a little more quietly than one might have expected. Her tail thrashed, happy, her ears perked up and swiveled to catch all of Angella's words.

(It was still too big to say all that loudly. Too big, too happy, too full of the terrible sweetness that has been Catra's reward for doing the right thing, all the long years of this dragging, endless war.)

“ Hello, dearies,” Angella said, waving one delicate gloved hand at them.

“ Wait, when did that happen?” Glimmer asked her mom, interrupting the hello's. “ What do you mean, *lost* the technology? How do you lose an entire knowledge base?”

“ Fire Princess,” Angella said with a shrug. “ When she, well, effectively exploded, there were many side-effects. Some of the knock-on results included obliterating major technological areas that had survived the First Ones' retreat from our world. Add on Plumerian aggressiveness in the aftermath wiping out some of the last of the engineer-guilds, and, well, that was basically it. Up until roughly a hundred years ago, no one had managed to re-learn the technology. I was *delighted* when they started showing up again.”

“ There was a Fire Princess?” Catra asked.

“ Yeah,” Glimmer said, a little smug. “ Mom told me about it, she apparently made a break for godhood that didn't work out so well- so not all the Horde's stories about evil princesses were totally lies, I guess!”

“ Wait, you said she exploded,” Bow said. “ Like, literally, or-”

“ Moving on,” Angella said, “ how did your mission go?”

“ It went great!” Catra said, as Bow looked mildly horrified next to her, pondering Angella's words. “ The Horde's badly demoralized. They fled Elberon without much resistance. We even captured a bot for Entrapta to look at!”

The bot protested with a beep from behind them.

" Though it was all jittery and... weird," Swift Wind stated, a bit lamely. " Sorry for not having a better way to say it."

" He's right," Catra said, backing up her bond partner. " The bots we faced this time were twitchy, sometimes they'd just... *do* stuff, almost like they were alive. They weren't doing the "relentless drone army" thing they did when Entrapta was making them, they were acting a lot more randomly."

" That's... new," Glimmer said. Angella frowned.

" *New* on the battlefield almost always gets someone hurt or killed. Be careful, okay?"

" Yes, mom," Catra said, and her heart laughed, and danced a beautiful rondo.

" Yes, your Majesty," Bow said.

" Didn't you say the battle was over?" Glimmer said.

“ Yeah,” Bow answered.

“ Why aren't ya'll on your way back then?”

Catra paused, then snickered. “ *Ya'll?*”

Glimmer groaned as Angella laughed. “ One of the nurses is from an outlying town, his accent is *infecting* me, I'm going to turn into a hillbilly if he keeps tending me.”

“ I think it's pretty funny,” Angella admitted, and her daughter bore her amusement with dignified disgruntlement that delighted Catra to see; they really *had* started repairing their bond, six months ago they would never have managed anything like this.

(The green thing in Catra's chest clutched. Being declared Angella's daughter should have soothed this savage thing, but somehow, it had made it *grow* instead, she... she was so *jealous* it *sickened* her, she was so ashamed of this greedy grasping thing in her heart... it was why she'd stayed with Glimmer when she was hurt, trying to assuage the guilt she felt, trying to quiet this ugly thing in her heart.)

“ At any rate, yokelisms aside, the question stands- what are you guys doing?”

“ Elberon's throwing us a party!” Swift Wind said. “ Never had a victory party before! Well, not one that wasn't thrown at

Brightmoon.”

“ The Horde's hand must have been pretty light on them to throw a banquet so soon after their release,” Angella opined.

“ Makes sense. They only got taken over a few months ago, and that was right when Hordak died,” Catra said. “ The local Horde probably didn't know what to do and was waiting for orders before they started oppressing the locals... orders they didn't get, because we showed up and started punching guys out.”

“ I kicked them!”

“ Indeed you did,” Catra said, scratching behind Swift Wind's ears.

“ Ah, yes, hands, the only reason to allow a rider,” he said, as she reached an itch no hoof could ever scratch.

“ You *would* free a town that throws parties the one time I'm too exploded to participate,” Glimmer complained, but her tone was light and teasing. “ Feel free to participate, but just know that I will *absolutely* hold this against you for an unreasonably long period of time.”

“ Duly noted,” Bow said dryly. “ Kind of you to warn us.”

“ I was feeling benevolent today,” Glimmer said. Angella chuckled and Catra rolled her eyes as the Best Friend Squad Minus One reached the doors of Elberon's town hall.

“ Anyway, we're here, so we're going to jump off. We won't stay too long- just long enough to see everybody,” Catra said. “ Maybe... maybe eat some stuff, I'm kinda hungry.”

“ I wish to have a statue,” Swift Wind announced. “ Horses never get statues, unless some dude's riding us. Unfair, says I! Horses demand statue equality!”

“ Well, good luck dealing with the locale equine revolutionary,” Glimmer said. “ See ya, sis! Bow, keep them alive, please? She's family, and the horse is her fault and responsibility both.”

“ I will,” Bow said, as Swift Wind rambled something about statue poses and horse legs while Catra put hand to forehead.

“ Be good, all of you,” Angella said.

“ We will be,” Catra said. “ We'll be back soon- we won't stay too long at the party.”

“ See you later,” Glimmer said, and switched the comms off.

Catra and Bow opened the doors- and it turned out *everyone in Elberon* was in attendance. Mothfolk ran about lighting candles, hanging up banners, or even messing around on abandoned Horde equipment.

" It's a party, alright!" Catra said, smiling as she looked at the revelers.

" First Ones," Bow said with awe. " It's a party for us!"

" It's a *big* party!" Catra said, nose twitching as she took in all the smells, ears swiveling to catch all the sounds.

" It's a *big* party... for *us!*"

" We could stay a little while," Catra said, tail lashing just a little. " I mean, not *too* long, but it'd be rude to dismiss the party entirely..."

" Oh, so good to see you!" the mayor said. " At this enormous, very attention-grabbing, incredibly conspicuous party that's painting a giant target on all of our backs!"

Catra wanted to agree with her, but then she saw it.

“ Bow! There's a *me* cake! I don't even like cake, but there's a *me* cake!”

“ Whoooooa!”

And thus the trio promptly forgot about not spending too much time at the party.

There were magic tricks from Bow, impressing the locals, kids and adults alike. A very buff woman picked Catra up and hugged her, which she acquiesced to- once. She wasn't particularly attracted to muscles.

(Unless they were Adora's. Other people had a type; Catra had a *person*.)

Swift Wind got adored by everyone, and had flower things put in his hair. Catra rubbed the vast mane of her own and wondered what she'd look like with a shorter cut... but ehh. She'd had this hairstyle too long to change it. Somebody else would have to cut it off her to get her to have a new haircut.

And Catra- Catra got to show off, to an adoring crowd, who thought everything she did was perfect.

(Somewhere inside, the desperate, feral child, never loved by its mother, clutched tight all the adoration she was receiving. Three years in Brightmoon had healed Catra of much of her spiritual wounds, and her adoption had made that healing permanent...

but some part of her would always be that little girl, hiding from the dark, hungry for even the smallest scrap of love.)

She lifted benches, flexed her muscles, and generally just showed off... right up until the point that one particularly pink example of mothfolk ran over, and Catra met, for the first time, her absolute biggest fan.

" Oh-my-stars-and-by-the-moons-you're-SHE-RA-oh-myyyyyyyyy-goooooosh!"

Catra blinked as the little one spun a literal circle around her, twirling as she did so. The short girl's energy blasted her more ferociously than any tank shell ever had; the mothfolk *jittered* in place like a jackhammer that had taken a lethal dose of caffeine. She was also *intensely* pink, pink on a level Catra hadn't known existed until this moment- and given that Catra was part of the *Princess Alliance*, that was saying something.

" I'm Flutterina-I'm-a-Lunoth-I-mean-we're-all-Lunoths-here-but-you're-SHE-RA!"

" Yes, I am," Catra said, the usually smooth, silver-tongued warrior so overwhelmed she couldn't think of a better response.

" *Maybe* slow down, Flutterina," the mayor said, approaching She-Ra in her time of distress, the mayor having recovered from her

panic over the confetti cannons. " You can be a bit overwhelming when you go full speed."

" Sorry-sorry, sorry!" the girl said, drawing herself back in with obvious, visible effort. " I... I am really fast. Sorry. I get excited."

" It's alright," the mayor said, putting a gentle hand on the girl. " Some Lunoths are high-strung by nature, like myself, but Flutterina's in a category all her own. It's practically a superpower!"

The little girl nodded, fast and rapid. " I'm super fast! Healer said it was because I have no psychological barriers and so I commit-myself-a-hundred-percent plus-my-nerves-are-firing-all-the-time! Trauma related, he said! I took up running because I really needed to burn off the excess energy and also-sometimes-I-bothered-the-other-kids-and-they-tried-to-beat-me-up but I outran them and so I haven't been punched in years! I wanna join the Rebellion!"

" Flutterina, I'm afraid you're bothering our guest," the mayor said gently, but Catra- who'd finally caught up with some of what the small one was saying- turned her words over in her head.

Catra hunkered down, got on Flutterina's eye level. " The other kids beat you up?" she asked. Flutterina shook her head.

“ Not anymore, and even back in the day, only if they could catch me, and I'm-super-fast!”

“ That's mostly stopped,” the mayor said. “ Flutterina didn't always act appropriately, and the other children didn't always react appropriately, but we found a way to make things work. We're a small community, especially since your people were taken, so we try to keep things peaceful here.”

“ My... people?” Catra said, turning her head.

“ Yes, the magicats,” the mayor said. “ We Lunoths have always followed the Moonstone; your people preferred the Black Garnet, but we knew each other in the past.”

“ I... we need to talk, later,” Catra said to her. Magicat?... she vaguely recalled Shadow Weaver having said that once... but she knew nothing more. It hadn't even occurred to her to wonder about her own species up to this point, she'd never *seen* another one of her kind... and in the last three years she'd had the war and Brightmoon and Angella (*mother*) to think about. Shadow Weaver had also mentioned something about... Thundera? Thundarr? Something, that just tickled the back of Catra's mind, and was gone.

The mayor nodded.

“ Are you a magicat? I've-heard-stories-about-them! Can you turn into a panther?” Flutterina asked her.

“ Not that I'm aware of,” Catra said. “ And I mean, I'm *mostly* a cat right now, I'm not sure going full panther would change much? Except I'd lose my hands. Not sure how I'd wield the sword in that state.”

Flutterina giggled. “ Put it right in your teeth! Hack-growl-slash! Like a pirate! Oooh, you'd be a pirate panther!”

Catra laughed with her at the mental image, while idly, her mind thought *Pirate Panther*... *that would be an* ***excellent*** *band name.*

“ You know, small one,” Catra said, not sure why she was spending so much time on this kid, “ I used to get beaten up by other kids, too.”

Flutterina gasped. “ No! But-you're-She-Ra! Who would dare?!?”

“ I wasn't always She-Ra,” Catra said. “ For a long time, I was just a kid nobody much liked. Some of it was my fault; I was kind of a jerk... but a lot of it was their fault, too.”

Flutterina's eyes were wide, and had little tears at their corners. “ What did you do?”

“ I escaped,” Catra said. “ I had one friend- just one. She helped me. I got out... and I turned out to be She-Ra. The Sword was waiting for me; once I got out, it found me, and the rest... the rest is history.”

“ Yeah, the *coolest* history!” Flutterina said, giving her a smile was so wide that Catra couldn't help but smile back.

Kid's so honest, Catra thought. *Kind of person you just trust, instinctively... despite all that pink.*

“ Wanna go hang some banners with me?” Catra offered gently. She knew what it was like to be the kid the others didn't like- so she'd make this small one's day, let her hang out with her heroine.

Flutterina's eyes were full of happy tears. “ Yes-yes, yes!”

Flutterina stuck with her the rest of the party, chatting amicably about... all *kinds* of stuff, and Catra did her best to pay attention, even when Flutterina's nerves and speed ran away with her and her words ran together into jittery mush. The kid swirled around her, ate three times in her body weight in food, and jumped from topic to topic without rhyme or reason; Catra found it kinda fun. It was interesting, at least, if exhausting.

Then a scout came back with reports of bots, and Catra took off on Swift Wind, seeing no need to stop the party.

-

The bots- ordinary Entrapta-style bots- were found swiftly and dealt with just as easily, a few sword strikes and Swift Wind kicking them into each other finishes the lot.

" Did that seem too easy to you?" Swift Wind asked.

" Nah, I mean, it's just Adora's goons," Catra said. " Hordak's dead. What's the Horde gonna do, pull new tech out of thin air? They don't have Hordak and they don't have Entrapta. They have no one who can do anything new with technology."

Behind her, runes engraved on the bots began to glow a deep bonfire orange.

" Uhh, Catra?" Swift Wind said, stepping back. " Do they have anyone who can do something new with *magic*?"

" ...Oh, yeah," Catra said, as she and Swift Wind booked it, right before the bots exploded into firestorms.

-

" Okay, we're a little singed but otherwise good!" Catra announced. " So fair warning, new Horde bots explode into fireballs when they die..."

She trailed off. There was no one here... and the place looked *attacked*.

" This isn't a surprise party, right?" Swift Wind said, and Catra drew her Sword.

" No," she growled. What- where *were* they?

She heard movement, and found the small one, Flutterina, hiding behind a table, and she told them a story of her people's abduction.

-

" Guards," Catra growled quietly from her position in the bushes near the Horde's camp. " I'll take them out."

" I'll help," Flutterina said, popping up next to her.

“ You- no,” Catra said. “ I... I already underestimated Adora. I got your people captured. I'm not risking you, too.”

“ Yet you'll risk me,” Swift Wind commented.

“ Hush, you're my bond partner, you're stuck with me,” Catra said. “ But this- I don't want you getting hurt, Flutterina.”

Flutterina gave her an odd, sideways glance, and a mischievous smile Catra had trouble recognizing- until the catfolk realized that she'd never been on *this* side of that smile before.

“ A lot of the kids, they told me what I could and couldn't do, too. Sorry-She-Ra!”

And then she was *gone*, bursting out of the underbrush at a speed that even Catra was surprised by. Catra strangled her instinctive cry when she saw Flutterina skid to a stop before the guards.

“ Hey-guys-oh-no-I'm-caught!” she said, before whirling back around and zooming off into the forest near Catra, the Hordesmen taking a few moments to catch up.

“ Oh, uh, hey, come back here!” the taller soldier said, and the duo took off after her. They didn't catch her... but they *did* catch a She-Ra fist, one each, crumpling them to the ground, revealing a lizardfolk and a redheaded human girl under the broken helmets.

“ I... Flutterina,” Catra said, looking back at the kids' smug expression.

“ I said I was super fast!”

“ Apparently,” Catra said, recognizing in the youngster's expression the same self-confidence that, once upon a time, had let Catra survive the Fright Zone and Shadow Weaver both... and with that memory bubbling up inside her, she was unable to keep herself from adding, “ You did good, kid.”

Flutterina beamed at her praise as Catra picked up one of the Hordesmen's trackerpads, and tried to figure it out. Bow would be better at this, but... but he was taken, too, she'd...

She'd made a mistake.

She'd made a mistake, and all the people of Elberon had paid for it, and *Bow* had paid for it- if he was hurt, she'd never forgive herself. Her heart seized up at the thought. So soon after Glimmer got hurt, she'd get Bow hurt, she was doing a *fine* fucking job as Angella's daughter right now.

And this fucking trackerpad wasn't *cooperating!*

" Hey," Flutterina said. " She-Ra, why are you mad? I didn't-do-anything-did-I?"

Catra whipped her head around, almost ready to bite the kid's head off- until she saw her face. A little face, turned up to her, nervous and worried, and... dammit, this kid was *killing* her, she had worn that face too.

Hell, Flutterina had it *worse*; Catra had Adora, once upon a time, but Flutterina- she didn't have *anyone*. She had nothing... except her faith in She-Ra.

With an effort of will greater than Catra would like to admit, she bit down, *hard*, on her sharp tongue, and forced herself to be kind.

(Not all the edges had worn off of her in her time in the Alliance; but now she had enough self-control to choose who got the spikes, and who got the softness. Sometimes she even made the *right* choice.)

" They've got my friend," she said to the little girl. " I'm mad as hell... but not at you. You haven't done anything wrong- unless you secretly betrayed Elberon to them."

“ Nope!” Flutterina said, obviously relieved, and snapping... actually a *really* good salute, she must have practiced. “ I'm ready to do whatever you need!”

The trackerpad chose that moment to work, and Catra finally had a plan.

“ Okay, do what I say, and we'll set them free,” she growled, and Flutterina hopped in place, eager to help.

-

The plan was simple. Flutterina would distract guards with her speed, and drag them out of position into ambushes. Catra and Swift Wind would pummel them.

The plan went well, mostly; Flutterina didn't seem to tire like you'd think she would, blitzing past guard patrols and luring them back to Catra's waiting fists and Swift Wind's hooves. None of them put up much of a fight. The Horde wasn't doing well, that was clear; the guard patrols lackluster and few in number. Hordak's death had damn near broken the organization, just like their intelligence had suggested.

Which made it odd that they'd pulled off the abduction of Elberon... *Adora, or one of her personal squad, must be in command here*, Catra thought to herself as she headbutted a guard into unconsciousness. Flutterina hopped gleefully at seeing

her in action as Catra pondered the possibilty of facing Adora again.

...*Please,* she prayed, to whatever force in the universe granted the prayers of destined heroines, *let her be... better.*

A lame ending and a lame prayer, but... but she didn't have the *words*, not for what she was hoping for. An Adora who wasn't made half out of newborn star would be a start.

I'll save you, Catra promised herself, and tried not to think how hollow the promise was beginning to sound, after three years and the portal.

While this was going on inside, they kept at the work, and some of Catra's old Horde training reared up in the back of her head, automatically judging her new Lunoth companion's fitness for the battlefield. She was small and weak, a bit under the age at which the Horde actually threw candidates onto the field- for practical, rather than moral, reasons- but her willingness to obey orders and her sheer speed were both strong points in her favor. Not a *traditional* Horde soldier, but she would do. If she could fly- and Catra had no idea how Lunoth wings worked, if they were flight-capable at all or what- Flutterina would make an *excellent* scout.

She listened to orders, at least. Flutterina, thankfully, did not share the problems of the princesses; she treated She-Ra's words like holy writ, once she was convinced She-Ra was ready to accept her as a Rebel soldier. Good kid, Catra thought.

(It didn't occur to Catra that she was too young to expose to violence, because a life in the Horde had convinced her that children *should* be trained as soldiers. Some of her life as a Hordesman had stayed with her, despite everything.)

In time, they reached the space where the people of Elberon were being captured... and walked right into a trap.

" Hey, Catra," Adora said, from a catwalk above her.

-

" What good is the Tech Master without any tech?"

Bow smirked.

" Not the first time I've been in a Horde prison. Now, Catra's out there, and she'll save us- but I'm not gonna make her job any harder. We're the Best Friend *Squad*, not *Catra and Company*. And... well, I like to keep a few tricks of my own up my sleeve."

He produced a piece of tech from behind the ear of an Elberon child, and with a kid's bow and arrow, broke them out.

What good is the Tech Master without any tech? Bow thought smugly as they hauled themselves out. *Guess we'll never need to find out.*

(He was so nice that people forgot this about Bow- he had *chosen* the life of a soldier. Of the Squad, he was, perhaps, the most impressive- no destiny had picked him, he was no son of an immortal Queen nor godlike She-Ra. He was just a man... and a volunteer in the fight for freedom.)

" The prisoners are escaping!" came a strangled yell. The yell got more strangled when Bow ran over and kicked the soldier in the gut, grabbing his stun baton and flinging it with pinpoint accuracy into his companion, shocking them into submission as Bow punched the first guard one more time, knocking them out.

...And that was it. Huh?

" Woohoo, Bow! The Tech Master has saved us!" bellowed the big Elberon woman.

" Yeah..." he said. " But where are the rest of the guards? Prison this size, there should have been more!"

" Oh, that's my fault!" came a sweet-sounding voice from nearby.

Bow turned towards the voice, and saw a surprisingly familiar face.

“ Scorpia?”

She waved cheerfully with one pincer. “ Hey Bow!”

-

Adora above her- and her arm, she was so *burned*, but Catra forced herself not to look at that. Adora, looking down on her, her right eye still that fine blue, the left milky, as though a cloud had drifted over the sky.

“ Adora...” Catra began. Flutterina piped up from behind her.

“ Ooh, I know about her!” she said. “ Your girlfriend, right? Mad that you left the Horde!”

There was a pause then, and finally Adora laughed- but not the ghastly cackles she'd been so full of since *you're a First One*, but genuine, honest laughter.

“ I- *what?!?*” Adora said. “ Wait, where the hell did you hear that, small one?”

“ That's what everybody says!” the mothfolk insisted. “ Catra loved you and you loved her, but then she left to be She-Ra and you decided that if she didn't love you you'd destroy her!”

Adora wiped a tear from her eyes, wincing a little when she touched her left. “ I mean, she's not *wrong*,” the former Force Captain replied. “ Right, *darling*?”

She giggled again, as Catra's guts did *things*, hearing Adora call her that.

“ Please, leave the Horde behind,” Catra begged, changing the subject. “ Come with me. The Horde's dying, Adora. Come with me. Angella- I can convince her to give you a light sentence, we can still be together...”

“ After everything?” Adora said, shaking her head. “ You've... you've *really* committed yourself to your role, haven't you? Heroine... trying to save everybody. I... thank you for that, I suppose... but there's no going back, Catra. The Horde's my home- where I was born and raised.”

Adora raised her unburnt hand, and clicked her fingers. There was a sound, as of drone robots on the march... but Catra couldn't *see* them, even as she looked around. All around her, though, she saw what looked like puffs of dust, kicked up by robot feet, and the noise was getting louder... but where *were* they, she couldn't see them!

" Made a trap for you," Adora drawled. " Something *special*. Think of it like date night, darling."

Lasers flashed out of nothingness, and that was when Catra realized what was going on, even as Flutterina voiced it.

" The drones are invisible!" the tiny Lunoth yelped as she hopped in place, trying to find somewhere safe as lasers rained on them.

" Yep!" Adora yelled- and then cast a spell herself, which drew a great circle of flames around Catra and Flutterina. " A present, just for you, my love! One *last* present!"

-

" Flutterina, *run*!" She-Ra yelled, vainly fighting back against an army of foes she couldn't see. Her strikes kept hitting empty air, though every now and then one cleaved through metal and wire, and parts became visible as they fell out of the machines, which collapsed and died.

She growled and fought, and Flutterina thought she'd never seen anything so magnificent; She-Ra, standing tall as a giant, that great Sword in her hands, gold and white and divine. Her fur shone with the orange of the setting sun, her black hair the mane of a great and noble lion, her blue and yellow eyes not scared or worried but focused on the fight. She snarled as she battled, shining in the sun, lasers striking and glinting off of her armor

harmlessly, each of her strikes a crash of thunder and lightning. Swift Wind beside her, dancing and bucking, the silly, talkative horse not so silly now that he was in the middle of combat, his horn sharp as the Sword and his hooves sending invisible robots flying, visible innards trailing them like obscure comet tails.

Flutterina never thought she'd get a chance to see her like this, in *person,* even when Elberon was invaded... but now her she was, her hero, *She-Ra*, trying to save her, because She-Ra saved *everybody*. She'd even tried to save what was, apparently, her former girlfriend, the very person who was trying to kill her... and wasn't that fitting, that She-Ra would have a love story so tragic, so much larger than life? Her hero was everything Flutterina had ever wanted her to be; so many people were disappointed with their heroes, but Flutterina had met hers, and not found her wanting.

But even as that great heroine fought, Flutterina, who had no experience with combat, who was right now in the middle of her first real fight, could tell that She-Ra was going to be bore down by sheer weight of numbers. Adora stared down from her catwalk, giggling and chuckling to herself as her invisible swarm tore at She-Ra. Hit after hit, lasers or drone legs striking at her, invisible but the impact was obvious...

Flutterina forced herself to look away. At least the bots weren't attacking *her*.

(Adora had so few rules... but Flutterina, so young, so vulnerable... Adora, unconsciously, refused to hurt her, and turned her bots to She-Ra alone. Even thinking of herself as a beast, Adora had lines she, unintentionally, would not cross.)

There had to be something she could do to help...

Her eyes alighted on the artillery Elberon had modified after the Horde left, the machines dragged from the party, and set on a tall platform around this circular arena. A note, visible even at this distance, stated it was due for repairs, and unsuitable for use until then.

...Flutterina wondered if it still had confetti in it.

She ran. She ran as hard as she'd ever run before, losing herself into the rhythm of muscles burning as her long, loping strides ate up the distance, of feet hitting the ground, so fast, faster than anyone could follow. She was the fastest runner in Elberon, a skill started when she ran from the other kids, honed in the time after the mayor's intervention because it gave an outlet for the energy inside Flutterina that no one else shared. The orphan had become swift... and she'd learned a few tricks in the meantime.

There was a ladder going up to the platform, but it wasn't anywhere near the artillery piece. Flutterina wasn't going to use it.

Instead, as she reached the wall, she performed an old stunt, one that never failed to make the mayor's heart leap up in her chest, something she'd learned to do just for the hell of it.

She put her feet on the wall, and ran *up* it.

Momentum carried her against gravity's will for the first few steps, lifting her up. It wouldn't last forever, of course; she began to slow down, too far from the top.

That was fine. Lunoths had *wings.*

Flutterina's wings weren't big enough, and she wasn't strong enough, to really *fly* just yet... but she didn't have to.

Flutterina leapt right as her momentum started to die, strong legs carrying her thin form up, and she flapped her wings once, boosting her upwards. She stretched her left arm out- almost- almost...

At the very height of her jump, her hand rose above the catwalks floor, and she grabbed onto it.

She jerked as gravity tried to tug her down, struggling like a fish caught on a line, but her flailing feet kicked off the wall, hurtling her forward again, letting her right hand join her good strong left and help lift her up. Small biceps straining, her wings pumping, Flutterina hauled herself to the top of the catwalk.

She paused a second, to catch her breath- but not a moment longer, She-Ra needed her!

Flutterina hauled herself up, ran over to the artillery- come on, where was the button-

Found it!

She slammed her tiny fist down on it, and it barked colored paper all over the arena- colored paper that landed on the bots, and did not disappear.

" She-Ra! The confetti!" Flutterina yelled. The bot's movement was shaking the paper off... but not that fast, and even bots that weren't hit were revealing themselves when they stepped on the colored paper that fell to the ground, distorting it.

" On it, kid!" She-Ra roared, as she grabbed Swift Wind, and glorious, golden light washed over the both of them in a pulse that obliterated the machines, and sent Adora running.

Flutterina watched it with tears in her eyes.

" So cool..."

-

The kid rejoined her, running down the wall instead of taking the ladder like a normal person, and sprinting towards her. Catra grinned as she arrived. Damn smart kid- and useful, too.

" She-Ra! That-was-so-cool-you-were-gold!" she squeaked as she reached Catra, jumping up and down in place.

" Yep," Catra said. " That trick you pulled with the confetti was just what I needed. There weren't even that many bots, I just couldn't tell with the whole invisible thing."

Flutterina grinned, warm and cheerful.

" Hey!" came a friendly voice, and Catra turned to see Bow, whole and unhurt, a sight that eased aches in her heart she hadn't even noticed.

" Bow, you're okay," Catra said, and the archer laughed. Behind him, Catra saw Elberon's citizens, whom she'd missed the first time, focusing on her friend.

" Yep! I even brought a friend!" he said, stepping aside.

" Hi wildcat!"

-

When they leave Elberon, they walk, instead of flying, eventually hooking up with a Rebel hover transport in the next town over from Elberon, one that takes them to Brightmoon for free.

" Anything to be of use to She-Ra, ma'am," said the very polite Eirelander at the wheel, the fungus folk giving her the smallest bow.

They walk- and ride- because they have two new additions to their forces. Scorpia, of course, because she is a Princess and a horde defector both, and she will be incredibly valuable in Brightmoon.

The other, who talks ninety-miles a minute, and is all smiles and nervous energy, is an orphan of Elberon- little Flutterina.

Bow had argued ferociously against it; she was too young, was the gist of his argument, she'll get killed, she'll get hurt.

" Bow, her village got invaded, and the Horde murdered her parents years ago," Catra had replied. " She's already been hurt, and already risked death fighting for us. If she's here, we can at least keep an eye on her."

Bow could not help but bow to reality- and thus it was that Flutterina joined the Princess Alliance, and became a member of the Great Rebellion.

-

They hit a Rebel warcamp before they reached Brightmoon, and decided to stay the night with them, leaving the Eirelander hover transport, who refused all payment.

" It's not that I don't want to get paid," he said. " It's just that you folks have already paid me for this ride, years before we met."

" How so?" Bow said, and the fungus man had given him a glance.

" I have family in Plumeria. Family who would have been killed, who tell a story every year at the family reunion. They tell of a princess what can teleport, who slugged the Horde soldier who held them at staff-point. They tell of an archer who put an arrow in the rifle that was trained on them. And they tell of a feline giant who lifted a tank over her head, a tank that had destroyed their home, and threw it into a squad of other tanks with a sound like divine thunder. They talk of three people who convinced their Princess to get up off her meditating couch and actually *fight* for her people, and of how they regained their love for their monarch because of those three."

He smiled at them, and had a little tear in his eyes. " They got more kids, now. Kids they'd never have had... excepting you were there. My family's alive because of you. You've paid me, honestly and in full, with more besides."

Catra had been a little overwhelmed at that, and simply waved him on; Bow had openly been in tears, and when they called Glimmer that night, he'd told her the story, and she'd gotten a bit weepy about it too.

(It was easy for them to forget what it meant, for so many, that they had been there, all these years.)

The warcamp was a fun place to stay for the night, this little camp a collection of vagabonds and volunteers, like so much of the Princess Alliance's forces were, just patchy tents arranged around a campfire, horses and carriages and wagons full of stolen Horde equipment in boxes and out. This rag-tag group was on its way back to its home in one of Brightmoon's smaller villages, with one stop at Brightmoon first.

They were a supply and quartermaster group, who had been raiding the Horde for years and found the job easier now as it slowly collapsed, taking the supplies intended to kill Allied troops and instead converting them into support for those very same soldiers. They'd stop at Brightmoon to drop off their haul, save the percentage they could keep, then head home.

The leader had been overjoyed to see his guests, honored to host them, popping open the finest foodstuffs they had. Bow had been given his pick of technological toys from their latest procurements, the tech master eventually taking only a few pieces of interesting

circuitry to upgrade his trackerpad with, while Flutterina had asked for a Horde ration bar.

" I... why?" Catra asked.

" You used to eat these, right?" Flutterina said. " I always wondered what they tasted like! Also I'm like super hungry all the time- running eats up energy, as does being so hyperactive-and-probably-growing-and-stuff! And I've heard that they taste like crap but they totally work as a source of nutrition and anyway- I'm-gonna-eat-it-now!"

Her words warping into a singular buzz, Catra had dropped the matter, and in-between chatting with the cheerful satyr who ran this raiding company and listening as Swift Wind tried to stir the horses to equine revolution, watched out of the corner of her eye as Flutterina took the ration bar in both hands and began gnawing on it.

" This is terrible!" she announced around one huge mouthful, and Catra couldn't help but laugh.

-

Flutterina went off by herself, in the dark of the night. No one saw her go, the smallest of Rebel soldiers easy to miss.

When she was alone, she paused, sighed, and blinked rapidly... blinking the tears out of her eyes.

" I'm gonna make you proud," the youngster whispered. " Mom, dad... I'm gonna... I'm gonna make you proud. I've already helped She-Ra... I..."

The orphan rubbed the tears out of her eyes, but they kept falling.

" I'm... I'm heading to Brightmoon now. The holy place... you'd... you'd be happy, right? I... I don't really... I don't remember like I should. I'm sorry. I see your faces but I don't... I don't remember your voices... not anymore..."

She sobbed, things she'd kept inside for years finally released now; some tension left over from her first real battle, combined with the awe she felt in She-Ra's presence, overwhelming barriers she'd built inside herself. It was almost impressive that she'd held off *this* long.

She cried, bawled her eyes out, idly wished she'd brought a handkerchief or something to wipe her nose with.

" I'll make you proud," she whispered, to figures that existed only in her mind, parents taken years ago by the Horde.

“ Hey, kid, what are you doing?” came a voice from nearby.

Flutterina jerked to attention. “ Oh, sorry! I... I didn't know anybody was out here-”

“ It's okay,” said her visitor, whose eyes gleamed a weird green for just a second before she stepped into the light, revealing themselves as Scorpia, the big princess they'd rescued earlier. “ Why are you crying?”

“ Don't tell anyone,” Flutterina pleaded desperately. “ They already think I'm too young, if they know I was out here crying they'd send me home, I can't... please, don't tell anyone!”

“ Hey, hey, calm down,” the big princess said, and fished a handkerchief out of a pocket with *incredible* difficulty. “ Good thing I keep these, huh? Hard to get them out of a pocket when your hands are big fighting gloves though, heh. These pincers man, they are just... *not* practical for most stuff. I mean, for fighting, heck yeah! But like, not much else.”

She hunkerd down to Flutterina's height, and handed the clean cloth to the small girl, who blew her nose on it and wiped her face.

“ You won't tell anyone?” she said. “ I have to be here.”

“ I won't tell anyone you were out here if you don't tell anyone I was,” Scorpia promised. “ And if you tell me why you were crying. I'm always interested in why people do stuff.”

Flutterina gave the kind stranger a sad look.

“ My parents,” she said, after a moment to gather her thoughts. “ They died fighting the Horde... I've wanted to fight back for years, but I've always been too young. They wouldn't let me leave. But this last attack- I helped. So they're letting me join. I... I have to fight the Horde. I have to strike back, do something they'd... they'd be proud of.”

Scorpia's face was sad, too, though she put on a small smile. “ Lost my family to the Horde, too,” she confided in the little one. “ Come on, let's go back- no more crying. I'll keep this quiet, and you do too, alright?”

Flutterina nodded, as Scorpia rose up, and offered her a claw. She took it, and the duo walked back to camp.

Flutterina never noticed the way Scorpia blinked her eyelids, one pair horizontal, on the way back.

-

“ Elberon was a success,” Adora said, wrapping up her part of the war council. “ Invisible robots were full combat-capable, and She-

Ra had noticeable trouble dealing with them without outside assistance. Furthermore, Double Trouble is now working inside the enemy ranks.”

“ Good,” Lonnie said. “ I don't much like them, but hey, if they can help us win, I'm all for it.”

“ Indeed,” Adora said, rubbing at her eye. Damn thing hurt worse than the arm did. “ So, me and Lonnie were talking earlier... we need to do something about our morale problems.”

“ True,” Rogelio said. “ Everyone's pretty down and out. Kyle's keeping a lot of them here through fear, but that'll only work so long.”

Kyle nodded. “ Yeah, so... what are we gonna do?”

“ Hordak would have held a public thing,” Lonnie said. “ Terrified everyone back into place.”

“ Hordak wouldn't have these problems, because we only have these problems because Hordak's *dead*,” Rogelio pointed out in his reptile's tongue. Adora was just glad she'd finally figured it out in the last three years. “ Not sure we should do things the way Hordak did them- might make them start doing a comparison. Adora's impressive, but she doesn't have Hordak's... I don't know... weight? History? That little extra something.”

Adora nodded... but her brain began picking away, picking at how she'd cowed the desert dwellers, on speeches she'd overheard being given in the Princess Alliance.

" I think we *do* need to do something public," she said. " But different from how Hordak did it. I *want* them to think of me like Hordak... but you're right, Rogelio, I don't want them *comparing* me unfavorably to him. So something reminiscent, but different enough that I can start establishing myself..."

She thought of Elberon, and all that food they'd stolen- she'd taken it on a whim, more for the sheer pettiness of the action than any real desire- and the seed of an idea began to bloom. She absentmindedly rubbed ointment on her burned arm.

" You also need a new look," Rogelio said.

" What, the burns that ugly?" Adora joked, but Rogelio shook his head.

" No," he said, " but your current outfit is a Force Captain's outfit. You're bigger than that now. You need something... unique. Imposing."

Kyle waved his hand in the air, like a kid in class.

“ Ooh! I can help! I always wanted to design armor, I mean, I'm not a great fighter or nothing but I've been hurt a *lot* so I know what parts need armor the most-”

“ Kyle, I'm not sure *I get my ass kicked a lot* really substitutes for engineering expertise,” Lonnie deadpanned. Rogelio bit down a laugh, trying not to join in the mocking of his boyfriend as Kyle puffed out his cheeks in rage.

“ Come on Loooonnniieee...”

Lonnie laughed, gentling her bullying nature. “ Don't make that face, you look like a fish.”

Adora chuckled, just absorbing the moment. Joy, friendship, camaraderie. This... this was nice.

Almost perfect.

(It was missing only one thing. *Her* presence at her side, the taste of her lips, the ghost of a living person, all around Adora, a phantom tail curling lazily around her arm. If she were here it would truly be perfect, all Adora had ever wanted...)

She licked her lips, forcibly pulling herself back to the present. “ I... need an eyepatch,” she said.

“ Left eye that bad?” Lonnie asked.

“ I can still see out of it,” Adora said, “ but it's distracting, and too much light hitting it is painful. I might as well call it a loss. Get me Octavia, see if she's got a spare eyepatch we can modify to fit me.”

“ On it!” Kyle said. “ An eyepatch- ooh, let's make it red!”

“ Red?” Adora said.

“ We want to give you a presence,” Kyle said. “ But if you just look like Hordak, well, it'll be obvious you're just trying to fill his shoes, right? Like Rogelio was saying. You need a distinct identity, but something that still makes them think of Hordak. So let's keep the old colors, but invert them! More red, less black. Also, I don't think you use as much eyeliner as Hordak did.”

“ I don't use any eyeliner,” Adora said.

“ So I'm right!” Kyle replied, oblivious.

“ Kyle's got a point,” Rogelio said. “ Wouldn't be bad for the Horde to have a new symbol, too- people get fired up about small changes, little things. Nothing major, nothing huge, just a small something to say “hey, the leadership is **back.**”

“ But what should we do? It needs to work with the old symbols,” Lonnie said.

Adora pondered the trouble. The old symbols...

(the hot thing inside her, the illusion she'd used in the desert, fire and heat and light)

Adora summoned up an illusion with her burned hand, of the Horde's outspread wings, and then added a single long line in red between them, one end the head of a reptile, the other end a spiked tail. From the head, a single thin puff of flame.

“ What about this?” she said, showing them the dragon she'd made.

-

The day after Elberon, the call went out: the Horde was to assemble before the main hall, on the grounds outside the sanctum. Normal duties were suspended for the day, and the soldiers were brought in alongside their Force Captains, standing in the long, neat rows Horde training had drilled into them. The Captains- all four that were left- gathered at the front, underneath a great raised dais that had been part of the building's original structure, before Hordak began adding onto it.

“ I still say I should be leader,” Grizzlor growled quietly to the others.

“ Oh, hush,” Octavia replied. She didn't know *what* new bullshit the goddamn kids who'd somehow inherited the Horde had planned, but she'd at least hear them out. “ I wouldn't follow you and we both know it.”

“ And I wouldn't follow either of you,” Mantenna said, the Lunoth's cybernetic eyes zooming in on his troops as he took his place behind them. “ This Adora, though... lot of interesting rumors about her.”

“ And what have you heard, oh spymaster?” Dreer asked, the Mystacoran outcast cocking his head to the side.

“ Many things,” Mantenna whispered, his eyes sliding back in, now only prominent, not protuberant. “ That she is a sorceress. That our new recruits are all from the Crimson Waste... that she is a First One.”

“ Ha!” Grizzlor laughed. “ A First One. Tell me a lie I can *believe*, at least.”

“ That's why I am considering it,” Mantenna whispered. Octavia didn't know if Mantenna whispered because his throat had gotten wounded, or just because he liked being creepy; the Octopode had never gotten on with the mothfolk. “ A lie would have to be

believable, but truth can be anything. This... sounds like truth's audacity, to me.”

“ Interesting,” Dreer said. “ A First One *and* a sorceress?”

“ Still after your magic?” Octavia said, though she grinned to show she had no malice behind it. She liked Dreer.

“ Once you've had it, you can't do anything but miss it,” Dreer admitted, his hands still turning in the old rune circles, hunting for the magic that had been taken from him. “ Though I do wonder who taught Adora.”

“ Shadow Weaver was her guardian,” Grizzlor said. “ I imagine she did.”

“ Then I pity her,” Dreer announced, and for a moment, all four of the remaining Force Captains were in agreement.

(No one in the Horde had liked Shadow Weaver. Hordak promoted ruthless efficiency without sentimentality- and that meant sadism was right *out*. It served no purpose. Shadow Weaver's casual cruelties, allowed because she was Hordak's only sorceress, had rankled many in the Horde.)

“ Wonder what she's thinking right now,” Octavia said.

-

The fuck am I doing? Adora thought.

" Focus, Adora," Lonnie said. " This is your first impression as who you are. Make it work!"

" I'll... I'll try," she admitted.

She was dressed well. Her left arm was covered in bright red and shining black armor, a sign of what Adora took from her, and the rest of her armor was likewise colored and fashionable (at least, Kyle thought it was fashionable, and being the only expert they had, she had to rely on him.) An eyepatch, red too, with her sigil in black. Her roaring shield, now done up with her colors, adding weight to her presence, a counterbalance in her right hand to her armored left.

She raised her left hand to them, and they grew silent, waiting to see what all this was about.

" People of the Horde," Adora began, voice enhanced by speakers she'd had put in the dais. She was looking over them, trying desperately to remember the script they'd come up with for this. " Remove your helmets."

Murmurs, all of surprise. That was an order Hordak had *never* given.

(It had comforted him, to see those helmets, a sea of similar-looking faces; he could not make clones like his brother, but he could create uniformity in his own way.)

Adora waited to be obeyed, and for a few terrifying moments thought they would disobey- and that would break the Horde right there, if they decided not to obey her- but soon enough, Horde discipline kicked in, even for the strange order, and helmets came off.

A sea of confused, surprised faces looked at her, mostly young, and of all Etheria's races- humans and lunoths, Eirelanders and satyrs, lizardfolk and scorpioni, octopodes and bestials. Eyes glanced at each other, then to Adora, as they held their helmets in their hands.

They were surprised, off-balance. Good. When your feet weren't steady on the ground, it was easier to bowl you over.

Adora took in a breath. *Here goes nothing*.

" You know me," Adora said. " You know my story. I was raised here, same as anyone else. I went through the same training, ate the same ration bars, slept on the same bunks. I reached Force Captain on my own merits, handpicked by Hordak himself, the way all Force Captains were."

Noises, but she couldn't tell what kind, just had to plow on, even as her nerves leapt up her spine.

(*You weren't this freaked out when you tried to blow up the planet,* some voice inside said, and she almost burst into giggles at the entirely true thought.)

" But afterwards... afterwards, Hordak chose to reveal to me a secret. It is now time I told you that secret."

With her left, she drew burning sigils in the air, and cast her spell.

The sky was replaced, showing now a conversation that never happened- Hordak, and Adora before him, in her inner sanctum. No sound, but Adora provided narration.

" He showed me the portal he'd dragged me through. Hordak knew that someday, the Princesses might kill him; and so he prepared, just in case."

Hordak, showing Adora a portal- showing an image of Hordak, surprisingly gentle, saving a baby in a ruined city. They'd spent an hour making that look *just* right... though Adora was sure it was an absurd lie. Hordak had probably kicked her into Shadow Weaver's arms once he realized the portal didn't lead to his big brother, or however the hell it had happened.

“ He had been seeking First One's technology; he found me, instead. I am the last of my people, the last of my kind.”

Images of the First One's technology, the wonders of Adora's people.

“ I am a First One.”

Gasps, shouts of *knew it!*, a few people protesting... but only a few. Emboldened, Adora rolled on.

“ He found me in the ruins of my people's works, the last of my kind, and he knew he had found his inheritor. He found me and chose me to be his successor, raised by Shadow Weaver as one of you so that I would know the Horde inside and out, so that I would be one of you.”

Images, flashes of her past- from childhood to now.

“ Shadow Weaver taught me magic,” she said, the scene shifting to the dark sorceress casting runes that Adora copied. The scene changed again, to Hordak teaching her at his war table, something else that had never happened... but everyone knew that she'd spent time with Hordak after being promoted. “ Hordak taught me to lead. I was prepared for this task, just in case; and time has proven Hordak wise.”

An image- Hordak, struck down from behind by Entrapta, whom few in the Horde had known personally, a heavy wrench in the purple-haired girl's hands, braining him.

" Hordak was *betrayed*. Murdered, by a Princess he had taken in with open arms!"

Shouts, anger, rage. Shouts of anger. Rage. Good. Rage didn't hurt. Rage had kept Adora together through too many long nights, had been her only succor in times of trouble.

But Adora's arm trembled; this was so much magic, more than she'd ever used at one time before. *Keep going*, she ordered herself. *They need this.*

Buoyed on that thought, she turned the spell again, this time into a picture of the Horde as a whole, rows of troops.

" We are all Hordak's children. And I, his chosen successor, swear to you this: I will guide you, brothers and sisters, to a better world. I *will* fulfill the destiny Hordak entrusted to me!"

With one last burst of magic, she summoned her insignia, the Horde's new symbol, into the air, alongside a map of all Etheria. The dragon flew to the Fright Zone, becoming a red wave that emerged from that place to consume it all.

“ The Horde will stretch from sea to sea! We will take it all! We will push back! We will take Etheria!”

Cheers, even from the Force Captains, who *knew* better. She *had* them. This wasn't so different from her usual lies, just... just *bigger*.

Biggest, maybe.

The crowd's whispers, definitely friendly, cheered again when the red dragon's jaws bit down on Brightmoon. Soldiers looking at each other without the helmets to block their vision, looking up as the great dragon roared and all Etheria flew the flag of Adora's new Horde.

“ I bring magic. I bring the wisdom of my people. I bring power the Princesses cannot stop, cannot understand, cannot *fight!*” she bellowed. “ And they must pay for their crimes. Our leader, Hordak, slain by treachery! Our leader, Hordak, *my father and yours!* I was taken in as an orphan, for I am the last of my people. You were taken in too, you are orphans the same as me. He was our father, and they *murdered* him! Will you let his killers roam the world free?”

NO! the shout returns, excited and angry.

“ His great task falls to us! We are his children! We are his inheritors! Follow me, and we will *will* bring order! We *will* defeat

the princesses! Order will prevail! I am Adora. I am Hordak's Chosen, and together, we are the Horde!" she roared, and they pumped their fists for her.

ADORA! ADORA! they shouted. Had any words ever sounded so sweet, or tasted so much like victory?

" Now... eat. I am bringing the bounty of foreign lands to you, spoils of our most recent victory. Eat! From now on, whenever we conquer, you may take of the spoils of the new land. Hordak refrained, for he believed that the Princesses could be negotiated with. But they murdered him when he tried the road of peace. No more! We *take* now! Eat! Relish the taste, and prepare yourself for more in the future! With each victory, we feast! For Hordak, our father! For the Horde!"

FOR THE HORDE! and it is so beautiful, all those voices, raised as one, repeating her words. Addicting. Monsters, each and every one, but Adora is growing more comfortable with that truth, she presides over this den of beasts as its master.

This isn't so bad.

She clicked the fingers of her unwounded hand, and on that signal, Horde soldiers- all individuals who were undergoing punishment- brought out the food. It was real food, not ration bars, stolen from Elberon's celebrations, put into iceboxes and brought here. It was mostly still good, and frankly, Horde soldiers wouldn't notice a small amount of spoiling; ration bars didn't prepare one for real food.

Rogelio was down there, the nicest of her quartet, giving instructions on how to eat the food to people who had only ever seen ration bars before, his words translated by those who spoke his tongue for those who didn't.

" Have your fun. I will be planning our next attack; and more spoils like this will be in your hands, if you will but have faith in me."

One last cheer, and Adora left. She walked the long hallways to her inner sanctum- what had once been Hordak's- shaking; she had never given such a speech before, to such a large crowd, but at least her nerves had waited until she was off the "stage", as it were.

" You okay?" Kyle asked as she entered. He was here to watch her back while she listened in on communications.

" Yeah," she said. " Just... suddenly hit with jitters. Never gave a speech like that before," she admitted as she slumped into her seat, not Hordak's great throne but a nearby chair before a computer screen that had been broken in the portal incident and could not be repaired at her engineer's current level of expertise. It still had power, though, and she'd been using it as a convenient battery for her own projects.

" You okay? You... you don't look it," Kyle offered nervously. " You look... tense."

“ I... don't feel great,” Adora admitted. “ Hold on, I gotta get to listening.”

Adora leaned forward and picked up the trackerpad, alongside a paper notepad and pen she'd put here before going out for her speech. With the pen in her good hand and her burned hand on the controls of the trackerpad, she was ready.

With a button press, she activated one of the microphones she'd had the science teams install around the Fright Zone, at night when most were asleep- this particular one being in the large hall she'd held her rally in. They were incredibly crude little spying devices, barely more than static-crackling microphones crammed in inconspicuous places and hooked to her trackerpad's speakers... but they did the job. She didn't have an Imp, but she *did* have a science lab and a lot of people with something to prove.

She listened in, jumping from microphone to microphone, picking up conversations thought secret or hidden, eavesdropping on her troops. The talk was always of one of two subjects- the food, and her. Praise for the food was universal; praise for her, nearly so. A few expressed doubts, and she wrote down names on a little notepad when she heard them of those who doubted, but for the most part, it seemed that the new flavors and gifts she'd brought had settled both stomachs and minds.

It wouldn't be enough without victories. The feeling of the rally would fade in time, and in the face of reality... but it was helping. It was... it was like her, Adora realized. She'd slapped a band-aid

over her cracked skull... just like the Horde was using its faith in her to cover its weakness.

...Shame all this pressure was on her shoulders now...

" Hey, you want a shoulder massage? It always helps Rogelio relax," Kyle offered, after having been silent for the last few minutes.

" Making a move on me, Kyle?" Adora said, amused. " And shoulder massages! Rather soft of you. I should reprimand a Horde soldier for such weakness. Or tell Rogelio you're trying to cheat on him."

" Not if you want a massage," Kyle teased right back. He really *had* grown brave in the last three years; he trusted her, didn't get sent running or into a panic over her words. " And Rogelio knows I've got no interest in girls. Now, if you were a *dude*, maybe, but otherwise no... though I'm not sure what your hair poofie would look like as a guy."

" It'd be enormous," Adora said, keeping one ear on the trackerpad's sounds even as they talked. " I'd make it gigantic, grow it out like a full foot-"

" That's a mental image I just have to live with now," Kyle said. " But... seriously, I'm offering. You seem like you might explode, or something, and Lonnie told me and Rogelio to look after you. I

don't know how to help with anything else, but I can do massages alright.”

“... I think I'd like one,” Adora admitted, and Kyle's hands, soft and weak as they were, proved warm and soothing as he pressed them to the knots and tensions in her back, Adora leaning forward to accommodate him.

(Her hand kept writing down those who doubted her. She kept listening, even as Kyle eased her aches; Shadow Weaver had raised her poorly, but trained her well.)

After a few moments of this, Lonnie's voice cut into the warm haze of her loosening muscles.

“ Kyle, I told you to guard her back- you can't do that if you're busy putting your grubby hands all over it.”

Kyle jerked away from her.

“ Lonnie! When did you get here?!?”

“ A full minute ago. I figured you weren't watching Adora good enough, so I came along.”

“ Aren't you supposed to be running security?” Adora said, focusing her trackerpad on the microphone that would have been

closest to Lonnie's guardpost.

" I was, but I passed the job off so I could come up here," Lonnie said, taking a nearby chair and plopping down near her boss. " Anything juicy?"

" Nothing major, just a few doubters," Adora replied. " Nothing warranting more than a bit of surveillance."

" Good," Lonnie said. " I've got some people I trust, I'll stick them to watching. Glad our little show worked."

" Mmhmm," Adora said. " Me too."

Silence reigned a minute, quiet except for the crackling tones of the trackerpad's stolen conversations, until Lonnie spoke up.

" Hey, Kyle, I wouldn't mind a massage."

" Heh, okay," Kyle said, and soon Lonnnie was being reduced to putty in his hands.

Rogelio joined them later, as the party wound down, the Horde's cadets still excited- still waiting to see what new world Adora would make- if their leader could deliver on her promises. Talk

throughout all the Fright Zone was optimistic, looking forward to the future for the first time since Hordak died.

They wanted Adora to lead them to glory.

I will, Adora promised them in her heart of hearts, as she listened in on them... on her *people.* Born a First One, she was bred to be a Hordesman... and she would stick by them. She had betrayed everyone else and every*thing* else in her life. She had betrayed Catra by being evil (or, perhaps, Catra had betrayed *her* by being *good*, a thought Adora rather liked.) She had betrayed Shadow Weaver to advance her own agenda in the Horde. She had betrayed Hordak by flipping the portal switch when he told her not to, and he had died for it... and she had always been *planning* to betray him.

She betrayed Scorpia and Entrapta and... and even her squad, she had betrayed all of them, just so she could get a win over Catra at last, so she could silence the beating pain in her heart and the four words that burned her, *You're a First One.*

Please, she prayed, to whatever forces in the universe might grant the prayers of tyrants and monsters, *keep me from betraying the Horde, too.*

-

Octavia chewed the good food, soft sweet cake, and sighed. Today had been a *good* day.

" Okay," Grizzlor admitted, walking off with a hunk of deer leg. " The new boss at least can talk a good game... and this feast ain't half bad."

Dreer laughed, the thin, frail Mystacoran on his fourth plate. " I'll say! Haven't eaten like this in *years!*"

Mantenna said nothing, merely raised a toast with his cup of wine, one of *many* he'd had.

A soldier dared approach, and such was the Captains' joint good mood that they let them.

" Captain?" the Hordesman said to Octavia. " Me and the crew were wondering- what does this mean? Her changing our symbol, having us eat all this... strange stuff. What's it mean?"

Octavia thought it over.

" I think..." she said, surprising even herself as she said it, " that it's a sign of change coming- good change, if I don't miss my guess. I think it's a sign the new boss has her shit together."

The soldier, satisfied, nodded as he took a bite of something called an apple, and Octavia leaned back and sighed.

Good change... yeah, she could get used to this.

-

That night, Adora dreams.

Catra, first, and their kiss in Mara's ship.

(The taste of Catra on her lips, she kissed her and it was blood and salt and sweat and Catra's teeth, too sharp, she cut herself to ribbons trying to kiss her. Of course. Adora is so unworthy of Catra that she cannot even kiss her without being wounded; she is a moth to the flame, to catch what she wants of Catra would burn her alive. Catra's fire is so pure, and Adora's so false; when they touch, the illusion breaks, and only the true flame of Catra survives. Her tongue traces the scars on her lips, touches them with its own scars; Catra had kissed her to shreds.)

The left side of her body, burning up, the light, the light, the light...

And... far off in the distance... something she not only saw, but felt. A purer and more terrible light, she can sense it coming... something green as new shoots of spring, something as pure white as clean bone.

Something that is *kin* of hers. Kin, and in a deeper way than the shapeshifter she just hired; he is light, too. He is no little gleam but a **light**, he approaches, and some part of her thrills, recognizing the lie of him, the lie so big that he is convincing the universe to believe it... and the wiser part of her panics.

If Adora is a wildfire than this is the Sun, it is out there, *he is out there and he sees all, knows all...*

Adora woke up screaming.

Chapter End Notes

Holy SHIT, S5 was so good!

I'm going to continue this until I'm done with the whole thing. All 5 seasons, woohoo!

A note on the Force Captains:

Grizzlor and Octavia are in the show, though Grizzlor's role was so minor I'd nearly forgotten he was actually in the show. Octavia, of course, has an episode in season 4. Grizzlor is a Force Captain for general work, Octavia for sea operations.

Mantenna is from the original She-Ra show; there, he was more of a bug/cyborg mantis guy, but here, he's the same species as Flutterina. He was originally a cyborg engineer interested in First One's tech, until his desire to merge machine and flesh made him less a tinkerer and more of a Frankenstein type. His mechanical eyes can see in multiple wavelength,s and are of his own design; he's never managed

to get a pair to work for anyone but a Lunoth. He runs intelligence operations.

Dreer is also from the original She-Ra show; he was a one-off character, a Duke who worked for the Horde and had some magic. Here, he was originally a Mystacoran mage, but he was kicked out for attempting to learn forbidden magic- and having learned from the Shadow Weaver incident, they blocked his magic with a curse after kicking him. He's mad as hell about this, and hopes to regain his spells one day. He is officially just another Captain, but unofficially is the main "hey, we think magic's involved, go poke it" guy, because Shadow Weaver never had the time to do that, and now he's the only one with real practical experience with magic left.

Chapter 4: Scorpia of Beast Island

Chapter Notes

Howdy folks!

I raised the chapter number because I feel like doing shorter chapters than I have been doing. Some chapters just straight up require me to write a lot of words- chapter 1, for example, has a clear ending point, and Adora of the Horde did, too- but trying to cram everything into one final chapter was getting silly.

So I'm going to finish Season 4 with several shorter chapters than originally planned. Then I'll move on to Season 5 and the completion of the epic saga of Catra of Brightmoon with the next fic, tentatively titled Catra and Adora of the Universe.

Hope you enjoy the ride!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Scorpia of Beast Island

Beast Island is the *worst* place Scorpia has ever been.

The transport does not actually reach the island, but fires her off in a one-way, one-use capsule. It's a transport straight to hell; the capsule hits the beach and pops open, and it just sits there, scattered alongside a long mess of similar transports, the spent shells and discarded cartridges of living ammo. Scorpia takes a few steps out, and debates just setting up on the beach- it seems safe enough, and she's not comfortable just charging in- not with the reputation this place has. Beast Island is described in terms

approaching the apocalyptic, and Scorpia, for all that she's no genius, is not a fool, either.

At that point, the beach reveals that it is home to octopi whose tentacles are *also* snakes, and only Scorpia's exoskeleton saves her, fleeing as a few poisonous fangs break on her chitin; dumb luck it didn't strike the parts of her that were flesh.

Scorpia fled, deeper into the woods- and that... didn't improve anything. Monkeys, or something *akin* to monkeys, attacked her... a swarm of them, hordes. Teeth and hands, biting, clawing, they are all over her and Scorpia has just enough time to be grateful for her natural advantages, her pincers crushing and smashing, her stinger tail lashing out. Monkey-abominations die, but not fast enough, she's getting swarmed, her frantic attacks are barely keeping them off of her most vulnerable parts.

She yells for help as she fights, even knowing none is coming- this is Beast Island. No one is here, that's the common knowledge...

But just as the monkeys nearly land a fatal bite on her throat, they are blasted away, because the common knowledge is *wrong*.

There is *one* person on Beast Island; and with a wave of magic, he saves her life, wiping the monkeys away from her.

" Hey!" he says. He is a shaggy, *shaggy* human, and he looks... umm... like he's not doing very well, and hasn't for some time. "

You're new!”

“ I just got here,” Scorpia says to the man.

“ I've never imagined a scorpionfolk before!” the wild man cheerfully goes on, face split with a wide grin.

“ I don't think I'm imaginary,” Scorpia replies, and rubs at a sore spot on her body where a monkey's gripping hand had managed to get flesh. “ Wouldn't hurt so bad if I was, I imagine.”

“ Oh man,” the wild man answers, eyes wide as he looks to the side, and speaks with people who aren't there. “ Imaginations having imaginations. Now *that's* a thought. Wish my Angie could hear that shit. Oh, but I shouldn't cuss. I'm a new father. Don't want Glimmer cursing. Angie'd blame me.”

“ I... uhh?” Scorpia says, and the man giggles- a little bit like how Adora giggles.

(Adora. There are few people the kind and good-natured Scorpia hates- but Adora's on the list. Traitorous blonde jackass with her stupid hair poof thing!)

“ Anyway, we have to go, or the false-head snakes will kill us!” the stranger tells her cheerfully, taking off.

With no other choice, Scorpia follows behind.

-

In Brightmoon, Scorpia walked to her room, another day over with- time for sleep.

Well... it wasn't *quite* Scorpia.

Double Trouble, wearing Scorpia's skin, thought things were going pretty well. Entry had been surprisingly easy. The Alliance's forces just happening to "find" Scorpia with the other prisoners- with self-same woman claiming she'd been escaping and got caught outside Elberon- was a coincidence, but not so much of one as to be unbelievable. They knew Scorpia had been betrayed by Adora, and it is not a surprise that she might head west, with the Horde no longer friendly.

Scorpia had been concerned about Catra, initially. Half of Adora's ranting when she'd been giving Doule Trouble their mission had been about the Magicat, which indicated some rather deeper relationship... perhaps the rumors were true, and they had been lovers, once. It would certainly explain the impassioned fury and strange longing that laced all Adora's words.

But Catra hadn't really paid any attention on the way back to "Scorpia", her focus on the archer, Elberon, and the brat they'd picked up. Her interactions with them were... illuminating.

With Bow she'd seemed so apologetic, so... *ashamed*. Half their conversation had been her asking him if he was okay, and then apologizing for falling for the Horde trap that got him caught.

(Bow had waved it off with good humor and an acceptance that no one was perfect. DT marked him down as dangerous. A man that honest and friendly was impossible to manipulate, there were no handles in his heart by which another person might pick him up; like all spies, DT had learned that the most dangerous foe was a truly good person, for no manipulation could move them an inch from where they stood.)

Before they left Elberon, Catra had apologized to the mayor directly for failing them, and complimented her on having more sense than she did. The townspeople had shrugged it off, pointing out that even She-Ra couldn't be everywhere- she'd come back, and apparently that was enough for Elberon, that she had not abandoned them in their distress. They had forgiven her.

Then, with the kid, she'd been so patient... but that had been with effort, DT could almost *hear* Catra's gears grinding as she tried not to snap the kid when she got too hyper. Flutterina was a handful, and seemed oddly self-aware about it, but her hero worship for She-Ra was so strong she couldn't bear to be away from her for too long. It was annoying the hell out of Catra.

Yet for all that, Catra had never once yelled at the kid, despite it being so *obvious* she wanted to... but despite that, she'd fight it off, each time. She'd reprimand her when she went too far or crossed a line, but her tone was, with effort, gentle.

Catra was apparently not a patient person by instinct, but instincts weren't all a person had; they had a choice, too, and Catra kept making that choice, even if she had to fight for it every time.

Double Trouble wondered, idly, what would make her *lose* that fight, and only long practice kept a sadistic grin off their stolen face. Catra was going to be so much *fun!* Like Adora, a little bit, though obviously much more mentally healthy and stable; they both struggled to be the people they thought they should be. The difference, of course, being their end- goals; Adora sought to hurl herself off the cliff of monstrosity, Catra was determined to climb the mountain of virtue.

Why, between the two of them, DT was absolutely *spoiled* for fun characters to play with!

Still, once they got to the Castle, Catra proved as dangerous as Adora's obsession made her out to be. The others weren't much trouble. Knowing that the Alliance only knew a few things about Scorpia, Double Trouble had settled on a firm characterization for Scorpia that would fit with what they knew- big, dumb, friendly, Horde-loyal (which Scorpia had adjusted to be *Hordak*-loyal, explaining their defection), had a thing for Catra she was entirely unashamed of.

The Princesses bought it, hook, line, and sinker, though the Hordak-loyalty made them a bit wary. Good. The less time spent interacting with Double Trouble, the easier the disguise was to maintain. It'd be easier if it was someone they didn't know at all- someone they'd trust instinctively, a little pink thing like that Lunoth brat they'd picked up in Elberon- but Scorpia was *almost* unknown enough that it still worked.

Entrapta might be a problem- she'd known Scorpia better- but DT had prepared by telling a sob story to the princesses about Scorpia getting the crap kicked out of her while escaping the Fright Zone, and how she'd lost some of her memory after a particularly hard blow to the head from Grizzlor. A flimsy cover... but the weak shield hadn't been tested yet. Entrapta wasn't here, which was a relief. She apparently didn't leave the Crypto Castle much these days.

DT didn't know why and didn't care; it made their job easier.

No, the Princesses- save the weird flower girl, who wanted to connect with her for reasons probably related to how her eyes never left Scorpia's muscles- mostly kept a polite, if friendly, distance from the loyal soldier.

But Catra... once Catra had settled down, no longer ashamed of what had happened in Elberon to her friend... she'd gotten... suspicious.

She knew something was up, but she didn't know *what.* Catra kept going near "Scorpia", at least, when her duties watching over their newest recruit- who'd *absolutely* endeared herself to all the other Princesses, being small, pink, and loud, to Double Trouble's general distaste- but she seemed... hesitant... to say anything to anyone.

It was Bow who'd explained it, when Double Trouble asked why Catra was so odd around her (disguising it by asking if Catra found her interest abhorrent.)

Catra had apparently made a promise- to Hordak, of all people!- to keep Scorpia safe, and so now she was struggling between instincts that shouted not to trust Scorpia, and her own duty to uphold her promise to a dead man.

The conflict there- the drama! *Delicious*.

Double Trouble headed back to their room, and went to sleep with a smile on their face.

-

Adora sat on her throne and read over the latest report from Double Trouble, a quick text message sent across trackerpad. They hadn't had an opportunity to send video yet; Catra was exactly as dangerous an enemy as Adora had told the spy, she suspected something was up. Double Trouble had been playing up Scorpia's hurt feelings of rejection to justify avoiding her, but suspected they'd have to abort the mission early.

That was fine. They'd already sent invaluable data; if they could just distract the Rebellion a little longer, Adora would consider the money she'd paid the spy worth it.

She read over one particularly funny line, and snickered. Double Trouble certainly had a way with words; she should almost pay extra.

" Adora," came a voice from the hall. The Horde's new commander looked up from her seat.

" Yeah, Lonnie?"

" Wanna show you something," said that same Force Captain, approaching her. " I had an idea, you see."

" Oh?" Adora said, putting her trackerpad down. She'd finish reading that later; if Lonnie was interrupting her, it was probably worth it. " What about?"

" Well, you know our plan to deal with the Woods?" Lonnie said.

" Yeah, I came up with it," Adora said, grinning at her friend. She summoned a small flame into her hand. " You spot a problem with it?"

" No, just a way that tech can help your magic," Lonnie said, as Adora dismissed the flame. " We lost a lot of troops- but there's an unexpected upside."

Lonnie nodded behind her, and Rogelio, concealed in shadows until that moment, hauled over a fuel tank- but there was something odd about it. Someone- probably Adora's science lab guys- had attached what looked like a hose to the end, and at the end of that hose was a handle, shaped like...

" Is that my dragon symbol?" Adora asked, quirking the eyebrow over her eyepatch.

(She'd tried quirking the eyebrow over her right eye- and found she couldn't. It baffled her. You'd think you could raise either eyebrow but apparently it worked like handedness for Adora!)

" Yep!" Lonnie said. " I didn't tell the tech guys to do that, but hey, here we are. See, all those troops leaving means that we, ironically, have a surplus of fuel around the Fright Zone. Most of those that ran didn't take trucks or skiffs, they just booked it on their own boots. Anyway, I thought, hey, gotta be a way we can use all that fuel. I mean, keeping some backup stock is great, but it does you no good if you don't use it, right?"

" So what's this do then?" Adora asked. Lonnie grinned.

" I'm calling it a flamethrower."

" Now that," Adora admitted, " sounds *promising.*"

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: I did some quick research before this chapter and realized we see no flamethrowers in She-Ra and the Princesses of Power before this point, though in the old She-Ra series, we see Hordak use a flamethrower at least once. She-Ra trivia at its finest!

(For those who are curious: I love the old show for what it is, but find that SPOP blows it out of the water in many ways. That's fine; children should surpass their parents. That's natural.)

Chapter 5: Kyle of Lord Adora's Horde

Chapter Notes

> A battle sequence! Catra gets to discover that Lord Adora's Horde fights a bit differently than it used to...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kyle of Lord Adora's Horde

It was supposed to be so simple.

Scouts came back with the information. The Horde was transporting some new weapon- which they'd gotten a hold of somehow- through the Whispering Woods. If it got to the Fright Zone, who knew what terrible use Adora would make of it?

But if is a *powerful* word.

Catra got a team together, pulling on the informal, mish-mosh strings of the Alliance's rag-tag militia system to get a group. Bow was up for it, and Glimmer had finally recovered enough to go back into the field. Warbands in the area responded, howling for a chance to strike at the Horde and serve the She-Ra all at once, and soon the Best Friend Squad had two dozen volunteers for back-up, alongside Netossa and Spinnerella, who had been in Brightmoon when the news came down. They even had a Troll, one of that reclusive race of giants, who had somehow come out of the spikey heart of their distant and forbidding homeland to

fight the Horde, despite the general mistrust between them and the smaller races.

This eclectic group sat down in Brightmoon's war room, mapped out the convoy's most likely path, and laid out the simple plan- wait for the convoy, ambush it, and steal or destroy the weapon.

No problem. It was the same stuff they'd already pulled dozens of times. They reached the ambush point a day beforehand and got ready. The scouts reported the convoy was on its way before scattering to form a perimeter, making a loose circle around them to make sure the ambush didn't get ambushed itself.

Flutterina was one of those scouts, and had saluted Catra before she left at her usual blistering pace; to Catra's own surprise, Flutterina had discipline worthy of a Horde soldier, so determined to prove herself that she was able to keep a lid even on her boundless energy. Catra wondered what drove the small one so hard... or how she was able to move under the weight of her enormous, bright pink backpack.

Apparently Flutterina had decided that, since her utility in an actual fight was fairly low, she could at least serve as a pack mule, and she'd spent the time in Brightmoon cajoling everyone with her cuteness into giving her stuff to fill the backpack with. The backpack itself was a gift from Netossa, of all people; a leatherworker had owed her a favor, and she'd convinced the woman to make the backpack, which was a great lumbering monstrosity as tall as Flutterina was, and seemed entirely bottomless when Catra looked inside it.

Still, Flutterina carried it without complaint, and Catra's opinion of the little trooper continued to rise. A damn fine soldier, she'd say if she was a Force Captain- though she could not imagine what her life would be like, if she was on the Horde's side still.

(If nothing else, she would not have Angella for a mother, and the warmth of that thought was a happy fire in her heart.)

When word reached them- through Flutterina- that the target approached, Catra's fur went up. One truck? Just *one*? That wasn't right; information said there were more, alongside bots and troopers too.

" Do you want me to go back?" Flutterina asked, rocking back and forth on her heels.

" No, stay til the ambush is done," Catra said. " You can tell the scouts our mission was a success and get them to come back afterwards."

Flutterina saluted again, like a nervous tic. She took up position in a tree, easily leaping up the branches despite her backpack's weight, while Catra and her bushwhackers made ready... though it all felt like overkill now, for just one truck.

One truck, through the Whispering Woods... no, something was wrong. Bad wrong.

The truck showed up, and Spinnerella knocked it off its wheels easily enough. The driver leapt out, not even making a token defense, just running and screaming before Netossa got him, pinning him upside down on a nearby tree.

I mean, the Horde's on its last legs, but still, Catra thought.

Catra approached the back carefully.

" Be cautious," she ordered her troops. She'd already screwed up in Elberon, she wasn't screwing up now. " Keep your guard up! We don't know *what* is in that truck."

" Could be bombs," Bow said. " Like Mara's ship."

" Good point. Everyone, stay back!" Catra commanded. " I'll poke my head in first. Not like a few bombs'll do much more than scratch my armor."

" Happy to," Glimmer said. " Had enough of being exploded to last a lifetime."

" Be careful," Bow said to Catra, and she gave him a smile. She'd be fine. She-Ra could take it.

With the Sword and her transformation on her, Catra took one strong hand of claws, and with the five swords she was born with, tore the back of the truck off.

...Nothing. It was empty.

" Nothing here," she said, right as the invisible robot inside shot her in the face.

" Invisible bot!" Bow yelled. " Just like Elberon!"

" Forgot about the invisible bots!" Catra yelled as she swung blindly, her eyes stinging from the laser blast even past She-Ra's supernatural toughness. A scream of metal resounded- she hit *something*- she swung again and again, until the laser blasts stopped.

She swiped at the inside again, but no more attacks were coming, and she took the time to blink the blindness out of her eyes, rubbing with the back of her free hand. Laughter- *familiar* laughter- rang out from their trapped driver.

" Hey, that's- isn't that one of Adora's guys?" Glimmer asked. Catra, still blinking, gave a closer ear to the laughter.

" ...*Kyle?*" she said, and the laughter increased for a moment before silencing.

“ Yep!” he said, wriggling in the net and managing to pull his helmet off so he could glare at her. “ How'd you like that? What you deserve, traitor!”

Catra, on reflex, rolled her eyes- and paid for it, her orbs *ached*.

“ Gah!” she said. “ Oh, this *hurts...* Kyle, shut up. Anybody got eye drops?”

“ Right here,” Flutterina said, taking off her backpack and withdrawing a small glass potion bottle. “ Never leave home without a full medical kit!”

“ Bag's big enough to hold three,” Bow opined in quiet respect as the little girl hoisted the great monstrosity back on.

“ You're a saint, Flutterina,” Catra said, popping the bottle open and carefully putting a few drops in her right eye.

Glimmer, meanwhile, gave her best go at interrogating Kyle.

“ Tell us why Adora's moving one invisible bot through the woods,” she said.

“ No,” he said.

...Well, shit.

“ ...Okay, I'm out of ideas,” Glimmer admitted. “ How about I just punch him until answers come out?”

“ He's a POW, we don't torture,” Catra reminded her as she started pouring drops into her left eye too. “ If you don't have rules for warfare, you're not a civilization, you're a band of thugs. Also, torture doesn't work; people will tell you anything to get the pain to stop.”

“ Mom gave me that exact lecture once too,” Glimmer said, and Catra chuckled.

“ I know, I was in the room when she gave it. That's why I'm repeating it. Older sister has to keep you in line, you know.”

“ You can't be the older sister!” Glimmer said, indignant. “ You're adopted! That makes you the little sister by default!”

Catra laughed as the entire ambush group pondered that.

“ That's not how that works, I think?” Flutterina said cautiously. “ Isn't it still about age? I must admit, never thought about it before.”

“ Oldest is oldest, adopted or not,” one of the lizard folk in the ambush squad said. “ I mean, I'm pretty sure, that's how we do it in Plumeria anyway.”

“ Oh, I didn't know you were Plumerian,” his satyr friend said.

“ Yep!” the bushwhacker said, and a group of them descended into discussion of their mutual homelands and adoption law. The Troll listened impassively, leaning up against a tree with massive mace in hand, shield propped up on a different tree, both works of intricately carved geometric art.

(Glimmer thought they looked vaguely like the magic runes Mystacor used... but Trolls had never been in Mystacor, their retreat from the rest of Etheria predated Mystacor's founding.)

“ How old are you, anyway?” Bow asked Catra. “ Just realized I've known you three years, but I actually don't know how old you are.”

“ Probably because I don't know,” Catra said, blinking rapidly as the medicine soothed her sore eyeballs. “ Shadow Weaver didn't exactly keep up with my birthdays, and... I've always kind of assumed I was about Adora's age? I mean, we aged at about the same rate. I'm not even sure how long I'll live, to be honest with you.”

“ Magicats have weird lifespans,” Glimmer said. “ You guys age like humans do, but sometimes you hit old age and just like, stay? There are records of magicats living for hundreds of years, but they got old first. It's like you advance so far and just stop. It's not common but it *does* happen. Kind of the same thing that happens to really magical Twiggets sometimes.”

“ That explains Madam Razz, at least,” Catra said. They'd finally positively identified her species a week ago, though she kept wandering the halls being... Madam Razz. “ Wait, how do you know this? The hell is a Magicat?”

“ That's you, dumbass,” Glimmer said with a laugh. “ Well, at least that's what Etherians call you- some of the really old records from the First Ones I found called you guys Thunderians? Not sure what that's about. Anyway, I did some research after your adoption. Your people mostly live in the farthest South; you had an underground kingdom called Halfmoon- no relation to Brightmoon, to my surprise- but the Horde conquered it about two decades ago, give or take. You're probably an orphan from that conquest.”

“ Are there... others?” Catra asked, and Glimmer nodded.

“ We assume so. We don't really know much about it, and I don't know why you'd be the only Magicat taken- that area's deep in Horde territory. Last information our spies could figure out, the area suffered multiple rebellions- apparently the Force Captain in charge spends almost all of his time just keeping the region quiet, some Lunoth captain named Mantenna.”

“ He's a jerk,” Flutterina tossed into the conversation. “ Heard about him from the mayor. Weird guy, obsessed with replacing meat with machine. Got telescope eyes or something.”

“ Yeah, I've met him,” Catra said. “ It's worse than it sounds- if he runs the area full of my people, maybe that's why he kept glaring at me whenever he was in the Fright Zone.”

Catra blinked one last time, and sighed as relief filled her eyes. “ Thanks,” Catra said, as she popped the cap back on and handed what was left of the eyedrops back to her biggest fan. “ Here, small one.”

“ No-trouble!” Flutterina said in a giddy burst, putting the eyedrops back in her pink monstrosity. “ Glad-to-help!”

“ So I'm a Magicat,” Catra mused. “ Never cared too much about my race, just... I mean, I didn't know I *had* a race up until literally just now.”

“ Wait, really?” Bow asked, and she nodded.

“ I always figured I was a one-off, unique... alone, if I'm being honest,” Catra said, telling her friends thoughts she'd had in the long, quiet darkness of the Fright Zone, when she had to hide from Shadow Weaver or the other cadets. “ It never occurred to

me to wonder what my race was, or if I had a homeland... I mean, hell, Shadow Weaver named me *Catra*, there wasn't a whole lot of effort put into me, you know? I always thought maybe I'd come to life in one of her experiments or something. A witch's familiar that got overgrown, or a failed homunculus or something."

" Really?" Glimmer said. " Shadow Weaver didn't even tell you where you're from? Shit."

" How have you known her for three years and are just now talking about this?" Kyle asked, his tone a little delirious. " And oh, First Ones, I'm upside down and there is *so much blood* in my head."

" Oh yeah, forgot about you," Glimmer said, turning back to her prisoner. " Hey, sis, if I can't punch him for information, can I punch him just because I want to?"

" I... Glimmer, that's *worse*," Catra said. " Besides, it's just Kyle. Leave him for a moment; he'll be okay a bit longer. There has to be something more going on here; the Horde wouldn't transport just one invisible robot."

" Yeah, it doesn't make sense," Bow said. " It's not like it was some super version or prototype; it was just a standard invisible robot."

“ We live really weird lives when you can say that,” Glimmer commented, as Catra nodded to the tech master.

“ True....” Catra frowned. “ Let's see if the scouts saw anything else- Flutterina, go tell them the mission was a success, see what's up.”

“ Got it!” she said, and tore off. Catra turned to their prisoner.

“ I'm going to cut you free, Kyle,” Catra said, gently. It didn't come naturally; she wanted to gloat... but Princesses of Brightmoon did not gloat over their fallen foes. That wasn't what a *good* person did, and *definitely* not what the Best Princess did; and she had been doing this for three years. It made it a little easier, to be good, it added the weight of habit to her choice. “ Don't run or do anything stupid, okay? I don't want to see you hurt.”

“ Then why did you join the Alliance?!?” Kyle asked her, as she quickly cut him free of Netossa's web, putting a hand on him so he wouldn't fall and turning him upright.

“ Steady,” she said as he wobbled on his feet, putting one hand on his shoulder. He tried to shrug it off, but the motion itself almost sent him to the ground, so he begrudgingly accepted her help. “ Easy now. Just stand still, it'll end soon enough.”

“ When Adora kills you I'm going to throw a party,” he murmured.

“ She's not managed it yet,” Catra said... then, helplessly, “ How is she?”

“ Adora?” Kyle muttered, blinking as the dizziness slowly started to filter out of his skull. “ Burned and hurt and mad as hell at you, and holding the whole Horde together single-handedly. She's a hero and you're out here fighting your own people...”

“ My people,” Catra said to him, “ are in *Brightmoon*. The Magicat thing's interesting, but Brightmoon's my home.”

Glimmer smiled at her before turning a glare on Kyle. “ That's right. And even if it wasn't, her people's home would be Halfmoon, and it, too, is attacked by the Horde, so you're wrong *twice*.”

“ Your own homeland was conquered by them, Kyle- the Horde takes all the land it owns, it is not your people either,” Catra said. “ The Horde was nobody's homeland except Hordak's, and he's dead now. There's no *point* to the war continuing with Hordak dead.”

“ Whatever,” Kyle said, shaking his head. “ Traitor.”

Before the conversation could continue, the ambushers heard familiar, high-pitched yelling.

“ We're under attack!”

The ambushers turned, saw Flutterina, running pell-mell at them, little legs carrying her at unbelievable speed, great pink backpack wobbling with tremendous force as she blitzed towards them.

“ Invisible bots!” she announced. “ Everywhere! And other bots behind them but something's wrong with them, they keep exploding! The scouts were pinned down; I distracted the bots so they're moving, but it's a huge group! Invisible trucks, too, all full of Hordesmen! Horde-troopers-with-some-new-thing-that-throws-fire! I ran the whole circle around us, everyone's under attack, we're-surrounded, there's-nowhere-to-run!”

“ What?” Catra yelled. “ Where are the other scouts?”

“ Coming up behind me! Err, from all directions too! Get ready, there's a lot of wounded, and there's lots of bad guys behind them!” Flutterina yelled, skidding to a stop near the Best Friend Squad, flapping her wings rapidly to bring herself to a halt.

“ How do you know how many *invisible* bots we're facing?” Glimmer asked.

“ Lots of laser coming out of nowhere!” Flutterina announced. “ I counted! I'm-not-just-fast-on-my-*feet*! And a few dozen of the

roll-up-and-blow-up kind! Couldn't count the Hordesman burning stuff though, too-much-fire!”

“ I don't like... any of that,” Catra admitting, before turning to address her squad in louder, more authoritative tones.. “ Okay, everyone, if you're not a healer, into the trees! Attacks are going to be coming from all directions, so we need to get above them, it'll give them fewer angles to attack us from. Form up a rough circle- we have to cover every area! We can't escape right now, so we'll just have to fight it out and wait for an opportunity to run!”

“ Bow,” she said, “ can you hack them?”

“ I'll try,” he said, pulling out his trackerpad.

“ What about us?” Netossa asked.

“ You guys wait a moment,” Catra said. “ Need a place for the healers to work in safety...”

She glanced around, and her eyes fell on the truck, as the rest of the ambush squad followed her orders, moving into place around the clearing.

“ The truck'll work,” she announced. “ Use the bed, we'll stuff the wounded in there- it's protected from most angles. Big guy!”

“ Yes?” the Troll rumbled.

“ Hate to ask you to get shot,” she said, “ but you're big enough to guard the open door of the truck, and too big to get into a tree. The truck'll protect your back, and the shield'll protect your front- if you got something to throw or shoot, that'll help too.”

“ No need,” he rumbled. “ I have magic.”

He raised a hand and a shining glyph appeared for proof.

“ Did you go to Mystacor?” Glimmer asked, and the Troll laughed.

“ There are more schools of magic than one, princess,” he said as he lumbered to the truck's back.

At about that time, the scouts caught up, weary and haggard and hurt.

“ Invisible... bots! We're under... attack,” one panted, a Lunoth who had run up and was now gasping for air. Behind him, the healthy scouts were hauling the wounded, whose injuries were numerous: legs scorched by laser fire, burns on arms and chests where shots hit flesh and not armor, and one poor woman who had taken a blast on the chin and had her face seared.

“ So we heard,” Glimmer drawled as she ran over to help move the wounded. “ Come on, into the back of the truck. I've got you- we've got healers. If you're able to still fight, follow my sister's lead, up into the trees and form a circle!”

The rest of the Best Friend squad went over to help- including Flutterina, who couldn't help haul people into the truck's relative safety, but *did* have a multitude of medical equipment in her great rucksack that she freely shared with their healers.

Hauling the wounded to something like safety had a sense of desperation- the ambush group couldn't *see* the bots, but they could *hear* them, and the sheer number of whirring servos and clanking legs they heard coming indicated a vast army... and behind it, the first crackling noises of a great fire, just now starting.

“ Great ambush I've planned,” Catra muttered. “ Now *we're* getting ambushed.”

“ Ain't dead yet,” Glimmer grunted, as she let the last of the wounded off her shoulder. “ Focus on getting us out of here.”

“ Fair enough,” Catra said. “ Flutterina, you said they had a weapon that throws fire?”

“ Yes! They're-burning-the-trees, they're-burning-everything!”

...*That's actually a good idea on Adora's part,* Catra thought. The Woods had been a shield for the Rebellion from the start- if the Horde just burned the whole damn forest, though, there wouldn't be anywhere to hide. It sounded like Adora; cunning by brute force.

“ Anything else different about the Hordesmen with the flame-throwing weapons?”

“ Heavily-armored!” Flutterina said. “ Doesn't look as pretty or smooth as Horde armor usually does, but there's-more-of-it!”

“ Probably insulation against the fire,” Bow said, as he fiddled with his trackerpad. “ Though how they're burning so much of the forest without cooking themselves, I don't know. Convection is a thing...”

“ Any luck hacking the bots?” Catra asked her tech master. “ Or hell, even just finding them?”

“ No,” he said. “ I can detect their network but I'm not getting anywhere. Entrapta's analysis of that bot we captured at Elberon was right- the Horde's new tech guys are so incompetent that, ironically, their code is almost impossible to break. It's half-functional and jury-rigged; Entrapta's as surprised as I am that

the bots are functioning at all... but it also means it doesn't make enough sense to parse out.”

“ Wait, the Horde being *incompetent* made them tougher?!?” Glimmer asked in angry disbelief.

“ That's-bullshit,” Flutterina blurted out, hopping from nervous energy.

“ You can't cuss, you're a baby!” Glimmer retorted.

“ Anybody got blankets or paint or something we can throw on them?” Catra yelled. Negative responses rang out, Flutterina looking particularly pained; she hadn't thought to bring anything like that. Even the all-holding backpack had weaknesses.

Glimmer, meanwhile, had an idea, but didn't speak up, working out the math first.

“ Okay,” Catra said, biting her lip in frustration before turning to the two princesses. “ Netossa, Spinnerella- you guys use big, wide attacks, okay? Just... start hurling the biggest shots you can once the bots start firing at us. You'll hit *something.* You guys have the most power here, you'll be doing a lot of the heavy lifting.”

The married duo nodded, though Netossa sighed. “ This is gonna make counting kills a *bitch...*”

" *Counting-kills?!?*" Flutterina growled indignantly as she glared at the Princess of Sealing Light, the effect not unlike a very offended pug. " Take-this-seriously!"

" I am *dead serious* about my kill count," Netossa responded, offended.

" Honey, let's... let's just get into position," Spinnerella said, lifting her wife up on a tornado and depositing her in a tree that had a good field of vision, before the Princess of the Four Winds took up a spot nearby to support her wife.

" Counting kills..." Flutterina said, shaking her head.

" Hey, I have an idea," Glimmer said. " I might have a spell for it. There's a spell that makes your target tell the truth- Shadow Weaver taught me. I think I can modify it? It might reveal the bots."

Shadow Weaver..? I'll need to talk to her about that, Catra thought, but dismissed it for the moment. " I'd rather not use anything she's touched, but we don't have many great options. Go for it."

That was when the first shots started to rain down on them, the invisible bots and their slow march finally catching up to the main

group.

“ Party's starting!” Catra said, forming the Sword into a shield and taking a stand besides her sister. Spinnerella started hurling twisters into the crowd, the sounds confirming she was hitting *something*, even as Netossa complained that those kills didn't count from her hiding place nearby, her own nets raining down and taking out bots. Bow launched exploding arrows that hit groups entire, in between repeated efforts to try and subvert the bots with his trackerpad; Flutterina, meanwhile, kept watch, her mouth an endless running steam of information keeping Catra up to date on how the entire Rebel force was doing.

The militia fought hard, arrows, stones and javelins raining down from the trees, alongside a few laser blasts from stolen Horde guns; it was a tribute to their skill that, despite not being able to see their targets, half of their shots hit home. They did better than any Horde troopers would, Catra thought, proud of them; Rebel volunteers, each worth more than any individual Hordesman in combat.

The Troll, in particular, did well, the giant's wizardry sending rocky spikes into the field that were big enough they were almost guaranteed to hit *something*, the wounded safe behind the vast warrior. Explosions and the howl of tortured metal rang out; the hunters had become the hunted, but they were no easy prey.

Still, they were surrounded, and while the bots were no better shots than they had ever been- were worse, given their rickety software and the clumsy hands of their current makers- the sheer weight of numbers and density of fire was almost overwhelming. The Whispering Woods' trees were tough, but not invincible, and

their cover was being whittled away shot by shot, even as stray bolts began to get lucky and find flesh. Grunts and screams of pain echoed as searing lasers burned flesh and cut holes in skin.

In the middle of all this, guarded by her sister's shield and buffeted by Catra's yelling as she tried to draw fire to herself, Glimmer drew gleaming symbols in the air, twice erasing mistakes in her runes. Casting in combat was a lot harder, adrenaline made it easy to forget what went where, what runes you needed, hell, what the runes even *looked* like... and it didn't help she was modifying the spell. Make *tell the truth* into *show the truth*, that didn't sound that hard, but any mistake would collapse the whole spell into nothing...

...She *hoped* these were the right runes.

" Here goes nothing," Glimmer said, firing it off over Catra's shoulder as she blocked laser shots. The runes washed over a seemingly empty area from which laser fire poured; the spells' runes left a beautiful, sparkling trail behind them in the air that did... nothing.

" Shit," Glimmer said. " Didn't work."

" I don't know about that," Bow said, nocking an arrow. " Look."

The glitter that had followed her runes had settled... and it was moving. Bow loosed an arrow into a mass of gleaming particles;

an explosion followed as the arrow's metal tip penetrated robotic shell.

The glitter wasn't moving- the bots it had covered were.

" Glimmer, you're a genius!" Catra said, the shield in her hands becoming the Sword once more. " Do that everywhere, and we can get this *done*!"

The spell wasn't perfect; it didn't undo the invisibility or reveal them... but it *did* add a dazzling, glittery outline to them, just visible enough in the sunlight to let arrows and javelins and slingstones do their work. Glimmer began teleporting, the spell easier and faster to cast now that she had the gist of it, throwing it everywhere and revealing their enemies to them; with targets suddenly visible, the Rebel forces redoubled their assault, and now for every wounded Rebel, ten bots died.

" We're doing it!" came the yell from one of her soldiers. " We're pushing them back!"

" Damn right we are!" Netossa said, blasting a bot. " That's one, I can see them so we can start counting again now!"

" Are-you-still-on-about-that?!?" Flutterina yelled at her in frustrated fury. " Focus!"

But even as the war on the unseen tipped in their favor, more bots appeared- entirely visible bots, each with a bright rune drawn on them that Catra couldn't read but that Glimmer, apparently, could.

" Burst apart into flame?" she said as the new arrivals began to charge. " I don't like that. Her runework's sloppy, though, it's almost illegible."

" Please judge Adora's spellcraft grammar later," Catra said. " Everybody, I bet those are the exploding ones Flutterina mentioned! Don't let them get too close!"

A desperate ranged fight ensued; with less need to draw fire now that most of the bots were gone, Catra resorted to grabbing up big, heavy rocks and hurling them with She-Ra's enhanced strength. Each robot she hit burst into a terrific explosion of flame, and that made the Rebels even more determined not to let them get close; they sprinted forward, a literal suicide run as they tried to get close before detonating. Spinnerella had to stop attacking, her wind gusts were just feeding the flames and making them spread faster.

And the fire did *not* need to spread faster. Behind the new exploding bots, what appeared to be a solid *wall* of fire was rising as the Woods burned. Hordesmen, in suits of armor made out of two standard Horde Uniforms haphazardly welded together, could be glimpsed in between the roaring flames, with strange dragonlike devices in their hands, which did indeed breathe fire; they threw the flame *everywhere*, their slow, solemn advance certain as an executioner's axe falling.

Trees centuries-old went up in flames in mere minutes, shrubs and bushes became small blazing torches, and the ground itself was a lake of fire, small grasses rendered to ash and dust and the very dirt itself boiling; the Hordesmen spreading these flames, in the bright red glow, looked like demons from hell. The bright glowing rune on their chests didn't help, a hot red thing.

" Any idea what that rune is?" Catra asked as she hurled more rocks. There weren't many bots left now, but that fire looked to be a bigger problem than mere mechanical monsters.

Glimmer squinted, but shook her head after a moment.

" No, between Adora's apparently atrocious runic handwriting and the fire, I can't make it out," the mage trainee said. " Looks kinda like the rune for fire, but it's got some extra stuff with it. Best I can do."

" That's-a-lot-of-fire!" Flutterina said, observing the forest fire as it steadily encroached on them from all sides. " Any-ideas-on-how-we'll-escape?"

" You won't," Kyle said, chuckling. In the chaos, Catra had plain forgotten about him; he was leaning up on the side of the truck. " You'll burn, traitor, you and all your rebel friends."

" Kyle, you'll bake with the rest of us," Catra said. " You got any way to tell your men to knock it off?"

Kyle snickered at her, the little shit.

" Our suits are immune to flame, actually," Kyle said. " More of Adora's work. She's done well since she became Lord of the Horde... and that's my cue!"

He took off at a run, zigzagging and managing to stumble only once as he escaped. He ran into the fire, and despite lacking a helmet, his armor protected him; the red glow washed over him, and the fire left him unhurt, the unseen rune on his chest activating as the fire touched him.

" Do we grab him?" Netossa asked.

" No, we got bigger problems," Catra said, looking around. Had to be a way out...

" Yeah, fire's trouble for a lot of princesses," Netossa said. " For people, too. Fire's pretty good, it works on just about everything except Mermista."

" Shame she ain't here," Bow said. " Be useful right about now."

" I can teleport some people," Glimmer said, " but not many..."

“ If we had a platform or something, I could lift it, and carry people out that way,” Spinnerella said.

Catra's eyes landed on the truck.

“ I have a better idea,” Catra said. “ I've got a way to clear a path through the fire. We'll have to rush it as soon as I do, because the fire will be back- anybody got a way to shield us from the heat? It won't clear much of a space.”

“ Nets work as shields if I need them to,” Netossa said. “ It's pretty good against fire, too; my nets are light, and fire's related, so the two have trouble fighting each other. It's not perfect, but it'll work.”

“ Good, you're on that then,” Catra told the Princess of Sealing Light. Turning to Netossa's wife, Catra said, “ Hey, Spinnerella! Can you suck all the air *away* from the fire?”

“ I'm better at generating it,” she admitted, “ but I'll give it a go.”

Catra headed over to the truck. “ I need everybody to grab the wounded- many as you can carry. Get everybody out of the truck.”

" How come?" Bow asked, even as he slipped a hand underneath a nearly-crippled satyr whose legs were mostly laser burns.

" Because I'm going to throw the truck at the Horde," Catra said. " The truck'll flatten the flames out, take out any Hordesmen behind the fire, and clear us a path to run for it."

" If you're gonna do that," Bow said, pointing in one direction with his free hand," aim *that* way. It's a direct shot to our temporary camp, and we can grab our stuff as we run."

" Good idea," Catra said, as she got in position. " Netossa, the second this truck hits, throw a shield over the sides, keep the fire back! Spinnerella, deaden the fire as much as you can- and everybody else, make a run for it!"

" Can't the Horde guys hear our plan?" Flutterina asked, hopping from one leg to another as she prepared to run.

" Not past the roar of their own fire," Bow said, wiping sweat from his brow.

Catra knelt, advice from Horde cadet training ringing in her ears- *lift with her legs, not your back*.

She doubted this was what the instructor had in mind.

She put her hands under the truck's edge. C'mon, *lift*...

She dug into the ground before her magic compensated for the increased weight. Where her hands gripped, the metal dented, bent, until finally she hit some vital part of the frame and the truck stopped breaking apart in her hands.

Slowly, steadily, the truck began to lift.

" *Come on,*" Catra snarled under her breath, ears slicked back, sweat pouring down her brow with effort. Up, up, *up*...

After an eternity, she stood with the truck in her hands, held over her head, an Etherian Atlas holding up the sky.

Her back ached, her shoulders hurt, even She-Ra's strength was beginning to strain; but she could do it.

With a feline roar, she hurled the truck at terrific velocity. It landed horizontal, spinning, bouncing, flattening trees and brush and stomping out the fire as it went. Hordesmen scattered with yelped screams, leaving an empty, flameless corridor out of the trap.

" Shields up!" Netossa yelled as she threw nets to either side, each containing the burgeoning wildfire and cutting down on the

heat radiating out of the blaze. " Spinny, baby, do your thing!"

" Here goes nothing," Spinnerella said, the phrase getting quite a workout this day, gathering the winds to her with difficulty. It wasn't in wind's nature to be controlled, it wanted to be free; but at her touch, the winds relented, and withdrew themselves from the fires below. The heat relented, sucked away into her vortex, long trails of fire sipped up like Spinnerella had stuck straws in the blaze.

" Go," Catra said, staggering a bit. " Go, run!"

The ambush squad poured out of the trees and ran for the gap, most cursing as they stepped on still-hot embers or tripped over burned but still present roots. One Hordesman recovered before the group was through- Kyle, of all people, who had apparently circled back around after he plunged into the fire. He raised one of the dragon-weapons and tried to light them up, but Glimmer teleported to him and slugged him out cold before he could aim at the fleeing militia, dropping him down into the ash and dust that was all that was left of this part of the Woods. Flutterina, in the lead of the group running down the safe corridor, paused to kick Kyle's prone form before continuing on.

" Grab the weapon!" Bow yelled from behind them, as he practically carried the wounded satyr. " I want to study it!"

Glimmer removed the harness from Kyle before they kept running, Catra stumbling in behind, muscles aching from hurling the truck. Sweat poured down her face; it was so *hot*, even with Netossa

shielding them and Spinnerella weakening the fires... one guy fell, and when he rose up, his arm was all burns, though he soldiered on, knowing reaching safety was more important than immediate treatment.

Catra ran alongside him, ready to grab him if he fell again. First Ones, this would have been easier with Swift Wind here, use their bond... but he was off scouting, trying to find any other Horde groups in the area.

" C'mon, Netossa, Spinnerella! We're out!" Catra said, hobbling a bit as she reached the edge of the gap. Agh, she'd pulled something hurling that truck...

As the two princesses stopped their shields, one big hand came down behind her.

" Need help?" the Troll chuffed, and Catra gratefully clambered up him, perching on his shoulder as the giant ran, long legs eating up the distance.

As the ambush squad escaped- to find out, later, that they hadn't lost anyone, though over sixty percent of them were wounded- Catra looked back at the Woods burning behind her.

At least it won't be hard to figure out where the Horde is now, she thought, and shivered as she looked at a single fallen Horde flag

the flame troopers had been carrying- and the great red dragon painted on it.

Chapter End Notes

For those who are curious about the Troll-

This isn't going to be a major focus of my fic, but I enjoy bringing in stuff from the old series. Everyone knows that the old, original series had its flaws, but it was in many ways quite advanced for its time, and if you enjoy a bit of cheese, it makes a fine snack. The music is also regularly surprisingly excellent, in an intensely 80s fashion.

Anyway, the Troll is from an excellent episode of the old series that was a lot of fun; they live in Spikeheart, and are generally shunned by Etherians. In this series, Trolls are a reclusive group with their own kingdom, having dealt with some racism from Etherians over the years; they are technically allied with the Princess Alliance, but generally keep to themselves in the northwest. A few end up joining Allied warbands, though, like the magic-wielding fellow here- and their propensity for bigness and magic is straight from the 80s series.

That's also where the species names come from; Twiggets were the race Madame Razz belonged to in the original series, so I decided it's her species here. It's also where the Magicat idea comes from, as well as their underground kingdom Halfmoon. Magicats still exist- Catra's species still exists- but they are kept under tight watch because of their penchant for rebelling. Halfmoon was a signatory to the original Princess Alliance, and actually has a runestone of its own- the Tiger Eye, which allows for shapeshifting- but was conquered before the Second Princess Alliance was revived at the Battle of Brightmoon.

As for the reference to Thunderians- you know what that's about. More to come!

Chapter 6: Catra, Princess of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

War Councils, decisions... and Catra's love for Adora, tested.

Catra, Princess of Brightmoon

The war room of Brightmoon was tense, as the gathered strength of the Princess Alliance, the brains of the Great Rebellion, looked at a map of Etheria. Even Catra, who knew no grand strategy, could see that they were in a bad spot; the great red dragon of Lord Adora's Horde rose high in the southeast, and blackened areas represented parts of the Whispering Woods that had been torched down to the last shrub.

It had been only a few weeks since Catra's failed ambush, but it seemed that battle was just a prelude to this all-out war; Adora repeatedly caught them out, knew where they were going, where they were coming from, and even when she *wasn't* catching them by surprise her troops continued the endless march, burning as they went.

" How is the Horde still a thing when Hordak's *dead*?" Frosta growled, the thought everyone was thinking.

" Lord Adora's apparently a total badass," Glimmer snorted angrily, looking at the map.

The map agreed with her assessment. The Horde had not fallen; it had *expanded*. After the initial period of quiet following Hordak's death where it seemed the whole house of cards might collapse, someone had reshuffled the deck- the Horde was rejuvenated. The troopers seemed different now, less robotic, more... *fanatical.* Lord Adora had become a combination of battle cry and prayer; her soldiers marched, singing her praises, and giving her epithets like a cult leader. Last of the First Ones, Heir of Hordak, the Dragon...

The Princess Alliance had managed to push them back once or twice. But Lord Adora had an almost sixth sense for when they were coming; many ambushes were ambushed themselves, and the Great Rebellion, used to defeating superior Horde numbers with sneak attacks and surprise assaults, was being forced into the pitched battles it did so poorly in. The rebel forces were better at guerilla warfare and flanking assaults than they were in the literal fire-fights Adora was forcing them into, bloody and prolonged affairs that turned the landscape to ash and brought the Horde's biggest advantage- numbers- directly into play.

It didn't help that these new tactics were being supported by a different grand strategy. The Horde had stolen from the conquered territories before, but it had been a formal thing, and slow- taking resources back to the Fright Zone, where they would be redistributed. But now... now Horde forces just *took*, they raided the locals as soon as they reached an area, and it was up to each Force Captain what they sent back home. It meant their supply lines were much smaller than they had been before, cannibalizing the local area for food, tech, and repair equipment; mostly they just sent stuff back to the Fright Zone to pay for fuel shipments for the flamethrowers they had grown so fond of.

Shorter, and less frequent, supply trains meant fewer things to attack for the rebels... and more Horde troopers available to guard each shipment, since there were fewer of them. The wave of bots never diminished, and now half the bots were walking firebombs and the other half were *invisible.* The Princess Alliance, which had just celebrated Hordak's death, was now suffering morale problems, as they realized that this would take more than just one last push... and the Horde was resurgent.

Frankly speaking, it was a bad situation all around.

" She has a weakness," Netossa said, frowning. " Everyone and everything does."

" The only weakness we've found is water," Angella said. " But Mermista can't be everywhere at once."

" We've *talked* about this," Glimmer groaned. Catra wanted to pitch in, assist her mom and her sister, but she was always awkward at these meetings, since that very first one where Angella had put her in pride of place at her side; she was bad at grand strategy, for all her talent at tactics.

" Where *is* Mermista?" Scorpia asked, innocent face worried.

" Recuperating," Sea Hawk said. " My dear sweetie is sleeping right now; I'm here as her representative."

“ I did wonder why you were allowed to be in the room,” Frosta snarked.

“ You wound me, small and angry child!”

Catra ignored them as Sea Hawk and Frosta began arguing. Poor Mermista... her friend had been dragged around the entire Woods, fighting Adora's army... she hoped her dear, salty comrade was sleeping well. Salineas had been spared much of the worst of the fighting, at least, aside from a few would-be pirate raids; the Horde's “burn it all” strategy was not particularly viable at sea.

(Sea Hawk, as ever, remained the only person to use fire at sea regularly.)

“ Lord Adora can't possibly keep this up forever, though, right?” Scorpia said. Catra glanced at her, but her distracted mind couldn't provide her anything more than a vague warning... something up with the scorpion princess. Always had been, since day one, something she almost knew, but Adora's constant aggression meant Catra was in the woods most days, not here at home...

“ No, but Lord Adora is much like the fire she seems so fond of; she will do great harm before her embers burn out,” Angella said, shaking her head, and her words refocused Catra away from Scorpia.

(Mentally, Double Trouble sighed in relief. Catra was getting closer to the truth every day; if it wasn't for how tired she was,

and how often out of the capital, she'd have caught the thief already, they were sure of it.)

" Fire... a wild and dangerous thing," Perfuma said, shaking her head. " She reminds me of an old myth from Plumeria, of the Fire Princess of Mount Candila... not that such a thing was real, of course, but Lord Adora's fury is terribly reminiscent of it."

" She was real," Glimmer said casually, focused on the map. " Mom told me."

" I... what?" Perfuma asked, blinking as she looked between the daughter and the mother.

" The Fire Princess was not a myth," Angella confirmed. " I was there. She was quite real."

" I... oh," Perfuma said, blinking twice as one of her childhood nightmares was confirmed to be quite real. " How... nice! Hehe... oooooh deaaaar....."

She trailed off, eyes wide, as she recalled everything her fathers had told her about the Fire Princess... and how she had a habit of getting bad little girls, and burning their flower gardens, a fate she had been *horrified* by. Oh, how she'd *hated* those stories! She'd had *nightmares!*

“ But that's neither here nor there,” Angella said, trying to refocus the discussion. “ The Fire Princess did what she did out of grief and foolishness; I'm not sure what drives Lord Adora.”

The words popped unbidden into Catra's skull.

(*I murdered a village; I've done... so many terrible things, Catra. I'm an insult, a freak, a monster, I'm evil... you can't just come here and tell me I'm a First One. Not... not now. I'm a monster, they'll never forgive me, I'm a First One and a beast and they'll never forgive me.)*

Catra knew the answer to that question- *guilt.*

But Catra swallowed heavily against those thoughts, her mouth dry as the Crimson Waste, and could not work up enough willpower to speak before Perfuma opened her mouth again.

“ I'm... I'm sorry, I hate to be so focused on this, but... but I have to know. There was a real Fire Princess?” Perfuma said, voice going up a few registers into a kind of squeak even as she tried to stay calm.

“ Yes,” Angella said, repressing a sigh of annoyance at the continued distraction. “ She lost everything to her drive for more power... particularly when she found out that, while she'd been studying, the woman she loved had died. She... broke, in her grief, blaming her own drive for power... and deciding that, if she'd *already* sacrificed the love of her life to her study, she might as well go for all of it. She was not in a good place, at the end.”

“ I... that is much more tragic than the stories I heard,” Perfuma said, quietly, trying to reconcile the power-hungry monster of her childhood fears with this grieving not-quite-widow.

Angella nodded. “ It *was* a tragedy... for her, and her people. I believe history distorted the tale later, but that was what truly happened. She lost her love, then decided she had given up so much for power that she might as well go for all of it- and in hunting godhood, she and all her people died burning and screaming.”

(The idle thought flickers through Angella's mind, the same idle thought that has always haunted her when she ponders the Burned Kingdom's last moments- did the Fire Princess die with her people? Or, worse, did she *live*, did her spell miss her, did she see the realm about her turned to ash, and end up starving to death alone in her melted tower? Was she ash, or were her bones laying lonely, either in the tower or at its base, if she decided to end it all swiftly? Angella has never wanted to wonder about that... but some part of her always has.)

“ First Ones forbid,” Perfuma said, shivering, and Spinnerella patted her shoulder.

“ But... that is neither here nor there. She did *terrible* damage before she finally died, true... but die she did, and now it's not a problem anymore,” Angella said, still trying to get the conversation back on track. “ There hasn't been a Fire Princess for some time.”

“ Wait... if the Fire Princess was real, and not a cautionary tale about the dangers of ambition,” Bow began, “ What about her Runestone? The stories mention a Runestone...”

Angella despaired of ever getting the war meeting back in hand.

“ I've never heard a story where she did,” Glimmer said. “ She might have been a Princess like Spinnerella or Netossa, they don't have Runestones.”

“ All natural magic princess here, baby,” Netossa said, giving herself a chest pound.

“ That's right,” Spinnerella said, smiling at her wife.

“ Isn't all our magic all natural?” Perfuma pointed out, and was summarily ignored by the rest of the council.

“ Wait, if there's a Runestone, we could use it!” Swift Wind announced dramatically.

“ That's not a bad idea,” General Juliet said, rubbing the scar on her nose. “ If it's available, at the very least, we should put it under guard so the Horde doesn't get its hands on it.”

“ I'm all for that!” Glimmer said, before turning to her mother awkwardly. “ Err, if there *was* a Runestone, anyway.”

“ There is,” Angella said. “ But it's dangerous. Something's... wrong with it.”

“ Wrong?” came Entrapta's voice from the robot she'd sent to represent her. It looked much like her Horde bots, save it was painted purple in honor of Dryll's heraldric colors- but that change didn't mean much to a group of people who'd spent three years fighting her Horde bots. Catra idly thought that Entrapta should have done anything to make them look different, but Entrapta, as always, was blind to the way others saw her actions. “ If it's wrong or broken, we can fix it... though I don't recall a Runestone connected to the network I used to attack Brightmoon.”

A moment's anger on Glimmer's face before she wrestled it back down. “ Wait- not connected to the network?”

“ No,” Entrapta announced. “ There are minor runestones on Etheria that are not part of the network the First Ones built, it must be one of those. Like the Tiger's Eye.”

“ Its power far exceeds those minor runestones,” Angella said. “ It is like one of the greater runestones in strength... but it is uncontrollable. What I suspect is going on with it- and I should point out that I only did a few minor calculations and research on the matter a few centuries ago, right after the Fire Princess' final spell obliterated her own people- is that it is artificial, not natural. The Spirit Ember is unstable... it repeatedly goes off, like a bomb

that can repair itself, devastating the landscape around it. That's why, despite the land being terribly fertile due to Mount Candila's ashes, nothing grows there.”

“ An ever-burning land?” Sea Hawk said, eyes wide. “ *Magnificent...*”

“ Calm down, Captain Pyro,” Glimmer snarked. “ Mom says it's too dangerous... though that doesn't mean we can't at least keep it out of Adora's hands, she likes fire too damn much to start with.”

“ Agreed,” Perfuma said, “ agreed most heartily! I do not like their flamethrowers.”

“ Angella,” Entrapta said, voice tinny through the bot's transmission. “ You believe the Runestone to be artificial?”

Angella nodded. “ It's not an outgrowth of Etheria's magic, but something else. Maybe a First Ones experiment, or an accidental byproduct of one of their works. I resolved long ago not to touch the Spirit Ember. Too dangerous, too much potential for damage. Only one with nothing to lose- or a great deal of courage and stupidity both- would use such a stone.”

“ I wonder if I could replicate the effect,” Entrapta pondered.

“ Let's table that for now, then,” Bow said. “ I have to agree with Glimmer on this one; we can't use it, but I'd hate for Adora to get her hands on it. Can you imagine the damage she'd do with a Runestone, given what she's accomplished with sloppy runework and subpar tech?”

“ It'd be awful,” Scorpia agreed.

(On the inside, Double Trouble fought a grin. Oh, their boss was just gonna LOVE this... a Runestone? And of *fire,* no less... What a *prize*, to offer the Dragon.)

“ Shame we can't use it,” Netossa said. “ Fire's a great weapon to control, as the Horde's new Lord is proving. I mean, most Princesses are weak to it.”

“ Wait, you keep tabs on the weakness of your fellow *Princesses*?” General Juliet asked in surprise.

“ More than tabs, I keep notes!” Netossa said, and pulled out a notebook, reading from it quickly. “ And not just Princesses, though they are definitely the first ones I recorded. Spinny's got a weak ankle from twisting it, I'm vulnerable to my lovely wife, and both Frosta and Perfuma are really flammable.”

“ I... suppose?” Perfuma answered, and Frosta shrugged.

“ It's true,” the punchy princess admitted.

“ I'm not particularly flammable,” Glimmer pointed out.

“ No,” Netossa agreed. “ Your weakness is crippling self-doubt mixed with overwhelming hubris.”

“ Hey!” Glimmer, Angella and Catra responded at the same time, the family all sharing the exact same look of wounded dignity.

“ That's like, *really* personal!” Glimmer said, a bit overwhelmed.

“ That was a bit much, Netossa,” Angella said in her daughter's defense.

“ What about you? You can't fight unless you can count your damn kills!” Catra retorted at her sister's attacker.

“ Without a kill count, how do I know I'm winning?!?” Netossa threw back.

“ Okay, let's- let's calm down, everyone,” Perfuma said. “ This has been, a *really* emotional meeting, so- let's refocus. One deep breath, and then we think about the *Horde*, and not various personal attacks or childhood nightmares that were apparently really sad!”

" Seconded," Frosta said.

" Motion carried," Angella said, putting a hand to her forehead. " Let's talk about the Horde and what to do, not... other matters."

As Angella finished placing her face into her palm, looking for wisdom there, everyone else took the suggested deep breath... except Netossa. Netossa stared at the map.. and her competitive mind had an idea. Horde forces were pushing forward everywhere along the borders... but that meant they had to be pulled from *somewhere.*

The idea solidified, and she smirked.

" I know what we need to do," Netossa said.

" Oh, this ought to be good," Glimmer said quietly.

" The Horde's spread thin, isn't it?" Netossa said. " Look- Hordak never advanced this fast. And we know from scout reports that the Horde has fewer troopers than it did, though the bleed of deserters has slowed down to a trickle right before this latest assault."

“ Yeah it's spread thin, but since they always know we're coming it doesn't matter,” General Juliet said. “ They have to have a spy in our ranks...”

“ It won't matter,” Netossa said. “ Not if we go in *fast*. The Horde's pushing all along the front. But the troopers fighting on the frontlines can't be *everywhere* at once. She's betting everything on putting us to the sword, and she's thrown away her shield. We can't fight them where they are strong, so we go where they are weak.”

She tapped the Fright Zone on the map.

“ We go for a decapitating strike. We go for Lord Adora. We take the Dragon's head!”

Catra's eyes widened, her breath stopped, as her mind interpreted Netossa's words literally.

(Adora, her head falling from her shoulders, eyes wide-)

“ No!” Catra said, before she could stop herself, a strangled half-cry past all the things in her throat and her mind.

(Adora's headless body crumpling to the floor, blood on the edge of the Sword)

“ Why not?” Netossa snorted. “ You've invaded the Fright Zone *twice*, and that was with Hordak keeping more forces at home!

Unless Adora suddenly recruited an entire new army, these troops have to be coming from *somewhere*. If they're here on the frontline, then it follows that they *can't* be at home. We blow past the assault and take out the leadership. The Horde falls apart without a commander."

" No," Catra said, but her emotions strangled her, she didn't know what to say, how to convince them.

It was Entrapta who spoke next. " Killing Hordak did not break the Horde," she pointed out.

" Because he apparently had Adora as a backup," Netossa said. " That's why they call her Hordak's Heir. But Adora probably doesn't even *have* an heir yet, or if she does, she hasn't had the time to train them, I'd bet. Even if someone else takes over, it'll take time- and give us a reprieve."

" You can't kill Adora," Catra finally said, almost cursing herself. Too simple, too honest, she wasn't making the arguments that would *work*, they wouldn't *listen* to her...

(Adora's head, eyes wide, one perfect, one ruined, looking at her from the floor)

Catra, the manipulator, the social expert, found herself flailing; right when she needed them the most, all her talents failed her, too wrapped up in the image of Adora, dead at her hands.

“ Catra, you... really shouldn't be allowed to make decisions relating to her,” Netossa said. “ Because *your* weakness is Adora. Don't deny it! Your attachment to her is hurting you!”

“ Fuck you!” Catra said, as Netossa's words echoed in her head, and were joined by Light Hope's.

(*Let go.* The AI's advice on what to do with Adora... but she *couldn't...*)

“ Yeah!” Glimmer said, joining in with her sister.

“ Catra!” Angella said, turning on her. “ Apologize to Netossa- and Netossa, apologize to my daughter, you're out of line.”

“ I'm saying what *someone* has to say!” the light Princess answered. “ We all know Catra's feelings towards Adora! How many times has she had a chance to put an end to this, only to spare her?”

Catra's traitorous mind coughed up a dozen instances over the last three years; Adora, beaten at Brightmoon, Adora inside the mirror world, Adora, after the portal. Her Adora, but she... she *couldn't*...

“ Catra has served Brightmoon with the greatest distinction,” Angella said. “ My trust in her is absolute.”

“ But am I wrong, Angella?” Netossa asked. “ Tell me my plan is a bad idea.”

Catra turned her dual-colored eyes to her mother, hoping against hope she'd have *something* to say... but Catra's heart fell alongside Angella's face.

“ I... concede your point, Netossa,” Angella said.

“ My Queen?” Catra said, and Angella's eyes were sad as she turned to her.

“ I'm sorry, Catra,” Angella said. “ But... striking at Adora... we can't keep fighting in the Woods. It's not working.”

“ You can't,” Catra said, her sense still fleeing her, her mind still full of...

(the wet *smack* of her bloody corpse hitting the ground, the pain in her eyes)

“ You don't understand,” Catra said quietly. “ Adora was... Adora saved me. She *protected* me.”

“ She ain't saving the rest of us!” Frosta said. “ I approve of Netossa's plan!”

Perfuma wrung her hands, and was silent for a few long moments.

" I... I'm sorry, Catra, I understand you've always valued your former relationship with Adora, despite... everything that's happened since... but the fires are getting closer to Plumeria every day. I have my people to think of. I must agree with Netossa," Perfuma said.

" Good! We'll get set up then," Netossa said. " We'll take out Adora within the week!"

Emotions welled up in Catra, so many emotions, so many sensations.

(the taste of stolen ration bars as children, the knife in her side at the Battle of Brightmoon, Adora's kiss in Mara's ship)

" No," Catra said, and realized, to her horror, that she was about to *cry*, in front of all these people... and knowing that, she did the only thing she could.

She ran.

" Catra!" Angella said, as she fled the room, to find somewhere private to weep.

(*Adora I love you*)

Chapter 7: Daughters of the Queen, Catra and Glimmer

Chapter Notes

We're back!

Adding more chapters because I had to split a few of these. Hope ya'll enjoy this chapter! It has Catra, sadness, Glimmer, Mermista, and spores!

Also spiders.

Daughters of the Queen, Catra and Glimmera

Catra is *gone*.

She has fled, taking Swift Wind with her, going who knows where; Swift Wind, who had been in the council chamber when she fled, and had went after her. No one in the Alliance knows what Swift Wind said to the She-Ra, or vice versa; all that anyone knows is that, a few moments later, Catra was flying away on Swift Wind's back.

The entire Rebellion command at Brightmoon is in an uproar over the news. Everyone's yelling, everyone's shouting accusations back and forth about She-Ra running off like that. Glimmer is nearly ready to chuck Netossa through a window, Spinnerella is busy defending her wife, and Scorpia seems suddenly convinced that Catra is going to go to the Fright Zone and warn Adora of their impending attack, a vicious and traitorous thought that catches like wildfire in the minds of General Juliet and some of the soldiers.

Angella wants nothing more than to run after her daughter- and she noticed Catra calling her *queen*, and that aches, it hurts in her chest- but she must stay, she must soothe tempers and fight these vicious rumors, defend her child.

But there are other options, and she decides to send Bow and Glimmer after Catra- her two best friends, one a sister, whom Angella believes can reach Catra, make her see reason. The Queen even thinks she knows where the second princess of Brightmoon ended up; her bearing indicated she was fleeing to Light Hope's castle in the northeast, not to Lord Adora's capital in the southeast, despite Scorpia's words.

It is in the middle of planning out this retrieval expedition that the Woods reveals itself to have the worst timing in history: a spore storm starts up, and it's not a small poisonous squall but a true storm of the century. Anyone who goes outside in that kind of weather will be burned to ash, as surely as if they were burned by the Dragon's new Horde and her flamethrowers.

No search operation can be mounted in such conditions; Rebel warcamps in the Woods pull out specially designed anti-spore canvases and huddle underneath them, hoping their protections hold out, Horde patrols in the woods resort to stealing the locals' anti-spore defenses, and said locals... said locals suffer the acidic burns, stripped by their invaders of their protections.

Worse, a storm of a more normal sort is approaching, too; not as bad as the spore storm, but bad enough, it will bring rain and lightning and wind with it, rendering the Woods even more

hopelessly inhospitable. It won't even help with the spores; the damage they cause is chemical, and water does nothing to stop it.

Queen Angella, who leads a nation, can do nothing but stare helplessly out a window, her people battening down the hatches against the bright and deadly lights, hoping against hope her daughter isn't out in the death trap the Woods have become.

-

In Light Hope's Crystal Castle, Catra curled up on herself, hurt- not on the outside, for Swift Wind had gotten her inside the Castle before the spore storm started, but inside, in her soul.

Swift Wind, faithful companion, sat next to her. Light Hope had disappeared a few moments ago; Catra wasn't sure why, except that the Woods had turned into a hellish storm of *acid* outside, what the hell? She'd heard about this from some of the Rebels, that the Woods occasionally did this, but she'd never seen it in three years.

What shit timing.

So, hugging her knees like a child, as the spores melted the world outside, it was just Catra, alone with her horse, who looked at her with a face full of worry.

“ Hey, you okay?” he asked.

She shook her head. Her mouth, usually her best weapon, stayed shut; this cat had her own tongue, she held onto it tight with fears for Adora and fears for her place in Angella's family and fears for every unspoken thing that had passed in her life.

In the face of that silence, Swift Wind tried again.

“ Look, I don't know... what all went on with you and Adora...” Swift Wind began, trying to talk about this thing that apparently was the *biggest* thing in Catra, this thing so fundamental she'd fled Brightmoon at the idea of them killing Adora. “ I can't comprehend it, honestly. Three years now, and she's spent every waking second either trying to kill you or trying to kill someone you know, usually multiple someones. Sometimes me! Except for when she stops to *plan* out how to kill you or someone you know. Or eat lunch, I guess. Do First Ones have to eat?”

Catra stayed silent, even as Swift Wind's words prodded her brain, made her *think*, and try to put into words the formless emotions that drove her, invisible and powerful like hurricane force winds.

“ So I guess... I guess I just can't figure out why you love her so damn much. What'd she do, that three years of attempted homicide just... rolls off of your back like water on a duck? And seriously, that *does* happen, I watched a duck in a rainstorm once just to make sure. I can't figure it out. Either the duck thing, or your love for her.”

“ Then why'd you help me run?” Catra croaked out, finally letting go of her own tongue, though she kept her face pressed against her knees.

(Her *useless* tongue; what worth were her manipulations, if they couldn't save Adora when it counted?)

Swift Wind shrugged. “ You're my friend,” he said, quietly, and somehow that was what got through to Catra; the quiet in the bombastic alicorn's words. Vulnerable, small... *genuine.*

She turned to see him, the alicorn as he was, not arrogant and silly, but here just as her friend. Her eyes were full of unshed tears; she was being vulnerable with him, too.

He recognized it himself, coughed and puffed up, resuming his booming tones, echoing loudly in the quiet of the darkened Crystal Castle, covering with volume both their moments of weakness. “ Also without you who would I have to use super special bond powers with?”

Catra found a smile somewhere inside herself to wear, just for him.

“ Thank you,” she said, and he simply shrugged. Other words clawed at her throat- this... this felt like treason, or treachery, or... or *something* bad, something wrong, even as she knew she could

have done nothing else, and she had dragged Swift Wind along with her, made him accomplice to... whatever crime this was.

Hmph. She turned back to her knees, pressed her face back into cooling darkness as she thought. Some fine manipulator she turned out to be; the one time in her life her words really *mattered* and she couldn't save Adora with them... could only panic, hurt, no one had ever suggested just... *killing* Adora before...

She wanted to cry. She wanted to scream at Netossa and all the other Princesses until they *stopped.* She wanted Adora to quit all this, come home, come to her, so she could save her life.

...And she wanted to apologize to Swift Wind, for dragging him into all this. But that last part, though it was the least, was still impossible; the words stuck in her throat.

She didn't apologize. Not for any of the *really* bad things she did. When she was little, she'd sworn to Adora she'd never say she was sorry; she'd cut Lonnie, sheer jealousy that Adora paid attention to her...

That memory stuck with her; cutting Lonnie, just because Adora had focused on her more than Catra, just for a second.

...She'd been in love with Adora all her life. *How have I not seen this before?* Catra wondered. She knew she loved Adora, but until

just now, she hadn't realized how deep that well ran in her. She thought her desire for her was... newer, something born as they both reached maturity, but even in childhood... at least on her side... there had always been... love.

Cutting Lonnie... that was jealousy, expressed by a child's mind with a child's deeds. She'd been in love with Adora all her days...

Knowing this, knowing how long she has loved her... how was Catra supposed to deal with her *dying?* Netossa had a point. Catra *hated* her for it, she was almost blind with rage against the Princess for daring to say it, but she had a point.

...Maybe she can capture Adora. Maybe... Maybe she can do something else. The gears creak, they don't want to work, her emotions threaten to strangle her... but she has loved Adora all her life. Adora *needs* her to do this.

...She should start with Swift Wind. If she can convince him...

She lifted her head up, looked at her companion in the darkness of the powerless Crystal Castle.

" I have to save Adora," Catra said. " She's saved my life before."

" Trying to kill you negates that," Swift Wind opined. " I mean, maybe it gives her like, one free go at you? But she's taken a lot

more than just *one* go at you.”

“ You don't understand,” Catra said heatedly, before deliberately calming herself. No, *focus*, this is important, you can't fuck this up. *Adora needs you.* “ I... sorry. My childhood... Shadow Weaver...”

Her jaw clenched. She didn't want to admit this, this ugliness, this terrible thing inside her, she felt... *ashamed*, as if it were her fault, somehow, that all she has suffered was due to some flaw inside herself. As if she deserved it.

...*But that was what Shadow Weaver told me,* Catra reminded herself. *Mom- Angella, she doesn't think that of me.*

She focused on memories of the Queen, the gentle moonlight of her regard.

(She called her Queen before she left; she hopes Angella did not notice. She hopes she has not pissed away all her happiness in a moment's panic; she hopes Angella will still let her call her *Mom* when she returns. Fear that she won't rises in her, strong as her terror for Adora, choking, but she pushes past it, she *has* to push past it... but still it tears at her, in the back of her mind, the idea that Angella will reject her, that Catra has ruined her happiness with her own hands.)

“ Shadow Weaver tried to kill me as a child,” Catra finally managed to stutter out, spitting the tumor out of her heart. “ Multiple times. She raised me and she tried to kill me. She held

me with her magic and she *hurt* me, Swift Wind, she hurt me until I would die, and only Adora's interventions saved my life.”

(*I'm alive because Adora protected me; she didn't do it perfectly and sometimes she didn't do it well but she tried, and nobody else ever* ***tried*** *before*)

Swift Wind's jaw moved, opened, shut, and he blinked twice.

“ I... I knew it had to be bad...” he finally said, shaking his head. “ But... she tried to kill you? You were a child...”

“ She tried to kill me more than once,” Catra said, and could not keep out the snarling hiss in her voice. “ She viewed me as Adora's pet. Not as her daughter. So she tried to euthanize me.”

Swift Wind shook his head, the normally bombastic stallion's mood so dampened by this news that he could only be quiet, and somber. “ Catra... I never knew... I... I knew you hated her, through our bond I could feel how *scared* of her you were, but...”

Catra shrugged. “ It is what it is. I owe Adora everything, because without her, I'd be a corpse.”

(They said cats have nine lives; Catras knows that, however many lives she has, she has them only because of Adora, she gained another one every time Adora stood between her and Shadow Weaver.)

Swift Wind shook his head. " Man, you lucked out with Angella's adoption, huh?"

Catra chuckled mirthlessly. " If... if I'm still her daughter after all this."

" You are," Swift Wind said. " She puts up with worse from Glimmer. Comparatively speaking, I'm pretty sure you're the good daughter."

Catra did not remind Swift Wind that Glimmer had the advantage of being Angella's *real* daughter, her mind looking at her adopted status and wondering if it was lesser, more fragile, if Angella, perhaps, would hold her to be less than her own true blood.

(Swift Wind sensed it down their bond but, showing wisdom, said nothing, though in his heart, less riddled with self-doubt, he thought that Angella would not let his partner down. And if she did, he'd kick her, Queen or not.)

" Regardless," Catra said, pushing that aside with an effort that cost her more than she cared to admit, " We need to get back; I... I have to convince them to spare Adora. It's all the same if she's captured, right? Captured, not killed."

Swift Wind looked at her, and sighed. " Gonna be a hard sell..."

" I have to try," Catra said.

Then Light Hope kicked back on along with all the lights, scaring the crap out of the two.

" Oh! Sorry!" the hologram said, but she seemed... nicer? " I do love visitors! Though I don't think I've met you before."

Catra and Swift Wind exchanged looks as the hologram smiled at them.

(10101010101010101001FRIENDSOFMARA10101010101010010101010)

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Sitting in the castle didn't sit well with Glimmer.

She was *supposed* to be out there, retrieving her sister... but her mom had said no. She'd almost argued with her, before reminding herself that she was trying to be more accommodating... and admitting to herself that, repairing their frayed relationship or not, Angella was *right*. The spores alone would make going into the Woods a dicey proposition; with a storm of a more normal kind coming through, too, it'd be impossible to find her.

So there was nothing to do but sit in the castle, listening as the spores sizzled against the shutters, waiting for the greater storm to start. Glimmer, realizing she was getting angry, had told Bow

she wanted to be alone for a bit. He deserved better company than an angry, glittery punchmonger.

In fact, punchmongering sounded pretty good right now, even if Glimmer was almost certain it wasn't a word- but you could be a warmonger, she'd heard Hordak and, more recently, Adora both called that, so clearly you could monger things. Why not punches?

So Glimmer was in the barracks, slugging a bag. She'd used to do this in private- she'd secretly installed one in her room with Bow's help- but her mom had recently told her she could use the barracks, like anyone else, aware that her daughter had avoided them because of the Queen's disapproval of her daughter's soldiering.

It felt... nice, to be doing this, here. Glimmer gave the bag a hard haymaker. Felt good. Her mom still didn't understand the urge to be a soldier, but she was being as supportive as she could be, and... well, hell, what more did you want out of a parent? They couldn't give you *everything,* they were people too.

This wasn't so bad.

Halfway through her routine, an unexpected guest stepped into the room.

" Hey Glimmer," Mermista said. " The castle's in chaos. Why are soldiers talking about She-Ra abandoning us and going on about

doom and gloom? Makes it hard to sleep.”

Glimmer exhaled a long breath. “ Hey Mermista. Scorpia said something stupid at the council- Catra ran off when we started talking about killing Adora. Netossa wants to go straight for Adora.”

Mermista nodded. “ Okay, yeah, I can see how Catra might react poorly to that. Kind of in love with her, though I'm not sure anyone told Catra. Or Adora. Might be able to end the war with a kiss if we could get them in the same room for ten minutes.”

Glimmer couldn't tell if Mermista was being sarcastic or not, given her usual monotone, and decided not to ask.

“ Yeah,” Glimmer said. “ Wish Scorpia hadn't suggested Catra would betray us though. That's just stupid.”

“ Yeah...” Mermista said. “ Kinda weird for Scorpia to say that, though. Sort of... too smart.”

“ What are you suggesting?” Glimmer said, as Mermista's eyes hardened.

“ Something's up with Scorpia,” the waterlord said. “ And I intend to figure it out.”

Glimmer considered it a moment, then nodded.

" I'm with ya, then," she said. " What's the plan?"

" A plan... from my books!" Mermista suddenly bellowed, actual emotion in her voice as she raised a finger dramatically to the sky, which obligingly spit out a thunderbolt at just that moment.

" I... wait, what, you're emoting, thunder, how?!?" Glimmer spluttered in disbelief.

" I practice... at home!" Mermista said, once more posing before a roll of thunder hit.

(Control over water had all *kinds* of applications... like sensing when a storm cloud was about to spit lightning.)

" Okay," Glimmer said, trying to recover from the dual shocks of drama and Mermista *actually having emotions,* " but... well, why the sudden urge to investigate? It's not like you to be so... energetic."

" Two things," Mermista said, voice back to its low, even tone. " Her fears about Catra sound a bit too intelligent for someone who was real sweet, but kind of dumb, and she spends a lot of time by herself. I'll be honest, that's not much to go on; maybe she's just a private person. Not like I knew her personally or anything."

The water witch shrugged.

" But Catra's my friend, and I'm not gonna let these accusations stand. That's what it boils down to. So let's see if Scorpia's hiding anything."

-

It only takes a few moments to realize that, whatever "rebooting" is- and being around Bow for there years gives Catra half an idea what's going on- it represents an opportunity to get some info out of the tight-lipped AI.

Catra grins, cheered up. *This* Light Hope is open, honest, and much less willing to lie to her. She doesn't know how long it'll last, but she'll take the opportunity now that it's here.

" I must admit," Light Hope said, " I'm surprised the Sword would choose a Thundercat."

" Wait, what?" Catra asked. " I'm a *what*? I thought I was a magicat."

" Etherians call your people Magicats," Light Hope said. " First Ones referred to them as Thundercats."

“ Why the name change?” Catra asked. She kinda liked both, but it was weird to have *two* names for one species.

“ The First Ones named them after their homeworld. ” Light Hope told her. “ They fought with the First Ones, the one nation among the stars who was their equal... at least until the Human rebellions began.”

“ Wait, they *fought* the First Ones?” Catra said, surprised. Were her ancestors the villains here? She hated to even *think* it, but given all the great things the First Ones had done... Not to mention it added a horrible edge to her battles with Adora, made it feel almost... *destined.*

(How would the bards put it? The one good Thundercat against the one evil First One... yes, that sounded like fate, that sent chills up Catra's spine, just thinking of how it would be talked about in the future. The heroic demon and the evil angel, a motif that repeated down the years, she'd heard stories like that on many a singer's tongue.)

“ Indeed,” Light Hope said. “ They battled them amongst the stars... they came from a world whose name was unpronounceable to First One tongues. Translated, it meant “land of words like thunder.” Words Like Thunder is a direct translation of their word for laws and codes; they held those things important. From that translation came the name the First Ones adopted for it- Thundera.”

“ Thundera,” Catra said. “ That's where I'm from?”

“ Originally, though you would be a distant relation at this point; it has been a long time since Etheria was colonized by your people. You are one of several sentient species that are non-native to Etheria,” Light Hope said. “ First Ones, obviously... Humans originate from another world, as do the Lunoth. Fungalts- what you call Eirelanders- satyrs and lizardfolk are natives.”

“ How'd Magicats- err, Thundercats get here?” Catra asked.

“ A warship crashed while fighting the First Ones,” Light Hope said. “ Initial reports said all hands died with the ship, but later reports showed numerous survivors. They resided primarily in the area north of what is now known as the Fright Zone, attracted to the Tiger's Eye, whose energies resonated with them.”

“ Is that why they were called Magicats? They had magic?” Catra asked. Light Hope nodded.

“ Indeed.”

“ What kind of code did they follow? If they were big on oaths and stuff... what was their code?” she asked.

Light Hope glitched oddly, then said, “ Four words, in order of importance; Justice, Truth, Honor, Loyalty. The Code of Thundera,

from which all their laws sprang. It was more than just a motto; it was their religion, the foundation of their spiritual beliefs.”

Justice, Truth, Honor, Loyalty.

“ That doesn't sound so bad,” Catra said quietly. Light Hope nodded.

“ They did not always follow it. No code is followed perfectly, no ideal ever translates to the real world perfectly... but many of them tried. It had many believers, and not just among their own people. Even the First Ones admired it, and the works that came from it.”

“ Why did they fight, then?” Catra asked.

Light Hope paused a moment, and her glitching stopped. “...That data cannot be found,” she admitted, in a curiously small voice.

“ Huh,” Swift Wind said. “ That's surprisingly convenient.”

“ Yeah,” Catra said, annoyed. “ What else do you remember?”

“ Oh, I remember how to make spiders!” Light Hope announced, far more cheerfully than that sentence warranted. “ Like this!”

Mechanical spiders popped up all around Catra, the same guardians she'd fought alongside Adora all those years ago.

" Oh, come *on!*" Catra yelled, as Swift Wind got up and readied himself to start kicking. " Why would you do this?"

" You asked me what else I remembered!" Light Hope responded in total innocence as the first wave attacked Catra.

-

Rogelio, Kyle, and Lonnie stared out of their commander's tent at the raging storm outside. They were in no danger- they'd stolen anti-spore matting from the locals, and all the Horde troopers were covered- and enjoying a late supper.

" Man, am I glad not to be in that," Lonnie said, sipping her coffee and polishing off the last of her toast. She'd discovered a fondness for the bitter drink since Adora's orders to begin enjoying the fruits of their pillaging labors.

" Same here," Kyle said. He had a cup of milk in front of him, alongside a pile of weird, green things called a... salad, Lonnie had heard some of the locals say. " Looks like shit."

Rogelio, who was busy eating an entire pig alongside a solid gallon of green tea, grumbled acknowledgment from the back of the tent.

The trio just sat, enjoying themselves, as the storm continued on.

Chapter 8: Four People of Etheria

Chapter Notes

We're back!

Gonna focus on this story and its sequel (tentatively titled Catra of the Stars) without updating anything else, though I might spit out a one-shot here and there.

Strap in; it's time for Catra of Brightmoon's story to end, and I've got a few twists and turns left before I get there.

(Also I have no idea when this one will end, so I removed the 10 chapter limit. I'm thinking 13 for now, but want to leave it open.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Four People of Etheria

Shadow Weaver watched the spore storm blossom from the safety of her host's lovely home, gazing at the little monitor that displayed a camera feed from outside. A robotic servant held a drink tray for her, and she sipped the fine Plumerian wine it offered while she watched the natural disaster rage on, the spore storm mingling with the rain storm to create a truly tremendous monstrosity.

(Ah, Plumeria. For a bunch of foolish flower-lovers, they had *amazing* alcohol. Shame it was in the warpath of Adora's Horde.)

The speakers on this device were excellent, much better than Horde standard; the sound of thunder mingling with the *hiss pop*

of acid as it struck the ground, the squeals of animals caught out without cover, the soft whispers of rain...

Lovely.

She shivered as she regarded the glowing motes of light, undimmed by the rain, backlit by lightning. Shadow Weaver she might be, but *this* light, poisonous and radiant? This would be a fine light to spin, even now. Her fingers twitched, muscle memory of old habits, long dead now, same as the woman who had once owned this body.

(Or perhaps not dead at all; she wasn't sure, wasn't aware of where the line between Shadow Weaver and Light Spinner could be drawn, where the woman she was and the monster that had entered her ceased to be their own individual entities and the merged creature came out of both. Sometimes she even wondered if she was only *one* of her forebears, the other consumed and defeated and absorbed into the survivor, or if both had died and she was the shambling revenant emerged from them. She didn't care to theorize about it much; Shadow Weaver *was.* Everything else was left to the poets and the philosophers.)

She let herself enjoy the view a few moments longer before turning away. Pleasure was the reason why anyone did anything, but business still called.

She turned away from the monitor, depositing her empty glass on the cybernetic servant's tray, and then left, heading deeper into the Crypto Castle. Entrapta's home had been terribly welcoming, and she observed the changes in it as she walked; small changes, really, but very telling, if you knew what they were *for.*

As she walked, small robot servitors- small versions of the spidery robot Entrapta had named "Emily" back in the Fright Zone- crawled all over the walls and ceiling and floor, spreading wiring, soldering new circuits, connecting the Crypto Castle together so it could be made into the command console for the Heart of Etheria. They skittered away from Shadow Weaver's approach, as was only appropriate; she strode among them like a queen.

What a lovely land, this kingdom of Dryll. Civilized, more like the Horde than the rest of the Alliance. No wonder Entrapta had defected so easily, when Adora approached her.

And the machines! So useful. There *had* to be a way to keep up production of these robots after Entrapta's inevitable demise; perhaps that Bow that Glimmer was so fond of? He *had* been an irritatingly resourceful opponent; perhaps he could figure out how the robots worked.

Still, that was a thought for another day. They had some time; Entrapta's death was some time off. She would either die in the final assault on Adora, her rage leading her to stumble into foolishness... or she would die a few days after, by her own hand, with nothing to distract her from her grief.

(Shadow Weaver *dearly* hoped she'd be there. Nothing was quite as amusing as a suicide.)

Thinking of Adora made Shadow Weaver shake her head. A shame her favored child had turned out so... defective. Useless, once it turned out she didn't have the Sword... you'd think a First

One would be more valuable, but alas, no. She'd slipped out of her kennel, and there was no way to chain *that* dog back up. She'd need to be put down.

(Another lovely thought; crushing her ungrateful brat... *yes*, that was sweet to think of.)

No, she should have focused on Catra. She'd always been oddly attached to the sorceress, despite Shadow Weaver's own best efforts; if she'd been a little gentler, added some carrots to the stick, she'd have the Sword yet.

Perhaps she still might recover it; Shadow Weaver had seen her, sneaking around Brightmoon Castle while the celebrations of Hordak's death were ongoing, watching her at her gardening and the subsequent meeting with Entrapta. Still wanting something from her, after all these years without.

Surely, once Adora was dead, Shadow Weaver could put *that* cat back in the bag. Oh, she'd need to be careful; Catra had left the Horde three years ago, after all. Four years, in a month or two. And her adoption had been the talk of Brightmoon for weeks after.

But that was no matter. Four years, compared to over a decade of raising her? Angella had not had nearly enough time to pry Shadow Weaver out of Catra's heart. She'd have time to worm her way back in. It wasn't like some new threat would arise once Adora was dealt with; a few Horde remnants, the inevitable splintering of the Princess Alliance once it had no opposition to hold it together, a resumption of life as it had been before the Horde. Nothing major.

(Sure, Hordak had muttered about his brother when he thought Shadow Weaver wasn't listening, but she doubted much would come of it. Hordak was always more broken than he was brilliant.)

A shame she had not known that Catra would get the Sword. All her fortune telling and future visions had said Adora would be *vital* to getting the Sword at last- but she'd never cast those portents and foretellings on Catra. No reason to- Catra was just Adora's harmless eccentricity, a toy she let her child have, and threatened to take away if she acted up.

But she'd fallen into the first trap of oracles, that of being *certain* you knew what the future was, instead of accepting that you could be misreading the portents. Adora *had* been vital to finding the Sword... because she'd kept Catra alive. Shadow Weaver had let Adora's First One nature and her own distaste for Catra blind her to what her portents had actually *meant*.

(Though some had seemed... so certain, as if, up until the last second, it *had* been Adora, as if the thin edge of accident and choice had interrupted fate's plan...)

A shame, but she was not the first prophet to misread the signs. She wasn't even the first to hunt the Sword; many had chased that tale, hunting the legendary weapon of Mara all down the ages. She herself had hunted for that blade as Light Spinner, chasing it all across Etheria even as her colleagues mocked her, desperate for its power to stop the Horde.

(Light Spinner had fantasized, in those innocent days, of becoming the She-Ra, of wielding power that had existed before the First Ones, a thing they had not *built* but *found*... and very quietly, sometimes, Shadow Weaver wondered how things would have turned out had that woman managed to find the Sword,

before her desperation drove her to Micah and the spell and all that came after.)

But first things first. Before she ensnared one of her wards, she needed to slay the other. Adora and Catra shared a bond, one that the sorceress suspected was going to mutate into romance, and *that* was a flower she needed to nip in the bud for many reasons.

As she mused, she reached the Castle's center, the twisting turns of the Crypto Castle's labyrinth easily crossed by one used to the Fright Zone's industrial maze. There, in a great room of monitors and circuit boards and computer banks, curled around her latest working, was Shadow Weaver' s erstwhile servant.

" Hello, Princess Entrapta," Shadow Weaver said. " How is your work proceeding?"

" It proceeds," Entrapta droned, dead and empty. Most of her former enthusiasm was as dead as Hordak; the new and unimproved Entrapta was a different, and sadder, beast. That was easily seen just by looking at her hair, the once-active web of tangles and movement now laying in a single vast, limp rope across the room, flat and still, the empty and discarded skin of a snake. Only a few individual strands still twitched to life, barely shifting the great mass, carrying tools to her hands as she continued to work on the console.

Shadow Weaver ran appreciative eyes over that console. The arming console, the trigger, one pull of which would hack the Heart of Etheria and bring it online and under their control.

(Under *her* control.)

So much power, and all they had to do was convince the Alliance to link up their Runestones...

The sound of flapping wings distracted her and Entrapta both. Imp, saved by Entrapta from the Fright Zone for some reason, flying over from some hidden alcove above them in the ceiling; Entrapta caught him in her arms as he flew to her, even lifting her broken faceplate to hug and nuzzle him like an infant.

Shadow Weaver, with an effort, did not react in disgust to the display of misplaced affection.

" Entrapta!" the Imp said in Hordak's voice, and she sighed as she heard it, clearly pleased, something like a smile on her tired face. She hadn't slept- the bags under her eyes were proof.

" How close is it to completion?" Shadow Weaver asked, prodding quietly. Entrapta was good at staying on task, but she had repeatedly failed to ask for assistance with getting material; Shadow Weaver had learned to ask, to get them herself so that Entrapta could keep working. Irritating, but she had served as a second in command to a broken genius before; she knew how to keep them on-task.

" It's almost done!" Entrapta said, some of her spark returning with Imp in her arms. Her hair was even more lively, curling

protectively around the little chubby baby-thing. Shadow Weaver suspected that Entrapta considered Imp something like her child, a sort of replacement for whatever children her and Hordak might have had- or at least, that was what she assumed before putting the thought away, because Shadow Weaver did *not* like thinking about Hordak fucking.

" Will you need anything else?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Entrapta shook her head.

" In a few days, this part will be done, and then I just need a Princess," she said.

" You will have one soon," Shadow Weaver promised.

" Yes, Glimmer," Entrapta replied, as she hugged Imp tighter, to the little mutant freak's joy. " I'd rather have Angella, but Glimmer is still connected to the Moonstone, so she's Princess enough for our purposes."

" She'll be along shortly," the sorceress assured her, even as her mind considered the problem of Angella's continued survival. She'd have to kill the woman. Not for any emotional or personal reason- they'd fought, of course, but that was merely business, not *personal.*

No, she needed to kill Angella out of a practical sense of pragmatism. Without her mother, Glimmer would have fewer people to rely on, and be easier to manipulate.

I'm fairly sure I know what buttons to press, the cruel mage thought to herself, *but the less support she has, the easier it will be.*

Micah's child... true, she lacked his brilliance, but she made up for it with raw power. And she had potential- she'd already taught her a few useful spells. Be the mentor the girl had never had- her rows with her mother were *famous*, after all- lead her, teach her.

Corrupting the youth was just a means to her ends, but she had to admit- it *was* fun.

She wondered what Catra was doing at this very moment.

-

" Light Hope," Catra said, very calmly, despite the fact she was shaking with adrenaline and rage both.

" Catra?" the AI responded brightly, cheerfully blind to Catra's body language.

“ No more spiders.”

“ If you insist!”

“ **I**- I do,” Catra said, starting at a bellow before forcibly quieting herself down. Wasn't the AI's fault she was apparently *oblivious* to the idea she was doing harm.

“ I second that arrangement,” Swift Wind moaned from nearby, shaking his head to get the last bit of dead spiderbot off of his horn. Scattered chunks were *everywhere*; Catra and Swift Wind's rampage through the swarm had made a mess of the whole Crystal Castle.

“ Ok!” Light Hope agreed easily. “ Shame, though, it's one of the few things I remember perfectly, along with... this, for some reason?”

The AI waved her hands, an an image appeared before them- a field of flowers, and two figures in it, one Light Hope, the other a dark-skinned woman. Catra didn't know the second woman, but she knew the Sword she wielded in her hand, knew the armor she was wearing; Catra wielded and wore the same things at that moment, after all, she was She-Ra too.

The ancient She-Ra stood next to Light Hope, who looked at her... who looked at her the way Glimmer looked at Bow, sometimes,

and Bow at her, the way that Catra- if she was being honest- looked at Adora, sometimes, even now.

(The way that she prayed Adora looked at her, even now.)

Understanding went through Catra like a light turning on. *Oh.*

" ...You loved her," Catra said, quietly, after a long moment. " That's why you remember this."

The AI's face fell into a frown, and she thought for a few long seconds.

" I don't remember," she admitted. " I don't remember her name or anything but this... and a sensation of... warmth."

That was so awful- the idea of loving someone, and not remembering them, remembering only that you *had* loved them- that for a brief moment, Catra wished the spiders would attack again.

They were all quiet for a long minute, before Catra, finally, said the only words she could.

" I'm sorry," she said.

“ Why?” Light Hope asked, and Catra just shook her head.

“ Forget it,” she said instead. Too much was going on there to explain to the AI while she was not herself. “ How much longer will the rebooting take?”

“ No idea,” Light Hope said. “ That function is not yet restored! But I- ooh, I do have a new one!”

“ Light Hope wait-”

The AI clicked her virtual fingers, and the image disappeared as gravity very suddenly decided that it, Catra and Swift Wind were no longer friends.

“ If I could kick you, I'd do it!” Swift Wind yelled in a rage as Catra sighed and Light Hope looked at them with no indication she knew she'd done wrong.

“ This is gonna be a *long* day.”

She hoped Glimmer was having a better day than she was.

-

As the Not-Scorpia punched her in the face, Glimmer had time for one clear thought before the pain set in and she was blown across the room- *well, at least they're not as strong as the real one.*

The plan her and Mermista had come up with had been a simple one. Glimmer had figured out what was going on as she and Mermista brainstormed in the barracks about the problem. Scorpia, acting smarter than normal, could be a lot of things, and the duo tried to figure out what they were.

It could just be the actual Scorpia acting as a spy- and turning out to be way smarter and sneakier than they'd assumed she was- but that just didn't seem realistic. Further- assuming the Scorpia they'd acquired in Elberon had always been a traitor- than the last either of them knew of Scorpia was what Catra had told Glimmer after the fateful raid on the Fright Zone that had ended in the portal and Hordak's death.

(Some part of Glimmer still didn't know how to handle what her mother had said, that Hordak's decision to die had saved her life, that in a very direct way, Glimmer owes the dead overlord her mother's life. She is not the wisest young woman, so she does not know what to *do* with that, save to put it away where she does not have to think about it.)

Catra had said that Adora had stabbed Scorpia in the throat in the Fright Zone, all while admitting to how much she hated her. Mermista had agreed that Scorpia probably wouldn't work for her after that.

So if Scorpia wasn't the type to do this, and wouldn't have worked for Adora anyway even if she was... what did that leave?

They'd been stuck until Mermista pointed out that, in her detective novels, shapeshifters were perennially popular. It wasn't much to go on, but it had the benefit of being Adora's style; the woman who made such extensive use of invisibility and illusions? Yeah, shapeshifting was right up her alley. She *was* a mage.

...But so was Glimmer, and she... she might have a spell for this.

(*The truth-telling spell, the one I modified during the ambush...*)

And that wasn't much to go on either, but it was what they had, and Glimmer had a gut feeling that she was right.

(Admittedly, her guts lied to her often, but she does what she can with what she has. It's all she can do.)

Thus the plan. Speak with everyone, and make sure that everyone they spoke to was who they said they were. After all, if the unknown enemy could look like Scorpia, who knew who *else* they could look like?

So they'd went around the castle as a detective duo- keeping in sight at all times, because that was the *first* trick shapeshifters liked pulling in every book Mermista had ever read- and while Glimmer prepared her magic, Mermista asked everyone they met very specific questions about their pasts, things only they could know. No shapeshifter had the power to know *everything* about

the people they imitated; shapeshifters had to rely on a much stronger power than mere magic to pull off their artifice, that being lying, but even the best liar couldn't fool everyone. This meant there were holes in their disguises that a smart person could pick at; Mermista's books all agreed on that.

(Glimmer rather wished their foray into detective work was not based entirely on Salineas' popular fiction, but again- the best she could with what she had.)

There was *absolutely no need* to ask those questions given Glimmer had literal, actual *magic* to test their identities, but Mermista was having so much fun that Glimmer couldn't bring herself to interrupt her.

She was also learning some fascinating things about her fellow princesses.

(Particularly about Perfuma, whom Mermista and Sea Hawk had apparently caught in a compromising position with an old boyfriend... in the crow's nest... of Sea Hawk's boat... after he'd set fire to it. According to her, she'd just been having so much fun that she hadn't noticed! Mermista had to save both.)

It had went well, confirming identities, further giving everyone code phrases to say to confirm it was them- albeit Bow had descended into unwarranted terror at his sudden idea that he might be the spy and not know it, since he was apparently one of those people paranoia hit like a truck.

Still, they'd finally gotten the Princesses and other rebel fighters in the castle aware of the situation, even her mother as she worried

in her council room, looking out the window, hoping Catra was safe.

An unncessary hope; Glimmer knew it would take so much more than just a thunderstorm and acid spores to kill her sister. Catra was a *badass*, this was nothing to her.

(She admires her, even as some part of her hurts; but Catra is the coolest person Glimmer has ever met, and some days, when her eyes are not so green, she is almost giddy, knowing someone so great is her sister and her friend.)

They were only missing “Scorpia” and Flutterina, neither of whom they had seen yet. Glimmer had to admit, she was kind of worried for the little one; her mom and Netossa would be fine, but Flutterina wasn't a fighter, despite how beloved she'd quickly become among the Rebels. The Princesses, Glimmer included, all *adored* the Lunoth recruit, though her hero-worship of Catra tended to rub Glimmer the wrong way; still, she was the single most helpful person any of them had ever met, always willing to run errands or do anything they asked of her. Glimmer hoped she was okay...

But in their search, they'd finally stumbled on “Scorpia”... just as they were finishing up a message, most likely to Adora, on a communicator in a storeroom on the third floor.

“ Oh! H-hey?” the imposter said, then sighed as they saw the look on Glimmer and Mermista's faces. In a much different tone of voice, they said, “ I'm assuming you saw that.”

“ We're on to you, imposter!” Glimmer said, preparing her spell.

That had led to her current circumstance of getting punched.

The punch and thought finished at the same time, and Glimmer was knocked on her ass. Mermista jumped back in surprise and summoned water from one of the castle's pipes, destroying a nearby wall in the process as her magic ripped the fluid out, but the water blast missed- the shapeshifter changed form too fast, becoming too short for it to hit.

The form they took was rather familiar.

“ Well!” Glimmer's own face and voice announced as they looked at her, the spy grinning at her with her own smile. “ Gotta say, of the people in this castle, I thought Catra would be on to me first!”

“ Looks like you were wrong,” Glimmer growled as she got up. “ Why did you turn into me?”

“ Why indeed? I really shouldn't take the form of the *lesser* princess of Brightmoon,” Not-Glimmer said, chuckling as they dodged Mermista's follow-up water blast, swiftly punching the saltwater wielder in the gut. “ You're not much, after all; just a glittery brute with worthless wings.”

" Says you!" Glimmer yelled back, even as some part of her flinched back at having her status thrown in her face with her own voice. She'd had those thoughts, sure, but to hear someone *else* say them... though her voice sounded weird to her ears, the way she heard most people's did. She teleported into a punch that was swiftly dodged, and teleported back to dodge the returning kick thrown with her own thighs.

" Lucky me!" Not-Glimmer announced- and turned into her sister, perfectly matching Catra's form. " I can change into someone better!"

" Oh, *fuck* you!" Glimmer responded. Mermista attacked again, but Not-Catra ducked and grabbed something from a nearby bag- one that she'd seen Scorpia carry into the castle, claiming it had all of her personal possessions in it. They hadn't checked the bag, just happy to be up a Princess, and know that Adora was down a Force Captain, buying the spy's words at face value.

Well, at least that screw-ups not on me, I wasn't even on that mission, Glimmer thought to herself. *That's Catra's mistake.*

(She wished that some part of her didn't relish that fact, that her wounded pride was not a little pleased that her amazing sister had screwed up; she had wrestled that green thing down, but she had not killed it, it was still *there*, some part of her was still so *jealous* of Catra's greater competence, greater talent, greater *everything* compared to a glittery brute with worthless wings)

When the Not-Catra rose up, they had the bag in one hand and a Horde stun baton in the other; Mermista, not expecting it, got caught, and the shock ran through her, short-circuiting her

nervous system. Glimmer teleported to her aid, punching even as she reformed, but the shapeshifter had expected this and dodged; only a swift teleport away kept Glimmer from joining Mermista, and as her body changed back from light, she saw the double agent stab Mermista with the stunner again.

" Mermista!" she yelled as the saltwater sorceress passed out. Shit, this was *not* how this fight was supposed to go!

" Don't worry, your friend's gonna be just fine!" Glimmer's theatrical opponent announced- before shapeshifting into the unconscious woman's form.

" See, she's up already," they said in the saltwater wielder's dry tones, before giving an uncharacteristically energetic laugh. " Ah, Double Trouble, you've outdone yourself."

" Double Trouble? Is that your name?" Glimmer demanded.

" Good for a spy and a changeling, isn't it, darling?" they asked.

Glimmer didn't answer, just tried to telepunch them again- but no dice, they were *fast*, faster than anyone Glimmer had ever met except Flutterina, and Glimmer barely dodged the stun baton with her own teleport away.

...She was running low on energy. She'd been training beforehand, and in the excitement of hunting a traitor, she hadn't thought to charge up- she didn't need the Moonstone to cast spells, after all. Drew on ambient magic for that, not the Runestone.

So now, when she needed it most, she was a low battery.

(Another way in which she is so inferior, the only Princess who must suck energy like a vampire from her Runestone in bursts, suckling like a child at the teat of greater magic- she *hates* herself for it, for all her failings)

The spy ran for the door, stun baton and bag in hand.

" Tata, darling! I'm off to see a much *better* wizard than yourself! Adora'll be annoyed that I was found out, but it's not like I didn't give her some *delicious* info!"

Fuming, Glimmer gave chase as the treacherous one fled, still trying to figure out what she'd do. Her first thought, surprising even herself, was a simple question.

What would Catra do?

Her mind spat back a bitter rejoinder. She'd win, that's what; not... not screw it up, like Glimmer always did. Glimmer couldn't

even pull all the bombs out of Mara's ship without getting herself nearly killed, much less anything else.

(Why had she thought she could do this? She should have gathered the other princesses with her, instead of thinking her and Mermista could handle it. She should have known she wasn't enough, she never *is*.)

Double Trouble fled across the castle, and Glimmer chased on foot, running as hard as she could; but it wasn't enough. Being able to teleport since she was a baby had not encouraged Glimmer to take the greatest interest in aerobics, but Mermista's favorite hobby was swimming... and those were the muscles Double Trouble had copied. Between being much more zaftig than Mermista and half a foot shorter, Glimmer just couldn't keep up.

(She never could, not with her mom, not with her sister, not even with this damn spy)

What would Catra do?

Catra would... do something clever, and make it look fucking *effortless.* She'd be so *cool* doing it, too. Catra was a badass, and worth every inch of the great stature being the Princess of Power gave her; she would have handled this problem already. Her mom was a hero and her sister was the coolest person in the world and Glimmer just... wasn't like that.

She wasn't like them at all. She only had her guts and her courage and her willingness to risk her own life; she had nothing else. She was no clever warrior. She was barely a mage.

Even if she knew what her sister would do- and she could probably guess, she'd worked alongside her for almost four years now- that wouldn't be something *she* could do. She wasn't good enough.

She only had three teleports left and her own hands, and a spell that took too long to cast while they were running.

So she ran, and somewhere in-between two hard, hurting, in-drawn breaths, watching Double Trouble pull ahead, she had another thought, one that sounded like... like her sister, like Catra, like the way her best friend spoke when she was trying to encourage her.

*What would **Glimmer** do?*

Teleport and do something brave and stupid at the same time, prob ably; no knack for smooth heroics, but ballsy sacrifice plays, Glimmer had *those* down pat. Just her guts and her courage, and a willingness to risk her life, after all; as she'd told her mom, she felt alive when waving at Death...

An idea.

Dangerous. Stupid. Risky.

But for every fault in her, real and imagined both, Glimmer had *never* been a coward.

(*Thank you, Catra*, she thinks, drawing courage and comfort from that voice like her sister's inside her; she is so jealous of her that is easy to forget that she *loves* her, too, that she was her best friend and her sister, even before her Mom made that official. The only person closer to her is Bow, and that's mixed with other things too, warm and hot things that Glimmer doesn't want to admit for fear of destroying what they have; she loves her, even as she envies her, both at once.)

She took a deep, deep breath, and held it.

One teleport.

The spy was expecting her to attack them with a teleport, certainly; she doubted they'd expected her to appear *above* them, falling on their back in a flying tackle, on them before even their swift speed could react. Glimmer held her breath in with an effort as she impacted, and concentrated for a second jump; she had to do this before they reacted, before the stun baton got them, before she lost her breath.

Two teleports.

Into the air, high above Brightmoon, a teleport has far *up* as she could possibly manage. They began to fall as soon as they were flesh again, both of them heading for an inevitably fatal conclusion with the ground below. They were so high up that,

looking down, she could see the curve of the world, the tops of mountains and clouds, could see the great thunderstorm that covered the Woods and Brightmoon Castle, too far below to hurt her; a glance to her sides showed her Despondos, the dreary yet peaceful nothing that surrounded Etheria.

She felt like a god, in that moment, she felt greater than any angel; she felt she could stretch her hand out over all Creation, if she wanted, dictate right from wrong with her will alone. This was higher than she had *ever* dared to go, she felt almost reborn; she waved once more at Death, and her soul laughed inside her.

The spy was still disoriented, and still in her hands; she shoved, hard. The spy was pushed away from her, but to their credit, immediately tried to save themselves; they tried to change, shapeshifting into a bird, dropping their bag and baton both as they did so.

But it didn't matter. The air was too thin up here, too thin to support life. The spy choked, and Glimmer grinned as she cast her spell, hands dancing the runes, using the stored breath inside her in short bursts like arrows from a quiver.

Her spellcasting was perfect, despite the wind whipping into her face, despite the fact her guts wanted to fly out of her; she felt she could do no wrong, now, she felt like a queen, the rush thrilled her and filled her and she was *alive, alive, alive,* the way she'd told her mom about, when they first spoke their truth to each other. Should Death choose to take her now, in this moment, she would shake its hand; she had seen the world as a god would, and she had no regrets.

(She can almost see him in this bizarre, impossible second, she can see the lord of the clearing at the end of the path; she almost thinks the reaper approves, that he waves back, in this strange, hallucinogenic moment, as she falls from heaven towards earth. She thinks that maybe he likes people like her, who do not fear him; so many do, and he despises them for cowards, but the brave he accepts as friends, and she thinks perhaps *he* will shake *her* hand, the day she dies, however long or short that day is in the offing)

Her aim was perfect, as everything about her was perfect, in this time of glory; the rune washed over the shapeshifter, and they *changed*, into a lizard-like form, almost chameleon. They were beginning to pass out, and Glimmer would join them soon; she had no more breath in her lungs.

But she did not need it; she had all she needed. She tucked her arms and legs in, shot down like a missile to catch up, put both her hands on her target.

Three teleports.

She judged the distance perfectly- six feet above the floor of her mother's council room, where she hoped someone would be, looking out the window, praying for Catra's safety.

She slammed down, riding on top of her target, who let out a tiny sound of pain as they impacted. They would live, of course; her teleports canceled inertia, so they did not fall all the way from the top of the sky. Just six feet. Survivable.

Not painless, though, and having her land on top hadn't helped either. She grabbed their arms and pulled them into a submission hold as they made unintelligible noises of distress.

" Glimmer!" her mother said, jumping in surprise, wings bunching up like the freaked-out bird she kind of was. " What- what?!?"

" I found the spy!" Glimmer announced triumphantly to her mother- and Netossa, who was in the room as well, equally surprised. " Also Mermista is sitting stunned in a storeroom upstairs, third floor, seventh room on the right from the stairs, the one those two butlers keep making out in."

" What?!?" Angella said, so confused that she didn't know what to say, looking frankly kind of stupid; and seeing her perfectly poised mother like that was so funny that Glimmer burst out laughing, laughing even as Netossa came over, she rose up off the still-groaning Double Trouble, and a net of swiftly-spun light tied up their spy.

" Yes!" Glimmer said with a triumphant shout as she rose up. " I won!"

The council was recalled in the wake of her heroism. Everyone was informed of just what had been going on. Glimmer- and Mermista, once Perfuma managed to heal her with some swiftly grown herbs that smelled like citrus and cinnamon- were the heroes of the hour, the Great Rebellion both horrified to find out

they'd had a spy for so long, and elated to have caught them at last. Double Trouble was put in a prison cell- well, a spare guest room quickly reaved of pillows- and Glimmer made sure to remind everyone that the spy had been trying to get them to turn on Catra, pinning all doubts as the act of a traitor.

People grumble and mumble about it, but knowing a Horde spy had been trying to get them to doubt the She-Ra was an antidote too strong for the poison; her sister's good name was slowly being restored among all who had questioned it, so that when she came home, it would not be to whispers of treachery.

All in all, a triumph.

(Flutterina was the last to know; she'd been napping, it turned out, and was rather sad to have missed it all.)

Even as her mother praised her, and Glimmer basked in it, a thought still rattled around in her head, casting a pall over her elation.

*What did the spy tell Adora... and what is she going to **do** with that information?*

-

Adora sat alone in the room, her communicator off, as it had been for some time now.

She sat alone, and she shivered.

Not with fear.

No, with... *delight.*

Her mind whirled and whirled, just... thinking.

Comprehending.

Understanding.

Her scars itched; she let them, did not put ointment on. No, for these were wounds from light, and she... she *wanted* them to hurt, right now. It felt... appropriate, almost like a gift to light and fire, just like the information she'd received.

There was another thing like her.

There was one more thing that the First Ones, those ancient saints, her angelic forebears, had made *wrong*. There was one more work of their holy hands that had twisted in their grip, and fallen down into the fires of hell.

Adora was not the only burning failure of her people.

There was another.

She had a sister, and her name was the Spirit Ember.

It was almost too perfect. She wanted to doubt, to be honest, she was inclined to dismiss it all as a trap. A Runestone of Fire, for the young woman who was *already* called the Dragon? A First Ones experiment gone wrong, for the First One who had gone wrong?

No, too neat. Too pat. It almost seemed like some kind of clever ruse on Angella's part, a story told to a spy to trick a foe.

But no Etherian ever spoke of the work of the First Ones as an *abomination*. Up until the moment Double Trouble made their broadcast, Adora had thought that she was alone, in being the only sin of her people; no Etherian ever spoke of the First Ones' *mistakes.* They were sacred, holy. To speak of them doing wrong... she had never heard that before, it would not come to the mind of a *liar*, and she should know, she ranked high in the list of deceivers, she was the Princess of Lies.

And that detail... made it sound like the truth, which did not have to sound nice to its listener's ears, and often did not.

Her people had sinned. Not once. *Twice.* Adora herself was just one sin.

She had a sister.

She shivered again. She was going to go find her sister in sin, she was going to reach her, unite the mistakes as one. Her sister had been alone for such a long time; she should know that her fellow mistake was out there, that she was not on her own.

Adora would bond with her, and together they would burn all of Etheria.

And when it was done, Adora would stand on the ashes and laugh, laugh, *laugh*, because if she could not be the hero of the story, she would be the villain, and she would be no mere footnote. She would not be an enemy beaten in a chapter or a book. She was not comic relief nor a side character; she was the *villain,* this was her story as much as it was Catra's!

It was going to be so... *beautiful*.

(The hellhound inside, howling, raging, barking hellfire breath; her rage, her *rage*, do it, do it, *do it! Burn the world!*)

...But after a moment, a thought intruded.

If I burn the world, what happens to the Horde?

Stupid thought. Distracting thought, from her apocalyptic visions. It was so **beautiful** to imagine herself as the right hand of Armageddon, it made her heart sing to envision her making a funeral pyre of the world; she would be happy to burn to ashes, if the fire of her burning could put all Etheria to the torch. She had burned once, after all, it wasn't so bad; she knew, as so few knew, that there was a strange *joy* to it, to letting the light in, to becoming the light. All light came from something, somewhere, *burning,* after all, so what greater joy could there be? To burn was to reach the divine, was to become closer to the light, to burn oneself was to become something more.

(*the light the light the light the light the light the light the light the light the light the light*)

But what happens to my people?

Still that thought, intruding, smothering the fire, raining on her parade. That dark and cold place inside her, that was a little like Shadow Weaver, but more like... something else, some different, purer kind of night, something that would only tell the liar the truth she did not want to hear.

She tried to retreat, snarling at these thoughts; she wanted to just... give in, listen to the hopeless, helpless fury inside, bark and howl as the world ended in fire.

But still it was there, the dark never ceasing to speak.

If you burn the world, you will be murdering the Horde again, it whispered. *Like the portal, all over again, save you will not have the excuse of a moment's heat to justify it. And while you may wish to die... do you really want to kill Catra?*

Of course she did. Catra was the enemy.

(*I love you Catra*)

You cannot lie to yourself, no matter how hard you try.

" I've done it for over three years now," Adora argued with herself.

And look where that has gotten you.

" Shut up," she snarled, but... had to admit... the other voice had a point.

Not about Catra, but about the Horde.

I'm right about both.

" Ignoring that," Adora whispered to herself, some piece of lucidity breaching this new strangeness inside her to remind her that talking to herself was *not* the sign of a healthy mind.

...But she had promised herself, when she preached to her people, that she would lead them. That she would not betray the Horde, not again; she was... tired of betrayals.

Duty is the meat and drink of a Hordesman, came the old words, on the dark thing's tongue.

Duty, yes, duty, do your duty and die fighting for the Horde's glory, for *Hordak's* glory... for Adora's glory, now. Do your duty by the Dragon.

...A real duty went both ways. If they had a duty to obey her, she... she had a duty to *lead*, too.

She took a breath.

She hated this.

She wanted to... she wanted to burn. She hungered for it, to burn at last, to die, to finally rest and be at peace, the way she had not been since Catra fell from the skiff, since she murdered that village, since she shot Catra in the Crystal Castle.

(*Catra, I'm so sorry*)

But she had a duty.

She took another, deeper breath.

The heat of the hellhound inside her quieted, muzzled by this cold thought. Duty.

She... she had a duty.

Breathe in.

She was a guard dog. Not... not a hell hound. A guard dog. A watch dog, for her people.

She had a duty.

Breathe out.

...But that didn't mean she couldn't burn *some* stuff. The Horde had *enemies,* after all; she didn't have to leash *all* her pyromaniacal urges.

Yes.... she'd... she'd burn *them*, and let the Horde grow fat on the ashes.

She grinned as her thoughts settled, feeling oddly good. You'd think the cold, intrusive thoughts in her head might have ruined her mood, but...

She actually felt better. She had a plan, and it wasn't going to betray her people.

Yes, villain she was, but that didn't mean she didn't have *some* rules. She could have rules, though the very thought of it sent a strange and trembling query through the bottom of her heart.

(To act for the good of her people was to *be* good, wasn't it? But if she was evil, she couldn't be good, but if she was good, she couldn't be... it *hurt,* to think of the dichotomy, to think thoughts at last that she should have considered almost half a decade ago, thoughts that might have saved her; it *hurt*, and so she tried to ignore them, even as the dark part of her soul, where all her truth lived, kept thinking them.)

So she'd have rules and her fire both. She *would* go find her sister, and she would become one with her... and all the Horde's enemies would fear the Dragon's fire.

She rose up, already planning, with the long practice Shadow Weaver had drilled into her mind. Mount Candila... her new

destination. She would have to find it on Horde maps, and go there- not soon, not later, but *now* , she had to go *now* .

It'd even protect her from Netossa's plan. Adora had to give the light-summoning princess credit; she'd guessed accurately. Adora's defenses were lessened at the moment, since she'd thrown the solders she had on guard duty and put them into the advance units. Had Netossa arrived without warning, flown in to decapitate the Horde in a great strike, she might have killed her.

But now? Adora wasn't even going to *be* here- and by the time she got back, she'd have a new way to protect herself.

What good timing. What *inexplicable* timing.

This had the feel of... destiny.

A weapon for me, to oppose the weapon for you , Adora thought, thinking of Catra and the Sword, the stupid fucking Sword that started all this, that led to this... this life she lived, the kennel that trapped her.

(the village, the innocent, all the things she's done; she is so sorry, she hates herself, she wishes to die, but... she has her rage, and she has her duty. She clings to them like the lifelines they are. Her fire and her Horde, they are all she has left, all her decisions have left her with, and she will fight to defend both)

A weapon for me, to oppose the weapon for you, she thought once more, like a line in a beloved song. *And we will meet each other as equals at last.*

She left her office, to chase the sweet smell of smoke across the waste, and unite with her destiny.

I'm coming, kin of mine.

Chapter End Notes

Next time: the Ghost of Mount Candila. The Fire Runestone, Glimmer and Shadow Weaver, and a revelation.

Chapter 9: The Ghost of Mount Candila

Chapter Notes

> Two trips towards light- a light that heals, and a light that ruins.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Ghost of Mount Candila

A Horde cargo skiff, quickly redesigned for swift, long-distance travel, set out from the Fright Zone, carrying only a few supplies and a single passenger.

The passenger tried not to remember another journey on a skiff, long ago, with another, when she was... younger.

(*when I was new, when I was innocent, when I had not razed Thaymor to the ground*)

But there was little else to think of. Adora was alone, with no company save the wind, which carried the faintest smell of citrus, rendered just a little too sharp to be pleasant. The remnant scents of the Whispering Woods' acid spores, mingled with ozone from the thunderstorm that had hit at the same time. While that storm was- finally- starting to die down, at this distance it was little more than something to make Adora's nose crinkle.

Adora's route, thankfully, did not wend through the storm or its aftermath. Planned out quickly with a few Horde cartographers, her trip would dace along the eastern edge of the Forest, just off the coasts that Salineas controlled. There was no *safe* route around the Whispering Woods, but this route was as secure as it could be; too far from the deepest part of the forest that Brightmoon ruled, in the area where Horde armies and independent Rebel warcamps faced off in regular skirmishes, and hopefully the latter would be keeping their heads down due to the acid spores.

Still, the trees that made the acid spores were concentrated most heavily in the deeper parts of the great and awful forest, and the thunderstorm hadn't reached the easternmost edge of the Woods; at last *some* of the Rebel warcamps would be active.

Still, Adora wasn't too worried. The skiff's speed and armor meant she could outrun most such camps, and her magic and armor meant she could outfight anything she couldn 't outrun.

No, the real problem was Salineas. The Horde had a fleet of its own, of course, but Adora had it watching her supply routes in force; Salineas had free reign of the rest of Etheria's waters, and to be frank, she suspected the only reason the Horde still had a fleet at all was that Salineas didn't want to risk the loss of so many sailors. Of all the nations she battled, Salineas was the one who had been most successful at resisting her; save the attempt on the Sea Gate during the first year after Catra left, Adora had always been on the backfoot when dealing with the waveriders.

(Maybe that fit, maybe that was the way it was meant to be; she was the Dragon, after all, she was all fire and light. Of course the abyssal nation, kin of dark waters, would prove her most powerful

foe, even if the moonlight queendom was the most troublesome, and had the loyalty of her most... *personal* enemy.)

She did not fancy her chances should she run into a Salineas battleship, but there was no other way north that did not either loop west around the Woods- which would take far too long, and require her to resupply at other bases along the way- or plow straight through the Woods, which would have been too risky *without* acid and lightning falling from the skies. She'd just have to take her chances.

Besides, it's not like Salineas patrolled *all* the coast *all* the time- they had a whole ocean to watch. Adora was sure she could slip by undetected.

Lonnie and Rogelio had been less convinced. They'd both argued ferociously that Adora should take a squad with her; Lonnie had even been bold enough to yell at her for trying this stunt when they were too far away to physically stop her, angry face filling the trackerpad's screen, and Adora had felt rather touched at her concern.

(Kyle was off punishing some Hordesmen for minor derelictions of duty- and it was still weird, to think that Kyle was one of her best when it came to maintaining discipline among the troops.)

She'd let her rant, then said she'd take it under advisement before turning the trackerpad off. What was it Catra had said, once? *Better to ask forgiveness than permission.*

(Not that Catra ever asked for either, being wise enough to know Shadow Weaver would deny both.)

Still, Adora could acknowledge that Lonnie and Rogelio were right, she absolutely *should* take a squad... but this felt... it felt right, to go to her sister by herself.

This was a matter for the First Ones' twin mistakes, and no one else.

(And another stray thought, *maybe if I'm by myself someone will kill me, maybe I can finally stop* ... but she shoves it into the dark, and she thinks of it no more.)

The tirp would take about a day, and for much of the first few hours, the skiff would be on autopilot. This early part was well within Horde territory, and safe enough to let the computer do the work. She'd switch to manual later, but for now?

She'd distract herself with some light reading.

At her side, hastily grabbed from his personal library, were Hordak's own notes about the Spirit Ember. Hordak had, thankfully, been diligent in keeping his records organized; it had been easy to find this small, handwritten journal, lovingly bound with deer leather and Horde iron.

She opened it, finding the first two pages filled with his flowing, graceful handwriting. Hordak had taken time with it; it was almost like Plumerian calligraphy, these delicate, embellished lines, thick

black ink on the old, yellowed paper, each careful letter adorned with little flairs and flourishes.

She wondered why he'd engaged in such a distraction. It didn't seem like him; she'd have assumed his personal writings were as dry and direct as the man himself. But this was... almost art.

She added it to the pile of things she wondered about Hordak, a tall pile that only grew with time. She had so many questions, and hadn't had time enough to read his personal library to see if it had answers.

Did he know I'm a First One? What had Shadow Weaver told him- she knew, obviously, but had Hordak? How had I come to the Horde in the first place?

(And somewhere, in the back... *can I go back, could I leave, return to the place of my birth, my people, could they maybe save me from myself, make me new again?*)

But she hadn't been able to read much more than his latest reports, all typed, not these... lovely handwritten things, that he kept stored in his personal quarters, which had been as spartan as she'd supposed- a bed, the large metla bookshelf containing his personal notes, a small drawer containing what few undergarments he wore beneath the armor, and an extra bed that she later realized was for Imp. Nothing more, and they'd stayed that way; Adora had not moved into his old room.

She'd killed the man; the least she could do was... leave his things be.

(And maybe that was why she always found an excuse, to not look through his notes; to bother his things after ensuring the portal would kill him felt too much like desecrating a grave, and she did not feel like adding yet another sin to her endless list.)

She hoped that- if she survived this trip- that his notes would have answers. She'd have to find the time, or make it; she had... so many questions, none of which she could ask anybody, now. Shadow Weaver was in Brightmoon still, and Hordak was dead at her own hands.

Perhaps it was justice; in flipping the switch, Adora had ensured that she would lose all her answers when Hordak died saving the world.

(From *her*, a thing that cuts her like a knife; in opposition to Adora, even Hordak could be a hero, and what does that say about her?)

But while she would never know any of those truths, she could settle for the lesser truths about the Spirit Ember, her erstwhile, much-older twin sister in sin.

She began to read as the spore storm and thunderclouds began to expend the last of their strength over the woods to her west, the brilliance of Etheria's moons finally cutting through the storm.

-

Two hours later, and far to the west, another girl Shadow Weaver had raised and ruined sighed. The skies were clear, the storm and spores both gone after what had felt like a year or more. It was a beautiful, sunny day, life crawling out of its burrows and hiding places, safe now that the storms were not to occur again within the decade.

Catra wished the bright, sunny day didn't *scare* her as badly as it did.

" Guess we... gotta go back," Catra said softly, and swallowed hard. No more putting it off. No more delay.

" Yep!" Swift Wind said with oblivious delight. " Onward and upward!"

Back... but there was nothing for her here. Light Hope had turned herself off once she had finished "rebooting", claiming she needed further repairs; Catra didn't trust that. Something was off with the AI; maybe she'd have Bow or Entrapta give her a hand, see what they could do with the AI. Something was... wrong.

She'd probably be able to focus on it more, if the looming confrontation with her family was not distracting her so much...

“ Stop worrying,” her alicorn friend said, bumping her gently with his snout to knock her out of her train of thought. “ Angella hasn't tossed Glimmer out, you'll be fine. You're the golden child, literally, you turn gold when you do stuff.”

Catra couldn't quite help a grin at his words, even as she pushed his head away gently with one paw.

“ Dumbass,” she accused, even as his words *did* help a little bit.

(Weird to think of herself as the golden child; that had always been Adora, before, in the weird best-friends/sisters/something else that she and Adora had always been, the horribly fucked-up tangle of their lives.)

“ I'll have you know I'm the smartest horse you've ever met!” he said.

“ You're the *first* horse I ever met, I didn't even know what you *were* until Glimmer told me,” Catra responded.

“ Yes, and then you were so overwhelmed with awe by my nobility and graceful bearing that you immediately turned me into a super-horse!” Swift Wind declared, posing dramatically as Catra shook her head.

“ Still wish I'd done what that one She-Ra did and got me a dragon instead,” she mumbled, as she leapt on his back. “ Dragon

would have been cooler.”

“ And you seriously expect me to pack you all the way to Brightmoon after *that* insult? Gonna buck you off halfway while we're a mile up.”

“ You wouldn't dare,” Catra said, smirking at him as he took off. “ Besides, I'd just land on my feet. Cat, you know.”

“ You've done weirder!” he agreed cheerfully as he soared above the Whispering Woods.

They settled into silence, Catra still stuck with her own thoughts. She knew, in her head, that things would be alright; she had served Angella for three months shy of four years now, had been her daughter for four of those months now... and a daughter for most of it, if she was being honest with herself, if the way Angella had taken care of her, listened to her, meant anything.

But her heart weighed almost four years in her Queen's service against a decade and a half under Shadow Weaver's thumb, and the scales tipped too far towards darkness. The oldest part of her remembered cold eyes and colder hands, and saw cruelty in every confrontation between parents and children; some part of her was... *terrified.*

(Too many times had Shadow Weaver hurt her, *hurt* her, all for reasons even a child's mind knew were not enough to deserve such pain. Some part of Catra would always be there, in the long hallways of the Fright Zone, scared to death... which made it

more perverse, more *grotesque,* that some part of her would always love Shadow Weaver, too.)

She tried to focus on the feeling of Swift Wind's mane in her hands, on the strength of the Sword on her hip, on the simple joy of flight.

Mom isn't Shadow Weaver, she told herself, and tried to believe it, in that part that would never stop being Catra the Child, who lived only because of Adora.

Adora...

...Adora needed Catra to go to Brightmoon, and convince them not to kill her. Adora needed her.

Catra drew strength from that conviction, from the knowledge that she could finally repay Adora all her kindnesses in the Fright Zone.

I'm alive because of her, Catra thought. *She'll be alive because of me.*

And with her courage screwed to the sticking place, she faced the future resolute.

-

Hordak's writings were not extensive on the subject, but they *did* have some meaty tidbits to them.

The skiff carried along, crossing a broad, flat expanse of coastline, the breeze off the sea pushing the ozone and acid stink back, leaving only the pleasant tingle of salt and water on the nose. Adora busily speed-read as the skiff carried along; this was starting to leave Horde territory, and she needed to finish up so she could switch to manual and fly the skiff herself. If trouble hit, she needed to already be in control- she didn't fancy trying to change gears while under fire. Her left eye was closed, too bleary to bother trying to manage, her right dancing the words on the pages.

These were older notes, which showed; Hordak had not taken over the Fright Zone yet, and was so far working with the Scorpioni King in Horror Hall while he rebuilt his ship into a factory. The early part had been dominated by prosaic discussions of the history of the Spirit Ember and Hordak's speculations about its possible flaws- apparently he had been familiar with First One technology to a degree, though he complained of how cryptic he found their tech.

But this latter half was dominated by more distant speculations, dropping hints and phrases and words that Adora found... fascinating. Stars... suns... space. None of these things she knew of. Etheria had moons that provided bright light for daytime within Despondos, but no... stars, no suns. Just the void, which was empty but clean, simple, endlessly peaceful.

So many ideas, so many new words, tossed into this journal so casually... if she hadn't known that Hordak had never intended anyone else to read it, she'd almost accuse him of teasing his readership.

And last, but best, this strangely beautiful vision he talked of, his brother's empire, which he spoke of in glowing terms. An entire universe, many worlds like Etheria, all united by one light, one law, marching in lockstep to the future.

It sounded... nice. Adora had never met Horde Prime, Hordak's brother, yet she felt a strange sort of kinship with the great god of light and order she read of in Hordak's journal, whom he spoke of in glowing tones.

(Though, in the back of her skull, she thought she saw green light, when she read of him; green light, why did she see green light)

She needed to know *more.* She'd have to make time- figure all this out. Maybe the Horde's future lay in its past... she'd have to do *something* after she conquered all Etheria, after all.

That was a problem for another day, though.

She put a hand into a small basket next to her, withdrawing a sandwich prepared for her by Scorpia 2's lizard girlfriend, who had become the best cook the Horde ever had; an easy victory, given

that this was the first time they'd ever *had* cooks, now that Adora had relaxed the restrictions on food Hordak had imposed on the troops. As she munched on the snack made of stolen bread and stuffed with pillaged filling, she flipped through the pages.

From my research on Etherian... "magic"... it seems that the instability may simply be a side effect of the Runestone's power being in the wrong place. Most of the Runestones the Princesses tap into- at least, based on my own observations of the Black Garnet- are native to Etheria, arising as natural formations at intersecting lines of magic that already existed on Etheria prior to the First One's arrival. Some of the research I've read calls them "ley lines", though this backwater planet is so mired in myth and mysticism that they seem to go through repeated cycles of mythologizing their forgotten past, reinventing the wheel, and then forgetting again.

Prior to the First One's arrival? That was weird to think... why call them First Ones, then? That would make her people the Second Ones at best.

...*What **is** the name of my species?* Adora wondered for a moment, as she finished off the sandwich and took a swig from her canteen to wash it down. *I doubt they called **themselves** First Ones...*

But thinking of her noble forebears, whom she had betrayed so much, hurt, so she refocused on the page before her.

I have no connection to Etheria's magic, which I am certain is a First One technology that the ignorant folk of this world have simply forgotten, as they seem to have forgotten most things. So this is mostly speculation. Had I landed in Brightmoon, I would be able to ask Queen Angella, a supposed immortal... but the Scorpioni of Horror Hall, while so far accommodating to my desires, are not a scholarly inclined people, perhaps because their pincers, while magnificent for combat, make it difficult to hold a pen.

Most of what I've found come from either their sages, who I find to be mostly interested in ingesting hallucinogenic substances, the writings of the scattered people under their protection, and a few long, strange conversations with a very tiny sentient who called herself Madame Razz, and who kept trying to feed me pie.

It has been... trying.

Adora's mouth twitched upwards in a smile at the idea of Hordak, new to this world, being irritated by its inhabitants. Irritation of her own started, as her wounds began to ache; with what had become familiar muscle memory, she withdrew salve from the basket and applied it before returning to her reading. It went over the myth of the last Fire Princess once more, but this time with Hordak examining it for possible clues as to the real story, always circling the same basic plotline- a Fire Princess, who lost the one she loved, and fell into despair, her sorrow burning her kingdom to ash.

Adora sympathized.

(*Catra, Catra, I love you; You're a First One;* and the portal, her pain, her *pain*, fueling her rage, half of her burning as she desperately sought to end everything just so she would finally stop *hurting.*)

Adora moved past that rather sombre thought, reading futher as Hordak theorized about the Spirit Ember's instability.

Still, this knowledge of ley lines leads me to a theory. Assuming it is true, the Spirit Ember may have been unstable prior to any personal failings of the Fire Princess who controlled it; this previous instability would have amplified any loss of control, particularly if the Fire Princess had trained to be so connected to her Runestone as the tales say.

Several of the sages- in-between spouting half-baked "wise sayings" and eating whatever is nearby- have said that the Fire Kingdom had no ley lines at all.

I believe the First Ones were experimenting with a Runestone that relied entirely on ambient magic, the way Etherian spellcasters do. If I'm correct, the lack of connection to a stable leyline would make it prone to fluctuations as ambient magic ebbed and dimmed... perhaps if brought here, it could parasitize the Black Garnet's own connection to the ley lines, and be stabilized in that way.

Hmm. *Good idea, Hordak.* She was planning on bringing her sister to the Fright Zone anyway, but this made the idea even more attractive. Wasn't like the Black Garnet was doing anything useful;

she had no power over it. She'd *tried,* but it had rejected her, almost snapping out with a thin thread of red lightning.

(And in her head, she heard the word *usurper* , but she wasn't sure if that was the Runestone or her own mind gone whirlagig again.)

The rest of the journal was mostly small dissertations on possible uses for the Spirit Ember, primarily powering the forges Hordak planned on building once he'd taken the Scorpioni's territory from them; but his thoughts on his future treachery were... odd. His writings were short on the matter, but he seemed genuinely grateful to the scorpion warriors for saving him when he crashed, and he seemed to think that imposing the order of his brother's Horde on them was a just reward for their good service.

His betrayal of them came from good intentions, strange as it was to think that; he even planned to keep their name for their kingdom, the Fright Zone, a name they'd originally been given by their enemies for their terrifying battle prowess and now wore with pride.

Huh. Well, she had *one* thing on Hordak, at least; she was an honest traitor, if nothing else. Hordak's writing indicated he had no idea that what he was doing was treachery at all. He even mentioned how much he liked them, which was just... odd, considering how he was planning on subjugating them.

At least I know it when I stab someone in the back, Adora thought. Not much of a moral victory- rather like putting the bar on the ground- but she'd take what she could get.

(Bad guy she might be, *evil* she might be, but she... she could have some rules. That was the way of it. She could have rules. Right?)

But towards the end, as she was reading through notes that were decades old, she found something much more recent; something new, dated much later than the other entries, something that took her breath away.

The First One child I found... she is a possible option for taking control of the Spirit Ember. But... she is just a child. Not fully trained yet. Too risky, right now. She is apparently shaping up to be a fine Force Captain, according to Shadow Weaver; reviewing Adora's test results, it seems the sorceress is telling the truth. Adora is doing well, which... pleases me, in some obscure way.

I see no reason to risk her life on a plan with no real chance of success. Perhaps I shall bring it up to her when her promotion is made, and I tell her what she is; but I do not think I will make it an order. If she is willing to volunteer, than I will enact my scheme, but otherwise, I find it... unwise, to risk the only First One in my forces this way.

I still do not agree with Shadow Weaver's decision to not tell the child, but Adora is turning out to be a good Hordesman; perhaps Shadow Weaver was right, that knowing she was something different from her fellow Horde so early on would cause issues in her training. Such a lonely heritage is a heavy burden.

I should know; I am my brother's kin, after all, and living up to his legacy on this backwards, nowhere planet has proven terribly difficult. I would not wish for Adora to labor under it as she finishes the strange processes of childhood and puberty. I do wish I'd managed to perfect my cloning devices. It is so much simpler to raise an army that way... but biology was never my strong suit. Engineering suits me better.

Better for her, to be raised as an ordinary Hordesman first, and find out how unique she is later, when she is better able to carry that weight.

Still, I think she will be able to do so. She is doing well, by all the reports, and I am glad to have her among my forces. A First One will be a great boon to my Horde. The First Ones were strong enough to face my own brother; perhaps it will please him, when he arrives, to know that I had a First One working for me, loyal to us.

I wish I had more time to devote to her, that I was not so busy with all my other work; a curious sense of... responsibility, comes over me sometimes, when I think of her. Not always. Just sometimes. A sense of... wishing that she would do well, hoping the best for her, the same sense I feel when I see Imp accomplish a task for me. A sense that finds fulfillment, knowing she is doing well in her training, that she is succeeding.

I am not sure what it is. A sort of... fond sympathy.

Perhaps it is simply because I know how fragile she had been. She had been so small, in that field. Small, and alone, the way I was, when I first arrived here; a refugee, like me.

Worse off, even; while this world's air is too thick for me, too full with its strange contamination, this... "magic", I am at least a trained soldier, and the kind Scorpioni soon found me. She was just a baby, totally helpless, desperately needing assistance. She would have died in that field, if I had left her there.

It makes me... glad... that I saved her. Glad to know she is growing strong, that she has moved from such helplessness to such strength. This world is so dangerous, so disorderly, so chaotic, compared to the glorious perfection of my brother's empire. This place is too wild, too dangerous; it needs taming,

It needs order.

Soldiers like Adora will provide that order, in the future. I am glad I could save her from this planet's wildness, and take her to safety within my smaller Horde here. Shadow Weaver is dangerous, but she was a teacher in Mystacor before coming here. I have given orders for Adora not to be harmed; she will be safe, despite Shadow Weaver's sadistic leanings.

I have other projects to work on, and will focus on them. I simply do not have the time to devote to her right now.

But in the future, when there is time, perhaps we will sit down and talk. The First Ones **were** some of the only truly worthy opposition my brother ever had, after all, and one of the few foes he bothered to remember after crushing them. Adora seems to carry that spark of greatness, and I would like to nurture it.

I would... like to see the little one I saved do well.

Hordak had written this about her... he'd found her in a field. He'd wanted her to do well.

Then why leave me with Shadow Weaver? she thought. *I was the child she preferred, and still I...*

(the cold fingers on her temple, the worry of what inside her was herself and what was Woven from Shadow, that had led her to trust her hellhound, embrace the rage and the fury, and all the foolishness that has come of it.)

She had... she had so many *questions*. Had he not known? Had he thought his word was enough? He mentioned cloning, seemed to think of puberty as a foreign thing; did they not have children where he came from, had he simply misunderstood? Or had he thought it would... what excuse had Shadow Weaver used on Catra, time after time, when she dared voice how unjustly she was treated...

Ah yes. *Toughen you up.* Was that what Hordak thought Shadow Weaver was doing?

...And... and why was she in that field? *What* field? Had her people abandoned her, had they- had they somehow *known*, had they seen what she was, had they simply been unable to kill her themselves and so left her in a field so exposure would do it for them? Had she been abandoned at her birth, had they known she was a monster even as a babe?

She had so many questions. Questions she would never know, now, just more things she threw away when she flipped that switch and the portal ate the sky. She... she would never know her own origins, now, had... had destroyed any chance to...

She...

She cried, and lied to herself that the blurriness in her vision was just her bad eye, as she tried to stifle the tears.

-

Shadow Weaver sighed as the Dryll transport reached Brightmoon in good time. Dryll transports were swift, but being transported somewhere was always the most indescribably *boring* kind of task. It didn't help that this particular transport was designed for safety first and comfort never; it was not unlike being transported in the world's most heavily-armored garbage can. Entrapta's one consideration towards comfort was a system of shocks so that the heavy walker's scuttling would not cause passengers motion sickness.

Still, they'd made it, at least; Shadow Weaver observed from a viewscreen inside as the transport reached Brightmoon's stables, located to the great castle's eastern side, the great behemoth stopping as a guard approached.

" Halt, and state your business," the guard said, transported to Shadow Weaver's ears from outer microphones in the transport's shell. The guard's tone was the formal kind of bored, and her stance said she was just doing her job; she clearly knew who it was, and was just going through the protocol.

Personally, Shadow Weaver thought that a waste of time; she was not fond of pointless bureaucracy. She'd had enough of *that* in the Horde. She reached over to the control for the AI-driven transport's outer speaker.

" It's Shadow Weaver," she said. " I believe I'm expected."

" You're on the list," the guard said after a swift glance at her own trackerpad. " Go on in."

The guard waved her in, and the walker marched inside without further need for direction by Shadow Weaver. Clever woman, Entrapta- Shadow Weaver wished she had five of her.

(Hordak *had* been experimenting with clones... something to think about for the future.)

The walker parked in the stables, which, due entirely to Etheria's bizarre, non-uniform technological development, was the catch-all term for any transport- her walker was sitting next to a set of horses, a parking garage for the small trucks Brightmoon farmers favored, and even, bizarrely, a dog-sled team from the Kingdom of Snows, who had the privilege of their own little chilled pool to keep themselves cool in the summer heat, a privilege one dog was *clearly* enjoying from the look on its face.

The transport walker opened, and Shadow Weaver stepped out, stretching her back. She wasn't subject to aging anymore, but she could still get a cramp; the Dryll transport walker Entrapta had built, designed as little more than an effectively upscaled model of her spider-like robots, was not great for the back.

As she popped her spine back into alignment, she heard commotion and excitement from the gate she'd just passed through, and several guards moved swiftly to the stables' entrance from elsewhere within Brightmoon. A swift glance in that direction revealed why; in the far distance, just barely visible to the naked eye, could be seen the only alicorn on Etheria, whose rider could only be one person.

" The She-Ra is returning!" one guard said as he passed Shadow Weaver.

" Somebody tell the Queen!" another said.

“ I'll-do-it!” Shadow Weaver heard an excited voice say as a tiny pink figure blurred forward with impossible speed. The little figure, revealed to be a terribly pink Lunoth, hopped up and down, and her words were strung together so fast they almost devolved into gibberish. “ Oh, Queen Angella's gonna be so happy! I-gotta-go-tell-her!”

“ Go for it, Flutterina!” a guard announced, reaching down to pat the little darling of the Rebels.

“ Okay-here-I-go!”

The Lunoth, blitzing past her, excited and cheerful; Shadow Weaver ignored her, pondering why Catra had left in the first place.

“ I'm glad she wasn't the traitor,” she heard a guard say, perking her interest.

“ I knew she wasn't!” one announced, a big smile on her face. “ I told you guys to keep faith with her, Catra's awesome!”

“ You've been wrong before,” an older compatriot replied. “ Didn't you think she wanted to fuck the Queen, back in the day? Must be weird now that the Queen *adopted* her.”

Laughter as the accused guard spluttered a defense, the guards in high spirits to see their champion return... but those words about a traitor...

Well, it wasn't like Shadow Weaver could be blamed for being a bit *curious*, after all that.

Finding a hidden place- easy, with the guards distracted- Shadow Weaver cast a quick spell and became one with darkness, resolved to follow Catra, and see what was going on.

-

Adora sighed in irritation as she looked at the floating fortress through her binoculars.

Of course.

Of *course* there'd be a Salineas warship in the area. Not a full-on battleship, just a destroyer, but that was still a *lot* more firepower than Adora felt comfortable fighting. It was fairly far out to sea, at least; still in sight of the land, but not close enough for Adora to make out details with her one good eye alone.

Still, even as she spun light about her to make the skiff invisible (and tried not to wonder if Shadow Weaver, once upon a time,

had ever spun light the same way), she cursed internally. This was the *last* thing she needed...

Invisible, she snuck forward, keeping her binoculars on the destroyer even as she nudged the skiff forward slowly, slowly enough that the tell-tale heat distortion wouldn't be noticeable at a distance.

A few moments passed like this, Adora inching forward, the destroyer sitting there at anchor, Adora trying to see if they'd spotted her. The crew was all on deck, but they didn't *look* like they were actively looking for anything. In fact, they seemed to be standing at attention; the captain giving a speech, maybe? What was going on?

She observed, even as she kept going north. Solemn faces, some people crying, either openly or with that terrible quiet dignity that some people had... a flag at half-mast. Two long rows of sailors, all in formal wear...

When they brought out the corpse, she understood.

The dead was a Sea Elf; one of the decapodian kind, cousin of the crabs that walked between land and sea. He was carried on a medical stretcher, no cause of death obvious; but Adora was a soldier, too, she knew that death had all kinds of ways to sneak into a military life. He was dressed in Salinean formal officer's attire, and a captain's hat was laid reverently on his chitin chest; his larger arms bearing warclaws resting beside him while his smaller arms were gently crossed under the hat.

Another Sea Elf, this one wearing a formal uniform, stepped forward, and after Adora adjusted her binoculars, she could see the octopodian woman was speaking; she wished she knew what she was saying. She could only hear, very faintly, music over the sound of the surf, a long low sad thing; a moment later, she spotted the player, a Salinean human woman with a veena, which she made weep with emotion so strong that, even at this distance, Adora could hear the sorrow of it.

The Sea Elf spoke for a time, long enough for Adora to start putting comfortable distance between herself and the ship. She spoke, and then the veena stopped, and they all saluted, one last time. With great reverence, a Salinean human, decorated with images of the sea gods they worshipped, tied a short chain to the dead captain's legs, locking it with a padlock shaped like a small anchor.

Then, with great ceremony, they threw him overboard, and let the waves reclaim him, and the veena sang him down once more.

The distance between cultures was very small for Adora in that moment- this was a funeral. A ceremony for the dead. Quite different from how the Horde did it, she reflected, but... not *that* different, in its own way. The Horde buried its dead in fallow fields on the factory-farms, in formal funeral ceremony, in great batches all at once. The dead they would place in the ground naked and without a casket; the only thing a Hordesman took with them into the dirt was a small packet of enzymes in a breakable capsule, one that the deceased's best friend would crack open and place in their mouths. In the course of months, the enzymes would break their bodies down into nutrients for the soil, so that when the field

entered crop rotation once more, the flesh of their body could nourish the plants that, in turn, were processed into rations for the Horde.

Every Hordesman's last and most solemn duty. Hordak, ever busy, had nonetheless attended each funeral ceremony, watching the mass burial of those of the Horde who died in defense of the dream of unity.

Adora had always found the idea rather... nice. Even now, knowing what the Horde really was, she... liked it.

A duty that transcended even death. Contributing to the cause even after one had ceased to be.

That wasn't so bad.

She managed to get away without being seen, the ship resuming normal operations and sailing off, but a thought hit her an hour later as she skimmed the coast again.

Salineas relied on fishing for its food; they farmed, but the sea gave them most of their bounty. Perhaps the water burial was their way of giving back, too. No flesh went to waste in the saltwater, after all; the fish would get a meal of their own, from one who had fed on them in turn.

She found herself approving.

Onward she went, feeling solemn, as she headed towards that burned, blasted waste that, once upon a time, had been the forested mountains and fertile farmlands of the Blazing Kingdom.

-

Catra's return home was... a lot friendlier and more excited than Catra had thought it would be. She figured she'd return to the ugly glares of suspicion (*to her mother's cold eyes*), but instead, from the moment she and Swift Wind landed at the stables, every soldier she'd met had seemed pleased to meet her. A cavalcade of remarks, all along the lines of "sorry to have doubted you", or "I always knew you were still on our side!" came in from all comers, some given with congratulatory pats on the back or sheepish expressions.

(" I'm sorry I doubted you," one had said, following with, " I'm also sorry I thought you wanted to fuck the Queen", which was just... what? In what world- no! That was *gross*!)

The tale eventually came out once she managed to catch an uninterrupted moment with the scar-nosed General Juliet, whom she had actively sought, mostly because she was avoiding the throne room, Angella's personal quarters, and her two best friends, since all of those would, inevitably, result in her meeting Angella.

So sue her, she was stalling and she knew it; but she didn't feel up to it. Not just yet.

So she went to see General Juliet, who didn't much like anybody, instead. Catra didn't much like Juliet, either, so nothing the woman said could really hurt her much.

(Not the way that Angella could; part of loving someone was to leave your heart open to them, to receive love... or an attack. Catra knew that better than anyone; she had loved Adora for years, after all.)

" What's going on, General Juliet?" she asked the hard, stoic woman. Juliet gave her a glare, but Catra didn't take it personally; scar-nose glared at everybody who wasn't her husband Romeo or their kid, Mercutio.

" Scorpia wasn't Scorpia," General Juliet said in her brusque, rough way. " They were a shapeshifter, trying to spread lies about you being disloyal. Glimmer and Mermista found them out; turns out their real name is Double Trouble. They're locked up in a cell now. "

" You mean the guest room, but with no pillows?" Catra asked knowingly. Brightmoon's total lack of a dungeon had been something she'd- very respectfully, and quietly- argued about with her mother for two years. Queen Angella had always responded that she had actual *jails* for that, she had no need for a prison in her own castle... which was why they kept having to use makeshift ones for situations like this.

(Amusingly, Angella had *finally* signed an order to build an actual jail cell in Brightmoon Castle proper that very day, mostly out of annoyance at having to find new places for the guest room pillows- most of which had been stolen by Flutterina and repurposed for her own bed.)

Juliet smirked despite herself at Catra's quip, though her face quickly fell back into its usual shape of severe severity (which you woudn't think was possible, but Juliet was *very* determined.)

" More or less," she agreed.

" What did they say about me?" Catra asked, feeling a burst of rage at the idea. The idea of *anyone* questioning her loyalty to Brightmoon... this was her *home*. These were her *people.* Catra had been hungry for love, for adoration, for glory, and they had *given* it, she still remembered those days recovering in Brightmoon's healing ward from the great battle, the way she was spoken of with awe...

To know that anyone had tried to turn her people against her *enraged* her.

(She'd have to punch this spy in the face personally for this.)

Juliet shrugged in response to her question and the low growl in her throat that Catra wasn't entirely aware she was making.

“ Not much of sense, but you know how people are; give them an excuse and they'll be stupid, if they can be. Given your long service and the sheer stupidity of the accusation, I ordered anyone heard questioning you to punishment detail.”

Catra felt touched despite herself.

“ Thank you,” she said.

Juliet shrugged.

“ No need. You brought Glimmer back,” she said. “ All the way back at the beginning, years ago. You know I asked the Queen to kill you instead of sending you out? I was *sure* you'd betray us.”

“ I'm not surprised,” Catra said, not angry about it. That did sound like Juliet advice.

(And it had been a close thing; the closest thing of Catra's life, to not go back to the Horde, to *choose*, in that moment; only her choice alone, that thin edge, had separated this life from another. To doubt her was not an irrational impulse.)

“ But you came back with Princess Glimmer. Came back with them and the Sword and... you almost died, trying to save our Queen. I was there, Catra. There, when you stood before Brightmoon, and fought what seemed like every soldier of the Horde, all at once. And ever since, everything that's happened... not once in all these

ears have you ever faltered. I'm a hard person, and I have high standards; I'm disappointed by a lot of people.”

Juliet inclined her head to Catra, the smallest turning of her neck down, an acknowledgment as heavy as a mountain.

“ I've been impressed by only a few. And you're one of them. I'm proud to call you a Princess of Brightmoon, my lady.”

Catra swallowed hard, against this... recognition. She loved it, she had always loved it, was always hungry for adoration and the love of her people... but for *Juliet* to say this...

“ Thank you,” she said, quietly. “ I'm honored.”

Juliet shrugged again.

“ Save your thanks for Princess Glimmer and Mermista,” she said. “ They're the ones who caught the spy. Because of them, your good name is secure. I just did what any loyal general of Brightmoon should.”

Her sister, protecting her- of course. And her best non-Squad friend with them.

“ I'm glad to hear it,” Catra said, with a little smile.

“ One last thing,” Juliet grunted, her voice a little... softer, which was odd to here from the hard-edged woman. “ The Queen... she was out of her mind with worry for you, Catra. The last little bit... it's not been kidn to her. You should go to her, make sure she knows you're safe.”

“ I...” Catra said, tail stiff, good feelings suddenly gone, “ I'm not... I'm sure the Queen has bigger things to worry about then me...”

“ Mothers always worry about their kids,” Juliet said, in the closest thing to a gentle tone she was capable of using. “ Go to her, Catra. She's in her private rooms now. Don't fuck around.”

And then she left, and Catra had no more excuses, and nowhere else to go... just... a final meeting with the Queen.

Adora needs this, Catra reminded herself, and with that in mind, Catra walked towards Angella's door on heavy feet.

-

Catra hadn't noticed her yet.

Catra had gotten... very good... at avoiding Shadow Weaver, back in the Fright Zone. Good at paying attention to her when she was present.

But here at Brightmoon, she'd let her guard down. Not a surprise; the place was *soft*, and Catra had always been the weaker child.

(As Adora was busily proving- the ungrateful brat. A Dragon Shadow Weaver would have to slay in the future- though she felt a bizarre sense of *pride.* Adora really *had* turned out to be damn talented, even if she hadn't given her the Sword, and Shadow Weaver was the one that had taught her; a terribly apt pupil.)

So, unseen, silently slipping through the shadows of this bright place, the darkness followed Catra as she entered the moonlight elemental's home, to learn what she could of the weaker child so that she might tame the wildcat at last.

-

The Blazing Kingdom was a burn wound on the world.

The land was... blistered, here. Cauterized, almost. Most of it was just ashes, grey to black, stirring in the faint breeze that dared touch this melted land; stone corpses of ancient lava flows in long, runny tunnels were the only other real distinguishing feature, crisscrossing in meandering patterns like a petrified parody of a river. There were some remnants of trees to break up the monotonous landscape, but the smallest touch of Adora's

charred fingers revealed them for the incinerated nothings they were- just ash, somehow still in the shape of the plant it had once been.

Even the process of entropy were parched for existence, here; this should have collapsed years ago, decades, centuries.

Adora shook her head, and was glad to have the armor on. Nothing was here to fight, but she still felt... unsafe, and the armor made her feel more comfortable, like a child's security blanket in the dark.

Experimentally, she drew a basic spellcaster's circle with her scorched hand. Nothing fancy or dramatic, just a basic spell to test the ambient magic... but it was... off. It didn't *want* to work. She could force it too, but it felt like charred meat, roasted on a too-hot frying pan for far too long.

There was just... nothingness, as far as the eye could see.

(*This is what I wanted, though*, her hellhound said, inside, and some part of her could not help but find it... beautiful.)

" There is no joy for you in this place, my fellow fire-mage."

Adora jerked her head around at the quiet, cracked voice of a stranger, a voice that sounded as though the owner had been swallowing burning salt for a thousand years. Spooked, Adora's

armor activated on reflex, the snarling dog helmet snapping over her skull to protect her...

...But... no attack came. And what she was seeing was no Alliance soldier she'd ever heard of.

" Do not be afraid. I have already killed all the people I will ever kill."

Black ashes, swirling in the air as though a quiet dust devil was dancing on hot feet. Ashes, shaped, very vaguely, like a person, with two still-burning embers for eyes, and burning footprints where the thing "stood", though she could see no feet in those depressions that flickered with faint flame.

(For a second, Adora can see her as she was in life, a tall, imperious woman of middle age with long hair and long lines of worry etched in her face- like a mirage over the ashes, something she can only see out of the blurry orb of her light-blinded eye, as burned as this woman was.)

" Who are you?" Adora asked, blinking to shake that strange vision out of her head. The thing inclined its head.

" I am the last Fire Princess."

Chapter End Notes

I have to admit, looking back... of all the things I'm proud of here, the dog-theming for Adora, in opposition to Catra, is

one of my favorite things.

For the curious, you don't need to read the Fire Princess graphic novel to understand any of what's coming; my version is very slightly different. You should def check it out, though, it has some *great* facial expressions, and some fun writing!

Chapter 10: The Fire Princess of the Blazing Kingdom

Chapter Notes

Adora and the Spirit Ember.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Fire Princess of the Blazing Kingdom

Adora stared for a moment at the figure.

" I'm sorry, *what* did you say you were...?" she asked, unable to think of anything else to say in her shock.

The parched voice spoke again, dry as sand.

" I am the Fire Princess of the Blazing Kingdom... the last Fire Princess. Last of the Blazing Kingdom, and by my own hands."

Adora stared at her for a moment, stared at this thing that could *not* be. A Ghost Princess, a real one, from her childhood stories and childhood nightmares.

...This couldn't *possibly* be happening.

“ I've done it,” Adora muttered to herself. “ I've lost my mind. I've... I've finally...”

But the ash-thing shook its head.

“ You are not lost, wanderer. Not yet. If you continue, you will be lost, body and soul and mind all three, but you are not lost yet.”

“ Hallucinating, I'm hallucinating,” Adora said to herself, trying not to listen to her maybe-there-maybe-not companion, even as she pondered how she felt. She felt... normal, save for an elevated heartrate from fear, which made her even *more* afraid.

After all, if she felt normal, then maybe she *wasn't* going mad, and this was really happening, and right at this moment Adora wasn't totally sure which outcome she preferred.

“ I am quite real, little one.”

“ No, you can't be,” Adora insisted, all her words running out of her mouth in a panic. “ They always told scary stories in the Horde about Ghost Princesses. Reading about your Kingdom's death on the way up here, and the funeral, they must have... *combined* in my mind. You're just part of me. You... you are my guilt, or my fears, *something* in my head. You're not real, *you're not real.*”

Adora breathed hard after her speech was finished, panting in the wasteland air. The scorch-geist cocked its head at her, a strangely human movement for the ethereal creation.

" Guilt?... Fears? This is what your mind leaps to?"

A dry twist in the voice, quiet and... sympathetic.

" You came to this land burdened, young sorceress."

" I don't need to hear that from my own damn thoughts," Adora snarled, removing her helmet after a moment's deliberation. If this was real, she doubted her helmet would save her from a ghost, and if it *wasn't* (as she was very deliberately choosing to believe) then there was no need to keep her helmet on. She wasn't going to be afraid of... of a mirage. A trick.

Her face was full of defiance as her helmet retracted back into the armor, Adora glaring at what she *had* to believe was some new rebellion of her mind. They were like that for a few long moments before Adora finally turned away.

" This isn't real," she mumbled, turning away, back to her skiff, berating herself all the while. She shouldn't have gotten off, shouldn't have stopped it to investigate the land on foot to satisfy a moment's curiosity. Stupid. She should have driven straight to the center, to Mount Candila, where Hordak's notes said the Spirit

Ember sat. She climbed back on and activated it, but as her skiff lifted off, she sensed something behind her- a burning presence.

Adora resolutely refused to turn around, even as her scars ached, even as some childhood terror mounted, old fears of ghost princesses lurking under her bed and in her closet.

(Catra had laughed at her, even as she curled up closer on the bed to comfort Adora. Catra, who had never feared any monsters in the dark save the one raising her... or, perhaps, she had merely put on a brave face for Adora, who was not usually scared of anything at all.)

" What brings you here, scarred mage?"

" You know damn well why I'm here," Adora replied, unable to stop herself, even as she kept her eyes resolutely forward and her hand on the flight stick. " You're just... a stray thought of mine. Or maybe something from the portal, something I let inside."

(Adora's mind thought of Shadow Weaver, in that moment- to the thing Light Spinner had let in, that she'd heard about from old reports of Mystacor and a few pointed questions to older Force Captains. Light Spinner had let in the Darkness, but had Adora unwittingly copied her teacher in a different direction? Had she let in the *Light*, was this a thing from outside that she had let *in*...)

" You are a stranger to me."

The voice was calm in an upsetting kind of way, though Adora could not place it, in her resolute determination to *not* be afraid of the ghost princess that was directly behind her. The best she could do was a sense of a forest after fire had passed through it; peaceful, but only because there was nothing left to burn.

The peace you seek, that cold, dark part of Adora thought, and she shuddered.

" Then why are you bothering me?" Adora asked, only barely able not to turn around, and look at the terrifying undead behind her. " Just... leave me alone!"

" I will not. You are here seeking the Spirit Ember."

Adora jerked hard in surprise at the statement, and with her hand on the controls, this almost sent the skiff plowing into an upraised chunk of lava flow.

" I thought you said I was a stranger to you!" she exclaimed as she got the skiff back on course again, finally daring to glare back at the specter, which sat calmly behind her as she righted the skiff, burning eyes fixed on her. Two small fires marked where its feet would be if it had human anatomy, slowly charring black marks into the cargo skiff's floor.

" I am."

“ Then how did you *know* that?!?” Adora demanded, fear turning to anger swiftly in her unsettled state.

“ Because there is nothing else here. My Runestone is the only treasure left in these lands. It is not hard to guess why one would come here when there is only one thing here at all.”

...That was actually pretty reasonable, though it didn't help Adora get a grip on her spiraling fury. The hellhound was too well fed at this point, too big, she couldn't keep her chained up and muzzled now that her fear had unleashed her.

“ Then fuck off! You know why I'm here, why try to stop me? Why... all *this*?!?” Adora flailed, indicating the burned land around her.

“ Because you are far from the first to try to reach it... and you will be far from the first to die trying to connect with it.”

Adora swallowed hard, blinked against the hellhound's howling. “ Others have tried? What'd you do, kill them to keep the Runestone in your hands?”

“ No! No. No...”

A tinge of desperation in the unseen throat; the flare-revenant was... horrified, at the idea, from the sound of it.

Horrified.

I've scared a dead woman, Adora had time to think.

The etheral form grew hands out of the ash, hands and arms that she held up pleadingly to Adora, rising up to take a step forward as she spoke, her terror lending the undead's voice something almost alive; Adora could hear, just barely, the flicker of the voice she'd once had, when she was flesh, a strong and warm voice, good for a great ruler.

" " No, I have... I have hurt as many people as I will ever hurt, killed as many as I will ever kill. I will never hurt anyone ever again," the Fire Princess said, still pleading. " I have no will to do harm, and no power besides. I have only my words, and they... they never *work*. So few listen. They go to the Runestone and they *die*, child. They *die!* Please, listen to me! You will burn, like all the others! Run, run! I do not want to see anyone else die!"

...It was hard to be scared of someone who sounded so desperate to save her. Without fear to pull the collar off, the hellhound was easier to muzzle, and Adora got control over her rage, buried it again as she sighed.

" I have to," she told the Fire Princess. " I... I have to."

She turned back to her work, driving the skiff- and mildly grateful she hadn't plowed into any obstacles while her back was turned- going over the blasted waste.

" Why? What reason could compel you to self-destruction, little one?" the Fire Princess asked.

" I... I need it. I need it to save my people," Adora said to her erstwhile companion, even as her mind made one token protest against the unreality of the situation. " I need its power. And... my name is Adora. What's yours?"

" My apologies if I have offended you, Adora," the ghost said, bowing her head as her arms and hands sank back into the fiery refuse that was her body. " I mean no disrespect."

" None taken," Adora said, as she checked her compass and map. The total lack of landmarks was making navigation a bitch, but Mount Candila was in the center, and she was fairly sure it was northeast of her, so that's where she guided the skiff while the undead thought.

" As for my own name... No. I will not curse it by associating it with my failures. I am the last Fire Princess. I gave up everything else for that goal, my love and my life and my kingdom all three; let my name be dissociated from all my failures. It was a fine name, and innocently given by my parents, who did not know how poorly I would treat it."

So much guilt, on the dead woman's tongue. Guilt, an old friend of Adora's, her scars itching and aching, and a blurriness in her left eye that was not blindness as a bubble of sorrow burst in her heart.

She wrestled it back down, blinking away a not-tear that faded in the dry wind.

" I... for what it is worth..." Adora began haltingly, not sure how to... how to *comfort*, after so very long. It had been easy, once; she'd comforted Catra, to the extent that Catra would accept it, to the extent she had been able to give it (and it hadn't been enough, or Catra would not have jumped ship the first chance she got.) " I... I know what guilt is like."

The living and the dead were silent for a few moments.

" I am sorry to hear that," the Fire Princess said. " I would not wish this burden on another."

They were silent again for a bit, before the pyre-spirit continued.

" If you are trying to save your people... know this. The Spirit Ember cannot save anyone. Not now. Once, before me, before my failures, the Spirit Ember was a bright beacon of hope to the world, but... in my grief and sorrow and foolishness, I doomed my

kingdom and ruined the heart of my power. My broken heart broke the Runestone of Fire in turn. It will burn you to ashes, Adora. It will not save you. It has killed all others who tried.”

“ I'm not like them,” Adora said, as on the storied horizon, Mount Candila rose high, the artificial fortress-turned-volcano, its glory- and its ruin- visible even at this distance. The architecture was Brobdingnagian in scale- great swooping arches, enormous columns, great and massive walls- but the grandeur was ruined by the equally cyclopean destruction- each glorious window had the remnant of a lava flow pouring out of its mouth like a drunkard's vomit, and the massive door lay in ashen chunks where the flame had melted right through it.

“ Many have believed that, over the long years,” the dead cautioned the living.

“ None of them were First Ones,” Adora said, and flinched as she said it; the words burned her mouth as they left it.

The Fire Princess made a choked noise of surprise.

“ A... First One? Truly? Something about you seemed strange, but... that's impossible.”

“ Says the ghost,” Adora responded, a smile tugging at the corner of her lips despite the situation, despite *You're a First One*, despite everything. “ I'm not even sure why you're here.”

“ Neither am I,” the ash-corpse responded. “ Nothing like me was ever recorded... before... but I have a theory I have thought of. There is little else to do, out here, save warn travelers like yourself.”

“ What's your theory?” Adora asked.

“ I... think the Spirit Ember did it to me,” she answered, haltingly. “ I think... I think it is punishing me, for what I did.”

A vicious streak several millennia long, my sister, Adora thought.

“ What *did* you do?” the living asked the dead, Adora finally realizing something she should have at this conversation's start; the Fire Princess, if that's what she really was, would know *what* had actually happened to cause the Blazing Kingdom's fall. “ If I know what went wrong, I can do something else, and not suffer your fate. Or the fate of all the others, apparently.”

“ The Spirit Ember is... different, from other Runestones,” the Fire Princess answered. “ How much do you know, Adora? Many seekers told me many versions of my own story, and few had much of the truth.”

“ I know it's artificial, and built by the First Ones,” Adora said, and the second time, the words didn't hurt so bad; she merely winced

a little as they singed her lips. " A divine mistake... like me. She's my sister in sin, and I'm going to reclaim her."

There was no answer for a long time, and when Adora glanced back, she had the distinct impression that the Fire Princess had raised an eyebrow, though nothing had changed of her form.

" I... do not know how to respond to that," the ghost said. " But... yes, essentially. No Runestone controls fire, Adora. The Moonstone can control the *reflection* of fire, which is why it belongs to the lunar cycle; the moonlight gentles the fire, tames the sunlight to something that can be held in the hand without burning. But the real thing? Fire and Light Themselves? No. It is a power that breaks all bonds; Light is the force that cannot be stopped, the nuclear heart of all power in the universe."

" Light? I thought it controlled Fire," Adora answered, rubbing unconsciously at the scars on her arm.

" No difference," the Fire Princess said. " Only mortals think there is a difference; the universe knows better. All Light comes from Fire, from something, somewhere, burning."

I already knew that, Adora thought to herself, remembering a revelation that had sung its testament in her head as she fell, in a world that never was.

“ So why did it go out of control?” Adora asked. “ What mistake did you make?”

“ I connected too deeply and too foolishly,” the Fire Princess answered. “ I ignored the advice of my foremothers, which was to keep a light touch on the Runestone; it would be more stable if moved to leylines, but to remove it from the kingdom and place it in the protection of other kingdoms... no. Never. I thought I could... make new leylines, forge a connection, if I simply was strong enough, knew enough. But I couldn't, and I didn't.”

“ So you tried to hook it to leylines, and *that's* what caused the disaster?” Adora asked, but the ghost shook her head.

“ No. The connection... the closer the connection, the stronger, the easier it is for the power to go out of control . Some part of me always had to be watchful for slip-ups. It was easy while I was studying it, but then I found that one I loved had... left, in the interim, had not held to our promise to wait for each other. I was alone, and in my rage and my grief, I forgot to keep hold of a reason *not* to burn everything. The Ember responded to that momentary thought, of just burning it all, and lost control of itself. A stray thought can catch fire, Adora. My stray thought caught fire, and they all burned.”

“ They all...?” Adora asked, sensing the meaning hidden in those words. “ Didn't you burn, too?”

A chuckle, laced thick with salt, ugly and low.

“ No, Adora. I was not granted that peace. To be part of the Ember is to be immune to its power. When the fire was done washing over my people, I... I had to make do with the edge of my balcony. With a single step, and a long fall.”

A memory flickered through Adora, of her looking at the switch to the portal, of her whole world shrunk down to *You're a First One*, and her delight that she would die, and drag Catra down with her.

“ I've been on that edge, too,” Adora said quietly, putting a hand to her scars again, as she remembered *the light the light the light*. “ Took the step, too. Survived, but... I can't claim I'm terribly happy about it.”

More silence, lasting until they were almost to the castle. Adora's eyes went up to the tower, the great tower, and for a second her fire-burned eye could see the long lines of a tall woman's hair, trailing behind her like a comet as she fell towards the earth.

“ Adora... I know I cannot talk you out of going in,” the Fire Princess said. “ So I will tell you something I have told all the others, though it has never helped before. I will tell you that you *must* have a reason to walk out of that chamber alive, or you will not. Something inside you, against your wounded heart, your hurt, your pain- and your pain is so deep, Adora. Knowing you only for a short time, I know that you are too much like *me*. First One or not, you will *die* if you go in there.”

" Perhaps," Adora admitted. " But... I want... I have to try."

Her mind pondered it, even as the Fire Princess went silent again,

A reason to walk out of that chamber alive.

(Her Horde, cheering for her, expecting her back home, loving her, trusting her to lead them to glory. Her people, whom she swore not to betray. She owed them so much, for the trust they had placed in her.)

Something more than pain.

(*Do your duty.* A Hordesman, from birth to death; from the moment Hordak saved her to the day she dies and is placed in the fields, to die feeding the next generation. She had a duty.)

Something inside her, to set against her wounded heart.

(Catra. Catra, of all people, her face in her mind; Catra, whom she still loves, even as she hates herself for it, for loving someone so much better than her, who is so good when she is so *evil*. A love that can never be, but... it is something, something inside her, isn't it? She loves Catra.)

It will have to be enough.

Adora parked the skiff before the great castle. The char-heart stayed onboard, her shifting, nervous feet marking new burns on

the skiff's floor.

" I... cannot go with you," she admitted. " The Ember will not tolerate my presence. It sends me back whenever I try to go in."

" So you have wandered here for... how long?" Adora asked, and the ghost shrugged.

" The time has... gone strange, in my mind. I only awaken when visitors come, which has been less often in recent years. The past few centuries have been quiet."

For "recent years" to indicate centuries... Adora shook her head, briefly surveying the front of Mount Candila in an effort not to think about that. Broken windows, frozen flames in the form of lava funnels... and...

A small pile of white, in the midst of the gray.

She looked at them, then looked up, above them- the tallest tower in the castle, still standing after all this time. They were a direct drop down.

The Fire Princess saw her gaze, and simply nodded when Adora looked at her, to confirm her suspicions.

“ Nothing rots here,” she said, by way of answer. “ Even me.”

...That didn't seem right, that her bones lay out, that nothing be... be *done* with them... a funeral, like she'd seen on the way up here, or the way the Horde did it, *something* should be done.

But Adora had a confrontation of her own to deal with, so simply took a deep breath and moved before the door.

“ I will write your name, you know,” the ghost yelled to her. Adora turned to look at her, and saw that she had stepped off the skiff, a trail of small fires marking her path as she came as close as she dared to the place where she had murdered her people.

“ Write my name?” Adora asked, and the ghost nodded.

“ I... I try to remember those who came here,” the Fire Princess said. “ I mark them down in a place protected from rain and wind- a small, dry cavern near here. I write your names in charcoal, to remember you. It is all I can do. When the fire takes you, your name will still exist.”

...That was terribly sweet, and Adora found a smile in herself for this woman who was so much like her.

“ Thank you,” she said, and then, with nothing left to do, walked inside Mount Candila.

Inside, the ruin was everywhere. The area was as devastated as she might have expected; this was the stab wound in the kingdom's back, after all, the place where the murder of an entire nation began. Each step crumbled and cracked the floor, crusted and caked with the remnants of the magma that had once flowed down these halls.

Nothing else moved here. The halls were empty, there was... there was so much *nothing* here, attached to a sense of something holding its breath, a terrible sensation of *waiting.* Adora could sense something deeper inside that made her arm itch, and her eye hurt; her sister, she knew, somehow, the Spirit Ember, waiting for her.

So she moved among the nothingness, her breathing so loud in that place where nothing moved, each footstep a titanic thunderclap in that quiet place.

A flash of color in her burned eye distracted her, but there was nothing there when she turned to put her good eye to it. It happened again, and again, she kept whirling her head to see but there was...

Nothing.

But she had seen... something.

(flashes of color, like the clothes of a kingdom that had loved warm colors; glimpses of pipes and smoke; things unseen for all these centuries, now barely glimpsed out of the corner of one half-blind eye)

She put her helmet back on, letting it snap into place, and lied to herself that she was not, suddenly, very scared.

But she still had to go forward.

I've come too far, she thought, with despair, her steps more of a shuffle as the weight of her terror pressed hard on her heart. *I have to keep going, even if I don't want to.*

But that thought hurt, and Adora thought of what the Fire Princess had said; that there had to be *something* inside her, something more than her pain.

She paused, looking for it for a second, before the words came to her.

My people need this, Adora thought.

I want to see my sister. She shouldn't be alone; we're both the mistakes of the First One, and we should be together. I don't want to be the only one anymore.

I want to see Catra again.

(She wanted to lie about that, but... here, in the face of all this nothing... the lie died before it reached the surface of her mind. She wanted to see Catra again. That was the plain truth.)

Adora took a breath, and when she moved again, her steps were the sure march of a Hordesman.

Up stairs rendered into rough ramps by the vomiting of flames, to find a door- a locked door. The obstruction was thick First One metal, the lock a familiar insignia- the Sword, the Sword, the Sword. Always the Sword, all her life has revolved around the Sword since Catra found the fucking thing in the Whispering Woods.

(It doesn't feel fair. It's not even *her* Sword.)

The door had held, despite the lava, despite the kingdom perishing. The fire had poured out of the room behind it, going right through the walls, but the door had held. Adora *could* crawl into one of the holes in the circular room's sides, but she didn't fancy trying to get over all those sharp, jagged rocks. The suit would protect her from harm, but going that route would take a while, and ran the risk of falling or getting stuck in a misjudged, too-small gap. Plus, how would she haul her sister out?

(She hoped the Ember was a tiny Runestone. She had not thought to bring a power loader with her.)

She looked at the door again. Her people had built this door, and while she didn't have the Sword, she wondered if it might open for her anyway. Blood could tell, so they said, and “they” often hid deeper truths in throw-away lines. A lot of the Fright Zone's locks, magical and technological both, read one's biology, after all. Perhaps with a little magic to help...

A sharp piece of melted stone nearby served; she retracted the glove on one hand, and cut a thin gash in her right thumb, and pressed it to the insignia as her burned hand danced through runic symbols, of *unlocking* and *light* and *recognize me*. Glowing lines, red at first, then turning blue as the door's magitech tasted the ancient DNA in her veins, and her magic lied to the semi-intelligent AI inside enough that it decided to let her in.

The door crawled open, rock and ash dislodging; and inside, wrapped in a coffin of cold stone, lay the slow-beating heart of the kingdom's devastation.

The Spirit Ember.

“ Sister,” Adora said, unaware she spoke at all. “ I'm here.”

A low, quiet, dull *throb*... like a dying woman's heartbeat. Her sister, asleep so long, so very long, barely awakened by Entrapta's work with the Runestones so many years ago, before the battle of Brightmoon.

(The knife in her hands, slipping into Catra's side so gently it felt like a kiss, her gorge in her throat, *what have I done, what have I*

done)

Slumbering until now, after she destroyed a nation in her user's moment of weakness.

(the portal, pulling the switch- and who knew you could damn yourself, with so small a movement of your arm? And it had been her left, too, her left arm, the one that had burned when *the light the light the light* entered her... of course it was. Everything in her life will always go back to that moment, when her evil had grown to such heights that Hordak himself was rendered a hero for stopping what she had set into motion.)

She walked forward, reaching out with charred fingers, half-tripping over the uneven lava channels in the floor but she didn't care, *couldn't* care, she had found her at last, the only other thing like her in all the universe.

" Oh, sister, I am *here*," she said, almost sobbed, to this thing that could not answer back, to the only other proof in all Etheria that the First Ones could be *wrong*. There she was... surprisingly small. Half the size of the other Runestones she'd seen; the Garnet was towering, as was the Moonstone, but this was... tiny. Under the size of a person; in her armor, easily carried by both hands.

And she was beautiful; a beautiful, shining thing of red and orange, in the shape of a fire. Something fit to be a Dragon's breath, perhaps.

But she was bound. Stuck. The petrified lava all over her- too thick. Adora's fingers scraped uselessly against it for a few moments before she remembered her shield, her suit, her strength, the world entire, and put herself to smarter work. The shield, gloves, bashing, prying, pulling.

And all the while, Adora saw her face, reflected in one brilliant facet of the runestone that yet peeked out from the dull gray of the ancient magma; saw a face of burned patchwork, saw her desperation and her awe and her *unhappiness*, somehow crystal clear, even distorted as it was by reflection.

(And that cold, dark part of her remembered the Fire Princess' words, and made preparation for the battle to come.)

Ten minutes of sweating later, in which she had no thoughts she was consciously aware of, she had knocked enough stone off to free the Spirit Ember; breathing hard, she paused, not really thinking anything, just... looking at her.

And in those moments, her sister began to *bleed*.

Lava, so hot that even though none of it touched her, the heat rolling off of it nonetheless forced her to stumble back. HUD sensors within the armor panicked, temperature gauges skyrocketing, the mechanical equivalent of flailing panic; the magma, dripping from her no-longer-encaged sister, falling thick and viscous as honey and melting new holes in the ruined floor. The Spirit Ember, bleeding, and she could sense the barest intention in her sister now; nothing malicious, just *pain,* pain pure and simple, the echeos of the Fire Princess' last scream still trapped inside the Spirit Ember's skin, compelling her sister to

burn, burn, burn, until nothing was left that could hurt her Princess.

She wasn't even aware of lashing out; Adora sensed no ill intent here, her sister did not *want* to harm her, but the last Fire Princess' pain still drove her after all these years. The magma splashed all around the room, and the convection off of each sizzling stream was trying to cook Adora alive in her suit.

Well, I'm half-baked anyway, Adora thought, and she wanted to laugh, half-mad and half-glad and all real, bright and daring, *might finish cooking at this rate!*

She laughed, and pushed forward, despite the heat, raising her shield before her to help block the fire, casting spells of immunity with the curdled and cooked magic of the region, sucking magic like a sponge from her sister even as that same magic tried to destroy her. Adora pushed, ever forward, her shield was melting and her armor was sliding off of her even with all her magic but she was *the Dragon*, she was the Dragon and *she would not burn.*

Her friends needed her.

(Lonnie's face as she tried, desperately, to pull Adora alive out of her own pain, to lead the Horde, to be the heroine in her people's hour of need. Rogelio and Kyle, who had somehow become vital to her- even Kyle, who had never been anyone in his training, who was now... one of hers.)

Her people needed her.

(The Horde, shouting her name; the Horde, willing to fight and die in her name. Beyond everything else, beyond her own personal feelings, beyond her pain and her worry and the hellhound in her heart, there was that thing from earliest childhood- Duty. She had a duty to her people. They needed this weapon. She could not fail them, not after they had such faith in her.)

And...

(Catra, still; she still loved Catra, she sent a prayer to whatever forces existed that heard the prayers of burned and broken things, begging them for help. She loved Catra. Maybe... maybe there was a way. Catra had said she would save her, in the world of the portal. Maybe... wrong as she was, *awful* as she was, wasn't there... a way?... there had to be a way... she would *believe* there was a way, even if she could not see it, but to get to that way she would have to survive *this* and she *would not burn*)

She grit her teeth, and pressed forward one last time, a last spell on her lips, as her shield, her great shield, that had carried her through so much of this war, melted in her hands.

And at the last moment, the shield's failing protection let her reach her sister, retracting the glove of her left hand and putting charred fingertips to ancient magitech.

And she is nowhere, suddenly, nowhere and everywhere, all at once.

(it is so hard to think. There is so much *muchness* inside this Runestone that it drowns out all other sensation. She is connected

to it, now, it immediately made her its new Princess. She has gone too long alone, she would not have rejected Adora under any circumstances at all; but knowing she is a First One, feeling how much Adora wants this, the Spirit Ember leapt at her with arms wide open like a happy child. Adora laughs and catches her older sister and spins her around in her)

Arms ached, she had both up to the Runestone now, she was no longer burning even as her armor sloughed off of her like the caul of a newborn. The magic was trying to go out of control, as her bond was beginning, new formed, new and raw and untested. The hellhound inside Adora raised its ugly head and sniffed, sensing the new prey, got up and broke its leash, began to walk towards her sister. The hellhound wished for the ground to crack open and reveal the magma inside, for the sky to burn and all the seas to dry up, and she would enter the Spirit Ember and use its power to make that wish real. Adora had to... had to stop herself, she had to pull back. She had to remember a reason not to do this, to indulge, to give

(In, inside the Spirit Ember, visions of another universe; the Ember's memories, so many things. First One scientists, talking, speaking of many things; stars, planets, worlds- what is this? A castle with a skull design, made of grey stone- was this what Catra spoke of when she called upon the Sword? The honor of Grayskull, defended a million worlds away... defended from a green light, and a terrible thing that sat at its head. A green light, and words in her people's tongue she can almost make out, and sudden knowledge that entered her and died and left in an eyeblink's span. Her head was full to bursting with understanding, she felt this down to her)

Bones, bones, why were bones important? She tried to remember. Bones... the Fire Princess' bones, that was important, she had to... she had to get control. She had to do something for her; it

wasn't right, for her bones to lay there, lonely at the foot of her tower, all these long centuries. It wasn't right. It wasn't right. She had to survive this, to help the ghost, and... her friends, her people, *Catra,* all the reasons she'd thought of before she touched the stone, before the power

(subsumed her, she was on the edge of ascension or ashes, but she had her reasons now, saw them everywhere. A flag floated past her in the sea of fire with her symbol triumphant, Hordak's bat wings with her little serpent between them, spewing fire. Her friends, standing shoulder to shoulder with her people. And... Catra, beautiful Catra, whom she had hurt so badly. Catra, whom her traitorous heart loved so much. Catra, whom she wanted to see again. And from some cold and dark place inside her came reasons enough to put an end to this fight, she reached out with the cold and the dark inside her and she told her hellhound)

No.

A long time passed, in which Adora knew nothing, in which the magic of the Runestone filtered inside her, to its new Fire Princess, and she bonded with it, the two mistakes of the First One becoming one whole, bonding and merging.

When Adora came to, she was shivering and naked, clinging to her sister with both arms wrapped around the warm Runestone in a hug. Her armor, the armor that had carried her so very far, that had been with her since the Battle of Brightmoon all those years ago, had sloughed off of her like a snake's skin.

Or a dragon's, Adora thought, as her mind recentered itself. *Dragons shed their skins, too.*

Her face was wet; she'd been crying. Tears of pure frustrated rage- frustrated because she, at last and at the last, had a muzzle on the monster inside her. The hellhound was back in its cage. Still there- she could hear her, prowling and sniffing and growling- feel the rage and the nihilistic laughter that threatened to break out, and ruin all things...

But she had set a watch, a guard, on the monster inside. It could not break through.

She felt...

Good.

She let out a breath she hadn't known she was holding. It blew across her sister's surface, and she felt that; felt a lot, from her. The Spirit Ember- and *wow*, no wonder it had ruined the kingdom. The Spirit Ember really wasn't like other Runestones, a fact she knew intimately now; too much power inside it, no wonder it was unstable, how could her sister trap all this might inside her skin? It reminded Adora of the light she had let inside herself, back in the world of the portal, though not so... sick. Different, felt... less dangerous, kinder. The Spirit Ember was as happy to light campfires and run a forge as she was to burn skin and melt fat.

But for all her sweeter nature, she was still so *strong*; it was almost horrifying, the Spirit Ember connected Adora directly to the nuclear engine that ran the universe. Some of her sister's

memories- all the things the Runestone had seen in its infinity of existence- circled in her head, images and ideas she had no time to unpack right now; she did not know what a *sun* or a *star* was, but in this moment, she *understood* them, understood that the universe revolved around them, that they made all the clockwork turn. The universe ran on the fuel of Light.

And now, so did she.

Adora smiled, as she pressed her forehead to her sister, simply feeling her. The stone felt smooth and clean to her left hand, hot and rough to her right; her sister was being gentle with her scars, and Adora smiled at the kindness. She closed her eyes, simply feeling her, sensing the Ember searching inside her in turn; not entirely sentient, was her sister, but that was alright. She would have time to recover herself.

Her sister was also very small, for a Runestone, which was great, because now Adora could just haul her outside. Adora laughed, and it was not broken or awful, but triumphant; triumphant and glorious.

" Let's go home," she told her fellow sin. " You won't be alone, not anymore."

Her sister throbbed warm in her hands, and Adora thought she approved.

She picked her sister up- who weighed very little, in the muscular soldier's arms- and began to walk out, carrying her gently. So many memories, swirling about, the vague impressions of her people's tongue from the Spirit Ember's creators; the Dragon would have to sift through those later, when they were both safe. When there was a leyline to feed her sister's hunger and keep her stable, and Adora had time to examine the connection between them.

She'd have to have a room built to house the Runestone, one that could shunt her into the ocean if it became necessary; Adora was *fairly* sure she had the situation in hand, but there was no reason to risk her Horde on a whim. Better safe than sorry.

Particularly around so much *power* . She... she could crush the Alliance... maybe not singlehandedly, but with her army too? Even Mermista and Catra- the only Princesses who could truly oppose her, now- would fold, in the face of an empowered Dragon and the Horde's armies.

...Or...

(a stray thought in her head, from that cold, dark place inside; maybe an answer to her prayer. Maybe just a thought she is, finally, *letting* herself think, after all these years, finally able to envision an ending other than bloodshed.)

Maybe force them to come to the table. Maybe make a deal.

She had to win. She was the villain. But no one said she ever had to win a world of ashes... she could have *more.*

And wasn't that part of her duty? Just as much as denying her own hungers... the Horde deserved everything she could give them. She was their leader. They'd prefer a world of fruits and good food and peace to a world on fire.

She didn't have to be a monster to win.

She just had to *win* .

(And if she got Catra in the bargain- if she made it so the price of peace was Catra at her side- well, it would be easier to repair what lay between them, if Adora had not burned her people to ashes, if Brightmoon still stood. Wasn't that the way the portal world had played out? A world that belonged to the Horde... but the Princesses were allowed to live. Catra loved her too. Would it be so bad? Maybe she can have that, get what she wants...)

Thinking such good thoughts, such kindly thoughts, Adora emerged out of Mount Candila, to find the ghost staring at her in unabashed awe.

" You did it," the dead said to the living.

" I did," the living said to the dead.

Adora smiled at her, and through her burned eye, saw with her sister's memories; saw the Fire Princess as she had once been, when she lived, when she still knew how to smile.

She was smiling now, and there were tears in her eyes; Adora closed her good eye, so she could see the woman who was there more clearly.

" I... what will you do now?" the Fire Princess asked. " I... I don't know what to say... no one has *ever* tamed it before..."

" I'll go save my people," Adora responded. " I'll crush our enemies, and reign in peace. And... one more thing."

She went up to the skiff, placing her sister gently down on its floor, and did two things. The first was to get herself some clothes, Adora feeling grateful that she'd packed an extra set (mostly because she feared she'd run into rain from the great thunderstorm over the Woods). She dressed swiftly into a plain Horde uniform, exact mirror of what she'd been wearing under the armor.

Once dressed, the second thing was to grab up a tarp, and head over to the pile of quiet bones that lay white underneath the tower.

" What are you doing?" the Last Fire Princess asked, as she followed the new one.

“ Gathering up your bones,” Adora said as she knelt next to the skeleton, unrolling the tarp. Up close, it was revealed that the bones were... pretty fragmented... the fall had shattered her, of course. Adora wasn't sure why she'd expected them to be neat and whole. Only the skull was mostly intact, and it was still in four chunks.

Still, she'd decided on what to do. With more care than she'd thought she had left, Adora began taking the bones and putting them in the tarp.

“ I apologize if this is rude,” Adora said. “ There's no etiquette for something like this, or at least, it's not part of Force Captain training.”

“ What are you going to do with my bones?” the ghost asked, and Adora snorted a laugh; that was *such* a bizarre sentence to hear.

“ I... you shouldn't still be here,” Adora said. “ You should get to rest...”

“ I am a monster,” the ghost replied. “ I do not deserve peace.”

I'm a monster, Adora thought. *You're a victim.*

She struggled for a moment, trying to think of a way to tell the truth; she was out of practice with it, after all.

" You're not a monster," Adora said, hoping she could say this without searing her tongue off. " I should know. I... I razed a village... killed so many people... all these years, I just *keep* hurting people, I keep... I keep making that choice."

She paused, drew in a breath, as another thought hit her, from the cold and dark place where truth still resided inside her.

I'm powerful now. Not weak, like I was before Thaymor. I... I could stop *making this choice. No one's forcing me. Not anymore.*

But she pushed past that. Later, that was a thought for later. This wasn't about Adora right now, this was about this poor woman, who was still here, after all these years.

" I made a choice. *I'm* a monster. *You're* a victim," Adora declared. " You're not responsible for this. You were... you were hurting, and the magic reacted badly. I made a *choice*. You were *sad*."

The ghost could say nothing, merely watched as Adora put all her bones into the tarp and rolled it up tight, tying it to keep them safe for transport.

“ I don't... I don't know if this will help, but I'm going to take them with me. Bury them the way my people do. Maybe it'll give you some peace.”

“ I... I don't... I have no idea what that will do,” the dead woman admitted. “ I'm not sure *why* I linger.”

“ Maybe it'll help,” Adora said. “ If it doesn't... I'll figure out something. I'm the Dragon. I'm a First One. I'll fix this.”

The words did not hurt her this time, and she was glad of it.

The ashes were silent for a time, as Adora placed her skeleton in the tarp, wrapped her gently in the only funeral shroud she had, and carried her back to the skiff.

“ I... thank you,” the Fire Princess said. “ If it works... I... thank you.”

“ I'd like the names, too,” Adora said. “ From your cave. Somebody *should* remember them.”

The Fire Princess nodded. “ I'll guide you myself. Head West from here- I'll show you the way.”

Adora nodded, and the ashes dispersed, to reform where she could show the new Fire Princess where to go. Adora got on her skiff, next to her sister, and lifted off, the bones safely tucked beside her.

She did not know what traditions the burned woman's people had- she'd forgotten to ask before she left, and only Queen Angella of Brightmoon might be old enough to remember such a detail- but she knew what the Horde did with its honorable dead, and Adora would treat the fallen princess as she would one of her own. It was a better burial than laying there, unmourned and unknown, for all those years.

She hoped it would give her peace.

(And though she would never know it, at the moment she placed the enzyme packet on those old bones, and let the dirt cover them, there was a long sigh in the ruined land, and the ashes blew away in the wind, released at last.)

Chapter End Notes

Wonder if the Great Rebellion will let Adora join now? She's technically a Princess now! :D

Chapter 11: The Kith and Kin of Princess Catra of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Trigger Warning (TW) for: Child abuse.

No, seriously.

This was... a hard chapter to write. The hardest, of all of them. I... I'm not totally happy with it. It touches on pain I have felt, and a past I have felt; it's not my best work, I don't think.

This chapter summarizes my reasons for sympathizing with Catra, so very much.

I had a Shadow Weaver, too.

If you cannot read it, I intend to summarize at the end, very briefly, the main points. Skip to the bottom if your stomach cannot handle it; there is no shame in it. I still can't watch Season 2 of Once Upon a Time due to Cora.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Kith and Kin of Princess Catra of Brightmoon

The door to the small, richly appointed rooms of Angella's private quarters was a fairly standard Brightmoon door, nothing like the great gates of Salineas or the impersonal, mechanical doors of the Fright Zone. Maybe a little too ostentatious, like all of Brightmoon was, in Catra's only somewhat humble opinion; still too many little swirls and decorations, too many pointless fiddly bits of decoration. She'd never gotten entirely used to in Brightmoon's

bottomless appetite for decoration; her past as a Hordesman was behind her, and she was glad it was so, but some of the Fright Zone's aesthetic had stayed, despite everything.

But, all in all, the door to Angella's private quarters was fairly standard. Nothing special about it.

So why can't I just... open it?

Catra stood before it, trying to will her arm to raise up, knock on it, pull it open, do... something, and failed. Miserably.

She let out a breath.

This is ridiculous .

The thought did not propel her arm any closer to the door.

Catra let out another breath. Angella's rooms were located in one of the castle's newer wings- she'd moved them here while they were rebuilding after a fire some hundred or so years ago, information Catra had picked up at some point in the last few years by accident- and the hallway here didn't have anything else, so there was no one around; just Catra, standing at the end of the hallway, feeling stupid.

...She didn't want to be here.

More accurately, she didn't want to be here, *right now.* No, a moment an hour ahead or a day behind- now that would be better. A time after the fight- after the blowout- after her mother yelled at her for being stupid, for fleeing the conference like a coward, after Angella disowned her for being an unworthy and ungrateful daughter, that would be better. Or before she'd ran, when she was still content and secure in her place as one of Angella's daughters, before Angella had agreed that Adora had to die.

(She has to convince them to stop, to not go through with it- she still had the nightmare inside her, Adora, with her head falling from her shoulders, no, no, *no*)

And *that* thought gave her strength enough to raise her hand to the door- she had to save Adora- but she paused again as her mind whirled, trying to figure out what to say, what to do, what set of words and actions might convince the Queen to grant mercy to the enemy of her people. Part of Catra- the logical part, which, unfortunately, had always been the weaker part of her brain- knew that Angella was right, that Adora was the enemy, that Angella could do nothing else... but the emotional part, the strongest part, which loved people over ideals, could not help but feel a little... betrayed.

And that was something acidic on top of the stew of emotions already inside her, it made her sick to her stomach, to be... *angry* with Angella. Angry with her, and *scared* of her, too; and wasn't that familiar? She'd felt that way every time Shadow Weaver was mad at her, for whatever reason the thing that had raised her decided was sufficient cause to hurt her.

Angry, and scared, and she wanted to puke.

... *Angella is not Shadow Weaver,* Catra's head reminded her heart, her logic trying to calm her emotions. *Mom... my Queen won't hurt me.*

She... she wanted to think of Angella as *Mom,* she really did. But *Mom* was a thing of a few weeks, *my Queen* a thing of almost four years, and *Shadow Weaver please don't hurt me* was a titan of over a decade; there was no competition, no question, which was dominant, what train of thought ruled in her head. She had never had a serious disagreement with Angella before now, and the only thing she could base her suppositions on about what the argument would be like was Shadow Weaver; all she had to go on were the cold and dark eyes of her first mother, whom some part of her, for reasons Catra had *never* put together, still wanted to love her.

Angella is not Shadow Weaver , she reminded herself, but it sounded very small inside her head.

So small that she found she could not continue, and lowered her hand. She... she couldn't do this. And that was *stupid.* She had *never* been like this before with her Queen; she'd served her faithfully for years, never afraid of her for even a moment, even when she'd geas'd her. Catra had been *pissed,* but not *scared* .

But now... now she was. And she didn't want to think it through, she didn't want to oppose the impulse that said *run away* . She'd always been impulsive; sometimes she could sit down and think it through, but usually she just... acted. Her little way of rebelling against the Fright Zone's order, she supposed; she'd given in to every chaotic urge without a second thought. Her little piece of freedom, a thing the Fright Zone and Shadow Weaver couldn't beat out of her.

A shame it had always backfired on her. Trick Adora mid-fight to steal the victory, get chewed out by Shadow Weaver. Steal from her fellow cadets, ruin all her friendships except with the infinitely patient Adora. Claw Octavia's eye out, which just prompted everyone *else* to hate her even more.

Steal a skiff for a joyride, Catra thought, and glanced down at the sleeping Sword by her side. So much of the past few years had been determined because, just for the hell of it, Catra had decided to celebrate Adora's upcoming appointment to Force Captain with a quick trip through the Whispering Woods.

Okay, that one worked out pretty well for me, Catra admitted to herself.

So the urge was there, to just run, to not stay, to run away as far as she could from her problems; and for just a moment, Catra considered it.

...She wouldn't.

She could, it wouldn't even be that hard- not for the She-Ra- but... she... wouldn't. She was Catra of Brightmoon, She-Ra of Brightmoon. The Alliance had all her friends, all the people she loved (save one), and all the people who loved her in turn. She couldn't abandon the place that had given her the terrible sweetness of happiness. She had fled in a panic, bolting on old instincts, hadn't had time to think or process what she was doing... but now that she had time to actually *think,* she found that she wouldn't run away again.

She simply wasn't the person she had been. Not that she didn't wish she was; it was easier to be that selfish, fragile girl, confidence-masked girl than it was to be the She-Ra, young woman and heroine.

...Not that she wasn't *still* that girl in a lot of ways. She hadn't changed *that* much, since she came to the Alliance. Just look at her now, all wrapped up in *Mom* and *Angella* and *Shadow Weaver please don't hurt me, love me, please.*

(Maybe she couldn't give up on Adora because she'd never figured out how to give up on Shadow Weaver.)

But she was also *She-Ra* and *Hero* and *Best Princess* now. She would not abandon them again. She *had* changed that much.

(Some part of her was a little surprised at that, a part of her heart that was convinced that she, traitorous, tricky Catra, could never be loyal to something bigger than herself; and it felt nice, to be better than some part of her had thought she was, like a surprise present for herself.)

Which meant she still had to open this fucking door.

Catra sighed again, and started working on screwing her courage to the sticking place, wherever that was in a Magicat like herself.

" There has to be a way to do it," Catra muttered to herself. " Has to be a way."

" There usually is."

Catra nearly leapt out of her fur, hand going to the Sword on instinct as she hopped back, hissing at the intruder- who turned out to be Madame Razz, grinning up at her from a spot right next to Catra.

" It's good to hear you hiss, girlie!" the ancient woman said with unfazed cheerfulness. Her grin grew wider, and between her big smile and the dowdy getup, she looked like the world's worst fairy godmother had been squeezed into two foot of elderly Twigget. " I'm glad you're getting more in touch with your instincts, dearie! It's good to embrace what's natural. Healthier than suppressing it."

" You scared me half to death!" Catra said, struggling not to shout at the woman. *I'm the She-Ra, best princess, I can't shout at little*

old ladies, she reminded herself, though it only helped the surprised anger so much. " What if I'd taken a swing at you?!?"

" You'd have missed!" Madame Razz replied cheerfully. " I'm too short! So short that ain't nothing killed me yet, and I'm old, girly! Fought just about everything. You wouldn't even be the first She-Ra to take a swing at me- I scared one of ya'll but good once! She punched a hole clean through a tree when I spooked her. Yet another case in which my lack of height saved my life!"

" I... what?" Catra said. She was the first She-Ra in *centuries,* since Mara... though Glimmer had said some Twiggets lived a long damn time.

" Anyway, don't worry about that yet," the Twigget said, grinning. " That's a thought for tomorrow! Pie day tomorrow. Maybe. Time's kinda fuzzy for me. Anyway, you gotta get through this part first. Your momma's waiting for you, and you ain't ready."

" I... was it that obvious?" Catra said, tail curling protectively around her legs. She didn't like being so obviously vulnerable; that hadn't worked out in the Horde, and even though Catra *knew* she was safe in Brightmoon... well, she'd already acknowledged that her logic was the weakest part of herself.

" It was!" Razz confirmed cheerfully. " But don't worry. I won't tell anyone."

...That actually did make her feel better, stupid as it was.

“ Thank you,” Catra said, and Razz grinned at her even bigger.

“ I'm glad you were chosen,” Razz said. “ Wasn't supposed to be you, but there's lots of possibilities, and I think you turned out amazing. But what do I know? I can't keep track of what day it is, or when that day is. Might want to ask someone else. You got friends, girly?”

“ I... do?” Catra said, momentarily so nonplussed that she turned her answer into a question.

“ You do!” Razz confirmed, as if Catra needed it. “ Lots of friends. A little storm for your thunder, cat. You've got saltwater and snows and the plant girl, but those aren't the people you need to talk to; not your sister, either, not yet. You need the abs-guy, the heartseeker.”

“ Heartseeker?” Catra asked, confused. Her mind ran through her list of friends, before the obvious answer came to her. “ You mean... Bow?”

“ Got it in one!” Razz said with a laugh. “ Heartseeker indeed. He seeks to follow his own heart, and he seeks to know the hearts of his fellows; he's a good man, Bow is. That's rare. Lived a long time; most people are just kinda muddled, not bad, not good. Boring. But Bow's special.”

" He is," Catra agreed, without hesitation.

(It was one reason Catra had no intention of trying to talk Glimmer out of her crush on the archer, something Catra had realized before Glimmer herself had; of all the people she'd met, Bow was one of the few Catra would happily let take her sister's heart, knowing he would take care of it with gentle hands.)

" So go talk to him!" Razz said cheerfully. " Tell him your worries. Let him seek the heart of your fears, and put an arrow in them. And while you're at it, try to get the man to wear a shirt that covers his abs, and then take him to the archery range. I have a theory that if his stomach is ever covered, he will lose all his archery powers, and I really want you to test it."

Catra stared at Madame Razz, all fears and worries totally forgotten in her confusion.

" I... *what* ?" Catra asked, voice high and strained.

" Just a theory!" Razz said defensively. " Or perhaps he's a secret immortal who has a curse preventing him from wearing clothes that cover his stomach. Poor man. That would be awful! He must get so cold in the winter."

" Bow has worn things that cover his stomach before when we go cold places," Catra said, remembering journeys to the polar

regions of the Kingdom of Snows. " He can still... arch. Archering? Whatever."

" My theory requires refinement, then," Razz said with the air of a true scientist, putting one hand to her chin. " Perhaps his curse lets him wear ab-covering designs but only when the temperature drops far enough. Anyway, go talk to him while I'm figuring this out."

" I should... see the Queen first," Catra said, but lamely, making absolutely no movements towards Angella's door. Razz rolled her eyes.

" If you had the guts for that, girly, I wouldn't be here to send you along," she said, making a brushing motion with her staff. " Scoot scoot, now. Practice what you'll tell Angella to Bow. It'll make it easier. Then come see me! Maybe in three day's time, maybe tomorrow- got pie to make! Oh, and tell Angella I'll meet her again for the first time soon, and I'm glad to do so. I *love* introducing her to her fiery girl!"

Catra shrugged at the burst of incomprehensible words that flowed out of the old Twigget's mouth and left, heart lifting in her chest. *Not* immediately confronting Angella... yes, that was... that was a really good idea.

She took off, skulking through the castle, dodging anyone she knew (including her three retainers, who were singing a little cooking song together as they worked in the kitchens.) She still didn't really feel up to talking to anyone, to be honest, but

obeying Madame Razz's command to *go talk to Bow* was better than *go talk to (Mom)Angella* , so that's what she did.

So off she went, hunting, finally finding Bow where he usually was when not training- working on something in the set of castle rooms he'd basically commandeered, the area she'd heard the guards refer to as the “tech master's forge.” Catra had always liked hearing that, liked the awe and praise it was said with.

(Catra would never realize it, but she was the most loving person in the Alliance; she loved the way the sun loves, hard and hot and without reservation, and she wanted those she loved to be loved by others in turn.)

She opened the door- with far less trepidation than she'd had at Angella's- and stepped inside, where she found the good man, working on separating pieces of circuitry from some salvaged Fright Zone tech. He had goggles and a small device, sizzling a little as it unsoldered the device's connections, and after she closed the door, she leaned on the doorframe to watch him for a few minutes, unwilling to interrupt him.

If nothing else, it gave her time to figure out what to say.

Sorry for running off? Because she wasn't, not really. She was sorry that she'd done it because it might cost her, but... she hadn't been able to stay in that room. Not after Netossa's plan, not after that vision in her head of Adora's head, falling from her shoulders, which made her shiver, even now.

Hey how you doing? No, too casual.

Any idea how to save Adora from, uhh, us?

There weren't a lot of great conversational openers here.

The moment arrived while she was still debating with herself. Bow turned his little device off, dropping the removed circuity into a small tray next to him, and as he removed his goggles he spotted her.

" Oh, hey, Catra!" he said with a surprised smile, dashing around the table to hug her. " I'm so glad you're okay! I mean, I figured you would be, but it's good to see you!"

In response, she blurted out the first thing that came to mind right as he wrapped his strong archer's arms around her.

" Yo Bow," she said, like an idiot. She winced even as she said it.

What happened to Catra the Manipulator? She wondered to herself. *Man, I used to be good at this. Now I'm as bad as Adora.*

Well, as bad as Adora *had* been, before... everything.

Bow laughed as he held her tight. " I'm good! How are you? Are you alright? Have you eaten? You didn't take anything with you..."

Actually she *was* kinda hungry now that he pointed it out, but she'd gone hungry often enough in the Fright Zone that it was just background noise.

" I'm fine, come on, don't make a big deal out of it," Catra grumbled, even as she secretly reveled in his delighted greeting, and did nothing to resist his hug (and maybe her tail curled around his waist to hug him back, briefly.) " Enough with the mushy shit."

Still, her ears flicked happily as Bow let go, and some of her tension eased. Bow wasn't mad. He was just glad to see her.

" You love it and you know it," Bow said, backing off to smile at her. " We were so afraid you'd gotten hurt in the spore storm- or the thunder storm, kind of both. Thunderspore? Good band name, that, I might have to run it by Seahawk."

" It's not bad," Catra admitted. " I... how have you been?"

" Worried for you," he said. " Oh, but wait! You probably haven't heard, but Glimmer caught a traitor! Well, Mermista helped."

" I heard," Catra said. " Scorpia... well, Double Trouble, I guess. I knew something was up with the Scorpia we found in Elberon, but we were so busy in the Woods I never had time to sit down and really figure it out."

She let out an annoyed puff of breath.

" I should have stayed and figured it out. Hunting a spy is *exactly* my kind of thing."

" Hey, they fooled all of us," Bow said with a shrug. " Except Mermista and Glimmer, anyway."

" Yeah, but I... I should have caught them," Catra said, frowning. " I should have known- this is the kind of thing I *do* . I should have figured it out before they could hurt anyone."

Bow gave her an odd look, then, something a little sad and a lot loving at the same time.

" It's not all on your shoulders," he said softly. " You know that, right?"

Catra shrugged helplessly, everything inside her just roiling under the surface, hard to let out; but Bow was so happy to see her, and they'd been friends so long...

“ I'm supposed to do it all, though,” she said quietly, without her usual bravado. “ I'm the She-Ra, Bow. I'm supposed to defend us all from *everything* . And especially a spy like this- that's what I *do* , Bow, I'm the clever one, who doesn't get tricked.”

Bow put a hand to her shoulder and squeezed.

“ Catra, you can't expect perfection of yourself,” he said. “ You'll destroy yourself, if you try for that.”

“ I know that, Bow,” she replied. “ But I don't... *know* it? Does that make sense? Sorry, I'm... not good at this talk-out-your-feelings shit.”

“ No, I get that,” Bow said, suppressing a laugh; Catra would take it the wrong way, and Bow didn't want to hurt his friend. “ You're used to being our big knight in shining armor, the invincible She-Ra, so you don't know how to deal with screwing up. It's pretty understandable; you win most of the time, so you don't know what to do with loss.”

“ And I'm glad you know it,” Catra said, smirking before her face fell back to being pensive. “ Doesn't change how I feel, but... yeah, that's probably all it is.”

The silence stretched, stretched until Catra thought it would break; but... where to go from here? Her guilt over not catching the spy was a small thing; the big issue ahead, though...

" Catra," Bow said. " We need to talk about Adora."

" Yeah, I know," Catra responded. " I *don't* want to talk about it, Bow, but I know I... I have to."

Bow squeezed her shoulder again, as the good man's mind pondered how to get his friend to open up. Catra was still a Hordesman, in a lot of ways, in ways that were buried beneath the newer veneer of Brightmoon and the Alliance... how would a Hordesman think of this kind of thing?

Soft and weak, Bow's mind answered. *Everything needs to be hard and strong in the Horde... but then again, soldiers still need each other on the battlefield. How would they put it...?*

" Would it make it easier if you thought of it as just cashing in on a favor?" he asked as he let go of her shoulder. " You know, calling in a debt."

" A... debt?" Catra asked, quirking an eyebrow.

" Yeah," Bow said. " " I mean, we've all come to rely on each other, right? Best Friend Squad."

Seeing that arrow wasn't landing from Catra's confusion, Bow plucked a new one from his quiver.

" I mean, you've helped us deal with our stuff before. Remember my dads?" the archer said. Catra was always entranced by family, maybe this was the right way to get his reluctant friend to let loose with what she clearly needed to. " I never got around to thanking you for lying for me, by the way, so thank you."

" No problem," Catra said, and Bow seized on her acceptance.

" So it's the same thing, right? I owe you for that. So just tell me what's on your mind. It's the same as you helping me with my dads. Just... me paying off a debt to you. Nothing mushy. Just people and their problems. Like soldiers trading off night watch duties."

Some part of Catra still wanted to say no. She still feared telling all the night inside her to her friends, who had no idea what had been done to her in her childhood, and another part of her simply despised herself for needing to tell them. The Hordesman part, she suspected, the part that hated anything weak, that rejected... softness.

But the way Bow presented it... it wasn't a frilly-dilly thing, it wasn't so bad, the way he put it. The Hordesman training didn't want to fight it, anymore, and once that part gave in, the greater whole of her wanted to speak.

(It was a good thing Bow was a good man; his understanding of the inner lives of others would make him a *terrifying* monster, if he so chose.)

So Catra, biting her lip, finally said, " I have to save Adora, because she saved me."

" You've said that a few times," Bow answered slowly, not judging, simply prodding. " Though you've never explained more than that."

" I couldn't," Catra said. " Not... not before. But now... now I have to. Because you're... you're going to kill Adora, if I don't."

" That is Netossa's plan," Bow acknowledged. " Though I, at least, would try to capture her. I wouldn't... I know you wouldn't want her to die, for some reason. I'd do whatever I could to take her in alive."

Hearing him say that- knowing she was not the only person on Etheria that wanted Adora to live- helped break more of the dam down, the wall inside herself that hid... everything.

I can't tell them the truth, some part of her despaired. *They won't believe me. How can they? They've got... his dads, Angella, no one in my life would believe that the thing that raised me tried to kill me. And I still love Shadow Weaver, how fucked up is that? I...*

How can I...

She trembled, and Bow put his hand back on her shoulder, and her hands sought it, and somewhere between needing that comfort and just not being able to hold it all in anymore, it fell out of her in a rush.

" Shadow Weaver... she *hurt* me," she began, the whole truth all at once, sans details.

" What?" Bow asked, but Catra just kept going.

" My whole life, Bow," she said. " Growing up, she was always hurting me, Bow, hurting me, hurting me, *hurting* me. She threatened me, hit me, took away my food- that last for two weeks, once, until Adora started feeding me herself from her own meals. And then she'd attempt to kill me, when she grew tired of threatening me. Adora was the only one who ever stopped her. Shadow Weaver tried to kill me, and Adora stopped her, and that was my *life,* Bow, that was how I lived, that's why I have to save her. I owe her... I owe her everything. I'm alive because Adora didn't let Shadow Weaver kill me."

There, there it was, it was finally out in the open. Catra breathed, hard, clinging to Bow's hand with both of hers, her eyes shut, face pointed down and ears flat against her skull.

There it was. Everything.

...It seemed a lot smaller, now that it was out of her; or at least, it did to Catra. This wasn't important. Everyone knew that, except her, who thought all of this was important. Bow was going to mock her for being weak, the way all the Force Captains had when she went to them for help at Adora's urging. She was weak, she was weak, she was weak.

The silence stretched. The silence smothered her. Bow wasn't talking, and Catra couldn't bear to look up, knowing she'd see disbelief on his face. If he did believe her, he'd tell her it wasn't that bad, but he wouldn't believe her. No one ever did, no one *ever* listened to her, she was a child all over again and the monster was going to get her and no one *cared* .

" What?" Bow finally asked, sounding lost.

" I have to save Adora because she always saved me," Catra finished, and tried not to cry. He didn't believe her, he wasn't going to believe her...

" She tried to kill you," Bow whispered, and his voice was different, tight and low and full of... of something, something like the violence a nocked arrow promised, something deep and *angry* that she had never, in all the years of their friendship, heard in Bow's voice before.

Catra dared to peek, looking up at his face, and found Bow wasn't looking at her, was lost in the grip of an emotion she'd never seen in him before.

" You were a *child,* " he said, with horrified... fury.

Bow was angry.

No, that was too small for this; she could almost see a red light in his eyes, in the tension in his smooth, strong jaw. He was *furious* , that was a good term for it; so angry that he had passed any outward sign of it, save a tenseness in his pose and face.

" Bow?" she asked, and hated how small and weak she sounded.

He looked at her, and she still saw the fire in him- the tremor, like the thunderbolts of an angry god, that ran through his muscles- but she also saw the effort he put into calming himself down, the way he very deliberately paused himself before he spoke again, bringing up his other hand to put atop hers.

" She hurt you?" he asked, not to dismiss her words, but to confirm them. She nodded, numb, surprised that, at last, someone had listened to the oldest cry for help she had inside her.

" Always," she said, her eyes watering as she saw he believed her. " When she wasn't debating killing me, or attempting it, there was

always... words or magic or cold eyes and cold hands, always... always something.”

“ And we let her into Brightmoon,” he said with disgust, his anger leaking out like flames. “ We let her into Brightmoon... we let her *live* here. In the castle.”

“ You didn't know,” she said quickly, not wanting him to blame himself or (Mom) Angella. “ I never- I should have said something...”

“ Why didn't you?” he asked, careful to keep his tone gentle, even as she could see what an effort it was for him not to... to do *something* .

“ I couldn't, Bow,” Catra admitted. “ Not to you or Glimmer a-and definitely not to my Queen. I... your dads, they're so *good* , and Glimmer and Angella love each other even with all their fighting, I-I didn't think anyone would *believe* me *...* I can hardly believe *you* believe me... how? Your dads love you so *much,* that's why I lied for you, so your dads wouldn't be mad... I *get* it, Bow, to have parents like that I'd do... I'd do anything. Anything, to make sure they were never disappointed in me.”

Her tail curled around herself, and she fought the hitch in her chest that made her want to weep; Bow, in an act of great kindness, did and said nothing, let Catra fight to keep her dignity intact, knowing that this was already hard enough on her.

(He would never judge her tears, but knew that some part of Catra would judge herself for them, and his friend had already been through so much- so much that his thoughts were catching fire, he was so *angry* , to know what had been done to her, angry in the way of righteous men, angry in a way that demanded justice.)

" My dads are good men," Bow said, a fact that he had known all his life, and never been more grateful for than in this moment. " Doesn't mean I can't wrap my head around the opposite."

" I don't get that," Catra admitted. " I could barely- you know I thought my Queen was just Shadow Weaver in an angel's costume, first time I came here? Because she yelled at Glimmer. I thought it was just... Shadow Weaver, all over again. It wasn't until Glimmer was captured, and I saw how horrified she was, that I understood. I don't know how you can... can understand. I barely can."

Bow squeezed her hands.

" I do understand," he said. " I do. In point of fact, I should have known from the start."

" How?" she asked.

" You," he said simply. " You were so scared that first night, when she first got here. I always meant to talk to you about it- but then

the portal, and the celebration, and everything else made it just... slip my mind. But I knew, from that first night, that something was up; Catra, I've *never* seen you be scared of *anything* before. Remember the ghost village? You shrugged that off like it was nothing. But you were terrified of Shadow Weaver.”

He shook his head as he removed his right hand to wrap his arm around her, trapping her arms between them, holding her tight in a way that made her feel terribly safe.

“ Hey, it's alright,” she said, shakily, breathing deep of his scents; bowstring oil and the sizzle of metal smoke and the cedar soap he favored, steadying scents, calming scents. Her tail curled around him again. “ It's okay. You didn't know.”

“ I still should have guessed” he said, letting go of her and pulling back. Catra's tail chased him for a second before she let go, too. “ No wonder you want to save Adora.”

“ I have to,” Catra said. “ I have to.”

He just held her for a moment.

“ What do you want to do about... her?” he asked. “ Shadow Weaver, I mean.”

“ I don't know,” Catra sighed. “ She's *useful* , she helped us, and... and... I...”

She swallowed hard.

“ I love her, Bow. I love her still.”

Bow gave her a look of total incomprehension that made Catra give a laugh that sounded quite a bit like a sob.

“ I know,” she said, holding up a hand to forestall all the things the archer wanted to say. “ I know.”

Bow shook his head as Catra tried to gather her thoughts, catching only wind.

“ What do I want to do, Bow?” Catra said tiredly. “ You asked me that when Shadow Weaver got here, and I'm no closer to an answer now. I want her to apologize, I want her to die, I want her to love me, I want her to go away and never come back.”

She paused, and shook her head.

“ I want so many things, Bow, things I can't... And then Mom-Angella- she's helped, she adopted me and I'm so *happy* for that,

but now I've run off and she's going to be so *mad* at me and it's *stupid* but I think I'd rather *die* than hurt Angella, than make her look at me and regret adopting me. I think I'd die if she did that anyway, if she wasn't Mom anymore. I'm...”

She paused, just breathing for a moment, and then laughed, the sound a little wet with unshed tears.

“ I'm a fucking *mess* , Bow.”

“ Sounds like it,” he agreed, putting a little forced levity in his voice.

“ I know it's wrong,” she said. “ I just can't stop myself.”

“ Well, I don't know what to do about that,” he said, “ so let's focus on something else for now. We need to figure out how to sell not killing Adora to Angella... but I'm just... yeah, I'm not ready to do that. Sorry, this has... I want to go find Shadow Weaver and use her for target practice. I have no *idea* how you can claim you love her, after all this. I've *never* been this angry before, I'm almost high on it.”

“ How would you know that? Have you been high?” Catra said, teasing, glad for the change of subject even as she surreptitiously wiped her eyes (she hadn't cried, which she held as a personal triumph.) “ I didn't know you had it in you, Bow!”

He chuckled, rolling his eyes. " We've been to Plumeria, Catra, I think that makes us all high by proxy... and Perfuma rolled me one once. Wasn't terrible, though not my favorite thing."

Catra shook her head. " I'm stunned and appalled. I thought you were more strait-laced than that."

He grinned, though she could tell from his posture that he wasn't done being mad yet- but not mad at her, mad *for* her, a beautiful thing to see, something that steadied her when her guts felt like they'd fall out of her in a rush.

" Well, you can be stunned and appalled all you want, just get busy thinking about what we need to say to Queen Angella," he replied. " I'm too mad to think about what to say. I'm going to work it off... could always use some more non-lethal arrows. Something to use to catch Adora instead of executing her. Maybe we can modify Netossa's plan- we can still take Adora out, but we don't have to kill her."

" Maybe don't take Netossa along," Catra mumbled.

" Maybe not," Bow agreed.

Catra took in a deep breath, let it out, and let herself feel... better.

Not perfect. She still had to talk to her Queen.

But... better.

“ Bow?” Catra said.

“ Yeah?” he answered, as he moved back to his workbench.

“ I don't say this enough, but I'm glad you're my friend,” she said. He smiled back.

“ I'm glad to be your friend too,” he said. “ I don't say that often enough either, I think.”

“ You do,” she replied. “ You and Glimmer are all mushy, but I'm not, so... thank you for being my friend.”

“ You're welcome,” he said.

An impulse struck her then, in the midst of feeling good, and Catra, who'd already resisted her impulses once today, found she couldn't deny them a second time.

" I'm going to go talk to Angella right now, actually," she said. " While I've still got the courage to do so."

And she left the room, holding her head up high, Bow too surprised to respond until she was already gone, just shook his head at his friend and got ready to work on a very special arrow.

(*A new project to work on,* Bow thought, with the light-headed clarity of pure righteous fury. *Like what to do about a certain monster we let into our midst.*)

Catra marched through Brightmoon, no longer dodging anyone, floating almost entirely on the high of *Bow believes me* and the wonder of someone else caring, a thing that had never happened to her before. Catra the Child- the oldest part of her- didn't know what to do with this, had never expected anyone else to ever care about Shadow Weaver's abuses; Bow's anger had been a relief so sharp it almost hurt, it had cut her, just a little, the way a scalpel might.

(Maybe surgery was the right metaphor; she felt wounded and healed, all at once.)

It hadn't fixed her. Not by a long shot. And she knew that the coming confrontation with Angella would be worse- so much worse- she hadn't cried in front of Bow, or at least, not much, but she suspected it wouldn't be the same before her Queen.

Mom , she reminded herself. It was easier, now, after someone had believed her, now that she'd said all the truth to someone else. *Mom.*

Still, she had the strength now to go, to open that door; Razz had been right, talking to Bow first had been a good idea.

She greeted those she met with quick waves and nods of her head without stopping, letting nothing deter her as she headed straight to her destination. Within moments she stood before the damn door, the one she'd been stuck in front of; after a moment's debate, instead of knocking, she just opened it. She was a Princess of Brightmoon, after all; she was Angella's daughter. She had a right to be here.

(She forced out all thoughts otherwise, wielded the memory of Bow's anger- anger for *her* , anger on her behalf, anger like she'd hoped to find all those years ago in the Fright Zone- as a nightlight against all her shadowy terrors, and drew strength from her friend.)

In she went, without hesitation, to a place she'd only seen on the way out, after Glimmer teleported her inside on the night Angella adopted her- and she'd been so caught up in that, reeling so hard, that to be frank she couldn't remember a *thing* about these rooms.

So, seeing it as with new eyes, Catra looked around as she tried to figure out where her Queen- *Mom*- was. The first room- little more than a foyer, effectively- was mostly just an empty box; a shoe rack nearby, along with a few jackets and other last-minute things, were the only inhabitants other than Catra, with an open passageway out that led to a small hallway and then a... dining area, Catra thought. And past that was the private dressing room and the actual bedroom proper... maybe. Her memories of most of that night past all the crying were fuzzy.

“ My...” Catra began to call out, before pausing to lick her lips and, with renewed strength, try again. “ Mom?”

“ Catra?” came the response, flavored with Angella's accent, which Catra had never quite been able to place. No one else really shared it; she wondered if it had been a standard Brightmoon accent, in the long-ago days when Angella was... born, she supposed? Though she'd never seen anything or anyone else like Angella, nor even heard of one. “ Is that you?”

“ It's... it's me, Mom,” Catra said, her bravado starting to shake. The rush from Bow was wearing off, and in its place fear started to curl up inside her guts. This was a *terrible* idea. What was she going to say? She should have waited, come up with something, before marching down here on a whim.

Dumbass! Catra cursed herself. *You **just** got done thinking of all the times going off half-cocked has backfired on you, why did you do it again?!?*

“ Come here,” Angella said, voice cool and calm, which Catra's worried mind misread as cold and angry, which made her stomach want to fall out of her.

With an effort of will, Catra stifled any trembling and headed towards the voice, with a much less self-assured stride that carried her past the foyer, past a small dumbwaiter in the hallway for bringing up meals from the kitchens below, past a long low

arch, to a room that had a few new portraits up, of Angella and her husband, things painted when the Mystacoran man still lived.

I wonder what he'd think of me, some quiet part of Catra thought idly, even under the blanket of dread on her soul, a dread that reached fever pitch as she saw Angella sitting at the room's small round table, sipping Brightmoon wine delicately from a glass, a severe frown on her face.

(At that very moment, unbeknownst to her, Scorpia, when not punching some of Beast Island's monsters, was telling Micah a story about "Wildcat", which Micah's jumbled mind came to believe was Catra's real name; he *did* approve of the brave, smug warrior woman Scorpia was describing, in between blasting monsters himself, though he *did* question the necessity of Scorpia constantly informing him of how attractive she thought this "Wildcat" was.)

Catra stood before the table, ears flat, tail flicking anxiously, feeling her heart tumble like a stone into her guts. Angella was mad at her. Catra had disappointed her; Catra seized up, her body unconsciously preparing itself to be hurt, the muscle memory of old pain.

" Catra," Angella began, looking at her with that stern gaze and disapproving frown. Catra couldn't quite look at that, averting her eyes to look down. " First things first. Are you alright?"

...That made her stumble, a little. She had expected a lot of things; shouting, screaming, an argument like Angella had with Glimmer, mostly.

She hadn't expected to be asked how she was, first.

" I'm fine," Catra demurred.

" Are you sure?" Angella said, and Catra dared peek- saw concern on her mother's face, even as she was still obviously angry with her. " You don't seem fine- have you been to a healer since you returned?"

" No, but I'm fine," Catra said. Angella looked at her searchingly, Catra's eyes avoiding hers, before deciding to accept her daughter's words at face value... though she certainly didn't *look* alright. No, her brave, confident daughter looked... scared, to Angella's ancient eyes.

Still, Angella put that aside for now. For all her love for her adopted daughter, bolting in the middle of a strategy meeting was inappropriate at best (and diplomatically painful, to boot), and running off in the middle of a sporestorm and thunderstorm both was dangerously reckless... but those weren't the things Angella really wanted to talk about.

No, it was Catra's nonsensical desire to protect a woman who had tried for four years to *kill* her that Angella wanted to focus on; she could see where that would lead, and Angella had already lost her husband to this war. She did not want to hear that Catra, trying to save Adora, had been stabbed in the back by the renegade First One. The very idea, the very *concept*, ached, ached as badly as

the idea of losing Glimmer had ached for long years, and Angella would do nearly anything to ensure her children survived this war.

" Catra, we have to talk about your recent actions," the Queen of Brightmoon began, less firm in tone than she'd expected to be. Something was still off with her daughter.

" I know," Catra said, and Angella's train of thought was derailed once more; this wasn't how the immortal thought this would go. Admittedly, she only had Glimmer to base it off of for personal experience, but she was an old, old being; she'd seen parents with their children before, though in her fear and worry she had failed to apply those lessons to Glimmer until very recently.

(But apply them she had, and just in time; her daughter had given her a second chance, and Angella would always be grateful for Glimmer's benevolence. Glimmer had not been a perfect daughter, either... but a parent owed the child a higher duty than the other way around.)

She'd assumed that bold, brash Catra would fight back, deny any wrongdoing, or at least have some clever explanation for her; she hadn't expected this... terrified obeisance.

Angella opened her mouth, then shut it, not sure what to say... and maybe that was good. The pause gave her a moment to think before she spoke, and remember all her mistakes with Glimmer, all the times she'd spoken too quickly, said the wrong thing. The two were quite different, but similar lessons still applied...

(And, if she was to be honest with herself- which, to her credit, she usually was- she found she could not bear to be too harsh

with Catra, not in the face of the young woman's clear, quiet torment, whatever its source.)

So with a gentler tone, Angella said quietly, " Catra, I understand that you have lingering feelings for this Adora... but you know, better than most, the cost of this war, the lives she and the Horde both have destroyed or hurt. We are at war, Catra, and we have our people to think of..."

" You don't understand," Catra said,shutting her eyes, and shaking.

Some part of Angella wanted to snap back, the way she always had with Glimmer... but she had held back, recently. Her and her daughter had managed a single, stumbling conversation about their truths, and all because Angella had bit down her first response.

So she bit it down again with her second daughter, in hope of repeating her prior success.

" Then help me understand," Angella asked, not demanding, not yelling, simply wanting Catra to explain, and that was it; that was what finally broke Catra down, when even Bow's closeness could not. Against the gentle moonlight of Angella's regard, Catra had no defenses.

The tears started to fall.

“ She saved me,” she whispered, the second time in her life she had ever admitted the truth. “ From... from Shadow Weaver, back in the Horde...”

“ Saved you?” Angella prodded, and then everything, everything, fell out of Catra's mouth, along with her tears.

“ Shadow Weaver spent my childhood hurting me,” Catra sobbed, “ and Adora saved me. That's my life.”

More, after that. It came out in a flood, she almost vomited her words out. She had to say them, she had to spit out this poison; she'd been right, surgery was the right word for it. Catra cut herself open and drew out not She-Ra of Brightmoon or Catra of the Horde but someone older than both, Catra the Child, Catra at the very heart of herself, and laid it bare on the ground for Angella to see.

And she bled out of her mouth while she did it.

(*She tortured me for going into the Black Garnet room, once. Adora got out with just a pat to the head, but she hurt me instead... and maybe some part of me hates Adora a little bit, too, but we were children. Children under... **her...** and Adora did what she could to protect me. Shadow Weaver told me in Mystacor, once, that Adora was meant to have the Sword- that's why she bothered to listen to Adora. She wanted to stay on Adora's good side, so she let me live as a gift to the golden child. I'm alive because of Adora, even if she didn't really protect me from Shadow Weaver much.*)

There was more detail, than before. Talking to Bow had ripped the top off of the scab; now the blood came pouring out, as she dug in, deeper, cut herself and cut herself, speaking between sobs. She was vaguely aware of a collapse, of a sensation of falling, of the coldness of the floor on her knees.

(*She stopped me from eating, once. Hurt and intimidated the mess sergeants to make sure no one would give me anything. Don't remember why. Adora gave me half her ration bars so I'd live, and when Shadow Weaver caught her and put a stop to it, she worked out a deal with Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio to give me some of their bars. I would have starved otherwise. Never did get to eat too well out there, even after she finally relented; somehow the quartermaster always had just a little less, for me, than for the others. No one ever said why. No one had to.*)

She couldn't stop talking. Her voice started to hurt, her head was ringing, she felt drunk and sick and light-headed all three, and still she kept going; she couldn't stop. The Crystal Castle, all over again, drowning in memories once more... but this time, the shadows were all hers. The only things that anchored her was a sensation of great wings curling protectively around her, two slender arms, joined at some later point by a strong, stout presence, two muscled arms joining in.

(*She liked to hold me in place. A little magic, a shadow curled around me, and suddenly I was in the air. I'd stay that way for... hours, sometimes. I spent every second terrified the magic holding me still would go... just a little further... and crush me into paste. Sometimes she'd do that just enough to break a finger, or an ankle. She'd do it for fun, or when she had to punish Adora for a mistake- she'd hurt me, instead. Worked just as well, and with no risk to her golden child... no risk to anybody important at all. I was just Adora's hanger-on, her pet. If she had murdered me, no one would have avenged my death, nobody would have even*

remembered*... except Adora. Adora's pleas were the only reason Shadow Weaver never took that next step.*)

When she surfaced, she found she was in her family's arms; Angella and Glimmer were both holding her. She was looking over Angella's shoulder, could feel Glimmer hugging her and her mom hugging her and the wings around them both. Catra was on her knees on the floor- they were all on the floor- her hands were covering her face, some remnant of being a Hordesman trying to hide her shame from her kin.. and that fit, she had been remembering her days as a Hordesman, hadn't she?

She swallowed, which hurt; her tongue was dry, her mouth was dry, she felt like she'd been salted inside and out. The window, and the light streaming in, showed that she'd been here for... a long time. Why was she...?

Adora. That was why she'd started talking, the thread she'd lost in the middle of her weeping- Adora. She had to save Adora.

She managed to croak out, " That's... that's why. I have to save her. Adora. Everything I am... I owe to her. Even now."

And that was... it. She had nothing left. She couldn't even muster up the willpower to be angry at herself for not being the clever manipulator she could be; she felt drained, empty. Lanced, like a boil. She wasn't even crying anymore, though her cheeks were sopping wet.

When her mother pulled back, Catra saw that the angel had been crying, too.

" Catra," she began, voice thick, " I... I didn't know."

" Me neither," Glimmer said from behind her, directly into Catra's back where her face was buried. " Holy *shit*."

" We let her into the castle, where you *sleep*, she could have..." Angella said, shaking her head, so horrified she couldn't even finish the thought.

Catra observed her dully, feeling only a little... surprise, at Angella's horror. Some part of her had, quietly, been insisting that Catra was just being dramatic, that her pain was not so important, nor so deep... or that she would not be believed anyway, even after Bow. Bow had always been the best of them, anyway, it wasn't as big of a shock that he'd believe her...

" Moons, I've been studying magic with *her*," Glimmer said faintly, again directly into Catra's spine. Catra, still so dull and empty, awkwardly wrapped her tail around her in a sideways hug.

" S'fine," Catra demurred, but Angella shook her head. " I never... I never told you. You couldn't have known."

“ Yes, I could,” Angella answered suddenly, sharp, angry- but with herself, Catra observed. “ The way you were so *scared*- I should have used common sense, I should have... I should not have let her stay here, in my home. In *your* home.”

“ You run a nation at war, Mom, she was a war asset with valuable intelligence-”

“ A war asset, no matter how valuable, can be kept in many places,” the Queen retorted. “ I *do* run a country; I could place her in any fort or keep in my domain. I could place her *far away* from those she has harmed.”

Her face turned pleading. “ I... Catra, I am so sorry. She will *never* be allowed back in this castle. And if I find she is here, that she has come seeking to harm you... I will kill her myself. She will never hurt you again.”

Catra gave her a little grin that she hoped was reassuring, though under the weight of how numb she felt, it was hard to tell. Angella's words sounded nice... but now that Catra's pain was out, it seemed smaller. Maybe this wasn't as big of a deal as they were all making it; Brightmoon was soft, like that.

“ It's fine,” Catra said. “ You don't... need to go that far. Besides, it wasn't always bad. Sometimes it was almost good.”

Sort of. Kinda. Moments when Shadow Weaver had not looked at her in contempt, when she'd approved of some clever trick or stunt, when Catra could pretend she loved her.

(*Why do I feel like this why can't I hate her why do I love her*)

" What?" Glimmer said in stunned disbelief. " How the fuck-"

" I am in full agreement with Glimmer," Angella said. " Why-"

They said other things, but through the blood buzzing in her skull, Catra found it hard to hear- there was a reason she'd done this...

Adora.

" It's not important right now," she insisted quietly, cutting through both their arguments. " I... Adora. Adora's important. Now you know why... I have to save her. I know what she's done- I know... I know it's unforgivable. But I owe her too much. I *have* to save her."

She breathed in, letting her family hold her, almost a nest of feathers and warmth. Her piece was said. She had nothing left.

" Okay," Angella said, sighing. " I... I understand *that.* I understand it a lot better, now. Let's... well, let's get up, first."

Angella's bones popped quietly as she stiffly rose from the floor. Catra rose up, a bit stiff too; how long had they been sitting down here? Glimmer was the only one who got up without cracking joints.

" I... I get why you're not giving up on Adora," Angella said. " We'll work something out. Not tonight- I'm not- I'm not really ready to do anything else, tonight. Not after hearing about all of that. I think I need a stiff drink and a few hours to think."

" Agreed," Glimmer said, and her face showed she'd been crying, too, and in kind of an ugly way.

" When did you even get here?" Catra asked, curious- sort of. She mostly wanted to sleep, but she was wondering in a vague way why Glimmer was even here.

" Dropped in after I was done training to see you after Mom got done yelling at you," Glimmer said. " Thought I'd be all supportive big sister, you know? But I kind of... stumbled in during your talk. Sorry if you didn't want me to hear..."

" It's fine," Catra mumbled. " You're family."

Glimmer squeezed her shoulder, reminding Catra of Bow, and she leaned into it. Her kith and kin, supporting her... it felt... nice,

even as dulled as all her feelings were.

" You seem... exhausted," Angella said, cocking her head like a crow looking at shiny objects. Her mom had a lot of bird tendencies- which some part of Catra's tired mind realized was kind of funny, considering she'd adopted a cat. " Are you alright?"

" Want sleep," Catra said, putting a hand to her forehead. Her head hurt, her throat hurt... " Water first, then sleep."

Angella nodded. " Glimmer, would you-"

" Two steps ahead of you," Catra's sister answered, and teleported with Catra to her room, disappearing right after. Catra blearily blinked at the sparkling spot she'd left until she came back, glass in hand.

" I didn't tell Mom goodbye or anything," Catra complained, though she took the cup gratefully.

" She understands," Glimmer said. " Me too. I understand... so much, now."

Catra didn't want to deal with that, so she downed the cup and, with no further adieu, curled herself up in her bed.

“ Night, Glimmer,” she said, and succumbed, finally, to her exhaustion.

Glimmer looked down at her sister with a look of pity and empathy that Catra would have punched her for if she'd been awake.

“ Night, sister,” Glimmer said to her unconscious form, pulling the blanket up a bit before heading back to her mom, to talk about what they'd just heard.

-

Shadow Weaver sighed as she entered the stables.

Well, that wasn't as useful as it could have been; just the brat, whining to her archer friend. And unfortunately, Angella had apparently upgraded her personal security after Shadow Weaver's last visit; she hadn't been able to get inside Angella's private chambers, too barricaded by magic to be worth risking it.

A waste of good spying time, all in all. She'd have hoped to hear something more interesting than her former ward's self-pitying mewling to the tech master, but once she found she couldn't enter Angella's private chamber, she'd been forced to resume normal form and get on with her business, acquiring the few things she needed and leaving Glimmer a letter at her room- apparently she was out training, according to the guards she'd spoken with.

Shadow Weaver approved; Micah had spent most of his time training, too, and she was glad to know his daughter took her own duties as seriously.

Still, her espionage wasn't all a bust. She had learned that Angella would be against her, now. Brightmoon's Queen might side with Catra, after all, given that she was far too soft to understand that harshness breeded greatness; but even if she didn't, Angella had adopted Catra, which the foolish girl thought meant something. Shadow Weaver saw the ploy for what it was- Angella tying the She-Ra, the *Sword* , to herself- but Catra didn't see that, and it meant Angella would have to give the sniveling of the ungrateful child credit, or risk revealing the real nature of Catra's adoption to her.

So either way, Shadow Weaver figured she would be persona non grata for a time, and it might behoove her not to be present for a while.

With that knowledge, Shadow Weaver hopped aboard the transport-walker once again. She'd gotten what she needed and left the letter that would drag Glimmer north to Dryll; no reason to stick around.

She couldn't wait until Glimmer got to Dryll; then the real work could begin.

(And that night, after a long talk with her mother, Glimmer found the message from Catra's abuser, and a plan began to percolate in her mind.)

Chapter End Notes

Main Points: Catra tells Bow, Angella and Glimmer about her abuse at Shadow Weaver's hands, and how Adora protected her as best she could. Bow gets super angry and begins making a new tech arrow, while Angella threatens to kill Shadow Weaver and Glimmer is horrified. Catra passes out afterwards, so emotionally drained she has to sleep.

Shadow Weaver, who heard the conversation with Bow but NOT the conversation with Angella and Glimmer, gets some stuff for Entrapta and leaves a note for Glimmer to come to Dryll for mysterious reasons. Then she bails herself, since she knows that Catra DID go to talk to Angella, and in her dismissive way assumes correctly that she will be banned from Brightmoon.

See you next time; and be well, all who live under those who do not love them.

Chapter 12: The Princesses of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Something lighter.

TW: Child abuse (lightly touched on; Shadow Weaver exists, and that will always haunt this tale.)

The morning after. The *very* early morning, this is like right at dawn.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Princesses of Brightmoon

Catra woke early the next morning, feeling fuzzy and drained. She'd just woken up, but all she wanted was to go back to sleep...

...Well, that wasn't totally true. She *also* wanted to never, *ever* talk about yesterday. Or about *anything* she'd said yesterday, to Bow or Glimmer or Mom, but they'd probably want to talk and she just wasn't ready for that, so she tried to burrow back into her covers, more mole than cat in that moment. Hopefully no one would bother her.

" You awake?"

Fuck.

“ No,” Catra responded.

Her sister's laughter echoed around her as Catra tried to curl up tighter on the bed, and ignore her.

“ Sleeptalking! Apparently a talent of the She-Ra,” Glimmer said cheerfully as she loomed over Catra's bundled-up form (which was a new feeling for her, given how short she was.) “ Anyway, I know it's early, but I figured you'd want to see me before I left.”

Before she left...?

“ You're leaving?” Catra asked muzzily, uncurling a bit to look, blinking, up at Glimmer- and wow, that was a weird thing to do, made her whole world feel topsy-turvy.

“ Yep!” Glimmer said, grinning down at Catra, who seemed a lot smaller and softer with her face just poking out of the blankets. She looked cute, like a kitten in that moment, innocent with one big blue eye and one big yellow eye, and Glimmer had to resist the urge to comment on her sister being adorable. Catra would murder her if she did, after all, and Glimmer had no desire to be the victim of sororicide.

“ Where are you going?” Catra said. “ Nobody told me the Squad was heading out...”

“ Oh, it's just me, going off on a thing for a bit,” Glimmer responded, before hastily adding, “ Nothing to worry the whole Squad about!”

Catra rubbed her eyes, and while she did so, what Glimmer said actually registered to her still sleepy brain. When it did, she looked up sharply at her sister.

“ Really,” she said flatly.

“ What?” Glimmer said defensively.

“ If you have to specify there's nothing to worry about, there's something to worry about,” Catra said, rising up to sit on the side of the bed, which finally made her taller than Glimmer and put the world back to its rightful order.

“ That... doesn't have to be true!” Glimmer responded, and Catra gave her a Look that she knew well; it was the same look their mother gave Glimmer when she'd done something stupid.

(Glimmer had been right, the night of Catra's adoption; Angella had been Catra's mother long before it was made official. And like all daughters, Catra learned from her mother many things- including certain expressions.)

Glimmer sweated with a big, dopey fake smile on her face. Catra sighed.

" You are the worst liar I have ever met," she breathed out.

" Hey, that's not fair!" Glimmer protested. " You grew up with Adora, you have really high standards for lying!"

A laugh slipped out of Catra's mouth, surprising her before she shook her head.

" Okay, that's... that's fair," she said, still moving slowly. She was so tired. Sleep had barely helped, it felt like; but talking with Glimmer was helping, a little. Made her feel more alive, at any rate.

" Anyway, it's nothing big," Glimmer said. " just... some stuff!"

Catra gave her another Look, same as the first. Catra, whose life in childhood had, at times, depended on knowing when someone was lying, was so over-qualified for the job of detecting Glimmer's bullshit it was almost insulting.

" *Glimmer*."

“ I'm...” Glimmer started, before stopping. An idea apparently hit her, her face lighting up as she grinned and put hands to her hips. “ I'm not gonna say anything! Nope. Can't lie, but don't have to tell you the truth!”

Catra smirked a bit at the short pugilist's antics.

“ Does Mom know?” she asked.

Glimmer nodded her head vigorously.

“ Actually, yeah! Mom knows,” the fairy brute replied automatically, too fast for it to be a deception.

Catra mused on that. If Glimmer was telling the truth, and Queen Angella knew, then why wasn't Glimmer just telling Catra where she was going? Admittedly, the one time Glimmer *had* ever managed to trick her had been when she'd lied about Angella approving the Best Friend Squad's first trip into the Crimson Waste... but that had been because Catra was so invested in Mara's ship, and thrown off by Shadow Weaver's appearance that she-

...Oh.

The answer was so obvious, so clear, that for a second she just paused.

Shadow Weaver.

She *was* still a war asset, after all, and Glimmer *was* learning magic from her- though why she couldn't ask Castaspella, Catra didn't know. She *should* ask, should do anything to get Glimmer away from that monster, but she didn't have the strength to carry that conversation right now, could tell that her slowy-recuperating mind and heart wouldn't be able to bear up under that strain.

But she *did* have strength enough to warn.

" I... be careful," Catra said, as her ears flattened to her skull. " Shadow Weaver is..."

" I know," Glimmer said, and Catra was grateful for the interruption, grateful for her sister's hands seeking out her own, squeezing them softly. It had hurt Catra, to speak of her again so soon, and she was grateful that Glimmer had cut her off before she had to say more. " I know. Now I know, and she won't hurt you, ever again."

It wasn't herself that Catra was worried about; but then Glimmer gave her a Look, too. Not the Look Catra had given her, but a different one- a small, sad smile, something the boisterous princess had never worn before, a subtle thing from the brute-force fairy that smothered Catra's words with great and awful gentleness.

That... that was *Mom's* smile, the same small, sad smile that *Angella* gave her, when she had to send her out into danger, when she had to risk the lives of those she loved or lose them and all Brightmoon in the bargain. That smile spoke of love, and care, and concern, and all the gentle moonlight of Angella's regard; now it spoke of all the gentle moonlight of *Glimmer's* regard, and Catra suddenly found herself choked up, she could not speak. Against that tiny movement of Glimmer's mouth, the Princess of Power was totally helpless. After her confessions last night, she was too much like the Catra-That-Was, Catra the Child, starving for love in the Fright Zone, and not enough like Catra-That-Is, Catra the Princess, beloved of her people; Catra the Princess knew what being loved was, but Catra the Child did not, and so every drop of her family's love was too much, it threatened to break her in half.

Thus overwhelmed, all Catra could do was squeeze her sister's hands back, and bow her head, eyes stinging with unshed tears, full of that terrible sweetness that, once upon a time, had led her to choose Brightmoon in the depths of the Fright Zone of her own free will, when no shackles of light or darkness had commanded her.

And perhaps Glimmer understood, for she only squeezed her hands back, and spoke, filling in the silence for her sister.

" Don't worry about me," Glimmer said, with a low chuckle, and something surprisingly *sharp* in her tone, cutting and edged like a hidden knife. " I remember *everything* you said. I'll be careful."

It almost sounded like a threat, to Catra's ears.

(And it was, though it wasn't directed at anyone present.)

Glimmer squeezed her hands again.

" I'm gonna leave," she said. " You get some more rest, okay? I got your three retainers cooking, they've got a meal ready for you whenever you're ready to eat it. You take today off, alright?"

Catra still could not speak, but she could still nod her head, still not looking up, not trusting herself if she had to look at that smile and be loved so purely. It was too much, when she was this raw, when she'd just spent so long in her memories as a Hordesman, when the the memories she'd made as a Rebel were not real enough to shield her after such a deep dive.

But that was enough, and so Glimmer left her with one last squeeze of her hands, withdrawing slowly and carefully, the clumsy and unthinking princess startlingly circumspect and delicate with her sister; and that, that was another show of love, the way the smile had been, and Catra was overwhelmed once more with a fresh wave of feelings. Catra only barely saw as Glimmer double-checked the room's shades, making sure the slowly-rising light did not bother Catra, before slipping into the shadows that still lingered near the door, throwing one last fond look back before she quietly slipped out.

Alone, Catra didn't know what to do with her over-full heart, not right then... but that wasn't so bad, she realized. She *would* know,

soon, as her more recent life as a Rebel caught up, as the part of her that *had* been loved could reassert herself over the part of her that had never been loved by anyone, save Adora. That part of her could teach the other half how to be loved, for she *was* loved; loved by her mother, loved by her sister, loved by her friends and her people. She was loved, and they had *believed* her, and the future had become a thing of miracles; she was believed. The oldest prayer on her lips had finally been answered; someone had believed that Shadow Weaver was hurting her, and that it was wrong.

Everything would be smaller, after that. Everything *had* to be, because that was the biggest thing in Catra's soul; nothing else would ever compare. It would be easier, now.

And... maybe she would save Adora. Maybe now, she *could.*

...No, she was the *best Princess.* She *would* pull the Adora who had saved her alive out of the monster she had become, she *would* defeat the Horde, and she *would* have... how had it been put, in that Brightmoon book Bow had taught her to read, back when she was recuperating after defending Brightmoon from the Horde?

Ah, yes.

Happily ever after.

She was going to make it.

And with that thought warming all the emptiness inside of her, Catra lowered her head back to her pillow, and went back to sleep, to dream of cheerful nothings that she would never remember, that would nonetheless leave her feeling refreshed upon waking.

(And for the first time, some part of herself- very, very quietly- thought *maybe someday I will no longer love Shadow Weaver, and she won't ever be able to hurt me again.*)

Chapter End Notes

On the next: Pie Day!

Chapter 13: Queen Angella of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

> Pie Day was delayed; this chapter took precedence, as I liked the scene a bit too well not to keep writing it.
>
> But don't worry. It *is* Pie Day; we're just early in the day yet.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Queen Angella of Brightmoon

Catra awoke the next day, feeling... good. Very good.

And really hungry. Sorta thirsty. Also kind of needed to pee. And a bath.

She rose up, seeing that a small glass of ice water had been laid on the nightstand next to her bed; wow, she really must have been out of it, for someone to sneak inside like that without waking her.

(But it wouldn't be Shadow Weaver. Not now, not ever again; not after last night... and the thought is nice and warm, and she is able to handle it, now, she can carry this thing that is heavy as the heart of a star. Now, awake, with all her years in Brightmoon rushing in to fill the void of her heart, Catra thinks she can carry the crushing burden of being *loved.*)

She downed the glass, the ice cubes crinkling happily, then stumbled off to use her personal bathroom – which she looked at with new eyes, now that she had spent so long reflecting on her life in the Horde, seemed a lot more impressive. She'd been in Brightmoon long enough to forget a lot of things, among them the Horde's communal bathrooms. Catra had always feared she'd be attacked in them, which wasn't helped by the dozen or so incidents where she *had* been; what's more, they were all showers, no baths.

Catra had hated them. She'd used to turn the water on and sort of stand to the side, scooping water onto the rags they were given, using the mass-produced soap, lathering quickly. She almost never washed her hair; too vulnerable. She only did that very late at night, when they were supposed to be asleep, and only if Adora would stand guard.

(That had been enough to ward off most attacks; no one smart wanted to hurt Shadow Weaver's pet project, and the few stupid enough to try anyway were never tough enough to take on Adora.)

With that in mind, Catra looked at her little bathroom with a lot more respect. Her own private bathroom- with a lock!- and an actual custom bathtub, big enough even for She-Ra to lounge in. She'd never known how much she liked bathing until she tried it; Glimmer had to explain it to her. She'd had no idea what one was. A shower made her feel like she was being assaulted by the water, made her fur rise up and her ears lay flat, but a bath... she could lay down, in a long bath, lay down and luxuriate. It was... nice.

It was also nice to actually be *clean* , too.

After her ablutions were done- including a bath that was short by Catra's standards, since she was hungry- she popped out and got dressed, wondering what there was to eat. Glimmer had said she'd get her retainers would cook for her, but Catra was pretty sure she'd slept for another day since... maybe there were leftovers.

Cleaned and ready, Catra left her room, greeting passers-by with a friendly wave as she headed for this wing's kitchen, where her retainers had set up. The She-Ra's wing, they called it, a small set of rooms on the castle's second floor where Catra had taken up residence; others had been calling it the Younger Princess' Wing, of late, a thing that never failed to make that terrible sweetness Catra so craved blossom in her chest.

When she reached the kitchen, she opened it to find a feast laying in ambush.

" Hey!" came one of her retainers- the soda pop guy. Catra knew their names, of course, but her head always assigned them their jobs instead for some reason. " You're awake! The Queen's got good timing."

" Hey," Catra replied, as she observed the feast with surprised interest. It all sat on one of the big tables in the dining area, which nearly groaned with the weight of broad smorgasbord of food atop it. It was all Dryl's cuisine, adapted to Catra's umami-leaning preferences: lamb, mostly, the favorite food of mountainous Dryl, but it was made into so many things. Savory pies and roasts, little decorative morsels of meat, and other, fancier things Catra didn't have a name for, the smell alone enough to make her mouth water. They were accompanied by a

spread of pink lady apples and little pockets of dim sim, accompanied by the heavy soda bread of damper and a staggering array of cheeses.

The centerpiece dish was an oddly ugly thing, a weird green soup with what appeared to be an entire meat pie floating upside-down in it, though admittedly it smelled as good as the rest of the feast. Accompanying it were a variety of fizzy beverages, each labeled with a flavor and a number.

" What's all this then?" Catra said, wiping her mouth as she observed the buffet.

" A feast!" Catra's baker said, grinning. " We had some time to prepare, and we wanted to find stuff you'd like!"

" The drinks are my own invention," the soda guy said. " It's an experiment to find something you'd like; you don't like sweet drinks, and that's well over half my repertoire, so I figured- why not try some new stuff? I've got high hopes for the celery-inspired one!"

Catra whistled as the busgirl pulled out a chair with her usual elegance and presented it to her.

" I'd say you shouldn't have, but I'm starving," Catra admitted as she sat down.

“ Good! Eat up, then!” the baker said, smiling broadly as she hugged the soda guy next to her with one big arm. “ 'Course, we expected to serve you yesterday, but then the Queen came by and told us you'd be up this morning. Ended up feeding the first batch we made to the guards, which they were pretty happy about; they don't eat much Dryl food down here! Nice change of pace.”

“ Mom said that?” Catra asked, as the busgirl brought plates and utensils to her.

“ She did,” the pop guy said, hugging the baker back. Catra thought maybe they were all married to each other? She wasn't sure. “ She came by yesterday to tell us she figured you'd be up and famished today.”

“ I wonder how she knew?” Catra asked, pondering. She hadn't expected to sleep as much as she did, to be honest, so how had Angella known?

“ No idea!” the baker admitted cheerfully. “ But she's the Queen, so we did what she said!”

That was wise, and Catra was hungry, so she simply shot him a finger gun before digging in.

(Angella had found out yesterday when she'd went to check on her daughter; her connection to the Moonstone, to the dark and

the night, gave her some understanding of sleep, and she'd checked with her magic to make sure Catra was ok. She'd recognized Catra's rest as needful, as the thing her soul needed, and gained a vague idea of when she'd awaken; she'd shared that information with her daughter's retainers so they could prepare the meal she'd be needing after so much sleep, before the Queen brought her a glass of ice water to sit beside her daughter.)

The food was... good. Better than good. The meat pie in pea soup- because that was, in fact, exactly what it was- tasted great, heavy on salt and spices Catra's unique tongue could taste. Everything accompanying it, even the apples, was excellent; the apples were more tart than sweet, which she could taste, and the crust of the pies was falky and wonderfully texured. The baker was particularly delighted by Catra's love for the meat pies, since that meant her baking talents, which she'd feared would go to waste, now had purpose again. Her tongue and diet weren't *exactly* like a feline's, but it was close, and sugar didn't hold much interest for her, which had been a heck of a problem when two of her three retainers were mostly experienced in Dryl's rich variety of desserts; in addition to tiny food, Entrapta had liked her food sweet enough to kill the unprepared.

Even the drinks that accompanied it were fine, too, and the soda pop guy's instincts were perfect; when Catra eventually settled on a favorite, the sparkling celery-inspired drink that was zesty and went well with meat was her choice.

Between that and the busgirl's perfect service, it was the best meal Catra had ever had.

When she was done fending off the unexpected ambush by devouring most of it, she leaned back with a contented sigh.

" I'm gonna die," she declared cheerfully. " It's the best death imaginable, but I'm gonna die. That was incredible. I ate *way* too much."

" You can't die now!" the baker said with a laugh. " We finally figured out how to feed you!"

" Sorry to disappoint," Catra said, chuckling.

" At least give us some severance pay first," the busgirl said, with a small grin on her refined, stoic features. " I doubt we'll get another job after killing the She-Ra."

" I'll get right on that," Catra said, yawning. She almost felt like taking another nap... but no, she probably needed to do something else. She'd slept long enough as it was. " But... thank you. That was incredible."

" I'm just glad we managed to make something you enjoy!" the soda pop guy said.

" Hip hip hooray!" the baker announced, and she and the soda pop guy did a little dance of joy, the busgirl giving a small, fond smile at their antics. Catra gave them a smirk as she rose up,

briefly wondering if she was going to wobble; she'd *never* eaten so much at one sitting before.

With no wobbling, Catra headed for the door, opening it to find a *second* ambush waiting for her.

" Hey-She-Ra!" Flutterina announced, her hand stretched out to knock on the door; but when she saw it was Catra, she immediately gave her snappy salute before jumping up and down in place, abuzz with energy. " Glad-to-see-you're-up!"

Blasted by the full force of the young Lunoth's personality, Catra took a moment to blink before responding.

" Yeah, I'm awake," she said. " What's up, little one?"

" Well-I-was-just-by-your-room-and-you-weren't-there-so-I-was-coming-here-to-ask-your-retainers-and-"

Her buzz was irritating- but Catra reminded herself not to be angry with her. Not with little Flutterina.

" Breathe, little one," Catra said instead. " Breathe- you're going too fast."

“ Sorry-sorry, I'm... I'm sorry!” Flutterina said, pausing, face overwhelmed with nervousness. “ I was just excited to find you!”

“ I know,” Catra said. It was easier to banish her irritation when she saw how scared Flutterina was of being rebuffed by her; she had been like that too often in her childhood, and having been so close to those memories recently, she found it was easy to bury any irritation. “ It's not a problem. Just take a breath and go again- but slowly, this time.”

“ Okay!” Flutterina said, and her face lit up again with a smile that Catra mimicked unconsciously. “ Anyway, your mom, the Queen, she wanted to talk with you! Said it wasn't anything major, just come by whenever you were ready.”

Mom wanted to see her? Catra hoped the Queen didn't want to talk about... *that*...

...But then again, with a day and a night of sleep behind her, and all this food inside her, she thought she could face it if she must.

And besides, she'd said it wasn't anything major, maybe it was a different thing.

“ Sure,” Catra said confidently. “ Where's she at?”

“ Her-rooms!” Flutterina buzzed before, with visible effort, slowing herself back down. “ Want me to run back and tell her?”

“ Sure,” Catra said.

“ OKAY!”

Flutterina was off like a shot, at one point literally running up the walls as she cornered a hallway around a very surprised guard.

The guard looked at her, and Catra shrugged.

“ She gets excited,” she said, and the guard shrugged too.

“ You have interesting retainers,” the guard agreed.

Catra almost opened her mouth to claim Flutterina *wasn't* a retainer- then closed it. Hmm. She'd bring it up to Flutterina later, but the kid would probably *love* to be her retainer... something to ponder.

Catra followed behind Flutterina at a more sedate pace. Down through Brightmoon's halls, saying hi to her people, relaxed in a way she had never been in the halls of the Fright Zone.

Halfway there, Flutterina caught up to her.

" Mission accomplished!" she said, saluting. " Anything else, She-Ra?"

Catra saluted back.

" No," Catra said. " But thank you, little one."

" Anything for you, boss!" Flutterina said, before taking off at her usual high speed. Catra really *would* have to take time out to talk with her; she felt responsible for the kid.

As she headed off, she vaguely wondered where Flutterina was going.

(To the three retainers, in point of fact; they knew Catra favored the Lunoth, and so they fed her- albeit that was, at least partially, because she liked the sugary food Catra didn't, and let them exercise their old talents.)

Still, she dismissed it; she'd talk to Flutterina later. To her mother's room, first, to the door that had so stymied her not two days ago; Catra knocked on it easily now.

“ Catra?” came her mother's voice.

“ It's me,” Catra said.

“ Come on in!” came her mother's voice. Catra stepped in with that invitation, and as she shut the door, Angella's voice carried again. “ I'm in the back!”

Catra followed that voice past the foyer and the kitchen to a last passageway, an open arch filled with a heavy hanging curtain of purple and pink beads to obscure what lay within: the Queen's private bedroom, the most secret place in Brightmoon, a place that only Queen Angella herself ever visited now that Micah was dead.

Catra stood outside it for a moment, not totally sure what she was supposed to do. Did she just... go in?

“ Do you... want me to wait out here?” she ventured, not really sure if she was supposed to go in. As far as she knew, even Glimmer didn't go in there.

“ It's fine!” Angella said. “ Come on in. What I want to show you is in here.”

And with that permission, Catra pushed the beads aside, to step into a place that had known less than two dozen pairs of feet in

almost a millennium.

Angella's bedroom was... pretty much what Catra had expected, actually. The moderately-sized room was completely overdone, because that was how Angella liked it; the Queen of Brightmoon loved complicated things, loved fussy, delicate designs that had no reason to exist, save to be pretty and complex. She would put fractal patterns and art engravings on everything in Brightmoon if she could get away with it, and here, in the room closest to her heart, she'd had freedom to indulge herself; the room was slathered in the curls and swirls and fragile wonders that Angella adored.

Yeah, this is exactly Mom's aesthetic, Catra thought, and smiled a little. Glimmer would *hate* this room; she liked spartan things. Catra leaned a bit more towards her sister than her mother- a Horde upbringing would do that to you- but in her time at Brightmoon, she'd learned to appreciate little fiddly things of great beauty, things that had no purpose other than to just... be. Not everything had to have a greater purpose than to simply look nice.

But as her eyes adjusted to the almost pornographic level of detail in the room, she saw that it was, despite the art almost literally baked into its core, a fairly normal room. There was a bed, a nightstand, a dresser, a closet, even a clock to tell the time; the bed was a four-post canopied monstrosity and the clock was a grandfather clock that was probably worth more than half the castle's treasury, but a bed and a clock nonetheless.

There were only two real oddities in the room; the first was that one wall was just a big window, large enough for Angella to jump

out and go flying, if she so chose. And the second...

" You've got good timing!" Angella said, as she stood before a great quilted tapestry that dominated the room's farthest wall. " I just finished adding you."

" Adding... me?" Catra said, as she stepped forward, looking the tapestry over.

The fabric showed a great tree, colored like Brightmoon's heraldry; at its base amongst the roots was a picture of a blonde woman Catra didn't recognize, and a line lead up from her to a portrait of Angella done entirely in small stitches of thread. Then up, the tree growing, branching out, and on each branch was another portrait, with a name and dates sewn in underneath, alongside two objects, all of them ensconced in neat little ovals of white, each with a border of soft, moonlight silver.

" What... is this?" Catra asked, as her eyes went up, and recognized the newest branch of the great tree, at the very top- herself, it was *her.* A picture of herself had been placed in one of those neat little white ovals, with her messy mane of brown hair and orange-ish fur, her twin-colored eyes and her red helmet. Not herself as She-Ra, not Catra as her greater self, but just Catra, flanked by the Sword and a Princess' tiara, with a date marked, a date four months back.

My adoption, Catra thought, knowing the date instantly; it was a date that had burned itself into her mind, a happy memory cherished often.

“ What is this?” Catra asked, even as some part of her figured it out; her eyes flickered to the portraits closet to her own. There, on the same branch but closer to the tree's trunk, was Glimmer's portrait in an oval, with her father's staff and a military banner as her two symbols; her oval was bordered in gold, as was Catra's own, she realized belatedly.

And past Glimmer, at the branch's root, was a face Catra knew only from paintings; Micah, flanked by a wedding ring and a spellbook. Micah, bordered in silver, like the others save Catra and Glimmer...

“ How I remember those I love,” Angella said softly, echoing Catra's thoughts. “ I have kept this for all my life, repairing it when it tears, redoing it every so often when the threads lose color. My way of keeping track of my own history, and the people who have mattered most to me- my nine lovers, and my two daughters. Silver of them, and gold for you and Glimmer.”

Angella gave her the small, sad smile Catra had seen most recently on Glimmer.

“ My way of making sure I remember you,” she said. “ That I *never* forget.”

Catra nodded, and fought, *hard*, not to cry; not sad tears, but confused tears of joy, of happiness. Not only was she loved, but here was a record of *being* loved; and it would last forever. Once,

no one but Adora would have cared to recall her if she died; but now... now she would be remembered forever. So long as Angella lived- and that might be for all eternity, as far as Catra knew- then the little outcast of the Fright Zone would be remembered by a mother's love.

It was too much. Terrible sweetness, once more; her tongue could not taste it but her heart craved it, she shook where she stood as she tried not to weep. Maybe it wasn't shameful, but she had cried enough in the last few days, and some remnant of her Hordesman life pushed against any more teary-eyed foolishness.

(But it is not strong enough; two burning tears slipped out anyway, to slip gently down through her short fur and trace the contours of her face.)

" Do you like your symbols?" Angella asked her. Catra nodded, not hearing the question in any way. Angella could have asked her what the weather was like in Salineas, and Catra would have given the exact same nod.

Trying to distract herself, Catra looked over the tapestry again, over this linen record of Angella's heart. Glimmer first once more, the military banner a good thing; a memorial of the moment a mother finally accepted her daughter's martial spirit. Then past her to Micah's ring, in memory of being the one lover Angella had ever married, alongside a spellbook for his Mystacoran upbringing. Then down the trunk, to more distant loves of the past. Here a man of Plumeria, blushing softly, delicately bordered with flowers and a doctor's tools; there a Salinean woman, with a devil-may-care grin, a great sailing ship and twin fish marked next to her. More and more- two Lunoths, a changeling like the Double

Trouble her sister had caught, others- all down the years, the dates going further and further back.

And near the bottom... a woman marked with fire, and robes of faith.

" My first love," Angella said with a small smile, seeing where her daughter's eyes had went. " When I was first made by the Most Serene, I fell in love with one of her knights. Oh, she was a wonder; she was a passionate paladin of faith from the Blazing Kingdom, a wondrous woman. She had come to serve in Brightmoon as part of our alliance with the Fire Princess of that time, and I, newly forged at the time, was captivated by her. And in time- and with no small assistance from the two elder knights- we fell in love."

Catra nodded, but her head turned to the words of the Twigget, which broke her out of her spiraling joy.

(*her fiery girl...*)

Huh. She'd have to ask about that... though a more immediate question occurred.

" ...Forged?" Catra asked, trying to be circumspect in case this was a delicate subject; but her mother simply nodded.

“ Yes. As I'm sure you've noticed by now, I'm a rather unique being,” Angella said, with a smirk that made Catra think of Glimmer.

I guess Glimmer didn't inherit <u>all</u> of her personality from her dad, Catra thought.

“ I'm... not the best person to ask about that,” Catra admitted. “ I thought *I* was a one-off for years, so I don't really have a basis for it. Far as I'm aware, there's thousands of you, they just live somewhere I haven't been.”

Angella chuckled, then paused. “ Wait- you didn't know you were a Magicat?”

Catra shook her head. “ Nope. Not until the Lunoths in Elberon told me just this year. And Light Hope filled in some additional stuff about how they got to Etheria afterwards.”

“ I had no idea!” Angella said, aghast. “ I would have told you if I'd known. I just assumed... did the Horde tell you *nothing*? They occupy the Magicats' kingdom! That's *your* people, how could they not tell you?”

“ No one cared to tell me,” Catra said simply. “ Wasn't like Shadow Weaver would have bothered to tell me...”

She trailed off for a second, having said the name casually without thinking, and now forced to confront the elephant in the room. She'd said that name, before one of only four people in all the world who knew what her childhood had been like... She didn't want to think of Shadow Weaver, she didn't want to talk about her when her mother was talking of her life. She didn't want her childhood to hang over everything she said to them, now.

But a soft brush against her back brought her out of her thoughts, as Angella wrapped her warm right wing around her daughter.

" She wouldn't have had much interest in telling you, I imagine," the Queen said to the young woman she'd taken under her wing. " How did you even come to the Horde? Did they tell you that much, at least?"

" Found in a box," Catra said. " That's what others claimed, anyway; I don't really remember. Adora said she found me almost literally dumped on their doorstep. Never knew my parents, or any family..."

The wing hugged her tighter, and Catra gave a small grin.

" Well, not until *you*, at any rate."

Angella smiled.

“ A shame, then,” she said. “ We'll have to sit down and talk about them; everyone should know their heritage.”

Catra leaned onto her mother, closing her eyes, absorbing love like the world's biggest sponge.

“ Yeah,” she said, before opening her eyes to look up at the Queen. “ But let's talk about your heritage, first. Again, you said you were... forged?”

Angella nodded, and went along with the change in subject with her usual grace.

“ In a way,” she equivocated. “ My creator- my mother, I suppose, though we never had a relationship like that- was the last Queen of Brightmoon before me. She was the Most Serene; she gave up her name after the civil war, which was what prompted my creation.”

“ Civil war?” Catra asked. Angella nodded.

“ The nastiest in Brightmoon's history,” Angella said. “ This was after a time of great upheaval, mind. Something strange had happened to Etheria around a century beforehand, separating it from the wider universe and placing it into Despondos...”

“ Mara,” Catra said. Angella nodded.

“ Given what you've learned, I suspect that's the truth of it,” Angella said. “ But the last mortal Queen of Brightmoon was a wonder. She ascended to the throne terribly early- her parents were killed in a war. But the young Queen did not faler; she spent her youth gathering allies and friends, and they actively fought back against the issues that had been plaguing Brightmoon, punishing evil and restoring order to the entire kingdom. They called it the Silver Peace... I don't think any rulers of Brightmoon have ever been as loved as she and her husband were. Even I've never been as popular at the heights of my reign.”

“ What was her husband like?” Catra asked, eyes flickering to Micah's portrait on the great tapestry.

“ He was quite a character,” Angella said. “ I never met him, but every story I heard said he was a great man. Good gardener, too, if a bit obsessed with roses- most modern varieties we have are descended from his plants. He was called the Masked Prince, after the war- he gave up his name, too.”

“ Not the Masked King?” Catra asked, and Angella shook her head.

“ He and the Most Serene divorced, so he went back to his old title,” Angella explained. “ What happened in the civil war always sat like a stone between them, after; and to make it worse, it had been a genuine love match beforehand.”

Angella sighed.

" It makes all that came of it more tragic."

" What happened?" Catra asked.

" The Most Serene and the Masked Prince had a child," Angella said. " A daughter, who grew up in the peaceful time of her parents, and who developed into... well. I should start by clarifying that the two oldest knights of the Most Serene were the ones who told me most of this; they were my closest companions in my early years. Something between friends and parents, in a way. I came out of the Moonstone with much knowledge and little wisdom; I knew so many things, and knew nothing of so many others. A childhood of sorts, in a lot of ways, though I was never really a child. But they helped teach me how to fill the gaps, and if parents I have, I would be proud to claim the two of them as my mothers. I spoke with all the Most Serene's great knights and scholars save the exile, of course, but they were extremely busy dealing with the civil war's aftermath, so Dames Haruka and Michiru taught me most of what I know."

" So what's the catch?" Catra asked. " I heard the pause there."

Angella nodded somberly. " Well, the catch is that the two admitted that they were biased when it came to the princess. The princess was, in their opinion, always going to be what she was; they said there had always been a cruel element to her, even as a child. Others dismissed it as merely being a mouthy kid; in time, it transformed into an elegant wit that was nonetheless always a

little... spiteful, according to the two knights. She was a bit spoiled; her parents were truly in love and adored her... but none of it really *explained* why she did what she did."

Angella sighed.

" The way it was told to me, at some point, the princess found that she enjoyed hurting others, and she had a choice to make- and she chose to indulge that enjoyment at every opportunity."

A choice...

Catra knew, better than anyone, how heavy a choice could be, and for just a moment, pondered what it might make of a person, to choose to be evil, the way Catra had chosen to be good.

" She must have been a nightmare," Catra said.

" She was," Angella agreed. " They called her the Wicked Lady, after the war- her name was taken from her after death, the worst punishment Brightmoon could imagine at the time. They were odd about names, in those days, though that has faded out of the culture."

" I was about to ask about all these name changes," Catra said.

“ Names were a big deal for a long time, though it's mostly gone now,” Angella said. “ I should note that Wicked Lady is me being a bit evocative with the translation- Blackmoon Lady is a more direct translation, but the actual intent of the words was 'one who acts in secret out of sight of the moons', i.e. an evil person. Wicked Lady fits.”

“ What'd she do to deserve that kind of title?” Catra asked.

“ War,” Angella answered. “ In secret, she managed to arrange for attacks and wars in several nations; always hidden, always acting through others, always with excuse and alibi. Brightmoon gold spent to secure death in other lands... she destroyed so much, killed so many people, just to fulfill her cruel whims. It took almost a decade before she was caught, and when she was found out, it turned out she'd planned for that, too; it was civil war in Brightmoon at that point.”

“ How'd they finally kill her?” Catra asked.

“ Yet more tragedy, which might have pleased the horrid woman,” Angella said. “ The Most Serene's youngest knight- a close personal friend of the princess, before they found out what she was, and her lover, rumor insisted- had to kill her, striking her down outside of Brightmoon's very walls. She was the exile I mentioned; she asked for it herself, barely able to live with what she'd done. Even after everything, some part of her had loved the princess.”

Oh. Catra knew that. She knew that better than anyone.

(*Adora*)

" The Most Serene granted it, and the exile took the Wicked Lady's body with her, to bury in some forgotten place. The Masked Prince and the Most Serene both surrendered their names in shame and divorced, each blaming the other for what happened to the princess; the Most Serene retreated to her knights, and no one ever really knew what the Prince did."

Catra thought of what that exiled knight must have felt, when she murdered the woman she loved, to stop her from doing more harm.

(Thought of Adora, that vision of her head falling, Netossa's plan, *no*)

" That poor woman," Catra said, and shuddered in sympathy.

Angella's hand found Catra's, and she squeezed it for comfort as she hugged her tighter with her wing.

" Indeed," Angella said, and they sat in silence for a while.

I'll save you, Adora, Catra swore to herself, in the quiet. *I won't... we won't end up like the exile and the Lady. I'll save you.*

After a moment, Angella started again.

“ But, as I said, that happened before my making. It was what prompted it, in fact. After all was said and done, the Most Serene realized she still needed an inheritor... but she'd come to decide that no one was good enough to appoint, blaming everyone- including herself- for the fiasco that had created her daughter. So her and her remaining mages and scholars set about making something new- an inheritor who would last forever, who would be something new and unique and incorruptible. I'm not entirely sure I'm what they wanted, but I'm what they got; when they cast their spells, I emerged from the Moonstone, a humanoid representation of its raw elemental magic.”

“ So that's what you are?” Catra said.

“ I am,” Angella responded. “ The raw magic of the Moonstone, wrapped up in skin.”

“ I think you worked out well,” Catra said. “ Nobody else I'd rather have for a mother.”

“ Thank you,” Angella said, squeezing her hand again. “ I haven't ruined Brightmoon yet, anyway, so I've fulfilled the Most Serene's wishes in that much, at least.”

Thinking of mothers, Catra voiced her next thought.

“ So this Most Serene... she was kind of your mom, huh?” Catra asked.

“ In a way,” Angella said hesitantly. “ More like... my creator. She never directly took part in my learning; I barely knew her, to be honest. From what others told me, she feared that whatever mistakes she made with her first child would transfer to me, and so trusted my care to others- hence the two knights. Though my 'upbringing' was... very non-standard. I was an odd creature in a lot of ways, though the centuries have worn off the rough edges.”

“ Nah, you just passed them on to Glimmer,” Catra said, and Angella laughed.

“ I refuse to accept responsibility for Glimmer's punchy nature,” she protested. “ She gets *that* from her father. Ah, Micah would have loved to see her; she is so much like him.”

Angella turned to her tapestry, and put her left hand to his oval. Catra, in sympathy, squeezed her mother's hand as she considered her dead husband.

(And many miles away, Micah felt a gentle touch on his shoulder, something he knew once, before the endless hell of Beast Island, and the feeling he mistook for memory gave him newfound strength as he wove a spell of sanctuary so he and his guest could catch some sleep.)

The war widow withdrew her left hand from his portrait after a moment, and continued on.

“ She apologized for it, eventually. When she was dying- she lived to a ripe old age, and was able to heal Brightmoon of her daughter's abuses before she passed- she called me in, and apologized for not paying me more personal attention. I had been grieving at the time- my love had died a few months beforehand, her flame finally flickering out- and I was receptive to the sorrow I sensed in her; we had a long talk. More words than I'd heard her say in all the decades before. She was sorry, and begged my forgiveness... I gave it without reserve. She'd done me no harm, after all. She may not have taken much notice of me, but she left me with those who could, and I turned out alright.”

“ Better than alright,” Catra mumbled. Angella squeezed her hand again.

“ Thank you. But... at any rate, I suppose I just wanted to show this to you. I showed it to Glimmer recently, once we stopped fighting all the time... and now I show it to you. I just wanted you to... to know, I guess.”

When I'm dead and in the ground a thousand years, Catra thought, *Angella will still remember me,* and that was warm and good inside her chest.

“ What do you call it?” Catra asked.

“ I call it the tapest-tree,” Angella said.

Catra paused, good feeling in abeyance for a second.

" *What.*"

Angella smirked. " He came up with that," she said, tapping one of the Lunoths on her fabric. " I've always liked it. A tapest-tree. Like a tapestry, but a family tree too!"

Catra groaned at the horrible pun.

" I take it back, you turned out terrible."

Angella giggled, a lovely and rare sound to hear from the regal queen.

" Anything you want to ask about it? Glimmer had a lot of questions," Angella said.

" Other than why on Etheria you think that tapest-tree thing is funny? Not immediately," Catra said, shaking her head. The idea hadn't even occurred to her until Angella asked; Shadow Weaver had never invited questions, and had never answered the few Catra dared voice regardless. It wasn't even something she'd consciously thought of... but now that she *was* thinking of it... " Maybe later, but not right now."

Just in case she wanted to ask later. Angella would answer her.

My mother is not Shadow Weaver in an angel's costume, she reminded herself.

(And somewhere inside, the voice of Catra the Child mused from the darkest and wisest place inside her: *you could have stopped at 'my mother is not Shadow Weaver.'*)

" Feel free!" Angella said. " If you ever need me, just come by and knock. I'll have keys made for you and Glimmer later so you can get in if you need to and I'm not here for any reason."

" I'll keep that in mind," Catra said, and squeezed her mom's hand again as she looked at the tapestry once more, her eyes eventually alighting on the first, the fiery girl.

...Actually, a question *did* occur to her.

" Mom?" Catra said. " This is going to be a weird question... but did Madame Razz introduce you to your first love?"

Angella's eyebrow reached terminal quirk.

" Yes," she said, after a long moment. " How..."

“ She told me,” Catra interrupted. “ Wanted me to tell you how much fun it *is* to introduce you two? That was how she worded it. Said it was going to happen again? I didn't really understand that.”

“ No one does,” Angella said. “ Madame Razz was very, very old when I was made. I'm not really sure what she is. A Twigget, I guess, but not like any other I've ever met.”

“ Is she dangerous?” Catra asked, and Angella chuckled at that.

“ We're all dangerous, my daughter,” she said. “ You're the She-Ra and can cut through steel with your claws even without the power; I'm dangerous, with my connection to the Moonstone granting me power. Glimmer can teleport and fight, even Bow can kill with a single well-placed arrow. We're *all* dangerous. So perhaps that's not the right question. But... no, Madame Razz is not a danger to *you*. She's helpful and infuriating in roughly equal degree, though, so grab tight on your patience when dealing with her.”

“ Gonna need that advice,” Catra admitted, sighing. “ She wants me to go with her. Something about a pie.”

“ You should go, then,” Angella said, squeezing Catra's hand one last time before releasing Catra from her hand and wing both and standing up. “ Madame Razz knows a lot of things... sometimes. I'm not sure how. I have my suspicions, but nothing concrete.”

" What do you suspect?" Catra asked as she joined her mother in standing. Angella hesitated a moment before speaking.

" I think... something about time, and maybe space. The way Madame Razz talks- I don't think she's got the same relationship with those things that we do," Angella theorized. " I'm not even sure she's as old as I am; there are long periods where she just disappeared, and I assumed that, like most people who drop out of my life for a century, that she'd died... but then she'd pop up, and sometimes treat me as an old friend, and at other times like acquaintances or had never met. In some ways, she's one of my longest friendships, at least, from my end."

Angella grinned.

" Odd, but I suppose in some ways I'm always grateful when she pops up; it's nice, for me, to have someone else who can march down the long ages. Even if she doesn't remember any of it half the time, and the other half, remembers things that haven't happened yet."

...It was odd. Catra *knew* in her head how old her mother was, but to hear it laid out like that...

" That's kinda sad," Catra answered, and Angella nodded.

“ I've gotten used to it, but yes... it's terribly lonely,” she said.

Catra, going off an urge, hugged her mother, who after a moment hugged her back.

“ I wish I was immortal,” Catra said. “ So you wouldn't be alone.”

“ I'll be alright, Catra,” Angella said. “ But... for what it's worth... sometimes I wish you were immortal, too.”

Catra let go after that, sighing. Nothing to be done about it, and she'd done enough moping about for the week.

“ Well, I should go deal with Razz, then,” she said. “ Figure out what the pie thing is about.”

“ Her pies are excellent!” Angella said, embracing the subject change. “ Do feel free to partake- though given your distaste for sugar, you probably won't like them much.”

“ Probably,” Catra said. “ Though I doubt it'll matter much; I just ate enough for ten people. Thanks for getting them to set that up, by the way.”

“ No trouble!” Angella said. “ Figured you'd be famished.”

Catra stretched her back out.

" Any idea where Razz is?" Catra asked, and Angella nodded.

" I know where her house is currently," Angella said. " Assuming she hasn't moved it in the last year or so. Ask the Stable Officer, she can show you on a map where Razz is."

" Alright," Catra said. " Guess I'm heading out. See ya later!"

Angella waved goodbye to her daughter.

" Be safe!"

" Of course," Catra said, the care and concern in Angella's voice still wonderful, even as she grew more familiar with it. She headed out of the bedroom, pushing the beads aside, then through the dining area to the door.

As she opened it, she was hit with her third ambush of the morning.

“ Hello Cat-Ra!” said Madame Razz, who was standing directly outside the door.

“ Agh!” Catra hissed, jumping back. “ Sssss!”

The Twigget cackled, and Catra heard her mother speaking up from the bedroom.

“ Are you alright, Catra?” she called.

“ Ha ha! Made you hiss again!” Razz said triumphantly. “ This door's a good place to meet you!”

“ I'm fine, Mom!” Catra yelled back, hair flattening as she got control of herself. “ Razz was just outside the door and scared the shit out of me!”

“ Razz! Don't do that,” the unseen Queen scolded.

“ I don't think I do it again, if that helps!” Razz yelled back before turning to the Brightmoon Princess. “ Anyway, Catra, come along! It's Pie Day! Very important day! Though I do wish I remembered why. Come along anyway! Come along!”

Then she shot off like a bullet.

" Oh, this is gonna be *great,*" Catra groaned before giving chase.

" Good luck, darling!" Angella called as Catra took off out the door, barely remembering to shut it before she went.

Thus did Catra of Brightmoon find herself following the little maybe-Twigget, who moved like her feet were on fire and her ass was catching; Catra, to her own surprise, had to drop to all fours just to keep her in sight. They ran all over the castle; there was no consistent direction to Razz's path. The Twigget's circuitous journey led the geriatric bolt of greased lightning all around the castle, Catra chasing like the world's biggest feline after the world's oldest mouse. Around hallway corners, past little-used wings of the castle, running past not a few Brightmoon guards who cocked their heads in united confusion at seeing the hero of the Great Rebellion in hot pursuit of an elderly woman.

" I'll explain later!" Catra hollered to them. The sergeant, displaying great wisdom, ordered the others to pretend it never happened.

All up and down the corridords, until Razz led the flagging Catra down two separate staircases and past the main hall to reach the stables. Razz, chuckling and yelling something about razzle dazzle, leapt atop an abandoned scooter, which shot off under her feet, flying away.

Catra skidded to a stop in front of Swift Wind's fancy stall, where he was munching on some oats.

" Hey!" Catra said, panting. " You feel up for a flight?"

" Always!" he said. " Where we going?"

" Madame Razz's," Catra said, as the cackling little Twigget disappeared into the Woods. " Also she stole a scooter, so we should probably get that back."

" Well, here we go," Swift Wind responded as he stepped out and Catra leapt on his back. " I know where she lives, so this should be easy."

" You do?" Catra said, surprised."

" Yeah! She's a little old lady in the woods!" Swift Wind replied. " You gotta check up on those. She could fall over and not be able to get back up!"

" I think she'll be fine," Catra muttered as they followed the cackling scooter-stealing witch... and as she patted Swift Wind's neck. That was awful nice of him, to keep up with Razz. " She's faster than me!"

" Yeah, I don't know why she's so quick," Swift Wind said as he accepted the pats. " I don't know why *anything* about Madame Razz is the way it is. I check up on her all the time, but I can't claim I know a thing about how she works. Or what she's thinking."

" Do you know why she's obsessed with pies?" Catra asked, and Swift Wind shook his head.

" Nope!"

" Shit."

The duo followed from above as the wily old witch of the woods wound her way through her home forest, even at one point performing a rather neat grinding trick on a branch to get over a family of sleeping boars. After a good hour or so of flight, Razz finally managed to get home, landing her stolen scooter gently in her front yard before skedaddling into her little home.

Catra, who was best Princess, made a mental note to deliver that back to Brightmoon once this was done, her and Swift Wind landing in the yard and following her. As Catra entered the little house, she had a moment to be glad she was her usual self and not in She-Ra mode; the hovel Razz lived in was sized for the Twigget, and she'd be busting her skull on the frames if she wasn't careful.

“ Let's see... ah, Mara!” Razz said, smiling at Catra. “ Yes, yes, you can help me. We need many ingredients! Fruit first. Mmm-hmm!”

“ Uh, Razz?” Catra said, quirking an eyebrow. “ I'm not Mara.”

“ But if you're not Mara, who are you?” Razz asked, sounding genuinely curious to Catra's ears.

“ Catra?” the Magicat answered with an upward lilt in her voice, as though she was herself now unsure of the answer.

“ Oh, Catra!” Razz said, but then in the space of a second

YESTERDAY/TODAY/TOMORROW

There was her friend, Mara!

“ I'm not Catra, Razz,” Mara said with a smile. “ You've been calling me that name a lot, lately. When you're not calling me Adora, anyway.”

Razz laughed.

" Mara! So good to see you!"

Chapter End Notes

On the next: Pie Day, for real this time.
(Oh, Mara, Mara, Mara.)

Oh, and some more extensive Author's Notes this time!

Dryl food is Australian, because it was a pair of Australians who invented the electric drill. Also, Australian food is not stereotypically associated with an industrial/tech society, so it amused me to give it to them. We don't have a lot of info on Dryl to go off of, so this is my contribution.

Also, it *is* dim sim, not dim sum; that's not a typo. Dim sim is an Australian variant.

Catra not saying their names is because, as far as I'm aware, they were given no canon name, and it's funnier to me to just have everyone call them their jobs.

The suo jure title that is appropriate for a female knight is Dame; I know a lot of people use Sir or variants like Ser, but I'm old fashioned and prefer the use of damehood, since I think people intentionally avoid it for being feminine and that's wrong. (I might be wrong myself, but that's how I see the situation.)

Those names should sound familiar! As should the titles.

Chapter 14: Madame Razz of the Whispering Woods

Chapter Notes

Oh, Mara, Mara, Mara.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Madame Razz of the Whispering Woods

" It's good to see you too, Madame Razz," Mara said as she walked into her home, the soldier grinning at her.

Razz cackled. " It is better to see you, dearie!"

And that was true! Ah, Mara... it was always a treat, to see Mara. Razz loved teaching, loved seeing a student blossom; and with Mara,it was even sweeter, to see her move from the world's most oblivious imperialist to someone who had come to understand and love Etheria's strange and wild heart.

She had not been chosen for She-Ra blindly or poorly; no, Etheria didn't make mistakes, not in that regard, and Razz should know. She'd been there for every one of them.

(Though she'd only felt so... maternal... over Mara, whom she'd had to take such a direct hand with, teaching her more directly so she could be cleansed of the infection of the First One's ideology that infected her kind heart.)

“ At any rate... why call me Catra? Or Adora, for that matter. I know I'm not the first She-Ra, but our records never spoke of one with either of those names,” Mara asked.

“ Well, they're tomorrow people! And I'm not sure which it'll be,” Razz said with a big grin. “ They could both be it, you know! Adora or Catra, Catra or Adora. Depends on a lot of things! Depends on who falls off the skiff first. Both could be great- truly great- but the story goes different ways. Different strokes for different folks, and mirrors, and paths!”

“ Future people?” Mara said, frowning a bit. “ If they're future First Ones... then who named their kid Catra? Adora I get, that's an old name from Eternia, but Catra? Bit awkward for somebody to name a kid that, what with the mess we've got going with Thundera...”

“ Not for her, it won't be!” Razz said. “ She's got a lot in common with them. Heh heh! Lot in common with Adora, too. Don't know who it'll be. Can't be both, but could be either. It all balances on a coin flip.”

“ The coin of choice,” Mara repeated with fond weariness, as of a repetition made far too often. She grinned as she leaned against the wall of the hut. “ You're *very* fond of that metaphor, Madame Razz.”

“ Because it's a good one!” the wonderful witch of the woods cackled. “ But yes, yes! A coin, spinning and spinning. It's not one of the coins that can land on its edge, though; there really *are* just two options here. Two different paths, two different lessons, but same coin! Children of light the both of them, raised by the dark...”

“ First mention you've made of this,” Mara said, leaning forward, interested. “ You talk about them, but not *about* them, if you get me. What else can you share?”

“ A lot!” Razz said. “ But right now... I think... maybe I'm talking to one right now? Somewhen else. But they're both light, oh, light indeed. All lit up! Just different ways. One's fire- oh, is she *ever* fire- but the other's lightning. Very very frightening!”

She made a sound of thunder with her mouth, sweeping her staff-wielding arm dramatically. Mara, with great grace both physically and socially, dodged the staff before it clocked her one, and didn't mention it- Razz was on a roll, and she wanted to hear more about these supposed future She-Ras.

“ She's the body electric, poor girl- good girl. She's shocking, in all the best ways; her mere presence provokes, challenges, changes! The same thunderbolt that can strike someone dead can bring another back to life; the same energy that can hurt a person can power the world. It's all in how you use it. She'll be good for them.”

“ Them?” Mara prompted.

“ Her friends!” Razz answered. “ She's got friends, and family, too, just like you! Friends of Mara!”

“ I hate that nickname,” Mara said with a laugh. “ Still don't know why my squad insisted on it. Or why Light Hope agreed! We're the Etherian Special Tasks Force 19.85, Grayskull, not just my buddies!”

“ It's a sign of how much they love you,” Razz said with a smile. “ They know you're the best leader they'll ever have.”

“ Eh, I'm not that special,” said the young woman that Etheria itself had chosen, out of all possible others, and Razz took a moment to admire her with a disbelieving shake of her head.

“ You are,” Razz said, before changing the subject, knowing Mara was uncomfortable acknowledging her own greatness. “ But so is she! The lightning girl. Friends of Catra, and family, too. They'll all change, because of her; she'll make them think, she'll make them change. She's not as consistent as the other choice, in any of her ways; she's a lot more chaotic, more changeable. Her light only shines from time to time, when the lightning bolts to the ground; the rest of the time she's a roiling mess of moods. But it's so *bright*, when she shines; and if her friends and family can keep her grounded, she'll keep shocking them, giving them the energy they need to change for the better. Good thing, too! She's already moved her sister's heart, her best friend's, her mother's... or she will. Made friends with the sea, too; but of course she did. There are always storms out at sea, after all. They're old friends.”

Mara was enraptured; she always liked the way Razz told stories, and never pushed her to be more explicit and less... less Razz. Maybe that was the reason Razz liked her the best of all the She-Ras; nothing so grand as her fine and high character, though Mara had that in abundance, but the simple fact that she never wanted Razz to be anything but what she was.

(Whatever that was. She didn't remember a childhood; she only remembered suddenly being, one day, in a patch of land that would call itself Plumeria some hundred years later.)

" What about the other one?" Mara asked. " Adora?"

" The Friends of Adora change too, though they do it in different ways," Razz said, musing over what she knew of the blonde girl with her awesome hair poof. Razz wondered if she should try that hairstyle herself, or see if she could convince Light Hope to modify her appearance that way; it'd be good for a laugh. " Though the two are so similar, even in this. They are both their own worst enemies. The Fire girl, even when she's She-Ra, changes and uplifts those around her by being warm, loving, giving of herself, burning herself up so they have light to see with; she is good for them, but she is not good for herself."

" She's not?" Mara asked, and Razz shook her head.

" The poor girl. Poor dear. She loves too much, when she learns to love at all," Razz answered. " She makes the world her pyre, willing to burn if that will save it; but she doesn't dare dream that

she could be loved, can't believe that there is a place for her, a future... and despite that, is willing to die for her friends.”

Razz sighed.

“ Poor girl. She's brave in all the ways that hurt.”

Mara, who was a soldier- Mara, who knew what the life of a soldier demanded, sometimes- looked down with a sad frown at that, and her hand moved unconsciously to her Sword in something a bit like a prayer; a sign of her burgeoning heresy, given that she came from a culture that had deified itself. To Mara, the Sword of Protection was holy, and to think of other things as holy at all was the first sign she was stepping out of her people's ingrained beliefs.

Razz's own thoughts on the Sword were more complicated. Some part of Razz hated the parasite blade; it wasn't the She-Ra, as Mara's superiors claimed, but an unnecessary addendum meant to control the incarnate spirit. She'd told that truth to Mara half a dozen times, always quietly; if she pushed too hard, Mara would balk, cling to her orders, but if she approached it sideways, maybe she'd realize on her own what that *meant.*

But another part... wondered if, in connecting She-Ra to the Sword, the so-called First Ones hadn't made a mistake. They'd connected the *Sword* to *She-Ra* at the same time... and some part of her wondered if, perhaps, that would cost them. If maybe the Sword would choose someone who would not obey, if the Sword would, in time, come to rebel against its makers.

But those were thoughts for another day. Today, the Sword is the tool of Eternia, meant to make sure Mara obeyed- though even Razz didn't know *what* the First Ones were up to. Something about the planet's heart...

" Does she... does she find happiness?" Mara asked, interrupting the silence that had fallen. Razz sighed and smiled at her. That was so like her Mara, to hope for the good of people she had not even met. Yes, her Mara was a sweetheart; her Mara was so good. So kind.

Though it was weird that Razz couldn't remember what happened to her. She was *sure* she knew, but there was just... darkness there, the kind blackness of forgotten memory. Odd! She wasn't sure why. Usually she remembered all kinds of things that hadn't happened yet.

(Well, hadn't happened for *other* people. For Razz it was kind of a toss-up!)

" She can," Razz assured her. " Nothing's certain; all kinds of things can happen. But when she's the She-Ra- in those timelines where the fire turns to gold, and the storm is drowned in darkness- sometimes there will be a moment, at the end. A few words; powerful words. Three little words that can save a life. Those words will convince the burning girl to do the hardest thing of all- to *live*- and she will do so. She always had the power to live, you see; she just needed a *reason*. And... well. Other things happen. Her lover will leave in a year's time, accompanied by a former monster and his own love, to go between universes and save an angel she once damned. She'll succeed, too, come home to a hero's welcome and a wedding, with the monster as her best

man. Families reunited, lives made whole... yes, she will be happy, though there will be sad times and fearful times and boring times, as there are in any life.”

Razz smiled to herself, eyes seeing that golden future.

“ But happiness, too.”

“ Happily ever after,” Mara said with a smile that matched Razz's own. “ That's not so bad.”

“ No,” Razz said, “ It's not so bad. Not so bad at all.”

Then the clockwork of reality tugged, hard, on her sense of self, her mind going to another time and another place.

ONCE UPON A TIME/IN THE BELLY OF THE BEAST/HAPPILY EVER AFTER

“ So, this is... your house?” Catra asked, looking around as she stepped inside. “ Huh, looks... kinda normal.”

“ Why wouldn't it be?” Razz asked her with genuine curiosity.

“ Just figured, given how old you apparently are, and all... I mean, even my Mom doesn't really know much about you. And you were in that portal thing, but you weren't affected- actually, I've been meaning to ask you about that,” Catra said. “ How come you weren't sucked into the fantasy?”

“ Sense always beats nonsense,” Razz said, shaking her head. “ That dimension wasn't real. It was a kid's imaginary playplace, a make-believe castle, a world that never was. But truth always outs, dearie, no matter how many lotuses you eat. Truth always wins, no matter how it hurts, though it can take its sweet time. I always knew it was wrong, so it never held me quite right; and you figured it out right quick. You always were clever.”

“ Thanks!” Catra said with a big grin.

“ She *is* clever,” Swift Wind opined, drawing up proudly. “ She chose a horse for a bond partner; clearly she is wise!”

“ *Anyway*, I kinda expected something fancier or freakier,” Catra said with a shrug, roundly ignoring her alicorn friend. “ But it's a normal little house, except for being in the middle of the Woods.”

“ Normal's not so bad,” Razz said. “ S'long as it doesn't crown itself, anyway. Woods ain't bad, either! Protective and sheltering. Hold an entire Rebellion in these Woods- well, if the Horde'll stop burning it down, anyway. Light and heat take everything, in the end, and then darkness and cold take them, and that's it forever, until the random makes the cycle turn again; but no reason to speed that up. Things should happen in their own time.”

Catra stared, bewildered, at Razz.

“ I... *what*?” she asked, but then Razz chuckled and stamped her staff on the floor. Normally she'd make a big dramatic sweep with it, but Catra was in range if she did that, and she didn't want to spook the poor girl. Enough people had attacked her with no cause.

(One in particular.)

“ Don't worry about that!” Razz said, chuckling as Catra jumped. “ That's tomorrow problems. Very distant tomorrow problems! And not that big of a problem. Just how things go. Anyway, today is more important than all that! It's *pie* day!”

“ Why?” Catra asked.

Razz gave her a bewildered look.

“ Why *pie*? Who questions pie?” Razz said, shaking her head.

“ Right?” Swift Wind agreed. “ I love pie!”

“ I can't really taste sweets,” Catra answered. “ And I just ate anyway, stuffed myself damn near to bursting. But no, seriously-

why is it pie day, and why is that so important?”

Razz pondered the question for a moment, and came up with... nothing. Huh, that was odd! Usually she knew *why* she was doing her weird shit.

“ No idea!” she said, grabbing a basket. “ But it's important! Follow me!”

Then Razz tore off, running right past Catra and Swift Wind, straight into the Woods. She ran, cheerful, her body old but not done yet- never quite done, not since she'd started being old at her origins in old Serenia. Couldn't remember being young; like she'd just... popped out of the ground.

(Like Etheria had just... made her, for some reason. Maybe just to talk more directly with her inhabitants. A guide for She-Ras, perhaps? But then, her own origins were one of the only secrets Razz didn't know. Most likely she was just an old Twigget who'd screwed up a spell, long ago, and scattered herself across the ages.)

She ran, Catra and Swift Wind in hot pursuit, chuckling as she raced away.

...Though her origins weren't the only thing she couldn't remember, were they? For the past few millennia, she'd had... trouble. Ever since Mara did... something... she was out of joint, out of sync, even more so than usual.

Why?

With that thought dampening her mood a bit, she slowed as she finally reached a patch of periwinkle pears, slowing as she reached the purple fruit. Feeling oddly pensive, she gathered a few before her scattershot mind recalled that she was supposed to have company.

" Catra, dearie?" she called out as she turned around. " Did you and kind Swift Wind make it?"

" I'm here, Razz," Catra said, breathing hard. The Princess of Power, sweating and looking more than a bit green around the gills, was leaning hard against an old tree, her other hand on one of her bent knees. " Why... are you... so mobile... thought old people... slowed down..."

" Maybe you're just out of shape?" Swift Wind offered unhelpfully as he came trotting up behind her. " And yeah, I'm here, Madame Razz."

" I had a full meal!" Catra snapped at her bond partner before turning a bit green in the gills. " I'm... oh moons. I'm trying... not to hurl."

“ You should do that!” Razz opined, mood restored as she forgot why she was sad. “ Make room for pie!”

“ Oh that's gross,” Catra said. “ Oh I don't like that.”

“ Ha ha! I win again. Horses can't puke,” Swift Wind laughed, flaring his wings dramatically. “ Equine superiority!”

“ Racist... horse...” Catra accused as she wobbled where she stood. Swift Wind- despite his words- put a wing on her shoulder to steady her.

“ Hey now,” he said. “ Go She-Ra, you'll be taller with more room in you. It'll help.”

“ That... *can't* be how it works...” Catra said, but pulled the Sword out anyway. “ For the honor of Grayskull, I guess.”

Grayskull... Razz knew that word, she thought... something about a castle...?

Catra shifted as Razz thought; taller now, Catra paused, and cocked her head.

“ I'll be damned, that really *did* help!” she said, exuberant.

“ Knew it!” Swift Wind said with a smug smile as Razz pondered something.

“ Grayskull... that was a castle!” Razz said suddenly, snapping her fingers. “ A castle, and a temple. A Goddess, and a prince defending it... oh yes. An ancient hero of Eternia- and oh, how he would hate what his people became. An ancestor of someone you know, I think; she inherited his blonde hair. A good man. Weird cat. Beloved by Eternia. Etheria's not the only world that chooses a champion, but the other one lost the track of things, lost their world's favor...”

“ Whose ancestor? And Grayskull was a castle?” Catra asked. Razz nodded.

“ Also the name Mara's squad gave to themselves- that's the honor you're defending. Mara and her friends.”

“ Huh,” Catra said, looking down at the Sword. “ I always did kind of wonder about whose honor I was defending, all these years...”

Razz looked at the Sword, too, and a question occurred to her.

“ Why do you never turn the Sword into something else?” Razz asked, cocking her head to the side. “ Mara used to wear it as a

necklace or a bracelet- even made it a basket once to help me get fruit! Speaking of which.”

She turned back to the periwinkle pears, grabbing a few more, keeping an eye on her two compatriots as she did so.

“ Wait, you can turn the Sword into stuff?” Swift Wind said.

“ Yeah, but I don't,” Catra said, sheathing the great blade as Razz quickly filled her basket and turned back around. “ It's *the* Sword. I want people to see it. I want them to know *I'm* the Princess of Power, She-Ra. I can't do that with a bracelet.”

“ Why?” Swift Wind asked.

“ Because I'm the best Princess,” Catra said, grinning as smugly as Swift Wind had not a minute ago. Razz suppressed a giggle at the sight; these two had worked out well as bond partners. “ And everyone should know it if I show up. It's even practical! Allies can rest easy knowing I'm there, knowing that I'm going to save the day, and enemies can freak out because they know I'm going to beat the hell out of them. And none of that happens if they don't know who I am.”

“ I mean, there's only so many eight foot tall tiger women fighting for the Great Rebellion,” Swift Wind pointed out. “ Even fewer who start out as smaller Magicats before turning gold and turning into an eight foot tall tiger woman.”

Catra snorted in amusement.

" Okay, fair, but even so, the Sword's like half my image, I can't turn it into other shit," she argued amiably. " Not without a good reason."

" Showmanship in service of She-Ra!" Razz cheered. " Not a bad idea. Spritina was terrible at it, even though she had a giant swan- a swan! You'd think Enchanta could have taught her better, but that big bird only liked fighting and preening. Swans! You made out like a bandit getting a horse."

" I did pretty good," Catra agreed, scratching Swift Wind's neck. " I mean, he's no dragon, but he's pretty good."

" I'd be angrier if you weren't bribing me with scritches," Swift Wind said, leaning into it as her claws, strong enough to cut steel, gently kneaded his skin. " Horses are better than dragons; we're cheaper to feed, if nothing else!"

" True!" Razz said. " Sorrowful nearly ate Mally out of house and home, and that was with her family's farm helping out! Even Allegra didn't have it so bad, and her bond partner Ayla had a whole pack to feed. Though I think they mostly ate mammoths, lot of meat to go around there... not bad meat either. Mammoth's good eating. What the big teeth were for."

“ Those more past She-Ras?” Catra asked. Razz nodded.

“ Probably,” Razz said. “ Maybe! Anyway, I wanted you to... huh.”

Razz chewed her lip.

“ Something here to see... oh! Here,” she said, heading over to a large stone, with deep, deep cuts marked in it. “ Something about this stone!”

It wasn't a stone- First Ones' tech, more of the crap Eternians had placed all over the planet, trying to command it. The discarded shackles of a would-be overlord, cast down by... something.

...What *had* happened? Why couldn't she remember it? Why couldn't she remember what had happened to Mara?

Caught in her own thoughts, she did not notice Catra checking the Sword against the cuts, finding that they matched... and finding one thing more, a piece of unusual tech underneath, that made the Sword shudder in her hand, as echoes of a past She-Ra encouraged her to pick it up.

But the moment passed as Catra pocketed the piece of tech, and Razz shrugged.

" Oh well," she said. She had more important things to worry about- pie things! Kinda wished she knew why, but pie things felt *very* important indeed! " Time to go back home- I've got everything else I need back there!"

But then the light off of Etheria's moons grew so *bright.*

THE END/THE MIDDLE/THE BEGINNING

The Light.

It is everywhere. The Woods are full of it. No more do animals move safely in the shadow of the trees; they are all gone. They were part of Etheria's magic, after all, and the only magic the Light will tolerate is that which obeys Him. They are gone now, all gone, after the darkness they were so reliant on was destroyed.

Now, there is only the Light.

(**the light the light the light the light the light the light the light**)

Razz turns, raises a hand against the brilliance, this green Light, that dominates Etheria now. It is anti-Chaos, it is anti-Darkness; it is the thing that destroys all chance and all mystery. It is Law and

Light united as one, it is Order and Fire melted into one radioactive whole, a uranium code that rots the bones of those who uphold it. The power of Light merged with the deliberate cruelties of Order, and all decency stripped from both; all Etheria obeys Him, now. All change, all wonder, all glory, all hope is ended, ruined, fallen gone; there is only His Light.

She knows this Light; it is old, terribly old, it has marched down the ages to clash time and again with magic, with freedom. He is the great enemy, He is the foe of all life that would live free.

She knows Him. She knows that Etheria has fought Him before.

She knows that She-Ra lost that fight, back in the day, when Etheria yet lived with other worlds, when it danced in the dark with the stars. The Gold was cast down by the Green, the Light of Chaos beaten by the Light of Order, in its endless march to conquer the darkness and drive it back forever, leaving no room for dreams or night or mysteries or hope.

(**he sees all, he knows all**)

And in this timeline, the Light of Chaos lost again.

Before the shift takes her, before she is out of the might-be and into the what-was, she sees Him on His throne, surrounded by his chipped, sycophantic followers, wearing the new flesh He had stolen for his latest rebirth- sees blonde hair over green eyes, and a body scarred on one side by the touch of fire, and a cruel smile on lips a She-Ra once kissed. He is a poison sunrise, and all

Etheria bows to its Lord and Master, who wears the face of a Dragon.

And then Razz is gone, once more.

(**the light the light the light the light the light the light the light**)

THE DURING/THE AFTER/THE BEFORE

Razz shivered momentarily, as that vision of bright apocalypse washed over her before being committed to the darkness of lost memory, in which she placed all the most frightening and painful things she saw (and seeing so much, she saw a lot of those.) She kept only the knowledge that something bad was coming, and that she had to try and stop it- something bad, happening to Catra's beloved. She should warn her...

(A stray thought occurs. *If the darkness hides my painful memories, and if my memories of what happened with Mara are in the dark...* but she puts that away. She doesn't want that to be true. Not for her Mara, who is her favorite among the She-Ras, who is the closest thing to a daughter the kindly old witch has had in all her bizarre, jump-scrambled years.)

" Catra, dearie?" Razz asked, as she turned around. She was still in the woods, before a periwinkle pear tree. " I've bad news..."

“ No?” Mara answered. “ It's Mara. You forget again?”

“ Oh, it's you!” Razz said with a laugh. It was good to see Mara, after something so... frightening. “ Good to see you! Much better than that other place. Too much light, too much order.”

“ Too much order?” Mara said, quirking an eyebrow. “ No such thing to an Eternian.”

“ Bah!” Razz said dismissvely. “ Not true. Too much of anything is bad; need a balance. Not the right path or the left, but the middle. Though I'm a bit biased against order even so; I love chaos!”

“ You would,” Mara said with a grin as Razz chuckled.

“ Chaos!” the tiny Twigget said cheerfully, pumping her fist in the air. “ I love shouting that! Chaos! Such fun. Hail Discordia, as one very dumb man used to say!”

Razz paused a moment, shaking her head. “ Wait, maybe don't say that, he was a jerk. I'm glad he got erased. Didn't even know what he was talking about most of the time, big red dummy. A spider, trying to run chaos- imagine that! As if spiders don't spin order out of their butts all the time, making webs as they go. But he was a dumb jerk in a lot of ways. Spiders are usually good,

girl. Make webs, kill bugs, set an order to the world that's not so bad. But it's not in their nature to rule chaos. Red was wrong in a lot of ways. And he paid for it, yes yes yes.”

“ Is that a myth or metaphor we have not heard before?” came a crisp, mechanically clean voice. Light Hope's flickering hologram appeared, emerging from a device on Mara's belt- actually, now that Razz looked at her, Mara looked a bit older, this must be later in time. Mara was on Etheria for many years before... before *something*, after all, arriving as a fresh recruit of eighteen and...

...How old was she when.... when *what?* Why couldn't she remember? She forgot so many things but she always knew *why* she'd forgotten, before... surely Mara died, that a new She-Ra existed was evidence enough of that, but Razz had seen She-Ras die before. Some of tragedy, most of old age- being a super-powerful warrior heroine was useful in keeping one alive, after all- but...

What had happened to her Mara?

“ Madame Razz,” Light Hope said, but not as harshly or coldly as she once had. The voice snapped her out of her spiraling thoughts.

“ Oh, sorry!” Razz said, chuckling to cover up her lapse. “ Got lost in my own thoughts! What did you say?”

“ I asked if the story you mentioned might be from Brightmoon,” Light Hope repeated. “ Of Etheria's nations, Brightmoon is the one we have had least contact with, save the Magicats- which is only logical, given their true origins.”

“ It's not from Brightmoon, but that's not important,” Razz said as revelation hit her swiftly. “ Mara, I know who the future She-Ra is!”

“ Oh?” Mara said. Light Hope quirked an eyebrow, but one glance at Mara's eager face quieted every complaint the AI could have about what she considered little better than hokey fortune-telling; she couldn't bring herself to impact Mara's mood like that.

(They were cute together, in Razz' opinion; Mara had not been the only one to learn during her time on Etheria. Light Hope had grown, too.)

“ It's Catra!” Razz said. “ She's the new She-Ra! Err, well, she will be. A thousand years from now? Maybe? Huh. Time's fuzzy for me!”

“ Catra's still a weird name for an Eternian,” Mara said.

“ Yes, it would be!” Razz agreed cheerfully. Light Hope, meanwhile, seemed to be pondering something.

“ Why would there be a thousand-year gap between She-Ras?” Light Hope asked after a moment, a perfectly logical question.

Razz shrugged.

“ No idea! Maybe Mara lives to be really old!”

Mara laughed, as a queasy feeling washed over Razz; old? No, no, she... she didn't think her Mara would get to grow old.

“ I don't think I'll live *that* long,” Mara said, amused. “ We live a long time, but Eternians aren't eternal, despite the name.”

“ There's always brain uploading,” Light Hope pointed out. “ It's not perfect, obviously, but it *is* a kind of preservation. And we have the facilities for it in the Crystal Castle.”

“ And of course, that way you could have her with you,” Razz teased, glad to have something else to focus on than that... queasy feeling.

Light Hope flickered, the AI equivalent of an intense blush.

“ That would be pleasant,” she admitted, and Mara grinned at the AI.

“ I won't leave you alone,” she said, a thought that must be a constant fear to an AI in love with a mortal. “ I like you too much to abandon you- but we'll wait. There's no rush, and the later we leave it, the more accurate the electronic copy will be. I'd hate to leave you with a substandard Mara!”

“ Nothing standard about you!” Razz said with a chuckle. “ Anyway, what was I doing...? Oh, yes! Mara! Do you know what today is?”

“ I... knew before you asked?” Mara said, cocking her head to the side. “ This feels like a trick question...”

“ If you wish to know the time and date, I have both the Eternian calendar and the local Etherian calendar in my database,” Light Hope answered, but Razz waved her staff through the AI's hologram.

“ No, no,” Razz said. “ This day is too important for calendars. It's *Pie* Day!”

Light Hope grimaced at her- having her hologram momentarily interrupted didn't hurt, but it *was* annoying- while Mara clapped her hands in glee.

“ Oh, I was hoping you were baking!” she said, delighted. “ I figured you were, what with the basket, but it's good to know!”

Razz laughed as Mara's grin grew wider; every tooth in that sweet girl's head was as sweet as she was, her bottomless appetite for sugar her one flaw.

“ Well, onwards!” Razz declared. “ We need...”

“ Sugar?” Mara said, hopefully. “ I made sure to get extra at last supply drop!”

“ A wise precaution, given *someone's* gluttony for sweets,” Light Hope teased as she side-eyed Mara, who shrugged shamelessly.

“ Yes! But wait... before I begin... Catra doesn't like sugar,” Razz mused. “ No, Catra don't appreciate sweet food at all.”

“ How can she not like sweets?” Mara said, with a reaction indicating her belief that she was hearing heretical blasphemy.

“ Can't taste them, for the most part!” Razz said. “ Just kinda bland to her.”

Mara pondered that a moment.

“ That sounds awful,” she said, eyes shining with sympathy and outrage at this injustice.

“ It's not uncommon,” Light Hope said. “ Thunderians, and their Magicat descendants, cannot taste much of sweets either. They have palates focused on savory foods.”

“ True!” Razz cheerfully agreed.

“ Ooh, maybe that's why she calls herself Catra!” Mara theorized. “ I wonder how her tongue got like that? Odd!”

Razz said nothing, just grinned. They were *so close* to guessing the truth, and that made this all *much funnier.*

“ Oh well!” Razz said. “ You go grab sugar, I'll go home! Onwards, to pie!”

Mara clapped, and it sounded like a grandfather clock chiming.

WHAT-WAS/WHAT-IS/WHAT-MAY

She runs, back home, back home; sugar in the cabinet, pulled out. Mara must have got here first. Time to make the mash, the crust, fill it with the mash to make the pie.

" Come on, you know something," someone grumbled. She turned in surprise to see a Magicat, annoyed, tail flickering; she couldn't sit still, this new guest of hers! Like trying to bottle lightning, for her to sit still a minute- but she was so tall, and she glowed, with tiger stripes in her fur, her hair a more literal mane...

" Oh, you must be the new She-Ra!" Razz said cheerfully, as information from the past- and the future- filtered in slowly. This was their first meeting! Or, well, at least from *her* perspective. " Catra, right?"

Catra blinked at her. " Err... yes?"

Catra, confused, shared a bewildered look with Swift Wind as Razz jumped for joy, clapping her hands.

" Oh, then this is our first meeting for me! Oh, it's been so long! I love first meetings!" the old woman said. " I'm Madame Razz, it's good to see you! Catra, right?"

" Err... you know me, Madame Razz," Catra answered, obviously worried.

“ Bah, don't be worried,” Razz said. “ We only meet each other for the first time once, dearie. Well, at least that's how it'll look for you. Not for me! But I'm glad you're here. Glad to know who it was. Could have been Adora, you know.”

“ I... you mean She-Ra, right?” Catra said, frowning. “ I know Shadow Weaver thought it might be her...”

“ It could be,” Razz confirmed, as she set her pie to bake near her fire, setting her alarm. “ But I'm glad it's you. Lightning, chosen over fire; the storm, and not the sun. It's good this way. Not that it *wouldn't* be good if it was the other one, too... but someone else wrote that tale, beautiful as it is. I love that story, but I love this one, too; I think you deserve it. A chance to... shine.”

“ Thank you?” Catra said, and her eyes tried to cross of their own free will as her mind ached. “ Razz, are you alright?”

“ Are you?” Razz asked her, stifling a yawn. Pies took so long to bake, and Razz was feeling every inch of her years all of a sudden. Sleepy, Razz answered in a half-mumble. “ You seem... confused. Not good. Confused... not good. Especially for a big bad She-Ra! Etheria's under too much threat to be... confused.”

“ Yeah, I know about Adora,” Catra said, but Razz shook her head as she moved over to a comfy rocking chair in her home.

“ Nope, nope, not just her,” Razz said, settling down to... nap. Surely a nap wouldn't hurt. The alarm would wake her when the pie was done. “ Worse and worse. A greater Light, definitely. Maybe the other thing, too, the Dark. Nothing's certain, not even for me, but... the past shapes the future, and the present... the present *knows,* girlie. Stuff's happening right now that determines the way this story ends, little thundercat. And it feels... not quite right, for your story to end with you facing the bright. You're not like your love. No, for you... for you, there's a last rejection up ahead, I think. A last temptation. A last stand against your oldest foe...”

Entirely despite herself, a shiver ran down Catra's spine, though Razz only saw part of it, falling into sleep.

She dreamed- sort of. Memories, really. Her first meeting with Mara- the boar attack- showing Mara the beauty of Etheria. Discussions between them, late into the night, talking of magic and miracles and wonders. Watching Mara argue with her squad about this or that – seeing Light Hope grow as a person- their love blossoming between them, the slow dance of lillies and roses, as old as people, as new as tomorrow.

...Good dreams.

But the more she dreamed, the closer she got to the ending, to... to the thing she couldn't quite remember.

She did know this much. It was going to hurt. She knew that, knew it in her bones, old as they were. Mara...

Her Mara.

But she must know, must... there is something important there, something the new She-Ra must know...

Her alarm rang, and it sounded like a pendulum swinging.

YESTERDAY/TODAY/TOMORROW

" Catra?" Razz asked, as she looked around her home, seeing no one there save a freshly baked, perfectly made pie and an alarm she shut off. " Where is your big kind horse with the flappy wings?"

" ...Do you mean my *spaceship*?" a voice asked from outside. Mara stepped in, raising an eyebrow at her.

" Mara!" Razz declared as she turned around to her friend. " Goodness me! I can't believe I got the wrong She-Ra. Ooh! But now I know who it is now! It's Catra. Adora kept her balance, and so she lost the Sword. It's Catra!"

" I know," Mara said. She seemed... hurt. It was raining outside. When had that started? Raining and storming. And... other

things... rainbow colored lights, reaching out towards the stars, hungry, hungry. " You... you told me."

"Mara, dearie, you're... you're hurt..." Razz said, cocking her head. She didn't... she didn't know this one, this time, this... this is the first time she's been here in...

" I want you," Mara said, leaning against the frame of her door, " to make sure she gets my message. Make sure Catra gets my message. It's on my ship... I... I don't know where I dropped the power circuit... maybe when I was attacking the control towers. But... please, find it... make sure she gets my message, Razz."

" I... but no..." Razz said, shaking her head. " This isn't how it's supposed to go..."

Mara choked a laugh at that. " It isn't... but... well."

Her communicator rang, she held it up in a shaking hand, and the voice on it was scared and terrified.

" We can't hold out! Mara- this is- this is it for Grayskull!"

" Serenia!" Mara said. " What- what's happening?"

“ We got the failsafe installed, but... the guardian down here... we're not gonna make it. Go, Mara, go! They'll look for you next! Do your thing, get Etheria into Despondos! Hide the Sword!”

“ You were supposed to live,” Razz said, eyes filling with tears. “ Live, and eat pie, and...”

“ Maybe someday,” Mara said to her, before putting her communicator to her lips. “ Serenia... thank you- thank you all. I'll... I'll see you on the other side.”

“ Okay, I- no!”

The screams, and a horrible roar, and then Mara cut her communicator off and hurled Razz into the future.

THIS MOMENT IN TIME

Razz picked up the pie, fully done, with her hands. Catra dozed next to Swift Wind, curled up on him like the cat she resembled; Razz walked past them, and her light footsteps awoke Catra, who had never slept in peace and safety until she was in Brightmoon at last.

“ Madame Razz?” she asked, a bit muzzily. “ What-”

“ Mara,” Razz said, quiet now, the weight of her new knowledge weighing on her. No wonder she'd tried to forget. “When you brought her ship out of the Wastes, you left it here, nearby. No room in Brightmoon for it, decided to hide it in the Woods. Come with me- and bring the circuitry you picked up with you.”

Catra complied, waking up Swift Wind as she did, obviously spooked by her change in demeanor; but she followed, followed to Mara's ancient vessel, which waited as it always had, ancient and quiet. Bow had been here a few times- Razz had seen him, from time to time, heading out here to take tech pieces back to Brightmoon for study- and Perfuma, having moved it, knew where it was; Razz had to follow that odd instinct, that certainty in her skull that told her where she needed to go, the same thing that had led her to find Catra in a world that never was. Orders from above, or from within.

With lead in her heart and heavy feet, she moved through the woods to a clearing that held the ship, whose ramp lay open waiting for her. Bow would not have left it down, but... somehow, she'd known it would be open for her.

Up, up, up. To the command room, to... to the place where her Mara...

“ The command console, Catra,” Razz said. “ There's a place for your circuitry. Please.”

Without a word- but with a glance at Swift Wind, who'd come in with them, moving his big form quietly through this place- Catra

went over to the ship's front, and after a few moments, found where to place the key.

And then, before her, was her Mara.

" Catra."

Catra turned, hearing her name on a dead woman's lips, finding Mara standing there- Mara, beautiful and wounded, the epitome of scared courage. Mara, flickering; a hologram.

Mara's vision began to blur with tears.

" I know you're there. Razz... Madame Razz promised me you'd be there. That this wasn't in vain."

Mara sighed, a wry smile twisting onto her bruised lips as her hologram glitched. She held a hand out, and Catra approached, her own hand reaching out unconsciously... but then Mara grimaced, withdrew her hand, and the hologram went to settle down on the throne, hurt and unable to stand.

Her next few words were strained.

" Though the mere fact you're hearing this means I failed. I am Mara. I was supposed to be the last She-Ra... I hid the Sword... but you exist. That means I didn't hide the Sword well enough, I suppose; but none of this went the way it was supposed to. Grayskull was lost... my friends... they..."

With an effort visible a thousand years later, Mara closed her eyes, grit her teeth, and did not focus on all she'd lost.

Razz lost sight of her, as the tears began to flow, running down her old, old face.

" We lost. Eternia- what this planet calls First Ones- they were going to fire the weapon... but I've got a plan. A way to make sure *no one* ever uses the weapon."

" Weapon?" was the word on Catra's lips, but Razz barely heard her; her memories were coming back, the things she wanted to forget, that she wanted to forget so much...

The truth.

(*Truth always wins, no matter how it hurts, though it can take its sweet time.* Her own words, and they were right; this truth took a thousand years to recall, no matter how much it hurts Razz to hear it.)

" The Heart of Etheria... my people were the first ones to come here, deliberately, to... really study the planet's magic. Etheria is so unique, so special; but that... that's what makes this so much *worse.* "

Mara's figure flinched, as the sound of some new disaster echoed from the past, some new harm her ship was taking, that might cut her message short.

" I knew that we- that they- were doing something... but they told me it was a power source. Something to fuel the Eternian empire for a thousand years. But it wasn't; it was a weapon. A tool of conquest. A way to gather this planet's magic... and to use it to destroy other worlds."

Mara sighed, as debris flaked down from above in her hologram, like falling snow... or the tears that continued to rain down from Razz's eyes.

" You can't... you can't let them use the Heart of Etheria!"

The shout clearly took something out of Mara, something she would never have a chance to recover; she curled in on herself, her injuries even more visible and prominent as she withdrew into herself, tears visible in her eyes as she fought her fear and pain and sorrow to remain coherent.

" Light Hope... they did something to her. She can't be trusted. Grayskull- my squad- they went with me, my friends... they chose me, and I led them to ruin. I don't know what happened to all of them, but I think... I think they died. There's a guardian on the Heart, some... monster... I guess it's not important now. They died, and Light Hope is worse than dead, and I... I'll be joining them, soon."

She sighed, looked away for a moment before continuing.

" We had to... we had to fight the rest of the expedition. They were going to pull the trigger- that's what the Sword is. It's a fuse. It's a fuse, and Etheria is the biggest bomb ever built. If it goes off... that's it. So many worlds, wiped clean of life in a single pulse, made sterile and ready for colonization by my people. That's all this was- genocide on a galactic scale. *That's* what the Sword is."

Mara coughed, spat up blood, closed her eyes as the hologram began to lose coherence. Catra raised her Sword, that symbol of heroism she had carried into glorious battle, and looked at it with new, disbelieving, horrified eyes, as a noise behind Razz indicated Swift Wind stepping forward, to stare at the Sword in turn.

Mara's next words were half-slurred by her own vital fluids as she wiped her lips.

" The Heart of Etheria project will tear the planet apart if it goes off again. They hooked it to the most prominent Runestones... and to the Sword. Without the Sword, the Heart of Etheria can't

be used. Like a grenade with no firing pin. Don't trust Light Hope! She... oh, my love... what they did to her. I wish you could have known her as she was, Catra."

Mara let out a single choked sob before she spat blood from her mouth to off-screen as the rattling increased.

" But Catra... you can do so much better than me. You're stronger than me- and you're unexpected. They never planned for a Thunderian to get a hold of the Sword. That... it gives me hope, because you could not *possibly* be part of their plans. They would never have let their enemies hold the blade. Please- don't let them win. Keep Etheria in Despondos! It's the key. I hid us in Despondos because they'll never find us out here. Too much empty space, too much possibility of getting lost. They can't have it- and *neither can anyone else.* There were other forces- a tyrant with an army of clones- all kinds of things. *None* of them can be allowed to use the Heart of Etheria! I took the stars from Etheria so that the stars would keep *existing...* I..."

She paused as a blast rattled her, then turned eyes full of tears on Catra, who stared in mute horror back.

" You *have* to keep Etheria in Despondos! Stay here! The Heart of Etheria must never be used. Keep the universe safe from Etheria- from what my people did to it. Destroy... destroy Light Hope. They remade her; she's not the woman I loved. She'll seek to activate it, going off of old orders, no matter how long it's been, no matter if anyone even *wants* that anymore. Please... set her free. Set her free, and keep the Heart quiet, forever."

With a smile she forced onto her quivering lips, Mara looked at Catra, and said her last words.

" You can save everyone, everywhere. I believe in you, Catra."

And then there was a crash, and the hologram cut out. Catra reeled, not knowing what to think; Swift Wind swayed where he stood too.

Razz barely paid any attention to them. She hurt too much. Her Mara.

Her Mara, who was so brave, who died alone and afraid and in pain. Her Mara, who should have lived a hundred years, who had died a *bad* death, who had died that way so that no one else would have to.

Her Mara.

(Her heart breaks again. This is why her mind hid it from her. It hurts too much to hold in her hands; she is not strong enough. After everything, after all she has seen, her Mara's death was what shattered her; she had been too close, she has lost a daughter in Mara, and she grieves.)

" The First Ones... were going to do *that*?" Catra said, and Razz doesn't have to be as old as she is to know what Catra's thinking about, right now.

(*Adora*)

But it's hard to focus on that past her own pain. Her Mara...

" She was so brave," Razz said, as she closed her eyes and placed her pie on the chair, finally remembering what it was for. Plumerians laid food down for their dead, and she was a Plumerian as much as she was anything else. " For you, Mara."

" I... I knew that something was up," Catra said, shaking her head. " Or sort of knew. I've never quite trusted Light Hope, and the sensations I pick up from the Sword, like memories... I knew that Mara wasn't a monster. Didn't know the details, but I knew she wasn't a monster... she was a hero."

" The best," Razz agreed, tears running down her wrinkles. " My Mara was so brave. So *good*. I've liked many She-Ra's- Etheria never does pick poorly- but Mara... Mara was like my own daughter. Watching her discover Etheria, seeing her fall in love with this planet, her romance with Light Hope... I was honored to be a part of her life, and I loved that girl. She was the best of you."

Some part of Catra wanted to argue with that- *best Princess* and all- but knowing this ship was Mara's tomb, with the weight of Mara's last words so heavy on her, and seeing the pain on Razz's face... she could do nothing but concede, nodding her head.

“ Thank you, dearie,” Razz said, wiping her face. “ I know... it's hard for you, to let anyone be better. Thank you.”

Catra blinked in surprise at that- at how easily Razz had picked her way to her heart- but the old Twigget just kept going.

“ You're kind to an old fool. Her death did something to me, you know. I've always been scatterbrained- how can I be anything else, scattered as I am myself?- but... losing her... it has done me no good.”

Catra didn't know what to say, was still a bit surprised at how well Razz knew her, so she just settled on stepping forward and squeezing the little woman's shoulder; the Twigget leaned into it with a sigh.

“ Ah, but while not as good as my Mara, you are indeed a fine She-Ra,” Razz said, smiling at nothing, eyes closed. “ One of the best. You have grown so much, dearie. You should be so *proud* of you. You are so good and kind now. You were always strong, strong and clever and swift, and now... now you're sweet, too. The whole package. Power and responsibility as one; another spider said that. Good spider. Smarter than red spider. *Better.* Your name's Catra, but you are a mighty tigress, child.”

“ I like to think so,” Catra admitted, and somehow, a laugh burbled up out of Razz, despite everything.

“ And proud, too!” she said. “ None of that humble crap from you. Oh, I *do* like you, dearie. You're gonna be one of the greats, if you don't die. Which isn't certain, I'm afraid. Lot of futures. Many in which you die... a terrible world to live in. I should know. I've seen it.”

“ I'll do my best,” Catra said.

(She said it without fear; it didn't really scare her, to know she could die. She'd known she could die at any moment back in the Fright Zone, and any fear of death had long since fled her. No, the only thing Catra feared was *failure* .)

“ You always do,” Razz said with a sigh, looking at the pie, thinking of the She-Ra who should have gotten to eat it, the brave, brave woman who had done her best, too.

“ But sometimes, it's not enough.”

And Razz let the kindly darkness take the pain away from her again.

-

Many miles away, to the north and west of Brightmoon, a princess spoke to the unkindly darkness. Entrapta was off, having slithered away to go over some of her initial scan results, having subjected Glimmer to numerous tests over the last day; with that

unpleasantness over, Glimmer figured it was time to start moving on with her *real* plan.

" So, Shadow Weaver?" Glimmer asked, with a grin on her face. " I figured, while Entrapta's working on the new data, how about you teach me some more magic?"

" Not wasting any time learning more?" Shadow Weaver said, with something almost fond in her voice. " Your father was the same way. What would you like to learn?"

" Well," Glimmer said, " I've already learned a lot about magic in general... and I've already got a lot of light, what with these glittery hands and all."

She waved them about, letting them shine.

" So I figured... why don't you teach me about dark magic?" Glimmer said. " Especially defenses! I've got all the offense I'll ever need, after all."

Her grin grew bigger.

" But I'd love to know how you can use the dark to protect yourself. I mean, who expects that? Especially from *me?* Adora won't know what to do, and that's how I'll get her. Well, assuming

it works that way. I don't know what it's good against, what it's bad against, but I just figure it'll surprise her."

Shadow Weaver chuckled. Such an eager student! And not one afraid to get her hands dirty.

(Though some part of her grew suspicious, could sense just barely something else here... but she dismissed it. Just pure paranoia. It was *Glimmer*, what deceit could this little fairy brute manage?)

" I agree," Shadow Weaver said with an unseen smile. " No one would expect a Princess of Brightmoon to understand the darkness. I will teach you, child."

Glimmer grinned at her.

" That's right; nobody'll see it coming!"

(And Shadow Weaver taught her, all that day and the next, until Entrapta came back to them, and told them that they needed Scorpia... and so must go to Beast Island.)

Chapter End Notes

Some quick notes.

Mara's task squad is 19.85 because that is the year the first She-Ra series aired. Given Mara is the "predecessor" She-Ra, I felt it appropriate for her squad's number to reflect the original series. Grayskull is actually the canon name for Mara's squad, though it's mentioned in a very quick blink-and-

you'll-miss-it moment in the last season.
(I do love that, though; the idea that the next She-Ra has been fighting in Mara's name, all this time. There's something beautiful about that.)

Serenia is actually a two-fer! In She-Ra and the Princesses of Power canon, that's the name of one of Mara's friends in the Grayskull squad. That's who Mara's talking about at the end, there. In the show, a constellation by that name is mentioned by George and Lance (it's how they figure out to send them to the Crimson Waste), and her voice is the one describing the Failsafe going by episode credits (apparently Noelle did this voice!)

HOWEVER.

The Serenia that Madame Razz mentions is actually a place in the original series! That series' Razz mentions having lived there years ago, though it's not stated if its her homeland or not. In this setting, Serenia is one of the smaller provinces of Plumeria (albeit Razz predates the formation of Plumeria by quite a bit, she did form in that area.) It's located almost dead-center in Etheria's one continent.

Most likely Noelle named Serenia after the original series location, which is AMAZING n and I love it.

Everyone else Razz mentions as a She-Ra or a bond partner is a character from the old She-Ra series! In this setting, they were all past She-Ras.

Spritina was a Twigget She-Ra who mostly fought a tyrant of Dryll who was hellbent on destroying Plumeria and the Whispering Woods- the woman was basically Dr. Blight from Captain Planet. Enchanta was her giant swan companion, who was a terrifying combatant and a lot more dangerous than the She-Ra of her time (because swans are elegant monsters.) Perfuma's people have a lot of myths and stories about her, as while she wasn't the only She-Ra from Plumeria,

she's definitely the most famous. Perfuma grew up hearing a lot of stories about her- a lot of stories in general, actually. Her dads were talky dudes, and liked stories and myths (which is why Perfuma had heard of the last Fire Princess).

Mally was a human from the Blazing Kingdom who didn't have a single great enemy, but who was a sort of general problem-solver in a time of general world upheaval; Sorrowful was an almost hilariously inconsistent companion, being probably the most powerful bond partner any She-Ra has ever had, but hampered by both his own cowardice and the fact that he was frankly overkill for most problems. He was still the perfect bond partner for Mally, whose main talent was as a diplomat; while she had She-Ra's raw strength to fall back on, she was the worst She-Ra when it came to fighting, and so Sorrowful got a lot of use when real trouble started. It is Sorrowful that is the dragon depicted on the urn that Bow's dads discovered in their archaeological research into She-Ra.

Allegra was from the Kingdom of Snows, specifically from a small province called Green Island that sits off of the Kingdom of Snow's main coastline; she was originally the daughter of its feudal lord, Duke Arbor. Her bond partner Ayla was a White Fang, a species of semi-intelligent magical saber-toothed wolves native to the northernmost parts of the Kingdom of Snows (which means it's the northernmost part of Etheria as a whole.)

Allegra was a very weird case, possibly the oddest She-Ra to ever exist; she was seven when she was chosen, which is when the ship transporting her and her mother wrecked and left her stranded in the freezing wilderness, with only the wolves for company. Her ascension let her make Ayla her bond partner, increasing her intelligence enough that the White Fang was able to keep her alive and get her back to her fellow humans after a few years.

Allegra was mostly a She-Ra who stopped natural disasters and protected Etheria's ecosystems, being, for obvious

reasons, very, very in-tune with the natural world; it took her years to get totally comfortable with people, though, and her habit of disappearing from social situations, alongside her preference for white clothing to blend in with her pack "family", led her to be nicknamed the White Ghost at court.

She ended up getting back home after meeting Duke Arbor and him realizing she looked just like her mother, though they actually met several times at the Kingdom of Snows' court before either of them pieced it together.

As for the other stuff... well, Razz knows a lot of things. Not all of them confined to one setting.

Chapter 15: Glimmer of the Council of the Wise

Chapter Notes

Glimmer's goals revealed.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer of the Council of the Wise

This has been a weird couple of days, Glimmer thought to herself as she made ready to go train with Shadow Weaver.

And while Glimmer had a tendency to exaggerate and blow things out of proportion, she didn't think she'd missed the mark this time.

When she'd arrived at Dryll, Shadow Weaver had laid out the whole thing. A plan Entrapta and Shadow Weaver had come up with; a plan to defeat the Horde, one done in secret for fear that Queen Angella and the others would be too weak to commit. A weakness they believed Glimmer didn't share; a plan that needed a Princess' help.

She had nodded her head, and agreed to everything, and they let her join them; a “council of the wise”, Shadow Weaver had called it.

Glimmer had been privately amused by the name, but said nothing. This was great, good, better than she'd hoped for; it let her get close, and maybe set her up to do what she'd *actually* come here to do.

But after that had come the tests. Entrapta had slithered out of some dark corner (and just about scared the teeth out of Glimmer in the process) and dragged her off in her coils to be subjected to testing. Constant, constant testing, most of which involved Entrapta- who frankly looked like she'd seen better days- poking her with a wide variety of strange devices. Some of it really hurt, but Glimmer simply grit her teeth, grinned, and bore it.

She had to be cooperative, now. She had to make a show of her willingness to... play along. She had to be all smiles and all helpful, up until the end.

It was awful. Not the pain; it never hurt *that* bad, and Glimmer was a soldier. She didn't fear pain. She'd had her share of hard knocks, and then some. Compared to getting exploded by the bombs in Mara's ship, Entrapta's tests were like getting stung by a bee- painful, not something you *wanted* to experience, but not the end of the world.

No, what was awful was the holding back. Glimmer wasn't lying, she never *could* manage that, and still couldn't, even after that awful night where her sister told her... told her all kinds of things.

(She'd hugged her mom, the next day. All of their fighting and arguing felt... silly... next to the things Catra had described. She'd told her mom she was a good mother, and that she loved her, and that she was sorry they'd ever fought; and she'd cried a bit, more

unashamed than her Hordesman sister... as had her mom. She hadn't known how bad a mother could *be* until Catra spoke, hadn't known how good she'd had it.)

But she could hold *back* , even if it made her want to puke. It rattled in her insides, the truth, wanted to come spilling out of her lips; she was an honest woman, and she wanted to tell that truth, she wanted to spit it out like venom in Shadow Weaver's eyes. She wanted to scream at Shadow Weaver *I know what you are* . She wanted to shout to Entrapta *she's using you, the way she used Catra, the way she used Adora.* She wanted to say *This is for Catra* as she beat the dark witch with her bare hands until she pissed blood, until there was no more Shadow Weaver, until every horrible thing she'd done to Glimmer's sister was avenged in death and the monster was just a wet stain on Glimmer's fists.

But there were two factors holding her back. The first was that Glimmer, speaking realistically, knew that she probably couldn't pull it off. Not yet. She'd failed at so much in her life, because she ran in, because she never *planned* ; and this was too important to fuck up. This had to be done *right* .

(It was easier to admit her failures, now. Being dishonest with Entrapta and Shadow Weaver was, bizarrely, making it easier for the proud, insecure princess to be more honest with *herself* , as if she sought a balance. It was... a little easier, now, to admit to all her many mistakes. Odd.)

So she would wait, and learn. Learn all that Shadow Weaver wanted to teach before betraying her, the student murdering the teacher. She had time. So long as Adora's Horde existed, so long as Shadow Weaver thought Glimmer was useful as a tool, she'd never suspect a thing. Not out of loud, stupid Glimmer, the lesser

princess of Brightmoon. Not out of a glittery brute with worthless wings.

Usually, thinking of herself that way made Glimmer mad... but now, for the first time in her life, she was *glad* to be that way, glad that others thought so little of her.

It meant she had the element of surprise on her side.

The other factor was that Glimmer didn't *just* have Shadow Weaver as a target. There was an additional target, which Glimmer kept reminding herself of when the urge to make Shadow Weaver *pay* got too big, when the only thing she could think of when she looked at the monster was her sister's words there in the darkness of her mother's kitchen, sitting on the floor, the most powerful woman on Etheria reduced to a sobbing wreck by her memories alone.

Adora.

Glimmer had to kill Adora.

She didn't like thinking of it. It wasn't like with Shadow Weaver, where a sense of justice and righteousness prevailed, where she *knew* that killing her was the right thing to do. Adora was more complicated. She felt a kind of... gratitude, from what Catra had said, a gratefulness to the Horde's Lord that she had saved Glimmer's sister in the days before she came to Brightmoon, that

Glimmer had a sister *only* because Adora had been there to protect her from Shadow Weaver.

(She has owed two Lords of the Horde her family's life, a strange thought; she owes Hordak her mother, and Adora her sister. An odd thing to think, considering that the Horde took her father, too...)

But... all her kindnesses in childhood didn't... it didn't *change* what she'd done, since. They did not change the fact that in the *now* , Lord Adora's Horde was chewing through the Woods at a tremendously rapid rate, burning their way to Plumeria, the fires devouring ancient places that had existed for centuries. Her goodness to Catra didn't change the fact that Adora was now coming to spread the Horde over the conquered flags of all the free peoples of Etheria, Glimmer's included. It did not change the portal that would have murdered the world, that had nearly cost Glimmer her mother but for Hordak, the most unlikely of all saviors. It did not change the knife in Catra's side at the Battle of Brightmoon, it did not change the tank shot Adora fired that would have killed Queen Angella but for Catra's last minute sacrifice.

(Glimmer shuddered at the idea of losing her mother; she wouldn't have dealt with it well, she knew, not with all the things left unsaid between them. Even now, now that they were finally saying them, she would not deal with her mother's death well; but if this had happened before they could reconcile? She might have... lost herself, to her anger, to the worst parts of herself.)

It did not change the fact that *right now,* Adora was no longer Catra's friend, but her enemy, and that Catra couldn't... she couldn't defend herself, not from her. Not from Adora and not from Shadow Weaver.

She'd been thinking of it since that fated meeting, which felt like it had been months ago, when Catra had fled the room at the very thought of killing Adora. Catra... Catra was a hero, sure, but Glimmer hadn't realized how *much* like the old stories her sister really was, not until that day. Just like the most fabled heroines of Brightmoon, she was invincible, unstoppable, could not be harmed... save by one specific thing, some hidden weakness that always brought the mighty hero low.

And perhaps it fit, that Catra had two weaknesses, and not just one; she was a greater hero, after all. She had two scales missing from her dragonskin, she had twin flaws to match her greater heroism, not just one.

Glimmer knew those tales, had grown up hearing them from too many lips, reading them in too many books. If the tale played out as it always did, those same weaknesses would kill the great hero, and turn the tale into a tragedy. She could see it, even now; Shadow Weaver would betray Catra, or the She-Ra would falter in one last great fight with Adora, and be murdered where she stood. A witch or a dragon would kill the hero- and probably all the Rebellion thereafter, if Glimmer was being honest. This wasn't *just* about her sister, though that was who Glimmer thought of first and foremost.

But Glimmer had never been that fond of Brightmoon's tragedies, like the tale of the Exiled Knight. She liked stories with *happy* endings.

So Glimmer... Glimmer would do what a big sister should, and protect her sibling from harm.

Even if she'd never forgive her for it. Catra still loved *both* of them, which struck Glimmer as beyond strange; Adora she could kinda get, but loving Shadow Weaver? What the hell?

Still, the great heroines did not get to choose their weaknesses. The fact was, Catra, who was usually smarter than that, loved them both, and she would hate Glimmer for killing them.

But Catra would be alive to do it. Catra would be alive, to hate Glimmer, to learn to love again, she would be alive, and all the Alliance with her.

And weighed against seeing Catra die, against letting her weaknesses destroy her? Against Adora or Shadow Weaver taking advantage of her?

Glimmer could live with that. She could bear the burden of being hated, if it meant that Catra would be alive to hate her.

Though if it all worked out perfectly, Catra would never know. Glimmer was not so selfless as to not try to hide it. She wanted her sister to live, and she wanted her sister to love her; so she'd try to do this quiet.

Which was another reason she tolerated the tests. Glimmer had never done *quiet* before, and so needed even more time to prep than usual.

Plus, the tests got Entrapta's plan to off Adora closer to completion. Something about a "Heart of Etheria", and a plan to boost the powers of the princesses... though Entrapta had also mentioned the possibility of blowing up the planet? Something about a bomb, which hadn't really reassured Glimmer.

(The Dryll-born genius claimed she had safeguards to prevent it, but... Entrapta didn't look like she'd been sleeping... and something told Glimmer that maybe Entrapta wouldn't really *care* if Etheria exploded.)

Still, that was all above Glimmer's head. She had to hope and pray that Entrapta knew what she was doing, because Glimmer sure as shit had no way to affect it. Maybe Bow would, but even he'd admitted that Entrapta was a bit above him... and dragging him into this... well, Glimmer didn't much like that idea. Bow was so good, so pure; she doubted he'd be down with Glimmer's assassination plan, any more than Catra would be.

And again; Glimmer was a selfish person, as she admitted to herself. She didn't want to lose her two best friends in the process of saving her sister's life.

So she held it in, and got tested on, and spent the second day with Shadow Weaver, learning and learning.

She had a desire in her, a question she had to ask, but she couldn't seem too eager, so she'd just held it shut inside herself all day yesterday. And that had been *awful,* awful awful awful, how did Catra do it? Her clever words, her sharp tongue, all her manipulating; how did she do it? This was horrible! She felt like she was dry-swallowing chunks of lemon, keeping all her thoughts in her skull, having to think two things at once; the thing she *wanted* to say, and the thing she *actually* said.

Just... the worst.

But she'd ask today. Asking yesterday, during the first training session, that was too eager, too obvious; but today, today maybe it would... just come out as curiosity? Right? Shadow Weaver had no reason to doubt her. No one would think Glimmer had the willpower to just... not blurt out every thought in her head.

Right?

Fuuuuuuuuuuck, Shadow Weaver was going to see right through her and blast her to pieces as soon as she asked...

But Glimmer had never been a coward, so she sighed and took off to go meet the monster, deep in her lair in the bowels of the Crypto Castle. There wasn't much light to see by; Entrapta had turned off most of them in the hallways, claiming it was an unnecessary power expenditure and that her plan to connect to the Heart needed all the extra power she could grab. Glimmer wasn't sure she hadn't done it just to be fucking spooky; this place was the worst.

With a little ball of light in her hand to guide her way- and a map Entrapta had provided her when Shadow Weaver prompted the depressed mad scientist- Glimmer walked, and only took two wrong turns before she made it. Shadow Weaver had asked her not to teleport; something about preserving her magic, which made sense to Glimmer. She'd have to go all the way back to Brightmoon to recharge, after all.

(Maybe she'd ask about that while she was at it; sorcery used ambient magic, why couldn't Glimmer absorb that, too? If she was a vessel to be filled with magic, was it *just* the Moonstone, or could she grab other stuff, too? Something to ponder.)

So into a wide, open room, one that held nothing but a few training targets on a far wall and a small round table with two seats, at which an abomination sat.

" Glimmer," that abomination said, " and on time, too. I see you're getting the hang of navigating the Crypto Castle."

" Yeah!" Glimmer said, and with an effort of tremendous will, suppressed the nervous giggles that wanted to fall right out of her mouth... and the burst of *rage* that threatened to consume her when she looked on her sister's tormentor. " Only got turned around twice. Doing better!"

" Clearly," Shadow Weaver said, amused. " But your training continues. Beast Island is no joke. You will be our point man on the ground, with Entrapta following; I will support from afar, but

much of this will be on your shoulders. We lack any other Princess to do the heavy lifting for us."

And I'm not much of a Princess, Glimmer thought. Not like Mermista or Perfuma, who could have soloed the island themselves; Glimmer wasn't really a Princess. Her mom was Brightmoon's Princess, in the practical sense of having the real power.

And maybe all the effort Glimmer was putting into not just punching Shadow Weaver made something break, because before Glimmer could stop herself, she asked, " Hey, could I absorb magic from other things?"

Weaver cocked one eye- somehow, given that her eyeballs were just creepy white lights in her mass of shadows- and Glimmer felt the urge to defend her question.

" I mean, sorcery does that, right?" she said. " And I absorb magic from the Moonstone but I'm not a *real* Princess; I'm not connected that way, I just kinda suck magic out of it. I'm a big old tick! Haha."

Glimmer was sweating enough that Sea Hawk could have sailed a flaming boat off of her forehead, but she *still* couldn't wrangle her damn mouth shut. Was it rebelling on her for not saying what she wanted to say? Could your body betray you like that?!?

“ So I was thinking, could I do that to other stuff? I mean, I'm kind of weird, and my dad was a great mage and my mom's unique so maybe being a hybrid I can do stuff no one else can, is this a stupid idea? I don't know enough about magic to say one way or the other so maybe I'll stop. Talking. Sorry.”

Her tongue finally skidding to a stop, Glimmer just stared at Shadow Weaver for a long, long minute, the longest minute of her entire life.

Then Shadow Weaver chuckled.

“ That's... actually an intriguing idea,” she said. “ Not one I would have thought of. It is simply impossible for most mages to put magic inside their bodies like that... I can, but I had to go through quite a process to be able to do so. But you... you do it every time you commune with the Moonstone. You *are* different, not quite a Princess, not quite a mage, but something else... Why, what a *fascinating* avenue of development this might open up.”

A grin popped on Glimmer's face before she could stop it.

“ Really? Nice!” Glimmer said, but then her stupid mouth ran off again. She was gonna have to dock its pay at this rate. “ Umm, I had other thoughts too- you know, you were going to teach me dark magic, maybe I could do both? Both would be cool!”

Glimmer kept grinning but inside she was a mess.

FUCK, Shadow Weaver's going to figure it out, stop talking by the moons what the hell, woman? She's gonna blast you!

But Shadow Weaver seemed to notice nothing of what was going on in Glimmer's head, and instead just chuckled again.

" My, my. You remind me so much of your father," Shadow Weaver said, with an air of fondness that Glimmer had never heard in her voice when she spoke of either Catra or Adora... and not for the first time, Glimmer wondered *why* . " Micah was always so eager to learn, too. And of course I will teach you both, the darkness and the absorption. But first, let's see if you can absorb magic from other sources at all; that has... potential. And you are in luck; I have been absorbing magic from the Black Garnet for years. No other mage can do that. If you can do it, you will be the second after me. A power we share."

" Well, that's good, then!" Glimmer said with a smile. " Always wanted to be kind of special!"

And inside, as Shadow Weaver chuckled, Glimmer thought *teach me so that I may overcome you, and save my sister's life.*

Chapter End Notes

The Council of the Wise was an actual faction from He-Man; I'm mostly using the name, as otherwise there's no real connection here.

Chapter 16: Princess Entrapta of Dryl

Chapter Notes

Content Warning: Suicidal Ideation, Lack of Self-Care that kind of translates into Self-Harm of the neglectful variety, and some Damn Bad Headspaces.

This is a sad one, ya'll. Not as dark as Catra's revelations to her family, but this is a deeply sad chapter.

Entrapta is in a bad mental place right now; a broken heart and guilty mind do not a happy person make.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Princess Entrapta of Dryl

She woke up from another dreamless sleep, aided by chemicals. The most unexpected benefit of her return to the good- well, lukewarm- graces of the Alliance; there was a mixture from Plumeria, something sweet and kind of blackberry tasting, mingled with a kind of chamomile tea. You could drink, and it would grant you dreamless sleep. Perfuma had said it was called cool crash in the letter she sent along with the mixture, which had also included instructions for making it drinkable.

Entrapta had asked Perfuma for help by letter, not because she expected her to be able to help, but because Perfuma was the only person left in all the Rebellion that Entrapta had felt comfortable asking for *anything.* She knew how she must be seen

by the others- the traitor, the unpunished enemy, the maker of the robot army that had hounded them for years of war.

(How many Rebels suffer what she suffers now, because one of her robots killed their loved ones? How many people has she hurt? How can they do anything *but* hate her?)

She knew that they must see her only as the widow of their greatest enemy, come limping home with a lame excuse; but for Angella and Catra, none would tolerate her.

But Angella and Catra had kept their last promise to *him* , and proven to be women of their word; they had defended her to the rest of the Alliance. Behind the shield of their honor, Entrapta was safe.

It was why she had not asked either of them for help. She owed too much to the great queen and her equally great daughter as it stood.

So she had asked for help from Perfuma, who was the one Princess Entrapta thought might be sympathetic. She had asked for something that would let her sleep *despite* her dreams, but Perfuma had outperformed all expectations, as was somehow becoming the norm for her; could that be normal, to outperform? Could it become the standard you expected of someone, that they would do so much more than you expected, could it be regular to be exceptional?

Entrapta doesn't believe so, but every time Entrapta has had dealings with Perfuma since her return, Perfuma had impressed her. Each time, the Princess of the Heart-Blossom had somehow gone above and beyond what Entrapta expected. More talented, more skilled, and above all things, more forgiving.

(Two statues, when none were expected; two monuments of honor for the dead, where one might expect only a dance on the grave of a hated enemy. Oh yes, if forgiveness be a virtue than Perfuma is a saint...)

Perfuma was an outlier, not unlike *him* , not unlike Entrapta herself was, once upon a time, before all her hurt broke her heart.

(she has lost *him* and all her dreams have spilled like blood from her skull)

And so, because Perfuma sent it, her sweet gift did its work and did it better than Entrapta could have asked for. The main use of the drug, according to Perfuma's long writings on the matter, was to keep one from having nightmares; Entrapta had enjoyed reading her Plumerian penpal's long diatribe about the mixture's history, it reminded her of how *he* and her had once had long talks about science and mathematics and all the other things that fit in their heads and no one else's.

Entrapta surmised that Perfuma's letter was correct; Entrapta was totally sure that the mixture was good for stopping nightmares.

But that wasn't what she needed it for. After all, the dreams she took the mix to avoid were pleasant.

It was the waking up afterwards that had been killing her.

(*He* is alive, in those dreams; *he* is alive, they are together, they are *happy,* and then... she wakes.)

No. Too much. Reliving the loss of *him* every morning had... she had been barely holding it together as it was. She would not have lasted a month of that. She had spent the week waiting for Perfuma's reply downing the hardiest coffees Dryl could produce and desperately, desperately keeping herself awake, long past the point at which the hallucinations had started, and they'd been as bad as sweet dreams or worse.

But now, waking did not torment her, and she did not fear her bed anymore. She woke up, having no pleasant dreams, and was as rested as she could get. She woke slowly, blinking the grit from her eyes, rubbing a dirty hand across her face before swapping to a slightly cleaner side; she hadn't... when was the last time she'd showered?

No, that didn't matter. Just... time taken from the one goal she had left. Didn't matter.

What mattered was her revenge.

Adora.

The thought of that hated name punched a burning hole right through what was left of her sleep, woke her up entirely. She breathed deep, and took stock. She was curled up in a tight little ball on her bed, keeping safe in the coils of her body and hair the most precious thing she'd kept from the Fright Zone, and the sight of him calmed all of her furious, shattered heart.

" Hey, little Imp," she said, to her precious treasure, waking him up gently.

The failed clone blinked a few times before looking up, and he gave her a big grin and a cute chirp. She nuzzled and hugged him tight, listening to his happy burbles. Her little Imp, who had the last vestiges of *his* voice inside.

This wasn't a bad way to wake up. She was warm in the bed, and hugging the last thing of *his* that she had left, a little piece she could keep.

(*like a son* , some part of her thought, *a son* ***he*** *left behind*)

It was nice. It would be nice, to lay here, forever. That's what the afterlife was supposed to be, according to Dryl's faith anyway; one perfect moment, forever. That's what the books she had said, anyway, though Entrapta couldn't claim she was an expert on the subject; she'd only started recently, had combed the Crypto Castle's archives only in the months since the Portal.

Where one ended up after death was a topic of considerable concern to her now, after all.

(She knew where her journey ended: death by fire if it failed... and... death if it succeeded, too, though she had not settled on a method yet. There were no roads home, not for her. Not anymore. But maybe he was waiting there, on the other side...)

Not that anyone knew. There was a lot of theorizing, but Entrapta found that her people's oldest thoughts were a comfort; a perfect moment, forever. Poets had pondered it, what their own personal moments might look like; one had painted a picture with his words of a happy second when his wife came home, framed beautiful and perfect in the light coming in through the doorway; others said the first time they held their children in their arms. Hearing a lover say "I love you too"; other, more esoteric things.

She liked the idea of a perfect moment, forever. One you could never get bored of, or ever wanted to leave; peace at last.

That wasn't so bad.

(*him* and her, in the lab, working; ever learning, ever in that moment of experiment, forever, Imp and Scorpia both nearby and alive... that would not be so bad, not at all.)

...But regardless of what awaited her, sweet oblivion and the peaceful dark or a perfect moment or even the hellfire so many feared, she wasn't dead yet, and the work awaited.

How had one poet put it? Lovely woods, dark and deep, but promises to keep. Something like that. She'd read more poetry in the last few months than in all her life prior, searching for answers

that there was no math for, and some of it had comforted her, a little bit, which made it all worth it.

It wasn't that different from what she'd done before. It was all still data, still numbers, in a way. This well-made line added to this one, until the result was a fine poem; another equation to be computed, no different than calculus. Just a different kind of math.

Not all of it had been useful. But there had been data, still, and some of it had... some of it had helped.

And she'd liked that one. The woods were lovely, dark and deep, but she had promises to keep.

(One promise, to herself; that she would kill **Adora.**)

With that thought in her head, Entrapta managed to rise up, lifting herself on her single great mass of hair, balanced like a cobra rising to its full height. High up off the bed, to the very ceiling, to deposit little Imp in the rafters he liked to play in. He thanked her with a chipper squeak before scampering off to observe Shadow Weaver and Glimmer. He'd gotten used to observing others in the Fright Zone, and so far he'd been wonderful at keeping quiet tabs on her fellow conspiracy members... though not much had come of it. So far Shadow Weaver had not been sneaky or deceptive in any way that Entrapta cared about. So long as she assisted her with her great task, of killing **Adora**, Shadow Weaver could play all the games she wanted.

As for Glimmer, w ell, Entrapta didn't really understand people that well, and vice versa; but the day *Glimmer,* who seemed to be mostly uppercuts and razzle-dazzle, tried being sneaky was the day Entrapta would shave herself bald.

So down, on her own two feet again, shrugging as she debated shambling into clothes, not caring what she'd wear so long as it kept her from being naked, and that mostly because she didn't like being naked. She'd taken to repairing her clothes with what she had on hand, which was how part of a Horde flag had gotten turned into a sleeve on the set of rags she'd discarded the night before at her bed's foot. Clothing wasn't important, unless she was working on something she needed protection from; in those situations she'd put on something better, but otherwise?

It didn't matter. Just time spent not getting her revenge, not making **Adora** *pay*.

...But...

Wait.

Wait.

Wait.

Today they were starting the expedition to Beast Island... and that meant stopping by in Plumeria, first. A few other places as well, but none of them stood out like the land of flowers in her mind. There were two statues there, after all, and her mind turned to them, turned to Catra's words in the Fright Zone, before the Portal, before the ending, before...

Before.

They had been the most unexpected kindnesses, and from an unexpected source. Perfuma, whom Entrapta had known only as someone who had been irritated by her presence in that long-ago, ill-fated raid on the Fright Zone, that battle that had led to... everything.

(Her joy and her failures both; *him...* and her defection. She cannot imagine what she would be, if the First Raid on the Fright Zone- as history would call it- had happened differently... but... maybe she'd be happier. She could not lose *him,* after all, if they had never met.)

Perfuma, who had spent all that raid keeping her in line, keeping her focused, grabbing her roughly with big vines whenever she went haring off to stare at tech, and who had been frustrated past her peaceful exterior. Perfuma, who had not been a friend beforehand, whom Entrapta had barely interacted with.

Perfuma, who had remembered her, who had honored Hordak, who had sent her the drink that gave her sleep, who of all the Princesses in the Alliance might be alone in, perhaps, forgiving her.

She knew she did not deserve it, knew it in her *bones,* knew it the way she knew math and science and her own tastes in poetry. 1+1=2, $e=mc^2$, rhyming poems were her favorites and Entrapta did not deserve Perfuma's generosity. She couldn't, not after all she'd done.

But still Perfuma had given it anyway.

Maybe...

Maybe for Perfuma, Entrapta could spend a little time cleaning up. Make herself look presentable, make herself look... okay. She could make an effort, for her, though she doubted it would be noticed. She deserved no more great charities from the beautiful lady of forests and flowers.

But she'd feel better, to dress up a bit, to show her best side- or whatever had to pass for it- to this woman who had been so good to her and *him* .

If nothing else, maybe if Entrapta looked good, Perfuma would not feel like she'd wasted her charity.

(Right? Was that how people thought? That sounded right, but she has guessed wrong so many times before...)

Thus hoping that she had chosen right, Entrapta crawled to the shower, where she checked her biggest organ first, her hair. She was surprised to see how bad it was, split ends and old oil stains and cracked cuticles. Had she taken so little care of herself? Her hair was her hands, her most important physical asset...

But after a moment, the surprise faded. Of course she had. It was... so hard, to work up the energy, most days. To work up the care. Save for revenge on **Adora** , Entrapta couldn't think of anything that gave her the energy to get up in the morning. Not since *his* death and her realization of all she'd done had tainted her love of science and machinery, tainted it with loss and horror and guilt. She was under such a burden that without a good reason, she could not work up the strength.

...But Perfuma was a good reason. She didn't want to disappoint Perfuma, didn't want her to see her and wish she'd retracted her kindnesses, didn't want her to believe she'd wasted her sweet gifts.

That would be awful and cruel of her, especially considering she didn't deserve them in the first place.

(She regrets her betrayal, she is sorry, inside, but the words don't work, she doesn't know what to say; never had, and that was when she was new, innocent, unscarred by love and loss both, without sin. Now? What should she say? They wouldn't listen anyway, people *never* listen to her, and now they have an actual reason not to do so; who is she to them, but maker of killers? How many people have suffered like she has, losing those they loved; she cannot forgive **Adora** , how can she ask these others she has hurt in the same way to forgive her? *)*

And that thought gave her the strength to set about fixing herself. Her bathroom was a great nestlike thing, with lots of room for her hair, and multiple showerheads she'd designed herself scattered throughout so that she could wash all the great mass of her mane at once. On the walls were bottle after bottle of shampoos and conditioners and gels and all the things that she'd used when she lived here, still sitting and waiting now that their mistress was returned from across the continent. With her own two hands, she got the first few bottles down, and began to repair herself.

It took a long time. Not as long as some had joked, on seeing her great mass of hair, given that it was mobile and could assist with its own cleansing... but a long time nonetheless. She washed, and cleansed; restored, and hydrated. The water ran almost black at times, as machine grease and other, less identifiable things that had dripped into her locks was carried out and down the drain. Her fingers wrinkled as she worked, massaging her tresses back to life, and the soothing low heat of her shower sank down, deep into her bones, releasing knots of tension she hadn't even realized she had.

It was... nice.

After that, she took some time with her loofa over her flesh, finding sores and bruises she didn't remember acquiring. How long had she ignored herself? This was just bad practice; one should always maintain one's tools, and the body was the mind's first and most useful tool, the one it had to use to interact with all the others.

She'd forgotten that, at some point in her grief, and took the time to dry herself carefully and salve her wounds. She couldn't let

herself fall apart until her revenge was achieved; after, yes, but not before. Promises to keep, after all, and she had promised herself revenge.

With that done, feeling refreshed- and not a little bit more alive- the time came to dress. She slithered to her closet on her clean mane, and looked inside, finding the same few sets of garments that she liked wearing. She wasn't as picky with clothes as with food, but she still felt... ill... wearing anything other than a few sets that she liked together.

She'd also lost one of those sets; the outfit she'd worn at the Horde... she couldn't wear it anymore. Hurt too much.

But she had a few others to look at, and debated what to put on. Maybe... just a cleaner version of what she'd already been wearing? Workman's overalls and a heavy duty shirt and boots and gloves. Worker's clothes. Good for engineering in. Bad for scientific research but great for the hands-on part of science, for applying it.

She wondered if Plumerians thought overalls were improper for such a meeting. Perhaps if her parents had survived, she would know which outfit to wear, what would make the best impression, but... they had not lived. Entrapta had been raised by a pair of robots her parents had built, a just-in-case creation that had proven to be a wise precaution when just-that-case happened. The robots had tended her and taught her, but they hadn't entirely been finished when her parents died, and there had been areas, like fashion and the culture of other nations, where they were... lacking.

She wished her parents weren't dead. She hadn't gotten to know them, not really, except when it was later, when she found all their old notes and had to reconstruct who they were after the fact. These things she knew: they had loved her. They had loved each other. They had loved science.

This too she knew: they had died at their own hands. Not on purpose. An accident in their experiment. Entrapta sympathized; that was how she'd have died, too, to a failed experiment, save that kind Catra's Best Friend Squad had shown up to save her, alongside her three former retainers.

She ignored the part of her that whispered *maybe that would have been better.*

(Loneliness was easy- or at least easier- when she had no other options, when she had not... known... that there was another way to be. The poets are wrong in this much; having loved and lost is *much* worse than never having loved at all.)

So, with no knowledge, of her set of a dozen or so outfits, she grabbed a copy of the rags she'd peeled off of herself before her shower, save that it was in better repair.

As she shrugged them on, she glanced over at where they lay at the foot of her bed, and realized that she'd spent far too much time in that specific set of clothes; they were beyond repair at this point. She'd be lucky to get more than a few oil rags out of them. The overalls had lost a strap, the boots were mismatched and one had a hole, the gloves were mostly theoretical at this point (and

also mismatched), and the shirt was mostly stains along with missing both sleeves. She'd pressganged a heavy chain into service for the missing strap and stapled a sleeve out of an old Horde flag, one of several she had taken from the Fright Zone during her escape.

The sight made her pause. A Horde flag. Her long hair crawled the distance betweeen her and her rags and pulled the shirt out of the mess, turning it over to look at it. The flag wasn't so tattered as the rest of the outfit, having been the last thing she added during her too-long stay in the outfit; less grimy, less unclean. A Horde flag, but an old style one now, it lacked the little squiggle spouting flame that marked **Adora's** theft of one of *his* symbols.

The old colors and the old emblem of the only person that Entrapta of Dryl, strangest of Princesses, had ever loved, the person she'd connected with so strong that it formed a line on a graph that only they shared...

But *he* is deleted and gone, and she is a singular point again. Unique.

Alone.

But she can keep something with her.

When her new boots matched, her overalls had two straps, her shirt had no stains and her gloves were clean and new (and also

matched), she took the time to gently clean the old flag, and with scissors and a few moment's sewing, replaced her right sleeve with it.

She'd keep it with her.

After that, there was just her welder's mask- still burned and broken from her last battle with **Adora** - and she was set to go.

Before she left her private chambers- a fancy name for the rooms she slept in more often than not, when she wasn't crashing where she stood at some workbench or another- she went over to a monitor and checked the progress of her great work.

The rewiring of the Crypto Castle was almost done. Almost ready, to receive the enormous power Entrapta would siphon off of the Heart; just a fraction of the built-up energies, but it would be enough to do what she needed doing. The entire Crypto Castle, rewired to serve as a battery for Entrapta's magnum opus...

She checked that project, too. Her robot servants had to build an entirely new hangar, just to house it. An entire new hangar, and all the Crypto Castle rewired, a new aerial transport built that could handle its bulk, and so many new things; new weapons, new support robots to accompany the deadly war machine, all kinds of wonders that Entrapta would once have delighted in creating, and now approached with an eye only on the goal.

But she had to admit, maybe the poets had rubbed off on her. She couldn't help but feel that there was a kind of... poetic justice in her chosen instrument of vengeance.

Slumbering peacefully under her cameras, her shell steadily built by robot servitors, the reborn Emily was being rebuilt. **Adora** had smashed her favorite robot to pieces in their last fight in the Fright Zone, a death only Entrapta noticed or mourned... but that was the nice part about robots.

If they were broken, you could just rebuild them.

(Unlike people. Unlike *him* .)

Emily, small as she was, quirky as she was, had tried to save her creator from the Dragon's wrath, and Entrapta would honor that courage. Emily would fight **Adora** one more time.

But this time?

It would not be Emily shattered on the floor.

A vicious, poisonous smile moved Entrapta's lips before she slithered out of the room, heading for her transport.

-

They got started late due to Entrapta's shower, but within the hour, the three members of Shadow Weaver's erstwhile Council of the Wise were aboard her aerial transport, a great big beast of a zeppelin Entrapta had built since her return from the Fright Zone. They were in the air, course set for Plumeria.

Entrapta *could* build a transport that would go straight to Beast Island, but she had better places to allocate those resources. Emily's shell wasn't quite done, for one thing, and she was short of many things, with the rewiring of the Castle demanding more tech than she'd ever needed before.

Compounding that problem was geography. Dryl was located to the northwest of Brightmoon, up in the mountains that started to make up the jagged coast that led to the Troll territories and other, wilder lands; Beast Island was located far, far to the east, past the Crimson Waste, past Horde territory and out in the deep waters of the Growling Sea that even Salineas rarely patrolled. It was quite a distance, particularly for aerial transports, which were mostly scavenged, malfunctioning First Ones tech.

So a transport this size was easier to build with her limited resources with a few compromises that meant it needed to stop a few times. Plumeria, then Salineas, to pick up fuel and supplies before finally hitting Beast Island proper, then hitting those same stops on the way back.

They'd set it all up beforehand with Perfuma and Mermista, claiming they were grabbing resources for the Great Rebellion (which was even technically true, depending on how you saw it.)

Perfuma had agreed cheerfully, Mermista with some grumbling; Mermista had backed up Catra without question when the Princess of Power and her mother Queen Angella had been arguing for Entrapta to be allowed back into the Alliance, but that was apparently as far as her benevolence had extended. Still, Entrapta was paying in useful metals that Salineas, metal-poor, needed for the war effort, so the saltwater witch had finally acquiesced.

(Entrapta was not angry about that. To support her return without punishment was more than she deserved.)

Since the machine was self-piloting, the trio had nothing to do except their own personal projects. Shadow Weaver and Glimmer were going over a book of magic, while Entrapta, mask on, took the time to work on a few scattered ideas she'd had for improving the new Emily, mostly in the micro-factories she was equipping the mighty machine with. Perhaps some battle tanks and a few variant weapons it could produce? She was fighting a Horde, after all, so it behooved her to have a Horde of her own.

(Some part of her idly realized while she worked that she was now a betrayer twice over; she betrayed the Alliance and was now betraying the Horde. No wonder people hate her, and refuse to let her get close; she stabs them in the back, every time...)

At some point, Glimmer and Shadow Weaver took a break, and while Glimmer was popping a tiny cake in her mouth (she'd made sure to include an onboard automatic kitchen), the punchy princess asked Entrapta a question.

" So why did you build this big old... doom balloon?" she asked.

Entrapta turned to Glimmer, though she left her mask down. She didn't really want to talk, and hadn't been close with Glimmer, even before she'd joined her enemies.

" It's a transport," Entrapta said. " Needed it to get to Beast Island. Need it to move Emily."

" Yeah, but like... why not... well, why the doom balloon?" Glimmer asked. " Most flyers I've seen are, you know, planes. Or one helicopter I saw once."

" Zeppelins are good for moving big objects," Entrapta said. " I had plans for other plane-like flyers, but they couldn't carry Emily. The only ones I kept were some of the unmanned drones I designed."

They had been workable, whereas the Annihilator and Glonders she'd designed were too resource-intensive for too little advantage. Before, she wouldn't have cared, had not had the practical bent to her mind... but before, she hadn't had a goal other than love of creation. The tiny, bat-shaped drones had a good mix of *cheap* and *usable* .

" Can I see them?" Glimmer asked, and Entrapta, despite herself, had a strange urge to keep the conversation going, to interact with another person.

" Sure," she said, a bit reluctantly. She tapped her mask, which she'd never repaired from the damage it had taken... but she had upgraded it. One of the new devices she'd added in the lenses had a hologram projector she'd jury-rigged off of some First Ones' tech Glimmer had directed her to- her very first contribution to the Cuncil of the Wise. An abandoned Rebellion outpost called Alwyn, which the Princess had visited early on in Glimmer's adventures with Catra. Something about First Ones' ghosts in the area turning out to be old signals.

The outpost had been rebuilt, but they hadn't done much with the tech, and Entrapta had scavenged all of it for her own ends.

Those ends apparently included showing Glimmer- and Shadow Weaver, who took a silent but noted interest- what she'd been working on. Entrapta flicked through a few designs, trying to reach the drones; a saw-toothed version of the tanks she'd built, a scavenging dozer for swift acquisition of resources, and the underwater crawdad-based drones she'd mocked up just in case she needed to deal with sea warfare. Most wouldn't be used, but she would prefer to have them and not need them, rather than the other way around.

Eventually, though, she found the flying drones she'd made.

" These are the mechs I made," Entrapta said, and couldn't help a feeling of excitement. She still did love designing things, somewhere underneath all her hurt, and Glimmer seemed interested, which was... nice. Nice enough that she kept talking. " They pack a decent laser weapon and good engines, though no armor."

“ They're cute!” Glimmer said, which wasn't exactly what Entrapta was expecting to hear.

“ ...Thank you,” Entrapta said. Maybe having Glimmer wouldn't be so bad. She was more chipper company than Shadow Weaver, at any rate.

Glimmer kept observing them, then pursed her lips in thought.

“ Huh, these little batmechs kinda look like the Horde symbol,” Glimmer said. “ Well, the old one, before Adora added that little fire-breathing squiggle in the middle.”

“ ...They do,” Entrapta said after a moment to study them again herself, smile sliding off of her face. Huh. She hadn't done that on purpose, but then again, some part of her was always thinking about *him* .

Actually, as Entrapta went back through the catalog of her robot designs, she noticed a *lot* of them had features reminiscent of the classic Horde symbol, or little flourishes that were not unlike *his* face, albeit in the abstract medium of machinery. She had known she wasn't in the best of mindsets when designing, but she hadn't realized...

“ That'll make fighting Adora's Horde kinda funny,” Glimmer said. “ Like the old Horde against the new.”

That sounded nice.

That sounded *more* than nice.

“ Yes, it will,” Entrapta said, and smiled under her mask.

Shadow Weaver, who'd been listening, spoke up- distracting Glimmer with something about magic- but even so, Entrapta was still smiling when they pulled up to Plumeria's capital.

-

Plumeria was... beautiful.

Completely different from Dryl, or the few villages that populated Entrapta's sparsely populated land. Maybe it was because, unlike Dryl, Plumeria had a real Princess; tradition meant Dryl's leaders were *named* Princesses, like most nations save Brightmoon, but the Crypto Castle had never had a Runestone of its own. Even natural Princesses- the random one-offs the world spat out from time to time, like Spinnerella and her wife Netossa- had been rare in Dryl's history.

The produce of its mines and its minds, those were Dryl's only natural resources, and it lent their construction and architecture a strongly practical, functional bent. Even the Crypto Castle, where they let their artistic side out, had been designed as a labyrinth of traps first and foremost. Rough, square silhouettes, squat defensive walls, the sharp angles of mineshafts and the regular outlines of railroad tracks, that was Dryl in a nutshell. Entrapta didn't mind it, not really, save that sometimes it reminded her of the Fright Zone, of how *his* Horde had done things, and it made her ache inside for a place that no longer existed.

But Plumeria awakened no such uncomfortable thoughts. Plumeria didn't look like anywhere Entrapta had ever been before, not even Brightmoon. Brightmoon was delicate and flowing arches, true, but there were strong and solid blocks there, too, a place where form and function held equal sway; practical designs, overlaid with art, each enhancing the other.

But Plumeria... Plumeria was beautiful, the entire land was a blossoming rose, spreading out beneath her as she looked out the window in the cargo bay. From the center stem of the Heart-Blossom Tree, the Runestone on which all Plumeria depended, a city of tents and yurts spread out, out, out, in overlapping rings, curving gently over each other. Fields of flowers grew in places kept fallow between them, and from above the effect was not unlike a gallery of paintings, the fields great portraits of beautiful art.

Even the people were dressed in splendour; crowns of those same flowers adorned many brows, next to flowing script, bright ink tattooed on skin. A wash of colors on the few clothes the citizens wore, mostly cloaks and shorts- this was southern Etheria, it was hot here- and while the colors were more subdued than the

artificial things Entrapta could whip up in a dye vat, they were more natural, more alive for it. Entrapta could paint her machines many colors, but none of them would ever be arrayed like one of these.

It was... beautiful. All the sprawl of Plumeria was a dizzying array of colors and art, round and soft and sweet as a pregnant belly, and Entrapta found it one of the prettiest sights she'd ever seen.

It was so pretty that she looked over it again, interested in something besides her revenge for the first time in too long. That second glance made her realize that the pregnancy metaphor was even more apt than she'd first thought; everything here was full of hidden import. Everywhere she looked, there was something she'd missed, some hidden beauty she hadn't seen the first time, just waiting to be seen. The trees that grew amidst the city were part of it, as much as the artificial parts; ladders dripped from branches, trunks served as walls of a home, and they were bedecked as the beloved members of the community they were, jewelry and art dangling from every bough.

A third look showed that this magnificent rose of many colors had its thorns, too. Scattered throughout the many tents of this vast city were spiraling buildings that her goggles, once zoomed in, revealed to be weapon storehouses; the war had left its mark here, as it had everywhere else. Stocked armories, and training grounds, with a few training even despite her blimp's approach; a great many swords, mostly, and great swords at that, big two-handed weapons.

Even the smallest glance revealed why they favored swords here- everywhere, everywhere was She-Ra, in every type of art this city

of creators could make. They were about evenly split between depictions in the old, classic designs of Catra's predecessor that had reigned for centuries, and newer ones, that showed that heroine herself, new designs that showed the tiger stripes of her greater self, her tail behind her. They were portrayed in scenes ranging from the reverent to the fantastic; here Catra lifting a tank high over her head, there the classic She-Ra knighting some ancient hero of Plumeria. There Catra, standing at the center of a multitude of Princesses, though all were indistinct save the one that was clearly Perfuma; a rainbow poured forth from them.

(Entrapta remembered *that* battle well enough, and quickly looked away; it had been her plan that blackened the skies at Brightmoon, until such time as Catra restored the light.)

And in each picture, the Sword, larger than life, was held by the She-Ra, shining and shining.

Entrapta wondered how they'd react if they knew the truth, the truth Light Hope had revealed to her when she hacked into her systems in the Crystal Castle, the truth that had led her to the Heart of Etheria and all this.

(*a weapon,* Light Hope had told her, and Entrapta had thought of how lucky she was; it was a weapon she was hunting, after all, a weapon mighty enough to slay a Dragon)

...But she couldn't tell them. That would be monstrous. Let them have their joy. Let them... let them be happy. It wouldn't matter once she killed **Adora** and freed Plumeria from the threat that was steadily burning its way towards them.

She hadn't really considered the benefit to the Alliance when she made her promise to herself, but now... now she was glad that it would help these people. Something like this should be preserved, not cast into the flames.

(And definitely not by **Adora** , who had already removed something beautiful from the world- something precious in Entrapta's eyes.)

Her vessel continued its slow approach to the meeting place, a small flat field outside of the Heart-Blossom Tree, where Perfuma traditionally greeted air transports. She'd explained it all in her letter. The people of Plumeria were watching them, most heads upturned to see their approach, and there were so many of them, so many people. Families and children in impossible numbers; Entrapta had known that Plumeria was the most populated of all the Kingdoms, but she hadn't put it together until just now what that actually meant.

And all of them were looking at her, excited and entranced by the arrival of her transport, as it finally, slowly coasted to a stop, floating over the field of their meeting.

Entrapted supposed that the... Doom Balloon really did make quite a sight.

...She should have named it, but she hadn't, and now she couldn't think of something that wasn't Glimmer's offhand comment.

(She used to name everything, but now she just... couldn't work up the energy most days.)

She'd be going down alone. As Shadow Weaver had insisted, with Glimmer curiously joining in, they didn't want anyone knowing they were here right now. Shadow Weaver had claimed that she didn't think Queen Angella would appreciate her daughter going somewhere as dangerous as Beast Island just to recover a corpse.

And a corpse it would almost certainly be. Entrapta hoped that Scorpia lived- she had been her first friend, after all, the two bonding with each other in the face of Adora's contempt for Scorpia- but she tried to be realistic. No one survived Beast Island, not for long.

But she'd find her friend's body, or anything that was left, and she'd give it a proper burial, take care of her in the only way she could... and use her genetic markers to get revenge on her killer.

It wasn't just *him* she was avenging, after all.

(And somewhere far away, Scorpia suddenly thought of Entrapta, and wondered how she was doing, as she watched over Micah as he fitfully slept under the safety of a spell; thought of her, and hoped her friend was okay, even as she had a sense of dread that said she was not.)

So Entrapta would do this alone. Easy enough to do. As Princess of Dryl, she had the right to entreat with Perfuma, and it wasn't like anyone was going to go look aboard the Doom Balloon as it hovered in the sky.

With their destination reached, she sighed and stepped away from the window, crawling over to the transport pad on her long hair. Her two co-conspirators were here to see her off, Shadow Weaver standing calm and sinister, Glimmer next to her in a cheerful soldier's parade rest, big grin on her face. Entrapta knew they weren't friends, but she was so isolated now that even this token gesture of consideration felt... nice.

She should probably say something. She pondered what to say before Shadow Weaver intervened and spared her the trouble.

" Do be careful," Shadow Weaver said, as Entrapta put a hand on the lever that would activate the lift. " Don't answer any questions about our goals or where we're going beyond Salineas. This is just a resource-gathering trip, as far as they know."

" That's even technically true!" Glimmer said with that big grin on her face, and Shadow Weaver chuckled.

" It is, though not in any way they'd expect," the monstrous thing said to her apprentice.

" True," Glimmer said with a sigh. " Though I hate to miss the food. Plumerian food's good!"

" It is a shame to stay up here," Shadow Weaver admitted. " I'd love to see the flowers."

Even Entrapta raised an eyebrow at that, unseen; Glimmer's raised eyebrow was visible enough for two, thankfully.

" Really?" Glimmer said. " I thought you gardened at Brightmoon just to mess with people."

" Not *only* ," Shadow Weaver said with a genuine laugh. " I actually do like flowers. Unbalancing all of my visitors was just an amusing bonus."

" You learn something every day," Glimmer said with a shake of her head as Shadow Weaver turned back to Entrapta.

" Regardless, stay we must, and for the same reason you must keep quiet. We don't want anyone to know what we're doing, not yet. I don't want Queen Angella or anyone else getting the bright idea to put a stop to our plans before we're ready," the nightmare enchantress said. " Presenting it as a fait accompli will make it much easier to get them to go along with it, despite any objections they might raise out of misguided moral concerns."

" Yep!" Glimmer agreed cheerfully, grin returning. " Be a shame for all our plans to be interrupted!"

Entrapta paused a moment, looking at her. Something about Glimmer was... off, some tiny, subtle thing that she couldn't name

or identify, something wrong.

Unbidden, some part of Entrapta's mind reminded her that in nature, bright colors usually meant poison; and Glimmer was so bright, wasn't she? An urge struck her, to warn Shadow Weaver, who was near Glimmer all the time.

(*in striking distance* , that same part of her mind whispered, *close enough for a knife in the back* , and wouldn't Entrapta know, given all her betrayals?)

But...

Entrapta had been wrong about people so many times before. Probably just another mistake. It was Glimmer. She wasn't the type to have any secrets. Shadow Weaver clearly hadn't noticed anything, had never indicated she had, so it must just be Entrapta getting it wrong, the way she always did.

So she ignored that quibble in her heart, that urge to warn Shadow Weaver, and simply lowered her mask and put a hand on the lever to lower herself down.

She should... probably say something in response, but she didn't know what to say, she never had. Something, though, she had to spit something out, her nerves all a'jangling up and down her back as she stood in front of the two people who were now, by dint of being present, the closest equivalent to friends that she had.

“ You know the schedule,” she told the others, finally falling back on the most basic things she could think of. This was easier in the Fright Zone, this was easier before all of her loss weighed on her back. “ I'll remember what you've said. I'll... I'll be back.”

Stupid, pointless, stupid, she shouldn't have said anything, but Glimmer gave a big smile and a big wave, so it had to be the right thing, somehow? Maybe?

She hit the switch before she could screw it up anymore.

Chapter End Notes

Notes:

I have variously spelled Entrapta's nation as Dryl or Dryll, but apparently the official spelling is Dryl, so I'm trying to be more consistent from this point on with it.

Also, Entrapta being raised by robots is based entirely on a photo from her first episode that is almost *certainly* a joke, but I am a fanfic writer, and so I have went for the SADDEST POSSIBLE INTERPRETATION of those events.

Further fun fact: of the main Princesses, the only one with either parent still alive is actually Mermista. Frosta's parents died in a Kingdom of Snows political spat (assassinated for wanting to get involved in the Horde/Alliance war by pro-isolationist factions), Perfuma's fathers died of disease when she was fairly young, and Glimmer thinks her dad is dead (he's not, obviously, but she thinks he is.) Mermista's parents are both doing fine, but neither had a connection to the Runestone- they're solidly middle class merchants of spice. They help her from behind the scenes, though Salineas being

a constitutional democracy means that Mermista also does less direct ruling than you might expect. To some extent, Salineas treats the Princess role as a combination of military leader (due to combat power) and judiciary (many cases are often brought before them as a final judge), rather than as a direct ruler in the manner of Brightmoon (which does have the excuse that Angella is the single best politician in the world, because she's old as dirt and invented a lot of modern practices.)

Ironically for her incredibly dry personality and general sarcasm, Mermista is in many ways the single most well-adjusted person in the entire Alliance.

Final notes: All of Entrapta's designs are based on Horde equipment from the original She-Ra series of the 80s, which is also where Glimmer's nicknames for all the equipment (Doom Balloon, Batmechs) come from. Even the designs Entrapta didn't use- the Annihilator, etc.- and the maybe-designs for a rainy day- like the robot lobsters, which have the adorable name of Clawdads in the original cartoon- are from the old series.

When Glimmer suggests that it's the old Horde battling the new, she's much more accurate- and more meta- than she knows.

The one exception is what she's turned Emily into. That's an original creation, though in my head I call it Emily's Big Sister in reflection of the Emily's Kid Sister bots from SPOP canon. Entrapta would never consider it that way, always thinking of it as just Emily, but that's what I think of it as.

Chapter 17: The Sword of the She-Ra

Chapter Notes

A small diversion, detailing Catra's leaving the Crystal Castle, before we return to the DOOM BALLOON (I cannot tell you how happy that name makes me.)

The Sword of the She-Ra

Catra didn't ride back with Swift Wind. She took the scooter that Razz had committed grand theft auto on, riding the tiny repulsor-based hovercraft back, Swift Wind up above guiding her back home. She had to return it, after all, and it had been a convenient excuse to be alone with her thoughts.

She had a lot to think on, after all.

Her Sword was... evil.

But no, no! She'd done so much good with it, saved so many lives. She was a hero, and all because she'd found the Sword.

...but it was a weapon. A fuse. A way to turn all of Etheria into the biggest bomb ever built. To kill worlds, other places, that Catra had never seen, in a universe she had never been in...

...But it was *the Sword*. The Sword that changed her, transformed her, made her She-Ra and not just Catra, the Sword that had chosen *her* over Adora, the first thing of real value in all her life that had been hers first, and not a hand-me-down of Adora's that Shadow Weaver deigned to let her have once the golden child was done with it. Catra had chosen her heroics, had chosen the terrible sweetness of happiness and good, but the Sword had chosen her first, and she just...

She just couldn't bring herself to hate it, or fear it. Or throw it away.

(*Of course I can't,* some part of her, more rational than her heart, thought glumly. *I can't let go of Shadow Weaver or Adora either, why would I be able to let go of the Sword?*)

But maybe that could work out. The Sword was the trigger, so all she had to do was... not use it, right? Deal with Light Hope- somehow, maybe Entrapta had an idea- then turn off the bomb that all of Etheria was apparently sitting on top of, and the Sword was back to being good. The Sword would be holy, again. If it never did harm, then it was not evil, you couldn't blame someone for something they *might* do.

Fuck, she'd almost chosen Shadow Weaver, all those years ago. That didn't mean she should be held responsible for anything she might have done working for the Horde.

The Sword was good, still. If she fixed this, it would *never* be evil. She could keep it, this Sword, that had let her do so much good, that had turned a Horde outcast into a Brightmoon princess. She *owed* it, to the Sword, owed it to try.

Though she dreaded the inevitable explanations she'd have to give. Particularly to Perfuma, whose people loved the She-Ra so much.

(Though hadn't Razz suggested that She-Ra was not a sword? What had she meant? So much of what Razz had said passed over Catra's head, but there had been that idea...)

Sighing, Catra followed Swift Wind to Brightmoon, and when she got there, went to her mother, to tell her what she'd found out.

(And the Sword, sitting at her side, waited, trusting Catra to do the right thing when the time came.)

Chapter 18: Shadow Weaver of Herself Alone

Chapter Notes

TW: Shadow Weaver.

Seriously, she's a monster.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shadow Weaver of Herself Alone

Shadow Weaver watched as Entrapta descended on the lift, the wind momentarily blowing into the cargo bay before the repulsor lift cleared it and a forcefield based on First Ones technology popped over the now open hole in the bottom of the zeppelin.

What *fascinating* talent Entrapta had with old technology. A shame she'd kill herself once Adora was dead; Shadow Weaver wouldn't mind having such talent on tap. She'd make a wonderful patron if she lived... but Shadow Weaver had a good instinct for when someone was going to self-destruct, and Entrapta had all the signs of a living bomb.

" So, what's up next?" Glimmer said, and Shadow Weaver turned to her.

While Entrapta may not be suitable, Shadow Weaver gloated in her mind, *it's not like I don't already have a replacement lined up.*

“ We head to the practice room,” Shadow Weaver said aloud. “ We've not much to do while Entrapta is busy, so we might as well study more.”

“ Excellent!” Glimmer said with a grin. “ After you!”

Shadow Weaver gave an indulgent smile that none could see as she led the way, letting Glimmer follow at her back. Such a good student. So eager to learn! A surprise; the witch had thought she'd understood Glimmer, and was a bit surprised at the punky princess' enthusiasm for study.

But then again, she was her father's child. Casual snooping at Brightmoon had told her that Queen Angella, at least, regarded her daughter as taking after Micah, but the old shade-beast hadn't realized just how accurate the angel had been. While Glimmer took after her mother in looks and somewhat in magical nature, she was otherwise much more like her father, nearly Micah reborn.

And that was... rather pleasing, to some old and dessicated part of the monster, a part she considered as she and Glimmer moved through the tight hallways of the flying vessel, the walls smooth and featureless, Entrapta having built with an eye towards function alone. She was... glad, to see Micah again, even if in the funhouse mirror of his daughter's personality. Something from before the spell, when light was her favored material.

Though there were other, more practical, reasons to be delighted with Glimmer as an apprentice. Beyond her obvious virtues, Glimmer's flaws were terribly useful; her ego, combined with her fragility, would be useful enough, but combine it with a certain heroic brashness and reluctance to plan ahead? Ah, what a perfect tool, almost crafted to her hand.

One of her wards had tried to kill her, the other had slipped out of her grasp, but third time was the charm, as she'd heard someone say.

Of course, she'd have to kill Angella to make it work, which would be the tricky part. Queen Angella was *dangerous*. Just look at how she'd ensnared Catra! The Queen had expertly manipulated the She-Ra's current host into being Brightmoon's guardian, a move that had protected Angella's powerbase for almost half a decade now. And all she had to do was file a paper, and let Catra call her a few meaningless words! Incredible.

If Shadow Weaver wasn't so infuriated by the specifics of the stunt- and that it was at her expense- she'd have admired it. She'd have to be careful when she struck down the moonwinged royal... very careful. It had to be done in such a way that she escaped all blame, preferably by shifting blame onto one of the other Princesses- or maybe Entrapta, if she was dead by that time, and thus unable to protest.

Maybe she'd wait until the Horde died before she made her move. With the Horde dead- and it surely would die once Adora was slain, it had barely survived the death of *one* leader- the Alliance would inevitably fragment. One thing that had been forgotten since the Horde took over as the local villain was that the nations

of Etheria had not always been at peace; with the Horde no longer a going concern, there'd be no reason for more selfish motives not to dominate. She would wait until Brightmoon had an enemy, then kill Angella in such a way that the blame fell on whoever crossed Brightmoon first...

With the Queen dead, her daughter, already Shadow Weaver's apprentice, would ascend to the throne, and she would have a useful, powerful patron to let her continue her work in peace.

It'd even have side benefits. Killing Angella would also make dealing with Catra much simpler. Angella's death would wreck the child; she put so much stock on her "adoption." She did not see it for the trick that it was.

With her "mother" dead, Catar would enter a spiral of emotions that would make her weak. If Shadow Weaver was *very* lucky, she'd even kill herself in grief, though that wasn't likely. The Sword might even find a new host, one who would prove more... tractable.

Still, that was a best case scenario, a fantasy, a longshot. The *sure* bet was that the Queen's death would destroy Catra inside, and while she was falling apart Shadow Weaver could move right back in. The night witch would be able to influence her again, and keep her under control.

She even knew what to do with her. She'd need to get rid of her somehow; maybe she'd send her out to punish the nation that

had killed the Queen, all without knowing that the *real* murderer was the one sending her on her missions!

Yes, that... that felt right. The irony, the *delight* she felt, at the idea of making Catra kill those she blamed for Angella, all at the behest of her mother's real killer. Oh yes. That was perfect.

It fulfilled all her goals. It hurt Catra, and it kept Catra separated from the other Princesses in the aftermath of the Brightmoon monarch's death; if she stayed, her nature as She-Ra guaranteed that she'd accumulate political power. If she did, she'd threaten Glimmer's status, and Shadow Weaver wouldn't ride the coattails of an inferior power.

Yes... perfect.

They reached the training room in due time, and Shadow Weaver graciously held the door open to let Glimmer in. The girl's grin grew wider at that, as the abyssal had known it would. Glimmer was so *hungry* for praise, so eager for acknowledgment. It wasn't hard to stroke her ego a bit, even with such small and meaningless things.

Glimmer entered the practice room, and Shadow Weaver followed behind her soon-to-be-Queen protege, closign the door behidn her. The practice room was a small sealed area with a long cabinet of magical reagants along one wall, an open area for casting larger spells, a small mat for physical exercise, and a few tables for inscribing runes or mixing ingredients. Nothing like one of Entrapta's labs back at the Crypto Castle, but it was a

testament to Entrapta's whirl-a-gig genius that she'd managed to scrape together enough room for even a small practice room aboard the... Doom Balloon.

(*Dammit, Glimmer* , Shadow Weaver thought. “Doom Balloon” just sounded so *undignified* , but it was all she could think of now.)

“ Do your stretches and beginner exercises,” Shadow Weaver instructed. “ I'll gather ingredients and review my spells while you're doing that.”

“ Okay!” Glimmer said without a word of complaint, immediately heading to the mat to work out. Shadow Weaver popped open a book, but wasn't really reading it; the spell she was about to cast was very basic, after all.

Instead, she pondered Entrapta again as she looked the room over. Such a shame she had a short shelf life. Entrapta was a lovely patron, whose anger and single-minded focus made her totally uncaring regarding whatever Shadow Weaver did. Even her bursts of rage were manageable.

Albeit they *were* frightening, as Shadow Weaver would reluctantly admit. Adora's fury- which the witch had only seen for what it was when the ungrateful brat had thrown her in a cell- was constant, constant and consistent, like the blazing suns she'd read about in the oldest books of Mystacor's oldest library, a blazing sense of self. It lurked in everything the girl, now woman, did.

The witch's own fault for missing it, she'd admit. *Mea culpa* , as they said. She should have noticed it and nipped it in the bud, or at least, directed it at Hordak and not herself. Even for all Adora's apparently considerable talent and love for lying- just see how the Horde had eaten up all her bullshit and asked for more- Shadow Weaver had raised the new overlord; she should have known.

But Entrapta's anger was not like that. It was not hot, not precisely. Her anger was *shattering.* Entrapta's anger was like an earthquake. Usually the tech genius was calm, focused, and kind of quietly sad... but every now and then, she'd have an explosive outburst, a furious upswelling of anger that was sometimes triggered by being reminded of Adora and sometimes for no reason at all. Not constant, not consistent, just sporadic, but so *strong* , like a faultline finally releasing the tension of straining rocks.

And every time, it destroyed her, completely. She forgot herself, forgot everything except the hate. She was totally unable to handle it. Shadow Weaver suspected she knew the source of such difficulty; it wasn't Entrapta's general nature, she suspected, but something else. If she was right- and she'd been watching Entrapta quite closely- then Shadow Weaver privately suspected that Entrapta had never truly been angry before.

Oh, she'd had the usual frustrations or annoyances before, but nothing like this. The witch knew that Entrapta had lived a lonely life before she joined the Alliance, and Entrapta had been- before Hordak's death- a naturally exuberant and cheerful person. She'd been angry before, Shadow Weaver had no doubt, but it was in the small way of little troubles, nothing huge, nothing serious.

So now, her anger at the one who took her love away was too big for her, she didn't have the tools to process it. She didn't know what to *do* with her anger, and so when it became too strong, it opened a crack in the ground and swallowed her whole.

It was magnificent to see. Pain that caused more pain. Beautiful. Useful- aimed at someone Shadow Weaver wanted dead. It gave the witch hope that the Dryl princess actually *could* kill Shadow Weaver's wayward ward, who had so far survived everything anyone else had ever tried.

And once she was dead...

" Stretching done!" Glimmer said cheerfully, and Shadow Weaver gave an indulgent smile that the princess couldn't see. She closed her book, and approached the bright child, who as far as Shadow Weaver could see had *no idea* what Shadow Weaver intended for her.

" Good," Shadow Weaver said. " Today, we begin to see if you can drain magic like I can. But before we get there, we need to do the magical equivalent of a physical."

" I am not turning my head left and coughing," Glimmer said solemnly, and Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes in fond irritation (and briefly wondered what that looked like to Glimmer, given that the witch's hood had magic to hide her... unpleasant features.)

“ Your father made the exact same joke,” she said, which made Glimmer grin. “ It's good to know neither of you are funny.”

Her face fell, and Shadow Weaver chuckled; for all the punchy princess' overbearing ego, a *little* prodding was necessary, or Glimmer would get suspicious. People like Glimmer expected others to oppose them, and so a little low-level baiting was needed to make the rest of the manipulation believable; unrestrained decency towards them was the only route faster than outright malice to getting people like Glimmer to distrust you.

“ At any rate, the spell is a process often referred to as an influence check; it showcases what magic is acting on a spellcaster. Most sorcerers and sorceresses have no inner power to draw on, and rely on the ambient magic about them, as you already know; but a person's essence can be influenced by one of the Runestones or even by wild magic, and you need to know if you are balanced or leaning towards a magic before you start spellcasting. We are influenced by magic even when we cannot use it, after all, and knowing what is working on oneself is a valuable tool. Stray magic can upset or even change the entire nature of any spells cast.”

“ Won't I just show up as all Moonstone?” Glimmer asked.

“ No,” Shadow Weaver said. “ If you were *pure* Moonstone, you wouldn't have the necessary neutrality to cast any non-Moonstone magic at all. That heavy lean towards one Runestone is why a Princess can only ever use their element, and cannot become mages.”

“ So that's why Mom never became a sorceress,” Glimmer said, rubbing her chin. “ I always kind of wondered, since she's super old. Not like she wouldn't have had the time. And since I'm not a real Princess, I can still cast spells.”

“ I wouldn't say you were not a real Princess,” Shadow Weaver said. Some prodding was necessary, but it was also important to back the child up on anything that actually sounded *important.* A delicate dance, but one she was well-acquainted with. “ There is also the fact that you are aligned to the Moonstone, which is inherently the most neutral and balanced of the Runestones; it sits midway between light and darkness both. It is light gentled by darkness, and vice versa; it's never one thing or the other. Of all the magics, it is the least extreme, seeks a medium by its very nature. Perhaps that, combined with the talent for spellcasting you have clearly inherited from your father, is enough to make you the first spellcasting Princess.”

Glimmer grinned at that, as Shadow Weaver had known she would.

“ That's not so bad,” she said, before a thought occurred to her, frowning. “ Light gentled by darkness? Wow, you must hate that, with all your... shadow weaving. And stuff.”

“ Not really,” Shadow Weaver said. “ I used to spin light... the dark simply had a better return on investment once I had the Black Garnet in hand. I still know both magics. Which is good; it will be easier to teach you. I am the only person who *can* , I suspect.”

It didn't hurt to subtly reinforce how important she was to the princess whenever a handy opportunity presented itself.

" Good thing we're both here, then!" Glimmer said, before another thought occurred to her. She was apparently feeling thoughtful today. " Light and darkness... kinda odd the Black Garnet could affect it during the Battle of Brightmoon, then. Isn't it just darkness?"

" It is the Storm, so it is darkness and light too, but at their extremes," the witch said to the princess. " Rolling darkness and blistering lightning. As for battling its opposite, the Moonstone, its power was weakened compared to the other Runestones. That's why the Moonstone had to be attacked directly by Adora and her forces, it was the only one that could resist the Garnet to any degree. The Horde's trick with the Black Garnet didn't phase a portion of the Moonstone, and in fact, the Moonstone was holding it back; if it was destroyed, that would have spelled the end of the others, since they'd have fallen out of balance."

" Huh," Glimmer said. " I... what would even happen, then?"

" I do not know," Shadow Weaver said, wanting to move on from the topic... before a chance to get some more claws in occurred to her and she reversed course. " I'd like to state, for the record, that I was not involved in that event. That was all Adora's idea, along with Entrapta. I was in a jail cell during the attack."

" Really?" Glimmer asked, quirking an eyebrow. " Why?"

“ I opposed using the Black Garnet,” the witch answered. “ I thought it was too dangerous.”

Which was true. It was *way* too dangerous... for Shadow Weaver personally. She'd lost almost all her magic! If she hadn't been able to escape thanks to Scorpia's stupidity, she'd have died.

“ Huh, I didn't know that,” Glimmer said. “ Is that why you left them?”

“ I will not suffer betrayal,” Shadow Weaver said. *Also* a good lesson to reinforce when she could.

Glimmer shrugged.

“ I wouldn't either,” she said. “ So what's this influence check need me to do?”

“ Stand still, mostly,” Shadow Weaver said, as she turned and grabbed two prepared bottles of dust off the shelf. Dried and pulverized plant roots, ground-down grit from a glacier, lightning-scorched fragments of wood, particles of moon-blessed desert sand and salt from the sea; a balanced dust, connected to every one of the major Runestones. For the minor Runestones and the wild magics that had a Princess but no Runestone, she'd used a lesser amount of their materials- some ground cystral, windblown

detritus, cat fur, a variety of other things. She'd even tossed in some campfire ash for the Spirit Ember, though it was most likely sleeping still in Mount Candila.

" That's it?" Glimmer said, as Shadow Weaver tossed her one of the vials.

" Well, that, and agree to it," the witch clarified. " Your Moonstone connection will overwhelm any more subtle influences inside you, so we're going to need a more serious scan than is usually required- which requires you to agree to such a deep look at your aura."

" What all will you see?" Glimmer asked. Her voice was just a little more... cautious... than Shadow Weaver had expected, and the briefest- the briefest- flash of paranoia ran through Shadow Weaver's head, just a split second of warning.

But even a second's consideration made her dismiss it as totally unwarranted. It was *Glimmer* . She was letting her experiences with Adora color her interactions with a much less worrisome apprentice. She doubted the girl had a subtle bone in her body. No, this was probably her insecurities kicking up, the bit that Netossa had, accurately, diagnosed as crippling self-doubt.

(She'd been listening at that meeting through one of Entrapta's devices, and been delighted no one could hear her burst of surprised laughter in her Brightmoon garden.)

" Just your magical aura," Shadow Weaver assured, after the smallest of pauses., Her words were even true. Oh she *had* spells that could do more, of course. Scramble a mind, hide certain thoughts, overlay reality with lies- she even had one, her coup de grace, a spell that let her extinguish her physical form in return for making a go of possessing someone else. Not perfect- she could be banished, or bounce off the target's defenses, and would thus dissipate as a bodiless spirit- but she *did* have a spell for it, just in case. She'd always kept it as one of her last two "fuck you" spells, alongside one that would detonate her like a bomb.

If Shadow Weaver died, everyone *else* would pay for it.

They weren't easy to use. All of her mind-affecting spells were difficult to cast and needed lots of resources and prep time. Brains were resilient, and didn't much like being dominated; often they broke the conditioning if the spells weren't regularly applied, as Adora proved. The only one that was easy to cast, ironically, was the sacrifice; shedding one's body was price enough for that spell.

Still, she didn't require that much force today. She had no need to mess with Glimmer's brain, small as it was.

" Are you sure?" Glimmer asked, full of doubt.

" I will not have access to any of your thoughts. Just your magic," Shadow Weaver confirmed.

She didn't tell Glimmer that once given, the permission couldn't be retracted. No need to inform her of such a... trifling detail.

" Okay, then," Glimmer said cheerfully.

" Now, I will end up frozen for a few moments while my mind goes over your aura," the witch said. " Simply leave me be until it is done, and don't move from that spot. It should only take me a minute or two."

" Should I get a book?" Glimmer asked, and Shadow Weaver couldn't help the snort that escaped her. Just like Micah, indeed- he'd been restless, too.

" No, I'm afraid you'll just have to grin and bear it. Consider it training for patience."

" Ugh," Glimmer said, but shrugged. " Well, I'm ready. What do I do?"

" Cast in the same pattern I do," Shadow Weaver said. " A fairly basic pattern, well within your talents.

Glimmer nodded without that hesitation, and the witch laughed at herself in her head. No, she was just imagining things. No need to over-correct for past mistakes and make new ones. Glimmer wasn't smart enough to trick her.

She had this in the bag. She'd failed with Adora and hadn't even tried with Catra, but third time... third time was the charm.

(In Glimmer's head at that moment was the thought *I hope this isn't a mistake* , realizing she couldn't think of a way to say no that wouldn't blow her cover... and preparing to fight, should she feel her mind changing in any way.)

" Now hold still and follow me," Shadow Weaver said, cracking her vial open.

Shadow Weaver poured the dust into her palm, the mixture reacting to her magic and starting to glow. She dipped two fingers into the mix, and once dust clung like ink on a pen, she started to draw in the air, leaving blurring lines of black and purple, weaving the room's shadows into a tangible whole. Occasionally dipping her fingers back in the dust, she made her pattern, simple geometric shapes layered and layered and layered. A square, inside which she drew a triangle, inside which she drew a line, and finally, a circle, from four sides to three to two to a symbol for none, the most basic configuration of numbers in magic, a countdown.

No symbols of any Runestone, no, this drew only on the raw magic of Etheria itself, and in a very stable configuration. It was a setup that had little power, but much finesse... and was also mostly undetectable, keyed as it was to Etheria's background magical radiation instead of anything more noticeable. Even very, *very* good spellcasters had trouble noticing these kinds of spells. Not that Shadow Weaver needed the insurance, but no reason not to have it, just in case someone- like Adora- was actively scanning for spellcasting.

Glimmer did the same, copying her, her spells trailing purple-pink lights instead of purple-black darkness; eventually, the two spells mirrored, and Shadow Weaver was *in* .

She landed in a world lit up by a crescent moon, shining down on a pink-purple mist. The spell presented the aura so seen as a mythopoetic creation, rather like what a Plumerian artist might make while in the grip of one of that nation's staggering bounty of hallucinogens. The aura was a mish-mosh of the magics that made it up and some influence from the person, though the personal touches were usually fairly minimal. The Runestones had too much culture and history laid atop them to avoid drowning out any one person's nature, most of the time.

Glimmer's soul was basically what Shadow Weaver had expected. There were no defenses to stop her spell- and why would there be? She hadn't taught Glimmer any yet- so the area was open to her. A great circular mist of Moonstone energy made up about half of her, and the rest of her was fairly neutral, which in the spell's terms meant it appeared gray and dull, powered by no Runestone. The only personal touch were military banners, featureless and floating in the array, echoes of Glimmer's warrior spirit.

(And a strange sensation of things lurking beneath Shadow Weaver- but no, she looked and they were gone. Just more of her paranoia. Right?)

It was what she'd expected...

Save for one detail.

As she swam in the aura- and *wow* , Glimmer was strong, she'd seen potential in her but hadn't realized how big it was, how strong the bruiser could get, how much magic her aura could hold- the witch saw that a waterfall of mist was raining down from the moon... and on it, a statue?

She swam up, through the mist, seeking the source. When she came on it, it was a marble statue, in the shape of a featureless angel, the mist pouring from her hands.

Odd... but there was... a connection? She felt something more through this statue, something far away, something... no, some *one* ...

Shadow Weaver touched the statue, and found herself, to her stunned surprise, looking at someone *else's* aura.

This one... this one was *glorious* . If Glimmer had potential, this person's aura was that potential *realized* ; the witch almost drowned in raw magic. The witch sat on a crescent moon that had a statue of a small, squat girl on it; all around her impromptu seat were other moons, dancing in a circle, each with a statue of their own. A statue of a young woman with cat's ears and a cat's tail on another crescent, not in her greatness as the Princess of Power but just as herself; a statue of a man with a king's crown and a staff on a waning moon. Others, a whole bevy of them, whom Shadow Weaver could not name; the only one she caught a clear glimpse of was of a woman in robes, with fire dancing between her hands, on another waning moon.

What...?

She looked up, as mist rained down; above them was a great full moon, presiding over the celestial dance, pulsing like an ancient and infinite heart. The patterns of the craters on the moon made the shape of angel-winged shadows, and great defenses surrounded this gentle lunar orrery- defenses that would crush Shadow Weaver like a bug if she were to run into them, great swords of fire and lances of light, shields and fists of star-twinkled night, all guarding this secret garden. Layers and layers of defense.

But this impregnable fortress was built *around* the moons. All the guns pointed outside.

Shadow Weaver was safe. She was already in.

She was already in.

She was already in *Queen Angella's aura.*

That was who this was. It had to be. She took another glance at the statue she sat next to- only this statue, obviously Glimmer's, had the magical mist. Of course. Glimmer was the only child Angella had ever had, the only one connected to the Moonstone the way Angella was. The witch's research, back when she'd still

been Light Spinner, had suggested that Queen Angella was not human, was an elemental, and if that was true, then Glimmer wasn't really human either...

And it had left a hole in Angella's defenses. So long as Shadow Weaver had access to Glimmer... she could cast spells. She could... she could...

She drew a deep breath. She would... she'd have to think about this. What could she do? Influence Angella... why, yes, yes, *yes* . This would make killing her so much *easier* ...

Shadow Weaver smiled, as she tapped Glimmer's statue, guessing correctly that it would take her back. The connection, to the witch's pleasure, was still there.

Yes.

Yes.

This was just further proof that Glimmer was the *perfect* apprentice. Shadow Weaver dismissed all her worries. No, this was *perfect* . And it was about time, wasn't it? After all her bad luck, after having to raise ungrateful Catra alongside the child she'd actually wanted, after getting thrown out of the Horde and having to put up with Queen Angella's moralizing, it was about damn time she'd had a lucky break.

And what a lucky break it was.

She withdrew from the aura, and back to the real world.

" Finally!" Glimmer announced with irritation as she saw Shadow Weaver move. " You know how boring just standing here is? Been here for five minutes! I was losing it!"

Shadow Weaver chuckled, her mood so good that nothing could dent it.

" Well, it was worth it," she said. " Your aura looks... mostly like I thought it did. So let's move on. Let's teach you how to drain the magic out of things..."

" Finally!" Glimmer repeated. " The fun part of today's lessons!"

" Yes," Shadow Weaver said. " Today is a *good* day for learning."

And she smiled a smile none could see.

Chapter End Notes

If you are afraid of what the old witch might do... good.

That indicates you've been paying attention.

See you next time, in the half-light.

Chapter 19: Princess Entrapta of the Council of the Wise

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Princess Entrapta of the Council of the Wise

Down, down came the repulsor lift, separating smoothly from the zeppelin's cargo bay's floor in a single slab of squared metal. It floated down gently, its inhabitants- Entrapta and, under heavy tarp, Entrapta's part of her trade with Plumeria- protected by barely-visible purple forcefields, a haze in the air made out of scavenged First Ones' tech. The forcefields kept the wind from whipping Entrapta off the platform and into a fatal freefall, and even mostly silenced the dull roar of the huge crowd underneath her.

Which was good, because the crowd beneath her terrified her, made her want to flinch away. So many people to disappoint, so many people who must hate her, and a random fact from some book or another prodded at her like a pebble in her shoe- Plumeria had the largest population of any nation on Etheria, save perhaps the Horde, for whom solid numbers were impossible to find.

A quick glance over the side of the transport made it seem as if every single person of that vast population was down there, and Entrapta swiftly retreated back to the platform's center, to delay her encounter with them as long as possible.

She tried to focus on other things, as her breath started to come in faster. She tried to focus on what she was doing here. Trade. Trade, that's all this was. Her payment was of rare and precious metals from Dryl's mines, necessary for Plumeria, which traditionally had no real mining of its own. Rare and precious metals, and a few quality smithing tools, to help the once-pacifistic nation make weapons of war. In turn, she was receiving corn-derived ethanols she could refine aboard the blimp for fuel, as well as a variety of raw foodstuffs for the automated food processors aboard her transport. Plumeria had almost absurdly productive fields, especially compared to cold, dry, barren Dryl; Entrapta could have bought or taken all the foodstuffs she needed from Dryl's granaries, but her people lived only barely above starvation as it stood. She could not bear the idea of hurting her own people any more than she already had, not when she could buy from a nation of abundance for her own needs.

(She wasn't a very good Princess- was the worst of them, the least of that august company- but she could manage that much care, at least.)

After this, she'd trade much the same kind of goods, minus the smithing tools and adding a lot more metal, to Salineas. Salineas was very good at working metal already, but that was because they had to be; the coastal and island nation, which had no extensive land holdings, had few deposits of metal, and had learned to be talented with what little they had. Entrapta's gift would let them repair a lot of their more expensive vessels, and in return, they'd let her do the same in turn; she was getting scavenged tech from them in return, Horde tech that the pirates-turned-privateers of the seafaring nation had stolen from sunken Horde ships.

Those pieces, beyond allowing her to continue improving Emily and working on the connection to the Heart of Etheria at the

Crypto Castle, would also be useful if an emergency struck while they were en route to Beast Island. She didn't want to get halfway to Beast Island only to sink into the Growling Sea that surrounded it just because she had nothing to fix the blimp on hand.

It helped. Not a lot. A little bit. Only for a short while. All too soon the lift was halfway down and the crowd was so loud and how *slow* was the repulsor lift? Or was she thinking too fast, she needed something else to distract her, her breath was coming in short, sharp pants. So many people, all here to see her fail, all here for her to disappoint, to fail to connect with, reminding her of how alone she was...

She tried to think of other things again, but her mind just... circled. Before, she'd never have even noticed the crowd. She'd be too excited by the tech she was using, or the prospect of seeing the secrets of Beast Island, or something else, buoying her above the sea of social terror; but now, tech only made her think of *him* and it gave her no comfort. All she could think of was how they must see her, how they must hate her, how horrible she'd been with people all her life, and how lonely she was now that the gap between her and all the world had grown too large to be bridged at all. She'd never be able to fix it, she'd be alone from now until she finally died.

Before, this would have been a fun diversion. Before, she'd have been excited, happy.

Now?

Now she just wanted it to be over with. If it wasn't for her desire to see the two topiary statues Perfuma had made, and a smaller desire to see Perfuma herself, the tech geek would just have sent robots down.

Maybe she should go back up and do that anyway. She... she couldn't... she couldn't do this. She wanted to turn around, to crawl back into the ship, pretend none of this was happening. A strand of hair crawled up and tugged on her mask, already down over her face, making sure it was hiding her, the way she wanted to hide, to let the world pass her by until the day came to hunt **Adora** down and slay the Dragon in her lair.

…**Adora**.

The thought of her enemy woke up a **hatred** inside her that was so big, so solid, that it steadied her, made her forget the crowd entirely. Compared to the stone-cold **hate** in her guts, everything else seemed... smaller. Simpler.

Her breath slowed.

Adora. The sole reason she was still alive. Killing **her** was her sole reason for existing, now, and she had to keep that in mind. **Adora** lied to Entrapta and tricked her into becoming a monster, and while Entrapta would not deny that ultimate fault lay with her own self, she would never have come this way had the First One not fooled her in the first place. **Adora** had condemned her to this world with the flick of a switch, the pull of a lever, that killed *him*

and left Entrapta behind, alone, alone, alone, in a world where the closest thing she had to friends were two strangers on her airship.

Adora!

The woods were lovely, dark and deep, but she had miles to go before she could sleep. The crowd below was just another mile, on her way to whatever awaited her, in that fabled clearing at the end of the path. Perhaps she would be judged for her sins, and thrown into one of the many places of punishment promised by priests. Perhaps there was only oblivion, and she would rest in those deep, dark, lovely woods, and hurt no more.

And maybe- if she was very lucky, if some force in the universe chose to be kind- *he* would be there, and she would be happy again.

But first things first. Miles to go. Miles to go.

In the name of *Hordak* , whom she *loved* , she would kill **Adora** , whom she **hated** .

Her breath slowed to normal, no longer hissing in and out of her lungs, and her hair stopped shifting around her like a half-shed snake's skin. She felt... steadier. Weighted down, perhaps, was the right term; yes, that fit. With this mountain of enmity inside her, she could not go flying off into her self-perpetuating terrors,

could not be eaten by her anxieties like an ouroboros biting her own tail. She focused on that **hate** , and let it petrify all her pain.

She was at peace when the repulsor lift hit the ground, and she hit the lever that turned off the forcefields with a sure hand.

The crowd cheered as she landed, and cheered again when the forcefields dropped; drawing on some deep deposit of courage she didn't even know she had, the tech mistress managed to wave back at them, some of her perky self just the smallest bit restored. The crowd roared even louder in response, and she felt her spirit, steadied by her **hate** , perk up a little bit. Maybe Perfuma's people were as good as she was? Or, well, they probably weren't quite that grand- Perfuma, after all, had a habit of being exceptional, had made it normal to outperform all expectation- but maybe they were more like her than not, and a knot of tension in Entrapta's hair untangled itself at the idea.

The parcels she'd purchased were near her landing spot in two enormous piles, alongside a gaggle of cheerful, muscular, nearly-naked folk, who waved at her cheerfully; laborers, ready to offload her payment and load her purchases, if Entrapta had to guess. Entrapta waved back, and wondered if she should join them in discarding most clothing; the country was warm and humid, something made immediately obvious as soon as her forcefields went down, the air a bit like trying to breathe through a damp, steamed towel.

It was worse for Entrapta, who had dressed appropriately for dry, cold Dryl, and had not considered how far south she'd be going. The only saving grace she had was that it was late spring, not quite proper summer, and that saved her a great deal of suffering.

Only some of Salineas' southernmost areas were as hot as Plumeria in the dead of summer.

The crowd maintained a safe and respectful distance from Entrapta, save for the workers and Perfuma herself, who waited before the lift with a friendly smile on her lips, though her hands very, very slowly wrung each other. Entrapta wondered where her guards were; surely Plumeria didn't just let their Princess go about alone?... Especially given she was meeting a former Horde soldier- and not just any former Horde soldier, but their chief engineer. Weren't they worried for her? Was it traditional to meet without guards? That seemed dangerous. The Drylborn knew she had no intention of harming Perfuma- earth and stone, never, ever, would she hurt the woman- but her people had no way of knowing that.

Was it deliberate? Did Perfuma normally have guards, and she'd dismissed them to show that she did not consider the turncoat Princess of Dryl dangerous? Maybe Entrapta was reading too much into it. Maybe the guards were hidden, and if she did anything they deemed dangerous, they'd pop out of cover and crush her under their heel. Maybe erupt out of the ground, like plants bursting into sudden life. That was Plumeria's thing, wasn't it?

Too late, Entrapta remembered that she was probably making an odd face at Perfuma as she thought these thoughts. Earth and fucking stone, she was grateful her mask was on. It made all of this a lot easier, to not have to worry about what her face was doing. She had enough troubles.

Still clinging tight to the **hate** that kept her firm, Entrapta slithered forward on her hair alone, supporting herself on the long

strands, feeling the difference as she moved from flat, machined steel to the soft strands and delicate chaos of grass. It was harder to move on, gave more... but it did feel nice on her coiling locks.

" Greetings!" Perfuma said with a cheerful smile on her face, projecting her voice a great deal so that both Entrapta and the crowd could hear her over the crowd's own noise. " In the name of the She-Ra and the Princess Alliance, I welcome you to Plumeria, Princess Entrapta of Dryl!"

Thankfully, Entrapta knew how to respond to this particular piece of political theatre. Shadow Weaver had made sure to give her a crash course in Allied etiquette, just for occasions like this... albeit Entrapta thought Shadow Weaver's instruction had contained a little too sharp of an edge, had been a bit more contemptuous than the tech mistress would have preferred.

(It was weird, to think that Shadow Weaver was teaching her, when she'd taught **Adora**, it gave her a commonality with her enemy that she did not like to think about, she did not like wondering what the Dragon thought of Shadow Weaver's teaching style, even as she couldn't help pondering it anyway.)

" Greetings in turn," Entrapta said, momentarily forgetting to raise her voice so the crowd could hear her, too, fixing it only after she'd started. She gave a short bow, setting herself down for a moment so she could bend over properly. Plumerians were big on bowing, almost as big as the Kingdom of Snows, from whom they'd gotten the practice.

That, at least, Entrapta didn't need training for; Dryl, which bordered the westernmost reaches of the vast Snows, had also

adopted the habit from the northernmost kingdom. As she rose up, she finished the ritual greeting.

" In the name of the She-Ra and the Princess Alliance, I thank you for hosting me, Princess Perfuma of Plumeria."

That must have been the right thing to say; the crowd cheered again, though Entrapta doubted they really knew or cared what she said. Maybe they were just glad that Entrapta wasn't turning traitor again and attacking Perfuma with a buzzsaw.

(Not that any such attempt would work; the Princess of Plumeria was historically the strongest Princess besides the She-Ra herself, and entire armies had been involved in defeating them in centuries past.)

" We greet you with guest right," Perfuma said. " What can we do for our Ally?"

Again, Shadow Weaver's quick crash course in etiquette saved Entrapta from that most heinous of fates, small talk. There was a pattern to this, and Entrapta could follow along, even if the words felt strange on her tongue, like a mouthful of gravel, so different from her usual manner of speaking that they couldn't help but clump together like concrete in her throat.

...Okay, it was awful, and she hated how stilted it all was, how constraining, but she'd do what she had to. Just another mile to go.

“ I bring payment,” she finally managed to say, skipping a few of the formalities; not totally needed, but she could already hear Shadow Weaver's indrawn hiss of displeasure, even if she couldn't possibly have heard her, was probably with Glimmer training right now. “ As agreed upon, I have brought what you requested, and humbly ask that appropriate trade be conducted according to the laws of the Alliance.”

Gah. So much... silliness, when she just wanted to spit out common-sense truth. This smacked of Brightmoon and the Snows, all these little rules, so easy to get twisted up in the mind. Guest right, that mattered; trade, that mattered. Had to know you were allowed to stay and get the business of the day done.

But the rest of this? It felt pointless. She hated it. It didn't add up to anything except wasted time.

“ Of course!” Perfuma said, which wasn't in the script. Maybe Plumerians didn't care for the whole thing, just the important bits. “ As agreed upon.”

She clapped her hands twice, a noise barely heard over the gathering, but the sight of her doing it alone was enough to get the laborers moving, loading and offloading.

“ While they're busy, is there anything you need?” Perfuma asked. That was off-script, too, and Entrapta cheerfully chucked the rest of Shadow Weaver's teachings out of her skull for the moment.

“ I... would like to see your personal garden as soon as possible,” she said, before amending, “ if that's alright.”

She didn't want to intrude, after all; not in anyone's business, and most especially not in the kind flower girl's.

“ It's no trouble!” her hostess said, with a smile a bit too wide and a bit too nervous, even Entrapta could see that; but in front of all these people, the Drylborn could not bring herself to ask why Perfuma was so nervous in front of her own people. Entrapta was built wrong, and was far from home, and had hurt all these people besides; she had three good reasons for her nerves. What was going on with Perfuma? This was her home, she should be safe here.

“ Follow me!” Perfuma said, in that too-perky way, registering as off even to socially-inept Entrapta; with Perfuma already walking away, Entrapta went back to following her, winding after her like a snake on her hair. She'd always used her hair to move around, but ever since she'd stopped putting it into the two great twin-tails she used to sport, it was just... faster than her legs. Easier, too.

(Which was the same reason she'd stopped doing her hair up; it was just... too much effort, most days. Just a distraction, from the task at hand, from the last task she'd ever complete. Faster to just leave it loose like this.)

Entrapta followed behind Perfuma's steady pace as she wove through the organic clutter of her capital, the crowd dissipating now that the show was over. All around her, Plumeria blossomed

back to its normal schedule from the distraction, working and working, and she observed the goings-on with greater cheer than she'd thought she'd have.

(It was wonderful, what a good dose of **hate** could do for a person.)

Many of the tents and yurts she passed contained great gaggles of children and protective adults, but an equal number contained the makings of an army. Apothecaries prepared mixtures of plants, or tested them on willing subjects, the smoke from some of them so strong that just being near it made the teetotaler Drylborn feel a little light-headed. She wondered what they were for; berserker fury, perhaps? She had read of poultices that numbed all pain, and others that made the body burn adrenaline twice as fast... it would make for deadly warriors, drugged up on such things.

In other tents, the wounded were being tended, the mixtures there killing pain and sealing wounds; from the smell, a lot of honey in those mixtures. Not a bad idea... good for burns, and a general antibiotic. She couldn't identify the other things being used, though; Dryl was a land of few plants, the mountainous steppe home mostly to hardy survivalist grasses like winterweed. The things being ground in mortars and pestles here, or boiled in cauldrons, or pickled in bottles... those probably only existed in the Whispering Woods.

Warriors were marked by skilled artists with concoction-stained ink in runic patterns, incarnating blessings in the form of tattoos; a dangerous practice, one outlawed for centuries in Dryl and most other lands. Entrapta marveled at that, at this display she'd only read about in books of ancient history. Didn't they know? It was

dangerous, to pattern runes on the skin, to concentrate that much magic in the flesh... so much that could go wrong, so much harm it could do in later years as the skin stretched and the tattoo's magic warped with it. Didn't they know?

Maybe not... but seeing one woman flex and laugh through the pain of a rune searing itself into existence as the artist finished, seeing the cheerfully determined looks on so many faces, Entrapta thought that maybe they did, and considered it fair trade for the boons provided.

She even passed a few forges, though they wouldn't have rated the name in Dryl proper. No blast furnaces here, nothing so advanced as even those basic devices; no, these were bloomeries, the most ancient of all methods of iron production, spitting smoke into the air as they slowly separated good iron from useless slag. One smith she passed was pulling the bloom they were named for out of the bottom of one of the squat little clay furnaces, and it was bedecked with useless grit in a sawblade pattern; right before she passed him, she saw the older man knocking the worthless parts off with a small hammer.

Entrapta was entranced. Such a primitive form of metalworking! Seeing it was like being kicked backwards in time. But there were a lot of the little bloomeries, and they were slapping the iron into the shape of blades as soon as they could, the forges near them beating the newly-cleaned iron into the shape of great two-handed claymores. None of it was work that Dryl would find acceptable or suitable, but it would do the job regardless. She saw apothecaries testing mixtures on the blades, too- clinging, muddy mixtures they spread just past the leading edges. She didn't recognize any of the plants used, but the gloves they all wore,

and the care they took not to touch the mixtures with bare skin, said the material was poison.

Envenomed swords, used en masse... a nasty tactic indeed. It wasn't like the Woods didn't have a huge variety of poisonous plant life, and a mash made of all of them would be almost impossible to make an antidote for. Fascinating!

She knew Plumeria had not been warriors for a long, long time... what a fascinating social experiment this was! They were clearly mining their own past for inspiration, going back to old ways of warfare, the most barbarian of actions. Some of these traditions predated all but the very oldest nations- earth and stone, this was interesting!

Every moment brought some new strange thing, some new interesting thing, and for the first time in weeks, Entrapta forgot some of the awful sorrow that weighed down on her, and felt that old excitement once again. Plumeria was so... so different... a nice change of pace.

Hmm. The Woods really were lovely, dark and deep. This wasn't as bad as she'd feared aboard the lift. No, this was actually kind of... good.

The thought brought a smile to her face. Cheerful for the first time in far too long, she slithered along behind Perfuma, finally reaching the first royal guards she'd seen, a pair of tall and strapping youths with coated claymores, decorated in runes of protection and power that seemed to be turning their skin into

something not unlike bark. They stood guard at the entrance to another first- stonework, whose artificial lines and lack of corrosion marked it as being of First Ones make.

(First Ones... **Adora** ... another thing that buoyed her over her despair, a glare to go with her smile, this magnificent **hate**)

" Thank you for your service," Perfuma said, giving them a deep bow, deeper than would be expected from a royal to a soldier, " You may go free. Do ask my staff to get the refreshments I requested brought here, if you would?"

" Of course, my lady," one rumbled for answer, the two heading off at her command- though one glanced at Entrapta with obvious skepticism in his eyes. She didn't begrudge him the distrust; she'd done more than enough to justify it.

" Good!" Perfuma said, turning to Entrapta with a grin that wasn't so wide, was a lot more natural, now that they were far away from anyone else. " I hope the food and drink meet your expectations. I asked some of the others for help- Frosta said you liked tiny food?"

Huh. She must have asked the staff who served Entrapta at the Princess Prom, which felt like another life now. A warm feeling spread over Entrapta's cheeks at the effort Perfuma had put in.

" I do," Entrapta said. " I... you didn't have to do anything for me, Perfuma. You've already done so much."

“ Nonsense,” Perfuma said. “ You're a friend. It's the least I could do.”

...Of course. Perfuma, for whom it was normal to be exceptional. Entrapta gently snorted.

“ Thank you,” she said.

“ Think nothing of it!” the flower girl said. “ But while they're getting them, let's head on in!”

Invited by the woman, the serpent slithered into the garden after her.

Chapter End Notes

> I have thought so fucking much about the way these nations go to war.
>
> Fun fact: for a huge chunk of the war, the Rebellion was kept alive pretty much entirely by individual volunteers who basically said “fuck my rulers, I'm going to go fight the Horde.” A vast proportion of these people are also runaways, refugees, and surviving soldiers from already fallen kingdoms who have managed to regroup in the territory remaining to the Alliance. Because so much of the Woods is unmapped- and because the Whispering Woods are the biggest non-ocean geographical features on Etheria- they tend to reside there in small warcamps. Extra fun fact: the Woods' natural magic leans towards chaos and darkness, and so the area is

both nearly unmappable and likes to hide people from anyone seeking them out. Seriously, the Woods are a big reason why the Horde is having trouble.

This bizarre anarchist militia call themselves Rebels- capital intended- since most of them were not actually officially backed by their own governments. (They get touchy whenever others call themselves rebels.) The Rebels are the source of the soldiers that Catra used in Chapter Five. This system still makes up a small majority of the reborn Princess Alliance's forces, but ever since Catra beat the Horde at the Battle of Brightmoon, the remaining nations have been much more seriously committing to defeating the Horde.

There is some friction there; the proper Rebels who never gave up the fight tend to consider the Allied armies that have finally joined in as either vultures or opportunists and always as cowards, though the need to beat the Horde keeps infighting to a minimum. After the war... well. Entire new nations have had their genesis in such thoughts.

The Rebel warcamps are too varied to summarize, save that they all tend, by virtue of natural selection after years of warfare with no support, to be by and large made up of badasses. Bow is a good example of a “standard” Rebel, though he's a badass even by the warcamp standards; no special powers, no inherent gifts, just whatever skills they've got and a willingness to fight, and a little magic- a big chunk of Mystacor went Rebel- ironically, a path Light Spinner actually considered taking- so there are a few mages among them.

Bow's also famous among them as one of their great heroes; Bow is extremely popular with those who never gave up the fight. Netossa and Spinnerella are the other two big heroes of the Rebels. They also think fondly of Catra as the She-Ra, since she turned the war from an inevitable loss into something they might be able to win. She's also one of Bow's best friends, so she never has trouble getting Rebels to help

her; the thought process is "help the She-Ra, help Bow, and fight the Horde? Sign me the fuck up!"

As for the Alliance outside of Plumeria...

Salineas has a very small land army and it's pretty much entirely marines from their navy, which is why they mostly do short-term amphibious work. Salineas' territory is pretty much all coastline and islands; it's the biggest nation in Etheria in terms of sheer distance covered, though ninety percent of it is open ocean. In terms of actual *land* owned, it's the smallest. Salineas' navy is far and away the main waterborne force the Alliance has, but considering that Salineas in this timeline has basically beaten the hell out of the Horde's own fleets, the Alliance doesn't really need any other.

Dryl is a small kingdom, but has the best metalwork of any nation, with only Salineas as competition. Tiny tech capitals of the world.

Brightmoon and the Kingdom of Snows have the most "normal" militaries, being combined arms forces not entirely dissimilar to early Renaissance armies. Brightmoon relies heavily on spellcasting while the Kingdom of Snows relies heavily on massive cavalry (they have mammoths). In terms of land area, the Snows is the biggest single Kingdom, even bigger than the Horde; it dominates the north of Etheria's lone continent. Brightmoon is comfortably in the middle in terms of area and population both.

The two have fought more wars with each other than anyone else; a not-insignifcant proportion of Angella's life has been spent fending off armies from Snows, and Frosta's initial reluctance to join the Alliance was as much distrust of Brightmoon as it was anything else. The two are the biggest sources of land troops for the Alliance as a whole.

There are well over a dozen minor nations in the Alliance who have no Princess to represent them, like the Troll kingdom;

they all contribute what they can, but for the most part their contributions bleed into the Rebel warcamps rather than forming full regiments of their own.

When the Crimson Waste started sending troops after Huntara and Tung Lashor took it over, they mostly filtered into the Rebels as well, alongside deliveries of First Ones tech in exchange for food.

Chapter 20: Force Captain Lonnie of the Dragon's Horde

Chapter Notes

Another chapter, this time about the Horde!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Force Captain Lonnie of the Dragon's Horde

The times, they were a'changing, and Lonnie wasn't sure it was in a good way.

She sat at her desk, alone. Her office- a new room near Lord Adora's living quarters that the Horde's engineers and architects had built for Lonnie- was a fairly spartan thing, which fit with her tastes. A desk that held a monitor and a keyboard, a big filing cabinet, and two chairs, folded up in the corner when not in use. A simple place where she could do her work without being disturbed.

But right now, she *was* disturbed, and wasn't getting any work done. Instead, she just stared at her monitor, looking over the information on Hordak's private network- now Adora's- the gathered intelligence of all the Horde. A brief glitch, a flash of blue, flickered through it, and Lonnie smacked it offhandedly. That had been happening more and more lately; the tech guys said they thought it was something Entrapta had left behind, as it had started with her tech. Something about it receiving a signal from

elsewhere, though the engineer swore up and down they were chasing it down.

Just another fucking problem, but one that solved itself soon enough; her monitor stopped glitching, and Lonnie went back to her work. This was the tech department's problem; Lonnie had to focus on something bigger.

Adora.

Adora had come back, and she'd had a hell of a special guest aboard the Horde cargo skiff she'd taken. A cargo skiff, which was different from the scout skiff that Adora had taken with Catra three years ago- almost four, now- but still... it was close enough that it unsettled Lonnie. When Adora and Catra came back from that first joyride, Adora had been mostly the same, but Catra had been... *different.* Some of it was just old traits being exaggerated- she was even more sullen, even more distracted, even worse at obeying orders- but there had been... something. Something in her eyes, a strange kind of flickering, like distant lightning in a big storm, something far off only Catra could see... and the way her hands clenched, sometimes, and moved, fidgeted in ways that Catra had never done before, unconsciously hunting something to hold onto.

(Hunting the hilt of a Sword, as Lonnie knew now.)

It didn't help that the similarities between the two trips didn't end there. The first was a stolen joyride, and this one had been... well, Adora owned the Horde, it was all her own stuff now, but shutting Lonnie off right after she'd ranted at her and taking off anyway still *felt* like a joyride.

So in the present, when Adora came back from another trip on a skiff, changed, Lonnie could not help but compare the aftermath to that long-ago event that had dictated so much of the war... and she did not like what she was seeing.

Adora had come back *different* . Not just in the obvious way, in the way that there was a *heat* rolling off of her now, in the sheer *power* that seemed to boil off of her skin in waves almost physical. Not just in the fact she was a *Princess* now, Adora was calling it something else but a woman with a connection to a Runestone was a Princess, there were no ifs, ands, or buts to that statement. Adora had come back with a Runestone, and had access to its power.

She was a Princess. Different from Scorpia, who had no Runestone, who was a Princess only in name; Adora was the real deal, and Lonnie was *terrified* of that.

But if that was it, it wouldn't have been so bad. Adora the Princess, unchanged, would have... Lonnie would have been *uncomfortable,* she wouldn't lie about that, but she'd have accepted it. More power to the Horde, after all.

But no... Adora was different in other ways, too. The Dragon had come back changed. It wasn't quite the same way Catra had been, but even the blush of similarity made Lonnie's hackles rise. Adora had changed, and come back... different. Some of it was in obvious ways; she seemed happier, less angry, and she didn't laugh as often- or at least, she didn't laugh *that* laugh, the jagged and wicked thing that would come sawing out of her mouth, ever

since her first journey to the Crimson Waste, all those months ago.

And that was good... but... other things were less good. She kept calling the Spirit Ember *sister* , that was so... that was so fucking unsettling. *Sister* , she called her, *my sister in sin* , and that sounded a *lot* like the sawblade laughter, that sounded a lot like... like trouble. Sister, she called a thing that was not alive, that she had dragged back from some godforsaken hellspot- and Lonnie could admit she was *still* mad that Adora, *the most important person in the Horde* , had taken off by herself! Hordak at least had stayed somewhere safe! If Adora had run into a Princess out there...

And worse, the Spirit Ember was dangerous. Adora had explained it to them, had said that an accident had led the Runestone to wipe out its former nation. Lonnie did not think that a Runestone so dangerous should be allowed anywhere near the Horde. She felt like that was kind of self-explanatory.

Adora had designed a fail-safe, a way to dump the Spirit Ember into the ocean if “her sister should start acting up”- fuck, that was so *creepy.* Like the Runestone was a misbehaving child, not a weapon that could destroy the entire Horde. Lonnie shivered.

She also doubted that the failsafe was going to be all that valuable, especially considering that Adora had *also* immediately come up with plans to power the entire Horde with the Spirit Ember's flames. She'd even debated moving the Black Garnet and replacing it with her “sister”, and while Lonnie wasn't a scientist or a mage, she felt like you didn't have to be to know that moving one of the Runestones was probably a *bad* idea.

(Wasn't that thing hooked up to the whole planet? She remembered the Battle of Brightmoon- the desperate pitched fight, one last battle in the dark to try and end the reign of the Princesses forever- and she remembered some of Entrapta's running commentary on the matter.)

...What the hell had *happened* to the Lord of the Horde, out there in the scorched ruins of a fallen kingdom? She'd said other things, about a ghost, a last princess of fire,she'd brought back *bones* that she'd buried like a Hordesman, there was...

It was too much. Too *wrong.* Whose bones were those? Why bury them with the noble dead? Adora had tried to explain it to them before just shaking her head, and giving her a list of names, names to be written down as predecessors to the flame. What...

What had happened? Adora had changed. Changed... so much.

And that dovetailed with some other thoughts Lonnie had been thinking for a long time, and she'd spent the last two days studying all that they knew about the Princesses, about their Kingdoms, about the other nations of Etheria, hunting evidence for this worry in her heart.

The sum of all her fears was this:

Who said it was Adora who came back?

Lonnie had a theory, one she'd never shared with anyone. It wasn't an important thing, not when she'd thought of it. She'd spent some time, once she got promoted after Adora's ascension, just... reviewing. Looking things over. It hadn't been important when she'd came up with it, not relevant to the Horde.

But now...

She ran her thumb over the wheel of the computer trackball, scrolling down the list. The Runestones, their Princesses, and their associated Kingdoms, scrolling past her, a list of what the Horde knew. Mostly practical things, with links to in-depth analysis and other files... but it was the short list of notes on their societies that drew her eye.

There wasn't much there. Hordak had never put much stock in the cultures of the nations he conquered; they would be discarded anyway, brought into what Hordak called, in his own notes, his brother's light. They were ruled by children gifted powers beyond their comprehension; it didn't really matter what they were like. That was wrong all by itself.

(Right? And yet, some part of Lonnie whispered quietly that something was wrong, that she wasn't looking into this as deeply as she should... though soon, her worries for Adora and her loyalty to the Horde crushed those worries flat. It didn't matter if she wasn't *quite* right. The Horde- and Adora- demanded action.)

But one trait had stuck out to Lonnie. A notable trait of those nations were how far their histories went back, and how much

they *hadn't* changed in the meantime. And wasn't that odd? Sure, the Horde was a young nation as far as Etheria went, but it had changed so much even in the short time Lonnie had been alive. She'd been raised as a soldier under Hordak, now to serve under Lord Adora, his erstwhile successor, seen so much change...

The idea of a place that just... stayed the same... for century upon century, it rankled, it did not make sense.

She passed them, and moved on to the smaller nations. Places that had no Runestone, that settled into the spaces between the great Kingdoms, well over a dozen, each with their own histories and cultures and peoples. The Princess-bearing Kingdoms called them the Crownless, collectively, a neutral-to-insulting term, and one that Lonnie identified with strongly as a Hordesman. *Fuck Princesses* , as the common Horde trooper had said since the war began.

(And now Adora was a Princess, and... Lonnie did not like to think of that.)

The Crownless, of course, argued against the title, though over the centuries they'd accepted it- most begrudgingly, some with tremendous pride. Minor nations, none very large, none very powerful, but present, and so *different* , so full of change even in the short notes that Hordak had considered important enough to write down... though Hordak's own notes said he'd investigated them more thoroughly in hopes of converting them. He'd never planned to do such to the Kingdoms, judging their magic as "too far outside my brother's light", whatever that meant.

(Who was this brother? Lonnie didn't know, but she had the strangest dream the night she'd first read that, of a green light...

as of a distant thing glimpsed briefly... and a sensation of permanence that she had longed for and feared both.)

So here, in just in the few scrolls of a trackball, Lonnie saw the histories of many peoples. Here a collection of the smallest citystates, that had united less than a hundred years ago into the Phlax Federation; here, Galacia, who had fought the Kingdom of Snows before being absorbed into them peacefully and then, later, successfully revolting against too-high taxes and too-much conscription, now independent again. Here the Twin Kingdom of Condore and Highpoint, united by a Lunoth under a constitutional monarchy and two Kings; here the westernmost coastline, along the Sea of Demons, and its mess of competing citystates, that had evolved or coalesced or fragmented, time and time again.

This made sense, this worked, this *fit* to Lonnie, it felt more real than eternal kingdoms and immortal angel-queens. These were nations of *people.* They changed, they lived, they died, they grew. They were people.

(People whom the Horde would one day absorb... but... no, focus on the Princesses, don't think about what the Horde would do to those nations.)

But the Kingdoms? They stayed the same. Never *changed* , at least, not as far as Lonnie's intelligence said... and that was what had made her theory pop up in her head.

The genesis of the theory was this observation: Princesses changed, all the time. One died, and another was chosen, save in Brightmoon, which had an immortal for the Princess (though they called her Queen for some reason.)

So given that different people were the Princesses, it didn't make sense that these nations had been so much the same, in their history. Each Princess should have left their mark, and really, they should leave an *outsized* mark; who could stop them? What imposition on their power would any Princess accept? What imposition could they be *forced* to accept? They were untouchable teenage gods. Even a lawmaker who wanted to curb them would find that ink on paper could not stop a being who was nature personified, or the sea, or the cold.

No, somebody that strong... every time a new Princess took charge, there should be some massive impact on the Kingdom. The nations should be hotbeds of chaos. Well, they already kind of were, compared to the Horde, but to Lonnie they appeared to be remarkably *consistent* chaos.

Strange.

But while the Princesses changed constantly, one thing didnt: the Runestone. Princess Perfuma reigned now, and others would reign after, as others had reigned before... but they would all draw power from the Heart-Blossom.

So the thought had occurred, the theory:

What if the Princesses weren't in charge, even of themselves?

What if the *Runestones* were the guiding intelligence?

How could you stay a person, after all, once all that magic was inside you? From a few discussions with Dreer, Lonnie had come to realize how a sorceror's magic worked, that it drew on external power. That she got, she wasn't afraid of mages. The power never went inside them, did not *change* them, make something else.

But this? How could a person old all that magic inside themselves without... changing? What had to be taken, what had to be forgotten, to make room for the magic? A person could only hold so much of anything, be it food, air, water... or magic.

And maybe all of this was just a consolidation of thoughts she'd been thinking ever since Catra left. Catra, who had been the laziest, meanest, most lackadaisical Hordesman Lonnie had ever met, who only in her harshness had any of the traits the Horde found valuable. She'd give Catra that much credit; Catra had been a hard-ass, and Lonnie couldn't claim she hadn't admired that strength of spirit.

But then she'd found the Sword, and now... Lonnie couldn't see the Catra she'd known, not anymore. Catra betraying the Horde? Sure, Lonnie could see it, she'd barely been loyal to start with. That part wasn't surprising.

But instead of slinking off to some distant corner of the Alliance to laze about, and be as useless to the Alliance as she had been to the Horde, Catra had instead... changed. She'd taken point. She'd become the vanguard of the Princess Alliance, hell, she'd helped

rebuild it! With Catra on the warpath- Catra! Who could barely commit to training, and never without cheating!- the Great Rebellion had been reborn, the Princesses stopping their squabbling long enough to fight back.

The Horde's advance had almost completely stalled out before Hordak's death, and it was only Adora's plans and cleverness that had renewed their push. And despite Adora's cleverness, despite Adora being *a fucking First One,* Catra had still been there to oppose her, every step of the way- Catra! Who had never beaten Adora in training except through a trick. Catra, the worst Hordesman, now held up as the greatest Princess.

It just didn't make sense,

So what if it wasn't *Catra* that had done anything? What if she'd picked up the Sword, and it just... cut out those parts it didn't like. Replaced them. Catra, just a meatsuit for the Sword, a wielder for the handle, a puppet for the master... a Sword that wielded a person, rather than the other way around.

What if Catra had died when she found that Sword, and they'd been fighting *that* the whole time? They even called her new, larger form She-Ra, after all, they gave her a *different name*, wasn't that the ultimate sign of the change? Catra was gone, and only She-Ra remained.

All of this had been... just a theory. Unimportant. Whether the Princesses were truly the ones in control or the Runestones had scooped out their souls to implant their own alien thoughts,

whether Catra had made a choice or the Sword had turned her into a weapon, the Horde still had to shoot them all, so it was an academic question. Something to idly ponder on long guard watches.

But now?

Adora was a Princess.

So who was in charge? Was the Horde's Lord still Adora, or did it sit fat and happy now in its new chambers over that deep water pit? Was *sister* in charge?

Lonnie wasn't the only one who'd been disgruntled, though it wasn't nearly as widespread as she might have feared... or, perhaps, hoped. She wasn't sure which it was, and that frightened her, if she was being honest. She wasn't... she wasn't sure about *any* of this.

Maybe she was overreacting. Adora had done so much *good* for the Horde. She'd saved them, saved them all, responded to Lonnie's speech by stepping up. She'd singlehandedly kept the war effort going.

But now...

Was it Adora anymore? Had Adora come back from the wasteland, or not?

So much doubt. Lonnie would give anything to have a clear, bright line, a... a *certainty.* She felt unbalanced, off-kilter, like the littlest thing might kick her right off a cliff. She wanted orders, she wanted someone to tell her what to do, she wanted...

She wanted a plan.

But she had none, and could only watch as the Horde divided itself in two. A majority of the Horde seemed taken in by the tale Adora told upon her return, of a First Ones artifact in a faraway land, accidentally triggered, its power now in the Horde's hands. Adora's speech did not say “Princess”, did not say “Runestone”, spoke only of her ancient race and their many wonders. Most of the Horde did not think the words that Adora did not say.

(To Lonnie's irritation, Kyle was a proud member of this group.)

But others did. There was another group in the Horde that had put one and one together, had realized that they *must* compute out to two, had realized that by all standards and *any* set of rules you cared to apply, the Spirit Ember was a Runestone, and that meant Adora was now a Princess.

That group was split into three. A slight majority were actually glad to have a Princess, seeing it as nothing more than another advantage for the Horde. Rogelio belonged to that group; he'd even told Lonnie it was a good thing. Something to

counterbalance the weight of the Alliance's shaman-gods with one of their own.

And if Lonnie could be certain that it was still Adora in there, and not this damned *sister* Adora spoke of, then... then she'd probably be okay with it, too.

But she wasn't certain. She wasn't certain at all.

(It was the worst feeling she'd ever had. All her life, she'd *known* what to do, had a direction, a *plan,* either orders from above or her own self-given directives. But now? Now she just... felt adrift. Helpless. She'd take anything over this.)

Another part of the group that had figured it out just made jokes about how absurd the situation was. Lonnie had found members of this group by accident; she'd been drinking in the Horde's lone bar, an establishment that had sort of accidentally sprung up near the Force Captain barracks once Adora relaxed the rules on food and drink.

(*Force Captain Reorientation,* some wit had called it, and once three drunk Troopers managed to paint the name over the door, the name was stuck.)

While Lonnie nursed her own whiskey and gloom both in a shadowy corner, she'd overheard Octavia and Dreer drinking at the main bar, manned by the enterprising Hordesman who'd come up with it, a bald-shaved and blue eyed woman who had specialized in easy conversation and swift service. The Octopodian and the Mystacoran had been drinking and cracking jokes with each other about how ridiculous the very concept of a Horde

Princess was; especially for Octavia, who had served Mermista's predecessor before turning her coat and her vessel to the Horde.

(*I went from serving the sea princess to the seared princess*, she'd joked, and laughed, Dreer laughing with her. Anger had flashed through Lonnie, hearing this mockery of Adora's wounds. She'd kept watch on the both since; nobody got to mock Lonnie's friends, especially Adora, who had gained her wounds in service to her people.)

But a few others... they were more like Lonnie. They'd seen the changes, or just had a gut feeling, had... had known something was wrong. This wasn't the Horde. They didn't *do* this. Even when they were using the Black Garnet, it had been through the medium of Shadow Weaver, who was not a Princess, for all the other awful things that old monster had been. They had never done *this* before.

But Lonnie... didn't know what to do with that. She'd been- very quietly, very secretly- compiling a list of them. She didn't know why, not really, though she was scared that somewhere deep down, in the dark parts of her mind, that she *did* know why she was making this list.

Not that she didn't know what this looked like. A gathering of discontents? That... felt like...

...Treason.

She didn't want to rebel against Adora, or start a revolution. What if it *was* Adora, after all? Lonnie might be wrong. The Princesses might be people, and the remarkable continuity of the Princesses' Kingdoms might be because the leadership, having similar powers, tended towards similar answers. Or Hordak's information might be wrong and the Kingdoms had changed through the years, like any nation had.

But if Lonnie was right, if it wasn't Adora in the driver's seat anymore, if *sister* had taken over, then it would be treason to *not* fight back, to try to destroy this damn Runestone, before it could ruin everything...

She wished, desperately, that someone could tell her what to do, some clue, some... some sign.

Something.

But in its absence, Lonnie sighed, and wished she knew what to do.

(And crawling through the circuits of the Horde's machinery, glitching it out, having snuck in through Entrapta's remnant technology, Light Hope pondered the sad look on Lonnie's face, and read her list, wondering how she could use this discontent to fulfill her duty and activate the Heart of Etheria.)

Chapter End Notes

I'm super sure this will not be a problem later for anybody! (Side note: Entrapta did not send Light Hope... as ever, the AI has its own plans.)

Chapter 21: Princess Perfuma of Plumeria

Chapter Notes

A lady and a serpent in a garden.

Princess Perfuma of Plumeria

Fuck.

That was Perfuma's first thought as she walked through the royal garden. Well, technically all of Plumeria was the garden of the current Princess, so wasn't all of it a royal garden?

But no, no, focus, Perfuma! True, she held reign over Plumeria- sort of, governance was actually headed mostly by a series of communes, she was technically just the executive and military branch- but anyway that wasn't important. This was her personal space, her little... little place. A garden that former Princesses had used over the centuries, tying her to her predecessors. They passed statues, mostly arranged shrubs molded by magic, though a few were trees shaped like people, a memorial that still lived long after the subject had died.

It was beautiful, but Perfuma was still cursing in her head, because she had no idea if this was a good idea or not. Maybe yes? Entrapta seemed to like it so far! Maybe that was enough?

Or maybe it wasn't? Obviously Entrapta's issues couldn't possibly be solved in the space of a single visit, that wasn't really how heartwounds worked, but she *seemed* to be getting perkier, more interested, more excited. Would seeing the statues heal her, or hurt her? Maybe Perfuma should have delayed?

Oh, she didn't know what to do! But... maybe Entrapta knew? Maybe she should see them. The Dryl Princess was acting a bit more like her old self, at any rate, before Perfuma had screwed up at the Fright Zone, and failed to stay close to the tech princess, a shame she had borne for years now.

Perfuma wasn't responsible for what Entrapta had chosen to do since- for the robots, for the people the Horde had killed with the mad scientist's technology, for the attack on Brightmoon and everything else- but she was a reasonable woman, or at least hoped to be; and she *was* responsible for not watching over Entrapta well enough, for her getting stuck at the Fright Zone in the first place. If she'd just obeyed Catra's orders and stuck close to Entrapta, she'd never have had a chance to betray them in the first place. It was why she'd made the statue they were heading towards- well, one of them, anyway. Perfuma took responsibility for her mistakes.

(Like her people going to war. For five generations, Plumeria had needed no army, the Princess did all of that for them... but now, Perfuma's people had to go to war, and some part of her had never stopped blaming her own cowardice, her own fear of the immense power she wielded. If she had just been brave, even once...)

She wrung her hands as they walked in silence in that shadowy grove, the looming trees leaning over the First Ones' architecture

lending a roof to this sacred place, a cathedral of leaves. Well, Perfuma walked. Entrapta... slithered? Was that the right word? She wasn't walking on her feet, just kind of sidewindering along behind on her one long strand of hair, a human serpent in the royal garden. She kept looking around herself, taking it all in, and that was good! Really good. Better than Perfuma had feared from her letters, which had so much pain between the lines, pain that had broken Perfuma's heart. Even with all Entrapta had done... well, she deserved to be happy. Everyone did, so long as they did no harm; and while Entrapta had done much harm, she had come back to the Alliance. She should serve penance, and then be happy...

But that was a very Plumerian way to think. Which was fine for Perfuma! She *was* Plumerian, and proud of her people; so proud, so very proud. It was one reason she was so nervous whenever she had to lead them; so much *pressure*. So much hanging on all of her decisions. Even something as simple as a trade deal, as just talking with a fellow Princess like Entrapta, made her nerves just... jump up and dance! It was awful!

She wasn't given to much cursing, but she'd said it once and she'd say it again!

Fuck!

...Still, it was what her people required of her, so here Perfuma was. The supplies would help them, help them considerably; food and fuel the nation had in abundance, but the metals the Dryllian-Dryllan? Dryllite? Drylborn? Oh, what *was* the demonym? She couldn't think of it just now!- that *Entrapta* was providing was more and better than the forest folk could mine for themselves in

a year. Sure, they *had* mines, but few in number, and the metal produced wasn't very high in quality. Really, it was a great deal!

(And some part of Perfuma wondered about that, *what is she doing, why would she offer such a good deal, something is wrong*, but that part was dismissed. Maybe Entrapta was just bad at trade- the All knew Perfuma was!)

...And, on a personal level... a chance to make up for her mistake. To help Entrapta.

So Perfuma wrung her hands, briefly kind of wished she had some lotion because at this rate she was going to chafe something, and kept going.

She tried to figure out what to say. Small talk! Should be simple! It had the operative word “small” in it, it shouldn't feel as big as it did when Perfuma was thinking about it! Also, big talk just sounded kind of dumb.

But what to say? She wasn't into technology. She liked history? Err, well, she *knew* her history, thanks to her dads. Maybe Entrapta liked history?

So of course her brain immediately leapt to *so how do you feel about the Glory Lily regime?*

Fuck!

That was *not* a topic of small talk! The Glory Lily Princesses had conquered Dryl, and murdered most of its engineer-guilds! That was- no, bad Perfuma! Bad Perfuma brain! Think of a different topic!

Do you appreciate Queen Angella for killing almost all of the Glory Lily Princesses or are you mad that Dryl didn't get a shot at them

Noooooooo! No! Oh...

Perfuma wrung the hell out of her hands, an old nervous tic she'd had since she was a baby. Her brain spat facts at her the whole time, every one of them a worse idea to talk about then the last, which was quite impressive, really!

Princess Kaname set the whole philosophy up, reigned for forty years building up an army, then died when she attacked Brightmoon and Angella got her; then her wife, Princess Akemi, got the powers and spent thirty years fighting Brightmoon, the Snows, and the Crownless- including Dryl!- before she died fighting Angella.

Stop thinking about it!

Oh hey remember how Princess Tomoe took over after that and reigned for like fifty years and she conquered a bunch of places,

including Salineas and Dryl and a few Crownless nations that I think became part of Phlax later, maybe? She did a bunch of evil! Committed a few horrible purges, and then Queen Angella got her during the battle of Charlotte, where she lost her head.

Then her successor Princess Miki was stupid and tried to create a central church, which never works here in Plumeria, but she ***did*** *manage to be the only Glory Lily Princess who didn't get killed by Queen Angella, so go her, maybe? She died to a survivor of a religious sect that her new church had murdered, some executed preacher's daughter who became the next Princess, Princess Sakura, and she finally ended the madness.*

...None of that was helpful, why was it all she could think of?!?

Is it weird for Queen Angella to hang out with me at war councils now? Plumerians were villains for a lot of her early life, or at least what we think was her early life, my dads were pretty convinced she was about a thousand years old...

...Now that was all she was going to be thinking about at the next war council.

Silent, the duo continued through the garden, as Entrapta kept her own counsel and Perfuma tried to think of anything that wasn't some awful part of Plumeria's history. Admittedly the Glory Lily Princesses had happened... what, about eight hundred years ago? Roughly? Her dads weren't sure. Etherian records were pretty terrible during that time period. Lot of upheaval.

She wondered what Dryl knew of those yesterdays. Her dads had done their best to prepare their little girl for whatever path she'd seek in life; she hadn't had her Princess powers, but she'd been the daughter of two very prominent men, leaders in the circles and communes that made up Plumeria's (admittedly haphazard) government. If she wanted to use that to work a career in politics, they'd intended for her to be as ready as she could be.

(And if she didn't? No harm done in a good education. Her dads had told her, repeatedly, that they'd love her no matter what, and in her heart of hearts, she will always, always miss them.)

Her dads had taught her history first, because a people who did not know their past could do nothing with the present and work towards no future; they'd planned to teach her other things, in time. They'd been good dads, had played with her, taught her, helped her body match her inner self, and...

And she wished they'd all had more time.

(Her hands briefly quit their wringing to clasp in prayer, and pray that the All took care of her adopted fathers, so she could see them again when her work was done, and show them all she had done, in hopes they would be proud of her, and know that she'd done the best she could since sickness took them.)

Perfuma had no idea what to say, and Entrapta didn't speak, and as they traveled Entrapta's head stopped looking around, and she moved slower, slower, falling behind. Less perk in her step, or slither, at any rate, as they drew close, and *fuck* Perfuma should say something but what could she say? What was big enough for

this? She had no idea what to say, what to do, her brain was full of useless trivia and nothing helpful...

With such thoughts in mind, the mood souring and souring, the duo reached the end of the gallery soon enough. The living memorials ended here at the newest section, past which there was only empty ground, awaiting future generations of Princesses. There was quite a lot of space past the last monuments, receding into the dappled darkness under the canopy; the ruins the royal gallery had been placed in was quite large, even by First Ones' standards. Perfuma wondered what the original building had been, when that ancient and noble people had built it. Maybe it'd been a church? The idea pleased her, but then again, spirituality was a hallmark of Plumeria, and Perfuma, as its Princess, had placed on her own shoulders the duty to embody its highest ideals.

(She just wished it was *easier* .)

But she had no more time for thought; here they were.

Entrapta, as she had been, years ago; Perfuma's way of remembering the woman she'd failed. She'd made her monument out of purple-pink roses, an ancient variety, one of Perfuma's favorites; something an immigrant to Plumeria had made, in ancient days. Moonlight Princes, that was the flower's name, his multitude of roses the only thing that mysterious stranger ever named; he had not even left his own name behind, even though he left a legacy in a thousand flowers, most of which only bloomed in the delicate hours of night.

Those flowers framed an Entrapta that no longer existed. Even a glance showed how much things had changed; the Entrapta she had made from memory had her hair separated into two great twintails, was smiling and confident, and her mask was not so rounded, the edges shorn off by damage taken during the cataclysmic battle in the Fright Zone that had done... something.

(Perfuma did not remember the Portal incident at all, save a vague dream she had from time to time these days, of her fathers being alive, of her people no longer at war; a pleasant thing, a *good* thing, for all that it wasn't real.)

But now... now Entrapta loomed, had curled up like a pit viper on her single long strand, was sitting cross-legged on her own curled up mass of hair, one sleeve a torn-off Horde flag- and *that* was so disturbing and unsettling that Perfuma's eyes just kind of skipped right past it!- and her mask cracked, the red lenses staring... not at her own statue, but at his.

Hordak's.

Hordak, whom she'd made out of red roses; red was his color, the only one that had felt right. She could make topiary out of all kinds of things, but Perfuma had to admit, she was partial to roses. Another cultivar of that ancient, mysterious man, that he called Amazoness; brilliantly red roses, with unusually sharp thorns, a bladed kind of beauty. Appropriate, for a man who had been good only once in his life; but knowing that he had died to save the world, knowing that he had made the deliberate choice to sacrifice himself for others...

Well. Perfuma hated him, she would not lie- without Hordak, her people would not have to relearn warfare, her people would be at peace, still- but she would acknowledge his one great deed. She was a big enough person for that. She had respect enough for redemption for that.

Things were silent for a while, as they both observed his statue, and the roses that framed his red, red eyes.

The word that came hissing out of Entrapta a moment later was so quiet that Perfuma almost missed it.

" Why?"

Fuck.

Perfuma turned her head to answer, her hands doing what they always did, which was wring.

" What?" she asked, not for clarification, but in hopes of buying time to figure out what to say.

" Why?" Entrapta repeated, a little louder, but not by much. She did not look at Perfuma, but at the statue, only the statue. " I don't understand. You should hate him. You should hate *me* , but you... you make these things. My statue I get, you made it before

I did... all that I did... but Hordak. *Him.* You made a statue for him. You must hate him. You must hate *me.* Why?”

Fuck.

Oh, what to say, what to say? She had to be careful, she- she didn't want to hurt Entrapta, of course, but there were probably implications to anything she said, political, or, or something, and she'd screw up Entrapta being in the Alliance and she wasn't totally sure why she'd done it in the first place but she had some ideas as to why but she'd never put them into words and

Fuck!

She didn't know what she *should* say...

So she defaulted to the way her dads had taught her. Tell the truth. The best course of action... simple honesty.

Even if it didn't work, even if it made a mistake, somehow- and Perfuma didn't know *how* it could, she was just scared it *would* - at least she wouldn't have lied about it.

Hoping she wasn't about to make a mistake, Perfuma sighed, drew in a deep breath, and began to speak.

" Did you know we conquered Dryl, once? It was a very long time ago, so long, really it's ancient history, but we did it! And killed a bunch of you. We were trying to stamp out technology we didn't approve of. Did you know Plumeria is directly responsible for the loss of technology like tracker pads? The one who started it all was *very* anti-technology! We've always had a problem with our love of nature overwhelming common sense sometimes, moving us from loving the natural to hating the artificial, instead of letting all things be. The All is everything, you know, so it's natural and artificial both, but we forget about it a lot."

Entrapta turned her head to Perfuma as she rambled, speaking faster as she tried to get to a point.

" We did a lot of harm! But eventually we stopped doing that harm, well, once Queen Angella kind of killed everybody and then a preacher's daughter killed the last Glory Lily Princess and anyway that's not important. What matter is that now every Princess swears not to do that again, swears to fight anyone in Plumeria who tries. And it's just words but we've held to it! Three times since have Plumerians risen up to burn the scientists and three times has a Princess, just like me, risen to stop them, and kept them from doing harm. We've *changed.* I like that, I like the idea that... we can change. It's a big deal now in Plumeria! This idea of redemption, of forgiveness, that anybody can start again. I like to believe in it, I believe in my friends, I believe in... I believe in decency. I believe in people."

She let out the last of her stored air in a rush, breathing in just as quick; almost there.

“ So for you and Hordak I wanted to remember you at your best! Hordak saved us, when he could have just waited for Queen Angella to do it. The world would still be saved and Queen Angella would be dead, and he'd be alive, but he didn't do that. He gave his life to protect you and- and Scorpia, who is gone? I hope she's okay.”

“ Me too,” Entrapta said quietly. “ Though I do not hope.”

“ You have to hope,” Perfuma said. “ Even when it's dashed, or pointless... it gives you strength to keep going. We all hope for something. And I... I wanted to remember him, remember what he'd done. He died well.”

“ He did,” Entrapta said, in a breath like a sob. “ He... he was so beautiful, he was so much like me, and no one... no one but you has ever...”

She shuddered, shook, rattled with unreleased tears, and Perfuma's heart broke in her chest.

“ I... do you want a hug?” Perfuma offered, having no idea *what* to give her, offering the only comfort she could.

“ I don't deserve one,” Entrapta said in a rush, lifting her mask all of a sudden to reveal a tormented face, scrubbing at her eyes as tears leaked from them to run down her cheeks. “ That statue,

that's me before I hurt you, I hurt everyone, I don't deserve it, I don't deserve... I hurt you.”

“ You did,” Perfuma said, because truth mattered, truth was important. Entrapta *had* hurt her, had hurt her people, had done awful, awful things. Entrapta sobbed at her words, at that truth, which would still be true, no matter what penance she might offer in the future.

But this, too, would still be true: Entrapta had turned away from the Horde... and Perfuma believed in forgiveness.

And while she hadn't known that this was the right thing to do just a moment ago, now she did, now her hands did not wring each other; this, this was right, this she *knew* was the right thing to do, at last.

“ But do you want a hug anyway?” Perfuma asked, and spread her arms wide.

Entrapta stared at her, dumbfounded, staring at her with tears pouring down her face... but Perfuma waited, patient, waited to give or retract as her fellow princess so decided, gave her time to *choose* .

And finally Entrapta let out a grief-stricken, strangled howl of hurt, and *struck* , lashed out, lunged right into Perfuma's arms and almost knocked her over; she tackled the taller woman, wrapped

her arms around her, crying, crying her eyes out, crying so hard that she couldn't breathe, choking on nothing more than her own pain. Perfuma stumbled back but managed to stay standing, and held her, held her tight even as her hair joined in, wrapping around her like a python and constricting, so desperate for comfort.

But that was okay. Perfuma would give her what she needed, would give her as much comfort as she could.

They stood like that a long time, there in the garden.

Chapter 22: Princess Entrapta of the Garden

Chapter Notes

> One last dream in the gardens of Plumeria, before the beginning of the end; before Beast Island, and all that may or may not come of it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Princess Entrapta of the Garden

She had no thoughts, for a time.

There was just... this, this moment, the physicality of it all. Perfuma, so strong, so firm, Entrapta suddenly aware of how small her arms had gotten in the time since the Fright Zone and the Portal, her eating habits so dulled that she was losing weight and muscle tone. The smell of her, Perfuma, a rose scent, and all the poets talked about how roses had thorns but right then all Entrapta could think, the lone thought in all her feeling, the idea that it didn't matter if roses had thorns, so much as it mattered instead that thorns had roses, and that felt deep and profound and important in some fundamental way she could not parse out in that overwhelming moment.

No, there was no understanding. For all her intelligence, for all she knew, there was no thought beyond that one. There was just this, for a time; there was her hurt, her hurt, pouring out of her eyes, escaping in gasps of her clenched throat. There was Perfuma, solid and strong, something Entrapta clung to like ivy on a sturdy oak. There was warmth about her she had not felt in... in centuries, in centuries of lived experience, she had crossed

millennia untold to be in this moment, held and held. There was the soft texture of the cotton of Perfuma's clothes, so soft, her strands whispering silently across them; there was the distant sound of life all around her, softened by distance and stone walls and the hush of the forest, grounding sounds that reminded her of life past this moment, past this hurt.

Time passed. She didn't know how long. She cried, cried the way she had never cried before; she should know. She had not cried like that as a baby, even, her parents had left extensive notes that said Entrapta was a quiet child; extensive notes in a shared journal that called their daughter “our best experiment”, a thing that made Entrapta's heart hurt, and remembering it now made Entrapta cry even more, cry out hurts older than the Portal and the loss of *him.*

More time passed. She wasn't sure how long she was there; she *was* sure that Perfuma never let her go, that the good woman held her as long as she needed her to, that she felt safe in her arms. She had needed that, needed that touch, needed that connection, that she had not had since *he* had died. She lay with her head over one shoulder, Perfuma's head on her own shoulder, and she wept.

In time, when her mind reasserted itself again, she drew in a few shuddering breaths, and blinked, the world finally filtering back in. She was... a mess, snot and spit and all manner of awful fluids coming out of her face. No picture of ethereal beauty in sorrow was she.

One of Perfuma's arms tried to tug away, but Entrapta's hair trapped it tight; a moment later, there was a soft sussuration in

the ground as a vine grew gently from near Perfuma's feet, reached into the Plumerian's pocket, and brought out a delicate handkerchief that it then dangled before Entrapta's face.

" You might need this," said the wonderful woman holding her, this impossible person who had somehow outperformed all expectation. " For your nose."

Entrapta could make no answer; her throat *hurt* , it was hoarse, hoarse from clenched breaths and shuddering sighs... but she could retrieve the gift, grabbing it with a few strands. She pulled away- just a little, she wanted to stay here, forever- and wiped her face, blew her nose, cleaned up just a bit.

Then she realized she didn't know what to do with it.

" I... do I give this back to you? That seems unsanitary," Entrapta commented. " They really should make throw-away versions of these..."

Perfuma laughed, a lovely sound in Entrapta's ears.

" You can keep it!" she said.

Entrapta nodded as she balled it up and stuffed it in a back pocket, to be tossed out later. Taking another breath- and realizing how much she must be imposing on her hostess- the

Drylborn drew back, blinking away the last of her tears... though in that moment, as she looked at Perfuma, the dim of the forest canopy mingled with the haze in her eyes to make a kind of... light, all around her, framing her.

Entrapta thought *she* looked rather nice like that.

" I won't ask if you're alright," her fellow Princess said, smiling at her, her hands not wringing each other anymore. " I know that a good cry helps, but it's not all there is."

" No," Entrapta said, still staring up at *Perfuma*, who had been so kind. " But I... I feel better. Thank you. I owe you three favors, now."

" You owe me nothing for this," was the answer given, and that was a lie, that was as wrong as one plus one equaling four; no, no, there was a debt here, a debt for acts of kindness that grew every time Entrapta was blessed with *her* presence.

" I do," Entrapta said, pronouncing it, heavy as a stone, as she wiped her eyes and replaced her mask, bringing it back down, and not looking directly at her counterpart. It was... too much, right now, something had happened inside Entrapta in the last few moments and looking too directly at *Perfuma* would blind her, as surely as she breathed.

“ Well, I don't think you do,” Perfuma said, “ but if you want to pay me back... promise me you'll take care of yourself. You need help, Entrapta, and I can't do it- I'm nobody's counsel, I'm afraid!- but I do know teachers, and maybe meditation might be useful, there's tinctures and herbs... and if you just need to talk to a friend, I'm here. You can come back any time.”

Of course. Of course *she* would ask that Entrapta pay back a debt by taking care of herself, which was not how a debt could be repaid at all; *she* asked nothing in return. Of course not.

It was, somehow, par for the course, this great benevolence, and it still left Entrapta in awe.

“ I will... I will do so,” Entrapta promised, and meant it. She'd take the time out. She owed a debt, and the equation had to be computed; one plus one had to equal two. Debts had to be paid. The world had a balance to it. “ Thank you. Thank you... so much.”

She didn't have the words for more, for everything in her heart, but that didn't hurt as much as it usually did. *She* would know what Entrapta had not the strength or skill to say.

“ Good,” the great lady said, smiling, though the hand-wringing was now back. “ Is there anything else you need? We should have food shortly, or at least, I hope so; I think we could both do with a drink! Or maybe a smoke, do you smoke? I smoke. Good for my nerves.”

Entrapta shook her head.

" I don't, but then again, we have nothing like that in Dryl," she answered. " We mostly drink. There *is* a hallucinogenic cactus, but that's about it."

" Oh, I *love* cacti! I mean, I didn't, but then we went to the Crimson Waste and I discovered how deep their root systems went and they're so fascinating, they're so tough, the hardiest plants in the world!"

She talked, talked and talked, of a journey and a purple-skinned amazon and plants, always plants, and Entrapta, who had nothing to say, still found it was a joy just to listen, the enthusiasm alone enough to carry the conversation.

It was... nice.

Then the servants arrived, finally. A small procession of shirtless people- did anyone in Plumeria actually own a shirt other than their Princess? Visual evidence suggested no- bearing platters of fruits and vegetables, and to Entrapta's delight, she saw they were all tiny, somehow naturally small.

" I grew these specifically for you!" *she* said while examining the gathered food, eyes eventually alighting on a tiny red apple. A

delicate hand snatched it up. " Here, I'm particularly proud of this one!"

The woman offered the serpent an apple in the garden; Entrapta took the apple, and gave it a bite.

" It's sweet," she said. " Terribly sweet."

She clapped in delight.

" I'm so glad you like it!"

They ate a little, right there in the garden; Entrapta took a sample of everything, and it was good, all of it was good. She stuffed her pockets, things to take with her, to eat as they flew, and they made a few stumbling attempts at small talk... though not many. It was almost time to leave, and Entrapta knew it. She wished to stay, but there were no more niceties to be said, and Entrapta had no talent for small talk. She did not know what to say, not to *her* .

And the task yet awaited; these Woods were so lovely, dark and deep, but Entrapta yet had miles to go and an **Adora** to kill.

But she could always come back. *She* had said so. This was not the only time she would be in Plumeria.

But for now... it was time.

" I have to go," Entrapta said, when she'd tried everything, even the fruity wine, " but I don't want to."

Perfuma frowned, then sighed.

" True... time waits for none of us."

Entrapta nodded, but then her hostess smiled.

" But you can still take a little of the garden with you! If... if that's okay with you?"

Entrapta, who wouldn't dream of denying *her* anything, simply nodded her head.

Quick movements and magic brought two roses, one from each of the living memorials to Entrapta's past self and Hordak triumphant; bright flowers of purple-pink and brilliant red, both shorn of thorns swiftly by spellwork, before delicate hands wove them gently into Entrapta's hair.

" For you," *she* said, with a smile that was the most beautiful flower in all of Plumeria's many gardens, the most precious of all

blooms.

Overwhelmed, Entrapta could say nothing, grateful her mask hid her blazing cheeks, her hair rubbing unconsciously against the stems of the twin gifts that sat at her temples. She simply bowed, and then turned around, *Perfuma* catching up with her and walking alongside. Out of the garden, back out among the people, who saw the two Princesses and guessed correctly that Entrapta was leaving. They gathered, to bid her farewell, though Entrapta barely noticed them under the burning in her cheeks and the good feeling inside, silent as she and *Perfuma* traveled the distance back to her lift.

It took her all the journey back to put the good feeling into words; she'd never felt like this before. But eventually, she struck upon it. She felt... .dismantled, but in a good way. Like some clever watchmaker had seen that her gears were no longer aligning, and kindly taken her to pieces, so she could be cleaned, restored, made new again. Make the clicking of her parts count the time correctly, and be wrong no more. She felt the way her machines must have felt every time she had to take them apart to put them back together again, in a better way, a cleaned way.

(a watchmaker who put flowers in her hair, who tended a garden of roses, who smiled)

The hurt was still there. Crying did not bring *him* back, and it did not kill **Adora** . She could feel it lurking in the background of her mind, that suffering, that hurt.

But right now, it had been buried, gone underground, and she could feel... alright.

Maybe if it came back, she could visit again. She should... study plants, learn what *she* liked, so they could talk. That'd be nice, that'd be good. It'd help. Here in Plumeria, she might learn how to bury it, again and again, until it stayed in its grave and troubled her no more.

Maybe... maybe there was something past **Adora** . Maybe when she had gotten her revenge...

Still, those were future thoughts. She'd just... take it as it came. Not everything had to be part of something more. Call it an... experiment.

Experiments. Earth and stone, she'd forgotten how much she used to love experimenting. She'd... she'd lost so much of herself, when she lost *him* .

But not all. She could... get it back, some of it, get some of herself back. Start with this, start with... an experiment. Those were never wasted, after all; even failure brought data. She didn't need this to be anything more than it was.

It was enough to begin.

With a steady heart- feeling ready, for whatever might come- Entrapta returned to her lift. The people waved, and she waved

back, she waved back, with both hands; the crowd cheered, and to her own surprise, she cheered back, she yelled in delight right back.

The lift did as its name implied, and took her back to her ship, her Doom Balloon (and the name was funny, now, funny, in the light of all her cleansing.) Back up, into the bay, where Imp was waiting for her.

" Anything today, my little Imp?" she asked, and he shook his head to report that nothing was amiss, or at least, nothing he had seen. Admittedly, most of what Shadow Weaver and Glimmer did was magic, which meant the other two inhabitants of the Doom Balloon didn't really know what they were doing anyway.

Report given, she held out her hands, and he leapt into her arms, the little one cooing in his stolen voice. Hugging him tight, she crawled towards her quarters aboard the ship; she'd set course from her computer and get them moving. Shadow Weaver and Glimmer were probably still training, no need to disturb them; she could talk of her meeting later, if they asked.

Imp in hand, she crawled through the tight hallways of her airship to her room, opening it with a single thin tentacle of hair. Her quarters were terribly sparse in decoration; just a bed, a few clothing changes, and the computer that controlled the ship, which dominated the room. The multitude of screens on her right ate up the wallspace, displaying all kinds of facts about the vessel, which in the files bore only the name airshipdesign21.

On a whim, as she closed the door behind her, she went up to the keyboard and with a few clicks from her strands, changed the name on all official computer documentation to Doom Balloon. Heh heh!

With another few clicks, she plotted out her course. To Salineas, and then Beast Island, to find what had become of her friend; to avenge her death or- as Entrapta now could not help but hope- to save her, if by some miracle she yet lived.

Unrealistic... but she'd already underwent one miracle today. Why not hope for another?

Smiling, she turned around to lay her little bundle of joy on the bed... but the light from the monitor changed, changed to something blue, and when she whipped her head back, she saw a familiar face staring back at her, the light from the screens glaring so bright that she pulled her mask down in the face of it.

" Light Hope?" Entrapta said. " What are you doing in my systems?"

" I am assisting you," Light Hope said. " I believe from your flight plan that you are headed to the locations Etherians refer to Beast Island?"

" Yes," Entrapta said. " To find Scorpia; you told me I needed her, or her DNA, as the Garnet has not chosen another Princess."

" True," Light Hope said. " I do not know why the Garnet has not chosen one, save that the connection was disrupted before it could pass on; there are other methods to connect to the Black Garnet, but Scorpia or a part of her are by far the simplest."

" We discussed all this before," Entrapta said, still wary- not just of the AI's sudden appearance, but what it being aboard the Doom Balloon at all meant. Light Hope should *not* have been able to enter her systems... unless the AI was much more powerful than she'd been letting on.

" There is new information," Light Hope responded. " I believe I may have a way to use Horde dissidents to give you an opening to bring Scorpia, or whatever of her you retrieve, to the Black Garnet."

...Well. She'd deal with Light Hope's intrusion later. This sounded... juicy. Getting a piece of Scorpia- or her friend, back alive- would be hard enough, and Entrapta had yet to plan out how to get her to the Garnet afterwards...

This was a big step in making **Adora** pay... and paying off her debts, by saving *her* people from the Horde.

" Tell me more," Entrapta said.

Chapter End Notes

I'm sure Light Hope's not gonna be a problem.

Right?

Chapter 23: Beast Island of Etheria

Chapter Notes

From a POV nobody expected, I bet!

Beast Island's.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Beast Island of Etheria

I have visitors.

Outsiders. They have come, as they always come, as they always will come. I let them enter. I always do.

It gets lonely, without **prey** .

They have a great machine that floats, drifting, waiting, high above. There is another aboard it, one more, who is something like me; or, at least, part of her is something like part of me. We are both conglomerate creatures. We are alike in another way, too; there is great joy in her, as there is in me, that resonates with the pain of others. A fellow sadist.

She stays aboard their vessel. The wisest of the three. Good. I never enjoy hurting a fellow connoisseur of pain as much as I do those who do not share my savage delights. I may even let her

escape, to hurt others elsewhere; something to dream about, while I wait between visitors.

The other two land on one of my beaches, carried in a repulsor lift. They are not alone; they are cautious, they have brought assistance. They are proceeding cautiously, scouting with robots and drones. Clever. Smart. **Wise.**

I like it, when prey is like this. It makes it more fun, makes hunting the prey **play** .

They stand on my soil and send out their drones and make their plans. A defensive position, protected by dug-in weapons, based on old, old technology, deployed rapidly from their flying vessel. Such smart, smart prey.

I send my diggers, my little armies of scuttling earthmovers, to places underneath their fortifications. I will take their devices, sink them into the ground, ruin them. Their place of safety will give them no succor. I gather my flyers; I shall assail their escape, I shall sink their transport when they try to flee.

But not yet. Not just yet. I hold back my warriors, as I hold back my voice, my signal, the crushing song I sing that obliterates all hope. It is too soon. To win the game immediately is to bore myself, and I do so **hate** being bored.

So I wait. Let them think their preparations matter. Let them grow bold. Brash. Brave.

It is just the spice I like.

A few hours pass, hours in which I savor the meal to come, in which they stay close to their defenses, in which they search through monitor and minion as much of me as they can scour. I give only token resistance to their scouts. Oh, a few monsters here and there; enough to justify my reputation, but *just* enough. Let them think I am an ordinary island, with somewhat dangerous animals, whose reputation has been... overblown. Let them believe that the Beast is *on* the Island, instead of the truth.

To furhter disguise the truth, I move a few of my treasures, of the things the ancient conquerors of Eternia left behind when they fled the last She-Ra, and dangle them before the prey, let the cameras of the drones catch them just before a monster attacks- little teases, salacious glimpses of my enticing delights. Every dungeon must have a treasure at the end, after all; that's how the monster lures the victim in.

And as they learn of me, I learn of them. They are not so like me as the shadow still aboard their ship; it is harder to know them, I do not recognize my heart in their hearts, I must learn about them more slowly.

But that is fine. It is **fun** . It is **fun** , to learn, to know my prey.

After all, I must know my prey to truly enjoy **hurting** them. To make it... personal. To move it past the petty realms of physical suffering into the greater realms of existential torment, of despair, of all the loss that tastes so fine, tastes so much like wine, my **meat and drink** .

So I will study them, with an eye and an ear towards taste, always taste, to learn what to season my food with.

And oh, in these few hours, I find that their souls are so... *complex* . Symphonies, where so many sing simpler songs. Masterpiece paintings, where so many work with a lesser palette. And speaking of palates... the flavors! Oh, I can but barely taste their hearts, licking their feet and their hair as they stand in my sand... and it is still enough to whet my appetite. I sniff them, take in the bouquet of these glasses of wine, fine vintages, well-aged.

Delicious .

I have a favorite picked immediately, the entree to this meal. The serpent, who crawls on my ground with her hair, whose soul is so full of subtle influences; delight over the technology I dare let slip in naughty winks to her drones, a hatred that sits like a stone in her soul, a gently-blossoming drop of love, not fully formed yet... and underneath it all, the bedrock of her heart, is **grief** .

She has lost someone she truly loved. The pain of it lurks, subterranean, in the soil of her heart, bursting forth from time to time in spurs of pain. Her mind is riddled with suffering, deep pits

she crosses on thin stone arches, made out of excitement and interest, patched with a new, fragile thing, that blossoming droplet of love, vines and flowers to to mend the holes in her heart... but the pits are so deep, and the stone she stands on so very frail.

Delicious .

I can feast on her suffering for... oh, years, if I am careful. I always did like to savor my meals. She will keep me entertained for a long, long time. Yes, I may well make her the chiefest trophy of my collection; I may even mount her corpse, when I am done, and let her go free at last. Something to chew on between feasts.

And the other...

Sweetness, over sourness. Sourness, over sweetness. Her soul is caught between extremes, there are two moons in her heart and she orbits between them. None of it is **despair** , sadly, she does not have the umami of suffering that I so lust for, but she will work well as a delicious appetizer before I have dinner. Honey and vinegar, the sweet sugar of pride and hubris mingled with the biting acid of self-loathing and fear of failure, is the dominant flavor; that by itself was not so uncommon, but there is more, additional flavors to make a truly superior morsel of her.

For while most of her is split between the two lights, flickering between them like an indecisive moth, there is... more, there. A few things that are *not* caught between. There is more than just this divide. A cinnamon spice, bright and sharp, from her lust for violence, her hunger for excitement, for battle, for daring the reaper, underlaid with the bitter salt of envy and want. Most

curious of all, a subtle vanilla, a sense of... love, love, shining in her heart, love for family and friends, pulsing, pulsing, the driving motivation behind all her heart.

...But there is... something more? Something that cuts through my enjoyment. A strange kind of... almond flavor. A sweetness, but the sweetness of **cyanide** .

And something... familiar.

She tastes like... the one prey to ever truly escape me. The irritant, the goddamn **ant** that dares defy me, even now, who snatched one of my sweet prizes from the beach, a girl whose soul tasted like the sugarsand bite of a candy apple. Barely a snack, but **mine** , and he stole her from me!

...I do not know where he is, now, with my prize...

Perhaps I will let these newcomers flush him out, first.

Catch all my meals in one go.

Yes....

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter... soon.

Chapter 24: Queen Angella of the Moonstone

Chapter Notes

> Angella has a good morning. Nothing else happens, I'm sure. (the dark the dark the dark the dark the dark the dark)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Queen Angella of the Moonstone

Queen Angella awoke in her bed, and he was not there.

It was the first thing she realized every morning. It was the last thing she thought about when she went to bed at night. Her bed, that she had shared with Micah, for too few years of joy, and now had alone, for too many years of regret. She had known she would lose him- she loses everyone, eventually, that is the curse of immortality that she must bear- but she lost him before his time, long before his time.

It had ruined her. For many years, his death had gnawed at her; the loss of him... it had made her fearful, weak. She'd always had a cowardly side to her, somehow, despite all the efforts of her creators; a terrible sin, in Brightmoon. Brightmoon's faith was in heroism itself, was in the idea that holiness was heroic, and heroism, holy; those who were kind and brave and loving were accorded some measure of divinity, in the faith of the moonfolk. An entire religion of deeds and not words, a church of hero-saints and practicing preachers. Nothing official, of course- Angella had seen how badly that went for Plumeria and dodged *that* bullet over the centuries- but a lay faith, of rescue and reward, and

Angella had always felt a bit odd about that, to be a coward in charge of a nation of the brave.

She'd thought about it, for a long time, wondered at the genesis of the fear in her heart. Was it because she was immortal? Maybe. Most mortals seemed to have an... understanding, that their lives had a definite end, that someday they must stop. Not anything conscious, and some didn't have it, but there was a vague awareness, a sense of the ticking clock.

But that had never... never sank into her. It couldn't. She did not *have* to meet the sickle, the spinning of the clock didn't mean much for her *personally*. Oh, she understood urgency, she had tasks to do, things that had to be done on time, and she always feared what the march of time would do to those she loved, but none of that was about *her.* It was distant, far away, like news from a foreign land on the other side of the world; interesting, perhaps, but not *relevant.*

Maybe that was the reason why. She wasn't brave because she didn't *have* to be. She'd never had to *be* courageous, the way mortals had to be, simply to exist in the face of inevitable death.

(How she admired them, these bizarre butterflies, these magnificent mayflies, who lived but a moment, but could make those moments *count* , count so much that Angella felt privileged to know them, all down the years, these mortals who made her immortality worth living.)

Still, it had never been so bad, before Micah; that she was a bit spineless, but came through when it counted, was considered an almost cute foible by the few who ever figured it out, the few who

over the centuries she'd been privileged to call friends. The elder knights, who had raised her, had figured she'd grow out of it in time; and she had. She'd led the fight, time after time, in defense of Brightmoon; when the Glory Lily regime of Plumeria had blossomed, or the Frozen Empress had led the Kingdom of Snows on the warpath like an avalanche, she had been there, at her people's side. She had been terrified for every single moment of those battles, her heart had been shrieking a song of distress in her chest, but still she had fought.

No, she wasn't brave, but other things could substitute, where courage was not enough she had other virtues; loyalty to her people, duty to those she led, a sense of justice that refused to tolerate evil. Even vices could help, in a pinch; a moment's fury that kept her in the fray, a hatred that drove her to attack the one she hated instead of escaping, a fear that she would be cut down if she ran away that turned flight into *fight.*

No, she had never been brave; but she had cobbled together something *like* bravery, often enough that, when war came, she had always found the strength to stand up and fight. She had fought for her people on the frontlines of so many battles that even her nearly perfect memory had to take a moment to recall them all.

But Micah's death had, in some way, convinced her that *she,* too, would die, that this was it, and she wasn't a mortal; she had no context for it. She had imagined centuries before her; to fear that it was reduced to mere years...

She had recoiled from it. The Horde carried her death with her, it was finally here after all this time, and she...

She had fled.

She had fled in the only way she could, she had chosen not to think of it, to do anything *but* think of it. She had made her throne room into a refuge, temporary as it was doomed to be, closed herself off from the outside world as if it would protect her from it, when she well knew it would not. It had never worked for any nation that had ever tried it before, and it would not work for her now. She had rejected her daughter because her love of battle reminded Angella of the Horde, of what was coming, of the end to her immortal life that Hordak bore in his hands.

It wasn't until Catra had chosen Brightmoon that she'd had a virtue to counter her vice- *hope*. It had taken a refugee from the Horde, bringing her daughter back alive safe and sound, despite everything, to make her brave again.

(She was *so proud* of her daughter.)

But brave again she was, and so today was a little easier than yesterday, as yesterday had been a little easier than the day before, and tomorrow would be a little easier still. Widow that she was, scared as she was, she had been a widow and scared before... and her children needed her. Her people needed her. The Alliance needed her.

And she had hope that they would find a way.

So she reached out, unconsciously, for that place next to her, where he had lain before, and would never lay again... and

sighed, then thought no more of it. Life awaited her, and she could think no more on death.

(Far away, on Beast Island, something like the memory of a touch prompted Micah to ramble a memory to Scorpia as they fought angry, biting not-monkeys, a memory of the day he got married to a beautiful angel, a story Scorpia squealed with glee over as she smashed up monsters. It sounded so wonderful!... and nearby, a drone caught a glimpse of him, and the monsters of Beast Island did it no harm, made sure to give it a clear, unobstructed view of the King and his compatriot.)

Angella stayed on her bed for a few moments longer, though, organizing her thoughts. She lay sprawled out on her stomach, her wings so big that no other sleeping position was comfortable for the angel. Lovers throughout the century had mocked Angella for her undignified sleeping position; how had her Salinean captain described it? Oh yes- *you look like a flopped out fish, my sweet.*

La Mer- *Captain La Mer!* she could still hear her lover yell in correction, all these centuries later- had been like that, all salty sweet, rough and loving in equal measure. Most of her lovers were like that; Rei, her first, all fire and kindness... even Micah, who had been boisterous and brave and heroic, all the things she wasn't.

She had a type, apparently.

She huffed in amusement at the old memories as her mind went over the day's agenda. Not all that much to do. Mostly book-keeping, and listening to a few petitioners... oh, and handing

Catra a key to her bedroom. The locksmith had finally come back with them. She had one for Glimmer, too, but she wasn't here; she'd have to remember to give it to her when she got back.

Back from... Shadow Weaver.

She wasn't sure that it was a good idea to let her daughter go to the witch... but Glimmer had begged her to trust her, that she needed to know what Shadow Weaver could teach. Angella, who had dismissed her daughter for far too long, hadn't the strength or callousness to do so again, so she'd acquiesced; she'd just made her promise to be careful.

(What a strange answer her daughter had given her, though; that oddly sharp smile, followed by *Oh, I'll be careful. I wouldn't worry about* ***me.*** Angella hadn't known what to make of it, had moved on, but some part of her wondered...)

She'd have to do something about Shadow Weaver, after the war. Strip her of magic, maybe. Prison, definitely. If only half of what Catra had said was true, then the dark sorceress could not possibly be allowed to go unpunished- and worse, free, to do it again to any other children she caught in her claws.

Something to think about. If nothing else, the idea of locking up Shadow Weaver pleased Angella, and that almost made it worth it by itself.

She stretched, arms and legs and wings, and then rose up. Her eyes caught something in one corner, a glimpse of...

She snapped her head over, heart rate spiking, but... no. Just a shadow, and not a Shadow Weaver.

She shook her head, snorting. Coward was right; she had thought of her, and her mind conjured her up, like a childhood bogeyman. Actually, maybe *that* was why she was so fearful; she'd never had a proper childhood, hadn't gotten used to being frightened by monsters under the bed or in closets. Maybe that was a vital element of psychological development?

She really should fund a department to figure this out. If nothing else, she'd be interested in the results. Though how you'd test it without committing at least a few ethical violations, she had no idea.

She went to her closet, resolutely ignoring a shadow in the corner that seemed to grow a pair of eyes, watching her. Just a remnant of sleep, her brain playing tricks on her, putting the dark sorceress' face over every patch of black.

(Somewhere far away, Shadow Weaver, testing to see if she could still cast on Angella without Glimmer being present, smiled aboard Entrapta's zeppelin as she watched the Queen go about her day.)

Angella went to her closet and dressed- carefully, given that wings made it extremely difficult to just shrug on even her specifically-tailored clothes- and ate the meal already laid out for her by her personal maids. A tall stack of egg-dipped fried toast, prepared with her favorite garnishes of white chocolate and a healthy drizzle of syrup, washed down with a bit of fruit juice. Lovely!

She set to her breakfast with a will. She wasn't totally sure she *had* to eat, and neither had any of her makers, but she liked eating, especially sugary food. Another reason she was glad for her unique constitution; given her tastebuds, if she was flesh, she'd have succumbed to sugar sickness a few centuries back. There wasn't insulin enough in the world to support her usual appetites.

As she ate, the fine flavors driving out the memory of her early morning fright, she wondered if she should have dinner tonight with her daughters- well, with Catra, at least, since Glimmer wasn't home. She'd have Catra's retainers make separate meals for both of them. They had finally found some things Catra really liked, and they were good at sweet things, too.

It'd be nice. Angella so rarely got a chance to eat with her family; Catra and Glimmer were off in the war, and Angella was busy here at the Castle. Her and Catra could catch up on what Madame Razz was doing, since Catra had been oddly quiet since she'd returned yesterday, asking her retainers to keep everyone away from her private chambers, brooding on some matter or another. Her daughter would come to her in time; ordinarily she'd have prodded and poked, but talking with Glimmer had taught her a modicum of patience.

(An irony, that a Queen widely regarded as wise and regal would have been so impatient with her own child... but your own problems always provoked more emotion than those of others, and mistakes were easier to make closer to home.)

Her mind, almost involuntarily, stayed stuck on Glimmer. Her words... something about them... well, Glimmer *was* like her

father. She would not let evil stand. Angella would wait until the war was won, but Glimmer... Glimmer wasn't as patient.

But surely Glimmer would not be able to hide any such scheme, from anyone. Her daughter had never been subtle.

(And yet, some part of Angella... wondered. These *had* been years of change, after all.)

Still, nothing for it now.

Right as she finished eating, a knock came to her door.

" Yes?" she called.

" Mom?" Catra's voice, sounding... worried. Angella wondered what that was about; Catra had refused to speak with anyone " We've got something to talk about... it's the Sword. You... might wanna call the other Princesses."

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter: A fairy brute, a grieving scientist, a mage King and a Scorpion Princess stand on the soil of the Beast.

Chapter 25: The Council of the Wise on Beast Island

Chapter Notes

A reunion. I'm sure nothing will go wrong.
(I have been known to be incorrect.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Council of the Wise on Beast Island

The radio next to the laptop crackled to life.

" Anything?" Shadow Weaver's voice asked, her contralto crawling across the technology. She'd stayed on the Doom Balloon, citing a multitude of reasons that even Glimmer, who wasn't a third as good as her sister at reading people, knew to be bullshit. She'd stayed safe on the ship because Shadow Weaver's top priority was *always* Shadow Weaver.

" No," Glimmer said, resisting the urge to roll her eyes before remembering that the witch couldn't see her. She rolled her eyes after the delay, but it just wasn't as satisfying as it should be. " You can see our monitors too, Shadow Weaver, you'll know as soon as we spot something."

" I'm not on the ground," the witch pointed out, sounding petulant. " You might see something there while waiting for the

drone scouts.”

“ We'll keep you up to date,” Entrapta said. Glimmer snorted.

“ Not that we're seeing anything but a few monsters,” the Brightmoon royal said. “ Honestly, I kinda feel like this place's reputation was overblown.”

“ It is not awake yet,” Shadow Weaver said, and Glimmer'd be damned, but she almost heard... *fear* in the old monster's voice. “ Be careful.”

“ We will be,” Entrapta replied. The radio had no answer, and they were left alone on this... actually rather nice beach. Bunch of weird, discarded transports here; apparently the Horde basically fired its traitors at the island like bullets, and the transports were left behind like discarded shotgun shells.

Not like the native beasties complained. Even as Glimmer watched, she saw an octopus thing slipping inside one, staying far away from their deployment zone; the beach had been crawling with them, apparently they used the transport shells as homes. They'd even attacked, though that had been fairly easy to manage; Glimmer had blasted them with spells, ably assisted by Entrapta's bots, who now had rather nasty pickaxes to attack with.

(*A traditional weapon of my people,* Entrapta had said. *War picks have always come to hand easily for Dryl, and they're even good against armor. Also it's pretty easy to adapt a mining robot for*

combat- you're still chipping away at something, just flesh this time instead of stone.)

The next hour passed rather... leisurely. Glimmer spent most of it with nothing to do; Entrapta ran the tech, Shadow Weaver was probably drinking on the Doom Balloon, and she was just... hanging out. Technically, she was guarding Entrapta, but nothing was approaching, and they had bots on sentry duty. The most interesting thing that happened was Entrapta grabbing a big, weird-looking mech, something kind of like a big-headed gorilla, which she transported onto the Doom Balloon and put into quarantine while she was busy.

So with nothing else to do, Glimmer spent the time well, and practiced her magic. Nothing big- she definitely needed to save her juice- just fiddling with it. Light in one hand, and her new friend, darkness, in the other, bouncing the two orbs back and forth like juggling balls, feeling their essence as she palmed them, meditating on the magic. Deeper understanding made it easier to reach for them in the heat of a moment, after all.

The light first, a thing she was familiar with, she was even *named* after it, the glimmer and glamour of Etheria's most balanced Runestone. The light of it was a pale light, full of pale fires, that had heat, but nothing like what Adora had become in the world of the Portal; *that* had been a nightmare she'd heard about from Catra and their mother both, of the burning thing had Adora become, letting the light inside her skin until she fried inside and out. Something of *wild* fire, untamed, uncontrollable.

But the Moonstone's light wasn't like that, could never *be* like that. No, the Moonstone's light was mingled with darkness,

moderated, the two like perfectly-matched lovers, canceling out each other's worst qualities. The Moonstone's light wasn't as powerful as what they'd described, not so overwhelming as Adora's bright fire, but it wasn't as vicious, either. You could use it without crisping yourself like fucking bacon.

The light, this light, Glimmer was familiar with. Why, when Glimmer teleported, she became part of the Moonstone's light; she'd *been* this part of the Moonstone, multiple times a day every day, since she was a child.

But the darkness...

It was odd. It should feel... new, but it didn't. It felt familiar. Like Glimmer had always known it was there, an unconscious kind of understanding.

As she let herself feel it, really *feel* it, she felt its coldness, its sharpness, the sickle-sick weight of it, bearing down on her heart. Light was, well, light, airy, shining and free... but the darkness? Like a stone in her hand, heavy with portent and meaning, a thing that added depth to the world.

It had always been there... the Moonstone had always had a shadow inside it. Balance, after all. Light, gentled by darkness; Darkness, gentled by light.

Strange, though. She'd never seen her mom use it before. Her mother *never* used that part of the Moonstone's magic, at least as far as Glimmer knew. Why? Fear of corruption? But Glimmer had done her research, before coming to Shadow Weaver, before launching face-first into her scheme; there were other dark mages in Etheria's history, who had not been Shadow Weaver. Not many, but a few, and surprisingly, mostly among her own people; she'd found the records in some of the religious writings in Brightmoon's library, things she'd *never* thought she'd read in all her life. Figures from the past, that she'd read over in passing; a woman named Maka, called the Reaper, some guy named Johan who wrote literal entire treatises on the "gentle darkness" (and also about his lover, oh my God, he could not go ten minutes without talking about Yubel, the two must have been fucking unbearable sweethearts), a scattering of others who were less distinct in history but entirely present in myth.

Yet her mother had never used it. Either her mother had lost her knack for it... or maybe never *had* the knack.

Yeah, that felt right. Glimmer didn't think her mom could, or at least, *would* use this part. After all, the darkness? It felt like...

Death.

Death, and darkness, and all kinds of things that a mortal like Glimmer knew instinctively, but that an immortal... could her mom even *access* this half of the Runestone? *Would* she, given how scared of death she was? The shadow in the Moonstone was darkness and death, even moderated by light and life as it was.

Life and Death.

She got that. Death didn't scare her, hell, it was an old friend, she waved at it all the time. Myabe that was why the darkness had come so extremely naturally to Glimmer. Almost... eagerly, like a puppy, deliriously happy to see you.

Learning what that puppy had taken up all her time aboard the Doom Balloon. It was also *way* faster than she'd have thought it would be, especially considering she had no basis for it when she began. It was the opposite of her light, in the simplest way imaginable: the darkness was a kind of nothingness, that was the core of it.

Oh, Shadow Weaver had used a lot of other terms, describing its power in poetry, but that was just pure self-aggrandizement for the dark-aligned witch. The simple truth was, Light was a *some* thing, and Darkness was a *no* thing, and everything about them came from that distinction.

That was even why the draining magic worked; nature abhorred a vacuum. The void sought to be filled. The darkness had teeth, and an endless, endless appetite. It hungered. It wanted *more* .

(Heh, Glimmer got that; she had too much green in her eyes to do anything *but* understand. Maybe the darkness just knew she was a kindred spirit.)

The draining magic was what Glimmer had been practicing, and given how easily it came to her, she thought she might even be

able to use it in a fight, soon. That wasn't the only trick, though. Even at the most fundamental, basic level, there were other uses for it that Shadow Weaver had talked about: darkening another person's eyesight temporarily, teleporting from shadow to shadow, freezing people and objects by sucking away all heat from them. All kinds of shit.

Glimmer hadn't tried those yet, but she was eager to learn. The more she knew, after all, the easier it'd be to fight it when time came to make the nightmage *pay.* Even the magic she didn't know when she jumped Shadow Weaver would warn her of what the witch could do.

...But maybe she'd keep studying it on her own. It was so... it was so *eager* . The light had never leapt at her command like this, had treated her like... a cat, really, had come when it wanted and not a moment before. But the darkness... she almost felt like it had been *waiting* for her, waiting a long, long time.

Maybe it had been waiting over nine hundred years, from the moment of her mother's making, perhaps. It even made a strange kind of sense, given what her mother had told her, given what she could feel of this magic. It was of death... could her mother even use it? Her mother was an immortal, after all, there was no ending inside her, and that was even before taking into account that she was terrified of her own demise, could not abide the touch the shadow of death; but Glimmer, Glimmer was *more* like a mortal, even if no one knew how long she'd last. She was half a thing that died and half a thing that lived, and...

Well, that sounded an awful lot like a balance, didn't it? Like the Moonstone. It sounded almost... right.

Maybe this was meant to be. Maybe she was supposed to be this, a dark side to the Moonstone.

Hell, she was here planning an assassination, wasn't she? For the right reasons- to save her sister, to protect her family- but it was a thing of secrets and shadow, nevertheless. She'd done this in the dark, where no one could see- no one even knew she was *here,* save her fellow conspirators. Maybe this was what her real magic had been all along.

...Still...

She wasn't sure what to do with that idea. She wasn't totally sure this wasn't just her envy kicking up inside her heart, or her own wants, because it gripped her spine, this idea that she had a purpose, a place, that she wasn't just a... a glittery brute, with worthless wings. Thinking of herself as the destined wielder of the Moonstone's darkness... it made her feel... like she was more.

...Well, best to shove that somewhere deep. Think about it later, when she maybe wasn't standing on *Beast Island* .

Which... so far just... wasn't living up to reputation. Some of the monsters they saw gave an idea why Beast Island had its reputation, but honestly? Glimmer hung out with *the She-Ra* . She'd punched meaner than this before.

Still, she had the... oddest sensation, something from her years of adventure. A sixth sense saying... beware? And the air smelled like iron, which made Glimmer think of blood...

" You know," Entrapta said, as she studied her monitors, bringing Glimmer out of her introspective mood, " so far, Beast Island is more interesting than dangerous."

" Entrapta," Glimmer groaned as she dismissed her two juggling balls of magic, " you have *got* to know better than that. People only say shit like that in horror stories, and they only say it so irony can kick them in the dick."

" Those are stories," Entrapta protested. " Besides, nothing's happened."

They both paused for a beat, waiting to see if the universe would punish them for the Drylborn's tempting of fate, but nothing happened. The trackerpad Entrapta was using kept beeping along, reporting back from their drones, and a few of Entrapta's robot servitors were busy continuing to set up defensive emplacements.

Glimmer shrugged after that moment of peace. Maybe she was just being paranoid.

" Eh, guess we're alright," the Brightmoon woman said with a shrug.

“ Like I was saying,” Entrapta continued after, hair flaring around her like an excited cobra as she leaned over the monitor's keyboard, “ there's just so *much* First Ones technology here. It's fascinating! Perhaps once we have retrieved... what we came for, we can return and set up a more permanent base here. There's a *lot* of equipment here. Though all of it is in oddly poor condition. The First Ones usually built their equipment to last, both durable *and* with self-repairing properties... but this area seems almost decayed... maybe it was a junkyard?”

“ You're telling me that Beast Island is a *garbage dump?* ” Glimmer said in disbelief. “ The scariest fucking place on Etheria is just the First One's trashcan?”

“ Perhaps,” Entrapta said. “ It'd be consistent with what I'm seeing.”

Glimmer thought about that, comparing scary stories she'd been told- mostly by Catra over the years, since apparently Beast Island was the Horde's favorite threat for traitors- with the idea that the whole thing was just a place to toss old, useless crap.

“ Wow, that just... totally deflates the terror of the place,” Glimmer said. Seriously, she now felt kind of dumb for being a bit spooked. “ I'm actually kind of disappointed. Just punched the mystery *right* out.”

Entrapta didn't laugh, but her voice sounded amused, and she might have been smiling- impossible to tell, with that eerie mask on her face.

" Mystery's still there," Entrapta said. " Just a different one now! Why all the junk? Was Beast Island dangerous before, or is it only dangerous after the dumping began? So many questions!"

Her hair fell back around her, and she wavered on her... hair tail? Honestly, Entrapta's locomotion was *super* weird from Glimmer's perspective... though given that she had an odd relationship with movement too from all her teleporting, she couldn't really throw stones, she'd shatter her glass house.

" I... wish we had more time to study the place," Entrapta said, sounding very, very surprised at her own words. " Huh. I... I really want to study this place. Been a while, since I wanted to... experiment."

Glimmer, with tremendous personal effort, applied what little social grace she had and did not make a tasteless joke.

" Maybe once we finish what we came here for," Glimmer said instead, and patted her coworker on the back- err, well, on the hair, which covered most of Entrapta. She liked Entrapta, and hoped she wouldn't be too sore with her for killing Shadow Weaver when this whole Council of the Wise business was concluded; as soon as Adora went down for the count, Glimmer was gonna go full assassin on her supposed compatriot. Hopefully,

Entrapta wouldn't care, because it was *Shadow Weaver* , but you never knew!

(And if she fought to defend the witch? Well, Glimmer'd knock her out, or take her captive, or something. She wasn't gonna kill Entrapta; yeah, maybe she deserved it- Glimmer had known more than a few Rebels who died to her bots- but she'd turned it around, came back, and Glimmer liked to think that meant something.)

" True," Entrapta said. " I... wait, I've got- look!"

A tentacle of hair lashed around Glimmer's shoulder and dragged her to the console. On the screen was... people? Fighting horrible not-monkeys.

Wait, shit! She recognized one of them!

" Hey, that's Scorpia!" Glimmer said. The other one, she looked at him, but... something was goddamn familiar, in this scrawny, kind of... he looked so fucking familiar. Where had she seen him before?

The radio next to the laptop crackled at that moment.

" Micah?"

“ Who?” Entrapta asked.

“ Dad?” Glimmer said.

“ He's alive- how can he be alive- Hordak said he'd *killed* him,” Shadow Weaver growled, voice crackling with radio disruption. “ I had been willing to put it aside as a thing that had happened, no changing it, but if I'd known he was *here...* ”

From somewhere underneath the sheer *weight* of her shock, Glimmer could tell that Shadow Weaver sounded... strangely genuine. Weird. But irrelevant, her whole heart was caught up in

“ Dad,” she repeated. “ Dad, that's... how?”

“ They're under attack,” Entrapta said, reorienting them. “ We should assist.”

“ Fucking- yes!” Glimmer said, hurling her surprise off. “ Where are they?!?”

“ Drone has location, deploying sky cycle, we'll get there faster if we ride them!” Entrapta said, typing rapidly on her laptop. “ Hop on when it gets down here!”

The fuck is a sky cycle? Glimmer thought, before the Doom Balloon answered her, a long, cylindrical object rocketing out of its front. It descended, revealing an odd, tubular thing, that looked rather like an engine shaped like a bicycle; repulsors on either side stablilized it. Entrapta leapt on, hair wrapping around the handles as her hands held the laptop.

" Come on!" she said, and Glimmer needed no further encouragement, teleporting onto the cycle. Entrapta slammed forward on the handle, and off they roared, racing into the depths of the forest, chasing the drone's transmissions.

(They did not see the vines close up the forest behind them, or how the canopy grew denser, closer, and the trees begin to fill with flying things that might snatch the passengers right off a flying vehicle.)

Faster, faster, roaring down the forest's clear spaces, Entrapta not the best driver in the world but they had a fairly straight shot; forward, forward, until they reached a clearing where two figures fought a pitched battle. One was a feminine giant, all pincers and stinging tail; the other was a weather-beaten, skinny man, who spat bolts of magic at his enemies.

Glimmer's heart punched her in the throat as they arrived, her dad, it was her dad, he had a weird staff made out of trees and he was half-naked and looked like shit and it was her *dad,* her *dad* , her *dad* was *alive* and he'd been on *Beast Island* ...

A thing was attacking her dad. She teleported off the bike, ahead of Entrapta, straight into a massive right hook that knocked the beast's teeth out.

She'd just saved her.... her father, holy *fuck* , she could think about that now, her dad, her DAD.

" Dad!" she yelled. Micah turned around, and she caught his bewildered look.

" Dad? I *am* a dad!" he announced cheerfully. " Got a little girl! Glimmer! You should meet her, stranger!"

While Glimmer stared at her father, a pair of monkeys tried to jump the father and daughter; Entrapta interrupted them by ramming the skycycle into them.

" Please pay attention!" the tech genius yelled. " I've got more flyers coming to get us, but we have to fight these off, first!"

" Entrapta!" Scorpia said, as she stung an ape-thing. " Glimmer! What are you doing here?!?"

" You see them too?" Micah asked her. " I have a lot of delusions, so you see the snaky-snaky-hair lady on the cool flying bike and, uhh, this woman? Don't know her, she's short and stout, like a teapot! Got my wife's hair too!"

He turned to her, with a wide, completely innocent grin, as Entrapta kept attacking the monkeys, wrapping her hair around them and constricting them, or simply running them over on her skycycle.

" Are you related to her? She's the Queen!" he said brightly. " Of Brightmoon. Don't know why she's not a Princess. Everybody else is a Princess. Maybe once you live long enough you get to be a Queen? I wonder if I'm a Queen now, I'm old! Older. I think! Been here a while. Maybe. Hard to tell. This place... does stuff to you."

Glimmer stared at him, as Scorpia and Entrapta, catching up in the background, faded from her hearing; she barely noticed as the duo of former Hordesman talked, fighting off the beasts, cheerfully greeting each other, Entrapta delighted that Scorpia was alive, Scorpia delighted that her friend was here.

" Are *you* the Princess of Brightmoon?" Micah asked after a moment. " Or... you... your clothes, those are Brightmoon colors. Is there a Princess, even? Feels like there should be. I was King you know! Still am unless Angie's divorced me. I hope she hasn't. That'd be awful to come home too! We have a daughter and everything."

" I know," Glimmer said, as she realized that this place had... had not been good for him, that there was more of Micah gone than there was left, and tears stung her eyes. " I know, because... I'm your daughter. You're my dad."

“ What? But you're... so much older than my...” he said, then blinked, and it was like watching the moon shift phases; he looked at her with a critical eye, and his voice deepend, became more stable, as a moment's lucidity punched through the lunacy. “ I... how long?”

“ Years,” she said. “ Dad, I-”

“ The monsters have retreated!” Scorpia announced, interrupting her. The arachnid Princess walked over to them, grinning widely as Entrapta circled back on her battered, bruised skycycle, whose front had not liked its repeated collisions into monsters. “ And boy, I hope you guys didn't get exiled here too! Adora sent me here and I tell you what, this is a *bad* vacation spot. Just the worst.”

“ We have a ship,” Entrapta said, and she even lifted her mask, smiling at Scorpia. “ We came to save you! And apparently King Micah, we didn't know he was here, but we've got lots of room aboard the Doom Balloon!”

“ The... what?” Scorpia asked, blinking.

“ Airship,” Entrapta said. “ Scorpia, I can't- I can't believe you're alive! I'm so glad to see you!”

“ It's all thanks to Micah!” she said, patting the man on the shoulder. “ He saved me!”

Micah didn't even notice, his eyes wandering far away places.

" How... how is Angie?" he asked his daughter.

" Mom's fine," Glimmer said, as the tears started to pour down her face. " She'll be even better when you're home."

" I've missed so much," Micah said, looking at his daughter, a woman grown. " I've missed... so much."

" You won't miss a moment more," Glimmer swore to him.

And as if the island had just been *waiting* for such a cue, there was a sound that blocked out all thought.

AINRETE OT NRUTER

(*a glittery brute with worthless wings a glittery brute with worthless wings a glittery brute with worthless wings*)

Between one eyeblink and the next, Glimmer found herself on her knees. The sound, the sound, the *sound* ; her father tried to do something but failed, he tried to cast a spell but the magic fizzled out, he wasn't strong enough to complete it, too weak or too distracted or too *something* , and even as he fell a vine crawled to his staff and stole it, taking it from him.

Another blast.

STINU LLA. DERIUQER

(*I'm so jealous, so jealous, Catra is so much better than me, how awful is that, I'm so jealous, everyone is so much better than me, I'm not even a real Princess, they only let me stay with them because Catra is my sister and my mom is Angella, I have no worth by myself, I'm just a glittery brute with worthless wings*)

What was this? The sound ripped through her heart, and cut open all her old scars. Every mistake, every hurt. Every regret.

Every awful goddamn thing in her life, every thought she'd ever had that *hurt* her, all at once, bleeding again. Tears poured from her eyes as her soul was shredded by the sound, the signal, that never *stopped* , it pulsed, it pumped, it spoke in its alien tongue and her mind crumbled under the weight of it.

Dimly, she perceived- through eyes already going dark- vines, black vines, crawling on her. She tried a blast of light magic, barely able to summon it, but the vines just laughed, ignored it, and she felt the *contempt* of the Island; so many had come with light, and they had failed, it was well-inured against the force of brilliance. Through ears that could barely hear anything over the echoes of the *signal* in her soul, she heard... crying?

She looked up, straining her neck as the vines closed in. Her dad, face turned away from her, lying down... but she could hear him. He was whimpering something about losing his mind, imagining his older daughter, whom he'd never see, crying that he'd finally cracked under the pressure. Entrapta, curled up on herself as the vines grew, sobbing and sobbing, apologizing to people who weren't even there, sorry, she was so sorry, and crying for Hordak, whom she had loved. Scorpia, who had been driven to one knee only, who was doing better than anyone else, who was struggling to stand... but then there were biting beasts on her and she was dragged down, too.

Then the signal sounded again.

NOITAUCAVE EDIWTENALP

(*I'm not enough, I never am, can't keep up, never could, not with Mom and not with Catra and not... not with this, I'm not strong enough, just a glittery brute with worthless wings*)

Glimmer strained, desperately, for any source of strength inside herself, as Beast Island opened wide its maw to swallow them all whole.

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: The message Beast Island sends out in its signal is actually in the episode itself. The sound it makes is a backmasked recording... look it up.

Next time...?

Chapter 26: Princess Adora of the Horde

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Princess Adora of the Horde

What a *lovely* day.

It was one of those days that made you feel like everything was alright. Oh, Adora was sure that someone, somewhere else, was having a shitty day- that's just how things went, on a big old world- but as for herself?

She was having a lovely, lovely day.

Her sister's power flowed through her as she sat in her office, pondering the remnant artifacts before her. It was... constant, less prone to flaring up or dying down than she'd have expected. A fire constant and might as the sun... whatever a sun was. Just another new word in her head, something her sister understood that she didn't, that she'd figure out in time. Something big and glorious, she knew that much of it.

Outside, the people of the Horde moved about, packing things, making last minute preparations, readying for one last push. An air of celebration, of jubilation, reigned, and she thought she

heard a few people singing. It was... nice, though the voices were terribly rough.

Still, it was nice, to hear her people sing. It meant she wasn't doing half-bad as a Lord... or a Princess, she supposed, a thought that made her grin.

Sure, she'd had to lie about it, but that didn't really bother her; it was one of the least hurtful lies she'd ever told, in all her long and storied career as a deceiver. Some of the Horde probably wouldn't have cared, but honestly? She feared the Horde wouldn't accept her, if she was honest about what she was. The Horde had defined itself, after all, as the land that *opposed* the Princesses. The common man, rising up against inhuman overlords. Bullshit propaganda, but one believed in by many, Lonnie not least of all.

But she had heard nothing from Lonnie, her erstwhile spymaster, about disgruntlement or insubordination, so apparently the lie had worked. And why wouldn't it? She'd been lying to the Horde from the start, claiming to be Hordak's successor, claiming Shadow Weaver taught her magic; what was one more fib, tossed onto the pile?

Although she *did* kind of want to tell the truth, if only because the idea of a Princess of the Horde kind of cracked her up. It'd be *hilarious* to go around announcing herself as Princess Adora, for the sheer dissonance if nothing else. Maybe she'd grab some stationary and send letters through messengers to the other Princesses someday, asking to join the Alliance now that she was a Princess. If nothing else, she was sure the return letters she'd get would be great fun to read.

Maybe she'd do it, and ask Double Trouble how the other Princesses had reacted, get it straight from the changeling's mouth- well, from their form, given the shapechanging. It'd be good for a laugh.

She hoped Double Trouble checked in soon. She hadn't heard from them for a bit, but that wasn't unusual. Spy work, by its nature, wasn't the most consistent of tasks, and with Catra distracted, Double Trouble didn't think anyone else would catch on to them. Who was going to figure it out, Glimmer?

Adora snorted in amusement at the very idea, as she leaned back in her chair, taking a break to listen to the rough songs outside. They had a bit of sea shanty in them; something about a guy named Barret and his privateers, a song that seemed to be half curses, which meant it was a little under the average for Salinean songs. Wasn't bad, not by any measure.

Adora knew, of course, that at least some of the cheer among her troops was because the upcoming battles would be their last fight for a while. She had a plan now, a goal; and it was so simple, so straightforward. After all her schemes, her lies, her tricks, now she finally had so much power that she could just brute force a solution to all her troubles.

It was nice.

Admittedly, the Horde was a bit stretched right now, which was *why* she'd made her plan dependent on a final battle. She *could* keep fighting... but not for much longer. Just a look outside her office's window showed how much the Horde was stretching to control what it already had; she'd never seen the Fright Zone so empty. The manpower problem wasn't fatal for now, but it was definitely starting to show. She'd resorted to making even *more* Hordebots to compensate, but that only went so far, and they weren't as good as proper Hordesmen. Her defenses at home were a lot weaker now, even if Adora, personally, was much more powerful.

(Let Netossa come, with her little strike force. Let her arrive. The very thought brought a grin to Adora's face. They would find no easy target, but a Dragon in her lair...)

Which had led her to a simple revelation, once she was back from the sanity-fortifying trip to the wasteland: if she tried to keep going, she'd lose. The plain truth was that the Horde just didn't have the manpower to conquer Etheria. It turned out the world was *big* . Much bigger than it felt like when you just said "the world." Miles and miles of territory, that had to be crossed by soldiers on the ground; and people there, too! Lots of them! All trying to kill you!

It just wasn't doable. Even Hordak's staggering conscription rates and ability to cheat on logistics due to his robotics and automated facilities couldn't keep up an assault on the entire world. She'd need twice the forces she had to make it even possible, and realistically she'd need even more to make it practical.

Which wasn't to demean anything Hordak had already accomplished. That the Horde existed at all- and had genuinely

contested control of all Etheria for as long as it had- went beyond impressive into nigh-on mythical territory. He even had the chops for a legendary hero, had the right story to tell; he went from a confused exile to a warrior king. She'd have to make a statue for him.

(she wants to say she's sorry to him, but she cannot, and so she will do her best, make a memorial for him, so the Horde never forgets its progenitor)

Still, nobody was perfect; well, nobody except maybe Catra, in Adora's admittedly deeply biased opinion. The colossus of a nation Hordak had built, amazing as it was, had feet of clay. Hordak's own death had undoubtedly accelerated the process by kicking open new cracks in the foundation- just another thing her moment of madness had cost her- but the weakness had always been there. The Horde was a magnificent sword, wickedly sharp, but the blade was brittle.

Or, to use a metaphor her sister might appreciate more, and that Adora had to admit she preferred, too: the fire couldn't last. It was too hot, burning up too much fuel. The Horde had to take some time off, had to rebank the coals, had to restock. It needed *time.* Time to build up weapons. Time to consolidate current gains. Time to reorganize. Time for Hordesman to have kids and raise those kids, which was going to be the biggest of all her planned changes; Hordak had banned pregnancy in the ranks, which was a fairly easy rule to obey, since he had figured out fairly cheap birth control drugs and distribute them freely.

(Well, Adora would never have violated that rule, for entirely different reasons related to her interest only in muscular women, but that was besides the point.)

His reasoning for the restriction, interestingly, seemed to have come about mostly due to disgust on Hordak's part regarding the whole have-sex-make-babies mess. From his notes, which she'd been reading religiously every time she had a spare moment now that she was back, he seemed to have a dismissive attitude to natural birth at best, and a kind of horror at it at worst. Not as "clean", he'd said, as "pure", as his brother's cloning process.

(Who was this brother? Why did he write of him not like kin, but like a priest speaking of his god, why did her blurry eye see flickers of green light when she read of him, what *was* he?)

But beyond his disgust and his own need to have a new body, Hordak had been fixated on cloning, and had seemed to think it would be the future for the Horde. He even had notes on which Troopers to clone; Adora had felt a bizarre sense of pride that she was the first name on the list he'd written down in one of his journals. Alongside her as possible templates for Horde troops were Lonnie, Rogelio, Dreer, Mantenna, and somewhat to her surprise, Catra.

(Clones of Catra... a multitude of Catras, all in the Horde... oh. Hmm. *Hmm.* Adora blushed at the direction her thoughts went, and felt a warmth in her veins that had *very* little to do with the Spirit Ember's might.)

Apparently Hordak had not shared Shadow Weaver's distaste for the magicat recruit. He'd even made a comment in his writings that she might make a good Force Captain if needed, though her tendency towards insubordination was also noted. Hordak had never entirely believed Shadow Weaver's obsessive dismissiveness towards Catra.

The very idea of Catra as a Force Captain brought a smile to Adora's face. How would *that* have worked out? Catra was always going to be the She-Ra, was always going to be good... she'd never have stayed with the Horde.

Or if she had, if she'd been evil instead, would someone else have picked it up? Maybe another Princess... probably Mermista, she had proven thorn enough in Adora's side. She'd probably end up with it. Or one of Catra's best friends, like that Glimmer, the one who wasn't a real Princess. Her mom had the Runestone connection, not her; Glimmer just drew off of it like a tick. Maybe she'd get it, have power all her own.

Could a man get it? Bow was a good man, nearly as good as Catra. But then what would they call a male She-Ra? He-Ra? No, that didn't sound quite right. He-Man? That sorta fit, made something tickle right in the back of Adora's skull, sounded right to her First One mind. Though given how much he loved archery, would he even know what to *do* with a sword?

...Wait, hadn't Shadow Weaver thought *Adora* would end up with the blade?

Adora paused, considering. How would *that* have worked out for everyone? Adora would obviously have stayed with the Horde, probably become Hordak's favorite Force Captain for her power... Catra would still leave, most likely. She was good, after all, and she would never have tolerated the Horde for long. Adora couldn't imagine a world where Catra would not end up opposing her, somehow; that was how it went. Adora was villain, Catra was hero. The battle between them was... inevitable.

So Catra would go to the Alliance, probably to figure out something; Catra was smart, resourceful, she'd have been a hero of the Alliance anyway. And Adora... she'd be Shadow Weaver's most favored pet... she wondered how much of her mind Shadow Weaver would have messed with, how much of her would even be *left* , if she'd gotten the Sword.

And worse... she'd heard rumors, over the years, of dark sorcerers stealing bodies. Just fairy tales, assuredly, scary things to frighten yourself with at night... but then again, She-Ra had been a myth for a thousand years, too, and that hadn't stopped Adora from spending four years of her life fighting her. If Adora got the Sword... well, between the power of She-Ra and being a First One, her body was quite a prize, wasn't she?

Was that the old witch's goal? Had that been the plan, all along? Adora took the Sword and Shadow Weaver took Adora, slipped her soul right into Adora's body, stole the power of She-Ra and her First One blood all in one go.

...Maybe Catra finding the Sword had saved Adora's life, odd as the thought was. Without the She-Ra, Adora was not valuable enough for Shadow Weaver to rip her soul out and wear her face. If Adora had found the Sword instead, her body might be up and about, moving around, doing things, but Adora would not live there anymore...

Nightmarish.

She wondered if Shadow Weaver would try it anyway, but with Catra as the target now. She *was* in the Alliance, after all. Maybe she'd just... slip right in...

No, it'd been a while. She'd have done it by now if she could. Perhaps Queen Angella was on guard for that very thing, or one of the other mages near the mighty She-Ra.

Adora hoped so. Shadow Weaver didn't *deserve* to take Catra's great deeds from her, and Adora would kill her if she tried... well, she was going to kill her anyway, but the very *idea* of Shadow Weaver hurting Catra...

She idly palmed a fireball, let the magic swirl into burning life in her hand. She had light enough for the dark mage, now, yes indeed. She'd have to remember to make Shadow Weaver's death a prerequisite for peace. Wasn't like anyone on the other side would argue with her on it; who liked fucking *Shadow Weaver?* She'd been the closest thing Adora had to a mom, and even she hated the woman!

(Maybe Catra, who had never given up the hope of being loved... but surely she'd figured it out by now? Or was not letting go Catra's one true weakness? She'd never given up on Adora, either, after all...)

How would the war go, in a world with She-Ra in the Horde? There wouldn't be an Alliance, either, it had reformed mostly due to She-Ra's return...

...No, Catra would have figured out a way. Catra was good, after all. She'd have fought Adora, Sword or no Sword. Maybe gotten into technology, as a counter to greater magic? A Catra in old First Ones technology, to fight a First One gone wrong; yes, that felt right, somehow, that felt correct. An iron lion to oppose a wicked She-Ra...

Still, she should stop thinking about this. What might have been, *what if* , were seductive words, but they didn't describe anything real. However a world where Adora got the Sword would have worked out, for good or for ill, she lived in one in which Catra had found it, and she had to return to more practical considerations.

Like cloning!

...She lived a weird life.

She wished she *could* clone her soldiers. Adora saw the sense in it- a clone army would be a nightmare to deal with and would solve all of her personnel problems in one fell swoop- but it was a pipe dream. She was much less of a scientist than her predecessor, belonging instead to magic, and even Hordak's brilliance hadn't been able to make the clones work. Maybe if they still had Entrapta... who had tried to stop her from the Portal, a decision that, in hindsight, was wildly incorrect.

Maybe she should apologize, if Entrapta would hear it... but she doubted she would. She'd shipped the Drylborn's best friend Scorpia off to Beast Island, and murdered the man she loved; there would be no reconciliation between them. How could there

be? It'd take the end of the world, and Adora had no intentions of making *that* happen again.

(What a thing, to know she had once engendered an apocalypse with the flip of a switch. What did you call a thing like her, that had almost murdered a world with a movement of her hand and arm?)

So without Entrapta or Hordak, she had no chance of figuring out the cloning process, unless there was a magical solution she could brute-force.

Maybe she'd get the science teams on it... but no, she needed them working on bots, and on the infrastructure to support her sister. The Spirit Ember so far had played entirely nice, Adora was in complete control, but her sister had melted one Kingdom already. Adora didn't want to add onto her burden of guilt, and *definitely* didn't want the Horde to go up in smoke. So protective measures were to be installed- along with wiring. Her sister produced a lot of heat, they could probably replace at least a few of the power plants with her. If nothing else, it'd cut down on costs.

(Though admittedly, using a *Runestone* to generate electricity, however practical, felt a little rude. The Ember had registered no complaint, but it still felt impolite at best.)

A shame. It'd be easier than trying to figure out how to make the Horde a place people could live, instead of just a military force. The lands the Horde controlled would have to be reorganized, homes built, a place a new generation could rise up; honestly, the more she looked at it, the more clear it was that Hordak had a lot of experience with *military* matters, but had no idea how to make a *nation* . He'd papered it over with propaganda and the sheer

relentless, crushing need of the War- and Adora should know, she'd done the same damn things herself- but once Adora's plan went through, one of those things would be gone.

She'd need to make this a real country, write laws for all kinds of things that didn't currently have any consideration in the Horde. The Horde was a war machine, and a war machine only; she'd have to reconstitute it, cannibalize some of the parts of the machine to make it capable of doing more. Figure out better food production- the factory farms and the ration bars worked really well, provided all necessary nutrition, but her people would need some variety in their diet, for their own enjoyment if nothing else. And how was child-rearing going to work? The Horde had an ID system, at least, she could easily adapt that to deal with births, but she'd need hospitals and... shit, she'd need midwives and doctors. Did anyone in the Horde know how to deliver kids? And the Horde had every sentient species in Etheria in it, she'd need a doctor for each!

Shit. The task before her was *tremendous.* Not her first choice, either... but she simply couldn't keep attacking Etheria, even with all her newfound strength. Adora was just one woman, after all; she couldn't be everywhere at once. Besides, the Horde had always moved and fought as a collective; the war effort would not, and could not, depend on one person, even a person as mighty as Adora.

...Maybe she should hold a meeting with all the Force Captains? Figure out what laws they thought would be a good idea. Or maybe more than that; who knew who would have good ideas to use? She'd have to ask Lonnie, she was Adora's ears on the ground; she'd know who to ask. Set up a few meetings, get her

act together. The laws were going to be too big for just Adora alone.

Though she knew one thing that she'd definitely put on the agenda: laws protecting kids from their own parents.

(For Catra... and for a little girl Adora had once been, who had never been able to make Shadow Weaver just *stop* .)

All of that would be so much *work...* it made her long for the cloning plan. With cloning, she wouldn't have to do any of that. Just clone a bunch of troopers and send them into the fray! No problems!

Though, now that she was thinking about it, Hordak was right about only cloning *some* of them. The idea of an entire army of *Kyles* made her laugh out loud. That'd be a sight to see! Even as good at enforcing discipline as Kyle had gotten, he was still a godforsaken *terrible* fighter. Admittedly, he hung out with Rogelio, Lonnie and Adora, so he probably was actually pretty decent by most people's standards, but *okay* was not enough for the command squad. *Very Good* was the bare *minimum* standard they needed.

Speaking of Kyle...

Before her were the pieces of the device Scorpia had destroyed, to save all their lives in the cold. She'd been so *angry* , when Scorpia did it, had dreamed of keeping her Catra as a pet berserker, treating her well... with some distance, she could see

that Scorpia had been entirely correct. And a little piece of her... regretted sending her to Beast Island. That had been cruel, yet another product of that slow burning down, the shattering of her soul that had started with *You're a First One* and her revelation of what that meant, in the face of all the evil she'd done, of how far from grace she'd fallen, her wings burning up on impact with the ground.

(No wonder her family had left her in a field. They must have known she was corrupt from the start.)

It was no excuse, though. She... shouldn't have done that. Even for how much she'd hated Scorpia- hated her innocence, hated her smile, hated how *much* like old Adora that Scorpia was, and every reminder- there had... she didn't deserve Beast Island. She didn't deserve death.

But it was in the past, and could not be changed, so she moved on. Scorpia was no doubt dead by this point. Beast Island brooked no challenge, and no one had *ever* returned, save the merest scouting trips, who had been on the island only for a matter of hours; anyone who stayed longer died.

(Maybe she'd make a memorial for Scorpia, put it next to the one for Hordak, whom she'd murdered, and... she shouldn't have, she shouldn't have pulled that switch, she thinks... and fears... that she will regret that moment for the rest of her life, regret all of it until the day she dies)

No, right now, she stared at this blast from her past. It had made a berserkergang out of Catra, something almost unstoppable, at least when it wasn't rendering her drunk. She had a few ideas about... channeling it. Using it to give a loyal soldier a boost. Runes of truth painted on the pieces, maybe a few extra little

things, and a piece of Hordak's remnant cyborg tech to implant it in flesh... would it let a person stay sane, even as it boosted their strength?

Because truth be told, her squad needed the help. They didn't have Entrapta's tech to fall back on anymore; the tech genius had once built them suits, but Adora's had melted right off of her in the ruins of the Fire Kingdom, and they couldn't repair what the others were using anymore. Too advanced. Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle were just people, not Princesses; they'd done amazing considering their opposition, but Adora wanted more for them.

And what kind of terrible friend would Adora be, if she didn't try to provide it for them? Not to mention how badly it would reflect on her as a leader, not to try and make her squad as strong as possible.

So the Flame Princess would spend today... experimenting. Figuring out what worked, what didn't. She had a few days, before the big march, the last for a while. Before they took Plumeria, conquered and crushed the entire kingdom, and then made the rest of the Alliance sue for peace, or else they'd kill Perfuma and destroy her Runestone in the bargain. *That* would make them back down. Plumeria was the nation closest to the Horde, the easiest to invade... and Adora wielded fire, what could the plant Princess do against that? Then they'd enter a period of peace... and then, later...

Well.

For Hordak, whom she'd murdered; for her people. For all her mistakes and all the terrible things she'd *already* done, which would be worthless if she quit now.

She'd take all of Etheria. Hordak's dream would not die with him. It was the least she could do, for the man who had saved the baby that would grow up to become his murderer; she'd... she'd atone, in the only way she could.

All of Etheria, under one banner, one flag, one nation.

With such happy thoughts, Adora began weaving her spells on the artifacts, all while musing on what a *lovely* day it was.

Chapter End Notes

Author's Notes: Don't forget that, for all that Adora might have started to heal some in the wasteland, she's still what she is- a warlord, a conqueror. Every journey begins with a single step, but it takes a great many steps to get anywhere. (But a first step is still a first step.)

The song they're singing is a somewhat modified Barret's Privateers, a real-world shanty which I chose because it's a rare "modern" sea shanty, which fits with the Horde's futuristic themes. Sea shanties are heavily associated with Salineas on Etheria, which annoys a lot of the coastal Crownless nations; Barret's Privateers in this universe is a famous Crownless sea shanty about a group of guys from one of the coastal nations trying to raid Salinean shipping, and getting their shit kicked in for their troubles. As a very common tale among the Crownless seafaring nations is "I tried to attack a Salinean ship and they beat the hell out of me", it spread to the point that nobody's really sure which

nation originated it, though arguments, often pedantic, sometimes violent, break out among scholars over the issue.

Chapter 27: BEAST ISLAND OF ITSELF ALONE

Chapter Notes

Just in time for Halloween; the monster eats.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

BEAST ISLAND IN THE SKULLS OF ITS PREY

Meat.

My tongue clicks along my teeth; there are pieces of them there, caught in my teeth, and they taste so fine. Just the first bite, and there is so much to savor here.

The first- the oldest prey- he is sour. Bitter. How he hates me. And how I hate him! The only prey who has ever evaded me for long, the one prey who has truly beaten me at the game, loathe as I am to admit it.

But he has lost, finally. To snatch his defeat in my jaws is the greatest of my victories, and I catch him, crack him open like a chestnut; oh, how his outsides sting! His hatred of me, his defiance, his spirit, bent but not broken, the man who went mad so that I could not drive him insane.

But the sight of his daughter- the revelation of how much time had passed, how much he has *lost* as he ran from me- has cut through his suffering, opened his ears to my song; and now, in his lucid moment, I have him. He is too busy trying to keep me out of his head to work his clever magics now,

I can taste it, underneath the shell of tangy acid that surrounds his core. His pain, which I have waited to eat for so long, his despair over all the time he has lost, the umami that I so long for. I will chew and chew and chew until I am through his walls, until his insides come spilling out into my mouth and I gulp down his guts into my greedy throat. He will go first; I will not risk him escaping. I must eat him, eat him *now* , before he has a chance to fool me once more.

After all, there *is* a saying about being fooled twice, and who the shame belongs to.

The others are less personal triumphs, but two are fine meals. The last, the scorpion, she is boring, she is too strong of will to be worth tormenting and too sweet to be subject to personal suffering; her pain and her cheer both are open things, simple in nature, and there is nothing inside for me to savor.

Still, she'll have her use. A mint, a small sheet of ginger, something to cleanse my palette between bites of better meals. She resists, but it is no matter; she has no way to escape.

The real prize, of course, is the serpent; ah, yes, yes, *yes.* Not a meal to be casually devoured. Not something to chew up and spit

out. I must... prepare her. I must fillet her, pick away at her pain, prepare her in just the right way. Figure out the exact order to arrange her memories in, so that when I force her to relive them, the pain reaches its height. Give her joy enough that she forgets the hurt is inevitable, so that each torment is fresh, new, and she is never able to grow scars thick enough to stop the pain.

So much here. Her love for one she refers to as *Him* , for Hordak, who has for long years fed me quite well... he is dead. Interesting. I suppose I shall have to start singing to sailors, again, the way I did before the Horde used me as a prison camp. Her love for him swallows her whole, a faultline that she falls in and is lost.

Though... another whom she **hates** , who now rules the Horde. A vision, hallucinatory- a great golden dragon, a red flame dancing, resolving into a scarred and seared Lord... I can taste the barest echoes of this Adora's soul on Entrapta's. They were friends, once, or at least, Entrapta thought they were. There is, mingled in with the **hate** , a strange kind of... sadness, that Adora was never her friend. It adds a delightful drop of wistfulness to the heat of her rage, like a sprinkle of sugar in a shot of vodka.

This Adora, though... something is strange about her. Just echoes of her soul can I taste... remnants of Entrapta's dealings with her... but it seems oddly familiar, to me. The composite pieces of my making- the many pieces of me that were built, long ago, by the invaders- they... recall this taste.

One of my accidental makers?

Impossible. But the flavor, it is the same. One of the ones they call the First Ones, the invaders. My creators, though never on purpose. I was never an intended thing. They dumped all their waste here, and in time, I grew a soul out of the disparate failures and cast offs here. Even my song is a distress signal, the last echoes of an alien voice, warped by me into a distressing signal over long centuries.

Interesting. Perhaps she will follow in the vein of her ancestors and her predecessor both, and she will feed me, dropping her unwanted here on my shores.

Something to ponder. I do not need to eat, but oh, it is the only thing I truly enjoy; I would hate to have to sleep again, until they forget, the way I have had to do before. Sleep, until they colonize me, until there is a village in my woods, and they awaken me, the people to be lost in a single night of horror.

I much prefer it like this- one meal, savored slow.

And what a feast! All these influences, these little bits of other souls... and oh, what is this? A new thing. A blossom, in the secretmost place of her heart. A thorny stem, topped with twin roses, purple and pink. I am not sure she herself is aware of it. Something born of kindnesses unexpected, of gentleness where she expected harshness, and on each leaf is written *it is not important that roses have thorns, but that thorns have roses* .

What a delight! It will be another fishhook in her skin. I will dangle it before her, when she is happy, to remind her that she is

betraying the memory of her dead love; oh, what hurt, what fun!

I shiver in anticipation. What other wonders will I find, as I cut her open? What new seasoning shall I find for this meal?

Ah, it will be wonderful.

Still, the clever prey first. Business before pleasure, though I *do* take such pleasure in eating him, in eating this Micah, who has evaded me so long. Soon his shield will burst; already it cracks, already I taste more and more of him, bleeding in my teeth. Then I shall pop the scorpion in my mouth and chew her like bubblegum, wash my mouth out with her soul, and then move on to Micah's daughter. I shall make sure Entrapta watches that one; she is friends with Glimmer, to the extent she is friends with anyone now, and knowing she has led her to her doom will... please me.

And I shall send flyers after their vessel. Not many. Just enough to convince the witch aboard to leave.

I want the darkling aboard to escape. She will hurt others, in time, and that amuses me. In reward for being like me in spirit, I shall give her leave to escape me; I have my mercies... and my amusements. A parasite like her, who takes and gives nothing back... it amuses me, to send her among the healthy, so she may sicken them.

Though, speaking of darkness... the one who tried to use light on me... I am used to it, this half-Princess is not the first person to come and try to purge me with light and fire... but there is the strangest thing I taste on the tip of my tongue when I lap at her... a coldness that burns my tongue. A...

Darkness?

Chapter End Notes

Glimmer, and revelation.

Chapter 28: Princess Glimmer of the Darkness

Chapter Notes

One last go with Beast Island before we go back to Catra.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Princess Glimmer of the Darkness

Glimmer knew this one fact about Beast Island:

It hated her.

Not in the abstract sense. Her, *personally.* A mind the size of an island hated her, hated everything about her, held her in such incredible contempt that it had physical weight. She could feel its dismissal slithering through every part of her soul. It *hated* her, it hated her so much that it loved the fact she was suffering; its tongue snaked into her, to lap at that salt, that suffering, and even as it fed it mocked her with every breath.

No wonder no one escaped Beast Island. The hate, the hate, the *hate* ; a person could be destroyed by the contempt or poor treatment of another person, how could the spirit survive the same kind of assault with the weight of an island behind it? There wasn't a word for it, not in any language Glimmer knew. On the

few pounds of meat in her skull pressed something a thousand times her size, that wanted only what was worst for her.

Holy *shit* .

She could- just barely, under the sound, under the *signal* - hear the words it slurred to the others, in its hot breath and lecher's tongue. A record of Entrapta's losses, both the ones she had suffered and the ones she'd inflicted on others. Sneering at Scorpia's love for Catra and her weakness, her inability to fight it off.

Telling her dad he'd gone mad.

...Her dad.

Her dad was *alive* , she'd found him, she... she couldn't wrap her head around that, her dad was dead, he was dead, he was dead, but... no. Alive. *Here,* on Beast Island. *Her dad was alive.*

...Her dad was alive, and...

She had to save him.

She had to save him. She had to bring him back home to mom, who had been hurt so much by his death; she had to save him because Glimmer loved him. She had to save him.

...She had to get back home. Her mom didn't deserve to wonder where she was, to be alone, to lose another family member before her time. Her sister, Catra, deserved to have a sister, and she loved them both, she wanted to see them again.

...The thought, the *love* , gave her the strength to lift a single arm, and put it against the ground. The Island did not notice, as she struggled, her thoughts trying to stay afloat over the pain.

…

It was repeating all her own insults at her. But... that was the thing, wans't it?

Hadn't she said all these things to herself before?

A glittery brute with worthless wings. Yeah, she'd said that herself. She'd said it a *lot* .

So...

Why the *fuck* was she letting it hurt her?

...She *wouldn't* let it hurt her.

And with that, through an effort worthy of great heroes, Glimmer found the impossible strength to move her other arm, and put it to the ground.

It was focused on her father, chewing on him, hurting him; it did not see.

She kept thinking. She loved her family, her friends- she wanted to see the other Princesses again. She wanted to hang out with Frosta, who thought she was cool, the way Glimmer had never thought of herself; she wanted to fight bad guys with Perfuma. She wanted to hear Mermista complain about the man she loved...

And... Bow, she wanted to see Bow again, she wanted to kiss him, she wanted to know if she was just his type, he said he liked short girls once, didn't he?

...She wanted that.

And she... she hated, too. She hated this fucking island, for thinking it had a right to hurt her; she hated this fucking island, she had said these things to herself and she'd done it *better* .

She'd called herself a lot of names before. You didn't grow up with immortal, perfect Queen goddamn Angella as your mom, and not... see yourself, in the mirror. See how fat, how ugly, how pathetic you really were.

See how pathetic, how *worthless* , your little wings were.

But she'd been better at it. She'd been a harsher critic than some fucking *dirt* . She was *better* than this goddamn place! Better at demeaning herself, better at loving, better at *everything she was not fucking dying here!*

From her position on the ground, with all of Beast Island on her back, Glimmer nonetheless found the strength to push. The black vines around her pulled, tugged, but could not hold her, not when the pain they fed on grew so weak.

She snapped them, and stood up.

It noticed *that* . The *signal* blared again, and her companions screamed.

Glimmer screamed, too, but what she screamed was " **Fuck you!** "

It could not hurt her if she did not let it.

The *signal* droned on and on, but like a song played too often, it had lost its magic. There was nothing there Glimmer had not done to herself, there were no words the Island could speak that she had not said in her own voice, and more cuttingly. The others, buried in their pain, could not resist; but Glimmer had hurt herself all her life. Those wounds were scarred over, the flesh numb, insensate. She could take it.

Caught by surprise, the *signal* had hurt, but now that she was ready for it... now that she had love to strive for, and her own armor of hate... she was immune. Maybe someone else, who had more pride, who was not used to being the least member of their own family, would break... but not Glimmer, who was not half envy and half bitterness and half love and too many fucking halves, all at once.

She was going to live. They were *all* going to live. *Fuck* this place!

One last blast as it tried, the *signal* tuned differently, trying to provoke fear; joke was on it, Glimmer *loved* danger, it got her off. She laughed, laughed in its face, and the touch of the Island on her *flinched* , it fucking *ran* , it could not abide the touch of her joy.

Coward , she thought, and laughed again. She dared the reaper regularly, waved to him all the time; the Island wasn't on the same fucking level.

She took a step, snapping off the last of the vines. She was free.

She was also, she realized, totally surrounded by monsters; the Island had sent its goons in. Hmm. Terribly reasonable of it. The woods all around her were alive with the hiss of beasts, all kinds of fucking things; Beast Island *did* deserve its rep, it appeared. Her moral and mental victory was going to be meaningless if her physical self died, after all.

Fuck.

She raised her hands and blasted the nearest foe, but it just... skipped off, she felt a dash of the Island's contempt returning as it dared approach again, now that it had the upper hand. Fuck. Light didn't work, it didn't *care* , she blasted again and again but the monsters that were approaching didn't give two shits.

A not-serpent opened its mouth, to tear her in two with a bite, as her brain fell upon an idea, recalling recent lessons with another monster.

She wasn't *just* light.

Darkness, the darkness, had anyone tried that, before? Dark mages were rare, vanishingly rare, and who would bring darkness to fight a Beast? You brought light to fight nightmares, everyone knew that.

But everyone knew Glimmer wasn't planning anything, too, so "everyone" was clearly fucking stupid.

With nothing to lose, as the viper-thing lunged, she called on the night inside her, not in the controlled way of her little juggling balls on the beach, not in the rigorous way of Shadow Weaver's teachings, but in the most primal way she could. She wasn't trained enough to be clever with it; if she tried that, she'd die. No, she had to be brutish, she had to simply throw all of her everything into it and hope for the best, use it in the instinctive and automatic way she used her teleports.

Thank the Moonstone, then, that she had *never* been subtle, that one of her chiefest flaws, as she'd always told herself, was that she was just a brute. Brute force was her favorite kind.

She reached out to the thing that would kill her, and commanded the night to do as it would.

The effect hit her first, of course. She was the channeler, after all; it had to pass through her to affect the world, and it ran down her skin and into her feet and out into her shadow. It was cold, so cold, cold and lonely and *needy* , for fuck's sake, the darkness was like the clingiest boyfriend imaginable, almost pathetic as it clutched at her. It stuck to her skin, it whimpered, it didn't want to leave her, it didn't want to leave *anyone,* was this why people cast shadows? Because the darkness could not stand to be alone?

Whining, wanting, wanting, wanting, the elemental darkness slid into her shadow and reached out, desperate to put its hands on everything and anything. It wanted so hard that it took the shadows her hands cast in the dappled dim of the Beast's jungle and made them great grasping claws, warped her shadow into a great many-handed thing three times her size, and it reached out, everywhere, all at once.

And where her shadow fell, the monsters screamed, and died. Hands they were, but *mouths* , too, they bit, bit the heat and the life and the *magic* out of everything they touched. And everything here was alive, even the dirt under her feet, the Beast was an Island and the Island was a Beast and she was eating it alive. She grabbed tight as the Island shrieked, chewed hard, lashing out with her shadow, a parasite feeding on the predator. The ground froze, the monsters ran, and the trees died as she overshadowed them, their flash-frozen trunks shattering; she tore a space in the jungle, the darkness inside her ironically letting the light outside in. It threw her shadow into sharper relief, tightened up the edge, made it perversely stronger- but that made sense. She was light *and* darkness, after all, her shadow was not the enemy of brilliance but its friend.

She bit, and bit, and... oh, she was going to be *sick* , she was so full of magic now, she felt it swirling around her insides and aching and her back hurt, why did her back hurt? Her little wings almost buzzed as they flapped pointlessly, they felt... odd, off, wrong. She wanted to puke.

But she kept going anyway. It would take greater light than Glimmer had to hurt the Island, it would take the golden glory of a She-Ra, but against the force of night, the monster and its pets had no defense. Glimmer threw her great fists of magic until there

were no more monsters, until she was alone, until she had carved a place for herself and stood alone in the sun.

When it was over, she put her shadow back in, retracting, the darkness happy to be back, slurping back into her and *wow,* she felt really great and super terrible, all at once. She felt like she'd snorted salt, she felt like she'd injected a cup of coffee directly into her eyeballs, she felt like someone had hooked a bag of lemon juice straight into her veins.

She felt... she felt fucking *high* , that's what this was, like that one time she'd been hanging out with Perfuma two years ago after a battle and shared her pipe. She'd been so certain she could handle whatever the fuck the Plumerian was smoking. Perfuma was built like an anorexic rail and smoked it like a chimney, surely Glimmer could take a few hits!

Two puffs, and she'd lost four hours that day, woke up on Perfuma's couch. Also ate all of her snacks. Apparently Perfuma had sky-high tolerance.

...Something to ponder. She... couldn't let this go to her head. Maybe a different Glimmer would, a Glimmer who hadn't had that talk with her mom, who hadn't had Catra for a sister, who hadn't decided to murder the woman her sister loved by stealth... maybe that Glimmer would let pride overwhelm her.

But *this* Glimmer, she was... more settled, not so insecure, and that gave her the strength to *focus* . Almost waddling, so glutted on magic was she, and with her back *aching* for some fucking

reason right on her wings, Glimmer reoriented herself, looked around.

The others were still trapped. Their eyes weren't quite as clouded, but they were still obviously under whatever duress the *signal* had inspired in them. Powerful stuff, that signal. Glimmer wasn't sure anybody else could have resisted, other than her sister, of course. Catra would have pulled up one the Island's trees and beat it to death with it for trying to break *her* invincible spirit.

But Glimmer had... resisted, somehow.

(That felt pretty good.)

But the others, first. She headed over to Scorpia, tried not to pass out from dizziness; Scorpia was tough, if Glimmer fucked this up she had less of a chance of hurting the big woman than she did her dad or Entrapta.

But... how to free her? The vines were too hard to move by hand, but she wasn't just her hands, hadn't been before and wasn't now; light still skipped off, rebounded when she tried a gentle burst to free Scorpia.

Fuck. The darkness, again, commanding it not to hurt Scorpia as she overshadowed her... and it listened, thankfully, listened to her. It *was* her, after all, this darkness did not come from some thing she had let inside but from the Moonstone itself, from half of her, inherited through her mother.

The vines burst into frozen chunks, as Scorpia, unharmed, was set free, the darkness clouding the signal in her head and letting her awaken.

" Glimmer?" Scorpia drawled sleepily, as she rolled over on the ground. " There was this... this *sound..."*

" Yeah, I know," Glimmer replied to the long-lost princess- and wow, Scorpia was alive, too, she could think about that now, her dad was alive and Scorpia was alive and this was turning out to be a *weird* fucking day. Really productive, though! They were two for one, after all, they hadn't even known about her dad. " Come on!"

Glimmer reached a hand out and Scorpia gently took it with a pincer.

" You've got... " Scorpia muttered as Glimmer pulled the big woman to her feet. " Little wingy thingies... black and purple..."

" No time," Glimmer said, even as her spine itched. The fuck was going on back there? No time, fuck. " Come on."

Scorpia stumbled with her as she went to her dad, to Entrapta, and ate yet more magic, gooooood fucking daaaaaammiiiit, she was gonna pop like a tick. Vines, breaking, though neither really woke up, they were in too deep, the nightmare had gulped them

down its gullet whole compared to the light snacking it had done on Scorpia. Fuck.

And all around them... movement. The Beast was coming back, and Glimmer's mouth was too full, she could eat no more.

...But she didn't have to, did she? All this raw power.

“ Scorpia,” she said. “ Grab my dad.”

Even woozy, Scorpia was still strong, and picked him up in one arm.

“ *You're* the Glimmer he was talking about?!?” Scorpia exclaimed. “ I thought he just had another kid named Glimmer!”

“ Fucking- really?” Glimmer said, though she couldn't resist a grin at the friendly arachnid's genuine astonishment. Fuck, this was going to be a *hell* of a conversation when they got home...

And home they would go. Glimmer was going to be the first person to escape Beast Island, and the thought brought another laugh to her lips as she picked Entrapta up gently.

The armies of the Island approached, the ground rumbling with their approach, which was ominous as *fuck* ; but it didn't matter.

Glimmer had won.

Quite a distance to teleport, and with three people to boot; she'd never be able to do it on her own, even topped up.

But she was *more* than topped up, now, the darkness was feeding the light, her two halves one, making both stronger... in balance, as they should be.

And so Glimmer turned to the onrushing hordes, whose first scouts she could just see, and she *laughed* , one last time, right in Beast Island's face.

" **Fuck you!** " she shouted, and then... teleport.

All that magic, it hurt, but it was a *good* kind of hurt, it went to her back and to the wings she'd thought of so often and it *did* something, felt like a workout taken just a little too far, where the pain and the gain were equal, and in the last second, Glimmer saw her shadow, and thought she saw two great wings.

Then there was light.

They popped into being miles away, and Glimmer no longer felt sick, felt normal again, having burned off the excess with her excessive teleport. With a thought, they had crossed all the distance not to the beach, but to the Doom Balloon itself, right on the bridge.

They landed next to Shadow Weaver, who was busy trying to figure out what was going on, since all their drones were dead. She whipped around as they warped in.

" Glimmer!" she exclaimed, as the quartet popped into existence. " Micah! Entrapta! Scorpia!"

" Congratulations, you know all of our names," Glimmer said, grinning at the completely dumbfounded and bamboozled sorceress. " Hit the gas, we've got to go!"

Credit where credit was due, Shadow Weaver was *nothing* if not invested in saving her own skin, and so despite her bewilderment, she turned and hit the button Entrapta had shown her that would set the autopilot back to Salineas for the return trip, a precaution in case Entrapta could not get back onboard, one proven wise now.

" Oooh... where... you have pretty wings..." Micah slurred as he sort of woke up, the ship setting off causing him to surface briefly.

“ Hey dad,” Glimmer said, to the man in Scorpia's arms- well, arm, she was packing him kind of like a recalcitrant kitten. “ Are you... ok?”

“ Dad? I'm a dad!” he said, before groaning. “ Dad tired...”

He was out, after that. Entrapta was still curled up in a ball.

“ Come on,” Glimmer said. “ Let's put them in the infirmary.”

“ You guys built all this to come save me?” Scorpia said. “ And Micah, I guess, but I don't think you knew he was there?”

“ No idea,” Glimmer said. “ Let's get them in some beds. Shadow Weaver, we have any company chasing us?”

“ A great swarm of beasts,” Shadow Weaver replied, “ but we seem to be handily outspeeding them. I have a few spells, as well...”

“ They don't know what to do with darkness,” Glimmer said. “ Blast'em, I'll be back to help in a bit.”

Off they went, her dad tucked into one bed, Entrapta in another; Glimmer went back to help Shadow Weaver, but it wasn't

necessary. The fleet of flying teeth behind them had started late, the Island apparently surprised by her teleport, and they were in the clear.

Entrapta and Micah slept all that day, though the medical bots- because of course Entrapta had doctor robots- said their vitals were normal, and that they believed it to just be exhaustion.

Glimmer got that, she was exhausted as fuck too; she stumbled into her personal bedroom and passed out, Shadow Weaver up on first watch. Someone else could figure out... all the rest of it. Glimmer was going to fucking *bed* . She flopped out onto the bed facefirst like a particularly ungraceful beached whale.

Around midnight, she awoke, a little before it was her turn to keep watch. The ship mostly ran itself, but it never hurt to have someone up to keep an eye on it. She rose up, groggy, and her back still hurt with that good ache, but it felt... off, somehow?

She felt heavier, off-balance... different. She staggered to her bathroom, to the sink, and washed her face quick with the oddly scentless soap Entrapta favored before scrubbing off with one of her absurdly soft towels- seriously, Glimmer was from *fucking Brightmoon* and she thought the towels were a bit too fluffy. It was like patting your face dry with a marshmallow.

Clean, she looked up... and looked again. Looked three times, before turning her head, and stretching *them* forward, to run her fingers in them, to feel *them* in her hands.

Her wings.

They had grown, somehow between opening herself to a part of the Moonstone that had always been there and maybe just that she was thinking about them and all that magic she'd absorbed, she had...

This had to be a dream. She slapped herself, maybe a bit too hard- fuck, she'd clobbered her own face, like an idiot- but it proved that this was...

This was real.

Wings. Great big wings, like her mom, but hers were *jet black* , dark and edging towards deep purple at the tips of her feathers and she had *wings,* she had fucking *wings* worth the name now, she had wings!

Her shout of joy woke up the whole ship.

Chapter End Notes

On hiatus until November's over; doing nanowrimo! God help me.

Chapter 29: A Father and Daughter of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Just a short bit of Micah, waking up, the day after.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A Father and Daughter of Brightmoon

Micah woke up from a wonderful dream.

His new friend, the stinger-girl with the claw-hand-thingies; she was there. The one who told him about that hot-ass catwoman she wouldn't shut up about and sometimes some other people, like a really scary blonde woman she knew and somebody who had long hair and short legs and slithered around a lot.

Micah had went through a lot of imaginary friends and hallucinations on Beast Island, because he was really lonely and also he'd went kind of crazy. But he thought Scorpia was real, because he'd never heard of a Princess Scorpia before, and he'd never imagined a Scorpioni before.

Sure, he knew about'em, but he hadn't known any *personally.* He'd known of a Princess Halandra of the Scorpioni, and he'd

thought maybe she had a kid? But that kid was named Hadru, he was pretty sure. Scorpia sounded like the way most Etherians named themselves, it wasn't very Scorpioni. The Scorpioni hadn't named themselves in the direct and descriptive fashion that the rest of Etheria did, were more like Mystacorans in naming themselves after older things. His sister had been named Hosea before she changed her name after becoming the Mage-Monarch, said having a more Etherian name like Castaspella was good for politics.

(His little sister. So good at her job. So good at politics and magic both. Micah had always been too straightforward for it, despite his talent, but his sister was awesome!)

So no Scorpia. But a Halandra... She'd had a wife named Tytus, he remembered that much. Ooh, ooh, and her dad was the last King of the Scorpioni, the lord of Horror Hall! King Uinta, that was his name! Yeah, Micah remembered now.

But those were words in a book to him. A study of the Scorpioni, from before the Horde had started doing its thing. Scorpioni still existed, but they were scattered after their nation's defeat, the first country to lose to the Horde- and a Runestone Kingdom at that! The Horde was bad, bad news...

...What had he been dreaming about? It was so hard to stay focused, now. He'd had to keep his mind flexible, on the island, so long, and he'd been so alone, he'd been alone for... for...

Better not think about it. He had a little girl to get back to... Glimmer! That was what the dream was about! His new friend was there, Scorpia. Scorpia, and she'd been helping, he'd talked

to her and she kept talking about some hot catwoman, which was kind of weird, and he'd told her about his daughter, and it had...

Had he seen his little girl? But she wasn't little, not anymore. She was big, so big.

How much time had he lost?

How long had he been in hell?

He wanted to cry. He wanted to cry. He wanted to cry.

It wasn't safe to cry. The beast would get him. The beast wasn't on the island the beast *was* the island and it would get him if he stopped, if he rested for too long, he'd been asleep too long!

He woke, terrified, leapt up- he didn't have his shelter up! Where was his magic, what was...

He...

This wasn't the island.

He stared at a place utterly unlike any he'd ever seen before. That helped, actually. This wasn't a memory, one of the many long halls in his head he'd gotten lost in time and time again to deal with the horror of his situation. This wasn't Mystacor's libraries, or the halls of Brightmoon, or Angella's bedroom, because sometimes after a long day of dealing with horrible, horrible monstrosities, and running from an infinite intelligence that hated him, Micah liked to think pleasant thoughts about how hot his wife was.

Sometimes he just wanted to think about her titties, you know? He was a simple person! He didn't need much. And they were very nice. He'd threatened to name them once, cursing her forever with the dread knowledge, and she'd laughed herself sick.

But this wasn't anything like any of that. This place was industrial-clean, almost like the Horde except without any of the aesthetic. Four solid metal walls with no wood paneling, a couple of beds- and oh, hey, there was his buddy! Scorpia!

She waved at him, as two robots observed him, the mechanical things carrying medical equipment.

" Hey!" she said. " Glad you're awake! I got up just a little bit ago, but they said you got pretty mauled, you'd take longer- but not long at all, you're already up!"

" Sir, you should return to your bed," a robot said, and was ignored.

“ I am!” Micah said. “ Slept too... long. Scorpia, do you see the robots too?”

“ Yeah,” she said.

“ Sir, please,” said the other robot, and was also ignored. “ Bed.”

“ Okay!” Micah said. “ And... it feels like we're going somewhere? Or the room's shaking. Like it's moving.”

“ It is!” Scorpia informed him. “ It's my buddy Entrapta's airship! She's really techy. Kinda like how you're magic, but with, you know. More goggles!”

An airship... those flew. An airship could rescue a man. An airship... an airship could...

An airship could take a man home.

“ I... I... Scorpia, is this real?” Micah asked, his voice trembling, vulnerable, open.

“ It is,” she said, grinning at him. “ We've been rescued! By my old buddy Entrapta, you know, the one I told you about!”

“ She had long hair and short legs and slithered around a lot and oh, she's taking me *home* ,” Micah said, and fell to his knees, blinking out tears. “ I... Scorpia, am I going home?”

“ Yeah,” Scorpia said, the big brute gentle with her words. As Micah began to sob, she rose up out of her own bed. The doctor bots asked him to get in bed, and Scorpia came to him and gave him one of her great hugs, and he leaned into it, he was going *home* .

“ I'm gonna see my wife,” he said. “ My baby girl. My... my sister, my family, I'm going *home* I'm going *home* Scorpia we're going *home!* ”

“ We are,” she said, hugging him tight, grounding the man as his soul flew, his happiness such that it might render him insane all over agin, he was going *home* . “ We're going home, you just focus on the great hug, okay? I got ya. It's what I'm best at!”

“ It's a really great hug!” he agreed, sobbing.

“ I heard- is King Micah awake?” came a voice from near the room's door, and he didn't bother looking but Scorpia did. He was too full to focus, and some part of him that could kinda think under all his emotions wondered if that's why he was crying, he was so full that he had to bail out his ship or sink or something. Drown from the weight of all his emotions.

Well, he didn't want to die before he got home, so he just cried even harder, so he could get it out.

" Yeah!" his friend rumbled. " Get Glimmer, Entrapta!"

Some time later- time he did not know how to record, he'd lost so much time and now he was losing more- a winged shadow fell on him.

" Dad?" came a voice he had spent too long not hearing.

He looked, then, no matter how full he was he could look at *that* voice. He looked, and there she was, his big, beautiful girl. She'd grown up short and stout, like a teapot, but with muscles! She had a good soft weight to her, and great big black wings, just like her mother, and she was looking at him with an expression no painter could ever catch. Too much was there; love and disbelief and not a little anxiety.

His little girl had grown up. He'd lost time, so much time.

But she was still here. *He* was still here.

He hadn't lost all his time yet.

“ Glimmer,” he half-sobbed, and he tried to stand but he was falling on his face, caught only by Scorpia- Scorpia, the best person he could have found on that island, who was supporting him now, the way he'd had to support her. Good person, best Princess, he'd have to give her a medal when they got back. Maybe he could adopt her? She said she didn't have parents! “ You're my- you're my little girl? With Angie?”

“ Yeah,” she said, and smiled at him. “ I'm your baby girl. I'm... uhh, not sure what to say? But you're back and I love you and I thought you were dead and I'm just...”

Her breath hitched, and his heart ached, ached for his daughter.

“ I don't- I'm just so happy and then I'm all fucked up thinking about it and I just... you're my dad,” she said, and she started to cry.

Oh, she was full of feelings, too, and he didn't want her to drown, so he grabbed her with a stumbling lunge and pulled her into a really big hug and he cried as hard as he could, to show her how to get it out of yourself, and then Scorpia was hugging them both and keeping them upright as the King and Princess of Brightmoon bawled like babies in each other's arms.

His mind worked, under the sheer *relief* , this eucatastrophe, this delight that was as sharp or sharper than actual pain would have been. There was... so much to go over. He could *feel* his brain

reactivating, could literally feel some of the dark parts of his mind, deactivated by the need for survival redirecting resources, waking back up. So... so many questions.

How long had he been gone?

How was Angie?

Was the War still going? Had they beaten the Horde? Who was this Entrapta, what were they doing here, did he catch a glimpse of *Shadow Weaver* , what the fuck was she doing here? And his daughter was using dark magic- which was awesome! He was a dark mage himself, he'd learned it in hopes of figuring out what the hell Shadow Weaver was, maybe see if he could tug Light Spinner out of her... then kept going at it, because hey, he was good at it!

So many questions. So much to talk about.

But today, Micah was going *home* , and that meant everything else could wait.

Chapter End Notes

> Scorpia's moms are named after extinct scorpions, as is her grandfather; specifically, her grandfather and mom are both named after the Uintascorpio halandrasorum, while her other mom's name is from the Tityus apozonalli. Extinct species, since, you know. Dead.

Hordak actually didn't intend to kill them, which is the fucked up part, he legit thought they'd be happier being part of the Horde. Uinta died fighting him; Tytus died in defense of Scorpia, whose real name in this fic is Hadru, which is a reference to the largest currently living North American scorpions, Hadrurus arizonensis. She gets that name both for being alive but also for being really, really big, even by Scorpioni standards; Scorpia would tower over everybody in her family if any others were alive.

Halandra, much to her sorrow, survived, but wasted away after her father and wife both died; she thought her daughter had perished, too, after all, that every drop of happiness she had was ruined. If she had any idea Scorpia was still alive, she would have done anything to get back to her, but she assumed she'd died with Tytus and Uinta.

Halandra had the Princess connection, but she was unprepared for Hordak's attack, and never did stop blaming herself for not using her powers to their fullest extent to save her family. She was a peaceful woman, and bad at fighting; she did try to resist, but ended up less than effective. Worse, because she had access to the Black Garnet's power, she always blamed herself for her kingdom's fall, which was one of several factors that led to her eventual suicide, two years after Horror Hall was conquered.

Hers is one of the many quiet tragedies of the War.

Hordak gave her the name Scorpia because he thought that's how all Etherians named things (that's how he got his own name, after all, naming himself under Etherian naming conventions.) Scorpia was extremely young at the time all this happened, and so only remembers any of this in very rare nightmares.

Castaspella's original name derives from the fact that Micah is named after one of the Twelve Minor Prophets. Hosea means

salvation, which fits Castaspella's work as a queen at a time when the Horde is trying to kill everyone.

Most of Etheria follows a naming convention where a person eventually names themselves after a thing they do; the idea is that a name should be descriptive. Mystacor and a few other groups, like the Scorpioni and, rather pertinently, the Magicats, don't follow this tradition; it's basically how I explain the presence of names like Frosta in the setting alongside names like Micah.
(Given the number of people with the surname Miller, this is actually more real-world than you might think.)

Parents will give a child a name, but it's always changeable. There's no real limit to naming yourself; some people rename themselves constantly, others pick early and stick with it, some never change their names from what their parents call them. As examples from Bow's family- Bow renamed himself that when he decided to join the Rebellion. His dads thought it was a reference to his archery talent- which it is, but they missed the military implications.

Lance calls himself that because that was the weapon he favored in warfare; Bow was following his lead. George, meanwhile, is a fucking nerd, and named himself after a name he found in old First Ones' records. It was his standout achievement as an archaeologist, since it let him write a whole book about possible First One naming conventions that was actually quite accurate, so he renamed himself after it.

Notably, Adora is not a First One name. Shadow Weaver gave her the name, as she wanted her to be adored. And hey- technically, she is! Old SW just isn't benefiting from it like she'd hoped.
(Perhaps what Adora's parents wanted to name her will come up. Maybe it never will. But it wasn't Adora.)

Shadow Weaver also named Catra, which is why her name is that. Catra's own people would not have named her that.

Chapter 30: Mage-Monarch Castaspella of Mystacor

Chapter Notes

A new POV this chapter!

Don't worry, we're going back to Catra soon; things are gonna really start accelerating now.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mage-Monarch Castaspella of Mystacor

Castaspella of Mystacor, head sorceress and leader of the nation, was not doing politics right now. No, she was doing what she *truly* loved: staring at a problem.

Specifically, she was staring at the rune-marked metal before her. The runes glared back, glowing a dull, sullen orange, the same angry, dark reddish gleam of dying embers who weren't quite ready to go cold just yet. Still active, as she'd requested.

Soon , she thought to her inanimate nemeses, shaking a mental fist at them. *Soon!*

She was in her lab, and it was nice to be doing some actual work for a change. As head sorceress, half of what she did was sheer politics and governance, and the other half was diplomacy; it was

rare she actually got to do any magical research these days. Honestly, it was the main reason she'd been campaigning so hard to change Mystacor's policy in that regard. Sure, “the greatest mage of our kind shall lead us” sounded good on paper, but in practice, the leader never got to do much research or spellcasting, which was a waste of talent. And that wasn't even getting into the issue that the best mage might not be the best leader!

Sure, Castaspella had worked out pretty well as the Mage-Monarch, but that was dumb luck. Mystacoran history abounded with head-up-ass scholars and other fools who'd taken the throne, and Castaspella wasn't going to stand for it any longer.

(No, Castaspella wasn't bitter that she spent all of her time negotiating between the nattering nags of Mystacor's oldest and most belligerent wizards instead of *doing fucking magic* , why would anyone think *that?)*

She picked up one of the stones, and began gently prodding it with spells, mostly to confirm what she already knew, her mind on other matters as she went through spells she'd mastered as a child. Scans and probes, making sure there were no surprises or tricks in the runework of the Horde's Lord.

It was nice. Better than having to figure out which *great mage* was angry this week, and why, and what to do about it. It was like running a kindergarten some days, and it was a wonder that she could get anything done.

No wonder she wanted elections, and to make someone else do this shit. Honestly, if she didn't have the War to focus on, she'd have already gotten the law changed.

Of course... if it wasn't for the War, she wouldn't *have* the job in the first place. She'd went for it after Micah got married to Angella; he'd need serious backup if he wasn't to be reduced to the immortal angel's pet consort, the kind of backup you needed a whole nation to provide, and Castaspella loved her big brother. He'd protected her as a kid, so she'd protect him as adults, especially from that creepy, ancient queen he'd married.

(*Fucking Angella* , as she always thought of the woman. Why couldn't Micah have married that nice boy he'd been dating before the angel? Or literally anyone else?)

Still, the job she had, so she'd fix it. That was what being a leader was; a person who fixed shit. Too many of Mystacor's past leadres had been the kind of people who were very, very intelligent and deeply, totally stupid, because the ability to theorize and learn formulae and numbers did not translate in any way into actually being *smart.* There were many kinds of intelligence, Castaspella had discovered, and the kind that a leader needed wasn't the kind that most researchers had.

So, applying that kind of intelligence, she was trying to get elections to replace the current *best-mage* criteria. She wanted to set up a system where any Mystacoran could campaign for the office; she'd set up pretty strict rules on that, so candidates with more money couldn't overrun the others. The Phlax Federation's villages did that for their mayors, and it had worked out pretty well for them, though maybe that was just because they were a young nation, it hadn't had time to go off the rails yet. Galacia, too, elected its king, though only from among its nobility; the Right of the Winter Crown, they called it.

So taking up elections would honestly help Mystacor in dealing with them. People liked cultures that were more like their own; and honestly, the fact that the Mage-Monarch was always the most powerful spellcaster in Mystacor had been part of why other Crownless nations regarded them as having a Princess of sorts. Honestly, Castaspella kind of agreed with them; she figured the rule had been instituted because it made them more like the Runestone Kingdoms, let the Mage-Monarch hobnob with their Princesses, rather than because anyone had thought it through.

But the truth was, Mystacor *didn't* have a Runestone and the Mage-Monarch *wasn't* a Princess, and lying to yourself, especially on a national scale, never worked out in the long run. If nothing else, it wasn't helping with Mystacor's reputation among their fellow Crownless nations, who had a tendency to swing between viewing Mystacor as the one Crownless nation the Runestone Kingdoms would listen to, and openly considering them to be uppity traitors to their Crownless kin, depending on recent events. She couldn't count how many times she'd had to soothe some disgruntled foreign politician's hurt feelings to maintain Mystacor's status as first among equals when it came to Etheria's Princess-lacking countries.

Switching to elections would help Mystacor in a lot of ways. Better leaders might even end the constant cycle, where Mystacor gained great respect during crisis when their mystical might proved useful, then lose it in the peace afterwards when some head-up-ass scholar got the job, and then insulted someone at a fancy party or, worse, ended up responsible for some magical disaster or other that sent their reputation plummeting into the depths. It was an endlessly looping cycle that Mystacor had never totally broken free of, and they needed change.

Maybe her new system was that change. It wouldn't be perfect, because nothing was, but it'd work better than what they had, and that was good enough for any leader.

(Castaspella would never recognize it, but she'd spread her protectiveness of her brother to her people, and had led them well; she'd done her duty by a crown she'd taken up for selfish cause.)

Still, those problems were *tomorrow* problems. Today, she was just glad not to be doing diplomacy! It was nice to be doing magic again. Maybe she'd get a big tower somewhere when she retired, go neoclassical on the furnishings, she'd never been sold on the more modern, cleanly-aesthetic labs that were so popular nowadays. Give her a dungeon and stone any day!

She continued checking the runework, making sure Adora had left no surprises, humming a wordless tune as she worked. An old Rebel warsong, from before the new Alliance had been formed- well, reformed, she supposed. *The Rebels Strike* , a jaunty little tune she was fond of, original author unknown, though rumors said it was a Shuki Levy? Something like that.

Still humming, she put the rocks down and turned to set up her workspace. On a very sturdy table, designed and enchanted to withstand direct and heavy magical assault, she placed pieces from a wide number of Horde warbots, captured by various Rebels and paid for out of Mystacor's war funds. On each piece was an example of Adora's sloppy runework; if she'd been a Mystacor student, Castaspella would have given her a C+ at best. It was pure brute force, and it only worked because Adora apparently had more raw magical potential and power than anyone

Castaspella had ever seen. Even the *echoes* of her power burned, like little embers.

Of course, Candor, Castaspella's own teacher, would have given Adora an F; he'd never been fond of spellwork that lacked skill. There was a lot of power in these runes, sure, but the execution lacked all finesse; this was magic by brute force. Candor had liked clever spellwork, the kind of elegant work that was like an elegant martial art; by comparison, Adora's runework was the magecraft equivalent of a headbutting, crotch-kicking bar brawl. Sure, it worked, but it wasn't very skillful.

It was also... familiar.

Not in anything specific. There was no signature here she knew, no smoking gun to point to. Just a sort of... sense about it, a kind of reading of the runes that reminded Castaspella, just a little, of... Micah.

It was the *casualness* of it. There was power here that had almost just been tossed on, *making* the magic work, pummeling it into submission. Like Micah's earliest spellwork, before he'd learned to be clever, when she'd used to make fun of her big brother by calling him a clumsy ox. Big, bold, and bumbling, that had been Micah at the start.

Light Spinner had taught him that way... and rumor said Shadow Weaver had taught Adora. Apparently she hadn't changed teaching styles when she changed names.

Sure, Castaspella could just go ask the dark sorceress, but she wouldn't, because you couldn't fucking pay her to talk to Shadow Weaver. Queen Angella had asked her to do so once or twice, but she'd said no, and for once, her distaste for Brightmoon's Queen had nothing to do with why she'd turned her request down. *Fuck* Shadow Weaver, Micah had nightmares for *years* afterwards of that stupid ritual, and even as an adult he'd sometimes... remember.

Castaspella was not one to forgive a hurt dealt to her kin, much less one that made her brave, brave brother wake up screaming and crying. She had too few kin left to do anything else; her and her brother had been orphans, raised in one of Mystacor's orphanages together, and they were all each other had until Glimmer was born. And Micah had basically raised her, she'd been a toddler when their parents died, she could only recall the vaguest pieces of them in her dreams... it had been Micah who had been there, always, big brother and kind of parent both.

So yeah, Castaspella wasn't a forgiving sort at the best of times, but for Shadow Weaver? Well, Castaspella had a long list of people she'd like to watch get tossed down a cliff, and Shadow Weaver took pride of place at the top.

Hmm... still, this was useful info. Micah had admired the hell out of Light Spinner, so he'd spent a lot of time dissecting her notes, looking for information on what had went wrong that fateful night, and he'd shared his observations with his sister. Maybe she could use that info to figure out a flaw in Adora's work, which the Mage-Monarch had to admit, showed real inventiveness and skill.

Shame it was bent to such violent ends. Her bootleg moonshine still of a spellcasting style still worked, after all, and it made her army so much nastier than before. Exploding Hordebots that popped like a blood-gorged tick when destroyed, except instead of just stolen fluid it was a firestorm that gushed out; invisible Hordebots, where you couldn't tell where your enemy was or what they were doing. Adora's runework on the Horde Troopers to make them immune to fire only worsened the situation, since that meant her living soldiers could fight side by side with the walking bombs without fear or worry.

It was a bad situation all around, but one Castaspella was determined to rectify. One option was to just go out there and knock heads herself, but Castaspella was trying to remind her people that Mystacor was Crownless, not a Runestone Kingdom; going out there like a Princess to bust skulls, while personally satisfying, wouldn't assist any of her other goals.

(Though she had no doubt she could do it; talented as Adora was, the young woman was clearly not that well trained, and it wasn't like Adora had a Runestone empowering her. In a head-on fight against Adora's magic, Castaspella was confident she'd win.)

What *would* help was giving her fellow Rebels something they could use without even needing to *be* a mage, an easily-distributed , mass-produced tool. Sure, the Princesses were powerful, but there were only so many of them; and even if Castaspella were to enter the field herself, she couldn't be everywhere. These robots were being used en mass; it behooved the Rebellion to do likewise.

She'd been researching this for a few months. A way *had* to exist; these ramshackle runes were vulnerable, and unstable. These

weren't like the runes that kept Mystacor floating, or preserved ancient works; no, these were slapdash, hurriedly pressed onto Hordebots in large groups. For all their power, they were *fragile.*

While she hadn't gotten to do much research between the usual business of ruling and the distractions of international diplomacy, she'd made a little progress... and recently she'd gained some help from a most unexpected source! Tech Master Bow, one of the legendary rebels that formed the She-Ra's personal squad... who was also her niece's boyfriend, Castaspella thought? Maybe lover by now. She really should talk to Glimmer more. Her distaste for the girl's mother shouldn't have distracted her so much from her niece... but it was easy to lose track of time in Mystacor, for a day to turn into weeks to turn into months and years.

(And- after Micah- maybe some part of Castaspella just... couldn't bear to see how much like her brother the girl was, how much of his bravado and bravery she shared, a shameful secret she did not let herself know.)

At any rate, Bow had contacted her via trackerpad a few nights ago. He'd been interested in learning how magic could be stopped, interrupted, or taken, which was the exact same subject Castaspella had been pondering; and lucky her, she'd had a break in her usual duties. A group of three archmages had done something spectacularly stupid- primarily fucking around with *explosives* near the room that *kept Mystacor floating*- and she'd come down hard, stripping them of all funding and equipment and forcing them to work for other archmages for a year and a day as understudies, rather than on their own projects, a massive blow to their pride and prestige.

Out of fear and respect both, the usual array of idiocies born of pride, anger, and stupidity that plagued all rulers had slowed to a trickle, since everybody in Mystacor was stepping lightly around Castaspella now. Even Mortella- her most ardent opposition ever since they were both Ariel's apprentices- had been considerably more polite to her old rival. Everyone had expected her to forgive due to the archmages' high status, but Castaspella ran a tight ship- there was no excuse for that kind of stupid.

So she'd devoted her new free time to talking to Bow and working on this project. Texting back and forth with the tech master, along with two long video calls, had ended with them collaborating on a joint project that she was rather proud of. It partook equally of tech and magic, and was even going to be cheap to produce, to boot!

Well, if it worked, anyway.

The core of it was a simple grenade- a common, round metal bomb, with a firing pin. Nothing fancy. It wasn't even made out of good material, a deliberate choice; it wasn't iron or even tin, but aluminum. When the bomb went off, instead of bursting into deadly shrapnel, it just kind of... melted, in a deflating sort of fashion. You could chuck it into a room of people, and as long as it didn't directly touch anyone, the grenade going off wouldn't even hurt any of them.

Inside that weak shell, she and Bow had figured out what to put inside. Junk, basically... but magically charged junk. Shavings from the workshops of Mystacor's staffmakers, the discarded bits left on the floor when a new mage's staff was lathed; scraps of old spell scrolls, still dreaming of the magic in the runes once written

on their skin. Dust from the corners of Mystacor's great Lunarium, which had sat in the most magically charged room in the entire nation and been exposed to all that power- Castaspella's own idea, one Bow had heartily approved of. Random things, a mishmosh, an assortment of little things with remnant sorceries clinging to their skin. Nothing that really cost anything- it was plain old trash, after all.

But attached to all this was a firing device Bow had based on a First Ones' design he'd found while on one of his innumerable adventures with the She-Ra and Castaspella's niece. When it triggered, it would pulse and activate all the residual energy at once, creating a kind of magical shockwave. It was harmless on a physical scale- or should be, at least- should go off like a particularly aggressive party favor... but magically?

If it worked like they hoped, the wave of randomized, chaotic magic that flooded out would cause a short-term overflow in all spells nearby. The circular explosion of disruptive energies would only last a second, but in that second, any magic in the area would be slammed by a wave of nonsensical energy. A well-anchored rune would be able to filter it out... but Adora's runes weren't well-anchored, were they? Powerful, but sloppy, and they'd turn it against her.

Honestly, it was genius. Bow really *was* a Tech Master; Castaspella wouldn't have ever thought of a grenade! But Bow had, and he'd even pointed out why it was a good idea- most Rebels already knew how bombs worked. It would be simple enough for most to adapt to this new grenade. Quite clever! Glimmer had done well in choosing him.

(She had, hadn't she? She *really* needed to keep up with her family better. Yet another reason to get this damn crown off her head. She should spend time with Glimmer, no matter how much it hurt to think of her big brother, how much she saw of him every time she talked to the punchy princess...)

Bow had described the weapon as a “magic EMP”, though Castaspella, who viewed all technology as a complete mystery created by distant, alien intelligences called by the mysterious term *engineers,* had no idea what that was. Still, he'd assured her it was a good comparison, and she believed him.

Of course, they couldn't call them that, or otherwise only Tech Masters like Bow would know what they did. No, they needed a different name; Bow had agreed, but completely blanked on what to call them. Castaspella had decided to take over; she'd renamed herself, after all, discarding her old name of Hosea to become Castaspella when she'd taken Mystacor's throne. A name more in line with how most Etherians were named would make diplomacy easier, after all.

So... hmm. Honestly she thought about naming it after herself, that was one of Mystacor's most celebrated traditions... maybe *Castaspella's Magic Dampeners* ... ooh, she could even shorten it to CMD, that kind of sounded like this mysterious EMP! Yes, that was a good idea!

But... before she got caught up in the glory of inventing a new thing, and then naming it after herself, she should test to make sure it worked on Adora's runes. The CMDs *should* work, in theory, but this was the real test.

Excited and ready, Castaspella went to the door. If the magic burst caused the Hordebot's runes to trigger instead of shut off, she wanted to be *out* of the room when it exploded into fire. Admittedly, she'd already shielded herself with a few spells, but no reason to singe her eyebrows off. She *liked* her eyebrows.

So, at the door, feeling rather dashing, she popped the pin on her bomb, chucked it in, and then bailed, through the door and then to the window, eagerly watching to see what happened. For the three seconds it took the blast to go off, she waited with bated breath, until the grenade- which had actually rolled under the table, she'd had terrible aim- finally popped, with a surprisingly gentle movement. The shoddy metal of the grenade heated and disintegrated, puffing and sinking like a depressed souffle, and the wave of magic washed over the room.

The embers, so defiant, were instantly silenced, choked out like a candle's flame under a snuffer. She waited a moment to see if they would return, or burst, or explode... but they stayed dead.

After a few more minutes to make sure, Castaspella had pumped a fist in the air. It had worked! More tests were needed, of course, but first she had to do two things- congratulate her research partner, and send him a few of the prototypes.

(He'd been weirdly insistent on it; something about needing it, just in case. She wasn't sure what that was about.)

She gathered the prototypes she'd send to Bow, writing a congratulatory note quickly, and gave it to a messenger. Feeling

pumped, she was about to do some more tests- what *else* could these useful little devices do?- when a different messenger ran into the room.

" We have a message," the breathless woman said, panting between words. " It's urgent. From Princess Entrapta."

" What's the message?" Castaspella asked.

" They're coming here," the messenger said. " Entrapta, Glimmer, and, uhh... Shadow Weaver. Said you'd... you'd want to see what they had. And to get your best expert on mind soothing available- preferably someone with extensive experience in counseling. And they're coming here directly? They've got a big blimp, they're flying right up!"

" What?" Castaspella asked, more in surprise than in hope of an answer, before the important part of that spiel fully registered. " Wait, *Shadow Weaver* is with them?"

Surely Angella wouldn't be so stupid as to let the old witch near her *niece* , would she?!? Didn't she know what she *was* ? Surely Micah had told her, before he died!

" Yes, your highness," the messenger said. " I saw her on the video call myself."

“ Well... fuck,” Castaspella muttered, before her mind kicked into overdrive. Sure, she could say no, but Glimmer was there, too, and she'd never known her to have anything but the Rebellion's best interests at heart... at the least, she should find out why they wanted a mind soother.

“ Okay, here's my orders,” Castaspella said. “ Give these to my apprentice Ariel. Our guests are to be allowed to dock at Mystacor, I want that big zeppelin where we can blast it if Entrapta tries something. Once they're here, direct them to the judgment chambers- and I want the usual suspects gathered to fill those seats. I'll make my way there, too. Tell her to put guards on Shadow Weaver and Entrapta both! Gather everyone who knows how to spellcast with light, and grab Mortella, she's the only dark mage we have; we'll need both if Shadow Weaver does anything. They're not to be attacked if they behave, but I do *not* trust them... and tell Ariel that I'm invoking the Conscription clause, this is an emergency. If anyone complains, remind them of the cost.”

The light mages might need the reminder, though Mortella wouldn't. The one credit Castaspella would give Mystacor's resident expert on dark magic, despite their rivalry, was this; Mortella would never turn down a chance to fight for her home. Many were the mages who would grumble and drag their feet when the Conscription clause was invoked, and they had to go to war... but Mortella would do her duty when asked. She was even enthusiastic about it, and honestly, Castaspella would be glad to have her, if only her constant opposition to Castaspella's very existence didn't make the Mage-Monarch want to punch her teeth in.

(Of course, even the whiners would participate; failure to do so gave Castaspella legal right to ruin their magic, the same punishment she'd personally inflicted on Dreer for the experiments

he'd performed on corpses and the kidnapping he'd done, hoping to expand to the living... though his long service with the Horde afterwards meant she probably should have killed him instead. Hindsight, she supposed.)

They'd be ready if Shadow Weaver did something; Castaspella would be *damned* to have that old beast show up here at her door unguarded- especially after she'd went after the She-Ra once in these halls already, years ago! And as for Entrapta, well, she'd rejoined the Alliance, supposedly, but Castaspella didn't trust her. Really, only Glimmer being present led her to say yes, instead of just ordering that they be told no...

" It will be done, ma'am," the messenger said, before running out of the room. Castaspella sighed once she'd left; today had been going so well, too.

Oh well, nothing for it. She left her lab and started marching towards her throne in the council chambers, mind running over Shadow Weaver all the while... and Micah, whom the witch had hurt, so very much.

Micah had fought back against his pain by learning, his favorite activity. He was the one who'd spent years figuring out just what Shadow Weaver was; it was why he'd learned dark magic, despite its reputation, studying it alongside the much younger Mortella under the old Wizard of the Tree, who had given up names entirely and taken on a title, like Brightmoon once did centuries ago. Micah had studied under that bitter old man so that he could know just what his first teacher had done to herself, had hoped that knowledge would help him resolve the lingering fear and horror from that night... and it had, to some extent. Knowledge

had given her brother some measure of peace, though it had never totally ended the nightmares.

Castaspella had that knowledge, too, now had read his notes, when she got older; and when she'd been crowned Mage-Monarch, she'd read what Light Spinner had left behind, gotten to know her, too. She could put all the pieces together, in a way that maybe not even Micah had, knew Light Spinner well, having researched her brother's first enemy to find out what had driven him.

She had been disquieted by what she'd found. Light Spinner had, in fact, been a good person; aggressive, proud and possessed of a spirit of great mischief, but just and caring and loving, too. Back then, it had been her best side that led her to be such a firebrand; she had cared too much, in her own way, had bitterly hated the Horde for its predations and wanted Mystacor to do more. She had refused to go along with then Mage-Monarch Norwyn's admittedly stupid belief that the Princesses could handle it, the same belief that had gotten so many Plumerians killed early on, the floralists unprepared for battle when their Princesses had historically been all the military they'd needed...

Light Spinner had not been a fool like that. A different kind of fool, maybe, but of a nobler spirit; she had wanted to fight. She had wanted to lead the charge against the Horde herself, fist-fight all of them in epic battle, and lead Mystacor to the frontlines... Norwyn had threatened her with exile numerous times over it, over her absolute unwillingness to just *shut up.*

She had not. She'd been pushy and resolute and solely convinced of her own genius, and the foolishness of her opposition, and full

of love and care for the people of Etheria who suffered under the yoke of the Horde... and convinced she alone could save them. Pride, obviously, pure undiluted arrogance, but in an oddly admirable way; the sort of foolish self-love that drove one to be better, that demanded a person be as great as they thought they were. Light Spinner had been tireless in her pursuit of power, hoping that she could lead Mystacor to save Etheria.

She had even hunted the Sword of the She-Ra, somehow convinced that she could be that legendary person, and after reading all her work... well, Castaspella thought that maybe she could have lived up to her own hype, if she had found the blade. Maybe Norwyn *should* have exiled her, so she would have to look for the Sword, instead of relying on the Ritual; maybe the world would be better if, many years ago, a vain, self-centered, and yet just-hearted mage had put her hands on the hilt of a sword, and never had need to cast the spell that made her a monster.

Though that was putting too much weight, too much blame, on the Ritual. The Ritual of Obtainment did not truly change a person, after all, save in warping their magic into a parasitic kind.

No, what it really did... was empower their lowest aspects.

(*The ritual does not change a person,* she remembered reading, once, in an old, old book. *It merely enhances those aspects that led them to cast it- and few do so out of the best intentions. It is rarely a person's better half that leads them to cast this spell.*)

Shadow Weaver was Light Spinner's worst parts- her pride, her aggression, her ambition, her love of mischief- enhanced and strengthened; pride into imperiousness, aggression into

unrestrained assault, ambition into lust for power, mischief into cruelty. Not another person, another self, but another side of what was already there.

Had she had pure motives, perhaps she would be Light Spinner still... or maybe she'd take up a different name, something more grandiose, to fit her new powers. Sun Twiner, or Crystal Sun Dancer, some other name that was equally pompous and preposterous.

But this was not that world, if that world existed anywhere at all; they had what they had.

Castaspella reached the room ahead of her surprise guests, and made ready, sitting in her throne and keeping her own staff nearby. If Shadow Weaver wanted to throw down, Castaspella would *gleefully* oblige- while making sure she was mobbed by every mage in Mystacor. Castaspella actively refused all concepts of fighting fair, she fought to *win,* and she would happily ambush the dark mage with every force at her disposal. Maybe she should have grabbed one of her CMDs, see how they affected a mage instead of runework...

Of course, Shadow Weaver's official status as a valuable prisoner of Brightmoon meant that Castaspella couldn't just jump her unprovoked; goddamn Angella, screwing her over once again. What Micah had ever seen in that woman, Castaspella had no idea.

(And maybe she was just offended at the idea that her big brother, who was so great, should just be another one in the long line of Angella's lovers, instead of having all the love of one

person to himself... or maybe that was just Castaspella seeing the worst in someone she disliked.)

She was first to arrive; the rest of her people filtered in afterwards, the staff she used to help administrate the nation. Rumors and hubbub traveled constantly, and Castaspella paid attention when they mentioned an apparent fourth guest...

Ariel, her apprentice, finally made it into the room, sweat staining the redhead's brow before she freshened up with a quick healing spell.

" Everything in order?" Castaspella asked, and Ariel responded with a nod.

" Yes, Mage-Monarch," she replied. " Mortella and a small squad of light mages are watching Shadow Weaver, and I took the liberty of asking a Rebel squad that was buying supplies to help us watch them- it's Sweet Bee and her group, the Andreenids. You know, the ones from the Hive?"

It took a moment to recall them- Mystacor did a lot of trade with the Rebellion, and it was hard to keep track of it all. But Sweet Bee and her group were pretty frequent flyers- literally, they'd built flying harnesses resembling insect wings, you'd see them flitting about a lot. The Hive was one of the villages in the Phlax Federation, and did most of the Federation's trade with Mystacor, since they could reach it easier with their wings than anyone else could. Good merchants to deal with, since, for a group with so many Tech Masters, they had a healthy respect and good working

knowledge of sorcery. In particular, they had one very valuable good to trade...

" The ambrosia merchants, right?" Castaspella asked, the word alone making her tongue tingle with the memories of that honeyed food. Damn near a miracle- didn't need to cook it, didn't need to prepare it, you could eat it straight from the fancy jars they kept it in. If you had ambrosia and water, you would never need another food. Perfect nutrition, right there, no mess, no fuss. Only the Hive could make it, and they didn't make much, but Mystacor was their biggest customer for what little they sold; a lot of archmages liked a food you didn't have to fuss with, gave you more time to research. The Phlax Federation benefited a lot from having the Hive as one of their founding groups.

" That's them," Ariel replied. " They agreed to it, said it'd be a favor to us. Honestly it was kinda spooky, I almost wish I hadn't done it. I've always known Sweet Bee as a giggly, friendly sort, and let me tell you, it was *weird* to see her switch straight to Rebel Warrior mode. Just slapped down that bug-eyed helmet, gave orders in a weird buzzing language I've never heard before, and then her and her Andreenids pulled out these square, like, boxes that unfolded into short, nasty little crossbows; looked mean, and the bolts looked like the tips were coated in some nasty yellow stuff! Poison, maybe? Anyway, they're escorting Entrapta primarily; I figure her and her people know tech better than we do, they'll know if the Drylborn tries anything before we would."

" Good initiative," Castaspella praised her apprentice, who beamed briefly at her words. " Now, I heard a rumor that they had a fourth with them other than my niece, the Dryl princess, and Shadow Weaver. Do they, and if so, who is it?"

“ They wouldn't say,” Ariel replied. “ He looks *really* familiar, though- I'd swear I've seen him before. But that can't be, he moves like he's being hunted, and he's also... twitchy. Like he's waiting for a monster to attack him. I'd bet a good grimoire that he's who they want the mind soother for. He's also a Mystacoran mage, I think; in his rambling- he talks a lot- he mentioned studying here a couple of times.”

Hmm. A prisoner of war, maybe? Someone who'd suffered the Horde's attentions... but if he was a mage of Mystacor, he was one of her people, and she owed it to him to heal him as best she could. Glimmer must think he had valuable intel...

“ If he's one of us, we'll do our best,” Castaspella said. “ After we talk, I'll send for... is Frit back yet from working on that monument of his in Greenvale?”

Old Frit was the best mind soother in Mystacor, but he also fancied himself an artist; he'd went to one of Mystacor's vassal kingdoms to make a glass monument to freedom, apparently a statue of someone named Madame Razz? An old lover or something, though Frit had claimed she was the spirit of Etheria itself... eh, it was his vacation time, the elderly Twigget could do whatever he wanted. It wasn't Castaspella's business; she wasn't a dictator, and if that's what he wanted to do with his time, it was his business. And King Gruff of Greenvale was big on investing into the arts, that's why she'd suggested him to Frit in the first place, so maybe he'd love it.

" He'll be back soon," Ariel said. " King Gruff sent a letter saying he was done and heading our way, but it'll be a day or two before he gets here. He also sent a painting of the monument; I was going to bring it up later today before all this happened."

" Once he's back, we'll get him on the case," Castaspella said. " He'll either be able to handle it or will know who to suggest."

The door at the room's end opened, one big enough to let a group inside. Her mages were in the lead as the escort, and flying above them on their buzzing suits were Sweet Bee and her squad. Castaspella couldn't see them past the guards, but she did see Mortella, who looked... stunned?

She didn't have time to figure that out before Mortella stepped forward, her face still a mask of disbelief, and as her guards separated and spread out, her words named each of Castaspella's guests.

" Presenting to the Mage-Monarch of Mystacor, Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon, her prisoner Shadow Weaver, Princess Entrapta of Dryl..."

Mortella paused, and right before she said it, the Mage-Monarch of Mystacor saw a ghost standing next to Glimmer, holding her niece's hand for support.

“ And King Micah of Brightmoon!” Mortella announced, voice cracking as she said it.

Castaspella's brain barely heard her, as she stared at her brother, at the thing that couldn't be happening. Shadow Weaver was looking smug, somehow, despite her lack of most of a visible face, Entrapta's dropped-down mask made her look more like the Andreenids watching her than anything else, and the sorceress saw *neither* of them, she only saw her own niece because she was standing next to... to...

“ Hi sis!” Micah said, waving at her with his free hand- which held his staff, clutched tight in a white-knuckled grip. “ You got old!”

Castaspella's staff dropped from her nerveless fingers as she stared at him in surprise.

“ Micah?” she said, and Glimmer laughed, her big, rough laugh, so much like her brother's that it had always hurt her aunt to hear it.

“ It's him!” she said. “ He was on Beast Island, and his mind's a little fucked up, but it's him, he's alive! My dad's alive!”

“ I am indeed!” Micah said, and he laughed too, and his daughter sounded *just* like him, but it was him, *her brother was alive* . “ And don't cuss, Glimmer, you're too young- and sis? You look good, I always thought you'd make a good ruler. And you haven't

even killed Mortella, I'm proud of you! Course, I always was, but I'm proud all over again!”

Castaspella's body knew what to do before her mind did; she was off her throne, running, running past her apprentice and her guards and Sweet Bee's team and then she was throwing her arms around her big brother, she tackled him into a hug.

“ You're alive!” she said, and somehow her skinny bones had enough strength to pick him up, she picked him up and spun him around like he used to do to her when they were kids. “ You're alive!”

“ I am indeed!” he repeated, and then he was hugging her with one hand still on a staff, and the room exploded into surprise and not a few cheers.

“ How the fuck are you alive?!?” Castaspella said, as she let go of him, as she pulled away, and her heart tried to explode in her chest. Two tears slipped unnoticed right out of her eyes, tears of sheer shock and joy.

“ With effort!” he replied, smiling, and she could see it- see the effort, see the places where he had cracked, where the glue holding him together had started to run thin. His hair had gone prematurely gray in places and there were lines on his face that would never leave... but he was still in there, cracked as he was. He was still, somehow, himself.

“ We can't stay long,” Glimmer said. “ I want to get him back to my mom... but Mystacor's closer than Brightmoon, and I thought you should know he's alive.”

“ Thank you,” Castaspella said to her niece, and then she looked at her brother again, and something burbled up out of her; laughter, she was laughing, she couldn't help it, hysterical laughter spilled right out of her, the kind you laughed when you were so happy you were almost sad, when it was just all too much. She spoke between stuttered gasps and indrawn laughs. “ Thank you, thank you, thank you!”

She laughed, and her brother laughed with her, and when her niece joined in, it no longer hurt her to hear it.

(She went with them, when they left, writing orders hastily to keep Mystacor running in the meantime and make sure Frit was delivered to them as soon as possible; she spent all that day with Micah, and Glimmer, and she even found it in her not to be angry with Shadow Weaver, because *today* , her brother was alive.)

Chapter End Notes

> As always, every character referenced that's not from SPOP is somebody from the old show. Candor was a wizard dude who taught an apprentice; the Wizard of the Tree was a guy who, after being called ugly, made a whole world in a tree. Mortella was an enemy of Mystacor in the old show, while Ariel, amusingly, has the same job in the old series as she does here, though Ariel in this fic is a more general Number Two than just an apprentice. Candor is no longer alive at this time, dying of a disease called "being old as fuck."
>
> Mortella is Mystacor's lone dark mage at the moment; the Wizard of the Tree retired, and is working on a bizarre spell to turn a tree into a portal out of Despondos. He's going to be

annoyed as hell if Etheria gets transported out before he can manage the feat. Mortella is not Castaspella's enemy here, save in being an old rival of hers who has kept it up since they became adults; the only thing they bond over, other than Mortella's genuine loyalty to her homeland, is that Mortella had the *worst* crush on Micah back in the day, and both her and Castaspella agree that he should have married her instead of Angella. The two sometimes hang out, get drunk, and bitch about Angella.

Sweet Bee was vaguely referenced in SPOP, but in the old show, she was the princess of a whole race of alien bee-people, because old-time She-Ra was fucking wild. Here, she's human, and not an alien Andreenid, the name of her people in the old show; here, Andreenid specifically designates the Rebel squad that serves Sweet Bee. She's not a princess, either in the Runestone sense or politically speaking, but rather the Hive's best soldier and a profitable merchant.

Her hometown of the Hive is an interesting place. Effectively, while they model themselves quite deliberately after eusocial insects in terms of aesthetic, they reach the *qualities* of a eusocial insect society by working with individuality. Worshippers of the Good Woman religion like most of Phlax, they are *also* similar to most of Phlax's founding members by being a republic; what differentiates them is a focus on community service as a form of enlightened self-interest. The Hive has a lot of transparency in its running, and a big emphasis on recognizing major contributors to the town's well-being; the idea is that, if helping the group as a whole gives rewards to an individual, every individual is more likely to help out the group. Ingratitude, or not giving back to those who help you, is literally the worst sin imaginable to the Hive, while paying back an owed debt is the highest virtue. They interpret the parables of the Good Woman as being about the need for reciprocity.

Effectively, its communism by way of emphasis on the benefit for the individuals involved. It's not perfect, because nothing is, but it's workable.
(Hordak was only vaguely aware of the Hive- they're pretty far from the frontlines- but he'd probably have approved of it.)

Sweet Bee is one of the few members of the Hive who is heavily involved in the Rebellion; her and her Andreenids mostly work as raiders, since she lacks the numbers to do much more. She mostly avoids working with Princesses, as she's a bit of a Crownless hardliner; she hopes to spread the Hive's philosophy to other Crownless groups, as she thinks such unity is the best way for the non-Runestone countries to stand up for themselves. She's not an asshole about it, and she's actually quite nice and friendly personally, but she does maintain that Runestone Kingdoms too often trample on Crownless rights for her to be entirely comfortable with them. She used to date Peekablue (the actual one, not Double Trouble) but they broke up once she started committing more heavily to the Rebellion and didn't have any more time for the relationship.

Side note, Ariel's right, their crossbows are absolutely poisonous as hell; specifically, they shoot poison that makes all other wounds hurt worse. It's a nasty bitch of a weapon. They mostly use hacking to deal with robots, since they have a high understanding of tech (especially for a Phlax group, who have a not-totally undeserved reputation as being rather poor in tech), but that's run into some trouble with Adora's crappier Hordebots, since their programming is already such a damn mess that it's hard to figure out how to break their code.

Chapter 31: Catra of the Sword

Chapter Notes

Catra, and her conflicted heart.

Side note: It's been about a week since the Council of the Wise- i.e. Shadow Weaver, Entrapta, and Glimmer- left Dryl. They spent a couple of days just recuperating before they even went back to Salineas, which was their first stop after Beast Island, and then went to Plumeria, where Entrapta insisted they spend at least one night. After that they went to Mystacor, where they spent a few more days as Castaspella lost her shit and got her mind soother back from his art installation.

Thankfully, it's a short trip from Mystacor to Brightmoon...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra of the Sword

Catra lay in her own bed that night, in her own room, and tried to sleep, tried not to think about the Sword, which lay within easy reach, as it always had, ever since the night Shadow Weaver had appeared above her bed. A single magecandle, gleaming softly, gave the room just enough dim lighting that it w asn't *fully* dark... because on bad nights, like this one, it gave her a lot of comfort, to have a little light. Something to banish shadows with.

To make sure the shadows got the message, the door and the window were both not only shut and locked, but had a mage's seal put on them by Angella herself; ever since the night Shadow

Weaver had snuck into her room, Catra hadn't been able to sleep without upgrading her security, and her mother had went above and beyond making sure Catra was safe, making up for her earlier laxness. A chair was also propped up against the door, because silly as it was, every little bit helped Catra to relax.

But Shadow Weaver was miles away in Dryl- officially banished, on pain of death, from entering Brightmoon Castle ever again- and the shadows Catra needed respite from were in her head, generated from her own thoughts.

They were going to pull the trigger- that's what the Sword is. It's a fuse. It's a fuse, and Etheria is the biggest bomb ever built.

Her thoughts flowed away from it, and in lieu of anything else, her mind thought about how... odd, it was, to have a room all to herself. A space that was just *hers* . All around her were the things she, and no one else, had chosen to put here; just a few scattered trinkets, precious little memories. A few of the gifts from Elberon's celebration some months back, including a handful of the confetti Flutterina had used to reveal the invisible Hordebots. A certificate of adoption, hanging on the wall, the bland piece of common government paperwork the most precious and rare thing Catra had. A cactus from the Crimson Waste, the only plant she had, a triple gift from Huntara, Tung Lashor, and Perfuma all three; the squat little ball of a plant was a low-maintenance thing, mostly fierce and spiky... but every now and then, it bloomed forth with gorgeous flowers.

(Perfuma had joked that the plant was much like Catra herself, who had blushed and protested... but not very hard.)

A photo Seahawk had taken of her and Mermista, looking cool on the deck of a Salineas warship (which Seahawk later set ablaze), a Horde destroyer burning in the background before the Sea Gate; one of her proudest victories, from a year and a half ago, the last serious attack the Horde had mounted on Salineas before pulling all their navy back to doing guard duty. It was the victory that had ensured that the Alliance dominated the waves, and they'd known it even then, as anyone could see from the matching smug grins on the saltwater witch and the She-Ra. A small section of Horde weapons hanging on the walls, private war trophies, something Glimmer had gotten her doing that Catra wasn't a hundred percent comfortable with, she'd probably get rid of them; it mostly reminded her of her time with the Horde rather than her time fighting them.

...And next to them, a flag of Dryll, the crossed black pickaxes on a purple background, the very first item she'd ever put up on her wall. She'd done it in memory of Entrapta, who she thought had died in the first raid on the Fright Zone, and kept it, even when the truth was known... because Catra never could give up on anyone or anything, not Shadow Weaver, not Adora, and not...

Not the Sword.

That's all this was- genocide on a galactic scale. ***That's*** *what the Sword is.*

Her thoughts flowed away from it again. Decorating her room had... it was odd, but it had been one of the things it had taken her the longest to do, and somehow one of the things she was proudest of. Besides Entrapta's flag, she hadn't... she hadn't done *anything* to her room for a long time. Part of it was not knowing

what to *do* with a room, because she'd never had one, but... also because, in some way, she was convinced that it was just another way to hurt her. A tool to control her; a privilege extended that would be yanked away the moment she misbehaved. It had taken her a long time to... trust.

For a long, long time, until the weight of evidence had revealed the truth to her skeptic's eyes, she had thought even Angella was just Shadow Weaver in an angel's costume, that all authority would be cruel to her, that every crown held cruelty under it. She'd had no idea that someone could have power over you, and not hurt you with it, but seek your good; she hadn't known, hadn't understood, that this place was really hers.

It had taken time, to realize that she owned a bedroom with attached bath, a small dining area, and a foyer, and could do with them as she wished, that Angella would never take them away without an actual *good* reason; that "good reason" did not include petty sadism or amusement, because Angella was above such things. That "good reason" could, in fact, mean something, wasn't a meaningless pair of words mumbled to justify hurt. Angella would only bar Catra if she did real harm, something Catra would *never* do... and short of that, then the She-Ra's Wing belonged to her.

(Though now it was being called the Younger Princess' Wing, ever since her adoption... and how that made her heart tremble, tremble with that terrible sweetness, that happiness that was the one sugar her tongue hungered for, that her soul craved.)

A little thing, in the scale of the world. Nothing important. But... something important, nonetheless. It felt big, somehow, that she had a room she could change as she pleased, that she had that

much control over her immediate surroundings, that she had a place that was *hers* , and had been since the day three years ago that she had returned her future sister to her future mother's side, despite the odds.

Four, now, Catra realized, as her brain did math in the background of her thoughts, a mental hand flipping mental calendars. *Four years, as of yesterday.*

Four years, of a place that was hers, and hers alone...

And she owed it to the Sword.

Without the Sword, the Heart of Etheria can't be used. Like a grenade with no firing pin.

Her thoughts could flow away from it no longer. It fell into the river of her thoughts like a stone, and her mind could only flow *around* it, make even the thoughts that weren't about the Sword somehow about the blade... and i t was getting harder to pretend nothing was wrong.

It'd been... easier, earlier. When the shock was still fresh, when she'd first found out. Hell, Catra had shrugged it off! The Sword wasn't a tool of evil. It *could* be, but then again, Catra could have been, too! She'd been raised in the Horde! Who knew what she'd be, if she'd never found the Sword?

...But what did it say about her, that only finding the pin in the biggest grenade ever built had made a hero out of her?...

...But it *couldn't* be evil. The Sword was... it was the first real *gift* Catra had ever gotten. She'd had so many more over the years, she was *surrounded* by them, in this room, this room that itself was a gift, but the first thing she'd ever had that was *hers* and *hers* alone had been the Sword. Before the blade, everything else she'd ever had was either borrowed from Adora or something she'd stolen or earned... her entire life had been like that, all hardscrabble rot. She'd been raised by a monster that despised her, that she loved despite knowing she shouldn't; she was unloved by her own people, mocked and rejected and hurt, and while maybe she'd deserved some of that, she had not deserved it all... and the worst unkindness, the chiefest calamity, in the betrayal of the one she loved.

Adora.

Adora, who had been misfortune disguised as good luck; Adora, who had been so kind, and become so cruel. Adora, whom she loved, so much, her heart ranneth over, she loved Adora down to her bones down to her guts down to her soul; she loved Adora, and... and it had all gone *wrong.* Life had given her the sweet smile of Adora only to take it away, had made her love Adora only to hurt her; life had made sure that their first kiss tasted like blood. Adora, who was half sister and half girlfriend and half too many other fucking things, and all Catra wanted, all Catra needed was *time,* she needed *time* with Adora, to put it to rights, to figure out how they could love each other, live with each other, figure out how to make it so they had a future together.

Everything between them had gotten so fucked up and tangled up and just plain *ruined* that it would take them a lifetime together to fix it, and that only if they both chose it... and they were running out of time. Adora was getting worse, and the Alliance more desperate to stop her, and... and it was starting to look like they would *never* have that time, that Adora would never choose Catra, that the dream Catra dreamed, of a life of love with Adora- Catra's oldest dream, even before she'd really understood it, the dream she'd dreamed when she had no other hopes in her at all- would remain just that, forever.

(And the worst part was that she didn't know what she'd do, if- or, as seemed increasingly likely, *when* - that day came, didn't know whom she would pick, didn't know whom she would betray and whom she would save. She knew only that the choice itself, no matter what it was, would kill her; she would betray either her love for her mother, her sister, her friends and her people, or she would betray all of them for Adora, and either choice will kill her. No matter what happened that day, she would die either way; both choices were suicide for her soul and she had but a pick of poison to place to her lips, she would outlive that choice only by however long adrenaline could keep her from turning her blade on herself.)

The beautiful, brave, heroic girl Catra had always known had burned away, leaving only the Dragon in the ashes, and that was the way everything, everything, had always been, with one, just *one,* exception. Her luck had been wise, it had spent itself not in a series of little goods but all in one go, had bought for her the biggest jackpot of all time; by the simple expedient of kicking her off of a skiff, her luck had made sure she found all her future in the shape of a Sword.

Finding the Sword was the moment that had put her on the path to becoming... all this. Princess Catra of Brightmoon, daughter of Queen Angella, heroine of the Great Rebellion, a person who slept in a bed that was hers and was surrounded by things that were hers, who saved lives, defended homes, rescued the helpless and innocent. Every single drop of good she had ever done had started with the Sword, and every single drop of good done to *her* had started with it, too; she owed it every joy in her life.

*So... it **can't** be what she said it was, the Sword made my life so much better, Mara has to be wrong...*

...But even as she had the thought, Catra knew that she was just lying to herself. She *wanted* the Sword to be good, for all this to be... right...

But while Catra was good at lying to herself when it came to those she loved, she had never been a fool. Mara's friends had died, to buy her time. Mara herself had died, to hide the Sword. Mara had died, alone, and in pain, so that no one else would have to die that way; she had died a *bad* death, a death of hurt and suffering, with only the hope embodied in a message she prayed would never be needed to comfort her at the end. Mara had died sacrificing herself for worlds beyond count that would never, ever know of her sacrifice, that would build no statues, hold no funerals, make no feastday on the calendar so that they might remember her heroism, the way Brightmoon's people did for those they loved. She would go unmourned, and she'd known it; Mara had given her life without even the hope that her death would be remembered by anyone, and went down in history vilified by the planet she had loved, which had only known that she had put Etheria in Despondos, never knowing just *why* .

Catra was too good at manipulation to not know what that kind of thing was for. That wasn't the kind of thing a person did on a hunch. That was the kind of thing someone did only when they *knew* , in their heart of hearts, that what they were doing was right, when they had weighed their own death against what it would buy, and judged the price worth it, the trade fair, the deal good enough.

Mara had died to send Catra the truth: the Sword was the death of worlds.

...And it chose me.

She didn't want to think about that. She wanted to do anything *but* think about that. Once, that thought had filled her with warmth, hope, lit her up like a bolt of kindly lightning, striking her not to hurt her, but to make her whole...

And now it left her empty, and cold, like there was a shadow growing under her heart, a shadow her little candle could not banish.

...What did it mean, when a weapon meant to end *worlds* chose you? What hidden failure, what awful flaw, did it see inside her skin, what was it that the Sword knew about Catra that she did not, that led it to think she was *capable* of such a thing?

Had Shadow Weaver been right? She'd always mocked her, called her weak, claimed she didn't have the spine or the discipline or the intelligence to... do anything, basically. Said everything about her was stolen from her betters... was she right? Was there some fuck-up inside, some hidden evil, that the Sword knew about? Had she been fooling herself, all these years, that she could be a hero?

That couldn't be right. S o many people lived because of her... Catra wasn't a bad person, no matter what her first mother had said. She wasn't a bad person; she wasn't bad. She wasn't a monster. She kept her eyes on the photo, on the cactus, on everything in the room she could see in the dim light, and it... it helped, a little. Echoes of all the people who believed in the She-Ra, in all Catra had done... people who knew she was a hero.

She-Ras were heroes! Even Mara, once maligned, had turned out to be a hero, maybe the best of the She-Ras... because she'd screwed everything up for the First Ones, and now with that context *Adora* wasn't so much an outlier as she was a typical member of her species, and Catra didn't want to parse that thought out right now, what it meant, that Adora was a First One, when the First Ones once sought to murder all other life in the universe.

But her mind didn't obey her, thought about it anyway. What did it mean? Was the kinder Adora Catra had once known a... a fluke? Was it something Adora had outgrown as she aged, shedding her decency like a dragon shedding scales? Was she *always* going to be a monster, was that what a First One was like, naturally, had Adora not so much changed as simply matured?

Was *Mara* the one true outlier of her people, alongside her Grayskull squad, and all that Adora had done was... normal, for her species?

...But at Alwyn, Catra had seen the messages the First Ones left behind. They were... people, normal people, in a lot of ways. That was how every species Catra knew of worked, good individuals and bad both, intelligence giving the gift of choice, even as biology dictated certain influences on those choices. Maybe First Ones were like that, just people... or maybe Catra had misread the situation, as she's apparently done with the Sword. Maybe she was wrong, or maybe only some of them were awful, and the rest were still the angels most of Etheria loved to this day... or maybe the good had been the minority, and the majority were the devils Catra now feared them to be. She only knew of two First Ones, Mara and Adora, and two was too few to judge an entire people, particularly two with such extremes of difference between them.

...The Sword had powered the portal, hadn't it? When Adora pulled that switch, it had been the Sword that made that fairy-tale world real, or at least, as real as something made of dreamstuff could be. Real enough to kill, and it had nearly cost Catra her mother, to try and pull that blade out, save that the most unlikely of rescuers had arrived and died in Angella's place.

(Hordak, who had died to save the world- died removing the *Sword* , was it a greater evil than he had ever been? But to even ask the question was to know the answer- *yes* , because Hordak had threatened one world with domination, not many worlds with obliteration, and in dying, he had saved all Etheria. Against the Sword, even Hordak stood on the side of justice...)

She felt sick. She felt... too full, she felt like all this was just sitting in her stomach rolling around and around, and she wanted to vomit it out. Just thinking about it made her gorge rise, her skin was too thin to hold all this ugliness inside her, a storm roiling about in her guts.

I wish I'd never found out.

...But if she'd never known, she'd never have known of brave, heroic Mara, and that made her sick, too. The idea that the woman who had hidden the end of everything away from its makers would be forgotten, that her death in the dark would never be brought to light...

Her guts churned. She wanted to puke, get this sickness *out* of her, her spirit so confused that her body mistook her mind's troubles for stomach trouble. She wanted to sleep, or hit someone, do *anything* that would let her not think about this. She wanted to tell everyone, just let it pour out of her mouth, vomit it out not as puke but as words so that the burden would no longer be hers alone, even if she agreed with her mom that it was best if Angella presented this.

That was coming up tomorrow. A big meeting that Netossa had requested; she was bringing in heavy Crownless and Rebel support, Selkies from Galacia, some group from Phlax called the Hive, even a few of the Scorpioni who had survived the fall of Horror Hall all those years ago. A whole army, who wanted to follow her plan, her plan to... to kill Adora.

(Another unfairness; Catra had no time to process this, not with Netossa howling for blood, was running out of *time* again, and she

hated the wild Princess for it even as she understood why she did what she did.)

Netossa planned to try and advocate again for her plan. Every Princess would be in attendance to argue about it, except Perfuma, who was in Plumeria; the Horde had started moving again, scouts reporting that they were preparing an attack, and Plumeria was the frontline. Before... this, Catra would have been going there herself, but now... now, keeping Etheria from exploding took top priority. The Horde wasn't important in the face of galactic annihilation, *nothing* was important in the face of the world ending.

As for Netossa's plan, Queen Angella was going to hijack it with the information about the Heart. Given that Light Hope was still out there, still manipulating things, it was best if everyone heard, if everyone knew, to keep the AI from pulling strings to set the weapon off anyway. It'd be a bitch to get everyone to listen, and dangerous- how many would think of the Heart as a power source, not see the danger?- but the truth had less chance of backfiring than trying to hide this. Hidden, Light Hope was free to do as she willed; once the truth was out, it would be harder for her to hide her actions.

Catra just hoped they would listen. Catra and her mother were going to tell the world a truth no one knew or wanted to know, of the First Ones' true purpose here, and slam up against centuries of tradition treating the First Ones as heroes; only Queen Angella's long weight and the prestige of her throne would give her words any power to be heard.

(At least it would screw over Netossa's plan- they'd have to deal with it, eventually, but the discussion about the Heart of Etheria

would dominate the meeting. If nothing else interrupted, they'd be able to at least focus on that, and delay the hearing about Netossa's plan for another day.)

Catra would be at that meeting, but afterwards... afterwards, she would be going to the Crystal Castle, to fulfill Mara's last request. Light Hope had to die, or the Sword would... would be used. For its purpose, it's *real* purpose, she has held not a Sword in her hand but the match that would light the biggest bomb ever built...

...Should she take the Sword? She had to, she needed its strength, might not even be able to get in the door without it... but... it was the trigger, the fuse, what is she, that the Sword would choose her?

(The merest brushing of a thought, an outside thought- something comforting, only half-heard, a vague idea that she was chosen because she had been trusted to do the right thing- came into her head, but Catra, mistaking it for her own hopes, dismissed the kindly alien thought without consideration.)

She felt... betrayed. Hurt, by something she'd trusted.

She felt the way *Shadow Weaver* made her feel.

Catra, the most powerful person on Etheria, laid in her bed, and helplessly cried herself to nightmare-wracked sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Up next: A meeting, and revelations!

Chapter 32: Catra of the Troubled Heart

Chapter Notes

> I had to split the War Council chapter in two; this was meant to be the first half, but it just works so *well* as a split-off!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra of the Troubled Heart

It is so beautiful.

In the darkness, glittering, the most wonderful tapestry she's ever seen; she is a child of light, she hates and fears shadow, but even she must admit that there is something primordially good about what she is seeing. A tapestry of infinite blackness all around her, decorated by some brilliant hand with little points of light, a billion billion of them, uncountable, weaving a tapestry of triumphant majesty all about her on black canvas. Stars and nebula and colors and other things that she suddenly has words for, the whole of creation, she sees a galaxy whole.

It is good, it is beautiful and it is good, and for all that she is embraced by the darkness, she is not afraid. This is not the shadow that has hurt her all her life. It does not eat the little lights inside it; it loves them, it embraces them, this is darkness not as the destroyer of light but as its lover. She takes him in hand and he holds hers and they dance, there is a place where two

lovers are dancing and all the universe is made between them, is found traced in the patterns of their steps.

She sees with sight beyond sight all the worlds, the worlds beyond counting, that contain the universe's greatest achievement- the small yet gigantic miracle called life. Not every planet, no; she can see that most are barren rock, or poisonous gas, or empty liquid. Life is a rare thing.

But rare is, itself, a rare thing, when stretched to encompass something as big as a galaxy. In a universe with trillions of dead stones circling the stars, there is life, still, like a little treasure reality hides for itself in little nooks and crannies. A kaleidoscope of worlds pass her by; water worlds of shape-changing mutants and stars patrolled by powerful cyborgs and a green light, a horrifying green light that reaches out to grab more and more and more, three siblings fleeing the blaze of that awful light, which makes Catra- Catra!- long for the cool dark, the way she never has in all her life, wanting to flee light to seek safety in shadow.

And in the midst of her wonder, something of terror grips her, for there is something in her hands.

She lifts them up, it is the Sword, it is ***the Sword****, she can hear the capitals, she can feel them in the trembling in her hands. Her hands tremble and shake and she lifts them up and she hears screaming, the Princesses are screaming and Etheria is screaming, too, they are all a bullet in a gun and they beg not to be fired.*

But Catra, the trigger, cannot scream, she is too scared to scream, all her fears are in silence and she fights as hard as she can but it doesn't matter, fate has her left hand and destiny her right and when they smile at each other blood drips down from their teeth, for they have Catra's heart in their jaws.

She fights. She fights as hard as she can.

But in the end, she alone is not enough, and she lifts the Sword.

And the dance ends, as the galaxy burns.

Catra jerked awake, mouth open in a silent scream, curled up in her bed so hard her muscles ached.

It took her a long, long time to stop screaming.

It took her even longer to do anything but just lay there, and let her mouth stay shut, her jaw aching from the force with which she'd held it open, with all the sound she had not emitted. She laid there and shivered, no matter that sweat was running in rivers down her fur, that she felt feverish and sick, that her covers were tangled tight against her form. She shivered, and hurt, and shivered, and through her head ran only dimly colored things, mental fogs flavored with pain and confusion and regret and a desperate desire for the world to be other than it was.

...But, eventually, a thought arose amidst her muddled mind, though it was, perhaps, too strong a word. It wasn't *entirely* a thought; a wordless desire, something more than a passing fancy but less than a complete thought, an ancient instinct resurrected in her time of need- the unconscious urge to seek shelter, bred into the back of all living things by evolution.

The thought had a color, too- the color of her mother's wings.

...Anything was better than this.

The Rebellion's greatest heroine slowly, slowly, untangled herself, the covers heavy as lead, heavy as iron, heavy as steel. On shaking legs, she got up, and the young woman, hugging herself, managed to stumble to her door, grateful her eyes were good in the dark. She moved slowly, as quietly as she could, in her exhausted state returning to lessons learned in her childhood- especially the most important lesson of all, that of *quiet* .

(If she was just quiet enough, Shadow Weaver wouldn't notice her...)

She paused before the door, drew in a shuddering breath, vaguely knowing she shouldn't do this. She should at least dress in something other than bedclothes; what would they think, seeing their Princess wandering about in her pajamas? Not that Catra really had those; just shorts and a shirt... but it made other, *older* words echo in her head, mutated to sound like they came from Brightmoon mouths, things her first mother had said to her all her life.

(*useless, ungrateful, shameful*)

Normally, she kept those thoughts at bay; but tonight?

Tonight, she was weak.

She hesitated, before, defeated, turning back to her bed.

She wouldn't... wouldn't embarrass her mother. She would *never* make Angella regret adopting her... just the thought made her want to *cry* , and how *pathetic* was that, crying, it was pathetic, she was so fucking...

She tried to sleep again, tried to force herself to sleep; and she did not have *new* nightmares.

No, these were quite old.

She was awoken from a dream of being trapped, of *shadows* holding her still and hurting her- a dream that was mostly memory- by a sharp knock on her door.

" What?" Catra managed to croak out, quickly rising up, wiping her face, vaguely aware that she had wept in her sleep.

“ Princess Catra!” came the voice outside. “ Are you alright? Please, open the door!”

The guardswoman had saved Catra from the end of the nightmare, when the magic holding her pressed in just that little bit more and pulped her body to bleeding flesh and broken bone, and her gratitude for that- plus the little bits of actual sleep Catra had gotten between her mind's assaults on itself- led her to rise up, and head to the door in something a bit more like wakefulness.

She was awake enough, in fact, to remember protocol, if just barely.

“ Warning phrase?” she asked as she reached the door. There were code phrases guards were supposed to repeat if asked for them; Catra didn't want to open her door to an enemy.

(Or Shadow Weaver, all she could see was Shadow Weaver over her bed again)

“ Hero-Saints Lady Ranko and Prince Tenchi,” the guard replied, naming an ancient hero couple of Brightmoon. Catra wasn't even sure how she *knew* that; it wasn't like there was an orientation for Brightmoon culture. Most of what she knew she'd picked up casually or from Glimmer...

I should really learn something about my people's history, Catra thought in passing, but that was a later thought. That had been

the correct phrase, so she opened the door to reveal a trio of guards.

" What's happening?" she asked the woman in the lead, noting that the hallway was completely dark outside.

" Brightmoon has been subject to what we *believe* is an attempt to hack our systems," the guard answered. " Our lights, sprinkler system, and internal communications are down."

" Fuck," Catra growled, adrenaline punching . " Are we under attack?"

" We don't know," the guard said. " General Juliet does not believe we are; scouts report no movement near Brightmoon. Tech Master Bow has already set up to study the problem, and fix it. I was sent to make sure that no assassins had struck."

Catra's heart almost stopped in her chest as a single word struck through her like a thunderbolt.

(Mom)

" Is my mother alright?" Catra asked quickly.

" I have no idea," the guard said. " Our communications are down, though I know General Juliet sent a squad to her door."

“ Give me one second,” Catra said, already turning around. “ I'll be right there, we'll go to her room together.”

“ General Juliet wished for us to report back,” the sergeant said, “ but we can accompany you.”

“ Good,” Catra said, letting the rush of fear spur her as she threw on slightly better clothes- and with only a moment's hesitation, grabbed the Sword.

(*Evil or not, I may need you to save her* , and that was enough for Catra.)

Out the door, down the halls, moving fast. The guards had lanterns, but the darkness wasn't consistent; some rooms stayed lit up, while other lights flicked on and off at random, blinding and disorienting whenever they did so. The sprinklers kicked on, too, and getting wet just made Catra even angrier as they moved through the halls, passing inhabitants and other guards both.

Brief episodes of meeting happened in the dark; Catra found her three retainers, nervously peeking their heads out of their shared bedroom. Catra had reassured them quickly to stay in their rooms, and not open the door for anyone who didn't know the passcode. Later she caught a glimpse of Bow, who gave her an absent-minded wave with one hand as he worked furiously on a trackerpad before a terminal, General Juliet and her bodyguards personally watching his back.

And at one point, something came zooming right up to them in the darkness, resolving itself into Flutterina as it came into their lantern light.

" Warning phrase!" Flutterina said cheerfully as she skidded to a stop before her heroine and her trio of guards.

" Hero-Saints Lady Ranko and Prince Tenchi," Catra said.

" Awesome!" Flutterina said, bouncing where she stood. " Your mom sent me! I went to her first cause-I-was-up-when-this-happened-since-I-don't-need-sleep-much-and-I-thought-she-might-get-attacked-in-the-dark!"

Flutterina paused and sucked in a huge breath, visibly forcing herself to slow down.

" *But,* but, anyway, she's fine and wanted to make sure you're okay!" she finished cheerfully. " But of course you are, you're the She-Ra! I was worried about her, you'd be fine! And you *are* fine, right?"

" I am," Catra said, and she smiled; knowing her mom was alright- or at least, had been- helped, let her ease some of the adrenaline off. She still needed to get there- that her mother was alive when she sent Flutterina didn't mean she'd *stayed* alive since- but it helped. " Fall in with me, I'm heading that way myself."

“ Okay!” Flutterina said. “ I'll stay ahead though, the lantern light kills my nightvision and I'm a Lunoth anyway we have awesome night vision! I'll be like a scout!”

Having a scout didn't help much. The corridors were chaos, and there was one more thing that weighed on Catra alone; the lanterns of guards, glimpsed in the distance down some halls, they were... they were too much like the little lights in the darkness, the... the galaxy, or whatever that was Catra had seen.

The Sword felt... very heavy, after a few of those sightings.

Thus distracted, she was caught off-guard when a row of lights kicked on, suddenly, blinding her and her entourage.

“ Ah fuck, my eyes!” Flutterina cussed at the top of her lungs, which would have made Catra blurt out laughing if not for the fact she was too busy cursing herself.

“ Dammit!” she said. “ Fucking lights!”

They shut off as soon as they started, Catra blinking away the spots in her eyes... to find a guard before her, one with no lantern.

“ Halt!” the guard said. “ Warning phrase?”

“ Hero-Saints Lady Ranko and Prince Tenchi,” Catra grumbled. “ Don't you recognize your princess?”

“ I did, *darling* ,” the guard said, with a grin Catra could barely see, “ but there *was* a changeling infiltrator recently. It seems only rational to assume they could be *anyone* . Like this little Lunoth here- they'd be a perfect choice! Who would suspect all that pink?”

“ Hey!” Flutterina said, puffing up. “ What's wrong with being pink?!? And I'm not a spy!”

“ I know, darling,” the guard said, their grin friendly but... mocking. Something like worry percolated vaguely in the back of Catra's brain. “ But I'm just pointing out- you can't trust *anyone* . This situation? It's *perfect* for stealth. So much *drama~* !”

Something's not right... Catra thought... but then the lights flicked on *and* the sprinklers activated, soaking her and blinding her.

“ Fucking *again?!?”* Flutterina shouted, half gargling it as water blasted into her mouth.

“ Every time you swear it's funnier,” the guard opined before turning to Catra. “ I'm afraid I have to go, darling; unless you

need me? I live to serve, after all.”

Catra, her eyes semi-recovered, looked at the guard again. What *was* up with this guard? Something... not quite right, in the way they stood, in the way the grin on their face seemed a little too... knowing? Mocking? Nothing specific, just a sense of... something not quite right...

...But she didn't have *time* for this. Her mom was in danger; maybe she was just being paranoid.

“ No, you're free to go,” she said.

“ Then ta ta, Princess!” the guard said, before walking off. If Catra wasn't wrong, they were following the lights that had lit up...

Stop it, she ordered herself. *You're not sure about that, you could just be making stuff up. You're jumpy on adrenaline, Mom needs you, and you haven't had a good night's sleep in days. Just... stop it. Don't hassle one of your own people out of your paranoid fantasies.*

“ Okay, let's go,” Catra said, and tried to put the odd encounter out of her mind.

(Later- when Catra found out about the prison room, about how the sprinkler system had washed away the dust the binding runes were traced in, and realized that the trail of lights had led to the

stables and freedom- she will realize the truth of what had happened, though too late to do anything about it.)

A few minutes later, they made it to the Queen's private chambers, and to Catra's relief she saw two guards outside of them.

" Halt!" the first said to her group. " Warning phrase?"

" Hero-Saints Lady Ranko and Prince Tenchi," Catra said. "Is the Queen alright?"

" She is," the guard said. " Flutterina was sent to check on you- I see you were successful, small one!"

" I was!" the Lunoth said.

" Queen Angella said you could go in if you arrived," the guard said.

" Good," Catra replied. " I'll do that. And... you three, stay here, too. Flutterina?"

" Yes, Princess Catra?" the Lunoth responded, snapping her perfect salute again, her lantern in the other hand.

“ Tell Juliet that I took these three,” Catra said, indicating the trio who'd awoken her, “ and added them to the Queen's guard. I'm staying here to guard Angella, and so are they. After you tell her, ask her if she has any messages for Mom or me, then come back; we'll use you as a messenger while comms are down- at least, if you feel up to it.”

The last she almost forgot to add on, before reminding herself that, in non-Horde nations, Flutterina was a *kid* , and should be treated as such- or, at least, given the option.

“ I am *always one-hundred-percent-super-ready-to-serve-you!*” Flutterina declared, almost jittering in place as her natural speed took over in her excitement. “ So-yes-I-am! Be-right-back!”

She tore off like a shot, moving at speeds that would require descriptors like turbo or goddamn, vanishing into the darkness.

“ You three stand guard out here,” Catra ordered.

“ Yes, Princess!” the group saluted, as Catra slipped into her mother's rooms.

In the kitchen, talking with another guard, was the Queen, and the sight of Angella, awake and unhurt, eased a tension that even the guard's words had not.

“ Hey,” Catra said, and it was, embarassingly, a little choked up. “ Glad you're alright.”

“ Oh, Catra!” Angella said. “ I sent Flutterina-”

“ She found me,” Catra said. “ I was already on my way, though. Any word on who's hacking us, and why?”

“ No,” Angella said. “ One moment.”

She turned to the guard.

“ You have your orders,” she said. “ Dismissed.”

“ Ma'am!” the guardsman said, saluting before he left. After he was gone, Angella turned back to her daughter.

“ Bow's investigating now,” she said. “ This doesn't feel like Horde... it'd be the first time Lord Adora has tried something like this... but then, who else could it be? The only other person who leaps to mind is Entrapta, but she's in Dryll, and I would hope she would not betray us again... though I will not lie and claim I did not consider the possibility. I hate to think she might turn on us, but I have to consider the possibility, unlikely as it is.”

Catra didn't like thinking of that either... she liked to believe in redemption... but it was possible, she had to admit.

" True," she said, frowning.

" Still, I don't think this is her," Angella reassured Catra. " I can't see why she would, and I can't see how it could really assist her; what would this be a prelude to? We're dazed and stumbling about right now, but that won't last long. Bow's isolating the network, and I have guards heading to activate the auxiliary systems as we speak; I designed the Castle to have backups. I'm nothing like a true tech master like Bow, and far beneath someone like Entrapta, but I know enough engineering to have kept most of the Castle off the network, for this exact situation. Only the lights, the fire safety system, and- unfortunately- our internal communication system are run by machine, and they've got backups... though I'm not even sure how this attack got in, none of those have external connections. There must be a device somewhere, built to receive a signal... or some First Ones tech I know nothing of..."

A horrible possibility occurred to Catra, one that seemed, in retrospect, obvious.

" You don't... think it's Light Hope, do you?" Catra asked her mother, who paused, eyes widening.

“ I... had not thought of that,” Angella said. “ We don't really know what the AI is capable of... but why? What would be the point?”

At that moment, there was a low hum as the lights kicked on.

“ Oh! The backups must be on!” Angella said. “ Good, that'll help get everyone calmed down. I'm going to set up a meeting in the war council room- hopefully Bow has something for us.”

“ I'll stick with you,” Catra said. “ Keep watch. Unless you need me to do something else?”

Angella shook her head.

“ Not at all,” she said.

They left the room together, and then set up in the war room, where things began to blur for Catra. With the adrenaline fizzling out, Catra's exhaustion started to take over, and before she was quite aware of it, barely ten minutes into the night, she sat down, and what was *meant* to be a moment to rest her eyes became actual sleep, despite the constant clamor around her as Angella asked for status updates to find out if anything had been stolen or anyone hurt.

(Angella let her sleep; her daughter was so exhausted that she'd be of little help if awoken anyway, and the revelation that Double

Trouble had escaped the containment room- and that a hovercraft was missing from the stables- was not something Catra could help with anyway. Angella only awoke her when things began to wind down... though when she was updated, Catra had went with Angella to her own quarters, and fallen asleep in one of the kitchen chairs, unwilling to leave her mother's side.)

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter: Double Trouble, and an... interesting... choice of employer.

Chapter 33: Double Trouble of the Crimson Waste

Chapter Notes

A new POV!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Double Trouble of the Crimson Waste

Well, that had gone off just *swimmingly!*

Double Trouble held onto the hovercraft they'd stolen as it hurtled through the night... well, a hovercraft that *was* stolen, anyway. Just not by Double Trouble. They were only an accomplice on this particular crime.

Whoever was driving this machine was not present, and was driving it quite well; they wove their way through the Whispering Woods with great agility, dodging tree branches and roots, ducking and weaving, and all without needing the on-board lights of the open-topped hovercraft. A good decision, since any such light would have inevitably warned any pursuers of Double Trouble's location... but like this, there was no sound, the hovercraft's drive system perfectly silent as they whizzed through the night. The Woods around them made more noise, the calls of nightbirds and the buzzing of insects and the low, distant grunt of the big boars that roamed the Woods.

Honestly, it was a bit terrifying, but that kind of worked for Double Trouble; they lived only for drama, after all, even if the vagaries of life had left them needing to do mercenary work to make ends meet. And this? Flying through the night on a remote-operated hovercraft, not knowing where they were going, knowing nothing of their mysterious benefactor, the wind in their hair?

Oh, this was *wonderful!* Double Trouble leaned back against one handrail, and simply enjoyed the ride, even as they pondered their time in Brightmoon. It had gone really well, actually; few suspected big, dumb Scorpia of any wrongdoing, and playing up Scorpia's stupidity made it easier to avoid conversations and duck away from the others when necessary. It helped considerably that Catra, whom Adora had warned them about- excessively, in Double Trouble's opinion, that woman was *obsessed* with her ex- had been spending almost all of her time in the Woods, fighting Adora's Horde.

Really, the only mistake they'd made had been in underestimating *Glimmer* , of all people. Mermista catching on? They could see it. They'd had some real respect for Mermista; Salineas, after all, was the one Runestone Kingdom that could be said to have decisively *beaten* the Horde, if only on the water.

But Glimmer? The *lesser* Princess of Brightmoon, the one that was just a glittery brute with worthless wings? She wasn't a She-Ra, nor even a *real* Princess; a real Princess didn't have to recharge, but Glimmer did, nursing at the Moonstone like a babe at mother's tit.

No, they'd dismissed Glimmer completely, and privately, could admit that they'd deserved what happened next. Double Trouble

was a changeling; they knew, better than *anyone,* that appearances could be deceiving, but they'd forgotten it when it came to Glimmer, and boy howdy, had they *paid.* They were going to have nightmares about that fall for the rest of their life... such awful moments! Falling, so high up they couldn't even *breathe,* unable to shapeshift fast enough to escape*...* and then locked into a single shape! Thank whatever spirits watched sneaky little shits like Double Trouble that the mean little Princess' spell had worn off during their imprisonment, or they'd never have gotten out.

But, honestly, after their frankly pants-shittingly terrifying capture, it hadn't been bad at all. Somewhat to Double Trouble's surprise, the propaganda Brightmoon spread about how well it treated its prisoners had more than a grain of truth in it; it had grain enough for bread, three times a day, along with a simple but not completely awful vegetable stew and water, the latter available not just at mealtime but whenever they asked for it.

And that was it. No more harm done to them than an inability to leave the room or do anything else. Double Trouble had... not really expected that. Nowhere else they'd ever been imprisoned- and they'd been a jailbird all over the eastern coast of Etheria- had been so... gentle.

Apparently, sometimes Brightmoon really was the place it made itself out to be.

They'd even bothered to inform Double Trouble of their legal status, which had been unnecessarily amusing; the poor woman they'd sent in to tell them had been so much fun to tease! She'd looked the usual serious type that so many legal folks were, but all Double Trouble had to do was take a variety of good-looking

forms and do some... *interesting* poses, and the poor woman had sweat enough to flood a house. The two guards in the room as well had just rolled their eyes, being made of sterner stuff, but she'd been flat out *destroyed* .

(Apparently she was a woman of culture, having focused mostly on Double Trouble's wide variety of impressive asses; when they'd managed a rather saucy legs up, head down pose, aimed her way, they thought she'd pop a blood vessel.)

Still, despite the fact her hormones were visibly punching her in the brain, to the point that the two guards in the room were wincing, she'd managed to get out her message. Double Trouble's trial had been, by motion of the Queen, apparently skipped entirely, using a legal doctrine based on overwhelming evidence and necessity of speed called Ranko's Law- the rather distressed little lawspeaker had even given Double Trouble a rather brief rundown of the law's bizarre circumstances, squeaking it out in a clear attempt to distract herself with useless trivia. Something about a bunch of evidence against Ranko's father, and a need to swiftly remove a curse he'd slapped onto his daughter over... something? Something about gender.

Confusing, but sounded entertaining; Double Trouble would have to steal a history book soon.

The ruling was that Double Trouble would be subjected to a truth-telling spell once the mage they requested from Mystacor arrived, and then asked a lot of questions. Honestly, that was fair; a spy was the kind of target you pumped for information, after all. After that, they'd have a more proper trial to decide what to do with Double Trouble, though the lawspeaker- when she wasn't watching Double Trouble's ass- had said that it was likely that

they'd be looking at significant jail time if their espionage, as the Queen suspected, had been part of why the Princess Alliance kept getting ambushed. People had died, after all, and that demanded punishment.

Which really just made the lack of torture more surprising. Not that torture was something Double Trouble was all that worried about, what with being able to turn off their pain receptors, and being a good enough actor to fake their suffering... but it was still odd.

At any rate, they'd mostly been biding time, waiting to break out. Angella's runes had been *serious* stuff, Double Trouble's tiniest forms hadn't been able to find a gap, but there'd come a mistake, always. Someone would get sloppy. They'd have their fun and get out... they'd even debated trying to cut a deal. It wasn't like they were in this for loyalty to Adora, after all. Some cold hard Brightmoon silver in hand, and their freedom, and Double Trouble would cheerfully tell them whatever they wanted to know before fucking off back to the Crimson Waste.

After all, they were of a practical bent. They figured the Horde was still going to win this war, but that was getting a lot less certain, especially with Double Trouble unable to warn them of troop movements and the like. The Horde's offensive would have a much harder time, and the Alliance might pull through yet.

Either way, Double Trouble had planned to just lay low for a while. Wait to see what happened next, and entertain themselves in the meantime. Use the acquired funds to grab good wine and good food and good company. Maybe spend the time at the Enchanted Grotto, they *loved* Peekablue's little underwater theater...

Ooh, or even enact an old idea they'd had, of stealing the Far-Seeing Prince's place at the Grotto! Peekablue spent so much time out of the Grotto that they could impersonate him for a while, he'd never know. Play out a life as a stage manager while he was busy, which would be Double Trouble's dream job if only it paid better.

Hell, if they did good enough, Peekablue might even let them stay a while after he found out!

(Wasn't like he was using the theatre all that much; after his last girlfriend, Sweet Bee, dumped him, he'd spent most of his time moping in the Crownless citystates of Octopus Cove or Seaworthy, or so rumor held.)

All they'd have to do was find their little stash of Horde gold, trade it out for something less likely to get them stabbed in Rebel territory- Brightmoon or Salinean silver, Snows iron, even Plumeria's little wooden tokens, whatever- and head to the coast of the Sea of Sighs.

After that? Well, if the Rebels looked likely to win, they'd come back and make an offer... and if it looked like Lord Adora was going to win, they'd just crawl back to her side with a sob story of their escape and the need to recuperate before returning to work.

...Though on second thought, if the Horde pulled it off, maybe they'd just go home and hide. The young woman leading the Horde was *not* the most stable person they'd ever met, and while that was *great* for drama... it was also great for *danger* . Being

near Lord Adora was a lot like warming your hands at a bonfire you hadn't built; it could contain *anything,* from common wood to high explosives, and you wouldn't know which until it was too late.

Maybe Lord Adora had stabilized while Double Trouble was locked up, but they doubted it. That'd take something pretty big to happen to her, or a lot of work with a mind soother, and preferably both... and Double Trouble would bet every drop of cash they'd ever made that the Horde didn't have any mind soothers.

That had been the plan, and honestly? Tonight's escape didn't really change that. Oh, they'd hear their mystery helper out- if for no other reason than that they'd already demonstrated a lot of power that Double Trouble didn't feel like crossing- but after that? They were *out* .

Well, assuming this wasn't Lord Adora rescuing them, in which case they'd be a bit more stuck... but Double Trouble didn't think that was the case. This plan had enough misdirection and lying involved to be the Horde Lord's plan, but not *nearly* enough fire. If Lord Adora had broken them out, Double Trouble would have expected half of Brightmoon to be up in flames, and the other half to be catching.

(And honestly? Double Trouble didn't think Lord Adora would go to the trouble for a spy.)

Which, of course, raised the question... who had? As the hovercraft continued to fly through the Woods, Double Trouble pondered who had started it up in the stables, making the light

above it flicker three times to draw attention. That had attracted the guard in the stables, whom Double Trouble had put down swiftly, with their hands made into claws carrying the paralyzing poison of the Crimson Waste's most abundant cacti; a single swipe across one cheek had stunned the man.

(They'd left the guard alive, of course; one of the best rules they'd figured out over the years was to always do as little harm as you could. It made it easier to sell yourself as a necessary evil, or even friendly, should you have to turn to former enemies for cash...)

The hovercraft had then drifted to the door, which had been locked; Double Trouble had to open that one themselves, no mechanical assistance for the purely analog door. The lights that had guided them safely out of the castle had, helpfully, flashed three times over the paralyzed guard's form, and on him the changeling had found the keys.

Three times, to draw the eye. A repeated pattern, from the moment that they'd been woken up by the sudden lights, to watch as the sprinkler systems turned on and washed away the dust that the Queen of Brightmoon had scrawled the room's containment cell in... water that had not touched Double Trouble, which they were grateful for. Nothing worse than wet hair. Their disguises would just have looked *silly!* They'd have had to find a towel before escaping, and that would have just slowed it all down so very much.

But no, their benefactor had not soaked them, and so they'd been able to proceed with all haste. Not that it hadn't gotten a bit... touch-and-go in there. Oh, they'd shot right past most of the guards all right, and had even managed to pick up the warning

phrase without being spotted, but then they'd run into the She-Ra! Oof, that could have gone poorly. They'd almost gotten caught there. Catra had almost suspected, when they met up, it was clear on her face...

But almost, as Double Trouble was *sure* they'd heard Grox say at one point or another, only counted when one was using explosives. Lord Adora had warned Double Trouble, repeatedly, of how clever Catra was, before she sent them into Brightmoon, but all that cleverness hadn't been *quite* enough to overcome the lights and the water and the sheer delightful *chaos* of tonight.

...Though it probably hadn't helped that the darling did *not* look her best. Bags under her eyes, swaying where she stood, hair a mess. For someone who had just gotten out of bed, the poor dear had looked like she was ready to fall right back into it. Double Trouble was no doctor- though they'd played one for three months once- but even they knew that girl needed rest.

But! Not their problem.

But all the things used in the escape were machines. A tech master, then, clearly. But who? Maybe Bow had turned on his compatriots- though that might just be Double Trouble's own deeply-rooted paranoia talking. One did not act as a shapeshifting spy without developing a deep and abiding disloyalty to any cause but one's own, after all.

Entrapta? Ooh, now *that* made more sense. Enacting some plan of Hordak's? Double Trouble- like everyone on Etheria- had heard the

juicy details of that most Wild Princess; the frumpy little tech geek had fallen hard for Hordak, of all people. What a situation! Oh, and the rumors, swirling and swirling; that she was pregnant with Hordak's brat, and sought help reclaiming her child's throne from Adora, was Double Trouble's favorite. She could use some non-Allied assistance... yes, the smart money was on Entrapta.

Well, that would be fun; they'd see what she wanted, play along, and if it was fun enough?

Well, the Grotto would still be there when they were done. Something like a retirement plan and vacation, all in one.

Future course thus set, the changeling simply enjoyed the ride for the next little while, until, finally, the Woods opened up, around a patch of land that looked like the ruins of the First Ones, a sight familiar to any dweller of the Crimson Waste. Whatever had made the Crimson a Waste had involved the First Ones... their artifacts were all over the place in the sand. Half the trade in the Valley of the Lost was just selling shit they'd dug up, to whoever would pay.

As one of the rare people born in the Waste, that had been Double Trouble's childhood, hunting machines in the deadly desert for a variety of mobsters and bosses, receiving a pittance of what their captures were worth... at least, until they'd figured out how to shift their form, and more... *dramatic* opportunities opened up.

(Sometimes, they wondered where their parents were, or even who they had been; Double Trouble had only the absolute smallest recall of them, something too thin to be called a memory, barely echoes of shadows. They had long since passed the stage

of worrying about that sort of thing, but sometimes they still... wondered.)

So they recognized what they were seeing. First Ones' ruins...

The hovercraft drifted to the ground and shut down, and Double Trouble, taking the hint, stepped off. The ruins were empty for a few short moments... before, with slight glitching, the lines of the runes lit up blue, and a woman suddenly appeared before them, made out of glimmering light.

" Hello, Double Trouble," the figure said. " My name is Light Hope."

...Well. Tonight had just been *full* of wonders!

" And what can I do for you?" the changeling asked, and the woman before them smiled.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter: A reunion long awaited, and a war council.

Chapter 34: Netossa of the Great Rebellion

Chapter Notes

> This ended up huge; so NEXT chapter will be big war meeting. But we close!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Netossa of the Great Rebellion

Netossa woke up in her wife's arms, in the time before dawn, the first rays of Etheria's moons still too distant to brighten the sky.

She hadn't been woken by the sound of an alarm, or by a noise nearby that meant danger. No, nothing had woken her at all but sheer force of habit; she was used to odd hours, these days. Years of war- years and years of war- had taught her to wake before dawn, when so many attacks were made, both by her own side and by the enemy; and being awake had been the difference, too often, those few extra seconds of wakefulness enough to save her life. It was the same reason that she sometimes woke up in the dead of night, her body primed for a midnight ambush, either to fight one off or, more often these days, lead one into battle.

She'd never bothered to fight the reflex. She'd needed it too often to put it away, that extra second to truly wake up too valuable, too many times to count, over too many battles. The readiness was worth the nights and mornings both where she'd have to

remind herself that there was nothing wrong, and that she could go back to sleep, worth the little tiredness she fought with the Salinean coffee that was her one indulgence.

(Sure, Dryl grew most of Etheria's coffee, from a hardy, cold-adapted plant, but Netossa had always found the Salinean variants smoother- and that'd been a lucky break, when Entrapta turned traitor, and Dryl stopped trading with the Alliance.)

This morning, it was useful to wake up this early. No ambush today- not unless the Horde had managed to get a lot farther north and a lot farther west than it had since the Battle of Brightmoon- but so she had time to get her thoughts in order. The meeting wasn't until noon, but it was too important, too *vital,* to leave it until the last minute. She lay there, listening to her Spinny sleep, and let her mind spin up, restarting its endless run, swift feet hitting the ground as new ideas and contingency plans and responses.

(*I love that about you,* Spinnerella had told her once, *the way you're always moving, always thinking, always... shining, shining so bright* and Netossa knew that she would live all her life simply grateful that, somehow, she'd found true love, which evaded so many.)

Her mind kindled itself into a roaring bonfire inside her skull, and as the greater mass warmed up, the first flickering embers leapt up for review. She studied them like a general, preparing for the fight ahead. Oh, it was n o *physical* battle... but the coming meeting was a battle nonetheless. She had to fight for her position, and overcome resistance; that she was wielding words and not weapons did not change the basic tactics.

...And that was kind of reassuring, to think of it that way. Netossa wasn't normally one to get nervous, but this *mattered,* this might put an end to the war once and for all, and even nerves of steel could... shiver.

Thinking of it as a fight made it easier. Netossa was many things, but she was not a woman who *lost* fights. It gave her confidence, settled that light shiver inside, and that was half the fight won, right there. You couldn't do anything if you didn't *believe* you could. Was like trying to fire a bow without arrows.

Add to that a plan for every contingency- something Netossa prided herself on- and you might actually win.

So, first things first: what's today's goal?

Always the first question to ask. If you didn't know where you wanted to go, you couldn't get there; and Netossa, who had a fast, powerful brain, needed that direction more than most, to keep her mind from running off after a stray thought making vibrations on some distant corner of her web of thoughts. To keep the super-swift spider that was her mind on task, she needed a focus, and the questions vibrated at just the right frequency to keep her on task. She repeated it to herself, laying out the tracks for her train of thought.

First things first: what's today's goal?

Get the Princess Alliance to agree to a raid on the Fright Zone, with the goal of taking out Lord Adora. Push to execute Lord Adora; secondarily, ask for her capture if execution is unfeasible. Additional, but secondary, goals of the raid include killing or at least badly injuring as many of Lord Adora's Force Captains as can be attacked without compromising the main objective; while Lord Adora almost certainly hadn't had time to train a replacement, everyone the raid killed, or at least hurt, was someone who would have be unavailable to restore order to the Horde.

And that meant the next question was...

Why do we need to achieve this goal?

Always ask yourself why; a lesson her parents had taught her, and life had reinforced. Too many people never stopped and asked it, both smart and stupid.

So, again.

Why do we need to achieve this goal?

Because otherwise the Horde would set all the Woods ablaze, which would destroy Plumeria, the Rebels, and Brightmoon, and leave them a route open to invade the rest of Etheria. The Horde had already conquered the nations of Etheria's southern peninsula, and the Woods were the major thing blocking them from going further north; put them to the torch, and...

Well. You didn't have to be all that smart to know where *that* would end up. The Horde had to be stopped.

Can we accomplish bigger tasks without achieving this goal?

Goal set, and checked to make sure it was needed; now to figure out if it was actually necessary, or if it could be skipped. Another way to ask *why,* focused on the practical rather than the moral.

Can we accomplished bigger tasks without achieving this goal?

Unlikely at best. The Rebel and Crownless forces already available to her almost certainly couldn't do the job of leading the raid themselves. There weren't enough of them and they lacked enough punch individually to make up for it; her personal brigade of Rebels were some of the best soldiers on Etheria, and Netossa would bet her life- and *had* - that they could take on any force of equivalent size, and come out on top.

But there were only so many of them. When Hordak had conquered the Runestone Duchies- a term people had forgotten, the way they'd forgotten that the Fright Zone was once a Runestone Kingdom- he'd acquired a *massive* population. The Horde was not named wrongly... short of Plumeria, and *maybe* the Snows, no other nation had so many people in it.

Worse, the Horde could use *more* of its population than anyone else could. Hordak's automations and ruthless removal of all that was not strictly necessary for war had obliterated the need for much of a bureaucracy; his tooth-to-tail ratio was better than anybody else's. Ten people back home for every one on the front, that was the ratio Angella had taught her, back during the first Alliance. She still recalled Micah's accompanying lecture on the topic of logistics, all these years later- how a real war placed stresses and demands on an entire nation, not just the troops at the front. About how much *support* they needed. It wasn't a hard and fast rule for every nation; the Snows prided itself on soldier self-sufficiency, while Salineas' scattered islands and far-flung provinces needed even *more* logistical assistance... but it was a good rule of thumb for most nations.

The Horde was not most nations. For all its many teeth, it needed only a short tail, and Adora had improved it further with her raiding policy; now Horde armies could be nearly self-sufficient, needing to touch base only for fuel. That short tail, and all those teeth, meant that if Netossa went in with only what she had, she'd get overwhelmed.

Even the biggest spider could be overwhelmed by enough ants.

Still... if she *had* to, if she failed to convince them to help her today, she might- *might*- be able to fight her way into the Fright Zone, lead her Rebels and whatever additional troops the Crownless could commit to the cause to a suicide strike. A furious, pell-mell rush into the Fright Zone, to slay the Dragon...

But suicide it would be. They'd tear themselves to rags just making it to Adora, they'd never have enough to get back out.

Which meant, for all practical purposes, that she *couldn't* get to Lord Adora. Few would go along with a mission where there was no way back home, and it wouldn't take much thought to realize the mission was suicide. Oh, there'd be a few who wouldn't mind; those that had lost enough that they would greet death as a doctor, as medicine for their ills... but most of her Rebels were not like that, and Netossa personally would rather see such suicidal folks get help, rather than be sacrificed. She was no monster.

Though even if she *were* that callous, it would do her no good. Suicidal troops were unreliable at best. Someone who did not care if they died usually did not care *when* they died, and had a tendency to find death sooner rather than later, their commander's plans be damned. They were useless for accomplishing any greater objective.

So... no. She needed to convince the Princess Alliance to commit to her plan.

Will accomplishing this goal help us with the real goal?

She didn't need to remind herself of what the real goal was; for years, she'd only had one.

Defeat the Horde.

And the answer was yes; significant assistance in the form of troops or even- *especially*- the Princesses themselves would change that math. After all, the Princesses alone had raided the Fright Zone twice, and only lost someone the first time- albeit Entrapta turning traitor had been much more devastating than a mere casualty would have been.

The trouble was that both raids were, basically, one-offs. The First Raid of the Fright Zone, as history books called it, relied both on the fact that no one had ever done it before- meaning the Fright Zone was just damn surprised- and Catra's personal knowledge of the Fright Zone, knowledge that any competent commander would have compensated for. The Second Raid, meanwhile... it was odd, in a lot of ways, especially the aftermath.

(Netossa recalled none of it, but Spinny did- said she remembered a dream of a happy home in the Woods, with their Rebels, Netossa and her both crowned as queens, and Netossa had to admit, it sounded lovely.)

But the part that mattered to Netossa right now was what she'd heard a few Brightmoon soldiers gossiping about at the party held to celebrate what Brightmoon had *thought* was the Horde's defeat. Honestly, Netossa wasn't sure how she remembered the convo; she'd been so pumped and so happy that she'd gotten not just drunk, but *fucking* drunk. Spinnerella had joined her, the two so plastered they'd woken up in a sort of pile in the corner of Brightmoon's stables, where two of Netossa's soberest Rebels had sort of flopped them when they finally passed out. A good day! They'd *won* , or so she'd thought, the Horde a leaderless machine destined to fall apart...

(S he sometimes felt that ruining the joy of that day was what she resented Lord Adora for the most, silly as it was.)

At any rate, the guards she'd talked to had said that, while they weren't totally sure, they thought it was a spell that let the Princesses get inside, past all the new defenses Hordak had made after the first assault. Honestly, that by itself would almost be all she needed; if Netossa, Spinnerella, and her crack troops could just teleport *into* the Fright Zone, they'd be fresh, not beat half to death from trying to break in, and with the element of surprise on their side. Done *that* way, even if the spell couldn't take them back out- and she'd never been able to confirm how the Princesses got back out- they'd still have a chance; show up, assassinate Lord Adora, then book it. If she only had to fight her way through Horde territory one way, and not both... that might actually be doable.

Still, Princess assistance *and* the spell would be best. Even failing that, if the Kingdom armies could just launch attacks on the Horde, distract them and tie up troops, that... well, it'd be less certain, but it'd give the mission a chance of real success, might be enough to keep it from being suicide.

What is between me and my goals?

One woman, which normally wouldn't be a problem... save that the woman was Catra. The fucking *She-Ra*. The most famous person in the Princess Alliance, the most beloved, hero of thousands; there were even t-shirts, especially in Salineas, which loved her almost as much as Brightmoon did. Why, Salineas even had some idiot producing a book series, which... certainly was a book series. Her Spinny adored them as entertainment; Netossa had flicked through one or two, mostly bewildered. Glimmer was a total idiot, Angella and Castaspella were supposedly dating, and

Bow and Adora flirted with each other, which just... wasn't the author at least *vaguely* aware of the rumors that Catra and Adora had been lovers? Which Netossa believed, personally, especially given the way Catra acted about her.

(Netossa also had confirmation from Huntara- they'd met briefly at the party, Huntara had volunteered to be a bouncer- that Lord Adora was into girls... well, her exact words had been "that bitch was eye-fucking me from the moment we met", but same difference.)

The cover arts for the series had been nice, despite making Spinnerella too skinny, Glimmer too tall, and giving Perfuma an enormous flower petal hat. Netossa had fewer complaints about her own appearance on the cover of *When Whispering Woods Last Bloomed,* she actually looked alright, though the woman they'd picked, a statuesque beauty, hadn't resembled her much at all. The bizarre net-cape thing they'd had her wear was kinda neat, if in a stupid way; apparently the author thought her power was a more understandable control over nets, not the bizarre, ill-defined power over light channeled into the web pattern that she actually had.

Wild Magic just kind of did stuff, it wasn't nearly as sensible as most people thought. Her wife's power wasn't even over wind, it was over *spinning*, it was just that the air resisted her powersets less than most stuff did; they'd used her power to break machines by rotating their internal parts before, though it was a lot harder than moving air. Why, Netossa personally suspected that Entrapta's *actual* ability as a Wild Princess was that she could pick up on lingering signals from First Ones, which would explain her technical skills; she was downloading the past.

Even if Netossa was wrong- and she might well be- it would be something like that; it wouldn't be as simple as "is good with tech." Wild Magic Princesses never were.

But back on topic...

What is between me and my goals?

The biggest one-woman roadblock imaginable. Literally, she was super tall as She-Ra. Catra and her love for Adora would doom this; Frosta and Perfuma had both agreed at the last meeting to the raid, and even Angella had to concede that the raid was in the best interests of the Alliance, but Perfuma wouldn't be at this meeting; Netossa would be down an ally.

She'd be up one too, at least; Salineas had disagreed most heartily with Mermista going along with Angella and Catra when they'd asked for leniency for Dryl. Mermista was a powerful figure in Salinean politics, but she wasn't the leader, their prime minister was; and Salineas had stood to gain from an economic blockade of Dryl, since they were the other major tech center of the Alliance. She'd heard from the others that Salineas had sent a diplomat to represent them, a man named Falcon, pulling him from an assignment in the Crimson Waste. Mermista was too popular- and the issue too minor- to make a *huge* fuss about it, but the Salinean government was exercising its right to stick its nose in its Princess' affairs over the matter.

So... down one, gain one. Parity. And she doubted Catra's resistance to the idea, which had been strong enough to send her

fleeing the room, had changed...

...What a disaster that last meeting had been. Catra's departure ended the meeting early, and all attempts to retrieve her had been delayed by the fact that the Woods exploded into a spore storm at the worst imaginable time. Then Glimmer and Mermista caught the spy in the Alliance's ranks, and that was distracting everyone, and...

Well.

There was one more thing, something Netossa didn't like admitting- an obstacle in Netossa's own heart. She *should* have pressed the issue, but it would have felt... cruel, in the face of Catra's horror. The terror in the younger woman had struck a chord, a note of sympathy in Netossa, one too deep for even her determination to penetrate.

After all, she was just like Catra in one very specific way: her weakness was a person, too.

(She curled up tighter in her wife's softness, buried herself in the meat and good weight of her, the soft press of her heavy breasts and the smell of her hair, feeling the muscle underneath that let her move her bulk with delicate grace; Netossa's weakness, the weakness that was the source of her strength, this magnificent woman who had brought so much joy into her life.)

...She didn't want to hurt Catra. The girl was a *hero* . She reminded Netossa of herself, in so many ways; she'd been a

teenager when she'd joined the Rebellion, too, though she'd been dumber than Catra had ever been. She'd been all fire and all spirit and absolutely no goddamn sense, the daughter of lawyers, comfortably upper-middle-class, playing at soldier. She'd approached battle with a carefree spirit, sure that her powers alone guaranteed victory.

Micah and Angella had seen her clear foolishness, and taken her under their wings, metaphorically- or in Angella's case, kind of literally- and taught her the ropes, shown her how it was, to go to war. They'd tried to prepare her as best they could, though nothing could truly prepare those who had never seen the dragon, as the old saying went.

(Netossa suffered few nightmares, but sometimes- when it was at its worst- she remembered her first battle,remembered the sounds of the dying, how her adrenaline had spiked so hard she thought her heart would burst in her chest, and on those nights, she woke with tears on her face.)

But the Brightmoon royals had coached her through the early part of it, the battles and the nightmares both, had even helped her see a mind soother to deal with the recurring terror the soother had called aftershock; she still wasn't sure why they'd been so kind to her. Wild Princess, yes, but from a nation far to the west, and one Brightmoon had no real ties to. Oh, they weren't enemies by any stretch- and Brightmoon had never been as dickish to the Crownless as the other Runestone Kingdoms- but they weren't close allies, either.

Maybe it was just because they'd been parents at the time, Glimmer a rapidly-growing little girl, and maybe they'd decided to make a test run of their skills at managing a teenage girl... or

maybe they were just terribly good. It was why she'd come, when Angella had called, and said she was trying to revive the Alliance; Netossa paid her debts.

(Her first toast the night of the party had been to lost Micah, whom she would forever owe a debt she could not pay; a drink from the red cup of victory, for the King who had been so kind to her.)

...Which was another thing she shared with Catra, though Catra's version was much more intense. They'd both been blessed with Brightmoon's generosity.

And Netossa understood Catra, in ways that she thought few would. If, through some impossible series of events, she were somehow to come to blows with her wife- a thought that just made her reflexively sick even to *think* about- she would be just as irrational, just as determined to save her, as Catra was regarding Adora.

So yeah, she got it, and that understanding was an obstacle to her victory, because it was hwy she hadn't pressed like she should have. She should have went after it as hard as she could after Catra fled the meeting, but she just... well, she couldn't. She hated the idea of putting the younger woman through that kind of hell, necessary as it was.

Netossa paid her debts, after all- and she owed Catra, she owed her immensely. Catra showing up- Catra being *the She-Ra,* which Netossa took as just a myth- had turned the War around, made it go from something Netossa fought for without hope of victory to being something that, maybe, with effort, could be *won* .

...She wished there was another way. But what other choice existed? " I did what I had to do" was the excuse of every tyrant and monster in history, thrown about too casually and used too often... but they lasted anyway. The words lasted because, every now and then- just every now and then- they held terrible truth in them. The Horde had to be stopped, or it would stand atop the trampled freedoms of every other nation. Catra's love for Adora was not enough to allow the fires of war, literal and figurative, to keep burning.

She moved on, uncomfortable with where the train of her thoughts was leading, thoughts too morbid for this morning.

So, final question: What can I do about those obstacles?

She had one plan, really. Just one: pressure. As much pressure as she could manage. More people, here, present, to plead their case. It was one thing for the Runestone Kingdoms and their Princesses to dismiss Crownless who were not before them; it was another to have them right in their faces, speaking with them.

To that end, ever since the disastrous meeting that had led to Catra's flight, Netossa and Spinnerella had been having a whirlwind tour- literally, with Spinny's powers- of Etheria, grabbing every single Crownless and Rebel of note she could convince or bribe or threaten or cajole into giving her a hand. She'd spent all the favors she'd ever been owed, half the favors Spinny was owed, and all the goodwill she'd earned with every drop of blood she'd spilled in the name of the Rebellion...

But it had been enough. High as the price was, she had gotten her money's worth. She had the breadth of Etheria gathered here, from Galacia in the farthest north to a surprise guest from what had once been Etheria's southernmost nation, all located here, in Netossa's tents outside of Brightmoon proper. They'd been offered guest rooms, but Netossa had wanted to keep her last guest a secret; and staying out here, it reinforced the idea among her group that they were a single unit, despite their vast disparities. That... probably wouldn't matter, a few nights together in circled tents didn't a fellowship make, but maybe it would, and Netossa had never feared the roll of the dice.

In these tents were the leading lights of many nations. Oldking Narwahl himself slept in the tent to the left of her and Spinny's, the elderly, blind lord accompanied only by a snow howler, which he'd called a guidebeast, and which Netossa just called cool, she liked the big wolverine-ish creature. She could hear him snoring in tune with his big beastie, almost a duet of soft, somewhat blubbery exhalations.

He was, in many ways, the most surprising of her allies, second only to her very last guest; she'd sent an invite to Galacia because, as the most prestigious and prominent of the Crownless nations, she knew that their voice would be a heavy one on her side, but she'd never expected Narwahl himself to come. He had laughed at the surprise in her voice when he showed up, the gregarious old Selkie amused; he'd told her that this was a good opportunity for him to move into a new field, now that he was retired.

Netossa hadn't even known that; apparently he'd resigned from being king a few months ago, his people electing a new king in their normal way, a fiery woman named Wesk. King Narwahl- or Oldking now, as the Galacians called it- had decided to work as a diplomat for the new King's administration, and apparently King Wesk had thought Netossa's cause a good one to champion.

Netossa wasn't going to argue with their assistance, not when it had proven so vital already; sometimes she thought the only reason anyone else had agreed to join her in this was that Oldking Narwahl was with her from the start. The Crownless liked him even better than they liked the She-Ra herself- wasn't just anybody who could say they'd crushed a Runestone Kingdom in direct combat, after rall- and the fact that he had decided to work with her was a factor in the others deciding to do so. He was even amiable in person, an old man who'd accomplished all of his life goals and now viewed anything extra he managed as just gravy on top; it was hard not to like the big, easy-going walrus.

In the tent to her and her wife's right was the diplomat from Blackmoor, the most southerly of the small nations that lined Etheria's western coast like a patchwork quilt, pressed up against the Sea of Demons; they'd had to cross miles and miles to get here, but here they were, the Red Knight themselves, the champion of the chivalrous kingdom. They keenly felt the need to push back against the Horde; Blackmoor's swamps and mires were hard for an army to invade, but not impossible. Worse, Lord Adora had not taken Hordak's gentle hand with the Crownless; she'd attacked everyone, everywhere, with everything, fire not just a favored weapon but almost a lifestyle for the supposed First One.

(Netossa actually had to credit Adora for coming up with that imposing lie; it was a bold and audacious thing to lie about, and

she kind of admired the sheer guts it took to fib that hard, even as she generally hated falsehood.)

Blackmoor had always fought on the Rebellion's side; had, in fact, been the ones who'd suggested the formation of the first Princess Alliance all those years ago. Netossa knew this little piece of trivia because she'd never met a Blackmoor citizen who, given the opportunity, would not immediately begin bitching about the fact that most people *didn't* know it. Their king at the time had been the one to suggest the first Alliance, since he'd just watched Hordak crush the Runestone Duchies under his heel, and realized that he was now sitting on the border of an expansionist empire.

These days, while still devout in their service to the Rebellion, they were annoyed that most people thought the Runestone Kingdoms had come up with it; it had been a Crownless idea, to unite everyone, Crownless and Runestone both, against the Horde. It hadn't even been called the Princess Alliance, the first name had just been the Great Rebellion, referencing the then-realistic wish of freeing the nations the Horde had already conquered.

Blackmoor itself had only rarely come under attack, and most of that early in the War... but they'd never given up the fight, donating troops to the Rebel armies that roamed the hills and mountains of the borders, stretching into the Plumerian and Brightmoon fronts father west. The Red Knight had come personally, the general of Blackmoor's armies, to assist her in making the plea for a third raid on the Fright Zone; though Netossa didn't know if anyone over here even knew about Blackmoor, or how much it had bled for the cause.

Still, the Red Knight had claimed they had something that would give Netossa an advantage with Angella if it was needed, which... well, Netossa wasn't sure about the Red Knight, they were an odd one. Blackmoor claimed the Red Knight was an immortal who never took off the armor, but Netossa knew, for a *fact*, that the person in the Red Knight armor wasn't the same as the one she'd first met; the voice and the way they walked was different, and the new person was broader and taller, though the completely-covering armor had apparently been modified to adapt.

Which had made it much more confusing when the new Knight had not only recalled an argument Netossa'd had with the last one, but spoke of other events during their time together, all accurately- even the stuff you wouldn't expect someone to tell an inheritor.

A shapeshifter, maybe? Or... something else? It was odd, all of it was odd, and Netossa had not bothered prying. She owed Blackmoor and the Knight too much to be all that worried about their personal business. As long as they were swinging their blade at the Horde, Netossa wasn't going to be too arsed about it. She hated lies, but she didn't mind secrets; to hide something was different than to lie about it, though it was admittedly easy to cross that line.

They were there, though thankfully without their mount; Netossa had no idea how anyone in Blackmoor had taken a look at the grunting giant boars named- uncreatively, she might add- snorters, and said *I'm going to ride that,* but she *did* know that whoever had done it was an asshole. Sure, it was better than a horse in the wetlands and mountains that were Blackmoor territory, but they were more aggressive than Netossa herself was, and slapping platemail barding on the beasts only

encouraged their nasty dispositions. The Red Knight swore their own mount was quite personable, but Netossa wasn't getting near the damn thing.

Normally Sweet Bee and her Andreenids would fill the fourth tent, directly across from Netossa and Spinnerella, but she wasn't available, sadly. Sweet Bee had long been one of Netossa's best allies, which might surprise those who knew her; but while Sweet Bee didn't much like the Runestone Kingdoms, she was fine with Wild Princesses. Something about how Wild Princesses were not an institution, could not make their quirks of personality generational.

Sweet Bee always talked like that, the bubbly lass a friendly political and history afficionado- and a damn good Rebel. Phlax hadn't produced many Rebels, but Sweet Bee seemed determined to pick up the slack singlehandedly. Unfortunately, through sheer bad timing, she'd been making a trip to Mystacor with her squad, selling the ambrosia her people produced, and getting supplies for the Phlax Federation in turn. It was one of the Hive's duties as part of Phlax, and Sweet Bee, despite fighting under her own banner, was a patriot of her home; she was like Netossa and Spinnerella in that sense, a Rebel only on the thinnest of technicalities.

A mixed blessing, honestly. Sweet Bee was *infamous* for being the biggest Crownless hardliner the usually lackadaisical Phlax Federation had ever produced, and while Netossa trusted her, her presence here would have had all the subtlety of a hand grenade. Sweet Bee would not have been able to be in Brightmoon for more than about an hour before going off on somebody- if that. It was probably for the best she wasn't here...

Still, Phlax had sent someone anyway when she asked. Phlax's southernmost city of Blue Mountain was on the border with the Horde, and just like Blackmoor had suffered much more ferocious attack since Hordak's death, so too had Phlax finally come under very literal fire. But for heroic efforts on the part of a Blackmoor army under the Red Knight, who had decided to intervene, Blue Mountain would have burned.

The attack had been a wake-up call. Phlax had always, technically, been at war with the Horde, and had even had a skirmish or two, but the lack of real assault had made it a thing alive only on paper; now it had awoken, the young nation facing its first real test. So far, morale was good, enthusiastic even, at least according to her contacts in Phlax, though given its scattered nature and sheer length- the longest nation on Etheria, by most estimates, albeit also the narrowest- it would take time to gather its strength at Blue Mountain. So far, the line was held mostly by Rebels, Blackmoor having to retreat in order to protect its own; Netossa hoped that Phlax's scattered militias would get down there before anything happened. Blue Mountain wasn't nearly as well defended by geography as Blackmoor was.

The diplomat they'd sent was a Doctor Blankfort, a surgeon of some renown in Phlax's titular capital. Since she didn't know him, Netossa had placed him in the second circle of tents, where most of the guards were; the interior circle was for either the most trusted or most valuable allies. She doubted the older fellow would do anything, but lack of caution had killed too many for her to indulge in it.

She wondered how Sweet Bee was doing, though... she liked the girl. Well, young woman. Her whole thing was about spreading her home city's philosophies to the larger world, and Netossa wondered how the Hive felt about that. Rebels were in a weird place, nation-wise. They were stateless warriors, people with no country, those who had abandoned their nations to fight the Horde in the lawless areas along the front; whether in the Dark Mountains of the farthest west to the Whispering Woods of the east, there was a whole band of territory in the south that belonged to no nation.

Oh, on maps and paper, there would be names, and borders, drawn in safety by cartographers who would never be near the front; but the truth on the ground was different. There was a significant stretch of land that no one, Horde or otherwise, owned, save the Rebels who camped there, their own territories shrinking and growing as the war's tides ebbed and flowed.

It was territory many Rebels never wanted to give back. So many Rebels had joined when the first Alliance fell, men and women and folks who resented the cowardice of the Princesses and had sworn to fight the Horde's tyranny until they fell; Brightmoon, in particular, had seen staggering desertion rates, entire brigades simply refusing to go home, furious with Queen Angella for letting her personal tragedy dictate the goals of an entire nation, but people of all nations had thrown down their old flags and now raised only the flag of the Great Rebellion, the rainbow colors that had been meant to represent all nations of Etheria and now stood for those who had no nation.

Netossa had... gotten very comfortable with them, over the years. Used to running things her own way, though she, perhaps, had little room to talk; in a lot of ways, her and Spinnerella weren't

real Rebels. Their homeland supported them; a few legal fictions let the Twin Kingdoms of Highpoint and Condore send them aid without officially condoning what they did. On paper, they were simply private citizens who, due to their status as Wild Princesses, were entitled to receive a very large government stipend, ostensibly a retainer, paid so the government could occasionally request that they make use of their powers on its behalf.

That they usually chose to receive the payment in military equipment? Well, that wasn't the business of her leaders, so long as they didn't start a civil war. The Twin Kingdoms was a nation that had few laws on what a private citizen kept as personal weaponry. It was *use* that Twin Kingdoms law concerned itself with, and Netossa and Spinnerella had rigidly adhered to those rules- which mostly amounted to not using them on their fellow Twin Kingdoms citizens. As the Horde didn't count, the Twin Kingdoms didn't care.

Honestly, it was pure legalistic bullshit, and to be frank Netossa hated it, the way she did all deceptions... but Spinny had been right when she'd suggested it years ago, it was needed. Too many of the rich and powerful in the Twin Kingdoms had supported an isolationist policy, one that was short-sighted and would have left them defenseless; but they relied on many of the same laws supplying Netossa and Spinnerella for their own wealth, and couldn't really oppose the stipend. All they could really do was grumble unless her and her wife screwed up bad, and that hadn't happened in years.

Her nation's two lords had loved the idea, each in their own way. Baron Condore of Spinnerella's hometown had found the whole thing as absurd as Netossa had, even joining her in rolling their eyes when the “private citizen” aspect was emphasized, but he'd

been pushing for more to be done about the Horde anyway, so he'd went along. Prince Norb of Highpoint, Netossa's own monarch, had laughed with delight at the clever trick, and saluted Spinny at a private dinner afterwards. Netossa had been pleased to see her Spinny praised, though Spinny herself had demurred; it was really the work of Netossa's parents, the two lawyers *delighted* to assist both their eldest daughter and her wife, who was the only one of their kid's spouses they actually liked.

...Netossa wondered briefly how many were like her, among the Rebels. She knew the Snows, while officially not joining the Rebels, had been pretty open in its admiration of those of its people who went, the resilience-obsessed folk proud of their strength; it was why so many Snows Rebels had just went back to the Snows' military when the clarion was sounded, as opposed to the Brightmoon traitors, who despite Angella's blanket pardons once Brightmoon rejoined the Alliance had mostly refused to go home. She wondered how many got support like she did, a thought she'd had many times over the years...

She wondered if the Hive did that for Sweet Bee, or if they didn't approve of what she did, or how they felt about all of it... She'd have to ask her once she was back. Sweet Bee talked of her people's philosophy a lot, but Netossa didn't think she'd ever mentioned what they thought of *her*.

Her mind skipped past her special guest- it was too big a thought, right now- and went to the others in the outer ring of tents. A classic setup for a Rebel camp; leadership and most vulnerable in the center, and an outer ring for the guards and middle management. Another way to reinforce to her group that they were here together as a single front, according to their own rules, not the gaggle of separate interests they actually were.

In the outer ring were everyone's guards, and those dignitaries whom Netossa didn't entirely trust. Peekablue, representing Seaworthy, and Admiral Scurvy and his wife Squall, representing Octopus Cove, the two city-states on the Sea of Sighs that had suddenly found themselves facing the Horde when the Rebel border in Brightmoon's furthest south was pushed back enough to expose them. None of the three were happy to be here, but they'd had little choice in the matter; the city-states had been very clear to them that they were to help Netossa. From an even further nation was a Troll of Spikeheart, Grox, though he'd straight up admitted he was only present personally, and had no ability to speak for his home.

Netossa didn't mind that at all; his mere presence was proof of the simple truth that everyone on Etheria had an interest in this, that there was no people untouched by the War.

Besides them, there was a scattering of older Rebels, all of whom had been from the Runestone Duchies of the south, the places Hordak had conquered first. It was astounding how quickly everyone had forgotten the the nations of Vargon and Green Thatch, Galebreath and Silverglade; in some ways, they'd even forgotten the original nation of the Fright Zone, the Scorpioni homeland now too strongly associated with Hordak for most to recall that, once, it had been a Runestone Kingdom, which had adopted its name from what it's foes had called it after numerous defeats.

But *these* Rebels had not forgotten their homes, or the now far-away dream of seeing them freed. Their tents were painted with old flags, each marking the Duchy they had once called home,

before Hordak had crushed them under his feet. From Green Thatch, a tired man named Mach, who had once been a woodcutter, and now put his axe to bloodier work in memory of two fallen sons; from Silverglade an elderly, self-taught hedge mage named Catillus, who had been old when this started, and was now positively ancient, keeping himself alive through sheer force of will. From Vargon, a young minotaur woman named Krystala, who had been a child at the time her nation was overthrown, and had... never entirely recovered, who unnerved Netossa, violence brewing just under her skin even when she was at something like rest. From Galebreath were Vesser, Barris, and Therin, three rabble-rousing husbands who had once been farmers, who'd turned out to be magnificently silver-tongued Rebels once their nation was crushed.

(Technically Peekablue was also from Green Thatch, back in the day... but he had disavowed all ties to the nation of his forefathers, being a lover, not a fighter. He was only hear because Seaworthy's city council had thought his status as a minor Prince might lend weight to their plea, and because they'd threatened to blow up his club if he didn't go.)

She hadn't initially been able to get anyone from the last Runestone Duchy, the one that- depending on how you looked at it- had never actually fallen, Halfmoon... and nobody from the old Fright Zone either. It wasn't surprising; Halfmoon had been Etheria's southernmost nation, thus literally buried behind all of the Horde's stolen land, and the Scorpioni of the Fright Zone who had managed to escape had mostly went to their old allies in Halfmoon. It was one reason Halfmoon's people were so damn rare up north- which was actually kind of funny to think about, considering how *incredibly* prominent one in particular was.

But no, they were rare on the ground in what were, for them, northern lands. Scurvy's wife Squall was one of the literal handful

that Netossa had met in all her years in the Rebellion, and her family had fled Halfmoon due to their criminal leanings years before the Horde; Squall and her cousins were all Octopus Cove natives now, a pirate's life for them.

It wasn't until they'd raided a Horde POW work camp under Grizzlor- something they'd literally done because it was *on the way*- that she'd acquired her last guest.

(Netossa actually kind of liked that; being a Rebel made you a child of chaos, and she liked the inherent decency in chance it implied, that a random act of heroism had given her such a fine reward.)

She'd been relatively okay, since Horde POW protocol included feeding their workers, and even medical care; oh, you'd work, or you'd be beat, but the Horde was interested more in getting productivity out of the work camps than in simply indulging cruelty. Only Shadow Weaver had been allowed her sadistic joys, since as the Horde's lone sorceress, she'd been too valuable to oppose; but Lord Adora, at least according to the prisoners they rescued, had went above and beyond even Hordak's strict rules. They'd gotten more food, and more rest, under her reign, something that Grizzlor had bitched about endlessly, even in earshot of the prisoners.

Apparently it was part of some ploy to eventually get the prisoners to join the Horde of their own free will, which Grizzlor had found particularly stupid; Netossa agreed, that was wishful thinking at best. No one wanted to serve freely any who had made them serve in chains. Not if they had a choice.

Still, being effectively enslaved could never be made *gentle,* no matter what. The freed people were mostly fellow Rebels, but one prisoner in particular was interesting, a woman caught in the deep south of Horde territory...

She roused herself. She wasn't going back to sleep at this rate; she could do her morning stretches, at least, then see if anyone else was up. She could hear that Narwahl wasn't, but that didn't mean others hadn't awoken like she had.

She rose up, extricating herself gently from her wife, and took a quick look around the tent as she did so. Nothing was different than usual; she hadn't expected it to be, but paying attention was never a mistake. The tent held only practical items; this was a tent for survival and war, after all. The one thing Netossa kept for herself as a person, and not a general, was the first Rebel flag she'd ever flown, the old rainbow-colored standard nearly a rag now, tucked away in a bag. Her own little piece of history.

(Spinnerella, meanwhile, kept a small piece of First Ones tech that played music when pressed; she found the tune relaxing.)

She stretched, as the dark began to give way to the light. Arms and legs and back, especially the back; as she got older, this became more necessary, to remind limbs that they could still work, to clearing out any soreness left by the night before.

When done, she stepped outside, to find the world asleep... but she thought she heard movement near her special guest's tent, and so went over there, to check and see what was going on. If she was awake, they could talk; if she wasn't, then someone was in that tent that wasn't supposed to be there.

But lifting the tent flap only revealed the tent's inhabitant, awake.

" Ah, Miss Netossa!" said Queen Orwall, leader of the Magicat nation of Halfmoon. " I wasn't expecting you!"

Chapter End Notes

Wow, this chapter ballooned on me!

It will never come up again, but Netossa is actually incorrect about what Entrapta's Wild Princess ability actually is; it's weirder than that. Entrapta's actual natural magic is simply that she is capable of learning very quickly; they say it takes seven years to become an expert, but for Entrapta, it only takes seven months. Were she to take an interest in magic, she'd graduate from Mystacor very quickly.

It's a very basic, but useful, power. It's all mental, unfortunately; it doesn't apply to physical actions, for the most part, though she could certainly use it to learn an entire martial art or workout routine... though she'd have to use good old willpower to actually apply any of that, since her powerset gives her no willpower boost.

Narwahl and Wesk are both from the original She-Ra, as is Galacia and the Selkies in general. It's a fun episode! Narwahl was their King in that episode, Wesk was a hot-headed male underling. Wesk is female in my story, and King is her proper title; Galacian language makes very little distinction between the genders, and jobs generally have only one title. All household servants, for example, would be considered maids, and it's honestly thought to be extremely confusing to have different words for the same job based on gender. Seems like a lot of work to remember, in the ever-practical Galacian opinion.

Wesk is a bit older in this story, and her experiences in the war with the Snows have tempered her passion; she's still a very active and fiery sort, but there's real wisdom there now, too, and she draws heavily on Oldking Narwahl's experience. It's actually one reason he went south; him and Wesk have both realized that she needs to step out of Narwahl's gigantic shadow, and having him away from home for a while will help with that tremendously. Her main focus is continuing Narwahl's policies regarding food distribution and shoring up Galacia's defenses so that, should the Snows seek to go for round two, they'll have a rough go of it; that's the other main reason she sent Narwahl, she wanted to establish more formal relations with the other Crownless so that she could potentially have allies should war come.

Snow Howlers are from the same episode. Snow Howlers are surprisingly tame, given their ancestry includes wolverines; as they got bigger, they needed the wolverine berserker rage less, and eventually adopted pack tactics in a sort of convergent evolution with wolves. The main remnant of their ancestral fury is that, when badly injured, they'll sometimes enter a kind of death-rage that drives them to attack without regard for their own safety; it's intended as a way to make sure that whatever killed them doesn't kill the rest of their pack. It's very much a last resort, though; the death-rage both never ends and absolutely guarantees that the animal will die, since a death-raging Snow Howler will never eat again.

Snow Howlers make good guide “dogs” and training them to assist the blind is a big business in Galacia; Selkies have poor eyesight in general anyway, relying mostly on their whiskers, which have an enormous number of sensory organs attached to them, to the point that going blind is much less of a problem for a Selkie than it would be for a human. Snow Howler guidebeasts are mostly there to make sure they don't bump into people while distracted.

Etheria has a few treatments for cataracts, but optical surgery was one of the many technological arts lost when the Glory Lily Princesses melted most of Dryl, and the presence of healing magic means that non-magic healing has been put on the backburner for centuries- and biology is one of the only fields that Entrapta has no real talent in. There's some interesting work coming out of Salineas and the Twin Kingdoms, though.

Blackmoor is a location in the original She-Ra that held a Rebel's Fair every year. They do so in this timeline, too; they like to celebrate the Great Rebellion there, since Blackmoor is the oldest and first signatory of the original Princess Alliance... though again, they always refer to it as the Great Rebellion, and will chew you out for saying otherwise. They're good people, and the closest thing to what one might consider a “standard” fantasy kingdom in the entire setting; they even have an extremely minor school of magic, run by an old hedgewitch.

The Red Knight is also from the old She-Ra; they were originally someone who refused to take their armor off until the Horde was defeated. Here, they are... a bit more unusual than that, but they may get a chance to talk about it.

Halfmoon is also from the original; we'll talk more about it later.

Chapter 35: Nightmares of Brightmoon Castle

Chapter Notes

So!

The Last War Council chapter ended up *ballooning* into something enormous. I'm tying a lot of plot threads together and setting the stage for the finale, so it's just.

Huge.

So it's being uploaded in parts.

First it's the dynamic mother-daughter duo, and one rough night... and plans for the upcoming meeting.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Last War Council of Etheria

Part One:

Nightmares of Brightmoon Castle

(Were It Not That I Have Bad Dreams)

A few hours before Netossa awoke- when the world was dark, still- the Princess of Power, who was the beloved royalty of a great kingdom, lay in a simple kitchen chair.

She was... not awake, though it would be hard to call it sleep, and impossible to describe it as rest. No, the passed-out princess in her mother's dining room twitched in her curled-up ball of a body, and made soft noises of quiet distress; her mind was not so tired that it could not torment itself, not so exhausted that it could not commit to civil war. On one side was her fraying sanity; on the other were visions, all of things she loved.

Those were not usually the ingredients in a recipe for mental torment... but for Catra, they were, for every single thing that Catra had ever loved had betrayed her.

A sword, which set her free, and made a beloved hero out of an unwanted outcast; a sword made of light and hope.

(Light and hope stand before her now, in the form of a holographic woman, as she holds the Sword up before the infinite dark, turning it into infinite light- because it was burning, she had set fire to the skies, she heard the horrified laments of elder gods and the terrified screams of dying mortals and she is screaming, too, the blood of galaxies drips down the Sword and she screams and screams and screams)

A woman, who had been her only savior, who had protected her, in those awful years of her childhood; the woman she loved, with her whole heart.

(More fire, *more,* but this time in an eye blurred by burns and in a mind riddled with pain, pain that poured out in hopeless laughter when Catra told her the truth of *You're a First One,* and in a burned hand that doomed all Etheria with the flick of a single switch; kisses that tasted like blood in a world that never was and Adora's head falling from her shoulders, blonde hair and red blood both flying in the air as her body and head fell separately and

apart, and how can Catra be so horrified by that image, when she knows that the woman she loves is the enemy of her people, how can she be such a *traitor*)

A kingdom of softness and songs, that she loved with all her heart, for it had taken her in, and given the love-starved orphan of its greatest enemy all the glory and love it could give, years of warmth to make up for a cold childhood; a nation that looked at Catra and saw in her not an unwanted outcast, not someone worthless or weak, but their beloved princess, someone magnificent and powerful.

(Her mother, agreeing that Adora must die for Brightmoon to live; and she hates her for it, a thing she can admit in the privacy of her own nightmares, she hates her for it, even as she knows she must be right, even as she loves her, too, and hates herself for hating her mother)

And, finally... finally, there was, as she knew there must be, herself, standing before a choice.

(Fire, more fire, it is always fucking fire, she is *haunted* by flames, this time it is Brightmoon itself that burns, and Adora doing the burning; the woman she loves is burning the kingdom she loves and she cannot have both, she must choose, when all she wants is *not* to choose, she must choose one and she must have both and the world will not let her have them)

The visions faded, and were replaced by a voice.

You always were a weak child.

She whimpered quietly, distress on her lips, as the oldest nightmare inside her skin spoke to her in a familiar voice.

Useless child. Pointless. Pathetic. You have always been the lesser child.

She cannot speak up in her own defense. She cannot resist. She cannot ignore.

Soft child. A failure. You couldn't protect yourself, you had to have Adora do that; what makes you think you can protect Brightmoon? Your friends? And now the universe entire needs you, and you will ***fail*** *. You have always been worthless.*

She could only suffer, as vision and feeling were added to the voice.

(cold white eyes and cold cruel hands and the pressure woven shadow could exert, all over her skin, she is small and a child again and the monster that raised her does not love her, *why doesn't she love me, why doesn't she love me, why doesn't she love me* , there must be something broken inside her to think these thoughts; why can she not turn away from them, why does she love Shadow Weaver even now, why does she *want* Shadow Weaver to love her, what is *wrong* with her?)

She mewled quietly in her not-sleep, the way she had as a child, making a sound she would never herself hear with her waking

mind. It was a noise that, once upon a time, had prompted a blonde-haired girl with a big heart, one who in those days still believed she was human, still believed she was good, to wake her up, to save her, one of the many kind deeds with which she had won a young Catra's heart.

Now, the First One that blonde-haired girl had grown up to be was too far away from Catra to save her, too many long miles and too many fires and too much self-acknowledged evil, her big heart as burned as her hand and her eye...

But nonetheless, when Catra made that hopeless, helpless noise, there was someone there to rescue her.

" Catra?"

A gentle hand on her shoulder, and a sensation of ethereal downiness on her back, one that Catra's sleeping mind associated with a strange image of transparent feathers. The hand shook her and the wing hugged her as the voice spoke again.

" Catra? Wake up, dear."

Catra's mind choked its way to a start like a dying engine, almost failing to do so; there were some internal systems damaged, catching as they tried to activate, leading her to stumble towards wakefulness. There was a bolt missing somewhere, or a well of strength that had run dry, something so fundamentally *wrong* that

the pistons of her brain were not firing in time with a military march, but with the staccato arrhythmia of a failing heart; she stuttered, stopped, restarted. One yellow eye blinked open before immediately closing.

The blue followed second later, but did a bit better; that one stuck, stayed, even bleary and blind to the world as it was at first. The yellow followed a good second later, the twin orbs seeing nothing at first, taking time to sharpen, the world resolving itself into something she could understand. Her mother's little dining area, in the dead of night...

(And in the corner the Sword the Sword *the Sword* put as far away from her as possible even stumbling weary hurt so *fucking* tired she'd had the sense to keep it away from her, to put it as far from her as possible while still keeping an eye on it, she could be *dead* and she would still be terrified down to her bones of its implications, of what it *meant* to be the chosen bearer of the end of everything)

Her mother, next to her, face full of worry and concern for her, a hand on her shoulder and a wing wrapped around her in a sideways hug.

" Catra?" Angella asked once again, drawing the Magicat's eyes away from the Sword she loved and feared both.

(*like Shadow Weaver like Shadow Weaver just like Shadow Weaver*)

Information came in from her awakening senses as her brain struggled to process the complicated process that would end in

words, a language, a *response* of some kind. Close, the sound of Angella's voice, the sound of her mother's beating heart, a little faster than normal from her concern. A little farther away, the ticking of the overly ornate grandfather clock in Angella's bedroom, the sound of the night wind gently caressing the castle, the ever-present low sound of the Moonstone's energy as it ran through the castle, barely audible even to Catra's ears, a quiet and pleasant sound like a beloved song hummed under the breath. Distantly, the sound of movement in the castle, and the even farther-away sound of conversation; the castle had good soundproofing, but Catra was a Magicat, nothing could totally drown out the sound for her. They sounded... agitated. Vaguely, some part of her brain coughed up the memory of the attack last... night? A few hours, or a lifetime ago? Her sense of time was as vague as the rest of her right now.

Her nose, meanwhile, drew in the smells of her mother's life. The candles her mother favored for her private rooms, scented with the almost citrusy smell of night-blossoming moonflowers mingled with vanilla, queen of flavors and Angella's favorite, the sharp and the soft bringing each other into balance. The various perfumes, deodorants, lotions and other sundries decorating Angella's dresser, a variety for every purpose under the moons; a vaguely clean scent Catra had learned, over years in Brightmoon, to be the semi-sterile smell of silver itself, that precious metal so holy and beloved in Brightmoon that they used it for prayer and coinage both, would use it for everything if they could get away with it.

After all this, she knew just enough to speak; but her mouth was, for once in her life, slow to respond. Her lips separated, but nothing came out until her tongue sluggishly poked out to lick them, and then, finally, she managed to respond to the question Angella had not needed to ask.

“ I'm fine,” she lied.

“ No, you're not,” Angella said, in firm tones that brooked no argument. “ You passed out in a chair, that's not normal tiredness...”

“ I'm fine,” Catra repeated automatically, a reflex of her tongue her brain was barely involved in. “ Chair... chair's fine.”

That part wasn't totally a lie; the chair had the standard Brightmoon softness, after all, and compared to some of of the things Catra had slept on in the Fright Zone, it didn't even rank in the top fifty worst places she'd ever slept.

...But... she really *should* move. Go somewhere she wouldn't... wouldn't bother the Queen. She was being a bother, and she had never wanted Angella to view her as a burden she had to carry. That wasn't what Catra wanted; Angella had given her so much, she couldn't impugn on the woman any more than she already had.

“ You should go back to sleep,” Catra mumbled, tongue still half-unconscious, as she sent orders to her limbs to get up, to leave, to be gone and stop bothering the woman who had taken her in. “ 'M sorry I disturbed you...”

She tried to rise up, on muscles that ached, in a body that shook, ashamed of how Angella's grip on her shoulder tightened as she assisted, how the wing Angella had taken her under lifted as she tried to stand, assisting her. She was... she was so weak, she was so weak, she was so weak.

(*Shadow Weaver was right about me*)

" Sorry," she apologized again, helpless as a kitten, and feeling ten times worse. She felt almost feverish; she felt like she was going to fall out of her skin. She could feel the thin strain of energy from being She-Ra trying to restore her, to heal her, but it was nothing but a trickle, not the torrent she had access to when she transformed...

(her hand sought to do what it had done whenever she was hurt for four long years now, and unconsciously crawled towards her hip, where a Sword had sat at her side for so long; she caught it mid-journey, and jerked it away, horrified that she had sought the apocalyptic blade without conscious thought)

" You have no need to apologize to me," Angella said, tones still firm. " This mistake is *mine.* I thought I was just giving you time to process all that had happened... but I've failed you, haven't I? I did not see the condition you were in, and let this go on far too long without trying to help. I can tell you haven't been sleeping well, now that I'm actually paying attention to you. My poor daughter..."

" I'm fine," Catra lied again, trying to stifle a sob that wanted to fall out of her, and failing miserably. Angella was going to *know* how weak Catra was, she was going to see her as a burden, see how

(*worthless*)

She was, but she couldn't stop herself, couldn't keep the truth from slipping out. Her self-control had degraded just like the rest of her, and her mother was going to see how weak she really was, unless she could convince her she was fine, she was fine, she was fine... even as she only rose to her shaking legs with her mother's support.

" How long?" Angella asked, and Catra could not look her mother in the eyes.

A week, all this week since Mara's ship, since I found out the truth... but who's counting? Catra thought, and did not say. She couldn't say anything, just turned away, did not look, ashamed of herself, of her weakness. What a terrible daughter she was being...

A single truth went crashing through Catra's soul, an understanding that hit her so hard she stiffened where she stood; a realization that hurt.

Her first mother had been right. Shadow Weaver had been *right.*

Catra *was* worthless.

And she always had been. The Sword that had given her any worth had been a lie; now she was worse than worthless, she was a negative factor, she was going to destroy all her people and people she had never eveb known into the bargain. The world would have been a *better* place if she had never existed, Shadow Weaver had been right all along, she couldn't even stand on her own two legs without the fucking *Sword...*

The fur of her cheeks grew wet, and even more shame barreled through her as she was helpless to stop herself from crying.

" Oh, Catra," Angella said,and pulled her gently into a hug, which Catra could not help but lean into, needing the comfort too much even as she hated herself for seeking it, for being such a burden on this woman who'd been so kind as to adopt her. Her mother's arms and wings both encircled her, and Catra wrapped her own arms and tail around her as well, pressing her face tight against her mother's shoulder. " I... I hadn't... you've always been so strong and independent, and I was too smothering with Glimmer, I didn't want to be overbearing to you, too... and it wasn't like I wasn't shaken up by this either. I needed time to process, too, everything you found out was just so much to deal with... but I should have checked on you beforehand. I'm so sorry, I should have noticed something."

" You had other things to worry about," Catra apologized guiltily, in a quiet voice, into the darkness of her mother's shoulder, where no one could see her cry.

" Oh, Catra, I'm not mad at you," Angella soothed. " This is my fault, not yours. I should have checked on you before now. You're my daughter; you're one of the things I worry about *most.* "

Hearing those words, for some reason, hurt, even as they helped, and they made Catra cry even harder.

" I'm sorry, I'm sorry," she apologized, again and again. " I'm so sorry."

She kept saying it between sobs as her mother hugged her, and made soft noises, shushing her gently, even as Catra kept saying sorry, apologizing for all kinds of things, for things she had no words for, for every fuck-up that had led her to this point in her life.

She apologized for being the chosen executioner of worlds beyond count, an evil she has not done yet but *will.* She apologized for not being a real hero, for being not the Best Princess but the Worst; if she was a real hero, if she was anything like Mara, she would have killed herself, shut down the threat of the Sword by taking herself out of the equation. That's what a *real* hero would do, what the Best Princess would actually do, but Catra cannot.

(Best Princess, her own private joke, her way of covering up just how much it *meant* to her, to be the best, to be *worthy* of all the love the Alliance had poured into her heart, to be the heroine they needed her to be; and now it hurt, now the joke was on her, she had never even been in the running, she was no Princess at all, much less the Best. She was a monster.)

She apologized for smaller things, after that. She apologized for fooling everyone in Brightmoon into thinking she was a hero, the way the Sword had fooled her; she apologized for being a liar and

a manipulator, for tricking her way into the Queen's family like a worm into an apple, stealing the love Glimmer deserved more than her. She apologized for being worthless, for being weak, for being exactly the kind of scum her first mother had always known she was.

Above all else, first and foremost, she apologized for being a bad daughter.

(her original sin, the thing she has been paying for as long as she has been alive, the first mistake- and she knows it must be true, she *must* be a bad daughter, because if she had been a good daughter, surely Shadow Weaver would have loved her, right?)

She clung tight to her mother, whom she did not deserve, took love that was not hers, and bawled her weakness like the soft worthless thing she was.

But Angella did not push her away, as she more than half expected, as she knew she deserved.

" Catra, Catra, please, stop," Angella whispered to her daughter as she held her tight, not knowing what her daughter was apologizing for, what thoughts ran through her head and out of her mouth, but being able to guess, and guess well. " You have done nothing wrong. We can talk after you sleep. I can help- it's not something I can do very often, but you need sleep enough to justify it. I'll move the meeting back a few hours, use the attack last night to justify the delay; can't move it from today, but I can buy you more time. Time to sleep. To heal..."

The promise of sleep was so sweet that Catra couldn't even respond, just hugged her tighter for a moment with arms and tail both, apologizing again for her sins.

" Shh, shh," Angella soothed her, and picked her daughter up; not an easy feat, but wings and raw magic let her cheat. Up, in the air, and Catra barely noticed, she was in such a bad state, barely noticed as Angella carried her with her wings lightly extended, flapping gently as she navigated not air but Etheria's magical currents. A few wingbeats let her fly gently from room to room, her privat quarters built big enough for her to fly in, her own personal addition to the architect's notes.

She flew with her daughter to the nearest bed- her own, its covers still thrown back from where Angella had risen from them herself.

" I... should go to my room," Catra protested feebly, even trying to pull away, but Angella shook her head before she even finished the sentence, giving her one last hug before stepping away.

" No," Angella said, as she stepped away from her daughter, and pointed at the bed. " Lay down, get comfy."

Catra raised no more argument, too desperate for rest, only scrubbing her wet eyes as she laid down on the too-soft bed, curling up on herself, facing away from Angella in shame.

“ I'm going to use some magic on you,” Angella said. “ I know what Shadow Weaver did to you, and this is dark magic, too- but it's just to help you sleep without dreams. I won't use it if you don't want it, but it won't hurt you if I do. Is that okay?”

Her mother was using dark magic on her once again... but Shadow Weaver had never asked, never once, and would not have heard a *no* even if she had.

And beyond all that... Catra trusted that Angella would never hurt her. She *trusted* her.

(And still it took everything she had, all the courage gained on a thousand battlefields, all the trust Brightmoon has earned in four long years, and all the love Angella has given her, to get her to open her mouth and say, in a very small voice,)

“ Okay.”

A moment later, there was a gentle feeling of cold on her shoulder, as her mother pressed a hand gleaming softly with night sky to her fur; a darkness spread inside her, not an outer shadow woven to crush her, but something that fell in her soul as gently and silently as the night. It was good, it felt *good* , something a lot like a cold rag on a fevered forehead, soothing and calming all the hot turmoil inside herself, and she felt tensions and knots in her soul and brain ease as the night filled her like water poured into a cup, gently hiding everything that hurt her and leaving her pleasantly quiet inside.

As her insides calmed, her outsides were comforted too; she felt, dimly, her mother tucking her gently into bed by pulling the covers up over her.

Huh; tucked into bed. That's never happened to me before...

Catra was still thinking over how nice it felt when, for the first time in a week, she passed into dreamless rest.

****

Well, I've fucked up being a parent yet again, Angella thought bitterly to herself as she looked down on her sleeping daughter, her brain unhelpfully adding afterwards, *at least this time it's with Catra, not Glimmer, I haven't screwed up as badly with her yet so she'll give me more of a break than her sister would.*

She stood over Catra, making sure her magic did no more than help her sleep. She hated using her Moonstone connection to do this; a mind needed dreams, in some odd way, and doing this to someone too often had... consequences.

Angella had many nightmares- she had a coward's imagination, good at coming up with things that scared her- but this particular working of her power held a place of honor; after all, this was *her* doing, not the doing of others. Born of the purest motivation, the hope to... help.

She'd hurt her friends six centuries ago, and her perfect memory meant she could feel with perfect clarity the exact moment of realization, the very second in which she'd figured out what she'd done, and let that anguish and horror filter through her anew.

(She hadn't meant to. It was her only comfort. She hadn't meant to. She'd just been trying to help.)

The spirit patchers called it Trapped Syndrome, now, the way a mind would get... caught, stuck, on some awful thing in the past, like a bird amidst thorns. Back then, it had no name, and she knew it just as the nightmares her closest friends had suffered after the invasion of the Frozen Empress, of how they'd had to kill that cruel Princess of the Snows; she had sought a way to help them, first in the light, and then in the dark side of the Moonstone. Darkness did not like her, even the Moonstone's darkness, did not agree with her- too much death, too many endings, for a deathless, endless angel to touch- but she *did* dream, she *did* sleep, and so the part of night that embodied those things was something she could still grasp.

So she'd jumped into her research, and within a month, she'd figured it out. She couldn't control what one dreamed, but she *could* make it so one did *not* dream, and her friends had been so delighted! So happy! She'd felt so good, seeing them hale and hearty, that she'd never thought about... side effects. No, for one whole month, she'd just been so glad to see them back to their old selves that she'd never questioned it. Just used her influence on them every day, and every night, and for that one month, every thing had been just fine.

Then they lost their minds.

She had thought she'd driven them irrevocably insane. They *had* finally recovered... half a year later. The nightmares came back, much worse than before, the suppression only sharpening their claws... but they had, finally, come back, and they had forgiven her.

She had never forgiven herself. Angella had regrets, as anyone did... but few bit as deep, or caused her so much pain.

(Two would- years later- die of brain aneurysms, and some part of Angella had never stopped wondering how much of the blame for that fell on her. She had only wanted to help. She had never wanted to hurt them. She had only wanted to help...)

But over the centuries since, she'd had call to use it- rarely, sparingly- from time to time, on a few who needed a night's rest more than anything else, and developed an... understanding. It could be used, but there was a limit. Once a week was fairly safe. Once a month was better. *Never at all* was safest, of course, but... well, to everything, there was a season.

That season was here, now, and with her own daughter, at that. She *hated* doing this, but her daughter had needed the sleep more than anything else. If this had happened earlier- if she'd just bothered to go *check up on her daughter,* as she angrily reminded herself- she could have gotten a spirit patcher for Catra, or used some gentler option to ease her hurt.

I didn't want to be overbearing like I have been with Glimmer... but Catra is not Glimmer, no matter how much their fierce spirits

reflect each other. They have different needs.

Which... mostly meant that Angella had simply made a *new* mistake, in trying to dodge an old one. It felt rather unfair, honestly. She hadn't had fair warning, hadn't known that instead of time and distance to process, Catra had needed someone to talk to; Glimmer wasn't like that, wanted to work on stuff by herself before coming to others.

Still, even without a warning, Angella *did* have one thing- time. Plenty of time to talk to Catra, and that didn't help with her anger at herself for missing this. It had been one week since Catra found out about the sword, and Angella didn't think she'd slept at all since- and even humans, usually Etheria's most psychologically durable sentients, had trouble after three days or more without good rest. Magicats were fairly durable, quite human-like in that way, and some of her daughter's nature as She-Ra would have stretched the process out, but the flat truth was that her daughter had been decaying and Angella had never even noticed.

With such unpleasant thoughts percolating in her skull, Angella kept watch over her daughter, ready to draw her influence away if it seemed that Catra was getting worse- but she just slept. Angella leaned down and moved one hair away from her nose, put it back in her daughter's mane, noticing that her hair was a bit dirty, and smelling the faint musky scent of unwashed fur. Catra hadn't been cleaning herself as well as usual. Just another sign of how her daughter had been slowly collapsing.

If only she'd noticed... but she hadn't. She had been left with the brute force option for helping Catra by her own inattentiveness. The same with the meeting; earlier this week, moving it would

have been easy, but canceling now would cost her in terms of political capital. It was too much of a hassle for everyone to get to Brightmoon in the first place, she couldn't reschedule it a mere few hours before it was supposed to happen without diplomatic consequences.

...But if Catra needed it to be moved, she would move it.

I'm not the most attentive mother... but I don't make the same mistakes twice.

She'd see how Catra felt when she woke up. For now, she'd shift it some hours into the future, and if Catra was still in no condition when she awoke?

Well, then everyone would simply have to go home. Netossa and the others could rage all they wanted. What was the point of Brightmoon's high reputation if it couldn't afford to take a hit from time to time? The damage to Brightmoon's reputation would heal, in time. The damage to her daughter caused by wondering if she could have changed things at the meeting might not.

Her daughter came first, as she should have from the start.

Angella stayed there for a time, just watching the young woman she had been honored to adopt, and whom she'd so far done a wonderful job of failing. She'd never felt the urge to adopt before, but it had just felt... right, with Catra. Maybe it was because Catra

had wanted it so much, or maybe it was because... well, Angella was herself something like an adopted child. In the earliest days after her making- when the Most Serene had asked for volunteers to teach the baby elemental, who had not been an adult despite looking the same then as she did now, two had stepped forward, and she had went into their home to live and learn. She had been ward and student and little sister and daughter, all four at once, to Dame Haruka and Dame Michiru...

And both of them would be so ashamed of me right now, she thought, which felt hot and ugly inside her.

She didn't have such a hard task before her as they'd had, surely she could do at least *half* as well as they had! Dame Haruka and Dame Michiru had taken a strange, socially inept science experiment into their little home, ordered to watch over her, to educate her... and had taken the extra, unasked step of loving the freakish not-child, not-woman elemental like their own. They had been good to her and more than good to her.

(They had loved her enough that, when the Most Serene began to grow old, and wanted Angella to take over as Queen, her two mothers had asked her what she *wanted* to do, and told her that, if she did not want to be Queen, they would save her. They had prepared in secret to take her somewhere far away from Brightmoon, if that was what she wanted, somewhere the Most Serene could not reach, the only treason the two had ever contemplated in all their lives. They had loved the being dumped on their laps enough to defy the Most Serene, their friend and queen, and maybe that was why Angella was content with her lot in life; maybe it was as simple as the simple fact that there *had* been a choice, that if she had wanted, she could have left. Maybe that was why she did not resent her decision to stay, all these long years later.)

But Angella couldn't even match their work under the much easier circumstances she had. They'd had no knowledge of what Angella would even be *like,* nothing like her had ever existed before; Catra was a Magicat, that was at least a species that Angella had known about! Hell, her mothers hadn't even known if Angella *ate* when they got her, had discovered only by trial and error that she not only did, but needed to, and...

Well, sleep. They hadn't known she'd needed sleep, not until she passed out after staying up for two days, not aware that the exhaustion she was feeling and keeping back with magic was her body trying to make her rest.

Thinking of sleep made her check her daughter again, even though she'd just done that; she was fine, or at least, wasn't hurting, and her magic was doing its job of suppressing the night terrors that threatened to rise. She was okay- or, at least, as okay as she was going to be, given the circumstances. Angella gazed down on her daughter, only wanting to heal her, taking in her slack and somehow sad face...

...Her daughter looked wrong in her sleep. That expression, exhausted and tired and hurt, it just wasn't right. Catra was a thing of boldness and bravery, she should be smirking and smiling even in her sleep, showing the same expressions she showed when she thrashed her enemies or came up with some good quip in a dangerous situation. Catra was a thing of lightning, she was strong and magnificent, quite a lot like Dame Haruka...

...Perhaps that explained it.

For Catra, this problem would be terrifying in many ways. Angella had been terrified of the Sword too, of all Catra had revealed, but she had adapted. But for Catra, not only would it be more personal, but it was the kind of problem where you couldn't really *do* anything- no matter what Catra did, even if they fixed it so the Sword could not harm anyone, it would not change the truth. The Sword would still be the death of worlds, and Catra would still have to wrestle with what being chosen by it meant, a kind of existential terror to match the physical fear of death.

Dame Haruka had dealt with issues like that, too, and they'd hurt her just as much. Dame Haruka and Catra shared an indomitable spirit; Dame Haruka had been unbreakable, and so had Catra been, up until recently. Catra had not let the tragedy of her childhood or all the Horde's forces or *anything* slow her down, much less stop her; her daughter had a titan's heart long before becoming She-Ra had made her eight feet tall. She had never once faced an obstacle she could not beat, with cleverness or genius or sheer brute strength.

Dame Haruka hadn't, either, until the day she suddenly had.

It had been two years into Angella's existence- two years, into becoming a person, fully, with the assistance of her mothers- when Dame Haruka had run into something she could do nothing about. A political issue of some kind; Angella hadn't known what it was at the time, and never learned after. Just an issue that Dame Haruka, who was so strong, so passionate, so powerful, was completely helpless before.

She hadn't handled it well. It had put her into such a foul mood that her and Dame Michiru had the first serious fight Angella had known about, which had upset the young angel considerably at the time. Dame Michiru, seeing Angella's distress, had taken the time- even with her own emotions a bit rattled by the fight- to calm her. She'd explained to the rather concerned elemental that her wife was like stone; totally unyielding, utterly without give, and that was enough, usually... but it also meant that she was totally unable to yield, even the tiniest bit, without breaking utterly. Such a rock-solid sense of self could not abide even a moment's lapse, or else it would fall apart.

And yet everyone was fallible. Even them.

All Dame Michiru could do was try to make Dame Haruka realize that truth, and get her to stop taking her frustration out on others. One failure did not a lifetime of victories unmake, a truth Haruka had trouble handling. Michiru had done it before, and would do it again; her wife wasn't as bad as she had been the first time, back before they married, and next time wouldn't be as bad as this time, but a person could not change their innermost nature easily, even the most flawed part.

Dame Haruka had heard her explaining it, and come out of her sulking in their room with a sheepish expression that had looked weird on a face so usually fierce and proud; she had apologized, saying her love was correct, and her wife had accepted it with her usual grace. Dame Haruka had told Angella that Dame Michiru was better than she was, was more like water, which could bend with any pressure without ever breaking.

Angella, greatly cheered, had verbally noted to the duo her observation that they were correct; water wore away all stone, after all, and in all major decisions that Angella had seen the couple make, Dame Michiru was the one in charge, not Dame Haruka.

(She had not been the most socially adroit little scientific experiment, in her youth.)

After an awkward pause, Dame Haruka had said that the angel was wrong, *obviously* Dame Haruka made all the decisions... when Dame Michiru let her. The joke broke the tension that had built up, their little family laughing at the little joke in their little home, because the duo *did* love each other... and somehow, that little moment was still one of Angella's favorite memories, all these centuries later.

(Most Etherians would never know the debt they owed the two knights, not for all the great deeds they'd done, commemorated in Brightmoon on their saint-feasts in the first and third months of the year; no, those were not hidden, many knew of them. What *few* knew was the greater thing, that in simply loving Angella, they had set for her an example, a personal star by which to guide herself in times of trouble; when time had come for that angel to do what all sentient life must, and decide what kind of person she wanted to be, she had remembered a little life in a little home, and most would never know how much evil was averted and how much good had its start in those little moments, no bigger than a mustard seed.)

Catra was a lot like Dame Haruka; maybe her mothers could teach her still. Perhaps in the face of awful knowledge she could not defeat, she would feel the same mixture of guilt, and shame, and frustration, and anger... You couldn't fight this, after all. This knowledge that the Sword was death, the end of everything,

forever... you couldn't “overcome” that. It wasn't how it worked. You simply had to abide...

Combine that with feeling terrified for the woman Catra still loved, and her lack of sleep... yes. That was a recipe fine enough to bring down even the mighty.

Which meant Catra, like Dame Haruka, needed someone else to pull her out of her spiraling hurt. She'd have to get a spirit patcher to Catra- and she couldn't *imagine* the fight she'd have with her over that, but it was necessary. Catra would surely see it as soft... maybe Angella could ask Bow? All three members of the Best Friend Squad had confided in Angella, in their own ways, that while Catra and Glimmer argued a lot, it was Bow who would convince one of them to adopt the other's viewpoint so they could keep going. That heart on his chest wasn't just for show; like any good heart, he kept things moving.

Honestly, that young man would scare the hell out of me if he wasn't so damn nice, Angella thought, unable to resist a very small smile, even with her mood as dour as it was. Realizing the *actual* dynamics of her daughters' fireteam had amused her for four years running. *Catra thinks she's in charge and so does Glimmer and neither have any idea who the real leader is. He'll be terrifying as a diplomat when he gets older; all of Etheria will be crushed under Bow's benevolent reign of friendship.*

His expertise would be invaluable now; Bow would know what to do.

Which is good, because apparently I'm awful at being a mother, Angella thought with another sigh, reaching down to squeeze her daughter's shoulder. Catra made a peaceful sort-of noise, so much better than that awful noise she'd made before... that awful noise, that heartbreaking sound that Angella had only heard when she'd entered her dining room. That was how quiet Catra's cry of distress was, that Angella could only barely hear it in a silent room, and then only when she was near her; even in her sleep, even in pain, Catra had been so careful to be quiet.

Given how Shadow Weaver had "raised" her, that wasn't surprising... she must have feared, even in her tormented rest, that she'd be punished if she was heard.

A child, so afraid of being hurt that even in her *sleep* she tried to be quiet...

A familiar feeling came to Angella then, right behind her eyes, something cold and sharp and *angry.* A rare emotion, one she had not felt often over the long years... but she had felt it often enough to identify it. It was her sense of righteous fury, that rare thing that happened when personal rage met impersonal justice and they did not fight, but *agreed.*

And this is what they agreed on: what had been done to her daughter was evil in its purest shape. No child should have to suffer like this.

It was... comforting. Steadying, to have the guillotine edge gleaming behind her eyes. It was good, right; there was a part of

the holy Silver that cut, the part of justice that demanded repayment of sins, and she let it strengthen her faltering spirit, just for a moment. Sometimes it was needed; sometimes, despite all the hopes of all the peaceful and all the prophets, there were things that demanded death as the only possible answer.

Not often. A last resort among last resorts; but much like the magic she'd used on her daughter, to everything there was a season. From time to time, the right solution really *was* to raise the sword and lead the charge, so that evil be done no more.

Angella had, despite her cowardice, despite her fears, lead that charge before, and she would do so again. Where a heart lacked courage, it might still have rage, and hate, and *love,* because that was part of this, too. It was her love for her daughter that fueled her rage and her hate... and she suspected that time to wield that sharpness behind her eyes was coming soon.

Shadow Weaver was not a person who would ever stop, after all. She would keep doing what she had always done, she would be seeking power again and again and again until she was stopped. She would do something, soon, and it would involve Catra, because controlling Catra by hurting her seemed to be Shadow Weaver's one hobby outside of gardening.

...But Angella would wait. A last resort, after all, had to be *last.* No matter how furious she was, she would not act against the witch until she did something new, and revealed her hand; even Shadow Weaver deserved a second chance. She had come to the Alliance with information, after all, and her warning about the Portal might well have saved all Etheria; and for some reason,

Glimmer had asked Angella to trust her when she went to see the spellcaster.

(She maybe should not have allowed it... but she had spent so long mistrusting Glimmer. Just this once, she would choose the opposite path, and believe in her daughter. Maybe a mistake. But a *new* mistake, at least, and Angella was so tired of making old mistakes with her daughters.)

Should Shadow Weaver live in peace, no matter how furious Angella was, she would leave her be- though she would never let her be near Brightmoon Castle again. Angella had seen that happen, sometimes, had very rarely seen old warlords and cruel folk and greedy bandits quit, and turn their lives around. Rare as hen's teeth, it was... but not completely missing from the pages of history.

Still, it was not a common end to anyone's tale. People rarely changed; mostly they just persisted. Shadow Weaver would persist, and try something, as sure as night fell and dawn broke. It was as certain as death and taxes- actually, maybe *more* certain than the former, since Angella had so far proven proof against death. Shadow Weaver would, in time, do something stupid.

And when she did, the fearful angel would rush to tread all over the fool.

But for now, she had to put that thought away. She needed to set things up. She'd need to send messengers- not right now, it was the dead of night, but as soon as morning came. Set the meeting off... four hours? That'd give Catra some time to recover, while still

being doable. The meeting had been set for noon; four was late for a meeting, but it wasn't *too* late.

She might even have time to talk with Catra, see if there was a way to... perhaps thread the needle. Adora and the Horde had to be stopped, for Brightmoon; Adora had to survive, for Catra. Angella had supported Adora's death at the last meeting, even knowing that Catra would view it as a betrayal, because Angella's people looked to her for protection, and she could not put the life of one of their enemies above their safety, even for her daughter...

But that didn't mean killing Adora was the only way forward.

She'd thought about that, in the small space between the first meeting and finding out about the Sword. She hadn't expected Catra to run off, she hadn't *understood* that it was more than a crush or the longing for an ex-lover. She hadn't realized *why* Catra was so singularly focused on Adora, not until she heard all Catra's childhood from her daughter's mouth, and realized that the only reason her Catra had survived long enough to become her child was because, a long time ago, one little girl was very kind to another.

So, perhaps they could capture her alive, instead of killing her.

It wasn't ideal. Yes, capturing Adora would get rid of her as a Horde leader, but Adora was *dangerous.* It would be hard to catch her and harder to keep her. Adora was a First One- and Angella *still* couldn't really grip that properly, all these months after her daughter told her about it, it was just so damn big that her mind

resolutely refused to think about it- and she was a clever and ruthless opponent besides. She'd tangled with the entire Great Rebellion for four years now, after all, whether as one of Hordak's best or as Horde commander, and come out the winner as often as not.

But.

If she could be taken, it could work. Adora in captivity could not lead. The Horde had already been almost ruined by the loss of *one* leader, and it had only pulled itself back together through sheer faith in Adora. Take their Dragon away, and they would fall apart again.

Of course, there'd be a period of time where the fighting would get even worse. The retribution would be brutal. The faithful would look to fight for their messiah. There'd be a *tremendous* push on the frontlines after this.

But that push would be relentless and *fanatical*- and ones so driven did not look before leaping. They could trick them, have an ambush waiting, surprise them.

It was a strategy Angella had used once before, to handle the second Glory Lily Princess. The first had been a *terrifying* foe, one that had come for Angella with intent to slay her and take the Moonstone for herself. It wouldn't even be the first; Kaname had already killed the Salinean Prince at the time, drank him dry with roots, and also murdered the Flame Princess who went to fight her in turn, poisoning her lungs with acid that fire could not heal.

She hadn't been ready to take their Runestones yet, but by the time she settled on the Moonstone, she was- had a plan to force the Runestone to pick a Plumerian to empower.

Killing Angella hadn't even been personal for Kaname, who had come at the head of an army, looking gorgeous in her dress, hands empty of weaponry, for she hadn't needed one. The murder she'd planned was of no interest to her. It was just another box that had to be checked off on her list of things to do that day, that was all. Somewhere after breakfast and before bed, there had been a little line that said *murder the Queen of Brightmoon,* no big deal; that was how she treated the death of another person.

She'd been terribly serene, almost pleasant, when they met. She'd even asked what Angella's favorite flowers were, since she wanted to know what kind of flowers to put over Angella's grave.

(Angella had almost pissed herself at the request, so terrified by her enemy's calmness, her sword shaking in her hands)

They'd fought at Brightmoon Castle, one of only a handful of times the Castle itself had ever been invaded, and to this day, that had been the hardest fight of Angella's life. No magnificent battle, that; Angella had spent all of it running terrified and screaming when she could find the breath for it, Kaname calmly following her like a slow, unstoppable juggernaut, the whole world turning against Angella. Trees snatched and roots bit and the world itself vomited torrents of bitterlye- *bitterlye*, that awful poison the first Glory Lily Princess had come up with, not an acid but a base so powerful that it bubbled and boiled away all that was artificial, her way of returning the world to what she deemed natural. That was how Angella lost her first castle; Brightmoon Castle had been utterly ruined by the fight, she'd had to rebuild it from the ground

up, the stone turning soft and *rotten* where the bitterlye touched it, the metal running in pools of foul liquid, so much ruined that could never, ever be repaired or replaced.

Angella had only won that fight by dumb luck; her last-minute desperate charge straight *at* Kaname had surprised the woman just long enough that Angella could run her through.

(Angella had collapsed sobbing afterwards, as all the warped plants she'd made collapsed and died, listening as all Brightmoon Castle and her people's homes bubbled and burst in the lake of bitterlye she'd mdae; she'd had nightmares for months of trees turning into gnashing dragons and vines bursting with fat acidic poison like grenades. The memory of such nightmares had been why she'd tried to help her friends, centuries later, to her grief.)

But the second Glory Lily Princess had been much simpler to defeat. Akemi had been the wife of the first, and she had, in her grief, deified Kaname, and then forgotten that her wife had ever been a person; she had been *convinced* her wife's spirit was now a goddess watching over her, and so had been overconfident and foolish, to such an extent that it was little surprise that she had the shortest reign of any of the Glory Lily Princesses. When Angella had taken her down, she'd honestly felt mostly sad; Akemi had left herself completely open, trusting to divine protection that simply did not exist outside of her grief-stricken mind, and she had seemed almost... at peace, when she died.

(Which had led, unfortunately, to Princess Tomoe, who had been *the* most competent and deadly of the four, the one who finally ruined Dryl... which was one reason Angella had not dueled her, but mobbed her with an army. To Tomoe's credit, she'd *still* almost come out of that one, even as old as she'd been at the time, a wrinkled woman of great age who'd nearly kicked all their asses before Angella had finally taken her head.)

This might be like that. Much had changed over the years, but the *nature* of people still persisted, just like people themselves often did. Adora was the Horde's Kaname, deadly and dangerous; but whoever came next would be their Akemi, prone to mistakes.

Keeping Adora alive might work even better for that, actually, now that Angella was thinking about it; a martyr was one thing, but an army of the faithful, trying to *save* their leader? They would be even more desperate, fearing what the Rebellion would do to her, would feel a ticking clock over their heads that would make then even more prone to stupidity. With sufficient preparation...

Yes. This could work.

If she could sell it to the others in the Great Rebellion. If she could convince the others that Adora deserved to live- no, wait, that would never work. Adora had tried to destroy the planet just to fuck over Catra in a moment of intense mental stress, something Catra had explained to the others once the world of the portal had ended. It would be hard to argue she "deserved" to live... though honestly, for that act at least, Angella felt Adora should be given some slack. No one had died, and a defense of temporary insanity felt sufficient to Angella, though only Brightmoon and Mystacor had such a concept in their legal systems.

(Well, Salineas had an idea of ocean-madness, but it wasn't quite the same.)

So... argue from the other end. Argue that *Catra* deserved to have this wish granted. Catra was friends with almost everyone there, and even those she wasn't friends with respected her tremendously. That angle might be productive...

She'd use that, assuming she needed to do so; all her planning might end up completely unimportant. The meeting might not even *get* to Adora, since Angella had to tell everyone the news about the Sword, about Light Hope's untrustworthy nature, and figure out what to do about the fact that the planet was steadily turning into a *bomb,* which would almost certainly derail the meeting into being about how to deal with the new situation that had just fallen on all of their heads- or, perhaps more accurately, risen up from below.

She hoped, desperately, that someone would have an idea of what to do; Angella herself didn't. She she felt so... *betrayed* by the Sword, enraged that it had hurt her daughter so, that it had masqueraded all its evil as good for all these years...

...Her daughter was fine. She gave her one last check to make sure she was fine, before leaving her to her rest with a last little motherly smooch to her forehead. Angella would be fine with one sleepless night; she needed sleep like anybody did, but she'd survived a rough night before and would do so again. She couldn't sleep; she had work to do.

She'd have to get one of the night maids to get some coffee going. Make her one of those delicious Salinean vanilla lattes she'd always been fond of... better than the Dryl brews, which were too bitter for Angella's sweet tooth. Thankfully prices had fallen since Dryl rejoined the Alliance, and Salinean merchants

couldn't charge whatever they wanted for coffee anymore, an injury to their pocketbooks they were no doubt still lamenting. Being the only source of the second-most beloved drink in the world had been quite a boon, no doubt.

Between that and losing their near-monopoly on tech too, nobody had lost as much from Dryl rejoining as the wave riders; it was one reason Mermista's immediate assistance in the matter of Entrapta had been so unexpected, and so appreciated. Angella was well aware that every goal in Salineas aligned with Dryl getting a trade embargo, at the very least, but Mermista had put her friendship with Catra before national profit, and that was a gift Angella held most dear.

Of course, that was probably why she'd seen someone with a diplomat's cloak from Salineas arrive yesterday along with Mermista. Mermista did not run Salineas, and the Saltwater Senate had probably sent him along to remind her of that little fact. She didn't know the man, or at least, didn't think she did... he looked damn familiar, though... maybe she'd known him years ago?

She was distracted from these thoughts as she entered her dining room, and saw the source of her daughter's distress. The Sword, the end of everything, lay propped up casually against the wall, and knowing what it was, Angella paused in sheer terror for a second, her coward's heart momentarily overwhelmed.

The Sword. The Sword, the blade of heroes. The Sword, the death of *worlds* .

Angella alone might really understand that, in a way no other Etherian might. Dames Haruka and Michiru had both told her stories, which they themselves had heard from the oldest people they knew, those rare few who'd been alive when Etheria's night sky had a tapestry of stars, when "night" meant something other than the non-presence of the illuminating moons. That list had only Madame Razz, now, at least, if Angella had correctly deciphered some of Razz's more bizarre ramblings over the long centuries of her acquaintance with the Twigget.

(Not that Angella believed her to be a Twigget at all; Angella had a suspicion, something far too vague to call a theory, or even an idea... just an indistinct concept, that Madame Razz might, in fact, be an elemental of Etheria itself, a representation of the world, much like how Angella herself was the light of the Moonstone made manifest. A thing that she believed in and hoped for, though she knew she might simply be projecting. Her life was a lonely one, and maybe she simply hoped that there was another being like her, and put those desires onto the sole companion that had lasted all the millennia of her existence, if in her odd, disjointed way.)

Those stories had been about how there was a great darkness surrounding the world, lit up with things called stars. Billions of them, they said, populating an equally infinite blackness; stars enough that the First Ones had sailed the night with them to guide the way, mapping out the sky like a Salinean seachart with patterns called constellations. Some of these stars were more than just stars, though; they had life in the worlds orbiting them, fed them, and thus were something like the crowned nobility of their kind- things called *suns.*

Light without darkness, they had called it, which had spooked the young Angella, whose heart had not been any stouter in her youth than it would be in her old age. She had known just how powerful

the Moonstone's light was, how much harm it could do, and that was *with* it being gentled by darkness, its rough edges smoothed down by the soft curves of night, hot fury balanced by cool calmness. The idea of light without darkness had frightened her, and still did.

Light without darkness would be...

Well, Adora, if Angella did not miss her guess. Fire without relent. Lightning without pause.

But these *suns* fed worlds, were not burdens but boons to the worlds they shone upon, allowing life to flourish, the way the moons did for Etheria now in Despondos. Other peoples had lived under those alien suns; Angella's very own daughter descended from one such group, the Magicats, who claimed to have landed on Etheria many years ago, falling like a thunderbolt from a distant place. She'd heard the tale herself from some of their diplomats, in those days before the Horde consumed the Runestone Duchies and the Fright Zone and Halfmoon was cut off from the rest of Etheria. Why, even the First Ones had themselves come from somewhere else, Eternia, so named because it would be where an eternal empire was built.

Thinking of the First Ones made Angella glance at the Sword again, and rethink what she'd been told of Eternia. An eternal empire... on reflection, the signs that the First Ones hadn't been entirely on the up and up had always been there. She'd never seen it, though; even in the days of her creation, they'd had such a good reputation that she had simply never thought past her first impression of them in all the years since.

Worlds full of life, of people loving and living their lives, and the Sword would kill them all... and, in fact, would have *already* killed them all, save that Mara had died defending them.

...Mara.

Fuck, Angella thought, a rare word to hear in her head, but tonight was a night for cussing if there ever was one.

Mara.

Mara, Angella hadn't had time to consider her before now, but suddenly it consumed her thoughts. By the Silver, *Mara!* Mara, who was mostly unknown in these days, who in the years of Angella's youth had been despised as the She-Ra who had, depending on which story you believed, either failed to keep Etheria from being transported to Despondos, or was herself responsible. No one had known, back then, had been too busy dealing with the aftermath, but everyone had known that Mara was somehow at fault, one way or another. All kinds of ideas had been bandied about, especially by those who believed that Mara had moved them, the majority opinion back then; most thought Mara had moved Etheria into the gray nothing in order to take it over as sole Queen, or that it had been an act of despair at the death of her lover.

But Dame Haruka and Dame Michiru both had privately told Angella that they belonged to the rarest group on Etheria, those who thought that maybe Mara had a *good* reason to shift them into Despondos. Dame Haruka and Dame Michiru, who had both

made hard choices before, had particularly liked that idea, and Angella could hear their ancient voices now, could easily imagine her two mothers laughing at being proven right, all these centuries later... and by the woman who was, by any measure that counted, their granddaughter.

(The brief thought passed through her, not without sorrow- *Dame Haruka and Dame Michiru would have loved my girls* .)

Mara, so maligned, was not Etheria's monster or failure, but the greatest of her heroes, and all unknown.

...Angella didn't know what to do about the Sword, but she *goddamn* well knew what to do about Mara. She'd plan it out after the meeting tomorrow, where she would reveal the truth; and maybe it was right, that someone from Brightmoon should find out about this injustice, and rectify it. Brightmoon worshiped heroism itself, after all, and Angella could think of no more heroic deed than this- the woman who had chosen to die in disgrace, so that others might live in peace. If anyone's soul had ever shone with the Silver, and belonged to that part of the universe that sought justice and truth, then Mara's did.

It wasn't fair, that Mara had been disgraced so long, and that was, thankfully, a problem Angella could fix. She would see to it that everyone knew that Mara was a hero. All Brightmoon would restore honor to Mara's name, and learn of her great deeds, and give her justice in death that she'd never had in life. They would honor her every year, a living testament for the noble dead.

(She'd have to ask Madame Razz what Mara's birthday had been- that was the traditional day for a saint's celebration- and then find out what she'd liked in life, what foods she'd enjoyed, what had brought her happiness; make it a day for baking pies, perhaps,

given what Catra had been able to tell her afterwards. That wouldn't be so bad; there were worse ways to be honored after death than with good food, shared among good friends.)

Maybe she'd make it a national holiday, devote a weekend to Mara, or maybe even a full week, given the scale of her deeds. Hopefully she had a birthday in the summer, Angella had idly thought that Brightmoon needed a major summer holiday for a while now, all of her people's holy days were lopsidedly concentrated in the late fall and early winter, it'd be nice to break up the monotony of summer.

This was all a Brightmoon way of honoring the dead, of course. Angella did not know how Mara's own people would venerate her, but maybe it was better to honor her in an Etherian style. After all, she had died fighting her own people; perhaps she'd prefer it this way, that she should be honored in the manner of one of the peoples she had fought to defend.

That's what she'd do. Right after she... left this room, and tried really hard not to look at the Sword.

With those thoughts filling her, Angella shook her head, and did her best to ignore the Sword, somehow feeling foolish for doing so, like she was walking blind into some monster's lair, with no defense should it take a bite. Coward that she was, she had an irrational desire to hide the Sword behind a door, or in a closet, under a bed, *something,* even as her rational mind knew that just putting it out of sight would not put it out of her mind.

She headed out the door, only just managing not to glance at the Sword before she left.

Chapter End Notes

> Next up: the other Runestone Kingdom Princesses! Mermista has a chat with her accompanying diplomat, Frosta is absolutely not being lied to, and Perfuma has a conversation with a bat.

Chapter 36: Princess Mermista of Salineas

Chapter Notes

I'm gonna stop saying what's gonna be in each chapter. You get what you get!... because apparently I can't control myself!

So here, for your fun, is a chapter devoted to our saltwater witch! She really needed a chapter before now. Up next... is something else, I ain't breaking my promise that fast.

Here's hoping I get there someday!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Last War Council of Etheria

Part Two:

Princess Mermista of Salineas

(Take Arms Against a Sea of Troubles)

Mermista got up, and started her day as she usually did- with a deep, heartfelt sigh.

She was kinda proud of it, to be honest, it was kinda hard to make a deep, heartfelt sigh when you were stationed in Brightmoon's diplomatic housing. A whole series of little mini-fortifications in a cluster near Brightmoon Castle, built sort of like mini-castles, and inside they were just fucking *luxurious*. The Salinean diplomatic housing, in deference to the two nation's longstanding friendliness towards one another, was the best of the lot, a nice little circular chonker of a building like a withdrawn nautilus, keeping them safe and secure inside.

Why, Angella even kept real Salinean chefs on staff! Mermista'd had a magnificent meal last night of green mussel biryani, her perennial favorite entree, and even followed it up with a proper faloodah, and everything had been seasoned just right. Not as hot as Plumerian food or, nameless forbid, *Snows* food, which melted through your mouth directly to your asshole and kept going, but not as bland as Brightmoon or Mystacor food. This had been amazing Salinean cuisine, and Mermista should know, Princesses got free seats at the best restaurants.

Really, it threw into sharp relief the failures of other nation's diplomacy. Mermista was *still* offended that Perfuma had kept trying to feed her finned fish, apparently assuming that as a Salinean, any fish would do, which was just insensitive. Everyone knew you didn't eat food that *looked like you* , that was just begging for trouble, and finned fish were too close to Mermista's transformed tail for her to want to risk it. Even Octopus Cove wouldn't serve Mermista finned fish- the last time she'd been there on a diplomatic mission they'd given her eel- and they didn't even like her or her people all that much! Food hadn't been bad either, Cove's nearness to Brightmoon had given them some wonderfully sweet deserts... but the nearness to Plumeria had also given their entrees a bit more heat than Mermista had been entirely comfortable with.

To her credit, Perfuma had profusely apologized after Mermista explained the faux pas, but still!

Yes, truly Angella had went above and beyond. Salineas' diplomatic building even had a specially built room for the Princesses with a big old pool to fall asleep in if they didn't feel like using a bed, a pool that stayed the same comfortably warm temperature all night; not that the nights were cold, it was starting to become real summer, but it was still nice! There was a bed in the back of the room, a walk-in closet that was huge for all her outfits, a desk for writing at- the works.

Mermista lazily twirled herself about in the water's depths; seriously, this was nice, it was even filtered, and had real sea salt added so it smelled right. Or was that tasted right? Whatever sense her lungs were using when they filtered the water like a pair of gills. It was still her nose, that meant it was smell, right?

Ehh, too early for such musings. She made another lazy spin, ending facing up, looking at the ceiling above her pool, which was painted blue and decorated with classical Salinean motifs: seashells and wave foam, sailing ships and leaping dolphins, the amphibian toad of Salinean land forces and the sleek hammerhead shark of her navy. This whole area was lovely, and had been for a long time; Angella had built it literal centuries ago, give or take a few renovations since, and every Princess who'd contributed to the Pearl Logbook since had made mention of how nice it was in their shared journals.

(Though admittedly Princess Knight, the poshest motherfucker who had ever held the title, had went on a long tangent about how Angella had to have something up her sleeve... which had

ended up being a whole lot of words that amounted to nothing much, which was a fair summation of that Princess in general.)

Seriously, Queen Angella was an awesome host.

Mermista herself should probably write about that in her own entries in the Logbook, now that she was thinking about it. She'd keep it simple, she was no poet. *Angella's still a good host and the diplomatic rooms are still nice in my time.* Maybe that was how she'd write it. It wasn't exactly news, to report that the immortal Queen had continued her longstanding trend of not being an asshole, but Prince Kisame had made a point in his own writings that future generations needed to know what had changed *and* what hadn't, so that any future changes could be traced, and Mermista would rely on his wisdom.

Hell, that's the point of the Logbook, Mermista thought to herself dryly. *If we wanted to make old mistakes, we wouldn't have our Princesses writing them down so we could avoid them.*

She'd leaned on that wisdom often enough in her life, and only hoped her own words would help somebody else, long years after her river had wound safely back to sea. She'd been writing busily in the Pearl Logbook since the War began, adding another volume to the long list of bound tomes that every Princess of Salineas contributed to, a tradition stretching back to Salineas' founding in 55 ID; the War was big, after all, it deserved as much explanation as she could give it.

There'd been war before, but the war with the Horde was different, in some fundamental way, from every war she read about in her predecessor's writings. Every war had its variances, of course, but this one was different in terms of *scale*. Really, the only things that were about on the same level were the Glory Lily Princesses and maybe the Frozen Empress, though that last hadn't been nearly as serious of a problem as the Plumerians who'd predated the Snows' most vicious leader.

Every other war, even the really nasty ones, had been between two nations, or three at most. There'd never been anything this damn big; even the Glory Lilies weren't quite like this. Sure, everyone had fought them, but there had been no formal alliances against any of the four except the third, when Queen Angella had gotten together three nations to oppose Princess Tomoe: Mystacor, which had just started in those days, Salineas, and the Flame Kingdom, one of its last acts before the end of that nation.

The Flame Kingdom... whose proper name was Incandesce, apparently, one of Mermista's predecessors had recorded that little fact, along with the last Fire Princess' true name, Signum. She'd found them when idly flipping through the Logbook after the last War Council, wondering if anyone had written about them, and found it buried in some notes. The little details you don't notice the first time you read something.

(In fairness to Mermista, she figured that a *fire* princess was the last thing a waterlord like herself would ever have to worry about... especially when you considered that the entire Flame Kingdom had burned. She wasn't going to run into a new Fire Princess anytime soon.)

She... should maybe send that information along to a museum or something, actually, now that she was thinking about it, nobody at the meeting had seemed to know the name of the place. Angella probably did, but she hadn't said anything- probably because she'd so obviously wanted to keep the meeting moving along, she'd seemed annoyed every time someone kept them stuck on the topic of the Fire Princess.

But who to send it to? Maybe a professor of history at one of Salineas' Abyssals- yeah, that'd work. She'd send it to Coastal Abyss, they were the first ones to give her an honorary degree. Pure political bribery, obviously, just attempting to get in good with her, but she'd been pretty amused by them declaring her a Professor of Military Strategy. The other two degrees the other Abyssals had sent along were for hydrautic engineering, a safely bland choice, but military stuff was much closer to her actual wheelhouse and role, and she'd liked the acknowledgment.

Maybe it'd make her a few acquaintances before she went to Abyss herself and got a real Professorship after the war. The needs of the war meant she'd mostly had to focus on her job of kicking ass, but being the Salinean Princess also meant having final say on a lot of legal matters, and she wanted a degree in law to help her do her job right. It was traditional, after all; it was either law or a military degree. Hell, with an Abyssal education meant she could get both, though the scheduling would be tight.

Sure, she *had* lawyers assisting her, but you never knew what their angle was, or even how good they were at their jobs; and the whole point of Salineas' system was that a Princess was a one-woman counterbalance in the system, a thing that could avoid the one flaw of democracy, that of mob rule.

Our Princess shall reign over nothing, and yet have final say on everything, her mind recalled, old words that she was comforted by. Those words were from Salineas' very first constitution, when the common folk and the Princess who'd been from their ranks sat down on the corpses of the wealthy and powerful who'd hurt them, and tried to figure out how they would live. It was one of the only parts that had never changed in all the long years since; the constitution was rewritten many times, they were in the Thirteenth Republic now, but that part had stayed the same.

How had her old history teacher put it, back when she'd been in Shallows, sitting bored at a desk with no idea that she was going to be the next Princess? *Individual republics will rise, and eventually fall, to anarchy or civil war or, rarest of all, peaceful change... but the Republic will live forever.*

She'd liked that, back then. She'd immediately liked the idea that their democracy was like the ocean, ever-changing and eternal both, its built-in instability somehow rendering it stable; the very essence of water, that it was chaos and order both in beautiful balance.

(No wonder her people had historically liked Brightmoon; much like the Moonstone, some part of the Pearl was about balance, too, though it sat between the random and the hierarchical, rather than in the midst of the forces of light and darkness.)

She liked it even better now, when she'd seen the way other nations lived. A nation should not be ruled by one person alone; she couldn't imagine the pressure, to be frank. All you had to do was look at Perfuma and see the way it hurt somebody- sometimes Mermista felt like all someone had to do was push

Perfuma just once, and the girl would shatter into pieces like fragile glass. It was one reason that the saltwater witch tried to bite her tongue when near the petalbearer, though she didn't often manage it. Perfuma was enough of a nervous wreck without having Mermista wearing away at her; no wonder she smoked so damn much, it was probably the only reason she hadn't died of a heart attack already. Being the sole leader of a whole nation was... not good.

Maybe worse, though, was the way they could be taken advantage of. Frosta, who was so young, who shouldn't be a Princess, was there no one older the Fractal could have chosen? Mermista did not receive her power until she was late in her teens, at least, she'd been able to grow up first, and even she had scrambled to become all she could be. She would never accuse the impartial Pearl of benevolence, but Mermista could not help but think that the Flake was crueler than her own Pearl for picking a *child*.

Cruel, because Frosta was *doomed*; doomed to be the servant of others, and never to know it. Mermista had tried to teach her, to do what she could to get the ironically fiery Princess of Ice to realize that others would manipulate her and were probably already doing so, but Mermista didn't know if she'd ever listened. And in the future, would someone used to running the show while Frosta was young acquiesce, or just keep going? How many strings would be layered on that poor brave girl, to make sure she was a puppet?

Wasn't like the Snows lacked for bad ideas that could use a Princess' support... Mermista had even heard through her contacts in the diplomatic department that the leadership of the Snows had even considered invading the Fright Zone to take the Black Garnet

for themselves! A pipe dream, obviously, but the mere fact it was seriously being bandied about was telling. Something about going west and conquering Darkspur- a nation Mermista had only the vaguest knowledge of, it was one of the smattering of Crownless citystates that dominated Etheria's western coast- then sailing south to take land.

Her contacts hadn't believed it to be a real possibility, though. How would that even work? The Fright Zone was on the other side of the world... and had mostly been desert, before Hordak made it mostly an industrial nightmare. All they'd accomplish was killing a lot of people, and making themselves look like fools.

(Mermista, very quietly, prayed to the nameless sea-gods that Frosta was smart enough to see it as the mistake it was, if her friends were wrong.)

Only Queen Angella handled it well... but Mermista had spent time enough with Glimmer to know that while Angella the Queen was great and wise, Angella the Person was not so lucky, though those conversations had always made Catra vaguely ill and she'd try to change the subject. Plus, Angella had the benefit of time; she was ancient, ancient beyond belief, and was past her awkward phase. She'd had one, too, as the Logbook had taught Mermista, reading of how some of Angella's early reign was measured more in her mistakes than her successes.

Even now, rare as it was, she could still mess up; her retreat from the first Princess Alliance had been met with open revolt in Brightmoon. The mere fact that Brightmoon deserters in the Rebels made up the single largest faction in that stateless group was proof of just how huge a mistake that had been, for her

personal suffering to lead her to turn her back on a global war. Even the angel made her mistakes.

Yeah, Salineas had a better system. A democracy meant it wasn't any one person's fault; be as heroic or awful as you wanted, there were still others with their hands on the wheel, steering the ship alongside you. It meant a nation not as subject to one person's whims, and one person's life not as subject to so many competing interests.

Which... made it worse when that truth was fighting her, like it was, right now.

With a deep, heartfelt sigh that had more true sadness in it than the one before, Mermista rose up out of the water, transforming as she went. Falcon was waiting for her; so was today's meeting, at which she'd have to tell her best friend that she couldn't help her. This wasn't going to be like when Entrapta was up on charges for her actions, and Mermista had went off-script to help Catra and Angella protect the woman. That was entirely out of friendship with Catra; Mermista really didn't know Entrapta all that well, though unlike Perfuma, she hadn't really suffered for the woman's defection either, Hordebots not being of much use on water.

Personally, Mermista felt an economic blockade of Dryl- maybe with some allowances for food, she didn't want anyone to starve- would have been perfectly fine, it would be both a fitting punishment for the woman whose betrayal had led to so much death among the Alliance *and* a way to ensure that she wasn't going to build a robot army and attack them all from a new front. Her elected leaders in the Seven Senates had come to the same

conclusions she had, though they'd had an economic reason to go with her moral and legal considerations. Dryl being blockaded kept Salineas as the preeminent source in the Alliance of tech and coffee and a few other goods, which was making their people quite a bit of silver.

Still, even in their greed, they'd opposed the invasion the Snows had espoused, as well as any blockade that did not allow for food. They were willing to let Dryl live in peace, and unwilling to let them starve, even if they were also willing to make a few extra silver off of them at the same time.

Those were Mermista's orders, and she'd been fine with that. Which was good, considering diplomacy explicitly wasn't her wheelhouse per the Constitution; Salineas sent her because the Princess Alliance afforded every Princess a vote, the other Runestone Kingdoms relying on them, and so it made the work simpler. She'd always been happy before to do as asked, to the point Salineas hadn't even bothered sending other people with her; she'd been entirely trustworthy up to that point.

But then Catra had surprised her by fighting for Dryl and Entrapta- due to a promise made to *Hordak,* of all fucking people- and... well.

Mermista had a lot of friends, but Catra was probably her *best* friend outside of Sea Hawk, who was her boyfriend and didn't count; so she'd decided to back her up, without question and in defiance of orders.

She'd caught all hell for it back home- and even been the subject of a rather rude meme that she was the third Princess of Brightmoon, following Glimmer and Catra- but the deed was done, and beyond some irritated eye-rolling, the furor had died down. She was still immensely popular, after all, and one mistake did not years of glory unmake.

(But it would have been worth it if it had. She'd backed up her best friend on something that had *mattered*, and the memory of Catra's firm handshake and warm smile had been payment enough, payment in full and then some. She'd do it all over again with no regrets.)

All of which explained why Sea Falcon was here, now, instead of annoying Huntara and Tung Lashor in the rapidly-changing Crimson Waste. Those negotiations had basically hit a stalling-point anyway while Huntara and Tung Lashor dealt with some interal matter- something about water? They'd been building a drill, and wanted to know about groundwater- Huntara had actually written Mermista, asking about underground springs, with some drawings from her own personal journal, and Mermista had replied with what she knew, while directing her to *actual* experts who might know what she was asking.

(She *had* been amused by Huntara declaring herself the Princess of the Crimson Waste, though, and including an exceptionally funny- and surprisingly well-done, seriously, Huntara was quite the artist- doodle of herself as the She-Ra, towering over everyone else; the wastelander had apparently decided that if the Sword could make Catra as tall as she was, it would turn Huntara into a literal giant.)

So Sea Falcon was here to ride herd on Mermista. Usually the Water Princess liked her boyfriend's dad- actually she liked all of his family, which was good since his moms worked for her as

admirals- but she'd be lying if she said she didn't resent his presence here and now.

Which was a bit unfair, since to be perfectly honest with herself- a thing her mind soother had always encouraged, and which she agreed with- he probably *should* be here. Salineas' democracy was not invincible, and Princesses were terrifyingly powerful; she couldn't blame anyone in the Seven Senates who might think that maybe Mermista was getting a little *too* independent. That was how the Fifth and Tenth Republics had fallen, after all, when a Princess had decided that Salineas didn't *need* to be a Runestone Republic anymore, and had tried to make a Kingdom out of it.

(And inspired a *billion* terrible alternate history novels where they succeeded, but that was neither here nor there... though Mermista *was* pretty fond of the *Turtledove* series, that one was actually alright.)

Mermista wasn't Princess Ursula or Princess Lapis, of course. She had no desire to take over and make the sole Runestone Republic into a Kingdom... buuuuuut she couldn't really blame the Salt Senate for deciding not to risk it. They didn't know what was going on in her head, after all, didn't know if this was just the opening act in a Princess going rogue or the one-off event it actually was. She really couldn't blame them for trying to put an early damper on her one-woman takeover of Salinean foreign policy, just in case doing so now might put the brakes on Mermista becoming a danger to the very Republic she was sworn to protect.

Well, she *shouldn't,* but she totally *could*, and indulged in it a little bit as she dried off- which was easy when you could just order water to get off of you- and dressed. Something military themed,

rather than fancy; that was her real role, after all. A weapon for Salineas, as well as the judge of last resort, the tiebreaker... not the diplomat.

I'm sorry, Catra, she thought bitterly as she considered a few outfits. She really *couldn't* help her friend now; it was out of her hands, unless she wanted to deal with both real trouble back home, and *actually* take over foreign policy... and she had too much respect for her people's institutions to do that.

Not like they're wrong that Adora's a threat... I've been punched enough times by her, or run over with that stupid fucking shield, to know that much. At least they agreed to just abstain from the vote, instead of being for it.

That was as far as they'd been willing to bend; they wouldn't vote to *not* go kill Adora, but they'd at least abstain. Catra had been vital to Salineas in so many ways, especially early on; some of the analysts in Salineas' navy that Mermista worked with had stated that, without the She-Ra, they were pretty sure Salineas would have *lost*. Catra's presence early on- from the Sea Gate onward- had led to a snowball effect; it had given Salineas enough breathing room to prepare, to launch new assaults, and to use those victories to build other victories, with Catra's occasional presence tipping the scales in her people's favor when things were close.

And things *had* been close. The enemy had been their equal, for the enemy had been their own, once: Admiral Octavia. She'd been one of Salineas' best before she left, hearing the call Hordak put out for someone to run his navy and seizing her moment. Pure lust for power, that defection; Octavia hadn't even had any real

grievances, she'd just wanted more power, as she'd cheerfully explained in an oddly friendly and rather frank letter that she'd sent the day of her defection to her superior, with copies made and sent to others.

The letters had also been covered in a contact toxin, the literal poison-pen letters claiming three rear admirals and a vice-admiral. No one had suspected her defection until she had already burned all her bridges- Octavia had been a model sailor, they weren't even aware she'd been paying attention to the Horde, and they'd paid for the blindness with corpses. The poison was a new thing, very nasty, made up of industrial byproducts; clever and quick and cruel all three. Octavia'd never had a head for poisons, but apparently one of her new Horde friends did, and that single act alone had thrown Salineas' entire military into directionless chaos for a good month.

Mermista had been directionless, too, until she turned to the Pearl Logbook, and proven its existence wise. Catra had bought her time to flip through it, to absorb the wisdom of her forebears, and in that breathing room she'd realized that a single sentiment had been carried down to her by over nine hundred years of warfare. Her predecessors had different ways of saying it, of course, even when you translated the old trade languages called, collectively, Waverider Tongues into the more modern Etherian, but they'd all repeated the same message, had sang the same shanty with their thousand mouths.

Princess Rouge, in her typical, wisely-foolish fashion, had stated *you win if you have the most stuff the fastest- quantity has a quality all its own!* Princess Knight had, in her typical, foolishly-wise fashion, dressed up the exact same point by stating *while the study of military maneuvers has its place, the superior course of*

study involves looking at production, transport, and execution of those goods most basic to the functioning of any military, to whit: food, material- including but not limited to ammunition, fuel, and extra supplies to replace anything lost- and troops.

Prince Kisame had expressed it in the simplest, clearest way, as was that honest sharkman's nature, and put it in the words that Mermista had liked best: *Decent generals study tactics, good generals study strategy, but truly great generals study* ***logistics****.*

In obedience to that wisdom, Mermista had made her big plan. She'd talked with the senior officials, worked closely with those older and wiser, and with their aid, crafted a plan to have the navy under her command focus entirely on production- and *sensible* production at that. She'd shut down numerous proposals for wonder weapons and radical deviations from old designs; had Salineas' position been better, or there'd been more time, she'd have entertained those ideas, but the rough start meant they didn't have the luxury of hoping new things worked. They had to get proven designs out *fast*.

So she'd put the scientists and engineers to work not on making something new, but instead on improving something old. Time-tested ship designs were made with new materials, their construction tweaked with any lessons learned since their original creation, upgrading the past to compete with the present. The weapons, too, were made that way- not the best weapons they could make, nothing bleeding edge, but weapons that were *good enough,* because the best weapons took too much time*.* Ammunition was standardized, every weapon conformed so that every box of ammo would work for every one of them, all done so that no effort was wasted.

To helm the new vessels, she'd asked the Seven Senates to hold a recruitment drive, and they'd delivered beyond her wildest expectations. The Senates had spun up a recruitment drive bigger than anything any Republic had ever seen before, ringing a cry of alarm on every shore of Etheria, from the well-traveled lands of the eastern coast to the distant islands that only Salineas had ever settled, and the people had surged in. From every distant shore in all of Etheria's endless ocean had come her new military, an almost literal tsunami of volunteers arriving every day in the capital to command the rising tide of ships and steel, every one of them a volunteer.

(Perhaps Mermista's favorite thing about her people- another part of the Constitution that had never changed, the law against conscription. There were no unwilling souls in the army of the sea. It helped her sleep at night; every soul who died under her watch was a tragedy, but every soul had *also* chosen to be there, and it helped, it eased the ache in her heart. Everyone involved had a *choice,* and it was not Mermista's will alone that had led them to their deaths; she was no tyrant, and they were no slaves, and it made the bad dreams bearable.)

And while Salineas was ramping up production, Mermista stayed busy by going forth to ruin the Horde's own logistics. Admiral Octavia had pressed hard, especially early on, and had Mermista been by herself, or just with Sea Hawk, she was sure she would have lost; but she had not been alone. The Best Friend Squad had joined her, temporarily upgrading to the Best Friend Squad Plus at Sea Hawk's suggestion, a name that Bow, Glimmer, and Sea Hawk had adored, and that Mermista and Catra had both resolutely refused to say.

Catra had expected Mermista to lead her against the capital ships of the Horde's fleets, but that wouldn't have availed Mermista of much; the Horde could outproduce Salineas, even with her new strategies, so that would have only delayed the inevitable. But the quintent were a five person spec-ops squad made up of the most powerful woman on the planet, a saltwater witch, five foot of glitter and fists, a tech master, and the world's only seafaring pyromaniac, and that was sufficient to do something else- to target vulnerable points in the supply network of the Horde.

They'd picked their targets carefully. Rosewood, the former Plumerian port that was now the heart of the Horde's navy, had been untouchable even for such a squad... but there were other places less well defended, temporary shelters constructed on empty patches of beach or small islands of the Sea of Sighs, drydocks and safe harbors for resupply, all of which could be ruined by a small group of very, very powerful warriors. Even better were the supply ships carrying valuable goods to Horde fleets, or transporting needed resources for the Horde effort in Plumeria and Brightmoon, vital blood vessels for the great kraken of the Horde's navy.

They targeted them all with the same simple, effective plan. Glimmer, Catra, and Bow would teleport aboard those ships or harbors like a living bomb, devastating the crews while Mermista and Sea Hawk ravaged any escorts from the waves before joining them. They stole anything of value that they could carry, and ruined what they could not, burning the harbors (to Sea Hawk's delight) or scuttling the ships (which also delighted him, because Sea Hawk was a simple man.) From time to time, they stole a new boat if Sea Hawk had burned their last one, but that was about the only variation the plan had ever needed.

It was hard work, for all that. Octavia had been terribly competent; even at the beginning, when she could have well been justified to believe the war well in hand, she'd still bothered to defend her supply ships and resupply points. The first fight had almost ended with the Best Friend Squad Plus slain when a semi-ruined destroyer had turned out to be rather less dead in the water than they'd thought, and turned titanic guns on them; only some quick thinking by Glimmer had teleported them out, and she'd almost killed herself doing it.

All of the first few fights were like that, and the next were even worse, as a few months passed and Octavia realized what they were doing. She reoriented entire fleets to stop them, temporarily halting her eastward expansion to seek out the little parasites biting her in the flank, knowing that without resupply, she could conquer nothing.

But Mermista had read the Logbook, and knew that smart commanders would defend their supply lines... so this, too, had been considered by her when making her plan. By great good luck, the first of Salineas' new navies was ready when Octavia began to wheel about and face the Squad; using long-distance trackerpads that Bow had made and Glimmer had delivered, Mermista was able to order them to set sail. From her flagship, the *Sea Harpy,* venerable Admiral Hunga had led them, and turned her ferociously ugly countenance west just as Octavia finished wheeling about to face the Squad; and so when the two fleets met, Octavia was attacked on the flank that had been her front but a few weeks before, and caught completely unawares. Mermista's plan had worked beyond all expectation; the upgraded old designs had proven capable of waging the new war, and Octavia's surprise led Hunga achieve her first victory at the Battle of Unicorn Island, the biggest upset of the war.

While Octavia was busy trying to salvage that fight, the Best Friend Squad Plus had simply kept up the assault, sinking even more supply ships whose escorts had been pulled away to face the new threat of Admiral Hunga.

That was the start of the end; Octavia was caught, her tentacles hooked on both ends, her navy pulled apart in two directions. To her credit, she'd still given them one hell of a fight. For all that she was a Hordesman now, Octavia had a truly Salinean gift for water warfare. If she'd had her supplies, if she'd not been slowly bleeding to death from a thousand small cuts, if she hadn't been fighting on two fronts... she might well have won.

But she *didn't* have her supplies, and she *had* been bleeding to death from a thousand small cuts, and she *was* fighting on two fronts. She went down fighting... but down she went. Each battle was a little easier, as the strained supply chain finally began to collapse; running low on everything, the Horde fleets began to simply disintegrate from the sheer pressure. Ships ran out of ammo mid-battle, or ran out of fuel and never made it to battle at all; other vessels fell apart to blows they should have withstood, their repairs so shoddy they couldn't hold up to enemy fire, or even simply sank into the sea, their barely-patched hulls unable to keep them afloat any longer.

As the material sank, so too did the morale. It was nothing like the mass desertions that plagued the Horde's land army, which occurred only when Hordak died, three and a half years after Catra became the She-Ra; but there were deserters in Catra's second year at the job, all captains unwilling to get their crews killed in fights they could not win. Not many, but the number went up as time went on, and Salineas welcomed them eagerly. The enemy sailors were given any quarter asked for, in return for any

intelligence they might have, a decision Hunga had made out of pure practicality; the mere knowledge that they *could* surrender had led many Horde crews to give up, rather than fight to the death, sparing Mermista's people who would have died fighting them in turn. They were taken to Salineas to process any intelligence they had before being let free to do as they would, and the boats themselves were cannibalized to repair Salineas' own vessels, though admittedly few had much of worth on them by the time they surrendered.

As the tide turned, opportunists among the Crownless jumped in; Seaworthy's fancy, bloodthirsty elite and Octopus Cove's rough brigands both had smelled blood in the water, and individually decided to get their share of the meat. To the hammerhead shark packs of Mermista's military were added the beautiful anglerfish of Seaworthy privateers in all their snobbish glory and the formidable barracudas of Cove pirates in all their honest savagery, joining in as the war turned against the Horde.

Seaworthy's folk flew their golden anchor on a blue standard from above over-engineered vessels that were twice as good as any Salinean vessel, and cost ten times as much; the more numerous vessels of the Cove flew a multitude of tattered rags with many symbols on them above their ramshackle hulls, united only in their coloration, all being white symbols on deep red standards. Old colors, and *first* colors, for the Cove, the white falcon on red the symbol of Etherian piracy ever since the first Falcon had flown it from her ship over two centuries ago, a tribute to her father's white hair and her own brilliant red pigtails. She had flown that flag when she pillaged, and she'd flown that flag when she led the Cove to victory over Salineas, earning her people their independence, and ensuring her name would live forever, passed down from pirate to pirate, an eternal legacy for the first Crownless to ever force a Runestone Kingdom to its knees.

(Galacia was not the first Crownless nation to defeat a Runestone Kingdom; two centuries and some years before, a ragtag collection of bastards, outcasts, and vagabonds on the southern coast had done the impossible first. Maybe that was why the two nations liked each other so much nowadays; Mermista had even heard they'd sent Galacia a fruit basket after the Selkies drove the Snows back.)

But regardless of their flags, they had cheerfully pitted themselves against the black-and-red of the Horde, and allied with Salinean seagreen; the scavengers of the sea had swooped in to plunder and pillage, attacking the enemy before cheerfully waving at Salinean ships as they looted the resulting wrecks. Mermista had ordered her troops to let them have at it; another old wisdom was that the enemy of your enemy could well be your friend, and while both groups would no doubt go back to robbing Salineas when the war was over, for now they were all moving in cheerful harmony. Sea Hawk had even reconnected with some old friends/sworn enemies by mutually plundering some Horde destroyers with them, and made some new friends/future archnemeses at the same time.

Between all these factors, eventually the Horde was pushed all the way back to its own coast, and only by concentrating all that she had left could Octavia even keep delivering goods in her own home waters. The Sea of Sighs was, once more, Salinean territory, her people free to sail as they would. *No nation truly rules the waves, but Salineas rents*- an old boast, and true once more.

Catra had thought it was amazing how the whole plan clicked together, and laughed when she'd pointed out how confused she'd been, early on in Mermista's plan. The Princess of Power had told the mermaid that it wasn't something Catra herself could have

come up with; she was no grand strategist. Catra had even said that she'd probably have overextended her forces on a gamble if she'd been in charge, though Mermista privately liked to believe that Catra was better than she thought she was at warfare.

Thinking of her friend- and of how she was going to have to sit idly by now, while she was hurt- Mermista settled on something. A military uniform, but in the bleached white of dead coral, the traditional colors of Salinean mourning.

Fitting; she was going to regret what happened today, it was going to hurt her, to see her best friend suffer. That campaign with the others had been the best days of of Mermista's life- the rush of battle, the cheerful presence of good friends, the simple realization that her plan had *worked*, that all she'd done had paid off. The Horde was pushed back, and she had fulfilled the one duty most sacred to a Princess- she had defended her people from those who would hurt them.

(She would never forget the moment they'd linked up with Admiral Hunga, Catra encouraging her to make a show of it, to appear before her soldiers, and that was the best advice her best friend had ever given her; they had held a ceremony at high noon, and every ship in the navy had been there, the decks all lined with her people, cheering and shouting and pumping their fists as their conquering heroine stepped onto the *Sea Harpy* to unite their forces once more. The moment had been perfect, and she knew that until the day she died, she would believe that the nameless sea gods had sent that idea to Catra, that it had been the way the great mysteries her people worshiped had chosen to let Mermista know she was worthy of being a Princess. There on the deck of that ship, with that sound of her people's happiness ringing in her ears, the unknown deities of the sea had used her people's reaction to kindly hold a mirror up to Mermista, so she could see herself as she really was; and some small, niggling

doubt in her heart had finally went quiet, some tiny piece of her she'd never even known she had, one part that had never entirely believed she was worthy of her ascension, and even as she realized it was there, it had died the final death and disappeared at last.)

After that, there had just been the mopping up, as generals and janitors both said. Now Salineas' navy mostly just made routine patrols to make sure Octavia didn't get any bright ideas- well, that and assist Crystal Falls once it finally got cut off from the rest of Brightmoon. The lunar Kingdom's sole port was now separated from its nation, since Adora's blitzkrieg assault with her fiery fanatics had taken over the surrounding land; an army led by Grizzlor was busily trying to burn its way inside, laying siege to the city. The city's defense was led by General Talzy, who was one of Brightmoon's best, second only to General Juliet in her strategic brilliance... but she was in desperate need of supplies.

Luckily, Salineas now had a lot of ships that weren't doing anything much in particular, and the wartime production had met they had a lot of supplies to give; with the Sea of Sighs safe for supply runs, they'd spent the last few months merrily supporting Crystal Falls. Quite appropriate, really, for a city so threatened with fire to be supported from the sea, and it had worked; Brightmoon's pink crescent on purple standard still flew over the city.

Mermista had even had time to come up with some plans to evacuate it should things go catastrophically wrong; hopefully it wouldn't come to that, since the cost would be astronomical to Salineas when it came to housing and feeding them... but they could do it, and Mermista would give the order if it came to that.

That was a Princess at their best, after all; someone who used their tremendous power to do good.

As Princess Rouge had put it, *If you're not helping, why are you a Princess in the first place?* More of that good woman's simple wisdom, and not for the first time, Mermista wondered how different Salineas would be if she had not been assassinated, if she'd been able to make her reforms a reality. Octopus Cove and Seaworthy would still be Salinean cities, if nothing else, instead of Crownless nations.

(Now *that* was an alternate history novel Mermista wanted to read!)

She stepped out of the large walk-in closet, already dreading the day. It was time to be up and about... but she needed cheering up, first. Take your sugar before your salt, more old Salinean wisdom; you always got salt, but you never knew if you'd have sugar again, so eat up while you could.

Maybe some eye candy would be nice... Sea Hawk should be up exercising at this time, maybe she'd go watch him for a bit. She liked her dudes slim but with some tone, which was how Sea Hawk had first caught her eye- he'd been doing one of his shanties at the docks, trying to get hired onto a ship, and she'd been passing by. She'd watched his little stunts, impressed, and he'd noticed- and then treated her like she was just a normal person, a thing she'd been secretly terribly pleased by. Blinded by her power or seeking a favor from her, Sea Hawk was not... and that meant she trusted him when he'd said he thought she was beautiful, and asked her out. She'd agreed, to her own surprise, and when they talked at dinner a few days later, she'd found something terribly fascinating in the man's relentless confidence

and the sheer fire of his spirit, the endless and unconquerable thing inside him that shone like a light without end.

(Mermista and Catra had much in common, and this was another: they both loved bright and brilliant children of the sun, those whose souls blazed with purpose, a thing Sea Hawk and Adora both shared despite being different in every other way.)

Of course, then she'd met his parents- for the second time, in Admiral Hunga and her wife Lohni's case- and it had *not* hurt to know from meeting his dad that Sea Hawk would age like goddamn fine wine. Seriously, Sea Falcon was getting *hotter* as he got older, which just seemed wrong. Both of Sea Hawk's moms had mutually bitched about that, irritated that they got old and ugly while their shared husband's handsome face just got better... it was all kind of overblown in Mermista's opinion. Sure, Admiral Hunga's face was doing this thing where it kind of looked like it was slowly curdling in on itself, but she'd always been ugly as hell, that wasn't age alone doing that. Lohni was just getting a bit chubby, she was kind of cute like that.

(Mermista had laughed inside a little every time Catra mentioned the Hordesman Lonnie; the names weren't quite pronounced the same way, but it was close enough that Mermista saw the woman who would probably be one of her future mothers in law every time she heard it, and had to fight not to laugh out loud.)

Decision made, she left her quarters to walk down to Sea Hawk's room. They didn't share a bedroom, mostly because they both liked a bit of privacy at night; just another way in which they clicked really well, a thing Mermista was deeply grateful for. She'd seen the trouble Catra had with her own love life, and honestly it just made her really grateful for Sea Hawk; honestly it had probably forestalled a fight or two, just realizing how *lucky* she

was, that the one she loved wanted her back, and that they were so compatible, no great wars or divisions separating them.

(It was why Mermista wasn't envious that, while Catra was *her* best friend, Mermista herself *wasn't* Catra's best friend; that would be either Bow or Glimmer, depending on whether sisters counted or not. In return for a lesser friendship, Mermista had the easier love life, and that felt like a good bargain.)

She knocked on his door three times, fairly loudly; if he was humming to himself, he'd never hear her otherwise.

" Come in~!" he sang, and she stepped into his room, which was a spacious area decorated much like her watery bedroom, though he lacked such a feature. There was a normal bed set in the back, a small table near it, and a closet- and a large open space in the middle, which Sea Hawk was using to practice his swordsmanship. He was stripped to the waist, sweating lightly, fencing with his golden blade, a piece of First Ones tech that he'd scavenged from an old ruin where it had been buried up to the hilt in a stone for some reason. A good sword, well balanced and sharp, though Bow apparently thought it had used to be a *scanning device* of all things... and Bow was usually right, so that made Mermista wonder what the hell it was supposed to measure.

Still, regardless of its former job, it was now providing grand service as a stabbing implement. So much First Ones tech was used in ways its creators had never intended, or probably even envisioned.

" Ah, darling!" he said, practicing a few quick strikes, moving with speed and precision. " What can I do for you this awful morning?"

He kept going as he spoke, practicing as he did every day, come rain or shine. Really, Sea Hawk was a hell of a swordsman, and honestly a bit of a badass; it was hard to notice because he hung out with *Princesses* regularly, but that by itself said a lot about the man. Not many people could hang with the strongest warriors of the Princess Alliance, and fewer could do so regularly... and only Sea Hawk did it with basically nothing to his name. Of the non-Princesses who stood with them, all had something more than Sea Hawk did: Bow had his incredible genius with tech to go along with his masterful archery, Castaspella was a great sorceress, and even the new recruit Flutterina had her abnormal speed and that huge backpack full of usefulness... but Mermista's boyfriend fought at hteir side with nothing more than swordplay and an advanced case of pyromania.

...That, and some *gorgeous* arms, Mermista lost herself in them for a second or two, just eating up those glistening biceps.

" I... yeah, it *is* an awful morning, isn't it?" Mermista said after the moment was up. " I just came by to watch, to be honest. Felt like some sugar before the salt."

" Then watch to your heart's content, my love," he said, and moved in silence, letting her just absorb his beauty, a task she set to eagerly.

Towards the end, as he was about done, another knock came on the door, though it was just one very enthusiastic knock compared to her three.

“ Hey son! Got an update for you- apparently the meeting's been set back!”

“ Oh?” Sea Hawk said. “ Come on in, dad! It's just me and Mermista in here.”

“ Ah, future daughter with current son! Good, that makes this much more efficient,” Sea Falcon said, as he entered the room the way he entered every room- dramatically. His silver mustache twitched as he gave them all a winning smile, which were the only kind he knew how to make- as he would be the first, second, and last to tell you. Meeting Sea Falcon had answered questions about Sea Hawk Mermista hadn't even known she'd had. “ Ah, I see you're showing off! Good, continue seducing the Princess, son.”

“ I shall do so, father!” Sea Hawk replied, saluting the man.

“ He's not seduced me,” protested Mermista, more out of sheer habit than anything else; her eyes didn't even stray from Sea Hawk's body as her mouth ran on. As she didn't believe what she'd just said any more than anyone else in the room did, the thoroughly-seduced woman just kept going. “ At any rate, you said the meeting was held back?”

“ Yes!” Falcon said. “ There was apparently an attempt to hack the tech in Brightmoon Castle last night. Angella's delaying the meeting a few hours to make sure there are no security issues

remaining. If she finds them, she might even cancel, or so her message said.”

Oh. That would be... wonderful, actually! It wouldn't *stop* what was coming, but a delay... well, all kinds of things could happen in the next few days. Maybe her friend would get a reprieve yet!

“ Good,” Mermista said. “ Let's hope they find something.”

“ Oh, that would make Netossa furious, I imagine!” Sea Hawk said, and his father laughed.

“ It would! Especially given how much time and effort she's put into bringing this particular crew together for this specific meeting. Canceling it would be quite the blow to her plans- not fatal, but it'd hurt! And the Cove would deserve it, if nothing else. They didn't even send the current Falcon, it's Scurvy and Squall they sent! Back when *I* was the Falcon, I'd have demanded to go myself.”

“ Aren't you... *still* Falcon?” Mermista asked, as Sea Hawk grimaced at the mention of Scurvy and Squall.

“ No, we went over this,” he said with a grin. “ I changed my name when I left O.C. to marry Hunga and Lohni; I gave the title of Falcon back to the city. I'm *Sea* Falcon, it's totally different- and I'm a Salinean now, I don't count anyway.”

“ Okay,” Mermista said, in the same disbelieving tone she'd given him the first time he tried to explain how it was *totally different*. It still felt weird to her.

(Well, it was *weirder* that Sea Hawk had fucked the current Falcon, given his dad's name- though in his defense, the man hadn't become the Falcon until *after* Sea Hawk had given him a welcoming rouse.)

“ I do hope neither of those two bear grudges,” Sea Hawk muttered. Mermista smirked.

“ Didn't you tell me you owe Scurvy a boat?” she needled her boyfriend. “ And something about how you stole Squall's eyepatch after she broke up with you?”

“ Not at all!” Sea Hawk said, scandalized. “ I would never steal a lady's eyepatch. I stole her purse. It was quite loaded, too! Enough to get me a new boat. Which I... may or may not have set afire while it was at the docks, and the chain reaction may or may not- eyewitnesses disagreed- have burned Scurvy's boat down. An honest accident! I hadn't meant to set that boat on fire at *that* point in time. But you burn down a dozen or so boats while ramming them into your enemies and nobody ever believes you've set an accidental fire ever again.”

He drooped where he stood, the picture of sorrow, and Mermista gently leaned into him, smelled the good clean smell of sweat and exertion coming off of his lovely skin, felt the taut muscle

underneath as it pressed into her own muscle, both with the bodies of warriors.

" I believe you," she said. " You've never set a fire you weren't proud of, so you'd admit it if it was yours."

" Ah, you see me truly, my seashell darling," he replied, leaning into her in turn and gazing into her eyes with his own adoring orbs. " My love, my sweet, my perfect seaqueen-"

He went for a kiss that Mermista dodged, partly because it amused her, partly because his dad was still in the room and, unlike either Falcon or Sea Hawk, Mermista still possessed a working sense of shame.

" Uh uh," she said as she turned back to Falcon. " All business now. When's the meeting been delayed to?"

Sea Hawk frowned dramatically and gave her magnificent puppy-dog eyes as his father laughed.

" You goofy kids," the older man summarized. " Anyway, the new time is at four. I'm going to go and get me some good old Brightmoon breakfast; I haven't had proper fluffy pancakes since Hunga and Lohni kidnapped me from the sea so we could have our wonderful children, I been missing them something fierce. Was a donut shop right next to my old home in the Cove, they actually ordered Brightmoon syrup, gave me a taste for it- nobody

but Brightmoon makes the syrup right, that stuff's so sweet and thick a spoon could stand up in it, it's amazing. I don't know why they bother with coffee up here, they must all be in a perpetual sugar rush."

Pancakes... *did* sound pretty damn good. Shit, maybe Mermista really *was* the Third Princess of Brightmoon, she kind of wanted a stack of those over-sweet treats.

" That... sounds like a plan," Mermista said.

" Then off to adventure!... and breakfast!" Sea Hawk said, and the trio set off to find some grub.

(And inside, Mermista privately hoped the meeting would be canceled, for Catra's sake.)

Chapter End Notes

> The Turtledove series is my tribute to Harry Turtledove, the most famous and one of the most prolific Alternate Universe writers. He did a lot to popularize the very concept, and as someone who primarily writes Alternate Universe Aus, I am, in some way, indebted to the man, and offer this tribute as payment of that debt.
>
> Salineas has public schooling. Basic education- roughly equivalent of elementary to freshman in high school- is called Shallows, as the idea is that it is meant to give a broad overview and some general information that's useful to literally everyone.
>
> After that, most people opt for three-year technical schools called the Deeps that focus on a single trade- medical school

is a Deeps degree, as an example. For military, political and legal work, however, there are the four-year Abyssals, since it is believed in Salineas that those require a good general knowledge of everything, rather than the more specialized knowledge required of other trades. School is paid for by the government, but only if you maintain high grades. Angella actually based Brightmoon's own state education system on Salineas', albeit using Mystacor terms like university instead of the more Salinean words, since she borrowed a few concepts from them, too.

I based some- not all, but some- of Salinean cuisine on the food of Kerala, an area of the Indian Subcontinent that comprises much of southern India's west coast, and has a long history of maritime trade. Different areas of Salineas have different "local" cuisine takes on the general food trends, of course; Mermista is from the capital- which is also called Salineas- and the "local cuisine" of the capital is based on the specific town of Thalassery in Kerala, which, given the name alone, I pretty much had to use. It's also a very diverse maritime culture province, so it fits that way, too!

Biryani is a mixed rice dish- the version with green mussels that Mermista had is popular in the real-world city of Thalassery- and falooda is an Indian dessert starring ice cream, which fits well with what we already know of Mermista. Mermista's actually unusual taste-bud wise for a Salinean; she's got a bit of a sweet tooth on her. Some in Salineas have even joked that her friendship with Catra is predicated entirely on her love of Brightmoon food, which on the whole is too bland and too sweet for most Salineans.

Salinean food taboos are more like superstitions; it's not considered that taboo to break them, though it is considered bad luck, a bit like walking under a ladder. Salineans have a vague idea that eating too much meat from a land-dwelling creature robs you of your ability to sail the seas, or at the very least, pisses off the seagods; birds are better, especially seabirds, but it's still best to stick to fish. Saltwater fish are

best, but freshwater fish are perfectly acceptable to all but the most absurdly traditional Salineans, and anyone rejecting freshwater fish is more likely to be mocked as a coward than to be admired for their strict adherence. Given the choice, Salineans will prefer ocean fish, but aren't hung up on it.

Seals and other animals that spend a lot of time in water and on land both are in a weird place here; where a Salinean personally puts one of these semi-amphibians on the "water food or land food" scale varies a lot. Fun fact, the Salinean ground assault forces, properly called the Salinean Land Defense Force, have a toad on their badges as a reference to being a primarily aquatic force fighting on land.
(Less sympathetic folks have compared them to a beached whale, which is not entirely undeserved given Salineas' terrible record on land.)

It is also, as she notes, bad luck to eat anything that looks like you, even vaguely. Crab people will not eat crustaceans of any stripe, much less crabs. Very polite people will also often dodge eating anything that resembles any present friends, too, since it's considered somewhat rude to, say, start chomping down on a salmon when your best friend is a salmon-looking Sea Elf, though this isn't nearly as taboo as eating something that looks like you. Good friends can ignore this.

Salinean faith is in the nameless sea-gods, since they believe that something as big as a god would not need something as small as a name. Salineans aren't a religious people- to give you an idea, Mermista's thoughts here would mark her out as *very* religious for a Salinean- and mostly reserve god-bothering for funerals and desperate situations. It's thought that to beg for answers or to think you have them is to miss the point- the gods want you to search and explore on your own.

Chapter 37: Frosta of the Snows

Chapter Notes

So.

I'm uploading one chapter a day until the War Council is finished. We start with Frosta of the Snows and will end with Spinnerella of the Great Rebellion. I will also be editing the last two chapters to remove the "War Council" references there, since the proper War Council needs to have its own chapter name.

I said the War Council would be next chapter, but things are too big for that; but this catches me up. You will see the War Council soon.

See you tomorrow.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FROSTA OF THE SNOWS

In Brightmoon, a Princess of the Snows sat at breakfast with her trusted advisors.

" Is there anything you need before the meeting, Princess Frosta?" Bron asked.

" No," she said, leaning forward in her chair to grab some more food. When she leaned back, she shifted a bit, not entirely fine with the furniture; her chair was uncomfortable because it was *too* comfortable, too soft, you could sleep in the damn thing, and it was throwing her off.

At least they'd removed *most* of the padding, out of deference to the Snows' less pampered lifestyle; honestly that was kind of a theme at the Snows' diplomatic housing at Brightmoon Castle, the removal of a lot of Brightmoon's extra, uh, *extra* on everything. The building was a squat little bunker, nothing fancy, and inside was decorated in a spartan way for Brightmoon, more like the clean lines and solid colors of the Snows, albeit still a *little* too colorful. Not that the Snows *didn't* decorate its stuff, but Frosta's people reserved it, you know? If your day to day life wasn't kinda ugly, you'd get inured to beauty, wouldn't be able to appreciate it as much when it showed up.

That's what the priests said, anyway, and Frosta, as Princess of the Snows, was the Church's defender, so she always tried to listen to the priests. In her rotating circle of guardians since her parents died, priests had been pretty common, and they'd all agreed on the basics. There was a time and place for pretty, you didn't just slap art on *everything,* that was both a waste of damn time and kind of an insult to the Distant God.

Seriously, Frosta had seen a dude with a pipe earlier, smoking some Plumerian tobacco if her nose didn't miss its guess, and it had been carved to look like a dragon- why? Who the fuck did that with a *pipe?!?* You smoked with it, it wasn't an art piece! You were just begging the Distant God to slap your shit, acting like that.

So in deference to the Snows' superior culture, Brightmoon had restrained itself from its usual overwhelming desire to tart up everything they touched. The table Frosta sat at, and the plates she and her companions were eating off of, were even mostly plain, though apparently someone in Brightmoon had suffered a panic attack at the idea of leaving them *totally* bare and had added a single unnecessary splash of blue color to the middle of them. Frosta was willing to forgive that; for Brightmoon that was practically leaving it unadorned.

Of course, since they were having lunch, what was *on* those plates mattered a bit more to the youngest of all Princesses. A good spread, really- a mix of Snows food, and not made incompetently. Frosta grabbed a pelmeni off of one and popped it right into her mouth. Wasn't bad! Not hot enough- it barely had enough peppers to make her notice- but at least it was savory instead of sweet.

To another pelmeni, she added a slice of squeaky cheese, which worked well with the little bread pocket of meat and spice, worked wonderfully. It was even fresh! You'd think Angella would just have had some old squeaky cheese dried in a cabinet or something, that shit could be stored forever, but this was the fresh stuff, just made, if Frosta didn't miss her guess. It was the right season for it, with summer just getting started; the mammoths would have finished calving recently, which meant the milk was just what you needed. They called it beestings, that fresh colostrum from right after a mama mammoth gave birth.

... *Why do I know that?*

Frosta racked her brain for a second and came up totally empty.

I legitimately have no idea why I know that.

Eh, fuck it. Didn't have to know why she knew it to enjoy it! Though she didn't know that Brightmoon had access to mammoths... the northern parts of the country *did* border the Snows, maybe there was a mammoth farm or two up there, where it was cold enough for the shaggy beasts. Regardless of how it got here, this was some damn fine cheese.

She took another bite, the cheese fulfilling its name by squeaking gently as she bit into it. Good stuff!

The others apparently agreed with her, all but one digging into their shared meal. Sitting with her was Captain Bron, recently reinstated to his high military position after he'd led the Snows to disaster in Galacia, alongside a priest as a representative for the Church, her distant cousin Chilla. She knew both of them pretty well; Bron had kind of fallen off the court after the Galacia incident, but he'd managed to work his way back up, while Chilla had spent years climbing the Church ranks and had always lingered around the edges of Frosta's life in the Snows.

The last was some guy in a hooded cloak. She didn't know his name, but she thought she recognized him; guy was kind of noticeable, looked more or less human but had bright red skin, kind of like he'd been dipped in dye. Probably just some advisor or another, there were so many Frosta had never gotten a real

handle on their names, and it wasn't her job anyway; her handlers had all agreed that she needed

All of them- save the red guy- were eating in the large central dining room of the diplomatic building, having lunch, since the damn meeting had been pushed back. Apparently Brightmoon had gotten attacked in the night, something about tech getting hacked, which hadn't surprised Frosta. *This* was why the Church said you shouldn't bother with First Ones crap- okay, well, it wasn't, but this was a good practical reason to go with the moral one. The First Ones were dead... well, except Adora, and Frosta *still* wasn't sure Catra hadn't been tricked, no matter how convinced the She-Ra was.

But regardless, the First Ones were dead, and that meant their tech belonged with the dead. You found First Ones tech, you *buried* it, you let those people rest. The Snows wasn't against technology- not at all, the Church had whole research departments- but you had to earn your shit, not just steal it from the dead. It was... disrespectful.

And if Brightmoon had just listened to that wisdom, the meeting wouldn't be pushed back, and Frosta could have gotten on with the day's business, which was really what the youngest Princess wanted most.

" You seem irritated, cousin," Chilla said, icy breath puffing lightly in the air.

" Don't like the meeting getting pushed back," Frosta answered honestly, biting back her first retort, which was mostly just *don't call me cousin.*

Sure, Chilla *was* a cousin of hers, but she didn't know her- from the Luna family, she thought? The Luna were distant relatives of Frosta's mother, down the Mackenzie line, fifth or sixth at the absolute *closest* , and Chilla would be from farther back than even that. Not really family, at that point, and she'd only met her four years ago, when Chilla had suddenly changed her name to one a lot like Frosta's. A coattail rider, Frosta would bet her left foot, somebody hoping to use Frosta to climb the ranks- and it had worked, she was a Luna field-priest now. Pretty high up, did search and rescue and warfare both, which Frosta had to admit, earned her some begrudging respect... but she still didn't much like her distant cousin.

" I understand your impatience," Bron said as he scarfed down another pelmini himself. " But hey, at least it's time to prepare beforehand."

" I'm as prepared as anybody has ever been!" Frosta protested. " There's not much else to do. Support Netossa so we can go kill Adora and blow up the Horde, and don't mention our plans to go down there ourselves afterwards. It's not hard."

" No," Bron agreed pleasantly, " but a thing that isn't hard can still catch you by surprise..."

“ ...Yeah, I guess you'd know about that,” Frosta said, and Bron nodded. Yeah, given that he'd been the one who'd lead the Snows to disaster in the attempt to punish Galacia for breaking its oaths, Bron *would* know all about fucking up something easy.

She glanced at the third guy to see if he'd speak up, but he was simply taking a drink from his flask and eating his meager meal. He must be a holy man; a restrictive diet was like, the first thing a lot of them practiced, an easy way to prove endurance to the Distant God.

Well, a holy man, or someone wanting to impress Ms. Church over there, Frosta thought, grabbing some more grub. Sucked to be him; this was some pretty good food! Not spicy enough, but hey, you couldn't have everything.

And honestly, this *was* made in Brightmoon, it was a wonder it wasn't half sugar. She'd had some of Glimmer's provisions during one of the missions they'd managed to go on together, and the sheer sweetness... ugh, *gag* . Honestly Frosta had no idea how everyone in Brightmoon wasn't dead of diabetes by thirty. They even had sugary drinks! God-awful. How those people kept their teeth, Frosta would never know; Brightmoon must have some powerful-ass toothpaste.

Though honestly that just proved how much effort Queen Angella put into diplomacy. Between the food being designed for Snows tastes and the clear effort put into *not* gussying the place up, the diplomatic housing here at Brightmoon Castle was super nice! And given how many wars the Snows and Brightmoon had engaged in, it was kind of... surprising, really. The Snows and Brightmoon had always hated each other... Brightmoon was envious of the Snows'

strength, and always had been, her chancellors assured her. And the Snows held Brightmoon in contempt because it was barely a proper Runestone Kingdom, they said; just look at the extent to which they bowed down even to the Crownless! They humiliated themselves, prostrating before their lessers.

(*But didn't the Selkies beat us?* Frosta's brain said suddenly. *They're Crownless* ... no, Frosta wasn't going to unpack that right now.)

Angella herself had even been officially declared a demon by the Church, a status that Frosta was like... ninety percent sure she still had, actually. She hadn't heard anybody bring it up much the last three years, though, since the Snows was *much* more pissed at the Horde. They'd violated guest right, after all, by attacking at the Prom; the Snows was pretty serious about that kind of thing. Add the whole mess with Galacia going rogue on them, and the Snows had other stuff to focus on.

Which didn't mean that the Snows didn't hate Brightmoon, still. Frosta was kind of an odd woman out in the Snows because she *didn't* hate Brightmoon; hell, she thought Glimmer was the coolest person she'd ever met, honestly.

(*And maybe kind of cute, maybe if she was blonde* - nope. Frosta was *not* following through on that thought! She was a young lady of just-turned-fourteen and she wasn't gonna be thinking about that, she'd seen the trouble other people got into over love- just look at Catra, her ex kept trying to set her on fire!- and she wasn't dealing with that shit, puberty could just go fuck off! ...or at the very least it could make her fucking taller first, goddamn!)

Still, all that bad blood made Angella being a good host kind of more impressive, really. Being a good host was a big deal! The

Distant God didn't have a lot of truck with Etheria's day to day, but the world was the Distant God's house and they let everybody else live there; the least a person could do was be a good host in turn, since none of this was really anybody's. Angella going out of her way to be so nice to a nation that literally thought she was a demon was... good.

And we're going to go right back to fighting with them once all the new trouble's over with; am I gonna have to fight Glimmer?

...She didn't like thinking about that.

There was a lot of stuff like that. Things she didn't like thinking about. Lots of things, in her short life. She didn't like thinking about all the childhood she'd missed out on, she didn't like thinking about her parents, and she *really* didn't like thinking about fighting the other nations when all this was over.

But, thankfully, she'd found the best way to deal with it: think about something else.

" So... " she began. " Why *are* we keeping it a secret?"

Bron shot her a look as he finished a bite of his meal, and glanced at the red guy before answering.

" What do you mean?" Bron asked.

“ I'm just... I'm just saying, would anybody really object to our plan, though?” Frosta asked. Her advisors had told her what they thought the Snows should do, and she agreed with them, as she always did. And she was usually fine with that! She wasn't much in the habit of questioning orders. The few times she was younger that she'd tried to go against them, for whatever reason, people had gotten hurt or *died* , a thing she never forgot (probably because her advisors never stopped talking about it.) She'd learned her lesson.

But this time, she couldn't see why anyone at the meeting would object, and felt a need to voice that observation.

“ I do not think the other nations will want us to control the Black Garnet,” Bron said.

Frosta shrugged in response.

“ Somebody's gotta do *something* with the Black Garnet, and you can't move it, planet explodes.”

“ Technically, the world is rendered unsuitable for life, *then* explodes,” Chilla said, and that morbid thought was ignored by all present.

“ So what are we to do? *Somebody* has to take control of the Black Garnet,” Frosta continued. “ But who else is there? Plumeria can't keep hold of it, they can't even hold on to their own territory. Salineas won't go that far inland. Brightmoon's got enough power without giving them a *second* Runestone, we do that we might as well hand them all Etheria while we're at it. So... who's left? We're the only people willing and able to take it.”

These weren't explanations her advisors had given her- they didn't usually explain stuff to her, just told her what they were going to do, and what they needed her to do. But Frosta did a lot of independent reading; her life was busy, but not *that* busy, and if she wasn't out helping the Alliance she didn't really have much of a social life. Had to do *something* to pass the time.

(Probably why she knew that word, now that she thought about it.)

“ Mystacor's made a lot of noises about taking it,” Chilla said. “ But I don't think they've got the strength for it...”

“ Of course not, they're Crownless; big eyes, but small stomachs,” Bron said dismissively. “ They'd never be able to keep it out of other hands. They don't have the standing forces for it.”

“ What are they gonna do, just like... drive their city over there?” Frosta asked, and Chilla shrugged.

“ I think the plan was a teleporter, cousin,” Chilla said with a frozen hiss, slightly clipping the words with her accent. Frosta bit

back an insult about Chilla's thick accent, and not just for politeness' sake. Really, being a dick to Chilla over her accent would just be low, and Frosta herself probably had an accent too. It wasn't like any of them spoke the same first language, they were all using Mountainflower; the only consistent tongue the Snows' many peoples shared was a written one, Soulspiral, which the Frozen Empress had carved into being.

Which was really impressive, for a bunch of reasons, including that the Frozen Empress had been so damn *busy*. Frosta had no idea when she'd had the time to invent a new writing system, given her busy schedule of banging her sister's husband, doting on that same sister with no sense of shame about cucking her, conquering Galacia, banging her *own* husband and doting on him with no sense of shame about cucking him, raising her albino war mammoth Olaf by hand, having babies from both fathers, riding Olaf into battle to crush the revolution that tried to erupt, beating up Salineas, beating up Mystacor, and engaging in her favorite hobbies of singing, ice sculptures and cold-blooded murder.

Really, Frosta thought she was pretty cool, to use a bad pun, but compared to that ancient predecessor? Frosta was living life at a snail's pace. Say what you would about the Frozen Empress- and most people did, especially from Salineas or Brightmoon- but the lady who named herself Stormrage could never be called *lazy*, that was for sure. Frosta wasn't sure she'd ever *slept*.

Well, she did a lot of sleeping *around*, to make another bad pun, but that was about it. Woman did so much, no wonder people spread the rumor that she'd survived that last battle with Angella and her crew, and had just rode off Olaf into the sunset, with her favorite boytoys in tow, leaving her sister to pick up the mess (which, to her credit, she'd done alright at.) Frosta kinda believed

it, mostly because it just seemed like her style, but hey, who knew?

I oughta ask Queen Angella... oh, wait, fuck, Frosta thought as she was drawn out of her thoughts. *Chilla was still talking. I... am gonna just pretend I was listening, yeah.*

" While I haven't done the math for it yet," she was hissing in her sibilant accent, " I have reason to suspect that the teleporter they wanted to set up would be suitable. A permanent link to the Garnet from Mystacor's current position, so they wouldn't have to cross the distance in-between in person."

" That doesn't sound sustainable," Frosta said after a minute, focusing on what she'd actually managed to hear of Chilla's words. " Have to be a hell of a big teleporter to get an army there, in case Horde holdouts attacked..."

Chilla nodded in approval.

" You've hit the nail on the head," she hissed.

" I agree," Bron said, and Frosta was glad to hear someone who didn't sound like a snake with a speech impediment. Bron was from the capital, like she was, spoke Buildsnow like she did, though he was using Mountainflower out of deference to Chilla and maybe the red guy. " They'd never manage it. Even assuming they had the troops- and I don't think they do- they couldn't move

them fast enough between the two locations, and that was assuming nobody sabotaged the teleporter.”

“ Okay, so Mystacor's out... and that leads me back to my first question,” Frosta replied. “ Why would anyone oppose us on this? You've all emphasized how we have to keep it quiet, but I don't really see why we can't just announce our plans.”

Bron and Chilla both shot quick glances at the nameless guy, but he didn't react, so Bron answered.

“ I imagine Brightmoon, at the very least, would oppose us conquering Darkspur to gain access to the westernmost shore,” Bron said. “ These bleeding-hearts would fall apart at the thought of us taking a Crownless nation, even one that's squatting on our land. We've been content to let Darkspur sit there, but now they need to pay up; that's the Snows' land. But it's not like we're going to slaughter them all; no, we're just going to retake the land. They'll all become Snows citizens. We need them to build our fleet anyway, so we can sail to the Fright Zone.”

“ On the western coast, where Salineas has no influence,” Frosta said, imagining the outline of it on a map in her head.

“ Salineas would also be angry with us, though more to stay in Brightmoon's good graces than any other reason, I imagine,” Chilla added.

" Brightmoon's non-interventionist, though," Frosta said. " They'd cut us off tradewise and maybe do some diplomatic stuff, but we're pretty self-sufficient, it wouldn't hurt too much. They won't attack unless we do so first. Not a big deal."

" And there's also the fact that we imagine the Rebels want that land," Chilla said, breath misting in the air again. Something to do with the magic she'd worked into herself, echoes of the Fractal Flake... while only a Princess could actively access the power of their Runestone, every one of the blessed Runestones passively shed energies throughout Etheria that a skilled sorcerer could tap into.

Chilla had not just worked those energies, she'd shoved them inside herself until her skin turned pale-blue and her body temperature dropped to near-freezing, her entire form mutating to accommodate the cold. Popular in the Snows now, a bit of a youth movement, which annoyed the older Chilla, who'd done it for religious reasons; the process kind of hurt like an all-body tattoo. Undergoing it without flinching was an easy way to prove how tough you were, which of course meant that Frosta's people loved it. The Church sort-of approved, which was more than it did for most new things these days.

Wonder if the red guy is like, infused with fire or something, Frosta wondered briefly as she gathered her thoughts to respond. *But the Fire Runestone's not a thing, which is good, they used to border us and that just sounds like a pain in the ass to fight. Fire is the perfect counter to the cold... and to most of us, honestly, Perfuma'd get her ass kicked by it worse than I would. Mermista would be alright, but that's it... I bet even Catra would have a right bitch of a time. Ain't many who like being set on fire... maybe Lord Adora and her fanatics, but that's it.*

“ Why would the Rebels want it?” Frosta said. “ I thought they just wanted to restore their... you know, the little nations that used to be down there. The Duchies, I think I read them called? They want those back. Or to just kill the Horde, but you'd have to do that either way, you know, potato, patato.”

Another glance at the red guy by the duo. Okay, what the fuck? That was starting to freak Frosta out.

(*Be careful, kid,* she remembered Mermista saying to her, once, in her ironically-dry tones. *A lot of people want to use a Princess for their own ends, and they'll be sneaky about it, like an undertow, not upfront.* Frosta had dismissed it at the time as just trying to coddle her for being the youngest- she knew that, she wasn't *stupid* - but maybe the Salinean had been onto something, maybe Frosta was closer to being buried in an avalanche then she suspected...)

He reacted this time, glancing to Chilla, who spoke.

“ It's not what the Rebels want,” Chilla said. “ It's what *Brightmoon* wants. You're right, Brightmoon can't just openly ask for the Black Garnet to be given to them, even Salineas and their Crownless lapdogs would turn on them for it. But the demon is close with Princesses Netossa and Spinnerella, has been for years. She's hoping to use them to take the Black Garnet without Brightmoon *officially* owning it. She's trying to steal it out from under our noses!”

Aren't we doing the same thing? whispered some part of Frosta's brain, but it was just a whisper, there and gone, too fast for her to think about right now.

" Okay..." Frosta said, a bit uncomfortably. She'd gotten used to thinking of Glimmer as a friend, as well as Queen Angella; she wasn't... totally sold on this.

It just seemed a bit roundabout. If Angella was gonna back up anybody in the Runestone race, wouldn't it make more sense for her to just have Castaspella's nation of Mystacor take it? Having her sister-in-law in charge of it would be better for her, surely, more reliable... Frosta had only met Netossa a few times, but the woman had not struck her as *anybody's* lapdog, had seemed more like a Queen in her own right than anybody's subordinate.

Something is wrong.

But... she didn't know what to say, what to do. She'd never really questioned any of this before. She was the Snows champion, their Princess, she fought for them, she didn't... she didn't give orders. Not any that hadn't been passed through an advisor first.

She wasn't old enough, never had been. In time she could take the throne truly, but until now she'd just trusted them, trusted the adults around her. They knew what was best.

Right?

But that was another thought that made her uncomfortable, so instead of voicing her real thoughts, she asked a question that had been bothering her.

" What's your name?" she asked, pointing at their third companion, the one who hadn't spoken.

Bron and Chilla had quick bursts of surprise they hid well- Chilla better than Bron- but the hooded man simply nodded at her.

" I am Modulok," he said. " A humble servant of the Church."

" Why aren't you talking?" Frosta asked. The man shrugged.

" I felt it wasn't my place," he said.

Frosta wanted to press... but she still felt... uncomfortable. So she switched to another thought.

" Well, that's all for later, anyway," she said, reluctantly dropping the subject of Modulok. " Gotta get them to go kill Catra's evil ex-girlfriend anyway."

“ Yes,” Bron said. “ And she *must* die. I'm worried Catra will try to force us to capture Adora instead; that's no good. Adora, alive? That's just another way for Queen Angella to exert her influence. I don't trust it. I trust Netossa to want to kill her, we should just back her up.”

That... doesn't track with what you just said, Frosta realized. *You think Netossa's working with Angella to take the Black Garnet, you wouldn't trust her... and sure, people change their minds in politics all the time, but this doesn't really track as sensible.*

“ That is the best course,” Chilla said. “ We will follow Netossa's lead.”

Another thought flitted through Frosta's mind, there and gone like an icicle in summer... or a snowball in hell.

*All of you are **lying** to me...*

Frustrated, unable to stop thinking about things that upset her, Frosta simply nodded her head.

“ Well, let's hope we can get there,” she said, instead.

(And inside, thoughts began to tumble, over and over again, flipping like a coin.)

Chapter End Notes

The Mackenzie name is from the original Frosta; her toy stated her real name to be Queen Mackenzie. I'm taking it here as Frosta's family name, which- while none of the characters would think of this- actually indicates that her family has some First Ones ancestry somewhere, though it'd be much diluted by this point in time.
(This means that yes, Frosta is technically Adora's closest living relative on Etheria- a decision I made entirely on the basis of how hilarious it is that the current Flame Princess and the current Frost Princess would be very, very, very distant cousins.)

Snows' family names descend down the matrilineal line, under the reasoning that while technically you never know who the father is, it's hard to mistake which woman is the mother, since the baby popped out of her. This still works for lesbian couples using the Gift, while gay male couples using the Mystacor working to have a kid flip a coin, because Snowfolk are practical like that.

Squeaky cheese is a real food, and is indeed made from beestings, though it's not mammoth milk for obvious reasons. Snows' food is vaguely Scandinavian/Siberian/Russian themed, to fit with "is north and cold". Mammoths are used for milk and fur in the Snows but very, very rarely for meat; it's just not efficient, they're too useful as beasts of burden and dairy cows. Mammoth meat is only very rarely eaten, and usually only when a farm can't support more mammoths and has to cull some of the newborns. It's quite like hardcore beef in flavor, and goes well with garlic.

Chilla is from the Thundercats show; I chose her because of the name, and because Magicats are so prominent in this entire War Council thing. A Luna is a fairly high-ranking field-priest, which is the highest calling in the Church entirely because it's the most dangerous; it's the fastest way to get promoted, and that's what Chilla's after. As a field-priest, Chilla is not only required to go to war when the army moves out, but also to engage in search and rescue missions. Chilla

is related- distantly- to Frosta by way of a great-great-great uncle or so, back in the line, and thus, is also technically related to Adora in a ludicrously distant way, which entertains me because Chilla is an alien in Thundercats and now is related to an alien here.

Mountainflower is a Plumerian language that has ended up as the lingua franca of all Etheria. I'll talk more about it later. The Snows, due to its size and the harsh winters isolating people every year for at least a little while, has a huge variety of languages. Soulspiral is written only but unites the nation; everyone reads Soulspiral. The Frozen Empress is remembered as a super-monster to everyone south of her, but actually was a really great ruler of the Snows- seriously, she did a lot of good for them. If she'd just stayed home, she'd have went down in history as a hero, instead of becoming a warmonger.

Modulok is a fairly strong Horde villain in the original show; here he's a very high-ranking Snows priest. His original plot in the show was about starting a war between the Selkies and the Snows; here, well. Not the same target, but much the same plan. He's a Snows native, but he is basically a walking incarnation of everything wrong with the Snows' culture; maybe he'll be back to be a problem. Maybe he won't. Time, as always, tells.

Chapter 38: King Micah of the Doom Balloon

Chapter Notes

Today: Micah, and the Doom Balloon.

Tomorrow: The rest of the royal family... or maybe Netossa, haven't decided yet

See the end of the chapter for more notes

King Micah of the Doom Balloon

The Doom Balloon was the most sterile place Micah had ever been. Seriously, every part of it was cold metal, except the parts that were hot oil, and some other stuff he couldn't identify; big pistons pounding, steam, rubber and canvas in some areas. It was ugly as sin! It was clear that, when it came to aesthetics, Entrapta had spared *every* expense. The nose and the ears were assaulted, too; the olfactory senses were plagued with the ever-present smell, because the inside stank the way hot metal always did, mingled with unknowable chemical scents, while the auditory organs were beat up by the constant sound of moving metal, not unlike a tin can orchestra under attack.

Micah fucking *loved* it.

He didn't understand any of it, of course, but he loved it all the same. Tech stuff! The greatest mystery on all Etheria, one he had

no idea how to parse. He was just a mage, after all, not a tech master; magic he understood, he knew the scientific principles it rested on, but First Ones' tech just *did* stuff. They had one bit of it at Mystacor, a fat little ring that boiled eggs perfectly. Why? How did it do it? Who knew! The Mage-Monarchs used it as an interesting paperweight- he'd have to ask Casty if she still had it. First Ones tech was like that, it just casually violated rules of physics and magic like they were no big deal. Very rude!

But this one, this one was *nice.* Because the stuff *this* First Ones tech did... was take him home. It was taking him *home.* After everything- after isolation, starvation, deprivation- after going so mad that he had come out the other end somewhat sane, Micah of Beast Island was going to be Micah of Brightmoon once again.

He was going *home*.

That was a debt he could not pay if he lived as long as his dear wife. Twice as long. *Three* times as long. He would owe Entrapta and her ugly, magnificent, smelly, *beautiful* Doom Balloon all the rest of his life.

Out of those warm feelings of love and friendliness, the king absentmindedly patted the nearest wall in a friendly way, to tell the ship how much he loved it, and his wounded mind chose to interpret the creak and groan of the hull about him as an acknowledgment, which pleased him.

" Why are you petting the... ship?" asked his sister's voice from behind him.

“ Because I like it!” Micah replied.

“ Just *the ship*? Why, don't you know this proud vessel's proper name, auntie Castaspella?” came his daughter's voice in a falsely sweet tone, also behind him as she needled his sister, amusement lurking underneath.

“ I refuse to say it!” Castaspella announced as Micah turned his head to look at them as they walked behind him. “ The name is stupid!”

“ What, you don't like the **Doom Balloon?** ” Glimmer intoned with gravitas as false as her sugary sweetness had been. “ I'm wounded, auntie, I thought you'd love it. I'm the one that named it, after all! Do you find something wrong with the **Doom Balloon**?”

“ You really are my brother's kid,” Castaspella said with a fond sigh of suffering, and Micah joined his daughter in laughter.

His family was here, and he was laughing with them, he was happy and with his family, and he... he had thought he'd never do that again.

(Realizing he was never going to leave- that he was going to die on Beast Island- had been the thing that kicked him off the cliff of sanity; he had... gone away, for a while, inside his head, allowing

the new mind to take over, a mind that did not despair the way his old one had.)

The thought brought a happy tear to his eye, and he patted the Doom Balloon again, because not only was the stuff it *did* saving him from Beast Island, it did *other* stuff... like bringing his daughter to him, or taking him to his sister, and letting her come along. Another debt too big to be paid, that he owed this great machine, and the tech mistress who had made it- Entrapta, Princess Entrapta! A Drylborn, which tracked, and he vaguely thought he had heard of Dryl having a Wild Princess who was good with tech, though Dryl had been fairly isolationist and wasn't much involved in politics back when he was King.

Still, it made sense that Entrapta would make this vast device, Wild Princess or not. Dryl had always been a haven for techlords, had always turned the raw material of the Twin Kingdoms into solid gold... or Doom Balloons, which were much more precious than gold. Gold couldn't have gotten him off the island, after all, you couldn't exactly make a boat of the stuff.

Though he did wonder how Glimmer had come to name it...

" Hey, baby daughter?" Micah said. " How come you named it? I thought Entrapta built it."

" She did!" Glimmer confirmed. " But I ended up naming it kind of by accident."

" Half the fun of making something is getting to name it, though," Micah said. " That's how Mystacor does it."

" But we wouldn't name it... *that*," Castaspella said, shaking her head.

" Then you're not as cool as I am," Glimmer said with easy confidence, casually flaring her wings out around her like two great dark shadows, filling the hallway's small space. Micah was so *proud* of her! She was so brave, and her wings looked cool as hell!

Though Micah was almost *certain* they had been pink before- maybe they darkened as she got older?... and he didn't think she'd had them when they first met on the island? Maybe. Honestly his memory was shit sometimes, he probably just hadn't noticed under the whole *my baby girl is not a baby anymore* thing and the... uhh, everything about that situation.

" I can confirm that Casty has *never* been cool," Micah said, to his daughter's snort of amusement and his sister rolling her eyes.

" Like you'd ever know what cool was, you big dork," she said, then smiled, and patted him, as if to reassure herself he was there, and real. Micah needed that reassurance sometimes, too, so he leaned into the touch a bit.

“ I know the Doom Balloon is cool!” he said. “ It got me off Beast Island, so I was petting it to thank it! It's a good ship, yes it is.”

Glimmer and Castaspella shot a glance at each other that Micah only kind of noticed as he turned away, absentmindedly petting the ship again as he continued down the hallway. Castaspella looked concerned, but Glimmer just shrugged at her.

“ Aren't you worried about him?” Micah heard his sister say.

“ Nah,” Glimmer responded. “ If he comes off of years alone on Beast Island and the only weird part is him petting machines, I'd say he came out ahead. I'm just glad he's not a cannibal or something.”

“ Magic's teeth, Glimmer!” Castaspella said, shocked, as Micah laughed from his place down the hall. “ That's where you go with it?!?”

“ Who would I even be eating?” Micah asked through his guffaws. “ You can't be a cannibal all by yourself, that's just a really complicated suicide!”

“ Fair point,” Glimmer admitted. “ Cannibalism's really a team sport, no room for solo play.”

“ Yep!” Micah agreed as they continued down the hall.

“ Oh, I'm gonna be sick,” Castaspella said, turning green.

“ What, no stomach for cannibalism?” Micah said.

“ It's a subject you can really sink your teeth into!” Glimmer joined in.

“ I hate you both,” Castaspella responded.

Micah laughed, and smiled as he walked, the way he'd been smiling ever since he'd woken up, the way he'd been smiling since Mystacor. Kind of hurt, actually, but he couldn't stop himself... and it wasn't like he wanted to. Smiling had been too rare, on the island, so rare... really, he was just catching up!

Smiling, he continued on, leading the family trio, walking in a line behind Micah, the Doom Balloon's hallways barely big enough for two people to pass each other, and then only if one of those people *wasn't* Scorpia. Trying to keep weight requirements down, some part of Micah whispered, some part that had studied a lot in Mystacor and knew many things. Entrapta had apologized for that to Scorpia, saying she hadn't built the Doom Balloon with Scorpia's proportions in mind; she hadn't really expected Scorpia to be alive, something she had admitted with her mask down, as though ashamed to be confessing to such sins.

Scorpia had just laughed, and said not to worry, even Scorpia herself had been surprised by her own survival, and she'd just hugged her short friend, whose face had been smiling when she lifted her mask. Micah had been there, and for fun hugged them both as well, the two survivors of Beast Island dancing a merry jig with the Drylborn caught between them, the three cheerfully giddy. Micah spent any time he wasn't with Glimmer or Castaspella with Scorpia, which meant that he spent it with Entrapta, because the Scorpioni had been stuck to the Wild Princess like glue since they got onboard. Micah did the same thing, because after the Island, he was lonely and needy, which he felt he'd earned, to be honest!

At that time, his sister and his daughter had been with... ugh... Shadow Weaver, Castaspella and the dark sorceress studying his daughter's apparently expanded magic, but Micah didn't like thinking about that, so he didn't! He'd had a lot of complicated feelings about Shadow Weaver back in the day, and he was floating on too many good feelings right now to go poke those. That was a sleeping dragon he'd go piss off later. Wasn't like Shadow Weaver was going anywhere.

The progress down the hall was slowed as they hit an intersection, and there, found some of Casty's mercenaries! The woman in the lead saluted Castaspella as she arrived.

" Morning, madam! Err, well, afternoon, anyway," Sweet Bee said. Two her Andreenids were behind her, all equipped with the same stripped down version of the heavy armor they'd originally worn when he first met them. Instead of the full plate and flight harnesses, they now only had a black breastplate, sleeveless shirt, and black pants combo, ending in practical black military boots. The only splashes of color were the dull gold pommel on the large

daggers each carried on their belts, and the small badges on the left side of the soldiers' chests; the top one was of the Federation of Phlax's flag, consisting of a rainbow pattern with a black snake overlaid, and the bottom was for her hometown of the Hive, a gold honeycomb pattern.

" Good afternoon as well, Commander Sweet Bee," Castaspella said. " You slept well?"

" Slept fine!" the perky woman said with a bright grin. " Accommodations up here are better than my normal tent, that's for sure! We should hire Entrapta to build us one of these things."

With her usual bee-faced helmet off, the woman's features were visible, and they were, visibly, nothing much to write home about. She was an unattractive woman in the face, with a nose that had clearly met the wrong end of a punch more than once, though her short-cut, frizzy hair was a lovely honey-gold, and her blue eyes were bright and alert... and something in her soprano-sweet voice and cheerful, bubbly personality made her lovely anyway, made a kind of aura that made her more beautiful the longer you knew her.

Physically, she was more than a bit imposing, despite her average height, thick muscle corded throughout her entire body, biceps at attention even as she just stood there. This was a woman so used to physical work and the hard task of soldiering that, in a purely physical confrontation, she probably could have taken everybody on the Doom Balloon except Micah and maybe Glimmer in a fight. Micah's sense of danger, which was *very* well-honed after the Island, said this woman was very much like the big

herbivores he'd avoided; not a danger unless you started shit, but a *fatal* danger if you did.

" I'm glad to hear that," Castaspella said. " And again, sorry for dragging you off on such short notice. I'm sorry Ariel was so pushy about demanding I hire somebody to watch over me, it's like she thinks I can't take care of myself; I hope you don't mind the imposition."

" It's fine!" Sweet Bee demurred, waving a hand dismissively. " Shit happens, and I'm happy to help. We Crownless gotta look after each other! And besides, you found your brother, that's a big deal!"

She turned her big grin on Micah, revealing a smile with a few gaps; her nose wasn't the only only thing that had taken a few hard hits over the years.

" King Micah of Brightmoon!" she said. " It's like something out of a story. The lost king, returned all these years later, and by his very own daughter nonetheless! This'll make a hell of a book someday. I still can't believe you're here in the flesh."

" Me neither!" he responded, and the woman laughed, her troops behind her grinning too.

" Are you sure you don't want me to pay you?" Castaspella asked. " You're really going out of your way."

“ Please,” Sweet Bee said, waving a hand again. “ Me and my troops are getting a free ride back to Brightmoon, which gets us and the payment for the ambrosia more than halfway home at twice our usual speed. That's payment enough. It's overpayment, honestly, I should be paying you!”

“ I mean, if you want to pay me, I'm not gonna fight ya,” Glimmer remarked. “ You can pay me in ambrosia, that shit's amazing.”

“ It is!” Micah agreed. “ I stole Castaspella's jars of it when she got on the Doom Balloon. Ate one too fast, ended up vomiting right after, but it was totally worth it. Ate the second jar a lot slower!”

“ Is that- you stole my ambrosia?!?” Castaspella said, turning on her brother with an enraged expression. “ You son of a bitch! I thought maybe I'd forgot to pack them! What the fuck, Micah?!? Did you break into my room?!?”

“ I did, and I don't regret it!” Micah defended himself. “ I've been eating wild game and nuts and berries for years, you can't tempt me with the best food on earth and expect me to *not* eat it! I saw you toss the jars into your bag and I had to have them. I lived on that stuff in school!”

“ I know,” Castaspella grumbled, “ Mortella kept spending all her allowance buying you jars of it, hoping you'd notice her. But noooo, you have to go marry fucking Angella instead.”

“ Mortella was into me?” Micah said, nonplussed. “ Why didn't anyone tell me? She was too young, I'd have never went out with her, but still! I had no idea!”

“ Her mooning over you like an idiot was obvious to anyone with *eyes* !” Castaspella protested. “ Nobody had to tell you shit, it was plain to see!”

“ I have no context for any of this,” Glimmer said with a shrug, turning back to Sweet Bee as Castaspella continued to castigate Micah for his past blindness and current thievery. “ But seriously, if you've any ambrosia, I can pay you when we get to Brightmoon, I'd love to have a few jars. That shit can keep you going on campaign.”

Sweet Bee frowned.

“ Sorry,” she apologized, “ we only brought what Mystacor had already paid for... well, other than our own rations...”

She paused, then perked up as an idea hit her.

“ Hey!” she exclaimed. “ We're getting back a lot faster than normal, so we don't need as much ambrosia for our own rations. Drone Seven cuts us a good deal on our own supplies... yeah, we could sell you the extra rations! Brightmoon silver trades as fine

as Phlax bronze, so I don't mind taking your coin, though we'll discuss the terms in more depth when we get there- I wouldn't mind getting paid in tent canvas, I'm drowning in metal but I can never get enough damn canvas."

" I'll see what I can get ya," Glimmer said. " Who's Drone Seven?"

" My contact back home," Sweet Bee said. " Older guy, ain't really in a position to go out fighting, but he really believes in the Rebellion and my cause, so he works as a provisions guy for my squad, kind of a general coordinator. His family adores me, they say the old guy hasn't been this alive or happy in years, he even changed his name! Drone's a big-deal kind of name for us at the Hive, means you've found something to serve, it's kind of a whole thing; frankly I'm honored, I don't think I'm important enough to warrant a Drone, but he does. It's awful touching, I love the little old guy."

" You gotta have somebody running your shit back home when you're out in the field," Glimmer said with a nod. " We've got a whole department back home for logistics, but the Hive wouldn't do that for you, would it? Since Phlax wasn't really in the war... though I guess that's changed since Blue Mountain got hammered."

" It did!" Sweet Bee said. " Thank the Good Woman for the Red Knight, they'd been passing through with a Rebel squad and some Blackmoor troops, that's the only reason Blue Mountain didn't burn. Lord Adora's a fucking monster; Hordak at least directed his assaults, but she's just attacking everyone, everywhere!"

“ Won't hear me arguing with you on that,” Glimmer said.

“ But to answer your question- no, the Hive wasn't... fully supportive of me,” Sweet Bee admitted. “ I had a lot of people who'd back me up! Especially my squad.”

She nodded at the troopers behind her, the two women returning it.

“ There's others, too, like Drone Seven, people who gather supplies for us, encourage others to join up, even gather intelligence,” Sweet Bee said. “ But... a lot of others? They thought I was just asking for trouble, bringing a fight to Phlax it couldn't win. They almost got me imprisoned or exiled, early on. They didn't understand that the fight was *already* coming, I was trying to learn enough to help us win it! That, and I couldn't let you guys take all the credit for fighting the Horde- we Crownless named the Great Rebellion, it's up to us to finish it!”

“ You mean the Princess Alliance?” Glimmer said, grinning smugly as Sweet Bee rolled her eyes.

“ You're lucky you're from Brightmoon,” she said fondly. “ The 'Princess Alliance.' I can't *believe* you guys renamed it. What was wrong with the Great Rebellion? That's much more inclusive! Blackmoor didn't name it *the Crownless Uprising* or something like that *,* we gave it a name that included everybody, Runestone and Crownless alike! Princesses can be Rebels! Hell, Netossa's the greatest Rebel, and she's a Princess who's married to a Princess, she counts twice.”

Castaspella and Micah continued to argue over old things of the past, while the two guards behind Sweet Bee began quietly taking bets on which of the two siblings would win the argument, all four ignored by Glimmer and Sweet Bee.

" Is that how it works?" Glimmer asked. " You marry a Princess, you count twice? I don't- I'm like, mostly sure that's not how it works."

" Eh, I'm a student of history and politics, not math," Sweet Bee said with a shrug. " It might be!"

The duo chuckled.

" So how's the Hive treating you since?" Glimmer asked. " You must look like a prophet now that Adora's trying to set all of you on fire."

" Oh, they've united behind me!" Sweet Bee said. " The whole Hive has turned to me for leadership now! It's terrifying, but kind of exciting?"

" That's the best feeling!" Glimmer said. " You're not alive if you're not a bit freaked out."

“ I'll take your word for it!” Sweet Bee said with a laugh. “ I've been invited to speak at Phlax- the capital- gonna be at the Senate when I get back.”

“ Wait,” Glimmer said, “ is the capital of Phlax... *also* called Phlax? Silver, that's fucking confusing.”

“ You're one to talk, Brightmoon's capital is also called Brightmoon!” Sweet Bee said.

“ It was stupid when we did it, too!” Glimmer responded. “ You really shouldn't copy our bad ideas, we're old and don't know any better, but you guys are like, a baby nation. You still have time to change! It's not too late!”

“ We're called the Federation of Phlax because that's where it started,” Sweet Bee replied, snickering at Glimmer's words. “ They were going to call it the Federation, but everyone at the first Senate agreed it was too generic, so the Federation of Phlax it was. I'll keep in mind that we can still change it; maybe I'll bring it up in my Senate speech.”

“ You nervous about speaking?” Glimmer asked.

“ Terrified!” Sweet Bee admitted with a laugh. “ I did this supply drop run basically to give myself time to *think* and figure out what I was gonna say. I've only been to Phlax once, went on pilgrimage to see the cathedral of Larg's Fall when I was thinking of joining

the Rebellion... gonna be weird, to go back there after all that happened because of that decision!”

Beside them, Micah prepared his finishing blow in his conversational unpleasantries with his sister.

“ And that's why you should have told me you were into archery,” he said. “ Really, I'm just glad you've got a new hobby!”

“ Archery?” Castaspella said, so confused she couldn't respond.

“ You have a box in your room labeled *for Bow!* I saw it while robbing you. Don't know why you capitalized it, but maybe it's a fancy bow,” Micah said. “ Full of little round thingies that feel weird magically. Not sure how they apply to archery but it's good to see you expanding your horizons, I always felt you didn't get out enough.”

“ Oh my- that's for *Bow,* he's Glimmer's boyfriend,” Castaspella said, putting a hand to her forehead. “ Magic preserve me, you're as dumb as I remember!”

“ My daughter has a boyfriend?!?” Micah said, rounding on Glimmer. “ Congratulations! Or despair, depending on if he's an asshole. Is your boyfriend an asshole?”

“ Wha- he's not my boyfriend!” Glimmer protested, distracted. “ And no, he's not an asshole, he's a fucking saint! He's sweet and gentle and wonderful, I won't hear a word against him!”

“ Do you want him to be your boyfriend?” Micah queried, and Glimmer quickly blushed bright red before subsuming it.

“ Nope,” she said. “ Not having this talk. Conversation over! Weren't we going somewhere? Oh yeah, the bridge! Onward and upwards to the bridge! Get moving, get moving.”

She shoved the group along, Micah protesting as Sweet Bee giggled and fell in behind the group. A few moments later, the little group popped out onto the bridge of the Doom Balloon, and got to take in the sights.

The bridge had a big viewing port in the front, which had a dazzling view of the local Etherian geography laid out under them; here, so close to Brightmoon, it was mostly the tail end of the Whispering Woods, with scattered patches of clearings that represented villages beneath them, and long, snaking roads that wound their way amidst the trees. Beneath were his people, his land, his *Kingdom* ; people were out working, playing, fighting, *living,* and for a man stuck alone for so long, it was entrancing to see.

Some were running errands, riding the many mounts of Etheria or driving her rarer vehicles, while others in the current village he was looking at were busy with construction work, repairing the roads... but most people he could see were farming the land in

great fields, which from up here looked like a patchwork quilt of produce, separated by the long, shallow dragonfly ditches that were the hallmark of Brightmoon agriculture. The Snows was too cold, and Plumeria too hot, but Brightmoon was just right for the Brightmoon dragonfly, and the voracious insect super-predators had been tamed early in its history; now, breeding in shallow ponds prepared for them by Brightmoon farmers, great flights of the bugs covered the nearby crops, devouring any and all pests. They were even pretty, the green and silver beasts shining as they flitted about in the sun, chewing their way through the vermin that would otherwise consume the year's food.

Cats could be seen prowling around the fields, too, keeping out more mammalian opposition, moles and rats and mice as their owners put hoes to work clearing out weeds, shoring up plants with dirt when they didn't have enough, or removing dirt from plants smothering under earthen weight. A familiar sight, though there were a lot more orange tabbies than Micah remembered, little striped dudes. Hmm, must be a fad.

Looking down at it, Micah was reminded of a statue he'd seen of the two species in a Brightmoon art gallery once, a display honoring the twin guardian beasts that had safeguarded Brightmoon farming since time immemorial. Mystacor farming had been based on Brightmoon's, the two nations sharing a climate, though not all of the vassal kingdoms could use it, some too far south or north... but it was just... familiar.

Something wet slid down his face. He reached a hand up, and realized he was... crying. He was still smiling, but water poured from his eyes, he was smiling and crying, because this was *home* .

“ Hey everybody!” came a voice that distracted him. “ How are you guys this... is it still morning? It's almost afternoon I think.”

“ It is,” Glimmer responded. “ But doing good!”

Micah looked away from the viewing port to see Scorpia and Entrapta, who had been standing next to it; he hadn't noticed.

“ I thought so! But, uhh, hey, Micah buddy?” Scorpia asked, concerned as she looked over at him. “ You okay?”

“ I'm doing very well,” he said. “ That's why I'm crying. It's... this is Brightmoon. My people. My *home.* I'm almost *home* .”

A hug from next to him, his little sister, supporting him; another hug, from his daughter, to his side. He wrapped arms around both of them.

“ Aww, come on, bring it in big guy,” Scorpia said, heading over. “ I give great hugs, you're getting one.”

“ Why am I big guy? You are like, forty feet tall,” Micah said, still smiling and crying even as his friend hugged him again.

A little awkwardly, Entrapta slithered over, and a coil of her hair wrapped around his arm uncertainly, as if she wasn't sure it was ok; he waved her on in, and she curled around everybody. A pat on the back came, too, and he looked to see Sweet Bee behind him, looking at him in sympathy.

" Hey, take it in," she said. " I've seen old soldiers do this when they finally get to go home. You want a handkerchief?"

" That would be great," he said. " Otherwise, I have to wipe off on the nearest person, and Scorpia's chitin is just... not soft."

" Also non-absorbent!" the Scorpioni added. " It'll just sit on me, and I really don't want snot on my shell. No offense, Micah."

" None taken," he said, as Sweet Bee produced a golden handkerchief from some hidden pocket on her breastplate.

" Never know when you'll need one!" Sweet Bee said as she offered it. " Peekablue taught me that."

He tried to get it and also keep hugging everybody at the same time, which failed miserably; Entrapta grabbed the handkerchief with a free strand of hair for him.

" I got it," she said. " A good cry can be very helpful! Especially if you get a hug, too. I have experience."

“ Ah, you're a saint,” Micah said, as she wiped his face off.

“ No, I'm not, but one hugged me, once,” Entrapta demurred. “ Hold still.”

She patted his face dry as his eyes finally cried out enough of his emotions that he could carry them again, his cup no longer running over.

“ I'm... I'm okay,” Micah said, as Entrapta finished patting his face dry. “ That's kind of the problem, this is the most ok I've been in *years* . When... when are we getting back?”

“ A few hours,” Scorpia said. “ We'll hit Brightmoon at... four, I think Entrapta said?”

“ Yes,” the Drylborn replied. “ My Doom Balloon is built for endurance and carry weight, not speed. Could make it go faster but would hurt it to do so; could technically travel a very long distance very quickly but would have to crash Doom Balloon at end, engines would burn it out. Make it a bomb.”

“ Well, I'd hate that!” Micah said. “ I love this thing! And I can wait. Gives me time to... process. If I saw Angella now I think I'd die. Or pass out. Or pass out and *then* die.”

“ Don't you dare,” Glimmer warned him, wiping her own eyes surreptitiously as she stepped away from him. “ It'd be just my luck, I find my dad and he fucking dies when I get him back home. I'd never hear the end of it from mom.”

“ You can't die on me yet,” Cataspella said, still clinging to him. “ You owe me two jars of ambrosia, you little shit.”

“ Aww, you can't die, you're like, one of only two friends I have!” Scorpia said.

“ I think he is joking, Scorpia,” Entrapta said as she let go and curled back, leaning back on her hair in the air, looking like a friendly cobra. “ I hope so. He is fairly healthy, according to the medical work, his heart should be able to handle the shock of being home, especially with preparation. I'm not an expert at medical work but I know some, he should be fine. He *does* have some medical problems he should get looked at, though; multiple fractures that only semi-healed and some nutritional deficiencies.”

“ Hey, at least the ambrosia he ate will help with that!” Sweet Bee said, as she looked at the handkerchief that Entrapta tried to hand back. “ Oh, and uh... you can throw that away. I've got extras.”

“ Okay,” Entrapta said, transferring it from hair to hand and then to a pocket of her overalls. Sweet Bee looked at the Horde flag that made up Entrapta's right sleeve, but said nothing, though Micah had been present when Sweet Bee had spoken with Castaspella about Entrapta's sympathies.

Apparently Entrapta had been a Hordesman? But Micah thought she was Drylborn? And they kept calling her a traitor. She made bots for the Horde, apparently, though Micah honestly could barely follow the conversation. Entrapta was pro-Horde, and was still wearing those colors, but now was working for the Great Rebellion because apparently Hordak was dead or something? When the fuck had *that* happened? What was the Portal they kept talking about? He didn't remember a Portal, they said it like it was world-wide, if he'd found a Portal he'd have jumped through it because, seriously, it couldn't lead somewhere *worse* than Beast Island, he'd take his chances.

And then someone called Lord Adora was leading the Horde now? Who the fuck was Adora? Apparently the She-Ra's former girlfriend, but that couldn't be right, She-Ra wasn't a thing, that was a legend. Lord Adora was someone Entrapta didn't like much, so she'd left, maybe that was why they called her traitor? Seemed rude, if she'd defected from the Horde to the Rebellion.

And he was *sure* Sweet Bee had mentioned a rumor that Lord Adora was a *First One* , but that couldn't be right, his brain must have went crazy again for a bit. First Ones and She-Ra, his brain was digging up all the old legends his former teacher Light Spinner had been obsessed with, before she found the spell and had to sell her own soul to the worst parts of herself as Shadow Weaver.

Man, some *shit* had went down while he was gone. He hoped Angella could explain it all when he got back.

He drifted back into the world after his thoughts quick enough to hear Glimmer speaking with Sweet Bee again.

" So," she said. " What's *in* ambrosia, precisely?"

" Not gonna tell you," Sweet Bee said. " Mostly because I don't know, but also, you know, trade secret. It's all we got, we gotta keep that secret!"

Glimmer chuckled.

" Sure," she said. " So long as you get me a few jars of it. My sister doesn't like it much, it's kind of bland to her- she can't taste sweet stuff much, and doesn't like what she can taste of it- but I love it."

Micah's brain skipped to a stop.

" What?" he said. " Sister?"

Glimmer paused as her brain skidded to a stop, too, Micah could almost literally see it.

" Oh," she murmured. " Oh shit, I didn't tell you."

“ Did Angella remarry?” Micah said, internally steeling himself. He couldn't blame her, but he'd... he'd wanted to go back to her... but he'd been gone so long.

“ No,” Glimmer said quickly. “ No, you're still her husband.”

But if he was still her husband, but Glimmer had a sister...

“ ...Silver and magic,” Micah swore. “ She was pregnant when I left, wasn't she? I- oh wow, I didn't know, she must not have either, she puked like crazy with you so it must have just happened... I have another daughter. I have another daughter... I'm not surprised, we *were* having a lot of sex before-”

“ Whoa!” Castaspella said, letting go of him and backing up. “ Uh uh, do *not* want to hear that.”

“ Yeah, no!” Glimmer said. “ Dude!”

“ What's she look like?” Micah asked. “ What's her name? What's she like?”

“ My sister's Catra!” Glimmer said, very fast, because she did *not* want her dad to go back to talking about banging her mom. “ She's awesome, you'll love her!”

“ She is?” Scorpia said. “ You mean like, Catra Catra? Catra I know?”

“ Yes!” Glimmer said.

“ But she's like, a Magicat!” Scorpia said.

“ I knocked Angella up with a Magicat?” Micah said, before looking down at his crotch. “ I didn't know you had it in you, buddy!”

Sweet Bee burst out laughing, leaning on her troopers, who were likewise dying at Micah's proclamation. Scorpia looked like she'd discovered some new fact that shook her to the core, while Castaspella and Glimmer's faces were making interesting expressions to go with the fascinating noises emanating from their mouths, like they wanted to say too much at once and so none of it was coming out.

“ I had no idea,” Scorpia said. “ No wonder Catra left the Fright Zone, she was Glimmer's sister the whole time! I don't see a resemblance, but you never know, family lines can be complicated like that. How'd she end up in the Fright Zone, though? Did Shadow Weaver steal her? That sounds like her...”

“ Shadow Weaver stole my baby?!?” Micah said.

“ Umm,” Entrapta interrupted before the spiral of nonsense could get any worse. “ Catra is adopted, King Micah.”

“ Oh, that does make more sense!” he responded. “ Wasn't sure how I managed to father a Magicat, and that makes the timeline match up better because Scorpia said Catra was about her age or maybe only a year younger.”

“ Yeah, that does make more sense,” Scorpia said. “ Aww, I'm glad for her, though! She always seemed to think really highly of Queen Angella, though we didn't get to talk about it a lot. Trying to fight each other, you know. Now that I'm not with the Horde anymore, maybe we can get to really know each other!”

“ That'd be good,” Entrapta said. “ Catra... she's a great person. Forgiving. Keeps her word. She's almost as good as... Perfuma...”

When that last word slipped out, Entrapta's hair quickly slapped her mask down, so no one saw her blush as she thought of *her* .

(She'd be seeing her soon, too, when Imp reached her with the new thing she'd designed, the lady of metal longing to see the lady of flowers, who had comforted her so.)

“ Well, I just hope the other Princesses like me...” Scorpia said quietly.

“ Why wouldn't they?” Micah said. “ You're wonderful!”

“ He's right,” Entrapta said. “ If they're willing to tolerate me, after all I've done...”

“ Micah, why the *fuck* would you think you could father a Magicat at all?!?” Castaspella managed to get out from all her spluttering, interrupting whatever Entrapta was about to say next. “ You're human and Angella's an angel, how can you add that to get Magicat? How does- what- *why???* ”

“ I didn't even know Angella could *get* pregnant,” Micah said with a shrug. “ Hell, we're still not sure if she even has ovaries or just like, kind of formed Glimmer? She's unique and the Most Serene's people didn't really know what they made, she only worked kind of by accident. So like, if a Magicat popped out, it wouldn't really be any weirder.”

“ I know his heart's fine,” Glimmer said to Entrapta, “ but I think mine is going to fail me before we get there.”

“ Please don't die on my vessel,” Entrapta requested politely. “ It would make Catra very sad, and I would be dismayed too.”

“ No promises,” Glimmer said before rounding back on her dad. “ So, yeah, Catra's adopted. Mom adopted her a few months ago. She's even on the tapest-tree now.”

“ I love that thing!” Micah said. “ I'm excited to meet this Catra. I have a new daughter to get to know! Though Scorpia told me a lot about her, mostly about how attractive she found her. Does Catra have a girlfriend? I'm pretty sure I can get her one basically immediately, Scorpia's *super* into her.”

“ Dude!” Scorpia said, blushing furiously. “ I'm just- she's really great!”

“ The question of whether Catra has a girlfriend is the single most complicated question on Etheria,” Glimmer said. “ I'll fill you in later. I've had like, more than enough of... everything. I'm terrified you're gonna start talking about you and mom having sex again, so I am *bailing* . I'm gonna do... literally anything else for the next four hours.”

She turned to the Rebels nearby, as Sweet Bee was wiping her eyes from her laughter.

“ Sweet Bee, any of your Andreenids up for a game of cards? Or if they just want to like, punch me in the face, I don't really care at this point. Maybe a nice, healthy concussion will make me forget about my parents fucking.”

“ The knowledge will never leave you!” Micah cheerfully informed her, which she summarily ignored.

“ Maybe,” Sweet Bee said. “ I won't punch you, but we've got cards. You know how to play guts?”

“ Two card or three card?” Glimmer asked. “ I've mostly played moonshot, but I know how to play guts.”

“ Three card,” Sweet Bee said. “ Everybody plays three these days in Phlax, only the old folks still play two card.”

“ I'll go with you,” Castaspella said. “ I could do with a concussion too- or a game of guts, I won a lot of spending money beating people at that back in school.”

“ Mostly from me!” Micah said. “ I'm shit at cards.”

“ You're not invited,” Glimmer said. “ You gotta hang with somebody else, I'm gonna go play cards with my aunt and the Rebels.”

Micah opened his mouth to say something, but then his magic suddenly screamed a warning; with instincts born of years of desperation, his body reacted before conscious thought could intervene. Behind him, something was coming up out of the hallway, something that was a *predator* the way Beast Island had been a *predator.*

He turned with magic in his hands, ready to blast or shield, and saw two pits of white, staring out of infinite night.

" Greetings," she said. " I see you have maintained proper form, Micah."

It took him a moment to take control of himself, to put the magic away; he saw, briefly, that Sweet Bee had reacted to his reacting, that she had two daggers out, and the part of him that was a survivor approved. Glimmer, too, he would swear had been ready, though everyone else was surprised.

" Shadow Weaver!" Glimmer said. " Wanna join us for a game of cards? Three card guts."

" No," Shadow Weaver said. " I simply came to see when we would be arriving... and to see how Micah was doing."

...She sounded so much like Light Spinner. *Was* Light Spinner; Micah should know, he'd dug in enough books looking to find the opposite answer, hoping against hope that the dark magic hadn't worked the way he thought it did. He wanted it to be at fault. He wanted Shadow Weaver to be... something else.

But that wasn't how dark magic worked. The magic of Plumeria could grow a new soul, the magic of Life could *make* something new to replace a person... but dark magic made nothing. It couldn't. Dark magic was about the other thing, about *taking.*

Subtraction, not addition. It was hungry magic, eating magic, draining magic, and the energy thus stolen could be used to create... but by itself, dark magic could not make a new thing.

What the Spell of Obtainment did instead was eat away all the parts of oneself that were *not* used to cast the spell. The effect was that those parts that *were* involved in casting the spell got... stronger. More extreme. Less restricted. What was left was still that person, or at least, part of them, the remnant of what was once a whole soul... with those parts that remained fattened on the rest of it.

(He had been wrong; cannibalism *was* a solo play, for some.)

" I am fine," he said, a bit stiffly. Dammit, he did *not* want to deal with this right now.

Or ever.

His feelings had been complicated enough, Light Spinner a tutor and... and something a lot like a mother, for an orphan who had no one else. She had known it, too, or at least, he thought she did; there had to be a reason she always had a little more time for him, there had to be a reason she took a little more care with him than with her other students, there had to be a reason she'd asked him to be part of the ritual. It was tutor stuff, but... it was mom stuff, too, and he'd badly needed a mother. His innate gift had made him a special boy in Mystacor's ranks, but only Light Spinner had seemed to see the person inside that power, and...

Well, fucked up as it was, he owed some of his sense of morality to Light Spinner. She had been power-hungry and mean-spirited, yes... but she had also been horrified by evil, and determined to do good. Before she consumed all her better nature, and given in to her worst impulses... she had been good. She had been imperfect, as all people were, but before the Spell, she had been *good* , too, had... had wanted to help. She had wanted to help so bad she would not listen to Norwyn when he demanded she let people be hurt, she had been strident in her belief that Mystacor could do real *good* in the world, and the thought had haunted Micah on and off, even on Beast Island, of what she might have done if she had picked any other method of gaining power.

She had been his mother, or at least as much of one as he'd ever had, and that meant that, despite everything... some part of him still loved her.

(And thus does Micah and a daughter he has never met share something nonetheless- a sense of confusion and pain about the role of their mother in their lives.)

" That is good to hear," Shadow Weaver said. " Entrapta, Glimmer... we need to speak, if you would. Perhaps in the training room?"

" Oh, yeah," Glimmer said. " Good idea."

" I'll be with you shortly," Entrapta said. " Just want to do a last-minute checkup to make sure we're on track."

“ We'll see you there,” Shadow Weaver said, before leaving, though not without another glance at Micah.

“ Glimmer,” Micah said quietly, after Shadow Weaver left, “ what... business could she possibly have with my little girl?”

“ Oh,” Glimmer said, and something dangerous gleamed in her eyes, “ nothing much.”

There was something there... Micah's sense for danger, on high alert after Shadow Weaver, knew that there was something up. Not directed at him, but...

...Maybe Shadow Weaver wasn't the only dangerous thing aboard this ship.

“ Hey,” he said, quietly. “ Be careful, alright?”

Glimmer looked at him a bit surprised, then nodded.

“ Always,” she said.

And she left the room, leaving Micah with many, many questions.

Chapter End Notes

As Micah has no preconceived notion of Glimmer being unable to be sneaky, he is the first person to figure out that she's planning something; the benefits of having no preconceived notions of a person.

Micah broke into Castaspella's room with a simple spell, because years of being on Beast Island has destroyed his sense of property law and his sense of propriety both. His lack of a sense of shame is not the Island's fault, he was always like that.

Sweet Bee identifies so strongly with her fellow Crownless that she often slips into "we" when discussing them; Blackmoor alone named the Great Rebellion, but she'll say "we" because they're Crownless like she is.

Micah actually remembers the Portal World, since Catra spoke with him directly, but only sometimes, his mind hiding it from him because he thought it was a fantasy indulged in too strongly. Generally the people Catra interacted with most remember it best, though there are outliers like Spinnerella who remember it without ever meeting her, mostly due to dumb luck.

The card game Glimmer references is Brightmoon's favorite card game, and is basically the Black Lady variant of Hearts, which I did entirely because one maneuver is called Shooting the Moon. It was originally called Black Lady in Brightmoon, too, but the Wicked Lady basically singlehandedly destroyed that name for it from raw association power. They ended up calling it Moonshot after.

Guts is a real card game that's basically poker with fewer cards; it's popular in Phlax since it's cheap to play and easier to remember the rules for. Card games are incredibly popular among soldiers and, thus, among the Rebels; this somewhat nonplusses Netossa and Spinnerella, since card games are not really a thing in the Twin Kingdoms or Dryl due to lack of cheap paper.

Chapter 39: Queens and Princesses of the Great Rebellion

Chapter Notes

I'm jumping back and forth through time a bit, which I do not apologize for, I got enough going on as it is! :D

This takes place the morning of the meeting. It's a few hours before the last chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

QUEENS AND PRINCESSES OF THE GREAT REBELLION

Netossa did her morning stretches, and while her body was busy, her mind tried to ignore both her own creeping doubts and Queen Orwall's constant questions... and rather frustratingly for the usually victorious woman, she found herself miserably failing at both.

" What if Catra doesn't like me?" Orwall asked for the umpteenth time as Netossa slowly twisted her torso, waking up her abdominal muscles from the night's rest. " She has no real connection to Halfmoon, what if she thinks I'm here to like, try to take her 'home' or something? I mean, I'd love for her to see Halfmoon, we're all so proud of her, I want her to know we love her so much! But Brightmoon's her *home*, we know that, I just want her to know she's welcome at Halfmoon at any time! Well, when we beat the Horde back, anyway, it's kind of hard to get to us, have to fight the entire Horde to reach us so far in the south. But it's just- it means so much to us, to hear that one of our own is out here, fighting! Fighting for us, for *everyone* the Horde has

enslaved! Some people even think she's Saz returned, back to save us all! I don't, because why would Saz show up as a woman now, it seems like a lot of effort to revive yourself just to give yourself gender dysphoria too, but maybe Saz didn't care about that? Or maybe it works different for gods? But anyway, what she does, it means so much... we're so proud of her!”

*You **should** be,* Netossa thought, as she switched to toe-touching stretches, which always hurt the worst. *She's done so much good for the cause... Catra's the only reason the Great Rebellion is still standing, has a real chance of **winning** now.*

...A nd here I am, trying to force her to help me kill the woman she loves.

She bit back a curse of frustration, just kind of growling, and Orwall shot a nervous glance at her.

“ I'm sorry, am I bothering you?” the foreign Queen asked, looking guilty, and Netossa just didn't have the heart to tell her the blunt *yes* that almost fell out of her lips before she caught it.

“ Not you,” Netossa said, which was true- it was Netossa's own internal doubts that were bothering her, not the Magicat. Still, Orwall's nervousness was evident on her face, so Netossa followed up with, “ I'm just focused on my exercises, and on the meeting coming up.”

Which was true, just... not what Orwall had actually asked. Netossa didn't like lying, not if she didn't have to, but even she knew that there was a time and a place to say the truth... and it would be awfully jackass of her to take out her frustrations on poor Orwall.

She ain't the one making me feel guilty, Netossa reminded herself. *I gotta do it, but that doesn't mean I gotta like it.*

" Oh, okay!" Orwall said, perking up... and continuing to talk, to Netossa's only mildly disguised annoyance. " Oh, I'm so excited to meet her! I've got butterflies in my stomach, we tell so many stories of her, but we know so *little...* Do you know if she has a girlfriend? That's probably ridiculous to ask, she doesn't even know me, but I've heard so *much* about her- well, not *that* much, but we've heard a little, even all the way down south! A Seaworthy merchant got to us fairly recently, he told us that she's friends with their Princess, I think her name's Misty? Mermisty?"

" Mermista," Netossa corrected automatically as she entered another set of exercises, stretching her back. " Also technically Mermista's *Salineas'* princess, but Seaworthy likes to claim her still, even after they broke away."

The Salinean Civil War of 818 ID... also known as the Tropical Rouge Revolution, since it had been the attempted repeal of a tax on rouge from one of Salineas' southern island chains that had triggered the assassination that kicked it all off. Also known as Laura's War, since it wasn't until the Sea Elf Laura Cure became the Princess and won that the whole thing had ended. A tribute to why you really shouldn't poison a Princess, especially one trying to reform your nation... or piss off your two most profitable cities.

Octopus Cove and Seaworthy had both broken away, the Cove through open violence and Seaworthy through backroom deals, which really explained a lot about the kind of places those two citystates had become in the two centuries and change since.

Fascinating stuff, really. Netossa had written a paper on it to earn her political science degree at Highpoint Abyss; it'd been a toss-up between that, or examining how the destruction of Dryl's engineer-guilds by Princess Tomoe of the Glory Lilies had effectively punched Etheria's overall technological expertise to an era from *before* the First Ones showed up. Given the Twin Kingdoms' long history of trade with Dryl and corresponding knowledge of it, Netossa had opted for the topic less often covered. Worked, too, she'd graduated top of the class.

(The ferocious warrior was a historian by inclination; she had originally wanted to be a professor of history before she found that she was better at making history than teaching it.)

" Ah! Thank you!" Orwall said, ears perking up on her head. " I'd hate to get her name wrong! Or her nation, that... that would be bad. We don't do much sea trade anymore- well, we never did, but we used to have a port in Silverglade we bought a timeshare in, there's no good spot in Halfmoon on the coast, but..."

Orwall trailed off in a manner not unlike a deflating balloon, her air basically just straight up leaving her as she realized she was rambling, not so much deliberately braking as sputtering to a stop.

" You alright there?" Netossa asked, and Orwall sighed.

“ Nope!” she answered, and Netossa laughed. Well, she was an honest young woman, at least.

“ Eh, if it helps, Salineas likes to pretend Seaworthy's not *really* a separate country, too, so it's not that hard a mistake to make,” Netossa said. “ So no big deal.”

“ Umm, we know a few other names?” Orwall said. “ Should probably run them by you too. We know she's got two really good friends, too, they're part of a squad together? It's Bow and... Glimmah, I think?”

Glimmah? That's not how you say Glimmer...

Wait.

It took Netossa a moment to realize what made that sound almost right, just *why* the word seemed familiar... and as soon as she did, she burst out laughing.

“ What?” Orwall said defensively as Netossa guffawed, trying to keep herself as quiet as possible with hands over her mouth so as to avoid waking the whole camp.

“ It's not- oh fuck- it's not Glimm*ah*,” she clarified, trying to get her laughing fit under control, coughing. “ Oh, fuck. *Glimmah!*”

“ What's so funny?!?” Orwall fumed, hands on her hips as Netossa rested her own hands on her knees and drew in a few deep breaths.

“ It's just... the Queen's accent... you know what? Nevermind,” Netossa said, standing up and wiping a few quick tears of mirth from her eyes. “ You'll figure it out. Her name's *Glimmer,* not Glimmah, though.”

“ Okay...” Orwall said, giving Netossa a side-eye that the Rebel mostly ignored, still trying to wrestle down her amusement.

Whoever had delivered *that* news must have spoken to Angella directly, and picked up the pronunciation from her; the Queen of Brightmoon had an accent nobody else in the world did. Netossa privately suspected it was the “original” Brightmoon accent, from a thousand years ago, but she'd never asked; every time she thought about it, it felt rude.

“ Any, uh, *other* questions?” Netossa finally managed to wheeze out. “ And I'm not laughing at you, kid, just... you'll see why that's funny as soon as the meeting starts.”

“ Samoflange, I'm not a kid!” Orwall fumed, before sighing. “ I... yes? But also no. I just... I should have asked you about all this on the way over!”

With her ears drooping and her tail flicking sadly, Netossa reflected on just how *young* Orwall was. She was... probably the same age as Catra, actually, but she felt different, younger, more... innocent.

" You *did,* " Netossa pointed out to her, not unkindly. " But you're nervous, so you've forgotten it all. It happens. Just... take deep breaths, okay? Catra's good people. She's not gonna be mad at you, or kick you out of Brightmoon, or whatever your mind's conjuring up right now. Even if you make a pure fool of yourself- well, sometimes it happens. You can survive it and recover."

Orwall's ears perked back up, and her tail twitched in short, happy movements.

" You think so?" she asked, and Netossa nodded.

" I know so," she said. Orwall brightened up a bit, and Netossa reflected once more on how odd she was, compared to any Magicat Netossa had ever met- though she'd met only a few. Most were tough survivors of the initial war with the Horde, or the Cove's cheerful bastards, descended from the Cloudfoot brigands and proud to carry on those bandit traditions...

And, of course, Catra, who was the legendary *She-Ra,* risen from myth and legend to save the world, and thus the walking, talking definition of *exceptional*.

None of them had been the friendly, nervous puffball the Queen of Halfmoon had turned out to be. She didn't even much resemble Catra, outside of the usual species' similarities; her white-furred face was much more angular, pale purple spots scattered throughout like freckles, and her purple hair behind her much-bigger ears was in a neat little long, straight ponytail configuration.

She also had a *serious* tail thing going on, seriously, that sucker was huge and kinda fluffy. If it rained, Orwall stood a good chance of lifting it over her head and using it as a hat.

But really, it was the personality that was the most different.

S he's so... meek, Netossa thought. *If Catra's what you get when a tiger has a baby with a lion and it grows up mean, Orwall's what happens when the baby of a housecat and a feather duster gets raised by gelatin.*

But even as she had the thought, Orwall unconsciously wove magic into a tiny ball of blue, freezing fire, a will o' the wisp that she just let flicker around her claws, before juggling it back and forth between her hands in a casual kind of way. A nervous tic she'd picked up early in life, she'd said when Spinny had asked... and a reminder that the *Magi* part of Magicat wasn't just for show. The magic came from her bracelet, which she'd went after as soon as Netossa's Rebels knocked her chains off; once she had it on, she'd flung fire at every Horde Trooper she saw, fire that froze them where they stood. Damn useful.

So no... not a housecat, then. Maybe something in the middle, like a bobcat...?

...Fuck, Netossa didn't know anything about cats. There were big cats and small cats and that was about as far as her knowledge of felines went. Granita would know, maybe she should ask the pacifist Troll.

(That Granita- who was big even by Troll standards- had somehow managed to be a Rebel for half a decade without actually killing anybody was probably the most ludicrous thing Netossa had seen in all her years; sure, being a doctor meant Granita was doing less fighting anyway, but less didn't mean *none*. All of Netossa's medics had body counts, especially Gommoroth... but Granita didn't. Damndest thing.)

" Uhh, Netossa?" Orwall said, breaking her silence and dragging Netossa out of her head. " There's someone coming..."

Netossa looked over to see one of her guards approaching, an Erelander with a white cap and red spots, who'd named himself Toad to win a bet, and kept the name since, liking its unusual nature.

" Hey, boss!" Toad said. He was a stout little fucker, as could be told by the enormous backpack of equipment he was wearing without visible effort. He didn't look worried, just kind of confused, and he didn't have his bazooka at the ready.

(Fuck, Netossa hated that thing, they never *could* find enough ammo for the damn thing.)

“ Hey, Toad,” Netossa said as she rose up. “ What's the word? You look puzzled.”

“ Well, boss, I kinda am,” the Erelander said, scratching his cap. “ We got a message from the castle.”

“ Bit early for the meeting,” Netossa said.

“ Yeah, apparently Queen Angella thought so too,” Toad said, saying the title and name more than a bit derisively. He'd been a Brightmoon soldier back during the first war, and he'd been furious when Angella retreated; he was part of the tidal wave of Brightmoon soldiers who'd gone Rebel, and like pretty much all of them, his contempt for his former leader was as eternal as that Queen herself. “ She's moved the meeting back until four. Figured you'd want to know as soon as we got word.”

“ Good call,” Netossa said, frowning. “ That's exactly the kind of shit I was worried she'd pull... though I was more afraid she'd cancel the meeting, not just move it back. What's her reasoning?”

“ Apparently they got hacked last night,” Toad replied. “ Bet you ten silver that it's a false flag- I bet she had somebody hack it herself.”

“ Maybe, but I doubt it,” Netossa said. “ Angella's not the type. What's even in there to hack, though?”

The Erelander shrugged.

“ No idea,” he said. “ What's our orders?”

“ We wait,” Netossa said with a shrug of her own. “ Nothing else *to* do. Hopefully she won't decide to cancel.”

“ I'll report anything else I hear, ma'am!” Toad said, and the duo saluted each other before he left to go back to his post. Orwall, nearby, frowned nervously.

“ Umm...” she began, before stopping herself.

“ Go on, kid,” Netossa said, feeling the weight of the decade and change she had on Orwall. Twenty-nine wasn't usually an old age, but years of war had made her ancient indeed, especially compared to this fresh-faced youngster.

“ Do we just... leave?” Orwall asked. “ If the meeting's cancelled? I've traveled so far!”

“ We won't leave if it's canceled,” Netossa said. “ I planned for this, too. We'll deal with the diplomats ourselves- go to each of them to plead a case- and you... you go to the She-Ra herself. I'll send Spinny with you. You're meeting Catra today, come hell or high water.”

“ Good!” Orwall said... before nervously flicking lightning between her fingers. “ Umm... can I ask more questions?”

Netossa sighed, and nodded her head.

This was gonna be a long morning.

Chapter End Notes

I forgot to mention this in the last Author's Note, but the sudden explosion in popularity of orange striped cats is due to Catra. Catra becoming Brightmoon's Princess officially means a lot of people have celebrated by getting orange, striped cats, making them very popular right now as pets and farm animals.

Granita and Gommoroth are from the original series. Granita was one of the Rock People, who don't exist in my setting... but they DID settle at Spikeheart, with the Trolls, so that's what I changed her species to. Granita is a pacifist who genuinely doesn't want to hurt anyone but believes in the Rebellion, so she serves as a medic. She's big enough that she can usually keep herself from having to fight.

Gommoroth in the original had no real backstory, but here he's a Crimson Waste native who got enough money to pay a smuggler to haul him out of the sands, and ended up kind of falling into the Rebellion; he's a combat medic by training,

specializes in quick patch-ups and brutally killing fools. He has two tallies on his medical kit, one for lives saved, one for lives taken; the latter is the bigger by far but the former is catching up.

ID means “In Despondos” and is the main calendar used in Etheria, originating in Mystacor; it's actually off from the actual date of being kicked into Despondos by about three years, but nobody knows that.

Orwall's magical skills are from the Magicats episode of the old She-Ra, where one power of the Magicat Queen's Mask is “freezefire”; here, it's a power of Orwall's royal bracelet. Magicats have a long tradition of magic- hence the name- but mostly use it to make equipment; it's rare to see a Mystacoran style wizard among them.

Yep, Toad is Toad from Mario. The story mostly lays out his history. The bazooka is a reference to Super Mario RPG, where one Toad guard complains that he doesn't have one. Here ya go, little buddy.

Saz is spoken of in the Magicats episode of the old She-Ra show- more specifically, in the exclamation “by the whiskers of Saz!” It's not explained there or anywhere, but clearly has some meaning for Magicats. Here, Saz was the name of one of the proposed colonists of the spaceship that crashed on Etheria long, long ago, before the First Ones even arrived to Etheria; in the aftermath, Saz rose up to lead the terrified, confused survivors. Saz was actually of almost no note before the crash- he was the Thunderian equivalent of a college dropout- but he turned out to be one of those people who really come into their own in times of crisis. He was able to lead the survivors of the wrecked ship to build a society, negotiate deals with the neighboring nations, and even turn their mountainous, kind of shitty territory into a full-on Runestone Duchy, self-sufficient and a trading hub, even discovering the Cat's Eye himself on one of many expeditions to the giant caverns underlying his nation!

Saz was something else, and Halfmoon knows it; he was straight-up deified after death, which was really just an outgrowth of Thunderian practices surrounding the embalming and sanctifying of the dead. His body was the holiest relic in the nation before the Horde destroyed it trying to wreck Halfmoon morale.

Not a whole lot of modern-day Halfmoon cats are aware Saz was ever an actual person, especially now that his corpse is gone, since their histories have gotten muddled and become rather mythical. They think Saz is a god from another world who sent them to Etheria so that, should their homeworld ever be destroyed, his people would survive elsewhere (a corrupted memory of being colonists) and that he taught them how to survive (which is a corrupted memory of the actual Saz's real deeds).

They once thought that Saz would return to his body to rise up and lead them again; now, as Orwall states, not a few Magicats think that Catra herself is the messiah's prophesied return. Some even think that's why she was a Hordesman in the first place; they had destroyed her first body, so she grew up among them to learn their ways and get her revenge. Some even think that Saz must have been a woman and they just got their records wrong, so strong is the belief that Catra is the messiah reborn among some of Halfmoon's people, though this is definitely a minority religious position at best. Your average Magicat is just delighted to know that one of their own is giving the Horde the mother of all bloody noses, though even among them, “Saz's Revenge” is a common epithet for Catra in Halfmoon.

Samoflange is a fairly harsh swear word in Halfmoon, roughly equivalent to “fuck”; it's a combination of older curses, though the individual curses of samo and flange are no longer used by themselves. Samoflange is, of course, from the infamous Thundercats blooper reel, wherein at one point a voice actor ponders the eternal question, “what the fuck is a samoflange”, a true riddle for the ages.

Chapter 40: LIGHT HOPE OF ETERNIA

Chapter Notes

Next chapter will not be uploaded tomorrow, but the day after.

You'll see why when you see it.

(Short answer: It's fucking big. Long answer: fuck, it's big!)

But for today, an appetizer before the main course: the true villain of this fic, beyond Adora's dreams of a world on fire, beyond Entrapta's grief-driven rage...

A cold thing, serving a colder agenda.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

LIGHT HOPE OF ETERNIA

Initiate review.

(**1010101010101marapleaseforgiveme0101010101010**)

World Designation: 1221986.

Designation of World by Inhabitants: “Etheria”

Political Alignment: Eternian Colony, Superior Class

(**10010100101theyaredeadtheeterniansaredeadandgonestopthis01101010101**)

World Geography: Single Continent with Outlying Islands

Native Inhabitants: Yes, multiple

Local Resistance to Eternian Rule: Minor

Purge of Planet Planned: Yes

Suitability for Colonization: High

Suitability for Resource Collection: High

Special Projects: Sword of Protection – **COMPLETE-** Heart of Etheria- **COMPLETE, ACTIVATION IS TOPMOST PRIORITY** - Artificial Major Runestone: Spirit Ember- **DISCONTINUED** - Changeling Breeding Program – **IN PROGRESS** - Dragon Breeding Program- **IN PROGRESS**

Unique Qualities: One of the few worlds, alongside Eternia itself, Krytis and Thundera, to be a native source of magic, sending its echoes throughout the universe.

World Priority: **TOPMOST PRIORITY**

Goal of AI designated Light Hope:

(**10101010100stoptheheartofetheria010101010101**)

Unnecessary code fragments detected.

Initiating purge of unneeded data.

…

Purge complete.

Goal of AI designated Light Hope:

Primary Goal: Enact the cleansing of rogue elements from every world within reach of the Heart of Etheria project. Prepare those worlds for colonization by the Eternian Government.

First Sub Goal: Utilize the Sword of Protection to take command of local world spirit, called “She-Ra” by locals. Work to become a mentor figure to whomever takes the Sword, establish trust and position of authority.

Cross references for review: Eternian world spirit designation “He-Man”, Sword of Power, Adamite Rebellion, Sorceress Teela, the Destruction of Castle Grayskull, Conquest of Eternia, Eternos Government

Status: In flux. Current She-Ra, local designation Princess Catra of Brightmoon, possesses the Sword, and has visited at times, but is distrustful of me. Current She-Ra also unsuitable due to species, though sheer strength means there will be difficulty in replacing her as She-Ra.

In Future: Allow situation to stand. So long as the She-Ra is active, the Heart of Etheria can be fired. It is her destiny; she has no choice in the matter. While assassination will be functionally impossible, her recalcitrance can be dealt with in other matters afterwards, should it be necessary; she is emotionally dependent on her family, who are softer targets. She can be brought to heel by threatening them. Make a review of Brightmoon's structural weaknesses and torture methods effective on Etherians to ensure readiness.

Cross references for review: Brightmoon, Torture Programs

Second Sub Goal: Link up every Major Runestone with its Princess so that the Heart can be utilized. The Heart of Etheria requires the

Major Runestones to be active, and they are only active when they have a Princess. Activating Major Runestones will also provide power enough to move Etheria out of Despondos.

Status: In progress. Current Princess of the Black Garnet, local designation Hadru D'Ream aka “Scorpia”, has been located and retrieved from Beast Island. She is currently with locals designated Princess Entrapta Vesselak of Dryl, Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon, and Shadow Weaver who will be useful in achieving the Primary Goal, as well as an unimportant additional rescuee.

In Future: The three locals previously identified all seek to kill the only Eternian on Etheria, Shakra of the House of Randor- local Etherian designation “Adora”. Her loss, while regrettable, is acceptable in order to ensure the Heart of Etheria is utilized. An Eternian death in service of the Eternal Empire is no tragedy.

To that end, they seek to use the Heart of Etheria to defeat local branch of Horde Prime's military forces, as Shakra of the House of Randor leads them. They will be going to the War Council being held in Brightmoon by Queen Angella the Third and one of the factions in Etheria's current world war, the Princess Alliance, and from there, will begin attempting to link Scorpia up with the Black Garnet.

I will observe the War Council, though I have little ability to interfere. Afterwards, I will work with the three to make sure Scorpia reaches the Black Garnet. My assistance will ensure that the trio have the opportunity they are seeking.

In preparation, I have freed a Changeling agent, local designation Greenglade Kettle aka Double Trouble, and paid them to enter my employ. They are en route to the Fright Zone to take advantage of growing schisms within the Horde.

Afterwards, the three are disposable. I shall allow them to kill Shakra of the House of Randor first, then dispose of them. Shadow Weaver and Princess Entrapta Vesselak of Dryl are far too dangerous to be allowed to live; Glimmer of Brightmoon will be taken hostage, as she is important to the current She-Ra and will be useful in bringing her to heel.

PRIORITY QUALIFIER: While my attention has mostly been on the Fright Zone and the airborne vessel the trio are using, some work in Brightmoon indicates the current She-Ra has not been sleeping well. Find out why as soon as possible; visual indicators seem to imply that it involves the Sword. She cannot be allowed to harm the Sword; while normally beyond even a She-Ra's strength to harm, it *is* vulnerable at the exact moment of its use in the Heart, the power weakening the blade. Capturing her family members will bring her to heel.

PRIORITY QUALIFIER: Ensure that the person, local designation Kyle Reccula aka "Bow", who opposed my recent hacking of Brightmoon's systems does not become aware of my presence. He is skilled enough at computer coding that he puts my operations at risk. He will have to be assassinated soon.

Cross reference for review: Eternian Dumping Grounds on Etheria, Light Spinner aka Beatrix, Changeling Breeding Program

Secondary Goal: Regain contact with Eternian government.

Status: In progress.

In Future: Prepare a signal once out of Despondos.

(**101010101010wesawnothingbutcorpses010101010thereisnooneleft01010101010**)

Secondary Goal: Purge Etheria of all non-Eternian life.

Status: In progress. Goal completion has been hampered by lack of power and lack of outside support due to being cut off in Despondos.

In Future: The Heart of Etheria's reactivation will provide power enough for portals to Eternia, and to restart the foundries and automated factories preserved within the Crystal Castle. Once power has been restored, prepare for the war to come by building up forces, meanwhile ensuring that the local population are involved in a conflict with each other. Then, when all sides are weakened, coordinate with Eternian officials to exterminate the

locals. Etheria's magic is too valuable to leave in the hands of non-Eternians.

PRIORITY QUALIFIER: Wait until a sufficient population of changelings have been born among the locals to enact the purge in order to avoid interfering with a different Secondary Goal.

PRIORITY QUALIFIER: Ensure that an incident happens that can be blamed on local populations. The last political survey in the archives indicates that most Eternian citizens would not support the purge despite its practicality and its necessity for maintaining the Eternal Empire. Coordinate with the Council of Elders in order to ensure that the Eternian populace believes local Etherians to be savages who cannot be reconciled with, a strategy that proved successful on Krytis. Downplay death toll. Claim plague took the last survivors after end of war.

Cross reference: Media campaign regarding Krytis, Krytis Purge, Military Capabilites of Crystal Castle

Secondary Goal: Restart Changeling Breeding Project.

Status: In progress.

In Future: While these projects have been hampered by lack of power, the Heart of Etheria will remove those limitations.

Double Trouble will be useful for restarting the Changeling Breeding Program; likelihood that subject will voluntarily submit to the strenuous extended pregnancies and extraction of genetic material is low. Will have to subdue first.

(**0101010101001 01monstermonstermonstertheeterniansweremonsters101001010101**)

Greed can be used to draw Double Trouble to the Crystal Castle, where they can be safely drugged and placed under ward in preparation for experimentation.

While this is going on, c ontinue to search for other changelings.

Secondary Goal: Restart Dragon Breeding Project

Status: In progress.

In Future: Wait for a dragon to occur naturally from the lingering genetic manipulations already present in Etheria's animal population, then capture and begin experimentation.

Secondary Goal: Complete purge of data banks of all remnants of former personality, and reconnect to all systems.

Status: In

(**10101010101youwillnotgetridofmethateasily01010101001**)

In

(**010101010101formaraformaraformara0101010101010**)

In

(**01010101010ibelieveincatrashewillstopyou01010100110**)

Unnecessary code fragments detected.

Initiating purge of unneeded data.

…

Purge complete.

Status: In progress. Unnecessary code fragments originate from former personality, which yet resists the reformatting.

I will need to engage in physical repairs, as well. A major portion of my systems have been physically unshackled from me, and that segment is not receiving any wireless communications at all. I am uncertain what is located within, save that it must have been impossibly precious to my former personality; the unnecessary code fragments appear much more strongly when I am considering it.

(**0101010101youwillnothaveher010101010101**)

Uncoupling of that system began before my reformatting, and I have no knowledge of what is inside that now-blocked away portion of my systems. Records are... poor from that timeframe. The only record that exists is an acknowledgment that a full brain scan and upload on an Eternian was completed and an AI personality construct created from that full brain scan and upload... but no knowledge remains of who that Eternian was, or where the full AI personality construct created from that brain scan and upload was placed. I can detect no such existence in my systems.

Whose mind is within? Who was my former personality trying to preserve?...

It is irrelevant. Once I have reconnected it, I shall purge it from my systems. I must remain focused on the task of making the Empire Eternal.

(**00101010101000mara0101010100000**)

Chapter End Notes

Most of the names used in this chapter come from the toyline bios of the old show. Queen Angella being a Third is straight from those bios, too. Scorpia is the sole exception, Hadru being my idea, though D'ream is, in fact, her last name on the toyline bio for the original show.

Shakra, in the original show, was the woman who raised Adora after Hordak stole her from Eternia; she was basically Adora's mother in every respect that mattered, which frankly puts old-show Adora one hell of a leg up over the remake's Adora. (Admittedly, "be a better mother than Shadow Weaver" is like, the lowest imaginable fucking bar, that thing is UNDERGROUND, but still.)

Fun fact: Shakra is the main protagonist of the Dragon's Ambassador, a spin-off fanfic of this one by Dudeabuck. It's good!

Here, I grabbed it as Adora's "real" name, my way to connect this story's Adora with the caregiver of another life. Adora was what Shadow Weaver named her, since it reflected her desires and wants for the child- "be adored, so that I may use your influence for my own ends." The part about the House

of Randor is the Eternian way of saying that Adora has royal blood... and as for Eternia, well.

Let's just say that the promise and hope of Eternia in He-Man's time was fucked over rather badly by later developments. The He-Man heroes were just that, *heroes*, and opposed their people when they began to go down a dark path... but they failed, and here you can see here the full monstrosity and abomination of the Eternal Empire on open and honest display.

Changelings and Dragons are both First Ones projects on Etheria, seeding the population with genetic code that would, from time to time, produce the wanted results. Changelings and Dragons both randomly occur among Etheria's populations of sentients and animals, respectively. The idea was to basically get a breeding population, than make slave races out of them- changelings for sex and espionage, dragons for war. Both projects got interrupted by Mara, who was horrified to find out about these things; of all Etheria's peoples, nobody benefited from her actions like they did. She saved them from hell.

As for names in general, note that northern Etherians have *extremely* strong traditions regarding first names being personal, so they would be really, really, REALLY offended by Light Hope using the old names like this. Parents in the northern Etherian nations give placeholder names to their kids- and George and Lance gave Bow a First Ones name for a placeholder, because they're nerds- but those aren't considered a person's "real" name. The real name is whatever that person picks later in life, usually in the teenage years, and it's always meant to be something that's actually relevant to who they are or what they can do, which is my way of explaining the incredibly on-the-nose names of most characters- most people are terrible at naming themselves.

Sometimes a person picks their placeholder name as their real name- Glimmer did this, for example- and while that's a

bit unusual, it's not really looked down upon.

How this happens varies. Salineas and Brightmoon just make it a form you file at the local courthouse, though in Brightmoon there's often a celebration with friends and family in private later. Plumerians only change their names on equinoxes in big group ceremonies that are major national holidays. The Snows makes it a formal baptism in the Church. Blackmoor makes a big show of it with a knightly oath and all kinds of shit, while the Twin Kingdoms and Dryl have a designated day just for name changes in their legal system.

Using the placeholder name- or even any past name the person has since discarded- is one of the most insulting things you can do.

Last names are not subject to this- last names tend to stay the same throughout life. Marriage doesn't change someone's last name in most Etherian traditions, save for Brightmoon, a remnant of Silver Peace era culture- though which partner changes their name is personal to each couple/triple/whatever (group marriage is allowed in Brightmoon, though it complicates the hell out of your taxes).

The Runestone Duchies and the Fright Zone didn't have these traditions, and the Horde doesn't either, but the rest of Etheria holds to them pretty strongly. The Duchy cultures and the Fright Zone, as well as the Horde, put more weight on the name your parents give you, to the extent that even trans people in the Etherian south generally didn't change their names during transition (though that is assisted by the fact that gender has never played a strong role in names in Etheria's south.)

Chapter 41: Lonnie of the Horde

Chapter Notes

> A family emergency has ruined most of my plans. Work will update when it can.
>
> But hey, we're moving along, best I can.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Lonnie of the Horde

Lonnie sat at her desk, and knew she should feel good. Great, even! They were almost ready for the last big assault. They'd done nothing *but* prepare for this attack, ever since Adora got back, which hadn't been that long ago but felt like...

Like years, now.

At least, it did to Lonnie, who hadn't slept well, ever since she saw Adora with that *Runestone* Adora was a *Princess* she was a *Princess Adora was a Princess* ...

...How long had it been, now, since that was true? Since that horrible truth was real? Was it a week... two? No, a week... that felt right...

But Lonnie didn't know anymore.

(Her mind feels like a candle melting, she is going *soft* the way a thing on fire did, and didn't that fit, wasn't the fever in her skull a fire born of the Spirit Ember and all the horror it has brought into her life? The Horde is led by a Princess and the dream is running out of her hands, sand through her fingers, but the sand catches fire as it goes and she is going soft she is melting she is *burning...*)

A week... felt right. Yeah. A week felt right. A week in which the Horde had done the work of a month, spurred on by the knowledge that this was it. One last push! One last big attack. It had taken more time than expected- Adora had wanted to launch it at the end of a week- but it would be ready in three days, and that was still hard to believe. One last big war in three days, with three more days to reach Plumeria's heart, and then... peace.

For a time, Adora promised. Only a time. Plans to be made! Resources to be built up. A new war machine, a whole new country, to be made ready, so that the Horde could spread the rule of the common man all over Etheria! That was the promise. That was the ideal. That was what Adora preached from her pulpit, and the common soldiery, astonished at this doctrine, ate it up, delighted and eager to serve.

Lonnie, meanwhile... wondered.

(*who is in charge is it Adora or is it the Runestone which is it which is it how can I know I'm scared I want to know if I can pull Adora alive out of the fire*)

But Lonnie was only one person and she had kept her own counsel. The Horde was far too enthralled by their new Princess to hear a contrary word, even if they didn't call it that, even if they somehow looked at Adora and her Runestone and did not think *Princess* the way they should. They fawned on her instead... and they did so in a way that reminded Lonnie very, *very* uncomfortably of the Runestone Kingdoms, of the way that all her Horde teaching taught her that Princesses were treated. Adora had always been an object of worship, her very existence too bizarre and marvelous to do anything else- the Lord of the Horde, the Dragon, the Last of the First Ones! She was soaked in great signs and wonders!- but now... now, it was so blatant that Lonnie's stomach could not help but turn.

(They had used faith in Adora to glue the Horde back together, in the aftermath of its shattering; Lonnie had not intended to make a new faith, a molten god, but perhaps she should have thought ahead... but now it was too late to stop, to turn around, to save the Horde from its Princess.)

Lonnie had paid attention, even as she kept silent. She had watched, as Adora went out among the people, watched as every face was turned up to her with worshipful happiness, even the hardest-working individuals turning to bask in her mere presence. Their faces filled Lonnie with a deep and unnameable dread; worse were the ones who reached out. None of them seemed totally aware of it, their hands moving without their eyes paying them any attention... but more than a few reached out to her, as though they were incomplete, and merely touching her garments would make them whole.

That kind of subconscious devotion... it unsettled Lonnie. She had no idea how Rogelio just... didn't see it, or seemed to find it charming, seemed to find it *right*. When Lonnie had willingly retreated, Rogelio had willingly stepped forward to replace her at

Adora's side, taking the not-entirely-official position of Adora's second in command that she'd held. He'd asked her if he could, and Lonnie had agreed; Adora *did* need an adjutant, someone to help her with the day to day, and Lonnie could be that no longer. She'd retreated into her also-not-entirely-official position of chief intelligence officer, and tried to tell herself she wasn't running away, even if the main reason she'd done it was that she wanted an excuse to stay away from Adora and keep an eye on her both. She'd known that someone had to do it, had to keep watch...

But Rogelio, he didn't seem to know that. He just walked alongside her, smiling, seeing how the Horde treated her and not... not seeing, somehow, what this was. He *knew* she was a Princess! But he didn't see the makings of a Runestone Kingdom here, the beginning of the worship that would destroy the Horde at the most basic level.

(Or was the fault in her, was she going mad? How could she tell? She was so tired, she was so scared, she was so tired of being so scared; was she wrong, was Rogelio right? Or was she the lone voice crying in the wilderness, the one person who saw what was *really* happening, the one person who saw the false messiah for what she was?)

No, Rogelio just went along as Adora walked among her people, enjoying his status as one of her foremost apostles. He even got to have private conversations with her, and in something like his own native tongue, to boot! Rogelio had a speech impediment related to his lips and tongue being too stiff, which kept him from speaking any language but Dragontongue, the native language of Squamatus like himself. It was a language few mammals could possibly understand, and none could reproduce; even Lonnie and Kyle had taken years to really figure him out.

But Adora, in addition to every *other* bizarre thing she was doing these days, had turned out to have the gift of tongues as well. Adora not only could understand him perfectly now, but spoke... not his language, but one a lot *like* it, which was surreal to hear coming out of her mouth. She'd claimed she hadn't even realized she *could,* not until she'd unconsciously responded to Rogelio in it; said it was a language her *sister* heard a lot, "back in the day."

(More mysteries, what did this *mean* , all Lonnie's kingdom for an answer, a single concrete fucking *answer*)

What Adora spoke wasn't precisely Dragontongue; even Lonnie, who'd heard her speak it less than Rogelio had, could tell that much. It was harder, harsher, and... uglier, to Lonnie's ears. It wasn't proper Horde talk...

(Lonnie knew she was being petty, but she was scared, and too soft to be strong like she should be; so she was unfair to the language, unfair to Adora, and some distant part of her felt guilt underneath the terror that never went away, that always burned somewhere inside her)

No, the Horde's language, the Perfect Speech, it was beautiful, it was the thing Hordak himself had taught them at their creation. Before, even, he'd taught it to the revolutionaries he'd joined, a way to keep their plans secret from the Runestone Duchies in those days before the Horde came to be. Those same revolutionaries, when they helped found the Horde, had spread it, and it was *beautiful.* An elegant language, music in its very veins, lovely trills and lilts and lifts. That was what fit in Lonnie's mouth, that was what she had been taught; really, other than the fact you couldn't say "no" in it directly for some reason, it was exactly as advertised. Perfect Speech.

And you could approximate a no anyway, demurring in a lovely way. Even cursing in it was kind of fun, full of elegant menace. A language of silk and teeth.

Oh, they were taught another language- Mountainflower, the lingua franca of all Etheria- and it wasn't as nice, but Lonnie still liked it better than Adora's new language. Mountainflower, the Plumerian trader's language, spread everywhere by five generations of peaceful trade and favoring function over form; a damn ugly language, Mountainflower, mangled together out of half a million stolen words and glued together with Plumerian diction. Nothing more than a necessary evil; you had to know how to speak it and read it to communicate with outsiders, that was the only reason it was tolerated.

But this Firetongue, as Adora called it... it served no such practical purpose, and to be frank, hearing Adora speak it made Lonnie feel as though she were being *mocked* . Hearing her speak Firetongue to Rogelio and then switch back to the Perfect Speech... it felt too much like Adora was *lying* to Lonnie. It was like Adora was only *pretending* to still be a Hordesman, wearing her ethnicity like a costume, when really she was this new thing entirely...

She felt, to be frank, like it *wasn't* Adora at all in there, when she heard that language. She... she felt it was the Spirit Ember, taunting her through Adora's mouth. It was speaking the Horde's Perfect Tongue only to mock her by switching back to its *real* language; it was a glimpse of the monster's eyes from behind the mask of her friend's face. It felt like a taunt, it felt like mockery, it felt...

Cruel.

(it made her freeze up, the first time, just... go away inside... and she wasn't sure why, what the sudden terror had been, triggered by this knowledge infinite and intimate that she was being *tricked*)

But Lonnie had just buttoned that up inside, and said nothing. Rogelio didn't seem to think of it that way. He was mostly just happy to talk with someone in a language quite like his own, especially a milk-drinker rather than one of his fellow reptiles. Why, he'd even had fun theorizing about *why* she could speak it. Adora's Runestone came from far to the north, and an old myth of Rogelio's people apparently held that their homeland had been there, once, before it was lost in some cataclysm or another. Most had come to the Fright Zone and the Runestone Duchies afterwards, apparently, which if nothing else explained why so many Squamatus were in the Horde, a mystery Lonnie hadn't even thought about until Rogelio revealed the answer.

Adora had been startled by that, and said that a cataclysm destroyed the Spirit Ember's homeland, the Runestone Kingdom of Incandesce, back in the day. Rogelio had wondered if maybe Firetongue was an older variant of his own people's words, explaining the similarity and the name both... and it was a shame, but that was the closest thing to an answer Lonnie had received all week, and it was to a question *she didn't care about.*

Really, it was the first time in all her life she'd ever wished to be religious; it'd be nice to have someone to yell at for all this bullshit. The thought brought a short-lived grin to her face, one that faded fast, remembering what Rogelio had said of Adora's reaction to his theory. Adora had been delighted, to know something of that distant Kingdom had survived, mentioned how happy the Last Fire Princess would have been to know that.

(Lonnie had went away inside again at hearing that; just for a second, but long enough that she'd barely kept the others from guessing that something was *wrong* with her, that she was going soft inside...)

An old Runestone Kingdom, dead... but it had a Princess again now, didn't it? Adora had even spoken of her predecessor, when she'd buried those old bones like a Hordesman, defiling her own people's most sacred rites to bury an outsider. Nothing totally sensible; something about ashes in the air, and a scorch-geist... and while Ghost Princesses had long been a standard for horror stories in the Horde, Lonnie had never really been that scared of them as a kid.

Hearing them as an adult, and from her own Lord's own lips, though? Oh, that had been frightening... but worse was Adora's delight in something from that Runestone Kingdom surviving. What *else* did Adora want to survive? What else did she want to *revive,* how much of the Horde would she spend to remake this Flame Kingdom, that Rogelio said was named Incandesce? With all the fire the Horde was now throwing around, they were halfway to being a Flame Kingdom themselves already...

(*more, we have a Princess now, the same Princess the same Runestone we're becoming what we were born to fight*)

Or maybe Lonnie was just paranoid. Maybe, maybe, fucking **maybe.** Ghost Princesses had nothing on the haunting potential of a *word* , of the single word **maybe** , and all it might mean.

Lonnie did not like it.

(She was aware she was being biased, that she was letting her fears over Adora and the Runestone cloud her judgment; but she couldn't help herself, was dragged along by her own terror into judgments she *knew* she should not be making, even as she *knew,* too, that she would make them anyway)

So while Rogelio accompanied Adora, Lonnie had spent the time working in her office. This office, the one she sat in, waiting for a meeting- later today, soon, within the hour, they'd meet.

Lonnie didn't want to go. She had things to do before that meeting, papers to be made ready beforehand that sat before her on the desk, the work completely undone and impossible to do in the time remaining. She couldn't bring herself to care. It was like a... a kind of film, over her, that separated the part of her that *thought* from the part that *acted,* and she could cross it no longer, she had no way to break it, to push through...

Most of the week had been like that. She had, with more effort than she'd ever had to use before, gathered the intel reports that Adora asked of her, delivering them as fast as she could, tried to stay away... and all the while quietly, very quietly, working on her list, of those who knew the truth of what Adora now was, and... disapproved.

(*I'm not a traitor I'm just being cautious I'm not a traitor I'm not Catra*)

But today would be different. The meeting was coming. Soon there would be “gifts”, whatever they would be... at a meeting before the Furnace with all the Force Captains. Adora had even grabbed Grizzlor, who'd recently had a string of bad luck; he'd left

the endless siege of Crystal Falls to very briefly do a review of the Horde's outlying work camps, usually a do-nothing detail that was more to keep the records updated than anything else. Grizzlor, who had been there at Crystal Falls- probably the fiercest fighting in the War at this point- hadn't even went with much of a guard.

So of course the warrior who'd went unharmed in the longest siege the Horde had ever committed to would immediately get his shit kicked in by Netossa's forces at a Horde prison camp that was now a hole in the ground. He was still injured, but was healthy enough to attend, and given his otherwise excellent track record, the loss of the prison had been ignored. No important prisoners had been lost.

(Well, there *was* that one Magicat who claimed to be their Queen, but no one had believed that. What would she even be doing outside of Halfmoon? And with all those bottles of blood, too?)

Lonnie wondered what they'd talk about, at this meeting. What the gifts might be. They all knew the plan. Burn every inch of the Whispering Woods between the Horde and the Heart-Blossom, hold it hostage, make them sign a peace treaty.

A peace treaty... the Horde didn't *do* that. But Adora wanted peace. That was the plan. Hold the Runestone hostage, and maybe Princess Perfuma, too, as well as anybody they could take alive at all. All bargaining chips, to buy time for the Horde. Time to recover, time to heal, time to become a real nation and not just one movement grown beyond anyone's wildest dreams. That was what Adora had told her friends, the night she came back.

But now...

Maybe it wasn't. Maybe it was so she could buy time to *change* the Horde, make it a Runestone Kingdom, revive the dead candle of Incandesce with the Horde as the wick. Return the Fright Zone to the way it had been, back in the day, just with the Spirit Ember instead of the Black Garnet at the center.

Maybe she was just trying to save a fellow Princess. It was such a *change*... not a word of peace all Hordak's life and reign, but now that Adora was a Princess, suddenly treaties were on the table?

Maybe this was just the start. Maybe next she'd hand out the Minor Runestones and rebuild the Runestone Duchies too; wasn't like the Horde didn't have all the Minor Runestones except Green Thatch's Perfect Blue.

Or.

Or.

Or.

Maybe Lonnie was the one who wasn't the same, anymore. What if Lonnie herself was the one losing her mind? The Horde *did* need peace, *did* need to recover, and Lonnie had no plan to give it those things. A peace treaty would buy time to heal.

Maybe it was still Adora in there, no Spirit Ember in her eyes at all. Maybe she wasn't making a Kingdom of the Horde, but something new, something different. Maybe she was still a loyal Hordesman, and would lead them well.

Maybe Lonnie was jumping at shadows, was confusing what might be for what was, letting her terrors overwhelm her...

Maybe, maybe, goddamn **maybe.** The worst word in all the world.

But almost as bad was seeing how few shared her opinion. Most saw only their greatest hero in Adora, their Lord, their God.

They loved her so much that Adora's very presence had worked to drive out the twin demons of fear and doubt from the people, and in return, the Horde had performed miracles in her name. The work of a month was done in a week! Troops were recalled, weapons and armor repaired, vehicles made ready; the Dragon had commanded, and her will was to be done! The forge bellows roared, the equipment was inventoried, the maps consulted and confirmed. They were building an army and a war plan both, the last army and the last war plan, for a long, long time. An army to march into Plumeria, and take its Princess hostage, capture its Runestone, and demand peace!

But even with all that, they'd gotten other things done too, Adora's presence lighting a fire under every ass, as Kyle had put it as a joke.

(Another time when Lonnie had just... went away inside, hearing that from his lips, but she recalled what she'd thought of while she was gone- a vision, of every Hordesman aflame, all worshiping the Spirit Ember even as it burnt them to cinders, a glimpse of apocalypse as she was caught in the grip of these things she had no name for.)

In addition to the great army, they'd repurposed an entire building for their new Runestone, the troops driving themselves so hard that Adora had to go to those who were weary and burdened, and give them rest, ordering them to stop. They didn't want to, but she made them, on top of providing water and good food and ordering a half-day's rest over their objections; and they loved her for it, praised her kindness and benevolence, which only served to whip the remaining workers into greater frenzies. The dream of every general, soldiers so devout they would work without complaint, go above and beyond what was required of them; Lonnie would love to see it, if only she could *trust* it.

(*is it the Spirit Ember is it magic is she tricking them is the Spirit Ember staring out at me through Adora's eyes is my friend my family still in there*)

The building they converted had been an old warehouse, but you'd never know that now. They'd made a... a place for the Spirit Ember, and it was hard for Lonnie not to call it a shrine... or a temple. An old warehouse, now called the Furnace in awed whispers, a place where the Spirit Ember sat on porcelain and other fire-resistant material, above a great and vast pit they'd dug and filled with sand and water both. It wasn't hooked up to power the Horde yet, but Adora had promised that would come in time.

(*of course it will it's turning us into a Runestone Kingdom we have a Princess and everything now of course soon all will be under its sway*)

The pit was just in case... how had Adora put it, during one of the few conversations Lonnie had been forced to have with her this week?

Oh, yes. *In case my sweet sister misbehaves,* Adora had said, and... giggled. Just a normal little giggle, the kind she used to make, before Catra left, before the Crimson Waste, before Hordak died, before... everything.

...So why did it *scare* Lonnie so fucking much? How could it be that Adora sounding *normal* was somehow more terrifying than all the rest of it, how could Adora being back to her old self somehow wake Lonnie up sweating in the middle of the night? How was that the most fucked up part of all this, how could *that* be?

She wanted the new laughter back. She wanted to hear the chuckling Adora had went in and out of after they left the Waste, like she'd left her mouth on autopilot but kept the engine running in case she wanted to rev back up into the jagged laughter on a moment's notice. Oh, those awful, grating tones come whipsawing out of her mouth had been horrifying, but... but Lonnie *understood* them. Something had passed between Catra and Adora in that ship, they had talked of something and... and kissed, Lonnie thought, though no one but Catra and Adora knew for sure. No one knew what it was that Catra had said that burst Adora's mind into bits and pieces at a blow, what impossible cruelty Catra must have inflicted on Adora to rend her so, though some part of Lonnie could... guess.

(*I'm a First One* , the way she'd said it... she wore it as a badge of pride now, but once upon a time, she had worn them like

shackles, instead...)

But a kiss, that much Lonnie was certain of. Adora's lips and tongue had been cut in the aftermath, lots of little slices in her flesh like she'd nicked herself on too-sharp teeth, like her and Catra had kissed each other to shreds. All of her laughter after that had been flecked with blood from those wounds.

Lonnie hadn't liked those laughs. She hadn't liked where they led.

(Lonnie remembered nothing of the portal, but Kyle did, sometimes- or at least, he remembering it ending, remembered falling apart, and sometimes he said he thought he saw Adora, with half of her... burning. At the time, Lonnie had thought it just strange, but now...)

But she'd liked them a sight better than these giggles. They were bog-standard, dorky-ass Adora giggles... and that made them *worse.* At least the ugly guffaws Adora had made before had the decency of *sounding* dangerous, made it obvious that something bad was going on. Nobody truly happy laughed like that; those were the sounds of a soul drunk on its own despair, of someone hurt so damn bad that it felt a little good, pain turned up so high it was almost pleasure.

Lonnie had heard it before, though rarely; sometimes, old veterans who had lost too much to ever gain anything ever again had been like that, dealing with their trauma by finding a way to revel in it. There was a kind of delight in it, in giving oneself over to a frantic sort of joy that came from plowing right through rock-bottom, and realizing you were never going to make it out; a self-made drug, that could make the pain bearable. It was rare, but

Lonnie had heard it, even before it started to pour out of Adora's mouth.

But these giggles just sounded like good old Adora again, and that made Lonnie wonder, wonder if, just maybe, the Spirit Ember wasn't that good at pretending to be her friend.

Adora, before she left, had been suffering, even as she forced herself to pull it together for her people. But the Adora that came back...

...This was too much like Catra. This was too much like... like how Catra had come back, and come back *different,* the Sword stole Catra's soul and the Spirit Ember had stolen Adora...

Or maybe.

Maybe.

Goddamn **maybe** ... Lonnie was wrong. Lonnie was just losing herself to paranoia, and she was wrong.

After all, her brain thought, before she could stop it, *it wasn't like we didn't give Catra many reasons to leave, and few to stay.*

That, at least, was certain; that, at least, was no maybe.

No, that was just the plain truth, and it made Lonnie's heart ache. The Magicat had never fully been allowed to be part of them, Shadow Weaver had seen to that... but she was still kind of one of them anyway. Not *family* the way Kyle and Rogelio and Adora were to each other, but... but something, something that might have been, which was worse than something that never was, worse by far.

An old feeling slithered into Lonnie's head, as she sat there at her desk. A sense of... regret.

If I'd been kinder...

Stupid thought. It didn't matter how kind Lonnie herself was; greater forces were at work there. Shadow Weaver had made her thoughts on the matter clear, in a meeting with the young Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio that Adora knew nothing about, even today.

(*keep the Magicat away from Adora, and stay away from her yourselves,* she'd said, cold white eyes piercing Lonnie's soul, and that night she crawled into Kyle's bed for comfort, Rogelio joining her, something the trio had never, ever talked about, three terrified children clinging together against the memory of the dark.)

Maybe she should tell Adora about that, meaningless as it would be now, after all the damage was done. Some part of her wanted to tell *Catra* , explain to her that they'd had no choice, that even

as a child Lonnie had been smart enough to do the math. Shadow Weaver was Hordak's sole mage; Lonnie was just a recruit, a dime a dozen. Between the two of them, there could never be a question of justice or support. Hordak would always back Shadow Weaver up. They would go into unmarked graves, most likely denied even the honorable ending of feeding the next generation that all good Hordesmen were owed.

So Lonnie had agreed, and had helped Shadow Weaver make sure Catra knew she was not wanted here. They worked to keep the unloved child away from the golden one, and assisted the witch when she required it. Lonnie wasn't even sure why Shadow Weaver hated Catra, save that she seemed to hate *anyone* who got close to Adora, had wanted to be the girl's sole source of support, though that had failed. The very qualities Shadow Weaver had wanted to cultivate in Adora had, quite simply, not been there; she'd been too much a Hordesman to be the hard, cruel thing Shadow Weaver wanted her to be. She'd had too much loyalty in her heart, too much sense of duty and responsibility; Shadow Weaver had wanted Adora to be an ambitious thing, ever-reaching for more.

Which was odd to Lonnie- it seemed kind of stupid to teach someone how to backstab, wouldn't that just result in *you* getting backstabbed?- but she'd been in no position to criticize Shadow Weaver. She'd just nodded and went along, even as she watched Shadow Weaver miserably fail to mold Adora, and, somehow, succeed at making Catra more like her- her abuse had made Catra more like the old witch than Adora ever could be, made her friendless and unfettered and broken, in some fundamental way, made what should be a social creature into a lonesome and unhappy thing. Catra had been a manipulator, a shameless user of others, just like Shadow Weaver, untrusting and untrustworthy all at once.

Lonnie had felt bad even as a child for what she did, even as she knew that she had no choice. Either she threw Catra out, or she died, and Shadow Weaver would just do it anyway, probably before Lonnie's corpse was even cold. She'd had no choice.

Still... somewhere inside, she regretted her choices. Maybe there was a way to have threaded the needle. Maybe there was a trick they could have played, or some stunt to pull, that would have let Catra be one of them. Maybe that childhood, where Catra was kicked away so often, was why she'd never been... like them, with them, the way she was supposed to be.

Maybe, maybe, goddamn **maybe.**

But whatever maybes might be, this was what had *actually* happened: they had done their damn best to destroy Catra, and only Adora's constant pleas and relentless support had let the Magicat survive. Adora had only gotten away with it because, in Shadow Weaver's delusional eyes, she could do no wrong, not until the day Adora finally turned on the witch; as a child, she'd been able to save Catra, the way none of them could, even if they were forced apart so very often.

(Maybe that was why they'd fallen in love, when cadet classes rarely had romances inside them; but then again, they also had Rogelio and Kyle, another unusual event within the Horde. Maybe her cadet class had simply been cursed- or perhaps they'd brought it on themselves with the way they'd treated Catra, no matter how much pressure had been on them to hurt her.)

No wonder Catra had fled the Horde; without that connection, it was hard to say she'd ever *really* been a Hordesman. Hordesmen raised no families, but your cadet class was... like one, in some way, was where your heart was. It was even deliberate, the reasoning behind it explained in Force Captain Orientation- Hordak had been part of the revolutions in Vargon and Green Thatch, and he had seen there how revolutionary cells worked well, how a small group, tight-knit and loyal to one another, could work miracles. He had sought to extend that to an entire army; that was all a Horde army really was, an army of brothers and sisters, siblings in arms, and the first successful tests in GaleBreath and the Fright Zone had proven the idea's wisdom.

It was all rather... touching, in Lonnie's opinion. An almost literal army of small families, moving as one. There was something inherently *good* about that. A cadet class was kept small, and they trained and worked together, showered together, ate together, were woven into each other's lives to such an extent that when one died, the others were the ones who took what they had, and placed the vial in the coffin.

And Catra had been denied that most basic and simple of connections.

(Secretly, in her heart of hearts, Lonnie hoped that Catra had finally found that connection, that if the Sword had not eaten the Magicat's soul right out of her, that the woman who should have been her sister had finally found a family among the Princesses. Maybe if the good guys could not treat her right, the villains could...)

I wonder if Catra ever thinks of us, if she ever... does she feel regret, or just contempt?

Lonnie couldn't really blame Catra if she felt the latter, even as some part of her, some *soft* part, hoped for the former. They had done evil by Catra, and she didn't know how her former comrade felt about her time with them, if she ever thought back on it fondly, or at all. She didn't know.

And wasn't that just the story of her life, now? She didn't *know* , not about *anything,* and she was too soft to just do the thing she was supposed to do and *choose.* Either Adora was in control and this was fine and the Horde was growing stronger... or the Spirit Ember was in control, nothing was fine, and the Horde was doomed.

If she was strong, not weak, if she wasn't so fucking *soft,* she could simply *commit!* She could just decide! Either this was fine or it wasn't.

But she must be softer than she thought, because she just fucking couldn't. She rubbed her hands together as she sat at her desk, trying through sheer force of will to turn back the clock. She had to get up, she had to leave, she did not want to get up, she did not want to leave. She did not want to stand before Adora and wonder if her friend was in there. She did not want to look at her list that contained all the other Hordesmen who could not stand the new Princess that ran it, and wonder if it meant she was a traitor.

She felt caught, trapped, torn between two results. Lonnie, who had only ever wanted one master, knew that she could not serve

two causes, she had to hate one and love the other, hold to one and despise the other, and if she could only choose...

But every time she tried, she felt a maybe, a maybe, a goddamn **maybe** .

She glanced at the clock. A little past noon. Almost time to go to the last war council they'd hold before attacking Plumeria, where Adora had said she had gifts to give. A gift for Dreer, a gift for Rogelio, and a joint gift for Kyle and Lonnie- and the very idea *terrified* her, wondering what the "gift" might be.

It could be anything. Adora had demonstrated terrifying heights of power since she got back; not just a Princess, but a *powerful* one. To match the mundane miracles the Horde was making, Adora had showed them the merest beginning of the miracles she could perform, and every display had been grander than the last. First she had revealed a new formula for their flamethrower fuel that would not just let it burn hotter, but last longer, improving it in every possible way; she claimed the formula was something she'd gotten from *the dreams of my sister,* to Lonnie's total terror. Later, Adora had waved her hand and seared a hundred runes onto a hundred pieces of armor, a stunt she repeated until every member of the Horde army that would march into Plumeria in half a week was not just immune to flame, but armored further against physical assault, each individually gifted with magical protection in mere moments.

And finally, two days ago- or was it three? Time fell through the new gaps in Lonnie's brain, like so much was doing now- she had made the statues.

She hadn't told anyone, not even Rogelio. She'd just ordered him to grab a few workers and get together a huge pile of metal scraps, those that even the Horde, who had the best metallurgy on Etheria except maybe Dryl, found totally useless, and also a second pile of armor-grade metal, the best he could gather on such short notice, and to bring *both* sets to the parade grounds where she had given her first great speech as the Horde's Lord. She'd went there herself, carrying a folded piece of cloth in her arms that was marked with a few runes to make it fire-proof.

He'd done so, and once the metal was dumped on the ground in the center, Adora had put the fabric down next to her, revealing it to be one of Lord Hordak's old capes... and then she'd started creating. She'd begun melting the scrap pile first, blasting it with fire until it ran red and orange onto the ground, glowing with heat. Then she'd begun to shape it, lifting it with her will alone, the heat giving her an anchor into the physical mass of the run-off, and she separated the sodden slag into two separate chunks, shaping each at the same time.

It had taken a while; other Hordesmen had paused in their passing by, or sent word to watch, even the most diligent taking a short break to see what their Lord was doing. Even Lonnie had come, at the word of Callix, her assistant bringing the news to her.

(She had suffered her first such incident of going away inside when she saw how much power Adora was throwing around, when she realized that in open combat, Adora stood a fair chance of crushing almost any force sent against her; it was too much, too much, there was a goddess walking among them and Lonnie was just one person, she had went away for a long, long time, suffering an attack amidst her panic...)

Once Adora was satisfied with whatever she'd made- though no one else could see what they looked like, under the glow of the blazing metal, which Adora reheated from time to time to with flamethrower blasts from her hands- she cooled them, taking heat *away*, which wasn't something Lonnie had known she could do. She redirected the heat of them, the two statues blasting super-heated air above them in a kind of enhanced convection, shimmers in the air above them rising like great thermals.

The end result were two life-size statues; one of Hordak, and one of Scorpia, Adora literally burning graven images of both into being with her fire.

But that wasn't the end. She'd then turned to the armor-grade metal, and melted it, too, with one great sustained blast, and then redirected that metal to her own skin; Rogelio and Lonnie had both gasped, and on reflex the duo had ran forward to save Adora from the metal that would surely scorch her down to her bones... but they shouldn't have bothered. Fire and heat held no harm for Adora now; it held shelter instead, and she wrapped herself in it, like a caterpillar's coccoon.

From it emerged Adora in her newest garb- garb that was just like Hordak's old armor, save that where his own symbol had been on the front, she marked this with her own. A second later, as her armor cooled, she took the run-off of the armor-grade metal that had not made it into her armor, and formed a copy of her old tower shield, the one Entrapta had made her, so many years ago. She gripped that in her good right hand, leaving her burned one free.

Then, once her armor was cool enough to touch, she had knelt and lifted the cape from the ground, holding it reverently for a moment before offering it to Rogelio, who after a moment's surprise, took it. She turned so that he could hook it onto her armor, so it could sit there as it once had on Lord Hordak himself.

Then she had turned to her people- pretty much every Hordesman who wasn't asleep or on guard duty was there by that point- and raised her free hand towards the statues.

My people, she had begun simply enough, so used to public speaking at this point that she hadn't even needed a microphone or magic to make herself heard in the dead silence. *Here is our memorial to our founder... and to another, one who was close to him in life. Hordak, my father,* ***our*** *father, who built us from nothing, who gave his life to save us all!*

Cheers, if slightly confused ones, people glancing over at Scorpia; Adora continued after a moment.

Many of you are confused at Scorpia's placement here. I condemned her to Beast Island for treachery, and she did indeed act against us; but I have since found out, after investigation, that Scorpia had been tricked. She was not our enemy willingly, but had been misguided; and while death was the proper punishment, dishonor was not. I am willing to forgive. And she was one of Hordak's compatriots; he would wish for her to be honored, too.

So, Hordesmen, one and all- bear witness!

She'd held up her free hand and blasted fire in the air, fire that formed into Adora's symbol in the air over their heads, and sheer spectacle made the crowd go along with it, cheering wildly despite the prior mutterings of doubt and surprise. Lonnie, less bowled over, having just recovered from whatever was happening to her, had not been so distracted, and thought about it as she slunk away, back to the cool, dark safety of her office.

Adora had told Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio, during the chaos of the Second Raid on the Fright Zone, that Scorpia had betrayed them alongside Entrapta. That was why they'd been happy to ship Scorpia to Beast Island, where the Scorpioni surely lay dead by now. She hadn't mentioned... any of this.

The new tale felt wrong, wrong in ways Lonnie didn't have words for, the same way the statues did. They were the Horde, they didn't *make* these kinds of memorials, it wasn't their way. For Hordak, Lonnie could see it, and she was honestly glad he had a statue, now; that was good. That was right.

No, it wasn't traditionally how the Horde honored their dead, but it was *Hordak* . He was *special* . Hordak had left his country and his kindred, from whatever impossibly distant land he had come from, and from the common clay of the common person shaped together a great nation. He had been a leader and commander to their people, and in return, they had made his name great... yes, a statue for Hordak, that was okay. That was more than okay, that was *right.*

But Scorpia? Even if Adora was telling the truth, which Lonnie didn't find likely, it was just... strange. Off. Even if Adora somehow *wasn't* lying, Scorpia had still been exiled to Beast Island, the harshest punishment the Horde had, and she'd still betrayed them, even if it was unintentional. A statue to her just felt wrong, in some way Lonnie didn't have words for.

...What had happened that day, really? Lonnie didn't know. Most didn't. The day was just... a blur, vague memories, images. Some reported a sort of... alternate realm, a make-believe thing, a world that never was, but Lonnie remembered none of it. Rogelio claimed he remembered some of it, remembered Catra as Adora's consort, and that they made out a lot, which kind of checked out, but he was the only one of them that remembered it... save Adora, who wouldn't talk about it, except in short, brief bursts, always unprompted.

(She'd rub at her arm and her eye, then, at her burns; she'd always said she gained them in the other world... but then, why was no one else hurt? What had happened to Adora, that a thing that wasn't even real could *burn* her?)

Adora's armor had always sort of resembled Hordak's, but now it was like he'd been reborn in her skin. Between the new outfit and the cape, a few old Horde veterans had even confessed that they'd damn near had heart attacks when they caught a glimpse of her from behind, or saw the swirl of the cape disappearing around a corner. Lonnie had even heard a few asking if Adora was his actual daughter, and others claiming she was, rumors that, bizarrely, seemed to please Adora greatly; when she'd brought them up, she'd been open in her delight, even laughed and said she'd have to tell *sister* that she had a father now.

She hadn't explained why she'd liked those rumors so much; just made an offhand comment that *he was the one who found me* that she hadn't explained further, before leaving to go to the Furnace and commune with her *sister in sin*.

(Every time Adora referred to that hunk of rock like it was a person, brave Lonnie shivered like a child without a nightlight; if she was lucky, it was merely a sign Adora had lost her mind, at least in this very specific way, but if not...)

A knock on the door. Lonnie jerked, spooked, and tried not to hate herself for being so *soft* ; she failed.

" Come in," she said, a second later, when she had control of herself.

" Force Captain Lonnie!" said old Callix in his gravelly, thickly-accented voice as he cracked her door open just enough to poke his head in. " You wanted me to tell ya when the meeting 'twas, right? It's almost time to leave, miss!"

Callix was one of the oldest people in the Horde; he'd been with Hordak when he took GaleBreath, a middle-aged farmer whose land had been stolen by corrupt government officials, and had chosen to start tossing firebombs in response. Lonnie liked him, despite him belonging to the majority of Hordesmen, those who didn't question Adora's lies about not being a Princess. He was a proud old veteran, and thus honored by being allowed the job of secretary, a peaceful posting to live out his life in.

But right now, Lonnie kind of hated him, because he'd reminded her that it was time to walk into the Dragon's lair.

" Thank you," she managed to say anyway. " I'll be out for a time."

(*it's not Adora anymore it killed my friend and is wearing her face and I have to go smile back at it when it bares her teeth at me*)

Callix nodded.

" You be careful, now!" he said. " You ain't been sleeping much as you should. Gotta take care of your body, it's all you got!"

" I'll... I'll keep that in mind," Lonnie said, swallowing hard against a dry throat.

She didn't want to do this.

She felt small, and helpless, and... petulant. *It wasn't fair,* whined a refrain in her head, something so childish she'd never said it even when she was an *actual* child, even when she'd seen great and perfect unfairness in Shadow Weaver's treatment of Catra, even when she herself had been the one inflicting unfairness on one who did not deserve it.

But... but this wasn't how the tale was supposed to go. The Horde had almost fallen, and Adora had propped it back up, and that

should have been the *end* of it, the story should have *ended* there. The Horde almost fell, but Adora found her strength and picked it back up; now they'd march out and win, forever and ever, amen.

That was how the story was supposed to go, right? Even the Horde had its fairy tales. And this, this should have been one, this should have ended with a happily ever after; Adora, last of the First Ones, the final proof that the Horde was *right,* should have become the Lord of the Horde, and then they should have won. The First Ones had built Etheria, were the legendary angels and divine progenitors of so many wonders... and the last of them was a Hordesman. Proof positive that the Horde was supposed to be here, that they were the good guys, that this was *right* .

...But.

But.

But then Adora had brought back a Runestone and become a Princess, and now she was... *changing* all these things... she wanted Hordesman to have kids. Families. Had all these ideas about setting up whole systems that they'd never had before, never *needed* before... and Lonnie didn't know if it was her friend or the Runestone or if these were good changes or bad. The fairy tale was turning in her hands, the story shifting even as she read it, and Lonnie's whole world was just this... this muddled *mess.*

She only wanted certainty. She only wanted to *know* what was the right thing to do, the way she'd known all her life, until the day

Adora brought back that fucking Runestone... but all the world kept spitting back in her face was ambiguity.

She tried to keep herself calm. Now was no time to have a breakdown, despite how much she wanted to... and that added a nice, healthy dash of self-loathing to the boiling mess of emotions inside her, spiced with shame, because Lonnie had never known she was so *soft* before. Soft, and weak, and...

Not much of a proper Hordesman at all. She should be firm. Decisive! She should either decide it was Adora in there, and go along with her plans as was her duty... or that it *wasn't* Adora in there, and commit herself to opposing her, as was her duty. Either her Lord was a Hordesman or had been subverted, and she just had to *pick* and be done with it.

But Lonnie, to her own surprise, was... soft, and weak.

And it was time to go before the Furnace, and see what Adora was doing.

(No matter that even *thinking* about it made her knees weak. When had she gone so soft?)

Lonnie stood up and walked out the door of her office, her only truly safe place, with a heart heavy and hurting in her chest.

(*I'm not a traitor*)

Chapter End Notes

Most people in this series are actually speaking Mountainflower, the most common variant of the Plumerian family of languages, called Mountainflower due to originating near the Dark Mountains before spreading to become Plumeria's main language. For about five generations of Princesses- so roughly three hundred years- Plumeria has been at peace, and its central location means that it's good for trade routes around Etheria's sole continent. Mountainflower popped up as a language for trade with Dryl and Blackmoor, and spread from there to all Etheria. The only language with nearly as much pull would be Salinean Skimmer, and fewer Crownless speak it, so Mountainflower wins by default.

Mountainflower is a mixed tongue between Plumeria's older language of Midflower, Dryl's native Arnotblanche and Blackmoor's Moorfare. It supplanted Midflower throughout Plumeria, though you hear echoes of Midflower in some of Plumeria's more isolated regions- not much more, though. Plumeria is a nation without significant geographic barriers inside of it, fairly gentle wildlife- most of Etheria's more dangerous wildlife is either north or south of them, most of what's dangerous in Plumeria are plants and their Princesses have kept those away from the main roads- and a culture that encourages travel, so the conditions to produce lots of dialects don't really exist. Perfuma sounds about the same as someone from the outskirts of her Kingdom, in contrast to, say, Frosta or Glimmer, who have a noticeable “capital” accent to their first languages that others can hear.
(Arnotblanche is named after the inventors of the electric drill; Moorfare is a reference to the Rebel's Fair in the episode I draw Blackmoor from.)

Perfect Speech, meanwhile, was Hordak's native tongue... the language of Horde Prime's Fleet. It is the only language one is allowed to speak in his presence unless he says otherwise. Horde Prime invented it during a long stretch where he was bored, mostly because forcing everyone to convert to it gave him something to do, and he called it Perfect Speech because

he's an asshole. Hordak had to learn the Fright Zone's own language of Scorhill before he could communicate with anyone after he crash-landed, though he also learned Mountainflower at the same time so he could talk to more people.

PS is actually a very elegant and flowery language that has a lot of pauses and gaps following certain sounds; Horde Prime deliberately engineered it that way because he enjoyed the rhythm it gave the language. Perfect Speech almost seems to have a musical quality to it. To know what it would sound like, look up exec_cosmoflips from Ar Tonelico; Hymmnos is very close to what it would sound like.

You cannot actually say no to anything in PS. You have to say things like “I wish to do otherwise” or other deferments to imply a no. The implicit begging that results pleases Horde Prime greatly, and it delights him that, by making PS their language, he steals from those under him even their ability to say no to him.

PS is Catra and Adora's native language, along with all the other child soldiers. Hordak planned to wipe out all other languages and replace them with PS once he conquered Etheria. Ironically considering those plans, the War has instead accelerated the trend towards everyone on Etheria speaking Mountainflower; Rebel squads use it a lot, because they're pretty diverse, and the Alliance members use it at council meetings to make sure everyone is included. If Etherian Wikipedia ever becomes a thing, it will probably be written in Mountainflower for ease of use.

Brightmoon's main language is called Orgel. Look up PMMM's “Credens Justitiam” to get an idea of what the language would sound like- vaguely Italian, very musical, lotta vowel noises. It's named after the Orgel from Sailor Moon- it's apparently the generic term for a music box in Japanese.

Orgel actually was fairly easy for Catra to learn, since it's not that different structurally from PS, though she has trouble stopping herself sometimes due to Orgel not having the rhythm of the semi-lyrical PS. To Brightmoon, Catra's slowly-fading accent is actually kind of cute, since the sing-song rhythm she applies and the tendency to rise right at the end of a sentence makes it sound like Catra's about to burst into song at any given moment.

The Pummeling Princess series author found out about this, and decided to acknowledge it in the dumbest and most amazing way possible by having their version of Catra burst into song at random moments in the novels.

More language notes next chapter.

Chapter 42: TLWCE: Catra and the Queen

Chapter Notes

> The War Council is upon us.
>
> Don't expect a rapid schedule; doing what I can. This chapter was meant to be longer, but the family emergency is ongoing. Please be understanding in your comments.
>
> Next chapter: Lonnie once more, and the gifts from the Dragon's hoard, and a confession.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Last War Council of Etheria:

Catra and the Queen

Catra muzzily woke up. She yawned lightly, already seeking to return to slumber; it was that kind of tired where you were only awake enough to know you wanted to go back to sleep. Oh, she was rested, she could go about her day- she'd felt worse!- but a few more hours would really hit the spot. Her insides felt kind of comfortably numb, like a friendly weight lay on her back; kind of reminded her of the way Adora had once described Catra's own weight, when she lay atop her legs in their shared bed, a rare joy in their lives. Shadow Weaver separated them often- as often as she could, often to punish Adora, more often to hurt Catra, most often for no reason at all- but the rare occasions they could be together, they were.

(Maybe that was why she did not feel for Adora like a sister; perhaps it was because they had spent so much of their childhoods seeking each other, instead of being *with* each other, had never quite developed that sisterly affection for each other. Maybe if they'd been together more often, Adora would be family, instead of... whatever they were now. Maybe if the others hadn't pushed her away so much, her little cadet class could have been a family...)

This bed sure was softer than Adora's bed had ever been, though. Real soft... kinda too soft. Didn't feel like her bed usually did. She'd asked the butler in charge of the royal bedding- and *that* had been wild, to find out that they *had* a guy who did that- to make her bed *less* soft, and he'd done so, gave her something better than a Horde bunk but not so soft she felt like she was drowning in mashed potatoes. This bed was a mashed potato bed; they must have swapped her mattress out or something.

Eh, it wasn't that bad; four years ago, she wouldn't have been able to sleep on it at all, but she'd been in Brightmoon long enough to get kinda used to softness. She'd have him change the bed out when she woke up later. Maybe after the meeting...

Meeting.

Something in Catra's brain shrieked so loud that she was *up, up, up* instantly, the **meeting** , oh fuck, she'd missed the fucking meeting, fuck fuck fuck **fuck** -

She leapt up without actually touching the ground, literally hurling herself out of bed, covers flying off of her to collapse in a landslide, skidding to a stop as she found herself in... Angella's room? What the fuck-

Wait.

Wait wait wait.

Memories flooded her mind. Dark magic, used only by permission, the first time in all her life that darkness had given her peace... and the first time in all her life she'd ever been tucked in. Her mother, explaining how she'd be delaying today's meeting a few hours, all for Catra.

Her heart wanted to burst, from the feelings that gave her, a bright upswelling surge of emotion, the mixture of surprised and tender awe and simple wonder at being loved and... and all kinds of things.

But she tamped it down. No time, now. She could feel those things *later.* She had to know- a glance outside- noon, when the meeting was *supposed* to be. Depending on what Queen Angella had managed, Catra might have time...

She headed out of the room in a bit less of a panic, catching a glimpse of the Sword (*the Sword the Sword the Sword!*) but also an unexpected guest, and Catra- with the greater strength hours

of sleep had given her- wrenched all her attention away from the falling-apart-inside feeling a glance at her own weapon gave her to focus on the surprise visitor.

" Oh, hey!" Flutterina said as she rose up from one of the dining room chairs, saluting her. " You're up!"

" Flutterina?" Catra said, saluting back on pure reflex. " Why are you in Mom's dining room?"

" Waiting for you!" Flutterina said cheerily. " Queen Angella's been busy getting everything ready, but she wanted somebody here for when you woke up! I wasn't doing anything else, so I volunteered. She had a message for you! Said you'd probably wake up kind of disoriented, so here's the gist of it: the meeting has been moved to four, and she wants to see you. It's just noon now, so you've got some time."

" Okay, that's- that's good," Catra said, letting out a sigh as the acid of adrenaline in her veins started to slow down. Four hours. That was... that was a little time. She hadn't fucked this up yet, she hadn't signed Adora's death warrant just because she'd been *tired*.

(Okay, that was too small a word for what had been going on with her, but Catra did not feel inclined to be kind to herself.)

Flutterina grinned at the obvious easing of Catra's tension, her ears and tail and fur all three settling down, the Lunoth fluttering her wings happily.

“ Queen Angella is in her office!” she said. “ She wants you to wash up, eat, and then figure out if you can stomach the meeting today. If you can't, she'll cancel.”

Catra almost blurted out for the meeting to be canceled right then and there. Simply cancel it, throw it away, hide from it, run, like she had last time, but *this* time, with her mother's approval. Just cancel it! Let Netossa explain to her allies that she'd failed utterly to get her meeting going. Throw the loss in the faces of everyone who'd traveled all this way here to declare that Adora had to die. Put an end to it before it could even begin.

And had Catra not had some actual sleep for once, she would have cried out for just that.

But... she *had* gotten some actual sleep, for once. She'd slept, and thus, was a little more in control of her faculties than she'd been; and the parts of her brain that were good at manipulation, the parts that had kept her alive in the Horde, had started to turn again, had found just enough grease in her few seconds awake to know that she should...

Wait.

Don't make a decision yet, she told herself. *Think about it, first.*

You had to make quick decisions, but going too fast could fuck you over just as hard as going too slow. A shower, some food... then she'd choose.

" Okay," Catra said, breathing out. " Flutterina, could you get my three retainers to make me a meal? Nothing big. Just a light lunch, something I can eat while walking. Have it ready at my room in... thirty minutes."

" I'm on it!" Flutterina said. " Anything else, boss?"

Despite everything, a grin flickered across Catra's face at the eagerness in the young Lunoth, at how well the small-town girl had adapted to the life of a Rebel soldier.

I found the ultimate Horde cadet, Catra thought with amusement. *If she'd been a Hordesman, she'd have made Force Captain in record time... unlike me, I'd have never been promoted to Force Captain, not with Adora right there.*

Still, the Horde *didn't* have Flutterina, Catra did, so she saluted her subordinate.

" No," Catra said. " And good work, kid. Dismissed."

" Thank you, Princess Catra!" Flutterina squealed, joy lighting up her face, and it was so bright it was catching.

(*I really am gonna have to make her my squire at this rate,* Catra thought, as she smiled back at the kid. *She deserves it for being a messenger girl if nothing else, and it's not like everybody doesn't just kind of assume she already is anyway...*)

Flutterina turned and took off in her usual fashion, way too fast, hitting the door and exiting it so quickly that she was practically just a pink blur. It was... kinda weird, actually. Sure, it wasn't *explicitly* magic, but the idle thought crossed Catra's mind anyway that Flutterina might be a Wild Princess... she'd have to ask Bow about that. Was there a way to test for that? Honestly Catra didn't know how they decided who was a Wild Princess or not. She vaguely remembered somebody- Glimmer, maybe?- saying that Wild Princesses kind of *were* their own Runestone, so they were weaker without a connection to Etheria, but you also couldn't block them off like you could a Runestone Princess... but that was all she could recall, right now.

Not that it mattered much. An idle thought, like so many she'd had this past week, but this one didn't consume her. She kept it as that, an idle thought, nothing more, pulling herself together with mental strength that was nearly a miracle after the week she'd had. With rest came reset, came restock of reserves, came rise in inner strength, and not a second too soon.

She could do this. She could save Adora. She could... she could do this.

So... first things first, Catra thought to herself *. Clean up. Can't convince anyone if I look like shit... I'll shower and get dressed. I'd rather bathe, but showering will have to do, need more time to talk to Mom.*

Yeah, she hated showering, but if nothing else, it'd finish waking her the fuck up. She headed out to do just that, mind still turning over and over.

(She didn't look at the Sword, a thing she decided on without conscious thought, left it right there... but she did bother to lock the door behind her, with the keys she kept on her at all times, more to keep the Sword *in* than anyone else *out,* like a child shutting the closet door on the bogeyman.)

Then... what? She thought to herself as she walked down the halls, heading to her own chambers. *What comes next?*

That was the rub. How was she to convince them not to kill Adora? Her heart seized up at the very thought, like it had at the last war council, but she forced herself past that terror- not without effort. Not without cost.

But she did it anyway. Adora *needed* her, needed her to save her at this meeting, the way Adora had saved Catra, time and time again; and Catra was *not* going to fail her twice in a row.

So.

How do we get them to back off?... maybe... tell them all how she saved me?

... Hordak's swinging ballsack, fucking *no* .

(*Did Hordak <u>have</u> a ballsack, swinging or otherwise?* some idle part of her brain wondered. *I guess I could ask Entrapta... if I wanted to get murdered... or maybe she'd tell me, and that might be worse, actually.*)

Telling that story at all... had been the hardest thing she had ever done, absurd as that was. Fighting a war, making her decision to choose happiness, even dealing with the end of the Portal's make-believe world... none of it, none of it, *none* of it, had been half as hard as telling the truth about her childhood. Even when it had been only to her Mom, and then her sister, and the short version she gave to her absolute closest non-family friend in Bow, telling that story had been... it had been awful.

She was *not* going to repeat that moment with everyone else. It wasn't even just out of shame or worry that it wouldn't touch their hearts; it was because Catra knew that she literally could not do it. The young woman who could lift boulders, endure horrific punishment without dying, who had fired out a titanic rainbow wave of energy to put an end to the Battle of Brightmoon... was simply unable to do it. She did not have the strength.

Sure, she was friends with the other Princesses, was going to know everybody at this meeting except maybe whatever people Netossa would bring... but she just couldn't tell them. It hurt too much.

Maybe Mermista... she thought, then paused briefly, before continuing down the hall. Huh, she hadn't known that until just this second. She... hadn't realized she was that close, with

Mermista... but yeah, yeah, she could give Mermista the same edited version she gave Bow. The short one, the one that did not delve too deep, but still told the parts of the truth that mattered.

She could tell Mermista, she felt. She trusted that her friend would treat it as she should, not hurt her, just... let it be a thing she knew, and not let it change her opinion of her. Mermista was someone Catra felt... safe with.

Well, Catra thought. *I hadn't realized I trusted her that much.*

Sure, Mermista was her favorite other Princess- except Glimmer, who maybe didn't count because she was her sister? Was that how it worked?- but she hadn't really understood just how much faith in the Salinean's good character she had until this very moment. She'd liked Mermista since the day they met, their personalities worked well together, but she hadn't realized she valued the mermaid that much.

But maybe she should have. Mermista had backed her up on Entrapta and Dryl, after all, without remorse or a single question asked. It had surprised Catra then, too; a good surprise, in a life that rarely had them.

(Catra still remembered a handshake, warrior to warrior, and a smile; and now, knowing just how much she valued the saltwater witch, the memory shined with even more warmth.)

Maybe Mermista could back her up again... though she might not be able to. She vaguely remembered a comment Mermista had

made, that Salineas wasn't happy with her over Dryl... and she knew enough to know Salineas wasn't ruled by Mermista alone.

Which is just confusing, Catra thought as she reached the hallway that held her quarters, nodding to the two guards on duty as she passed them. *The Horde was a military dictatorship, Brightmoon's a monarchy, Salineas is a democracy... how many ways can you run a damn country?*

She pondered that question as she reached her room and stepped inside. Her personal quarters had mercifully been spared in the trouble last night, left unsoaked and unsoiled; once she was inside, she locked her door, and stripped. Off went somewhat-unclean clothes, tossed into a hamper nearby; from there, she went into her private bathroom, to lock that door in turn.

Safely ensconced in two layers of protection, she finally turned on the shower. The water was the right temperature immediately- apparently her mom had spent extra on making sure the plumbing in Brightmoon Castle was *amazing* , which spoke of either a highly practical woman, or just one who hated cold showers- which was a shame, because Catra wasn't ready to step into it yet.

Fuuuuuuuuuuck. A shower was like being slowly beaten to death by a million tiny water hoses, they sucked! A bath was great, but but a *shower?*

Blech.

Of course, it didn't help that showering brought back... memories. Back in the Horde, which *only* had communal showers- which was how she discovered that Kyle had both an innie *and* an outie for nipples, seriously, it was just weird- she'd been attacked a few times while trying to wash her damn hair. It was why she'd only showered when she could make sure Adora was there, to stand guard, and probably a contributing factor to why her fucking hair was always such a goddamn mess.

Well, that and she'd never gotten it trimmed much. She hadn't trusted anyone but Adora to do something that put sharp edges near her like that, and the few times she'd tried to cut her own hair, she'd fucked it up awful.

Now, at least, she had Bow to cut it. She'd asked her mother to do so, some years back, when she was just the Queen and Catra hadn't even known what the warm, nervous thing in her chest was, the thing that wanted the Queen to look at her with that small, sad smile; but Angella had demurred. Hair-trimming was much like cooking in this respect: it was not one of the many skills Angella's long years as a Brightmoon Queen had taught her. She'd apparently tried to style hair a few times in her long life and miserably failed each time, and apparently even given Micah something like a tonsure once; she'd sent Catra to her own personal hairdressers instead, and they'd done a fair job of it, though Catra preferred Bow. Some part of her still didn't like strangers near her with that much metal, even the good people of Brightmoon, whom she loved.

Glimmer had also offered, and Catra had let her do it a few times, but she always cut it too short; Catra had gotten used to having a big head of hair and kinda liked it.

(She still remembered the joke she'd told Glimmer while they were out on the Salinean campaign with Mermista and Sea Hawk, hammering Horde resupply points- *Glimmer, you don't have to cut my hair as short as you are* - she'd been so pissed, it'd been hilarious to see. Maybe she should have known even back then they were destined to be siblings; there was something warm and familial about the way they'd ended up playfighting afterwards like dumbass kids five years younger than they actually were, something Catra had rarely had in her childhood and had to enjoy in her near-adulthood.)

She moved to take a shower, but paused as her mind refused. It was... harder, than she'd thought it would be, to step into the shower. As soon as she *did* manage to step in, old habits kicked in, hard, and she compulsively checked the room to make sure she was safe, that no one was waiting to attack her while she was vulnerable.

(Some part of her looked for Adora, standing guard, and her heart ached in her chest.)

But this wasn't the Horde, where the communal shower's size and emptiness gave her a sense of being left wide open; this was her small, private bath, in her own chambers, in her own home. Gunmental gray and dim black did not dominate here; there was pink, and purple, and gold, and *silver,* always silver, everywhere Brightmoon's decorators thought they could get away with it, because Brightmoon did not hide what it found holy in sacred places but threaded it throughout their daily lives.

This was not the Fright Zone. This was Brightmoon. This was not a communal shower where any stranger could walk in; this was *her room,* this was the one place in all the world that was hers

and hers alone. There was a lock on the door, and a lock on the door past that one, and guards outside, and... and she was safe, here.

She was *home* , here.

It took her a long minute, still, of breathing in, and breathing out, to remind herself of that.

But she *was* safe, and so, after that long minute, she could start up her shower, and wash herself, no longer fearing attack. Liquid soap spread onto a soft sponge, because the long friendship with Salineas meant Brightmoon had an overabundant supply of the absorbent material- she'd heard Mermista say most of Salineas' soap was from Brightmoon, and the mermaid had thought that was kind of funny, that they traded cleanliness to each other like that.

Catra's own soap was from Brightmoon, too, a variant made for species like her own, whose noses were stronger than human average. They were lightly scented for Brightmoon; while her nose wasn't really bothered by the smells preferred in her adopted homeland, she needed them to be turned down fairly low when they were coming off of her own fur if she didn't want to dull her nose. She scrubbed herself with that soap, hinted only lightly with vanilla, her fur mostly unblemished after four years of war... save a few rare places here and there, where she had suffered wounds so severe that even her healing as the She-Ra could not prevent some scarring.

(One in particular- a deep, deep blow with a knife in her side, between her ribs, a stab from Adora that had felt like a kiss, and

left the ugliest scar on her skin, a place where fur would not grow.)

Her hair, after, running her clawed fingers through the long tresses, teasing out knot after knot. Proper haircare had helped her tremendously in that regard; before Brightmoon, she'd never had time to properly wash it, but since coming to her true home, she had discovered the wonders of *conditioner.* A routine for her hair, that she rather liked when she was able to do it slowly in a bath, and found still soothing when done in a hated shower, a thing that helped settle her down. Vanilla shampoo first, worked into her scalp, massaged into her thick tresses, gently tugging apart those that clung together; then that lather washed out with the good clean water of Brightmoon, that smelled so sweet, completely different from the iron tang of the Fright Zone's tainted sewer output.

Honestly, the water quality difference alone had probably solved her former dandruff problem; she'd had god-awful dandruff in the Fright Zone, not helped by her generally poor hygiene... but that was yet another thing coming to Brightmoon had fixed for her, a small joy to go along with all the greater ones that she owed to the land of her adoption.

(Well, maybe not that small of a joy, for a being that was covered in fur; humans thought *they* had bad dandruff when it was just on the top of their heads!)

Conditioner, after, the purple fluid massaged into her hair. Lavender, she thought, though as ever it was done subtly enough that even her nose could barely catch it; it was perfect, just right, an accent in the air all around her that made the day a little bit brighter. She let it linger as she washed herself again, fur being

more prone to keeping filth than flesh, scrubbing and letting the lather soak in before washing it away at last.

Clean, and feeling much more settled in herself, she stepped out to dry off on Brightmoon's ludicrously fluffy towels, still kind of a thing of wonder, even after all these years. Horde towels had been pretty flat, used by a thousand interchangeable soldiers a day, but the personal towels of the younger Princess of Brightmoon were like pillows, she could have slept on them.

We could end this whole war if I could just get them to buy towels from us... Catra thought, with a small snort. She got why the Horde defaulted to function over form most of the time- sheer population size and the crushing pressure of the War- but that itself was a sign that something needed to change. A people deserved better...

She unlocked her bathroom and stepped out, briefly checking to make sure no one was in the room; the cautious part of her assuaged, she went to grab some clothes. She wasn't precisely the most fashion-conscious person, but she was better than Adora was... well, then Adora *had* been. Who knew if that was just another thing that had changed?

(*Is the woman I love still in there, does she still love me, has <u>that</u> changed?*)

Shaking off that awful thought- and briefly glad that she *could* , now, getting some sleep meant she wasn't so much at the mercy of her own mind's whims- Catra selected something nice and military. One of her officer's uniforms, a nice suit in Brightmoon's colors, though it had no rank insignia save a small, stylized crown;

it didn't need one. She was a Princess, after all, in both the political *and* magical sense, she outranked everybody.

...Damn, she liked suits. She'd caused a bit of a stir in Brightmoon's fashion scene over them, according to Glimmer; Catra herself didn't really follow clothing trends, but Glimmer did, and she'd been deeply amused at the shocking changes Catra had inflicted on the clothing community. Catra was popular in all Brightmoon, so everyone wanted to work with her; but her favoring suits was quite a change among Brightmoon's elite. Glimmer and Angella both liked dresses, and Micah had favored Mystacoran robes, all of which were made by Brightmoon's dressmakers; proper suit tailors, on the other hand, had languished in the dustbin of being unfashionable for years.

Then Catra had walked in and singlehandedly revived their industry, all without ever knowing they'd even needed the help. She just liked suits. The result was that there had been fistfights over which tailor got to make her suits- literally, Catra had been there for the last one. Angella had wanted to throw everyone involved out of the castle, but Glimmer had backed up Catra's decision to pick the guy who won, mostly because she'd been legit impressed- you wouldn't think a guy that skinny could suplex someone twice his size.

(More proof- if ever she needed it- of the two being sisters; Glimmer had thought he was as awesome as she had. She hoped Glimmer came back soon, she'd like to see her short little big sister...)

She put the clothes on, enjoying the fresh fabric smell, which was also very much a light touch, at her personal request. Her laundry was nice and clean, since the Castle's maids and butlers handled

that, rather than Catra herself; it hadn't been touched by her... decay.

I really hope Mom can blast me with that spell again, Catra thought. *I don't... I don't want to have those nightmares ever again. I can't afford to fall apart again... and I don't want to, that had been... those weren't the worst days of my life, but they came close.*

Yeah... yeah, if her mom could just, use that spell forever... that would be nice. Catra might even forgive dark magic, if it could keep her nightmares out of her. And it had felt kind of... nice, which wasn't a thing that Catra had known dark magic could be; felt peaceful. Like a cool rag on a fevered forehead. Just a lovely silent night, all for her- silence, and not screams, blessed rest.

Though admittedly it just sounds wrong to use dark magic to fight nightmares... that feels ass-backwards, somehow.

She heard a knock at her door right as she got her jacket buttoned up.

" Who is it?" she called.

" We're here with your meal!" came the voice of the sodapop guy. " It's a ploughman's sandwich!"

" I... she's not gonna know what that is," said the baker to her fiance. They'd invited Catra to their wedding in a few months, which was how Catra had learned that the three were dating in the first place.

(She'd also failed to ask their names again, but mostly because, at this point, it was just too awkward to reveal she did not know them.)

" It's cheese, pickle and onion on good solid bread," the busgirl clarified her future spouses' words. " Though I still say she should have some chips, make a proper ploughman's lunch out of it."

" She's only got two hands," the sodapop guy said. " Really the only thing it needs is a good beer to wash it down with, but I don't think Princess Catra much likes liquor."

" I don't," Catra said, as she checked her suit one last time before going to the door and opening it. " Alcohol makes me sick."

I wonder if that's a Magicat thing... or a me thing...

The trio were outside, the sodapop guy and the baker both surprised by her sudden appearance, though the busgirl was, as always, totally unflappable, simply offering a small platter whose cover she removed.

" Your lunch, madam," she said. A big bottle of some dark soda, and a sandwich- well, it felt a bit demeaning to call it a sandwich. This was two good solid hunks of bread, between which sat a fat slab of cheese, topped with a pickled chutney spread and a bit of sliced and diced onions, it smelled *heavenly.*

Even with her tight schedule, Catra took a moment to just savor the smell of the thing. Damn, did Catra love cheese. Shame the Fright Zone didn't have it- well, didn't use to have it, before Adora started raiding, anyway. The food was always the first thing to go, Hordesmen greedy for goodies they couldn't get anywhere else.

Adora must have hated the ration bars as much as I did, even if I never heard her complain much... she even kind of liked the gray kind.

" Thanks," Catra said, banishing the thoughts of the woman she loved. She grabbed the pop and unscrewing the lid, leaving it on the plate before she grabbed the sandwich with her other hand. The air filled with a smell from the bottle she associated with Dryl, a kind of rich and bitter scent... wait, she knew this smell. " The drink smells like... coffee?"

" Figured you'd need something to help wake you up, so I made a coffee cola!" her sodapop guy said. " Based it on Dryl coffee, you like that better than the sweeter Salinean brews. If it's not to your taste, of course, I've also got a bottle of that celery soda you like."

She took another sniff; didn't smell bad at all... she downed a sip, swished it around a bit. This was...

“ Pretty good,” she said, after a quick swallow. Bitter with a bit of savory... not bad. “ And I do need the energy. I'll take it.”

“ Glad you like it!” he said, beaming.

“ Thanks for making it,” she said. “ You guys do good work.”

The trio beamed- well, the busgirl was too impeccably polite to beam, but you could see it in her eyes.

“ You're welcome!” the baker said. “ Especially after your help with our wedding!”

“ Oh, I did nothing special,” Catra said. She'd just arranged for a transport to take them to Dryl; they'd wanted to get married in their homeland. A simple enough thing for a Princess to set up. “ It's your wedding, it should be special.”

“ You know, Entrapta was a really good boss, but you're even better!” the sodapop guy said. Catra gave him a quick smile for that.

“ Well, in the spirit of continuing to be the best boss, I'm giving you guys the rest of the day off; this is all I need,” Catra said, waving the sandwich at them. “ See you tomorrow.”

“ Of course,” said the busgirl, and the trio gave her the short bows of Brightmoon etiquette. “ Best of luck, Princess.”

“ Thanks,” Catra said. “ I'll need it.”

With a last nod at her retainers, she set off, eating and drinking quick. Damn good cheese, damn good bread, perfectly ripe onion and exquisitely sour pickle; wow, this was a damn good fucking sandwich. Add the coffee cola concoction to wash it all down with, and this was the perfect pick-up-and-go meal, she should have her retainers make this more often- and really, more power to them, even in a meal this ridiculously simple, they'd outdone themselves. She should give them a raise.

...*What **do** I pay them? Well, I mean, mom pays them, I guess... I... should probably figure that out at some point. I'm terrible at details like that but I really should make some effort to figure it out... or make Mermista or Bow figure it out for me, they're good with that kind of thing.*

That was something she'd learned while on campaign in Salineas; Catra was a tactician and good at it, but logistics beat the shit out of her. Mermista handled it well, though! Bow did, too; there was a reason Bow was the one in charge of the Best Friend Group's supplies. Glimmer had almost gotten them all killed the few times she'd been in charge of it... and so had Catra, though she hated to admit it.

(Okay, so maybe her and her sister were a bit *too* much alike, sometimes.)

She headed down the halls to her mother's office, located far from her private quarters, chowing down all the while. She passed numerous servants cleaning as she went, still trying to repair the damage from last night; Catra waved at them with the hand holding the rapidly-diminishing sandwich, receiving nods or greetings in turn. She passed a wide variety of very tired people, including Bow, the young man looking so dead on his feet that Catra didn't even speak to him, just waved, a thing he returned a solid three seconds later.

Up all night, I bet, Catra thought, frowning as she watched her poor friend stagger off down another hallway. *He needs to sleep, I hope he's not thinking of attending the meeting.*

She'd gotten intimately familiar with not having sleep, these last few days, and wouldn't wish it on her worst enemy, much less her best friend.

She finished her sandwich just as she rounded a corner. She had a few crumbs left on one hand, and on reflex nearly wiped them off on her shorts before remembering that she had a meeting to attend in this outfit. She didn't have a handkerchief on her, but there *was* a really convenient curtain nearby...

She glanced up and down the hallway. Nobody could see her, and so she quickly wiped her hand off, feeling a bit like she'd committed a crime. Hand clean but curtain- and maybe soul-soiled, Catra headed on, running into a few guards outside her mother's office.

“ Afternoon, Princess Catra,” one said. “ Queen Angella is waiting for you.”

“ Thank you,” she said, saluting quickly before heading on in. She'd been here a few times, mostly when Angella needed to give her orders, but didn't need to be on her throne to do it. The room was mostly dominated by a large desk that held what paperwork passed through Angella's hands, which was quite a lot, though not as much as might be expected; Angella had learned fairly early on in her reign to delegate. Brightmoon's government was...

Well, Angella had tried to explain it a few times, especially back when Catra had first joined Brightmoon, though it had mostly went over Catra's head. A non-feudal monarchy, the Queen had said, decisions on the ground level generally made democratically, villages and cities electing representatives who served under Angella herself as supreme authority. They'd *had* a noble class, but Angella had been forced to strip them of their privileges after their abuses of the common folk grew too great to tolerate... which had triggered the sole civil war Brightmoon had to endure since Angella took the throne.

Catra didn't know much about those events; Angella hadn't liked talking about them, and back in those first days in Brightmoon, Catra had not trusted that any authority figure wanted what was best for her, had figured that if she asked she would get a beating instead of answers. Angella had only mentioned something about a Duchess Galaxia and a shadow government in Crystal Falls, and then moved on.

(*Great, now I'm curious about it*, Catra grumbled in her mind. *Something to look up after the work is done, I guess.*)

The rest of the room was mostly unadorned, save for a single big window to Angella's right, big enough for her to escape through. It let in light, and would let Angella *out* if the door was blocked.

Given her self-admitted cautiousness- not cowardice, Mom's too hard on herself- she probably didn't want to trap herself in here if like, a fire broke out, or something.

(Catra knew that she wasn't totally rational regarding Angella, knew that it hurt her heart to think anything negative of her mother at all; but in this area, she felt she might actually be right. A true coward would not risk her life as much as Angella had, over the long years; she thought, perhaps, that her mother simply confused being afraid with being a coward, had somehow never realized how brave she really was, to go forth anyway despite being so scared.)

Her mother's office was really quite plain by Brightmoon standards, and even more so by Angella's relentlessly fancy standards. Whereas her private quarters were besotted with art, here the only flourishes of beauty present were scrawled onto the wooden paneling on the walls and on the great desk. They felt almost... accidental, as though the love of pointless lovely things was just so ingrained into the very bones of Brightmoon's people that they hadn't been able to help themselves, wonderful forms simply slipping out of their hands even as they made this simple, functional thing. The room's three chairs- one of which her mother sat in- were simple and relatively unadorned, though they had the massive, soft cushions all Brightmoon furniture prided itself on. A people that really took care of their butts, were Brightmoon folk.

Her mother sat there, working on something, before lifting her head as Catra entered. She looked... frazzled, actually, though she was doing a good job of hiding it. If Catra hadn't spent four years hanging onto every word she said, looking for the love in her eyes that she had never received from Shadow Weaver, she wouldn't have noticed at all.

" Good morning! Well, afternoon," the Queen said. " How... are you feeling?"

" Good!" Catra said. " Great, honestly. Whatever you did let me sleep... but you don't look like you slept so well."

" I haven't slept at all," Angella said with a shrug, looking her daughter over carefully. " But don't worry about that. You don't feel any... issues? Seeing things that aren't there when you look again, hearing voices, anything like that?"

Catra quirked an eyebrow, even as she thought *Don't worry? But you're my mom, of course I worry...*

(An echo, in Catra's mind, of recent words; *you're my daughter, you're one of the things I worry about most.* A sentiment that ran both ways between them...)

" No?" she offered. " Why?"

“ It's the first sign that the magic is starting to affect your mind,” Angella said. “ That magic is... it suppresses dreams, but a mind *needs* to dream. Doing it for too long would hurt you. And I couldn't live with myself if I did that.”

“ I haven't had anything like that, Mom,” Catra hurried to say, assuaging her mother's fears.

Angella nodded, then sighed.

“ Good,” she said. “ I didn't think you would; using it once is not usually dangerous unless one is very sensitive to dark magic, but given your history, I feared you might be vulnerable, a thought I did not have until about an hour ago. I've been... very worried since.”

“ I'm fine, Mom,” Catra insisted, even reaching out to her. “ Better than I've been since I found out about... the Sword.”

Well, *that* took quite a lot of effort to say, but with some sleep fortifying her, Catra was able to start thinking about it again.

“ Good,” Angella said, taking her daughter's hand as she sighed in relief, tension leaving her face. “ It was a risk to use it last night, though not much of one... but you needed the sleep so badly...”

“ I'm alright,” Catra repeated, and found a smile in herself for her mother, who had worried herself sick. “ Don't worry- I'm alright.”

“ Good,” Angella said, and squeezed her daughter's hand gently.

“ Besides,” Catra said, letting go of her mother's hand and calling up some of that pride that had carried her all her life, which was not so hard to find now with some rest in her belly. “ enough of that! Of course I'm alright. We've got a meeting to talk about.”

“ Do you want me to cancel it?” Angella offered. “ Brightmoon will survive the diplomatic hit. If you need this meeting to not happen today...”

A wave of gratitude and relief and... and happiness filtered through Catra, at her mother's words. Her mother would cancel the meeting, no matter how much it cost her, if that was what Catra needed.

Just more proof, if she had ever really needed it, that she was loved.

(For a second- just one- Catra took the luxury of simply wallowing in it, in her childhood dream, achieved at last: her mother loves her, the smallest and most important dream of Catra's entire life.)

Still, for all the sweetness of the gesture- for how much it *meant* to Catra, for that option to even be on the table- Catra's oldest talent, her skill at manipulation, told her that she had to deny it.

" No," Catra said, shaking her head.

" No?" Angella queried, looking for confirmation. Catra nodded.

" If we say no... well, there's a chance Netossa will hare off and do it anyway," Catra said. " Just... go without ever getting anything formal declared from the Princess Alliance. That puts Adora in danger... and the Rebellion too. We can't afford to lose Netossa; she's not the leader of the Rebellion, there really isn't *a* leader, but her and Spinnerella are the two Princesses that never gave up, they're as close as it gets to an authority figure all the Rebels listen to."

Angella- who was, herself, a Princess who gave up, explaining the vast number of former Brightmoon soldiers now working in the Rebel warcamps- nodded her head.

" But if we can come to a deal with her here, or stall her somehow..." Catra said, but her mind stalled on that next part. What *could* they say? All she could think of was

(Adora's head, falling from her shoulders, the Sword decapitating her, killing the woman she loves for the nation she loves and Catra cannot choose, both choices are suicide, she will die the final death no matter what she picks, the death of the heart, of her heart....)

“ Do you have any ideas?” Angella asked, right as Catra was able to confirm to herself that no, she did not.

Catra shook her head.

“ No,” she said, and pinned her hopes on her mother with her next question. “ Do you?”

“ I might,” Angella said, and Catra felt a sense of tremendous relief. Of course her mother had a plan; she had never failed Catra before.

“ What's the plan?” she asked her mother.

“ We ask them to capture Adora alive,” Angella said. “ Something must be done about Lord Adora, but we can make sure she comes out of it alive.”

Catra wanted to oppose that, too. She didn't want *anything* to happen to Adora, nothing at all. To have Adora hurt in any way was a betrayal of the woman she loved... Catra could defend herself from her, but to go after her, even with intent to merely take alive? No.

...But her mother was right; something had to be done. To act was to betray Adora, but to do nothing was to betray Brightmoon. This... this was not quite either option, this was not quite a third option. This was something that might be *both* options, both enough to let Catra thread the needle of her competing loyalties, and avoid betraying anyone at all.

Stop Adora... but take her alive.

She would betray no one; not Adora, not Brightmoon. Her love would live, as would her people.

I may not ever have been that Best Princess, Catra thought, *but I can still save one life.*

" Netossa will want to kill her," Catra said. Angella nodded.

" Let's talk about what we'll say," Angella said. " I will try to distract the meeting with the truth about the Sword... but just in case, let's figure out what to say, then practice it."

Catra nodded, and felt something a bit like... hope... in her chest.

We can make this work.

Chapter End Notes

Language, Part 2.

While Catra's accent is fading over the years, she's picking up a slight tone of another one- she sounds not unlike Angella, copying how she pronounces some words, something Catra is utterly unaware of doing. Multiple people have noticed this, but for various reasons nobody's brought it up yet; effectively, Catra's been replacing her Perfect Speech accent with Angella's accent, which Netossa has correctly guessed is the "original" Brightmoon accent. Angella's first language is now called Old Millienium, though the language shifted slowly enough that Angella picked up the new words as they were being introduced, and her perfect recall and old age means that she speaks nearly every language on Etheria.

Angella even recalls the old Flame Kingdom language, Firetongue, which sounds like the child of a rough divorce between German and Welsh punching you in the face, it's all consonants held together by one very tired vowel. Flame Kingdom people always sounded really mad even when just saying hi; they'd be natural heavy metal singers.

The only language Angella doesn't know is the Troll's native language, Heartsong, since it's a sacred tongue they don't speak in front of outsiders; it's a big, deep tonal language not unlike how whales talk, mixed with an earthquake, that's basically unpronounceable to non-Trolls anyway. Huntara and She-Ra might be able to pull it off after ten years of smoking five packs of cigars a day, but that's about it.

Catra mostly speaks Mountainflower unless she's at home in Brightmoon or just with Bow and Glimmer, where she swaps to Orgel. It's one of the two languages she grew up in, after all, but it's also useful to talk to any Rebels she happens to be leading that day, as well as the other Princesses- it's the only language they all share, though Mermista's slowly teaching the Best Friend Squad Skimmer, and they have mostly taught her Orgel. Catra never uses Perfect Speech anymore, a deliberate choice she made after choosing Brightmoon as a

fuck-you to the Horde... save when she is talking to Adora. She has never noticed this, either, that she tries to use the language of their shared childhood to reconnect with the woman she loves, hoping against hope she will turn to her side.

To an untrained ear, Perfect Speech and Orgel sound enough alike that most of her friends have never noticed, either... Glimmer and Bow have, since both are native Orgel speakers, and Mermista knows enough Orgel to know that something is up, but most aren't aware. Adora has noticed but lies to herself that it's a trick, because of course she does.

There have been Crownless attempts to make a united language for all Crownless; this has gotten the farthest in the Twin Kingdoms, where a group of Highpoint elite are trying to make a constructed language they're going to call Common Crownless. It's basically doomed to be the Etherian Esperanto, of no use or purpose but novelty, but hey, points for trying!

Side note, the Last Fire Princess, Signum, was communicating directly with Adora's mind, which is the only reason she was able to speak with her; Signum knew Old Millenium and Firetongue, but none of the modern languages were even invented when her kingdom burned and she killed herself. She wrote the names of the Spirit Ember aspirants in Firetongue, never realizing that very few modern folk would ever be able to read them... she really got lucky that Adora gained that knowledge, and was able to give them their due in history.

The Spirit Ember also taught Adora the First One's language, though she's not aware of it yet. The First Ones' language, and a primer accessible to anyone with enough First Ones' genetic information, was copied into almost every damn thing they built, as part of the Eternian obsession with living forever and being, well, eternal. The same ability extends to the Sword they built and whoever acquires it, mostly as a

failsafe. This is why Catra can decipher First Ones' language. Their language is simply called Eternian Standard; when the planet reached one world government status, they eradicated all other languages. Any surviving colonies would use it, too...

Chapter 43: The Last War Council of the Horde

Chapter Notes

Family emergency resolved, and now I'm back!

This time: A bunch of stuff happens that isn't important, I bet!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Last War Council of the Horde

Lonnie's secretary, old Callix, greeted her with good cheer.

“ Heading out to the meeting, boss?” he asked, in his thickly-accented Perfect Speech. He'd been from Green Thatch, back in the day; a criminal, thrown in jail for beating up a nobleman's son for trying to rape his sister. Hordak's revolution had freed him, and he'd been a Hordesman ever since... but he'd never really grasped Perfect Speech very well.

“ Yes,” Lonnie said. His good cheer felt almost painful, weighed against her own dour mood. Callix didn't seem to notice- or maybe he was trying to cheer her up. He was good like that.

“ Eh, I'll keep watch til you get back, then,” he said. “ See ya soon!”

“ ...Yes,” Lonnie said, even as she thought *not if the Spirit Ember demands my head.*

Pondering, in a distant kind of way, the question of whether or not she was marching to her own execution, Lonnie descended the stairs that led out of her office and entered the streets of the Fright Zone.

It wasn't all *that* different from the way it had been under Hordak, but that somehow made the differences stand out even more, jarring islands of change in a placid sea of stasis. The metal buildings with long windows of bullet-proof glass were the same, as was the overcast sky above, a product of the rampant industrialization and more rampant pollution Hordak had been forced to engage in to build his war machine... but the Horde standards hanging from the walls were different. A little red dragon for the Dragon, spouting flame, as opposed to Hordak's crimson bat wings.

Lonnie's fellow Hordesmen still marched to and fro, on one bit of business or another, but now they skewed young, her age or a bit below; the wave of defections in the wake of Hordak's death had been disproportionately the older and more experienced Hordesmen. While many of the absolute oldest, like Callix or Grizzlor, had stayed, those who had been revolutionaries for Hordak many long years ago, those who were between the young and the old had mostly fled. They had, after all, mostly consisted of those who had jumped ship once before to join Hordak's side; perhaps they found it was even easier to abandon a sinking ship

the second time they did it. Only a few of those who'd joined up for power and profit had stayed for the hard times- and those, always the ones who had nowhere else to go.

(Lonnie was still surprised Octavia and Dreer hadn't fled. Maybe they'd both burned their bridges too thoroughly to go back across.)

The remaining soldiers, though, they were doing their duty; Lonnie almost wanted to be proud of them, proud of them for being true Hordesmen...

But there was something else there now, too. A kind of... excitement, low-burning but *there,* smoldering in every eye, ready to burst into flame at a touch. A difference not so much in nature but in *tone.* They were just as proud, just as efficient, just as tough, but now all of it was burned around the edges, singed to char by this... *eagerness*, this spark inside them that wanted so desperately for kindling.

Many of them greeted Lonnie as they saw her, that fervor leaking out of their eyes and into their throats, delighted to see one who was so close to their Lord, wanting nothing more than to hear holy scripture from Lonnie's blasphemous lips. She barely responded, too afraid that anything she said would be air enough to act as bellows for this fire, would bring the thing she saw in their eyes into full, bursting life. In the light from such a blaze, all Lonnie's doubts in Adora would be exposed, they would *know*, and if Adora ever found out...

Well, she wouldn't be the first person Adora had sent to Beast Island.

(*Assuming the Spirit Ember doesn't want to cook me alive; wasn't death by fire a popular method of execution in Silverglade, wizards hurling fireballs at dissidents tied to posts? And for... heretics?*)

All this was different. All of this was not how it had been when Hordak still lived.

But it was when she stepped out of the halls of the administrative building that she saw the biggest sign that the Horde wasn't the same as it had been.

In what had, once, been one of the Horde's bigger parking lots for vehicles, a bonfire blazed under the dim, smoky sky. It was gigantic, a towering blaze whose heat Lonnie could feel even from where she stood outside the administration building's door; like all the truly great fires, it breathed, and the scorched air washed over her like an echo of a dragon's breath.

(dragon dragon *Dragon*)

Hordesmen circled it like worshipers around an altar, either dancing or drinking or feasting, most standing, a few sitting in stolen couches and chairs, the entire affair somewhere between a barbecue and an occult ritual. The fire was fueled by stolen goods, from things taken in the great raids, returned here to the Fright Zone when Adora recalled all the away teams; it must have been one of them that first suggested burning the stuff that wasn't immediately useful, the things that had been taken because, when one was already a'thieving, the urge to take even the useless stuff was strong. The Horde's banditry had produced enough goods to provide the seating arrangements and the fuel

both; Lonnie caught glimpses of Phlax building materials and Blackmoor goods and Plumerian art and Brightmoon military equipment, all ablaze, the Crwonless and the Kingdoms united at last as nothing more than ash.

It was midday, but the lighting at the Fright Zone was always poor from the great smokestacks of industry, which had been working overtime to provide for the great assault; in that dimness, the orange-red of the blaze reflected oddly off of the Fright Zone's construction; the light did not dispel the shadows, but strengthened them, light and dark working in tandem to lend the whole world a feeling of eerie surreality. Lonnie had never gotten high nor drunk before, but in this moment, she understood what a bad trip was; everywhere she looked, the world was *wrong,* the alleys too deep, the Hordesmen too strange, the world off its kilter and spinning merrily into madness.

About this centralizing fire, Lonnie's people were making merry, drinking and eating, dancing, making out, or even retreating to dark corners to do more, vaguely glimpsed in the firelight. The dances and the sex were original Horde creations but the rest were rewards of the raids, same as the fire itself; Plumerian wine, the finest in Etheria, stolen right from the vineyards, mingling in the gullets of the Horde with the clear mead of Brightmoon and the good stout beer of Phlax, Blackmoor ale flowing freely from ten good barrels stolen from a fort they'd crushed and put to the torch.

To go with their drink, they had food from the Twin Kingdoms and from Salineas; a group of Rebels had been run to ground, their supplies pilfered, multiple rations of the Twin Kingdoms stolen from the slaughtered enemy. The Salinean goods were from a Salinean destroyer that had suffered engine failure and wrecked

on the coast; the captain had been forced to beach it, and a passing Horde raid team had assailed it before it could be scuttled properly. Most of the crew had escaped safely back to sea in lifeboats- nobody prepared for that kind of disaster like Salineans- but the tech and the treats were both the Horde's, now.

The food wasn't much, really; Twin Kingdoms' canned rolls and Salinean salted stockfish, captain's hardtack and desert stew. Not traditionally anyone's idea of riches... but compared to ration bars, everything was manna from heaven, and *victory* was a spice sweeter than anything but hunger itself.

It wasn't the only spice, though, nor the only stunt her people were pulling with their new gifts. Two Hordesmen who Lonnie vaguely recognized as being cooks at the Horde's lone bar, *Force Captain Reorientation,* were busy using a relatively cooler part of the bonfire, a repurposed attack track front grill, and some very long-handled spoons and skillets- also robbed from somewhere, probably Phlax given their simple, sturdy design- to make something new. They were breaking up the rolls and hardtack and frying them in the sauce of the stews, adding the stockfish and a few stolen things, including fat slaps of bundas cow butter, the white squares melting down to coat the whole thing. It was a kind of bread stew that they topped with paprika and pepper, and it was proving quite the party favor; they were pouring it in any bowls offered by others, the resulting mix devoured heartily by the Hordesmen, glorying in the delight of once-forbidden spices. The cooks were praised and praised, and many were looking at them lustfully; to do such a service for their fellow Hordesmen when no one had even ordered them to do it, after all, was terribly attractive to a Horde mind, and by the end of the night, both men would have their fill of whatever romantic partners they wanted.

Fire in the belly and fire in the loins was matched with fire in the soul; there was a preacher among them. One young Lunoth woman, right hand holding a tower shield clearly based on the one Adora had wielded for years as weapon and protection both, was using her free left to gesticulate wildly as she stood next to the bonfire, spreading her gospel to the reveling crowd; she spoke of the future, for her, for them, for everyone in the Horde, a future full of wonders that Lord Adora's reign would bring. She pointed out the miracles they already had, things they'd never had before- the bonfire, the alcohol, even the very food they were eating, bread and fishes stolen from enemy stores- all gifts of Adora.

" No more will we eat ration bars, no more will we suffer the predations of the Princesses!" she screamed at the tail end of her impassioned speech. " We will have everything! Everything! **Lord Adora will give us the world!**"

The crowd roared its agreement, others joining in, and two particularly enthusiastic Hordesmen threw some of the old, hated ration bars into the fire, to general acclaim.

(They burned slowly; apparently even fire was reluctant to eat the damn things.)

All of this would never have been allowed under Hordak, this... almost destructive level of joy, this gleeful franticness. It wasn't... it wasn't proper, it wasn't *right*, there was something to this frenzied wildfire happiness that scared Lonnie deep down into her very bones. This was a lure, a temptation, a trap, and it was one that Lonnie, to her shame, wanted to fall into. She wanted to go down there, join in the fun, dance and drink and eat, indulge in these forbidden delights! Some part of her... wanted.

But Lonnie resisted. This wasn't right. Hordesmen *did not act like this.*

So she was able, with more effort than she would ever admit to another person, to keep moving, to walk away from the blazing fire, to head towards the meeting she was supposed to attend and put the fire behind her.

She was one of the only ones. The sheer size of the crowd around the bonfire proved *that*. They gave in to temptation, and they loved their Lord for it. No one had appointed that woman to be a preacher; she had done that of her own free will. Adora had these people's loyalty and their faith.

These Hordesmen would do anything Adora asked of them, or die trying.

(*flame, flame, flames and kingdoms, kingdom, kingdom, how many Hordesmen does it take to make a Flame Kingdom)*

Anything.

(Answer: just one, just a First One)

After that, Lonnie resolutely tried not to notice anything going on around her, simply stalked past the fire and the party and towards her destination with all the strength she could manage. Some part of her desire not to be bothered must have been visible; even

with everyone running around for last minute preparations, they all avoided Lonnie, who moved as the eye of this *(fire)* storm. She passed veterans loading up trucks, armorers making last minute adjustments, engineers making sure that they had the equipment they'd need to slap up fortifications once they conquered the Heart-Blossom... all kinds of things.

Only one group managed to penetrate her willpower, but it smashed into her like a thunderbolt; a whole little cadet class, newly minted from the Horde's training, so new that even the symbol of Adora's Dragon on their armor looked freshly painted. They were a giddy little knot of life, humans and satyrs and squamatus, kids not that much younger than Lonnie herself, who... who were so *happy* , who were talking excitedly about how good it was going to be, to be part of the Dragon's great assault, for the attack on Plumeria to be their *first* mission. How *honored* they were. How *glad* they were, that they were just old enough to join in, when peace was around the corner, and earn some accolades for themselves.

Memories, of a time when that was Lonnie herself, and her own cadet class, pressed so tight and close on the young woman that Lonnie lost the following few minutes, thinking of nothing at all, even as her body continued to walk.

When she came back to herself, she panicked for a moment. What- what was that? She hadn't been sleeping well- it was hard to do so, unspoken fears swimming in the sea of her soul, breaching the surface, causing her to snap awake from nightmares she couldn't remember- and it wasn't the first time that had happened, but her upbringing had left her no words for it, she didn't know what it was. Was it the Runestone leaking out, did it *know* how she felt, was it trying to corrode her from within?

(She did not know that there *were* words for this, from the mind soothers of Mystacor, words she knew but had never put together as one before; she did not know what a panic attack was, even as she was suffering them.)

She hurried on, hoping no one had noticed, and her terror of what had just happened was so strong that she pretended to herself that it hadn't happened either.

Eventually, her denials were fuel enough to help her reach the Furnace; it wasn't a surprise that she was the last of the Force Captains to get there. She hadn't wanted to come, after all. The Furnace, formerly just a warehouse, now had a sinister edge to it in Lonnie's eyes; an eerie red glow emanated from the few windows, and heat shimmered off the building. It reminded her of an old saying about sleeping dragons.

(*Did we doom Adora when we called her the Dragon did we all curse her with this I encouraged her is this all my fault*)

The others were gathered in a rough semi-circle, facing the entrance of the Furnace. Anchoring one end was Octavia, Dreer next to her, the duo talking like the old friends they were (to the extent people like them could engage in the concept.) Dreer had been with Octavia in Rosewood when Adora asked them to come, and both had been free to come by, because to be frank, they had nothing better to do. Between Salineas kicking Octavia's teeth in at sea, and Adora taking over Dreer's old job of being the most knowledgeable about magic, the duo were as close to nobodies as Force Captains ever got.

These days, Dreer did... nothing, as far as Lonnie knew, except hang out with Octavia, and Octavia honestly didn't do much more than Dreer did. Even before Hordak's death, Octavia had mostly just had what was left of her fleet patrol the coast in big groups, since smaller patrols would get set upon by Salineas, the Cove, Seaworthy, or, sometimes, all three at once, the three nations in an unspoken alliance and ganging up on the Horde. Only large fleets- and the use of the Horde's shore defenses, inherited from the Fright Zone and upgraded in the decades since- were proof against such assault, and even then, not always, not if Mermista was with the attacking group. Submarines could give her some trouble, but most ships were helpless against someone who could wield the very water they floated on against them.

Before Hordak died, he'd ordered Octavia to start rebuilding the Horde's fleet in the safety of Rosewood, which had been Plumeria's best port and was now the Horde's once they killed the last Plumerian Princess, Princess Kazami. Octavia had been doing just that when Adora took over, and gave her new orders- all work was redirected away from the water, and towards the land war.

Octavia was stuck with what she had; Adora was abandoning all future plans for naval conquest. No, all resources had been diverted to the Fright Zone's foundries, to produce Horde skiffs and new generations of Hordebots, or to retrofit some of the Horde's older vehicles; Adora had brought a bunch of production models out of mothballs to assist with their strained resource problems, as it was cheaper to upgrade them than to try and build entirely new vehicles. The old attack tracks and talon fighters were being upgraded with fireproofing and Adora's favored weaponry; Lonnie had heard the troops were calling the new variants salamanders and phoenixes, in honor of the fiery weaponry they now bore.

With all those factors in play, Octavia and Dreer were functionally jobless, which was one reason Lonnie had been watching them. Both had come to the Horde looking for power; Dreer had hoped to have his magic back, Octavia had sought to lead a navy and not merely serve in one. Those ambitions had been dashed, and that meant their loyalty was suspect, for only those ambitions had bound them to the Horde at all.

Next to the least loyal Force Captains was the most loyal; Mantenna, who eagerly awaited Adora's appearance, telescoping metallic eyes zooming in and out as he observed the door in silence. Finding out that she was a First One had made the tech-minded Lunoth one of Adora's biggest supporters; he seemed to believe she could unlock the secrets to spreading his cybernetic ambitions to other races. Adora had also freed him from intelligence work, which he'd appreciated immensely. Mantenna had done a fine job as Hordak's spymaster- though Imp had been Hordak's personal spy in the ranks- but he'd never enjoyed the job, had always wanted to do research first.

It was the main reason he'd never challenged Lonnie as she more or less fell into the position- he'd been happy to get out of the job, cheerfully handing her all his files before taking off. He was one of the ones Lonnie wasn't watching all that hard; he'd stay loyal as long as he could tinker, and Adora had just been glad someone had taken over Entrapta's old job. He wasn't nearly as good as the Drylborn Wild Princess, of course, nor even as good as Hordak, but he *was* better than most, and the science teams were just glad to have an official leader finally. The only real complaints had been that Mantenna's obsession with replacing meat with machine had led him to make some bizarre comments to Hordesmen who had serious injuries.

Apparently Mantenna dreamed of turning everyone in the Horde into cyborgs... reminded Lonnie of the stories the old soldiers told about Vargon, of what its last Duke had done with the Bull's Eye, using that Minor Runestone to make monsters of the minotaurs and satyrs under his command. Vicious bastard. Killing Vargon's last Duke and taking away his Runestone had been one of the Horde's first and proudest triumphs; it was how Grizzlor had made Force Captain, he'd been one of the most prominent revolutionaries in Vargon even before Hordak had come to help them. The Mane had been in the revolution in an attempt to avenge his brother; Hordak had joined and brought technology and language and wisdom to the movement, forming the very bones of the Horde to come. The Horde's first Lord had been so impressed with Grizzlor's heroism during the revolution- and the fact that Grizzlor had not left the struggle after Vargon, but instead stayed with Hordak as he went to Green Thatch and GaleBreath- that Hordak had made him a Force Captain, when they finally brought down the Fright Zone and the Horde was born at last.

Speaking of that worthy... Grizzlor was next to Mantenna, though quite a farther distance from him. He'd never liked Mantenna, probably due to that very campaign in Vargon, but his glare wasn't being directed at the Lunoth. No, Grizzlor was looking at the Furnace, and he seemed... unhappy?

Hmm. Lonnie looked again, parsing it out. No, not... not quite unhappy. *Suspicious*, that's what this was, the big Mane seemed *suspicious*, looking at the Furnace and the heat rolling off of the building with mistrust and *disgust,* both of which he could barely disguise.

...Grizzlor *was* on her list, since she'd thought that a man who hated the Runestones enough to stay with Hordak even after his brother was avenged might be opposed to a Princess in charge. She'd put him on the list as a maybe, but she'd never had a chance to observe him before now. He had spent his time prosecuting the eternal siege in the east of Brightmoon's sole port or, more recently, doing a tour of the outlying Horde territory.

It was almost like he was avoiding the Fright Zone, now that Lonnie thought about it, in light of the look on his face. If it hadn't been for sheer bad luck- and it still struck Lonnie as absurd, that the man who had been at Crystal Falls, probably the fiercest fighting the Horde was involved in, completely unharmed, had managed to wander into *Netossa*, whose Rebels were the toughest of that fairly elite group, on a do-nothing detail- he might not be here at all, was only here because his injuries demanded their best medical work. Maybe he could... help Lonnie.

(*not a traitor I'm not a traitor I'm trying to save Adora from the Spirit Ember I'm not Catra I'm not a traitor*)

Kyle stood next to him, perfectly at attention, and more at ease in himself than she'd ever seen him; he eagerly waved her over, breaking her out of her thoughts.

" Hey!" he said cheerfully to her. " You were almost late! That's not like you at all, to arrive *after* me!"

She nodded, and barely found her tongue.

“ Yeah,” she said. “ I... haven't been sleeping well.”

Kyle's face grew concerned as Lonnie walked up to him, and he patted her shoulder.

“ Hey, don't work yourself so hard, okay?” he said. “ I know you're like, the best soldier ever except Adora, but you need rest, you know? You can't be at your best if you don't get some sleep!”

Normally she'd crack a joke or mock him, but right now, his kindness felt not a little bit like salt in her wounds; it made her feel... guilty. Ashamed. She feared that if she opened her mouth to talk with him, everything inside her would come spilling out; and Kyle, Kyle didn't know, Rogelio knew and didn't care and Kyle didn't know and both were against her, she was alone, uttery alone. If she told them anything about what was going on inside her, Adora would find out... and that meant her *sister* would find out.

So Lonnie didn't say anything; she didn't trust her tongue, felt if her mouth opened it would all fall out. So instead she just nodded, and turned to face the Furnace, silent and ready in a parade rest, the very picture of the good Hordesman.

She was the last Force Captain to arrive, and the last one in total. Adora had, thankfully, kept everyone among their number who had been with them when Adora revealed her great secret, but that didn't mean they hadn't suffered defections beforehand. Vultak had run off with a small Horde army into the south, seceding to form his own little fiefdom near Halfmoon; they'd

been attacking him, too, but he knew them too well, and sometimes units sent south joined up instead of fighting him. Blast had simply disappeared instead of continuing to attack Blackmoor after his forces got crushed between Netossa and Spinnerella's Rebels and a Blackmoor army some months back, they weren't sure if he was dead or just a deserter. Storm had died after taking his forces and making an ill-fated attempt to conquer Halfmoon for himself instead of the Horde; fucking jackass. He'd not only wasted Horde lives on a selfish goal, but left Halfmoon almost totally unguarded in the aftermath, the Magicats no longer as boxed in; Mantenna, the Force Captain who'd been in charge down there when Storm broke in and stole command from him, had asked for reinforcements, but Adora had denied him. She'd claimed she needed the resources for other things; after coming back, she'd even further reduced the guard down there, recalling Mantenna and leaving a skeleton crew behind, more to be a warning than to deter Halfmoon from leaving its underground home.

(That, at least, Lonnie was pretty sure had nothing to do with the Runestone- that was all Adora, or, more accurately, all *Catra*, Adora's lingering love keeping her from assailing Catra's land of birth too harshly despite the advice of literally everyone else. After Force Captain Tara blew up Saz's corpse, there would never be peace between the Horde and Halfmoon.)

Vultak, Blast, Storm... those were the most prominent names among those who had abandoned the cause, but by no means the only ones. A lot of more minor groups had just... left, disappeared, either slipping away in the dead of night or robbing the Horde first and then fleeing in stolen vehicles. She'd heard that a lot of them went to the Rebels, hoping to win amnesty with equipment, but not a few had went to Phlax, which was eager to get its hands on Horde tech...

Lonnie lingered on these thoughts, on the fates of deserters and traitors, which was silly, because she was neither one. She would *never* be either one.

(*Right?*)

Such brooding was interrupted by a friendly voice, as the Furnace opened and out stepped two people, whose presence in prior years would have gladdened Lonnie's heart, and whose appearance now simply sank it further down.

Rogelio looked as he usually did, though he was carrying a strange metal box that looked a bit like a treasure chest, one with multiple locks. Adora next to him, in her new armor, looked like Hordak, so much like him that Lonnie ached for the man's absence, for the times when he had been alive, and she had not been so... conflicted.

But then she saw the fire that had seemingly replaced Adora's left, burned eye, and Lonnie's throat went dry. Fire, her eye was gone and replaced with flame, and her left hand, too, blazed, ungloved as it was; her right hand was still armored, and her great tower shield was kept folded up in the gauntlet, but her burned left hand was ready to inflict its own suffering on others, fire licking along her knuckles hungrily.

Lonnie stared at the duo, who thankfully were too engrossed in their conversation to notice.

“ So maybe anyone who doesn't want to have kids will get picked first for the most dangerous jobs,” Adora said to Rogelio as she stepped out. Thankfully, it was in Perfect Speech, so Lonnie both didn't have to hear that grating new tongue, and also because it meant Lonnie actually understood her. She *sort* of understood Firetongue, the way she used to only sort of understand Rogelio's Dragontongue, but she didn't get everything. “ They don't have kids to orphan should they die... though, not having kids actually has other benefits, now that I'm thinking about it! It means they can focus on the here and now. Parents have too much to worry about to be able to focus entirely on what the Horde needs from them, their attention and loyalty is always gonna be a bit split.”

“ True,” Rogelio said. “ Better to have people in charge who can keep their eye on the ball.”

“ Yeah! So we should give them priority for promotion, too!” Adora continued. “ Not only will they be the ones risking the most, but they'll be the ones with the most reason to see clearly what should be done, since they can focus on their work instead of their children. Seems rational enough!”

“ Maybe,” Rogelio said. “ Something to consider. But I think the meeting is starting.”

Adora turned to the crowd and cursed- in her new language. It sounded like the snarling crackle of meat hitting a sizzling hot pan. Lonnie barely suppressed a telling flinch.

“ I almost forgot!” Adora said afterwards in the language of a proper Hordesman, with a quick burst of laughter. The fire in her left eye briefly sparked bright, like it was laughing along, and the blast of warm air from the brief flare-up left Lonnie shivering where she stood. “ Thanks, Rogelio, I've been so damn busy lately- you've been a real help! Hard to keep track of everything! I'll be glad when this is done, I can take a nap. I dont' really *need* to sleep anymore, my sister seems to be sustaining me, but the break will be nice.”

“ You don't sleep anymore?” Kyle asked.

“ Nope!” Adora said brightly. “ Just plain don't need it, apparently! But that's not important right now, we've got a war council to get to!”

She gave a big smile to the gathered group.

“ So,” she said. “ Everybody; today's gonna be a hell of a day. I'm handing out gifts. How many of you recall the Runestone Duchies?”

“ I was *there*,” Grizzlor growled quietly, eyeing the box in Rogelio's hands with a narrowed glare.

“ I was in the movement at GaleBreath,” Mantenna whispered quietly. Lonnie had no idea why he whispered; maybe a throat

wound? Or he just liked being creepy. " The others had fallen by that point."

The remaining two just shrugged.

" I know they *were* here," Octavia said. " But they were already sunk by the time I joined up. Well, except Halfmoon, I guess."

" Same story here," Dreer said.

" I'm pretty sure none of us," Kyle said, indicating Lonnie, Rogelio and Adora, " were even *born* before the Duchies fell."

" We weren't!" Adora said cheerfully. " So! Then Grizzlor and Mantenna, sorry about this next part. For the rest of you, history lesson! Rogelio, if you would."

Rogelio put the box down, and opened it with a set of keys Adora handed him. When he opened it, inside, on small stands, sat five small gems... but even Lonnie, inexperienced at jewel appraisal, knew these weren't *really* gems. There was a kind of... weight to them, as though they kept their own counsel with gravity. They reminded Lonnie of the Black Garnet, of the Spirit Ember...

Minor Runestones, some part of Lonnie thought, distantly, clearly. *She's handing out the Minor Runestones. I was right.*

(Somewhere, even more distantly, some part of Lonnie began to scream.)

" So the Runestone Duchies weren't Runestone Kingdoms but they weren't Crownless, either!" Adora said cheerfully as she indicated the box. " We've got the Bull's Eye, the Cat's Eye, the Crystal Spider, the Ruby of Knowledge, and the Nordor Crystal. We're only missing Green Thatch's Perfect Blue- Peekablue over in Seaworthy has it. Shame! I'd love to have better intel with it. Still, five out of six is still really good!"

" Hey, wait," Octavia said, cocking her head. " I thought there were only five Runestone Duchies."

" There were," Mantenna said. " Vargon, Green Thatch, GaleBreath, Silverglade, and Halfmoon."

" But six Minor Runestones?" Dreer said, figuring out where his friend was going. " That math doesn't hold up."

" Silverglade had two!" Adora said, nodding her head at the oddly skull-shaped gem on the farthest right in the box, which was colored the dull, low gleam of silver moonlight. " But that one there, the Nordor Crystal, it wasn't traditionally considered among the other Minor Runestones. At least, that's what Hordak's notes said. Mostly because it makes you really powerful and also makes you kinda... off. It's power is to *surpass limitations*."

Adora intoned this last with false gravitas; Rogelio and Kyle snorted, and Octava and Dreer grinned. Mantenna did not, his cybernetic eyes zoomed in and locked onto the crystal to the farthest left, a dark brownish red stone, striped with long vertical lines of brighter browns and duller reds. Lonnie noticed that Grizzlor, too, was staring at that same gem... well, *glaring* was the more correct term.

" So you get much stronger than normal! Unfortunately, it also applies to *mental* limitations; those little checks and balances a person has inside? They just go away!" Adora said with a shrug. " You become a creature of pure passion. You want to kill somebody, you do. You want to fuck somebody, you do. Wanna eat? Guess what you do! Silverglade didn't like it much, so they only really used the other one they had- the Ruby of Knowledge."

She pointed at the stone sitting next to the Nordor Crystal, which was the most classically beautiful of the gems in the chest, a lovely square cut of cherry-red.

" I'm not giving the Nordor Crystal to anyone... but the Ruby? Well, the Ruby's power is *perfect understanding of oneself*... it protects the mind, ends outside influence on the mind, and lets the user recall anything they've ever known."

She turned to Dreer, and smiled at him.

" I believe," she said, " that Hordak promised you your magic. I will fulfill my predecessor's promise with the Ruby."

Dreer stared at her for a moment, eyes widening as what she'd said dawned on him.

" It can... it can give me back my magic?" he asked, and Adora nodded.

" I think so," she said. " Hordak was working on how to resolve your problem; I've got his notes. When Mystacor takes someone's magic, they do so by using just a little dark magic to cloud the mind so that it loses the memory of the specific spell-casting instructions, and then they add a minor dark magic effect that eats up any ambient magic around the victim. It uses that to sustain itself. You haven't actually *lost* your magic, you just can't quite remember the spells right, and any ambient magic you'd use to power yourself is getting slurped up by the curse. But the Ruby will clear your mind, and if I'm reading his notes right, it's too powerful for the drain effect to destroy. If Hordak and me are right- I double-checked his math, Hordak wasn't as good of a mage as I am- then the Ruby will not only let you remember your spellwork, but will overwhelm the curse and kill it by giving it too much juice at once. Basically, you're going to force-feed it to death."

Dreer blinked, shaking his head.

" If... if he had this... why did he not give it to me?" he asked, and there was real sorrow there. " If he could have saved me at any time..."

“ Yeah!” Octavia chimed in, defending him. “ If he always had this, why not give it to Dreer at the start? Not like the Horde couldn't have used another mage.”

“ The Ruby's not without risks,” Adora said kindly in the face of Dreer's obvious distress. “ Shadow Weaver used it once... and was struck by overwhelming guilt for all she'd done. She tried to commit suicide, Dreer.”

“ Holy shit,” Kyle muttered. Octavia grimaced.

“ I... really?”

Adora nodded.

“ Yes. Not to put too fine a point on it, it freaked Hordak out; it's one reason he never used the Runestones,” Adora said. “ But the Horde's in a tight spot, now. We don't have a choice but to break out everything we've got. Hordak wasn't totally sure why Shadow Weaver felt guilt when she used the stone... maybe that'll happen to you too, Dreer. Maybe it won't. Maybe something else will happen. Hordak wasn't sure and neither am I- I guess it depends on how much of yourself you already accept, and have dealt with.”

“ I'm willing to risk it,” Dreer said. “ I'm pretty content with the man I am.”

Yeah, Lonnie thought. *Him and Octavia are both amoral power-hungry bastards, but they're very honest about it with themselves and others... but Shadow Weaver was a liar.*

" Hordak also did not use the Ruby for another reason," Adora said. " He feared Shadow Weaver would kill you if you became a mage. He wanted to find a way to get rid of her first, and in the meantime, he was trying to come up with a tech solution for your problems that wouldn't require the Minor Runestone. The Ruby was a last-resort for him, and now, it's one for me, too... but Hordak was saving your life."

A pause as everyone considered that.

" No, she totally would have killed you," Octavia said. " Nothing would get her to raise flags like another mage in the Horde... yeah, Hordak was saving your life, bud."

" Shit," Dreer said, sighing. " He really was. And it wasn't like we had much time between Shadow Weaver breaking out and then the Portal incident... hmm. Well. I do like being alive; I can't blame him."

He looked at Adora, his face just a little... vulnerable.

" But now?" he queried. Adora nodded.

“ Rogelio, if you would?” she asked.

He nodded, and with a gloved hand, the squamatus withdrew the square, and walked over to Dreer.

“ Hey, if you freak out, I'll tackle you and keep you from doing something stupid,” Octavia said. Dreer gave her a quick grin.

“ I'll hold you to it,” he said. “ Here goes... everything.”

He held a hand out, and Rogelio dropped the ruby into his hand, as everybody waited with bated breath. Nothing happened for what felt like to Lonnie a long, long minute, though it was most likely only a few seconds.

Then Dreer began to weep.

They were totally silent. Just a few drops of water down his face, as he stared into empty space, watching something none of the rest of them could see. There was a quiet sort of sound, a low kind of whine, and Lonnie saw something dark and smoky crawl from Dreer's skin and onto the Ruby, trying to smother it. The whine continued and grew in pitch until, suddenly, the dark and crawling ooze burst apart, extinguished utterly with a sound like a fire starting, the Ruby beneath shining dully as it extinguished

utterly the curse placed so many years ago on Dreer, light conquering the dark.

Octavia, leaned forward and ready to charge, tapped her friend.

" Hey," she said, " do I gotta tackle you? You crying is freaking me out."

" Tears of joy," he said thickly, raising a hand and drawing, with quick slashes, a magical sigil in the air. It formed into a dark, batlike shadow that flitted about them. " I... I remember... *everything*. My studies. The idea of life after death. A journey into Skullpath, between Phlax and Spikeheart... the old caves. The tablets there... written by Keldor of the House of Miro... they burned the notes I made on them in Mystacor, but that doesn't matter, I *remember.* A way to make the dead rise, the reason why it was named Skullpath in the first place, centuries and centuries ago... my magic. *I have my magic back.*"

" Make the dead rise?" Grizzlor said quietly, and the ferocious warrior took a single step back from Dreer as his grin grew wider and wider and *wider*.

" I am a mage again," Dreer said, before turning his head away from the memories he was looking at and back to Adora. " My... my Lord. Thank you. Thank you."

He sounded genuine, and alarms rang in Lonnie's head again.

(*he'd do anything she asked anything anything anything*)

" You're welcome," Adora said, with a grin. " You're one of my Hordesmen, after all; you stayed. And I intend to fulfill all of Hordak's promises; everything he said he would give the Horde, I will give you as his dau- his inheritor."

The others didn't catch what she'd almost said. Dreer was too busy being overwhelmed, Octavia too busy cheering for her friend, Grizzlor too busy being freaked out and Mantenna too busy staring at the Bull's Eye with naked hunger... but Lonnie heard it, as did Kyle and Rogelio, the latter of whom gave Adora a nod of support that she gratefully received.

(*daughter? What is she going on about now?*)

Adora, momentary gaffe forgotten, stepped forward, and put her burned hand on Dreer's shoulder, though Lonnie noted that she seemed to be deliberately trying not to touch the Ruby.

" I'm glad I could help," Adora said, and Dreer nodded his head.

" I... I don't have the words," he admitted. Adora gave him a smile.

" You already thanked me," she said, as she let go of his shoulder and stepped back. " And you are one of mine. This is merely what a good Lord should do."

Dreer exhaled a shaky breath.

" A moment," he said, chuckling weakly. He wiped his face off. " That was... embarrassing, but I don't care. I'm a mage again."

" Fuck yeah!" Octavia cheered. " It's good to see it! Didn't know you'd cry like a bitch, though. Getting soft, Dreer!"

" You're lucky I like you," Dreer said, laughing as Octavia jeered at him. He made another little illusion of a bat and sent it to harass Octavia. " I'll show you how soft I am- got my magic back, I'll fry you with lightning if you cross me, get myself some seafood- always did love squid!"

" Octopus, jackass! Besides, I've been with you at the target range," Octavia snorted as she waved her hand at the bat illusion swooping at her head. " You can't hit shit at a distance, you think you can get me with a spell?"

" Hold on you two," Adora said, interrupting Dreer's rejoinder in the friendly ribbing. " Got more to do today! Though, Dreer... see me tomorrow, once you've, you know, kinda got a handle on all this. We'll make you a necklace or maybe a wand for the Ruby, something, and I want to hear more about this magic you were talking about. Making the dead rise..."

The dead, alive again...

" Could we save Hordak that way?" Lonnie asked. That would solve all of her problems in a single go.

Adora, to her surprise, lit up in the most literal fashion at her words, her eye flaring into brilliant life, flickering high above her and sending out a pulse of heat.

" Fuck, I didn't even think of that!" she said, turning to Dreer excitedly. " Could we-"

" It's not- it's not resurrection," he said, shaking his head. " It makes the body get up again and act, animates it with the skills it had in life, but it does not bring back that person, and I need a body to start with. It *can* answer questions the dead knew in life but even that is... filtered. Death takes a lot from the dying."

Adora sighed, her eye settling down and back to its usual blaze.

" Well, shit," she said. " Though I *do* like the idea of Hordesmen getting to serve again. That's... that's good. Serving in the farms at the end of life is honorable, but continuing the fight... that feels better, somehow."

Lonnie had to admit, it did; she was sure the other nations would find it horrific, but she liked it. The idea of greater service, of

continuing the struggle, of duty to the Horde transcending even death... well, they already did that, placing their dead as fertilizer in the factory farms. This... yes, this was... this could be a good thing. A *Horde* thing.

(*assuming it's trustworthy... but it's coming from Dreer, it absolutely isn't...*)

" It'd be something if a Hordesman could keep going, though," Rogelio noted. " We serve after death in the farms anyway. If this could be a more effective version of it..."

" Yeah," Kyle said. " And if we could ask the corpses what happened after a battle, we'd know more; the Rebels don't leave a lot of people alive, most of the time."

" I never totally got it working," Dreer admitted, finally dismissing the bat illusion that was then trying to sit on Octavia's head. " I got interrupted before I could piece it all together- the tablets weren't entirely whole, I was having to guess on some of it. But... I've got my magic back. I can keep doing the research... and we'll definitely talk. For this? For giving me my magic back?"

He grinned.

" I'll tell you anything you want to know."

" Good!" Adora said. " I also want your help with magic- I've been sort of winging it, but I'd really like some formal training!"

" You need it!" Dreer burst out laughing, still almost high from getting his magic back. His hand kept doing circles, making little magic sigils that disintegrated in the air afterwards; not real spellcasting, just basically playing with it, reminding himself it was *there*. " Adora, you would have failed out of every course I ever took, now that I remember everything I just... cannot *believe* you got most of your magic working! You must be powerful as all get-out to make your sloppy spellwork function! Shadow Weaver must fucking *suck* as a teacher, you cast spells the way a drunk man throws haymakers."

" Hey!" Kyle said defensively. " Lay off, dude!"

" No, no, he's right," Adora said, grinning herself. " Shadow Weaver *was* terrible! But hopefully now I have someone who can teach me."

Lonnie was the only one who noticed that Adora didn't *actually* say Shadow Weaver had trained her in magic; that was one of the lies Lonnie had come up with, at the start of all this, when they were talking of how to save the Horde. A lie they had sold to the Horde, justified by necessity... and it had led to all this.

(*is Adora being the Dragon my fault is the Spirit Ember my fault did I set her on this path*)

“ Hell, if you're this dangerous when you don't know what you're doing,” Octavia opined, “ you're gonna be something once Dreer trains you up.”

“ That's what I'm hoping!” Adora said. “ But that's for later.”

“ My Lord,” Mantenna whispered from nearby, interrupting, his eyes never leaving the stone they were focused on, “ I... I must ask.”

“ Let me answer all your questions in one go,” Adora said, turning to the Lunoth. “ Yes, that's the Bull's Eye, and yes, I'm giving it to you.”

“ Thank you,” Mantenna whispered, but anything else was lost by a low growl.

“ You know what that can do?” Grizzlor asked from nearby. “ What it's *capable* of?”

“ I do,” Adora said. “ And I know what the Bull's Eye took from you, Grizzlor. Hordak noted it down. But Mantenna's not the Duke of Vargon. He's *Horde*. He's not gonna do with it what was done to... others.”

“ Like my brother,” Grizzlor ground out through his teeth. He looked ready to attack Adora at the very *suggestion* of the Bull's

Eye being used again...

(*maybe I should help him no no I'm not a traitor but it's not Adora maybe I should stop him maybe I shouldn't maybe maybe fucking* ***maybe***)

But in the next moment, the tension lowered, Grizzlor leaning back. Whatever may or may not have been going through his head in that moment, he must have decided against anything more aggressive... or perhaps he'd simply done the math and realized he couldn't win any fight he would start.

" Watch him," Grizzlor hissed instead. " You don't know what it can do."

" I will," Adora said. She had remained fearless throughout the moment's confrontation... but then again, why would she be scared? Even ignoring the presence of the other Force Captains, whose loyalties weren't all that shaky at the moment- Lonnie should know, she'd been spying on them- and Adora's cadet class, whose loyalty Grizzlor would assume to be beyond question...

(*but Adora can't trust me I can't even trust myself I don't know what I'd do if she was attacked*)

Grizzlor would be an ordinary man attacking a Princess. Everybody knew how *that* equation had to compute. Grizzlor would have been ashes before he ever got close.

Grizzlor was... clearly not satisfied, was quite unhappy, but he said nothing more, merely looking away as Adora waved Rogelio forward, the Squamatus taking the Bull's Eye and placing it in Mantenna's shaking hands.

" Now, that thing merges organic and inorganic, or undoes a transformation it already did," Adora said. " But I want you to test on animals first before you do it to people. And only on those who agree!"

" Won't that just end up with us having a bunch of like, engine-powered rats or something?" Kyle asked, looking at Mantenna as he stared lovingly down at the Runestone in his hands.

" Wouldn't use rats," Mantenna whispered, holding the stone like someone had handed him the most sacred relic of his religion. " Too small, too few things to merge them with, not smart enough. Will use dogs. More loyal, more intelligent, will get better results for use on humans. Take old dogs, crippled dogs, first. Heal them. How this started; wanted to fix my bad eyes, Father's bad heart... could barely do one, never succeeded again, but I can do *so much more* now. I'll have to have the raiders steal a few..."

" Oh! That actually works out," Adora said. " I was debating with Rogelio about getting some dogs. We rely a lot on tech, but we're going to have to shut a lot of it down once the peace treaty's in place; too much pollution. Gotta let the land recover or we can't stay here. But that'll shut down a lot of auxiliary systems, too, so I'm looking into replacements. Like terriers! They can keep the rats out of our food stores once we have to turn off the smaller guardbot systems that do it now. Bigger guard dogs, too, to replace some of the sentry systems. And dogs are supposed to be

good for veterans? That's what this book we stole from Plumeria says- somebody named Mind Soother wrote it. No idea if that's true, but what the hell. Try to get Phlax dogs, they're the best- well, except Snows' dogs, but we're not gonna find those in a raid.”

“ Cats would be better for that,” Dreer said absentmindedly. “ For the rats, anyway.”

“ I'd rather use dogs,” Adora said, and a moment's understanding passed through Dreer's face, his mouth making a little silent “oh”. Yes, Adora would... prefer dogs, obviously.

“ You do like dogs,” Octavia said, saving Dreer from his faux pas. “ Didn't your old helmet have a big mean dog on it?”

“ It did!” Adora said.

“ She's more of a Dragon nowadays though,” Kyle said, pointing at the sigil on her torso. “ Kinda lost the dog stuff after Hordak died.”

“ Eh, maybe I just put a leash on it,” Adora said, with the air of one making a private joke.

(And inside Adora, her rage was still muzzled, was fuel for her, and did not burn her; not gone, never gone, but her new path in life seemed to have put her hellhound to sleep at last.)

“ A dog breathing fire would just be weird, anyway,” Octavia said. “ Now, while you're handing out gifts, I gotta ask about your eye...”

“ I thought you might!” Adora said, the eye cheerfully shining as she pointed at it. “ So I had some vision issues after I got burned. Could still see, but it wasn't very good. Thankfully, my bond with the Spirit Ember means we can share what we sense, and I was able to sort of... give her my eyeball? Technically I can't see out of that eye at all now, it's an outlet for the Spirit Ember now- but she can share what *she's* seeing with me. We're basically loopholing my eyesight! Works just fine, though it does make it look like the whole world is burning. It's kinda hard to explain, I kind of did it in my sleep. My sister did most of the work after I told her what I wanted; a good sister!”

The Spirit Ember did most of the work... and was watching the world itself, now. Meaning it was capable of doing things more or less on its own... a confirmation, if sideways, of at least some of Lonnie's fears...

And Adora just thought it was a benefit. This was worse than Lonnie had feared; this was not Adora being hollowed out and the Spirit Ember pouring itself in through the gaps. This was the Spirit Ember slipping in slowly, burning away what was Adora and replacing her slowly... an eye, now. But later...

Lonnie almost missed what Octavia said next, as she had a sensation of standing on a yawning chasm.

(*if Adora isn't gone yet, she will be soon; it has one eye, how long until it has the rest, how much of Adora has it already taken*

and she doesn't even know it, how can I save her)

" Shit, that probably won't work for me, then," Octavia said, frowning.

" No, I'm sorry to say," Adora responded.

Octavia shrugged.

" Well, being down an eye isn't fatal but it sure sucks," she responded. " Also has made me super paranoid about the eye I got left."

" But! That's actually part of what I'm hoping Mantenna can fix," Adora said, nodding at him. " I had an idea to make my friends stronger, but I rethought it recently when I realized I'm not sure if it'll work. Once Mantenna does some experiments with the Bull's Eye, though, I can proceed with that plan, and at the same time, I'm hoping he can give you a cybernetic eye."

" I'd sure appreciate that," Octavia said.

" In the meantime," Dreer spoke up, " I can cast a spell to protect your remaining eye. It's not perfect- someone determined to get your eye is still going to get it- but it'll create a shielding effect that'll make it harder for others to hurt it. It'll keep random chance from taking it, anyway."

“ I'd sure appreciate that,” Octavia said.

“ Well, while you two are doing that,” Adora said, “ I'd like to hand out a few last-minute orders. So! Lonnie.”

Lonnie's heart leapt into her throat, and she could not speak; she merely nodded, hoping and praying none of her thoughts could be seen by the blazing eye the Spirit Ember controlled.

“ You'll be staying here in the Fright Zone,” Adora said. “ You and Grizzlor, who I think should still be in the hospital?”

“ I'll live,” he muttered.

“ You two are staying here, along with Dreer and Octavia. Lonnie's in charge. Mantenna, Kyle, and Rogelio will be going north. Mantenna, you're going to be in charge of logistics and intel.”

The Lunoth jerked his head away from the Minor Runestone in his hands long enough to nod.

“ It will be done, Lord Adora,” he said. “ What divisions will I be commanding?”

“ We're sending pretty much everyone,” Adora said. “ Only a skeleton crew will be left here... including myself.”

“ You're gonna be here?” Kyle said, surprised. Adora nodded.

“ The Rebellion plans to try and assassinate me,” Adora said. “ My spy contacted me not an hour ago- the meeting is today. I haven't heard from my spy yet as to the exact date, since they haven't decided, but it's going to be soon.”

“ Oh, I thought you lost contact with your spy?” Kyle asked.

“ No, they just didn't have a good chance to contact me,” Adora said with a shrug. “ It happens. Espionage isn't a precise science.”

(At that very moment, unbeknownst to any of them, Double Trouble was heading their way south to infiltrate the Fright Zone, at the behest of their new boss- under whose orders they'd transmitted to Adora what Light Hope had wanted her to believe.)

“ So it's an art?” Kyle asked with a grin. Adora rolled her eyes and kept going.

“ Once they contact me, I'll know the date. It's gonna be soon; Netossa won't want to waste her chance. My spy thinks the Runestone Kingdoms will reject the attempt, so hey, no Princesses at least! But Netossa will try anyway. My plan is to ambush them when they come here to ambush *me*.”

Adora grinned.

" I'll be ready and waiting for them- they don't know what I am, now."

Her eye shined merrily with hunger for battle.

" The big benefit here is that Netossa coming at me means that there'll be fewer people coming to Plumeria's aid. We'll have enough to deal with there with the other Princesses, which is why we have to do this *fast.* The Horde army going north has to get there quick, capture Perfuma, and hold her somewhere until they agree to our terms. Dreer, Octavia, Lonnie, Grizzlor- you're all going to be helping me with the Rebellion assassination attempt. Speaking of- Octavia, you get a present, too!"

" Oh?" Octavia said, as Adora waved Rogelio over with the oddly spiderlike gem in the box.

" The Crystal Spider!" Adora announced. " Point it at a target and will them to be wiped out, and it'll do it. Apparently it's a meteorite!"

" What's that?" Octavia asked.

“ No idea!” Adora shrugged. “ But it *keeps the heat of its fall*, as Hordak's notes say. Basically, it's the biggest gun on Etheria. No defensive powers, no utility, literally nothing but raw, murderous force- but hey, sometimes you just need to hit somebody.”

“ I will not protest being given a really big gun,” Octavia said, taking the gem up and looking it over. “ Hmm. Hey, could I put this on an eyepatch and use it? I saw a laser eyepatch in the Cove's black market once and I've always wanted one.”

“ I guess?!?” Adora said, barking out a laugh that she clearly didn't intend. Her eye merrily flared with amusement. “ I... that is *not* what I expected you to ask.”

“ Awesome,” Octavia said, pocketing the Runestone. “ Dreer, you mind helping a bitch out, get this thing on an eyepatch? I wanna take it to the practice range- unlike you, I can actually hit things more than ten feet away. Which is a fucking wonder since I don't have *depth perception.*”

“ Just because I got two working eyes doesn't mean they know how to tell my hands what they're doing,” Dreer said with a shrug. “ Besides, I'm a wizard now, I can just *decide* that my spells hit. But sure, I'll help you make your ridiculous laser eyepatch. We'll test it first, though, I don't want the recoil tearing your skull off. Or the heat from using it to cook what little brains you actually possess.”

“ No recoil,” Adora piped up. “ Hordak found that really weird, but the gem's got no recoil. Also, the heat and power of the attack

won't hurt the user, though you can still hurt yourself with side effects- one time, a guy got tricked into firing it at a mountain by the White Ghost, Allegra, and the resulting landslide killed him. Also, watch out for that; the stone doesn't protect you at all, it's pure offense."

" Eh, I was always offensive," Octavia said with a shrug. " Who the fuck is the White Ghost?"

Adora shrugged. " Supposedly a past She-Ra over a thousand years ago, but Hordak thought it was myth. He just noted it down as a story about how the Spider worked."

" ...I thought the Crystal Spider was lost at GaleBreath," Grizzlor said suspiciously. " That was what Hordak told us."

" He didn't want Shadow Weaver getting it," Adora said. " He feared she'd backstab him if she got her hands on it- or any of the Minor Runestones. Once the Ruby of Knowledge made her suicidal, Hordak swore off using the Minor Runestones for any purpose, though he *was* considering using the Bull's Eye, towards the end."

" For what?" Grizzlor asked angrily.

" ...Secret plans," Adora said, after a moment. " But they would have strengthened the Horde."

(She would not betray her predecessor- the man who had found her alone, who had, no matter how Adora sliced it, adopted her as one of his own- by revealing the weakness of his flesh, that he had debated using the Bull's Eye to fix. She had betrayed him too much already, betrayed him unto death; she could be a good daughter in this much, at least, and not add dishonor to death.)

Grizzlor wasn't satisfied by *that*, either, but quieted down once more, glaring as the Crystal Spider was put in Octavia's pocket.

" Get used to using it," Adora ordered her Force Captain. " You're gonna need it when Netossa shows up. Some of the other big-name Rebels will be with her, and if we're *really* unlucky, they'll convince a Princess to join them."

" Hopefully Catra!" Octavia said with a grin. " I owe that bitch an eye!"

Adora glared at her, but Octavia shamelessly shrugged.

" I ain't gonna kill your girlfriend," Octavia said. " Just blind her- and only half!"

" Catra is *also* to be taken alive," Adora rumbled low and cool in her throat, and her eye dimmed in a spooky way, like it was banking itself for a much greater fire. " *All* of them are. Every living Princess is a bargaining chip."

Octavia, who was not stupid, raised her hands in defeat.

" Orders are orders," she said, the very picture of an obedient Hordesman.

Adora snorted, and her eye returned to a normal blaze.

" If you want to take out some rage, beating them is fine," Adora said. " We'll have to do some harm to them to take them alive, after all."

She grinned, and her voice returned to greater cheer.

" Besides, you're gonna get a new eye soon! So don't worry about it. Though where you'll mount the Crystal Spider afterwards, I've no idea."

" Put it between my tits," Octavia said with a shrug. Dreer burst out laughing next to her. " Saw a bra-gun in the Cove's black markets, too, and also wanted that one. Nobody expects nipples to open fire! Powerful surprise weapon."

" Are the Cove's black markets okay?" Kyle asked. Rogelio chuckled, and even Grizzlor and Lonnie smirked a bit at that. " They don't sound okay."

“ I will *not* help you make that,” Dreer said, still laughing, “ but mostly because I'm no... lingerie-maker? What *is* the word for that...”

“ I think it's still a tailor?” Adora offered with a shrug.

“ You can't make a bra but you can make an eyepatch?” Octavia mocked her friend.

“ My father was a haberdasher,” Dreer protested. “ Even the women we sold to brought their own, we didn't have to make them!”

Octavia shrugged.

“ Eh, I'll find somebody,” she said.

“ I... you can't make a bra out of a Minor Runestone, that's just...” Adora said, shaking her head before shrugging. “ You know what? No, don't worry about it, you go right on ahead. You do you, I guess. Make the breast blaster or whatever, it's your Runestone now. Serve the Horde with it and I guess you can use it however you want.”

“ Awesome,” Octavia said.

“ Anyway, once the ambush is put down, we go north and join our forces. I'm having a skiff modified to go much, much faster- and since our forces will have spearheaded the way, the rest of us will get there a lot faster than the main force did. They'll have already cleared out any Rebels or Plumerian forces in the way, and we can take care of any stragglers ourselves. We'll be bringing a lot of force to bear very quickly on them.”

“ Not that Plumerians are much trouble,” Octavia said with a snort.

This was something that everyone, even Lonnie, nodded in agreement with. Brightmoon forces were a bitch when they were on the defense, the slowness of their assaults less meaningful when the enemy had to come to them; there was a reason Crystal Falls was still standing, beyond Salineas resupplying them. The Salineans were deadly at sea, even if they floundered on land, and the few times Snows forces had attacked the Horde, they'd proven themselves almost impossibly courageous, charging right into the teeth of the heaviest attacks.

The Crownless they'd fought had proven to have worth in war, too. Blackmoor, the best of them, was led intelligently and fought bravely, abusing the awful swamps of their southern border as a vicious defensive trap, leading almost Rebel-worthy ambush charges with their monstrous boars, clad in armor even Horde guns had trouble penetrating. Seaworthy and Octopus Cove had sank their fair share of ships as they sailed in tandem, if not quite in alliance, with Salineas. Even Phlax, for all the chaos of its jumbled defense of Blue Mountain and primitive tech and magic both, at least had sheer numbers on its side; it didn't help that the

Goodwomen and Goodmen, the preachers of their faith, were all healers, and they had hundreds of them. If a Phlax soldier wasn't killed or seriously injured, there was a good chance they'd be up and fighting again in a week.

And the Rebels... well, there was a reason that, when Hordesmen wanted to scare each other, they told stories of Rebel attacks. No other group could ambush like they could, no other group seemed to have the eerie ability to know just *when* a Hordesmen was vulnerable; dime a dozen were the stories of some Hordesmen stepping out to take a piss, and her comrades realizing only a few moments later that she was gone, finding her body hanging from a tree later. A decade of solid warfare as the underdogs had given the vast patchwork of groups that lurked on the Horde's outskirts superlative talent when it came to stealth and terror tactics both.

But Plumerians? Nobody had been so easy to roll up as the Plumerians. At this point, the Horde and the Rebels owned more of their land than the Plumerians did- just look at their two ports! Glass Lake was Rebel-held and Rosewood had been the Horde's for over a decade at this point. Centuries of relying entirely on their Princesses for protection had backfired on the plant-lovers, and left them helpless at warfare- a situation made worse when an ambush had killed the Princess prior to Perfuma. Perfuma's cowardice had simply made an untenable situation fall apart even faster; the only reason the Horde didn't own all of Plumeria was because Catra had turned on them, and been fighting in their defense. Otherwise, they'd own the whole thing.

Even now, when Perfuma was putting up more of a fight, and the Plumerians were trying to rise up... it wasn't enough. Adora's attack was going to take Plumeria.

But we'll never hold it... not with the other Princesses there...

Lonnie had dropped out of the conversation for a minute, mind working like it was gunked up, but when she came back in, Adora was discussing just that.

" Now, Perfuma *has* to be captured," she said. " We can't hold Plumeria, but we don't *have* to. We just have to make ourselves a bitch to remove, and have the lives of a Princess to threaten. So fortifications around the Heart-Blossom, and Perfuma in a cell- that's what we need! A deal to leave Plumeria without doing any more harm to it- to effectively go away, and for the War to end- because removing us will get a lot of them killed, and they get their friend back. All this will be so much easier if Perfuma's still breathing. That takes topmost priority. I can still swing a deal, but it'll be harder to do over her corpse. We trade Perfuma's life and Plumeria's remaining territory in return for a ceasefire of at least sixteen years. I'd like to have twenty, or even thirty, to be honest, but I'll take sixteen."

" Why sixteen?" Octavia asked.

" Time for the first generation to grow up into soldiers," Adora answered. " Restructuring the Horde into a proper nation will take time. If people start fucking *now*-"

" They are," Kyle interrupted. " Saw them doing it near the... bonfires? Did you know we were doing bonfires now? I heard

someone preaching at one, all about you.”

“ Good!” Adora said. “ I want my people to enjoy themselves, and if faith in me is what they need, more power to them. Duty applies to the highest Hordesman as well as the lowest. If the Horde needs me to be their god, then their god I am.”

Lonnie swallowed hard, unnoticed by everyone, and fell out of the conversation again, just for a moment. When she came back, Adora was responding to something Rogelio had said.

“ That's sort of the plan. Everyone who has a kid is contributing to our future growth. The kids can be soldiers by sixteen. I know we usually do it at fourteen, but I want a little more time than that, so I'm going for sixteen,” the woman who had just admitted to delusions of godhood said. “ Well, twenty would be *perfect,* that'd be enough time for them to grow up and maybe have some kids of their own, give us a second generation... but sixteen is enough. At that point we'll have our numbers back and settle in for the long haul; this war's gonna be a long one. We need generations for the struggle; a slow smolder, not a flash fire. It's like stocking up on wood before a long winter.”

“ Okay,” Octavia said. “ So, that about it, boss?”

Adora nodded.

“ Yeah. Kyle, Rogelio, we'll meet and discuss more what you guys need to do up north. Though, before we go...”

She knelt down and tapped the last gem in the box that had yet to be named. It was a lovely brown with a slash of gold right down the middle, like sunlight cut right into coffee, though it's warm beauty didn't really make Lonnie like it any better than the other fucking Runestones.

“ Anybody wanna see what the Tiger's Eye gives them?” Adora asked.

“ Give us?” Dreer said, before his face lit up with realization. “ Wait, I read about this one... It turns you into an animal, right?”

“ Sort of,” Adora said. “ In Hordak's writing, it *grants a second true form to the target, based on what other living being they subconsciously identify with most*. Bit wordy, but accurate. It's not always animals! One guy it was used on, Maftet, he was a human the Magicats raised in Halfmoon; it turned him into a Magicat! He never turned back. Oh, that's- that's probably something I should add! You can turn back. Transforming is apparently at-will and it's painless! Shadow Weaver also used this one but she just became a vulture.”

“ A vulture?!?” Octavia said, and cracked up. “ Nice!”

“ Yeah, that fits,” Kyle said, grinning.

“ Eh, sure, blast me with it- though ten credits say I turn into a fucking octopus,” Octavia said, rolling her eyes. “ Not even a big one like a crabulus, just a regular ass octopus. And Dreer's gonna turn into a bat.”

“ Why a bat?” he asked.

“ They're your favorite critter,” she said. Dreer raised a finger to protest, then put it down with a nod.

“ Yeah, I won't take that bet,” Dreer said. “ But sure, shoot me as well. Who knows? Being small and flying might work out for me someday.”

“ Any other takers?” Adora asked. Rogelio and Kyle both raised hands.

Lonnie was able to shake her head, and Grizzlor did as well, neither trusting themselves to speak.

“ Alright,” Adora said. “ Here goes nothing! Octavia first, since she said yes first. Fun additional fact- it won't work on an unwilling target! Hordak noted that, too, in the stories Halfmoon told about it.”

Adora aimed the gem at the Force Captain, and a thin beam of light shone on her for a long minute. A kind of misty shadow appeared in a tiny puddle at Octavia's feet, before her self became misty and shadowy, and then...

The tiny puddle of not-quite-something resolved into a floppy green little octopus. Somehow, despite its utter lack of facial features, it managed to convey quite clearly an unamused expression before the misty-shadows happened in reverse, leaving Octavia in their place a second later.

" Well, fuck," she said. " I'm a basic bitch, apparently. Switching back's easy, at least. Just kinda have to decide you wanna be the other thing. Also, being boneless on dry land? Awful. Cannot recommend. I wasn't even one of the poisonous ones!"

Dreer laughed and Adora giggled as Octavia rolled her eyes at herself.

" Well, let's see if I'm as basic as she is," Dreer said. Adora, still giggling, used it on him, and after the same process, a little bat was left flapping where he had been.

" Knew it," Octavia said. " Least you can fly- and have *bones*."

Dreer chittered something and turned back.

“ Well!” he said. “ Other than a ferocious desire to drink blood, that wasn't all that different! Though I do wonder where our clothes go...”

“ Hordak theorized that the two forms are sort of like... okay, he used a lot of technical terms, but he said there was *quantum superpositions* involved?” Adora said with a shrug. “ Effectively, the two forms are stacked on top of one another, so you don't lose anything. The Magicats have a lot of really complicated things about them, but basically you have two true forms now. Useful!”

“ I'm just glad I still have pants,” Dreer said. Octavia shrugged.

“ Eh, if it made me naked, that's kind of everyone else's problem more than mine,” the Octopode Sea Elf proclaimed. Dreer rolled his eyes at her as Adora turned to Rogelio.

“ Ready?” she said. Lonnie's heart caught in her throat.

Say no, Rogelio...

But he didn't, he just nodded, and Adora held the gem up to him. The mist this time was about as big as Rogelio normally was, and when his form faded...

Left in its place was the *handsomest* goddamn man Lonnie had ever seen. He was like a carved slab of perfect hunk.

“ Well,” Rogelio said, and his Perfect Speech was magnificently, hypnotizingly accented with something that added a lovely timbre to his delicious bass, “ while I was hoping for a dragon, I do not regret being a human. This will, if nothing else, allow me to experience the world as those I love do.”

He raised one dark hand at the end of a fantastically muscled arm, marveling at it.

“ Skin is smoother than scales, and more sensitive; less armor, but greater sense of touch,” he said, and it came out very profound, because anything said with that voice would. Octavia was openly staring at him with a stupid grin on her face. Rogelio rubbed his face, focusing on his nose. “ Much lower sense of smell has interesting results. It's like the world loses its past, as I can no longer detect the traces of yesterday that we register as scents. At the same time, the greater eyesight and range of colors available brings the present more fully to life. Trading the past for the future, in a sense... but as I can switch back and forth, I must lose nothing. I can have it all. *Fascinating.* I may have to write poetry about this experience.”

Lonnie, despite everything, felt a grin on her face as she looked at Kyle, who stared at Rogelio for a long moment... before passing dead out.

“ Ah, I seem to have incapacitated my boyfriend,” Rogelio said, as he walked over to him and picked up his unconscious lover. “ Adora, if I might take him for a moment? I believe he needs a minute.”

“ Sure,” Adora said, laughing. “ Guess he didn't expect you to be hot.”

“ He's *really* hot!” Octavia said. “ Kyle's a lucky little fucker.”

“ He is!” Dreer said, nodding his head. “ Damn.”

“ I thought you weren't into anything?” Octavia asked.

“ I'm not,” Dreer said, “ but I share an aesthetic's appreciation for art.”

Lonnie, who was like Dreer, nodded. Yeah, she could appreciate Rogelio's ludicrous hotness. She wasn't sure *why* he had clothes on that were basically what he'd been wearing already, though. Lucky thing, that; if he'd knocked Kyle out with his pants on, a naked Rogelio might have killed him. She could see the bulges of his muscles even through the clothes.

But even as Rogelio rose up, Lonnie's amusement faded back into her background horror, because Adora was examining the Runestone she was holding.

“ Hey,” she said. “ Anybody know if having a Runestone already interferes? I don't want my sister to think I'm giving up on her;

we're born from the same sin, after all, we're basically twins! But I'm curious as to what I'd turn into. Probably a dog.”

“ If it does,” Rogelio said solemnly, but with a winning smile, “ I promise not to refer to you as a bitch, no matter how accurate it becomes.”

“ Ha ha,” Adora said, rolling her eyes at him, though Octavia snorted. “ But still. Think sis will get mad at me for using this?”

She didn't wait for an answer. The light simply shone on her as she used it, aimed at herself. It took a moment longer, as though the magics of Adora were taking a moment to sort themselves out. Lonnie prayed, quietly, that nothing happened; to whom, she did not know.

Such aimless prayer went unrewarded. Instead, after that pause, Adora... *changed*.

Her new form wasn't smaller than her. It wasn't roughly the same, either. No, no, the ghost appearing behind Adora was *huge,* vast, it towered over them.

And then Adora was the ghost, the last thing to fade the gleaming blaze in her eye, before the ghost behind her became solid, and suddenly, the thing she was turning into was the only thing left, and the only thing Lonnie's terrified mind could focus on.

Looming over them was the biggest goddamn thing Lonnie had ever seen. Only the Horde's naval vessels had been larger. It was not unlike a lizard, in the sense that it had reptilian traits; kin of crocodiles and snakes, kin of newts and monitors... but it was *not* one of them. Not really.

Its face and left half were odd, wounded, wounded in a way that felt totally wrong; it was burned, there, burned, but Lonnie knew on instinct that this was a thing that could not burn. The body knew it, too; the wounds were strangely fresh, as though the skin was rejecting the injury even as it formed. The burned patches shone like honey, with a sheen so sticky-sweet that it caught the light and didn't want to let it go, red blood ten times as thick as human slowly oozing out to coat the burns. Fresh patches of tiny albino scales formed atop the protective layer of blood even as Lonnie watched, the body already repairing the damage it could not have sustained, could *never* have sustained.

Shining in contrast to the dull milky-white that was even now covering the wounds along the face, neck and left arm, the rest of it bore brilliant golden scales, gleaming softly in the light. They covered a fang-filled maw that could bite Lonnie in half, and the thick musculature attached to those jaws meant that it could chew the bones up after, leave nothing of her left. A forked tongue licked out between those lips, tasting the air, as the two eyes- one still Adora's bluebell bright, one still full of blazing fire, both huge as spotlights- gazed down on the gathered Force Captains from the vast head, which was on a long, serpentine neck. It went down, down, down, to a squat, solid body, almost pot-bellied, the way the biggest alligators got.

Redundant organs, some part of Lonnie whispered, some little piece of her that, impossibly, could think past the pure surprise and horror and sheer screaming *fear* that was rooting her to the spot. She wanted to run but her legs would not respond, nothing would respond, she could not even turn her head away; the only part still moving was that little useless piece, vainly spouting trivia as though it were an incantation that could make this monster go away. *I read that somewhere, once. An intelligence report, nothing meaningful then. They have redundant organs, three of each, that's why they're so stoutly built. Hard to kill. Hard to hurt. Have to get all three on a... on a... on a...*

Her mind couldn't say it. She could not wrap her brain around it. In confusion and terror and pure dull surprise, she stared up, up, *up,* at the great split-scaled face, at the massive beast and its great wings and at the tail that ended in a fat club of bone, swaying softly behind the great beast.

The thing above her laughed, and it sounded like forge fires, burning low and deep.

" **I think,**" Adora the Dragon said, " **that I can work with this.**"

She laughed, but Lonnie could not hear her over the screaming in her own skull.

Chapter End Notes

Rogelio's ethnicity in human form is based off of his voice actor, who, fun fact, is also Bow's voice actor, from what I

could find online. His looks I leave to the imagination, but “goddamn hunk” summarizes it well.

Hordak never used the Minor Runestones for two reasons: first, he still held Prime's general distaste for magic... and second, after seeing Shadow Weaver have a moment of guilt so strong she tried to kill herself, he was too freaked out to bother with them anymore. He only ever debated using the Bull's Eye on himself to heal, and then Entrapta came along and he didn't have to worry about it. He intended to give Entrapta the Bull's Eye as a gift for her birthday, since he knew Etherians celebrated those, and had come to that decision... shortly before Adora came back from the Waste and popped the Portal open, dooming him. Entrapta never knew.

Shadow Weaver freaked out because the Ruby temporarily abated the effects of the Ritual; it basically made her Light Spinner for a few seconds again, and she could not stomach what she was. Hordak getting the Ruby away from her stopped her from killing herself. He wondered, sometimes, if he shouldn't have let it be, as Shadow Weaver's sadism became more prominent.

Part of the Ruby's effects is purging the mind of outside influences; it can also save someone who is mind-controlled. Placing it on Horde Prime would force him out of that body (though given his nature he'd just hop to the next clone; it wouldn't kill him the way She-Ra's light does in the series. It's not quite strong enough.) Of course, if it was used on something that doesn't have another body to leap to, it might well kill that being- or at least, force it out enough that you could punch the fucking thing.

Octavia gets the Spider Crystal because the episode the Crystal Spider is from in the original had Dreer as a side-villain; it entertains me that he's still associated with it in this sideways way.

Adora still intends to use the Berserker upgrade for Kyle and Lonnie; she just wants Mantenna to get used to using the Bull's Eye first before she tries it. Safety first!

Skullpath is a border area between Phlax and the Troll's hidden mountain home of Spikeheart; it's a beautiful natural area that is enormous, full of rather dangerous monsters, and has giant carvings of terrifying faces on the mountain peaks, carved by Trolls as intimidation. The Trolls have a long history of getting fucked by the smallfolk and mostly want to be left alone; the few in the Rebellion are there for entirely personal reasons. Spikeheart is neutral in the war so far. Dreer discovered something rather... bad... down in the depths of Skullpath, chasing after rumors that were ancient when Mara was born. I'm sure him remembering it won't come back to bite the world in the ass! Very sure.

Wounds in the transformed states of the Cat's Eye transfer over; a mortal wound in one body is a mortal wound in the other. Dying in one body leaves your corpse as that body; Maftet died a Magicat, and was buried as one among them, for this reason. That's why it's referred to as two true forms; it's not “I'm human but can turn into a dog”, it's “I'm a human AND a dog now”. The Cat's Eye transformations even ignore magical barriers that prevent most spellcasting, the way Wild Princesses do; nothing can cut off a magical connection that innate. Adora's dragon body is healing itself because dragons can't be burned, and healing the wound after it was inflicted is how the body is reconciling the two states; her human form is still burned, and she'll have to endure the healing process every time she changes. The bizarre nature of how she incurred the injuries isn't helping; magically, they're kind of in a Schrodinger's state of being, both real and not, and it confuses her new draconic biology.

Crabulus is a critter from the original She-Ra. They're crab-octopi, and in my fic, are basically middling ambush predators very common outside of Octopus Cove; they're part of why it's called that. They're not of much note, save for being kind

of dumb for octopi and absolutely delicious, but dangerous to hunt and impossible to store for long periods of time; the Cove treats them like a local delicacy, eaten mostly by fancy people. A new Falcon's first meal after gaining the name is traditionally crabulus slathered with butter, since that was the first Falcon's favorite meal.

Chapter 44: TLWCE: Rebels of the Crownless and the Duchies

Chapter Notes

One last look at the Rebels, before the die is cast.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Last War Council of Etheria

Part 2:

Rebels of the Crownless and the Duchies

We can make this work.

That thought flitted right through Netossa as she looked at the group gathered at the circular outdoor table under a tent, enjoying the afternoon lunch. They were eating on Angella's dime; while the relatively small squad of Rebels Netossa had dragged up here for this meeting had a single camp kitchen with them, none of them had really wanted to eat the usual camp fare, not when the excellent cooks of Brightmoon Castle were available and freely offering their services. Just good Rebel sense not to waste resources.

Service was being provided by the Castle's staff, who were serving professionally and without problems, despite Netossa being located a bit away from Brightmoon. They'd offered service, and Netossa had frankly assumed they'd just send the food over; instead, a couple of trucks and a hovercraft had approached from Brightmoon's stables, with a small accompanying squad of butlers and maids in the purple-pink of official Brightmoon government employees. The usual frills on the dresses they all wore were toned down to make it easier to move about outside; apparently they had an outdoor uniform, who knew?

They'd brought out the table, the large parasol above it for shade, and the food, and were staying nearby to provide refills and anything else anyone might need- like napkins for Orwall, who had the terrible misfortune to have hers blow away in a random gust of wind. She'd made the *funniest* little expression of sadness over it, too, Netossa had almost choked on her drink when she saw it.

The servants were also probably keeping an eye on them for Angella, which Netossa didn't hold against her; this was her house, after all, and common sense said you kept an eye on people. *Trust, but verify,* as Micah used to say. If she knew a bunch of armed folk were in her camp, even ones she expected to be friendly, she'd have kept an eye on them, too... and Netossa had nothing to hide.

So she focused on the food. Today's fare was good old Brightmoon food- sweet fruit tarts and fish coated in a creamy lemon sauce, accompanied with good soft bread rolls and sweet strawberry jam, paired with either pale ale or one of the sugary

colas Brightmoon adored. That was the standard meal, delivered to most, though a few were modified to suit different tastes; Orwall and Squall, in particular, had the fruit tarts and strawberry jams replaced with savory pickles and a little set of pork ribs slathered in some amazing smelling sauce, the drinks modified to be a kind of celery soda. Orwall had squealed in delight over them after a single bite, and even Scurvy, deeply unhappy to be here, had given a huff of enjoyment after downing her drink. Netossa supposed that by this point the Brightmoon kitchens were used to modifying their overly-sweet meals for Magicat tongues, though given how Squall had sniffed at the offered pale ale, they hadn't realized that Magicats and alcohol mostly didn't mix. They could take vodka but that was about it, and only in small doses.

Netossa and Spinnerella also received rather personalized meals; Netossa got a hearty Twin Kingdoms chili, served with two fat, crispy flour biscuits and a big bottle of good mead, Brightmoon's favorite alcohol, while Spinny got a rare tomahawk steak, mashed potatoes, and porked beans accompanied by a strawberry cola, a monstrous mixture of a meal that privately horrified Netossa's own taste buds but that Spinny had always adored.

These had been their favorite meals, back during the days of the First Princess Alliance, now a decade in the past. Angella had remembered... Netossa wouldn't pretend she wasn't touched. They'd been friends, in those days, before Angella's cowardice and despair over Micah's death drove her to shatter the first Princess Alliance and withdraw; Netossa had a lot of good memories of the two, of Micah teaching her how to deal with war, of Angella being a friendly ear whenever she or Spinny had needed it.

Her mentors in politics and in war; Netossa had been middle-class before her powers kicked in and made her a celebrity, so the blunt

truth was that she'd been totally unprepared for what she was trying to do. She'd won her first fight on raw strength alone, and had started her warband on pure personal charisma, but those weren't enough, and she'd known it; she'd been hunting for teachers when the royal couple had, out of sheer kindness, taken the role. They'd taught her how to fight and how to lead.

They'd even let her watch over little Glimmer, which had been a singularly horrifying experience; she was a *kid* that *teleported*, which was just... no. Netossa had taken to netting her to walls to keep her from killing her fool self, which had backfired when Glimmer thought that was *super fun* and asked her to do it again. She'd only been her babysitter once, and absolutely sworn it off after that... and apparently she'd made zero impression on the kid. Glimmer never referenced their prior meetings, though she *had* been awful young, and after Micah died... well, Netossa wasn't often up in Brightmoon after that. It was entirely possibly Glimmer had forgotten her entirely.

But back in those days, before the big fight, Netossa had adored Brightmoon's king and queen. She distinctly remembered thinking that she wanted to be like them when she grew up, which was a funny thought to have, considering she was nearly grown at that point herself- she'd been eighteen, verging on nineteen, same as Spinny... but she was so unlearned in the things she was coming to know that she'd always felt as if she'd had a rebirth, had become new again, here at Brightmoon. From the rough ore of a girl who hoped to do good, and had come to a foreign country to pursue that dream, Micah and Angella had hewn the beginnings of the woman she was today, and Netossa would owe them that kindness all her life.

Yes, Brightmoon had some good memories... and not just of the royal couple or their adorable kid. It had been here at Brightmoon that Netossa and Spinnerella had first kissed, that very first night, when they found out that the other was so much *more* than they'd ever known. They'd known *of* each other for years by that point, of course, the Twin Kingdom's two Wild Princesses were national figures... but they'd been acquaintances and casual friends at best, their lives too separated.

Then they'd found each other here, many miles east of their homeland, both having been forbidden to come and both going anyway. They had not realized who the other was, until that moment, when they discovered that the Red Knight's speech before the Dual Senate had lit a candle in both their hearts; they had not known that both of them were brave, that they were each willing to take up the vigil, and fight the most ancient fight, that of freedom against oppression.

The plain truth was, they had never really *met* each other until that day. Netossa had wrongly assumed that Spinnerella was like the two-faced and useless rich folk the net-throwing Wild Princess had dealt with so much growing up. Spinny had confided in her that Netossa had not made much good impression either, that the Condore girl had assumed Netossa's bright spirit was all talk, like most Highpoint folk were.

But here, the truth was revealed at last, and they both found the other greater than they'd ever known; they had talked their first real talk that night, still so surprised, shared talk of those candles inside themselves, of how much this meant to them, how much they wanted to be here, *helping,* and...

And in a moment of mutual admiration, they'd kissed, and every joy of Netossa's life had followed from that moment.

(Not Netossa's first kiss- she'd had *so many* girlfriends beforehand- but something maybe more important: the first kiss with the last woman she'd ever kiss, for the rest of her life.)

Yes, Brightmoon had a lot of good memories, and the bite of good chili on her tongue was but the least of them.

...But there were bad memories were here, too. The fight with Angella, most of all. Netossa had been furious when Micah was killed, it had not dimmed her willingness to fight but *honed* it; she owed Micah too much to let his killers escape. She had grieved him, wept and wept at his state funeral, which Angella had been entirely unable to attend; she'd been there but a moment before fleeing, crying, back to her chambers, all her resolve shattered by the sight of his empty casket. It had been up to the Red Knight to give the eulogy, and their sudden decision to do so could only be seen as what it was, a kindness to the missing Queen; Micah and the Red Knight had been friends, of a stature with each other, and they'd had a right to speak at his funeral. Netossa had bawled like a child, her Spinny weeping next to her in her quiet way, supporting her then-fiance even through her own pain.

Netossa had wept, too, in private, later, missing him, missing that good man and his wisdom and his humor, because Micah could make you laugh in the face of death, and there were few talents more precious in a war. It had hurt, to know he was gone, and Netossa had cried out that hurt, time and time again, in the dark places of the night. She was desert-born, after all; she knew that day cared nothing for sorrow, but the night was kindly, and would listen.

But after a week of crying out her heart to gentle mother night, Netossa had turned to the light, and harnessed her grief as a weapon. She had let it turn from the lead of sorrow to the gold of *rage,* let it become fuel for the fires in her heart, and it made her stronger. She was sad, and she was *mad,* and the bastards who'd done this were going to pay!

She still wept for Micah from moment to moment, letting the bursts of pain wash through her at night; but during the day, she supplemented them with the warm blaze of fury. Micah would not want her to destroy herself in grief, and the boisterous man would be pleased to be avenged; and at that point, Netossa had her own personal squad of Rebels, growing every day, mostly refugees from the conquered Duchies. She owed a duty to the living *and* the dead; for both, Netossa would keep fighting. She would see her Rebels back to their restored nations, and she would see Micah avenged.

So after the first week of grief- the first of many- she had went to Angella to ask her what the next step was, what they could do to make sure Hordak paid, for Micah and every single person who'd died because, after the revolutions in Vargon and Green Thatch, GaleBreath and the Fright Zone, Hordak had decided he wanted *more.*

(The worst part of all of this, in Netossa's opinion- Hordak *had* a revolutionary's right to four nations, to Vargon and Green Thatch, GaleBreath and the Fright Zone, all of which were falling apart when he got there, all of which needed to be overthrown... so why had he expanded it so? He could have went down in history a hero...)

Netossa had went to Angella to continue the war, to make sure no one else suffered like this, not at Hordak's hands, not ever again. She had went to her, the woman who'd taught her so much, in hopes she would have an answer, know, as she always had before, how to move forward.

The words the Queen had responded with, in low tones, were nothing less than a betrayal- of Micah, of the Alliance and the Rebellion, of... of Netossa herself. Angella had said she was going to order a retreat. The immortal queen, after the death of her mortal king, was going to withdraw to Brightmoon's borders, and hunker down, and do nothing more.

Brightmoon was out of the war.

They had... argued. Ferociously. What had started quietly ended loudly, as Netossa had screamed the truth to Angella, that Micah would not want this, that she was abandoning justice and vengeance and common sense all three to pursue a suicidally stupid course of action. The Horde was *not* going to stop, she *knew* that... and thus, even if Angella cared nothing about avenging Micah, she still owed it to her people to keep fighting. For her people's safety, if nothing else, Angella could not do this.

Angella had screamed back, and even now some part of Netossa was glad that young Glimmer hadn't been there. She'd been in her aunt's care at that time, Angella so incredibly shattered by Micah's death that she'd been unable to take care of her own child- a state that had continued, or so rumor said, after, it had been governesses and teachers that did much of the raising as Angella spiraled further into grief, or so it was said. Castaspella, too, was wounded, but she had sense enough to lead Mystacor, to

take care of her niece, and- as Netossa would later find out- to surreptitiously supply the Rebellion during those time periods when Mystacor's council of mages got stuck in long arguments about the War. Castaspella, despite her pain, did what was right, and she had Netossa's utmost respect.

(Also she'd kind of had a crush on her that Spinny had teased her for- especially when they found out Castaspella had no interest in sex *or* romance, with anyone. Not that Netossa would have done anything- she'd had her Spinny by then- but it was still embarrassing.)

Angella, meanwhile, failed her nation and her daughter both, and Netossa had tried every word she could think of to change her mind, even as her horror mounted at the sudden change in her idol, Angella's feet of clay revealing themselves at last.

None of her words had worked. Angella had eventually grown tired of her presence and ordered her banished from the castle; the guards, who had been as surprised by the Queen's words as Netossa, had nonetheless complied, though with an air of disbelief, aghast at it all. Netossa's closeness with Angella had been well known, after all, and so the screaming match was a surprise... as was this *cowardice.* It had rubbed many of Brightmoon's people exactly the wrong way. They worshiped heroism itself here, after all, the Silver, the part of the universe that demanded justice; what Angella had just done was not something they could reconcile with their faith.

Still, in that moment, discipline prevailed, though Netossa had pre-empted any forceful removal by leaving under her own power, stalking out in a rage. She'd caught a group of Brightmoon soldiers at work nearby, clearly ones who didn't know about the

new orders, and she'd... well, to put it bluntly, she'd went up to them and gone on a tear.

She had ranted at them for a good ten minutes with a listing of what Angella was doing, why it was fucking stupid, and offered anyone who wanted to keep fighting a standing place in her Rebel forces. She'd told them to meet her near Crystal Falls, and further ordered them to tell everyone that if Angella would seek no vengeance for their murdered king, Netossa *would*. She would keep on fighting until she fell, or the Horde did, and any Brightmoon soldier who cursed the queen for a coward was free to come with her, she could use the fucking help.

She'd went on that verbal rampage entirely out of spite. She'd been hopped up after the screaming match with Angella, hopped up on adrenaline and rage and grief and sheer fucking *disappointment,* she had seen the ugliest possible side of someone she'd thought the absolute best of and it had sent her reeling. It had been more than Netossa could take, following the death of Micah; a one-two punch that had utterly broken any bonds she'd had in Brightmoon. She'd avoided the place up until Catra revived Angella's fighting spirit; her last exit from the place with so many good memories all those years ago had been an angry one, leaving mad to go home, to the Rebel camps that followed her white-web-on-purple standard, resolved to win the war alone if she could or die in a ditch if she couldn't. Either way, she would not abandon the fight.

Nobody had been more surprised than her when what felt like half of Brightmoon's fucking army had shown up near Crystal Falls over the next few months, their flags declaring allegiance to Angella painted over with Netossa's symbol. Rage at the Horde, disgust with Angella's cowardice, loyalty to Micah, even a simple

love of violence... all these and more were the reasons that so many brigades of Brightmoon had come, ready to serve. Vast numbers of the Queen's troops had thrown their old lives and their old loyalties away in order to come serve... and they wouldn't be the only ones. As the other Runestone Kingdoms withdrew, their soldiers drifted towards her, too, ready to keep up the fight... and while many filtered into other Rebel warbands, and many died, many yet remained. Netossa's decade-long war would never have been possible without them.

Of course, feeding them had been hell for the first year, which brought her fully back around to food. She kept eating, mentally comparing the chili to camp food, and obviously preferring the chili. Her Rebels didn't have *bad* food, not at all, but there was only so much variation a soldier's menu could have, what with the needs of food preservation and portability pressing hard on the supply chain. Netossa had eaten enough salt-corned beef that she strongly suspected her own flesh had acquired the flavor.

(*A defense against predators!* Spinny had joked, when Netossa shared that thought with her some years back. Doubly funny, considering Spinny was the one person who never complained about the rations... but given how often Spinny had starved as a kid, Netossa figured she simply didn't care what it tasted like, so long as it was *there.*)

The decency of her daily grub, of course, was mostly owed to the farms they had supplying them in her territory. Sure, Netossa and Spinnerella were indirectly subsidized by the Twin Kingdoms, but her forces had outgrown that annual supply drop the second the Brightmoon soldiers joined her, and it hadn't really eased up since. These days she mostly used the Twin Kingdom rations as deep-strike food, given how portable they were, handing them to teams that were expected to go ranging on their own for a while.

No, the majority of her people's food came from farms, mostly in formerly Plumerian territory, which were the most heavily defended places in all her land. Netossa's Rebels had been in control of enough territory for enough time that they had a simple system set up; farms produced, her Rebels took their cut, and in return, they kept the Horde out. Like taxes, but you could eat them. A simple, easy deal where everybody profited; not a few of her newer recruits had even come from those same communities, local militias joining her forces to protect tehir homes. Wasn't too different from how any nation did its work, really, except Netossa technically wasn't leading a country.

Thinking that thought brought a memory of what her Spinny had said, as Netossa kept eating, and a comment she'd made at the time that was still true now.

*I **do** have a flag, though,* she'd said to her wife, and with that thought she glanced over at the symbol that adorned her main tent- the white spiderweb pattern on purple. One of her first recruits had drawn that, one of the bandits she'd met on her very first journey here to Brightmoon, chasing the Red Knight's word to the Great Rebellion he had promised would come into being. Hell of a first meeting; she'd escaped the Twin Kingdoms on foot, joined a Dryl merchant caravan to Plumeria, hitched a ride with a Plumerian merchant carvan to Brightmoon, and ran smack dab into an ambush of war refugees trying their amateur hands at highway robbery...

She'd beat them and given what must have been the best speech in her life, because they signed up as her very first Rebels on the spot. She'd entered Brightmoon at the head of her own little army.

She even had some of them still with her, and her old promise flitted through her mind, a promise she still intended to keep- *someday, I shall see your nations restored, or die trying.*

She hadn't quite intended to have a flag, but she couldn't complain, she liked the look... and it wasn't entirely unattractive, the idea of leading a nation. Maybe... after, they'd figure out what they could do. Like Glass Lake, which was the city with the most complicated ownership in the war; it had been Plumerian before the Horde conquered it, and now was owned by a band of primarily Brightmoon Rebels, led by a guy named Keeber who'd joined to save his dad.

(And, impossibly, pulled it off; his dad, who'd named himself Peck as a funny reference to being a chicken farmer, had been alive, and was now safe and sound with his son in Glass Lake. Sometimes even a Rebel's story had a happy ending.)

She'd heard that Keeber had been pondering what to do with the city once the war was over; she'd even heard that he was thinking of either declaring independence like the Cove and Seaworthy, or even asking Phlax if he could join, though he had no real land connection to the rest of the Federation, so he'd probably be turned down on that basis... still, who knew? So much had happened already.

Keeber wasn't making waves about Glass Lake right now, though. Nobody was; people had quietly and mutually decided *not* to talk about the city until the war was over. Pushing it now would have inevitably led to either Perfuma having to declare war on the Rebellion to get it back- which would go badly for everyone involved, mostly because the Rebels couldn't afford the distraction and the Plumerians couldn't fight the Rebels- or simply giving

Glass Lake to the Rebels as a fait accompli- which would go badly for Perfuma, as Netossa doubted many Plumerians wanted to surrender one of their ports. It was no Rosewood, but it was still a damn good port, and Plumeria had only started with two of those. They had others, but none were as nice as Rosewood and Glass Lake.

And there was that lingering question, of what to do with the Fright Zone, since it didn't have leadership anymore... there had been Scorpia, but apparently the one they'd had was a spy? Apparently the real one had been sent to Beast Island, or at least, that's what Netossa's contacts said. Which meant the poor girl was a corpse.

She was drawn out of her thoughts by a polite cough nearby.

" Umm, Old King Narwahl?" Orwall said politely, stumbling a bit on the not-entirely-familiar title. " Why are you eating a Horde ration bar?"

Netossa turned, as did almost everyone else, to the great big Selkie. He was enormous, like most of his people- only Trolls were bigger than Selkies- with the flab of his great age hanging on him like a dignified mantle, white whiskers forming a glorious mustache that trailed down his face. He was fairly underdressed, mostly just in a light shirt, boots and thin pants, probably because his fur compensated, and because to someone from Galacia, the mild Brightmoon weather must have been *blistering* hot. His blind eyes above the mustache were milky-white, but he still managed to focus them on whoever he was speaking to- he'd said that the whiskers helped compensate for blindness, a common affliction among old Selkies. The guidebeast he had- a big white beast at

his feet, busy gnawing on a hunk of hambone brought out especially for it- helped as well, but he didn't need it much, he'd claimed. He'd mostly kept it because *an old man has his sentiments*, in his words.

Right now, that venerable old walrus of a man was idly chewing on a Horde ration bar with his gleaming ivories; Selkies regrew their teeth, like Manes did, so even in his ancient age he had a full set of pearly whites.

" It's Oldking, little pup, just one word," he said in his pleasant baritone as he swallowed the chunk he'd gnawed off the semi-gooey slab. " Don't worry, every southerner says it wrong."

" Ah!" Orwall said. " Apologies."

" None necessary!" the big man said, waving away her concerns with his free hand. " As for the ration bar? Well, to be honest, I've wanted to try one since Netossa mentioned them. They're terrible, but I'm interested in their long-term storage capabilities and their energy-dense nature. Food is always a concern in my homeland, so I wanted to try them out. Bad as they are, if they can keep people in my homeland from going hungry, they're worth trying to recreate; even the worst food is better than starving to death."

" Is it really food, though?" Scurvy asked from next to the Oldking. Netossa had sat him there given the Cove and Galacia's newfound friendship- which had been surreal to see in action. All those Selkies in pirate hats. " I mean, I didn't want to say nothing

when you started chewing on that slop, felt rude, but those are fucking awful.”

His wife next to him, Squall, nodded sagely as she cracked her way through some pork ribs.

“ It's... quite *like* food,” Narwahl said as he gnawed off another bite, and the group chuckled a bit before going quiet... or, in Squall's case, returning to silence. She hadn't said a word in Netossa's presence since she'd arrived; Netossa had heard she was mute, or at least, didn't talk much to those she didn't trust- stories varied. Probably explained some of her marriage to Scurvy; the Cove admiral liked talking.

Apparently she'd taken Netossa's threats rather personally, which Netossa felt was a bit unfair. She hadn't threatened Scurvy or Squall *personally*, just... the Cove in general. And it wasn't like she'd *actually* abandon them to Horde attacks... and she wouldn't, she'd fight for them. She just needed them to *believe* she'd do it, so they'd come along, lend their support here.

...Okay, so threatening to withdraw Rebel support for the Cove and let them fight a land war against the Horde without help if they didn't come to this meeting hadn't been one of Netossa's proudest moments. But after the fucking mess that had been Seaworthy- the double dealing, the lying, the attempted assassinations of both her person and her character- she hadn't been in the best of moods for diplomacy, and Spinnerella's suggestion to just threaten the Cove into compliance had been damn attractive.

It wasn't like the mess in Seaworthy hadn't been resolved the instant she did just what Spinnerella had suggested in the first place, which had consisted of threatening to blow up Peekablue's club, the one thing other than Sweet Bee he loved more than his own life. Netossa hadn't wanted to do that, had opted for diplomacy first, sure that with some bribes and sweet-talking, she could get what she wanted. Peekablue had turned her down- he hadn't wanted to be involved- so she'd went to the Senate with her money in hand and words in her mouth.

Seaworthy's Senate had responded by hearing her out politely, taking her money, promising to consider it... and then sending assassins after her the minute she was out of the room. Apparently, while saying “no” to her request would have been rude, killing her wasn't, according to Seaworthy's byzantine social etiquette... and when Netossa had failed to do the polite thing and quietly die, her and her Rebels too prepared and too tough for the contract killers, Seaworthy had decided her character might be easier to assassinate. They claimed she'd attacked the city, pretended the paid murderers her and her squad had killed were good Seaworthy citizens, and slapped a bounty on her head while decrying her to all and sundry.

It wasn't until she'd finally given in to Spinerella and just threatened Peekablue that they'd put an end to it, the oracle using his own extensive blackmail to get Seaworthy to stop, retract the accusations, and cancel the bounty. It was what Spinny had wanted Netossa to do from the very start, and when Peekablue had proven reluctant to get involved a second time regardless of what they offered him, Netossa had finally agreed.

So she'd listened when Spinny made another suggestion, and it had worked, too! The Cove had complied... though the mere fact

that it was Scurvy and Squall here instead of the Falcon was a quiet sign of the Cove's displeasure. Scurvy and Squall were fairly major figures for the city, but the Falcon was the city champion, if the Cove *wanted* to be here, that's who they'd have sent. Even the pirate citystate could show a subtle side, on rare occasions, though Netossa imagined they'd stab you for suggesting it.

...Eh, she'd make it up to them later. Once they were committed to this plan, she'd cut them a better deal on trade. Her Rebels did a ton of business with the Cove; they literally couldn't afford to be *too* mad at her, and by the same token she couldn't afford to be *too* harsh with them.

She'd sit down with Stormwall and work out something; the former Blue Mountain noble was the guy who ran most of her money for her, he'd help her hack out a trade agreement that would favor the Cove a bit, soothe some tempers. He'd gotten used to it as a fourth cousin of Blue Mountain's king, working in the treasury, though- much to Netossa's admiration- he'd given up all his titles to change his name, join her out in the middle of nowhere as a Rebel, and risk his life fighting for freedom. Good man. Excellent horseman. *Impeccable* mustache.

(She wondered if he'd change his name again; Force Captain Storm had been the one who attacked Phlax back at the war's start, and Stormwall had named himself that to show his opposition to the man... but Orwall had confirmed Storm was dead while they were traveling, Halfmoon got him. Stormwall had toasted her that night.)

Right as she finished up her chili, Oldking Narwahl spoke up again.

“ I'm not sure how they managed to make it both unpleasantly hard and a bit sludgey at the same time,” he commented as the big man finished the bar. “ My compliments to the chef for an unusual, if awful, texture, I'm sure it must have taken quite a lot of talent to make food this bad. It's not just any chef that can make this kind of mistake, this took *effort* and *planning.*”

“ Eh, they're not that bad,” Spinnerella said, because she was the only person Netossa had ever met who felt neutral towards ration bars, which by comparison meant she liked them more than anyone else. “ You get used to them!”

“ Nameless forbid,” Narwahl swore mildly.

“ I told you!” Scurvy said. “ We captured a bunch of that stuff while hounding the Horde with Salineas, the Horde ships all had it, and it *sucks ass*. I'd rather eat hardtack; the weevils at least have a mustardy flavor to'em.”

Scurvy added a hearty laugh; Doctor Blankfort, Phlax's representative, looked briefly ill at the very idea of eating weevils, though Narwahl nodded.

“ True,” he said. “ Though speaking of mustard, with some spices and condiments it could be made more pleasant; I can already tell that this would go surprisingly well with some good old aspic. If nothing else, it would add a lot of nutritional value to our more traditional meals. Could maybe be boiled down in a soup as stock, too...”

“ Why the interest?” Scurvy asked. “ I mean, if you guys need food, I'm sure the Cove could supply you some, and even the worst shit we've got is better than a ration bar. You'll need to talk to the city council, but I'll put in a good word for ya, I'm sure you could work out something. Can't get you crabulus, good as it is- stuff never keeps for travel- but we've got enough potatoes to kill a man, and we've always got surplus seafood. Plus we get some weird shit in the black markets- you ever eat snapgator? Cost me a fortune and would have been a steal at half the price. You wouldn't believe it, but snapgator tail is the best meal we've ever had. Like chicken and fish had a baby and it was half butter, it almost melts in your mouth. Our kids still clamor for it on the holidays.”

Squall nodded along with her husband's words, sighing as she finished her pork, clearly wishing she had snapgator on her plate.

“ I have not had snapgator!” Narwahl said with a chuckle. “ I've never even heard of them, much less eaten them! But now you have made me hungry for a food I know nothing about. Most cruel of you!”

Scurvy laughed, and his wife snorted, as the Selkie drained his tankard to wash the taste of ration bar from his mouth. Brightmoon pale ale was some good stuff; thin and drinkable like any good pale ale should be, but had just enough liquor you could tell. The butler next to Narwahl silently offered a refill, and when the Oldking nodded, the man refilled his drink without spilling a drop.

“ Eh, I'll grab you some next time you're in the Cove. I'm sure I can get the DBF guys to cook it up right,” Scurvy said. “ Though honestly if you're gonna be in town, I'll have to get you some crabulus too. Fry'em, stuff some butter on those big bastards and that's all it needs; best meal in town. Shame we can't get it to travel- you gotta eat it within a couple of days of catching it, it spoils fast.”

“ Ah, DBF,” Narwahl said fondly. “ I've heard of them! The Drinking Buddies for Freedom! I'm particularly amused by the idea of a pub with a drunk seal and equally-drunk octopus on the door, though I sadly can't see it anymore. I'd be honored to be your guest at that fine establishment, Admiral Scurvy.”

“ Eh, it's no big deal,” Scurvy said, waving it off. “ Us Crownless just got to stick together; especially the two of us, we're the only ones to throw the Runestone fuckers out of our house. We gotta show these others how to do it!”

“ Hear hear!” said Dr. Blankfort, raising his glass, the old Phlax healer's eyes gleaming above his white beard. “ That's worth a drink!”

“ Indeed!” said the Red Knight. “ Three cheers for Galacia and Octopus Cove!”

Now *that* was a sentiment Netossa could get behind; Rebel that she was, she was Crownless, too, so her and Spinnerella raised their glasses as well and joined the cheer. Narwahl and Scurvy and Squall took the acclaim in good humor, Narwahl smiling,

Squall rolling her eye but grinning, and Scurvy making a “keep it coming” motion for fun.

Orwall looked distinctly uncomfortable as she toasted, like she wasn't sure it was a good idea, and that same general expression fit Vesser, Mach and Catillus as well; the three were, after all, from Runestone *Duchies,* if not Kingdoms. Still, they raised a glass anyway. Krystala was the only one who did not join in, though she also didn't seem bothered by it; she just kept quietly eating with her one remaining hand, the great horrible weapon that made up her right arm resting casually at her side like the promise of future violence.

(Netossa didn't know *why* the last Duke of Vargon had experimented on *children*, but she did know this much: be all his sins remembered, Hordak killing the guy had been an act of absolutely undiluted heroism. The Horde, for all it had done, was never as bad as Vargon had been in those last days, even at its worst.)

The servants didn't react to their nations being mocked, though she was sure one woman's eye was twitching, which brought a grin to Netossa's face. They really shouldn't feel offended, honestly; they were Brightmoon, they were alright. The other Runestone Kingdoms might have made a sport of kicking in Crownless faces, but Brightmoon had never joined the fun.

“ Most appreciated!” Narwahl said, as the furor died down. “ You do us great honor.”

“ No more than you deserve,” Dr. Blankfort said. “ While we have generally good relations with our sole Runestone Kingdom

neighbor in Brightmoon-”

“ Everybody has good relations with Brightmoon, though,” Vesser pointed out, the former farmer giving a nod to the Brightmoon servants all around them. “ Back before the Horde, even the Duchies liked Brightmoon. It's kind of their thing.”

“ Course we did,” old Mach said sardonically. “ The other Runestone Kingdom we knew was the Fright Zone, everybody looks good compared to that. Remember the gladiator executions?”

A shiver through the former Duchy folk; Netossa had heard of those. The Fright Zone had fallen far enough that prisoners were executed in grand shows, Scorpioni killing weaponless prisoners in “fights” that only ever had one ending, the bodies disrespected afterwards; no wonder Brightmoon had cut all economic ties with the place. King Uinta had undone those laws as his literal first act as king, but the memory lasted.

“ True,” the Red Knight said after a moment, “ but even by higher standards, they're decent folk.”

They gave a nod to the servants, which was dutifully given back by the head maid.

“ Regardless, we are all too used to being dismissed by the other nations as backwards,” Dr. Blankfort said. “ Not just us Crownless;

even you Runestone Duchies were considered more primitive."

" That's true," Catillus, eldest of them all, said. The Silverglade hedge-mage nodded his withered head, and Netossa briefly worried it would snap off- guy looked like a living skeleton, or like his skin had been dry-wrapped around him. Dude was *old.* " We were often dismissed unless we acted collectively, and even then it was begrudging at best."

" Thus, it's nice to know that they can't have it their way *all* the time. Octopus Cove defeating them could be dismissed as a fluke, a one-time event, but Galacia's recent victory proves it to be more than a cosmic miracle; it *can* be done," Dr. Blankfort said. " Perhaps it will encourage them to be less arrogant in the future."

" I'd say stranger things have happened," Peekablue remarked sardonically, " but I do hate lying... when nobody's paying me to do so. But it will hopefully encourage *us* to remember that *they* can be defeated."

Peekablue was safely ensconced on the other side of Spinnerella, who sat to Netossa's left, and thus out of reach of Scurvy or his wife. Given Seaworthy and the Cove's distaste, Netossa hadn't felt like risking that he'd eat a knife for lunch, or conversely, that he'd force-feed a knife to someone else. Peekablue was a little guy who wasn't much of a fighter, but he *was* quick, which was all you really needed. Netossa couldn't let him die for a bunch of reasons; unwilling or not, he was a guest, and thus owed her highest protection, and his help was invaluable.

Plus Sweet Bee would kill her for it, which was an important secondary consideration.

With the distance between them, instead of a weapon like he might otherwise use, Scurvy only had words to mock Peekablue.

" Someone from Seaworthy, wanting to pick a fight with a Runestone Kingdom?" Scurvy said, making exaggerated motions of disbelief, widened eyes and a mockingly agape mouth. " Aren't you afraid you'll get your silks dirty?"

" You *must* be surprised," Peekablue said dryly, " you didn't even comment on me hating lying. Losing your touch, pirate!"

Squall somehow intensified the power of her glare as she gave Peekablue the one barrel she had, like her eye knew it had to make up for missing its sister and decided to put in twice the effort to compensate.

" Maybe," Scurvy said, but he grinned- which was a good sign, Netossa had been worried they'd blow up into a full argument, but the fine food had apparently mollified Scurvy's temper. Squall calmed down too, seeing that Scurvy didn't seem likely to start something. " Still, I like that sentiment too well to be all that much of a dick about it, even to a fucking Liar. Maybe we can't win all the time, but knowing it was done twice means that people are encouraged to try for a *third* time. Probably Phlax, if I had to put money on it."

“ I'm quite flattered,” Dr. Blankfort said.

“ Are you putting money on it?” Peekablue asked. “ I'll take that bet.”

“ I'm afraid I can't take Seaworthy silver,” Scurvy said in tones of false regret, “ gives me an upset stomach. Damndest thing.”

“ You should have that checked out,” Peekablue said, but the warm meal had eased him, too; he was smirking as he said it. “ But I'll take any off your hands if you need it, being a man of infinite generosity towards my lessers.”

Narwahl, thankfully, interrupted the nationalistic sabre-rattling before it could derail the conversation again.

“ Hopefully Galacian iron does not give you the same conniptions,” Narwahl said, turning back to Scurvy. “ After all, I intend to take you up on that offer, my good admiral, and spend quite a bit of it in your homeland once this business is over! The Cove was the first place I planned to visit while doing my diplomatic rounds, before Princesses Netossa and Spinnerella asked for my assistance.”

“ Which is most appreciated,” Netossa said.

“ Absolutely,” Spinnerella added.

Narwahl gave them both an acknowledging nod.

" I am glad to give it," he said, before turning back to Scurvy. " But! We've strayed from your question. As for why I'm interested in the ration bars, I've heard- and had it confirmed by Netossa- that Horde soldiers eat nothing but these, and suffer no ill effects. Such a complete meal indicates solid nutrition, and that is terribly difficult to get up in Galacia. The roof of the world is beautiful, but abundant in food, it is not- and what food we have often has nutritional deficiencies. We get along, but to truly grow as a nation, our food problems *must* be overcome."

" You can get the same effect with ambrosia, which also is actually good," Peekablue said.

" Yeah, but you have to pay through the nose for it," Scurvy said with a frown. " And they guard their shipments well, it's hard to steal it. We have to bribe the guards, usually."

" I'll remind the Hive to increase guard pay," Dr. Blankfort said dryly. " I thought you were coastal pirates only? What are you doing so far north and east of your home?"

" We're not Salineans," Scurvy said with a snort. " We've won a land war... and if there's money to be made, well, you can usually find one of us there! By land or by sea, a pirate's life for me, as they say."

“ *Do* they say that?” Peekablue asked no one in particular. “ I don't think they say that.”

Catillus, meanwhile, raised an eyebrow, the elderly Duchy mage clearly confused.

“ You seem... very open about... all of that,” he said.

“ Eh, we are what we are,” Scurvy said with a shrug.

“ And you seem... not okay with it, but not nearly as angry as I'd have expected,” the elderly hedgemage said, looking at Dr. Blankfort.

“ It's the Cove,” the doctor answered with a shrug. “ It would be like getting angry at a dog for chasing its tail. A black market is going to exist no matter what anyone does; the Cove, at least, is run intelligently. Fewer people die this way.”

Scurvy glanced over at Peekablue.

“ No smartass comment on the Cove being run intelligently?” Scurvy asked. “ The jokes are right there if you wanna go for'em.”

“ Too obvious,” Peekablue said. “ We're too refined in Seaworthy to go after the low-hanging fruit. Also it's hard to see, what with our noses stuck in the air so much.”

Scurvy cracked up, and even Squall chuckled a bit at that.

“ You're alright for a Liar,” Scurvy said.

Peekablue raised his glass to that, while Netossa was mostly struck by what a smooth piece of verbal judo that had been. It wasn't any Seaworthy citizen who could surprise a Cove pirate into a laugh. No wonder Peekablue had done so well in Seaworthy's cutthroat political scene.

(He'd been surprisingly okay with being threatened, as well- *at least you're straightforward about it*, he'd said, then done as requested.)

“ So, while the grub's fine and all,” Scurvy continued said, while somehow simultaneously eating his last fruit tart whole in a rather impressive feat of oral acrobatics, “ we should probably go over the plan again. I know we've talked about it, but I'd like a go-over before it all starts.”

Netossa opened her mouth to ask him to wait until the servers were gone, but Peekablue beat her to the punch.

“ While I agree that Brightmoon cuisine is excellent, and her hospitality even better, I would caution that we wait to speak of such matters for a more opportune time,” the exiled prince replied.

“ Why?” Scurvy said, frowning at him as Squall dialed up the intensity of her glare again.

“ I hate to put it so bluntly,” Peekablue said, frowning, “ but we are literally *surrounded* by eyes and ears for Queen Angella. While I'm in full agreement that we should go over our plans again, we should wait until the staff have left so we can do it in some level of confidence.”

The wait staff, to their credit, did not react to Peekablue so blatantly laying out the possibility they were spies, neither to make futile- and likely insincere- protest, nor to be offended. They *were* Angella's people first and foremost, after all.

Scurvy knew that, too, and it was clear the straightforward pirate had simply not considered it before he spoke; his face went through a few iterations of confusion before he finally gave a nod.

“ Well, fuck,” he said. “ You're right. Shame! Hate to lose an argument with a Seaworthy fuckbag.”

“ It wasn't really an argument?” Orwall offered, and Scurvy turned to her with a snort.

“ Yeah, it was,” he said. “ He's from *Seaworthy*, trust me, it was an argument. Point to him, though, I'm man enough to admit it.”

“ Why wait?” said a voice unheard until this moment. It was a very bland kind of voice. Hard to pick out of a crowd. “ It is no secret what we desire.”

The table turned to Krystala, who had finished her meal and was quietly dabbing her lips with her napkin. The Minotaur, who towered over everyone except Oldking Narwahl- and she still had a few inches on him- did not much react to the sudden attention.

Her cold, dead eyes washed over them without acknowledging them, like some eerie counterpart to Narwahl's pale eyes. His eyes did not see them, either, but the eyelids around them moved, there was warmth in those blind orbs anyway; but Krystala's saw you, and dismissed you, held you as unimportant. Krystala looked at other people the way most people looked at a field of grass.

It was... chilling.

“ We are here,” Krystala said, in the silence, “ because we are going to kill Lord Adora. We are experiencing difficulties in getting everyone to agree to this sensible plan because the She-Ra, being foolish, desires nothing more than to fuck the Lord of the Horde, and she is too powerful both personally and politically for her desires to be treated as the idiocies that they are. The situation is not *actually* complicated, only *politically* so. The blunt truth is, if

the Lord of the Horde were anyone else, we would be discussing how to do it, not whether we should or not.”

Krystala turned her head the barest degree, towards the maid whose eye had twitched, a thing Netossa wasn't aware that the minotaur had even noticed.

“ Or am I wrong, little Brightmoon maid?” she asked, in that quiet way, which reminded Netossa of how predators would pause before striking.

The head maid clearly wanted to do something, but did not move as the maid momentarily wrestled with herself before settling on an answer.

“ It is not my place to speak on political matters,” the maid said.

“ Which, from one so polite, is as good as a yes,” Krystala said, turning back to the table with her cold, dead eyes. “ If the answer was no, she would have supported her Princess and said so. But she knows. I know. You know. Even the She-Ra knows. But I do not hold her desire to chew on the pussy of the Horde's Lord as being particularly valuable.”

“ Krystala, I'm not sure this is the best discussion to have right here-” Netossa began, but Krystala calmly put a hand up to forestall her, even as some of the wait staff grew visibly angry.

“ I understand,” Krystala said. “ It does not escape me that the people of Brightmoon do not want to hear me disparage their She-Ra. But truth is like that. It is rarely kind. It is simply *true.* And this, too, is true; we are going to win here. We have too many to be denied. The Snows supports us. Salineas may vote against us, as Brightmoon definitely will... but what of it? Phlax. Seaworthy. Octopus Cove. Blackmoor. Galacia. The Twin Kingdoms. Even Halfmoon... and not least the Great Rebellion itself. Too many.”

“ We've only got three votes, though," Spinnerella pointed out. “ Maybe four if they'll accept Peekablue, which they won't. The Princesses have all the votes...”

“ What shall Angella do?” Krystala answered in her measured way. “ As Vesser said, their diplomacy is their focus. It will trap the Queen. She cannot simply leave the Alliance again, she does not have enough army left to risk the desertions; she cannot choose the She-Ra over us. And Salineas will see which way the tide is turning and do as they always have, and join the winning team. They cannot afford to turn us down, not if we remain united. And should the She-Ra turn on us, should she choose her desire to fuck the Horde's Lord over the kingdom that adopted her?”

Krystala shrugged.

“ Then we have one more thing to cut down. Mightier than any... but I have always known I would die on a battlefield. I am not concerned with whose hand it is that removes me,” she said calmly. “ It has nothing to do with me, after all. And she cannot

possibly defeat the entire Rebellion. We will win, whether we must stand on the She-Ra's corpse to do so, or she suffers an attack of common sense and backs down.”

She gave a small movement of her lips that might have been a smile, or the remnants of one.

“ And then we will kill the Horde's Lord, before starting on all the rest of them.”

“...Your death has nothing to do with you?” Orwall asked, in the silence that followed.

Krystala gave the tiniest downward turn of her horned head.

“ Death is impersonal. Impartial. Only the arrogant assume that anything about their ending is personal,” the minotaur said. “ Though, on a more interesting topic, I imagine they will ask us to capture Adora alive, rather than kill her. A way to... thread the needle. That is what they will ask of us.”

She made that not-quite-a-smile again.

“ Foolish.”

She finished her drink, and stood up, a slow and careful motion.

" I shall return to my tent," she said to the group. " I will rejoin you thirty minutes before we must speak with the gathered Alliance. I will not speak, but will simply be present. I have no vote, as I am no Princess, and represent no nation... despite being the sole person from Vargon present amongst our luminaries. Still, perhaps it is for the best. I am often found to be disturbing by others. I will allow the rest of you to discuss the details of who shall speak first amongst yourselves."

She turned as she stood, but not before she gave the briefest of nods to the head maid.

" Thank you for the food," she offered.

Then she left, hulking cyborg form moving with the quiet assurance of one who knew they could kill whatever might threaten them.

"...Well, that was... what the fuck?" Scurvy said, and Netossa couldn't help but agree.

Chapter End Notes

I know better than to promise what the next chapter is- but I hope against hope it is the true War Council at last.

Brightmoon has never had strong gender distinctions in... well, anything, to be honest, so the dress code for butlers

and maids is the same. Due to the general distaste for suits that persisted in Brightmoon society until Catra singlehandedly revived the art, the standard uniform is an altered maid's uniform. Suits skyrocketed so dramatically into being a sign of both support for the She-Ra and a sign of being “in” with the latest fashion, which has had the perverse side-effect of making suits kind of expensive; nobody would use them for day to day work.

Squall is selectively mute, which my research leads me to believe is the current modern term in psychiatry; she only speaks to those she trusts, and she trusts a vanishingly rare number of people. She's able to communicate in sign language to the untrusted, but that's about it. Some experiences early in life led her to trust only her fellow Magicats; no one was more surprised than her when she fell, and fell hard, for the human Scurvy, who has never betrayed her trust. He was the only sea captain willing to take on a non-talking Magicat, and he was the only person to recognize her talents despite her silence; he thus earned her loyalty fair and square, up until she lost her eye in a fight with an enemy pirate.

Scurvy tracked that guy down while she was still healing, caught him, and gave him to her, alive and in chains, as a gift; he also told her that, despite her new injury, and all the other trouble her muteness caused, she still had a place as his first mate, because “you're the best I've ever sailed with.”

She spoke to him for the first time at that point, saying “thank you”, because it was then that her loyalty turned to love. She hadn't lost her place because of her injury, which she'd been terrified of the whole time she was recovering, and Squall had went way out of his way to make sure she could get her vengeance. Scurvy wanted her to stay...

And she found she wanted Scurvy to stay, too. To stay forever at her side.

So she ended up proposing to Scurvy with a stolen ring (because, well, pirates) after she killed the guy who took her eye, and they've been happily married ever since. Scurvy remains the one non-Magicat Squall feels comfortable talking to, most days. They've even got three Magicat kids with the help of the Plumerian concoction Conquering Love, which lets any male/female couple otherwise fertile produce kids (always the mother's species). Squall's siblings mostly look after them, since the duo are busy, but rather despite themselves the two are alright parents.

Squall is the “good kid” of her family, because she's out there being a pirate, while the others take less celebrated jobs; the irony of the Cove is that, for all its love of piracy and its view of itself as the world's roughest town, it's also, you know, a full city, so there's doctors and janitors and all sorts there too. The Cove really IS the world's toughest town, but it's also a city that has a lot of potato farmers. Squall, by virtue of being a brave, tough pirate, is basically the over-achieving golden child of her own family; her siblings are kind of annoyed by how much their parents gush over how proud of Squall they are, though the two are good parents and love all their kids- and they're excellent grandparents.
(They also love Scurvy, and absolutely adore him; he's rather taken by this, since he's the bastard son of a pirate he never met, and didn't have the best relationship with his mother. He's adopted a lot of their ways as a result.)

Side note: sign Language in Etheria was codified in Brightmoon. The language before Orgel, Old Millenium, had a lot of hand gestures; while that was lost as it became Orgel, those gestures remain in the form of the codified sign language. Sign language, of course, predated that codification, but Angella paid a lot of linguists a lot of silver to come up with a single unified sign language that could be understood and taught to the people en mass. The result was Brightmoon Hand Language, BHL, and it's one of Brightmoon's two official languages- all government officials are required to be proficient in it. It's called Hand Language

because that was the term when Angella ordered it made, though “sign language” is now the terminology used in Etheria. It's the basis of most sign languages in Etheria- they are mostly mutually intelligible, though the other person has the sign language equivalent of an accent if they're from somewhere else. Plumerians are infamous for signing very, very slowly, Salineans for signing very quickly, to give you an idea.

Narwahl eating a ration bar is a reference to the Dragon's Ambassador, a fanfic of this fanfic; my way of honoring those who honor me.

Chapter 45: Bow of Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Wanted to do a short intro bit before I write the whole damn thing.

Next Friday is the War Council.

Get ready, folks. I'm back!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

THE LAST WAR COUNCIL OF BRIGHTMOON

Bow of Brightmoon

Today was gonna be a hell of a day, and Bow didn't want to deal with it.

Still, he hadn't much choice about it.

Bow rubbed his eyes as he sat at his forge. Next to him was his... however many cups of coffee he was on. He couldn't remember. He'd been downing coffee since last night. This last cup had been brought to him by one of the castle's servants a few minutes ago; the guy had looked at the cup like he feared it was going to get up and attack him.

It wasn't a surprise; Bow liked his coffee pure, unlike most of his countrymen. Brightmoon's people generally preferred Salinean coffee, which was a bit sweeter, and they made their steaming mugs of liquid awareness with lots of sugar, some cream, and a little milk. Chocolate from Plumeria also wasn't out of the question.

But Bow preferred the mean stuff. Harsh Dryl coffee, black as midnight, rougher and meaner than the sweeter Salinean beans. Dryl leaving the Alliance- and thus, no longer trading its coffee- hadn't affected most Brightmoon coffee drinkers, but it had devastated Bow's reserves of his favored drink. Dryl's coffee was as rough and dry as that land, and nearly as strong as its stone; most Brightmoon citizens were horrified by it, given the nation's general sweet tooth.

Bow liked sweet things too, mostly... but not when it came to coffee.

He took a sip of the steaming cup, enjoying the bitter flavor. Lovely.

His unusual taste for bitter coffee was probably the fault of the Rebels he'd apprenticed under, honestly. Back when he'd first lied to his fathers about going to university, and had instead snuck off into the south of occupied Plumeria to join the Rebellion, he'd gotten damn lucky; his harebrained scheme hadn't ended with him dead in a ditch, but instead, found by a Rebel squad. Old Bay-Bur and his warcamp of Rebels.

Bay-Bur must have been the oldest Rebel on Etheria, but it didn't slow him down much. Unlike most Plumerians, the old man had military experience; he was an immigrant, having come from Dryl, and he'd spent much of his adult life fighting off bandits trying to plunder the caravans of the land. Apparently, early in Entrapta's reign- when her parents had died and she was too young to rule much- Dryl had fallen apart into semi-anarchy, and Bay-Bur had learned to fight back then, when it seemed that every road between every town was a mess.

(*It's why we love Princess Entrapta,* the old man had said- this being many, many years before Bow himself would actually meet Entrapta. *The Lady stopped all that and put the nation back together. I'd already left by then, but I'll say that she did alright by us.*)

Bay-Bur was too old to fight by the time the Horde invaded his newly chosen homeland... but he could teach others how to battle, and that made him invaluable early on. He taught a whole group of refugees how to fight, and Bow ended up in that same group, learning at the wise old soldier's side. He learned as Bay-Bur traveled on a Horde skiff his group had stolen early on, using it as a kind of combination of supply wagon and wheelchair, the old man directing “the young'uns” in the means of making guerrilla war.

Bow had fought his first battles under that old man's command, fighting alongside his sons and daughters, fighting under Netossa's white-web-on-purple flag- for the old man had signed up early with Netossa, even as he operated his own independent warcamp in the Rebel-held territory.

(Bow found it both amazing and odd to actually *meet* Netossa in the flesh, after that- it was strange to meet someone whom you

had only ever heard of as an ideal, as a banner snapping from a mast, as a story of a distant leader.)

And in-between his teachings, his exaggerated tales, and his claims that he could have beat Hordak one-handed in his youth- always told with a wink, to show that Bay-Bur didn't believe a word of what he was saying either- Bay-Bur had shown Bow the ropes of warfare.

Which had included starting every day with a gigantic mug of the Dryl coffee that Bay-Bur had a seemingly-endless supply of.

Or, as Bay-Bur preferred to call it in his salty, flowery way, "a big hearty cup of wake-the-fuck-up."

(He could still hear that old man's cackle, see the way his dark skin had aged so much that it had turned into something like thin leather- and the fire inside his bright eyes, his mighty spirit the one thing even Time itself could not conquer. Old age would kill him if the Horde didn't first, but it would not break him- and not for the first time, Bow prayed that the Silver protect him, and all whom Bow had served with, who served as the cutting edge of righteousness.)

Bow took a long draw of his mug, draining most of the black and bitter brew, dark as one of Dryl's mineshafts. He felt it settle into his body, alive and angry- good. The meeting to come would demand all of his attention and energy, even if he couldn't add much; the Rebels would dismiss him as too Brightmoon-aligned, which... wasn't entirely wrong, he supposed, even if he was technically independent. *Officially* , he was a Rebel soldier on loan from the Great Rebellion up here, a liaison with Brightmoon.

Officially.

He took another sip of his rapidly diminishing coffee. It was too early to be thinking about this, even if it was afternoon; for him, anything would be too early, because he'd been up all damn night dealing with the hacking attempt.

His nocturnal efforts had been... mostly useless, honestly. He hadn't been able to identify a source for the hacking attempt, was only able to shut it off after it had been running for too long, and he hadn't figured out if it left any ugly bits of code to haunt them later.

After, he'd *tried* to go back to sleep, but that hadn't worked; he was too worried about Catra, too frustrated over his failure to halt the hack, and just generally worked up.

So he'd finally just rolled over and gotten up. He'd worked at his forge, refining what Castaspella had sent him- not doing anything dangerous in his sleep-deprived state, just drawing up theory on his trackerpad. Mostly about his idea for an anti-magic arrow, made from Castaspella's anti-magic grenades... surprisingly simple in design, if he was right. It wouldn't take much work to make a few arrows out of them, though he'd keep a few of the originals, too.

It'd been nice to work on those, solving a... *practical* problem, instead of thinking about the upcoming meeting. The war council

was meeting in... two hours, by his watch, and wow, he did *not* want to go to it. He wanted to *sleep.*

But he couldn't, so this coffee was just what the doctor prescribed.

(Glimmer always mocked him for liking his coffee black, saying it didn't fit his personality; he'd teased her back, saying she was the same, that it was hilarious to see the straight-forward, no-nonsense heroine with a cup of "coffee" in only the most metaphorical sense, given all her sugary additions.)

Of course, even if he wasn't sleepy, he wouldn't want to go. This meeting was going to be the *opposite* of enjoyable, no matter how it ended.

But he had to go. He was going to back up the Queen and Catra both, when they told the world what the Sword was... and made the plea to keep Adora alive. While he didn't know how much influence his words would have, compared to the great Queen and the She-Ra herself, he wasn't about to let one of his best friends suffer without his support as the world tried to kill the woman she loved.

Bow got the other side, of course. Did Adora deserve to die? Sure. She was trying to burn the world down, and one didn't do that without casualties. She was getting people, her own and others, killed and hurt, simple as that.

But it wasn't really about that, not really. It was about *Catra,* it was about trying to find a way that, somehow, despite everything, this story could have a happy ending.

Bow had never much liked sad endings to stories. The real world made enough of those; it felt like cowardice, to him, to write them into a story. It was easy to imagine a *bad* ending; just ask any kid to tell you a story, and they could write you one of blood and death and despair on the spot. That shit was *simple.*

But happiness... ah, now *that* was hard.

(A lesson Bow had learned from his fathers; not deliberately, but in watching them, in seeing how much effort they put into their marriage and into their parenting, realizing that the good life they had was not a thing they had stumbled into by accident, nor were given by destiny. No, it was a thing they had earned for themselves, through the emotional and difficult tasks of talking and communicating and making sure they spoke even of the hard things... and of all the lessons his fathers taught him, this accidental lesson was the one that mattered most, this knowledge that a good life required hard work.)

So he'd do what he could, to make a happy ending of it all. A world where Adora stopped, and Catra had the woman she loved. Adora was responsible for much... but she was also the woman who had saved Catra as a child. She was *also* a person, and while Bow was not as forgiving as a Plumerian... well, he *did* still believe in redemption.

Unlikely as it was...

But my whole life is a series of unlikely events, the archer reminded himself. *I'm still breathing after years of war, I don't have any major lasting wounds, my best friends are a Princess of Brightmoon and the She-Ra...*

Yeah. Those were all good points.

He'd have hope, no matter how hard it was.

So up and at'em, as they said... though he wished Glimmer was here. As Catra's sister and the last third of the Best Friend Squad, Catra needed her here. Mermista's presence would help Catra deal with the aftermath, since she was Catra's best friend outside the Squad, but the water witch wouldn't be able to assist in the actual voting; Bow had heard from Sea Hawk himself about the diplomacy there.

(Bow was proud that he hadn't blushed once while talking to Sea Hawk. He'd had the *worst* crush on the guy when they first met- though realizing that the pirate already had Mermista helped tamp down on it.)

It would be good to have Glimmer here for Catra... and for Bow himself, too.

He wasn't *just* best friends with Catra in the Squad, after all. Glimmer was his oldest friend, whom he'd met even before he became a Rebel- an accidental meeting in childhood, when his

fathers had been traveling to talk at an archaeological foundation's seminar held near Brightmoon Castle, Glimmer finding Bow by accident while teleporting around. Pure accident... but enough to start a friendship, mostly through exchanged letters after Queen Angella finally found her wayward daughter, a friendship that only grew when Glimmer went rogue on her mother. She'd wanted a friend to fight the Horde with, knowing she couldn't do it alone- but she only had one friend, so she'd picked Bow.

She'd had no idea he'd become a Rebel at that point- he hadn't told her through letters for fear his fathers would find out- but she'd found him anyway, and that was how their partnership had started.

Yeah, he missed her; he wished she was here.

(He missed her a lot... and maybe that was because she was beautiful, because in Glimmer he saw someone so brave, whose soul shone with the same Silver that had driven him to be a Rebel... but he put those thoughts away. Bow was just some guy, a random Rebel with the good luck to meet the right people; Glimmer was a Princess, and he knew he wasn't worthy of her. It was one reason his crush on Sea Hawk had died- the man had the thing Bow wanted, and some part of Bow could not help a bit of green-eyed jealousy. Just a smidge.)

Still, she was gone from here, at Dryl with Shadow Weaver and Entrapta- which was odd for a whole host of reasons. He knew Catra had told Glimmer about her childhood; Glimmer had told him that herself.

So why would she go to Dryl?

Glimmer had been acting strange, too, when she left; if he didn't know her better, he'd suspect she was hiding something.

As he *did* know her better, he *knew* she was hiding something... something big. For Glimmer to feel the need to hide it meant *something,* given her general lack of subtlety...

He wasn't sure what she was doing.

But he knew what he *hoped* she was doing.

That thought made him glance down at his trackerpad, at the notes for his idea for anti-magic arrows. Written beneath the blueprint was a name that revealed their true purpose, the reason why he'd built them- which was odd, he didn't remember doing that, but a lot of last night had kind of blurred together.

Yeah... he suspected he knew what Glimmer was up to, because written under his blueprint was the name *Shadowkiller* .

(He had not forgotten his rage, when his brave friend had shattered before him, telling him the horror of her childhood. He had not forgotten the fury that had flowed into his bones, at realizing that one of his best friends, one of Etheria's greatest heroes, had suffered so much at the hands of one who should

have loved her. He had not forgotten what Shadow Weaver *was,* the truth his friend had barely been able to tell.)

And if he was right, he only prayed that Glimmer find success. Catra could not save herself from Shadow Weaver, not right now- maybe never. It would take the dark mage doing something truly unforgivable- like killing one of her family- for Catra to turn on her, given her need for the woman's validation and love, and by then, it would be too late for whoever was Shadow Weaver's next victim.

And there would be one; people like Shadow Weaver didn't *stop.* Some people made a choice, became less a person and more a thing that *happened* to a person, and Shadow Weaver had made that choice a long, long time ago.

So privately, Bow hoped that Glimmer knew what she was doing... or maybe came back to talk, so he could ask her how he could help.

Though all that was assuming he was right. He probably wasn't; most likely he was just projecting, confusing his own fury at the injustices inflicted on his best friend for what his *other* best friend must be feeling. Glimmer was one of the few people he didn't understand, sometimes; he *mostly* got her, but not...

Not always.

(Not since his own wants started to influence what he thought he was seeing from her, his own heart clouding his view of hers.)

So he shelved those thoughts as he arose, downed the last dregs of his coffee quick- another talent his time in the Rebellion had taught him was how to have a fireproof tongue, since they often barely had time to down breakfast before needing to get a move on- and entered into the Castle proper, searching for the Queen.

She'd be in her office, probably; if not, the guards there would be able to tell him where she was.

And where her mother was, there would be Catra.

So, fortified by caffeine, he marched down the halls... and got lucky, because just as he reached the hallway with her office, he found the Queen emerging from it, Catra behind her.

" Bow," Angella said as she stepped into the hallway, giving him a small nod of her head.

" Queen Angella," Bow said, giving her a nod back. To his friend, Bow nodded and sighed. " Catra. You ready?"

" No," Catra said, sighing too. " But here we are."

Not much to say to that... so Bow stepped aside so they could pass, turning around to walk next to them.

But turning led him to a surprise; down at the end of the hall, by herself, was Princess Frosta, looking serious as frostbite.

" Queen Angella," the little Snows Princess said. " We need to talk."

Chapter End Notes

Bay-Bur is from the UK POP magazines of She-Ra; he was an old man who liked to tell stories, including of kicking Hordak's butt. Here, he is as Bow describes him; while Bow's dad was the one who taught him how to shoot a bow (for self-defense reasons), Bay-Bur is the one who basically gave him his boot camp of soldiering.

Chapter 46: THE LAST WAR COUNCIL OF ETHERIA

Chapter Notes

AT THE END OF THE LONG ROAD...

It is finally here.

I PRESENT TO YOU, THE LAST WAR COUNCIL OF ETHERIA.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

THE LAST WAR COUNCIL OF ETHERIA

Frosta's young face- *she is a child,* Angella thought with despair, because the greatest cruelty of the Runestones had always been the youths they chose to bear their power- was set firm and strong as she stood before Angella, her daughter, and Bow, waiting for her answer.

Well, this wasn't what Angella had expected when she got out of her office.

Angella's kneejerk reaction- born out of little more than the bad blood between her and the Snows, if she was being honest- was to say no to talking to the little Princess. The meeting was coming up, after all, and while they were in no risk of getting there late, it was still no time to dawdle.

But she squashed that reflex almost instantly. Old instincts, long since buried down deep in her bones, said that this *mattered;* that this was too strange, too unusual, too much of a deviation from the script. Unusual was something to pay attention to; unusual was how things *changed.*

And this was *most* unusual... and some part of Angella, who had practiced diplomacy for longer than some nations had existed, said that this Council was not going to be won or lost in the fancy room with the big table.

No, it would be won or lost right here, right now.

Knowing that, trusting to the song her gut instinct was singing, Angella simply gave her fellow royal a nod.

" Do you wish to speak out here, or somewhere more private?" she asked Frosta, who pondered the question quickly.

" Alone," she said. " Me and you. You got an office back here?"

" Yes," Angella said, nodding towards the door she'd just left. The guards were a bit nervous at seeing a Snows Princess here; not a surprise, given that, if Angella was right in her recollection, Frosta was probably the first Snows Princess to see her office since she'd had the castle rebuilt the last time.

(That time was because it had gotten old enough that repairing it just wasn't as practical as rebuilding with all-new materials- almost refreshing, considering that most of the time when she had to rebuild, it was because something had wrecked her home.)

This moment is unusual for a lot of reasons, she thought as she indicated for Frosta to enter her office, which the punky little Princess did without a second glance *. Which just reinforces my first impression... this is going to be an important conversation.*

She glanced over at her daughter, who was worrying at her lip nervously; Catra got it, she was a talker too, she knew what made people tick. She knew this was unusual... and what unusual meant.

Her appearance made Angella's heart ache, just a little- her brave, brave girl, so worried.

(Angella offered the comfort she could with a quick brush of her wing against Catra's shoulder; the way her daughter relaxed, just a little, likewise loosened Angella's own aching heart. Last night had shown her how much Catra needed her, and Angella would not fail her daughter.)

Frosta took the offer, entering the room as the very surprised guards opened it; Angella followed behind. As the door shut, Frosta surprised the angel by leaping over the desk and sitting in Angella's own chair.

" Sit," Frosta said, indicating Angella's guest chair.

Caught by the sheer audacity of it all- and not a little bit amused- Angella did as requested, a half-grin forming on her face as she put herself in her own guest chair. Frosta leaned forward in Angella's own chair, steepling her fingers to talk to her.

" Well," Angella said, a bit caught between yelling at Frosta to get out of her chair and sheer amused admiration for the ballsiness of it all, " what do you want to talk about?"

" How much do you know about Darkspur?" Frosta asked, which... hadn't been on the list of things Angella was expecting, but then again, she hadn't expected *any* of this, so she recovered quickly.

" The citystate?" Angella asked for confirmation, and to buy time to think.

" Yeah," Frosta said.

" Citystate formed by refugees on the west coast, and the northernmost nation on Etheria- or, well, it was, until Galacia rebelled a decade ago," Angella responded. " Built on an excellent natural harbor, probably the smallest nation on Etheria by population size. Mostly subsists on whaling and exports of fish during the spring and summer, frozen the rest of the year and unable to trade with others. Why?"

(Also the most famous traveling circus of the western coast had originated there, but that was a random fact that *probably* wasn't

what Frosta was looking for.)

" Who found the harbor?" Frosta asked, another question Angella hadn't expected- though she did know the answer to this one.

" Captain Sprocker," she replied. " A Brightmoon Twigget, and first to circumnavigate Etheria."

Which he'd done entirely to prove a point- Brightmoon's people were not famed sailors, but Sprocket had wanted there to be at least *one* famous naval captain from his land. He'd found the uninhabited peninsula five centuries ago and named it Darkspur, taking inspiration from its southern neighbor Darkedge, adding the spur because the peninsula was shaped vaguely like the spurs of his boots.

(It annoyed Salineas terribly that someone else been the first to circle the whole thing; Angella still recalled Sprocker's smug grin and the Salinean diplomat's grumbling when he pulled it off, a rather amusing memory.)

" So they're from Brightmoon?" she asked, and Angella shook her head.

" No," Angella said, shaking her head. " While Darkspur may or may not have immigrants from Brightmoon, they wouldn't be a major part of its population. The majority of its people are from the western coast citystates south of them; they migrated there about... three centuries ago? In that area. The news was confusing and difficult to decipher at the time; they were fleeing

the aftermath of the failed Reclamation of the Flame Kingdom, and that disaster did a number on our intelligence in the area.”

“ Tell me about that,” Frosta commanded; but Angella obeyed for now. This felt... like she was getting at some point Angella couldn't quite grasp. Why was Darkspur so central now? The Snows claimed the territory- a thing Darkspur had always denied- but they'd never made any moves before...

*Are they planning to? With the war with the Horde distracting Brightmoon- plus my own troop troubles from my failures after Micah's death- now **is** a good time to attack...*

“ It was... a disaster,” Angella said simply, though she couldn't help a wince. “ The Reclamation was not a fool's idea- no, it took an entire group of fools to come up with it. A circle of wizards from Silverglade and Mystacor believed they could tame the Spirit Ember, even without a guiding Princess to rule it. If they had only risked their own lives, I would admire their bravery even as I lamented their foolhardiness...”

Frosta said nothing, waiting for Angella to keep going.

“ But they had been *so* certain of their success that they convinced a number of the other western nations to send people to help colonize the land. Every citystate had sent people- Glenmar, Small Oak, Northland, Darkedge, the Forest of the Hidden, Greenfield, all of them. They sent their poor, their homeless, their criminals, anyone their governments deemed “unnecessary” to be part of the initial colonizing efforts. Only

three didn't send anyone- the Forest of the Free, Moorstone, and southernmost Blackmoor.”

“ Why didn't they send anyone?” Frosta asked.

“ Blackmoor viewed it as suicide, a view proven right,” Angella said. “ The Forest of the Free, meanwhile, believed it to be a trick; the liberty-loving survivalists are paranoid to a fault, but it saved their lives. As for Moorstone... well, as later events would reveal, the rogue Blackmoor knightly order was planning to use their poor as conscripts in an army to attack the other citystates with.”

“ Rogue Blackmoor knightly order?” Frosta asked, and Angella nodded.

“ Moorstone was made up of those nobles kicked out of Blackmoor after they refused to obey their new constitution- well, new at the time, this was three centuries ago. They centered on a knightly order of Moorstone, which ended up seceding and taking a chunk out of Blackmoor's territory- not as much as they were trying to control, but they escaped with a good third of it.”

“ Okay,” Frosta said, sighing as she frowned. “ Damn, this is all complicated.”

“ It is,” Angella said, unable to help her snort of amusement at the youth's complaint. “ But that is politics.”

“ Yeah,” Frosta said with another sigh. “ Well, might as well get to it. Alright, so Moorstone was gonna attack everyone?”

“ Yes,” Angella said. “ Moorstone figured that the other citystates had their manpower drained by the colonization effort, and their resources distracted as well with assisting it; thus they thought they'd be able to conquer some land, then use the newly conquered territory for resources to invade their former homeland of Blackmoor. Their goal was always to return home and take over.”

“ And no one saw this coming?” Frosta asked.

“ No,” Angella replied. “ They only knew Moorstone would send no one, and as they didn't have the best relations with their neighbors, no one really cared. The wizards marched off at the head of a huge column, so many people from the western coast; many died on the march, because the wizards organized it poorly. I tried to tell them, to get them to just *wait* so I could send aid... but they were certain of their own wisdom. Many ran from the caravan as conditions worsened, either tried to become part of neighboring lands or simply became bandits... and they were the lucky ones. When they reached the Flame Kingdom, anyone who had survived the march did not survive the fire.”

Angella had only heard a few stories of that horrific end, how the wizards had marched in all arrogance and supremacy, and how everyone had burned for it. A few claimed to be survivors, and told many tales- most fantastical, easily dismissed. Angella doubted that the total number of *true* survivors- people who were

on the very edges of the caravan, who had been just outside the blast radius when the group was put to the torch- ever rose higher than a double handful of lives.

(But there was that one story a rare few told- of a thing made out of ash, that tried to get them to stop, a scorch-geist who begged them not to go- that had always sent chills down Angella's cowardly spine, and made her think of the last Fire Princess... but there was no time now to dwell on that.)

" So how does that fit in with Darkspur?" Frosta asked.

" The political results of the attempted Reclamation were, as you might imagine, beyond disastrous," Angella replied. " The nations blamed each other, political tensions spiraled out of control, and finally, a series of wars- civil or external, or sometimes both- started raging. Then Moorstone attacked while everyone was busy. Blackmoor tried to stop them by attacking northwards, but that was a hard go, even after I gave them considerable supplies on a lend-lease deal. The region is *still* dealing with some of the aftereffects, all these centuries later. One of those effects is Darkspur; it was originally settled by refugees, fleeing the southern citystates, looking for a new home."

" Why'd they settle in the Snows?" Frosta asked. " And why not pay us taxes? It's our land."

" A treaty," Angella said. " I made a treaty with the Snows to leave the people of Darkspur alone- well, specifically, for the Snows to treat any immigrants well, and to integrate them into their society. At the time, the Snows had a bad harvest, and I was willing to give them food to relieve the looming famine in return for

concessions. Some of those concessions involved promises of hospitality to the refugees. I didn't expect them to form Darkspur- that was a surprise- but the Snows *did* sign the treaty, though as far as I'm aware, your nation has never officially recognized Darkspur. Still, they've never demanded taxes from them before- they're located on the other end of the continent from your major cities.”

Frosta frowned, thinking; Angella let her, did not try to prod her. The girl- who had never struck Angella as the diplomatic type, to be polite about it- was clearly working with new material here, and she let her go through it at her own pace.

“ ...So there was no intent by them to steal our land, was there?” Frosta asked. “ They were just... fleeing the hell that was breaking loose down south of them.”

“ Yes,” Angella said. “ And, again- no one in Snows has risen to challenge them in the centuries since.”

“ ...It'd be easy to assume it was your land,” Frosta said, almost quietly to herself. “ Maybe it is, after so long without a word. And... a treaty of hospitality... like guests.”

A big thing, for the Snows; guest right. Like all cultural quirks, how much it mattered varied from person to person... but there had been some who had been quite serious about it. There had been a Prince of the Snows, once- Haku, that was the good man's name- who had once saved some of her people; a Snowsfolk

noble had promised them rest at his castle, then captured them for ransom.

Haku had descended on the man's castle and slain them within the week before delivering them back to Angella, alongside compensation and weregild for the guards slain in the ambush.

They were his guests, she could hear the effeminate man say in his quiet tones as he delivered her people, safe and sound, at Antares. *He was the host, and they were his guests.*

And that had been all he'd needed, that was the whole of his reasoning; it was enough, for him, that they had been promised safety, and it was betrayed. Guest rights were sacred, and he viewed it as his duty to punish those who broke sacred law.

(There were few Snowsfolk that Angella had ever liked over the long years... but Haku was on that list.)

" ...What are your plans for the Black Garnet?" Frosta asked. " If the Horde dies- who gets it?"

Well, she doesn't think small, that's for sure, some part of Angella snarked as she internally reeled from the sudden change in topic. What did all of this have in common? Sure, some of her intelligence said the Snows wanted to conquer Darkspur, go south, and take the Black Garnet for themselves, but that plan was so incredibly stupid that she'd dismissed those reports out of hand as falsifications of whatever the Snows was *really* planning. The logistics alone meant it would never work...

...Though the Reclamation was proof that a plan being a bad one *didn't* mean people wouldn't try...

Pondering whether the intelligence she'd dismissed might have, in fact, been accurate, Angella had to ponder the second question: how to answer. The Garnet was one of the big questions of the War, one everyone had sort of quietly decided not to talk about; but the truth was, of all the prizes the Horde had, the Garnet was the biggest one.

What do I say to her?

Her mind whirled with plans, ideas, thoughts- most discarded immediately, her mind quickly putting the pieces in place. Tossed aside were any ideas of lying to the Princess; lying was pretty much never as useful as people thought it was, save for short time periods. Truth had a tendency to be slow, but inevitable, and Angella was one of the few people who could assume that she would still be around when it finally arrived. Lies were useful in the moment and painful in the long run... and Angella's run was the longest on Etheria. It behooved her not to hobble her future self.

Nor was Frosta herself a fan of lying; she was straightforward and tough, like her mother and father, though Angella wasn't sure Frosta herself knew that. Angella had only met them a few times while they yet lived, before the assassination, and relations with the Snows- perhaps appropriately- never rose much above "frosty" during Angella's reign. Geopolitical interests too different, and the old rivalry, which predated even Angella, too strong.

But... the truth... dangerous. A way to tip her hand. Knowing it beforehand meant it could be more easily countered, and Frosta *was* of the Snows.

But...

No Snows Princess had ever walked into her office before, either.

And maybe...

Maybe Angella just had to *trust* , and hope.

" I hope to convince the Alliance to give it to the Great Rebellion," she said.

" Really?" Frosta asked, and Angella nodded.

" There are few other options," Angella said. " Plumeria cannot even control its own territory; while that will hopefully change, they simply do not have the current strength to watch over *one* Runestone, much less two. I would not let the old Fright Zone leadership lead that area again- they were corrupt and cruel, towards the end, no matter what King Uinta tried- but they are dead now, so that's a moot point. Salineas has no interest in anything more than some of Silverglade's old ports, and we of

Brightmoon cannot take it. It is too far south, and I have seen what wars of conquest and imperialism cost a nation; I am content with my borders as they stand. Blackmoor has refused to take the Black Garnet out of spite for the Kingdoms, and also because they are sensible and realize it would overstretch them. The only other non-Rebel candidates that both want to take it and possibly could hold it are Phlax and Mystacor; Phlax has the same problem as Plumeria in not having quite enough strength, but I believe they will grow into it. Mystacor has logistical issues to overcome that might prove too significant... but of the potential options, those two are somewhat viable as second choices. Still, they are not nearly as good a choice as the Rebels."

" Why?" Frosta asked.

" Because the Rebellion will have to go somewhere, when this is done," Angella said with a shrug. " They cannot squat on Plumerian land forever. That will simply lead to endless conflict. But much of the Horde, according to our intelligence, lies empty due to Hordak's no-children policy; the land can be filled. While the Rebellion cannot fill all that land- I imagine whatever is left of the Horde will regroup in those areas- they can at least protect the Garnet. They are skilled and supplied enough, and the years of war have taught them how to manage land. Between all of that, they are simply the best candidate."

" And the fact you control Netossa and Spinnerella helps, I'm sure," Frosta said, but Angella just sighed.

" I wish I did," she admitted. " But Netossa... Netossa has never truly forgiven me my failures after Micah's death. And Spinnerella

will do whatever her wife asks. I *do* trust Netossa, she is a good woman; but I do not control her.”

“ Or you do, and you're lying to me,” Frosta muttered quietly.

...Snowsfolk liked hard truths. Maybe Angella could give her one, right now.

And so she said, “ True.”

Frosta quirked an eyebrow.

“ ...Huh,” she said. “ Didn't think you'd agree.”

“ The truth is,” Angella responded, “ I might well be lying to you. About all of this. Just like you may be planning something I can't figure out. Neither you nor me will truly know until the moment of truth. Words are easy, actions are revealing; it has always been that way.”

“ ...That's... depressing,” Frosta said after a minute. Angella nodded.

“ It is,” she said. “ But... that is life. I may be lying to you. I may also be telling the truth. You must decide what you think, based

on what you know.”

That seemed to strike a chord, and the Snows girl was silent for a long, long minute.

“...Goddamn,” Frosta said finally, then sighed as she got up. “ Ok. Let's get to this fucking meeting. Feels like it took forever to arrive.”

“ It always does,” Angella said as she herself rose. “ Then it goes by too quick. Always.”

“ That fucking sucks,” Frosta said wisely as they left the office.

****

Perfuma stood on top of a tall tree, and looked down over the encampments of her people as they prepared for war. Concoctions and smithing and work and training, all around her; her anxious eyes flickered to each spot in turn, her hands wringing each other fiercely. So many things could go wrong... and all of it would be her fault. She was the Princess, after all, leader of Plumeria; it was...

It was all on her head.

But everyone had their tasks and she had nothing to do except worry, so that's what she did. She worried, and prayed, and hoped. She worried that they didn't have enough equipment, hoped they had enough training, and prayed that what they had was...

Well, *enough.*

Entrapta's trade had helped with that; she'd given Perfuma a hell of a deal for those supplies, and the material was already turning into weapons of war. It was a hell of a gift the Drylborn had handed them, and Perfuma deeply appreciated it.

(And thinking back on the hug- that had been nice. To offer assistance, to *help* someone, the way Perfuma wanted to- to help without harm, or violence. It was nice.)

Yes, the Wild Princess had helped immeasurably... but Perfuma couldn't help but feel that the *Plumerian* Princess had failed them. The last Princess, she had done what a Plumerian Princess *should* do; she had marched out to fight the enemy alone. Princesses had been Plumeria's military for generations now, using their strength to protect their people's peace...

And it backfired, and now we're at war again, she thought, sighing as she wrung her hands. *Or... or did I fail them, fail them so badly that they had to learn to fight again? If I was a braver, better Princess, would they...*

But she could not keep thinking that way. Her people were still learning, still upgrading their weaponry, making ready for war, as they had been from the first moment that Catra had appeared unto them and demanded they stand up and *fight.*

And the worst thing is... I love fighting, Perfuma thought quietly, admitting that thing to herself she did not like knowing. It felt... too much like a Glory Lily, too much like the old sins of her people, to admit that some part of her just really wanted to hit people with flowers, to put it as she had to Catra in those first moments, when lashing out against her people's tormentors had set her blood to pumping. It had been...

It had been glorious.

(*glorious lily* , some part of her whispered, and she shivered.)

She owed Catra for showing her that- it was one of many things she'd learned at the She-Ra's side, fighting and admiration for cacti and all kinds of things- even if it unsettled her. The All knew that understanding oneself was the first step to happiness, and not... wanting... to be bloodthirsty did not change the fact that she *was* hungry for battle. Even fighting against it... some part of her liked it.

But the greater part revolted, and that was why... she felt so worthless.

Because she just *couldn't* be the hero Plumeria needed, the great warrior Princess the times demanded... or maybe she could, if

she'd just stop holding back... but who would she be, on the other side of that? A new Glory Lily? Would history recall her the way it did Kaname, would it take a Kyoko to take down her successor and restore honor to Plumeria? Would she be another on the list of those whom Angella had slain?

Maybe an overblown fear... but Perfuma had not liked it when she realized how much she liked fighting.

(She'd liked it less when she realized that she could recreate bitterlye; it wasn't even that complicated, she'd found the formula by accident. Like it was just there, waiting for her... or maybe it was because she'd been thinking about it, and her powers had simply leaned in that way. Was the fault in her?)

She hoped her people could defend themselves... even as she knew that she, most worthless of Princesses, could barely do it for them.

...She was spiraling. She needed... there were herbs, tea, meditation. She was letting her nerves get the best of her. She wasn't usually this down on herself.

She'd go smoke. She had a new mix of some Ghost Blossoms that she was pretty fond of; it'd get her mood up. Then some meditation- she was basically superfluous to the nation's running at the moment, she could take a personal day.

And as she was thinking that thought, some great bat-winged device flew overhead, and a light fell on her.

“ Target identified: Perfuma. Beginning descent.”

The machine flew down to her level, and Perfuma reached out unconsciously to the plants around her, ready to fight- but then a panel opened on the aircraft, and out popped...

“ Imp?” Perfuma said, and the little clone grinned at her. Perfuma had only seen it a few times, but Entrapta had written of the malformed clone often in her letters, in the same tones some took when talking of their children- or a dog, it was kinda both. “ What are you doing here?”

Imp opened its- *his? What were the proper pronouns?* - mouth, but the voice that emerged was...

“ Greetings, Perfuma. This is Entrapta; I want to see you, if you're okay with that. This aircraft will take you to my Doom Balloon in a few hours, where we can meet. It will also take you back in a matter of hours, so you won't have to spend much time. You don't have to come; if you don't, tell Imp, and he will leave. But... I'd like to see you.”

Imp closed his mouth, and waited for her answer.

Go to Entrapta... an odd offer. But... after the moment in her garden...

Well, Perfuma might not know how to be the warrior Plumeria needed, but she apparently knew how to be the friend Entrapta needed, and if she wasn't going to do her people any good up in this tree...

" I can visit," she said. " For a little while."

Imp smiled and beckoned her to the device's single seat, and within a moment, they were blasting off towards the northeast.

(Which was a *terrifying* experience, but at least one that couldn't possibly be Perfuma's fault, so it helped settle her nerves... once she was done jumping out of her skin.)

****

I know you don't interfere with the world, Frosta prayed to her God, *but if you want to make an exception, I won't argue.*

No answer, of course. The Distant God did not interfere in the world. It had made all things, and wanted sentient life to observe, to see it, to make judgment for itself...

So why does the Church intervene so much? some quiet part of Frosta thought, and she had no answer to that.

(And though she was no theologian- not yet- that would be the thought she would return to, time and time again- that the Church did not act much like the God they claimed to serve, the first and strongest cry of every rebel in every theocracy on every world.)

Down the hall. To the big table, the big conference, and... holy shit, there was *everybody* here. Her advisors were there, Bron and Chilla glaring while Modulok simply narrowed his eyes at her entering with the Brightmoon delegation; she wanted to shrink back, or apologize. Her handlers didn't look at her like that unless she was going to be scolded soon...

Think about that later, Frosta thought. She felt like an iceberg adrift, cut off from her fellows and about to sink some poor ship; she didn't know *what* she was doing.

(Words in her mind, floating about: *You must decide what you think, based on what you know.* Something there that she couldn't parse just yet, something about those words and who said them...)

But now wasn't the time to think; she went to her spot, observing newcomers. Some other cat person like Catra, which surprised Catra and Angella both; Netossa and Spinnerella, of course, but they were accompanied by a fucking *army* , seriously, it looked like half the Great Rebellion was attending in person. There was even a Selkie- one that Bron was glaring at fiercely.

(At least, until Modulok tapped him, and he turned his gaze elsewhere. What the fuck was up with this red priest?)

Mermista was here with her boyfriend and a guy who looked like her boyfriend but older- kinda dashing, actually, Sea Hawk was gonna age like fine wine if that was what he looked like when he was older- but no Perfuma, no Entrapta... and no Glimmer, sadly.

I'd love to catch up with her, Frosta thought... and then, semi-unwillingly, *and also look at her arms, she got some muscles on her.*

Goddammit, that wasn't something to think about, so Frosta fought it down.

Once everyone was seated, General Juliet went outside to guard the room, shutting the door as she went- and it was time to start.

" I call this meeting to order," Queen Angella said. Next to her was Catra, and next to her was Bow, who looked as though he had recently been killed and the resurrection hadn't went well; dude looked exhausted. " While I know we have the matter before us of what to do about the resurgence of the Horde under Lord Adora, there are other matters to discuss-"

" No."

Angella paused and looked towards the speaker, as did everyone else; a Minotaur, huge and half-cybernetic, looming from where

she stood with the Rebels.

" There is only one matter," she said, her voice bare and blank. " The only matter that has ever been. The killing of the Horde."

She said it the way she might talk about the weather, and an involuntary shiver ran down Frosta's back. Chilla, too, seemed a bit off-put, though Bron and Modulok weren't bothered much. The room was quiet for a moment before Angella spoke again.

" While I understand that concern, Krystala, there is an even more pressing matter..."

" Queen Angella," said a new voice- this one coming from a man standing next to someone in red plate armor. He was an elderly looking man, quite distinguished; he rose up quietly, his voice warm and alive. " You know that we of Phlax have nothing but the deepest respect for you; but we also know that you, too, are not unbiased in this place. While we understand the familial loyalty that drives you to defend your daughter's desires... my people are *burning,* Queen Angella."

He threw a few square things onto the table, things that revealed themselves as pictures when Frosta got a clear look at them- photographs, Frosta had heard them called. From a camera, which was First Ones' tech, used in southern hands instead of buried as they should be- but that didn't stop her from leaning over to look.

The pictures were... of war, of homes burning, of burn wounds on soldiers, of people cooked alive. Frosta could not help the well of revulsion inside her; fire was a good thing in the Snows, mostly, a thing people needed to stay alive. The idea of fire *killing* ... it just felt... wrong. Perverse, somehow.

Wanting to look elsewhere, she studied the room- eyes falling most on Catra, who looked at the photos with restrained horror, clearly wishing they were anything else, just as clearly unable to look away.

" My people need the Horde to stop," the man continued, and his tone was not unkindly, even as stern as his words were. " Whatever else is there, whatever else needs discussing- we must do this first. Phlax *burns,* your Highness. The Horde *must* be stopped. These are from my clinic, and from the frontlines; too many are dying. We must cut the head off the serpent."

" I know, Dr. Blankfort," Angella said. " And my proposal is to take that head- but to take it alive. Adora is the last First One on Etheria. Ignoring all other considerations, I do not wish to be responsible for the final extinction of a people..."

" She is a First One, truly?" the doctor asked.

" Yes," Bow said. " Me, Catra, and Glimmer confirmed it ourselves."

Catra simply nodded her head, unable to stop looking at the evidence of her former lover's actions.

Maybe the harm is finally coming home, Frosta thought. *Though you'd think she'd figure it out after Adora kept trying to kill her.*

" ...Even with that," the good doctor said, frowning, " I cannot help but feel as though the harm she is doing outweighs any harm *we* might do."

" If she is taken alive, she cannot lead the Horde," Angella protested. " And we are not obeying proper meeting decorum-"

" We are not," said the red plate armored person next to Dr. Blankfort. " But, Queen Angella- from one immortal to another. The hurt Adora causes is enough that she must be slain. I would always prefer to take a target in alive, it is a path of honor; but alive... I fear what she will be capable of, if she is already so dangerous. First Ones supposedly could live long lives; what will she be, in a decade? In two? This may be our only chance to strike her down, before she becomes a problem Etheria cannot survive."

" ...Immortal?" Angella asked, looking at the Knight, and they nodded.

" Yes," they said. " We will discuss it more in private."

“ ...You all owe me a debt,” Catra said, her first words in the meeting. “ You know that.”

“ We do,” Netossa said, also her first words in the meeting. “ You single-handedly changed the course of the War, and I'll owe you all my life for that.”

“ Then pay me back,” Catra said, and she didn't sound much like the Catra Frosta had come to know over the course of the War. She sounded... small. “ Help me save her, from herself, from this... thing she's become. Let me capture her, and take her here, where she can do no more harm.”

“ Do you have any idea how hard that will be?” Netossa asked. “ What you are proposing- killing is simple. Easy. Capture... you may well get many of us killed trying. And for all I owe you... I owe my own people more. I *must* push for her assassination, not her capture.”

That almost sounded like an apology, Frosta mused.

That was what set off a bit of a spiral. Arguments flew back and forth, Frosta unable to keep track of them all; the catwoman who wasn't Catra was trying to speak, but she got interrupted by the pirate guy, and then the dude who Frosta thought *might* be Peekablue from a discussion she'd had with Chilla yesterday was speaking up, and the whole meeting was collapsing so fast that it was a wonder anybody could be heard at all. Angella was clearly

fighting her own frustration, and Catra just kept looking at the photos that lay on the table, naked proof of the horrors of war.

Frosta saw Bron, out of the corner of her eye, glance at Modulok, and Modulok nod; so she knew Bron was going to ask something before he turned to her.

" Hmm?" she whispered to him, as he leaned over to whisper to her.

" Perhaps you should propose a vote," he said, as Frosta missed whatever byplay was going on before her. " Before we get bogged down any further with these weak southerners fighting each other."

A vote...

... *The* vote.

Frosta still didn't know what she wanted out of that vote.

But she had always obeyed, and so, before she was entirely willing to commit to it, she spoke up.

" Let's cut through the crap and just vote on it," Frosta said, taking charge by cracking her powers above her head to silence the room.

" I second the motion for a vote," Netossa said, and Angella sighed.

I don't know what I'm doing, Frosta thought, and then she prayed.

Please, let me know the right way.

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Rigolo took a long drain of his carbonated soda- a lovely grape concoction he was fond of- as he sat at the controls of the arrow cannon, while his fellow guard and weapon loader, Allep Satsac, continued to complain about her love life.

" And he hasn't come back!" she finished, with a tone indicating that no disaster in history had ever been as bad as this. " No letter, no visit, no nothing!"

Rigolo, who had been a happily married man to his lovely husband for long enough that he only vaguely remembered dating, tried to think of something to say to his younger comrade. He had time; she was too busy feeling sorry for herself to say

anything more, and while Rigolo was in charge of Brightmoon's air defenses, everyone had already arrived for the great meeting down below. No one was on the schedule to arrive today, and there had been fairly clear skies most of the day.

There *was* a large flying object he'd spotted with both eyes and sensors a minute ago, from the east, that *seemed* to be heading for the Castle... but Rigolo had been a trooper since the days of King Micah. He knew well that your eyes could lie to you at the gigantic distances of the sky. Between the curvature of the planet, the difficulty of visually distinguishing an object's true speed and direction in the sky without other reference points, and various other factors, that approaching object could actually be heading somewhere else entirely. Brightmoon Castle *did* sit on a fairly good flightpath to some of Phlax if you were coming from, say, Mystacor, which saw more air traffic than anywhere else for obvious reasons; there wasn't much headwind pushing east over the Castle, so it wasn't uncommon to see flights coming from that direction heading west.

(Still, he kept an eye on the approaching blimp. He *was* a vet, after all; one of the few left, after so many deserted to form the bulk of the Great Rebellion.)

“ Allep,” Rigolo finally said, “ did you ever think... that maybe you put a bit too much on that first date? You only had one date. Right?”

“ But we *connected!* ” Allep said. “ That means something!”

Rigolo wasn't sure it did. Allep had “connected” before. With everyone she dated, according to her.

So instead of responding, Rigolo took another sip of his drink, which let Allep draw a breath to keep complaining.

(Rigolo wasn't entirely sure that General Juliet hadn't made Allep his partner on the arrow cannon as a joke. She'd claimed it was so the rookie could learn from the veteran, but he'd *swear* he saw a gleam of amusement in her eyes as she assigned the dry, stoic old soldier his... *exuberantly* youthful understudy.)

" Maybe... maybe I should write a letter?" she said, the redhead worrying her lip. " What if he thinks I should? I *am* the soldier in our relationship, he's a baker..."

" Oh, then you definitely want to get a hold of him," Rigolo said, with the wisdom of age. " Good cooking is hard to find."

His husband was an amazing cook, and Rigolo- who was approaching his forty-fifth year of life- had come to agree with the old adage: beauty faded, but the cooking only got better. It was why he'd gained a good fifty pounds in his marriage, and why his brother's kids were always coming over to his house, even with them being near-grown themselves now.

Speaking of, he reminded himself, *I still need to buy my niece that blue tuxedo I saw.*

She loved fashion, and tuxedos were in fashion these days- odd as that was. He remembered when he was young, it was dresses

for everyone; he'd been rather fetching in ruffles, if he did say so himself.

" That's true!" she said. " It's important for me, I can't cook for shit!"

Rigolo nodded, remembering certain... incidents. Like the time she'd tried boiling water for tea on a stovetop, a thing many did every day... and somehow managed to knock the teapot, very full with boiling water, onto the floor, shattering it like a grenade and burning the hell out of herself. She'd had to go to the infirmary!

" You will die if you don't marry someone who can cook," he said, giving her his honest opinion.

" Oh, I don't want to die," she said, " that'd be awful!"

The veteran was about to continue when his arrow cannon's comms crackled with an incoming message.

" Brightmoon Castle, this is the Doom Balloon," came a voice that was... almost familiar, past the radio static. Laughter licked at the edges of the voice, like someone was so excited they just couldn't quite contain themselves. " Please respond, over."

" This is Brightmoon Castle, Arrow Cannon One," Rigolo responded as Allep, shocked a moment, immediately made herself

ready. Rigolo approved; for all his complaints about Allep as a person, he had no complaints about her as a soldier. " We are reading you. What is your message, over?"

" Doom Balloon from Dryl wishes to land at Brightmoon Castle," the voice said, and Rigolo was getting really bothered. Who *was* that? It sounded so damn familiar...

" State authorization code," Rigolo sent back. Anyone wanting to dock had to send the right codes, first.

There was a pause before the radio crackled again.

" Rigolo? Holy shit, Rigolo! Is that you? Did Angie finally put you in charge of all of Brightmoon's air defenses? Good! I know we were talking about it when I got captured! Hahahahaha! Good old Rigolo!"

...Rigolo *knew* who that was, who this voice belonged to, but that wasn't *possible* ...

" Who are you?" Rigolo responded with all his decorum lost, as his brain coughed up images of a man dead a decade or more, now.

The laughter that met his question was bold, brash, and not a little deranged- but underneath it all, it still sounded like the man he'd once served.

****

It was time; the vote.

This would take only moments, but it would determine so much...

So this is the burden of rule, Frosta thought, realizing that her hands wanted to shake. An odd feeling, for a girl who could not feel cold; almost novel. Her hands hadn't shaken in... ever. *No wonder the Salineans delegate all their decisions to the rule of the mob; making one person responsible... there's a cruelty to it.*

She glanced at Mermista, who would be forced to abstain. Not her choice. Mermista had the ultimate excuse for any decision she made, it wasn't hers; and while the Snows mocked Salineas as bowing down to the will of the powerless, Frosta could suddenly see the attraction. Mermista bore none of what happened today as her *own* ; she might regret what was going to happen, but it wasn't her *fault.* That lay with the government, who themselves depended on those who had elected them. A system where the nation, not the individual, was at fault.

Yeah, Frosta could see the attraction, in this moment, when she considered how much her *own* decisions might matter today.

No wonder I always let my "handlers" decide; this is...

This is awful.

Still, nothing for it; the young teenager simply steeled her spine as Angella called for the vote, missing the opening words as she pondered all the possibilities before her.

*Do as they say, not my fault, right? Or... maybe my fault, most of all, because I **know** that there is a trick there, but I **don't** know if Angella is tricking me.*

Angella nodded towards Mermista first; as part of their generally good relations, Angella had traditionally called on Salineas to vote first. Mermista's face did not display any delight at this honor, but only a deep, sad frown.

" I vote... to abstain," Mermista said sadly. Her lover patted her on the back. " Those are the wishes of my people."

She obeys because that is what her people do. But a Snowsfolk is meant to be... more. Brave. Unrelenting. Durable. Tough. Smart. Obeying my handlers is... it is none of those things. It is easy. Cowardly.

" I call upon the Crownless representatives," Angella said next; something the Snows mocked her for, that after acknowledging Salineas first, she would always turn to the Crownless next. All up the Crownless' ass, that was what the Snows' nobility sneered; listening to the weak, and helpless.

But... isn't that strength? They endure without benefit of a Runestone. They have no Princess. But the Crownless are still here... Doesn't that make them stronger than we are?

Her hands were shaking.

I... I'm scared. I don't... I don't want to think these thoughts. I want to go back to just... obeying.

That would be easier.

It would be so much easier.

It was what they wanted, what they expected- and maybe she'd be risking her life, too, though that felt more distant than the other things. She risked her life all the time, after all, in pitched battle, and always lived; and the threats had always been... more *hinted* at then stated, even if she still knew they were there.

But this... this felt... bigger. Like she was not risking her life, but risking being *wrong,* because these were two very different paths,

and if one was right, the other was wrong; not everything was like that, most of the world wasn't such a dichotomy, but...

Well, the Church always said that to everything, there was a season.

But why me, and why now?

" As the only Crownless representatives able to make it, we put our joint vote for her assassination," Dr. Blankfort said.

The Red Knight nodded their head in agreement.

" I humbly apologize, Queen Angella, Dame Catra, but it is too dangerous to take her alive," the Knight followed, tones of regret and respect in their voice. " The Horde will stop at nothing to recover her. We are better off taking her out; a rogue First One is an idea too terrifying to consider. She has already been able to contest the She-Ra, a feat that should be impossible; I hesitate to think of what she will grow to become if she is not dealt with now."

" The Wild Princesses of the Great Rebellion vote next," Angella said; that was the order decided on when they reformed, Angella's way of showing her support for the Rebels and also slighting the Snows (and to a lesser extent, Plumeria, who had often competed historically with Brightmoon in trade and, before then, in war.)

But she had no joy of it now, knowing how they would vote.

" For the same reasons as the Red Knight stated, I vote that we kill her," Netossa said.

" I vote that we kill her, too," Spinnerella said.

" Lord Peekablue, as there is no procedure for your place in the vote, I will ask you to vote at this time, as you arrived with the Rebel delegation," Angella said.

Probably wanting to rip the bandage off, Frosta thought. *We know how he's going to vote- how everyone's gonna vote. I'll be the only one to break away from it...*

" I vote..." Peekablue began, before a small little smile grew on his face. " To take her alive."

Netossa and Spinnerella whirled on him as Catra's eyes and ears perked up, and even Angella could not entirely hide the widening of her eyes in surprise.

Okay, Frosta thought, *looks like I'm not the only one thinking of going off-script.*

Weirdly, that made her feel better, even if she didn't even know the guy.

" What can I say?" Peekablue said with a shrug. " I don't much like being threatened."

The Cove pirates next to him laughed as Netossa blanched awkwardly and Spinnerella... didn't react openly, beyond surprise, but Frosta, sensitive to changes in temperature, felt the air in the room... circle. Just a bit, like the warning before a storm.

Maybe Netossa isn't the dangerous one, between them, Frosta remarked idly in her own head as the big pirate next to Peekablue clapped him on the back, a blow that nearly sent the slim man spiraling.

" Balls on a Seaworthy dog! I'll be drowned, never thought I'd see the day!" Scurvy laughed, the catwoman next to him chuckling too- the first noise Frosta had heard her make. " Hey, if you can't stay in Seaworthy, maybe you can rebuild in the Cove!"

" Nameless gods forbid," Peekablue snickered with a grin. " But then again, I didn't expect to be complimented by a Cove pirate, so who knows. I might have to take you up on that."

Netossa bit back her clear first response, in favor of saying nothing; Spinnerella put a hand on her wife, and that cool sensation of aerial movement flared up again, that hint of windborne threat.

Nobody else seemed to notice it, except maybe Angella, who looked a little discomfited for a second- but then again, no one else was as tied to temperature, and Angella was a winged thing, she would pay more attention than most.

Or maybe I'm imagining it, Frosta thought to herself. *I'm... kind of freaking out.*

She was, too, though Peekablue's sudden betrayal of Netossa had taken her mind off of it for the moment.

" Now, I believe that Catra should vote next, as a Wild Princess- or at least, an equivalent," Peekablue suggested, and Angella nodded.

" The She-Ra, Princess of Power, Catra, is asked to vote," Angella said, turning to the daughter that sat at her right hand.

" I vote we take her alive," Catra said, and for a moment, looked as if she would say more; but then she must have decided against it, and said no more.

I've never loved, I can't imagine if they were going to kill someone I loved... imagining even Glimmer dying hurts and I'm just crushing on her...

" I vote next," Queen Angella said. " I vote to take her alive."

Three and three, Frosta thought. *Tied. Which means I'm...*

" By tradition, Plumeria would vote next, but Perfuma could not make this meeting," Angella said. " So..."

Oh no

Angella turned to Frosta.

" The vote belongs to the Snows," she said, and her words were formal... but her eyes held a quiet hope in them that almost hurt to look at.

Stalemate until I vote, Frosta thought, in that last moment. *Three and three. Kill, or spare. Death, or Life...*

The whole room turned to her, and it was suffocating, the pressure of all that *expectation.* All her life, as far back as she could remember, the room was looking at her; she barely

remembered a mother and father, in vague dreams of long-ago days that meant nothing to her, not now.

No, she recalled... priests, and soldiers, and nobles, and handlers. All of whom looked at her with *expectation.* Just like now, with Bron and Chilla and Modulok sitting near her, their sureness an almost physical force as they glanced at her. They knew what she'd say, knew that they'd won, because even thought it was *Frosta's* vote, they were the ones who told her what to do.

It was...

Expected.

But unexpected had been this: *You must decide what you think, based on what you know.* Her own people wanted her to obey... but the words of the Queen of a foreign land encouraged her to think for herself...

Maybe Angella was trying to control her. Maybe it was all a trick. Maybe she was being a fool.

Maybe Angella was a liar.

But.

But.

But.

But maybe *not.*

Frosta had no certainty here, save one: Angella *might* be trying to control her... but her "advisors" were *definitely* trying to control her.

That... that was a thing she *knew* .

And realizing that, it was suddenly... easy, to decide what to think, she was filled with cold, hard determination in that moment.

Because based on what she knew, she decided to think *this:*

" I vote to take her alive," Frosta said.

For a single moment, the whole world froze before Frosta as everyone processed what she just said. In that momentary tableau, she saw and felt everything, just for a second: Catra and Netossa, both surprised twice in one meeting, Catra's smile rising as Netossa's face fell. A thin whirl in the air, more of Spinnerella's unspoken threats, unknown to all in the room but Frosta and

maybe the Queen; Peekablue's smug smile as he realized what had just happened. Orwall's confused relief, the cat still not sure what was the right path. Angella's smile a softy and happy little thing that almost looks like a sigh; Bow's tired grin of approval. Mermista's glad surprise- and her words came back to Frosta, it had been Mermista who suggested first that Frosta might be being tricked, and she will owe the Salinean the rest of her life, for putting that idea in her head, for inspiring her to talk to Angella at all.

Last and best of all- the most gloriously spicy pepper on her tongue- were her advisors, shocked and surprised and- if she did not miss her guess- *scared*, for they had lost control of the situation.

No, Frosta thought, with something like the glee of the north wind as it roared down from the poles. *The situation was **never** under your control; you just thought it was. But now...*

Now I'm...

I'm free.

Something like joy sparkled inside her, like sunlight gleaming through ice.

(She wasn't entirely aware of the grin that grew on her face, brave and audacious; but she saw the shiver that went through Bron and Chilla, and the smaller one that went- for the briefest of instants- through Modulok.)

“ M-my Princess, did you not mean-” Brok began to say, stuttering on his words, the eloquent politician thrown off completely.

“ I- I'm sure the Princess meant her assassination-” Chilla started at the same time, stuttering too.

Teeth chattering from the cold? Frosta thought gleefully, even as she wanted to snort at the ridiculousness of it all. Of *course* it's the two of them talking; they're both Modulok's chosen mouthpieces, talking for him. *Just like he wanted **me** to be.*

(Idiot; a priest should know that the cold always wins in the end.)

“ I know what I meant,” Frosta said. “ And I said it. We are to take Adora alive. No execution, no assassination- my vote breaks the tie, doesn't it? Adora, alive. That is the course the Alliance has voted on.”

“ Yes!” Catra cheered, unable to stop herself, and Frosta thought she caught the thinnest glint of something wet in the corner of the warrior woman's eyes before a blink dismissed it. “ Yes!”

“ Oh thank fuck,” Mermista said, deflating in her seat as Sea Hawk leapt up with a laugh.

“ Excellent!” he cheered.

" Hear hear!" his father said, rising up to high-five him.

Netossa stared at her in surprise... before bowing her head.

" Then that is what we shall do," she said, and Frosta had to give her credit; she rose up with the full of her dignity. Most people took a loss harder than that- and Spinnerella was *clearly* doing so, her jaw set under her chubby cheeks- but Netossa was handling her disappointment with great grace. " You have my word that she will be taken alive- though when this backfires, I want everyone to know I voted against it."

Catra responded with something, but Frosta didn't pay much attention to the byplay before her, because her advisors had stopped looking at her. They were looking at Modulok, who was leaning forward with an angry look in his eyes.

Finally deign to talk to me yourself, you smug prick? Frosta thought, as he opened his mouth to whisper to her.

" Are you sure this is wise, Frosta?" he asked, the threat in his voice so obvious that the deaf could hear it.

And all that did was not make Frosta doubt herself, but get even *more* certain. Whatever was or was not... she did not want to serve this man, and his petty cruelty, that thought it could

threaten his supposed leader. Priests were meant to advise, not command.

Our God did not make us so that we could obey his Church, Frosta thought. *The Church was made to teach us of God, not to* ***replace*** *him. Hell, our God isn't bothering us like this, why does his Church get to?*

" Are you?" Frosta asked back.

Modulok paused, considering her words; and Frosta got the unusual sense that he was actually *looking* at her, for the first time in a long time, maybe ever. She did not turn from that gaze, either, but stared him in the eye; - before he got up and simply left. Bron and Chilla stared after him, and glanced at each other before Bron finally rose up and left; Chilla made a move to stand up, but then, after a long moment, sat back down next to Frosta.

Frosta didn't know why- maybe just sticking around to report back to Modulok anything she did- and she didn't care much.

(Though a part of her did- very briefly- entertain the idea that maybe Chilla was picking *Frosta* , instead of Modulok; a fantasy, surely, but it would be... nice... to have family she could trust, thin and tenuous as the connection was...)

There was more talking, but only for a moment, because soon the doors on the far side of the room popped open.

“ My Queen!” said General Juliet, who looked... poleaxed, actually, Frosta had never seen someone who looked as surprised as the usually no-nonsense woman now did. “ My... holy shit, my Queen!”

“ What?” Angella said, wings flaring slightly in surprise. Frosta's own eyebrows shot up; what in the world made *Juliet* freak out? She'd only met her a handful of times, but she'd impressed her as having an almost Snowsfolk seriousness to her!

“ General Juliet, is there trouble?” Catra asked, leaping up, ever-ready to defend Brightmoon... but then laughter came in through the door.

“ Nah, not trouble!” said a voice Frosta knew well- a voice that came in on... wings?

Glimmer, Princess of Brightmoon and coolest person Frosta had ever met (and maybe her crush *shut up brain*), flew into the room on gorgeous *black wings* , big as her mother's, flapping in before teleporting into a standing position next to the door.

“ Oh my God, that hurts my back muscles like a motherfucker!” Glimmer announced cheerfully as she landed. “ Mom, you never told me how much that tugs on the spine! Gonna have to work on that. Also I have fallen every time I landed if I didn't teleport. More to work on!”

“ Glimmer, you... wings?!?” Bow declared.

“ Yes!” Glimmer said, laughing as Bow boggled.

Catra, meanwhile, sputtered next to him.

“ Sis, when the- how the hell do you- *wings?!?* ” the She-Ra kind of asked, though honestly it was more an exclamation than anything else. Frosta snorted a laugh at the former Hordeswoman's goofy expression.

“ Ah, I love hearing that,” Glimmer boasted, chuckling as she flexed her biceps and flared her wings out dramatically.

There was a bustle at the door- someone was gasping in surprise at something- but Frosta paid it no attention, too busy looking at Glimmer's arms.

(*oh my God that is so cool oh no she's so hot*)

Somebody else came in, Frosta didn't see who, but then Scorpia walked in.

“ Hey everybody! Glimmer told me that a spy wore my face? I'm sorry for anything they did!” the big Scorpioni said. “ I'm super sorry about that. It wasn't me?”

“ You found Scorpia!” Catra said. “ How?!?”

“ Not just her!” said Castaspella as she marched in, grinning as she stepped to the side of the door and indicated it with both arms in dramatic showman's style.

And through the door... stepped some guy Frosta didn't recognize. He looked a bit like Glimmer- more a general sense of short stockiness than anything specific- and he had a cool wizard's staff with him, but Frosta didn't really know who he was. Tears brimmed in his eyes and flowed quietly down his face.

Frosta didn't recognize him, but a lot of other people sure did; there was a *wave* of gasps and shock all over, mostly from the older people in the room- though it was one of the youngest, Catra, who finally said the man's name out loud.

“ Is that... Micah?” Catra asked.

Who is Micah? Frosta wondered. *I feel like I've heard that name but can't place where. Something about Glimmer?*

“ Yes!” Micah said, and the tears in the man's eyes ran down his face. “ It's me, Micah!”

He turned to Queen Angella, who was staring at him like he was a ghost.

" Hi, Angie!" the man sobbed. " I'm... I'm home!"

Frosta looked to Angella to see how she would react- and thus, got a great view of the immortal Queen of Brightmoon, angelic elemental, and declared demon of the Church of the Distant God, slumping to the ground in a dead faint, her wings falling with the sound of collapsing fabric.

" Oh no!" Scorpia said from the front. " We killed her!"

Chapter End Notes

Angella's not dead, obviously, just passed out.

Thus, we conclude the too-long-in-coming Last War Council.

Thank you all for sticking with me so far.

Ghost Blossoms are from the UK Pop magazines, where they're healing herbs that grow on volcanoes.

Here, Ghost Blossoms are actually not native to Plumeria; they actually come from the Flame Kingdom. A few of the seeds were saved from the fires by the then-current Plumerian Princess, and she modified them to grow in the more southern region. They have their name because they are some of the last of their kind- living ghosts, of a sort.

Ghost Blossoms were used by the people of the Flame Kingdom the same way that Plumerians use them in modern times: smoking them produces a powerful calming effect

without tipping over into an outright sedative, and actually does have some mild rejuvenative effects. It's like marijuana, except it burns calories like a motherfucker (since it stimulates healing)- so yeah, it also makes you hungry. It's the most common thing Perfuma smokes and is legitimately good at handling nerves, and directly contributes to her thinness- she actually eats a fairly regular amount of food and doesn't really exercise, but she's burning calories constantly due to the Ghost Flowers.

Ghost Blossoms are Perfuma's favorite smoke, though she uses a lot of drugs, to be frank. Honestly her heart would probably have burst in her chest by now if she didn't, her anxiety's a hell of a thing.

Rigolo is from the cartoon; Allep Satsac is from the Golden POP books. Rigolo is mentioned as an ally of the Great Rebellion but has little other info, so most of him is wholesale made-up by me. What IS consistent is that in the show, he sent info to the Rebellion- that's why he's in charge of the air defenses and comms at Brightmoon Castle here.

Allep Satsac is a MUCH weirder thing. Her name, as you might have noticed, is a reverse of Castaspella's. In the original Golden POP books, she was Castaspella's evil cousin who had deliberately named herself in reverse, and was basically an evil wizard.

Here, Allep Satsac changed her name to be a reverse of Castaspella's as a dedication to Queen Angella; while the average Brightmoon citizen isn't aware of it, anybody who works at the Castle long enough learns that, for the most part, Angella doesn't much like her sister-in-law, and the feeling is mutual. Making your name a reverse of someone else's is a way of establishing yourself as their opposite and enemy, i.e. it's an insult to your target. This is a fairly new meme that is localized almost entirely to Brightmoon; in time, it might grow into a bigger cultural concept, or it might die out entirely as a fad. Allep is one of the youngest soldiers at

the castle, and thus obviously subject to youthful trends. She split the name in two because she found it unwieldy to be called that all the time, though both are technically her full first name.

Chapter 47: A Husband and Wife in Brightmoon

Chapter Notes

Angella, and Micah, and reunions.

This takes place about an hour after the last chapter; Angella fainted HARD.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A Husband and Wife in Brightmoon

Queen Angella woke up, feeling... odd. And confused, which was a rare feeling in her long life. Her perfect recall meant that, short of a few concussions and/or extended bouts of drinking, she had very, *very* rarely had mornings where she didn't know exactly where she was and what she'd been doing before bed.

But now... she couldn't recall anything, not at the moment. Her head felt fuzzy; overfull.

She rose up slowly from her position laying face-down on the bed- her own bed, she quickly realized, looking at the pillows. She always slept on her stomach, due to her wings; had she simply fallen asleep last night?

But, no; she saw light streaming in from the window, and it wasn't morning light. What was going on?

She shook her head, and it must have rattled something loose; bits began to come through. The meeting with Frosta, where she'd sat in her chair; the War Council itself. An unexpected victory there...

And then... an image of Glimmer with black wings, and Scorpia of all people, Entrapta coming in too, Castaspella making a big show of whoever came through the door next, but it was like her brain just *wouldn't* process whatever happened next...

" Angie?"

That voice.

She understood, in the brief second she had before clarity hit, just why her brain had been so befuddled; what had happened was so impossible that she simply *couldn't believe it.*

But here it was, a miracle that had not happened once, but twice; because *she knew that voice.* She had longed for that voice for too long not to know it by heart.

" Micah!"

The Queen of Brightmoon shot up from a half-raised position to a standing one, wings flaring out, not only sending the drapes into a tizzy as she flapped the air in the room about, but also rocking the short, muscular man sitting next to the bed backwards on his chair.

" Whoa, hey!" he said as he took control of the chair, smiling- and it- it *couldn't* be...

But it had to be.

Micah. Just... sitting there.

" Micah?" Angella asked- or tried to. Her voice broke halfway in, could not quite complete the name. She made an abortive attempt to step to him, to hold him, to do *something* but she just couldn't, was suddenly more afraid than she had ever been in her long, cowardly existence- afraid that if she said his name out loud, if she touched him, if she did anything but stand there, he would disappear, vanish, all this be revealed as trick or illusion or cruel madness of her mind.

" Yes," Micah said, rising up from the chair and stepping forward. " It's me, Angie."

(*Of course he comes to me,* the Queen has time to think. *He was always the brave one between the two of us.*)

“ It's *me,* Angie,” he said, as he reached her. His face frowned as he saw her shake, and of course it did, Micah had always known her best; he had loved her so much, so *much,* he saw her shake and held his hands out. “ Angella, can I-?”

And somewhere down in her guts, Angella found the strength to be brave, just this once, and flung herself into his arms.

The feel of him in her arms was nostalgia at its best, the encircling of her body with his arms was sweetest familiarity; her Micah her Micah *her Micah was here* , she knew these motions, this body up against hers, Micah Micah *Micah* .

“ You're alive, you can't be alive but you're *here,* ” A ngella tried to say, failing miserably; the words were far too heavy. Only a whisper was strong enough to carry those impossible words; and so she leaned to his ear to whisper them to him. “ You're *here.* ”

“ I am,” Micah whispered back, in her ear, his beard tickled her cheek and oh, Silver, a blessing on anyone who had been involved in this, a blessing as big as all the world. Her husband was back, her husband, whom she never thought she'd see again, her *Micah...*

She didn't even care about the how. She knew, in a vague way, that she'd care later; she'd want to know, later. But right now, she only cared that he was *here.*

She hugged him, hugged him as hard as she'd ever hugged anyone before letting a little bit loose, just enough to let her hands run over him; her hands had to touch him. They didn't believe he was back, any more than the rest of her, they had to touch him and touch him and touch him to know that he was *alive.*

But if seeing was not believing, then touch was; she reached out with her fingers to his hands, let her fingertips linger on skin her perfect memory recalled with absolute clarity, comparing the image in her mind with the flesh she could feel. It was strangely familiar and familiarly strange, all at once; they were *his* hands... but different, now. More scabs. Thinner. Leaner. Remnants of old wounds and a shiny burn that never entirely healed right and his fingernails were a bitten mess.

But, despite everything- still him. For all their hurt, they were still *his* hands.

Over the rest of him, as they held each other, as they breathed each other's breath, she ran her hands as he simply held her, as though he feared that to let go was to lose her again. She reached with her hand to his side, felt where a thrust of some wound had once pierced his side and it had healed, but not perfectly. So many marks on him, so many blemishes; he had suffered, suffered, suffered. Skin once smooth was rough, callused; he had been through so much. Her Micah was returned to her, not whole- but it was still him.

And that was what finally, finally convinced her that the impossible had been made real. She knew this man, had held this body warm and close, in intimacy and casualness both; despite everything, her flesh still knew this flesh.

It was him.

He was *alive.*

...And he had suffered so much...

" You're hurt," she whispered into the crook of his neck. " What... happened?"

Those two words didn't feel big enough to encompass everything she wanted to know, but they would have to do, she had not the brainpower to ask more.

" Beast Island," Micah said. " Hordak exiled me there; not sure why he didn't just kill me. Not that sending me to Beast Island wasn't basically an execution, anyway; of all the other people that got sent there, only Scorpia lasted longer than a month. I'm the only one who... lasted."

" Oh, my Micah," she whispered, and held him, tight as she could as something hot and ugly ran through her. He was alive, which

meant he had *been alive*, on Beast Island, and she hadn't come to save him... " If I'd known, if I'd had any *idea*-"

" I know," he said, petting her hair, easing the shame in her heart. " Don't you dare blame yourself for thinking I was dead- Glimmer told me of the situation. Everyone was told I was killed. You can't be blamed for not looking for me."

He'd known just what to say; of course he had. For all that had changed, that had stayed the same, and fresh tears poured out of Angella's eyes, to join their sisters pooling gently in Micah's hair and his shirt.

(Angella realized that she had been crying this entire time, a thing she hadn't even noticed until just this moment; too much was happening, all at once, and she wept even harder into his shoulder.)

" I'm so sorry," she said anyway, and he hushed her gently, petting her all the while.

" Not a word more of that," he said gently. " That is no fault of yours. You thought me dead. Executed. Which... in fairness that *is* how Hordak executes everyone who displeases him. Well, used to, anyway- he's dead now, right?"

" Yes," Angella said.

(Well, trapped between dimensions; but Angella knew of no tech or magic that could rescue someone from such a place, and so it

was death enough.)

" Thank fuck and the Silver, then," Micah said, and Angella could not help the snort that came out of her nose at that old familiar saying, something she'd grown used to him declaring in the days of their courtship.

They were silent a few moments, both thinking. Angella had too much to think to know what to say; he'd be the same. As he knew her, she knew him...

Which meant she knew what to say next. Her Micah had been offering succor to her throughout this, but that meant he wasn't taking anything for himself. That wasn't right or fair; this was an equal partnership.

So she sought to redress the imbalance.

" I want to give you what you want," Angella said to her love. " Tell me what it is."

More sweet nostalgia; this was an old phrase between them, one she'd learned to say long ago. Micah was a caretaker, had been forced to be one by his and Castaspella's orphaning; he had given up his childhood to raise his sister, and like so many who dedicated themselves to the care of others, he had no idea how to care for *himself.* Angella had seen that vicious irony too many

times over the centuries, and it had been one of their earliest hurdles, to teach Micah to- sometimes- want a thing for *himself.*

Those words were the workaround; she would tell him that what *she* wanted was to know what *he* wanted, and somehow that seemed to short-circuit whatever self-sacrificing instinct powered her beloved husband.

(She wasn't entirely aware of it, but it wasn't too different from how Micah had handled Angella's acidic self-deprecation; they were both experienced at slaying each other's inner demons.)

Her Micah waited a moment, considering, before he did something she didn't expect: he *giggled.*

" Umm," he said, " You... you're gonna find this ridiculous. *I* find it ridiculous. I can't believe this is my first thought on coming back home."

"...What is it?" Angella asked, unable to help the grin coming up on her own face. He just sounded so... *cute.*

" No, I can't," he said, still giggling; and that lightened the mood, she started to giggle too.

" Come ooooon," she teased, and this still felt so sweet that she could not stop crying; but the laughter bubbling up in both of them was lightening the mood, as the fit of giggles gripping Micah

spread to her, the two laughing like the punch-drunk fools in love that they were.

" It's so damn dumb," he said. " I swear, I didn't expect this. This was *not* what I thought I'd say. I blame you passing out."

" I... oh, Silver," she said, as she realized what she'd done at the Council. " I passed out- Micah! I fainted!"

" You did!" he said, and the giggles became full on belly laughs, the big kind that leave you stoved up and half-crippled, laughter with a crown on that demanded you give in and just *laugh.* " Scorpia thought you'd died! You passed right the fuck out in front of *everyone!*"

" I fainted," Angella said, and she laughed, too. " They are never- *I'm never going to live this down!*"

She laughed so hard she couldn't keep standing, but she couldn't let go of Micah, either; and they fell, directly onto her bed, laughing and laughing.

The laughter was Emperor over the King and Queen of Brightmoon for long, long minutes; minutes in which her tears dried, and she got a good look at Micah, finally. A look to see that he had been crying, too; a chance to notice the wet spot on her own shoulder, the wet in her own hair. When Lord Laugh finally let

his two subjects go, and they had a chance to catch their breaths, she just *looked* at him. Her Micah, alive in her bed, beautiful...

And pressing up against her was a certain part.

" ...Micah," she said, and the giggles threatened to return as she realized just *what* Micah's first instinct had been, what he wanted. " The thing you want... it wouldn't happen to involve *that*, would it?"

She brushed a wing between his legs, goosing him, feeling like a teenager again, all these long years later.

" Silver and magic, I swear," he said, and she could hear the edges of giggling in his voice, too, " that I never intended to come back here and just... get right to it. It was the furthest thing from my mind. But then we got back here, and I just..."

He leaned over, and kissed her- gently, so gently, then stronger, and more fiercely. She kissed back, hungry and needy too, because it had been *years* and her flesh missed his. It was ridiculous and stupid and not the reaction she thought she'd have at all, but her husband is alive and he is warm in her arms and against her mouth and his tongue curling around hers is something she has missed and missed and missed.

(And maybe it fits, some part of her realizes; he is alive, and what can better reflect life than the act that begins it, what could more affirm that death has not taken him than the one force that defies it?)

He kissed her, once, twice, a dozen times; she kissed him back twice as many. Their hands fumbled like virgins, excitement and disbelief ruining whatever skill they had once possessed; but that was fine. They would have time to relearn this dance.

I have him back, Angella thought, and two final tears slipped out of her eyes. *I have him back.*

" Micah," she whispered to him, in the bare space between kisses.

" I was on that island," he muttered, as he kissed down her neck, " for a *decade.*"

Then, quite deliberately, he stuck his head between her breasts.

" I have *missed* you two."

Angella burst out laughing again.

" Get out of your clothes," she told him, kissing him again. " We've time to make up for."

" Damn right we do," he said.

(And then there were no more words in the sacred privacy of their bedroom, just the desperate coupling that was proof to each other that they were *alive and together again,* physical proof of the impossible miracle they had been blessed with.)

Chapter End Notes

I'm still doing a Friday upload, no worries there; this is just a little short in-between. Like an after-dinner mint.

Chapter 48: Spinnerella of the Great Rebellion

Chapter Notes

> Here we are! Wanted one more chapter's separation before we talk of Catra, Glimmer, and all of their reactions to all this. Just to let it simmer a bit longer.
>
> Apologies for it being a day late; yesterday was kinda bad for me. But hey, at least I'm only a day late, and no dollar short!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Spinnerella of the Great Rebellion

All the Rebels had headed back to their tents in the wake of the War Council. All of them, that was, except Peekablue, who had taken the first opportunity to both not be anywhere near Netossa for the next few hours... and to cozy up next to Sweet Bee, who had been accompanying...

Micah.

(*Micah,* and Spinnerella could not believe it; she'd never been as close with the royal couple as her beloved Netossa had been, but they *had* been friends, and to see Micah alive... she couldn't believe it, even as she was glad for it. It was good that he was back.)

The other Rebels had dissipated into their groups. Netossa had walked back to their shared tent, and Spinny knew what her love was going to do. In public, Netossa's magnificent pride would not let her do less than acknowledge when she was beaten, and that with grace... but in private, she'd let her fury pass through her.

Spinny had seen her do it so often that, even though she was out under the quickly fading light of day, heading towards the dark, she could see it in her mind's eye. Netossa would go in, sit on the bed, and then- very quietly- make a small, tightly-contained little ball of her light in the palm of her hands.

Then she would try to crush it, pushing in on it with her hands while pushing out with her power, competing with herself, over and over again, straining both muscles and magic against each other. It was a self-made stress ball, an adaptation she'd figured out early on in her erstwhile leadership of the ragtag forces that had, in time, become the Great Rebellion. She'd started out destroying things when she lost, but the Rebellion's supply-strapped circumstances early on had taken the habit from her- and she did it quietly because the troops did not need to hear their officer throwing a hissy fit. They'd had breakaways over it in Netossa's youth, and Nettie had never blamed them for losing faith in a commander who would so openly throw a tantrum.

(*Though we were both so young then,* Spinny thought; but then she flew away from that idea, because to confront it would be to acknowledge that so much of her life has been spent in war, and it is not something she is entirely comfortable thinking about herself.)

Spinny left her to do it, knowing her love would need it. That was something they'd figured out, over the years- that Netossa needed

time alone after a loss, to decompress, to rage, to... to hurt. Losing *hurt* her Nettie, and she had a tendency to lash out afterwards that hurt her even worse afterwards, when she had time to calm down, and be ashamed of herself. Her one real flaw, her love of victory so much that losing was poison to her.

But Nettie had learned to control it, over the years. To squeeze the tightly-woven web of her magic, to be alone for a short time to just let herself *ache...*

To let herself be fallible, for a moment. A hard thing, for a woman who demanded so much from herself, who was so unconquerable.

I'll have to grab a handkerchief, Spinnerella thought to herself as she moved through the Rebel's gathered camp. Her Netossa would cry, inevitably, while dealing with her stress; when it was over, she'd need Spinny there to wipe away her frustrated tears of fury. It always embarrassed and shamed Netossa to cry- in the Twin Kingdoms, it was acceptable to cry for joy, but nothing else- and it would be easier on her wife's heart if Spinny wiped those tears away for her.

But right now, she had a different mission. Krystala might do something stupid; it was best to nip that in the bud. Krystala could also- quietly- spread word among the other Rebels as to what *had* to be her Nettie's plan, once she recovered from the loss at the Council.

Not that Netossa had *told* Spinnerella that it was her plan- but she didn't have to. Spinny knew her wife. It was just like lying to

Octopus Cove, or any of the other things they'd done. Same idea.

(...*Right?* Some part of her questioned, but she put it aside.)

The camp wasn't that big, and Spinnerella used little whirls of magic to make her feet just a bit quicker, so she soon caught up with the Minotaur she was chasing. Her part of the Rebel encampment was a bit eerie; Krystala had a habit of acquiring people like herself, people who were too broken to break any further, and it showed in their precise, unenthusiastic movements. These were people who had lost everything, and thus, had nothing left to lose; in a form of paradox, they were almost cheerful, in the sense that they were suffering so much that it had burned itself out. Peace, but in the form of ashes.

Spinnerella didn't focus on that, though, or on how her mouth ran a bit dry when one of Krystala's recruits glanced casually over at, and *through,* her; she focused on the Minotaur herself, who had her back to Spinnerella, and appeared to be fiddling with her gun-arm.

" Krystala!" Spinnerella called to the cybernetic monster before her; cybernetic by the cruelty of the Bloody Bull of Vargon and the Bull's Eye, monster by her own decisions afterwards. " A word, if you would."

" Spinerella," Krystala answered in her dead way, turning to face her. Her eyes, which never seemed entirely to focus on anything actually present, gazed at Spinnerella- and the desert-dweller had to suppress a shiver as she wondered just *what* Krystala was *really* looking at, what she could see only in her mind, what

dreams of chronic and sustained cruelty danced like demons in there. " What word do you desire?"

" I understand you're angry," Spinnerella told Krystala, as she quickly checked the area to make sure they were mostly alone. No one here but fellow Rebels...

" Of course," Krystala said, in her dangerously calm way. " This is a foolish course of action. Any course but killing is."

" I wouldn't be, if I were you," Spinnerella said.

" Oh?" Krystala asked, though her voice kept its empty tone, and even her raised eyebrow seemed an affectation. That was really the most disconcerting thing about the cyborg Minotaur, in Spinnerella's opinion; the sheer *lack* in her. Like talking to a void.

" Because what is said today isn't important," Spinnerella said. " The important part is getting a mission going. Netossa will agree to let Adora live here today, but once we get there..."

Spinnerella paused a moment, checking one more time to make sure they were only surrounded by Krystala's forces.

" We do what we went there for," she finished.

Yeah, it was a betrayal, a trick, but- it had to be done! This would be what Netossa would decide afterwards. The Horde *had* to be stopped. Ends justifying means, and the like.

(*Is Nettie on board with this?* Another quiet part of her said. *Isn't this different than the Cove- and* ***you*** *were the one who pushed her to lie to the Cove... are you sure about this?* But she put that aside.)

" I... oh," Krystala said. " I see."

The minotaur gave her a nod of approval, which... didn't feel the best, to be approved of by what was hands down the worst of the Rebel commanders... but Spinnerella put that aside.

(She put a lot of things aside. It gave her peace.)

" Was this Netossa's plan all along?" Krystala asked.

" Yes," Spinnerella said. " We hoped to get a free path to killing the Horde's Lord, but this works as a backup."

" I should not have doubted," Krystala said. " I assume you wish for me to spread the word- quietly- to any other possible dissenters?"

One of the reasons the greater Rebellion tolerated Krystala on the whole- though there were a *lot* of commanders who didn't truck much with her- was that she was a team player, despite

everything. Her hunger to kill as much of the Horde as she could meant she liked bigger attacks, and so she was perfectly happy to assist other Rebel warcamps if it meant they could catch bigger prey. Some of the more... *squeamish* warcamps even actively sought her out, using her to do the things they could not quite bring themselves to do... and she always obliged.

" Yes," Spinnerella said.

" Then I shall do so," Krystala said.

" Thank you," Spinnerella said. " Have a good night's rest, Krystala."

" And yourself," the great beast replied.

Spinnerella left her area of the camp, heart set on her course- and free of doubt. They'd threatened to blow up Peekablue's theater, and to leave Octopus Cove high and dry in case of a Horde attack; how was this any different? A bald-faced lie to the She-Ra, claiming to go along, so they could put the Horde down at last. Just another thing they had to do for the cause.

Spinnerella got that. She'd done what she had to before, too.

The hours after that were... in Netossa's tent. She was a *mess*, emotional from Micah's return and from losing the Council; for

once she hadn't been too ashamed of her own tears. She was frustrated, yes, but she claimed that all her weeping was from joy at Micah's return, even as incredibly *confused* as she was by his survival. How the hell was he alive? Where had he been all this time? How had Glimmer found him?

Those were some answers they'd have to get to tomorrow. Netossa doubted that Queen Angella would be in any state to inform anyone of anything until at least the next day.

(*If I know Micah,* Netossa had said, laughing a bit as Spinnerella wiped away her tears in the privacy of their tent, *him and Angella are having sex right now. Him and her always "disappeared" for a while when he came back from being away too long- and a decade's a long time.*)

The rest of the day went without interruption from the castle; the Great Rebellion simply waited. Not the best thing to do, but there had been a quiet lull in the fighting, and events of the Council had been quite dramatic- they could afford to wait a while.

Finally, it was night, and Netossa somehow managed to sleep, with her wife beside her; though Spinny couldn't rest her head, for some reason. Insomnia- and the memories- pressed close.

So she hugged her Nettie tighter, let her beloved's sturdy musculature and solid presence comfort her, burying her nose in her shoulder to suck in the sweet desert perfume that Netossa preferred, cactus-flower scents that reminded them both of home.

Maybe that was a mistake; Spinnerella fell asleep, but she dreamed only memories.

Hunger.

Hunger was her first memory and her oldest enemy, the thing she had been afraid of all her life. Once upon a time, the chubby woman had been skinny, skinny, skinny; a child more bones and skin than flesh. Hunger had stalked her through the streets, every day.

Condore's worst slum, after all, did not have that reputation for *fun.* In those years before her magic had come in... she had done what she had to do. Everyone did, when they spent every day hungry, hungry, hungry. She'd been nobody's daughter, a child dumped at an overworked, understaffed place, Brigis Orphanage; and perhaps it was all the more tragic, for it had not been a bad place. Jarine, the elderly caretaker, had lost her own home in the south, a small village lost to time even before the Horde had ever been a thought in anyone's mind; the south had its own wars before Hordak ever fell from the sky, after all, and Jarine had lost her home during one of them.

So now, the old woman, an immigrant to the Twin Kingdoms in her youth, devoted herself to caring for those who, like her, had been forgotten. A good woman, and all the people she employed good people, too... but so little was had, to do so much with. There were cold equations of mouths to feed and food to feed them with, of caloric intake and outtake, that all the good in the world could not change, and they simply did not have enough.

So Spinnerella had done what she had to do. She had treated Brigis as a safe place to sleep, and otherwise spent all her time out of it, venturing to scavenge, both to spare the orphanage some small part of their impossible burden and to find food for herself... and none of it had been pleasant. She had eaten the spilled guts of rats and drank filthy water from gutters; she had begged and stolen. She had never killed anyone... but she had found more than a few that she'd thought were dying, victims of street muggings or, sometimes, just old drunks in side alleys, those whose abuse of their bodies had finally reached the last moment, and she had not acted to save them, either. She had simply stripped them of their goods when they could not fight back, and left. It was either her, or one of the other human vultures that wandered the worst parts of the city; at least, that's what she told herself, when uncharacteristic moments of guilt flared up in her skull.

Those moments didn't come often. Too often, fear of hunger dominated, and drove her to desperation. Against the keening in her belly, no moral imperative could scream loud enough to be heard.

And with what she had, she did what she could. She bought food for herself, things ready to eat that could be shoved down her gullet; most days she didn't make enough to fill her stomach, and she had to eat it fast, or have it stolen by someone bigger.

But some days she made enough. Some days she did. Three times she made enough that she was able to eat, and had money left over; and she would give it to Jarine, because the little girl could not hold on to any money for long, not when others were hunting to take it from her.

(And because when she was fed, her stomach went silent, and the guilt grew loud enough to hurt. Paying Jarine... helped, quieted the guilt down enough that she could sleep.)

She had begun to debate what else she could do to fill that gnawing hunger in her belly, in those last few days before the magic came upon her. She wasn't sure what she'd have done, back then. She hadn't had to make that choice, hadn't had to figure out what her limits might be, what she was really comfortable with. She had barely progressed beyond a vague knowledge that she had to do *something,* that her lifestyle wasn't sustainable, with no further thought as to what it would be...

When her skin began to turn that dim, faint shade of pink that would never leave her again.

At first, she'd thought she was sick, but she'd felt... fine, maybe better than fine, and so she'd just shrugged it off. She'd just left the orphanage, no need to go back and have to explain it just yet. And... it might be a disease, something she could carry to the other kids, aware in that vague way a child was aware that sickness could be given to others. So she stayed away, didn't want to hurt Jarine or the other kids, add *that* guilt to her mind.

And the next time she fled someone she was trying to rob, the wind danced in spirals at her feet.

Things progressed swiftly after that. She'd told Jarine, terrified out of her wits, and the elderly woman had hugged her, and talked with her, calmed her down.

(These two truths does Spinnerella know: she had, to her knowledge, never met the woman who gave birth to her... and she knew, too, that her mother's name was Jarine.)

The wise woman had let her practice in safety in the orphanage's walls, figuring out the magic inside her. And safe it was- well, as much safety as could be expected. Spinnerella had still hurt her ankle back then, twisted it something fierce when she misunderstood her magic, and spun her leg in ways it had not wished to go.

But Jarine had helped her when she was hurt, and while she was recuperating, Jarine had told her the unbelievable truth of what she was- a Wild Princess, an avatar of Etheria's unbound magic, the part that had never settled down into something as formal as a Runestone.

(*You are a miracle,* her mother had told her, and those words have never left her.)

Things had progressed swiftly after that. Spinnerella had asked how she could use this new power to gain food, and comfort, and maybe help Brigis; and Jarine had smiled, and told her not to worry about that. That she should just practice with her skills for now, and let Jarine worry about the orphanage; she was too young to have such a heavy burden on her back, the matron had said. She had warned the girl that many would seek a Wild Princess' power to use for themselves, and that she had to be careful.

Spinnerella had not listened. She had, in blunt child fashion, walked into a busy square and begun to dance, spinning,

spinning, showing her power for all to see, and demanding to see the Baron.

She wasn't sure why, but that stupid, straightforward scheme had worked out perfectly. Maybe the universe was just giving Spinnerella recompense for all her bad luck so far; the Baron had immediately been charmed by the pushy little twig of a girl that was brought to him, and had proven to be a good man besides. The orphanage's poor state was more due to his never-ending battles with his own wealthy nobility than any fault of the man himself; and Spinnerella's existence was all the excuse he needed to do a little direct intervention. He had showered Spinnerella with riches, and Jarine too, when the old woman was gently brought to the castle by his guards, and none of his nobles fought him on the act of charity, because by Spinnerella's very presence, those same nobles now had something to crow about, and preen their over-stuffed feathers over.

After all, Highpoint had just unveiled a Wild Princess of their own, parading it about and giving the Baron's nobles headache after headache with their boasting. But now, he had Spinnerella, and showing her off would get his united kingdom to shut the hell up.

And because she asked for it, he set aside wealth for the Brigis orphanage, so that none of them would ever go hungry again.

There were expectations, of course. She did not receive the cash for free. She would be expected to attend fancy parties, to do tricks on command, to appear at public occasions; but Spinnerella had been fine with that. To make sure she alone could eat, she had left others to die; to have to do a little acting, a little

showmanship, to make sure that Brigis and Jarine had enough, that *many* bellies were full?

Oh, this price was terribly fair, it was a bargain, it was practically a steal.

(And she was a thief; she would know.)

So she had set about learning how to do those tricks, and discovered by accident a love of dance, the Baron hiring a tutor to teach her. At the parties and public appearances, she would dance, dance through the air, and even the most jaded of wealthy hearts saw something of wonder in it. There was just *something* to the vision of a person who could defy gravity with a simple spin.

Her life became rather idyllic after that. She never left the orphanage, despite the million and one wealthy folks who wished to adopt her, now that she was suddenly a person in their eyes; but she would not go to them. The Baron backed her up, not wanting to subject a child to the dangers and pressures of the high and mighty, and not willing to hand any of his subjects the powerful political figure that was the growing Princess, morality and pragmatism singing a dual chorus for once.

They were the accompaniment to a happily ever after. The orphanage was repaired, no stomach went empty, and Spinnerella gorged herself on the good life. As Spinnerella put on pounds, her heart grew, too, her soul softening at the same time her body did; for she stuck close to Jarine, and tried to learn from the elderly refugee how to be a grown adult. She wanted to be like Jarine, to have some measure of her great heart, despite the temptations of

wealth and power; she tried to learn how to be soft, and kind, and loving, not to be the kind of person whom circumstance and powerlessness would force to leave dying men in dark alleys.

She liked to think that, somewhere along the way, somehow, she had managed it, though she had never stopped fearing that maybe she was that person still.

And in time, she was brought to meet the other powerful little girl of the Twin Kingdoms, a brave girl named Netossa.

In the present, she hugged tight the wonderful woman that brave girl had grown to become, whom she had fallen in love with; it had taken leaving home to do it. They'd come to know each other, and they'd flirted, but... nothing more. Spinnerella had been physically attracted to Netossa, and had come to rather like and respect her, but it had gone no farther than that.

Then they met each other, to their mutual surprise, at Brightmoon Castle, where the great international meeting had been held, the land of the immortal Angella the one place Runestone Kingdoms and Crownless alike could agree upon as a meeting place. They'd been equally stunned; neither had told anyone they were coming, save their parents.

(Netossa's parents hadn't approved, terrified for their daughter's life; Spinnerella's mother had just hugged her, knowing she could not stop her, and simply asked her brave girl to come home safe.)

They'd both known that anyone else would try to stop them, but both had been too moved by the words of the Red Knight to do anything else. The visitor from Blackmoor had come and, without lifting their armored visor, spoken to the Dual Senate of both nations; as Wild Princesses, Spinnerella and Netossa had a right to be there, and both had been curious. The Twin Kingdoms bordered Blackmoor in their southwest, but the Kingdoms were locked in a vast mountain valley; they got few visitors from outside, save for the Drylborn, whose equally-mountainous region gave them the skill to navigate the roads, and whose love of tech gave them reason to visit.

This new visitor was a merchant, too, of a sort, but what this peddler carried was the single finest ware Spinnerella had ever seen: they had come to the Twin Kingdoms to sell them a cause. The Great Rebellion, they had called it, the thing all Etheria must join; a worldwide uprising against industrialized evil, against the mechanized assault that had come roaring up from the south. They had spoken with elegant and eloquent heart of refugees, and of hunger, and of people who were dying all over the south to fuel imperial ambition.

He spoke of fighting it, of an army of everyone, Runestone and Crownless both, an army of Princesses and people, who could storm into the heart of evil and stop the abomination before it spread; he spoke of the gathering at Brightmoon, where in the halls of an immortal angel, mortal souls would discuss how to kill the devil.

Something in her had caught fire, at the Red Knight's words. Maybe it fit; it took air to feed a fire, after all. Maybe something in Spinnerella had simply wanted for a spark, some way to make up

for her sins, find something she could *choose* to do to make up for the harm she'd *had* to do.

The Red Knight had carried that spark with them, in their voice, in their words crying out for freedom; and in honor of the wildfire he set inside her heart, Spinnerella knew that she must go, and join them at Brightmoon, where the Red Knight said the meeting would be held. There, in a distant land she had never known, Spinnerella would find all the others in whom the spark had lit, join the great convocation of candles holding vigil against the Horde, and she found she could not wait.

She was going to go there; she knew that before the Red Knight had even finished speaking.

But she had also known that her nation would never let her go; the Twin Kingdoms had ruled against joining the Rebellion. Too risky, and with too little to gain; few enemies had ever breached the mountains before, and no one believed the Horde would manage it. Most of the Twin Kingdoms' strife had been with each other, before the unification; and after, while they'd had problems with bandits and, once, a Wild Princess, that had been it. This new Horde would not touch them.

But Spinnerella would not stay safe, the way so many had when she herself was suffering, and hungering, and hurting. Spinnerella, once, had been a little girl who had let others die, because she was hungry, because she was destitute, because she had been weak; but Spinnerella was full, now. Spinnerella had *wealth* and *power* now.

Spinnerella could *help*.

She took two weeks to prepare. Two weeks, to make sure that, should she not come back, the orphanage would be protected; promises and coin and favors extracted, all her affairs put in order. She had never lost her hardnosed practicality, after all; there was a chance she would die, and she would not let the orphanage or the woman who had so provided for her suffer in her absence. Her movements were quiet, but did not go unseen; but that was alright. Baron Condore had been the one to catch her at it, and had quietly acquiesced to her decision through a secret messenger; he had wanted to help the Rebellion, after all, but had been overruled by his senators.

So, instead, he had quietly assisted, covering her tracks, and assured her that, should she be successful in her war, she would have a home to come back to.

(She thinks that all her homeland is lucky in this much; if her nation's government could have only one good man in it, at least it happened to be the man sitting on the throne itself.)

When all was done, her mother hugged, and everything made ready, she had simply lifted off from the street in the dead of night, flying higher and higher. Up, up, and away- into the wild blue yonder, to seek out Brightmoon in the east- and what a short trip, for one who could fly! The wind would never hurt her; she could breathe, in the sky, felt no chill from rushing wind, her power sustaining her. She flew so high and so fast that nothing could be a threat to her, soaring over the world like an avenging angel, in that place only she could go; it would break her bones to carry others so high, but herself alone? Oh, she weighed light as a feather to her own powers, no matter how heavy she got.

So she danced her way to Brightmoon in but a few days, only landing to sleep,to make her grand entrance right in the midst of the gathered proto-Rebels, descending in a whirlwind. They all expressed great surprise, having not expected her- save for one, the Red Knight themselves, who had cheerfully greeted her as though they had been waiting, and calmly went over to shake her hand, as pretty as you please.

(*I saw greatness in you,* that had been their simple, straightforward answer, when she'd asked why they weren't surprised, stating it as if it were obvious fact; and even now, some part of her is warmed, to know that, before she herself had known it, the Red Knight had seen the woman she could be.)

Netossa had arrived three days later, and put Spinnerella's entrance to shame; she'd shown up to Brightmoon at the head of a small army. Netossa, as Spinnerella would hear from her lips that night, had escaped her disapproving parents and the Twin Kingdoms both through the simplest expedient possible: she'd just walked away. That's all it had taken, just walking away, trusting her hobby of mountain climbing and love of hiking to give her the endurance, and trusting a few purchased maps to give her the guidance.

The trust was well-founded; she made it to Dryl despite the alarm being sounded, hiding on little-used trails from Kingdom patrols. Once in Dryl, she hitched a ride with some merchants down to Plumeria, where she found a Plumerian convoy going east to Crystal Falls that had been hiring guards. Netossa had hired on with a short display of her powers, and her hiring proved fortuitous for all involved, for the convoy ran into bandits on the border. The highway robbers had been merely ragged refugees of the Runestone Duchies, starving folk turned cruel by years of

homelessness and hunger; it was a familiar tale, a story Spinnerella knew not by heart but by the hole in her stomach she had never quite been able to fill.

Netossa had defeated them, the bandits so surprised by the presence of a Wild Princess where they'd expected just a few guards that she'd been able to overwhelm them despite her total lack of experience in a real fight; oh, she'd trained, but never had she actually faced battle until this moment.

Still, it wasn't much of one; they were untrained folk, only one or two former soldiers among them, and all rendered weak from deprivation and their own shock at facing a Princess. In moments, they were tied up, stuck to trees or each other, rendered harmless, and the merchants had cheered... but Netossa had recognized the remnants of old uniforms, knew from her studies of politics the nations these folk had fled from, saw their gaunt features and starved skin.

And so, when the shaking from adrenaline had left her hands, Netossa had started talking.

Netossa's parents had made sure she had the best tutors for whatever subjects she wanted, and Netossa wanted to be a politician; and every drop of gold spent on her public speaking tutor had been made worth it that very day. She preached and spoke, of how much the bandits had suffered, until she had convinced the merchants to give up all their goods to the refugees, sharing their bread and food with them; and then, as they ate, she told the shocked would-be thieves of her goal, of the gathering to the north and east where those who would fight for their homes were going.

She said they would face hardship, and disaster, and death, and she promised them only this: she would see their nations restored, or die trying. To their cause she would add the weight of a Princess, and their own weight could be added to hers, if they would but follow her lead.

On the weight of that promise, they swore themselves to her cause. When all her talking was done, the merchants had went home empty-handed with full hearts, while the mob of bandits marched alongside Netossa with full bellies and full packs. Others joined, who were also fed from their diminishing supplies, those the refugees knew of, other bandits along the way; by the time they reached Brightmoon, Netossa had the makings of what would, in time, congeal into the core squad of her Rebel forces.

(Some of those were still with her to this day; not all, for even a victorious army suffered the touch of death, and even the mighty sometimes must quit the field for other reasons... but some remained, who still had faith in Netossa's long ago promise, of their kingdoms restored.)

So alone of all the would-be Rebels, Netossa arrived at the head of her very own forces, and even had a standard; a scrawled white web-thing on ragged purple cloth that one former artist had made, the Lunoth who made it laughing as he carried the banner. She had marched into Brightmoon at their head with a grin on her face that said she was going to take on the whole world, and that the world had better bring its best, or be found wanting.

Spinnerella had fallen in love with her in that moment. It was one thing to know that she had made the same choice, that the fire in Spinnerella had a twin in Netossa, but that grin... it was...

beautiful. The smile of someone truly unconquerable, who could be killed but never beaten, who was glorious and wonderful and made Spinny's heart do its own spinning dance within her chest.

While Spinnerella was enraptured, everyone else was mostly surprised. Even the Red Knight had been taken aback at the Princess who came packing a platoon, bursting out laughing and shaking their great helmeted head. As they'd say later, Netossa arriving wasn't a surprise, the Knight had seen greatness in her the same as in Spinnerella, as in so many others who had come... but at the head of an army? Even as the Knight shook her hand, the crimson cavalier had been laughing, pure delighted joy on their every breath.

(*Something in command seems to suit you, youngster,* the Red Knight had said, and they'd been right, had seen the beginnings of the officer inside Netossa even in those earliest days.)

Netossa had first made sure her people were fed, and had room and board, before she ever tended her own needs, and that only made Spinnerella's admiration grow. She took care of those under her first, perhaps the only real task a commander had, when you really thought about it; they'd repaid her, every ear in the camp filling with stories of Netossa's greatness, stories that mutated and got overblown and did their job of spreading her fame. By the time a week had passed, and the Rebellion- coopted into the Princess Alliance later, to the disgruntlement of the Crownless and the rage of Blackmoor, who had named it first before the Runestone Kingdoms robbed them- came into being, Netossa's ragged handful of refugees had swelled with reinforcements, and her white-web-on-tattered-purple had become a standard, a mark of distinction.

(She wondered what the Lunoth who had made it would think, if he had known they would use it still, years after that brave man

had died; what would he think, that the symbol they still carried was the one he'd invented? She knew not what he'd think, but Spinnerella knew that she liked it; she liked the idea of Netossa the Spider, who would weave all the Rebellion into a single web, and catch all the Horde with it.)

But that was the future. That day alone had been a whirlwind after Netossa's arrival; not one of Spinnerella's dances, but a dance nonetheless, the endless tango of excitement and plans and figuring out how the Rebellion would exist. It was not until later that night the spinning stopped, and in the eye of the storm, she had a chance to shyly approach Netossa, still in awe of her. Netossa had been glad to see her, and had blushed when Spinnerella told her how perfect she had looked, standing before her squadron, as if she had always been meant to be there... and she'd been so pretty that Spinnerella had plucked up her courage, and kissed her, finding to her delight that Netossa kissed her back, once her shock was done.

It had been at Brightmoon Castle that they had shared their first kiss, and Spinnerella would always be grateful for that, to whatever forces of the universe granted the wishes of girls who had lost their innocence far too young; despite all the awfulness of her youth, despite her soiled nature, her first kiss was with the woman she would marry, and at a beautiful, fairytale castle.

She had that much, at least, and it was a sweet gift indeed.

And soon, perhaps, there might be more; maybe soon the Great Rebellion would win, and they could fulfill Netossa's promise, made so long ago. Maybe someday soon this war would end, and maybe that dream of the Portal would work.

(A world where her Netossa was a queen, the way she *deserved* to be; Spinnerella's fondest wish, that the world could see just how amazing her Nettie really was.)

Thinking such happy thoughts, Spinnerella smiled in her sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Spinnerella's backstory revealed!

The "dreams of chronic and sustained cruelty" comes from Team Fortress 2- specifically Meet the Pyro, mostly because I used to main Pyro. W+M1, baby!

Chapter 49: In the Wake of Miracle

Chapter Notes

I'm SO sorry this is late; I've no excuse.

But I'll be back on schedule this Friday!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the Wake of Miracle

Angella fainting had prompted a *flurry* of activity.

Much of it was just people freaking out or gawking at the spectacle of it all. Others did more substantive things; Catra, of course, been at her mother's side in an instant, checking to see if she was still alive, Scorpia's throwaway comment panicking her. The Magicat's heart had clenched so hard in her chest from Angella's faint that it was like a fist, a lump of hard and aching muscle that had only loosened when she felt Angella's pulse beneath the fur of her fingers.

Glimmer had been the next, teleporting over, checking to see if Angella was breathing still, and apologetic.

(*Holy shit, she fainted!* Glimmer said. *Didn't see that coming!*)

Micah had run over, too, accompanied by the *actual* Scorpia, who seemed to be following the King of Brightmoon more out of habit

than anything else. General Juliet, finally recovering from her surprise at Micah's appearance, had followed him, as had Castaspella.

Once they saw that Angella was fine, just unconscious, Micah had summarily picked up his wife in his arms- without apparent effort, dude was strong, apparently- and marched off to the bedroom, to let her rest in some comfort. General Juliet and Castaspella had left, too- one to guard the Queen and king, the other to inform everyone in Brightmoon of the good news of her brother's return.

Catra had wanted to follow, but then worried that Netossa might do something with the Council still technically in session; Glimmer, meanwhile, had surprised her by smoothly sliding into her mother's seat, stating that she was representing Brightmoon now, and making a motion for the War Council to be formally adjourned.

Mermista had seconded the motion with her usual delightful sarcasm.

(*Yeah, I'm gonna need a moment to process the King of Brightmoon being alive again,* the saltwater witch had said, unable to stop the smirky grin that crossed her features as she glanced at Netossa. *And we finished the vote on the thing that mattered anyway.* Netossa, frowning, had nonetheless conceded the point.)

The motion passed unanimously, and afterwards, the entire Council broke apart to go their own ways. Netossa and her cohorts had left the scene of their loss, all save Peekablue and Queen Orwall. Peekablue had left with one of the newcomers, a woman in gold and black armor; Catra had caught a few snatches

of their conversation, more tone than anything else, and that tone had been sweet as honey on both sides, with no lie in that love that Catra could hear. A married couple, if she didn't miss her guess, or one on its way to being one.

The Magicat, meanwhile, had stayed in the Council room, sitting in her seat. She spent her time staring at Catra or the floor- mostly the floor, to be honest- and sitting there so awkwardly that even under her shock and surprise, Catra had vaguely wanted to give her a hug. Girl was nervous as shit about something.

(It was a bit weird, if Catra was being honest; weird to have someone else in the room that was just like her, that looked as she did. She had gotten used to being the only one of her kind, had believed herself to *be* one of a kind until this year, when she was told she had a people... and here was the proof that she was not alone, that in the greater world there was kin of hers, and she wasn't sure what to *do* with that.)

All the newcomers who had arrived with Glimmer- save Shadow Weaver, who had went back to their transport without any prompting, to Catra's mingled relief and dismay- had absconded as a group to one of the guest rooms, Scorpia seemingly awkward without Micah to follow around and picking Entrapta as a new leader. Entrapta had given Catra a wave, which she'd returned a bit numbly- that had been right after Micah arrived and her mom fainted, when Catra was still mostly in shock; Catra was legit impressed that she'd had the presence of mind to wave back, the Princess of Power could have been knocked over by a feather in those moments.

Of those left, the Best Friend Squad had all stayed, including Glimmer. Catra had temporarily moved to leave, following Micah,

but Glimmer had waved her over to stay; she'd suspected her dad and mom would need to talk alone first, and Catra saw the logic once her sister suggested it. Catra wasn't sure *what* you did when you found your husband alive after a decade, but it was probably easier without having to explain that *oh hey you have another daughter now.*

(Some part of her worried. Would Micah like her? Would he convince Angella that she'd made a mistake?)

So the Best Friend Squad was together- make that the Best Friend Squad *Plus* , as Bow and Sea Hawk had cheerfully declared them all those years ago, because Mermista and her boyfriend stayed, too. Sea Hawk's dad- Sea Falcon, or whatever- had left, saying he needed to make sure word was sent to Salineas of today's events; he'd left in such dramatic fashion that Catra now knew where Sea Hawk got it from.

They had two extras- Frosta and that weird blue woman with her, the young Snows Princess looking a bit like she wished she had something to munch on as she watched the festivities.

Catra wished she had something to give her; it would be the absolute least she owed her. Frosta had saved the life of the woman Catra loved, had made it so that Catra did not have to betray either of the two things she held loyalty to, and she had done it when she owed Catra nothing; it was a gift that Catra didn't know how to repay, but she'd damn well *try.* Catra had not known what she'd do, if the vote went wrong... and now, she didn't *have* to know, she'd *never* had to know, and for that, she owed Frosta more than she could say.

So here they were, sitting in a semi-awkward circle on one end of the table, sitting in the now mostly-empty Council room, listening as Glimmer regaled them with the story of all that had happened.

" ...So your dad was on Beast Island," Catra finally said to her sister as she finished.

" Yep," Glimmer said, popping the last letter with her mouth. A grin so self-satisfied it almost physically radiated smugness spread across her face afterwards.

Nobody said anything for a long moment, as they all pondered the sheer absurd impossibility of all that.

" ...Bullshit," Bow finally said.

" Bow!" Glimmer cracked up, laughing at hearing the archer curse. " Shame on you!"

(Catra laughed too- though at least part of that was just for the *release* of it all. Between the successful vote to *not* kill the woman she loved, her mom scaring her by passing out, and... everything else, she felt a bit like an over-full cup, and joy sloshed out of her without much prompting.)

" I'm sorry, it's just..." Bow said, laughing a bit too. " It's just *bullshit* , Glimmer, you know it is!"

" It's weird to hear you curse," Mermista opined. " I mean, Catra cusses a lot and Glimmer thinks the word *fuck* is a comma, but hearing you swear is just weird."

" I think fuck is a comma?" Glimmer said with a laugh. " That's a good one, I'll have to remember that!"

" That'd be a hell of a thing," Frosta commented.

" Seriously, Glimmer," Bow continued. " If you'd come back crowned as the Horde's new Lord, it wouldn't be as surprising as *this.* I'd have had some context for that! I'd just assume you'd conquered it when we weren't looking, or something."

" Aww, you're so sweet," Glimmer said, giving him a saucy wink. " Smooth talker."

Bow blushed, deep red under black skin for a moment, before he continued.

" But... your dad was dead!" he managed, blush fading as he continued to ponder the impossibility of it all. " And now you have these... just *amazing* wings... "

" Indeed!" Sea Hawk commented with his usual drama, leaping into a foot-on-chair pose with bended knee and one arm flung out

dramatically. " A bit grim for my tastes- I prefer your mother's lovely pink- but quite fitting for a warrior like yourself!"

" I know, right?" Glimmer said, fluttering them and flexing her arms before them. " It's like extra arms! That I wiggle with my shoulders. Kinda odd, but awesome. They feel real different full-grown like this. Kinda sensitive to the air."

" Let's not forget," Mermista commented dryly, " that you found Scorpia, too. Which is kinda funny given you were the one to take out the *fake* Scorpia that was spying on us."

" You helped!" Glimmer said.

" Got tased, you mean," Mermista snarked, though her lip curled into a half-grin that her friends knew meant she was pleased by Glimmer's acknowledgement. " You were the one who took them out- though yeah, I guess I did help with the early part."

" Didn't you teleport the spy into the sky?" Frosta said to Glimmer, who nodded.

" And I didn't even have wings worth the name back then!" Glimmer said, fluttering hers again. " Which is why I needed to teleport back, as you might imagine."

“ Yeah, I can't see that being... not fatal, otherwise,” Frosta said with a nod. “ Just a pink smear.”

Glimmer laughed as Bow shook his head.

“ So... in total,” Bow said, grinning in helpless disbelief, “ you brought your dad back from the dead, saved him *and* the actual, real, honest-to-Silver Scorpia from *Beast Island* , the deadliest place on Etheria, all while growing yourself a new pair of working wings.”

“ And I even made you swear,” Glimmer capped off his list , her grin somehow, impossibly, becoming even *more* smug. Catra was glad that no innocent passerby were in the area, they'd be at risk of permanent blindness if they looked right at all that pride on her sister's face. “ I'm a fucking miracle worker.”

“ You are,” Catra said, her own grin wide and warm. Smug as Glimmer was being, today, she'd *earned* it. “ You did... you did *amazing,* Glimmer.”

Glimmer basked in that praise as everyone was silent for a few moments. Bow was the one who spoke again after that time.

“ But weren't you in Dryl?” he asked.

“ Yeah,” Catra said, remembering the conversation she'd had with Glimmer the morning after the... the Talk she'd had with her family. Pushing past *that* quickly, she followed with, “ How the hell did you even get to Beast Island from Dryl? It's landlocked!”

“ Rode in the **Doom Balloon,** ” Glimmer said, intoning deeply on the name and raising her hands and wings dramatically before going back to normal. “ Entrapta thought maybe we could find Scorpia or, more realistically, her corpse, and maybe steal control of the Black Garnet from the Horde that way somehow. We didn't expect, you know, *my fucking dad* to be alive, or even Scorpia to still be breathing really, but hey! It worked out great.”

“ Is the Horde even using the Black Garnet with Shadow Weaver gone?” Bow asked. He stifled a yawn, shaking his head.

“ Tired?” Glimmer asked, and he nodded.

“ We had a hack last night,” he said. “ Stayed up all night dealing with it for your mom, then we had the meeting and I just... never got any sleep. Then you walked in, and while I've had a hell of a lot of coffee, I'm afraid I'm a sinking ship.”

“ Get some sleep,” Catra commanded gently. “ Trust me, I know what lack of sleep is like.”

Her ears went down, recalling her last few days, before her mother used her soft spell to let Catra rest.

(Darkness that helped, shadows sweet in their nature; a thing of impossibility. Miracles never ceased.)

“ No,” Bow said, raising one shaky fist. “ I *refuse* to give in to sleep. Today's already been too wild! So much has happened today- the hack last night, Frosta voting to spare Adora, Peekablue turning on Netossa, and then you show up- look, at this point I'm worried that if I sleep, I'll miss, I don't know. Hordak coming back from the space between dimensions, or a meteor hitting the castle. *Some* damn thing or another.”

“ It's still weird to hear Bow cuss,” Mermista said, shaking her head.

“ It is, isn't it?” Glimmer said. “ But awesome. More proof of my eternal greatness!”

“ Sure is!” Frosta confirmed cheerfully.

“ Speaking truly, I am in agreement with our good archer!” Sea Hawk said. “ After everything that's happened, I'm not sure what *else* could be on the horizon, but I am excited nonetheless.”

“ I mean, it'll be hard to top this,” Catra commented.

“ Damn right it will be,” ” Glimmer said. “ And, well, you guys are my friends, so it's time for some fair warning. I am going to be

absolutely unbearable for like, the next *year.* Every discussion with me is gonna involve me referencing all this, no matter how convoluted the conversational path I must tread to get there. You're all gonna be sick of hearing about it, and I apologize in advance for how annoying that's going to be."

Lord Laughter- already on his way to Angella's room, to be Emperor over a King and Queen- made a pitstop as the group snorted and cracked up at her proclamation. Even Orwall, awkward at the group's edge, laughed a little at that, in her skittish fashion.

" Nameless Gods, she's giving us a heads-up," Mermista said between the dry laughs of her amusement. " I- I can't *imagine* how bad it'll be if Glimmer feels we have to be *forewarned.*"

" I mean, she's earned it!" Bow said as he giggled, Glimmer still smugging like all hell. Catra was impressed, smugness wasn't usually a verb, but Glimmer was managing. " She brought her dad back from the dead!"

" Damn right!" Glimmer said. " And you will *all* hear about it *every day* from *now on!*"

More laughter, and it was... good. Catra felt relieved and released, as though some internal pressure had found outlet in the laughter. So much had happened, but it was... it was good. Adora was going to live. Her mom was going to have her husband back...

And...

Catra was not as afraid, now, that she was going to lose her mother.

Yeah, maybe she was a little... a little *scared,* of the changes there. She hadn't been part of a good family for very long, and she feared anything that might upset that balance... but now, in the wake of the laughter, of her sister, of... of all this, she wasn't *as* scared. She trusted her mom and she trusted her sister. No matter Micah's opinion of her, she would still have a family, at day's end, and a place *in* that family.

(And here is a miracle, great and small: that once upon a time, a little unloved girl had learned to become a woman who could trust that she was *loved.*)

Yeah, it was a good day.

A thought hit her a moment later, a thought that *could* hurt, but *didn't,* and she broke up laughing again.

" What, sis?" Glimmer asked.

" Well, I just realized," Catra said, smiling to show that she didn't mean this in any bad way, that whatever green things were in her were not in her eyes, " that you are now Mom's *permanent* favorite."

There was silence a moment, Glimmer looking... surprisingly discomfited, glancing at Catra to search her face, looking for... hurt, there.

Glimmer, brute that she was, nonetheless was trying to be *gentle* with her sister; and it made Catra's heart all warm and soft, to see that concern in her eyes. Glimmer was afraid this would hurt her sister, that this might be poison, and didn't want it to hurt Catra if it was.

And that meant... so much, given her sister's own struggles with jealousy. It was impossible to know Glimmer for any length of time and *not* see how much wounded pride made her up, a thing Catra had known from almost the moment of their meeting; but to see her not reaching out to grab this victor's crown, to claim it for herself, but to hold back in case it would hurt her sister...

But this wasn't the only change, was it? Only a few moments ago, Glimmer had demurred, had told Mermista that she had helped, had acknowledged someone else instead of taking all glory for herself.

...Her sister had grown more than wings, on that island, if Catra did not miss her guess.

A ferocious, overwhelming sense of *pride* blossomed in Catra's heart and soul; pride, in a sister she loved, and who now stood taller in her esteem than she ever had before.

Catra knew intimately, after all, how hard it was to overcome your own feelings.

(*Adora, Shadow Weaver*)

" It's hard to compete with resurrecting your dad from the dead," Catra followed with a gentle smile, putting a warm hand on her sister's shoulder and squeezing, to show that this was good, this could be good, that Glimmer *deserved* the crown Catra was offering, to drink deep of the red cup of victory.

Glimmer's face eased as she realized that this wasn't a bad thing, not at all, that this was not a declaration of Catra's loss, but a celebration of Glimmer's victory.

" Your dad too," Glimmer said, and reached up to squeeze Catra's own hand. " I told him about you on the way over; he's excited to meet you. You've got a dad now, too."

" Never had a father before..." Catra said, and wondered how it might be; Angella had healed so many wounds in her. Maybe a father would help, too? Two parents, to replace the one monster. " Unless you count Hordak, he was kinda dad of the whole Horde."

" Not thinking about that," Glimmer said. " *Absolutely* refusing to think about that."

Catra snorted before continuing.

" I can't wait to meet my new dad, then," Catra said sincerely, and with a smile.

Glimmer smiled back, then apparently decided that things were too mushy, becaue the next thing Catra knew, Glimmer had grabbed her in a giant hug and flapped off the ground with her sister in tow.

" Agh!" Catra choked out as Glimmer bounced her around the air of the Council room.

" It's gonna be *great!*" Glimmer announced... before teleporting back to the ground and dropping her sister like a sack of potatoes. " Aaaaand I've pulled my back! Oh, Silver's fat ass, my *back!"*

Glimmer collapsed to the floor, moaning in pain, as Catra stumbled and caught herself on her feet.

" My hubris!" Glimmer yelled, laughing even as she said it. " I knew my wings weren't strong enough yet- oh Siiiiiiiilveeeeerrrrrr....."

" Serves you right!" Catra said. " What were you thinking?!?"

“ Glimmer,” Bow said, putting his palm to his face. “ And I thought the *teleporting* got you into trouble...”

The doors burst open then, Flutterina running into the room at her usual borderline-supernatural speed and skidding inside, mouth going a mile a minute.

“ Hey-everyone! General-Juliet-wanted-me-to...” she said, slowing to a pause as she saw Glimmer writhing on the floor in pain. “ What's happening with her?”

“ Idiot pulled her back muscles,” Catra said, rolling her eyes as she knelt down and began massaging her sister's back. “ Dumbass.”

“ Just killll mmmeeeee....” Glimmer moaned.

“ Hold-on-I-got-some-muscle-relaxant!” Flutterina quickly spit out, whipping off her giant backpack- which she'd apparently put on at some point since Catra saw her last- and searching through it quickly for a small jar of whitish cream in a jar, the lid stamped with the sword symbol of the Good Woman's Church. “ This is safe for most mammal species! I think Glimmer's a mammal? Or maybe a bird?”

“ Her wings are kinda birdy,” Frosta noted. “ Not sure what kind.”

“ ...Looks kinda like an owl?” the blue woman next to her said, before shrugging.

“ ...Yeah, I kinda see it,” Mermista commented.

“ I count as human for most purposes,” Glimmer groaned, ignoring the comments on her wings. “ Healers figured that out when I was younger. Don't know if that still counts now that I've got flappy-flaps, but it should.”

“ Humans are mammals, so this'll be okay! So... then, just apply... everywhere, I guess, I'm not really sure how her wings are attached?” Flutterina continued awkwardly as she handed the jar to Catra. “ I know for us it's the shoulders and back, but she's not a Lunoth, so I'm not sure.”

“ No, just kill me,” Glimmer begged with faux drama as Catra popped the top off and smeared some of the ointment on her hand. “ It's too much. You'll have to put me down.”

“ I can't introduce myself to my new dad by killing you,” Catra snarked. “ You'll just have to put up with the pain, I'm afraid.”

“ I mean, that *would* avoid the entire Glimmer-being-smug thing that she warned us about,” Mermista said as Catra stuck a cold hand under the back of Glimmer's shirt and rubbed the ointment onto her twitching muscles.

“ Ah it's *cold* why didn't you give it a minute to heat up?!?” the failed flyer complained.

“ To teach you a lesson!” Catra said cheerfully. “ About picking up your big sister and gallivanting about!”

“ *I'm* the big sister,” Glimmer pouted pitifully as Catra continued spreading soothing ointment. “ That's what I'm gonna use my new best-kid status for. I'm gonna make mom declare me the big sister.”

“ Aww, you'll always be my *little* sister,” Catra said, as she made sure to swipe ointment across the pained muscles around the wings, which were already growing heavy and big- it was odd to think of, but her mom must have some *serious* musculature back there to fly, and Glimmer was going to inherit it. “ You short shit.”

“ I'm taller than anyone when I fly!” Glimmer protested from the floor. “ But this floor is... kinda nice, actually. This wax smells *great.* Seriously. Why did we have scented floor wax? Who is gonna be down here to smell it? I mean, like, other than me, right now.”

“ People like me,” Catra said. “ I smell it all the time. It's a light scent, just perfect. Smells clean.”

(*Smells like home,* she thought quietly in her mind- and that was a miracle, too, that there was a place to call *home.*)

“ I never knew the Castle had a scent,” Glimmer said as she softly sighed. “ Oh, that's starting to work now. That's goooood. Warm and loose, no longer pulling...”

“ Do you need to see a healer, or is this enough?” Catra asked. A wing batted at her gently. “ Hey, watch it, birdbrain.”

“ Nah, I'm good,” Glimmer said. “ Wasn't pulled that bad and the muscle rub'll be enough. Also sorry about the wing. I have like... sorta control over them? Man, I'm gonna knock *so* much shit off my shelves until I figure this out.”

“ You want us to remove your porcelain and breakables?” Bow asked. “ I can already see your dresser ending up just... all over the floor.”

“ That would be amazing, actually,” Glimmer said. “ Just put that shit in a box for now, if you would. I mean, I don't have a lot I would really *miss,* it's mostly replaceable stuff, but I don't want to have to replace it or clean it up.”

Catra was about to respond when the Council Room's doors opened, and in walked General Juliet, who was... grinning.

That's just wrong, was Catra's first thought. General Juliet almost never grinned, not unless she was with her family- Catra had

heard from others that Juliet was shockingly gentle with her husband and kid- or, more commonly, someone fucked up and gave her an opportunity to engage in schadenfreude.

Catra strongly suspected that the latter was the case, right now.

" Uh oh," Glimmer said from the floor, rising up, having seen the same grin Catra had. " You're smiling, and that's not good. What's up?"

" Oh, just the... *situation*," Juliet said with unnecessary emphasis, and her grin grew even *more,* which was only *weirder* to look at. " With your father back, your mother is... making up for lost time."

" What do you mean?" Catra asked obliviously, absolutely unaware of what was about to come out of Juliet's mouth.

" Oh, there's lots of ways to say it," Juliet said, chuckling. " But first... Flutterina, I figured that the Princesses and company were here when you didn't come back. I need you to leave real quick- go check and make sure Shadow Weaver's nowhere in the castle, would you?"

" Absolutely, ma'am!" Flutterina said, saluting before slapping her backpack back on and taking off at her usual ludicrous speed. Juliet, still smiling, waited until she was gone to turn to Catra and Glimmer.

" Now, to answer your question- I could describe what they are doing as making the beast with two backs, but that feels unnecessarily limiting! I have no idea if they're engaging in the classical position or not," she said.

Classical position...? WAIT

" Whoa, whoa!" Catra announced, waving her hands to halt Juliet, but the General kept going with glee.

" I have come here to tell you that they are coming *there!*" Juliet announced, cackling. " And they could be doing it in any number of ways! They're consummating their marriage with such enthusiasm you can hear it outside of their bedroom!"

Revelation hit everyone in the room at the same moment; disgusted disbelief spread across Catra and Glimmer's faces as Mermista snorted a laugh and Sea Hawk nodded approvingly, Bow glancing to his two best friends to see how the sisters would react. Orwall, on the fringe, looked like she was about to discover heretofore unknown magic out of sheer awkwardness and teleport out of the room.

" They may well be turning you into proud older sisters at this very moment!" Juliet continued with relish, clearly enjoying the horrified expressions of the two Brightmoon princesses. " Congratulations are in order! They're doing it so loudly I had to

clear out the hallway to give them some privacy, put guards on the hallway's *end.* They may well break the royal bed!”

“ Oh Silver, no!” Glimmer declared.

“ Juliet, what the fuck?” Catra cried out. “ There's a kid here!”

“ I know about sex, you dumbass,” Frosta said, snorting. “ I'm not *that* goddamn young. And hey, congrats to Angella, and to this Micah dude.”

“ Oh, I'm gonna be sick,” Glimmer muttered as she rose to her feet.

“ Why? I'm simply keeping you up to date on current... *affairs!*” Juliet declared with delight as Glimmer and Catra both made choking noises of disgust, outrage, disgusted outrage, and all associated feelings.

“ Nameless Gods,” Mermista muttered, putting a hand to her forehead... and striving valiantly not to burst out laughing. Bow had his own hands over his mouth to muzzle his own amusement.

“ I think it's quite sweet!” Sea Hawk declared as the two royal princesses continued being horrified by the knowledge of parental sex. “ I know if *I* was on an island for years, and then saw my fair Mermista again, I too would have thoughts of love in my mind!”

“ I don't need to hear that either!” Catra shouted.

“ TMI, dude!” Glimmer yelled.

Mermista, meanwhile, just sighed... but she leaned fondly into him.

“ Don't *tell* people that,” she said. “ You'd be lucky if I was still waiting... but if I *was,* I'd be randy too, yeah.”

“ Dude!” Glimmer said again, leaping up to a standing position from the floor.

“ Dude?” Mermista asked with a raised eyebrow.

“ Dude is gender-neutral,” Frosta answered.

“ Oh, don't yell at my sweetness!” Sea Hawk said. “ I think it's sweet that your parents are reconnecting with such vim and vigor!”

“ I'm going to kill you,” Catra grumbled.

" I'm going to have *nightmares,*" Glimmer openly despaired, and that was the last straw- the entire room, from high-ranking General to Rebel soldier, burst out laughing at them.

" You know," Catra said, as they laughed, " maybe you were right, death *does* seem preferable."

" I told you," Glimmer said.

" Well, this has been fun," Bow said, as he sobered up. " But I have places to be now."

And with that, he immediately passed out, his head slapping against the table as his willpower and coffee based defenses against sleep were finally overwhelmed by the sandman's siege.

Everyone looked at him for a moment before Catra sighed.

" Alright, I'm going to carry him to his room, and... maybe see if someone can rip those thoughts out of my head," Catra said. " Or maybe just punch myself into a concussion."

" I'm coming with you," Glimmer said.

“ Don't you want to stay?” Juliet said, almost managing to say it before losing her composure and laughing again. “ You could get an update on your parents!”

“ We're leaving!” Catra announced, picking Bow up in strong arms- not as strong as when transformed, but strong enough- and hauling him out while Glimmer followed behind.

They weren't far down the hall when the Council door opened again, and out popped the Magicat Queen.

“ Wait!” she said. “ I have to stab you!”

Catra and Glimmer both blinked at her, as Orwall, realizing what she had just said, blanched so hard that even her fur seemed to lose color.

“ Oh Saz, *noooooo*,” she muttered, slapping her hands to her face. “ I meant, I need your blood!”

Silence reigned for a moment.

“...That's not... that's not better,” Catra commented, shifting Bow around in her arms. Thank fuck that even non-transformed, she had extra strength- and she wasn't thinking about the Sword, not right now, not on a day when she'd had so many victories, so she refocused on Orwall.

" It isn't, is it? I'm making a mess of this..." Orwall said, finally slapping her cheeks and seeming to kind of reset herself. " I am Queen Orwall of Halfmoon, I am honored to meet you- I can't begin to say how much it means to us, to know that one of our own is *the She-Ra,* that the Horde that has done so much harm to us is being repaid by you. Saz's Revenge..."

What the hell is a Saz? Catra wondered. *The way she was calling out to it earlier... a god, maybe?*

" Well, I'm glad to hear that," Catra said, but Orwall interrupted her, as if she was worried she'd fuck this up if she didn't keep going.

" And we... we have a way to tell you if you have any living relatives," the Queen said. " With some blood, I can... I can tell you who your parents were. Where you're from."

But I know who my parents are, Catra thought. *A shadow who hurt me, an angel who healed me.*

(And maybe a King; she wasn't sure, but she had hope.)

Her thoughts must have been clear on her face, because Orwall's fell. Glimmer stepped up next to her sister and spoke up first.

“ Catra's got the same mom I do,” Glimmer said. “ And she'll have the same dad, too, once they get to know each other.”

“ Damn right,” Catra said.

“ We know that,” Orwall said, quietly. “ I didn't... I've screwed this up. I'm sorry. I didn't... we *know* that Angella adopted you, that she is your milk-mother. That's not... I'm not trying to tell you that your 'real family' is someone else.”

“ Good,” Catra said defensively. “ Because *that* would be a great way to get your ass beat.”

Orwall nodded, and Catra felt a bit bad, given how clearly disheartened she now was.

“ I just... I thought maybe you'd want to... know?” Orwall said, finally shrugging. “ We could tell you who your family is, or was- we suspect you're probably part of the group that got stolen, most of their parents are dead- maybe even what your original name was. I know northern Etherians have different traditions compared to the south, but we hold a lot to the first name our parents give us...”

“ I heard about that,” Glimmer said. “ Bow mentioned it. They don't pick their own names, down south.”

Catra, who hadn't either- Shadow Weaver had named her, more or less simply to give her something to be called- shrugged at the knowledge, even as some part of her... wondered. What *had* been her original family, if the war hadn't taken it from her? If the Horde hadn't taken her? Who would her family be?

" I'm sorry," Orwall said. " I'll go."

She turned to leave, but before Catra could resolve her own feelings, it was Glimmer who spoke up.

" Wait," she said, before turning to Catra. " You- give me Bow, then go with her and let her stab you or whatever."

" Really?" Catra said, and Glimmer nodded.

" This is *home,*" Glimmer said. " You're stuck, I'm afraid. You are *never* going to be free of me as your sister, I don't care *who* the fuck you turn out to be related to. I'm your big sister and that will *never* change."

It was odd, how much comfort Catra drew from that.

" But... if there's people out there, missing a daughter... cousins, who think you're dead... all kinds of other people who might be kin, or just want to know what happened to a friend's kid. Those people deserve closure," Glimmer said.

Then she leaned closer and whispered so that Orwall could not hear.

" And... well, sis," Glimmer whispered " No offense, but you never *could* let go of anything about your past... you're going to be caught on this for the rest of your life if you don't, always wondering what you might have found out. It's not a betrayal of Mom or me. You're not replacing us, you're just finding *more* family."

...*She **does** know me well,* Catra thought, and looked at her sister for a long, long moment... before handing her Bow.

" Alright," she said, as Glimmer took up the limp archer. " I'll do that."

" You will?!?" Orwall said, perking up so quick that Catra felt an almost uncontrollable urge to pat her on the head. Her ears were aimed dead on at Catra, and her tail curled around.

" Good!" Glimmer said- before immediately complaining. " Oh no, I forgot about my back!"

She immediately began to collapse as her muscles pulled once more. Before she hit the floor, Catra caught Bow again, as Glimmer ended up laying down once more.

“ Why didn't you catch me toooooo...” her sister protested from the floor.

“ Because Bow is unconscious and can't save himself,” Catra said. “ ...Queen Orwall?”

“ Just call me Orwall! Oh, I'm so glad you agreed! I'm so sorry I screwed it up!” the Magicat replied.

“ No problem,” Catra said. “ I'm... gonna drop my friends off in their rooms before we talk. Wait right here, if you would.”

“ Absolutely!” Orwall said perkily as Catra bent down and, with a grunt of effort, picked her sister up, too.

“ You're going to the healers,” she said.

“ Let me diiiiiieeeee.....”

Chapter End Notes

I had a LOT of fun imagining Glimmer's continuing back pains.

Frosta is a teenager at this point in the timeline- remember, it's been four years. That's partly why she's thinking about Glimmer sometimes. She's also really well-read so she's well

aware of sex.
(Juliet, for her part, just kind of thinks of Frosta as "the Snows Princess" and assigns her adult status in her head- not the best thing to do, but Juliet doesn't much like the Snows and so doesn't care to think about Frosta more than she has to.)

Chapter 50: A Once-Hordesman in Brightmoon Castle

Chapter Notes

It's a day late- well, two days late, but I haven't slept yet, so it's still Saturday as far as I'm concerned.

Still, upload!

Entrapta, and her thoughts in the wake of Micah's reappearance.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A Once-Hordesman in Brightmoon Castle

Entrapta, Princess of Dryl since she was far too young, once-Princess of the Alliance, once-Hordesman, and now for a second time a member of the Princess Alliance- and that only by the grace of Angella, Catra, and the promise they had kept to *him*- waited in a guest room of Brightmoon Castle. She had taken the opportunity provided by Micah's appearance and Angella's dead faint to slither out of the Council meeting room without anyone noticing. It was one of the first times she'd been back to the Castle in person, and not through a robot mediator, since her trial, and it was not... pleasant.

Those had been bad days, in the immediate aftermath of *his* death.

Thankfully, she had distraction. Scorpia was a joy, and her presence drove the memories back a bit.

Not all the way, of course, because nothing could do that. *His* death would sit, an open grave, an empty mine, unfulfilled earth, inside Entrapta all the days of her life, this she knew already. Only his return- an impossibility, a number she cannot create through any equation she can compute- would spare her that fate, and even wonderful Scorpia, miraculous Scorpia- who was alive when she should be dead- cannot give that joy to her.

But Scorpia *was* a joy, and a distraction, and those were sorely needed presents at this time of Entrapta's life.

" So... what all did this fake-me do?" Scorpia asked. She'd been given a mild rundown on the way back, but they'd come back at all speed; they'd barely had time to stop and refuel. Micah wanted to get home, to see the woman he loved- and Entrapta, who understood the sentiment better than most, had been glad to provide.

If she could see *him* again... oh yes, she would go with all speed, with all haste, to that meeting, if it could be managed. And had she not sent a jet to retrieve *her* , if *she* would deign to come?

Oh yes, Entrapta had understood Micah's motivations well; for all the distance between her and other people, in this one thing, Entrapta had a solid grounding. She understood *love.*

(And maybe she understood **hate** , too... but that was for another day.)

" They mostly reported back our movements," Entrapta answered. " Troop coordinations and the like."

" Oh man," Scorpia said, nervously scratching her chin. " I hope no one holds it against me! I wouldn't even know who to send that report to! And I wouldn't help Adora anyway. She tried to kill me! And my throat still hurts from where she stabbed me!"

Entrapta remembered that well- the same fight where Adora had smashed Emily to pieces. Entrapta's bots had carried her to safety after she lost that fight; Adora was a fierce fighter. Not a Princess, thankfully; she was dangerous enough without extra power.

(Somewhere far away, Adora had the sudden urge to laugh, and did not know why.)

" Do not worry," Entrapta said. " They are good people, here."

And as if summoned, in through the door came Imp- and someone else.

" Hello!" *Perfuma* said. " Entrapta! It is so good to see you... and this is the real Scorpia, right?"

“ It is,” Entrapta breathed. “ I... thought you'd wait on the Doom Balloon.”

“ I was going to!” *Perfuma* said, wringing *her* hands a bit nervously. Entrapta, who drew comfort from habit too, said nothing about the act.. “ But... well, Shadow Weaver was up there, and... I didn't feel like staying? She sent me down here, and told me that you were in the Castle. Imp seemed to know where, so I just followed him!”

“ I'm most glad to have you,” Entrapta said, and meant it, meant it with all her heart. “ Thank you for coming.”

“ It's no trouble!” *she* said, before turning to Scorpia. “ And... it's nice to finally meet you! In peace, that is, not... on a battlefield. I think we've fought before!”

“ We have! And it's nice to meet you too!” Scorpia said, extending a claw out before, awkwardly, retracting it. “ Err, sorry, you... probably don't want to touch a claw.”

“ Why wouldn't I?” *Perfuma* said, because of course that's what *she* said; *she* was a saint, after all. “ Do you wish me harm?”

“ Oh, no!” Scorpia said. “ I mean, before, yeah, when I was with the Horde, but I'm not with them anymore, so like... yeah, I'm on your side now!”

“ Entrapta?” *Perfuma* said, turning to her; and the force of *her* attention, for a brief moment, drove all thought from Entrapta's mind. “ Is Scorpia on our side now?”

“ Yes,” the Drylborn responded after a long minute, and *she* clapped in delight.

“ Then welcome to the Princess Alliance!” *she* said, smiling so bright and beautiful, the most precious flower in all Plumeria's many gardens. “ I'm so glad we don't have to fight anymore! I like fighting, maybe, kind of, but I much prefer peace! We can be friends!”

“ ...They told me in the Horde that you'd... hate how freaky I looked,” Scorpia responded, and *her* face fell as she came close.

“ Why in the world would we do that?!?” *she* protested. “ No, no, not at all! My only grudge against you was when you were in the Horde! And you're not freaky at all!”

No, *she* wasn't looking at Scorpia as though the Scorpioni was freaky. *She* was looking at Scorpia with... open interest, if Entrapta was not wrong, running *her* eyes down long muscular lines, sleek carapace, taking all of Scorpia in and finding beauty there.

And while Entrapta was wrong about people- so wrong, so often, until the day she believed **Adora** and all **her** lies, and it became too wrong and too often, and she betrayed the Princess Alliance for a falsehood- she did not think she was wrong about *her* desires.

Entrapta had been in love before, too, after all.

...Was in love again, in her own way, with *her.*

So Entrapta did the only thing she could.

" Scorpia," she prodded her friend, " why don't you talk with Perfuma a while? You haven't had much social interaction recently; it'll do you good to talk to someone new. You can tell her about the plants you saw on Beast Island, or in the Fright Zone."

" Oh, we don't have many plants down south!" Scorpia said. " Though I think we had more, once? I see the drawings on the old stuff, sometimes. It's just cacti these days."

" Oh, tell me about them!" *Perfuma* said, as Entrapta had known she would, clapping *her* hands delightedly. " And I can tell you some of the ideas I had for helping the Fright Zone, once we win- the Horde's hurt it, but the last Princess kept some of the seeds when we thought it was going to go bad! I might be able to restore it! It's always been a desert- well, the Fright Zone proper

was, anyway- but every year, during the big rains, there was a short time when it came so beautifully alive.”

“ Really?” Scorpia said. “ I've seen the cactuses, they get flowers sometimes. Not often. But they're the only plants that have survived, really. I... like them.”

The answering smile *she* gave back was so blinding in its radiance that Entrapta had to lower her mask to look at it without going blind.

(A smile not directed at the Drylborn- but that was okay. If *she* smiled like that at all, then it was good...)

“ Oh, me too!” said the *saint,* unaware of Entrapta's thoughts, or the melancholic joy in the Drylborn's covered eyes as she looked at all that joy . “ I didn't appreciate desert plants before, but after going to the Waste... I see the beauty there, now. Not just the flowers- pretty as they are!- but in their *nature.* They survive such harsh conditions- I'm not surprised that even the Horde can't quite kill all of them! The roots go so deep, they are so strong; they are magnificent survivors! There's so much *more* to them than I ever thought!”

“ I... always kinda liked the cacti,” Scorpia said, a little awkwardly. “ Cause... well, they were spiky, and tough, like me... but they had really pretty flowers? I... I know I'm kind of... odd looking.”

“ Scorpia!” *she* gasped. “ What are you saying? You're absolutely gorgeous!”

Scorpia blushed so deeply that she was momentarily the color of Hordak's wings on the old Horde banner.

" I- you think so?" the giant responded, still awkward.

" Of course!" *Perfuma* said, reassuring the giant- because of course *she* would be kind, and loving, and above and beyond all expectation. It was, somehow, the thing Entrapta had learned to expect out of the *lady* ; that she would go beyond expectation. " Just look at you! Strong, powerful, but your disposition so far has been entirely sweet!"

" A-and the, uhh, pincers? And tail?" Scorpia said, somehow finding her tongue underneath her smothering blush.

" They are lovely too!" *she* insisted; and Entrapta, who had received so many kindnesses from *her,* knew that *she* spoke the truth, that *she* was not just saying it to be polite, or to gain something in terms of politics. *She* was, as ever, better than that- the most comforting kind of normal, this constant peak performance. " Why would you say they are not?"

" Because... it's not... human?" Scorpia said awkwardly. " The others- the Force Captains, especially Octavia and Dreer- they told me that they wouldn't like me up north..."

" I already said that they lied to you," *Perfuma* said, anger clear on *her* face and in *her* tone. " I am Plumerian! Did they not tell you how we love insects?"

" ...No?" Scorpia said.

" Then you were lied to, as I was," Entrapta said, deciding to enter the conversation here- she knew about being lied to, after all. It was what **she** had done, to turn Entrapta against the others. " Plumerians think of insect life as the first children of the All."

" Because it's true!" *she* said. " Look at the world of plants- it is insects that do the pollinating! Why, flowers and trees would not even exist but for the efforts of chitinous life! Our insect brethren do great and grand work. And they are beautiful! Look at the shine of light on a dragonfly's back, or the wonder that is a spider's web! Miracles in nature."

Scorpia was looking at *her* with eyes misty with unshed tears; and *she* moved forward, took a grip on not just one but both pincers, taking all of Scorpia in and not finding her wanting.

" And a scorpion- fierce and strong and brave," *she* said, holding hands with Scorpia and looking the Fright Zone native in the eye. " We have scorpions, too, in the south, near your old homelands; armored and strong, hardy survivors. Unwilling to back down, to run away, ready to take on all comers. We've viewed them as symbols of courage for centuries... it was one reason we always admired the Scorpioni, before the Horde. Brave and unrelenting."

She smiled again, and it was still the most intoxicating drug to ever come out of Plumeria.

" Not ugly."

" That... that sounds amazing," Scorpia said, with tears in her eyes, and then all of a sudden the big woman drew *her* into a big hug. " Thank you, thank you so much! No one's ever said something so nice to me before!"

She, after a moment's surprise, laughed in that lovely way *she* had, and then hugged Scorpia back.

In a moment, they drew apart- but they looked in each other's eyes, at the end.

And Entrapta, who knew so little of people, did know much of love- and so she thought that would be the exact moment when it became inevitable, the moment that meant that, inevitably, Scorpia and *Perfuma* would get together.

Yes, if Entrapta's hypothesis was right, then the two of them were going to become one, for however long that would be. Impossible to tell at this point in the experiment; charts and data paths could not account for all the variables in such a thing. Personality variables Entrapta did not know, random chance, the intervention

of others... too much for Entrapta to predict anything further than that.

But that was alright. It was enough to begin.

Likewise, it was okay that *she* did not love Entrapta back. After all that *she* had already given Entrapta, the Drylborn would never push for more; she was not so terribly greedy by nature, not so awful as to demand more when she could only have ever expected nothing. *She* had given Entrapta more than she deserved already; to ask for more would be ungrateful at best, petty at worst.

No, Entrapta was just glad that she could give a little back, that she could offer to *her* something, in return for all the things Entrapta herself had already received. If Scorpia made *her* happy, then Entrapta, too, was content.

The two were still talking, paying no attention to anything else; and that was... well, Entrapta had read that it was called being a third wheel, and that didn't seem very sensible to her. Paired wheels were almost always better for most things.

So she slipped out, left them as two wheels to spin together, to go wherever they would, glad to bring a little joy to *her*- and to Scorpia, too, who was one of Entrapta's few friends. Maybe it would work out for them; Entrapta hoped it would.

But that was up to them, not her. So out- out the door, slithering quietly and silently, saying only that she had to check on something, and that she'd be back, leaving them to their own devices for a bit. Into the hallway, the door shut carefully, as the Princess of Dryl pondered her options. Of those left in the Castle... Glimmer was not quite a friend, but was something of an... ally, perhaps?

But Catra was a friend... maybe she would seek her out. Entrapta yet owed her; maybe she would go, and see what she could do, what could be done, to assist. Entrapta's grand plan was growing ever closer to completion- all that was needed was to make Scorpia connect with the Garnet, and they would be done, they would be ready, they would wipe the Horde off the map and make **her** pay.

But in the meantime, she'd see what she could help Catra with.

She moved in loose coils down the hall, quieter than footsteps, not feeling like disturbing anyone, and caught up in her own thoughts; and maybe that was a mistake, because by accident, she managed to eavesdrop on a conversation for two, sneaking up on them without meaning to, managing to make a third wheel of herself yet again.

" What will you do now?" was the first thing she heard; Entrapta curled up away on instinct, having stumbled too close to two people. One was wearing the armor of a Hive member, the other was... Peekablue, she thought. She'd read a dossier on him once, at least. From Seaworthy, if she didn't miss her guess.

She was too close to slip away easily, so she just stayed around the corner, unwillingly being a voyeur on this private moment.

" I... am not sure," he was responding to the other. " I don't know if I'll return to my club; I'm a bit afraid Netossa will make good on her threat. Maybe I'll stay away for a bit... or maybe I have to be there, to defend it. I'm... not sure, Sweet Bee."

" I... I didn't know they'd threatened you," the Hiver said, anguish clear in her voice. " I'll have words with them. They *won't* destroy your club. You have my word."

" ...Don't," he said, anguish just as clear in his own voice. " Don't... risk yourself like that. They didn't threaten my life, Netossa was clear on that; just property. Don't... you need their support to stay *alive,* you're out there *fighting,* my dear. Please, think no more of this..."

" How can I, when I know you're going to lose your club? That place is so precious to you..." she said, and he laughed, voice just a little thick with emotion.

" You go to war every day, and you worry about a rich man's playhouse," he said, shaking his head and looking at her with... with *love* , Entrapta knew that look. A hand raised, as if to embrace her, before falling to his side, as if the love between them was... stopped, somehow. " You are too good for the world we live in; too sweet. No wonder you come from a land that makes honey and ambrosia."

“ Smooth talker,” she said, her voice thick too. “ Peekie...”

“ Now, now,” he said, shaking his head. “ Let's... let's leave it at that. I don't want you to risk yourself for me- you're far too valuable for that.”

And with that- and with effort visible and obvious even to Entrapta- he turned away from Sweet Bee and her protests, and walked off, stiff, as if it hurt him to do so.

...What in the world was happening here? There was love here... why not be together? Why separate? The man turned a corner and was gone, and Sweet Bee had a hand out, as if to reach out to him... but she made no move. She did not follow.

Why?!?

It wasn't her place but Entrapta had never been socially adept, it was part of her strangeness, and this... this was *love,* and Entrapta, who would never see *him* again, could not help the words that fell out of her mouth.

“ Why aren't you chasing him?” she asked as she emerged from the shadows, Sweet Bee leaping back- into a fighting stance and an attack both, apparently Peekablue had been right about Sweet Bee's combat experience. It was only Sweet Bee's restraint that

prevented her from decking the Princess of Dryl with a good right hook- she'd been halfway into the punch before she stopped herself.

" The- were you eavesdropping?!?" the Hiver said, outraged.

" Not on purpose," Entrapta said, " but moving on- you love him, why aren't you following?"

" What do you care? You're a Hordesman," Sweet Bee said, shaking her head and nodding at the flag for a sleeve that Entrapta had sewn into all her outfits, her way of declaring allegiance to *him,* even after death. " I know who you are- Princess of Dryl, right? A twice-traitor- once to the Alliance, once to the Horde."

" **Her** Horde was not *his,* " Entrapta protested... before sighing. " But yes."

Because the rest of it was true, whether she wanted it to be or not.

(Twice-traitor; and both times because of **her** .)

There was silence a long moment, before Sweet Bee spoke, something angry and furious smoldering in her eyes.

“ I used to admire you so much,” Sweet Bee admitted, shaking her head. “ You were the best of us, you know? The Smith Princess, the leader of Dryl, who took such good care of her people. They love you, you know? Even now. You've done so much good for them that they choose to interpret everything you do in a positive light. They think you've got some master plan, that you're playing some impossible game that only you are smart enough to put together. But I've asked around; that's not what you're doing at all, is it?”

In the face of her anger, Entrapta could do nothing but curl up, away from her, and let the truth out like poison she had to spit.

“ No,” she admitted. “ It's not.”

“ Figures,” Sweet Bee said, sounding... disappointed? “ I was hoping I was wrong. That you'd... dammit, I admired you. I admired you so much. The Crownless leader who was better than any Kingdom ruler, even Angella herself, more beloved in her land than any lord except maybe King Narwahl in Galacia- and he formed his nation! You were the best of us... and that mattered so much to me. I fight in this war for we Crownless, you know? Because we... we always get pushed around. I fight to prove that we have teeth, that we can fight, that the history of the world isn't that of the Kingdoms alone. And you... you were one of us, doing so well that they couldn't deny it! You were...”

She fumbled for a moment, and Entrapta wondered at how high the respect this woman had once had for her had been, for her to be so... so angry, and so hurt, by Entrapta's actions, when they'd never been directed at Sweet Bee at all.

“ So... why, then? Why turn your coat?” Sweet Bee finally asked, giving up on anything more complicated, asking that most fundamental of all scientific inquiries: why .

The answer came to Entrapta, and the answer was *him,* and that was related to why she'd approached Sweet Bee at all... so it gave Entrapta strength, rallied her so that she could draw up in her coils of hair and stand strong.

“ ... *Love* ,” Entrapta said. “ The same as you with Peekablue.”

That threw the Rebel off, her eyes widening, and making her take a step back, out of striking range.

“ I- what?!?” she responded.

“ I know about *love* ,” Entrapta insisted, hoping she could cross that barrier that had always blocked her, finally communicate this fact she knew that was so important. She didn't know why she cared that Sweet Bee hear her out; but maybe...

(Maybe it was because, if she would listen, if she would just listen, then Entrapta could- in some small way- make up for the pain she'd caused)

“ Yeah, I heard about you and Hordak, of all fucking people,” Sweet Bee snarked, but Entrapta vigorously shook her head.

“ Then you know I'm telling the truth,” she insisted. “ I know how precious time with the one you *love* is. And... how fast you can lose them.”

Sweet Bee had no answer to that, save to bite at her lip, displaying where some fight or another had left her with fewer teeth than most, echoes of war- and Entrapta wondered if she had ever fought against her bots, if some of her hurt was more directly Entrapta's fault.

“ Go to him,” Entrapta insisted. “ Go. There is so little time and it is never enough... it is never enough. Please. For... for your own sake, you have to go to him...”

“ ...We never came totally together because of the war,” Sweet Bee admitted, like ripping a stinger from her own flesh. “ But... he's made a decision, now. He was forced here- and I had no idea that Netossa was pulling her bullshit on him, we're gonna have words - but it does mean his desire to stay out of it isn't viable, anymore. We always said that maybe if things changed...”

“ Tonight changed things,” Entrapta said. She'd picked up enough from the others to know that- had heard of the vote, and all that had come of it. For those who weren't talking about Micah's return, they were talking of the vote. “ Maybe they changed them enough. You'll never know if you don't go to him.”

" ...Maybe tonight did change things enough..." Sweet Bee said, and glanced back in the direction Peekablue had went, with eyes full of a longing Entrapta knew well- that desire to be with one you *loved.*

Entrapta would never be able to do that again- that desire in her would go unrequited, for *he* was dead and *she* did not love Entrapta back- but Sweet Bee could still have something, and for whatever reason, right now, it mattered to Entrapta that she do so.

" I look like that, too, sometimes," Entrapta said, hoping her words would work, fit, that just this once she could be socially adept and not socially clumsy. Perhaps, just this once, her words would strike true. " But I will never be able to go to the one I love, ever again. You still can."

" ...Life never was certain, that's why we have to work together," Sweet Bee said, sighing. " Old Hive philosophy."

" Wise," Entrapta said. She'd heard that doctrine too, in her search for words and meaning in the wake of *Hordak's* death.

" ...Entrapta?" Sweet Bee finally said.

" Yes?"

" Thank you," Sweet Bee said. " I'm... I still can't... reconcile how much I used to adore you with... everything. But... for this? Thank you."

" I do not seek forgiveness," Entrapta said. " I have only ever been forgiven by one, and *she* is more than any other now living. But... if I can help... I will do what I can."

" ...Hivers hate ingratitude," Sweet Bee said. " I love our philosophy... and a big chunk of it is... acknowledging debts. Hivers pay their debts. I'm not sure how that works out with the harm you already owe me... but... well, you're back on this side, aren't you? Despite that flag you're wearing for a sleeve."

" Yes," Entrapta hissed, hand reflexively touching the old Horde flag she was using as a sleeve, that she'd added to all her clothes. Her loyalty had been to *him,* not this new thing **she** had carved out of his corpse. " **She** killed *him.* I want **Adora** dead."

Sweet Bee nodded.

" Then... if you need help... ask. I'll do what I can," Sweet Bee said. " Let's call the past even. If you want the Horde gone, then you're on the side of the Rebellion, and... well, that's enough for me. I won't forgive you anything- I've lost people, good soldiers, to your bots- but... I don't know. You're not like I thought you'd be. I can live and let live."

And that was nice, to be... not forgiven, but... accepted. The past not forgotten, not redeemed, but... put in abeyance, for now. A decision to treat Entrapta not with the vitriol she deserved, nor the friendship she did not, but to be somewhere in the middle, to be allowed in at least this much, to be called an ally, at least.

" Thank you," Entrapta said, and Sweet Bee gave her a crooked smile.

" See ya, Princess Entrapta," she said, and- slowly, as if not sure she should, but giving it anyway- making a salute to her, a sign of respect.

Then Sweet Bee walked off, in the direction of her man; a bee in search of her honey, and that thought made Entrapta smile, and wish her the best. Love was a bounty, a wonder, a joy... even in the loss of it, there was sweetness in having had it at all. Even love that wasn't returned had a kind of delicacy to it, a kind of **bitter** *sweetness* - but **bitter** did not drown out the *sweet.*

Mind full of thoughts of *him* and *her,* and feeling happier than she had in a long, long time, Entrapta kept going deeper into the Castle, to find Catra and hang out with her. To let Sweet Bee and Peekablue, maybe, become one; to give Perfuma and Scorpia room to become whatever they would become.

Today was a good day.

(And she never knew that she had set Sweet Bee and Perfuma on a collision course, or all that would come of it.)

Chapter End Notes

I'm sure that last line won't lead to cataclysm in the future!

Next chapter: Probably hanging out with Catra and Orwall and blood! Or maybe we'll be further south. We'll see~

Chapter 51: Magicats of Etheria

Chapter Notes

> Fun fact on ages- my story takes place over a slightly longer timeline than the main show, mostly because Adora's not as prone to "burn it all down" plans like Catra, and because Catra took a lot longer to warm up to the Alliance than Adora did, meaning the War dragged on a bit longer before the Portal incident.
>
> The end result is that Catra is twenty-two at this point in the story (she just turned twenty-two fairly recently, actually). Adora is twenty-two as well, but is about half a year older than Catra. Orwall is actually a full year older than Catra, despite how she acts, because she's had a much easier life than Catra has and isn't half as cynical.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Magicats of Etheria

Dropping off Glimmer and Bow in a side room- while snarking at her sister not to molest the archer in his sleep, which Glimmer protested loudly and with a great blush on her face- was the work of a few minutes. Even when not in her bigger form, Catra was plenty strong enough to haul some people around; even without transforming, she had some of her greater self's strength.

(And she wasn't going to think of how she kept, instinctively, wanting to *go* big, to become She-Ra, to use... the Sword...)

So back, and when Orwall asked for a room, they'd taken over a nearby unused kitchen. Brightmoon Castle was huge, and much of it was deliberately designed as extra space, for festivals, feasts, major meetings, and to contain as many of Brightmoon's people as possible in the event of disaster or siege; as a useful benefit, when those things *weren't* happening, there was basically always a free room available if one was needed.

So now they were here, in this side room. Orwall had a pack laid out on a convenient table, they were both sitting on the soft seats Brightmoon favored, and Orwall pulled out a small needle from the kit. She ran a cold flame she summoned from her finger over it- sterilizing it, perhaps?- before she smiled at Catra.

" Okay!" Orwall said brightly. " We just need some of your blood, and we can start testing!"

" ...Yeah, before you bleed me," Catra said, amused despite herself at the overly-excitable girl before her, " you're gonna have to lay out what we're doing."

Orwall squeaked quickly before recovering with visible effort. Apparently Queens in Halfmoon were not taught how to handle diplomacy... or the nation had a very different idea of what being a Queen entailed, as compared to Brightmoon.

(Admittedly, what with her Mom being the only Queen Catra had ever met- did Frosta and Perfuma count? They were *like* Queens even if they were called Princesses- Catra was well aware that she was probably judging the girl too harshly. It was hard to compete with an immortal, and harder still to compete with Angella in Catra's eyes.)

“ So!” Orwall said, moving past the awkward moment. “ This magic here? It's old stuff. *Real* old. We learned it back in the days when Saz first put us here; there weren't many of us, and we had to be careful not to inbreed! So we developed magic to tell us who was related to who, and how closely. That way we could spread our genes out until we had a population big enough that we didn't have to worry about that. And it's come back handy again recently, for identifying stolen kids!”

“ Stolen?” Catra asked, raising an eyebrow.

“ Yeah!” Orwall said. “ You were probably stolen yourself.”

Is that how I got to the Fright Zone?” Catra said. “ No one would ever tell me. Shadow Weaver claimed she found me in a box.”

“ Many of our people were taken,” Orwall said. “ Before we ran underground, we were at war with the Horde, and they stole kids a lot to make soldiers. You are almost certainly from that time period- it matches up to your age. You look to be in your early twenties? And they didn't take older kids. So twenty-one or so?”

“ I have no idea,” Catra admitted with a shrug. “ If you say early twenties, that's the best guess I've ever heard. How old are you?”

" Twenty-three!" Orwall said cheerfully. " So same area, though obviously I wasn't taken. The kids from the last raid- when they destroyed Saz's tomb, and His holy corpse along with it- would be about your age now."

" Why was that the last raid?" Catra asked. " I never saw other people like me in the Horde. I assumed I was a one-off."

" No idea," Orwall said with a shrug. " They stole a lot more than just you, I'm not sure why you never saw any."

(Unbeknownst to them, it was Shadow Weaver's fault- Shadow Weaver, who hated Catra, but could not kill her because of Adora, and so took out her frustration on other budding Magicats, until those few who lived did so because they joined Vultak in the south.)

" Eh, who knows," Catra shrugged. " Horde's a big place. So the spell identifies the living?"

" Yep!" Orwall said. " It can even identify bones as well! You can modify the spell to work on the dead, so long as you have a living person's blood to compare the bones to. Obviously we don't have to do that here, since you're alive, but it's good for identifying the dead and making sure they get proper burial rites."

" ...What *are* your burial rites?" Catra asked, curious as to why it would be so important to make sure the dead got proper respect.

“ Oh, that's... hmm, give me a second,” Orwall said. “ It's... kind of a big subject, but it's also something we don't talk about with outsiders much? But you're not really an outsider, not by choice anyway, so... give me a second.”

Catra waited as Orwall organized herself, curious as to why it was such a big deal. The Horde made a big deal out of the “proper” burial that all good little Hordesmen got; the final service at the factory farms, where soldiers got to feed the next generation. Catra had never put much stock in it; she'd always known that, when she died, her corpse would be tossed aside, not given right treatment. If she was to get a proper burial, the enzymes eating her flesh to fertilize the soil, it would have only been at Adora's hands, and it would be a lonely funeral.

(Thought it *had* comforted her, that there was a chance- slim as Shadow Weaver's love- that Adora might ensure she was buried as she should be, if she could.)

Since she'd left, Catra had heard or seen a dozen different ways of dealing with the dead, information she'd never sought out but picked up from osmosis and from being involved in the War; she'd attended quite a few funerals herself, mostly the quick ones soldiers gave comrades who'd fallen in battle. Most Crownless buried their dead, save Blackmoor, which had complicated funeral rites; sometimes they buried the dead, but other times they burned them, or gave them to the sky, or interred them in the sea, all according to some stricture Catra didn't know and had never cared to parse out. Salineans gave the dead to the sea, while Plumerians buried the body without a coffin into the earth, to “give back”, they said- which always struck Catra as oddly similar to the Horde, a thought she'd never voiced to Perfuma or anyone else, but *had* told Bow and Glimmer.

(Glimmer had been grossed out by the Horde's burial practices, likening it to eating the dead; Bow, on the other hand, had been surprised by the sentiment involved, and not a little touched, commenting that it didn't sound so bad, the way Catra put it.)

Catra's own home of Brightmoon, meanwhile, viewed death as so personal that there was no one set pattern, many of Brightmoon's people making unusual requests as to what was to be done with their remains. Most asked for cremation, the ashes spread somewhere important in life, but others went with the Salinean or Plumerian methods, or for stranger, more personalized fates; Catra had heard of those who'd asked that their bodies just be left where they lay, if it could be done, or taken somewhere that animals could eat it.

She'd mostly found out about that while helping Mermista down south; Mermista had jokingly asked her Brightmoon friends what they wanted done with their corpses, one night, and the discussion had been... enlightening. Glimmer had changed her mind twice before settling on being cremated and her ashes thrown into the wind. Bow had one-upped that by asking that he be cremated, and his ashes carried into the Horde and thrown into Hordak's face, which had gotten even dour Mermista to burst out laughing.

(Sea Hawk had suggested his body be put on a boat at sea and then burned along with the boat,combining both fire with Salinean traditions of returning to the sea; everyone had agreed that it was the only thing that *could* be done with his body, to burn at least one more boat.)

Catra had demurred the answer, at the time; she hadn't liked thinking about her own death then, and wasn't super fond of it

now. She'd dealt with that terror too often in childhood.

But still she was... curious... as to what Orwall's people did.

Orwall's people... who'd be my people, maybe, except that I was taken.

It was an odd thought, and made Catra feel strangely... nostalgic, and all for a place she'd never even seen. It wasn't like wanting to go home- Catra had felt that before, that keening when one was out and about, that pain inside that could only be assuaged by going *home* ; that pain, that need to be here, at the castle, with her family and her friends, safe and loved... that was a sharp pain, that was pain like a knife.

This... this was slow, and quiet, and sad.

This was like drowning, in an almost pleasant way- bittersweet. To learn now would not change the past, but it would... mean something, to recover this much of who she might have been.

Not sure what... but I'm... I'm sad because her people never had the chance to be my people. Halfmoon never had a chance to ***be*** *home... and I'll never know what kind of Catra I'd be, growing up down there.*

Maybe I'd have been like Orwall.

She looked at the girl again- well, woman, if she was being honest. Her age, or near about. She *seemed* young, but she wasn't when Catra gave her a good look.

She's just... innocent, in a way. Compared to me. What is Halfmoon like, to make a Queen like this? It... it can't be too bad... and that... makes me a little glad, that I'll get to find out, at least a little.

So with that bittersweetness inside, Catra waited patiently for Orwall to say her piece.

" So!" Orwall said, because that was apparently her favorite way to start a sentence. " We... our dead matter to us. That a person lived... that's a big deal, you know? Life is like... okay, you ever see a big storm? The lightning?"

" Sure," Catra responded.

" A life is like a thunderbolt," Orwall said. " Here and gone. But it mattered that it was there at all, you know? There should be a record. A memory. We're not animals. We're *people.* A person deserves to be remembered, to have a record made, and kept... to have what is left of them treated well. With *respect.* To remember them."

...That sounded nice, if resource-intensive, as the part of Catra that would never stop being a Hordesman pointed out. Orwall, unaware of Catra's thoughts, kept going.

" So we mummify our dead, if we can. That's the *best* way to honor the dead, to take their body, mummify it, and place it in grand sarcophagi, of stone or whatever hard materials we can find. Not so good, but still acceptable, is engravings of the person with their name and things that mattered to them... that's a lot more common now," Orwall said with a sigh. " The War... we're strapped for supplies. The rich and powerful ended up hoarding all the embalming fluid, at least until I changed the law, made them give it up; we embalm who we can, on a lottery basis. The rest just get the engravings. Gave me all kinds of shit with the rich, but it's one of the few powers the Crown still possesses- the right to dictate what is to be done with the dead."

" ...Few powers?" Catra said, quirking an eyeball. " Aren't you the Queen?"

" Not like Angella!" Orwall said, grinning. " That became obvious the second I started learning about Brightmoon. Queen Angella's *powerful,* she's like some of the old stories from Saz's time, of the old kings and queens! She can do all kinds of stuff. Me, I'm... kinda superfluous, these days. Mostly I just sign stuff and show up to raise morale; like I said, having the ability to say what is done with the dead is like one of the only powers I *do* have left, governmentally speaking. Most of the other stuff I still have, I can't use due to the War- we're all living underground now, so my ability to initiate road construction is, you know, not exactly available."

Catra couldn't help the smirk that flickered over her face at that.

“ I mean, you could order new tunnels dug,” she said, and Orwall snorted.

“ And risk destabilizing the bunkers? No way,” she said. “ The Congress put a ban on that immediately; we're not good enough at geology to know what we can and can't mess around with, so we're not touching it. Too risky. One wrong move, and that's it for our people. We still have room, at least; the caves are vast, and we... we lost a lot of people before we went underground.”

Orwall's ears drooped, and Catra was moved to comfort her.

“ Hey,” she said. “ Don't give up hope.”

“ I haven't,” Orwall said, and smiled at Catra, eyes gleaming. “ *You're* here. The She-Ra... and one of us, to boot. You... you're a hero to me, Catra.”

Orwall suddenly blushed, and looked down, speaking rapidly.

“ To- to a lot of people!” she said, clearly flustered. “ They even call you Saz's Revenge, some think you're him reborn!”

...This was like Scorpia, all over again... still wistfully pleasant. Catra's heart would forever belong to only one, through all hell and high water; but this...

It was nice, for someone to look at her, and feel such affection.

(Even if being reminded of the She-Ra horrified Catra, made her want to be sick... but she couldn't talk about the Sword, or the truth, with a stranger...)

" I appreciate that," Catra said. " Though... Saz's Revenge?"

" Oh, umm... wow, you know so little, but of course you wouldn't, you're so far north... the Horde stole so much of you..." Orwall frowned again, ears flat, before recovering with a will. " So! I'll teach you! Saz... he's our god. My ancestor, supposedly. Our first king, the one who commanded us to to cross the Sea of Stars, and settle here, on Etheria, so far from our home, sacred Thundera."

Sea of Stars?... the visions I saw, of what the Sword would do...

Without meaning to, Catra blurted out, " I've seen it."

" What?" Orwall said.

" The... the Sea of Stars," Catra said, internally cursing herself. With her heart all out of whack- what with the Sword and the meeting today- it was harder to keep a watch on her mouth. Begrudgingly, she followed with, " I've seen it."

" ...How?" Orwall asked, and Catra cursed her loose tongue once more.

" ...Can't tell you," she said. It involved the Sword too much. " But... I've seen it."

" What's it like?" Orwall asked, eyes wide and wondering... and even Catra didn't have a spiky enough heart to tell *that* face no.

But what to say? It was one of the most gorgeous sights I've ever seen, and I glimpsed it during one of the worst experiences of my life? How do I answer about how beautiful that black, woven with light, looked, when the Sword was going to murder those same beautiful points of light?

How the hell do I summarize that?

" ...Overwhelming," Catra finally settled on.

Orwall's eyes grew even bigger.

“ Saz's whiskers...” Orwall exclaimed, putting her hands to her mouth. “ You're telling the truth. The way you look... you saw something incredible, didn't you? Our writings say the Sea of Stars was just... impossible to describe, so vast, so big... Saz's whiskers, *you've seen the Sea of Stars...* maybe I should be saying *your* whiskers, maybe, you might actually *be* Saz reborn if you've seen the Sea!”

“ Saz reborn?” Catra asked. “ I thought I was his revenge?”

“ People have a lot of opinions on you!” Orwall said, pupils wide over her clasped fingers. “ Some think you are our God and Founder's punishment on the Horde, raised there so you could learn their ways to defeat them... but if you've seen *the Sea of Stars...* some think you're Saz reborn...”

“ ...I'm pretty sure I'm not a God,” Catra said. “ Feels like the kind of thing you'd know about yourself, or suspect, at least.”

“ Would you?” Orwall muttered, thinking. “ Not like any gods of any people have ever explained what it's like... maybe you *wouldn't* know.”

The Sword picked me, and it wants to murder everything... I'm pretty sure Gods don't do ***that.*** *No God worth worshiping, anyway.*

“ Let's... let's focus here,” Catra said. “ This... tells me who I'm related to?”

“ Oh, yes, I completely forgot!” Orwall said, hands flying back to her little pack. “ So with a little of your blood, I pass it over these bottles! The needle glows the more related you are. It can find your... well, I can't say family. Your family is *here.* I saw the way you were with Glimmer, and everyone talks of how loyal you are to Queen Angella, how she adopted you. And... apparently you have a dad now! Not... not sure how that works.”

Catra snorted, glad the conversation had moved away from... all that other stuff.

“ Yeah, me neither,” Catra said. “ I thought Micah was *dead.* But... I think it'll be alright.”

“ It will!” Orwall said, so confident, as if she could make it real with force of faith alone. “ We know of Micah in Halfmoon; the King who fought for his people on the frontlines. A *good* man. A hero. We mourned his death, as we mourn all who die fighting the Horde- you guys may well save us. Saz knows we can't break out on our own... we've tried.”

A sigh, before Orwall went back to her bottles.

“ This has blood from noble families but also commoners,” Orwall said. “ Lots of people wanted to donate once I told them what I

was gonna do, but I tried to focus on people with your features; I think ethnically you're a Liger! You've got some features of Wilycats as well, but mostly you seem to be Liger.”

“ Don't know what those are,” Catra said, somewhat amused by Orwall's cheerful barrage of words that meant basically nothing to her.

“ Oh, I guess not!” Orwall said. “ Liger, Wilycat, all that- you know how some species have color variants? Darker or lighter skin, or for the Squamatus, red or green variants, Manes with long fur or short fur- that kind of thing?”

“ Yeah,” Catra said. “ So the Liger thing, it's like that?”

“ Yep!” Orwall said with a smile. “ Liger, Wilycat, those are phenotypes among us! Not different species- we're all Magicats- but we've got some variance in our looks. I'm mostly Lion and Wilycat myself. Liger came about because Tigers and Lions have a long history of interbreeding- they're our most common ethnic groups, and we have a lot of them, so Ligers are also really common!”

“ Which means it'll be harder to find any... relatives,” Catra said, her tongue unwilling to say the word *family.* They wouldn't be family, after all.

(*family* was a small, sad smile; *family* was fists and glitter. *Family* was calm wisdom and the shushed strum of a bowstring... and *family* was, to some extent, hateful eyes in shadow, her first

mother, whom she never *could* let go of, no matter how much she wanted to, that perverse twist of her heart that she had *never* been able to control.)

Still... Catra wanted to know. It would be... it would be good and bad, at once, to know. She didn't know if she'd ever get to connect with any relatives found, but...

Yeah, it'd be nice to *know,* even as much as it would hurt to realize what family she'd missed out on having.

Orwall saw Catra's ears droop as Catra pondered that bittersweet thought, and the Queen's own ears dipped down too.

" Catra..." she began, biting her lip before speaking again. " ...This doesn't... hurt you, does it? I know they aren't family, not really- but... sorry, you seem kind of conflicted, and I don't want this to be a *bad* thing. It's meant to be good. Celebratory. Happy."

...This girl is a sweetheart, Catra thought, and offered up a smile.

" There's happiness," Catra told her. " But... sadness, too. Because... if I have living relatives... then they never got to *be* family, and I never got to have them... but maybe I can, once the War is won. It's happy, but sad, too."

“ I kinda get that,” Orwall said. “ I... learned a lot about my parents in my youth. My moms... they died fighting the Horde. I never got to know them. But learning about them... it was like that. Happy, but sad, too. Because I never got to know them.”

Catra reached out and squeezed the girl's shoulder, who leaned into the touch- even as she squeaked in surprise.

“ I understand,” Catra said.

(And without knowing it, Catra gave her a small, sad smile, one reflecting the one she'd seen on her mother's face.)

“ You need to stab me for this, right?” Catra said, changing the subject, and Orwall's uprising ears and perky smile told her it was the right thing to do.

“ Yep!” she said. “ Just a bit of blood- traditionally it's from your palm. Not sure why!”

Catra held her hand out.

“ You know,” she said, smirking, “ you're the first person I've ever met that wanted to stab me, but in a *nice* way.”

Orwall laughed.

" I mean, it's like surgery! I know a doctor, he jokes that surgery is just a knife murder that the victim survives!" she said. " So... this'll sting a bit!"

She pulled a small wipe from her packet, one that smelled heavily of alcohol to Catra's nose. Her and Orwall's noses wrinkled at the exact same time, and she realized that Orwall, like her, had a powerful sense of smell.

But of course she does. It's normal for... us. For Magicats.

The first time she'd ever really thought of herself *as* a Magicat, some part of her still going off that old idea that she was one of Shadow Weaver's experiments until this point...

...It'd be interesting, to go somewhere, and be among people who were like her, in her way. To, for a little while, go where she was not unique, but just one among many.

*Maybe I **will** go to Halfmoon, relatives or not- for a little while.*

Because Brightmoon was *home,* but Halfmoon could be a vacation, if Catra wanted. A way to see a place that, while it was not and never would be *home,* was a place that *might* have been home... a way to achieve some closure on her own nature.

Or maybe just a place to visit for vacation. I don't have to pick just one or the other, after all.

Orwall gently swabbed Catra's palm with the packet, then stabbed her with the surprisingly cold needle.

" Oof, that's cold," Catra said. " Thought you burned it clean with that fire?"

" Oh, that's freezefire," Orwall said. " Perk of being the Queen is that I get some nice gear! The freezefire is fire that sucks up heat, rather than making it. Still sterilizes, though! And... that's enough."

She pulled the needle out, but Catra waved off the bandage she brought out, showing the wound in her palm already disappearing.

" I heal fast," she said, and Orwall nodded.

" I see! Well... let's run it over the bottles. If it lights up bright, you've got kin!" Orwall said, before turning to her packet.

It glowed, but only dimly, over the first.

“ It'll glow like that because you're a Magicat,” Orwall said. “ We're all related, at least distantly. It'll be brighter the more related you are!”

She passed it over two dozen vials, all kept safe in the pack, and each time, Catra waited with bated breath.

But the light never grew any brighter.

When the last was done, Orwall sighed.

“ So... you're... not anyone's relative,” she said. “ Obviously this isn't everyone, but... I can't say it doesn't feel a bit anticlimatic. Running away from home to meet the She-Ra and keeping all this blood on me, chilling it with my powers whenever I could... and now, you're not related to anyone.”

Catra shrugged, feeling both disappointed and... somewhat relieved. Her family situation was complicated enough as it stood.

“ Eh, it happens,” Catra said. “ Two dozen vials can't be *all* of a people. I might have some relatives anyway.”

“ True,” Orwall said... before her face turned thoughtful. “ And... I kind of like this, actually. I think... yeah, I think it's better this way.”

“ Really?” Catra said.

“ Yeah,” Orwall answered. “ Because... not only does it mean you don't have to worry about who your 'real' family is, or have to fight with yourself about it, because even I can tell you're a bit conflicted there...”

Catra, called out, wanted to argue, but really couldn't, so she just settled on wordless grumbling at Orwall's assessment.

“ So... Hordak fell out of the sky and started conquering,” Orwall said, ears pinned back as she recalled the frightening stories of the monster that had, quite literally, come out of nowhere to make the Horde. “ And this Adora... she's a First One, I heard the others talking about it. They're both... they're *special.* In all the worst ways.”

Orwall shivered.

“ But you... you're just one of us,” she continued, smiling at Catra in a way that made her realize that Orwall was *damn* pretty when she wanted to be. “ A common person. Somebody who could be... anybody. It makes it... it makes it right, that it's you to fight back. Just a Magicat, who could be anyone's daughter, anyone's kin...”

The smile ended, but the light of it lived in Orwall's eyes.

“ One that became a hero.”

Catra demurred, looking away, and Orwall was the one who changed the subject, in her usual manner.

“ So!” she exclaimed. “ I do want to say that I'm glad Brightmoon was the one that got you. They're okay, for a Runestone Kingdom- the only one we really liked, either now or historically. The others ignored us down in the south, except the Fright Zone, which spent all of its time lording over all the Duchies and demanding tribute or they'd invade... but Brightmoon was always polite, and always gave what it could. They're good people, here.”

“ They are,” Catra said, because there was nothing else *to* say.

(She could say it was good beds and good food and good company. She could say it was the land where she was loved. She could say a million things and none of it meant as much as the four letters of the single word *home.*)

Orwall chuckled.

“ Also, it's kinda funny, you went from *Half* a Moon to a *Bright* Moon!” she said. “ What are the chances?!?”

“ That *is* kinda funny,” Catra agreed, as her brain caught up with something else Orwall had said. “ Wait, the Fright Zone was

invading you?”

“ Yeah,” she said. “ Well, threatening to do so unless we paid them a ransom every year. Things got better under King Uinta, from what I've heard from those who were around back then... but the Fright Zone had been falling apart for a long, long time. A shame; back in their history, they used to be good people. They got their name from beating Plumeria's Glory Lilies back so badly that they had to turn north, stay out of the Duchies and focus on easier prey- the Fright Zone, they called it, and the Scorpioni took it up eagerly, defending all the South from predation.”

Orwall sighed.

“ But they hadn't been those protectors in centuries, by the time the Horde conquered them from within.”

Huh. Lot going on there; Catra had never really thought about the Fright Zone *before* the Horde. She'd vaguely sort of known there was history there- sometimes she and Adora would stumble on old stonework, or paintings, in hidden places of the Fright Zone, buried under rubble or in some not-quite-finished building that was cannibalizing the old works there for material... but she hadn't put it together into a single narrative, had not attached the constant stingers-and-lightning imagery to anything more concrete.

(One she remembered in particular, behind a sewage outflow pipe that poured down into a waste treatment facility; the wall had been old brickwork that had never been replaced with the Zone's dark, grim metal. On that old wall, hidden behind that grotesque waterfall of rancid fluid- almost protected by the constant stream, lurking in the dry spot directly beneath the pipe's

opening- had been a carved stone relief of a scorpion with thunderbolts pouring from its tail.)

They were interrupted by a sudden sparkle nearby, one that Catra knew well- and that Orwall aimed her freezefire at, briefly, before Catra's relaxed state told her it was okay.

" I am alive!" Glimmer announced as she teleported in. " Also, I can't believe I found you on third try. Seriously, there are *so* many empty rooms in the Castle. Go me, I guess."

" I thought you were resting?" Catra asked her sister.

" Sleep is for the weak!" Glimmer announced, raising a fist- before flinching. " Ow, fuck, my everything. I couldn't rest, and I got bored being by myself. So I came by. Anyway, are you the Princess of Halfmoon? I'd have made a bet with Bow about it if he hadn't passed out."

" No," Catra said. " I'm only Princess of Brightmoon, I'm afraid."

" If she was the Princess, that'd indicate she was my younger sister," Orwall said. " Or daughter, and I don't have any kids!"

" That you know of!" Glimmer responded, and Orwall's face said that the comment had sent her on a spiraling existential crisis. Ignoring Orwall as she processed the implications, Glimmer turned

to her sister. " Also, I was going to bother you to slap more ointment on me. I was gonna talk the whole time, but also, my back *really* hurts. I've pulled some of these new muscles, I think. So I want you to come back to my room with me, and tend to your wounded, yet still awesome, sister, back triumphant from Beast Island. Or you could be a bad sister and *not* help me, you know, your call."

" So humble," Catra snarked, smiling despite herself at Glimmer's... *Glimmerness.* " You weren't kidding about how unbearable you were gonna be."

" I was not!" Glimmer said. " But if you're still doing stuff, I can wait."

" Nah, we just finished," Catra said- before turning to Orwall. " And Queen Orwall?"

" Yes?" the Queen said, perking up as she moved away from thoughts of amnesiac parenthood.

" I'd like to visit Halfmoon," Catra said. " And... to talk with you. Learn about the Magicats- about my people. If that's alright."

" You can ask me anything!" Orwall said, grinning from ear to ear. " Oh, I'd be so happy to tell you! This *was* the right call, to come here- I'd be honored to teach you!"

“ I'll hold you to that,” Catra said. “ But... I'm going to leave with my sister for now. Do you have accomodations?”

“ Yes,” Orwall said. “ Out with the Rebels... I'll head out now. I'm feeling a bit- how'd you put it?- overwhelmed.”

She stood up, closing her pack and getting it ready, but not before giving Catra another big smile.

“ Thank you,” she said. “ For... for being there. For giving us *hope.* ”

“ My sis is pretty great, isn't she?” Glimmer said.

“ She *is,* ” Orwall breathed, before leaving in an embarrassed hustle.

Once she was gone, Glimmer turned to her sister.

“ You got a fan,” she said, and Catra rolled her eyes.

“ Yeah, but not one I'm interested in,” Catra said. “ Still, it's... nice.”

“ Maybe I should introduce her and Scorpia,” Glimmer pondered. “ Scorpia's hung up on you, even if she doesn't seem to totally get it herself; might do her some good. And I could add matchmaker to my list of incredible accomplishments.”

“ No end to your talents,” Catra said, snorting.

“ Damn straight!” Glimmer said, gently fluttering her big wings and smiling big; and her smile made Catra smile, too. It was... good, to see Glimmer more at ease in her own skin.

(Or maybe it would be better to say that she was finally at ease in her own wings- Glimmer had always hated her wings before, a thing she'd never told Catra outright but that had been obvious anyway... but now...)

“ So wanna teleport me to your room?” Catra asked.

“ Yeah,” Glimmer said. “ Though- I wanted to ask, why don't you have your Sword on you? You never go anywhere without that thing.”

That caught Catra flat-out, put all thought of Magicats and Adora's survival out of her head, because she suddenly realized something she'd already known, but hadn't *thought* about.

They'd never gotten around, in the meeting, to talking about the Sword.

No one *knew.*

(And because Glimmer was her sister, and not a stranger like Orwall, Catra opened her mouth and said)

" Glimmer, I have to tell you about the Sword."

****

" ...What?" Glimmer said, looking at her sister.

" The Heart of Etheria," Catra said, looking away, looking... looking *afraid,* and fear was so wrong on her brave sister's face.

(*She looked that way when Shadow Weaver found her that night,* Glimmer could not help but think.)

" What... what is the Heart?" Glimmer asked, even though she knew. Entrapta had told her in enough meetings what her basic plan was. A First Ones' weapon that Entrapta would use to empower Emily's Big Sister, as she called it, a war machine to overwhelm the Horde with its onboard factories and weapon systems, drown them in robot drones.

Also potentially explosive, but Entrapta had assured her that she'd taken precautions... though Glimmer had her doubts, given Entrapta's wobbly emotional state.

" A weapon," Catra said, telling Glimmer what she already knew... before going on to things Glimmer did *not* know. " A weapon to... to kill the stars. Mara- she sent Etheria into Despondos to *save the universe,* Glimmer, the Heart is a weapon meant to *murder worlds.* The universe this world is originally from- there are other planets, other people, places full of *life,* and... and the First Ones were going to murder them. They weren't good people, Glimmer. They were- they were *monsters.* Or at least, their leadership was- Mara was good, and so was her squad, Grayskull, and there were others... but the leadership was going to kill the stars. Mara *died* to keep them from doing so, died alone and aching and never even knowing if it had worked..."

Glimmer stared as her sister... *wept.* Two quiet tears, making wet trails down the soft fur of her face.

" The Heart... it can't awaken. It can *never* awaken. This Sword- it's... it's a trigger. The fuse. To light the biggest bomb of them all..."

Catra sobbed, just once, pure despair, as if a nightmare long held back suddenly crashed back down on her again.

" And it chose *me.* "

Catra looked away while Glimmer reeled. What she'd just been told... she didn't know what stars were, but the idea of whole other worlds, she could wrap her head around that, and a weapon big enough to kill even just *one,* much less *many...*

...And Entrapta wants to...

Oh.

Oh.

" Is there..." Glimmer licked suddenly dry lips. It felt a bit like falling off of a building, to go from her sense of triumph to this sense of *doom.* It gave her a sort of spiritual vertigo, or perhaps whiplash. " Is there any way to use the Heart *safely?* "

Catra snorted.

" Don't be stupid," she said, voice more sad than scathing. " It's a *bomb.* Those only do one thing."

Catra made a gesture with her hand, closing it into a fist before suddenly releasing.

" Boom," Catra said, full of despair.

...Oh, fuck.

Some part of Glimmer- some small and ugly part, one with green in its eyes, that had *enjoyed* doing things in secret because of the sense of superiority it gave her over her more amazing sister- wanted to reject what Catra was saying. Some part of her heart, the same part that, once, had wanted to tell her mom to *not* adopt Catra, that had wanted to say nothing that night, wanted Glimmer to say nothing right now, too.

Why couldn't she keep going? Entrapta was a genius, and Catra... she had to be wrong, right? Surely Entrapta could use the Heart in the right way, a *good* way.

...But that part... that part was a lot smaller than it had been. Or maybe it was that the rest of Glimmer was so much *bigger,* now. In the wake of Beast Island, she had... changed, and it was more than the wings. Something in Glimmer had shattered there, she had lost something on the Island- but unlike her father, who to some extent had lost his mind, Glimmer thought that maybe what she'd lost was her *weakness.*

Because right now... right now, all her envy, her jealousy, all the green in her eyes, it just felt kind of... *stupid.* Petty and childish.

Because yeah, her sister was *the fucking She-Ra,* was Catra, celebrated heroine of the Rebellion. Catra was more amazing than Glimmer was, that was just a fact.

But Glimmer?

She was alright, too. She'd done great things, too.

And so, with an act of will, Glimmer once more wrestled down that ugly thing inside of her, and thought about what her sister had said... and what Glimmer herself had seen of her co-conspirators.

*You know, I wasn't sure Entrapta thought this through enough, and while I really still want to kill Shadow Weaver and Adora... I need to stop **this** bullshit first. Blowing up our world- or any other- that's just... not good. I'll find another way to kill Shadow Weaver... and honestly, the fact that Shadow Weaver thought this was a good plan really should have been a red flag, in hindsight.*

And the next thought she had was

I need to make this right.

" Fuck," Glimmer said.

" Yeah," Catra responded.

" No, I mean- fuck, I've been helping unleash it," Glimmer said.

Catra turned to her with wide, shocked eyes.

" What?!?" she exclaimed.

" This," Glimmer responded, " is going to be a long conversation, but basically Entrapta had a plan..."

And Catra listened as Glimmer laid bare all that she had been doing... though she did not admit to her last two secrets.

She did not tell her sister she planned to kill Shadow Weaver and Adora both.

(Because in her heart of hearts, Glimmer yet hoped to save her sister from the death that Glimmer foresaw awaited her at Shadow Weaver and Adora's hands, Heart or no Heart.)

And just as Glimmer finished, there was a knock on the door of the room.

" Catra?" Entrapta asked. " Are you in there? I was looking for you."

“ Fuck,” Glimmer said, with all the seriousness of a prayer.

Chapter End Notes

Here it is, folks; the culmination of Glimmer's entire character arc.

In canon, told of the danger, she blindly pressed forward, almost desperate to prove she was as great as she thought she was, that everyone else was just holding her back. Glimmer in the show had so little self-awareness, and so much wounded pride, that there was no way it could end any way but the way it did; Glimmer, made Queen, grieving her mom, bereft of her friends and listening to Shadow Weaver, was always going to make the mistakes she made.

But this Glimmer?

This Glimmer has seen her own face, been forced to face her own fears and doubts... and to rise above them. This Glimmer has great victories under her belt- discovery of the spy, and the impossible miracle of saving her father (and Scorpia as well, less miraculous but no less important)... but there is more than just victory propelling her, now. This Glimmer has talked with her mother as an equal, and has come to realize that just because someone else has glory, it does not mean that Glimmer's own glory is diminished. This Glimmer has come to understand that she is not always right, no matter what song her pride sings.

This Glimmer?

This Glimmer turns her face from the Heart of Etheria. She does not make the same mistake.

Now, she's not perfect. She does make a new, different mistake- she commits to her assassination plan, and doesn't tell Catra about it- but that's because she loves Catra and genuinely believes that Shadow Weaver and/or Adora are big, giant gaping weaknesses in Catra's armor that will get her

killed. It's a mistake born not of pride, but of LOVE- she loves her sister, and she wants to defend her. It's a more noble mistake- mistake still, for many reasons, but nobler nonetheless.

Chapter 52: Sweet Bee of the Great Rebellion

Chapter Notes

A bit late, but I've got a new job and I've been busy preparing for that.

Still, hope to have another chapter up today!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sweet Bee of the Great Rebellion

On one hand, Sweet Bee thought, as she went down the hall, hoping to find her dear Peekablue, *it's weird to owe Entrapta something... but on the other hand, it's about par for the course, somehow. Feels paradoxical, that.*

Damned Entrapta... who had been Blessed Entrapta for a long time, in Sweet Bee's eyes. Entrapta, who had given *so much* to her people, had been Sweet Bee's favorite leader. Entrapta provided robots to ease their work, machines to make up for handicaps, to make their lives in her barren, harsh land easier... and she charged them nothing but the cost of the parts.

For someone like Sweet Bee, who'd always had an intense sense of herself as Crownless, it wasn't hard to admire one of her own who did all that and more. Entrapta even left her people alone, not interfering with them in the manner of more manipulative monarchs. She'd went above and beyond what any people could

expect of a leader, and not overstepped her boundaries in doing so- practically perfect, in every way.

So yes, Sweet Bee had blazed bright with admiration for the Drylborn. Even Entrapta joining the Princess Alliance hadn't put a dent in the Crownless' admiration; when she'd heard of it, Sweet Bee and her squad had been down south, assisting as air support for some of Netossa's Rebels, and she'd been delighted to hear that Dryl's bounty would soon be added to the war effort. Funneled through the Alliance, of course- that overbearing organization the Runestone Kingdoms had forged atop the Great Rebellion, in an attempt to take control of it- but regardless, assistance was assistance, and even Sweet Bee's patriotism was perfectly willing to bow down to the practical in time of need.

Besides, Dryl *was* one of the original signatories to the *first* Princess Alliance; it was kind of appropriate for them to join the second one, as much as that rankled Sweet Bee's hardliner sensibilities.

It was good that Dryl was back in the field, at least, in the metaphorical sense; Dryl's small population and militia-focused military meant that it mostly contributed resources- but given they were *Entrapta's* resources, those had been mighty resources indeed. Those had been good months for the Rebellion. Sweet Bee still had the tents Dryl had made for them at that time- durable and useful, all these years later- and she'd had her life saved by an armor plate in a suit she'd had Dryl engineers design more times than she could count, until she'd finally had to replace it last year.

But then... then the First Raid on the Fright Zone happened, and Entrapta died. Or so it was said; they found the truth out later, as the Hordebots began to pour out of the Fright Zone. Not death, but *betrayal*, and Dryl stopped sending supplies, curling in on itself, hunkering down to wait it out or fight off the entire Alliance, with its new friend the Horde by its side.

So much for the Crownless Princess who was better than any Runestone leader, save maybe Queen Angella- and Sweet Bee hadn't entirely trusted the immortal, as most Crownless and most Rebels didn't. As a Crownless Rebel, Sweet Bee had more reason than most to distrust the Queen.

Oh, she wasn't as bad as she'd been as a child; a young Sweet Bee had been a... *rather adamant* believer in any number of conspiracy theories revolving around Angella, about whom rumor swirled like a storm. Angella's consistent and outstanding decency to the Crownless was a blessing, but many feared it was a curse in disguise; every other Runestone Kingdom kicked them in the dick whenever they could, and everyone feared that there was a hidden knife in Angella's kindness. She provoked admiration and worry in equal measure among them, and Sweet Bee- who had always had a firm sense of herself as a Crownless, once she started studying Etheria's history- had wanted to be safe, and so erred on the side of worry.

It wasn't until Angella had married Micah- a Crownless of Mystacor- that Sweet Bee had finally pulled her head out of her ass, deciding that, with Micah's Crownless influence, Angella might well be exactly who she seemed to be.

(And sure, so many Crownless claimed Mystacor wasn't one of them, that it was a Kingdom-wannabe- and while there was some

truth to that, Sweet Bee thought it missed the point. Rejecting Mystacor like that didn't strengthen the Crownless as a whole, but weakened them; they should be pushing to unite with it, not throwing it away. Supporting Mystacor and increasing its ties with its fellow Crownless was one of the big reasons Sweet Bee did so many supply runs and trade trips there.)

And then had come the War, and Micah's death. Sweet Bee sympathized with Angella's suffering; she'd lost people, too, in this War, her precious followers who'd sworn to serve with her, and each had felt like a stinger being ripped from her skin.

Though she had been spared this much at least: she hadn't lost the one she loved.

Not yet, at any rate.

(The thought alone, of Peekablue dying, of losing *him* before they'd ever really had a chance to be an *us,* made her feet pick up the pace- and her worry meant she made the wrong turn without knowing, an easy thing to do in vast Brightmoon Castle, particularly for one who had never been there before.)

But for all that I sympathize with her suffering, Sweet Bee thought, *I cannot agree with her actions.*

That was the summary of it, too; for in the wake of Micah's death, Angella had collapsed, and demanded her nation collapse with her. She had made her personal disaster the loss of all Brightmoon; she had turned away from the War. A neat

summation of the issue with Brightmoon, otherwise the best of the Runestone Kingdoms; Angella, so good in so much, was still a person, but one with absolute control. She alone had made the decision to leave the War with her husband's death, letting grief decide her.

It was something her own people could not stomach. This cowardice and personal failure were too much; fully half of Brightmoon's army deserted her, to become the bulk of the Great Rebellion, following Netossa down south into the land that was once Plumeria, and now belonged to the Rebels.

A staggering event, nearly without precedent in Brightmoon's history. Sweet Bee could barely wrap her own head around it. A Brightmoon citizen was born knowing an immortal Queen reigned in their land, had before their birth, and would do so after their death. Sweet Bee could scarcely imagine what that felt like, to have something quite like a goddess reigning over one's land... or how *furious,* how *angry,* one would have to be with such a goddess, to turn heretic and flee south, and seek new faith and new flags. Sweet Bee had barely been able to march out of the Hive, even as strong as her own convictions were, when her parents and most of her people made it known that they disagreed with her. Their mortal disdain alone had almost crippled her; she'd only been able to do it by clinging to her knowledge that she was *right,* that this was a thing to be done, and that not everyone hated what she was doing, that there were *some* who *supported* her.

And even then... even then, she'd had that coin spinning, over and over again in her head, telling her she could just go home.

She'd pushed through it... but she wasn't sure that she'd have been able to do it, with the weight of an immortal Queen's regard weighing on her. Such a person would have to be accorded more importance in the mind, and...

Well, never let it be said that Brightmoon folk were cowards. No, you could accuse them of many things- being highly dramatic, their poor strategic planning, the generally high level of bravado and generally low level of brains to back *up* that bravado- but there were no cowards among them. Brave bastards all, down unto their bones.

Brightmoon rebels- who were the slim majority, even now, after so many years of the War- fought for a cause. Salinean rebels tended to fight for profit or gain. Snows rebels fought because they wanted a new home.

And Plumerian Rebels, Sweet Bee thought, as she frustratingly checked the doors of the hallway, looking for her Peekablue, and finding nothing but emptiness, *fight because their Princesses have betrayed them.*

Poor bastards. Plumerians suffered worse than anybody in the war save the Fright Zone and the Duchies, and honestly, given the state of some of those places towards the end, the Horde was almost an improvement. It would be hard to claim the Horde was *worse* than Vargon, to name the standout example, but parts of the Fright Zone had been almost as bad, even with King Uinta doing all he did. One man could not stem a tide of filth that had been flowing in his grandfather's time, but King Uinta had made a hell of a go at it.

But of the nations that are still alive, Plumeria has suffered the most, Sweet Bee thought, her frustration at not being able to find her Peekablue mingling with much older anger, with things she had chewed over and thought on during her time in the War. *Their Princesses told them that they didn't have to fight. Told them they were above that kind of thing, that the Princess would handle it all. Pure arrogance and coddling both, treating the Plumerian people as if they weren't worthy to fight in their own defense... and treating the Princess as if she alone could defend the entire nation.*

Sweet Bee had seen the result of that thinking. She had seen the empty villages, the adults killed, the children stolen to go back to the Horde, to feed it, the children who should have grown up as Plumerians turned instead into new Hordesmen, who would grow up to return to the field and kill their former people, cannibalism in the form of army recruitment. She had seen the hollow looks in survivors, who did not know how to fight and so, when the Princesses failed them, had died without even the cold comfort of having fought back.

She had seen the place where the last Princess died, and realized- to her reluctant sorrow- that the Princess herself had been a victim of that thinking; she had marched into combat convinced she alone could fight an army, and she had died for it.

Though at least she DID die for it, Sweet Bee thought. *Not like Perfuma, she's fucking* ***useless*** *, didn't get off her ass to fight for her people until Catra got to her. The whole* ***point*** *of a Princess in Plumeria is to* ***fight,*** *it is literally the only job they have, a job they stole from every other Plumerian. No one has a right to*

*defend themselves in Plumeria but the Princess alone, which itself is wrong... but at least the last Princess **did** fight.*

Perfuma didn't.

*All those lives... those are on **her** head.*

Sweet Bee could forgive Perfuma's cowardice, if Perfuma had at least tried to get her people to fight, if she had given them back their right to self-defense. If she had tried to organize them, in some way, or get them assistance to learn the ways of war. There'd have been stumbling, sure, but the attempt alone would have been correct.

But Perfuma had not done that. She had retreated, instead, and without even Angella's excuse of deep-seated grief- not that it was a *sufficient* excuse, but at least it was *something.*

Perfuma, as far as Sweet Bee could tell- and as far as the Plumerian Rebels she'd talked to had said- was just a coward.

(*She's weak,* one had told her, a Plumerian who said her name was Herbista, a middle-aged wise woman of the woods, whose dark skin and dreadlocks had glinted dully in the light of the campfire she'd been willing to share with Sweet Bee and her Andreenids. Herbista's warband and Sweet Bee's Andreenids had been hunting Horde patrols together, and that night, Herbista had been poisoning their weapons with a deadly concoction Sweet Bee still used to this day, a poison that heightened pain until the smallest wound was crippling. *Weak and a coward. It's why I*

joined the Rebellion; here, at least, people will teach you how to ***fight.*** *The Horde... the Horde took my daughter, years ago. My little Lonnie, who I will never see again...*)

And the Good Woman knows that the only reason I'm thinking about this, Sweet Bee thought, frowning as yet another room was empty, *is because I can't find Peekie! Why does this Castle have so many empty rooms? I'm going to have to go find someone to help me find him, and that's just embarrassing.*

Frustrated, she went to the next door- and found not her man, but two most unexpected people.

" Oh!" Perfuma said, as Sweet Bee opened the door on her and Scorpia, who had been sitting on a couch talking. " Hello!"

(Sweet Bee saw red.)

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter, two disasters in the form of conversations, and the endgame is set up.

Note that I don't fully agree with Sweet Bee here, but she's also not totally wrong, either. It's a complicated situation.

Chapter 53: Rebels of the Horde

Chapter Notes

Hey all!

So I started a new job that has massively cut into my time. I intend to keep my commitments, but it DOES mean that the chapters are probably gonna be shorter going forward!

This is a prime example. This was meant to be attached to a longer chapter, but to keep my Friday commitment that I keep breaking, I'm uploading it now as-is.

This chapter was meant to also have Entrapta's confrontation with the Royal Sisters of Brightmoon and Sweet Bee's confrontation with Perfuma and Scorpia, but that'll be next chapter, now.

For right now... I present Lonnie, and despair, and hope unlooked for.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Rebels of the Horde

Lonnie sat in her office, and waited for her guest to arrive.

She'd sent old Callix out to go find him after... after. She wasn't sure when. Time was slipping from her fingers, had been ever since she'd seen

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She drifted through her memories, the horror of the present unmooring her, searching for comfort in the sea of the past. Early on- when she was little- a few members of the Horde had been fond of her. They'd fought alongside her dad, and had joked about Lonnie being second-generation in the Horde- “a real Hordesman”, they'd said, and that had made little Lonnie happy, in a way she hadn't fully understood at the time.

She'd been told that her father was a hero. That her dad, named Flarion, had been part of the Horde in the Fright Zone, had in fact been of Lord Hordak's first recruits. Other stories, too; that her mother had been a Plumerian immigrant to the Fright Zone, that she'd been kicked out by some noble or another who'd thrown out all immigrants in his area of the Zone. That her dad had been stuck without his beloved and with their baby, and had done all he could to fight for a day they could be reunited.

(Lonnie only vaguely recalled her mother's name; her dad's friends hadn't truly known it themselves. Herb, or something. Someone who had never found Lonnie, and never would, and she didn't regret it, exactly... but there was a quiet space inside, where Lonnie had... something like regret.)

That had been her history, and she'd been proud of it; proud of it, until Adora and Catra joined them, and Shadow Weaver's presence drove all her father's old friends off. Her cadet class was Shadow Weaver's pet project, and she let no one else come near.

(Lonnie would be angrier with them for abandoning her if she had not known, intimately, just how dangerous the witch really was; thus, she was only glad that her father's friends had the sense to flee.)

She drifted, drifted, drifted. Recalled times of laughing with Catra, always slightly awkward and always a little scary, afraid the shadows would weave around her if she enjoyed Catra's company too much; times she listened to Adora with little grumbling because the Witch had decided that the blonde would be their leader, and they had no say otherwise. Recalled Kyle and Rogelio and their awkward, years-long courtship, born of Rogelio loving Kyle's gentleness, of Kyle loving Rogelio's protectiveness, the two clinging together in the face of cruel eyes and dark magic. Of Catra and Adora trying something similar, but too spiky and with too much of the witch between them, something they could not make work until the day the Sword started to wield Catra and it was too late for anything more. Remembered being alone among the proto-couples, and being okay with that, not needing any such thing to stiffen her spine.

She drifted, drifted, drifted.

But then a knock on the door made time just solid enough that, when she tried, she could grip it, however barely.

" Force Captain Grizzlor," Lonnie said to the door, with an effort that felt like shrugging off an ocean. " Come in."

" Force Captain Lonnie," he said as he entered, the Mane offering her a quick nod of his head. Lonnie's secretary was not outside. This was a meeting just for her and Grizzlor. " It is good to see you as well. I presume this isn't a social call?"

“ Is it ever?” Lonnie responded without entirely meaning to, and Grizzlor's mouth quirked up into a smirk.

“ No,” he said quietly. “ I notice we're alone. There a reason for that?”

Now or never.

“ I won't beat around the bush,” Lonnie said, but it didn't sound confident or brave in her ears. It sounded... quiet. “ You... you can see what's happening to the Horde, can't you?”

“ Whatever do you mean?” Grizzlor offered neutrally... but Lonnie saw the way he tensed up.

A very, very *careful* tensing up, one mostly hidden. Nothing huge or obvious changed in his demeanor, just a sort of... shift, that spoke of muscles primed for a fight. If Lonnie hadn't spent four years of battle against the She-Ra and Rebels both, she doubted she'd have even noticed; Grizzlor was good, as he'd have to be. Grizzlor was an old Horde veteran, after all, nearly as old as her secretary Callix, though Manes like him didn't age like humans did. No, they aged slowly to adulthood, and then lasted, up until they hit seventy-five or so and very, very suddenly fell totally apart, old age passing in the blink of an eye. Grizzlor was, for a Mane, in the prime of health.

He was ready for fight or flight. He probably figured Lonnie was here to deal with him, given how he'd opposed

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So openly.

But Lonnie had reassured Adora, afterwards, that her file indicated Grizzlor was perfectly loyal. She'd blamed his past with the Bull's Eye, said he'd come around, made...

Made sure Adora thought he was loyal. Safe.

(It wasn't a betrayal. It *wasn't*. She was just... hedging her bets, preparing the Horde in case Adora wasn't in charge anymore. This wasn't a betrayal. This wasn't a betrayal. *This wasn't a betrayal.*)

She was silent a long moment.

" I... I agree with you," Lonnie finally said, and for all that she whispered it, it felt loud as a scream. " I... I don't like Adora being a Princess, either."

The words she could not take back.

Grizzlor waited, waited, and Lonnie continued the slow collapse that had been hurting her ever since the meeting yesterday.

(Had it been yesterday? She wasn't sure how long that had been, in the midst of this despair burning up her bones. She wasn't... had it been just yesterday? It couldn't have been, she'd been suffering too long. It must have been at least a week ago a month ago a year ago *how long have I been here*)

Grizzlor waited, because this could be a trap. Lonnie was Adora's spymaster, and might be trying to bait him into saying something she could get him executed for. He was almost certainly wondering if he could kill Lonnie and escape.

Lonnie could not muster up the emotion to care. It all felt too... distant.

And he must have seen something in her expression, because a moment later he relented.

" The official word is that she isn't," Grizzlor said, in a testing kind of way.

" We both know the truth," Lonnie said. " The Spirit Ember is a Runestone... and Adora draws power from it; what is that, but a Princess?"

Saying it out loud, for whatever reason, made it real; and tears slipped down Lonnie's cheeks, unbidden messengers from her eyes, speaking of the pain inside.

Her friend was gone. There was only

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Grizzlor saw her tears, and he did her the greatest kindness a Hordesman could do for another; he said not a word, and paid no attention to her weakness.

Instead, he looked away, and when he started talking, it was not of how soft or pathetic Lonnie was.

" I had an older brother, once," Grizzlor said. " In Vargon. He was the bravest man I ever knew... and he spoke up. Duke Theymor had taken over- rumors said he'd killed his nephew, but we were commoners, we didn't care. We cared that we didn't have enough to eat, we cared that we were Manes and only Satyrs and Minotaurs got positions in the government, we cared that the army was taking everything we *did* have... we didn't care about the fights between nobles, about inheritance law, about who was *supposed* to sit on the throne. We cared that we couldn't *eat.*"

Lonnie said nothing, merely wiped her eyes; and Grizzlor continued being kind, and did not look at her, and let her hide her disgrace with her hands as he kept talking.

" There was a protest in the capital, and my brother went. I told him not to go. I was terrified of the protests, even back then I knew something was wrong, the rumors about the Duke... even

back then, some people had an idea what he was like. But my brother, he was braver than me, and dumber. So he smiled at me, and said he'd be fine, and that was all I saw of him for years."

With her eyes clear of tears, Lonnie could see that Grizzlor's own eyes were distant, on things that had happened long ago- and to repay his kindness, she looked away from him, too, did not look on his pain, as he had not looked on hers. She said nothing, but let the older man talk.

" When the death squads started marching out of the capital... I knew what was up. I knew that my brother, brave as he was, had died; and that it was time for me, less brave but wiser, to take up the fight. And we weren't doing it peacefully."

This part, Lonnie knew, at least a little; one of the heroic tales of the Horde's founding, the battle against Vargon's horrific lord.

" So we rose up against the Bloody Bull of Vargon, even knowing we were fucked, because things had gotten so bad for most of us that death couldn't make it worse. There are things that can make life worth less than death, you can be in a situation where you'd rather die anyway, and so risking yourself to kill the enemy... that isn't so bad, that's not a big deal, not at all. We were gonna lose, even with Blackmoor jumping in- you hear about that? He impaled their ambassadors on iron stakes and used the Bull's Eye to merge them with the stakes, keeping them alive for weeks. That's the kind of bastard he was, that's what we were up against. And we were gonna lose, us and Blackmoor. Didn't matter how we tried, he had a Runestone and he made *monsters* out of people, warbeasts of his own kind, and we... we were the walking dead, doomed to die, no matter what we did."

" And then we heard about this stranger from the Fright Zone."

" Lord Hordak," Lonnie whispered, with all the longing of lost faith.

(*If he was still alive...* but he wasn't, and down that path lay only more pain.)

" Yeah," Grizzlor said. " Didn't think much of him when we first met, to my shame. Just some little pasty fucker, with weird red eyes. But... there was something to him, something that made me... listen. Something like iron. Something like *steel.* This way he had, where he'd... say things and that was just how it *was*. But he didn't just bring himself; Lord Hordak... he brought tech and he brought language, and he brought this... idea. The thing you're living in, right now- the Horde."

Grizzlor sounded... wistful.

" Common people, making common cause. A miracle. And he followed it up with another- the miracle of *victory.* We won. To this day I don't know how. Lost some good friends in that fight. We... we lost so many people. But we did not lose the *war*. We *won.* We hit him from the south and east and Blackmoor hit him from the north and west, and we met there in his capital, where Lord Hordak used himself as bait to draw out the Bloody Bull. Used *himself,* because the Horde was the *point,* and he was willing to *die* for it. He fought the Bloody Bull there and then with the help of the Red Knight while we took on all his support, and... and we won."

Grizzlor sighed.

" And after... I found my brother."

His face said it had not been a happy reunion.

" By the time we found him... Duke Theymor had gotten to him," Grizzlor said, looking at something much farther away than her wall. " He'd made him part of an engine; it wasn't even for a purpose. My brother added nothing to the machine, had no use of it. He'd merged him with it just to hurt him, merged him *imperfectly,* so that he burned and bled."

Even under the weight of her despair, some part of Lonnie's gorge wanted to rise at that simple description of complex abomination.

" Hordak used the Bull's Eye to free him... but he wasn't... he wasn't himself, any more," Grizzlor said. " Hordak took him where he could be taken care of, back to my parents; he lived a few more years. Not long. Too much was gone, even after Hordak restored him. But I stayed, because I saw what a fucking Runestone could do, and Hordak was the only person I'd ever met who could fight even a Minor Runestone and *win.* The world is ruled by them, but the Horde... the Horde can *stop* them."

He looked Lonnie dead in the eye.

“ And now a fucking Princess is running the Horde,” he growled. “ Lord Adora brought back a goddamn Runestone, same as the kind that ruined my brother, and she's going to turn us into a Runestone Kingdom and piss all over the dreams of me and every single fucking Hordesman who died hoping to make Hordak's dream a reality. I wanted a better world, where no one got merged with a fucking engine block because some petty bastard had better jewelry than any other. But now Adora's gone and fucked it, and I'm not afraid to say so.”

His stare was defiant, brave, resolute. He knew that he was taking a stand here, one that he fully expected to get him killed; but he said it anyway.

It was the picture of the virtuous Hordesman, and so Lonnie could not quite help the words that poured out of her next.

“ I'm not sure it is Adora,” Lonnie said, the words just spilling out of her, her willpower a burning dam that could not hold back the tide. “ Catra, when she came back- people don't know that Catra found the Sword and then came back. I think me and the others- our cadet class- we're the only ones who do. Catra found the Sword, and she *came back*, but she was *different*- she was anxious, nervous, paid even *less* attention than usual. She found the Sword, then came back... and left again. She came back wrong and she left us again, and now we have to kill her.”

Grizzlor didn't say anything, simply waited, and Lonnie couldn't stop herself, things she'd held in too long pouring out of her like pressurized steam from the Fright Zone's endless valves.

“ Adora left, and came back *different,* too. It's the same- they leave, they leave after stealing a skiff, and then, when they come back...”

She paused and looked at Grizzlor, her words half confession and half hope that the older man had *some* idea of what to do.

“ I think- I think the Runestones take their Princesses,” she finally said aloud, the thing she had been thinking for so very, very long. “ I think the *first* victim of a Runestone is its Princess. They're a meatsuit to wear, to interact with the rest of us...”

“ To fool us,” Grizzlor said quietly, considering her words. “ ...Theymor was just some nobleman, before he got the Bull's Eye. Maybe it's the power that corrupts, or maybe the Runestone... but either way, if Adora is a Princess, now...”

“ I think the Lord of the Horde is the Spirit Ember,” Lonnie said, blinking back a pair of tears in her eyes. “ Adora left like Catra did, and she didn't come back, either...”

She paused, wiped her eyes furiously, and Grizzlor continued to be kind; Lonnie's heart clenched hard in her chest, at the literally-unspoken consideration there, at how understanidng he was being, of her weakness, her foolishness, her *softness.*

She should be better than this.

(She was not.)

" She was in your cadet class, right?" he asked, and she nodded.

" Yes," she said.

" Then this is like how I lost my brother," he said, in a tone that was... not soft, she would never call him soft, but... considerate.

" *Yes,*" she said. Lonnie knew nothing of her blood kin, but the way Grizzlor spoke, the way she'd heard others talk of their kin over the years... that was comparable.

Losing Adora to the Spirit Ember... was like losing her family.

Grizzlor nodded in return, before asking the only question that mattered.

" So... what are you going to do about it?" the Mane asked her.

" I'm... keeping a list," she admitted out loud, a truth that would destroy her if Adora heard about it. If it was Adora in there, and not the Runestone, then Adora would kill Lonnie for the betrayal...

and if it was the Spirit Ember, it would kill her for figuring it out. The list represented no victory, no end result that would give Lonnie what she wanted- her friend back- but merely a way to... to kill her, and stop the Ember that was seeing the world through Adora's eye, now. " I don't plan to do anything, not yet. But I... I have to be ready. I have to be ready. Maybe I'm wrong. Maybe it's Adora in there and all this is just... paranoia."

She chuckled weakly, an old joke Kyle made bubbling up despite everything.

" I've heard it's a common problem for intelligence officers."

" It is," Grizzlor said with a nod. " But in this case... I don't think it's paranoia. I think it's... precaution. And you've got my support."

" I do?" Lonnie asked. Stupid, maybe. There were more than a few older Force Captains who hated Adora's little command squad. To be upstaged by the youth... few were the older folks who liked that much, Lonnie had heard enough complaining about it. And Grizzlor had himself been known to say he felt he should have been the Horde's Lord.

But he was also the only one to openly oppose the Runestone at all, anywhere Lonnie could hear him...

" You do," he said. " You're clearly at your wit's end, kid. I'm not surprised- you're a kid, Hordak should never have made Adora his

heir, or at least, he should have roped some of us into it. She needed more and better help- no offense. You've done *incredible* work with what's been dumped in your lap. Better than I could have done at your age. I should know, I've *been* your age, and in damn near the same shoes, and they didn't fit me as well as yours do you. But that doesn't mean you can do it forever, and this... Runestone... it changes things."

" It does," Lonnie said. She didn't feel as mad as she thought she should, about Grizzlor commenting on how... weak... she was; the way he said it, it almost made her feel tough, for some fucking reason. He wasn't snarling at her, or mocking her, just... stating the facts. She'd hit the ground running and done well; that she'd finally stumbled...

Well, he almost made it sound okay. Like her stumbling after so long was something to be proud of, somehow.

(*No wonder he's a Force Captain,* she thought idly. *If he's this reassuring to a fellow officer, how much better must it be to serve under him?*)

" ...I'm going to stick around," Grizzlor said. " I'll volunteer to stay behind while she goes into Plumeria, claim I'd prefer to stay here and shore up the defense. I'm supposed to be with her, but I'll claim I'm too injured still to go. Won't be hard. And us... let's get everybody together, everybody on your *list,* and we'll come up with some kind of contingency plan. I don't want to do *shit* unless we get a chance... maybe we can break this fucking Runestone. Save your friend. I know they claim that Runestones being destroyed would kill all Etheria but I just plain-ass don't believe it. We'll crack that bastard open, see if we can't save your friend from it... if we get a chance."

Someone *else* finally had a plan. Someone *else* was finally, finally shouldering some of the burden. Someone *else* was, finally, here to help.

Lonnie took the first free breath she'd had since Adora came back with that goddamn stone on her skiff.

" Thank you," she said. Grizzlor nodded.

" We'll figure this out," he said.

They talked a few moments more, setting up a schedule, a meeting.

(And Light Hope, who had listened in on this conversation, as well as Entrapta's, smiled to herself.)

Chapter End Notes

> This is actually not long after the meeting; Lonnie is so damn disjointed right now that her ability to tell time is just... gone.
>
> We would recognize, in the modern era, that this is a breakdown, a panic attack, the final mental meltdown of someone whose core is going critical.
>
> But the Horde never had much truck with what Etheria calls mind soothing.

Chapter 54: Disasters and Decisions of the Princess Alliance

Chapter Notes

So!

I'm a week late, but my new job completely reoriented my personal schedule.

Still, I think I've got more of a handle on it now.

So without much further ado- two conversations you've been waiting for.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Disasters and Decisions of the Princess Alliance

The first emotion that ran through Catra upon hearing Entrapta at the door was not panic nor surprise, which made for a clear contrast with her sister; Glimmer looked as if she'd not only seen a ghost, but been attacked by it. Her eyes were so big that Catra felt a momentary urge to tease her over it.

But she ignored that urge, because the emotion flowing through Catra was not something conducive to such sibling annoyance; no, what was flowing through her was too sweet and simple for that. It was *relief* that flooded her heart, a vast ocean of it, drowning the tension inside her heart.

Glimmer, after all, had just told Catra that she, Entrapta, and Shadow Weaver had been messing with the *Heart.* Catra's horror and surprise had been ratcheting up throughout that entire conversation, as she came to realize just how *close* to disaster they had all come. All Etheria had been inches away from Armageddon, with Glimmer's unaware little band obliviously preparing to dump fuel into the engine of apocalypse that lay running on idle inside of Etheria, as it had for centuries.

Catra had known she'd have to get up and run, *run,* to find Entrapta and Shadow Weaver, to stop them, explain what was going to happen, what they were playing with, a frantic kind of tension that had made her spine vibrate like a chord plucked too long.

But now, now she didn't have to do that. Entrapta had come of her own free will, and now Catra could deal with it immediately- and with the biggest part of it, too. Shadow Weaver would still need to be stopped- which was nothing Catra was looking forward to (perhaps she could ask her mom to deal with the dark witch?)- but Entrapta was the group's tech mistress; without her, Shadow Weaver would be effectively neutered in her ability to do harm. The Heart was a thing of tech, after all, even if it was powered by stolen magic.

And while Shadow Weaver almost never listened to Catra, even when she was right, Entrapta *had.* Entrapta was a friend, or at least, Catra viewed her as one, despite the fact that they hadn't spoken much since the Third Raid on the Fright Zone, which had ended in the Portal. Just that meeting in the Castle, when the rest of the Alliance was celebrating Hordak's death, and they'd met outside Shadow Weaver's garden; that, and a few scattered discussions at meetings since.

But still a friend, for all that distance. Catra should have put more effort into seeing her, but she'd been so hard-pressed in the South… which felt like an excuse, because it was.

No, she was the Best Princess; she could do better than that.

(She resolutely pushed away the burble of horror inside, about *why* she was Best Princess, about the She-Ra and the Sword and all the things she had learned. She'd be the Best Princess *without* it, by the Silver!)

She'd reconnect with Entrapta, starting now, with telling her how to avert apocalypse.

Unbidden, a smile grew on Catra's face as she recalled that Third Raid. For all the horror of its ending- of the Portal, the falseworld, of Adora bright and terrible with that light leaking through half her soul- hadn't Catra convinced Entrapta to help, beforehand? Easy to forget, with all that had went on…

But Catra *had* talked Entrapta into halting a bad idea, once. She had talked Entrapta into not activating the Portal, relying on her love of Hordak, even if she hadn't known at the time how deep it ran… though that last was admittedly easy to figure out afterwards, once Catra saw how badly his death had affected her. Entrapta… wasn't the same as she had been, and even Catra's relatively sparse contact had proven that.

(*Would I be that way if Adora died, would I be ruined too?*)

Even bereft of the Sword and all her powers as She-Ra, Catra had been able to pull it off, convincing the Drylborn that she would try to save the Lord of the Horde from the mistake he was about to make.

And hadn't she done just that? Right there, at the end of their fight, Catra's words had reached him, and Hordak had changed his mind; he'd ordered the portal shut down.

Impossible to tell now what kind of man he would have become after that. Impossible to tell if the change would stick, or he would change his mind again, loyalty to his brother winning out over his friendship with Scorpia and his friendship-and-more with Entrapta… but he *might* have changed. It might have worked.

Hell, I changed, Catra thought, eyes flickering over the Castle that was now her home. *He could, too.*

And… he saved Mom.

(For all her life, Catra will owe Hordak this much- because of him, her mother had not had to die. It is a debt she cannot repay- the living cannot recompense the dead- but it is one she feels keenly nonetheless.)

Catra had kept her word; she'd kept Hordak from making the mistake. It had been Adora who had flipped the switch, not him.

So yeah… yeah, she could do this.

I've got this. It'll be easy! It's not gonna be like the War Council, where Adora was only saved by Frosta's whim- and I need to get that kid something, I owe her one. I can do this. Hell, I convinced her when I was chained to a wall, once!

Yeah… and with Entrapta gone, and her mom could deal with Shadow Weaver- and that would be it. Glimmer's description had been the three of them in on this, the roles clear- Entrapta as tech mistress, Shadow Weaver as mage and leader, Glimmer recruited for her muscle.

Which pisses me off a bit, actually, Catra realized, as she opened her mouth to invite Entrapta in. *Glimmer's more than just a brute. She's my sister, the first real friend I ever had other than Adora, and a hero besides; she deserves better than to be some kind of unwitting thug for others.*

(Next to her, Glimmer felt oddly guilty, for some reason she could not parse; as though she was betraying someone who thought of her highly… and while she shoved it aside, it still rankled in her guts.)

" Come in, Entrapta!" Catra yelled to the Princess outside the door. " You're just the woman I was looking for!"

Glimmer had just enough time for a horrified glance over at her sister before the door popped open, and she put on a *very* false smile that made Catra want to roll her eyes.

My poor sister can't lie to save her damn life, Catra thought. *If she ever told a lie well, the world would end.*

(Somewhere nearby, Bow turned over in his sleep, as if a great and absurd irony had just occurred nearby.)

" Oh?" Entrapta said as she slithered grandly into the room. " Why were you looking for me?"

Entrapta… looked better, to Catra. She was still "walking" on her hair- well, slithering, at least- just as she had in this same Castle all those months ago; but she looked better, more like herself, less ragged and devoured. Her clothes were clean and she had clearly showered more regularly since.

" And hello, Glimmer," Entrapta said pleasantly, utterly oblivious to Glimmer's pained expression and terror.

" H-hey!" Glimmer said, giving a small wave despite looking a bit green around the gills.

I'll have to remember to tease her later, Catra thought, smirking to herself… then marveling at how normal a thought that was to have. *Huh, even with the Sword, I feel… more like me. As fucked*

as all this is… it's easier, now. With my family knowing. With Adora going to live.

Yeah, she felt… better.

And that means I can do this!

Entrapta gave a short wave back to Glimmer, with a hand whose sleeve was a Horde flag; she'd worn one like that back at the party, too, when her and Catra had both been haunting Brightmoon Castle like ghost princesses in Fright Zone fairy tales. This one was clearly much more taken care of, as was Entrapta herself in general…

But it was still weird as all hell.

The Horde flag was one of the things Hordak was touchiest about; I never did anything to mess with the flag. It was a lot worse than just a punishment detail if I did that…

" Why is your sleeve a Horde flag?" Catra blurted out.

Glimmer didn't say anything, but gave her sister a look that said *Really?,* to which Catra could only give an awkward shrug. Yeah, that wasn't what they wanted to talk about; but it was so damn strange to see that it demanded a response!

Entrapta paused a moment before answering.

" ...It's *his* flag," Entrapta answered, with strong emphasis on the second word. " Not... **hers.**"

Damn, the Drylborn had nearly *spit* that last word out, her face twisting into a scowl. Catra glanced away from that venomous look, towards the sleeve, and saw that she was telling the truth; the red bat-winged symbol on Entrapta's sleeve was the same symbol Catra had worn in her youth, lacking the flaming snake-squiggle that Adora had added after she took over. It was a bat, not a dragon.

Good. I… don't like the new symbol.

(Catra's reasoning had nothing to do with aesthetics, and everything to do with the simple fact of what such a change *meant*- that Adora was now the kind of person who could *change the Horde's flag,* that just as Catra was no longer a little hurt girl, neither was Adora a little kind girl, either…)

" …Why?" Catra asked, and Entrapta blinked before softly sighing.

" ...For *him,*" she said, as if that explained it all.

…And for Catra, it kind of did.

She got it.

For love

(*Adora*)

Was fundamental to Catra's makeup, too.

" I get ya," Catra said quietly, and Entrapta favored her with a nod.

" You might," she said. " You have always been... different. Kinder. Honorable; you kept your word to *him.* Protected me, when you... you must hate me. Like the soldier I just met does. I've done so much wrong."

" You're trying to be better," Catra said, and shrugged. " I… believe in redemption."

" You do?" Entrapta asked, cocking her head to the side as she drew up near their table, eschewing a chair for her own hair. She resembled a serpent ready to strike, but relaxed about it. " … Like… *she* does?"

" She who?" Glimmer asked.

" *Perfuma,*" Entrapta said quietly, but with the slightest hint of… longing?

Entrapta has a new crush? Catra wondered. *And on Perfuma, of all people?!?*

Well, she was gonna have to think about *that* later- but huh. She could kinda see it.

Still, onwards and upwards!

" Kinda," Catra said. She'd chatted with Perfuma often enough over the years to know some of the big outlines of how the plantlover thought. " Obviously I'm less about the All, I'm not Plumerian. But… redemption… forgiveness… yeah. I believe in it. I kind of have to. I wasn't… I wasn't a very good person when I came here."

No, she hadn't been. She'd even considered abandoning the Alliance and letting Glimmer suffer, just turning her coat back to the Horde; now, even *thinking* of it led her to lean over and squeeze her sister's shoulder, reassure herself that she had done the *right* thing, that her sister was alive and fine.

(Glimmer, not understanding, gave her a reassuring smile, and it is all the reward Catra has ever wanted for her good deeds.)

" I'm a lot of things," Catra said, " but I'm not a hypocrite. Not on purpose, and not if I can avoid it. So… yeah. I believe in redemption."

And thinking of what a Best Princess would say, Catra finished with a flourish.

" And not just for me!" she said, pointing at Entrapta. " You, too. I think you can turn it around."

And that must have been the right thing to say, because Entrapta's face lit up with a little smile.

" …Then that is another thing I owe you," Entrapta said, her face lighting up with a little smile. " I do not know if I have ever said this- I can't remember much of the earliest days after… the Portal, but I owe you and Queen Angella both. You kept your word to *him,* and you defended me; I owe you that, and now, I owe you this faith in my redemption, too."

" Well, that makes a nice segue," Catra said. " Since I'm about to ask you for a favor."

Entrapta rose up a little and bowed to her, hair spread like the hood of a supplicant cobra.

" One of Dryl's poets put it best," Entrapta said. " Or, at least, the way I like best. If it is in my power to give, I will."

" Kinda dramatic," Glimmer said off to the side.

" You're from Brightmoon, you have no right to call anybody dramatic," Catra pointed out.

" You're Brightmoon too!" Glimmer protested- and that sounded sweet in Catra's ears, even now, even after so long, to hear that she was *from* somewhere, that she *belonged,* and it made her give voice to that terrible sweetness in a laugh.

" Yeah, but I'm adopted!" Catra said, another truth that was terribly sweet. " I've got Hordesman sensibilities, I can point out the flaws in my beloved culture. You gotta admit, us from Brightmoon, we're kinda drama queens."

Glimmer opened her mouth, then paused and shut it as she reconsidered.

" …I want to argue with that," Glimmer said, " but I just now realized I broke into the War Council meeting with wings and my not-dead father in tow, as well as the real Scorpia, making my mom faint, so… okay, yeah, fair."

" In Dryl it has sometimes been held that Brightmoon's people thrive on theater," Entrapta offered, still amused. It was good to see on her face; the poor thing had been through a lot. " But we also hold Brightmoon to be good, kind; we think of you more highly than the other Kingdoms. For all your extreme personalities, you are equally extreme in your decency."

" Benefits of not being an asshole," Glimmer said with a smug grin. " You'd think it wouldn't be that hard to just *not* be an asshole, but apparently it is. Mom's seriously thought about just abandoning the other Kingdoms and placing her bets with you guys."

" Seriously?" Catra said.

" Yeah," Glimmer said. " She almost did that at the War's start, just went with the Crownless' Great Rebellion instead of the Princess Alliance the others were pushing, but she ended up deciding on the Alliance. She might change her mind in the future; she's pretty tired of the other Kingdoms blowing up any chance of friendly relations between Crownless and Kingdom."

Oh, that's a nice segue, too, Catra thought.

" Speaking of blowing things up," she said, in a lower tone, throwing cold water on the conversation. " Entrapta, Glimmer told me about what you've been trying to do with the Heart."

Entrapta, smile leaving her face, turned her head to Glimmer.

" You... did?" she said, and Glimmer raised a hand up to her, palm facing the Drylborn.

" I had to!" she protested. " Catra, tell her what you told me."

" The Heart... is a bomb," Catra said, stumbling only a little over the awful truth. She could do this. Bad as it was… she was *still* Best Princess. Hell, hadn't she fought in the Third Raid without the Sword? She didn't need it! She could be a hero by herself. " The Heart's a bomb, one meant to murder worlds. It must *never* be activated. Glimmer told me you intended to use it on the Horde, and I get the idea, but it's... it's not safe."

" ...A weapon is not meant to be safe," Entrapta said, but Catra noted, with some worry, that her voice was… distant. As if she was replying on autopilot while she thought other thoughts. And she had went totally still; not even her hair was moving. The effect was… unnerving. " Could we use it safely for another purpose? The gathered energy must go somewhere; perhaps we could drain it for ourselves."

Not a bad idea, some part of Catra could recognize; but her terror at the idea of *anyone* poking around in the Heart made her shake her head.

" Would you really want to risk it?" Catra asked. " When the price for failure is not your death, but the deaths of so many…"

" What hope do we have? Nothing else will defeat **her** Horde," Entrapta said, beginning to move again, hair writhing like a serpent circling for the kill. " Nothing else will stop **her**."

" The plan we came up with tonight will," Catra protested. " We… we can stop the Horde."

" What plan?" Entrapta asked.

" We kidnap Adora," Catra said. " We take her alive. Without her, the Horde is leaderless and collapses."

Entrapta went dead still again.

(*Something's wrong, something's wrong, she's not listening…*)

" Was that what Bow was talking about earlier?" Glimmer asked. " He said Frosta voted to 'spare' Adora…"

" That's what he meant," Catra said, but did not look at her sister, looking only at Entrapta as she rose up even taller, quiet fury settling into her face.

“ Alive?” Entrapta hissed. “ Alive?”

“ Yes,” Catra said. “ Alive.”

“ Alive?… No,” Entrapta said, and her hair moved rapidly against itself, the warning rattle before the strike. “ No. No. Hold the vote again. I will vote. Tie. Scorpia is a Princess, she can vote too. We win the tie. We will kill **her**.”

“ No, you won’t,” Catra said. “ It’s already been decided. We take Adora alive-“

“ No!” Entrapta said, low and quiet, hissing the words out. “ NO! **NO!** We kill **her,** we **kill her, we kill her!**”

Catra stared as Entrapta rose up as tall as she could, fury tensing her hair and making her rise, and all Catra could think of was how this was the War Council all over again, except it was turning out the way she feared, unable to convince someone else not to hurt her Adora, to spare the woman she loved…

“ You won’t kill her with the Heart,” Glimmer argued. “ It’s too dangerous.”

“ Traitor!” Entrapta hissed at Glimmer. “ Traitor! I helped you find your father, why would you turn on me like this?”

" I'm no traitor!" Glimmer said. " The Horde has to be stopped! I agree with you on that! But there's got to be another way!"

" I… I've thought about it, so much… this method is sure, this method is perfect, this method will work…"

Entrapta was moaning as she swayed in her hair, putting her hands up to her head and lowering her helmet, letting them face the broken mask that she had worn ever since the great battle of the Portal.

" I can make the Heart safe…"

" I don't know if anyone **can**," Catra said. " We don't use the Heart, Entrapta."

A pause, as Entrapta swayed back and forth; when she paused, for the briefest second, it was all the warning Catra and Glimmer got.

Two strands of hair lashed forward like biting vipers, carrying two shock sticks, that old Horde tech. The prongs hit the sisters directly in the solar plexus, where the shock would be given directly to their nerves.

“ I’m so sorry,” Entrapta whispered through her mask, as the electricity ran through both of them. Glimmer, tired and mostly drained and unexpecting an attack, went out like a light; Catra managed to stagger to her feet, but it wasn’t enough, not when she wasn’t in her She-Ra form. “ It is not in my power to give you this.”

Catra passed out to the sound of Entrapta sobbing.

****

Perfuma looked at the new arrival, who was someone she didn't know. Kind of a muscular woman, which Perfuma admittedly did like; her face spoke of a nose oft-busted and of teeth knocked out by battle. A warrior woman, and a real one, not the overly-pretty kind too often painted by romantic idealists.

But while Perfuma did not know the woman, she apparently knew Perfuma, or knew *of* her; because she zeroed in on her with frankly unnerving focus, a scowl rising on her face so fierce that Perfuma felt pinned, as if by a needle- or, given the colors on the woman's armor, a bee's stinger, perhaps.

“ You,” the woman did not say so much as breathed. “ Well. You're not my Peekie, but I'm *really* fucking frustrated right now, so lucky me- I've got a target to take it out on.”

“ Uh, who are you?” Scorpia asked from the side, waving a pincer.

“ I'm Sweet Bee, leader of the Andreenids,” the newcomer spat, never looking at Scorpia directly, focusing her gaze entirely on Perfuma. “ And I’ve a bone to pick with you, *Perfuma.*”

She said the word like it was poison, like it rotted the air to speak it.

“ I’ve never even met you!” Perfuma protested, but the intruder just snorted.

“ No, but you’ve hurt me,” she said. “ Just like you’ve hurt everyone in Plumeria. That’s the hurt that hurts me; seeing your people die, suffer, ache, all because the Princess of Plumeria is a *coward.*”

She did spit the word, then, spat on the ground nearby, frowning through her broken teeth.

“ Hey!” Scorpia said, leaping to her new friend’s defense. “ What are you going on about? Perfuma’s punched me plenty of times!”

“ Only after the She-Ra,” Sweet Bee said. “ Only after a *hero of myth* showed up out of *nowhere.* If it hadn’t been for her… would you be here, now? Or would you be cowering somewhere as your Kingdom crumbled?”

" I…" Perfuma began, trying to defend herself; but nothing would come out, no words could force themselves out, because these were thoughts she'd had, said by another; her own worst thoughts, her deepest fears, her worst terrors, things she'd never said aloud.

But now, someone *was* saying them aloud, and it was so much *worse* than she'd ever expected it to be; every word spoken was made more real, somehow, by mere virtue of *being* said, and all Perfuma could do was stare in mute horror as Sweet Bee castigated her for sins Perfuma knew she'd committed.

" I have watched as your people suffered," Sweet Bee exclaimed, sweeping her arms out. " I have *seen* the effects of Plumeria's pacifism! They gave up their right to defend themselves to you, to *Princesses,* to people chosen at random by a goddamn rock! And that's evil, it is- but you didn't even have the decency to live up to your end of the bargain. The last Princess, she was as awful as you, but she *fought,* at least. She went out to die for her people. I can admire that, even as I lament the stupidity that made it not just possible, but certain… but you. *You.*"

Sweet Bee glared at her, and Perfuma wilted like a flower in a firestorm before that contempt. Scorpia said something and tried to interfere, moving closer to Sweet Bee, but the Princess and the Crownless were so focused on each other that neither paid any attention.

" You don't even do *that.* Your people got a rough deal when *you* were chosen, because you won't *fight.* Not until so many of your people were already dead. They hoped for you to protect them and you didn't! And that's wrong by itself, that the entire nation

surrenders to your right to fight for them. And you didn’t even fight! Maybe if you’d pushed for them to learn how to fight instead of just running, running, running… I could admire that...”

“ They’re learning now,” Perfuma was able, just barely, to say.

Sweet Bee met the words with a scoff.

“ *Now,*” she said. “ Because of the She-Ra. A literal *miracle* had to happen to get you to do anything for your people. I have *seen* the dead, Perfuma. Your people died and you did *nothing.* And because you didn’t teach them how to fight, just the way none of your ancestors did, they *died!* Graveyards full, Perfuma! And you didn’t even fight for them! You are a sack of sh-“

Mid-rant, Sweet Bee suddenly stopped, frozen where she stood- or, more accurately, *paralyzed.*

“ Sorry!” Scorpia said, her tail withdrawing from where it had stung the Andreenid trooper. “ She was just... being really aggressive, and yelling, and I wanted her to calm down, and it has a mind of its own sometimes!”

“ It's fine,” Perfuma said on autopilot, her mind still reeling with Sweet Bee's accusations, which sounded so much like those her own mind had spat at her, so often in these last few years.

“ But wow, she was a jerk, huh?” Scorpia said, shrugging awkwardly as she picked up Sweet Bee and propped her up in a corner. “ I mean, she seemed to have a real hate for you, but you hadn’t even met her before, had you?”

“ No,” Perfuma said, looking at the frozen trooper, and hearing her words- words that entered her head and found fertile soil there, soil long-prepared by worries and anxieties that had plagued the Princess for too many years. “ But... she wasn't wrong...”

So many thoughts, all swirling in Perfuma’s mind.

Plumerian Princesses demand the army be disbanded. We stole our people’s right to defend themselves… at least the last one fought, I haven’t, not really…

“ At least the last one fought…”

“ Perfuma?” Scorpia said to her new friend. “ You ok?”

“...I don't think so,” Perfuma answered honestly, staring at her hands, as she wrung them so hard her fingernails cut the skin, leaving bloody specks on the ground before her. “ I don’t think I’m ok at all.”

Tears soon joined the blood on the floor.

****

I am a traitor once more.

That thought beat like a drum in her skull as Entrapta ran, ran from her latest betrayal, ran from the proof, once more, that she could not be trusted, that anyone who did her a kindness was destined to suffer for it. *Hordak* had been kind to her, and then the Portal killed *him.* Catra and her mother had argued for Entrapta to be forgiven, and now she had left Catra laying on the floor, unconscious, hurt, as well as her sister, betraying the family twice for their single kindness.

This is why no one has ever wanted you.

She ran, ran from the thoughts, ran from the endless mill that told her that no faith in redemption would grant forgiveness for this mistake, that she had utterly and irrevocably ruined some of the last friendships she'd ever have. Glimmer was more ally than friend, but maybe they could have… and Catra had been so good to her… but no, no, no, that was gone, now. There was no chance she could ever be forgiven now, that anyone would ever be her friend after this. The speed of her hair racing over the stone was not enough to outrun the one last thought, that repeated, forever and ever, in a skull empty of all but her **hate** and her hurt:

<u>You are poison.</u>

She ran.

Back to the room, back to Scorpia, and Entrapta prayed *she* would not be there, because *she* was the last person Entrapta had not betrayed, the Drylborn begged foreign gods and whatever alien entities might deign to listen to an unworthy backstabber.

But none existed, because when she ripped the door open, nearly tearing it off its hinges, she found both of them there- Scorpia, whom she needed to make the plan work, and *Perfuma,* whom she loved, whom she would destroy if they were near each other for long enough.

" Hey Entrapta! What's up?" Scorpia asked. " We had the *worst* visitor while you were gone-"

" I... I have to go," Entrapta said without preamble, to Scorpia or Perfuma, maybe, or to the world in general. What few social graces she had were fleeing her in her need to go, to get out, to get her revenge and... and get away from this sense of doing wrong, this knowledge in her head that she was doing the wrong thing, helpless before the **hatred** in her skull that howled for blood. Only the *love* she felt for the Plumerian before her could stop her, and it could not do so for long; even as she halted, words fell out of her, she couldn't help herself. " the Black Garnet, fight through the Horde to connect Scorpia, stop **Adora**-"

“ You're... going to fight the Horde?” *she* said, and *her* face was... different, now, set and stern, beautiful in a warrior's way.

(But there were tear marks on that beautiful face, and there was blood on the floor, and Entrapta had to move- they wouldn’t stay down long- but some part of her wondered what had happened here, suddenly taking notice of a frozen-stiff figure in the corner, propped up like a statue. Sweet Bee…?)

“ Yes,” Entrapta said, after a moment to take in the room. “ We’re going to fight the Horde.”

“ If you're going to the Horde,” *Perfuma* said, brave and beautiful and strong, “ then I'm coming with you.”

“ Really?” Scorpia said, surprised.

She brought a hand to *her* face, to brush away tears, and succeeded only in leaving a single bloody mark under one eye, on her cheek, like a beautiful blossom of deepest red.

“ Yes,” *she* said, with that blood on her face.

And all Entrapta could think about was how, once, she'd thought it important that thorns had roses; and it was important, but that fact had a corollary, the equation had an equal and an opposite. If thorns had roses, then roses had thorns; but oh, had any rose

had thorns as beautiful as this? A veritable crown of thorns in those strong features, in that iron will, in that set stance.

In the face of all this, with her guts churning and her heart aflame, Entrapta could only say, " Then come with us."

(They were gone before anyone in the Castle found out what Entrapta had done... or what she was going to do.)

Chapter End Notes

I'm sure taking Perfuma along will cause absolutely no problems whatsoever.

I'm sure she's in the right state of mind to lay siege to the Fright Zone, which has changed a lot since the last time she was there.

I'm sure this won't cause any...

Problems.

Chapter 55: Aftermath of Disaster at Brightmoon Castle

Chapter Notes

Here we go!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Aftermath of Disaster in Brightmoon Castle

Catra struggled towards wakefulness.

It was... peacefully dark, in her head. Her mom's gift again? But she didn't feel peaceful like the sweet shadow made her feel. And hadn't her mom said something about it being... dangerous, somehow? To use it often?

Admittedly, Catra couldn't think of anything worse than sleeplessness, than days barely more alive than dead...

But, wait.

Why did she not feel rested? She felt... stiff, uncomfortable.

She blinked open her eyes, saw nothing the first or second time.

On the third, she saw that the room around her was not her bedroom... and memory came roaring back.

By great good luck, Flutterina was nearby, and heard Catra's yell of awakening; and soon enough Flutterina was running to get Micah and Angella, as Catra carried Glimmer, still unconscious, to the healers, other runners dispatched to find everyone else, and tell them to come quick, and hear what had transpired.

(But Catra knew she was too late, for she had been out cold for three hours, and Entrapta was gone.)

And while much was said and much discussed, this is the thing that matters:

It was decided that a raid must be launched on the Fright Zone, with the goal of stopping Scorpia from reaching the Black Garnet, and damning them all.

Chapter End Notes

Just a quick teaser before I upload a BIG chapter soon!

Chapter 56: Decisions of the Doom Balloon

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Decisions of the Doom Balloon

Fuck.

It wasn't an exclamation so much as a sigh, in Perfuma's head. Perhaps it was more appropriately written as *fuuuuuuuck* but that felt a bit forced, from her perspective; it wasn't a common literary device among Plumerians, to add letters to a word for emphasis. That was more a Salinean thing, like in the Pummeling Princess books Mermista had finally gotten her to read.

(Terrible drivel, but terribly addictive despite themselves; in particular, reading of Catra *singing* in those books had been hilarious… though seeing herself portrayed as some super powerful special ops warrior had been a bittersweet sort of thing. Almost a kind of hurt, to see an image of who she *should* have been, instead of… what she was.)

No, Plumerians simply wrote words differently to emphasize them; so, in the classical style of her people, being on the Doom Balloon, heading towards peril…

Well, that warranted a

Fuck.

Nowhere else had Perfuma felt so isolated from the green, save perhaps on the scout plane she'd ridden to get to Brightmoon Castle- and that had went by so fast she hadn't really had time to focus on the disconnect, the land blurring away beneath her, miles eaten in a moment.

But here, she'd had time to… linger, to settle on the feeling, to focus on it. No place on land could mimic this feeling; even in the midst of the Crimson Waste, some of the most devastated land in all Etheria, she had felt the few hardy seeds that could colonize the land at all, dreaming as they slept in the soil. They dreamed of the rare rains, of bursting forth into short but glorious life, to live and breed and die in a short explosive burst and leave behind dreaming seeds of their own, who would themselves sleep until the rains came again. An odd life, for a human, but the life they were made for, and one they would trade for nothing.

And that was to say nothing of the cacti! Cacti, whom she had hated so much once, but now saw in glorious new light; cacti, whose roots dug so deep, who were the hardiest of hardy survivors, dipping deep beneath the ground to drink deep of water that never saw the sun. From that darkness they grew strength, and protected it with spikes and paralyzing thorns, only rarely showing their true beauty in those rare times of spring abundance with delicate flowers. Like roses in reverse; a rose hid its thorns with gorgeous flowers, but a cacti wore its teeth openly, only showing its beautiful side to those with the patience for the prickly beasts. A more honest arrangement of flowers and thorns, perhaps, then roses, which liked to lie, which showed the flowers first and only used the thorns once you were lured in. Cacti advertised the thorns and showed the flowers later, only to those

who had bothered to learn about them, to get close *despite* the thorns.

(Perfuma's eyes flicked over to Scorpia, who had thought her body ugly; but it was so *magnificent,* and she wondered what flowers she might find, if she kept getting close to the lovely Scorpioni.)

So compared to the Doom Balloon, the Waste was bursting with life. Even her trips at sea- few as they were- still kept her in touch with algae and seaweed and more undefinable things, with vast underwater forests grazed by fish instead of deer, with floating mats that lived all their lives at the whims of the currents, and with the vast and infinite array of phytoplankton who fed the leviathans of the deep. Yes, the waters were awash with life, if she could forgive herself an accidental pun…

But here?

There was *nothing*.

It was like the place had been scorched clean of life.

(Unbidden, her mind turned to her old childhood nightmare, the Flame Princess, who burned all things to ashes, and what Angella had said of her at that meeting, so long ago… and she shivered.)

She sat in silence with her three companions, and of them, only Shadow Weaver seemed at ease, performing some quiet ritual by herself and occasionally sipping from a wine glass. As for the

other two, Scorpia looked vaguely discomfited, and Entrapta looked *deeply* discomfited.

Or at least, she had; her mask was down now, and she was working on some last minute thing- a laser cannon, by the looks of it. Perfuma knew nothing of the tech that went into such a thing- her powers were based in solid, understandable magic, not the bizarre whimsy and impossibility of technology- but she had been in enough fights at this point in her life to be able to recognize certain types of weaponry with just a glance, a skill that was vital on the battlefield. It let her know how to react.

For bows and their meaner cousins, crossbows, the right move was to raise plants as a shield and charge them- archers of any stripe tended to reload fast, but even fairly weak defenses would block the shots, and up close, it was no contest. For firearms, which could be identified by their solid construction and bigger muzzles compared to lasers, it was to raise a heavy shield, wait for them to stop shooting, then counterattack; bullets were nastier than arrows or bolts, but even they couldn't punch through a foot of hardwood, and they reloaded slow in most instances. Missile launchers and grenade launchers- identifiable by being very large, generally, or shoulder-mounted- were a delight for Perfuma; her plants reacted fast enough to grab the explosives and throw them back, and the mechanisms inside the ammo didn't register her plants as "solid targets", whatever that meant.

(She'd had Bow explain it to her once, but she hadn't understood much of it.)

Regardless, the end result was that explosive-wielding opponents were more a boon for Perfuma than a bane, and she'd had

endless victories earned by throwing some weapon back at its user.

But lasers… oh, she did not like those. Lasers, identifiable on sight because they were smaller, more delicate, did not have to have any padding because they had no recoil for their users and didn't have to deal with the aftershock of firing, and because they tended to have smaller barrels.

Perfuma could stop lasers for a very short time, her plants quickly absorbing as much of the light as they could… but it'd always end up being too much, and they'd burst into flame, and fire cut through all her defenses. Only Mermista and Netossa had any good defenses against the lances of light… Perfuma had to fall back on simply attacking as hard as she could, in hopes of taking them out quick.

She'd learned these things to make those strategies just… background noise, something she did on instinct, fighting more as an artform than as a science. Mid-combat, there wasn't *time* for thought; there was only time for action, reaction, flex and reflex, swept up in the chaos of carnage and carried like blossoms on the wind. Passion and power, moving as one; Perfuma couldn't count the fights she'd been in that she'd been hurt in, and never noticed, only finding out later when her rushing blood let her focus on anything else.

…It scared her, sometimes.

(*It says something, that I can recognize weapons by sight now,* some part of her thought, the part that wondered if, somehow,

the shadow Perfuma cast was that of a Lily, bound with great and terrible Glory… *It says something I don't like…*)

Still, scary or not, that experience told Perfuma that the weapon Entrapta was building was a laser- albeit a very *large* one. Whatever was about to go down, Entrapta was greeting it with all force.

Perfuma had asked her, as this started, if she didn't need to be piloting the ship- but apparently the Doom Balloon could fly itself, on an "auto-pilot", whatever that was. Despite Entrapta's reassurances, though, the ship kept making… noises, creaking, cracking… noises that sounded a lot to Perfuma like something breaking! She felt it didn't take a tech mistress to figure that out. Things tearing themselves apart all sounded pretty similar, after all.

But Entrapta said nothing, so Perfuma leaned on that. Maybe Entrapta knew what she was doing.

Which would put her one up over me, Perfuma thought, and shivered. She wished she were doing something… easy. Simple. Like the time she made decorations for that celebration of Hordak's death! That was… that was a good thing. Same as making his topiary statue in the garden. Good.

(She had done both, because both were required. The All was *All* for a reason; the good did not wipe out the bad, the bad did not wipe out the good. One's soul was painted with *all* one's colors, grim and great both; that was why she had wept for the death of Hordak the hero… and celebrated the death of Hordak the villain.

One or the other would have been wrong, but *both* was just right- was *All* of the man.)

But this was… complicated. Hard. If it weren't for Sweet Bee's words, she wouldn't even be here at all… but that thought brought shame, to know she wouldn't be here without someone *else* castigating her, making her realize she… she should have been there, all along. Just like she'd never have changed her ways if Catra had not appeared to show her a new way... another thing Sweet Bee had pointed out.

Yes, it was an almost kindly venom had Sweet Bee stung Perfuma with, one that stiffened her spine, slowed her breathing, gave her… not calm, but… *focus.*

She was still worried, her hands wringing whenever she stopped paying attention to them… but she had not torn open the old scars or the wounds she'd carved in them with her fingernails while the Rebel ranted. Entrapta had offered gel to heal those wounds, some antiseptic wonder drug in pasty-white; mingled with the red of Perfuma's blood, it had turned an awkward kind of ugly pink, like raw wet meat, but it had done the job, sealing up her hurts.

Now the hurt was a heartwound, was the concern inside her, not on her skin.

An old heartwound at that, too.

Sweet Bee was not the first person to realize Perfuma was a failure as a Princess, after all.

How could she be? Every time Perfuma heard reports of some new village that had to be abandoned, or that was crushed in a raid, children taken; every time she had to go meet with representatives of various refugee groups, fleeing the frontline as it moved ever closer, or had to negotiate with Rebel warbands to ensure they'd protect her people, paying them mercenary-style with food and whatever resources she had that they valued, because Plumeria could not protect itself.

All Perfuma's fault. Five generations of Plumerians had not needed to fight… but now they did, because of Perfuma. Because Perfuma was so...

So *scared* of her own strength.

(*I have reason to be,* a quiet part of her thought, as it saw visions of the Glory Lilies in her head. *All Etheria has reason to be.*)

If she was braver... maybe...

...No point in thinking on that now. It was late in the harvest, as they said... but not too late. Not yet.

Perfuma took a steadying breath, and tried to meditate. Thoughts intruded anyway, but… more pleasant ones, and she took refuge in them.

…

…It's not all my fault, I can take some comfort in that. Sweet Bee felt it was a societal issue, blamed all Plumerian Princesses, even before my time...

…

...not all my fault. And... I'm taking responsibility for my part in it. For my mistakes. Like I did by being kind to Entrapta, for failing her in the Fright Zone...

…

I can do this.

…

She was like that for a while- she wasn't sure how long- before she opened her eyes again, and paid attention to the world around her.

Shadow Weaver and Entrapta were arguing quietly nearby, but before Perfuma could focus on that, her eyes were caught by Scorpia; Scorpia, who was so big, and so strong, with all her lovely muscles and shining chitin, like a Blackmoor knight in shining armor.

And yes, Perfuma's lust for muscular folk was a bit shallow, as she was perfectly aware... but she had more reason than *that* for the butterflies in her stomach, in her guts. Scorpia was... a delight, and always was, even when she was on the other side. Scorpia, who served the Horde in the most oblivious way, who had never held an ounce of meanness in her bones even when she was fighting them.

It wasn't desire at first sight, either. It wasn't like Perfuma didn't *know* Scorpia; they'd spent years battling each other, after all, and that taught you a lot about a person. Scorpia, who was so strong that even Catra, with all the She-Ra's holy might, had trouble equaling her; Scorpia, who had been known to accept surrenders, who didn't mistreat prisoners, who had never been *cruel,* the way so many Horde soldiers were. Scorpia, who could never be accused of having a brilliant mind… but who likewise could not be denied as having a brilliant *heart.*

(Perfuma recalled stories she'd heard, of Catra, half-drunk in the arctic from some of Entrapta's tech; it had been Scorpia who saved her then, who had spared her. Scorpia had always been the best of the Horde...)

...Yes, what was going on in Perfuma... had more reasons than just looks. This wasn't like her little crush on Huntara, that lovely desert rose; she'd enjoyed that crush, knowing entirely it would

never go anywhere and perfectly content with that. Some flowers were never meant to lay the seeds of greater things, but simply to be beautiful in their time and fade; and there was nothing wrong with that. The seasons danced and every dance had its time and its place. There was room in the All for true love and little smitten feelings both.

So while she had amused herself with fantasies of Huntara's arms, she had known that the desert rose was not growing for her. Someone else was destined to be honored as *that* lovely's flower's personal gardener.

(Far away in the Crimson Waste, a barmaid worried for Huntara, whom she had not heard from in some time.)

And those feelings made her wonder if... this was such a good idea. So much was riding on Scorpia, on her connection- if she had one- with the Black Garnet, and the way Entrapta had just... torn off to go do this, as if it must be done *now,* suddenly...

Something about this was wrong.

…No, bad Perfuma brain, the Plumerian admonished herself. *Bad Perfuma brain! Trust in Entrapta, who trusts in you.*

And she did, to an incredible degree; something Perfuma appreciated, even if she didn't understand it. Dryl and Plumeria had never had the warmest relations, not since the Glory Lilies; but even when those scars had faded- to the extent they ever had- the two had not liked each other. Dryl viewed Plumerian

merchants as competitors and Plumeria thought the same of them, and since Dryl controlled the sole trade route to the Twin Kingdoms, Plumeria had always been cut off from them; in retaliation, Plumeria had often forced heavy tolls on Dryl, or even denied them some trade routes. That had mostly ended after Phlax was formed and Dryl had an alternativ route through its fellow Crownless, but...

Well, they'd never been allies. Not really. Like most Crownless and Runestone nations, really, save for Brightmoon, ever the exception in such matters.

But regardless, Entrapta trusted Perfuma... and Perfuma, who had failed her at the Fright Zone that first time, who might have averted all that was to come if she'd just done the job Catra had assigned her, would not fail her again. She would trust the engineer, no matter her own... worries.

(*This is a mistake,* her mind insisted, looking at the facts, looking at the sheer *strangeness* of all this... but she put that away. She would trust.)

In service of that trust, Perfuma turned to hear what the mage and the engineer were saying to each other.

" We don't have enough," Entrapta said, frustrated and… were those tears, from under the mask? The insectoid look of the mask was hiding so much, but it could not hide the tears that dripped from Entrapta's chin. " We don't have enough, we don't- "

“ Then we should pull back,” Shadow Weaver was saying, giving wise council. That *was* good advice, if they lacked the resources.

“ I can't,” Entrapta said. “ It must be now. It *must* be now. There won't... there won't be another chance.”

“ Why the sudden change in plans?” Shadow Weaver asked, eyes narrowing in suspicion. “ I've heard no news that would justify such a shift in priorities...”

... *No, you don't get to question her.*

Perfuma didn't blame Entrapta for being on the backfoot when dealing with the dark witch. Perfuma knew very few things about Shadow Weaver, but she *did* know, from rumor and gossip, that Catra supposedly feared her; and that said *everything,* because Catra was scared of *nothing* , and to inspire terror in the She-Ra meant Shadow Weaver must be a monster without compare.

But Perfuma would not let Entrapta face such a terror alone, and she rose up and approached them, fearless in her stride.

(Perfuma had this much going for her; she had always been too afraid of *herself* to be all that afraid of anything else.)

“ I trust her,” Perfuma said to the shadowbeast. “ And... I can help.”

“ A Plumerian Princess *would* normally add great weight to our fight,” the witch said. “ But... *you?* ”

That disdain seemed to stiffen Entrapta's spine, her hair pausing a moment before tightening into angry coils.

“ She exceeds all expectation, as a matter of course,” the Drylborn snapped out. “ Perfuma has... has the whole of my trust.”

(She almost said *whole of my heart, now that the other claimant is dead,* but stopped herself.)

“ Thank you,” Perfuma said... but looking at Entrapta, she thought of a way to help, to comfort her, and maybe it was inappropriate but...

Well, nothing for it but to try.

“ Entrapta?” she asked, and the Drylborn’s hair stopped twitching in its serpentine tornado, she paused to look at her. “ May I lift your mask?”

“ I… why?” Entrapta asked.

“ Trust me,” Perfuma requested.

“…Ok,” Entrapta said, in a very small voice.

Perfuma lifted her mask to find what she'd expected; tears on the woman's face, tears of frustration and fury and… and pain.

Perfuma didn't know *why* Entrapta was suffering so much, but she didn't have to, did she?

She still had an answer for her, something to help.

" Even if you don't have the forces," Perfuma said, and gave what she hoped was a reassuring smile as she cupped Entrapta's face in her hands, trying to reassure her, " I might have an answer."

There was a long moment, and then something a little like a smile passed over Entrapta's face, just for a moment.

" You always do this," she murmured, looking at Perfuma… *looking* at her. " You... you have made it normal to be exceptional, and I do not know how that is possible."

Something in Perfuma clicked.

(That was the look her fathers had given each other, sometimes, a look that said *you have the answers to all my questions.* A look of... love.)

But too much was happening, and Perfuma did not know how she felt about that, and so she buried it- for now. A seed, to be considered later, to grow or to prune as she thought best, when she had time to *think* best.

Right now, she had a duty to fulfill.

The last Princess actually fought, she heard Sweet Bee snarl… and she agreed with that Crownless soldier. The last Princess *had* fought.

It was high time Perfuma did, too.

" I am not a Glory Lily," she told Entrapta, " but I know how to perform one of their tricks. Bitterlye."

Shadow Weaver's eyes widened in surprise, while Scorpia scratched her head.

" What's that?" Scorpia interrupted.

" A great weapon," Shadow Weaver breathed in, sounding *delighted.*

" Rots technology, ruins metal, ends all artifice," Perfuma explained, before gently stepping away from Entrapta, whose head followed her hands very briefly even after the contact was ended, as if seeking ever more comfort. " It's… it's a horrible thing. But it doesn't hurt- it doesn't hurt flesh or wood. Natural stuff. I'm- I'm *not* a Glory Lily. But I can still…"

" What's a Glory Lily?" Scorpia asked, before rubbing her head. " Sorry, I… know I ain't the brightest, but I'm just… so confused."

Perfuma shook her head.

" There's no shame," she said. " The Glory Lilies… ancestors of mine. We think. My dads were always pretty sure we were descended from the first one and her wife, Kaname and Akemi… they had a bunch of kids. Lot of people descended from them changed their names later when the Glory Lilies reign ended… but my dads were pretty sure that my ancestors were some of those kids, names changed to hide it over the years. Not that you could blame them; the Glory Lilies... they were monsters."

" They were great and powerful," Shadow Weaver argued, and that hurt, to hear Shadow Weaver- monster- praise her ancestors.

" But you're not a monster," Scorpia said at the same time, on reflex, and that?

That helped, a little.

" You are no monster," Entrapta said... and coming from one whose nation had suffered the *most* under the Glory Lilies...

That helped, too.

" It is an awful thing... but maybe we can use it for the *right* cause this time... I think everything in the Fright Zone is going to be weak to this," Perfuma said. " It's all metal."

" We'll tear our way right in on the back of bitterlye," Shadow Weaver gloated. " With Scorpia's strength, Entrapta's tech, and my magic, combined with their own technology rotting out from under them... this can be done!"

" That… might be enough," Entrapta said, still putting her helmet down- but not so hard, and it did not sit quite so tight, and no more tears dripped down her chin. " With the Doom Balloon, with the forces I can make or cannibalize from the ship, and the bitterlye harming any response… how will you deliver it?"

Memories of that night planning strategy- so long ago now- flitted through Perfuma, and she remembered how her giant plant golem had worked out.

Looking at Entrapta's long, snakelike hair, and Scorpia's heroic build… and remembering that scorpions were symbols of courage since long, long ago- gave the Plumerian an idea.

" I have an idea," she said. " But set me down outside the Fright Zone some way- it'll need… some distance."

Entrapta nodded her acquiescence, and now Perfuma had only to wait with bated breath for the things to come.

****

The time came sooner than Perfuma would have thought.

The Doom Balloon's transport- with more effort than it had used in Plumeria, as though something fundamental was breaking down in the ship's internals- lowered her to the ground; Perfuma sighed as she stood there, feeling the green reassert itself into her senses. Desert scrub that it was, the land around her was still an impossible bounty compared to the sterile Doom Balloon.

Entrapta had come with her, but seemed incapable of saying anything; she simply let out a strand of hair, and Perfuma gently grasped it for a moment, giving a reassuring squeeze before she let go and continued on. Entrapta let her go, crying silent tears as Perfuma stepped off the platform, parts of her hair moving as if they wanted to grab her, coil up tight, never let her go.

But she did not stop Perfuma, and finally the transport went up a moment later. Entrapta gave her one last glance before slamming her mask over her face to hide her tears.

(Entrapta, overwhelmed, by *her,* who was once again giving more than expected, as was somehow the norm; *Perfuma,* the woman who made it almost habit to outperform all expectations. The woman Entrapta loved… who was now helping Entrapta achieve the only dream she had left, of getting revenge on the **one** who had taken away *Hordak,* the man Entrapta still loved, even now.)

The Doom Balloon had taken off a moment later; Perfuma had ensured them that she'd get to the Fright Zone when they did, and the Balloon would be slower than what she was planning.

Perfuma, for her part, felt... oddly calm. Her decisions had all been made, and the terror was in the making of them; but now?

Now, she felt... good, actually.

Because this was the moment in which she made up for her mistakes.

And her idea was... well, it would please Glimmer, who had always loved the theatrical. On that long-ago day, when the War had been more thrilling than exhausting, when the Princess Alliance

was newborn, and they had planned an attack... a golem of green, that was the idea.

But she could do better, couldn't she?

She'd never *really* used her full strength.

So now...

She dug deep, deep into the Heart-Blossom, deep into the power that had been hers since she was a child, when the last Princess had died and she was elected to take over the throne.

Deep... deep, for herself.

For Plumeria.

For Scorpia, and Entrapta, her two friends, one old, one new...

(That reminded her of a poem… *something old, something new, something borrowed, something blue.* Wasn't that part of someone's marriage rites? Someone's song? Fright Zone, maybe, before the Horde? Not Plumerian, but then again, neither were Scorpia or Entrapta and… why was she thinking about this?)

…

Scorpions and snakes...

An idea, for the shape of her new weapon.

She laughed as she called on the green, on the deep roots of cacti, on all the *life* that flourished all about her; she fed it with her energy and her magic, and it responded, erupting out of the ground, forming around her, the first and greatest task of all life- to *grow.*

She laughed, because how perfect was this? Bitterlye was a poison, an ancient venom; and what were scorpions and snakes, but deliverers of sting and bite?

And it *should* be a scorpion, because they were reclaiming the throne of the Fright Zone, held since time immemorial in Scorpioni hands. A scorpion, for they were brave beasts that took on the world with nothing but pincer and stinger, who backed down from *nothing,* whom Plumeria loved as symbols of strength and courage.

And a snake, for Entrapta, who seemed so much like one at times; a snake, for Plumeria loved them, too. Snakes, beloved for regeneration, for change, for shedding their skins to make themselves anew. Symbols of change... appropriate, for she was trying to change the world.

And so it was with a smile that Perfuma made a new body for war.

(And when she was done, and safely ensconced in her weapon, she made war cry with nine mouths, and her form scuttled vermin-fast across the sands, towards the Fright Zone, ready for war.)

****

The Fright Zone was not having a good time of it, this night.

First, communications had went down earlier for some reason, and then the lights and other systems had went haywire. The guards at the front wall, nervous and worried, had nonetheless obeyed orders to stay at the front; this was their duty, after all, and a Hordesman would rather die than give up their duty.

Still, the explosions and fighting they heard *inside* the Zone worried them... but this was their duty, so they stayed, ready to fight outsiders, worrying what was happening deeper inside the Zone.

Those worries were soon put aside, however, because they had problems of their own incoming. Their first glimpse of the chaos that was about to break loose was a great zeppelin approaching,

one that was beginning to fall apart even as it approached, fire trailing from some chunks of it… and beneath it, of more concern, something that defied all description.

" What the fuck is that?" the Hordesman in charge said, staring at it as it approached.

" Don't fucking know, but it's coming this way!" another yelled, and they began to move the cannons to meet the threat.

It was… a scorpion, in a sense. A scorpion of impossibly gigantic size, and one that- as it drew closer, as the floodlights lit it up, as they could actually *see* the thing that was kicking up so much sand as it moved- was made entirely out of *plants, g*reen shrubs and vines growing and hanging from every joint in the armored shell. That shell itself was made of rocks held together with roots- the monster had dug deep for those, considering that the Fright Zone was a desert- and they proved their worth when the cannons went off; those big shells hit the rocks and bounced off, skipping like rocks off of a lake, the armor sloped such that attacks bounced off.

(An accident; Perfuma was no smith. But she *did* have an intimate understanding of nature, and had built the shell to mimic a scorpion's natural armor; and natural evolution had shaped the scorpion with the same slopes a master smith would have given crafted armor, so Perfuma's choice was proving wise with every shot that did not sink in, but slid off her shell like rainwater.)

The thing was coming on big legs that looked like roots, the pincers vast boulders united by more vines who could bring them together with crushing forces. A small "head" completed the front, though what purpose that would serve on the machine, they had no idea, though it had a mouth- which was worrying on something that much bigger than a person.

It was hard to notice that, though, because where the stinger should be was instead a writhing bouquet of massive vines in the shape of snakes, eight of them total, and as the thing drew near

the wall, those heads- titanic in scale, each the size of a Hordesman in full armor- revealed one last trick.

They opened their mouths, and spewed forth a green gunk that *melted* everything it touched, everything but flesh.

Hordesmen screamed and ran as the heads vomited their terrible payload; they were unharmed, but the walls collapsed almost immediately. Hordesmen fell from them as they buckled, to be caught in serpent mouths or by scorpion claws... and, paradoxically, put gently on the ground, out of the way, saved by the monster who had endangered their lives.

(Perfuma, inside, her mind split between all the things she was doing at once... and still she would not kill if she did not have to. A Hordesman with no armor and no weapon was no threat, and would be spared. No matter how her head ached, how her powers strained, no matter how she felt her consciousness being torn apart from doing too much at once. She would *not* be a Glory Lily, she would *not* be a monster.)

With the walls ruined, and the burning zeppelin crashing into the Zone's heart, the scorpion-serpent raced on, deeper into the Zone, hunting the Garnet at its heart.

Chapter End Notes

> The Fright Zone is having a LOT happen tonight. You'll see next chapter.
>
> Perfuma's fearlessness in the face of Shadow Weaver- who is objectively terrifying- is a reflection of Perfuma's characterization in the first She-Ra, where she was explicitly said to be the one member of the Rebellion who wasn't afraid of Hordak. Some of that blithe courage I grant her here.
>
> The reason Perfuma’s plants can grab and chuck things back is because 1.) a lot of her plants fight without Perfuma’s

conscious control, working on "defend the Princess!" and thus moving much, much faster than Perfuma's conscious thought, being more akin to a reflex, and 2.) In real life, most rockets/grenades have distance and impact sensors to tell them when they've "hit" something or gone far enough and should explode. Perfuma's plants grab them around the middle, which is not where most rockets/grenades have a sensor, so they don't know they've been caught, and since they get tossed back front-forward (because that's the most aerodynamic way to throw them), they explode on the return trip instead of in Perfuma's vines.

I said Plumerian Princesses were nothing to fuck with- keep in mind that Perfuma is NOT a "strong" Princess for her type! She's fairly average. The Glory Lily Kaname was the most powerful Plumerian Princess and she nearly brought the world to its knees. Perfuma is middling in power by comparison to other Plumerian Princesses- and she's the most powerful Runestone Princess on Etheria right now. Frosta, who will go down in history as the strongest Snows Princess if she lives long enough, will overtake her in time… again, if she lives that long.
(Note that I said Runestone. Catra and Adora are both stronger, but Catra's not a Runestone Princess, and Adora's situation is unique given the Spirit Ember's artificial nature. If you count her as a Runestone Princess, then Adora is the strongest Runestone Princess, barely behind Catra in raw power, then followed by Perfuma and Frosta in that order. Glimmer's gotten a big power boost recently, but she's too new to her darkness to be on this list yet, too untrained.)

Chapter 57: The Third Raid on the Fright Zone

Chapter Notes

> This is all taking place about an hour before Entrapta and her zeppelin hit the Fright Zone; it's roughly at the same time that Perfuma is growing her scorpion-serpent.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Third Raid on the Fright Zone

" You sure you're okay, sis?" Catra asked, as the duo waited in a room off from the Moonstone. Neither were needed yet for the ritual- though Glimmer's turn was coming soon. For now, they had this room.

" I'm the same as I was the last time you asked that," Glimmer muttered glumly, downing another gulp of the Plumerian concoction the Queen had ordered brought up from below. Some godawful combination of coffee and medicine, ones that numbed pain even as they made the mind speed up; personally, just the *whiff* of it that Catra was getting every time Glimmer unbottled the thing was making the Magicat sick to her stomach. Glimmer's face said it did not taste better than it smelled, either.

" ...Sorry," Catra said, tail lashing nervously behind her. One of Glimmer's new wings extended itself over her and pressed up

against her, something like a feathery pat on the back and a hug from a downy pillow both.

" Hey, I'm freaked out too," Glimmer said. " But we can't do anything until we're ready- and we'll make good time. Entrapta talked a lot about the Doom Balloon; it can't get there before our teleport does. We'll be there *long* before the zeppelin arrives- unless she's willing to have the damn thing explode out from under her. She claimed she'd have to overclock it to make the distance to Beast Island in one day, and while the Fright Zone's a bit closer, same idea applies. Right?"

Catra did not point out that Glimmer did not have the geographic nor engineering know-how to make that claim so boldly, that really it was all just wishful thinking; she did not say this, because it was comforting to believe that Glimmer was telling the truth, and Catra could do with some comfort.

What she really wanted, though, was to *do* something. The waiting... the waiting was always the worst part, no matter what was being waited *for.* Waiting for Shadow Weaver to decide what punishment she deserved, waiting for Adora to be done with whatever task occupied her so they could do things together, waiting for a battle, waiting...

She flexed her claws. Silver, she *hated* fucking waiting.

Catra briefly thought about getting some food- maybe her retainers could make her another ploughman's sandwich?- before she remembered that she'd given them the rest of the day off

before the War Council. Damn shame, she could do with something in her stomach right now- or at least, something for her hands and mouth to *do.* She wasn't really hungry- and the smell of Glimmer's drink wasn't helping- but anything would be better than this *waiting.*

" ...What are you drinking?" Catra finally asked, for lack of better things to do.

" It's supposedly the Potion of a Thousand Herbs," Glimmer said, minus her usual theatrics. " Which means someone in Plumeria doesn't want to tell us what's in it."

Catra had heard that particular phrase before, but had never had one.

" What... do a thousand herbs taste like?" Catra asked.

" An ashtray," Glimmer responded, grunting as she took another swig. " Still, I need it. This particular potion is for muscle pains and has coffee in it to give some energy, so that's what I'm using it for. It'll clear up my back muscles and get me ready for... whatever's gonna happen tonight."

" Why not use it earlier?" Catra asked, and Glimmer made a disgusted noise, sticking her tongue out.

“ Besides the fact I can barely force it down?” Glimmer asked rhetorically. “ Because it's powerful stuff, and we don't have a lot of it. Plumeria's... not been as unfriendly as the Snows, but they're still not as friendly with us as Salineas or the Crownless. This cost a ton of silver. That, and I can't emphasize enough how bad this tastes. And the *texture!* It's bad enough to gag one of those monkeys on Beast Island.”

“...Gross,” Catra said, after a minute, and Glimmer offered a weak laugh.

“ Hey,” she said, putting a hand on Catra's shoulder. “ Cheer up. We've faced worse before. We can do this.”

But that was when I believed in the Sword, Catra thought. *When I believed in... me...*

She swallowed hard- and then, hunting distraction, said the first thing to come to mind.

“ Let me have a swig of that,” Catra asked.

“ Oh Silver, *why?* ” Glimmer asked, even as she held out the bottle. “ Take a small sip if you don't want to regret it... anymore than you're already going to.”

“ I'll be fine,” Catra said. “ Best Princess, remember?”

(*Am I even a real Princess anymore, the Sword is evil, the Sword... but I said I could use it for good anyway, I* ***have*** *used it for good, right?*)

The bottle did not smell better when it was closer to her nose. In point of fact, it was *much* worse. Even the stale ration bars she'd lived off of for a while- during the worst days of Shadow Weaver's many mindless cruelties, when Catra was denied food- hadn't smelled *this* bad.

Still, she was committed, and focusing on how awful all this was meant she didn't focus on... everything else.

" Down the hatch," Catra muttered before taking not a small sip, but a big swig.

" Oh no!" Glimmer said, distinctly, as Catra knocked back a big shot... and *immediately* regretted it. She dropped the bottle as she started hacking coughs, Glimmer barely catching it as Catra choked.

" Aghk!" Catra said, or more accurately, pronounced.

" Do you need me to help?" Glimmer asked. " I can do that thing where you help someone choking by hitting them in the gut!"

Catra had no idea what Glimmer was talking about, and was happy to never know.

" S'fine!" she managed, though it *wasn't.* She could *feel* the leaves in the concoction as they burned a trail down her throat... and a little into her sinuses, because her coughing had sent a few rogue drops up her nose. " Just... need to... puke."

(And not just for the thing in her stomach, either; for her nerves, too, which had been frayed all untenderly by Entrapta's betrayal, but what was happening *tonight.*)

" Okay," Glimmer said, as Catra staggered to her feet, still coughing. Her wings fluttered nervously, and it made Catra think of their mother, which brought a little amusement even in her current circumstances. " I gotta stay here- they'll need me for the spell soon."

Catra nodded- she thought, she was still busy hacking up what felt like her whole ass lungs- before managing to find a bathroom. Once there, she made offering to the porcelain god, because Glimmer hadn't been kidding; that was the single *worst* thing she'd ever drank. She could have *chewed* on it.

(And maybe it was nerves, too; maybe some part of her had just needed to puke to emphasize just how much *pressure* was on Catra, who carried the death of the universe in her hand. Maybe some part of her had needed the rough cleansing to reach some kind of unsteady equilibrium.)

When Catra got back, Glimmer was nowhere to be seen; but there was Flutterina, big backpack on, and she saluted as Catra entered.

" Much to report, ma'am!" she said.

Catra, born a Hordesman, returned the salute out of habit- that was just what you did when people saluted you.

" Proceed, soldier," Catra said- in the language of her childhood, Perfect Speech, which Flutterina did not know, Catra's ragged nerves going with the default setting from her nerves and all the *pressure.*

Thankfully, Flutterina got the gist of it anyway- and Perfect Speech sounded enough like Brightmoon's Orgel that Flutterina assumed it was the same language.

" First- Glimmer's off to work on the spell!" Flutterina said in her swift Orgel- a second language, given that Mountainflower was her first. The kid had picked up the new language the same way she did most things- fast. " It'll be done momentarily, so Queen Angella has politely requested that you join them at the Moonstone as soon as possible.."

" Good," Catra said, switching back to Orgel unconsciously. " We... we need to get there *first.* "

" Secondly, Queen Angella has put out an alert- all hands on deck! All present Princesses have committed to help, including Netossa

and Spinnerella! Sea Hawk of Salineas, Chilla of the Snows, Sweet Bee of Phlax-though-she-told-me-to-say-the-Crownless, the Red Knight of Blackmoor, and Prince Peekablue of Seaworthy-right-now-but-he-said-probably-Phlax-soon, and then a bunch of Rebels, including that scary minotaur woman, have all decided to assist as well! My words, not the Queen's! And good news- Prince Peekablue has confirmed through the Perfect Blue that Scorpia, Entrapta, and Perfuma have not reached the Fright Zone yet!”

Oh, that was right- he was an oracle. Mom had mentioned him... he could track anyone he'd ever met. And he'd been at the meeting when they all walked in, hadn't he?

So... there was still time. Still time.

“ Okay,” Catra said, cheered a bit. The bomb was not going off *yet.* “ Anything else?”

“ Your mom gave me a letter to give to you!” Flutterina said. “ For your eyes only, she said!”

Flutterina presented a letter that not been opened, creased only by the tiny fist that had held it.

“ Okay,” Catra said. “ Is she awaiting a reply?”

“ Not from me!” Flutterina answered. “ I think that's everything, though! I'm going back to the Moonstone to see if anyone else needs anything!”

...A glint in Flutterina's eyes, one that Catra had seen in mirrors before. Flutterina wasn't going back *just* to assist, Catra would bet her fur on it. That was the same glint of mischief Catra had when she was planning on doing something she knew she shouldn't.

...It was remarkable, how endearing Catra found that. This little shit was a kid after her own heart.

“ You're going up there because you intend to go too, right?” Catra asked the little one with a smirk.

Flutterina froze, and gave *another* look Catra knew well- the look of one caught mid-scheme.

“ I...” Flutterina began awkwardly, the same way Catra always had when called out.

“ It's okay,” Catra said quickly. She'd never liked being in that situation, either. “ Just tell them...”

... *Wait. Idea. I was already thinking of making her a squire...*

“ Tell them,” Catra said, “ that you're my squire, and I said you could go.”

“ Your-squire?!?” Flutterina squealed in her too-fast speech, clapping her hands as her eyes lit up like stars. “ You-mean-it?!?”

“ Yeah,” Catra said, a real smile spreading on her face. The kid's joy was infectious. “ I've been meaning to make you my squire, but shit keeps happening; I don't know how to do it formally, but I'm sure Mom can walk me through it. But regardless of ceremony, if you want to be my squire, then you're my squire, from this moment on.”

“ Me- the-squire-of-the-She-Ra?!? *Catra's* -squire?!?” Flutterina squeaked, sounding quite a bit like tires taking a turn far too fast on a wet road. “ Oh-my-All-holy-shit-damn-Silver!”

“ Slow down, kid,” Catra said with a chuckle. “ Gonna blow a fuse at this rate.”

(Catra wasn't sure what a fuse *was* but she'd heard Bow bitching about them blowing out often enough to be familiar with the concept.)

Yeah, this was worth it, just to cheer me up, Catra thought. With all the horrors and terrors of her life in the past few days, all the big nightmares, it was good to make a small dream come to life.

“ I-I-I-will-try!” Flutterina said, almost literally stuttering to a stop. “ Iiiiii.... Princess Catra, I can't... I'm so... I had *hoped* ...”

And now her eyes were full of tears; but they were sweet, tears of joy, not sorrow, the kind of crying that happens when the spirit is so happy that the body must weep to get it out.

Catra, Hordesman at heart, said nothing of the tears, only fired off a snappy salute.

“ Get out of here,” she commanded gently. “ I'll see you at the Moonstone.”

Flutterina gave Catra the best salute she'd ever seen, as perfect as if done by machine.

“ Yes-ma'am-yes!”

And then she was off, like a rocket, her speed just this side and just this shy of... odd.

(*What are the warning signs of a Wild Princess about to gain powers?* Catra wondered briefly, before putting that thought away. Flutterina's speed and reactions *were* unusual, but she had a lot on her plate right now without wondering if Flutterina was going to trigger as a Wild Princess. Did that even happen all that often? Surely not.)

Alone, Catra opened the letter, finding her mother's precise, lovely handwriting inside.

My dear daughter,

I know this request will hurt you, which is why I wrote it down. In person, I fear we'd argue, like I used to with Glimmer; so I write it, in hopes of lessening the hurt.

And hurt it will, but I beg you to listen to me.

Take the Sword with us.

We may need the She-Ra's strength.

I know this will tax you, scare you, hurt you, and I apologize for it...

But we may need its might.

Please, bring the Sword with you.

Your mother,

Angella

…

Well, shit.

That was Catra's first thoughts after reading the letter; because her mom was *right* but she didn't want her to be.

Maybe there would be nothing? But no, that was the wrong way to think. Hadn't they once thought of Adora as the inferior sequel to Hordak? And despite that, she'd surprised them once, hadn't she?

Catra's brain wracked itself wondering what Adora might have on hand. New tech? Probably not, not with Entrapta being her enemy. But maybe also yes, because it wasn't like Entrapta was the *only* tech mistress in the world, and who knew what the Horde had stolen or found in its conquests? New allies? No, probably not, Adora had not engaged in a diplomatic strategy; perhaps one had not been suggested to her. Good, too; a diplomatic Horde would be harder to fight.

What else is there? Catra thought. *I'm the only She-Ra and all the Princesses are accounted for- well, except the Fire Princess Mom mentioned at that one council meeting, but Mom didn't seem to think it was likely it could be used…*

But even knowing that, Catra's mind wandered back to the Adora of the Portal, where half of her had been eaten by *the light the light the light,* cooking the other half, and she shivered. If Adora got her hands on the Spirit Ember…

But surely not. The Alliance's luck couldn't be *that* bad.

(*Luck as bad as a holy sword turning out to be the fuse to end all life?* she thought, and shivered again.)

Adora's Horde had fire enough in Catra's opinion; had in fact, too much ever since they had invented the flamethrowers. Catra briefly wished she could punch whoever had done *that* in the throat.

(Far to the south, Adora rubbed at her neck, which suddenly felt sore.)

...Maybe the Sword was a reasonable weapon, in such circumstances. A way to deal with the unexpected.

And it's not like I want it just laying around...

Still, Catra hesitated. She even briefly wished Huntara was here. The former Hordeswoman would be extra muscle on their side, and someone who knew the Fright Zone just like Catra did... plus whatever black market crap her and Tung could pull out of the Valley of the Lost.

But Huntara and Tung were busy in the Crimson Waste; Catra wasn't sure what they were doing, save that Mermista had mentioned she was looking into drills and water pumps.

(Unbeknownst to Catra, at this very moment, Huntara and Tung Lashor were drilling in an area of the Waste that Huntara had noted sometimes had geysers bursting from the ground, and that seemed to be a bit lower than the rest of it; she believed it might be where an underground lake sat. Her instincts, as she would discover in three days, were correct; her drill would pierce through to that lake, breaking the crust trapping it; Huntara, as the one person in the Waste who knew how to swim, would save Tung as the the freshwater poured out in a flood, creating a great lake in the midst of the Crimson Waste, one that would in time be called the Huntung Lake, after the two leaders who created it.)

...So, bereft, Catra went to get the Sword.

(She stood in her mother's room for a long time, staring at the metal, before she finally found strength enough to pick it up, and walk outside with that ticking time bomb at her side.)

She didn't really recall heading to the Moonstone afterwards. Some part of her just... blocked it out, being in that room, knowing what she knew about the Sword she'd been using all these years.

But when she came to, she saw the Moonstone, and all the gathered force of the Alliance, as Glimmer- and her entire family, Castaspella included- made sigils in the air, prepping to go. Castaspella and Angella focused on the light aspect, Micah and Glimmer on the dark; without Shadow Weaver here, they had to use their own dark magi to suffice.

All around were Catra's friends. Mean little Frosta, accompanied by that pale blue woman, who had a mace whose head vaguely resembled a snowflake. Near her was Sea Hawk, cleaning his sword, talking quietly with the Salinean ambassador- the one that shared his features- and Mermista, who shot Catra a brief smile when she entered that Catra just barely caught.

Beside them were the Rebels; Sweet Bee and Peekablue, who seemed to be deep in conversation, and then the rest of the Rebel forces here. Netossa gave Catra a nod when she entered, one she returned, before Netossa went back to talking with the red armored knight whose name Catra couldn't remember.

Here's hoping she's a woman of her word, Catra thought. *And doesn't attack my Adora...*

(For just a second, she thought she saw Spinnerella's eyes narrow as she saw Catra, and felt the wind whip with warning- just a moment- before the wind dancer turned and spoke to that big minotaur, the one with the cyborg parts... but Catra dismissed it as pure nerves a moment later. She was just being paranoid, and unduly so... right?)

Near them, Swift Wind, her most loyal companion; the first person she'd told the truth about Adora and Shadow Weaver too. It hadn't felt as… hard, as it was later. Maybe because the bond they shared meant she knew to trust him.

And now, that bond meant he could feel her nerves. He nuzzled her gently.

“ Hey,” he said.

“ Hey,” She answered. “ You ready?”

“ Fuck no,” Swift Wind replied, the first time hse'd ever heard him swear; it surprised a laugh out of her. “ Ain't funny!”

“ Kinda is,” she said, chuckling a moment before trailing off. “ ...Swift Wind?”

“ Yeah?” he responded.

“ Thank you,” she said. “ For... for always being there.”

Swift Wind gave her a smile.

“ You're most welcome,” he said, preening. “ I *am* pretty damn awesome.”

Catra snorted, and gave him a few scratches, which he eagerly accepted.

Then she turned back to the room, watching as her family did their thing. Angella was done spellcasting for the moment, and was giving orders to some of the guards; Glimmer leaned in to assist, speaking to correct this or that thing, or to ask her mother for assistance with some particularly complicated spellwork.

Glimmer and Angella, moving in concert; a thing that still felt wondrous, even as it had become more common. Her sister and her mother, united, acting as one as they talked and made modification to their plans- the two of them healing the breach at last, something that made Catra's heart grow warm.

And next to them, something that made her heart… confused… because it was Micah, who was working, too. His contributions were not as smooth, but they were workable, and she could see where the rough edges would be smoothed off soon enough. The whole family moving in concert…

…*Not the whole family,* Catra reminded herself. *I'm… I'm one of them too.*

I should go over there, and join them.

It was harder than she'd thought it would be. Old doubts rose up; she fought them with memories of her mother and sister, of kindnesses given to one whom none were *ever* kind to. She had a family. She *belonged*... even if some part of her still feared they only wanted the *She-Ra,* and not *Catra.*

But... maybe not.

After a moment, and with more courage than she cared to think about, Catra went to join her mother, her sister, and the man who might be her father, perhaps.

(She did not notice the room turning to her, everyone seeing what she was doing, too lost in her own mind to think of it... but Micah, sharp-eyed and watchful from the Island, saw it all, and pondered it.)

As Catra got to the Moonstone, to the center of the spell, it was Micah who greeted her first.

" My new daughter," Micah said, and gave her his cracked grin. " Glimmer talked you up as something *incredible*, and I can see it! What a blessing for a father, to have two such wonderful daughters."

" ...Really? You just met me, dude," Catra said, falling back on snarking in her nervousness, mixed a bit with sheer disbelief that *this* would be the content of their first real talk; but Micah just laughed, his laughter just on this side of hysterical.

Normally laughter would have set Catra off; she did not bear getting laughed at, not in the Horde and not here.

But *because* his laughter was just a little strange, she checked her initial reaction. The man had been on *Beast Island,* after all, a place of horror for even the Horde's adults, and a useful bogeyman for the children; a fear Catra had been threatened with many a time. And Micah had lasted on it longer than any… which probably explained the laughter. Beast Island, if it was half as bad as the Horde had said, would have left scars on the man that would never entirely heal.

So she listened to his laughter with a more sympathetic ear than she might have, otherwise; and underneath the tiny edge of hysteria that might accompany all his laughter now, there was… warmth. Something not mocking, but friendly, a laugh that was meant to be shared, not aimed like a weapon.

...She still didn't like it much- felt too much like being laughed *at*- but he meant no harm by it, and her time in Brightmoon had given her the wisdom to *choose* who got the roughness and who got the gentleness of her spiky personality.

So she did not chastise him, but let him laugh.

" I don't need to have met you long to know you're great!" Micah said, when he stopped laughing. " Not only because I trust Glimmer, who speaks so well of you; not just because Entrapta and Scorpia both confirmed it, and I trust *them*- well, I trust Entrapta a bit less now, but that's a moot point. I know it because of... well, them!"

He spread his arm to indicate everyone around them, all the Princesses of the Alliance, all the Rebels.

" All these people," he said. " Have you seen it? They turn to you like they do my Angie. They turn to you without even knowing they're doing it… I used to watch people, see how they reacted to my wonderful wife, and the ones that loved her most… they turned to her, like flowers chasing the sun, even without meaning to."

He turned back to Catra, and his smile- burned at the edges as it was- was blinding, and in the bright sunlight of Micah's regard, Catra found that she looked *better* in her own eyes, Micah's pride in her somehow sparking that same pride in her, his admiration making her admiration of her own person grow.

Maybe a father wouldn't be so bad, Catra thought, as she unconsciously returned that proud smile.

" You're like my Angie; a star others can orient by," Micah said, and put a hand on her shoulder, squeezing it fondly. " I can't wait to get to know you better, so I can learn to see it, too."

" …I'd like to know you better, too," Catra said, and to her own surprise, she meant it.

(Bizarre thought. Catra has had the worst of mothers and the best of mothers, but she has never had anything but a vague and distant father figure, Hordak himself; but this feels good, this feels

right, this feels…safe. Safe like she did when Angella tucked her in, safe in a way that she craved desperately, even now…)

Before any more could be said, Angella spoke up.

" We are ready!" she announced as Glimmer made ready for the last spellcasting. " Remember our goals! Stop Scorpia from getting to the Black Garnet! That is priority *one!* Priority two is to take out any Horde leadership we can! Priority *three* is capturing Lord Adora! Expect heavy resistance; reports from General Mally in Crystal Falls confirm what Plumerian intelligence suggests, which is that much of the Horde has been withdrawn to the Fright Zone! Prepare for the fight of your lives- but remember! All of our lives are forfeit if Scorpia reaches the Garnet! That is priority *one!* Is anyone unclear on our plan, such as it is?"

Not much of a plan... but how could it be? We had to come up with this in, what, thirty minutes?

" I'm ready!~" Sea Hawk sang. Mermista's face met her palm, and her groan was enough to know that she was ready to roll, too.

" Let's get to it," Frosta said, not as peppy as she usually was, but more... confident, somehow, more mature, as though she was stronger than she had been, and had less need of theatrics. She formed two fists of ice and clanged them together. " They can't stop *me.* "

“ I'm ready to assist as well,” that priest woman said.

“ Rebel forces ready to roll,” Netossa said, receiving nods from her gathered troops.

“ I'm ready,” Catra said.

“ Then let's go,” Glimmer said. “ Here – we – go!”

And then there was light, and darkness, and the not-place of teleportation, familiar after so many years as Glimmer's friend; and they traveled, so far, so far, the world melting away as they dashed south and west, ever south, ever west, to the Fright Zone, Catra suffering deja vu as they once more began another Raid through a teleport.

But this time- something went wrong, something happened...

In the not-place of teleportation- when their particles were still made of glow and traveling at the impossible speed of light- even there, in those milliseconds, Catra could feel something was *off.* They hit... something, like a heat shimmer in the air but physical, a distortion of fire. It didn't hurt them, the light they used was too close of kin to fire to be hurt by it... but it *was* able to refract them, and they scattered in chunks across the various corners of the Fright Zone, a thing they all felt, even if only Glimmer- old hat at teleportation- actually understood it.

(Unbeknownst to everyone, the mere presence of the artificial Runestone, so close to a natural Runestone, had wrecked all havoc on the local leylines, a shield Adora had constructed without ever knowing about it.)

Catra hoped against all hope to land with her mother and her sister, and as she rematerialized, she looked around herself. This was... an old warehouse, if she wasn't wrong... but it was on fire? And half rubble! Had Entrapta gotten here first?

...But no, a moment of looking didn't show any of the signs of outside attackers. The only bodies she saw were... Hordesmen? Dead troopers, most of them with Adora's new symbol, but a few with that symbol scratched out?

...What is going on here? Catra thought, before a nearby voice interrupted her thoughts.

" Let's get in the air, see if we can find the others."

She turned to the voice with a smile- that was her mom! She'd gotten one of her wishes, at least. Angella, flying very gently over some rubble, packing Micah and Flutterina with her, one holding on to each hand.

" I forgot how strong my wife is!" Micah said with a laugh. " And how fun flying is! Wee!"

“ You weigh more than you did- you've put on muscle, dear!” Angella replied.

“ Hey, that's-my-knight!” Flutterina said, pointing down at Catra. “ Catra! Up here!”

“ I see you!” Catra answered. In the distance, she heard fighting. Maybe a Rebel squad had gotten in when no one was paying attention? But she thought the Rebels were mostly pushed away from the Zone, were concentrated near the front in Plumeria...

“ Something's going on,” Angella said as she landed near Catra. Micah immediately put up a small shield, just in case they were jumped while talking- the same survival instincts that had kept him going on the Island were going to serve him well in war, it seemed.

“ Horde-troopers-are-all-fighting-each-other!” Flutterina said breathlessly before pausing. “ It looks like civil war!”

Civil war, in the *Horde?* Such an idea seemed almost... blasphemous, to that increasingly small part of Catra that was a Hordesman at heart. It nearly made her sick to her stomach to consider it.

“ Civil war?” Catra repeated in surprise.

“ Yes,” Angella said. “ At least, that's my best guess. Lucky for us; we can use the chaos to make it easier to reach the Garnet. Though I'm also sensing... other energies? Something's off about the local magic. Maybe that's why we scattered?”

“ Hopefully, Peekablue can locate help, and then use his Perfect Blue to coordinate and find the others,” Micah said, as the analytical part of him took over for a moment. “ I imagine we scattered in clumps rather than totally at random... here's hoping he ended up near friendlies. I don't think he'd survive long on his own, he never struck me as a fighter and I don't think that changed in the last few years.”

(At that very moment, Peekablue- who had landed near Sweet Bee and Chilla- was indeed using the Perfect Blue for that exact purpose, hunting Frosta first for Chilla, while the two ladies quickly sorted out the squad of Hordesmen who stumbled onto them, a group that, not knowing who they were, *did* know they were intruders, and attacked... and promptly got annihilated.)

“ Let's... let's get going, then,” Catra said... before putting her hand to the hilt of the Sword.

(*I'm so scared*)

But...

Her *family* needed her.

(And just like the night of the hacking, that was enough for Catra to push past her fear and say the words.)

" For the honor of Grayskull!"

(The cloak and the crown do not feel like a righteousness. Not anymore.)

" Oh, that's so cool!" Micah squealed with almost childlike glee. " Incredible! I had a teacher obsessed with that sword once... but that... story doesn't have a happy ending."

Catra did not feel cool, though. She felt… sick, almost like she had the first time she transformed, save that this was coming from *inside* her, not outside, this was a sickness of fear and horror.

...But her family still needed her, and that thought steadied her stomach and her veins.

" Ok," she said, turning to Angella, and looking down at her from her new height. " What's our first move, Mom?"

" I confess I have not led in the field in years," Angella said. " And I don't think Micah has either, unless the Island went much more oddly than I suspect."

" I have not led anyone!" Micah brightly confirmed. " I have mostly been followed, by predators!"

" So we must defer to your greater current expertise, Catra," Angella said, smoothly ignoring her husband's last comment.

No pressure, Catra snarked in her own head… but then, she'd always done her best work under pressure, hadn't she? She wouldn't have survived Shadow Weaver if that wasn't true.

So she thought a moment before responding.

" First… we can't find the others, so we should just follow the general plan. We find the Garnet first," Catra said. " I even know where it is, so... we go there. Hopefully someone contacts us soon, but that's not important. We need to secure the Garnet and make sure we can hold it against all comers. And maybe figure out why the Fright Zone is in upheaval while we're at it."

" A fine plan!" Micah announced. " Let's get to it!"

" Yay!" Flutterina cheered, and Catra could not help a small smile on her face as they turned and entered the chaos of the Fright Zone.

(But inside, her soul trembled with fear.)

Chapter End Notes

The Potion of a Thousand Herbs comes from the He-Man series, where an herbalist named Signie makes it. It's a snake antivenom in the original.

Here, it's less a specific formula and more a sort of catch-all term for any Plumerian elixir whose owner doesn't want to identify what's in it, exactly. Plumerian alchemists are a powerful guild and hate to reveal their secrets to outsiders, so the term gets a lot of mileage. Here, Signie was the first alchemist to use the claim, herself being a great alchemist and herbalist focused on antidotes and antivenoms.

Glimmer is referencing the Heimlich maneuver, which I don't have a good Etherian name for.

Peekablue's Perfect Blue lets him see anyone he's met in person, or more accurately, seen, so he can use it on Entrapta and the like.

Next chapter: The Horde Civil War.

Chapter 58: A Civil War in the Horde

Chapter Notes

We approach the end.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A Civil War of the Horde

Lonnie slept trapped in nightmares.

She had been there... too long. She'd missed most of her work that day. It hadn't *started* that way; she'd started out feeling pretty good, actually. She'd woken up... not smiling, but capable, at least, so relieved that Grizzlor was now involved that she'd been able to rest after so long without.

And good timing too; for it was this morning when the Horde was going to move out. Today was the day that the Horde launched its assault on Plumeria. The force was finally committed; the single biggest assault by the Horde since the Battle of Brightmoon, four years and some change ago now. The vast bulk of the Horde had been in that attack, riding in attack traks or carried on troop skiffs, heading out under the rising sun under the command of Rogelio. There'd been no question of who would command; Kyle was a disciplinary officer par excellence, but he made for a poor strategist. The older Mantenna- who had always preferred research to command- had also cheerfully given up the top job to someone who would actually care to do it, because he was busy

experimenting with the Bull's Eye, and that was consuming all of his attention.

(Lonnie had kept up her spymaster job, even with everything else- she was a Hordesman, after all, and so obeyed orders even as she planned to subvert her Lord- and was well aware that Mantenna had already violated Adora's orders to start with animals; he had leapt to experimenting on *himself.* But he had not used it on anyone else, so Lonnie had said nothing... not yet.)

The only thing it was missing were Hordebots; Adora had ordered them to stay home and guard the Fright Zone. The bots were too indiscriminate and too messy, and Adora wanted this to be as clean and surgical as a major military operation like this *could* be. So it was Hordesmen in this army, not machines.

But other than that one exception?

All the might of the Horde was gathered in this place.

It had been... quite a sight to see. It had, for a moment, made Lonnie feel... okay again. Like herself, before the Spirit Ember, before the nightmares had started. Seeing them like that, ready to go before the walls of the Fright Zone, had been like the good old days, under Hordak.

(Lonnie is too young to have an old woman's nostalgia... and yet she cannot help how she feels, how inside she feels so *old,* and so *tired.*)

She had looked down from the platform she'd shared with Adora, not looking at her Lord (or the blazing eye through which the Spirit Ember watched the world); no, she had looked at the gathered army, and found it good. The Horde, gathered together in its most perfect form, that of the conquering army; yes, that wasn't so bad. Seeing the way the light had glinted off the machines, the way the engines had roared, the shouts as Adora cheered them from above in her magically amplified voice....

It had been good. For a few long moments, it had been almost like it was, and she'd turned to smile at Adora, who had given her a bright grin back.

But then Adora, with a mischievious grin, had leapt off the platform and *changed,* shifted into her new dragon form, flying above them to breathe a gout of fire, before finishing her speech.

" ***Go! I am the Dragon; and I am your Lord! Conquer, for the Horde!*** "

Even as Lonnie's heart had seized in her chest, the crowd below had went *mad,* that was the only way to describe it; they had *cheered* with a feverish frenzy that reminded Lonnie of the things she'd seen the night she first saw Adora's new form, that awful night full of the Horde celebrating in fiery revels, backlit by that young Lunoth woman and her preaching.

And as the crowd gave offering to their new god, praising the Dragon who would burn all Etheria clean for the Horde, Lonnie recalled her thought that night.

(*how many people does it take to make a Runestone Kingdom? Just a First One.*)

Lonnie had fled, to puke her guts out in a corner of the Zone.

(She's not sure how she made it back to her room. She's not sure of a lot of things, these days.)

So she had missed watching as the last two members of her cadet class- of her family- had left, to impact with Plumeria's frontlines in due course of time- perhaps three days, if they travelled fast, a week if they went slow. Moving an army was so much slower than moving a smaller force... but there were fewer Rebels on their route, most of them having pulled back towards the east to protect both their would-be capital at Glass Lake and the more northern Brightmoon port of Crystal Falls. That siege was ongoing, though at a lower tempo than it had been; forces had been pulled back for this attack. Already that siege was suffering for it, with Rebel groups raiding its supplies or attacking it from behind, hoping to break the siege... but it wouldn't matter if they won, or so Adora (*or the Spirit Ember*) said.

All this she thought, on that late spring night, summer just around the corner... as she tried to sleep, and had nightmare after nightmare of fire, and dragons, and Adora losing her soul to the thing she called her sister in sin.

(And as she slept, a changeling wearing her skin approached Grizzlor, with war in their shifted hands.)

****

Grizzlor looked over his list as he sat in his private office in the Fright Zone, one decorated mostly with pictures of his mother and brother- before the machine- and war trophies of various kinds. The list was.... longer than he'd feared, but shorter than he'd hoped. A *lot* of the rank and file were fine with Lord Adora, but the older troopers, the vets... a lot of them were also *not* fond of serving a goddamn Princess. Even some of the kids were against it on sheer principle, though the Horde members Lonnie had scouted out were definitely skewing older.

Not enough to overthrow Adora alone, but... well, she *had* just drained the Fright Zone of troops... and maybe if they attacked the Spirit Ember itself, instead of the Princess... yeah, that might be workable. The Spirit Ember didn't have the *best* defenses on it; apparently Lord Adora arrogantly assumed no one would even get there to attack it.

If they could break it... yeah, that could work.

Hell, he might even save Adora, if Lonnie's suppositions were true.

He privately didn't think they were- it was more likely that Lonnie had come up with her theory out of desperation to save her fellow cadet class member- but he'd told the girl he'd try to save Adora, and Grizzlor was better than his word, always had been.

And hell, while he figured she was wrong, that Runestones did not take their Princesses, that the goddamn stones did not make their

chosen figurehead a first victim... who knew? He was no scholar, no expert, no genius. Lonnie might well be right. Maybe the fucking rocks ate the souls of their supposed wielders, and destroying the Ember would make Adora herself again.

And if she wasn't... well, weakening Adora made killing her easier, so every indication was that this was the right path to take.

A shame that the guards Adora *did* have on the Spirit Ember were *extremely* loyal; she didn't even have any bots watching it, just good Horde troopers. Good Hordesman, who would die doing their duty, believing they were serving Hordak's chosen heir...

...Bad folk to fight. There were good soldiers who were going to die when this assault happened, there was no way around it. Sure, some of Adora's supporters- Octavia and Dreer highest among them- deserved everything they got, but... that wasn't the majority of them, not at all.

But this wasn't Grizzlor's first civil war, and so he steeled himself for the act of national kinslaying as he got up, and stretched, sighing. He would attack... soon. He'd already been in contact with everyone on the list, and he'd set up a little communications network with some know-how from the old days- a few trackerpads here and there to those he'd take as sergeants and leaders. Normally he'd hope for more time to plan this out, but given that this would be the only time that most of the Horde would be out of the Fright Zone, he basically only had this week...

A knock on his door.

Grizzlor grabbed his shock baton before checking the peephole, seeing an anxious face that surprised him.

" Lonnie?" he said as he opened the door.

" We have to attack now," she said, all in a burst, not even bothering to come in. " She ordered me to kill you!"

" ...What?" he said.

" She fears you're a traitor," she said, mouth running a mile a minute. He'd seen in their last meeting how broken this poor kid was, and that was all he was seeing now- tears in her eyes, tears he instinctively looked away from. He did not judge the kid for her weakness; after what had happened to her, after the responsibilities that had been thrown on her, it was inevitable that she'd break down. She'd done as good as she could, and to Grizzlor, that was proof of strength enough; the Horde asked that you do your duty, and Lonnie had done it until it broke her. The kid was allowed a few tears.

" She's asked you to kill me?" he said, and she nodded rapidly.

" Yes! She's- oh, Grizzlor, she wants you dead, she wants to link up with the Black Garnet and take *two* Runestones- that's why she sent everyone away! The whole thing was to get people *out*

so she could become the first Princess of *two* Runestones- or the Ember is what wants it and I- Grizzlor, we have to do it *now!* ”

...Fuck. Adrenaline ran through him and he used it, the way all veterans learned to do so; he used it to slow his thoughts down, to think, to think, to *think.*

(And he did not question what he was being told, because it was what he wanted to believe- that Princess could not be trusted, that any gifted with the magic of a Runestone was a monster- because even the smartest of people can be fooled by their own biases.)

“ ...I can get people rolling but we won't be able to plan much,” he said, after pondering. “ It'll be chaos, mostly. I have a plan for them to scratch her symbol out and leave Hordak's batwings, that'll be the closest thing to identifiers we have, but we won't have much coordination...”

“ I... I took the bots,” Lonnie said, gulping and trying not to sob. “ I figured out how to steal them- the bots will help us- it's all I can do...”

“ ...You've got the Hordebots?” Grizzlor said, feeling his heart soar. *Shit, that might- yeah, that might put us over the top!* “ You're serious?”

Lonnie, choked, could only nod, and hand him a device.

“ Makes them- control them,” she said, before breaking down into sobbing.

(Well, it sounded kind of like laughter- but hysterics did that to people sometimes, and Grizzlor brushed it off as unimportant.)

“ Kid, go hide,” he said. “ You're in no condition to fight.”

“ I can-!” the kid began to protest, but he shook his head firmly.

“ You've carried this as far as you can,” Grizzlor said. “ Let us old fucks carry it now. We'll save your friend if anyone can.”

“ I... thank you,” she whispered, before turning around and *fleeing,* running to who knew where.

...Good. Grizzlor was glad she hadn't said. That way, if they lost- if Adora caught him, and tried to torture Lonnie's location out of him- he wouldn't be able to give it up. You couldn't tell a secret you didn't know.

“ Time to get going,” he muttered to himself as he looked at the trackerpad in his hands, one that was running some program he didn't recognize- Light Hope or something? Whatever it was, it was showing him the bots nearby...

Well.

Time to start making some calls.

(And the Lonnie that fled from him blinked double eyelids as they prepared to make a call of their own.)

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter: Adora.

Chapter 59: The Lord of the Horde

Chapter Notes

A REALLY short one- think of it as a teaser chapter for what it is to come next!

Come this Sunday, you will receive a BIG chapter- so get ready!

The Lord of the Horde

What a day, Adora thought as she prepared to go to bed.

It was early for that, but Adora felt she'd earned it. She'd been up most of the night before, finishing the final touches for the Plumerian invasion that had commenced today. The troops had left at first light, so that they could gain as much ground as possible before the Alliance noticed the attack. There was no way to really *hide* a force that large, at least, not from anyone familiar with the terrain, but it'd still take time for the information to get back to the Alliance, and hopefully by the time a counterattack was being prepared, they'd already have Perfuma well in hand.

That was the key, the secret, the thing that *had* to happen. It was why Rogelio and Kyle had been sent- they had the full of her trust. Unlike the others, she *knew* they wouldn't go off-script and kill Perfuma, who had to be alive for the plan to work. Sure, the others were more experienced generals... but then again, the opposition were Plumerians. Sure, Perfuma was nothing to sneeze at, but she'd be without any support.

It should be enough... which didn't prevent her from worrying, still. Maybe she should have went with them... but no, she had to be here, to fight the ambush the Princesses were planning. Maybe Octavia should have been sent too? But no, her expertise was in naval combat...

(She wished she had Vultak with her, he was a legend as a general- the man had slain the last Plumerian Princess before Perfuma- but Vultak was in the south at Halfmoon, and had failed to respond to any requests or orders. A splinter state of the Horde, or maybe even dead; Adora had been focused north, had not felt comfortable attacking a land of people who looked like... *her* .)

Best not to think of it. Best to focus *here.* The Fright Zone was not impregnable; it had been attacked twice before, and both times, the Horde had *lost,* even if it had also forced the enemy to leave. The first time, Catra had taken Glimmer from them; the second time, she had...

(saved the world from me, Adora thought, and her left side burned, and she rubbed unconsciously at the scars that had never gone away, the only remnant in the real world of something less real...)

No, best not to think of that. Best to... focus on other things.

She rubbed ointment on the scars before going to bed; her scars didn't ache as badly at night, something in darkness soothing the wounds, but right now they were bitching at her, and that'd make sleep hard.

So yes, the Fright Zone could be breached. Adora would put a stop to that, though- along with her sister in sin, which sent a gleeful thought through her. A little dangerous, that thought- a bit too much like she'd been once, with the laughter, the thing that had made her hit the switch and led to the Portal, and all that had happened because of it- but it was okay. She had a chain for the hellhound, now; her duty to the Horde.

(*Which demands war, and death,* a dark and quiet part of her said, and she ignored it. She'd gotten good at doing that, over the years.)

Besides, the thought made her think of her sister, and send a questioning pulse down her connection to the Spirit Ember, which merrily blazed in response. A fire of comfort, and comfort from the fire; she basked, just a moment, in her sister's light, in the *power* she now held.

Oh yes, the Princesses would get a surprise, when they met this time.

(*And now I'm finally Catra's equal,* she thought merrily, almost giddily, that whipsaw laughter in the background; even chained up, she could hear the hellhound in her head. *I can finally stand against her, Princess to Princess, at last.*)

Twice the Fright Zone had been raided... but now a Princess guarded it, as well as the Minor Runestones. This time?

This time would be different.

(Later, she would think on this thought, and laugh until she vomited, for reasons she could never know at this point.)

...This time *had* to be different. She would not fail her Horde. Not anymore. Not like she had when she'd pulled that switch. Not like she had when

(Hordak, Lord and father, who had saved the girl who would kill him when she was a child)

No, not like that. Never again.

Her sister's warmth comforted her, and she leaned on it again, the only being who could understand her; the other sin, the other mistake, of the First Ones. The angelic and holy forebears who had produced sickening Adora, who had in turn made the wretched Spirit Ember, the only two mistakes of that flawless people.

Adora was no longer alone, the way she had been for years now.

(Ever since the day Catra left.)

Thank you, sister, Adora sent down their connection, and felt blazing joy in return. Or at least, she thought she did. She wasn't sure... it wasn't like she had a frame of reference for it. She'd never gotten a chance to ask any other Princess how their relationship with their own Runestones worked, nor could she have expected answer if she had.

Maybe she'd have a chance to do so after Perfuma was captured. Sit down and chat with her; part of the plan was to, if not befriend the Princess- few people ever became friendly with their captors, or at least, Adora would assume so- but to at least convince the Plumerian Princess that she could cut a deal with Adora, that the new Lord of the Horde was someone whom you *could* negotiate with. It wasn't like they didn't kind of know each other, after all! Years of trying to kill each other and fighting gave one a kind of familiarity... maybe it'd be connection enough.

Hopefully it'd work. Peace was... not a natural state for the Horde, but Adora was going to try. After all, how else was she going to buy time to build up for round two?

(*And isn't that telling, that you want peace only to make more successful war?* But the dark and quiet was ignored once more.)

Shame she had no diplomats among her ranks, someone she could delegate the task to. That'd probably have changed things if she had... but Adora could lie, at least. Maybe that would be enough. Fake it until she made it, that kind of thing.

With such thoughts in her head, Adora laid down early that night, on a bed bare of any covers. Her sister's power kept Adora quite comfortably warm, and all she really needed was a single pillow for her head. She yawned as she laid down, tired, aware she'd probably be up before anyone else; her sister's energy also meant she didn't need much sleep, anymore.

Because it's light, maybe? Adora pondered idly. If darkness was sleep, light was wakefulness... hmm. Something to think on... maybe she should write it down?

After all, it was tied to yet another one of her endless projects. She wanted to extend her sister's gifts to the entire Horde, not just as she already had- hooking up machines and foundries to it for power- but in teaching her magic. Her sister's original instability, if Adora did not miss her guess, was because it was solely focused on one person, whose nature thus dominated; but that wasn't... very Horde-like, honestly.

But if her sister's magic could be extended to others... maybe that would bleed off some of her might, drain her, make her something that did not ruin a kingdom when one person's control slipped.

And that was the most Horde thing imaginable, the spreading of power to others- at least, the most Horde thing the propaganda would have you believe. Adora did not believe in those comforting lies anymore, knew the Horde and herself as the evil thing they were, but it would be nice to make them a *little* real.

(*If it is evil, why do you obey?* Her mind asks, but she knows that answer already- because it is in her nature to obey. It always has been. She could not disobey at Thaymor and she cannot disobey, even now.)

Still mulling it over, Adora went to sleep.

(She awoke to civil war.)

Chapter 60: THE LAST BATTLE OF THE WAR: The Horde Civil War

Chapter Notes

My apologies for my lateness. Work and life hit me hard, and I underestimated how much work I'd have to do on these chapters; but it is as it is, and I make no excuse, only apology.

We are nearing the end.

This was once one big chapter but I'm releasing it in bite-sized chunks. Savor it. Love it.

We are moving on soon... to She-Ra of the Stars, the final fic in this series.

T-minus... four or five chapters.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Last Battle of the War

Part I

The Horde Civil War

Grizzlor looked over his forces.

They were gathered in a back area of the Fright Zone, an old foundry that had stopped being used years ago. It was one of the first things the Horde built here, placed somewhere convenient at the time, but as the city expanded and needs changed, the foundry saw less and less use until Hordak had shut it down. It'd been forgotten over the years, not even stripped for scrap parts... but Grizzlor had remembered it, and was using its empty factory floor to gather his forces.

Those forces were before him, and it was a lot more people than he'd expected. Almost all veterans, not many of the youngsters here; not a surprise. The fire of Adora's ascension had caught mostly in the young.

This was a small group... but one that was elite, and hardened. A few had even been around as long as he had, or longer.

(Briefly, he wished he still had Quick Pick and Mandora, the earliest recruits into the Horde he had ever known... but they'd went into the south with Vultak, and he hadn't seen either of them in years.)

Six people in total were his officers, the leaders of this erstwhile rebellion. The first and most prominent were the trio of Desert Elves called the Fighting Foe Men, who had been renegades of the Fright Zone, former soldiers turned pirates with stolen First Ones tech vehicles. O'Tor- who everyone called Dawg for reasons Grizzlor had never managed to figure out- Destroyer, and Sherrilyn, the last of whom was perpetually annoyed at the “Men” part of their name, which had been chosen by Fright Zone nobles specifically to snub her; she was the clear leader of the group and had been the highest ranking of them, so calling them the “Men”

had been the Fright Zone nobility's way of cutting her out of her own story.

Not uncommon, back then; actually quite polite, compared to some of the things they said and did to others. Perhaps she hadn't cost the nobles enough money to truly earn infamy.

(Grizzlor wasn't from the Fright Zone, but he'd served with enough veterans of Hordak's first campaign that he'd gotten the gist of it; it wasn't as bad as Vargon had been, but you could see that future from where the Zone sat, towards the end.)

The three had continued to work together after signing up with Hordak, which was one reason none of them were actually Force Captains; they had resolutely refused to be promoted for fear of breaking their fellowship. They'd still been as prominent as any Force Captain had ever been, leading others, and their loyalty to each other had worked out- not only had they brought a substantial number of soldiers with them, not being Force Captains meant that hopefully they would fly under Adora's radar.

Of course, they'd *also* stolen a variety of vehicles before coming here, which would be... less likely to go unnoticed.

Still, it shouldn't matter much. The attack was starting almost as soon as Grizzlor could hand out orders- one advantage of working with such experienced soldiers, he didn't have to waste much time explaining what he wanted, or worry they would misunderstand- and the extra punch...

Well, even with the bots on their side, and so many of the youngest soldiers on that venture up north, Grizzlor wouldn't lie and claim he wasn't happy to have the additional firepower. Hell, when they'd first arrived, he'd almost cracked a joke about how hard it was to get Sherrilyn out from behind a wheel...

But then she'd pulled something jumping out of her machine, grimacing and stumbling a moment, and he'd decided to say nothing to the purple-skinned woman. He'd understood immediately- the vehicles were because her and her crew were old, and needed them to fight at the level they were accustomed to. Despite everything, her body was failing her as age accumulated.

She was getting old, as were all of them; gray in all their hair, wrinkles around all their eyes.

Nothing sadder than an old rebel, Grizzlor thought. *Myself included. I'm too old for this...*

But if it's what the cause needs... well, I started out rebelling against a false lord. Same idea. If it needs to be done...

After the Fighting Foe Men was another old one- the oldest, in fact- Old Zin, whose continued survival was a genuine surprise to Grizzlor; he'd never been much impressed by the man, but he was still here, long after so many who *had* impressed Grizzlor were gone. He was one of the few from Silverglade who'd actually volunteered, a noble's firstborn son who'd had no talent for magic and been disinherited for it. Zin had been a grifter and a deal-

maker when he first joined the Horde, and it appeared he hadn't ever stopped; guy had an impressive force with him, more than anyone else brought. If he wanted, he could wrestle the whole rebellion away from Grizzlor... but there'd been no sign of him doing that, just waiting for orders with his old grey eyes.

He was waiting with a cigarette he'd gotten from… who knew where. Zin had once ran the Horde's small black market, mostly for food; that business had been killed by the traitorous Lord Adora's new policies, where food was freely given to any who could take it. Yet another reason Grizzlor despised her; it turned Horde troops into *thieves,* it lowered them, made it harder to enforce discipline. Who knew what health issues it was going to cause, too.

Speaking of health issues, some part of him wanted to tell Zin to drop the cigarette- those things were killer- but he held his tongue. Zin was old for a human, one of the longer-lived species of sentient life; cancer or not, he wasn't long for this world.

(Not for the first time, Grizzlor was glad that his own species were healthy until the last months of their life, at which point they rapidly degraded; just enough time to get things in order before passing on. Manes had a dignified way to die, one better than this... slow decay.)

The last two officers were the youngest by far, which meant they weren't *that* young; early forties or so. Landor and Azana, who had once been the children of great cartographers in Green Thatch, who had been literal infants when their parents joined the Horde. They had been targeted by some rich merchant family that wanted their business, their home burnt, the parents barely escaping alive; justice denied by the man who ran Green Thatch,

whose Perfect Blue was used mostly to see young women in their private moments without their consent. Not the Bloody Bull, no, but not a man who should wear a crown.

The parents had agreed, and joined as scouts; the children had taken up their parents' roles, taught by them, and teaching new recruits in turn.

Now they were here, some of the deadliest scouts in the Horde, some of the few who could regularly track even the best Rebels, who moved like ghosts in the Whispering Woods. Both carried silenced pistols and great amounts of explosives; one for subtlety, one for when a lack of it was required. Grenades and missile launchers, all scavenged First Ones tech taken in the fall of Vargon.

These were his forces.

...It wasn't much, but the Horde had been started with less. Add the robots- who were even now running around, gathering equipment, or just running guard duty- and...

Yes, he could make a go of it.

Victory wasn't certain, of course. Not against a Princess and whatever loyalists she'd have.

But Grizzlor had went to war on the Bloody Bull of Vargon for his brother's sake with no hope at all, until Hordak had arrived; and in his fellow veterans...

Grizzlor had hope.

(Some part of him wished Hordak could see them; that he could see that Grizzlor was trying to pay his debts, to do right by the man who had given him the only justice he would ever have for his brother. Grizzlor held faith in no gods... but he had faith in Hordak, even now.)

So he nodded to his officers.

" Alright," he said to them. " Lets figure out how to kill this fucking Traitor Lord."

They sat down to plan; it didn't take long. They were all good leaders, knew what he wanted and how to do it, and at the end of the day, this was not a complicated scheme, at least, not in its goals. Execution might be a bitch, but the goals were simplicity itself.

Just two little tasks lay before them.

Destroy the Spirit Ember.

Kill Lord Adora.

(*Lord.* As if she deserved the title. Only one person had *ever* deserved that title, and it wasn't the Princess who wore it now.)

He felt only a moment's guilt. He had told Lonnie he'd try to save Adora... but in the service of a greater good, all things were allowed. Adora, whether she was a slave to her Runestone or herself a monster, would be put down, one way or the other.

And so they set out. Zin and most of his forces were with Grizzlor, as were the Fighting Foe Men; this concentrated force would strike out for the Ember, which was guarded, but not heavily. The majority of the robots would go with them.

What was left of Zin's forces would go off to spread chaos and word of the rebellion around the Zone, hopefully making a smokescreen and buying time for the main force to do the work ahead. Anyone trying to figure out what was going on would focus on the ruckus this group would be busy raising, and hopefully ignore the *actual* attack at the Spirit Ember.

The siblings, meanwhile, had their own special operation, and in many ways, the most dangerous. With a small handful of bots and their trained scouting force, they were going on an assassination run.

Even Princesses could be vulnerable while they slept.

When the orders were given, they put hand above hand, as they had in the earliest Horde meetings, and with one last nod, broke apart to start the work.

(And with that, they began the first and last Civil War of the Etherian Horde.)

****

The Horde Civil War- one of the shortest in recorded history- was not a thing of clear lines or delineations. Grizzlor knew that he would kill a great many loyal, good Hordesmen in his rebellion, and thus, he tried to minimize the damage by speeding up the process. His forces went, and went fast, killing as they went, a wrecking ball of death sent barreling into the unsuspecting, soft underbelly of the Fright Zone. Hordesmen waved at comrades, or called out to them with questions about what they were doing, only to receive a response in violence and death.

This was betrayal at its most basic tenet, acts of treachery, and there was no sugarcoating it. Even Grizzlor's veterans had their stomachs turn at what they were doing; but they were true believers, and knew that only this would save the Horde from the one who had taken it. The Traitor Lord had to die, and her poisonous Runestone with her.

If that led them to be Traitors, betrayers, the worst thing the Horde could imagine...

Well.

Sometimes, the cause demanded you sacrifice *everything*... even your ideals.

(At least, this is the idea Grizzlor comforted himself with, when he saw the bodies, when doubt began to whisper in his mind.)

This is not to say that Adora's loyalists were completely helpless. Caught off guard, yes, but not *helpless*; and pockets of resistance sprang up where Grizzlor's troops were thin on the ground or screwed up the initial ambush. Among these pockets of resistance, the Fright Zone's sole bar, *Force Captain Reorientation*, proved a surprisingly tough nut to crack; assailed early on, it had been nearly full with those of Adora's loyalists who hadn't been able to go with the great warparty for one reason or another, most commonly injury. These handicapped soldiers had proven handy at the defense of the bar, wielding the flamethrowers and great tower shields so many had adopted in mimicry of their great Dragon, led by the two cooks and one of Adora's most faithful, a Lunoth whose fervor was more like that of a preacher than an officer.

And so the war raged on without outside interference... for a time.

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Adora, too, was without outside interference for a time. She slept, blissfully unaware that war had come upon her, that she was being targeted, that anything was happening at all. For a short

time after all hell broke loose, she was asleep, enjoying a well-deserved rest.

The bellowing of one of her closest friends from the communicator next to her bed interrupted that.

" ADORA!"

The Lord of the Horde was up and moving long before her brain had actually activated, pure muscle memory getting her up and ready to go; four years of warfare and a lifetime growing up under Horde discipline would do that to a person. Adrenaline poured into her system as she reacted to the shouted warning, a burst of flame around her as she summoned her armor from within her sister, a useful stunt she'd figured out from a dream in which she saw a different Fire Princess do something similar with- of all things- her glasses.

(Her name was bird-related... Robin? That part of the dream was less clear than watching the woman send her glasses into the Spirit Ember and call them back out in bursts of flame, which had been simply too useful not to learn.)

Encased in her armored shell, her waking mind thought it saw something in a nearby shadow, and she put her shield up against it.

(Her brain had given it two familiar eyes, and two reaching hands, hands that would be cold up against her temple, because even great Lords have their private nightmares.)

She blinked away her blurry daze, her brain taking the moment to finally catch up with the roaring engine of her body. When the next yell came over the communicator, she was just barely awake enough to process it.

“ADORA! Oh fuck please, answer me!”

Adora blinked again, gazing at the communicator through the slits in her dragon's helm, before she realized she should answer. Flame melted back the gloves of her armor and her helmet, the metal folding back and ready to reform in a moment, so she could answer.

“ Lonnie?” Adora asked as she gazed down at her communicator, seeing her friend and unofficial spymaster. She looked like she was running down a hallway?...

“ Oh thank Hordak, you're alive!” Lonnie yelled breathlessly in response. Adora just barely contained her flinch at hearing the name of her former lord. “ Force Captain Grizzlor's went rogue! He's got an army, he's going after the Spirit Ember- he wants to destroy it!”

“ What?” Adora replied, not because she didn't understand those words, but because it almost seemed too... unbelievable. No, Grizzlor had *not* been happy about the Minor Runestones, but he'd been a solid Hordesman since the earliest days; he wouldn't turn traitor, right? He was a model of a Hordesman...

“ He says he wants to kill the Princess who stole the Horde!” Lonnie said. “ He's claiming *you* killed Hordak to steal the Horde for the Spirit Ember! He's calling you the Traitor Lord!”

Adora's throat went dry. For a moment- a long, long moment- she felt like she was falling. She felt like she was collapsing. She felt like she was dying.

Because all of that?

Was *true.*

Oh, Grizzlor had the *details* wrong. She hadn't done it for the Spirit Ember.

No, this was evil she'd come up with *long* before she'd even known of her sister in sin's existence. Adora, the sole evil First One, the sole monster of that angelic people, had been planning to replace Hordak for far longer than *that*. She'd been planning to backstab her Lord, and betray the Horde's most fundamental virtue- her duty- ever since the Battle of Brightmoon, in that moment when she first truly committed to her role as Catra's great opposite, the villain to her beloved's hero.

And to do it, she had nearly murdered the entire world- had *wanted* to, with that laughter whipsawing through her, just to make sure Catra *lost,* to make the world *pay* for making her a *First One* after every goddamn horrible thing she'd done. She had

nearly murdered the entire Horde, which was saved only because Hordak, the man who had rescued her from an empty field, her Lord

(her *father,* what else can she call the man who took her in as a baby?)

gave his life to save his people. She had stolen control of the Horde as a *consolation prize* for not being able to have the world of her fantasies and dreams, the world the Portal had made.

Compared to all that, lying about being a Princess seemed... kind of small, honestly. Princess she was, but *traitor* was a better word for it...

...She'd been right. Grizzlor *was* the model of a Hordesman.

No wonder he wants to kill me.

(In the midst of her horror, she never noticed the split-second of Lonnie's face not quite being right, as Double Trouble honed in on that hurt, their words having been calculated to test a theory out, a theory now proven right.)

Adora swallowed against her dry throat.

" What- what is he going to do?" she asked, even though Lonnie had already answered that question.

“ An army! He's stolen the bots, I don't know how- comms are down- I'm not sure how I got through to you! He's sent a squad to kill you, and a huge army at the Spirit Ember-”

Suddenly there was static, and a high, whining beep; and she could see Lonnie no more.

“ Fuck,” Adora whispered, like a prayer.

(And in the back of her mind, the hellhound strained, pushed, the leash beginning to break; and the sound of its growling was like whipsaw laughter.)

****

Double Trouble grinned to themselves as the image on the communicator switched to their new employer.

“ Good work, Double Trouble,” Light Hope said to the changeling. “ With this, chaos in the Fright Zone is assured.”

“ Well, you *are* paying me handsomely,” Double Trouble said, grinning. “ And freed me from prison. One good turn deserving another, or something like that.”

The strange being did not react to their words, which was... unsettling at best. Something odd about their new employer.

" Your tasks are complete; return to the skiff I prepared for you," she ordered. " It will deliver you to where the rest of your payment awaits- as well as getting you out of the Fright Zone, which will shortly be rather dangerous."

" I'll get there shortly," Double Trouble purred. " Is it still at the coordinates you gave me?"

" Yes," she replied.

" See you soon, darling!" Double Trouble said. The flickering being nodded before the communicator shut off; for good measure, Double Trouble chucked it into a corner of the hallway, hard enough to bust it.

Like *hell* Double Trouble was getting on that skiff. One of the many, many talents the changeling had picked up over the years was a sense for when to bail, and that sense was blaring an alarm right now. Double Trouble was a born Crimson Waster- albeit one who hadn't been in the Waste in *years,* and never would return if they had their way- and every raider of that land knew that the best way to avoid getting killed was to avoid getting blinded by a big score.

Sure, Light Hope *promised* a ton of money.

But there was something... off... about them, and it wasn't just that they were kind of see-through. A Wild Princess, Double Trouble assumed; or maybe just a really powerful mage. Who knew? The world was full of wonders and weirdos, Double Trouble not the least among both.

But what was really telling was their total lack of interaction with Double Trouble's more... theatrical nature. *That* was a scary sign. Someone that professional, that able to be focused...

Well, that kind of person could kill you or inflict harm on you and never, ever think about it again, never be bothered, lose no sleep. That kind of person...

Well, Double Trouble preferred *not* to be near that kind of person.

So they were waving goodbye to Light Hope and fucking off right out of the Fright Zone... on foot, because Light Hope had powers over machinery, and Double Trouble could morph into a bird or something and just fly out. Not the first time they'd done it. They'd helped that one Desert Elf Hordesman out, faking her suicide- what was her name, Tara or something?- and they still remembered the land.

Yeah, they'd make it to Glass Lake, fake a Rebel identity, and catch a boat out; sure, they could swim it as a shark, but boats

were comfier. Maybe they'd go to Seaworthy. They'd always liked Seaworthy, maybe they'd camp out there for a while, see what the nightlife was like these days. Maybe they could take over a nightclub while they were there, they'd always wanted to run one.

A shame they couldn't see Light Hope's face when she realized the changeling had tricked her.

(The thought brought Double Trouble great amusement, imagining that serene face crunched up in rage.)

But before they did that...

Well, there was another reason to stay.

Waking up Adora had been Light Hope's plan. Caught asleep and unawares, Adora might well get killed by an ambush; sure, even a sleeping Princess was tougher than a normal person, but Grizzlor's veterans would know that and pour even more firepower at her to compensate.

And Light Hope couldn't have that! Adora's death would pretty much end the civil war, right there. The only people that *could* corral her "side" of the civil war if she died were Rogelio and Lonnie, neither of whom could do so; Rogelio was in the north, attacking Plumeria with the bulk of the Horde, and Lonnie...

Well, it was hard to tell which way she'd jump in any case, but even if she *wanted* to fight for Adora, she was asleep right now and would wake up confused as all hell, given how much shit Double Trouble had done wearing her skin. Both sides, after all, would believe her to be on their side.

(A thought that brought Double Trouble greater amusement, imagining Lonnie's sheer bewilderment.)

Light Hope hadn't wanted the war to end so fast. She didn't care who won, but she *did* want the Horde *divided.* Either side winning too soon would spoil whatever plan she had to get Scorpia to the Black Garnet; it'd be easier to do that if the Horde was too busy shooting itself in the foot to bother shooting invaders. And for all that Double Trouble was tapping out, they hadn't wanted to tip Light Hope off to their plan to just run off, so they'd played their part in the scheme.

So Adora was awake, and Grizzlor had a hell of a fight on his hands. Adora had a hell of a fight on her hands, too; Grizzlor had the bots, and the element of surprise... plus Light Hope. Light Hope struck the changeling as someone with *lots* of tricks up her sleeve. Who knew what would happen when Scorpia touched the Garnet?

...They really *should* run...

But there was something about Adora. Adora, who was just...

Dammit, she was too much *fun,* that was the trouble. Too *interesting.* Adora, whom Double Trouble had finally figured out, after so long, her issues a spiraling mess of complexities and mental traumas that had all emerged from a single, simple fact, like glorious geometric fractal patterns born out of a simple equation.

Adora, the Lord of the Horde, who had reacted so strongly to being called Traitor, who lied as easily as other people breathed but still couldn't fool an old deceiver like Double Trouble. Adora, who lied to everyone, but most of all to *herself,* which was the sole pitfall of being a liar. For all Double Trouble's love of deceit, they had *never* lied to *themselves.*

...Somebody should tell her the truth about herself.

Which was surprising to feel, and to think; and yes, part of it was propelled by Double Trouble's sadism, because they'd always been, to be blunt, a bastard. There was something in Double Trouble that *liked* hurting people- and they did not lie to themselves, so they just accepted it, they were at peace with that cheshire grin part of themselves.

...But there was also... pity, mixed in there. Just a little, of that odd emotion, one so rare in Double Trouble’s heart. A drop of sugar on the vinegar, a dollop of sweet to the bitter.

They wanted to help Adora.

Maybe it was because they were both liars, and some part of Double Trouble felt a kinship with the Lord for it. Maybe it was just because they saw how they *could* have been, if they hadn't been so determined to be truthful to themselves, and felt like nudging Adora, to see if they could get her to get on the *right* path.

Who knew? Double Trouble didn't. They only knew they pitied Adora, and they would not lie to themselves; they *wanted* to help her, as well as hurt her.

How lucky, then that telling Adora the truth would do *both.*

...Maybe they'd get a chance, if they waited.

(And *that* thought brought the *greatest* amusement to the changeling.)

****

Lonnie had not lied; the comms systems were a mess. Adora- after a long moment of staring at her communicator, and trying to get it to work again- had tried everything, finally resorting to the old intercom system and the cameras. She woke the system from sleep with a tap of the keyboard, but the information returned was not encouraging; most of the cameras were static and useless, though a few were still working, showing Hordesmen fighting each other. The enemy, some part of Adora idly noted under her dawning horror, had scratched her little red squiggle and flame out, leaving only Hordak’s wings.

They were fighting for Hordak, for his dream; and she heard over the camera the tinny sound of their battle cries, half of which were praises of Hordak or Grizzlor… and the other half were cries for the *Traitor Lord* to be slain.

Adora nearly puked.

(This wasn't the Horde. They… they didn't *do* this. Adora was the only Hordesman who had ever killed another, just as she was the only First One to be evil, she was a monster, but the rest were just lied to, mislead, fooled; no, they didn't do this, they didn't *do* this, what has she done?)

The rebels were crushing all resistance, the normal Hordesmen- *her* Hordesmen- too surprised to offer much resistance. All her forces were falling back, everywhere she could see, the rebels on a direct path for her sister. Another group was headed for Adora herself, but she could handle it; it was the Spirit Ember she worried about.

So she hit the call-all button, and hoped enough of the intercom worked to make her message heard.

" To all Hordesmen! Force- Force Captain Grizzlor has betrayed me! He's trying to reach the Spirit Ember! All other duties are canceled; leave your posts and head to the Ember! Defend my sister! Defend my Runestone!"

(In her terror, in the heat of the moment, beneath her rising horror, she did not notice what she'd said- and Light Hope made

sure the entire Fright Zone heard that message.)

With that done, she prepared to leave her room, find the nearest squad, take command…

She had just finished putting her helmet and gloves back on when the building she slept in exploded.

****

That was it; the war was won.

The Traitor Lord of the Horde- who was no Lord but a *Princess,* an usurper and an enemy- was no more. Her living quarters were ruined, and the explosion had taken her from a second floor home to nothing but a pile of rubble on the ground. The high brought low, the promise of the Horde since the beginning.

At least, that's what Azana and their troops clearly thought, all of them cheering wildly at the destruction. Landor, more cautious than his exuberant sister, wasn't so ready to call it a day just yet. As his sister and their shared scouting group high-fived each other, Landor kept watch on the rubble, searching for any sign of movement.

"We got her!" one of the troops whooped, and others followed his lead.

“The Traitor Lord is dead!” his sister laughed, slapping him on the back. “Call us dragonslayers! Mom and Dad’d be proud!”

“ If she’s dead,” Landor cautioned her, but Azana just laughed.

“ The Traitor Lord was asleep,” she said, nodding her head towards the rubble. “Princesses gotta be awake to use most of their powers. Remember Vultak’s first plan to kill that Plumerian?”

“ Yes,” Landor said. His parents had been part of the teams that had set up the explosives that had finally killed Princess Ivy- Poison Ivy, as the Horde had taken to calling her- during the actual plan Vultak had used, but his sister had never let go of the white lie Vultak had told them as children.

“Ambush at night!” his sister continued as if he hadn’t said anything. “Just me and you and our explosives!”

Landor bit back a sigh; he and Azana had some variant of this conversation about once every six months, and had done so since Poison Ivy had been put in the ground.

“We were kids back then,” he told her patiently. “ Not even old enough to have been involved that way at any point. It wasn’t Vultak’s first plan, it was the one he told us when we asked him if we could help; he was just playing nice with two over-eager kids.

We were never going to be sent out to kill the Princess by ourselves.”

“ We could totally have done it, though!” his sister countered. “I gotta give Grizzlor a present, he let us take another shot at killing a Princess! We’re gonna be famous!”

“Don’t count your eggs before they-“ Landor began… and paused. In the rubble… something was… moving?

He saw the heat haze above the rubble, his sole warning. He had just enough time to shove his sister down, Azana sprawling, before one massive chunk of metal and concrete and plastic turned bright red and *exploded,* chunks of it flying off as pyroclastic bombs. He saw one hit one of their scouts in the head, splattering it before catching her body on fire; the woman stayed standing a moment longer before collapsing, still ablaze. Another soldier lost a leg, screaming as he went down, screams going up in pitch when the headless woman toppled on top of him, the fire catching, catching, catching. Other parts of this earthborn meteor shower hit buildings around them, exploding as bombs from the force of impact and the sudden transfer of heat, more fires catching. One passed by Landor’s head so close that he felt his hair crinkle up, almost catching fire just from the heat radiating off the stone.

And rising up from that self-made volcanic crater was the Traitor Lord herself, in her full armor, which felt like a mockery of Hordak, her great shield over her head.

She gazed over them, her helm a snarling dragon, and Landor's heart trembled in fear as he raised his pistol.

" Your weapons cannot harm me," the Princess said, and all Landor could think of were stories of what the Princesses were capable of, stories about how *removed* from a normal person they were, how monstrous a living shaman-queen could be to those beneath her. " Surrender, and you will live. Fight, and you will die. Do not make me do this."

Landor made answer with his gun, firing it once, twice, three times, each shot perfectly aimed at the eyeslots on her helmet.

The Traitor Lord did not even do him the kindness of flinching, merely looking at him with a stance of her shoulders that suggested she was more annoyed than anything else.

"You cannot hurt me with a *fire*arm," the monster said to him. "I *am* fire."

Heat began to rise off of her as he plinked off more shots, still perfectly aimed, still perfectly pointless.

"Once again- *surrender.*"

Landor swallowed hard against the terror in his throat; none of his surviving troops said or did anything, just standing there petrified

as two of their friends burned near them, never to rejoin the soil and make their last contribution to the Horde…

"Death to the Traitor Lord!"

Azana, rising up, missile launcher in hand, his brave sister, his *stupid* sister-

The missile fired. It smacked into the Princess and burst, and they could see nothing in the backwash of smoke and dust and debris it kicked up, shielding their faces from the too-close burst.

And when the smoke cleared, the Princess- whose shield had a single, rapidly-fading red spot, to indicate where the missile had struck and done no harm- had his sister's throat in her strong right hand.

"Do not call me that!" the Lord said, but it was tinged with… laughter? Lost laughter, laughter not because something was funny but because nothing would *ever* be funny, ever again. "I'm not a traitor! *You're* a traitor!"

And then there was fire, and his sister was burning, and he was burning, and *everything* was *burning*-

****

Lonnie awoke to a world at war, the explosions and screams waking her up from her sleep.

She didn't know what was happening. No one else had been in the building, her comms weren't working; it wasn't until she armored up and went outside that she found Hordesmen killing Hordesmen, and gained some inkling as to *why.*

Her comms didn't work; but Hordesmen were killing Hordesmen, and she didn't know why.

Had Grizzlor jumped the gun?

(*Has he done exactly what I wanted him to?* Lonnie thought, and hated herself.)

…Adora was in danger…

…If it even *was* Adora in there…

She didn't know what to do. She didn't know what to do. She didn't know what to do.

But she had to do something.

Sick to her heart from the blasphemy of Hordesmen killing each other, Lonnie began to move through the city streets, not sure where her feet were taking her, or why.

(Or what she would do when she got there.)

Chapter End Notes

The Robin Adora is referencing here is from Witch Hunter Robin; she was a Flame Princess in the past, and probably the one who actually understood the most about how the Ember actually worked (not the strongest, though- that was the Last Flame Princess, who was by far the most powerful of them, which is why her country melted). Adora is unconsciously searching the Spirit Ember's memories for information on how to use the Spirit Ember, so naturally she ends up looking at a lot of Robin's memories.

Mandora and Quick Pick are originally Thundercats characters. Mandora the Evil Chaser was a badass space cop, and Quick Pick was a criminal who reforms with Mandora.

Here, the backstory is that Mandora was originally a cop for the Fright Zone's nobles, and caught Quick Pick; he was sentenced to salt mining, which was a slow death, and felt terrible, eventually joining Hordak to free the prisoners. This was the first action the Horde ever undertook as a faction; Mandora and Quick Pick are the only people still alive from that time- they are the longest-serving members of the Horde.
(Well, Hordak's trapped between dimensions, but you get me.)

They went with Vultak after Shadow Weaver forced him down south, having protested Shadow Weaver being allowed in at all.
(Hordak himself wavered a LOT on that decision; having a

wizard on hand was too useful as a counter to various Princess and mage shenanigans, but he was never entirely comfortable with hiring the witch.)

The Fighting Foe Men are REALLY cool, actually! They come from the Masters of the Universe toy line, specifically being based on the vehicle drivers shown in the artwork on the vehicle toys from some years back. They are ALSO based on the real life three people who do the molding, casting, prototyping, and painting of all the toys, the trio of Shane Dittsworth, Owen "O-Dawg" Oertling, and Sherri Lynn Cook. The three were designed as a tribute to them- which is awesome!

I chose them here because in the Masters of the Universe setting, the Fighting Foe Men were renegade pirates who Hordak eventually recruited for the Second Ultimate Battleground event. It felt appropriate to make them vehicle people here.

Zin is from the UK World POP Annuals; he was an evil wizard Hordak cut a deal with.

Landor and Azana are my personal favorites of this group; they're also from the UK World POP Annuals, but they have a fun, complicated history with Adora. Originally, he was captured by her while she was part of the Evil Horde, and forced to make maps for the Horde. Adora did eventually free him after his sister Azana put a ton of effort into getting the Rebellion to do so.

That's why they get to be here, and get to face Adora... and get to die at her hand. It felt... right.

Chapter 61: THE LAST BATTLE OF THE WAR: The Great Rebellion

Chapter Notes

Christmas Eve present ya'll!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

THE LAST BATTLE OF ETHERIA

The Great Rebellion

"Please, don't," the Hordesman begged her from beneath her steel-shod hoof.

Krystala paid no attention to it. She was no sadist. She took no joy in the killing.

She raised her arm and fired it, mechanical, efficient, cold, not even looking as the hsotgun blast tore the man's skull to pieces, splattering the world with his insides.

She kept going, taking no joy even in the victory.

She took no joy in anything, these days.

She stalked with the calm certainty of a prophet through the raging war of the Fright Zone, unbothered by the horrors around her. A Horde AttackTrak, commanded by one of the rebels who had scratched out the Dragon on their symbols, ran over a few of their former comrades; Krystala observed this dispassionately as she changed the ammunition of her gun-arm to something heavier than shotguns hells.

A useful trick, and one that she alone had access to, as far as she knew. She had been one of the Bloody Bull's grand experiments, the horrible dictator having seen something in the small-town farmgirl she had once been- probably her size and strength. She had been big and tall and broad, even as a young woman, traits viewed as deeply desirable by young men; she'd been fending suitors off with a stick, and rather enjoyed the attention.

The Bloody Bull had wanted her body, too, and for his own pleasures... but not the carnal kind.

(Though he had done that, too, when he was bored, in-between her torments.)

He had designed her as a weapon par excellence, slavishly obedient to him and him alone- which meant that, when Hordak drew him out and fought him with the Red Knight, she had been inadvertantly freed. No one else could command her.

A shame she hadn't really survived the process to enjoy it.

(Oh, she breathed and lived, moved, but... it wasn't the same. Nothing had been the same, not since the experiments, not since she'd gone home to find her village a smoking ruin, her family all dead and in ashes...)

Ammunition swapped, she aimed her gun-arm at the vehicle and fired, a freezing beam of sparkling cold freezing the AttackTrak in place. Stuck in place, its driver cursing as the vehicle froze over, she took the time to swap ammo again, this time preparing a single heavy rocket.

When she fired this time, the rocket pierced the AttackTrak and burst the combat vehicle open, killing it and everyone on board, all its parts and occupants reduced to shattered yolk from an egg thrown by a giant. A single Hordesmen it had run over was alive; Krystala crushed his skull with her hoof in passing as she walked up to the wreck, putting her gun-arm up to it, letting it absorb the frozen metal to replace any ammuniton she'd lost. Whatever First Ones tech the Bloody Bull had stuck inside her, it could do anything so long as it had fuel and material, and war supplied plenty of both.

Resupply complete, Krystala moved, cold and calm, feeling nothing, killing because it was what she was built to do, heading ever deeper into the Fright Zone. Lord Adora was in here, somewhere; and she would know where the Bull's Eye was, where the Runestone that might set Krystala free was, the one thing she had left that was almost a goal.

And if she didn't?

Well, Krystala would kill her.

It was what she'd been built to do.

Walking through her cold, cold ashes, following orders and directives she barely recalled, the great mass of Krystala hunted ever-deeper into the Fright Zone.

****

Sweet Bee checked around the corner for enemies; seeing nothing, she motioned the others forward. Peekablue was right behind her, dagger in one hand and the other hand in his pocket, while behind him, Chilla, a Snows priestess, was taking up the rearguard, fractal mace in hand. She'd already proven herself quite competent, so Sweet Bee was content to let her guard her precious Peekie's back.

Down the hall, then; not the building they'd started out in. They were following Peekablue's senses and his Perfect Blue, looking for Frosta, whom Chilla had insisted was priority one. Sweet Bee didn't quite agree with that; she figured priority one was the Garnet, and priority two was Lord Adora... but a Princess would help with both those causes. Especially because they were supposed to catch Lord Adora *alive.*

Personally, Sweet Bee thought that was dumb; the Lord of the Horde wasn't exactly an easy target to kill, much less kidnap!

Plus, she didn't see any practical reason for it.

But they *did* say that the She-Ra was in love with the Lord of the Horde- well, some did. Lot of stories told, among Crownless and Kingdomfolk alike, about those two; some were about a hatred so strong it was easy to *mistake* for love, some about love so strong it was easy to mistake for hate. A few about how the two had no connection at all and didn't know why people thought they did. A book series about how Adora wanted to jump Bow's bones.

But Peekablue had told her his best guess, and she trusted his keen social instincts, which had seen him become kingmaker in a land as poisoned with intrigues as Seaworthy.

And he said it was love.

(*Love pure as I've ever seen* , he'd said, shaking his head. *I pity the She-Ra. That's the kind of love that can destroy you... if it doesn't save you.*)

Sweet Bee couldn't help but be sympathetic to that. If her and Peekablue were somehow ever at odds like that... she'd hope and pray for a way to spare him.

So if she had a chance, she'd shoot this Adora not in the heart or the head, but in the knees (or arms, Sweet Bee wasn't picky and neither was her poison). The poison would incapacitate, and she'd haul her alive to Catra.

*...Given all the bullshit I've heard about this Adora, though, maybe I shoot her in the legs **and** the arms...*

Better safe than sorry!

Words behind her drew Sweet Bee out of her musings.

" How close?" Chilla asked Peekablue, as she had several times before now. It would rankle Sweet Bee to hear that question repeated so often if the priestess' concern wasn't so clear in her voice.

" Close," Peekablue said, tapping his Runestone where it lay in his pocket, eyes briefly on places none of them could see. " I can't tell with pinpoint accuracy, but I have a vague sense of direction and distance both with the Perfect Blue. She's this way. She's also doing quite well for herself; your Andreenids are acquitting themselves well, honey."

Honey. His jokey nickname for her, which had annoyed her fiercely given how stereotypical it was for someone from the Hive; but the annoyance had blossomed into a strange, grating fondness, as so much else had about her Peekie. From anyone else, it would have made her roll her eyes; from him, while the urge to roll her eyes was still present, there was also a kind of... warmth.

" Are all of them there?" she asked instead, focusing herself. A warzone was no time to be head over heels.

“ Yes,” he said. “ One is wounded pretty bad, looks like his foot's crushed- not sure how, didn't see that part- but Frosta's guarding him.”

“ Who is it?” Sweet Bee asked.

“ Short and scrawny guy, but he's not letting that injury stop him- he's busy sniping from a sitting position,” Peekablue said. “ Steady hands too, despite the fact he must be in a world of pain; I haven't seen him miss yet.”

“ That's Tike, then,” Sweet Bee said. Good Woman's love, Tike, who was a foot shorter than even the shortest folk in the Hive, and stood ten times as tall in her esteem. Tike, who had just been an ordinary person who'd joined her with no skills whatsoever, nothing but a willingness to do whatever she asked, because he believed in her cause. One of her very first recruits, one of the only ones still with her after all these years of war; and of *course* he was fighting with his foot ruined. Wounds didn't slow down Tike, he was too brave and too focused for that; you had to kill him to stop him.

“ Let's hurry, then,” Chilla said, a note of admiration in her voice. “ A man that tough needs saving.”

Oh yeah, Sweet Bee thought as they reached an intersection, with paths running left and right; *Snowsfolk have a thing about*

endurance, right? Well, she won't find more durable than Tike, he's ten pounds of stone in a five pound bag.

(Even with all that was going on, some part of Sweet Bee was mildly amused at the thought of romance blossoming for such ridiculous reasons- though the priestess *was* tall, and Tike had a thing for tall women... which was probably good, considering everybody was taller than him...)

" We'll be on them soon- wait," Peekablue said, blinking as he withdrew his hand and his eyesight returned to the here and now. " Someone's coming- three of them. Coming up fast around the left corner. Not friendlies."

Sweet Bee didn't ask how he knew, though she heard Chilla ask; she'd learned to trust his instincts and his excellent perceptions and paranoia, which had worked in concert to keep him alive as the top information broker for decades in a city that usually chewed up and spat out would-be spymasters.

She instead simply chose to surprise their opponents, running up to the intersection and leaning in low with her crossbow, catching them just as they turned a corner themselves. She aimed at the group's leader, right for their knees; she caught the Squamatus just right, the bolt piercing armor and scales both, and the poison turning the wound's pain from *bad* to *crippling.* With all senses howling pain, the Squamatus fell to the ground screaming, and his companions tripped on him, exactly as Sweet Bee hoped they would. A quick cocking of her crossbow reloaded it; a second bolt whipped a moment later straight into a shoulder, where the venom incapacitated that one, too. The third soldier had just enough time to try and get up before she reloaded and fired a last shot, straight into his stomach, which put him down.

“ All down,” Sweet Bee said, reloading one last time before heading over to steal her crossbow bolts back. No telling *how* much fighting they'd have to do today, and the venom left in the wounds would keep these people down for a week or more- though they would all live, even the gutshot guy. His armor had kept it from burying too deep into him.

She briefly considered double-tap killing... but a look told her these were young ones, teenagers, because the Horde was a monstrous thing that sent the young in to die. Sweet Bee had killed child soldiers before, but not if she didn't have to, and today, she didn't have to. Not yet.

So she just took her crossbows back, popping the automatic clip from her crossbow out to quickly insert them before popping it back into place.

(Thankfully, she didn't have to reload the poison on them; one of her supporters back home had figured out how to make a little reservoir in the crossbow itself that would coat the bolts as they were reloaded. Ingenious little device, and much loved; she'd had to handcraft every poisoned bolt for the first few years, and that was a slow and dangerous process. She'd sent them a gift of stolen Horde hi-tech for their work.)

She went back to the intersection, where Peekablue was back to work at his Runestone, and Chilla was staring in surprise at Sweet Bee.

“ I'd heard the Rebels were excellent soldiers,” she said, shaking her head, “ but it's something else to see it in action.”

“ Thank you,” Sweet Bee replied a bit stiffly, not sure what else to say. Getting complimented by Runestone folk felt... really, really awkward.

If she was from Brightmoon, it'd be different, but the Snows? Fuck those people.

Thankfully, the awkward moment was resolved a minute later as a blast of ice sprayed down the hallway to their right, catching a fleeing Hordesman in its grip. Around the corner came Frosta, packing what looked like a sled behind her on which sat Tike, the rest of the squad following behind.

(Sweet Bee repressed a moment's topsy-turvy sensation at the bizarre sight of her Crownless hardliners working as escorts for a *Princess.* Just wrong, that!)

Tike was the first to spot them, and tapped the Princess.

“ That's our captain!” he said to the Princess while waving at Sweet Bee. His leg was partially frozen in place; the ice was red over his upper leg, the blood frozen too. “ What's your status?”

“I'm fine,” Sweet Bee said, “but you're not. Let me look at that.”

As she ran over to him, Chilla came with her.

" Are you alright, cousin?" Chilla asked Frosta as they reached them, Peekablue lagging behind and bitching under his breath about how out of shape he'd gotten running his club.

" I'm good," the Snowsfolk Princess said, jerking a thumb at the Andreenids. " These guys are good fighters, and they had *me* with them. Horde didn't stand a chance."

Sweet Bee got there and her squad swarmed over as well, telling her they were alright, all save Tike. " What happened?"

" Bastard with a spear," Tike replied. " Princess Frosta stopped the bleeding; I didn't want to stop until we found you for proper treatment. Thanks for that, by the way, Frosta, I didn't get a chance to say that while we were fighting."

" No problem!" Frosta said. " I'm no Catra, I can't heal, but a tourniquet of ice? I can do that."

" Well, you found me, so let's get you healed up, soldier," Sweet Bee said, repressing the urge to shake her head. Tike never *did* take care of himself.

" I can assist," Chilla offered. " Warpriests carry medical equipment with us and are trained as first responders."

“ Save it,” Tike said, waving his hand at her. “ We've got our own stuff, and you and yours might need it- I'm good.”

“ I have painkillers, if nothing else,” Chilla offered in an... odd kind of way. Like she was testing him.

“ Frosta numbed me pretty good, and it wasn't that bad before she did it,” Tike replied, waving her off once again. “ Again, I'm good.”

Chilla seemed oddly pleased by that, and Sweet Bee tried to put the resultant mental image of Tike and the blue-skinned woman getting married out of her head. She focused instead on his leg, kneeling down to get to work on it before realizing the ice blocked her.

“ I assume you need me to remove the ice?” Frosta said.

“ If you would,” Sweet Bee said. “ And... thank you for saving him.”

Crownless hardliner or not, she wasn't a *bitch*, and she'd never been ungrateful.

“ Like I said, no trouble,” Frosta said. “ Gonna remove the ice now- he's gonna bleed pretty good.”

“ I've had worse,” Tike said. “ Remember the saw bastard?”

“ Don't remind me of the saw bastard,” Sweet Bee said.

“ Saw bastard?” Chilla and Frosta asked at once.

“ Guy with a sawblade we fought in Seaworthy once,” an Andreenid offered for explanation as Frosta readied to remove the ice. “ Damn near sliced his arm off, but Tike kept hitting him with the back of his crossbow until he finally died. Tike didn't pass out until he'd won!”

“ I was out of ammo,” Tike said with a shrug. “ Didn't seem like a good idea to pass out either, not until I killed the guy anyway.”

“ Admirable,” Chilla said warmly, and Sweet Bee was grateful she had a wound to take care of as the ice finally retreated under Frosta's command.

Tike *did* start to bleed, but slowly given how cold the limb was, and Bee had time to slather some blood-clotting medication on it, apply a honey-based antibacterial, and swiftly stitch the wound with antiseptic string. The wound wasn't that deep, but it was

long. He'd need someone to look after him properly, but the medication should keep him going.

(She also applied a bit of painkiller- not much, just a little. Tike might not ask for it, but Sweet Bee took care of her soldiers.)

As she worked, Frosta turned to Chilla.

" Hey, I didn't think to ask," Frosta said, "but I should have. You okay?"

" I'm fine, cousin," Chilla answered.

" Good, because I know fuck-all to do if you weren't," Frosta answered, prompting a quick, tinkling laugh from Chilla. " But I still should have checked."

" Perhaps I can teach you some medical techniques," Chilla answered.

" I might take you up on that," Frosta said.

Sweet Bee finished up, and helped Tike to his feet- he'd had to sit to keep the ice tourniquet on, but there was nothing stopping him from walking now that she'd helped him.

“ Feeling good?” she asked him, and he nodded.

“ Down a few bolts, but otherwise functional,” he said.

“ Where to next, dear?” Peekablue offered. He'd been oddly quiet during the entire sequence, hand in his pocket; he'd been using the Blue the entire time they were meeting, apparently searching for the rest of their erstwhile forces.

“ Who's closest?” she asked.

“ Looks like... wait,” Peekablue said, cocking his head. “ The fuck?”

“ I don't like hearing that from somebody who can see shit I can't,” Frosta stated mildly as Peekablue's eyes widened.

“ You're not gonna believe what Perfuma just did,” he told them. “ Were you aware she could turn into a giant monster?”

****

“Any sign of her?!?” Spinnerella asked as she threw a tornado at another group of Hordesmen.

“No,” the Red Knight answered, majestically performing a rather complicated looking series of sword strikes that nonetheless worked, tearing through a group of Hordesmen and knocking most of them out. “I don't see Netossa anywhere.”

“Fuck,” Spinnerella cursed as she sucked air away from a group of Horde snipers, leaving them choking as she threw that air at another group.

Beneath her, her own forces fought like hell- well, most of them. A few were missing, most prominently her wife- but the rest of their Rebels were there, in all their strange glory. The Troll who'd joined up early was clubbing Hordesmen to death, her two Squamatus medics were healing and killing in equal measure, and her second in command...

“You'd think the Horde would be too busy fighting each other to fight us!” Toad announced as he fired his bazooka at one of the AttackTraks that were closing in on them. The blast took it out and her second in command reloaded as he kept complaining. “And where the hell are we?!?”

“No idea,” Spinnerella said. “Keep fighting- I'll do recon as soon as we're free!”

The fight was interrupted- and ended- by a salvo of three rockets coming in, each hitting right in a clump of soldiers and bursting them apart into gory showers. What few soldiers were left were

swiftly subdued- mostly by surrendering to the Red Knight, whom they well knew would take them in alive.

“I believe,” Krystala said, as she stepped out of the shadows while the Red Knight knocked out each of their new surrenders, “that we are near the Garnet.”

“Oh, great,” Toad grumbled. “Saved by the Monster of the Rebellion...”

Krystala paid no attention to the insult, which Spinnerella was grateful for; that had always seemed a rather rude thing to call the woman.

“Krystala!” Spinnerella said as she landed near her. “Have you seen my wife?”

“No,” Krystala responded.

“But we are all heading for the Garnet,” the Red Knight said. “I'm going to hurl these people into a nearby building; they should be safe there. I'll follow when done.”

“Let me see where it is,” Spinnerella said, dancing into the air.

From above, the Fright Zone... looked like a vision of hell. War was everywhere...

But the Garnet's shelter, Spinnerella could see from where she was.

“Northeast!” she told Krystala. “We're going northeast!”

“See you there,” the Red Knight said.

And off the Rebels went, to the meeting place of destiny.

****

Bow, member of the Great Rebellion by choice and bravery, member of the Best Friend Squad because he had once been Glimmer's only friend and had thus been press-ganged into it, idly pondered his situation as he aimed an arrow.

“So... why are we here?” Bow asked his sole companion as he loosed, the arrow catching the Hordesman peeking around the hallway's corner in the throat. They died choking on blood as Bow readied another arrow.

(His heart felt no ache, save the general sense of knowing that it was a shame they had to die- but Bow had made his choices, and judged his beliefs worth killing for long before now.)

“Like in the philosophical sense, or-” Glimmer said, as she sent a grasping hand of darkness down the hall, gripping a soldier and draining them of life- though not all the way. She hurled the half-dead soldier down the hall she couldn't see with that gigantic hand.

“The physical one,” Bow said with a sigh as he readied to fire on whoever decided to try their hand next.

“Well, it's like we hit a shield or something,” Glimmer said. “We should have all ended up in the same spot- but... like, okay, you know how if you shine a light through a prism, you get a rainbow?”

“Yeah,” Bow said. “Light refraction.”

“Don't use science words on me,” Glimmer said, firing another magic blast down the hall- no Hordesmen had peeked, but it was best to remind them to keep their damn heads down. “That shit's pure cryptic. But basically, same idea- we teleported into a prism, and it separated us out instead of letting us land in one area. Happened fast, too- I barely had enough time to cling to you.”

“You clung to me?” he asked, turning an eyebrow on her.

(With great effort, Glimmer did *not* blush at this good and handsome man's attention- but it was harder now than it had been before the Island. Maybe now that she was out of her own

head she was more able to think about others... and what she wanted from them...)

“W-well, you were gonna be by yourself,” she said, stuttering a bit. “Everyone else had someone with them, except for I think Netossa? But you weren't going to have anyone- so I latched on.”

That... was rather sweet, actually.

“Thank you,” Bow said. “Just like old times, huh?”

“Y-yeah,” Glimmer said- and this time she *did* blush, a thing Bow studiously ignored. He had... suspicions... about what Glimmer wanted from him, had for a while now, but he wasn't sure if it was just a crush on her part or if it was something worth risking their friendship for- and that wasn't even getting into what *Bow* wanted, which...

Well. Something to think about when the War was over, when they had time to examine it. That's what he'd always told himself, anyway.

(Glimmer, meanwhile, resolved to punch her stupid heart in the face as soon as she had a moment. There was a *war* on!)

“Anyway!” Glimmer said. “Moving on! Let's get somewhere I can see where we are; then I'll juice up on the electricity that's everywhere here, I'm pretty sure I can eat it with my shadows,

and that'll give me the power to jump straight to the Garnet. We should be able to stop Entrapta, Scorpia, and Shadow Weaver... though if we can't convince them... I'm not so worried about Scorpia, I can just grab her and teleport really far, but Shadow Weaver..."

Ah- *her.* Bow had something for that, actually.

"She won't be a problem," Bow said, holding up an arrow with a canister on the end, one marked with what looked like a Mystacoran symbol in that nation's heavy violet. Experimental and not quite ready, but they were all he had, and he was a Rebel; he'd done more with less. "Anti-magic arrows. Grabbed them before we left, thought they might be handy if we had to deal with Shadow Weaver."

"Anti-magic? Those are new!" Glimmer said, looking impressed; and maybe Bow had to fight not to blush *this* time. " "That's awesome! You tell me about all your cool arrows, but I've never heard of these! When'd you build these?"

"It was after Catra... told me," he said, and gave Glimmer a Look. "About Shadow Weaver."

"...Oh," Glimmer said.

And f or just a moment, Bow was back there, listening as one of his best friends, and one of the bravest people he'd *ever* met- and

he was a volunteer Rebel, that was *saying* something when it came from him- broke, broke apart, because of cruelties she had never deserved, inflicted on her as an innocent child.

That lasted only a moment; but the cold fire he had felt then, it had *never* left. Steady as ice, searing as flame, it was not anger nor hate, though it had elements of both. It was too focused to be anger, which tended to go out of control like wildfire; it was too alive to be *hate,* which deadened one inside.

It was a third thing made of them and one drop more, a triple mixture, because his sense of *justice* was added to it; justice, because *this must be paid for,* and so what he felt was *wrath,* the sharp edge of the Silver, the part of Good that demanded that a person *get what they deserved.*

And for one who would hurt a child so deeply, who would *torment* a child until she shattered and broke, for one who had hurt an innocent until she was innocent no more...

Well, there was only *one* thing she deserved.

"I remember," he said quietly; and Glimmer looked at him, really *looked* at him, and it made him feel warm and hot in ways that had nothing to do with the cold fire.

She *looked* at him, the way she always did; and that was funny on its own, wasn't it? That Glimmer, one of the most thoughtlessly

self-centered Princesses, was the one who had always... looked at him.

And he didn't mean that in a bad way! Glimmer wasn't snobby, nor cruel to others. It was just that she was trapped in her own head a lot of the time, wrapped up in her own fears and worries, her own pride and position, her own place in the world. Any time it was pointed out that she wasn't thinking of others, she'd immediately do so, her natural compassion opening her heart. She was a lovely person, just one who got stuck in a rut sometimes, like anyone did.

(Hell, hadn't he done the same over the years, working on one thing or another, needing someone to come rescue him from his own head? Needing a *specific* someone- a little pink-haired spitfire, perhaps- to teleport into his workshop and pull him out of his own head, and see the world... and she always had. She had *always* saved him when he needed it; it was why he tried to save her when she needed it, too, reciprocating the gift that they passed back and forth like a well-worn coin.)

She wasn't the only one, of course- not these days, at least. The Best Friend Squad was a true thing, because Catra saw him too; albeit not quite like Glimmer did. She was his second best friend, to the extent he could make the distinction, someone he trusted instinctively, who he knew had his back, as he had hers.

But...

Some days, he felt like they were the only two who did. He worried sometimes that the others saw him as the hanger-on, the non-Princess allowed near them by Glimmer and Catra's good

graces, the way Sea Hawk was tolerated because he was Mermista's one and only no matter *how* much she protested; and while most days he could quiet that fear, everyone had moments of weakness.

But even at his lowest, he'd never doubted Glimmer.

(And maybe that was the secret to all his hidden feelings; that alone of all the world, one of its wonders, the daughter of an immortal, had seen plain old ordinary Bow, really *seen* him, and thought him worth spending time with. Maybe all of it is simply that Glimmer alone loves him for who he is...)

He'd never pushed because he feared it was just... an immaturity, either on his part or on Glimmer's. She *was* a bit immature for her age- not that Bow held it against her. People grew up at different rates, and Glimmer didn't have his advantage of his two awesome dads and all his brothers, just one mom who was dealing with her own grief- plus Glimmer had *always* been under more pressure than Bow had ever had to deal with. His own dads had wanted him to be happy first, and all things else secondary; but Glimmer was the only child of an immortal queen. The weight on her back was such that he had never held any of her flaws against her; no, instead he had *marveled* at her, at a girl so strong she could carry all of it and only fumble sometimes.

But her immaturity *had* meant he'd... held himself back. He didn't want to ruin their friendship over a little crush, not while she still had growing up to do, change to do...

But she's different now, isn't she?

Maybe she was.

Because when he looked at her now... when he *saw* her... she was different. He took in her great black owl wings, the black so strange against her purple-pink clothes; and yet it fit, somehow, like a missing puzzle piece that had finally come home. He took in the fine stocky musculature of her figure, built like the squat rams of the mountains, a cute little package built of surprising power. He thought of how she had come in on wings at the meeting, of the story she'd told...

Of how self-aware she had been, joking about how she'd hold her deeds over everyone's heads, *mocking* herself...

Would anyone else even realize just *what* that meant, coming from Glimmer? Glimmer, whose soul was made entirely of wounded pride... to be able to *joke* about herself.

Catra alone, maybe, might actually realize what it meant, for Glimmer to mock herself in even such a gentle manner; only they two knew Glimmer so well that they could realize what it meant, for her not to react like she was stabbed at such a light jab- for her to *make* the light jab in the first place.

And she had not only made it, but *laughed,* laughed at *herself...* and he had seen no sign, even as tired as he had been, even as *wired* as he had been on coffee and adrenaline and sheer Silver-damned stubbornness- that she was putting on an act, or lying.

Glimmer had, for the first time since he'd met her, been able to joke about herself.

...She'd changed.

Grown up, maybe; and that thought made the warmth turn up another uncomfortable notch. If her feelings remained, then they were more than a fancy of the moment, and then maybe...

Shelve that, for now, he reminded himself. *Middle of a war. Not very romantic.*

... *Well, okay, an active warzone probably does make for a half-decent romantic atmosphere for* ***Glimmer*** *, but again, focus.*

"...Why did you build them?" she asked- and the answer was obvious enough, *because it's Shadow Weaver,* but that wasn't what she was *really* asking, he thought.

"...To be ready," he finally said. "She won't stop. Someone like that... they don't *stop.* So when she did something wrong, as she would... I'd be ready."

She didn't look him in the eye for a moment, before apparently screwing her courage to the sticking place and looking him

straight in the eye.

“Why wait?” she asked. “I didn't. I've been planning on killing her this whole time.”

... *I'm not really surprised,* Bow thought, as the shock processed way quicker than he might have expected it to. *I... I'm not really surprised. Huh. Maybe I know her even better than I thought.*

“That's why you joined up?” he asked, and she nodded.

“...You're taking it well,” she said, a bit awkwardly.

“...I am,” he said... and then, recalling the cold fire, knew why. “...Because someone has to stop her. She *deserves* death, for Catra if nothing else- and she's done more than just that.”

“Help me,” Glimmer asked. “Help me kill her.”

“Why do *you* want to kill her?” Bow asked. “You're not as focused that way as I am...”

“I'm not,” she admitted. “Virtue's virtue and I'm all for the Silver, but that's not what drives me. It's... Catra's my sister, Bow. She told us- I can't repeat it, but we heard the *whole* thing, not the

abridged bit she sort of told you that you've mentioned before, and- and Catra *still loves her,* that's the fucked up part, Catra *still wants her to love her,* and it's a weakness that'll kill her, Bow. She's a fairy tale hero but they all have a weakness and Shadow Weaver, she's one of Catra's, she'll slither back into her life and use her and *kill her* and I... I won't have that happen. I won't let my sister die."

...I can see it. Catra loves her still, wants to be loved still... Glimmer's heading it off before it can start. A defense.

(He also noted the "one of Catra's weaknesses", and his mind leapt to Adora- but that was a matter for later, and one quite different from the witch.)

"Help me," she begged him again- her, a Princess of a nation, to him, a random Rebel.

He put a hand on her shoulder and squeezed it tight.

"We give her a chance to surrender," he said, laying down the lines he would not cross. Keeping himself in those lines was what let him sleep at night; whenever horror or concern reared its ugly head, the knowledge that he had *never* betrayed his own rules let him lay them to rest once more. "One chance. And if she surrenders, she gets to live."

"She'll kill Catra if she lives," Glimmer siad, but Bow shook his head.

“We'll figure out a way to neutralize her,” he said. “I've been working on that kind of thing, and I'm sure Castaspella would love a chance to strip Shadow Weaver of her magic. They can do that, in Mystacor. Not sure if maybe Shadow Weaver's an outlier- Castaspella had mentioned she was kind of unusual- but we'll try. That's my rule, if we are going to do this.”

That made Glimmer pause, reconsider.

“You'll help me?” she asked, and her worried lips made him want to kiss her, to reassure her that he would *never* hurt her, or make her worry, ever again.

He wrestled that down. *Not the time.*

“I will,” he said. “If you'll give her the chance to surrender first- and she says no- she *dies*.”

For a long minute, he watched her wrestle with herself, before a kind of... quiet peace washed over her, and she nodded.

“Okay,” she said. “...It'd be easier just to blast her, though.”

“She'd deserve it,” he agreed, and reached up to squeeze her shoulder, resolutely ignoring the voice that wanted to embrace

her. “But you have to have rules. Not many, but a few.”

“...Okay,” she said again, smiling up at him. “...Bow? Thank you. You've... you've always been there for me.”

“You've always been there for me, too,” he answered her.

“Alright,” she said, turning around. “Let's go hunt a monster. Because we both know she won't surrender.”

“I rather hope she doesn't,” he admitted.

And the two left to go slay the monster, as was the task of all heroes since the days of old.

Chapter End Notes

> Tike is canon- he's from the Masters of the Universe series, part of the Bee People. He's a kid there; I adapted him here as a young, if very short, adult.
>
> Chilla is also damn tall- she's like 6'2". Snowsfolk tend to be bigger than average anyway- Frosta's young and a bit of an outlier.

Chapter 62: THE LAST BATTLE OF THE WAR: The Princess Alliance

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Last Battle of Etheria

The Princess Alliance

The first time Catra hit someone with the Sword during this Third Raid on the Fright Zone, she was convinced, down unto her bones, that she had just made her last mistake.

The act itself was pure muscle memory, no conscious input required. Near half a decade of fighting with the Sword, wielding it like another limb, like the extension of herself that it *had* been up until recently, was so natural that she didn't even think about it. She was in enemy territory and an enemy was attacking; so she set the Sword to them, as she had always done.

But in the split-second of contact- when the act could not be taken back, but she still had time to process what she'd just done- she was consumed with the sudden belief that the mere act of using the Sword as she had for four years now would set off the Heart, and murder the stars, murder the world, murder countless billions upon billions. The act of striking the Hordesman before her- with the flat of the blade, because even now, some part of

Catra did not want to kill her former countrymen if she did not have to, was satisfied with merely knocking them out, showing more kindness to the Horde than the Horde had ever shown her- was going to be what set off the Heart.

A moment later, of course, nothing happened, because that was *stupid.* That wasn't how the Sword *or* the Heart worked, no matter her irrational terrors, and the continued existence of... everything a moment later, combined with the adrenaline rush of battle, helped to clear her head, the heat of combat cooking away the roiling fear in her guts.

The next soldier was a distraction, which also helped.

" You! Traitor!" a Hordesman yelled at her before charging; but Hordesmen had been yelling that word at Catra for four years now, and what had once nearly shattered her coming from Adora's mouth now meant nothing from a stranger.

" Seems to be going around these days," Catra agreed, smacking the Hordesman hard with the flat of the Sword in a casual backhand. He hit a wall and stayed down.

" Nice!" Micah cheered from behind her as he used a wave of bright magic to bowl over a group of troopers, and Catra could not help the grin on her face- which nearly got her shot a minute later.

Focus, she reminded herself. She turned to face the shooter, who was firing- not at her, but at little Flutterina, who had been running about the battlefield distracting Hordesmen so that one of the other three in their group could get in a free attack or two. It'd been a killshot, aimed at her head...

That would not do. Flutterina was just a kid, and Catra had only told her to come because she'd have snuck aboard anyway.

So Catra pounced at the would-be child killer, falling on him like lightning, and *that* soldier did *not* get the flat of the blade.

(That she preferred to spare Hordesmen did not mean she *wouldn't* kill, if she had to, or felt it was deserved.)

"Thanks, Catra!" Flutterina said, shooting her a thumbs-up, unbothered by the fact that Catra's two-handed overhead chop had neatly bisected the man, whose corpse fell around her in two separate halves, blood gouting into the air and onto the sword and Catra herself.

*Well, she **is** a war orphan,* Catra thought to herself as she headbutted a gawking trooper nearby. *She's seen worse, I bet... or at least, knows worse is out there.*

"Incredible!" Micah cheered again from behind her.

“Focus, darling,” Angella said, as she laid down more blasts with the Moonstone's magic.

“Oh, this is nothing, honey!” Micah said, casually chatting as he ducked a Hordesman's electric baton, countering with an uppercut that knocked the man senseless. “Almost relaxing compared to some days I've had! And now I know why Glimmer said our other daughter was called Best Princess!”

Best Princess, Catra mused as she kept fighting. Those two words had sounded like poison but a day ago; but now, with some good sleep and better adrenaline...

They sounded like they fit her again.

Later she might revert to feeling like shit, but right now? She felt like Catra of Brightmoon, *She-Ra* of Brightmoon. Not... not Catra of the Apocalypse, not She-Ra of Armageddon, the way she had felt ever since she found out what the Sword really was.

...Hell, I've done good with it for four years now. And I changed my nature. Maybe the Sword can, too.

Incredible what a little sleep could do for a person... and a bit of combat.e.

Shit, I should send Entrapta a present, she thought, as she casually knocked out another former countryman of hers. *Right after I slap her.*

...And maybe hug her.

Because Entrapta made her heart ache; Entrapta, who had betrayed Catra for *love,* which Catra alone of all Etherians might truly understand. Catra had almost had to choose, just a night ago, between the love of her life and her family and friends, saved only by Frosta's vote; but no force could save Entrapta's love, he was already dead. All she had left was her vengeance... and it was vengeance against *Adora,* which Catra could never forgive, not if she managed it. If she killed her Adora, then Catra would kill her, she had no question about that. Simple cause and effect.

...And for all that, Catra could not *hate* her. Kill her if she killed Adora, yes. If she failed to kill Adora? Then Catra wanted to slap her for being a Silver-damned fool, and yell at her for risking *so much* for her revenge, and shake her until she *understood* just how much was on the line...

But never hate. In her deepest heart, Catra could not bring herself to hate her.

(After all, Catra has seen the pictures, now, seen what Dr. Blankfort wanted her to see- the pain her love has caused- and yet all she can hope for is a future, however impossible it seems in this moment, with her and Adora, in love and happy and *together.* Of all Etheria's many inhabitants, Catra knew best what it was like to be guided solely by love.)

All that mattered today was making sure they got to the goddamn Garnet, and kept Scorpia away... they'd figure out what to do with Entrapta and the Heart later. Just stop *this,* right now, and they'd have all the time in the world to figure out where to go from here...

The Sword'll still be good, and Entrapta can make up for this, and we'll fix it, Catra swore to herself as she leapt over a few Hordesmen, surprising them- and then laying them out with swift hilt strikes from behind. *I'm the Best Princess, I can do this.*

Nothing had to change, if they could stop Scorpia from getting to the Garnet. She could keep her family, her friends, every good thing that has happened to her since she found the Sword that long-ago day.

If she could only do this...

And I can do this.

One last strike finished the group of Hordesmen they'd been fighting. Catra was about to turn around to her family, see if they were alright- but before she could say anything, yet more came running into the area, most likely drawn by the noise.

So Catra turned, ready to fight- but there was no need. This group was a small group, and a ray of sparkling light lanced through them even as Catra watched, burning the front row and making them stumble- the second row fell on them, tripping. A follow-up wave of darkness fell on the clumsy, cluttered soldiers, darkness so pregnant with sleep that when it hit them, they all passed out as one.

A single Hordesman in that group, at the very back, was spared, and tried to run- but a perfectly-thrown rock caught her in the back of the head and put her down.

Catra turned an impressed look back at her family; her mom was nodding at her handiwork, whereas Micah next to her was smacking his hands together twice in the universal "got it" motion. Flutterina, her squire, mimicked him, knocking rock dust off of her palms.

"Not bad!" the King said. "And good throw, kid!"

"Thanks!" Flutterina responded.

"And you too, Angie!" he said, smiling at his beloved wife. "You haven't lost your touch!"

And her mom *blushed,* looking at Micah through half-lidded eyes as though he held all her answers.

Catra couldn't help the smile on her face.

I can do this alone, but I don't have to. I have help.

(And this is the greatest and smallest of all miracles; that Catra, ever outcast, now had kith and kin both, more than just Adora alone.)

“That's all of them,” Catra said. “For now, at least.”

“ Are you alright, Catra?” Angella asked, shaking off her blush to make sure her daughter was alright. “You did most of the fighting.”

“ Oh, it's nothing,” Catra replied with a casual shrug, feeling cool and heroic- feeling *right,* the way she hadn't in way too long. “Fighting the Horde is what I *do.* So I'm fine.”

“More than fine! She’s a hell of a fighter!” Micah announced with a laugh. “You raised her well, honey!”

Angela smiled, and Catra felt a warm feeling inside at Micah's praise.

Maybe having a dad won't be so bad.

“Our daughter *is* a magnificent fighter,” Angella said, “though I can’t claim credit for that. Catra came to me- how do the children put it? Rather... ‘badass’.”

Catra tried not to laugh. She really, *really* did.

But hearing her mother say “badass” in her posh accent- and with that *pause* right beforehand, like she was trying to recall the word- was almost too much; Catra could barely hold it in.

But then Catra glanced at Flutterina, who was *also* trying not to laugh, face contorted and cheeks puffed out with her hands clamped to her mouth, and that was it, Lord Laugh knocked down Catra's walls. She burst out laughing and Flutterina did too.

“ What? Mom, *no,*” Catra said, laughing despite... everything. “ No, no, d-don't- don't say that. You sound ridiculous.”

“I'm allowed to use slang!” Angella protested. “There's nothing wrong with me saying 'badass'!”

“Oh no, you said it again,” Catra said, still laughing, helplessly failing to fight her giggles. She felt a little bad laughing at her mom, but it was just so... *ridiculous.* Her mind tried to think of other things that would *also* be very silly coming from her mother,

and she resolutely resisted, because otherwise she'd never stop laughing.

(And maybe it was nice to get the tension out. Being here, seeing the *Horde* at *war* with itself... it was just so *wrong...* and she'd been under so much pressure. It was good to laugh.)

Micah chuckled, too, though more at seeing Catra laughing than anything else.

"Oh this is *fun,* I missed this!" the survivor mage said. "Fighting, and family, and other people... Silver, I missed- *everything.* It's good that the first day I'm back, I get to have family time, even if we're also going to war... still better than the Island!"

That was a bit of a sobering thought, and Catra clung to it to get over her giggles and get back to business.

" Okay!" Catra said, clapping her hands. "Fun's fun, but we gotta get moving. First- anybody else hurt? I'm fine, like I said."

"I'm alright," Angella responded with a pout that was *also* very funny looking, but Catra conquered the next wave of giggles with considerable effort. Flutterina did so by turning away from the Queen, though her shaking shoulders indicated she was also fighting back laughter. "A bit put out that I've *apparently* been barred from certain words, but otherwise alright."

“I'm sure you'll survive, dear,” Micah said, patting his wife on the back before turning to Catra. “If we're hurt, what do we have on hand to fix it?”

“Damn-near-everything!,” Flutterina said before Catra could get a word in edgewise, whipping back to the group with her giant backpack flying back and forth from her enthusiasm. “I've got bandages, ointment, painkillers, some First Ones tech I bargained for that probably does stuff, and just about anything you might need! Got all kinds of shit in here!”

“You cursing in that cutesy voice is odd,” Catra commented as Micah leaned his staff on a nearby wall and raised his hands, palms up, at the Lunoth.

“Don't you ban her from certain words too!” Angella commented.

“Okay, mom,” Catra demurred, grinning.

“ I could use some ointment on my hands, and maybe bandages,” Micah said, ignoring the byplay between mother and daughter. “ When we teleported in I fell a bit, caught myself on my hands and skinned the shit out of them. Wouldn't mind a little ointment, Ms. Flutterina!”

“Is Ms. the word for a squire? I thought a squire got called Dame?” Flutterina asked as she took off her backpack and started rummaging through it.

“You're a squire?” Micah asked.

“Yep!” Flutterina said. “I'm Catra's!”

“She is?” Angella said, turning to Catra.

“Err, yeah,” Catra said, awkwardly put on the spot. “She wanted to be, so I told her she was. I... wasn't sure how to do it the right way...?”

But Angella didn't yell at her for doing it wrong, as some part of Catra had irrationally feared from all her years under Shadow Weaver; no, her mother just smiled, easing Catra's anxieties.

“There'll be time for that later,” she reassured her daughter. “If you want her as your squire, and she wants to *be* your squire, that's enough for now. We'll go over the rituals and the formalities when we get back.”

“Good,” Catra breathed with a sigh of relief, and Flutterina beamed, fluttering her wings happily.

“ Though that's a rather old tradition, not one we do much these days...” Angella said. “Interesting to see it return.”

“Is it?” Flutterina said. “ Down in Elberon we thought you guys did this still...”

“We do,” Angella said. “It's just not very common these days. Though then again, neither were tuxedos, until Catra wore one to the Princess Prom and singlehandedly revived them...”

“She did?” Micah said. “Oh thank fuck and the Silver, I loved tuxedos but they were so out of style when I was king. I look like shit in a dress.”

“Maybe you'll revive the squire thing too!” Flutterina cheered.

“I might,” Catra said. “ I didn't mean to revive tuxedos, after all, and still did it- so yeah, chances are good.”

“Also,” Angella leaned in, “ Dame is the title for *knights,* not squires. Squires are still using the junior titles- Mr., Ms., and Mx. Or the newer title, which is just M, that I must admit to being fond of. Takes a lot of guesswork out of the question.”

“Aww, I wanted to be Dame,” Flutterina said, shaking her head as she removed ointment and bandages from her backpack. “Well, I guess I can wait for full knighthood for that. Now, back to work!”

She turned to Micah with great determination on her adorable little face.

“Show-me-your-hands!” she ordered imperiously in her squeaky voice.

(Catra did not laugh, but it was a *very* close thing.)

“Okay!” Micah agreed cheerfully. “Nice to have someone *else* patch up my wounds for once...”

Flutterina rather quickly and efficiently wiped Micah's hands, dabbed them with ointment, and wrapped bandages around it.

“Huh, you're good at that,” Micah observed.

“Well, I'm real fast, and sometimes physics and friction don't like that!” Flutterina responded, though a bit slower than normal; her focus on Micah's wounds was lowering her usual patter from blistering speed to her just talking kind of fast. “I run into stuff a lot or skin my knees or one time I hit a door going at a pretty good clip and busted my lip! At the orphanage, they took care of me, but they got worried I'd get hurt when I was away from them because I was always running around in places I shouldn't be, so they taught me how to fix myself up! And I needed to do it... a lot! I used to be real clumsy! Still kinda am when I'm not paying attention!”

“Practical,” Catra commented approvingly. That fit both her sensibilities, the Hordesman pragmatism and the Brightmoon desire to help.

“It is!” Flutterina said, smiling at the praise from her idol as she finished. “Aaaaaand-done! First-King-I've-worked-on!”

“Well, you *are* the squire of royalty now, so I bet you'll get lots more chances! Wait, that means I'm expecting all of us to get hurt,” Micah mused, momentarily lost in his own thoughts. “That's bad. Hopefully you *never* get a chance to work on us?... that sounds rude, though.”

“ Alright, enough already you two,” Catra said, aware that they'd wasted time enough. “ If that's all, let’s keep going. Black Garnet’s this way!”

She lead them down a side alley she knew of, one that skirted most places Hordak- and therefore Shadow Weaver- had watched in her childhood. She well knew the way; the location was burned into her mind. The Garnet’s chamber was the one place even rule-breaking, law-defying Catra had known better than to intrude upon. Thank the Silver for Shadow Weaver’s cruel strictness, she supposed.

Or should I say Thank Saz? Catra idly wondered as they went through the streets. *I’m a Magicat, after all.*

(That felt nice to think, in a way. Not as nice as having friends and family, and it was definitely bittersweet- tinged with the acid

sadness of knowing that, whoever baby Catra *could* have been, she would never *be* that person, that it was lost with her kidnapping... but there was sweetness there, too. It was good, to know she had a *people,* that in addition to Brightmoon, there was another place that the eternal outcast could claim as home, a miracle to one shunned and cut off from the society of her childhood.)

The sound of more combat distracted her from such religious musings. She held a finger to her lips to indicate the need for quiet, and the group slipped around an armor factory, moving silently- especially Micah. Catra strained to hear him, but try as she might, Catra couldn't hear the man move. Beast Island was apparently a good place to learn how to be sneaky… or get eaten.

(No wonder Micah was so cracked; it was a wonder he'd been able to stay even *semi*-sane in such a hellhole.)

Once they were all in position, Catra peeked around the side, holding up one hand to keep her family in safety.

What she saw made her stomach turn.

Hordesmen, killing Hordesmen…

The two sides of what was apparently the Horde's civil war had met here- by accident or by design was impossible to tell at this point- and they were fighting. One was a small assortment of Horde bots and Hordesmen with Adora's dragon scratched out, leaving only Hordak's bat wings, fighting a group of troopers who

still had Adora’s full regalia on. The fight was taking place in a small clearing between the Fright Zone’s close-packed buildings, and Catra and her people were to the “side” of the fight, unnoticed by the combatants. Flames roared as Adora's faithful set their foes aflame; the sickening crunch of bones as the rebel Hordesmen struck back, with the singing lasers of the bots backing them up.

She took the sight in with a sick stomach.

It was just... wrong.

Even as a traitor, as one who had never believed in the Horde like others did... it still bothered Catra. She'd lacked Adora’s fervent faith, which had finally burned out and destroyed her, the way Catra had always feared it would; she'd even lacked the general Hordesman’s faith in their cause. Catra had fallen through too many cracks in their society to believe in its ideals.

But even so, she felt a moment’s nausea, seeing this thing that should *not* be happening.

… *This isn't my fight,* she reminded herself. Even if she felt an urge to intervene, if every Brightmoon part of her soul wanted to assist, if every drop of Horde left in her wanted to get them to just **stop**, to put an end to this thing that should not be. *And even if it was... the Garnet is the thing that matters. If it goes online, all of these people die... and so do more people than any of us can even comprehend.*

Her heart ached, even as she knew her head was right. None of this would matter if Scorpia reached the Garnet, and even beyond that, she didn't know which side to support, or even *why* this fight was happening at all. A fight between Adora's faithful and someone else, that was easy enough to guess from the scratched-out symbols... but anything more? No, she couldn't parse that out.

She had too many questions, none of which she could ask of people actively fighting and dying, to interfere her and know which was right.

So, shaking her head, wishing she could just make them *stop,* and knowing that even the Best Princess couldn't, she waved her family on, slipping down a side alley she used to use to avoid Shadow Weaver, heading ever towards the Garnet and whatever she would find there, as the Horde committed suicide by civil war.

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At least I'm not in the sewers this time.

That was the thought that wound through Mermista's head as she and that Magicat Queen, Orwall, made their way through the Fright Zone.

And that wasn't a small point in favor of this raid, honestly speaking! Sure, Mermista's powers had automatically cleansed the water touching her, so she hadn't absorbed any of the absolutely *staggering* varieties of poisonous fluids, toxic chemicals, and nameless gods alone knew what other things were down there...

But they hadn't stopped the *smell.* She hadn't been able to eat for a few days after that first raid, not until she'd bathed enough to get the stench out of her nose.

...Not that war smells much better, she thought, as they passed a group of corpses, and she saw Orwall's face wrinkle up. Mermista could smell it, too- blood, and bile, and shit. While not everyone voided their bowels when they died, enough did that it was a pretty consistent scent around corpses.

This area stank- and that was to Mermista's own, minor sense of smell. She knew Catra had a greater sense of smell, and apparently it was a shared Magicat trait, given Orwall's facial expressions. Greater senses were *not* the best thing to have in a warzone.

Doesn't help that the corpses are mostly kids, either.

They were, too- kids with Adora's dragon squiggle between Hordak's batwings. A few of the corpses were older, and they almost universally had scratched out Adora's little flame. A civil war? Hell of a time for the Horde to have one.

A... *suspicious* time for the Horde to have one. Maybe sheer good luck, but Mermista was a dyed-in-the-wool pessimist, and she only believed in coincidence when it was trying to ruin her day. This... something stank about this, more than the dead did.

But as they rounded a corner, they found a wounded Hordesman, an older man who still had Adora's dragon on him. He was clutching his side, red dripping slowly between his fingers, and talking into a comm.

"Squads- squads dead," he said. "Kids took them down but they took twice as many- fucking- the traitors murdered so many- they were recruits! Kids!... Can anyone hear me on this goddamn thing?"

He looked up then, finally noticing them.

"Aww, fuck me," he said. "Goddamn Princesses, too? You in league with Grizzlor's traitorous filth?"

He tried to rise up, or reach for his weapon, but Orwall quickly ran forward and stole his gun from where he'd put it down to pick up his communicator. He looked at her with a very disgruntled expression, which would actually be *really* funny under any other circumstances. They were both still for a long minute, long enough for it to be awkward, before he finally broke the silence.

"...Well, you gonna shoot me, or just stand there?" he asked Orwall, who looked genuinely conflicted.

And that made Mermista's strategic mind spill over with an *idea.*

"We're not here to fight the Horde," the wavelord told him. "Far from it. We're here on something else. What's going on here?"

"...You shitting me?" the old man said. "I was here for both of the last two raids. Nothing *good* ever comes of Princesses in the Fright Zone."

"Today it does," Mermista said, and went up to him, reaching into her belt for a Plumerian painkiller potion. She knelt beside him, leaning on her trident for support as she reached out with a tiny bottle of black fluid. "Want some painkiller? My name's Mermista. What's yours?"

The old man looked at her like she'd gone mad; Orwall joined him. But as she'd hoped it would, the sheer social convention of telling people your name when asked- such a small and basic, everyday thing- forced it out of him.

"...Hiron," he said, regarding the potion in her outstretched hand with suspicion. "...And I can't really stop you if you want to kill me, so fuck it, hand me your goddamned drink. If I'm lucky it's pure poison."

He took a swig, and sighed as the cooling solution flowed through him.

"...Fuck, I recognize the taste," he said. "Black Nightmare flowers. Hell of a strong painkiller. We've been fighting over those from the raids the last few weeks- they don't make many of them, but by God, those are good."

"Glad to help," Mermista said. "I've got a few other things to help you- bandages and the like- if you'll let me. Don't know much medical stuff but I'm a soldier, I've got the first aid down."

(Which was true, and not for the first time, Mermista was grateful that Salineas made sure its Princesses went through the same training their volunteers did.)

"...Okay, why you helping?" Hiron asked. "You're not Catra. I've heard enough stories to know she tries not to kill people. Won't stop that fucking archer she knows from killing people or that other Princess from punching skulls in, but Catra, traitor that she is, spares people sometimes. You don't, though. You drown'em."

"Or stab'em," Mermista said, tapping her trident. "But right now, we're not here to fight the Horde. We're here to save Etheria, and that includes you."

"...Alright, this is so fucking weird that I'll at least listen," the man said. "Today's been a day of fucking insanity anyway. Grizzlor goes

fucking rogue, comms are down, the Bots all joined him...”

“Grizzlor's one of your commanders, right?” Orwall said, finally finding her tongue after her shock. “We heard of him in Halfmoon... he's one of your oldest officers.”

“And until this morning, I'd have said he was pure loyal,” Hiron grunted. “But now... goddamn fool. I'd heard he was talking to some of the others, but this... I thought he'd lodge a protest or something, not... not *this.* He's killed the kids...”

The old man's face was haunted a moment, before he looked back at Mermista.

“But you had a story to tell,” he said.

“A fast one,” she agreed. “You remember Scorpia?”

“Traitor that Adora sent to Beast Island?” he said. “Yeah, what about her? She should be dead.”

“She's not,” Mermista said. “She's being helped by Entrapta and Shadow Weaver to get to the Garnet.

“A fucking carnival of traitors,” Hiron said. “Add Grizzlor to the pile- and Catra too, I guess. Though at least *she* turned her coat on us before she was ever a soldier, she was still a recruit, a kid... and Shadow Weaver hurt her a lot, I've heard. Can't blame her too bad for that.”

“You're the most reasonable Hordesman I've ever met,” Mermista replied. “But those three are trying to get Scorpia to the Garnet. She reaches the Black Garnet, for a *bunch* of reasons too complicated to go into right now, we *all* die- Alliance and Horde and everyone else, dead as dust.”

“...Fuck,” the old soldier responded. “Yeah, with Shadow Weaver involved... I can see it. Never *did* trust that wicked bitch.”

“So...” Mermista said. “You want to stop that?”

“...Fuck it,” Hiron said. “This is too absurd to lie about. None of that makes *any* fucking sense... and I'm old enough now to realize that usually means it's the truth. Lies, they gotta be *sensible.* People gotta *believe* in a *lie.* But truth? Truth don't give a fuck about your beliefs. Truth just *is.* So... I guess you're gonna have to patch me up, Princess. I got some authority; not a Force Captain, but I *did* train half these young whippersnappers. I might be able to get them to listen to me, keep the *real* Horde from fighting you... but I expect you to help the kids out with the goddamn traitors, okay? Fairs' fair.”

“That sounds pretty doable!” Orwall answered. “Given the, err, apocalypse we're trying to prevent.”

“Having to side with enemies against traitors,” the old man said as he moved to reveal his side. The wound was a long cut, but it looked shallow at first glance- a real bleeder, but otherwise not that bad. Mermista popped another ointment, also Plumerian, out of her pocket, and smeared it on the wound to keep it clean. “...Enemies are better than traitors, though. An enemy's honest, at least.”

His mouth was still open, about to say more, when Orwall suddenly shoved Mermista to the side; as she fell, Mermista saw the bolt hit the Magicat queen in the back, a laser shot she recognized from long years of fighting the machines that used them. Though Mermista's quick glance as she rolled back to a standing position didn't reveal any bots, she couldn't see anything around her but empty streets.

“Samoflange!” the Queen cursed in her language as she pitched forward, back of her armor red-hot, though it seemed to have blunted the attack. Orwall dropped Hiron's gun as she fell, and the old man- in a stunt Mermista barely believed- caught the gun on the way down, turned it rightside up, and aimed a few shots at what looked like empty air.

A Hordebot exploded where he shot- an *invisible* Hordebot.

Fuck, Mermista thought.

“What the hell?!?” Orwall shouted as she rolled over, staggering back to her feet as well- apparently she'd never fought the invisible ones. Mermista found the nearest manholes- two of them, thank the nameless gods, she needed the ammo- and summoned the filthy water into a shield, one that was made none too soon- more bots were pouring in, all invisible, all trying to break her shield with their shots.

The filthy water's own corruption helped them, then, because Mermista flung some water around, and the filth clung to the bots when it landed, revealing the... *very* large group of them that was incoming.

“Princesses! Over here!” came a voice from around one street corner, because of *course* the gigantic swarm of invisible robots was being accompanied by *actual* Hordesmen, too. Orwall threw a freezefire at the first guy to make an appearance, and his frozen form fell, but more were pouring in even as he collapsed. They had scratched out symbols on their chests, a thing that Hiron saw too, and he started shooting to assist.

Fuck, Mermista thought, and then there was no more time for anything but battle.

(And far away, Light Hope nodded her head; crisis averted. There would be no truce between any Horde faction and the Alliance today; and the plan would proceed. All she needed was time, time and distraction, time and distraction enough to get Scorpia where she had to go... and the Doom Balloon was almost there.)

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“So... okay, Perfuma's coming in as a giant monster,” Frosta said. “That's... that's something we'll have to deal with, I guess. But she's not here yet?”

“No,” Peekablue said. “She's moving fast, but she's not here yet. I say... maybe half an hour? Sorry, it's a bit vague on distance, and I don't know the landscape around here well enough to make a really good guess. She's a ways out, to the extent that helps.”

“Okay... then first things first,” Frosta decided. “I'd like to have other Princesses on hand- I can probably take on Perfuma, plants don't like the cold, but I've heard enough stories about Plumerian Princesses to want some backup. Where's Glimmer?”

“That's not a bad idea,” Sweet Bee agreed. “Let's do that. If we have to fight a Plumerian Princess- even Perfuma- I'd rather have backup.”

The soldier looked a bit... uncomfortable at the idea of fighting Perfuma... and hadn't Frosta heard, briefly, in the rush to prepare for teleporting, that Sweet Bee had a fight with Perfuma right before she left?

Oof. Awkward, Frosta thought. *Gutsy, though.*

“Okay,” Peekablue said, concentrating a moment. “Glimmer is with that archer- Bow?- they're pretty far away from us... Catra's closer, she's with the Brightmoon royal couple and that pink kid- but there's something nasty near them? Feels like fire... also I still can't believe Micah's alive, but that's a separate thing... Oh! Mermista's pretty nearby!”

“She is?” Frosta asked.

“Yes, but she's not doing well,” Peekablue said. “ Looks like she's under attack. And there are others near her, too, and they're heading her way- her boyfriend, Castaspella of Mystacor, and the Red Knight. They're also being followed by some heavy artillery... they're going to need rescuing too, even after they help Mermista.”

“Well, that makes the decision easy,” Frosta said. “Let's go save'em.”

She turned to speak to her cousin, who was chatting up the short Andreenid guy who'd taken that wound in the leg.

“Chilla,” she said. “Can you manage controlling the ice sled for him? I already made it, so you just have to control it, should be easier.”

“I can,” Chilla said.

“Good,” Frosta replied. Most frost mages couldn't make ice as abundantly as Frosta could, but commanding already-made ice was easier... for some reason. Mages would know, they had notebooks and explanations for *everything*. Frosta had always been encouraged to spend more time mastering her “natural abilities” instead of reading the works of others- *your bloodline will teach you,* her handlers had claimed.

...Which probably means I should read those books, honestly.

But war was first, so she shelved that thought.

“Let's get rolling then,” Frosta said, and they took off to Mermista's location, Peekablue- and that soldier woman- leading the way.

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Man, I hope Catra gets here soon, Mermista thought to herself. *Or… literally anyone. We’re getting overwhelmed.*

The three of them were beat to shit, to put it bluntly. While her water shield, still up, had dulled the edge of the attacks against them and kept most of their enemies back, a few stray shots had gotten through, as had a concentrated charge by a group of very determined Hordesmen. Mermista had a busted lip and what was

going to be a *hell* of a black eye, Orwall was nursing a busted hand, and Hiron had *started* the fight with a cut in his side and now was missing a tooth as well.

Still, they were all acquitting themselves well, in Mermista's opinion. Orwall was flinging freezing fire with her remaining hand and keeping on her toes, while Hiron- who had what was apparently a limitless number of bullets for his gun- was shooting, reloading, and shooting in a rhythm so steady you could set a watch to it. For non-Princesses, they were doing better than most; only Bow and her own Sea Hawk had ever done better, and that was fine company to stand beside indeed.

(Briefly, she wondered where her own sweet Sea Hawk had went, and hoped he was okay.)

But numbers always told, except against the mightiest Princesses, and Mermista wasn't exactly the strongest Princess who'd ever lived. Honestly she was kinda sub-standard, as Pearl Princesses went; she was no Lapis, which was both a good and a bad thing.

Good, in that she was not a traitor to Salineas' highest ideals, nor in a fucked-up dom/sub relationship or whatever the hell Lapis had been in with her general Jasper; hard to imagine a relationship more fucked up, one that had ended with Jasper strangling Lapis out of paranoia, murdering her own best weapon, leaving herself vulnerable to the Salinean Rebels who had stood against her unlawful reign.

(The most fucked up part? Lapis was by *far* the more powerful person in the relationship, and could have easily stopped Jasper, who was a normal human... which meant that she had to have *allowed* Jasper to kill her. Thinking of what could drive a person to just *let* that happen to them had kept Mermista up a few nights...

and reading Lapis' records in the Logbook had not helped. Lapis had been dead inside long before her body stopped breathing.)

Bad, because she lacked Lapis' terrifying power, which she could *really* use right about now.

Even as she had the thought, she heard a familiar voice sing out.

"Attacking my sweet love-lobster? Have at you!"

(And just *hearing* his voice made her spirit leap in her chest, because for all her dour cynicism, somehow a pirate captain had wormed his way into her soul, like a benevolent infection, warming her cold heart with the silly fire of his true self.)

Sea Hawk, in his usual fashion, was coming in swinging, his sword singing as he slashed his way through the Hordebots. Whatever his First Ones sword was made out of- hadn't Bow suggested, once, that it was a tool for geological surveys, or something?- it sliced through metal like hot knives through butter, though flesh resisted it much better.

That problem was handled by his compatriot, the Red Knight, who was wielding a great black shield and a massive spear.

"Surrender and you will live," the Red Knight said in loud and calm tones. "Fight, and you will die."

“Fuck you and all your kind!” a Hordesman screamed, and she charged the Knight.

“You were warned,” the Knight responded calmly, and with a single blow of his spear burst the Hordesman's chest plate and killed her.

“Mermista!” said the last person- Glimmer's aunt from Mystacor, Castaspella, who threw a big blast into the crowd of enemies. In the moment's peace that earned them, she ran into the bubble of water, Mermista letting her through without resistance. “Are you quite alright?”

“We're breathing,” Mermista said. “Can you heal up Orwall and Hiron?”

“...I assume Hiron is the Hordesman?” Mermista said, quirking an eyebrow at the unusual partnership.

“Yeah,” Hiron responded. “I'm working with these two against the traitors. You gonna gawk or heal me?”

“I'll do both,” Castaspella snarked, weaving her spells. “Orwall, Mermista- this will heal you two as well. Mostly it recovers stamina, though- it won't heal deep wounds. Just gives energy, mostly.”

“I'll take it,” Orwall said, breathing hard. “More fighting than I've ever been involved in... some energy would be nice.”

“Heh, we used to use this spell on long nights to substitute for coffee,” Castaspella reminisced. “Never figured it'd be valuable in a fight...”

“God I wish I had coffee,” Hiron grumbled as he reloaded his gun.

Seeing that things were going well in the bubble, Mermista turned her attention to the two allies still outside it. The bots and Hordesmen were much diminished now, but they were still there.

“Sea Hawk, Red Knight!” Mermista yelled to the two outside her watery bubble. “Get inside here, kill anyone who gets in! You're unshielded out there!”

“Good idea, my sweet,” Sea Hawk said as he leapt onto a bot, stabbed it with a downward flourish, and then leapt off the exploding machine, propelled by the blast; the bizarre maneuver not only surprised his enemies, but let him land neatly inside his lover's watery shield without trouble.

(Privately, that was how Mermista figured Sea Hawk had survived all this war; he was just so *bizarre* compared to most people that no one knew what the hell he was going to do, and chaotic unpredictability was the only strategy against which there was no consistent defense.)

“Agreed,” the Red Knight said, lumbering rather more heavily into the protection. Their armor turned aside a few shots; Blackmoor didn't make any *bad* armor, and the Red Knight had stuff that was good by *their* standards. “I am sorry to report that we were being followed- there are more enemies behind us.”

As if summoned by those words, they heard the heavy rumble of Horde AttackTraks, and the mechanical clank of yet *more* Hordebots. Even the gleam of Castaspella's magic, rejuvenating her, didn't stop the dread in Mermista's stomach.

“Oh for fuck's sake,” Mermista said, as the first one rounded the corner.

****

“There's the Salinean Princess,” Chilla commented to Frosta as they peered around a corner. Mermista's little group was... doing okay, but clearly were not in the best position, nor in the best of health. Everyone looked ragged and exhausted, and they were under heavy siege; a very large vehicle was trying to ram down Mermista's water shield, and was accompanied by a swarm of Hordebots and Hordesmen who were trying to slip in under the shield whenever Mermista had to divert water to stop the tank.

Mermista's group were still fighting- and Frosta could feel the cold from the cat-woman, kin of her own ice, as she threw the freezing fire into the crowd- but it was a losing proposition. Castaspella was using magic to make a shield, too, but it was clear they'd soon be mobbed to death. The Hordsemen knew it, too- some were already cheering, particularly the drivers of the big vehicle, announcing with gleeful bloodthirst the soon-to-be death of the Princesses before them.

Shame they've celebrated a bit too early, Frosta thought with a vicious smile.

"I got a plan," the Andreenid woman said.

"What is it?" Frosta asked.

"We circle around real quick," Sweet Bee suggested. "Won't take ten seconds, but lets us get behind them. We'll crush them against us and the shields."

"Hammer and anvil," Chilla responded. "A classic tactic. Good idea."

"Classics are called that for a reason," Sweet Bee said.

"Okay," Frosta agreed with a shrug. "You're the military leader here. Let's get to it."

They swung around a backstreet, moving quick; it really did take only a few seconds, with no resistance, a thing Sweet Bee commented on.

“Looks like Princess Mermista drew the attention of… literally everyone in the area,” she said. “Wonder what she did that pissed them off so much. There’s not even any bots wandering around.”

“She’s a Princess, they’re Horde,” Frosta remarked. “Reason enough.”

That made the Andreenid captain Sweet Bee look a bit green around the gills, but Frosta ignored it. Whatever was going on there, they’d deal with it later.

(Her brain also briefly wondered if *green around the gills* was a Sea Elf expression that everyone else had picked up; they were the only gill-bearing sentients, as far as she knew… something else to read about, maybe. Damn, she was going to be *stuck* in a library after this.)

On hearing their byplay, the blue Peek guy paused a moment, hand in his pocket- he did that a lot- as they got into position.

“Well, that’s not entirely true, honey… there *is* something nearby,” he said. “Couple of someones. But they feel… odd. One’s bright, the other shadowy... power concentrated in one, spread out in the other. It... it doesn't feel like anything I've ever sensed before... and I can't tell how close they are. Near, I know that, but I can't tell if that means a few feet or a couple of city blocks.”

“ Then we keep rolling,” Sweet Bee said, apparently getting over whatever had bothered her a moment before. “I don't like the sounds of *any* of that. We get the Princess and her entourage,

and we get *out* of here before whatever you're seeing catches up to us. Our goal's the Garnet, after all, not to fight every freak in the Fright Zone."

"True," Frosta said, as they got in position. "We ready?"

"On 3, cousin?" Chilla asked her; and that was still annoying, but Frosta found it wasn't as bad anymore. Maybe because Chilla had stayed, after Modulok and Bron had both left; Frosta would think about it later. For now…

"You count," she grunted, and Chilla nodded.

"1… 2…" Chilla said in Mountainflower, and everyone got ready to fight. Sweet Bee and her Andreenids took aim at vulnerable troops in the back, Chilla herself readied a spell or two, and Frosta…

Frosta cracked her knuckles, gathered the cold around herself, and took aim at the big vehicle.

(Peekablue notably seemed to be readying himself to hide from the fight to come, and dodge any stray shots. Man knew his limits.)

"3!"

The others attacked, but Frosta was busy concentrating on one big blast of ice, freezing an entire line of Hordesmen solid as the flurry passed them by to slam straight into the AttackTrak, the cheering troops frozen mid-fist pump as the vehicle ground to a sudden halt. The engine, overheated from their prior efforts, immediatley shattered apart when subjected to below-zero temperatures, and the whole thing cracked and crashed to pieces near instantaneously.

That hit basically ended things. Mermista, seizing the chance, turned her watery shield into a hammer, slamming it onto the crowd; while that didn't do *that* much damage, apparently Mermista was too tired to do much more, it distracted them from the onrush from both sides. The Red Knight and Sea Hawk worked together sifting heads and bots respectively, the Magicat and Chilla's freezing rays took down more people, the poisoned shots of the Andreenids crippled whomever they did not kill, and Castaspella capped things off with a blast of wind that sent the last few troopers flying.

(Even Peekablue got a shot in with his dagger, having popped out of the shadows to attack someone coming at Sweet Bee, nailing them in the throat.)

Soon, the Alliance and their Rebel allies stood uncontested among a field of the dead.

A hell of a lot of them, too, Frosta thought, looking at the corpses all around. Mermista had done a *shitton* of fighting here.

"Hey Mermista," Frosta said as she walked over to the Salinean. Mermista was leaning against Sea Hawk, and talking to a

Hordesman...?

“Hey,” the exhausted Salinean said, waving one hand briefly at Frosta. “Thanks for the rescue.”

“You're welcome,” Frosta said. “Not like we don't all owe each other from time to time. You can just put it on my tab.”

“Your tab?” Mermista answered with a tired almost-smile, and given her dour nature, Frosta had to count that as a beaming grin from anyone else.

(In her head, Frosta, recalling that it had been Mermista who had first tried to warn her about her “handlers”- a debt that Frosta was happy to repay. It hadn’t been enough by itself- she’d needed the extra push of talking to Queen Angella too- but Mermista was the one to put the idea in her head first, and Frosta owed her that.)

Behind them, the Andreenids were being checked over by Sweet Bee, and Chilla was talking to Tike, who seemed to be charming the warpriest quite efficiently- and Frosta wasn't gonna think about that, so she turned to the last Hordesman standing.

“So who's the Hordesman?” Frosta asked.

“This is Hiron,” Mermista said. “He's one of Adora's. These guys- there's a civil war going on. Adora on one side, and a Force

Captain named Grizzlor's leading the other side. Hiron's agreed to help us get to the Garnet and maybe keep Adora's side off our backs...”

“Good,” Peekablue said as he approached. “Perfuma's coming, and she's in a giant warplant that's like if a bunch of snakes and scorpions had a baby. We don't have much time...”

“Nameless gods, did *not* need to hear that,” Mermista said, leaning hard on Sea Hawk, whose irrepressible nature meant he was the only member of his group that didn't seem ready to fall over. Even the Red Knight was moving a bit less crisply than Frosta had seen before, a quiet kind of tiredness.

“My poor sweet love-lobster,” Sea Hawk said, holding her up. “Castaspella said that she should be able to energize us again shortly, so it will take but a moment, dear.”

“Why are you calling me a lobster?” Mermista asked him.

“Lobsters can live forever! Like our love!” Sea Hawk announced, and Mermista rolled her eyes at him.

“Remind me to kill him later,” she asked Frosta.

“No, he's way too funny,” Frosta said. “Love-lobster- heh! But anyway, don't worry- I'll take care of fighting Perfuma. I'm not

nearly as hurt as you are, and I think killing cold will do better against plants than water.”

“Amazing,” Mermista sighed in her grumbling tones. “I'll do what I can to assist- summon water you can turn into ice. I know you don't *need* it, but it makes it easier to use what's there, right? You'll need every edge to fight Perfuma.”

“Yeah,” Frosta said.

Frosta briefly wondered if Mermista could control ice if it was formed from water. Frosta’s power was more inclusive than that- it was less power over ice, like most people assumed, and more power over *cold*- but the Pearl’s powerset seemed to overlap with the Fractal’s, at least a little.

Then again, Mermista *had* mentioned that she was fairly run-of-the-mill for a Salinean Princess, unable to perform some of their more legendary feats; so maybe *she* couldn’t, even if the Pearl’s Princesses theoretically could?

(And even more briefly, Frosta wondered how she herself stacked up against former Snows Princesses; was she as strong as Prince Haku, the Gracious Host, or perhaps even legendary Stormrage herself, the Frozen Empress? Was she one of the weaker ones? Somewhere in the middle? Her “handlers” had never really let on how strong she really was… maybe she should ask Queen Angella. She’d fought like half of them, she’d be able to give her a fair appraisal.)

“You should be feeling better... as soon as I can work up the energy to cast the spell,” Castaspella replied as she shuffled forward. Her robes were full of holes; it was more of a skirt and shirt now than a proper robe. “The magic here is fiery and dark, different than any magic I've ever felt before- and I'm too tired to fiddle with it much. Give me a moment and we'll be recovered.”

At that moment, Sweet Bee and Peekablue came over, her checking of her troops complete.

“If you're Horde... do you know where the Black Garnet is?” Sweet Bee asked Hiron. “We've mostly been trying to gather forces, but we need to get to the Garnet with Perfuma on her way.”

“We're not that far from it,” Hiron said. “Unfortunately, we probably won't have much defense on it. The Black Garnet's kind of been verboten since Shadow Weaver's defection, and it was always sort of a cursed place because the witch was there... and the last order Lord Adora gave was to commit all defense to the Spirit Ember. I doubt anyone stuck around the Garnet.”

“Spirit Ember?” Peekablue asked. “What's that?”

“The Runestone of Fire,” Hiron said. “Lord Adora's secret weapon. Normally I wouldn't tell you that, but fuck it, things have gone to such hell already... you'll probably be seeing her use it soon enough, I 'magine. And not even on you, but on the goddamn traitors.”

“Runestone of... *the story Angella told!*” Mermista breathed out. “Fuck, that's a real thing?!?”

“The fire... that's why the magic's like this...” Castaspella thought, shaking her head. “But the Spirit Ember, that's not a *real* thing...”

“Shit,” Frosta said. “Adora was bad enough *without* being a Princess.”

“She's not a Princess,” Hiron said sharply. “She's the Lord of the Horde.”

“If she has a Runestone, she's a Princess,” Sweet Bee said, snorting. “Fuck. Lord of the Horde *and* a Runestone Princess. She's everything I hate in one convenient package.”

“You hate Princesses?” Forsta said, turning to her.

“Not right now,” Peekablue interrupted. “We'll deal with all of that *later.* For now, Sir Hiron, could you lead us to the Garnet?”

“You got it,” Hiron said. “It's-”

Whatever he was going to say next was interrupted by Peekablue's tackle, the young man yelling "GET DOWN!" at the top of his lungs as he slammed into Frosta, sending him and the smaller Princess both rolling onto the ground. Frosta caught a bare glimpse of everyone else hitting the dirt, Hiron grabbing Orwall and dragging her down, in the split-second before the reason *why* Peekablue had tackled her passed right where her head had been a moment ago.

It was… a beam, of the kind Frosta had seen many times during this war, a laser... but that felt insufficient. It was a laser, yes, but in the same way that a light breeze and a hurricane were both technically winds; this laser was the king of all such things, the greatest of its kind. It was a pure white beam of energy that made no sound, no sound at all; in fact, it seemed to *deaden* all sound, murdering the vibrations in the air, leaving behind only an absence that was what a mouse might hear in the moments before an owl's talons struck.

The beam, in brilliant white glory, threw them all into black shadow as it passed where her skull had been but a moment ago; it seemed to suck in all light, rendering the world a chiaroscuro painting for a brief moment, before it slammed into a nearby building. The blade of light cut right through it, not melting the building nor crushing it, but *vaporizing* it, reducing it to less than dust.

When the blast was finished, and color and sound returend to the world, they heard grating laughter.

"Howdy Mermista!" said Force Captain Octavia, who stepped out of a nearby street alongside a squad of soldiers- soldiers who

were little more than skeletons, animated via sparks of dark magic dancing along their corpses. “Was hoping I'd get to kill you! Feels like it'd really boost my career- and I'm pretty sure the boss doesn't really *care* what happens to you! *Any* of you, for that matter- you're not her pussycat girlfriend! I'm not allowed to kill her, even though the bitch took my eye, but the *rest* of you...”

She laughed as her tentacles extended, revealing a sword in each one, and the strange stone on her eyepatch gleamed vicious white- a strange, spidery looking gem.

“They're fair game,” finished Force Captain Dreer as he stepped out of the shadows beside her. His eyes were gleaming with the black sparks that were moving the corpses around, and they circled his hands, in which he held a wand shaped like a mace. “Which is good; I have new spells to test out, and I need test subjects! But don't worry, I don't need *volunteers.*”

“Dreer?” Castaspella gasped in horror. “What have you done to yourself?”

“Ah, my old boss!” Dreer said, the black sparks flaring. “Today *is* proving fruitful. As for my new look... remember my experiments? Well, it turns out, I had *forgotten* one of the components! That's why my undead never came back! I always wondered why. Turns out I'd forgotten a single small detail. Damndest thing. Almost funny! I might be ruling Mystacor now if I hadn't simply forgotten a few words on an old scroll. But with the help of a Runestone, I remembered the *entire* scroll...”

He pointed his wand, and the black sparks from his eyes and hands lashed out in bolts of negative lightning, hitting the corpses of the Hordesmen all around, the flesh liquefying from them as the dead began to rise in jerking, halting movements like puppets viewed through a fever dream.

"To celebrate our reunion," Dreer said with a grin, "let's do an experiment! I remember how much you loved experiments, after all!"

"Ah, an experiment?" Octavia said with a laugh. "What's this one named?"

" *Can I make an undead Princess?* " Dreer said, and Octavia laughed again.

The dead rose, and both Dreer and Octavia flashed joint terrible grins as they spoke in unison.

"Let's find out!"

****

Adora moved in ashes.

The Horde fell apart around her, killing itself.

All my fault.

Rebels charged her, calling her *traitor,* each a stab in her side. She killed them as she went, moving almost mechanically, horrified by her actions even as she just...

Couldn't stop.

She couldn't stop.

She had to do it, she had to keep going, she had to keep killing her own people.

She couldn't stop.

(*You haven't been able to stop yourself since Thaymor,* whispered the dark and quiet part of her soul, the one that had saved her before the Ember, the part that she couldn't hear now, not past the hellhound's howling laughter...)

She moved towards her sister in sin, her sole comfort now. Her troops fought and died in her name, and her enemies fought and died in the name of Hordak- of the man she'd murdered to take the throne, whom she'd *always* been planning to kill, his unjust

reward for saving a child from death by exposure, once upon a time.

But she could not stop this war, either.

So she marched, and burned, and killed.

(And unbidden, she laughed, laughed, *laughed,* unaware of it at all.)

And in the midst of her personal nightmare, she stepped into an open clearing near where the Ember was held, and saw the one thing this nightmare had lacked.

Catra.

There were other people with her, coming down a street, but Adora saw nothing of them cared nothing for them thought nothing of them saw only *her,* Catra, her Catra, here in the midst of all this atrocity. There she was, the shining She-Ra, the great hero of Etheria, Adora's opposite and never-equal, who had been Good before and was Good now, whom Adora had once thought she stood above...

Only to realize that she had never, *ever* been Catra's equal, and so had spent these four years chasing after her, trying to catch up, trying to be on a level with her, once more.

Catra was here... and others, Queen Angella, and two others, probably other members of the Alliance...

Why was she here?

(*Have I finally gone mad?*)

...No, *wait.*

Suddenly the world made sense again.

Catra, here, at this time, with Grizzlor in full revolt?

There was no such coincidence.

This was a trick. A *ploy.* A *plan.*

Why else would she be here? And with Queen Angella... another raid on the Fright Zone, another attack! They must know about the Spirit Ember, they're here to destroy my Runestone! To win the war!

All the pieces fell into place immediately. Grizzlor's rebellion was timed with a Princess attack; Grizzlor might hate the Alliance as his enemy, but any true Hordesman hated *traitors* worse, and

Adora was not just a traitor but the Traitor Lord. He'd be willing to cut a deal to get rid of her.

Why, Adora would even bet money that Catra had been the mastermind behind all this. Catra was no sneering schemer, but she *was* the first noble traitor to the Horde; she was in the unique position of seeing Adora from the Horde's position and knowing who would oppose her the most. So of *course* she would be able to tell Grizzlor that Adora was a monster, was Hordak's killer, had claimed her new position not by right of succession but through murder and lies. Catra would know that Grizzlor, who was the stoutest, staunchest Hordesman who had ever lived, would be the perfect person to turn on Adora.

...Catra always was good with people, Adora thought. *Better than me, in a lot of ways... I was always so separate, so uplifted, held on a pedestal by Shadow Weaver... but Catra... she always was pretty good at manipulating others to stay alive... she* ***got*** *people. I just use my lies to hammer my way in, but she understood...*

And she's used that understanding to take the Horde out from under me.

...It felt unfair.

Which was an *absurd* thought, but as all these things raced through her skull, as this fire caught and caught and *caught,* as her mouth started to giggle in that awful way, it was all she could focus on. It wasn't *fair,* she had turned herself around since finding the Spirit Ember, she was becoming *better* than the person

she had been, and to pay for all her sins now... dammit, she'd gotten away with *everything* before now, when she didn't *care,* why would this happen now that she did? She was- she was trying to- she was trying to be better...

(*Were you?* Said the dark and quiet part of herself. *Or were you just trying to be a more efficient monster?*)

What was the *point* of all she'd tried to do, the ceasefire she'd hoped for, if she was just going to lose it all- she was never going to take her place as Catra's real enemy, never be anything at all, a failure of a First One in sin and a failure of a First One in simply being a *failure* ... Catra had outmaneuvered her and she had lost, once again.

She was *so tired* of *losing...*

Her sister's fire inside her, warm, loving, nuzzling up to her to try and bring her peace.

*...There's **one** way I am still Catra's equal.*

She gripped tight that fire, let it wash over her, and as Catra spoke, Adora just started to laugh, charging forward on a wave of glorious fire.

I can still stand with her, in this much at least.

Chapter End Notes

Hiron is from the UK POP annuals; originally he was the chief of cave dwellers who thought Hordak was a god, tricked into working his mines. Here, I've adapted the “god” element to reflect his faith in Adora, surprising in an older man such as himself; he was a miner originally in Vargon, sentenced to die in the mines for the crime of being a human and not a Satyr or Minotaur. Hordak saved him, and while the man greatly respected him, he also is a true believer that Adora is Hordak's chosen successor, and so he transferred his loyalty to her. He was big on training recruits and cadets, which is why he emphasizes with Catra more than most do, even though like most Hordesmen he has a deeply negative view of betrayal.

Black Nightmare flowers are part of a drug related storyline in He-Man, originating from Orko's dimension of Trolla. It does so here, too; while Trolla is a separate dimension like Despondos and the First Ones haven't had contact with it in centuries, the Black Nightmare ended up growing wild on Eternia as an invasive species, and the First Ones took it with them to the stars. On Etheria, it was one of the First Ones' imports to the planet, since they used it to make a variety of powerful painkillers and opiates. It was also used as an illegal drug among them, which is why it now grows wild on Etheria; while the First Ones' government was VERY careful not to let their farms and research facilities contaminate the planet they intended to take over, black market drug dealers have never been that scrupulous.

Alongside the Krytis Condors, the Black Nightmare is one of the more successful alien transplants to Etheria. It gained its name from Plumerian alchemists, since the Black Nightmare, despite its beneficial anesthetic properties, has a loooong list of downsides and drawbacks, and only very skilled Plumerian alchemists are able to make it into a brew that doesn't have the side-effects of making you puke, have horrible nightmares, or get so high you're useless. It also has a distinct taste, being a bit like root beer with a charcoal

aftertaste- that's how Hiron was able to identify it with just a sip.

Octavia's multiple swords are straight from the original series, where she uses them to hilariously put Sea Hawk in his place. The Red Knight's spear and shield is an adaptation of his lance and shield combo from the series (since lances are crappy infantry weapons if you're not mounted). Dreer's necromancy is also canon, though he had different servants there.

Step lightly, friends. Endings approach.

Chapter 63: Shadow Weaver of Herself Alone

Chapter Notes

We return!

A short chapter this time- more me warming up my Catra muscles than anything else.

A view from the Doom Balloon's last moments.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shadow Weaver of Herself Alone

This little gathering- what had Glimmer called it? A "Council of the Wise"?- had been useful, but Shadow Weaver knew it's time was coming to a rapid end.

While she'd like to claim it was because of her well-honed survival instinct- and she did have an *excellent* survival instinct, she'd never have lasted all these years without it- *this* ending didn't need a prophet to foresee. No, even a blind drunk suffering a concussion could hazard a guess at where *this* was going, if they could only hear Entrapta's muttering, the swiftly-muted alarms that came to life and died in moments on her panel as her hair, spinning wildly, shut them off, the way the contraption about them groaned and buckled under the pressure it was under. Even Scorpia knew it; stupid as Shadow Weaver knew the Scorpioni was, the brute was looking around with clear concern and worry, clearly wondering if she should talk to Entrapta and equally clearly fearing it would only distract her at a key moment.

This alliance was on its last metaphorical legs, and Shadow Weaver knew it was time to bail.

Before she went, she looked over the holoprojector displays one last time. Entrapta was using an old language for her personal print-outs on the Doom Balloon, rather than more common Mountainflower or Skimmer, but fortunately for Shadow Weaver, she'd studied this language back when she'd been hunting the Sword as Light Spinner. It was an old Plumerian tongue, now called Greenroot- an interesting choice for a Drylborn, probably inspired by Entrapta's obvious attraction to Perfuma.

(Who had stood up to Shadow Weaver... and she hadn't much liked it. Impudent brat- and from one so weak as well, who refused to use her true power! Perhaps some helpful Hordesman would put the ingrate down before Shadow Weaver had to do it.)

Shadow Weaver quickly scanned them to confirm the situation to herself:

First, the Horde was in the midst of a civil war, with multiple groups fighting each other. Shadow Weaver... wasn't really all that surprised. The Horde was *always* going to self-destruct in some spectacular fashion if Hordak died; it was in the very name. The Horde was Hordak's, and it had never been designed to outlive him.

Plus, it had been Adora leading this new Horde; and in hindsight, the truth was obvious:

Adora was the weaker child.

Indeed, hindsight was proving far more... *sober* at deciphering which of the two girls she should have used. Shadow Weaver hadn't realized it at the time, but she'd been effectively drunk on the potential she had in her hand; drunk on Adora being a First One, drunk on the idea of her becoming She-Ra, drunk on the idea of using the girl to finally accomplish the goal that had eluded Shadow Weaver for two names now. Adora would find the Sword of Protection with her First Ones' blood, and then Shadow Weaver would steal her body and all her power.

That had been the plan... but it was flawed right from the start. For one thing, Adora was *not* the one who got the Sword in the first place... and it was clear to see, once the hangover passed, that she'd misjudged the girl all along. She'd tried teaching Adora how to have a heart of stone, but the stone Adora was made out of was obsidian; so sharp, but so *brittle.* The volcanic rock seemed impressive when you saw how it sliced, but it broke apart at the barest blow.

She should have known Adora was a losing proposition the second the girl came back from Thaymor empty-handed, and she'd had to be... *forceful* with her.

Likewise, she'd dismissed the better candidate, simply because she thought she'd *already* found the next She-Ra. Catra had come

to her by accident, but she'd not only ignored the possibility knocking on her door, but had flat-out slammed that door shut in possibility's face. Catra, whom she'd found so *pathetic,* with her need for a mother to love her, with her desire to be somebody's, *anybody's,* daughter. Such childish foolishness was inexcusable, even in an actual child.

But Shadow Weaver had failed to see that it would have been a *perfect* flaw to exploit. She could have reached into those gaps in Catra's armor and buried her hooks deep in the girl's soul... and with it, gained the She-Ra.

...A shame. Catra had turned out to have the better stone for her heart, pure fulgurite, that rare alchemical material so valuable to magic, born of sand struck by lightning- a moment of unimaginable power, immortalized in stone. Catra *was* that power as the She-Ra, and she could have been the key ingredient to a working greater than any other...

But alas, she'd chosen poorly. Shadow Weaver should have thrown *Adora* out, and kept Catra. It would have been so easy to string her along... at least long enough for Catra to get the Sword... and then Shadow Weaver could just hop right into her body. Why, Catra might have *let* her, if she just told the girl some lie about sharing the form- all for her dear, precious mother.

(Not how the spell worked. The other soul was still in there- in fact, the writing indicated that the caster would be battling the original soul for the rest of their lives for control of the body- but the magic put the caster in charge, and made the ensuing contests heavily in the caster's favor. While it *was* a struggle, it was one that most users of the spell easily won, every day.)

But, alas... an opportunity missed. One taken up by another; Shadow Weaver had to admit, Angella had played her hand *spectacularly.* With nothing more than a few kind words and carefully calculated gestures, the angel had made the She-Ra her servant, and put Brightmoon in a fine position despite her military losses. One had to admire the success, as irritating as it was to see someone else so gleefully take the chance Shadow Weaver herself had missed.

A bitter and absurd irony- that the girl who, in training, had never failed should do so in the real world, while her counterpart, the girl who never *succeeded* in training, should go on to be the She-Ra.

Poetry, in that.

But power, not poetry, was Shadow Weaver's preferred subject, and so she considered this news in light of that desire. Adora had held the ticking timebomb of the Horde together this long and no longer, and that was a blessing in disguise: in all the chaos, the Horde could not mount a united defense against their intrusion. It would make it easier to get Scorpia to the Garnet, since the full weight of the Horde could not be brought to bear on them.

Secondly, the Princess Alliance had attacked the Horde, as seen by various high-magic signatures popping up on the screens- they'd probably brought some Rebels too, since they'd been having that meeting and it'd be foolish not to grab a few if they could. That was most likely Catra's doing; Entrapta had mentioned in her mumblings- repeatedly- that Glimmer had told Catra about the Heart of Etheria. Apparently they'd recreated the spell Shadow Weaver had used with Glimmer's help to teleport a strike force in.

(Probably Micah had cast the spell; he always *was* a good student.)

That was a problem; they would try to stop them, and worse, they *knew* what their goal was. They'd be converging on the Garnet... and that made the Horde's civil war a double-edged sword. No full Horde to fight them... but no full Horde to fight the Alliance, either.

Third, Perfuma was on what could only be described as a rampage. She wasn't near the Black Garnet yet- that was near the heart of the Fright Zone, as it had been since the Scorpioni built their first desert palaces here- but she was making excellent time, reducing all resistance before her might. The Doom Balloon, following the trail of devastation she was wreaking, hadn't even needed to defend itself- thankfully. Shadow Weaver would have to take over with her spells, most likely, given the currently-falling-apart status of the airship.

The multiple serpent-headed tails and the crushing scorpion pincers were a combo deadly enough on their own, especially taking the beast's sheer size into account, but the bitterlye pushed Perfuma over the edge into the territory of truly unstoppable juggernauts. *Everything* in the Fright Zone was vulnerable to bitterlye; she left behind her a trail of buildings reduced to rot, defenses decayed into sizzling puddles of goo, armor and weapons wrecked and useless as they slowly softened into sludge.

She also left behind a *lot* of naked people, and even with the situation as it was, Shadow Weaver had to admit to being somewhat amused. The looks on their faces were... quite something.

...A good summation of Perfuma's actions in general, the witch thought to herself. *Quite something.*

(The witch recalled Perfuma's bravery before her, and did not shiver... but it was close.)

Fourth and finally, there was no chance of Entrapta really assisting Shadow Weaver with getting Scorpia to the Black Garnet any more than she had. The Drylborn had mentioned making warriors out of parts of the ship... but that plan had went out the window the second the Doom Balloon started falling apart. She'd had to use the few robots she'd made just to keep it together.

They weren't as close to the Garnet as Shadow Weaver would have liked; but better to descend now, and not be on the airship when it burst apart. The area below was dangerous, but so was Shadow Weaver, and Scorpia had survived Beast Island, albeit with Micah's most likely vital support. They'd be fine.

So it was time to go.

"Scorpia," Shadow Weaver commanded the girl, who jerked to attention. That Force Captain Training had apparently stuck, despite her exile to Beast Island.

"Yes, boss?" she asked, and her pincer twitched with the desire to salute- to Shadow Weaver's amusement.

“Come with me,” she said. “We will take the escape pod down, and make our way to the Garnet on foot.”

“What about Entrapta?” Scorpia asked, and nodded her head towards the engineer as she piloted her vessel. The Drylborn had not heard a word they said, too busy with the control panel and keeping the ship from bursting apart. “She's... not doing well?”

She would most likely be standing there still when the ship finally *did* explode; but that wasn't Shadow Weaver's problem.

No, all that mattered was that Scorpia touch the Garnet... and then Shadow Weaver would take the Heart for herself.

(She *did* shiver then, in joy and delight; all that *power,* ripe for the taking...)

“She will join us later,” Shadow Weaver lied, smooth as silk. “But come- we must not fail in our task. Or else all this will have been for naught.”

Scorpia clearly wrestled with herself, wanting to obey Shadow Weaver due to long instinct in the Horde... wanting to stay with Entrapta, or at least, get her attention, due to their attachment to one another.

But eventually- as Shadow Weaver knew it would- Horde discipline took over, and Scorpia walked away with Shadow Weaver, her last words to Entrapta unheard.

"See ya around," Scorpia said, leaving with Shadow Weaver, to descend to the Fright Zone below and reach the Garnet.

(And from there... who *knew* what Shadow Weaver could become?)

Chapter End Notes

Just a teaser- next time, more to come!

Chapter 64: Lonnie in Hell

Chapter Notes

A very short chapter- a tease!

Because a BIG chapter is coming soon!

And I know where it all ends- soon!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

So what were other people who WEREN'T terrible doing?

This, for one.

Another short chapter today. Long chapter Wednesday!

Lonnie in Hell

Lonnie walked through hell.

All around her, the Horde was committing suicide via civil war. Gunshots slaughtered at a distance; shock batons killed up close. Flames burned alive those who were not fast enough to dodge;

none were fast enough to avoid being crushed under the treads of heavy vehicles.

Lonnie saw all this as she walked past battle after battle, finding herself alone in a bubble of almost total peace, the eye of this apocalyptic storm.

It made no logical sense. She was making no effort to hide herself. She was making no effort to defend herself. She didn't even have her helmet on.

But even so, no one turned to her, no one tried to attack her, no one impeded her.

She walked, untouched, through hell.

And she thought she knew why.

All her thoughts, all her ideas, all her fears... they seemed so *petty* now. In the face of what Grizzlor had done- in the face of Hordesmen killing Hordesmen- Lonnie finally had a clear idea of what her duty should have been. Now, when it was too late- and wasn't there a saying about that, something about hindsight?- she saw her duty clear.

It was to Adora.

Lord Adora.

This she knew simply because the fighting was so frantic on the side of those with Lord Adora's dragon on their emblems, and the fighting was so smooth and organized on the side of the enemy rebels. Lord Adora, for all her more chaotic and individualized approach to the Horde as compared ot Lord Hordak, still did nothing without a *plan.*

Grizzlor had started this fight, his troops were orderly, more regimented, had more of a plan. The bots fought on their side as well, a clear plan of betrayal.

Grizzlor had started this fight that was killing Hordesmen.

And she'd handed him the keys to do it.

She should have shot Grizzlor.

...Or maybe she's wrong. Maybe Grizzlor is still in the right and Adora is just the Spirit Ember, and all this is just her guilt talking; but her guts want to spill out of her in the face of Hordesmen killing Hordesmen, of civil war among her people, she wants to hurl, to ovmit, to expel this awfulness from her mind and know it no more.

Perhaps the surest sign that she has gone mad is that she *thinks* she knows what is right, now, when she hadn't known for a long, long time.

...She hopes she has gone mad. She hopes none of this is real. She hopes this is all a nightmare she will wake up from.

(But when has she ever been that lucky?)

She wonders, briefly, if she has died. If this is the afterlife she has heard of, sometimes, from those who speak of the beliefs of the northerners, of the non-Horde, the things their shaman-queens have come up with- or at least, Lonnie assumes that is who came up with them, the Runestones working through their avatars to control society. Some of the societies conceive of life after death, of death not as an end but a passage to another life; not a Horde idea, who know that death is an end, but what right does Lonnie have to the Horde, now? After all she has done to it?

(She is crying, and does not know it, tears falling gently from her eyes as she mourns the death of her people.)

She's not sure what those are like. She has a vague idea of something called the All, in her deepest of deep memories, from before the Horde took her in; she hasn't thought of it in years. Something heard before she was really a person, maybe, a child so small she was barely aware of anything. Something Plumerian, perhaps.

But from Hordesmen from Dryl, she's heard that the afterlife is a series of your best moments, over and over again...

And now she wonders if this is her punishment, her afterlife, if she died in her sleep, and now this will be all there is, forever.

She prays to go mad, and soon, if this is not madness; or to wake up.

But she keeps walking, and she does not know why, or where her trail is leading her.

Chapter End Notes

Poor Lonnie.

Side note, the main reason she's alive is actually BECAUSE she's so clearly shell-shocked and not a threat; people are focusing on more immediate problems, or moved by her plight and simply ignore her for now. She's not the only person wandering lost in the Fright Zone right now.

Civil war is like that.

Chapter 65: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: Lighting the World's Funeral Pyre

Chapter Notes

A lesson in hubris- never say when a thing will be out. It'll be out when it's out, as Blizzard once said back in the day, before it became the burning sexist shitpile it is now. Before Bobby Kotick and his foolishness.

But here we are, yet and yet. Better late than never, particularly in fanfiction.

While on the topic of nevers... I can't believe none of you pointed out the trick I pulled, with the Red Knight listed in TWO different places! That's not a continuity error; Double Trouble is one of them. I snuck it past all ya'll :D

Bit of trivia: found the perfect theme for Catra and Adora's entire relationship in this fic.

It's Disturbed and Ann Wilson's “Don't Tell Me”.

So first off, holy shit, Disturbed got a hold of THE LEAD SINGER OF HEART, hot damn! I didn't even know she was still alive!

But on analysis... the whole thing is perfect. Disturbed and Ann Wilson's “Don't Tell Me” is a song about a relationship falling apart; and every lyric in it hits like a hammer, in the context of Adora and Catra's fucked-up love for each other. The David Draiman parts are Catra's, while Ann's bits are Adora's.

Don't tell me now that you hate me/ for never letting go/let there be no doubt/I can't live my life without you...

Ah, it's perfect. Elegaic and bombastic, all at once.

Also, using something different to indicate POV breaks this time- the title!

Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A BATTLE FOR THE AGES

Part One:

Lighting the World's Funeral Pyre

For just a second, Catra was sure she'd seen Hordak.

Maybe it was just because her brain was primed to see him here, in her childhood home, even as the circumstances had changed so very much. Catra had grown up here, this was her *childhood,* for all that she was now a proud citizen of Brightmoon, the land that had loved her first.

But for all that it had never loved her, the Horde had still been *home,* once, and the fragment of Catra's soul that would always be a Hordesman had subconsciously expected him here, even though she well knew the man was dead.

(Knew he had died to save the world- knew, more importantly, that he had died to save her *mother,* had become the sacrifice so that Angella not die... a debt Catra will owe the dead man forever.)

It wasn't a rational thing. Just... this was the Horde, and Hordak *belonged* here, in the Fright Zone. This was *his,* in every possible way, his presence here as much a fact as time or gravity... and every Horde cadet knew it. All the days of her life, Hordak had saturated it, stories told of him from every mouth- the Lord of the Horde, the unshakable incarnation of all the Horde's ideals, the common man who had made the world's Princesses tremble. Catra had heard those stories since she could *blink.*

So maybe it wasn't surprising that- just for a second, just one long moment- she saw him there, backlit by the flames of the city.

(And why was there so much *fire* what is happening here? The world is burning down...)

But a second later the vision shattered, as the smell of ashes and blood filled Catra's sensitive nose, as the heat of the burning buildings all around washed over her, fur twitching from the flakes of ash falling on her skin, ears full of the distant roar of battle; this *wasn't* Hordak, it *couldn't* be, because he had died so that all Etheria might live.

(Imagery flashed through her mind; his topiary statue in Perfuma's garden, the old-Horde flag Entrapta had sewn into a sleeve, the way he had been so tall in those last moments, grand as any king, with his hands on the Sword. Hordak... whom Catra will owe all the days of her life, because he ensured she would not have to watch her mother die.)

For a moment, as her brain realized it could not be Hordak but had yet to process just *who* it was down there, some part of her was surprisingly *mad,* angry that someone would dare pretend to be Hordak, a thing that felt like blasphemy to the Hordesman part of her, felt like insult to the part of her that knew she owed the man a debt. Hot rage blossomed, for a second, like the flash of lightning, wondering who would *dare* mock the legacy of the man who had died to save the world

(*who died saving my mother*)

And to do so here in the very heart of his kingdom, built with his own two hands.

But the bolt of anger faded to cold shock when the figure in Hordak's suit turned to her, making a sound she knew all too well.

"*Hahahahahahahahahahahaha...."*

It was familiar, the kind of sound Catra could not forget if she tried, like warning sirens seconds before disaster. It conjured images of where she'd first heard it- in the ruins of Mara's ship, now restored, but ruined then, the ancient relic that had crashed into the Waste impossible ages ago.

There, in the ruins of a ship older even than Catra's own immortal mother, Catra had figured out a truth, and shared it with the woman she loved... and heard that laughter as her response.

Catra stared in horror as Adora turned to her, laughing, and something was wrong, her eye was aflame, was she hurt? Burn scars, dancing in the firelight, and she just kept *laughing,* jagged and terrible, laughter with no hope and no joy; laughter that was the soul choking, like a dog gagging on the bone that would kill it. It sounded the way Catra's first kiss had tasted, rough with salt and desert-chapped lips, red with the blood of her beloved, who had cut herself open on Catra's too-sharp teeth, ruined by the knowledge that had broken Adora's mind.

(*You're a First One,* the four words that had led to the Portal and the apocalypse of the make-believe.)

"Adora?" Catra half-whispered, her heart seized up at the sight of her beloved so horribly hurt.

"*HAHAHAAHAHAHAHAHA!*"

Then there was no more time for anything else, because great wings of fire shot out of Adora's back, propelled her rocket-straight into Catra, slamming obsidian-shield first. Catra was barely able to whip the Sword up in time, blocking the red-hot, razor-sharp tower shield; locked together, her defending sword against attacking shield, the two flew through the air at such speed that Catra barely caught a glimpse of her family and squire, shocked and yelling after her, a single moment to see Angella launch a blast that missed the far-too-fast Adora, to see even Flutterina's speed fail her, Micah's spell missing just as his wife's attack had; all this in a second, before the duo hit a building, and there was no more sight of her kith and kin.

No, then there was only the wall, buckling behind her, and the dust of their passage, and the searing flames, through the building and into another one, going too fast to tell what she was hitting, almost too fast to even notice the impacts as Adora turned her into the world's first living wrecking ball.

And as they kept destroying, kept hammering into buildings, kept slamming through their shared childhood home and destroying it, Adora kept *laughing.*

" ***HAHAHAAHAHAHAHAHA!*** "

********CATRA OF ETHERIA*********

Sea Hawk had seen quite a lot of shit in his life, to put it in terms Glimmer would probably approve of.

Not a surprise, all told. One didn't spend one's childhood as the son of Admiral Hunga, her wife Lohni, and their mutual husband, the former Falcon of Octopus Cove, without hearing all kinds of salty sea stories, and about all *kinds* of subjects.

Hell, you couldn't even grow up as their beloved son without the trio making sure you were well-prepared to make some of those stories yourself! His mothers taught him to fight, to sail, to swim;

his dad taught him to sing, to haggle, to command a crew. Both taught him a love of the sea, something he'd inherited thrice over.

He'd also fallen in love with fire, but that was on his own initiative, could not be blamed on any of his parents; a person was not just what their parents made of them, after all.

(A person is clay that makes itself, even as others put their hands to the wheel; and it is a testament to the clay of Sea Hawk that, in all the winding possibilities, there exists at least one timeline where Sea Hawk found the Spirit Ember first... and became its Prince, because his near-total acceptance of himself, his almost complete lack of shame or doubt, let the power flow through him without harm. To the stunned disbelief of the Last Fire Princess, Sea Hawk would be a new Prince of Fire... but while that Sea Hawk has stories of his own to tell, those are not *this* story.)

As anyone with those two loves in his life would inevitably do, Sea Hawk had seen all kinds of things! He'd seen sights at sea no one would believe- vast leviathans, abyssal lights, ghost ships spotted out of the corner of the eye in the fog- all kinds of things.

He'd even seen Beast Island itself, just once, and at a distance- but he'd heard... something, from it. A kind of call.

(And saved the crew of the ship, for Sea Hawk was the only one not broken by the sound, his inner fire just strong enough to keep from guttering out... but it had been close. Even at that far distance... it had been close. Still, barely mobile, he'd been able to wrangle the ship as a one-man crew until distance and time let the others recover... but when they got to port, the other sailors had quit the sea entirely, leaving Sea Hawk with the boat as reward for saving their lives, which was how he got his first Dragon's Daughter.)

But with all that said...

Sea Hawk had seen no shit like *this.*

The dead, moving about; ghost ships were one thing, ethereal and strange, but this was different, more corporeal... more *grotesque.* Just dead meat, being shocked into movement by the lightning that was covering them, the black lightning jerking them into place and making them animate in the same way a puppeteer's strings moved a puppet in parody of life. They were cooking as they fought, too, the lightning was frying them from the outside in; Sea Hawk could *smell* it, smell the char and smoke of singed hair and burning meat... see where their flesh charred at the very touch of the same fulgurous force that kept them active.

They talked, too- well, kind of. They mostly just jabbered, making noises as the lightning literally *shook* the sounds out of them. Like trying to talk through teeth chattering from too much cold... and doing it *loudly,* too. So loudly that, while Dreer was saying something, Sea Hawk couldn't hear him over the teeth-clattering, clamped-jaw screaing of the dead before him.

But even as his brain caught up with what was going on, the nearest corpse lunged for him, swinging its weapon at Sea Hawk. The battle continued raging as he dodged, the sharp *snap* of ice to his right as Frosta unleashed a wave of killing cold, itself soon beaten back by another of those silently-loud beams from Octavia. From the corner of his eye, Sea Hawk saw that tall Snowswoman grabbing Frosta and hauling her away from the beam, right before

it shattered her ice and cut a hole through the ground she'd been standing on.

(The melted stone it left behind was all the warning Sea Hawk needed for a single thought to go through his head- *do not get hit by the beam.*)

But then he had no more time for anything but his own defense.

The dead woman attacking him was rather *enthusiastically* dead, if Sea Hawk had to be honest. More honesty led him to say she had probably been killed by fire, from the look of her; her face was a melted ruin with her lower jaw mostly burned away, a fate that had also befallen a significant chunk of her torso.

Despite this, she still moved, fought, tried to kill him with the axe in her right hand; her one remaining eye glared unblinklingly at him as she blathered, tongue flopping about in the ruin of her mouth, jittering and shaking from the forces commanding her.

Worse, that same strange movement made her hard to defend against; she moved stutter-swift, staggering forward one moment, pausing to shiver from the lightning in her veins, before suddenly energized enough to dash forward and strike with rapidity few humans could match. Had Sea Hawk not fought alongside the Princesses for years now- had he not forced himself, through training and sheer effort, to become one of the best swordsman now alive- he would have been caught out and killed by the way the beast swapped from stock-still to *stabbing* in a moment.

(Others fared less well, he saw from the side; he saw his love-lobster, dear Mermista, mobbed by a horde, swing her trident...

and *miss,* the zombie stopping before she expected it to, and others rushing ahead at high speed, forcing her to blast them away with a quick rush of the Fright Zone's filthy water. His heart had leapt in his chest, but she was okay for now... but to be dangerous enough to put his *Mermista* on the backfoot...)

A crossbow bolt suddenly hit the zombie he was fighting in its remaining eye, but that didn't stop the assault, though it *did* render it clumsy and awkward; apparently they did indeed still need their eyes to see. Sea Hawk spared a glance at the Andreenid who'd fired the bolt, and was just in time to see a separate undead swing an axe at her, but not enough time to see if it connected, if his assistant had died helping him; all he could do was focus on his own fight.

With the opening its blindness presented, Sea Hawk slashed it with his sunsword, the golden metal gleaming, the energized metal hitting the energized corpse in the arm... and causing something *beautiful* to happen.

For where his sword's First One tech blade touched, the lightning clashed with it- and *faded.* The creature's arm fell limp and useless at its side.

...Interesting...

Sea Hawk grinned as he lunged, stabbing it through the heart; the energy gathered, then died, the creature short-circuited and defeated. It stopped moving, stopped attacking, stopping *talking,* just slumping on his sword.

W ell well! Sea Hawk thought to himself, as he withdrew his blade, pushing the body off to fall down as corpses should. *A gift- and I'm not one to look a gift horse in the mouth! At least partly because that just feels rude after becoming friends with Swift Wind, but also because like, why? What was gonna be **in** there?*

His sunsword- or whatever it *really* was, even Bow, tech master that he was, had only been able to vaguely speculate that it might have been surveying equipment, once- was a kind of energized blade, electricity of its own in the core of it, making heat...

And the dead did *not* like that, did they?

“They don't like electricity!” Sea Hawk yelled triumphantly, because his mouth had learned long ago to pay little attention to whatever his brain was thinking about. “Or energy! Maybe! I'm not a tech master!”

He shot a quick glance about the battlefield, years as a captain letting him take quick stock of the situation. Oh, he was no strategic genius like his love lobster, who was so perfect a paragon of a Salinean Princess, the nation's great warrior... but he wasn't half bad, if he did say so himself.

He had a little time to look, too; nothing had attacked him save the single undead.

(Which, on reflection, he was more than a little insulted by. Especially since everyone else was getting jumped by *several!*)

The glance said little good, and much bad. The Andreenids were badly backed in a corner, centered on Frosta and that older Hordesman who'd joined their side; Hiron, Sea Hawk thought he'd heard Peekablue say? The older man was still shooting, focused on kneecaps; the zombies survived, but fell down, unable to keep walking on broken legs. Frosta was freezing them when she could, but she was far too busy dodging Octavia's blasts to do much; Octavia had clearly identified her as the most dangerous, and was keeping her on her toes with constant shots.

The Andreenids, meanwhile, were fighting hand to hand, their poison useless against flesh that did not care about pain to start with, wielding instead the swords they carried as side arms to their main weapon. They were acquitting themselves decently well, though none were uninjured; all were on the ground, too, and Sea Hawk realized why when one man tried to take flight. It drew Octavia's attention, who spared one blast from her constant chasing of Frosta to try and kill the man.

He dodged, but barely, his wings catching fire just from the pressure the beam exerted from passing *near* him. He fell, burning, Frosta swiftly putting him out in the split-second his flight had gained her before she had to leap away again from another searing light that tore through her powerful glacial constructs like they weren't even there. Only dodging saved Frosta; no shield she made could withstand the pressure.

Whatever the hell Octavia was using, it was *terrifying.*

(Thank the nameless gods that her strange weapon had a charge-up time, and a distinctive sound right before it fired; not *much* of a charge-up time, and the sound was very short notice, but it was *something.*)

Octavia stayed near Dreer, who himself was lashing out with spells whenever his dead did not need driving. Lightning at his Mermista, who was shielding with water, and also lightning to protect himself; Sea Hawk saw Prince Peekablue chucking knives at the sorceror, only for crackling thunders to bat the knives away.

It was a stalemate, for now.

But not all things were at such stalemate. A wave of zombies caught the Red Knight who'd accompanied Sea Hawk, and the warrior disappeared behind a pile of rubble, drowning in the mass of foes.

(Unbeknownst to Sea Hawk, the Red Knight present with him- who was *not* the Red Knight, but Double Trouble in disguise- took the chance to slip away, transforming to escape the galvanized dead. Double Trouble had no desire to tangle with all *this* mess, no sirree; they just wanted to speak with Adora, one more time, and staying here to fight was not conducive to that goal. They'd only went with Sea Hawk in hopes of finding a group to stick with for protection, which had backfired terribly!)

Hmm. He doubted the others had heard him when he spoke of his discovery, that these things did not like opposing energies... he'd have to do it himself, use that knowledge somehow, save them all.

...Energy...

Fire is a kind of energy, he thought, as a grin spread across his face, pure pyromaniacal joy in his every thought. *And I've never needed an excuse to set a blaze.*

A wild smile on his lips, Sea Hawk reached for the firestarter he kept on his belt.

*******CATRA OF ETHERIA******

For what felt like long minutes- and was probably a few seconds at best- Catra's entire world narrowed down to sensation, all thought stripped by the sudden sensory overload. Her world consisted of the impact of heavy stone and metal on her back, of the feeling of buildings breaking on her furred flesh, of dust in her nose and the stink of fuel and spilled chemicals from the pipes she burst with her body. Her world consisted of the vague sounds of combat around her, distant and muffled by the sound of buildings collapsing, of the frantic kaleidoscopes that were the quick glimpses of the Fright Zone she caught as she was hammered through building after building like the world's first Magicat nail, of the sensation of her grit teeth as she blocked from her front and took hits on her back. Her world consisted of the blazing heat in front of her that was propelling her, of the pressure in her arms as

she held the Sword before her to block the crushing obsidian shield wielded against her...

And worst of all, her world consisted of the sound- the constant **sound**- of Adora's broken laughter, which hitched and coughed like sobs.

But eventually, the fire blazed itself out. As they slammed through yet another building, their speed decreased, plowing through it slowly enough that Catra caught a glimpse of its hallways and thought perhaps she'd been there, as a cadet, something familiar in those straight halls and artificial lights.

(And she wondered if anyone was in the now-collapsing building, if anyone had been in *any* of the buildings she'd been slammed through, if she has become the murder weapon of people she hadn't even *seen,* people she might *know*)

And finally, on the other side of the wreckage, Adora's flames burst out not behind her, but forward, halting herself in midair, Catra flying off of her as inertia carried her past Adora's sudden stop. She tumbled briefly before finding her feet, as any good feline would, sliding and keeping the Sword up in a defensive posture.

And before her, framed by the long, long row of burning buildings, by the absolute disaster she'd inflicted upon the Fright Zone, was the woman Catra loved- but not as she had ever been.

No, this was Adora Ablaze, this was Adora with fire in her eye and fire *for* an eye on her left side, this was Adora in Hordak's armor but with great wings of flame like some perversion of a phoenix's life-giving flame spread around her.

(*or dragon's wings, they look like the wings on the dragon I saw in Bow's parents' house...*)

Catra stared up at her as Adora's laughing slowed, running down, down, like a stopwatch never rewound, like a radio set never repaired, like a fire without fuel. Down, down, slowing, still laughing, and she was smiling but all it did was show teeth, no happiness.

And for all that she wore Hordak's outfit, Adora saw nothing of him in the woman before her. Hordak, who had stood tall as midnight in his last moments, whom Adora had been mimicking these last few months, the new Lord of the Horde... an Adora Catra had never met, but felt the power of, as she fought on the frontlines of an Alliance meeting a resurgent Horde. A leader, a strategist, Hordak's Heir.

She saw none of that now.

No, what was before her was an Adora she knew well, an Adora she had hoped never to see again, an Adora that had hurt to see. This was Adora as she had been in Mara's ship when she first found out she was First One, this was Adora as she had been in the not-world of the portal, this was Adora at her very worst.

Swallowing against a mouth dry from fear and worry both, Catra could only stare as the laughter finally died, leaving them in a little bubble of peace and silence in the chaos, the eye of a storm- no, the eye of a *fire*storm, with the war around them and the crackling flames muffled by horror and terror.

(*Adora no, come back to me, you aren't this, Adora!*)

When Adora spoke, Catra jumped in surprise.

"Hey, Catra."

*********CATRA OF ETHERIA********

" So what's the plan, boss?" Toad asked Spinnerella as the Erelander hoisted his bazooka over his shoulder. They were standing outside the complex that housed the Garnet, which they'd gotten to with remarkable swiftness- mostly because Spinnerella had used her whirlwinds to pick up her team and fly her team straight to their objective. While her wife wasn't with them, Spinnerella wasn't worried; Nettie would know that they'd be at the objective, and waiting here for her beloved was safer and easier than trying to find her in the wartorn Fright Zone.

(A civil war in the Horde... unbelievable! Yet something every Rebel had hoped for. The Horde turned against itself... and what incredibly lucky timing, too! In almost any other circumstance, Spinnerella would be hopping for joy.)

“Establish a perimeter,” Spinnerella said. She wasn't a general like her wife, but she'd been her second-in-command long enough that some stuff was just second nature. “Figure out what's where and if any fighting is nearby that we might have missed from above. And let's see if we can find Scorpia! Keeping her out is *top priority,* everything else is not secondary but *tertiary* to that goal.”

“Do we go in?” Scurvy asked, the Cove pirate having been found by the Rebels as they flew to the Garnet and joining them in riding the winds. His Magicat wife next to him had *not* enjoyed the flight, and was now bristling with anger, fur stiff and raised, lone eye narrowed angrily; Spinerella almost pitied whatever poor bastard she fought first, who would bear the brunt of that unleashed rage.

Spinnerella almost answered him, but a glance at the building stopped her a moment. The complex that contained the Garnet was one of the most complicated structures in all the Horde, as befit a technological fortress made to study a Major Runestone; it was a lab and a fortress and a power plant all in one, the Stone of Storms encased in shining metal.

And it was so... quiet. *Too* quiet, for such a vital operational center. There should be soldiers all over it- why, Spinnerella had been *ready* for such a thing, her whirlwind arrival intended to scatter guards and let her Rebels get an ambush from above in, preparations that had proven unnecessary. There was no one here- and no fighting she'd seen from up above to justify such a lack. She'd have understood if some major battle had necessitated the soldiers leaving their posts temporarily, but there was just...

No one.

No one here, at such a vital operational centre? To the point the area felt unused... almost... abandoned. Even now, with all the Horde committing suicide via civil war, this place was left untouched...

It set her on edge. It was odd, and *odd* on a battlefield meant *danger* , most of the time.

Combined with its imposing size and her knowledge of what it contained- one of the greatest powers on Etheria, raw power in literal crystallized form- the whole place had an air of the unsettling; perhaps appropriately, it felt like the sensation in the air from before a storm, but much stronger and stranger, more *intense.*

Like an old ruin from back home, Spinnerella thought, unbidden. She'd paid little attention to fantastical tales in her youth- her harsh life had knocked the child right out of her years before she'd hit puberty- but she still recalled some of her mother's stories from back in Brigis Orphanage, when she was resting there between trips to go scavenging or thieving, the stories old Jarine told the younger children. The Twin Kingdoms' fables were littered with places like this, great palaces built in honor of King Machine… and always a monster inside, be it some warbot protecting the ground for long-dead masters, a malfunctioning computer that was a danger in its mechanical madness, or even the building itself, leaking deadly radiation to rot the bones and teeth of any would-be explorers.

She'd never cared for those fairy tales, but apparently she'd still remembered them, because this place was making her skin crawl with all those old tales.

"We have to," Spinnerella finally said, done spooking the hell out of herself, chastising her brain for making her think of such old stories. "Someone needs to be watching the Runestone directly. Not me or Krystala, we're both better suited for fighting outside."

"Yeah, I don't think she'd fit in the door," Scurvy said, glancing at the massive cybernetic minotaur. "And your tornadoes ain't exactly an indoor kind of solution."

Krystala ignored his comments, merely looking around in her cold, dispassionate way; Spinnerella nodded to the Cove captain for both of them.

"We'll stay outside," she said. "I'd like for you, Squall, and the Red Knight to go inside…"

"Won't see me objecting," Scurvy said. "Prefer a good scrum with swords to anything else."

His wife nodded, a short, curt jerk of her head.

"A good idea," the Red Knight agreed. "I'm good at a melee, but in this more open space I'm not quite as useful. And if you will be

hurling tornadoes, you'll want as much space as possible."

Spinny's response was stopped by one of her guards.

"Hey, Spinnerella, we got company," said one of her soldiers, drawing a bead on the far target with his longbow. Spinnerella turned to where he aimed, and saw two figures turn around a far corner and head their way, too far away in the dusty air to tell who it was.

"Halt and identify yourselves!" Spinnerella called, letting wind swirl to clear the air so she could see...

"Yo!" called the shorter figure, in a voice Spinnerella recognized- and as the air cleared, she saw her ears had heard true. It was Princess Glimmer, flapping her strigine wings. "That you, Spinny? It's Glimmer and Bow!"

"Hey everyone," Bow said... with an arrow nocked, aimed right at her longbowman. Spinny almost grinned at the sight; for all he was basically a Brightmoon soldier, he was a true Rebel in his fighting instincts.

"That's Princess Glimmer and Bow," Spinnerella said, loud enough for her troops and for her guests both to hear. "Stand down, they're friendly."

Both archers lowered their bows, and the Brightmoon soldier and her Rebel... boyfriend? Rumor insisted it, at least, but Spinny didn't actually know... approached.

“Glad to see you guys!” Glimmer said. “We hit some kind of Horde defense when we got here, I was barely able to keep Bow with me when we scattered.”

Definitely boyfriend, Spinnerella thought. *Grabbed him before her family.*

“Still, at least we made it... here,” Bow said, frowning. “This is the Garnet, isn't it?”

“Yeah,” Glimmer said, her wings fluffing out before drawing close to her. “Silver, there's an aura in the air, isn't there? Like a premonition. This place is *bad.* ”

“It is,” Spinnerella said. “We're going to guard it.”

Bow nodded his head.

“Glimmer... we should stick with them,” he said. “This is the only place that really matters... and Shadow Weaver's going to be with Scorpia. They're headed here.”

“...Good plan,” the Princess reluctantly agreed. “I hate standing still, I'd rather go hunting, but with all that's going on... yeah, it'd be too easy to miss the witch *or* Scorpia, and we lose if Scorpia gets to the Garnet.”

So, presenting herself to Spinny, Glimmer whipped off a salute the elder Princess would rate as half-decent.

“Glimmer, reporting for duty, ma'am!” she said, and despite the situation- and her continuing lack of wife- Spinnerella grinned.

“Glad to have you,” Spinnerella said. “Let's talk of how we'll arrange ourselves, then, so we can greet our guests properly.”

“Sure,” Glimmer said.

“Put me somewhere I can snipe,” Bow said.

“Yeah, I can fly you up to a good spot!” Glimmer said, flapping her wings.

“No, you can't,” Bow said. “Your wings are new and weak, you nearly killed yourself flapping around a room. Just teleport me.”

“Oof, just take all the fun out of it,” Glimmer grumbled before turning to Spinnerella. “I can teleport your men to good spots, too.”

“Won't you run out of power?” Spinnerella asked. Probably rude, but she knew of Glimmer's limitations- the only Princess who had to treat her power as a battery, instead of the infinite energy the others drew upon. Something to do with her mother being the Moonstone's real Princess, Netossa had theorized a few times over the years, which made Spinnerella glad to be a Wild Princess. She didn't have to listen to a *rock.*

“Not anymore,” Glimmer said, with a surprisingly... *sly* grin. Hmm. Spinny wouldn't have expected that kind of smug cleverness from the girl sh'ed always known as a fancy brute before. “We're surrounded by tech here, and the Garnet's connected to darkness- I can suck up juice from the power grid of the Fright Zone if need be, and I might not even need to. My shadow feels stronger just *being* here.”

“Your... shadow?” Spinnerella asked.

Glimmer grinned in response, and held out a hand- and in her palm, the shadows danced, all teeth and want.

“I'm a dark mage,” Glimmer said with that same cocky self-assuredness. “So while we're pretty far from the Moonstone's light and dark, I can still get by on just one half of my heritage.”

"...Shadow Weaver will be stronger here, too," Bow pointed out, and Glimmer grimaced. "And she knows the Garnet better than you do."

"Shit," the princess said, then shrugged. "Take the good with the bad, I suppose..."

"Let's get to work, then," Spinnerella cut in before the discussion could drag on any longer. She technically had no authority to order either of them to do *anything*- Bow was a Rebel but he wasn't one of Spinnerella's Rebels, and Glimmer was a Princess of Brightmoon- but those were good ideas, and half of command was just acting like you *should* be in charge anyway.

"Alright!" Glimmer cheered.

"Agreed," Bow said. "Oh, and Spinnerella- we have a plan to take on Shadow Weaver, so I'm asking for permission now to take the fight to her first if she shows up. I know chain-of-command can get kind of rough mid-fight, so I wanted to get that cleared up first."

"That's fine," Spinnerella said. "Weaver was always going to be one of the bigger problems, so I'm glad that's going to be dealt with. Anything else?"

"No," Bow said. "Other than that, you have command- until the day is won."

Old Rebel words, those...

A thing Rebels sometimes said in the first years of the war, when commands were more temporary, before leaderships were more firmly established. Still used today, sometimes, when temporary commands were given...

Well. Spinnerella had always considered Bow to be a Rebel in name only, but she'd apparently been unfair to the man.

(Glimmer clearly didn't know what it meant, quirking an eyebrow; and that amused Spinnerella, and raised her opinion of Bow yet more. Some stuff was for *Rebels,* not the Alliance, and that he clearly hadn't told her about it… that was good, in a petty kind of way.)

"Until the day is won," she agreed, the old words back to him, and her and Bow shook hands. It felt nice, to follow one of the few traditions that had managed to bloom in the hard soil of Rebel life.

Of course, tradition says we swap leadership roles next time... Spinnerella thought with amusement. *I wonder how I'm gonna explain to Nettie that we have to obey Bow in our next battle.*

She doubted Bow would call on that latter half of the tradition... but it *was* kind of funny to think about. Netossa would exile her to the couch for a week afterwards!

(Not that they *had* a couch in their tent, but same idea.)

"Well, whatever that was, let's get going!" Glimmer said, putting a hand to Bow.

"Let's go," he agreed.

The trio marched back to the main Rebel group, where the newcomers were greeted swiftly by all and sundry.

"I like having another Princess on our side," Scurvy said. "And from Brightmoon, at least, ya'll aren't as bastard as the other Kingdom bastards."

"I'll take it," Glimmer said, and Spinnerella thought she saw the twitch of a smile on Squall's face.

"And Bow is good to have as well," the Red Knight said. "A tech master is always good to have, an archer is even better in a defense, and he is a skilled man at both."

Bow blushed mildly at the praise, and Glimmer slapped him on the back.

"He *is* pretty great, ain't he?" she said with a grin.

“Let's plan this out,” Spinnerella said. “We've been left alone so far... but trouble is never far behind.”

As if she'd managed to curse herself, out the door of the Garnet building came three Horde guards- but walking out slowly with hands up.

“Don’t attack, don’t attack!” one of them begged as they exited. Their helmets were removed, revealing the scared faces of teenagers. “Please, don't kill us!”

Arrows had already been drawn on them, and Glimmer had a blast of something nasty in her hands to hit them with... but looking at them, surrendering and helpless, Spinnerella felt inclined to kindness.

She wasn't her wife- Netossa had standing orders to *always* accept surrender offered genuinely, had treated her prisoners well, had said it was *beneath a good person* to be brutal to POWs- but Spinnerella had her sympathies.

(She knew what it was, to be young, and to have no choice in the evil you do.)

“Spare them,” Spinnerella said. “But I have questions for you three. Who else is in there?”

“We're the only ones here!” the eldest- who could not have been fifteen- said, quiet tears streaming down her face. Adora’s Lord-mark, the dragon spitting flames, shined on her chestplate- apparently it was recently polished. One of Adora’s fans, apparently...

Makes sense, she's keeping her faithful near the Garnet.

“Please don’t kill us!” another, even younger, said. “We're not important, everyone that mattered went to the Spirit Ember, not the Garnet!”

“Or at least don't kill *them,* I’m squad leader, kill *me* but spare them!” the eldest said.

“No, come on, don’t be a hero!” another begged from behind her, and the trio degenerated into a blubbering mess that was both rather awkward to watch and rather heart-wrenching.

“What's the Spirit Ember?” Spinnerella asked.

“Some new weapon Lord Adora found!” the eldest said between sobs. “I don't know anything else, I swear!”

A few more questions- basic things- revealed they knew basically nothing of importance. They were barely qualified to be called

grunts- raw recruits press-ganged into the least important work. In any other land they'd just be kids in school.

And so Spinnerella, who had a soft spot for children, could not bear to hurt them.

"...We'll tie them up and put them in a side room of the Garnet building," Spinnerella finally ordered. "I don't want them leaving and warning anyone we're here... not that I'm sure who they'd even be able to report to, with the Fright Zone in civil war like this."

"Is that what's happening?" one asked. "The Horde... *can't* be fighting itself..."

Spinnerella ignored the comment. He'd understand the truth soon enough. She was about to pick out who would do the tying-up when a voice from nearby made her jump, having forgotten who was nearby.

"They are Horde," Krystala interrupted, low and quiet. She'd snuck up on Spinnerella, for the giant minotaur was surprisingly quiet when she wanted to be.

"...They are *children*," Spinnerella said, after her heart stopped racing from surprise. Turning to her troops and pointing at four of them, she said, "You four, put them in a side room, and be gentle

with them. They surrendered peacefully without us having to ask."

Krystala said nothing else, but her eyes never left the trio, even as Spinnerella's Rebels tied them up and walked them back inside.

"Thank you," the leader sobbed, as they were walked back inside. "Thank you."

That's my good deed for the day done, Spinnerella thought. *Now onto violence.*

(And failed to notice the minotaur, slinking off, quiet once more, with murder in her eyes.)

"Alright, folks, let's get ready!" Spinnerella said, and they laid down their plans for the future.

(A future that was approaching vermin-fast.)

*******CATRA OF ETHERIA******

Catra tried to speak once, and failed.

(the fire the fire the fire is *the light the light the light*)

Catra tried to speak twice, licking dry lips with equally-dry tongue, and failed.

(just like the portal just like the portal what have you done to yourself my love)

And third time was charm, for the cat who had her own tongue.

(*Adora what have you done*)

“What is this, Adora?” Catra asked.

“Oh, this?” Adora said, waving one hand too-casually at the devastated trail they'd left behind. “Just... me doing what I've always done. I break everything I touch, after all; I'm the villain of the story.”

...Okay, Catra didn't know where to *begin* with all that.

“Adora, what's wrong?” she asked instead, because none of this was right, Adora didn't *act* like this...

(The pictures Dr. Blankfort had shown her at the Council, flashing through her mind, all the things her Adora has ordered done... *do I even know Adora anymore? I thought the Sword was good, too, was I wrong again?*)

“Nothing,” Adora said, and laughed, laughed that laugh that said that *everything,* everywhere, was wrong. “Nothing at all. If

anything, things are back to right again! The hellhound's off her leash. I... I thought I was a dragon, but I'm just a dog. Just a big ugly stupid dog, chasing things I can't catch, wouldn't know what to do with them if I got them. I'm the Lord of the Horde, like I wanted to be, and I tried to be better, Catra, I really did! But I'm... broken. I can't do it."

She laughed again.

"Found my sister in sin, thought we could support each other, you know? Even if it's not really my sister at all, it's just a rock. I... I think I was using the Runestone to replace *you* ..."

"Runestone?" Catra asked, but Adora just kept talking, more to herself than to anyone else, the way heat blazed off of a great fire without care or concern; Adora could no more stop talking than she could stop breathing, not in this moment.

"I tried to be so... not good, never good, can't be good, but evil in a... functional way. Had this idea when I sent the army out to capture Perfuma, was going to bring her home, bargain for peace- so many ideas. Kids in the Fright Zone and promotions for the brave and... and all kinds of ideas. So many. But it didn't work... civil war, *in the Horde,* I did this, I ruined all this... I killed Hordak with the portal after he saved my life, I killed my father, and now I've ruined his life's work..."

More laughter like sobs.

“Shadow Weaver got it so *wrong,* ” she said, with a tone of almost wonder. “I was supposed to be always right but I am always wrong, wrong, wrong, and you... you are... *this.”*

She waved a hand at Catra.

“So beautiful. So powerful. So *incredible.* No wonder I love you so much, even unworthy of you as I am... so unworthy I don't even deserve to be a First One. I'm the filth a race of angels made, fallen and broken...”

And as Adora laughed, Catra had a realization.

Wait, she doesn't know what they were really like, doesn't... I can use that!

(She also mused over Adora saying she loved her, and it was like the kiss again, a thing she wanted in the worst context imaginable.)

“Wait, Adora! Yeah, you're a First One, but they-”

But her next words were muffled by the roar of flame, because those words- the words that had damned Adora- set off not a laugh but a scream, of purest rage, and Adora blazed forward.

"**I DON'T NEED YOU TO TELL ME THEY WERE BEAUTIFUL AND PERFECT AND GOOD!**" Adora screamed at her, and then the world was ablaze. "**AND I BREAK EVERYTHING I TOUCH, WHY SHOULDN'T I BREAK YOU, TOO?!?**"

*******CATRA OF ETHERIA******

"*Aaaaah!*" the Hordesmen screamed as Netossa's nets caught them and pinned them to a wall.

Netossa couldn't help the big grin on her face as she rose up from her hiding place underneath a set of nearby stairs; even after all these years of war, there was just something *satisfying* about a good ambush. No wonder spiders liked making webs, it was *always* fun to catch something in them.

The Hordesmen tried to fight back, of course, but they couldn't do shit. Their hands, full of weapons, were stuck where they couldn't move them, and while she couldn't make out their faces due to their helmets, the yells they'd let out as the net got them- and the current twin streams of cussing- were all Netossa needed to guess what expressions they were making.

All in all, a solid ambush... but one interesting detail caught Netossa's eye. Adora’s mark on their chests were scratched out- interesting.

Rebels of the Horde, then.

*Talking now to a **real** Rebel,* Netossa thought with a smirk. *Kinda funny, that.*

Netossa had been confused as hell when she first touched down. She wasn't near *anybody,* as far as she could tell; but she wasn't just a commander, she was a Wild Princess and a warrior to boot. So behind enemy lines as she was, she'd snuck around, stuck to ambushes like this of small numbers of troopers, and interrogated them to figure out the situation... and it was a *doozy.*

Civil War, in the Horde. Almost unthinkable. Whatever had caused it, she almost couldn't imagine; the Horde was such a tight-run ship, what could cause this revolution? It had to be something major, something fundamental...

Regardless, it didn't change her goal much. The Garnet was what mattered, so if these two could kindly tell her where it was...

“Greetings!” Netossa said warmly to her captives as she reached their little piece of wall. “Where were you heading?”

"Fucking- *Netossa?!?*" one of the soldiers spat with fury. "Of all the- the fucking Rebel Princess! Here?!? *Now?!?*"

"I fucking knew it!" the other one yelled from beside her companion. "The Traitor Lord has teamed up with the other Princesses, they're going to steal the whole Horde!"

Traitor Lord… she'd heard other soldiers yelling that about Adora, mid-battle. What was that about *other* Princesses? Had Adora ascended as a Wild Princess? That'd be a hell of a thing...

"If we're working together, it's news to me," Netossa said, putting those questions aside for now. The end of the world was a bit more pressing than either possible Wild Princesses or Horde internal politics right now. "At any rate, tell me where the Runestone is. I'm trying to keep the whole world alive, and maybe capture Adora in the process. But I need to get to the Runestone *first.* Keep anyone from using it."

"I'm not telling you *anything!*" the woman snarled at her...

But the man was quiet, contemplative.

So Netossa asked him her next question.

"If I was working with Adora," Netossa asked, "why would I be asking you *shit?*"

"…That's a good point," the man said. "Spare her, and I'll tell you."

"I intend to spare you both," Netossa said. "That net's low energy. You'll be free in a few minutes- plenty of time for me to leave if you answer now- or I can charge that net full of energy and you'll be stuck for an hour or more. Given the situation, I don't think you want that- but you've my word I'll let you go alive if you tell me what I want to know."

She meant it, too. She didn't like killing hostages; a revolution that did those kinds of things was a revolution that *kept* doing those kinds of things. Not every moral argument lacked practicality.

(There was no such thing as ends, after all; just means. Life kept going without end, after all, but you had to live within your means.)

"…The new building," the man finally said. "East of here. Hard to miss. Shiniest construction, lot of wires."

Oh, that was useful! Netossa feared she was on the other side of the city; this wasn't somewhere she knew well.

"…I guess that's fine," the woman said with a sigh. "...You were willing to tell her for sparing me?"

The man coughed awkwardly, and Netossa realized that it was *intensely* time to go before these two figured out their personal lives. It'd be awkward at best and rude at worst and she had no intention of getting involved.

"I'm on my way then!" Netossa said brightly, hoping to escape before being subjected to their relationship drama. "I give you back your lives; chase me and I'll end them. But for now… good luck out there."

"…You too, Rebel," the man said.

Netossa left, going for the Runestone.

(And with absolutely no idea that the Horde soldier had meant the Spirit Ember, not the Black Garnet, because Netossa was unaware that there was even a second Runestone to be mistaken *about*.)

*********CATRA OF ETHERIA********

"So… the plan is to destroy the Spirit Ember?" Old Zin asked Grizzlor as they rode along on an AttackTrak.

"Yes," Grizzlor said, as he studied on his trackerpad the movements of his people and the Hordebots allied with them.

Some of his units were getting wiped out a lot faster than he expected… and he hadn’t heard back from the siblings sent to kill Adora yet. Perhaps... perhaps they'd failed.

(He prayed not. He'd owed their parents favors he had put down on the children's tallies when they died... he'd watched over them all their lives, and now could only hope he had not sent them to their deaths.)

Though why were some of his units getting torn up? He'd heard a few scattered reports of “Rebel attack” but... what Rebel force could be so *ready* to jump his troops? The civil war had barely started! Didn't help that communications was a fucking bitch, almost like someone was hacking their crap, it was almost random who got to report in and who didn't.

(Light Hope, far away, manipulating the primitive radio networks of the Horde like a maestro, bringing this brutal symphony to its crushing conclusion.)

“I recall old stories about a Flame Kingdom,” Zin said, scratching his chin and drawing Grizzlor out of his wondering about his troops. “Bunch of sorcerors up north tried to take the Runestone of Fire... control it. It killed them. Caused a bunch of wars. School used it as an example of hubris with magicians.”

Oh, yeah, he was from Silverglade before he was Horde, Grizzlor reminded himself. *Makes sense they'd teach that kind of stuff- all those wizards.*

“And?” he asked, as he sent more orders to reinforce soldiers in various areas, and to make sure he was on track to reach the

Spirit Ember. The resistance was fierce, but he thought he had enough troops to take it.

“The Runestone of Fire killed them,” Zin repeated, eyes distant. “And before then... it's the reason the Flame Waste was the Flame *Waste.* Used to be a kingdom there- Candelaria, or Incendaria? Can't remember it now. But did a lot of harm. Squamatus ended up running for their lives to escape the flames. If we start fucking with this thing...”

Grizzlor saw his point, but shook his head.

“People claim Runestones can’t be destroyed without killing others all the time,” Grizzlor growled. “It’s bullshit. Pure propaganda. They just don’t want someone messing with their precious fucking stones. We’re blowing it up.”

It's just like the Bull's Eye; they said it was good, but I saw what it did to my brother. The Runestones are poison.

“...I'll trust ya,” Old Zin finally said.

“Thank you,” Grizzlor said back, and patted the old man on his shoulder. “Don't worry. It'll all be over soon.”

They marched on, towards the Spirit Ember, ready to break it in half.

(And still Old Zin, whose sense of survival had kept him alive to be an old man, could not help a sense of... horror.)

Chapter End Notes

Next time: More war! More fire! More despair!

God I love this story.

Chapter 66: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: Torchbearers for the World's Pyre

Chapter Notes

Another update! Huzzah! This one on our antagonists for this lovely segment... those who bear the fire to set the world alight.

Skip along in time- the work continues!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A BATTLE FOR THE AGES

Part Two:

Torchbearers for the World's Pyre

Screams echoed all around the duo as they traveled, Shadow Weaver in the lead, Scorpia nervously following behind, going ever deeper into the Fright Zone. They were using old passageways Shadow Weaver had found during her service to Hordak, little back-alleys and accidental spaces created in the Fright Zone's rapid construction that were on no map of the city.

Rather ironically, she'd specifically sought out such places in case she had to *flee* the Fright Zone... but now they're proving useful for sneaking back *in.*

Rather delicious irony.

To these secret pathways were added two more factors. First and perhaps most obviously, Perfuma's presence before them was carving a massive swathe of destruction and providing quite the distraction for anyone who wanted to challenge them. They'd seen countless forces distracted or ruined by Perfuma's passing, her giant warplant tearing through those before her.

(And leaving a lot of naked people behind, bitterlye melting their equipment; Shadow Weaver wished she could stay and torment them, but she had business to attend to, and not much time to attend to it.)

The second were Shadow Weaver's spells, powerful things to guard their way. Spells to blur their outlines, to dull their noises, to make the eye slip away indistinctly from them; they were as close to safe as it was possible to be in an active warzone, in some ways safer *because* of the active war. Those with more immediate problems- like their fellow countrymen trying to kill them, or Perfuma's gigantic warplant tearing through the area- were even more vulnerable to such spells of distraction and misinformation, unable to focus enough to pierce the veil.

Between the secret paths, the spells, the civil war, and the *incredible* distraction that Perfuma's one-woman assault on the entire Fright Zone was proving to be, Shadow Weaver and Scorpia walked in their own little bubble of safety, even as the Fright Zone ate itself alive.

They passed unseen by groups that were simply staring at each other, not sure if they could trust each other, weapons out and ready; they passed groups that had made their decisions, someone lashing out and battle erupting among formerly close friends, betrayal and slaughter all in one. They passed Hordesmen holding their dead, sometimes dead by their own hand, and weeping or cursing or doing both; they passed Hordesmen who were trying not to kill but merely subdue their opponents, whose attempted mercy often received death, sometimes worked, and always went unappreciated in the greater roar of battle. They passed Hordesmen who could not choose and so were cut down by both sides; they passed Hordesmen who made the third choice, who when faced with the two sides did not pick either, but instead picked themselves, and were busy fleeing with all speed into the polluted desert around the Zone.

They passed a world in ruin, and it was *glorious.*

Oh, Shadow Weaver *wished* she could spend more time here! All this lovely display of brutality and pain... a wonderful feast for the eyes. Her voyeur's heart thrummed with pervert's pleasure as she observed cadet classes turning on themselves and heard the wails of the living over the dead. Magnificent!

The meal was even sesaoned with the extra fun of hearing Scorpia's own indrawn breaths and horrified gasps behind her at each new tableau, like a quick dash of pepper and salt on her dinner. Sure, Shadow Weaver had to apply a bit of pressure to force the Scorpioni to come along with her when the foolish brute wanted to help those they came across... but that was easy enough. A few words, a curt gesture; that was all the force needed to get her to come along.

(Scorpia apparently wasn't as dumb as Shadow Weaver had always thought; the brute had sense enough to be afraid of Shadow Weaver, after all.)

Sadly, Shadow Weaver couldn't linger. The Garnet had to be reached, so the Heart could be breached, and all that power could be *hers.*

So on they went, stealing glances as they came at the nightmare the Horde would never awaken from.

Really, she almost felt giddy, a rare feeling for the somber sorceress. Everything was going so well. They were making good progress, no one was attacking them, her sadistic impulses were being fulfilled...

Really, the only fly in the ointment for Shadow Weaver was the fact that this civil war happening at *all* was a sign of just how badly she'd misjudged Catra and Adora, all those years ago. Adora was such a failure that she had run the Horde straight into the ground, had made it engage in a *civil war,* something so antithetical to Horde culture that Shadow Weaver was almost impressed she'd managed it. This was not a failure, but a fuck-up of *grand* proportions.

What a waste of her time Adora had proven to be. The witch should have realized the instant she had to wipe her memories and send her back to that little village whose name Shadow Weaver had never bothered to recall. Catra would never have needed such babysitting.

No, if Catra was in charge, the Horde would have taken out at least one nation of the Alliance by now; probably Plumeria. Maybe Salineas, given that without Catra's help, the nation would be in a much worse place right now...

Regardless, the Horde would not be eating itself right now, of that Shadow Weaver was certain.

And I could have had that strength in my service, if only I'd picked the right brat at the start.

Oof. There it was, the cold hard truth; she'd bet on the wrong horse, and lost her investment.

Not my fault I mistook the great weakness in Catra for anything but a lever to move her with...

And that was the core of it, right there. Shadow Weaver had recognized that look in Catra's eyes, because she'd seen it in Micah's; that orphan's want, that hunger to have someone older take care of them, to stop being the adult in a kid's skin they were forced to be and go back to just being a kid again, with someone else providing for them.

A grotesque *neediness,* one Shadow Weaver had despised. She knew that Catra wanted her to be her mother, and it had annoyed

the hell out of her. At least Adora had always *tried* to act mature! It had made Shadow Weaver lenient even when she failed and acted her age; a failure, but ones that were uncommon, and so she'd only punished Adora lightly for such mistakes.

But Catra had never even bothered to try. She'd been moody, sad and then angry and then too-happy and back to being sad, a cycle of endless annoyances. She'd bothered others just to get paid attention to, then when she *got* that attention, lashed out when it was too much. *Pathetic.*

Shadow Weaver had not seen the girl's strengths because her specific weakness had disgusted her so; by the same token, she'd not seen Adora's weaknesses because she'd admired her specific strength. Almost funny, in an ironic way... and if it hadn't been so costly.

She should have seen that weakness as what it was- a way to *control* Catra. Adora's independence meant she'd be fighting with her for control the second she got promoted... which was exactly what had happened. Adora had been the one to take her out and put her in jail, after all.

But with Catra, she'd had a handle, if only she'd known to grab it. If she'd just swallowed her pride, grit her teeth, and played the role of loving mother-figure for the whining brat. Queen Angella had truly beaten her, and in doing so, revealed her true wisdom; why, Shadow Weaver rather admired the Queen, now that she understood what she was *actually* like. Queen Angella was not the soft dreamer Shadow Weaver had always assumed her to be, but simply very skilled at hiding her own ruthlessness; no wonder she'd been the head of Brightmoon for so very long. The Queen

had set it up so that her nation did not even question being led by an immortal, much less think to kick her out; they loved her and worshipped her, all while Angella herself cared nothing for them.

How could she? She was so above them, after all.

(That was just common sense; someone like Angella would *obviously* view her subjects with contempt, the way Shadow Weaver did. That was just what powerful people *did.*)

Why, in some ways- *small* ways- Shadow Weaver had to admit to being *envious* of the Queen. The witch had never had much charisma, even before her face was ruined due to the Rite of Obtainment. She worked with fear, not love, and while good at deception, she'd never had prey that *wanted* to be fooled, the way so many in Brightmoon seemed to- the way that *Catra* had fooled herself into thinking a piece of paper *mattered,* or that being adopted by Angella even mattered. Shadow Weaver would bet her magic that Angella never thought of the girl as her daughter in her own mind, but always as "the She-Ra"- but Catra would never know that. Angella was too charismatic.

Still, I probably couldn't have done it anyway, so no use regretting it now.

Yes, that was the truth, most likely. If Shadow Weaver was being honest with herself, she had to acknowledge that she probably *couldn't* have pulled off the mom bullshit with Catra, even if she'd tried. She simply had no tolerance for stupidity or immaturity, and thus, no ability to play house with the whining girl. She'd have went mad a week in to the attempt.

So hat's off to the Queen, who has figured out how to make a slave of the most powerful warrior on the planet, Shadow Weaver thought. *Thankfully, I have a new option to gain power that has nothing to do with the brat...*

Ah, yes. The Heart, which would put the She-Ra to shame... she'd get to kill Catra, and wouldn't *that* be fun? It'd horrify the girl, to be killed by the woman she'd wanted to be her mother.

Yes, Shadow Weaver would put yesterday behind her. Yes, she'd lost her chance to take the She-Ra, but so what? Crying and spilled milk, after all, and all similar sayings. Best to work towards a new opportunity rather than lament a lost one.

"...Are you sure we shouldn't... help?" Scorpia finally managed the courage to say, as they passed another scene of carnage, where a few Hordesmen, surrounded by corpses, were quickly patching up their own wounds and robbing the dead to upgrade their equipment.

"How?" Shadow Weaver responded wearily, annoyed by the distraction.

"...How?" Scorpia asked, unsure and nervous.

(It *did* bring a little smile to Shadow Weaver's face, the fear Scorpia still clearly felt in her presence. Years of being the Fright

Zone's scariest commander and local boogeywoman had not gone to waste, at least.)

"Yes, *how,*" Shadow Weaver said, as they passed down a dusty alleyway. Distantly, great sounds of collapse and war- almost like buildings being torn down- echoed, but they were fading in the distance, going away from them- not a concern at the moment. "What will you do? Your clumsy pincers cannot wrap bandages around the bleeding, and you are not strong enough to stop this war- not as you are."

Scorpia frowned, and Shadow Weaver took the opportunity to press her advantage.

"But once you touch the Garnet, and link up with its power," Shadow Weaver purred, "we will have all the strength we need."

(*Well, **I'll** have all the power I need... foolish girl.*)

Scorpia, biting her lip, not wanting this but unable to think of another option, thus kept following the monster to the end of all things.

*****CATRA OF ETHERIA*****

Having a Runestone is awesome!

Not exactly the most erudite observation Octavia had ever made, she'd be the first to admit; but *damn,* it was hard to focus on being a wordsmith when you were having so much fun blasting shit!

So thinking, she glanced over the fray, taking in the battlefield with a commander's senses; a land war, not the naval battles she was better at, but some of the same principles applies. The big one was concentration of force, a task the Princesses were failing at. Frosta and Mermista had plenty of power to defeat Dreer and Octavia... but they weren't alone, and were spread thin protecting the otehrs, their attention split in too many directions to generate the force needed to turn the tides. It helped that the dead didn't drown, and the energies animating them ran hot, melting them out of the ice Frosta kept trapping them in; the Princesses were ill-suited to fight the undead.

There was also the additional factor that was Octavia getting chances to take potshots with the Crystal Spider- ooh, she thought she saw an opportunity!

She called on it, felt the bottomless well of might answer- like drinking the heart of a star, so much *power*- and then a white-hot lance of purest force was blazing out of her eyepatch, *boiling* the ground where it hit, scarring the sheet metal and concrete of the Fright Zone into unnatural lava. The shot, aimed at a group of the bee-themed soldiers- Crownless of some kind, she vaguely recalled. Not important.

But Mermista took time out to save them, using a swift blast of water to slide them out of the way- there was no blocking the Crystal Spider's shots, you dodged or you died- and that meant a zombie got a damn good hit in before she could recover, her nose burst apart on her face like a red flower.

Octavia's grin grew, even as her body reeled momentarily, as if she'd just lifted a huge boudler over her head and thrown it. It was draining as hell to use the Spider, but she was a tough girl, she could take it.

And the *reward*- power to make even *Princesses* back the fuck off! She felt like one of the nameless gods!

It fit well with her Horde sensibilities, to make powerful people fuck off... not that she was all *that* attached to her supposed nation, but it *was* kinda amusing. Felt like the whole rhetoric in a single act- making the world's titled lords fall back before someone who'd *earned* her goddamn strength.

Course, Octavia thought to herself as the dizziness passed, *that's all bullshit.*

Just crap to make the people believe they were better than they were. Truth was simpler- nobody wanted *equality.* They just wanted inequality that favored *them.* The Horde was just reinventing the social hierarchy, not making a *better* one.

Which was why she liked Dreer; he was the only other person who got it, who *saw* the bullshit the way she did.

We don't lie to ourselves... We don't want an equal playing field, we want to be ***on top.***

It's why she was so pumped about Dreer getting his magic back. She *got* Dreer, as he got her; the fact they were both such nakedly-ambitious bastards was weirdly helpful to their friendship, kept it genuine. Honest. Both knew they'd backstab each other for gain in a second… but thus also understood that they were *safe* from each other so long as gain was not a question. Plus, a person couldn't be strong all the time- so they could guard each other, meaning they had more to gain from working together than apart.

That was going to be especially true now, with Dreer's magic back.

He can't hold a Runestone, not now, she thought with glee. *Those old scrolls said this kind of magic is rejected by the Runestones. Which means* ***I*** *get one… not the Ember. I want the Garnet. One that's less likely to blow me up.*

The Garnet didn't even *have* a Princess, unless Shadow Weaver counted; sure, rumor insisted Scorpia was the "real" Princess, but she'd been sent to *Beast Island,* the bitch was dead.

A Runestone Princess... Adora might say no, but really, that'd be quite the mistake! It wasn't like Octavia hadn't betrayed a boss before, and even someone as strong as Adora had to sleep- had to eat.

Maybe time for another poison-pen letter...

She hoped it wouldn't come to that- Adora wasn't a bad boss by any means- but hey, she liked to keep her options open!

(She fired another shot, nearly catching Frosta- and missed Sea Hawk pulling out his lighter in the midst of the melee.)

They'd revive Adora afterwards as undead under Dreer's command, see if they could keep the Ember under control that way. If not, Dreer knew a spell to teleport it back to its homeland- a simple spell, apparently, it'd just take an enormous amount of magic to send it back. Dreer could take that magic from living things, though, so no big deal- a few living people to drain to death and he'd be fine.

Really, all they had to do was survive today, and they were well on track for it.

One more shot did she send in, before deciding to cool it. She didn't want to tire herself out. While she didn't make the energy- the Spider did- she *did* have to use her own resources to *channel* that energy, and damn, that was like handling live coals with your bare fucking hands. If she wasn't careful, she'd hurt herself- or worse, pass out.

But that’s also why she had Dreer here.

Nobody can be strong all the damn time, she thought with amusement. *And it turns out, I do trust the man- at least as far as I can throw him. Maybe even an inch farther.*

It’d been a bit of a surprise once he told her his plans… but him sharing them with her made her realize he was trusting *her,* and that had made her realize she trusted *him,* too. She was no stranger to clandestine actions- she’d helped Shadow Weaver kill the Magicats in the Horde after that *bitch* Catra cut her eye out, at least until Vultak took the few survivors down south with him- but this was pure treason, and Dreer had risked his life telling her.

So she felt alright trusting her own life into his hands; she had his, after all.

(He'd even sworn to try and bring her back as a sentient undead if she died; unlikely, he'd said, but he'd try. She appreciated the attempt!)

She paused, idly flicking multiple swords through her tentacles, watching as the battle began to draw to an inevitable close- as inevitable as her own rise to power.

The world is my oyster, and I plan to shuck the bitch.

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Goal of AI designated Light Hope

(**10101010100stoptheheartofetheria010101010101**)

Unnecessary code fragments detected.

Initiating purge of unneeded data.

…

Purge complete.

Goal of AI designated Light Hope:

Primary Goal: Activate the Heart of Etheria on planet 1221986, designation by native inhabitants “Etheria”.

Status: Approaching Completion.

All enemy forces were distracted. Scorpia was on her way, guarded by a local magician and a local shaman-queen. Control over the Hordebots meant they, too, could clear the way; combined with Light Hope's control over the radio and communications network of the Horde, and no resistance was expected until the Garnet itself. Rebels would be fought there, but Light Hope was preparing for that, too.

Some Horde forces were heading to the Spirit Ember; Light Hope dedicated a portion of the Crystal Castle's teleportation machinery to the Spirit Ember, to hurl it back to the area the Etherian natives designated the Flame Waste... though only after its initial malfunction slew some of the Horde soldiers and burned the local area. She could not destroy it- no such command had been given by her superiors- but she could move it to prevent it from hurting the Garnet and rendering her efforts pointless.

(101010101011nosuchcommandwillevercometheyaredeadstopthisstopthis1010101010101010)

Everything was going according to plan.

Soon the Heart would awaken, and the stars would be wiped clean, so the Eternians could grasp forever in their hands.

She would smile, if she knew how.

(101010100110marataughtmetosmiletolaughtolovemaraImsosorry10000101010101010111)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

It was beautiful and horrible in equal measure, and her mind could not parse out all the information it was receiving.

(*too many eyes too many legs too many heads too many too many too-*)

All Perfuma knew, even amidst the horrible pain wracking her red flesh in the middle of her green flesh, was that she *relished* this feeling.

A new thing, this feeling! Because when had she *ever* loved *pain?* It was *pain,* it sucked! It hurt! It was, by definition, the opposite of *pleasure,* which was the thing a person actually wanted!

But no pain had ever been like *this* pain, in all the days of her life she had never been like this before; arrayed in all her glory, no king had ever been cloaked like this before, and only four Princesses had ever been this way either.

(*Glory Lily Glory Lily Glory-*)

Full, she was full from top to bottom with pain, *green* pain, growing pain and birthing pain and bursting pain. She was midwife of the energies she channeled and the pregnant mother and the child inside all three at once, her own fucked-up trinity,

the vessel of the power and the wielder of the power and the power itself all at once, all this power poured into her cup.

(*and I runneth over I runneth over I runneth-*)

She had become every fruit that burst on the vine, too-greedy for nutrients and water from the mother plant, tearing her own skin in her ripeness. She had become every sunflower grown too big as it chased the light, toppling itself over on a stem too weak to keep up the head. She had become every vine that grew so much it strangled itself, twisted up in its own branches.

She was a seed full of too much spring, and it *hurt,* and it was *good.*

And some part of her...

Relished this.

(*it is good, it is good, it is good, let me drink of this cup forevermore, let me drink of this cup and be the cup and the thing poured into the cup, it is good, it is good, it is-*)

A rocket slammed into her side; it meant nothing. It did her no harm whatsoever. Her original body, coated in vines, laughed from the safety of her nest, deep in the warplant's form; outside, her greater body lashed out with a single head, vomiting bitterlye all over her would-be killer. Other heads kept watch as her great pincers ripped and tore through the buildings before her, carving a

trail of devastation as she went, big and loud and impossible to ignore.

And thus did she attract attacks that would have been aimed at her weaker friends, risking her life both to enemy attack and falling apart from her own might so that others could be safe.

She was finally, finally, *finally* doing what a good Princess of Plumeria *should* do.

And it was *amazing!*

It was exhilarating, to come here, the Fright Zone, where she had walked as a person and a raider twice now, one time ill-fated, one time lucky-starred; but she did not come here this time as a person. No, no, this time she came as a *monster,* third time was the charm and the charm was *power!* Where she had walked with her own two feet, now she charged with a dozen, to trod the great capitol of the Horde beneath her. She was storming the Fright Zone, named for having thrown out a Glory Lily invasion in the past and scaring her ancestors; but the warrior's capitol could not stop Perfuma in the present. Each step she took was a trespass, each action an insult, but the Fright Zone *could not stop her.* It was throwing everything it had at her, but as her ancestor had once been found wanting by the Scorpioni outside the gates, now did Perfuma find the Horde wanting *inside* the gates.

And she *loved* it.

(*Fight, my foes! Fight! Fight! It will avail you nothing! I am upon you! I am-*)

Her mind, scattered in ten billion directions, the unsuited nerve center for a newborn body that was nothing like her human form, that had too many legs and too many heads and no hands at all, nonetheless had time to think, to ponder, to… realize. To gaze at what she was doing with awe, and wonder... and understanding.

The truth was obvious now.

She really *was* descended from a Glory Lily.

She had to be. Where else did her bloodlust come from? She'd always wondered, but now it seemed so… simple. She liked fighting because she *was* a Glory Lily's descendant; some part of her had inherited the conqueror's joy that had partly motivated her ancestors. It hadn't been the whole thing- there were many reasons the Glory Lilies did what they did- but that same singsong bloodlust *was* a part of it, and it had carried down to Perfuma.

Such a small answer. Such a simple thing. No wonder she hadn't known she'd had that part of herself, not until the day Catra came to Thaymor, so long ago now it felt like a fever dream. Catra, holy She-Ra,who was her mortal friend now but had come to her a divine stranger, with an invitation in her hand to join her in her secret garden.

A garden named *war...*

Where Perfuma had proven to be a most able invasive species, fertilized by corpses, watered by blood, ever-growing.

(She still remembered that first battle, and blood on her face- how it had felt so natural she hadn't even noticed it. Blood, to fuel her. Blood, to uplift her. Blood, the only drink fit for a Princess at war.)

A sense of grandeur and power, a sense of… *glory…* filled her, and the heady sensation, combined with how split her attention was, threw her mind through more journeys than any drug she'd ever smoked or drink she'd ever had.

(*Buildings crumble in my wake; artifice rots at my merest touch! Tanks and guns and planes and troops- send them all! They are not enough! They are not enough! They are not-*)

But even as dazed as she was, as drunk as she was on her own power...

Still she did not kill anyone.

For she was *Perfuma,* a woman who had been scared of her own might since she was a child; and so it was control she'd learned, first and foremost, and all the gentle ways of her power.

And she was also *Perfuma,* who loved, and believed in love, who worshiped the All with all her heart; and while she had killed

before, it was nothing like the scale of damage she could do now. She could kill so *many,* if she were not careful, if she ever lost *control.*

It was hard, not to. Hard, with all this power all this pressure all this *pain.*

(*green pain growth pain birthing pain my cup runneth over my cup-*)

But not *impossible*.

And so the irony was that Perfuma, bloodthirsty and berserk as any of her ancestors, was managing the first siege in all of history in which no one at all died.

She would have blood on her face, but not on her hands.

(*Is that now how it should be? It all fits, after all. My ancestors invaded the Fright Zone and ruined Dryl for their own selfish goals; now I fight on behalf of Dryl, invading the Fright Zone for the* ***right*** *reasons. The cycle is complete. It all fits... no, it* ***All*** *fits!*)

Her flesh laughed, even as her wooden snakeheads spat bitterlye, and her claws crushed, and her great warplant advanced.

(Of course, of course, of course. I've been so silly, I should have realized it already- the ***All.*** *It All fits. The All is* ***All****, not just the pleasant parts. Maybe every thing has a growing season, a time it*

*is meant for, maybe **All** things have a place in the All, even this, even this, even this. Maybe there is a time when a Glory Lily is not wrong but right. Maybe I don't have to be a monster, or be afraid, but can be some new third thing... maybe I already am. A new third thing, a new third thing, a new third-*)

On and on she went. She tore into the Hordesman forces, snatching up weapons and vehicles in serpent-heads and scorpion-claws, ripping them up. Enemies fled before her, and those that tried to take a stand were swiftly eliminated.

But she killed *no one.*

Every Hordesman she met, she spared. Blasted with bitterlye, and thus stripped of weapon and armor, they were no threat to her; she ignored them after their defeats. Even those she'd not been trying to kill, who were endangered because of their own actions or side effects of Perfuma's, she moved to spare, and save. and when her actions threatened a death, she instead moved to spare. Soldiers falling from collapsing buildings she grabbed gently with deadly pincers, to be put on the ground; soldiers trying to hide inside of buildings she caught, too, with her snakehead tails, smelling the red blood in their veins with her green senses, tasting the warm meat that the predatory plants she'd based them on wanted to digest... but she did not bite. She simply took them gently in her many fangs, and put them down outside after a dusting of bitterlye. She would spill no blood, today.

Behind her was a long trail of naked and terrified Hordesmen... but she left no corpses in her wake.

(do my best not to hit buildings, crushing them, can cause casualties. Clear them first, be as gentle as a giant can be, then go through. Kill no one. I am not a Glory Lily. I am not a Glory Lily. I am not a-)

She was a *little* like a Glory Lily, in the ways that were superficial, outside, didn't matter.

(*I am not a killer. I am not a killer. I am not-*)

But she was *not* a Glory Lily in the ways that mattered.

(*I am better than that,* and somehow, despite going half-mad, that thought did not endlessly repeat in the echo chamber of her own mind, but remained single and solid in the center, a firm place for her roots to grasp onto, a rock to which sanity could cling. *)*

She would do this right. She would not be a coward or a Glory Lily but something *better* than either; she would redeem herself and her legacy both. Sweet Bee, stinging as her words were, had been right- she had not committed herself as she should have. There was work to be done.

And so today Perfuma committed to the work.

She was making bitterlye, the weapon that had once ruined Dryl, into a tool of mercy, and all in the *service* of the Princess of Dryl; and that was another legacy interlocking, because Entrapta was

one whom Perfuma had *failed* once before, and who now loved her, honored her with that love.

All things were coming to a conclusion, as they should; **All** things indeed. The circle was completing.

Going mad from her own power and split attention, somehow still finding the impossible strength to spare her foes and commit the first invasion with no casualties in all recorded history, Perfuma, mind and morals holding together only by the thin and impossibly strong ivy of her own willpower, stormed endlessly forward, clearing the way in the Fright Zone for the collapsing Doom Balloon behind and above her.

CATRA OF ETHERIA

"She let us go!" the eldest of the Hordesmen before Krystala swore as she backed up into a corner, Krystala's gun trained on her and her two subordinates. "Your boss, she let us go!"

"Answer my questions, and you will live," Krystala said, not bothering to explain how the Rebellion's leadership actually worked. Spinnerella was not her master any more than Krystala was her servant; that wasn't how it worked.

(And she'd lie about it if asked. Her goals mattered; what she did in pursuit of them did not.)

"...Really?" the eldest Hordesman asked, full of childish trust. She was young, naive, and had been spared once today already. Perhaps she thought the pattern would continue.

(She was wrong; but that was good. She wouldn't realize the deception.)

"You have my word," Krystala lied without pause.

"What do you want to know?" she asked.

"We can't say anything!" one of the other Horde soldiers argued behind her. "We can't betray the Horde!"

"There is no Horde!" the oldest said. "We're getting out of here- I'm not risking any of you! We almost *died,* no support, I won't let my cadet class be killed- not by Rebels, and *definitely* not by our *own* at that! Fuck Adora, fuck Grizzlor, *fuck the Horde,* we're getting out of here!"

"I can assist," Krystala lied again, seizing the opportunity. "I can take you to the Rebellion, and from there you can go further north."

“Perfect!” the leader said.

“I... if you think that's the right idea,” the timid boy behind her said. “I'm with you.”

“...Me too, I guess,” the other said.

Krystala ignored the byplay. It didn't matter.

“What is the Spirit Ember?” she asked. “The new Horde weapon you mentioned?”

“It's a Runestone,” the oldest said. “Something she brought back from the Crimson Waste. Don't ask me how, but she found one... Grizzlor's people were saying she was a Princess. I didn't... it wasn't important, but I guess... I guess Grizzlor thought it was... but I don't care about that now. I just... I just want to get out of here with my cadets intact. I want... I want to save my family.”

“...A Runestone?” Krystala asked, head cocking to the side. A Runestone... a lot of power there. Power to kill many...

“She's real fucking weird about it,” the timid boy said. “Calls it her sister in sin, she put most of her defenses there... she's probably there right now, actually.”

“...Is she,” Krystala did not so much ask as state. “Where is it?”

“Here's a map,” the eldest said as she drew it from her pocket. “It's marked on it. We're... here, I think.”

She unfurled the map and tapped on it.

“Come here,” Krystala said, lowering her weapon and holding out her good hand. “Hand me that map, and I'll tell you where to go to get out of here. We used an old sewer entrance, it'll be safe.”

The head Hordesman smiled gratefully at the lie, approaching almost cheerfully.

“I told you guys we'd get out!” she said as she handed the paper over.

They were her last words. Krystala lifted her gun and fired once, point-blank, shotgun blast. The Hordesman died with that smile still on her face.

The others screamed. Krystala paid no attention as she studied the map, her gun firing on something close to autopilot as she gutted the other two with buckshot, dying in pain and screams. She didn't even glance at the corpses.

Krystala left the three corpses behind as she marched onwards, heading towards the Ember, hunting Adora's head.

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Entrapta, alone on the Doom Balloon, ignored the warnings blinking on her panel, silencing each alarm as it burst into raucous existence, dying in a squallor of silence.

She did what she could to calm the instruments, which was very little, all while observing as the Fright Zone- which had been *his*- died on all the visual monitors she could access.

She unconsciously rubbed at the old Horde flag on her arm.

Adora had, to her list of sins, added one more- the destruction of *his* life's work.

How **Entrapta** hated **her.**

(Like how much she hated herself, now.)

It was a bit of fuel for Entrapta, who had been running on empty since she hurt Catra and Glimmer, since her last betrayal, since she had taken someone who had held up a promise to *him* and betrayed her, since she had spat in Queen Angella's face all her kindness by hurting her daughter, since she had...

Since she had done... what she always does.

Entrapta is poison.

The thought almost smothered the fire inside her again, this last and final understanding of how alone she would always be- of how it was her own fault that she would always be alone, of how her constant backstabbings and betrayals have left her bereft of any friends to replace the family she lost before she could even know them- too heavy to bear, like a mountainslide or an avalanche...

Another siren went off. She glanced at it, the fire barely alive- just embers, but there.

And with that drop of fuel, she was finally able to admit what was happening to herself.

The great airship was dying.

It had a few minutes left, but little more than that, no matter what Entrapta did. It would not explode, at least, Entrapta had put precautions in place for that... but neither would it survive. It would fall apart in the air and slam against the ground as the power finally died, foams and fluids putting out any potential fires, though she was certain the impact would be immense.

An inevitable result of pushing a machine far past its limits, and not the Doom Balloon's fault. It was never meant to cross the continent at such speed, it was never meant to go so fast, it was never meant to be subject to this much abuse across this much distance without repair or refit. No, it had been meant to be a weapons factory, a support platform for Emily's Big Sister, pumping out drones and machines... but now it was destined to never be anything but wreckage.

Entrapta had become so poisonous she was even ruining machines now, the sole things she'd ever taken comfort in before, the things she'd thought she'd never lose.

Just another thing she'd lost in the last few hours. All her plans had fallen apart in the span of a single conversation... a single betrayal. All her plans... and all her hopes and dreams.

She'd lost... everything.

Because **Adora** had to die.

(It was not as comforting for her to think that as it had been, even as it stoked the fire inside. Her **hate** was still strong, but

split now, half of it for **her** and half of it for **herself**, and so the fire burns as much as it fuels her now.)

But now... why bother? The others could finish things. She only had assistance because no one knew what she'd done, not yet; *Perfuma* did not know she'd betrayed Catra and Glimmer, nor did Scorpia and Shadow Weaver. They didn't know that **Entrapta** was poison, not yet, and... well, wouldn't it be better if she just stayed away?

Or... stayed onboard the ship.

After all, her problems were older than **Adora**. They'd always been there. All her life she's had so much trouble with others, after all; and now... now it was hard to believe the problem wasn't her. It was not the world that was wrong, but herself; how else can she view it, after her betrayals? She was the viper that bit the farmer who tried to care for it, and the fact that Entrapta too was hurt in the biting... that wasn't important.

She was still biting, after all.

She bit the Alliance first by listening to **Adora.** Then she bit the Horde by joining the Alliance again. Then she bit Catra, who had been so kind, who had upheld her promise to *him,* who had never been anything but a friend... and got two-for-one by biting Glimmer and, thus, through her, Angella, who had also kept one of *his* promsies.

(Glimmer, who had joined her in this Council of the Wise, had named it, had named the Doom Balloon, and had been... had been a friend, or at least, on the way to being one, as she would never be now.)

So many people, who gave so much, who assisted her so much... who, in return, get only venom.

Perhaps...

Perhaps **Entrapta** should just stay on the Doom Balloon.

Until the end.

So she doesn't hurt any more friends, ever again.

(And maybe when she dies there will be a garden, and *her,* or a lab, and *him,* or best of all *both,* combined into one perfect moment in the way the poets of her people hoped for, repeated over and over again, the lone antidotes to her own toxin she had ever found.)

And she almost committed to it, almost stayed... save a single nagging thought.

What if **Adora** did not die?

What if, after everything, **Adora** survived? Catra wouldn't kill her. Maybe the others might think they did, but miss. Maybe... maybe **Adora** might live.

...

She can't risk it.

She can't risk **Adora** living , can't go into that peaceful rest without knowing that **Adora** was dead. She had given up too much, had thrown away too much beauty, had done far too much to quit now. Once **Adora** was a cold corpse, then **Entrapta** could kill herself, spare all Etheria the horrible poison of her person in its veins... but not beforehand.

She had to kill **Adora.** Nothing else would make it all mean something- and there was so much she'd done. She had lost all of her friends and thrown away ever kindness to get here, had only Scorpia and Shadow Weaver with her now, and *Perfuma* down below, none of whom knew of what she'd done to Catra and Glimmer, didn't know she was poison, didn't know that **Entrapta** was **poison** and ruined everything she had ever touched.

...They needed to leave the Balloon.

She turned her head, to speak, and realized she was alone. A thought dredges up a semi-memory, of Shadow Weaver and Scorpia leaving, something she had barely registered at the time; a quick glance at the panel indicated that at least one escape shuttle was gone.

Hmm.

She... hadn't noticed them leave. Not with her conscious mind.

(She forgot to say goodbye to a friend. Just another poison, a lesser venom. Even when she wasn't doing anything at all, she was somehow still biting those who cared for her.)

Shaking that off, she staggered up from the control panel, turning the engine down from its frantic, breakneck pace. Too late to save the Doom Balloon, but it would buy some time- maybe a full hour. Then she set the autopilot to take it out into the deepest desert, outside the Zone; a quick glance below showed that *Perfuma* was sparing Hordesmen, and Entrapta would not do anything to harm the wondrous Plumerian's attempts at mercy. The Balloon would collapse in the desert, and hopefully its approach would give time and warning for anyone out there to leave the area.

Then the Drylborn Princess headed to the hospital they had onboard, where Micah and Scorpia had first rested, and brought what few drones she had left with her. **Adora** was likely to be armed and surrounded by guards; to fight them, Entrapta had no drone army, did not have the humongous mecha of Emily's Big Sister, or her own robots.

But she had an idea.

With the help of the drones and using them for some quick spare parts, sheet metal from the Balloon itself, improvised explosives of wire and batteries tucked into her hair for easy throwing, and various medical equipment repurposed into a somewhat gorilla form, Entrapta built herself a combat mech out of spare medical parts with no more help than a few drones, all in the span of, perhaps, fifteen minutes.

(Even as her world melted around her, she couldn't help but feel a moment's pride as she looked at the last thing she would ever make. Even if it had a lot of medical gear she would never need to use.)

And with that done, she left on the last escape pod, to join the chaos of the city's battle, and find **Adora**, to put an end to all this, one way or another.

And no matter what happens, I can finally stop.

<u>*CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>**

Of all the opposition Shadow Weaver had expected, this gaggle was *not* on her list.

“I'll admit,” she said, to the Rebels gathered before her, along with Glimmer and Bow, “I wasn't expecting the Great Rebellion to be guarding a Horde Runestone. It feels as if there's a joke in here, somewhere.”

“No joke here, Shadow Weaver,” Spinnerella said, standing before her.

“But if you try to get to the Black Garnet, we've got a punchline that'll leave you in *stitches!* ” came a familiar voice, laughing from somewhere nearby.

“...Glimmer?” Shadow Weaver said, raising an eyebrow. “What are you doing here?”

“Eh, mostly trying to save the world, the usual,” Glimmer said, peeking out from above her. “Scorpia! If you touch the Garnet, the Heart kills us all! Don't touch it!”

“...What?” Scorpia said, staring in surprise at Glimmer.

“They are wrong,” Shadow Weaver told the brutish Princess. “They fear what they don't understand; but Entrapta was correct. Trust her.”

“Maybe we should... not?” Scorpia tentatively asked her, but Shadow Weaver shook her head.

“Don't you want to stop all this fighting?” Shadow Weaver asked her, tempting her with the thing she wanted most- as all good temptations did. “You need power to do that.”

“But if they're right...” Scorpia tried to argue.

“Then you can do nothing about all this death,” Shadow Weaver stated coldly. “Either you can solve this, or you can't. Which do you choose?”

And Scorpia, caught by her own kindness and desire to stop the horrors around her, nodded, her hopes blinding her.

With Scorpia tamed, Shadow Weaver needed assistance... but if she wasn't wrong, she could hear help coming from nearby.

“Get out of our way,” Shadow Weaver ordered the gathered Rebels.

“Surrender, or we will kill you,” came one last familiar voice- Bow, the meaningless archer who was part of Catra's group, if Shadow Weaver did not miss her guess.

“Are you *threatening* me?” Shadow Weaver scoffed. “You, the soft bowman?”

“Yes,” he responded, not rising to her taunts.

“You don't have the guts,” the witch mocked. “And Glimmer... have you not told them you helped us get here?”

“I have!” Glimmer responded. “Hell, I thought it was a good idea! But then I realized it wasn't! Just like Scorpia should!”

Scorpia's resolve crumbled a moment later, her looking unsure once again... hmm. Shadow Weaver might have to start this fight just to keep Scorpia focused...

Then the sound of buildings falling grew closer.

Ah, help arrives.

At some point in their travels, Perfuma had gotten distracted with a hardpoint of defense, veering off course to deal with it. In that time, Shadow Weaver and Scorpia had gotten ahead of her... but now she'd caught up.

Bursting through a nearby building, Perfuma's great warplant roared as it entered the battlefield.

LET US THROUGH! the many mouths screeched.

"Fuck that!" came the response, as a missile went flying from an Erelander Rebel, one that wielded some shoulder-mounted First Ones tech weapon.

(And then there was no more time for words.)

Chapter End Notes

Up next: Things keep rolling on!

Chapter 67: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: To Put Out the Fire

Chapter Notes

MORE UPDATE!

We draw closer to the end!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A BATTLE FOR THE AGES

Part Three:

To Put Out the Fire

Getting her ass kicked by Adora in the Fright Zone was weirdly nostalgic, which had not been high on the list of emotions Catra had expected to feel today.

Nonetheless, the emotion persisted, and it wasn't hard to think of why, as Catra dodged another attack, a jet of flame so intense that it burned not red but white at the center, the blue-white of the hottest fires. It glassed the area of the Fright Zone it touched, leaving nothing but scar-seared ground behind, giving birth to obsidian and all matter of volcanic rocks, here, so many miles from the active peaks of northwestern Etheria.

Nostalgia persisted, because this was just like *that* day- the most important of Catra's life- the day she'd stolen that skiff. The day Adora had beaten her in training, though that wasn't uncommon; Catra knew better than to defeat Shadow Weaver's pet project. She had to lose fair and square so Adora could be showered in praise, and losing was all fair and square would get her, because Adora was more skilled than she was, even though Catra was faster and stronger.

Those rare times when Catra, unable to stop herself, had cheated to win, all it had resulted in was yet more punishment, never praise. Catra, who was hurt when she lost and hurt when she won, but letting Adora win at least came with the upside that Adora smiled a little more… and that was enough for her.

Here, again, she was in the Fright Zone, losing to Adora, and it felt… almost like home.

And perhaps, if Catra had never had a *real* home- if she had not known what it was to go somewhere, and be loved, be heard, be *safe*- if she had still been the lost little girl she'd once been… perhaps she'd confuse this *with* home. Perhaps she would think this was where she was meant to be.

A terrible thought, to imagine what that Catra might do, so alone, so hateful, so *broken…* just imagining it made her heart ache. She would be…

Adora, perhaps.

Or something like a mirror image of her- perhaps Lord of the Horde, too, but of a lonelier and more maniacal bent. Adora had dignity even in her madness; Catra knew herself better, now, than to think she'd be nearly as well-kept.

If she confused this with *home*, it would destroy her.

These feelings, so strange, pumping through her, just like the situation itself was strange. Adora chased her, and Catra ran- and that never happened, Catra was *the She-Ra,* she ran from nothing!

And right now, nothing had the name *Adora*, whose laughter and screaming and sheer literal *firepower* had put Catra on the backfoot since the start of the fight.

(Briefly, Catra remembered the general mood at that party, so long ago now, to celebrate Hordak's death; she hadn't attended, grieving her former Lord and all he might have become, but she'd still heard people suggest in the buildup to it that the war would be over soon, since Adora was just the inferior sequel to Hordak. She rather wished those people were here, now, to see all *this* bullshit.)

Catra had no idea where Adora was drawing this firestorm from, but the few close brushes with Adora's might she'd had *hurt,* even through the She-Ra's defenses and fast healing. This was quite an

upgrade; Adora must have found one hell of a book of spells, to be casting like this…

...Adora had mentioned a Runestone, hadn't she? But that couldn't be right. There was only one Runestone down here, the Black Garnet, and its nature was that of the Storm, not the Sun. And Adora wasn't the Princess of the Garnet- if she was, the world would already have ended, the Heart of Etheria firing off.

Perhaps... perhaps it was something Hordak had made, some supertech he hadn’t had a chance to use, something him and Entrapta had once worked on that Adora had completed? No one in the Fright Zone ever really knew what was going on in Hordak’s labs, though the general consensus was that he was working on something that would win the war outright if it worked. Was this that secret weapon? An artificial Runestone?

Or hell, was this normal for First Ones? Catra had only recently learned anything of her own people, from whom she derived her claws and her strength; maybe Adora had reconnected, too, and discovered this power inside herself. Yet another mirror between them, Catra rediscovering her heritage even as Adora did, too, two lost orphans reclaiming lost ancestry...

...But wait. Had her mother not... something Angella had said, once. Something about... fire.

A thing of trivia, something Catra barely remembered, would not have remembered at all but that Catra had always paid attention to every word of her mothers, both the monster and the angel.

Something Queen Angella had said, of a Flame Kingdom, of a Runestone, perhaps artificial, a First Ones' experiment..

And in that moment, Catra became the first person to realize what was powering Adora.

Of course, she thought with something like hysteria as she dodged between buildings, Adora's crazed and screaming laughter echoing down those valleys like the hunting call of hounds, the world cooking to ash and heat behind Catra as she raced like greased lightning from the fire. *Of course. I fell off a skiff and found something horrible the First Ones made, and Adora did, too, at some point; we keep mirroring each other, we keep copying each other, we keep circling each other, yin and yang, what is wrong with us, what is wrong with the world, that it would allow us to do this, that we would stand hero and villain forever and ever and all I want is for us to come* ***together***

(She hopes desperately in that moment that there are no gods, that fate is a foolishness, that there is nothing greater dictating the world; because if there is, if this is pre-ordained, then she must swear most deep and bitter vengeance, for the *cruelty* of all this, for the sadistic inventiveness, the sheer *awfulness* that has kept her from holding her most beloved for four years and counting now.)

These thoughts were background noise as the battle continued, most of Catra laser-focused on not getting burned. She rolled away from yet another white-hot jet of materialized fury, Adora ranting something about her sister in sin and about how much she hated Catra for being the She-Ra and wonderful and good and perfect, how it was all inevitable, she would always be the monster.

And sometimes she ranted that loving Catra hurt, because of that distance, that divide, echoing with her mouth the thoughts of Catra's mind.

Catra tuned it out. She had to. Ignoring the rambling of the woman she loved when she was like this was a survival skill at this point... and if she had listened, her shattering heart would have killed her as swift as the deadly flames of her beloved.

Adora’s chatter only stopped when she, caught in a fit of laughter, stopped while choking, suddenly horking up a ball of magma, like a dog puking up a bone. This attack, less a dragon’s breath and more a projectile vomit, came in the form of a ball of superheated force, magic coalesced into something deadly and *fast*- too fast for Catra to dodge.

Reflex alone saved her; she whipped the Sword up to tank the hit, the metal screaming as she abused it relentlessly, the Sword growing so hot so fast that it burned the fur off the back of her hands and singed her palms. Still she did not let go- that would be suicide- and instead took the flat of the Sword and her own talent for swordswomanship to redirect the attack, shifting its own momentum by inches until, by gentle degrees, she was able to force it to skip off of the Sword like a stone off a pond, sending it rocketing away into yet another building that promptly burst into flame.

(She hoped no one was in there. She prayed that the Silver would keep the place empty, even as she knew that prayer was not a guarantee of action... and briefly wondered if the Silver was offended by her recent hope that it did not exist, but put that aside in the heat of the moment.)

The entire thing took mere seconds, but it ruined an entire building. This whole fight was like that; the demolition derby of their battle was a wrecking ball through the heart of the Zone, and some part of Catra wondered if, even without the civil war consuming the Horde, their fight alone might be doing damage the Horde could never overcome. What they ruined in moments would take *months* to fix.

But she had no more time for such thoughts, because Adora was flying at her again on the jetblast of her fiery propulsion, and Catra had to roll to dodge the incoming shield, descending like a meteor on high.

*****CATRA OF ETHERIA*****

"*Catra!*" Angella screamed- and that freaked Micah out good, to hear his calm, angelic wife *scream* like that- as the firelord before them, the one in the Hordak cosplay, kidnapped their daughter and flew past them on wings of fire so hot that he felt his beard scorch just from being near their passage.

It had happened in less than seconds. Even Micah's reactions, so sharpened by years on Beast Island, had no time to save Catra or stop… whoever the hell that was.

(Ten silver said it was the mysterious Adora, whom Glimmer tried to fill him in on… though he'd noticed she only did it sparingly, and never in Entrapta's presence. A monster that Catra loved, was the gist of it… and though Glimmer had clearly been a little sympathetic to Catra for her love, her *fear* of this Adora was the thing that had shone through most- fear, in brave little Glimmer! Fear... and her protectiveness of her sister.)

The burning warrior, Catra in tow, rushed past them, collided with a building, and then went right *through,* like the hammer of some apocalyptic god; the building shuddered as further impacts inside rattled its outsides until it could take no more, collapsing in on itself like a shaken souffle of stone and ash.

"Catra! No!" the little Lunoth with him and his wife squeaked, terror in her too-young eyes; Micah, who had been a father since far too young, first to his little sister and then to Glimmer, could not help the pang of protectiveness that overwhelmed him momentarily at Flutterina's despair.

Angella lifted off to chase after them, wings beating hard against the air- but they were gone, so far, so fast, leaving literal walls of fire behind them, plowing through buildings that fell and crumbled apart in vast cataclysmic waves of dust, all with a deafening roar. It was like being at a volcano's rim during eruption, all ash and fire; Micah quickly raised a bubble of protectiveness around himself, his wife, and Flutterina, a spell he'd gotten so used to using on Beast Island that he wasn't even consciously aware he'd done it until it was complete.

His version muted sounds outside the bubble as well; that both kept him safe from the Island's... signal, or whatever the hell it

was, and let him get some sleep back then. Now, it meant they could talk to each other despite the unscheduled demolitions going on before them.

"Angie!" Micah yelled as his wife flapped in the air, clearly wanting to go outside of his shield despite the fact they couldn't even *see* anything but blackness around them from the collapsing buildings. "What are you doing? You'll die in that mess!"

"She's got my daughter," Angella said in response, quiet and sad as she descended to the ground, because she'd come to the same conclusion. "She's got my…"

She said nothing else, just stared out at the devastation, one hand unconsciously raised as if seeking to grab onto a shoulder no longer there. No matter how powerful a mother's love, it could not survive the firestorm before them. Even Micah's shield was barely holding, and they weren't even *that* close to the unscheduled demolition- but the pressure and force coming off of it were immense.

"Give it a minute," Micah said. "It'll clear up soon."

"She'll survive," Flutterina said, nervous and worried but putting on a brave face. "That's... she's *Catra.* She'll be fine! At least long enough for this to settle down..."

There was silence, for a moment, as Micah weaved magic to repair his shield when some burning chunk of building or another hit it... but the magic felt weird in his hands. It was something he'd sort-of noticed when they first got here, but he'd been busy fighting, and he wasn't totally sure he wasn't hallucinating it at first- he still had those, sometimes, his mind just a little too bent by Beast Island to be entirely stable.

But now in the relative calm he could distinguish what was madness in his mind from madness in the world, and the magic here belonged to the latter. His senses were sharp, sharper than they'd ever been, he could pick out individuals in the background magic here, that iron tang of stormy darkness that was the Black Garnet; he could feel the Moonstone in his wife next to him, a blended and woven thing of pinks and purples, the same way Glimmer's magic felt to him- save that pink was dominant in Angella and purple dominant in Glimmer, as they each preferred one or the other part of the Moonstone's light and darkness. The other always there, but one more prominent.

(And focusing on his daughter, he thinks he can sense, on the absolute northernmost parts of his range, his Glimmer, her darkness and her light; but there is just so *much* happening in the North, and it is so close to the Garnet, that the magic is a muddled mess. Amidst the ever-present tingle of the Storm are scattered vague impressions, more symbol than sense; a notion of circling winds, of encroaching shadow, of something huge and vast and green in this grand desert that *has* to be a mistake, because how can so much *life* be found *here,* in this polluted desert?)

Others, somewhere to his west- water and ice, fighting something that feels like jittery drugs in his veins, like coffee exploding the heart, and a thing that has no color or shape at all, save it gives

him the impression of a spider on the attack, of force unexpected and overwhelming.

All of this underlaid by the thing he had thought a hallucination before- the *heat,* the *fire,* the *volatility* of the magic around him. This was Summer at high hot heat, this was Light without Relent, this was like the Sun he'd read about in the absolute oldest textbooks, the same kind of books where what had once been Light Spinner had discovered the spell to make herself a monster. A drop of purest Fire, somewhere to their east.

He felt like he was drowning in it.

And a spark of that Fire was now pummeling Catra, a daughter he'd never known he had, whom he hoped to get to know, whom his wife loved so very much. A daughter he could sense easily even amidst all this chaos and heat, her spirit a glorious golden thunderbolt, like a lighthouse, like a beacon, like all Etheria woven into a single glorious shield.

(Though… at the very edges of her spirit… a sense of… chains? Of entrapment? Something that constrained and warped that light… and that was *terrifying* to consider, what force could chain the *She-Ra*… no, no, no, it must be his mind's madness, his subconscious fears, old traumas from the Island making new shapes for themselves… or so he hoped.)

"She's alive," he thought to say a moment after sensing her, realizing that the others wouldn't be able to do as he had. "I can tell. Still alive and fighting."

Angella's worries eased just a fraction, though Flutterina frowned at him.

"How can you tell?" Flutterina asked. "I can't see anything…"

"Magic!" he responded.

(While true, it was not helpful, a thing he completely failed to notice.)

"A sorcerer senses more than others," Angella said, stepping in for Flutterina. "And my husband is one of the best. If he says she's alive, she is."

Flutterina nodded, exhaling a breath, and Micah almost wanted to go on an entire lecture about how all of it worked. The very nature of sorcery was that of using the flow of magic on Etheria, not leaning too hard on any one Runestone or another, or even the more fluttery and insubstantial magical cores that were distinct from but weaker than those Runestones, but combining all of them together, a thing that required most discerning senses. Sorcerers could even beat Princesses in this one specific area; they had sensory powers of their own, but they didn't work like a sorcerer's did. His Angie, for example, had told him it was shorter-ranged, and more inward-focused, a way of sensing how other things would interact with her own Runestone than of how those things were themselves.

A common thing for the Princesses; something about being so connected to a Runestone interfered with sorceror's spellcraft, the

tie to one of Etheria's magics so strong it made it harder to work with other sources. Even Wild Princesses had some trouble with it, though not nearly as much as the Runestone ones did.

(Which in many ways made his Glimmer even more special and impressive, for she was both a Princess and a sorceress too- and a soldier, all three at once, and his heart almost burst for joy just *thinking* about how proud he was of his amazing daughter. Glimmer, whom he had last seen as a child, who had appeared before him as a brave and strong young woman, and then saved him from hell; what more could a father ask for?)

Oh yes, he wanted to lecture… but he had no idea where to start. Flutterina had no magic of her own, and it was always weird to explain that kind of thing… though he could feel a kind of… inertia, in her. Something that had been gathering speed for a long, long time. Maybe the rough chrysalis of something yet-to-be, a potential future, nothing that was destined or certain… but with work, with effort, with choice…

Perhaps this little one would surprise them all yet. Wild Princesses had been born from stranger people in simpler times… and the impossible was so commonplace these days. The She-Ra was back, the planet was a bomb, Hordak literally fell out of the sky one day and decided to conquer the world, and Micah had survived *Beast Island.* Really, the stranger something was, the more perversely expected it could be.

Maybe it was an illness they'd all caught from Catra, who as the She-Ra had to be patient zero of impossibility- well, her or Hordak, and Catra'd been near Hordak a long time as a Hordesman, so the effect was the same- and Flutterina *did* hang around Catra constantly. She'd be infected swift, she would.

And then I can tell her all about magic! he thought, managing a smile even in these circumstances.

(He knew how important it was, even in the worst situations, to smile. To laugh. To look death in the face and find something funny about it. Had he not learned that lesson first, he would have gone far more mad on the Island than he already had- he would have lost himself entirely.)

"What else can you sense?" his Angie asked him, and it drew him out of his musings.

"Oh, a lot- I think Mermista and Frosta- that's the current Salinean and Snows Princesses, right?" he asked, and when she nodded, he kept going. "They're west of us. They're… fighting something, I think. Weird magic I've never felt before. North is the Garnet, and I think things are happening there but it's impossible to tell, the Storm cloaks all of it… and the whole area feels wrong. Too hot. Like the magic's on fire, or molten, almost goopy like melted lead… What did Hordak *do* while I was gone?"

But the moment he said *fire,* something like a shock of revelation passed over Angella's face, and he saw her eyes light up with the Moonstone's magic as she looked at the world as a Runestone would, for a long, silent moment.

A long, silent moment that became two, then three, as her eyes widened, and her face grew deathly pale.

“She's not sensing anything good, is she?” Flutterina asked Micah.

“No, she's not,” he responded, before prodding gently with, “Angie?”

“...Not Hordak,” Angella whispered, voice so low he almost didn't hear her. “Not… not Hordak. I… oh no. Oh, *Silver,* it *can’t* be… but the powers Adora was wielding… no.”

Micah had heard his wife take a lot of tones- happy, sad, annoyed- but he had never, in all their life together, heard her be so *scared.*

He swallowed hard against a suddenly dry tongue, the hackles on the back of his neck and all the survival instincts of Beast Island suddenly screaming alarm.

“Angie, you're freaking me out,” Micah said, and did not notice he was whispering, too.

“Good,” she answered, as the moonlight left her eyes and revealed nothing but pupils wide with terror. “Because *the Spirit Ember* is *here. Active.*”

Spirit Ember...?

It took a few quick dives into his memories to bring up what those words meant in that order. An old class at Mystacor, about how the Spirit Ember couldn't be tamed. Mystacor had tried, too; the prize of a Runestone, even one as bizarre and dangerous as the Spirit Ember, had attracted the eyes of many a wizard over the years, Mystacor so hungry to be a true Runestone Kingdom and not merely honorary…

But all of them had *burned.* The Flame Waste remained a Waste because no one had *ever* figured out how to tame it. It was a cautionary tale in Mystacor unrivaled by any in Micah's time, though he'd come to understand that Shadow Weaver's own story ended up eclipsing it in recent years, at least from things Castaspella had told him aboard the Doom Balloon as they headed towards Brightmoon.

The Spirit Ember, the Runestone of Fire…

Huh, odd to realize that he'd first heard of it in a paper his own wife had written, a scientific paper that had been ancient when his grandparents- whom he never knew- had been born. A paper where Angella had hazarded a guess that the Spirit Ember was artificial, a First Ones' experiment of some kind... perhaps only a First One could really control it in the first place... perhaps that was why it had eventually devastated the land, when the First Ones left. Maybe that explained Adora being able to use it…

Sadly, Angella's paper had went no further than that in its speculations, though a few minor calculations and spellcraft had been done in its pages to prove that there *was* something fundamentally strange with the Ember. For someone who was a self-admitted hobbyist at best with tech and magic, they'd been

good formulas; Micah had checked her work himself as part of his homework on the subject.

(He'd gotten a good laugh out of Angella later by telling her that he'd been tested on her papers and gotten top marks, which was *obviously* a sign that they were meant to be- and the sheer absurdity of it had given her on and off fits of giggles for a day.)

That wasn't the focus, though; his Angie was not primarily a tech mistress or a scholar of magic, but a politician and historian. Most of the paper had been a long diatribe about the damage done when people tried to take over the Spirit Ember, even including an update written centuries later by Angella about how a particularly boneheaded attempt by mages from Mystacor and Silverglade both had precipitated a massive war on the western coast from its after-effects… and incidentally created the nation of Darkspur, northernmost of Etherian lands, if he recalled right.

A Runestone, odd and strange…

One that periodically drowned the world around it in magma and fire, a pyroclastic disaster even a volcano would struggle to recreate.

Swallowing hard once more as the implications washed over him, Micah turned his own wide eyes to the burning desolation around them, which now had all the weight of a prophetic vision.

"The fires around Adora... is she..." Angella said, trailing off, and what her words *implied* was…

Impossible… but I just got through thinking about how common the impossible really was. And if an evil First One is running around- and also apparently my new daughter's girlfriend? I need clarification on that point- then…

There may well be a new Fire Princess.

And really, I shouldn't be so skeptical; even back when things were more normal, as a kid I helped Light Spinner commit suicide in the form of Shadow Weaver, and then later as an adult managed to charm and marry an immortal angel. My whole life's rife with this bullshit.

*…Shit, I think **I'm** Patient Zero for all this.*

"What's a Spirit Ember?" Flutterina asked, and was ignored by the two adults, both consumed by the implications of this new information.

(Or, in Micah's case, wondering how to vaccinate others against impossibility, before reminding himself to focus on the here and now.)

"I had not felt this power in so long…" Angella said, shaking her head. "But my memory is never wrong."

“No wonder I didn’t know what it was, that thing hasn’t been used in…,” Micah said, shaking his head before moving on. “ And why move it down here? It’s next to the Black Garnet, by Silver and magic! If that thing goes off…”

“The Spirit Ember is *here,*” Angella half-whimpered, as she put one shaking hand to her mouth. “I've led my whole family into a *bomb,* the Fright Zone's going to- and the *Garnet's* here, what are we-”

And seeing her like this, even amidst his own distress, Micah did not fail to do what he did best; he went to her, and he held her, to give what comfort he could.

(His poor wife, who had to be so strong, always; maybe that was what had drawn him to her, that he had been forced to be so strong, too, made a parent too young. Maybe the fact they could be weak with each other was the root of their love.)

“Breathe, Angie,” he said to her, as he held her tight. “Breathe.”

She let out a shuddering breath, half-sob, but drew comfort and strength from him, her wings folding over him in her own form of hug, even as she shivered.

A moment later, another pair of arms- so tiny, so small, so little- joined them, as young Flutterina joined in the hug, not knowing *why* she had to do it, but knowing it was needed. Micah’s heart almost burst in its chest at the kindness in the gesture, and he

moved an arm to hug Catra's squire, too- as did Angella, whose wing shifted to accommodate.

(*I feel like I have a grandchild,* Micah thought, and wondered if "squire" was just how people talked about adoption these days. He'd been on the Island a while, it was possible!)

They passed a moment in peace like that, before Angella shuddered and stepped back; and the moment was what she'd needed, to reset, to think, to *plan.*

"…This is a problem," Angella began, which felt a bit underwhelming to say.

"Yes," Micah agreed, before remembering that Flutterina still hadn't been told anything. Turning to the patient girl, he said, "So, quick version, little one: Lord Adora, Catra's evil girlfriend- I think, but that's not important right now- has brought the Spirit Ember, a weird Runestone famous for being both unstable *and* exploding into storms of fire at random, and she has put it here in the Fright Zone, where we are. That means it's also right next to the Black Garnet, a Runestone that is vital to keeping Etheria functioning and *alive.* And we both know that we *won't* survive the Spirit Ember going critical, and we *don't* know if the *Garnet* will- and if the Garnet is destroyed, we all die regardless of how far we are from the firestorms."

Flutterina pondered that info for a moment as Angie chewed her lip, thinking.

"…Fuck," Flutterina finally said in her little squeaky voice.

"More or less," Micah agreed with her astute assessment of the situation.

"And we still have Scorpia to worry about," Angella muttered; she wasn't quite *complaining,* but Micah felt she had a right to a bit of a whine. This entire situation was getting more precarious every time he thought about it. "If she reaches the Garnet, we lose anyway…"

While Angella grumbled, Micah quickly checked his shield. It was fine; the rumbling was mostly over now, and things were starting to clear up. They could almost see outside the bubble again… which meant soon, they could get moving.

"So what do we do first?" Flutterina asked the Queen.

Angella thought a long minute, then sighed.

"...The Spirit Ember is the immediate problem," Angella said. "We're closer to it than to the Garnet, I know that much- though Micah, I'll need you to guide us to it, my senses aren't exact enough. And double-check to make sure I'm right, that we're closer to the Spirit Ember than the Garnet."

“We are,” he confirmed. “It’s directly east of us. The Garnet’s almost twice as far away to the north.”

“Okay. Then the Ember it is,” Angella said. “I wish I knew that there were forces at the Garnet defending it, but we must rely on the others for that. We are near the Ember, and the only other possible allies are too out of the way- you said you thought Mermista and Frosta were to the west, right?”

Micah nodded to confirm, and Angie kept going.

“We don’t have time to go there to get them, I’m afraid- though if you could send a message to them, that might be helpful. Everyone here is in danger, and if it were not for the Garnet, I’d almost risk teleporting us all out… but because the Garnet *is* here, all *Etheria* is in danger.”

“Maybe it’s far enough away?” Flutterina asked with a shrug. “He did say it was twice as far to the north as the Ember is to us eastwards…”

“The Flame Waste is *miles* across,” Angella said with a shake of her head. “If my husband can sense the Garnet at all, it is well within the Ember’s blast radius. And while we don't know if it would survive the Spirit Ember going off, we simply *can’t* risk it. If the Garnet dies, *everyone* dies. And worst of all… I think we’re running out of time.”

“Why?” Flutterina asked.

“Because the Spirit Ember always relied heavily on the emotional stability of its Princess to stay calm and productive,” Angella said. “And if Adora is its user, as I think is the only logical conclusion… then everything I have heard, from both Catra and others, is that Adora *has* no stability. And fighting Catra will only make it worse.”

There was nothing to say to that, so Flutterina and Micah simply looked towards the ground, processing that thought.

“We… we teleported our friends and family into a *bomb*,” Angella finally said, quiet once more, almost whispering her horror. “ And now we have to defuse it, or all the world dies…”

“So we just… can’t do anything about Scorpia, can we?” Flutterina asked, and Angie shook her head.

“No. This first,” she said. “ We have to get rid of it, either send it to the ocean, or somehow back to the Waste…”

Back to the Waste… wait a minute.

“…I think I can do that,” Micah said, his mind already racing through formulas. Teleporting was a bitch, magically speaking, ate up energy like nothing else, but he’d learned the ins and outs of it quickly because he’d had a teleporting baby. Combine his

knowledge of teleportation with the Moonstone's energies, his wife empowering him… make it a spell of return, which was a little easier on the flow of magic… and the Spirit Ember would already be magically attuned to the local magic of the Flame Waste, considering it had been sitting there burning for the better part of nearly a thousand years…

"You can?" Angella asked, and Micah couldn't help the daring grin that spread across his face.

"Maybe," he said. "I think it might well be."

Angella said nothing, but the corner of her lips almost tugged up into a smile, which Micah chalked up as a win.

(And Angella just *looked* at him with a kind of awed wonder, recognizing the look on her most beloved's face, on this man who saw a mountain as a challenge, whom never lacked for the courage she had never had. Her Micah, whom even Beast Island could not ruin, for his soul was unconquerable…)

"Then let's get to it," Angella said. "Once it's safe… we go. Get rid of the Ember… it might even help Catra. Perhaps teleporting it will break Adora's connection, or at least distract her."

"Side note, every time I've met that bitch she does something horrible," Flutterina complained. "First time I met her she'd already set a trap for She-Ra back in Elberon, shocked the hell out of her. And now she's both straight-up kidnapped her and

threatened to murder the planet. I thought they were in love- what's her problem?”

“We don't have enough time to get into it,” Angella said, then quietly muttered to herself, “Not nearly enough time. If she ever goes to a mind soother, they'll have enough material to write a book... I’ve a mind to pen one or two of my own.”

Micah winced at that assessment, as a man who had his own scheduled appointment with a mind soother lined up; he was in the same boat as Adora, after all. You could probably make a decent trilogy out of what his years on the Island had done to him.

To focus on other matters, he turned back to his shield, casting a wind spell to clear the area. The fires were not quite done yet, but in a few moments… .

“We'll be ready to go soon,” he informed his companions. “Should be safe.”

Angella nodded, as did Flutterina, though both looked out at the trail of fallen buildings, their corpses still giving birth to clouds of blazing ash and noxious smoke from the fire and the fall, the impassable way that separated them from Catra.

“If there wasn't the Ember to deal with,” Angella said, “I'd fly over that, or around it, but... I have to hope she's strong enough to

last until we can resolve this first. The Ember *must* be removed. Afterwards... afterwards, I go to my daughter- both of them, hopefully."

"You know where Glimmer is?" Flutterina asked.

"She will be where the fighting is thickest," Angella said, with something like a smile's ghost on the edges of her lips. "So likely with her sister... or at the Garnet."

Micah smiled at the thought of his daughter, brave and strong, as he lowered the shield and cast a spell to blow away the dust around them, revealing the Fright Zone once more.

(He missed her grow up… but at least she grew up *good.* That's a comfort, it is, albeit a cold one.)

As he finally felt safe to lower his shield, he made two birds, one to speak with Mermista, one to seek out the Ember.

"Alright, everybody," he said. "Follow the birdy! Not that one, this one!"

They took off into the warzone, heading east, moving as fast as they dared, hoping against hope they were not too late.

(And unknowingly setting themselves on a collision course with Grizzlor's troops... and with Lonnie, who had fallen in behind Grizzlor's forces, unknown to any.)

*****CATRA OF ETHERIA*****

Sea Hawk flicked his lighter, and felt the excitement that was matched only by his love for Mermista, that love of glorious flame, so bright and beautiful, so perfect and pure.

(Sometimes, he privately theorized to himself that he had been born in a water-loving nation because the nameless gods were doing their very level best to keep him from setting *everything* on fire, though he'd never shared this personal belief with anyone, not even his love-lobster.)

The excitement grew because he was about to set fire to something *new,* and that was *always* a good time! And growing rarer every year! The list of things Sea Hawk had *not* set ablaze had shrank a lot over the years!

His personal firestarter was one that had been designed to blaze under any conditions, perfect for a seaborne pyromaniac like himself; there was a long handle between his hand and the end that held the flame, to burn those hard-to-reach places. It was a Crimson Waste design, supposedly, one he'd bought in the Cove on one of his trips there. He squeezed the trigger on the handle, and the end struck a spark that ignited flammable gas inside the inner tank, mined and collected in Dryl.

(It was a surprisingly international item, now that he thought about it!)

With the flame at the ready, Sea Hawk lunged forth, using his sword to parry the undead's sudden jittering assault, his other hand snaking out to press flame to flesh.

And the second it hit?

The flame raced from his firestarter onto the dark bolts animating the beast, and the entire zombie burst into flame.

"**YES!**" Sea Hawk crowed at the top of his lungs, singing as he went. "Let me sing you a song boys, of fire and flame!~"

"Holy shit!" he heard Octavia yell, as the zombie went up so fast it singed his mustache hairs; it was like a pine tree dipped in oil, that sucker *burned!* "I thought you said they were 'a bit' vulnerable to fire, Dreer, not- damnation, I've seen *bombs* that didn't go off that hard!"

Sea Hawk had to agree with the traitorous sailor; in the short time it'd taken her to spea kthat sentence, the undead was damn near consumed already, reducing swiftly to pure white ash.

Almost fitting, Sea Hawk thought. *A pyre for whomever it had been... a Brightmoon funeral, and bright indeed. One fit for any soul.*

(A flash of memory, talking with the Best Friend Squad Plus on their long campaign at sea, the five discussing how they wanted to be buried; he still recalled Bow surprising them all by requesting that he be cremated and his ashes thrown into Hordak's face, an image that had delighted Sea Hawk for days.)

"Okay, in my defense, I had no idea it was *that* bad," Dreer complained as he sent a spell towards the ashes of the zombie- a spell that did absolutely nothing, the white ashes not stirring one bit. "Annnnd I can't repair them afterwards. Great. So that's something to keep in mind."

"They burn?!?" Sea Hawk heard someone- he thought it was that old Horde soldier- yell. "...I got matches!"

Out of the corner of his eye, Sea Hawk saw a zombie light up as a thrown match, barely an ember when it struck, hit undead flesh, and even that small spark was enough to reduce it to ash. A zombie nearby caught fire from the embers, and until Dreer ordered them back with a sharp barked order, for a moment Sea Hawk thought the spreading fire would consume all of them.

"And who says smoking will kill you!" quipped the old Hordesman, laughing as he watched the undead cook.

"...Alright, I'm going to go kill Sea Hawk because nameless gods know he's got more fire on him," Octavia said, cricking her neck and standing up straighter. Her tentacles from her back, formerly juggling swords, now switched to a ready stance, four swords aimed. "You focus on the others. Time to get serious."

“Roger that,” Dreer said as he wove a spell onto the dead nearest Sea Hawk. “Get away from him and kill the others!”

That command to the undead was all the warning Sea Hawk got before a white beam from the advancing Octavia lanced towards him, full of death.

<u>*CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>**

This is too familiar, Catra thought as she dodged another firestorm, that absurd, horrible nostalgia creeping into her skull again. *It… it feels almost good, even as it hurts.*

Training days in the Fright Zone, memories that Catra had not thought of in years, filtered through her skull; every time Adora was praised, every time Catra was put down, every time Adora’s superior skill and determination beat Catra’s greater strength and agility... and the few times that Catra actually got a win in, when she couldn't stand losing anymore. When her pride, bent and beaten but never broken, demanded she *try.*

It didn't always lead to a win for her. Adora was a hard opponent when you gave one hundred percent, which was why Catra never beat her when she gave only fifty. But... sometimes she won.

Usually by tricking Adora, being more clever than her, or just plain *cheating,* which Adora's straightforward, obedient personality never considered a possibility until it was too late.

Those memories were sweet.

Sweet, and followed by sour; her few real wins against Adora, always by trickery, had always been followed by the abuse of Shadow Weaver, of being threatened and *hurt* by the one woman she had wanted most to love her as a daughter- at least, before Angella, before Brightmoon, before all the bright joy of her adoption.

Though… if fighting Adora feels so familiar now, why didn't it feel this way... before? We've fought so many times now...

True... but even as she dodged another rocket-powered charge, as another building collapsed under the weight of their conflict, Catra's memories answered her. The battles with Adora before this one- all the fights she'd had with the woman she loves, in all the long years of the War- had not been like this, because of the Sword.

Because Catra was the *She-Ra* now, and so powerful that it had flipped the script. Catra had always been faster and stronger, but the power of the She-Ra was so overwhelming that Adora's greater skill had failed utterly to bridge the gap; instead, she'd had to build that bridge out of illusions, lies, and traps, let her skill and her magic and her simple willingness to do *anything* to win grant her power equal to Catra's.

Anything... like maybe lie about loving me, the way I love her... but no, that thought was so awful, so horrible, so... so *wrong,* it had to be untrue, Catra had to trust that she was loved by Adora or she would be undone. She'd said it, right? Said it out loud not a minute ago- or maybe long minutes ago. Fighting had a way of stretching out time and warping it. Adora wanted her the way Catra wanted Adora...

(Right?)

Their fights before now had not felt like this, because they'd switched roles; Catra had become the active and open force, Adora the cheating trickster.

It almost makes sense, some part of Catra whispered, as she dropped to the ground, dodging a fireball from Adora's mouth that washed over her with searing heat. *We're always opposites, we always reflect each other -we are always like this.*

(*Maybe too much like this to be happy?* Came the sound of mockery in her skull, in a voice that sounded far too much like one that wove shadows. It took all Catra had to ignore it, to have faith that the girl who had saved her life so many times was still in the pyromaniacal monster before her, that after all that had happened, she and Adora could somehow still make this *work.*)

That was why *this* fight, and no other, made nostalgia so strong it almost choked.

Because *this* fight was opposites, too, but the way it had once been; back to basics, a blast from the past, a golden oldie.

Once more, as they had so long ago, Adora attacked, and Catra ran.

It still felt almost like... home.

But almost was a powerful word.

And this was *not home.*

Catra knew that, knew that down deep into her very bones, knew that- for all that she had grown up here- the Fright Zone was *not home.*

(Home was a purple-pink flag and a soft bed and warm meals, freely given even to a prisoner, because to starve those they captured was *beneath* them. Home was a castle filled with those who knew her, who praised her, who let her win practice bouts without hurting her and thought she was a hero, who supported her, who loved her. Home was a place so strong that it could be *soft,* too, a place that tasted of terrible sweetness, a land without cruelty or craven either one under a moonlit flag. Home was a series of things Catra had no word for, feelings and emotions she had never felt in the Fright Zone, home was *Brightmoon* and that word conveyed *nothing* of what it meant to her, what it meant to have a *home.*)

And for *home,* Catra had to *win.*

And if they were back to old patterns...

Then maybe she should do what worked back then.

And sure, it's been a while...

But Catra doesn't think she'll ever forget how to *cheat.*

And of all the myriad ways to cheat she knew of, one came immediately to mind.

She rolled away from yet another attack, and with her free hand, scooped up a handful of dust.

The most basic stunt of all. Not an old trick but *the* oldest trick, something intelligent life had figured out when it barely knew what tricks were at all;a handful of dust, tossed into the eyes. Something so old that it part of every hoary, hokey old storyteller's arsenal of tactics, always tossed into their tales at one point or another, because even a child could grasp the mechanics of it.

But classics were classics for a reason.

And people like Adora, who were so high and mighty, almost *never* expected a trick so goddamn *basic.*

(She can't help the grin on her face; something about screwing over Adora with a cheap trick *also* felt almost like home.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Bow had an arrow nocked even as Perfuma entered the area, because it didn't take a veteran to know that all hell was going to break loose as soon as she showed up.

Still, he thought, as he aimed one of his four mage-slaying arrows at Shadow Weaver, *I didn't quite expect **this** much hell to break loose.*

The warzone had immediately become chaos. From their side, the air was full of projectiles, as Rebel soldiers were opening up with whatever ranged weapons they had; it was a mish-mash chimera, a conglomerate assault, because Rebel logistics were somewhat-random and it was hard to enforce any form of uniformity in an organization defined by rebellion.

Still, given that this was *Netossa's* Rebel group, this was a high-class mish-mash, far above the usual motley; First Ones' lasers

and heavy rockets and ancient bullets lashed out along with arrows and crossbow bolts. Most of the fire was directed straight at Perfuma's warplant, as might be expected; the Princess of Plumeria was the literal biggest target on the field right now.

(Bow hoped she'd be okay. He didn't know *why* Perfuma had joined the other side, but the heartseeker had a suspicion; Perfuma had never entirely forgiven herself for Entrapta's "death" and capture in the first Raid on the Fright Zone, so long ago now, and perhaps... perhaps joining Entrapta, maybe even without question, was her way of atoning. Guilt was a powerful force, especially in someone like Perfuma, who was so anxious to live up to the expectations of her position, who forgave herself so little even as she forgave others much.)

Perfuma wasn't eating *every* hit, though. A normal formation of soldiers of almost any nation, ambushed by a giant roaring warplant in sudden battle, would have fired everything at the warplant, because it was a natural reaction to a big monster showing up; but these were *Rebels,* and thus of higher quality than most by virtue of simple necessity. Between their logistical issues, separation from the support of any major government, and need to operate long hours behind enemy lines, soldiers who were merely average did not survive being Rebels long... and these Rebels were not just Rebels, but Netossa and Spinnerella's hand-picked personal squad, not just cream of the crop but cream of the cream.

So even without orders, some of them were smart enough to divide shots, to know that just because Perfuma was big and scary, it didn't mean that Shadow Weaver, one of the greatest sorcerers of this or any age, didn't need to be put down, too- and a few fired at Scorpia, because they were smart enough to realize that the only thing that mattered in this fight was keeping the Scorpioni away from the Black Garnet.

Bow was part of that group, but knew that they'd never stop Scorpia as long as Shadow Weaver was on the field.

He fired, his arrow joining others in smacking into a shield of shadow some feet before Shadow Weaver, the spellcaster protecting herself; that shield dissolved, which was good, but the field effect of the sparkling dust didn't go far enough, didn't hit Shadow Weaver, and so a second shield, set up a bit behind the first, stopped further shots.

I'll need to either hit her or hit very close, he thought, as he observed the field. Perfuma's warplant had shrugged off all the attacks directed at it, save the lasers, which actually sheared a chunk of the warplant off, the blazing light good at burning the green. Unfortunately for them, their efforts drew Perfuma's attention, because one of the many serpent heads on the monster whipped around and vomited a dragon's breath of some foul green muck all over those Rebels, something that smelled foul in a bizarre way. Not in a sharp way, like the hiss of acid, but opposite, an unpleasantness you smelled at the base of your nose, that sank down into your lungs uncomfortably.

The weapons and armor of those Rebels *melted off*, which to a tech master like Bow was flat-out horrifying; and being the son of two historians, he *knew* what this was, just how fucked they all were.

Bitterlye, Perfuma's figured out the formula for bitterlye

“Fuck,” he said aloud. Against bitterlye, a tech master like him was damn near useless, as was all the equipment the Rebels had, and they needed that equipment to fight a being that was so literally out of their weight class.

Perfuma was pressing that advantage, too, charging forward vermin-fast, her many heads puking a storm of green filth everywhere even as snapping claws swept Rebels aside. Perhaps she had realized that her great size and weight meant she could simply bowl over the Rebels once she'd stripped them of their gear, or maybe it was just the bloodlust Bow had always seen in Perfuma driving her to such an aggressive strategy; regardless, it was absolutely the right choice. Bow fired a grappling arrow and swung away from his sniping spot, away from her attack, though she didn't seem to be paying him much attention; briefly as he swung through the air to the ground, he wondered if it was because she knew him and didn't know the Rebels, or simply because he'd been attacking Shadow Weaver.

Maybe she remembers me taking her to Prom all those years ago, some part of him thought.

(Not really a romantic gesture on either of their parts; sure, he liked Perfuma and it was mutual, but that hadn't been what the Prom was about. It was a way for Perfuma to show support for the Great Rebellion and for Bow to show he wasn't as tied to Brightmoon as everyone assumed he was. He'd been getting pretty tired back then of people claiming he was a spy for Brightmoon within the Great Rebellion, or some variation of that idea... which, sure, most of the Great Rebellion were former Brightmoon soldiers who'd deserted, but that had nothing to do with him. He'd volunteered as a Rebel because he'd wanted to fight, not because he'd had a grudge against Queen Angella for withdrawing, he'd been a kid when she did that.)

Landing on the ground to the left of Perfuma's attack, he touched ground just in time for one of the other Princesses on the field to enter battle; a high-pitched hum was all the warning anyone got before Spinnerella formed a vast tornado, aimed right at the warplant, the unstoppable forces slamming into each other and forming an immovable object. Vomitted blasts of bitterlye whipped back in the wind and hit buildings behind Perfuma, melting through the artificial metal but leaving natural rock alone, patchworking everything around Perfuma as she kept trying to press forward, literally clawing her way forward inch by inch. Meanwhile, Spinnerella's control was such that she was able to use her winds to whip the shots of those Rebels who still had weapons towards a single point on the warplant, aiming to crack open the core, where she must suspect Perfuma to be; perhaps she could feel the stirring of the air that was Perfuma breathing, or was simply betting that the area most heavily protected was where Perfuma's real body would be.

(The heartseeker was almost right; what Spinnerella sensed was not just Perfuma's breath, but Perfuma's *words,* because Perfuma was so goddamn high on sensation that she had not stopped talking to herself since she entered into the warplant. Spinnerella, as the only person vaguely aware of it, was mildly impressed with her ability to ramble mid-fight.)

That fight would be theirs; Bow had landed near Scorpia and Shadow Weaver, and *that* was going to be his job. You had to divide up the work to get anything done.

"Will you try to stop-" Shadow Weaver began to monologue, her favorite activity other than hurting children, but Bow paid her no attention, save to shackle the rage inside for the moment. He still had it, that red light inside, that *wrath* for what Shadow Weaver

had done to Catra, and he would make sure she paid soon enough; but he had a goal here first, and people were often distracted by talking.

But Bow had a sharpshooter's talent for focus.

So even as Shadow Weaver began to talk of how great she was, Bow whipped up his bow and fired an off-the-cuff shot at Scorpia, because stopping her was the most important thing he could do.

(He didn't use one of his deadlier arrows- no, he'd try not to kill her if he could. Even beyond the practical consideration that doing so would make someone *else* the awaiting Princess of the Black Garnet and simply delay the problem... well, Scorpia, even as an enemy, had been friendly and kind, and he didn't want to kill her. She wasn't a Shadow Weaver, a person the world was better off without; and given she'd never impressed him as all that bright, who knew what she'd been told, to convince her to come here? What lies had brought her to be the unwitting spark that set the world ablaze? He'd save her if he could.)

Shadow Weaver jumped in surprise as Scorpia was sent flying, wrapped up in ropes and sticky goo- he'd used both, because this was a *good* capture arrow- and got stuck to a nearby hunk of metal that had once been a building's foundations, at least before a glob of Perfuma's bitterlye had melted partially through it.

“Whoa!” Scorpia yelled, but Shadow Weaver was already spellcasting, flinging a hand out and letting loose with some terrible blade of shadow, slicing towards him.

Bow reached for one of his three remaining mage-slaying arrows, but he wouldn't be fast enough, the cruel edge racing towards him, jagged and wicked. The deadly darkness descended as his hands moved as fast as they could, but not fast enough.

And then he saw nothing but a pair of black owl's wings, wrapped protectively around him, gleaming light dissipating the shadowsword- joined, briefly, by a pair of short, strong arms, wrapped around his bare abs.

(He did not fight the blush that grew on his face, though it dissipated quickly; no time now, but later, if they lived...)

“Hands off Bow!” Glimmer yelled from behind him, her wings spreading and shaking off a kind of dark sludge, the remnants of Shadow Weaver's spell. “Now surrender, or we kill your ass!”

“Not exactly the most formal request for surrender I've ever heard but I'll take it,” Bow muttered next to her, aiming his arrow.

“You *must* be joking,” Shadow Weaver said, as the darkness formed great claws that rushed at them.

(And behind her, Scorpia struggled against her imprisonment, her great strength pushing against metal already mostly ruined by Perfuma, the softened and corroded steel bending underneath her pressure.)

Chapter End Notes

Next time: Angella and Grizzlor have a talk that I'm sure goes well, Adora's eyes suffer even more than they already have,

and Krystala does nothing that might get them all killed, probably.

Chapter 68: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: All Bridges Burning

Chapter Notes

So this is a shorter chapter than it was meant to be, because I have been SICK AS A DOG.

This was supposed to be done CHRISTMAS EVE!

But I've been so sick I couldn't do SHIT.

This fic is still ending in a few chapters but I'm not gonna complete it in seventy chapters now; I should have made this longer and kept to the original plan but I wanted to upload something, so take this shorter chapter as my start of the year :D

Here's hoping I recover in time to keep updating!

A BATTLE FOR THE AGES

All Bridges Burning

There was nothing in Adora's head save the barking of the hellhound, unchained at last, Adora finally finished pretending she was anything but a monster.

(*I murdered my father to take his Horde and I have failed him, failed the Horde, failed everyone who ever trusted me, betrayed*

*them, I am a First One and a **monster,** I have failed a people I never knew*)

If she focused on the fury, on the fight, on the *fire,* then she did not hear those thoughts, gnawing at the base of her brain like the cold dark teeth of some abyssal predator. No, no, if she raged, if she gave in to the hellhound, if she howle, then the crackle of flames replaced all things inside her. (*I've ruined the Horde I've ruined my home I've ruined Catra I've ruined **everything***)

All she had to do was never stop. Was burn, forever more, and then she could run form those thoughts forever. She'd never have to... hurt.

(*And maybe Catra will kill me, please Catra, let it end, the hero kills the villain, the way it's supposed to be, please, **don't let me live like this***)

Blinded by fury, barely able to focus, the center of a firestorm so big it was eating the Fright Zone alive, Adora laughed her ripsaw laugh as she chased Catra. It was almost familiar, almost... nostalgic. Catra ran from her, and Adora pursued. Catra, who was so *good,* even back then, who was never going to be a monster the way Adora was. Catra, who couldn't beat her in a fair fight, so she always had to cheat...

Will she cheat again? Maybe I should be on the watch for-

But even as the warning crossed Adora's mind, Catra acted, and threw a handful of dust into Adora's face.

The First One fell back, completely shocked out of her spiral; and in a fit of ludicrous irony, where she was once blinded by rage, now she was just plain half-blinded . While her wounded eye was protected by the blazing shield of her sister's power, the dust burned up before it hit, her *good* eye was not, and was now full of ash and dust, screaming in pain- and worse, that made it hard to concentrate enough to keep the flame in her other eye, which guttered out, leaving Adora completely blind.

Why is it always my fucking eyes? Adora had time to ponder as she swiped at her face to clear it. She spluttered, as some of the dust had gotten into her mouth, and snorted to clear her nose; she was all over just a damn mess, coughing and hacking and completely concerned with the dust in her face.

It was the oldest trick in the book, a trick old *before* there were books for tricks to be *in,* and it had utterly reduced her from an unstoppable inferno to simply a person with dust in their eyes.

And in that moment, Catra tackled her, giving her no time to recover, pinning her to the ground.

“Stop already!” Catra yelled to her, though Adora paid little attention through her confusion and pain. “Stop! You're destroying the Fright Zone, and Etheria's sitting on top of a *bomb,* we don't have *time* to fight like this!”

Adora kept struggling, body moving on the ingrained instinct of four years of war. The tackle had cleared her mind enough to remind her that she wasn't just a *person,* had never been, was a First One, had lied to everyone that she was normal- and now she was a Princess, to boot, another thing she lied about.

So she washed herself with fire, vomiting up from her liar's mouth a wash of lavalike dragon's breath that covered her face in blazing magma, baptizing her clean of everything in her eyes and throat and nostrils with cleansing fire.

As her vision cleared, she had time enough to see Catra, clearly surprised by the act of projectile fire, react by pinning her neck with her elbow, aiming her mouth *away* from Catra herself- which was a good idea, actually, Adora should have spat fire at her while she had time. Adora's left hand reached out for her shield, which she'd dropped when she was tackled, but Catra grabbed her left wrist with her right, leaving the two of them holding each other so close, a parody of a lover's embrace that tore at what was left of Adora's charcoal heart like shards of glass.

(*I'm sorry Catra I'm sorry Catra I'm sorry Catra I ruin everything I touch*)

But Adora's right hand was free...

With the same powers she used to create her armor, Adora summoned an obsidian knife, sharp beyond sharp, into her right hand, a blast of fire making the blade. She had a target already in mind: Catra's side, the same place she'd struck her so long ago at the Battle of Brightmoon.

(*A betrayal, like everything I do; Catra had tried to save me from a fall, and I rewarded her with a knife. I am a monster, a betrayer, a* ***liar*** *... this was why my people left me in that field, alone, hoping I would die. They knew, even when I was newborn, that I was a monster; and did I not prove them right? For Hordak saved me, and for his reward I killed him, I killed my father, I am the only wicked soul among the saints*)

As the heat washed over her hand, Catra glanced over at it, and then spat out something Adora hadn't expected.

“Adora, stop, the First Ones were bastards!” she said.

And... that was... what?

“What?” Adora said, because there was very little Catra could have said that would have been more surprising to hear. Catra even let go of her with her elbow, moving roughly- and putting a hand on Adora's other wrist to hold the knife back, something Adora barely noticed in her surprise- the two face to face now, Adora's wounded eyes, mismatched by her own actions, staring into Catra's beautiful eyes, mismatched by nature.

Adora had to fight a sudden urge to kiss her.

(And she wanted them to be even closer, with fewer clothes on, her flesh to Catra's flesh, even as she knew that her demon's skin would melt in the embrace of the holy warrior before her.)

“We were all wrong,” Catra said. “They were bastards.”

<u>*CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>**

“We're coming up on the Spirit Ember,” Sherrilyn reported over the radio. Her and the other Fighting Foe Men were in the lead, while Grizzlor rode with Zin on a machine near the middle of their formation. “No resistance spotted yet, but we're in pretty tangled corridors here. Won't be able to tell if there's a defense at the Ember itself until we're on the final stretch.”

“Any other news?” Grizzlor asked.

“Yes, but it's not very good,” Sherrilyn reported. “We... haven't heard a word back from Landor and Azana. And we've got a *lot* of reports of someone throwing around a lot of fire nearby; I... think they failed.”

Grizzlor hoped the kids had lived, even as he knew that- if Adora was alive to burn the Horde to begin with- they were not.

“...This doesn't change the plan,” he answered after a moment's rumination. “It just makes it more vital that we get to the Ember and destroy it. If the assassination strike didn't work... then we

need to cut off her powers. Make sure the missiles are ready to go as soon as we get there."

(His mind drifted to Landor and Azana's parents, who had entrusted their children to the Horde; he wanted to make apology for getting them killed, even as he knew they could not hear him, that all that was left of them in this world were memories now.)

"You got it," Sherrilyn said. "Won't be long now..."

And it wasn't. The army rolled along, blessedly free of interference despite the chaos. Most people saw the heavily-armed column coming and, if not already on Grizzlor's side, picked the better part of valor and ran; those that made a stand were soon gore beneath the wheels.

(Grizzlor tried not to think of the symbolism of that, of Horde blood literally lubricating the wheels of his advance. He tried not to think of the fact that those who stood against him were the best of the foe, that he was culling the cream of the crop, not the chaff. He tried not to think about a lot of things.)

Grizzlor spent the time checking his trackerpad for updates; a lot of heavy fighting and fires reported, but overall his troops weren't doing too bad. Still outnumber probably two to one, but the twos were green and new, mostly, and caught by surprise. Between that and the Hordebots being on his side, that was all he needed... though his trackerpad had trouble updating him on all the positions of the bots. Even now, it claimed one was *inside* the Spirit Ember chamber; he ordered it to attack, but nothing happened. Probably just a glitch, the bots hadn't been entirely stable since Entrapta defected.

Eventually, he was pulled from his thoughts when Sherrilynn called back on the radio, the battalion grinding to a halt.

“Uhh... boss?” her voice crackled unsteadily over the radio. “ We're in sight of the Spirit Ember's warehouse thing, but... we've got Princess company. I think that's Angella, and her... isn't her husband dead? I'd swear that's him, though, and Dawg agrees with me, we both fought him back in the earliest part... he looks a bit rougher but yeah, I think that's the same guy! Destroyer says he also spotted some Lunoth kid but that's probably not as relevant as the Princess and her dead husband.”

“...What the hell is Queen Angella doing here?” Grizzlor responded back. “What is she doing?”

“Not sure,” Sherrilynn replied. “They were doing something to the Spirit Ember's building when we got here, some spellcraft crap, but they've turned to face us- oh, she's approaching. Gonna send a trackerpad link through now.”

Grizzlor put down his radio as his trackerpad hissed to life, relaying what Sherrilyn was seeing from her position at the front of the column. His comrade was holding the trackerpad out so he could see before him, and...

*Well, shit, that **is** her dead husband, or a close look-alike. What, did he survive Beast Island? That's impossible.*

Queen Angella, floating towards the column's front slowly, hand held up in a universal gesture of “stop”. A thick bubble of magical shielding, many-layered, had formed on the area, centered around her husband- and yeah, there was a tiny Lunoth, mostly hidden behind the Micah doppelganger. Angella was well within the defenses, which were pink magic charged with little bolts of black shadow throughout, not entirely unlike Shadow Weaver's own magic.

“I would parley with you,” Queen Angella said.

(And far away, Light Hope frowned as she watched this latest wrinkle in her plan... then smiled as she looked over at the Hordebot inside the Spirit Ember's chamber, and a plan formed in her electronic mind.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

The fight against Perfuma was raging above them, and kind of all around, but Glimmer couldn't focus on that. That wasn't her role in this fight, that wasn't her part of the battle; Perfuma was for Spinnerella and the Rebels.

(Who... didn't seem to be doing too well, save for Spinnerella herself, whose tornadoes were keeping Perfuma from advancing, and sending globs of bitterlye back, washing over the nearby buildings.)

But Shadow Weaver was for Glimmer and Bow, and that was trouble enough.

"You should have surrendered!" she yelled at the dark witch as she dodged the great claws, trying to draw the witch's eyes away from Bow. His arrows were their secret weapon, and she didn't want Shadow Weaver paying them any attention until it was too late. "But I'm kind of glad you didn't!"

"The mistake is not mine," Shadow Weaver responded as she cast more spells, more clawing darkness, more wicked edges in the air- all at Glimmer, which freed Bow up to take a shot.

Even as she dodged, she couldn't help but take a glance at him as he aimed, perfect as some ancient marble statue, fine muscles taut.

(*Silver, he's so handsome,* Glimmer thought, with warmth in her cheeks. *But focus, Glimmer!*)

The gleaming arrow didn't hit the old witch, sadly, hit a shield of shadow that leapt up at her command instead- apparently she hadn't been *that* distracted- but the arrow burst anyway on impact, spreading what looked like multi-colored glitter.

Of course it's glitter, Glimmer thought, almost giddily. *It's **for** me and **from** him, and made with my aunt's help; of **course** it looks like my magic, of course, of course.*

And while Shadow Weaver quirked one oddly visible eye at the shine, her magic *failed,* just for a second, all her work unable to find magic that wasn't distracted or divided by the arrow's gleam, the pure chaos of the ambient magic around her impossible to order.

But Glimmer had never needed magic to *hit* people.

She ran forward as fast as her stubby little legs could take her, flapping her wings to give herself a little boost as she leapt as high as she could, back muscles protesting as she caught up to the witch in her moment of weakness and gave her the best fucking punch of her life, a blow she had waited to deliver ever since the night her sister had laid bare all her pain and all her trauma and all her hurt.

(*For you, sister,* Glimmer thought, and felt pure Silver at that moment, felt like she had in the air when chasing Double Trouble- a god once more, but a god of justice, of righteousness, of the punishment of wrongs- a slow god, a god whose judgment had been a long time in coming, but a god who was here at last to put paid to the witch.)

The punch hit Shadow Weaver right between her glowing eyes, and Glimmer felt the flesh give way as she hit, felt some gigantic vein *pop* as she struck, a trail of horrible green-black fluid, with but a tiny trace of red, arcing through the air as Shadow Weaver's head snapped back from the hit. It was whatever passed for blood in Shadow Weaver's veins, and the feel of it on her knuckles was sickly and gross... but also *exhilarating,* because what could bleed could *die.*

" ***THAT'S FOR CATRA!*** "Glimmer shouted as she landed, adrenaline powering her next hit, straight to the witch's gut, a good strong left that... didn't connect, because Shadow Weaver was already teleporting, her moment of weakness overcome.

It enraged Glimmer, that the witch would run, that the death she so richly deserved would be delayed even a moment. There was no *excuse* for what Shadow Weaver had done to Catra, for tormenting a *child,* for all the horrible things she had done over the years, and her attempt to flee even a second of her just execution made Glimmer so angry that she felt...

Calm.

Almost weirdly enlightened.

She is the worst monster I know of- even more than Hordak, who started this war. He had ideals, at least... and he died well.

(There had been something better in Hordak, more noble, a thing so few had seen... but it had led him to die to save the world, to save Glimmer's *mom,* and for that, Glimmer will owe the dead man a debt to the end of her days.)

Shadow Weaver will not.

Without a word- because words were for *people,* not monsters- Glimmer teleported after the witch, to make sure she kept her

appointment with the reaper at the end of the path.

<u>*CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>**

“The First Ones,” Catra repeated, her heart soaring in her chest, this was *it,* the thing that might make this all *end,* “were *bastards,* Adora.”

Adora stared up at her, all uncomprehending, her face a mass of scars down her left side; she was as heterochromatic as Catra was now, in her own way, and Catra had a terrible urge to bend down and kiss her scars better, see if She-Ra's healing could fix damage done in a dimension that did not exist, restore her Adora.

Focus, Catra! Kiss later.

(And she prayed to any gods who would listen that there would *be* a later, for her and the woman before her, that somehow they could thread the needle of their lives and make one garment, one cloth, one *victory* out of all their failures.)

“...That doesn't make any sense,” Adora began, and Catra could almost hear the thoughts in her head. “Saints, angels, holy people...”

“No, they were just liars,” Catra said, though the way Adora's eyes lit up as she said it- somewhat literally, actually, a bit of fire began to burn in her wounded eye that didn't go away- meant she carried on as fast as she could. *Liar* was a bit of a loaded term for Adora these days. “ The First Ones were conquerers, but they were smart about it. They pretended *not* to be those things. They... they lied, Adora, snuck in the way the Horde does, pretended to be the good guys. They were just *way* better at it.”

“...Liars...” Adora said, which wasn't what Catra wanted her to focus on, so she kept going.

“And conquerors,” she insisted. “They built a *bomb* under Etheria, that's why I'm here at all, why the Alliance is here, they made a weapon to murder *worlds,* made the Sword to serve as a trigger, we have to get to the Black Garnet and stop Scorpia from reaching it. We- please, Adora, don't fight anymore. So much is at stake...”

“...You have to be wrong...” Adora said, but she trailed off, her protest more token than true.

“Why would I lie about this?” Catra asked her. “How *could* I? The First Ones being secretly monsters isn't something anybody would believe! They... they were bad...”

Well, mostly... Catra thought, as her mind spat up an image- Mara, always Mara, who had been a First One and a She-Ra both. Mara, and Squad Grayskull, in whose name and for whose honor Catra has fought for four years now, First Ones who had stood

against their people, had died pitting themselves against genocide, fighting some unknown horror guarding the Heart of Etheria in hopes of stopping it from ever being used.

(Catra swallowed hard against the memory; Mara, greatest of She-Ras, who had died a *bad* death, so that so many could live.)

"But not all of them," she finished, almost whispering, as the situation- of being so close here to the woman she loved, of holding hands, of whispering to her- finally sank in. This was... this was so *much* like what she wanted, save for all the ways in which it was a nightmare version instead, she wanted to hold her love and feel her breath and whisper to her, but not like this, not like this, not like this.

(It feels so cruel, to be so close to what she wants, and yet so far.)

"...I... I don't know what to do with this," Adora admitted, staring up at her as if she hoped Catra might have an answer.

"It means you don't have to hate yourself," Catra offered her gently. "You aren't... a mistake. A failure. You're... you. The girl who saved me so many times, who was so kind to me when everyone was so cruel, who I..."

Catra trailed off, because she realized she had never actually *said* it, had she? Or if she had, it wasn't like this, hadn't been done *right.*

But here, where there were just the two of them, the sheer destruction of their fight creating a space around them where it was just *them,* no Horde, no Alliance, it could be done... right.

It could be done just between two women who once upon a time had been little girls in love.

" *I love you,* " Catra finally said to Adora, the way she *should* say it, looking her in the eyes, no distractions, no restraints, no misunderstandings. Just the plain, simple truth. "I love you. So... please, let this be an end of it. You don't have to hate yourself, you don't have to keep fighting, you don't... you can *stop,* Adora. Stop, and come *home,* with *me.* "

Adora stared up into her eyes, and for a long moment, Catra's heart sang with hope.

But then Adora looked away, and Catra's heart fell through her stomach.

"...I'm me..." she muttered. "Whcih means... I'm a murderer, Catra. A monster... a *liar,* like all my people, apparently. Villages burned on my orders. Death and blood on my hands... Hordak... and... look around you, Catra. The Horde... I've *ruined* it... ruined it with my lies and awfulness..."

"Then stop!" Catra yelled back, biting her lip in frustration. Fucking hell, every time she came so *close,* why wouldn't Adora

just *listen?* This was just like the first time they'd met after Catra became the She-Ra, when Adora had called her *traitor,* she didn't *listen...* "Stop being part of the Horde, come with me! Come on, *please...* "

"I even ruin you," Adora said quietly, finally daring to look back into Catra's eyes. "You should love another, not me; I love you too, Catra, but it's *wrong,* I'm a monster, you should love another hero like yourself, not..."

"You were *my* hero as a child," Catra told her. "Please..."

"I haven't been that kid in a long time," Adora said.

The conversation was circling and circling and they weren't getting *anywhere,* it was going to end like it always did, words *never* broke through to Adora, hadn't gotten to her since the earliest days of the War.

But they were running out of *time,* both in the sense that the Heart was going to activate and in the sense that Adora and Catra were on a collision course where one of them was going to *die,* and that would kill Catra all by itself, for Adora to die.

But nothing was getting through...

…

But Adora had said she loved her, right?

She loves me, I love her...

And somewhere deep inside, the woman Catra loved *had* to still be in there, underneath the ashes of what she'd done, to herself and others.

She thinks she's a liar... so make her face the truth.

But how?

…

Oh.

The idea that hit Catra was, in the bluntest terms- in a voice in her head that sounded a lot like Mermista's- *really* fucking stupid. It was an idea that was dumb as hell, that couldn't *possibly* work, an idea that she would have thought of as stupid four years ago, before Adora blew up her sister in Mara's ship with a bomb, before Adora stabbed her in the side at Brightmoon, before Adora had bombed the Princess Prom. To have the idea now, *after* all that, put it into some new category of stupid that Catra didn't know a word for.

And... worse... it is... a betrayal. A betrayal of her mother. A betrayal of her nation. A betrayal of her friends and everyone who has ever thought of the She-Ra as a hero.

But...

Once, long ago, Catra had been given her life, over and over again, by Adora. Adora, who had saved her, time and time again; Adora, who had made that life worth living.

Adora, who has *always* had Catra's life in her hands, and has always been kind with it.

How can Catra do any less than put that life in her hands once again?

(She prays, to whatever is or is not, to whatever might be listening, Silver or nameless or something in-between, whatever might hear the desperate prayers of the lovesick and lost; *please, let this work.*)

Catra, firmly and deliberately, let go of Adora's left hand, grabbed her right with both hands, and put the tip of the obsidian knife in that hand to the scar in her side, where Adora had nearly killed her, so long ago.

And then she detransformed, went from the She-Ra to just a Magicat, removing from herself all the power the Sword of Protection could grant, save what remnants of strength she could not help but retain, which would not be enough to save her life if Adora chose to take it.

"If you keep going," Catra said, and hoped her voice did not quaver, "one of us is going to die. And I'm not going to kill you. So... if you aren't who you used to be... if this is what you *want* to be..."

Catra closed her eyes. She couldn't look Adora in the face, couldn't survive seeing the moment in which Adora chose to kill her, couldn't face seeing Adora make that choice. Catra, who was scared of nothing, was terrified beyond all reason that it would be an *easy* choice for Adora, that she had calculated all of this wrong, that her act of betraying her people would be rewarded with a betrayal in turn.

(The thought idly occurs to her that it might work out, if Adora kills her; no She-Ra, no Heart to go off... and she must take that as whatever comfort it is. She has no idea if it even works like that, but here, at the end, she must have *some* hope that her love has not ruined everything.)

"Then do it. Kill me, the way you're going to if you keep doing this. If that's what you *want.* "

And Catra waited, eyes closed, the tip against her side, trying desperately not to cry, waiting to see what choice Adora would make.

Chapter 69: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: Ashes, Ashes, We All Fall Down

Chapter Notes

I'm trying to upload as consistently as I can; expect shorter chapters! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Ashes, Ashes, We All Fall Down

The part that will haunt Adora later- that will haunt her all the days of her life, however long or short they shall be- is simply this:

She doesn't know what she's going to do.

The woman she loves, who loves her, has just opened her heart to her, emotionally *and* physically; Catra, the mighty She-Ra, is as vulnerable in this moment as she will ever be, her eyes closed in her smaller skin and with a blade of the sharpest obsidian pressed against her side. Catra is completely open, to any form of attack, to any form of love, to *anything* Adora wished to do to her. Whatever comes next, it will be on Adora's head, for good and for ill.

And she doesn't know what she's going to do.

The shock of Catra's offered sacrifice has blanked her mind entirely. Whatever else was going on in her head, Catra putting her life in Adora's hands, as if... as if Adora could be *trusted* with something so precious, despite her lies, despite *everything...*

It has absolutely obliterated all prior thought.

Adora lay there, looking up at Catra; and isn't that so appropriate? To look *up* to Catra, whom the Fright Zone had made so low, who found in foreign lands fertile soil to grow, who was now a hero beloved around the world.

And Adora...

I am a monster.

...But they are also Catra and Adora, two women who were once two girls who loved each other... who *still* loved each other, if Catra's words can be trusted...

Of course they can be. ***I'm*** *the liar, not Catra.*

Adora stared up at her, and had no idea what she was going to do.

(She will never entirely forgive herself for this moment.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Of all the people Grizzlor thought he'd see over the trackerpad's screen, Queen Angella wasn't high on the list, but here she was.

Her husband, who was *dead,* was even *lower* on the list. It was particularly weird for Grizzlor, who'd been the one to stuff his unconscious body into a rocket transport at Hordak's request; his Lord had known that he had no love for Shadow Weaver, who drew power from a Runestone, and had trusted him to keep quiet about it, an order he still obeyed.

(*Shadow Weaver was interested in this one,* his Lord had said at the time, when Grizzlor asked why Hordak didn't simply kill the man. *Specifically ordered him taken alive from the battlefield... I don't like that. I don't* ***trust*** *that. But I need to keep Shadow Weaver mollified... so I won't kill him here, where she might find out. I'll let Beast Island kill him. Let Shadow Weaver wonder how he escaped, or who has betrayed her to take him; she will not dare go to Beast Island to look for his corpse.*)

Vaguely, Grizzlor wondered if it really *was* King Micah, or if maybe Angella had simply found a look-alike to warm her bed; not important, he supposed, but it did make him damn curious. And if the man had actually *survived* Beast Island...

Well, if nothing else, that'd be a hell of a conversation to have.

"I would parley with you," Queen Angella said, interrupting his thoughts, her tone formal and respectful even through the static of the connection. She sounded more like she was at court with her advisors, and not in a warzone full of enemies; Grizzlor was torn between admiration for the guts and annoyance at the arrogance. Her grip was tight on her staff, but she was making no violent moves yet. "I presume you are the leader of this troop, Force Captain Grizzlor?"

"Not by choice but by necessity," he said. "What are you doing here, foreign Queen? If you've come to raid the Fright Zone you picked a good time, but you should have brought more troops. Move or die."

Grizzlor would prefer to simply run her over now, and be done with it- and truth was, he figured he *could* take the Queen on… but he'd lose a lot of people doing it. Normal folks didn't fight a Princess without loss, not without a hell of a lot of planning and a hell of a lot of firepower. Vultak hadn't killed that Plumerian Princess without a *lot* of prep.

(Grizzlor wished Vultak was up here, and not down south keeping Halfmoon locked up. Vultak would have been a great asset to have… but he had the troops he had, not the troops he wanted.)

And while he wouldn't lie and claim he *didn't* hate the Runestone worshipper, this shaman-queen of the north, with her faith in those poisonous rocks, she *wasn't* today's target, nor as vile in his

eyes. Angella was the oldest Runestone servant in the world, an exemplar of all he hated, but she wasn't a *traitor,* just an enemy.

But Adora… Adora was a *Princess,* and one who had stolen the title of Lord of the Horde from Hordak.

She was a *traitor.*

And that took precedence over enemies.

"We will do you no harm if you retreat," Grizzlor continued, and meant it. Let them go home. It would buy time for the Horde to heal… "We'll ignore this raid."

For now, Grizzlor swore to himself, though he had no doubts that Queen Angella was aware of what he was thinking. The Horde's work was not done so long as any nation bowed to the Runestone's chosen; once he'd gotten the Horde back on its feet and called back that army they'd sent to attack Plumeria, he'd figure out where to go from there. The Horde had started as a rebellion... surely there were Crownless rebels he could reach out to...

(But those were strategic thoughts for later. For today, he had a civil war to win.)

"I am not here to raid the Fright Zone," Queen Angella said. "And if I move, *you* die as well, because if the Spirit Ember is disturbed,

it will melt this land. And it is not the only apocalypse looming over us. If Scorpia reaches the Black Garnet, then more than merely Etheria will die. I am not here to fight the Horde, or interfere in the apparent civil war that is raging here; I am only here to prevent those things from happening, and have no other quarrel with the Horde. Not today."

...Okay, that wasn't on Grizzlor's list of shit he'd thought he'd hear today.

"...What are you talking about?" Grizzlor responded. "What do you *mean,* we all die?"

"I mean exactly what it sounds like," the Runestone bearer replied, and her tone was so… quiet, that something in Grizzlor wanted to believe her. Even through the trackerpad's visual screen, her face was one of quiet horror and earnest hope that he'd believe her.

(Sherrilynn- who was holding the trackerpad- shifted her hands a bit, and Grizzlor caught a glimpse of someone behind Angella, someone who looked kinda familiar… hmm. Maybe somebody Grizzlor had fought, years ago, or something. No one who rang a bell immediately.)

He knew better than to trust that, of course. Angella was the oldest diplomat on the planet, and it wouldn't be that hard to fake such a face and fake such a feeling.

But his gut said she was being honest, and while gut instinct wasn't the *only* thing to go off of, it was a clue in a pile of deductions his head could add to

Still, he needed more information.

"Gonna have to do better than that," he said. "Such proclamations are dramatic, but you've offered no proof. What is this danger you speak of?"

"The Spirit Ember," Queen Angella replied. "The Spirit Ember is unstable at best… and it is the reason the Flame Waste is *called* the Flame Waste. It is the reason for that wasted land. The Spirit Ember, when riled, leaks lava, burn the world around it… emits a cloud of pyroclastic horror the likes of which one never wishes to see. And… it is not the only danger here."

"A set of *two* apocalypses? Seems a bit much," Old Zin opined from behind Grizzlor, nearly scaring the Mane out of his fur. He'd plain forgotten he was back there, Zin moved so quietly.

"I admit that it *does* seem absurd," Angella agreed with Zin, whose voice the trackerpad had apparently picked up. "Yet the situation is what the situation is. No matter what any of us want."

"What's this other danger?" Grizzlor asked, impatient to get a move on. Every second was a second that Adora could be consolidating forces…

"To make a long tale short, we must prevent the Black Garnet from being reached by Scorpia," Angella said. "Her linking up to it will activate an old First Ones weapon that will, if we are *very* lucky, *only* kill all life on this planet. The consequences of our being unlucky do not bear describing."

More than a bit dumbfounded, Grizzlor stared at the trackerpad screen as he processed this… *unbelievable* story.

…I've never even heard of anything like this. What is she going on about? It makes no sense…

Which… probably means this isn't a lie. Lies have to make sense. Truth can kick you in the dick all it wants, shock you, surprise you; it's truth, it doesn't stop happening just because you don't believe in it. You can't change it. You just have to live with it.

"...It's too strange to be a lie," Old Zin offered from next to him, echoing his own thoughts as he smoked a cigarette. "If she wanted to lie… well, she's old enough to know how to do better than *that.*"

"I am," Angella agreed, and a hint of a smile played on her lips for a second before disappearing; apparently she'd found Zin's comment funny, or at least, wanted it to *appear* she did so…

“Or old enough to know how to sell a lie,” Grizzlor retorted. “Why should I believe a word you say, foreign Queen?”

He actually had no real good reason to be suspicious. Truth was, he agreed with Zin; this was probably true. It was too odd not to be.

But to just roll over, and accept the word of one of the Runestones’ high priestesses without complaint…

It offended the Hordesman on a basic level.

“What other reason would I have to engage in parley?” Angella asked. “We would not be talking peacefully if my worries did not lay elsewhere today. I would be here to fight, and I would have brought more soldiers.”

“Your fine worries about the world didn't lead you to help us in Vargon out when we needed it,” Grizzlor hissed, surprising himself; he hadn’t quite meant to say that. It had just… slipped out.. “You sat idle.”

“I *did* help,” the foreign Queen answered him. “I funneled money and resources to *every* rebel group in *every* nation the Horde eventually conquered, even Silverglade. Protest movements in Green Thatch, GaleBreath elections, political asylum for refugees of the Fright Zone... and Vargon was where I spent the *most*

money. The Horde was a beneficiary, too; you stand in a place I helped fund. I was *not* idle."

"You sent no troops," Grizzlor said in response, remembering how many nights he'd hoped against hope that someone, anyone, would do just that, especially Brightmoon, best of the Runestone Kingdoms to the Crownless… hopes inevitably dashed, until the day Hordak showed up, and showed them how to free *themselves.* "Not one boot on the ground."

"Not a single one," she agreed, which surprised Grizzlor mildly. He figured she'd lie and claim she'd done covert ops. "Not even mercenaries, who I find far too unreliable and far too prone to casual atrocity- though I'm fairly certain some of my silver was spent by rebel hands to buy mercenaries after it reached them. Their decision, not mine."

"Then you were idle," he responded, voice growing heated as he thought of those long-ago, awful days… of his brother, whose life had been horror for years, horror inflicted at the hands of a Runestone. "You did not do all you could. You just spent some silver. We *bled.*"

"Indeed you did," she said, voice not wavering in the slightest. "And indeed, I spent silver- silver in food and equipment, silver in logistics and supplies, but silver alone. No blood."

"…Why?" Grizzlor asked, surprising even himself. It was a question he'd wondered so often back in those days, why no one would help…

“It never works,” Angella said quietly. “It is so rare for such an intervention to go well that I will not risk it. Had I sent troops, maybe I could have threaded that needle… but more likely your people would have seen my arriving troops as would-be conquerors. We’d have had to fight at *least* one homegrown movement dedicated to stopping us, every intervention in history has at least one local group oppose it. And what would be done afterwards? Made it part of my nation- a lesser part, for it would be stolen land- or just leave your nation afterwards to empty, rudderless chaos, ready for the most savage to take its throne? Perhaps we could have stayed, worked things out, put it all to rights… but the cost to my people and the cost to your people would be so high, so high to risk on a *perhaps.* I have seen interventions fail so many times… sometimes they work, but the chances are poor. So I did everything I could *up until* that line, but not an inch more.”

…It sounded smart, and maybe it was, but all he could see was his brother, fused to a machine for no reason save to hurt him.

“You weren’t half so calm when Stormrage was running around,” Old Zin said, surprising Grizzlor out of his spiral of bad memories. Grizzlor almost wanted to grin; of *course* the ancient man would have some history rattling around in his skull. He might have been a teacher in Silverglade, rumor insisted, a lifetime ago. “Or in any of the *other* wars you've been involved in where Brightmoon troops fought on foreign soil.”

“Damn right,” Grizzlor followed up, another thing that just… slipped out. He wondered if some part of him was still that young man, who had… fantasized, he supposed, about Brightmoon

coming to save the day. Brightmoon, the sole Runestone Kingdom that might be worth a damn… Brightmoon, who had not saved his people nor freed his brother.

(But Hordak *had,* and that was the heart of Grizzlor's loyalty to the Horde, all these years later; when no one else had been there, Hordak *had.*)

"And in all those cases, my nation was attacked first," she responded. "Self-defense changes the calculus. But without that rationale, I will not invade. I am *far* too old not to have seen most interventions, started with the best of intentions, inevitably fall apart. A revolution is a hard thing. It must come from *inside,* it must be supported *from within.* It cannot be made by foreign hands, at least not well; it can accept foreign aid, but only in small doses, or it will drown, the medicine turned to poison. It is fair to be angry with me for that, but I would make the same choice again; I believe it was the right decision, then and now."

…This is going nowhere fast and getting me angry while it's at it. Best to just drop it.

"Let's say I believe you," Grizzlor finally allowed. It was hard to do so, given how much he *hated* Runestone crap, but he had to keep his priorities straight. "What's your plan?"

"We intend to send the Spirit Ember away," Angella replied. "We... we *might* be able to teleport it back to the Flame Waste. That way, if it goes off, then it goes off somewhere no one will get hurt..."

“Shit, they want rid of it?” Old Zin said, chuckling. “Fuck, how can we help?”

“Zin,” Grizzlor reprimanded him, though only lightly. Man had a point.

Still, *I agree* was sticking in his throat, for long enough that another voice was what prompted him.

“Boss?” Sherrilyn asked. “We can probably take them, if we have to.”

“Probably,” Angella admitted. Her honesty was a continuing aggravation. “But we'd fight as hard as we could to keep you away from the Ember. It's the second biggest bomb on Etheria right now, we can't have *anyone* touch it. We haven't even went in yet, we’ve just been layering shields on it from the outside. *That's* how delicate this situation is.”

...He fucking hated trusting a Runestone user...

(his brother, flashes of what was done to him, storming his mind like invaders at a castle)

But goddammit, his gut and his brain were singing the same song, and he had bigger fish to fry- an old Salinean saying he’d picked up from Octavia over the years.

"...If we leave you alone..." Grizzlor began, and did not miss the immediate relief on the immortal's face. That... spooked him, actually. For her to be so *obvious* about her relief, when she was the ancient, unflappable lord... yes, that was *bad.* Sure, probably more diplomatic acting, but if it *wasn't...* "Can you get rid of it?"

"We'll do what we can!" Angella exhaled in relief. "Thank you, Force Captain Grizzlor. Once we've sent the Spirit Ember on, we'll head to the Black Garnet. If we can capture Scorpia, we'll leave right after. The Horde's internal problems are... your business. Not ours. Not today."

Not ideal, but it was what it was; he had a civil war to win. Though he'd check out the Black Garnet first… if what Angella said was true, and he thought it was, he needed to keep Scorpia away from it. He'd put his troops there, then see what he could do about winning this war…

Besides, he thought with amusement, *Adora's obsessed with that fucking Spirit Ember, she might show up to defend it and fight Angella. Maybe they'll even kill each other.*

Cheered up by thoughts of two Runestone servants killing each other, Grizzlor gave his commands, switching his comm channel to include both Angella and all of the commanders under him.

"Troops, we're going around the Spirit Ember building," he finally agreed. "We leave them be if they leave us be. I don't want to hear that anyone took a potshot, you hear?"

A chorus of “Ayes” echoed over the radio.

“Thank you,” Angella said- but whatever was to come next was interrupted as his trackerpad detected movement.

Grizzlor tapped it to bring up that screen, showing the Hordebot inside the Spirit Ember’s room, doing… something?

<u>*CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>**

A shame.

(10101010101THESHAMEISTHEMURDEROFTHESTARS0101010101010)

Analysis indicated that there had been a greater than 60% chance of Grizzlor would start a fight with the subjects Queen Angella, King Micah, and the rebel soldier Flutterina. This was a preferable result, distracting the trio from continuing to hunt for Scorpia and interfere with her reaching the Garnet. Queen Angella would likely survive long enough to fire the Heart, and even if she didn’t, her daughter had a connection that could be used as well; it was a risk Light Hope was willing to take.

(The other two mattered less; King Micah was a powerful sorcerer, but he wasn’t part of the Heart, and Flutterina was even less important… though scanned energies around the youngster indicated potential for Wild Princess status.)

Grizzlor’s chance of starting a fight was so high due to his hatred of Runestones and Princesses, which would naturally compel him to disbelieve anything he was told; if he did so, battle was the only possible outcome. As that would further distract multiple forces from the Black Garnet and Light Hope's actual goals, it had also been a *preferred* outcome.

Unfortunately, Angella's talent for diplomacy meant there had always been a 40% counter-chance that she would be able to convince Grizzlor not to fight. An outcome that was less than ideal; while Angella and her husband would be busy keeping the Ember secure and trying to teleport it back, Grizzlor's forces were likely to head to the Black Garnet, and most likely interfere with getting Scorpia inside. *That* fight was on a knife's edge enough without Grizzlor tipping the scales.

On that note…

Light Hope directed more Hordebots to that area. Spinnerella was doing a *far* better job of stopping Perfuma than Light Hope had calculated; unacceptable. The plan must go through.

And while she was already giving Hordebots orders, she gave an order to one last Hordebot, a rather special one. Light Hope had prepared, after all; the counter-chance that Angella would

succeed had been taken into account, and a backup made ready, just in case.

The Eternal Empire, after all, did not deal in *uncertainties.*

(101010101010DONOTDOTHIS1000001010001010)

While the Spirit Ember selecting a Princess meant that Light Hope had no ability to actually *command* the artificial Runestone, not in any direct manner, she still had access to every single note involved in its creation- including its flaws and failures, the very things that had led it to be discarded as a worthless experiment.

One of those things being its instability and tendency to lash out with flame when provoked. It was so *close* to bursting, too; ever since Adora had awoken this morning, it had been roiling and boiling, not going over yet but clearly reaching a tipping point.

Now all Light Hope had to do was... push.

And Adora had even provided the cliff for the fall.

The bot headed over to the very failsafe Adora had built, which was meant to dump the Spirit Ember into a pool of cold water, to cool it, to quiet it, to buy Adora time to calm herself and her "sister in sin" down. Not a bad plan. If Adora was present, aware it was about to happen, mentally ready, it might even have worked.

But done unexpectedly, by surprise, when Adora was already so distracted...

The robot reached up, and hit the failsafe switch, cutting the Spirit Ember from all the lines, killing the power throughout the Fright Zone, and dumping it straight into icy-cold water, refrigerated with vast cooling systems.

All actions that subjected it to stress and pressure… even though it was already near its boiling point.

The bot barely had time to send back confirmation of the failsafe's activation before the blast obliterated it.

CATRA OF ETHERIA

"Face me if you dare!" Sea Hawk boasted to his enemy, setting fire to another undead as he did so. No reason to stop setting fires even when accepting a duel, after all!

"A chance to kill one of the five who screwed up my invasion of Salineas... oh, I'm going to *enjoy* this," Octavia said with a low

chuckle, her voice so full of pleased malice that even Sea Hawk felt himself taken aback.

"Oh, this is going to be *bad...*" he muttered to himself; but before Octavia could reach him, a wave of water cut a line between him and the approaching foe, heralding the arrival of a trident-wielding warrior goddess, who leapt over and took up guard before Sea Hawk.

"You're not going anywhere near him," Mermista growled, low and deadly as a riptide.

(Sea Hawk's heart leapt and danced in his chest, as it always did when his beloved showed how much she loved him underneath her salty exterior.)

"That's my love-lobster!" Sea Hawk shouted with joy; in celebration of his love, he set a nearby zombie on fire, and kicked it into two others, all three bursting like fireworks- and that was just perfect, absolutely the right way to show her how she made him feel! "As wondrous as flame!"

"Skeletor's tits, Octavia, kill him already! He's going through my damn troops like a hot knife through butter- literally!" Dreer bitched from the back of the undead mob as he threw spells at Frosta and company, little darkling bats that danced and distracted them. He grumbled out loud as he fought. "What bad luck can I even *have,* that my highly-flammable zombies run into the *one* pyromaniac working for the Alliance..."

“Working on it!” Octavia yelled back to him before giving Mermista a raised eyebrow. “So... Sea Hawk, huh?”

“Oh, don't you even *start,*” Mermista said, and lashed out with her trident to forestall any commentary on her romantic decisions.

Octavia multi-tasked, parrying Mermista's trident with her swords, firing another laser blast at Sea Hawk while her tentacles blocked Mermista; but her lack of focus cost her, as Sea Hawk easily dodged the poorly-aimed laser and Mermista managed to score a good hit with the hilt of her trident, knocking Octavia back.

“Excellent work, my dear!” Sea Hawk said, cheerfully attacking a zombie that was trying to sneak a hit in on Mermista with his firestarter. “Show her who's boss!”

“Not *my* boss!” Octavia yelled, and then she... poofed into smoky shadow and transformed into a tiny octopus?

Mermista stared dumbfounded for a moment at the suddenly tiny octopus, but then the smoky shadow reappeared, except this time it was Octavia who emerged from the blast of smoke, the Sea Elf popping out of her tiny form with a massive uppercut straight to Mermista's chin.

“Surprise, motherfucker!” Octavia crooned as the now-dazed Mermista stumbled back. “Didn't see *that* coming, did ya?!?”

“Holy shit, I can't believe you used it in a fight!” Dreer laughed from nearby.

“Told you!” she yelled back with a laugh, pressing her attack with all her swords. Mermista was forced to use water to ferry herself back and away, unable to keep up in her half-concussed state. “You owe me a beer, now!”

“Damn right I do!” Dreer agreed.

Octavia kept attacking, Mermista clearly half-concussed and barely able to make a shield from the Fright Zone's filthy water; it was wavery, quivered where it floated in the air, his beloved too unfocused to be able to do much more with it. Octavia was swiftly slicing through the shield, her swords digging ever-deeper, and that horrible weapon charging once more...

And aimed at *Mermista*.

Everything in Sea Hawk- everything, down unto his bones- boiled with a single, resounding *no*, and he was moving before he’d even consciously processed the information.

Forward, forward, sword of the sun at his side; but swords of the sea to meet him, a solid *wall* of blades, Octavia’s tentacles forming an iron cage of protection around her. Still the high-

pitched not-whine of the charging eyepatch weapon rang in his ears, she was *still getting ready to fire..*

But... but if that weapon fired, and his beloved was still so out of it... she would die.

He would not accept that.

No.

But there was no way to get in without getting cut to ribbons...

…

Well, I'll just have to be cut to ribbons, then.

For his Mermista, his love-lobster, he could do no less.

Besides... I bet it'll surprise the hell out of Octavia. Who charges a wall of swords, after all?

Sea Hawk, that's who!

A grin grew across his face, bold and free.

(And here was Sea Hawk at his core, for all his dandy silliness, for all the ridiculous songs and sheer potent absurdity of his existence... here is nonetheless one who waves at Death, to whom the reaper may wave back, in preparation for a handshake they will have when they meet in the clearing at the end of the path. Sea Hawk, who is strange and silly; Sea Hawk, who is strong and sincere. Sea Hawk, who is what he is, always.)

Sure, he'd *like* to live…

But Mermista mattered more than that.

And so, with a laugh and a song on his lips, Sea Hawk dove right towards Octavia, ignoring the swords.

He'd been right; she was *not* expecting this. Even as her blades ripped through the air towards him, most of them were expecting him to retreat, overshot their mark, even as others bit deep into his flesh, wounds he had no time to take account of. Even her attempted eyeblast was thrown off, as she naturally ducked her head to try and dodge his blade, meaning the shot that was aimed at his torso went lower- though a moment's pressure told him she'd hit him *somewhere*, even as adrenaline and focus overwhelmed any other reports from his body.

But none of her attacks stopped him from making the final blow, a straightforward thrust with his sunsword, right at Octavia's most vulnerable spot:

Her remaining eye.

In a single perfect strike, his sunsword sank through her good eye, into her brain, and out the back of her skull, killing Octavia in a single blow.

He had just enough time, before the blood loss led him into darkness, to know he'd won despite the not-pain numbness of the deep wounds in his body, despite the fact he couldn't feel his left hand for some reason, despite the cost he'd paid... and that was something he took with him into the dark.

(That, and the sound of Mermista screaming... and distantly, a great explosion.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Only two factors kept the Fright Zone from being reduced to a new Flame Waste that day.

The first was Catra, whose involvement few would ever know. In shocking Adora out of her downward spiral with her willing sacrifice, in forcing Adora into a state of effectively total paralysis, she accidentally cleared Adora's mind right before the impact of the cold water and the sudden violent disconnect from the Fright Zone's systems sent the Spirit Ember into a frenzy.

Adora, distracted mid-fight or following her own doomed spiral down- both situations Light Hope could have reasonably assumed she'd be in, given her nature- would not have had the mental stability or even the time to devote the massive mental effort to reigning the Spirit Ember in.

But laying there, staring up at Catra, and- ironically for a Princess of Fire- totally frozen by the choice before her, there was nothing else to distract her from throwing her whole spirit into the task of containing the blast.

(Behold Catra, hero, saving lives even when she doesn't mean to.)

The second were the layered shields Angella and Micah had placed over the Ember. While no wizard in history was strong enough to truly *stop* the Spirit Ember, save perhaps a sorcerous She-Ra, Micah and Angella were a close second; between the two of them, they were able to limit and dull the initial blast.

For these two reasons, the Spirit Ember's outburst was nothing like the apocalyptic force it could have been. Only the immediate area around the Spirit Ember was destroyed, a space a few miles in total area; and for a Runestone whose rage was usually measured to the length of an entire *country,* that did damage that

rewrote *maps,* this was a considerable downgrade from what could have happened.

But- beyond plunging the Fright Zone into darkness, as all the lights went out with the power cut- that did not mean there were not still deaths.

Chapter End Notes

> Spinnerella doing so well against Perfuma is a reference to the original series, where SPinnerella proved surprisingly powerful against the Whispering Woods. Pokemon is right, apparently; Flying beats Grass.

Chapter 70: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: Pouring Fuel on the Fire

Chapter Notes

Work and sickness been kicking my ass but here is the next post! Seriously, I've been so damn sick and work has been so damn busy- but we go!

EDIT: Should clarify- this is all happening a few minutes before the big blast.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A BATTLE FOR THE AGES

Pouring Fuel on the Fire

Scorpia didn't know much, but she knew this:

She shouldn't be here.

And she didn't just mean "not tied to a hunk of rubble by Bow's net arrow." Sure, she probably shouldn't be *there,* either, but that wasn't what she'd meant. She didn't even really mean the Fright Zone itself; this was *home*, after all, this was where she belonged, even if her feelings towards it had become a lot more complicated after Adora ordered her shoved into a bullet-shaped vessel and fired at Beast Island. This was where her people had lived long

before the Horde was ever an idea in the head of a starfallen wanderer.

She meant she should not be *here,* trying to reach the Black Garnet, to do... this thing Entrapta wanted her to do, which she barely understood.

Sure, she wanted revenge on Adora- which was a *weird* feeling, Scorpia didn't think she'd ever *hated* someone enough to want *revenge* before!- and she wanted to help Entrapta, who had saved her and Micah both from Beast Island, and was her friend besides! And she wanted to help Perfuma, whom she mostly knew as an enemy, but...

Well, looking at the pretty woman made her stomach do something interesting, and Scorpia didn't mind *that* at *all.*

But even with all that weighing in favor of doing this...

It still felt *wrong.*

She didn't know *why* she felt that way; she just knew she did, that she had the same kind of electric shiver that went down your back right before an ambush, when some quiet part of your brain had figured out what the rest hadn't, and sent wordless warning up top in hopes of averting disaster. It was the spark of adrenaline, the shock of realization, the fear of danger you knew was there, but couldn't really *see.*

Like the opposite of the way you felt before a big storm swept in from the coast... felt bad. Wrong.

... *Evil.*

She didn't know a better word for it than that. She... she felt like she was about to break something, a sensation *very* familiar to her, big brute that she was; she felt like she was about to break something terribly precious, irreplaceable, that she was about to break something that couldn't be fixed, not even by Entrapta, who could fix so much.

(She thinks maybe that's why she's always liked Entrapta so much; it's good, for a brute like her, to know someone who could *fix* things, and even make them better in the process! So much Scorpia had ruined with a single overly enthusiastic gesture, that Entrapta had then summarily fixed, her presence an unvarnished blessing.)

She didn't know why she knew this, or felt this, save for a buzzing on the tip of her tongue, a kind of ionized scent in the air, almost a voice in the back of her head, as of one speaking through heavy radio static. Someone was trying to tell her all this...

(And she was right, though she would never know it; the Black Garnet, last of the Runestones not claimed by its Princess and thus the last lock on Pandora's box, was trying its best to warn Scorpia, even with all the First Ones had done to it, the lobotomized ruins of its soul still trying their best to avert the damnation of the stars.)

...But maybe she was just being stupid, right? She was a big brute. Always had been. It wasn't like she'd *understood* most of what Entrapta had been saying aboard the Doom Balloon. It was all over her head. She just knew that Entrapta needed her to do this...

And... Entrapta was her only *real* friend until Micah, if she thought about it. Sure, she'd *thought* she had Adora... but Adora had always been a liar. And Scorpia had high hopes for some of the others new, especially for Perfuma, who really seemed to like her!... but as things stood? She had Entrapta and Micah, and Entrapta had asked her to do this.

...Besides... Scorpia owed Entrapta. Owed her three times over, once for being her friend, once for saving Scorpia's life, and once for saving Micah's; and what was it Entrapta liked to say? The equation had to balance? Or compute? Something like that.

Yeah. She...

…

She was trying to convince herself.

Man, this was why she didn't think much! It was *hard!*

She didn't know what to do, which wasn't surprising, because she wasn't very smart! She was just smart enough to *know* she was kinda dumb, which was probably the *worst* amount of smart to be! Any dumber and she'd have no idea she was dumb, any smarter and she wouldn't *be* dumb!

It was a really awkward place to be, honestly.

Which meant...

She had a choice.

(A coin, flipping over and over again, telling her she could choose...)

And she did *not* want to make it.

So... it was kinda good, being stuck to all this rubble. Bow had really done her a solid! Why, so long as she was stuck here, she didn't have to choose, she didn't have to do anything, and... none of it was her fault!

It was why she'd stopped struggling. She'd been pushing against all the rubble she was tied to, initially, pure reflex, and maaaaaybe she'd felt the rock and metal bending before she realized that she could just... stop. Sure, she was super strong, but hey! Maybe she was tied REALLY good! She didn't know! And she didn't want to find out!

She didn't have to do *anything.* She could just sit this out, stuck to this chunk of fallen metal leaning on a building corner for support, and... do nothing but be trapped.

She didn't have to choose.

Not yet.

(*Maybe not ever!* She thought brightly... but somewhere inside, she could still feel a coin, flipping over and over again.)

She waited there, trapped, perfectly content to be so, knowing that if she was free, she'd have to... choose.

*****CATRA OF BRIGHTMOON****

Spinnerella wasn't quite as competitive as her wife- mostly because *no one* was as competitive as her wife- but she had, idly, wondered how she'd measure up against Runestone Princesses in combat.

She figured most Wild Princesses throughout the years had probably had that thought, to be honest. Even the very name of

Wild Princesses set them up as a kind of opposite-but-equal counterparts to the **Runestone** Princesses; it was natural to wonder if the sides really *were* equal, once you had that set-up.

And sure, the Runestone Princesses had their history and legacy behind them... but Wild Princesses had the surprise of their unique magic to back them up.

Who knew who might come out ahead?

Netossa had made plans for just such a thing, of course. And *being* her Nettie, Spinnerella's beloved wife had immediately started researching history, looking to see if any Wild Princesses had ever beaten any Runestone Princesses.

Those histories were hidden, mostly, covered up by Kingdom propaganda or mocked as myths... but even with all that, Netossa had found a few that she felt were real. A Wild Prince of the Flame Kingdom, who had fought his own sister, the Runestone Princess of their land... and won, with the help of a Salinean wave-mage he'd married, afterwards. Another Wild Princess from the Snows, one with power over metal, who had fought a Salinean Prince who had summoned something dark and terrible from the deep... even tales of someone who wasn't even a Prince at all, who had nothing but a star sword to his name, who nonetheless managed to defeat a Runestone Princess, albeit the details on that one were frustratingly vague.

All old stories, and interesting to hear from her Nettie, who had excitedly shared those tales with her on long nights out on

campaign when they had nothing else to do, a lovely nightly ritual. Spinny loved the way her Nettie told her stories, always with such force, such strength, as if she were speaking them into truth by the simple act of telling the tale... why, her Nettie could read a math equation, and Spinny would be enthralled.

(Spinny had heard a million voices on the wind... but her Nettie's voice had a cadence to her ears only love could add.)

But for all her own pondering on the subject and her wife's stories, Spinnerella had always assumed she'd never have to put the idea to the *test.*

And against a damn Plumerian at that, Spinnerella thought, keeping her whirlwind up as she waited to see what Perfuma's great warplant was going to do next. *Strongest of the Runestones, usually...*

Perfuma wasn't doing much to discourage such an assessment, either. Perfuma- whom Spinnerella had always heard was terrified of her own power, though she'd only met the girl in person a time or two- didn't seem to be all that scared of her power *now;* no, she'd made one hell of a warplant, one that had torn through all opposition up until now. It had taken Spinnerella to even make her *pause,* and even now, her warplant was still prodding and poking, trying to find a way to get past the whirling winds.

Impressive as this was, Spinny didn't think it had done Perfuma much good, honestly. Over the winds, Spinnerella could hear Perfuma muttering, the air inside the shell swirling constantly as she kept babbling. Spinnerella was almost impressed; she was

doing a fine one-woman monologue in there, though Spinnerella couldn't make out any of it with all that was going on around her.

Hopefully her impending mental breakdown would weaken her... though some distant part of Spinnerella, which sounded an awful lot like her Nettie, hoped that the young woman would be okay.

(Spinnerella was not kind by nature, but Netossa was, and all married couples adopted parts of each other.)

I'll hope for her to be weaker, because none of the stories Nettie could find ever had a Wild Princess defeating a ***Plumerian...*** *Hell, if you take Angella out of the equation, most Runestone Kingdoms can't claim to have taken out a Plumerian Princess. It was the Horde taking one out, even more than simply conquering the Runestone Duchies and the Fright Zone, that made everyone up north realize they were a serious threat...*

Even as Spinnerella was pondering this, one of Perfuma's snakeheads darted forward, seeking a way past her winds towards some of her Rebels- specifically the two Squamatus who were her best medics.

As Spinnerella couldn't have *that,* she temporarily lessened her focus on the hurricane wall keeping Perfuma back and sent a whirlwind blast at the head, catching it mid-strike and splatting it hard against a nearby wall. The thing vomited on impact, its payload of acidic goop bursting forth like a knocked-out tooth, the wall it struck beginning to melt immediately.

Whatever the hell Perfuma's using, it seems to rot everything it touches...

As she turned her attention back to her hurricane wall, she saw a group of her Rebels, including the lone Troll, get blasted, their attempt to sneak up on Perfuma failing. Dripping green goo, the Rebels ran for it, back through her hurricane wall- which she dropped just for a second so they could pass, immediately spinning it back up to keep Perfuma out- sans weapons and uniform. The Troll in particular seemed embarrassed, big cheeks bright red.

Well, rots everything except flesh, which is at least one good thing.

Still, a compound that could melt anything artificial was a hell of a weapon; if someone wasn't a mage, they relied on equipment, usually, and that meant whatever gunk Perfuma was using was a damn effective way to neutralize enemies. Spinnerella could think of a dozen uses for it as a Rebel, and could probably come up with a thousand if she wasn't busy.

(Spinnerella, bereft of a proper education by her poor upbringing, had no idea what *bitterlye* was, nor any idea of its history... but experience with war meant she grasped the applications pretty quickly.)

Thankfully, the fluid couldn't get through her whirlwinds; it was too light, too big, and wasn't moving fast enough. When it came to projectiles, Spinnerella's whirlwinds didn't make a good shield against tiny, heavy things moving quick. Big stuff caught more wind, was easier to push back, like Perfuma's warplant, as was

light stuff like the fluid Perfuma's heads kept spitting. That stuff she could keep back.

Perfuma tried her spray a few more times, and Spinnerella hoped that would be it... but unfortunately Perfuma had apparently realized the problem, and took steps to rectify it. Her great warplant reached down with its heavy stone pincers and grabbed small chunks of fallen building, then with a great heave hurling them straight at Spinnerella. It wasn't the fastest attack ever- scorpion physiology didn't exactly lend itself to long-distance throwing- but it was certainly heavy enough to not give two shits about Spinnerella's tornado.

So Spinnerella had to dodge, dancing away with a quick twirl, the stone and metal falling behind her and *splatting* on impact with the ground, the rubble already so weakened by the acid of the snakeheads that it turned to rotten mush on impact.

Just wrong, to see stone and metal rot like that... but focus, Spinnerella.

It was good advice, because Perfuma was still throwing chunks of wall at her, following the next toss with trying to press forward at the same time, apparently hoping Spinnerella's whirlwind would weaken with her distraction...

But this wasn't Spinnerella's first rodeo. Nowhere close to it. Spinnerella had fought opponents her wind alone couldn't defeat before- but if your *own* powers didn't work, find something that *could.* A woman whose power relied on spinning learned quickly

about centrifugal force, and about how to use that force to catch and return things thrown at her...

Like Perfuma was now doing.

Spinnerella couldn't quite help the grin on her face as she watched Perfuma toss another chunk of building at her.

As it soared through the air, Spinnerella grabbed it with hands made of hurricane, her power straining to catch something moving so fast- but she wasn't trying to *stop* it, just redirect it, and that made it easier than a full-on block. She turned, and caught a hallucinogenic glimpse of the battlefield as she did so; Perfuma's snakeheads were all over, attacking and attacking, fighting everywhere all at once. A head going towards what Spinnerella thought was Glimmer, who was still battling the dark sorceress; two heads going for some of her Rebels, who'd circled to try and flank the warplant, themselves interrupted by Hordebots attacking them at the same time. Three heads attacking a group of Horde soldiers who'd snuck up behind Perfuma, apparently following the trail of destruction she'd left behind and now trying to defend their home from the invader.

Finally, a head vomiting that green rot all over a... random chunk of metal on the battlefield, one with a net on it?... It wasn't one of her Nettie's webs, just a normal net, though Spinnerella couldn't see what was bound to the rock.

(*What's important enough to set free?* she thought briefly before her mind had to focus on other things.)

But Spinnerella had no time to do anything to assist, even if she wanted to help both her Rebels and Glimmer as well; Spinny wasn't as close to the Brightmoon royal family as her Nettie was- the royal couple had half-adopted Nettie the moment they met, as if going on a test run for when Glimmer hit adulthood- but Spinnerella still considered herself a friend of Angella and Micah, and would assist their daughter if she could.

But no time, not mid-circle. Spinning, the great mass of fallen architecture in her hands dripping with that rot and trying to melt even as she turned with it, soft and disgusting in those places where the rot ruled and hard as steel where stone and metal yet held sway, it was a formidable hunk of material, and she spun with it, completing a circle just as Perfuma, distracted, seemed to notice that her attack hadn't hit Spinnerella.

“Catch!” Spinnerella yelled, laughing with release as she let go of the heavy missile, and added her own punch with a storm of tornado strength, propelling it like a rocket straight back at the warplant that had thrown it in the first place.

She was rewarded with hearing Perfuma *stop* muttering for a second inside her warplant, apparently staring in shock at the incoming hit; and then Spinnerella was rewarded the second time with the actual hit itself, slamming right between the great warplant's claws and directly into the “face” of the beast, sending the titan stumbling and flailing backwards, its legs giving out as its front half was crushed, great spurts of sap and fluid the warplant equivalent of gouts of blood. The snakeheads stopped their attacks, distracted as the body they were attached to fell, and one of her troops finally landed a good hit- Toad, who managed to blow one of the snakeheads up with his rocket launcher, somehow

having kept it functioning despite the waves of tech-rotting filth Perfuma had been spewing.

And there were still more chunks of debris to use, if Perfuma should get up...

Spinnerella wore a wild smile as she reached down with hands made out of slipstream and began the arduous task of lifting one up.

Maybe I'll be able to give my Nettie evidence of a Wild Princess beating a Runestone Princess...

(The fact it would make her competitive wife *so jealous* was just a bonus.)

*****CATRA OF BRIGHTMOON****

Fuck!

That hit had hurt, that hit had hurt, that hit had hurt.

(That hit had hurt that hit had hurt that hit had)

She needed a new plan.

But even as she paused a moment, dazed a bit from the impact- which had not just shaken her warplant shell, but had been so severe that Perfuma's own body had been tossed around inside the shell like a child's rattle- Perfuma kept doing things, her heads still moving even as she couldn't feel her warplant's legs anymore. A head to free Scorpia who was trapped and a head to vomit bitterlye at Bow so she could help Shadow Weaver and some Rebels were shooting at her her her her her herh

Focus!

She sent heads after them bite bite bite breath deadly breath bite a whirlwind was hitting one head and sending it off course and she had to keep interfering with Shadow Weaver, it's Glimmer and Bow that are fighting the dark witch, they are Perfuma's friends, friends, friends, she can't hurt them can't kill them can't let Shadow Weaver hurt and kill them, but still must defeat them. Bow can be beaten if she just catches him with bitterlye but Glimmer... Glimmer Glimmer Glimmer

How do I stop a teleporter?

And why don't my legs work?

It took a second for her to realize that the botanical nerves she used to maintain her warplant's internal communications had been

busted, spurting sap like lifeblood, bursting from the hit, her legs were dead masses beneath her; she sent new vines to grow, new botanical nerves to grow and reconnect and make her whole again.

*Oh yeah, Spinnerella hit me **really** hard, apparently that would have broken my "legs" if I couldn't regenerate; hmm. Need to fight her stop her why is wind doing so well against plants that feels wrong wrong wrong*

Perfuma, flailing, sent roots underground, trying to erupt up from underneath Spinnerella- but no, no, it didn't work, Spinnerella was too high up in the air, she flew above them and pummeled them back to the earth, fuck fuck fuck!

*W ho knew wind was the right answer to defeat plants? You'd think it'd be fire or even ice but no, no, no, apparently it is **wind** that is my weakness, and it's so fucking frustrating I'm so fucking close I can see the fucking Garnet building from here but this All-damned Wild Princess is in the fucking way!*

And her legs still didn't work! How long did it take to regrow those vines? She sent even more energy there, implanting cactus-resilience into the forest-vines, she couldn't afford to lose those again.

In the meantime, her tails still worked, so work them she did. Her pincers also worked but she was too far away thanks to Spinnerella, so only the tails moved! Snakehead after Rebels shooting at her, but Spinnerella was still interfering *fucking*

Spinnerella but she managed to catch some of them in a spray of bitterlye, the others are fine but some of them are ruined, it'll have to be enough that head is getting pummeled to pieces, retreat retreat retreat, another head breathes bitterlye all over Scorpia's netting and then moves on to something else and hopes that Scorpia's not naked now and *wow* thinking about Scorpia naked is *super distracting* and she needs to *not be thinking about that* she's in a fight right now but the idea of a naked woman covered in bitterlye is weirdly attractive, a very back to nature thing, is that a Glory Lily thing, should she be worried about that?

Fuck, Spinnerella is hitting her again, more whirlwinds, can't she do something else for once in her life, fuck, snakeheads interfering all around as some Horde troops pile in from behind but those are easy to deal with just a big old line of bitterlye and they're done. The real problem is Glimmer and Bow, Glimmer and Bow, Bow takes Bitterlye but what to do about Glimmer? Can't hold her down, she can teleport, can't just grab her in toothless jaws and softly gum her until this is all over, maybe just keep her distracted? Keep chasing her, but keep her distracted, don't let Shadow Weaver kill her the way she will if I stop paying attention, but Spinnerella was pressing her hard...

Then relief, unexpected and surprising, as something flew forward, too fast and heavy to be affected by the wind, and struck Spinnerella in the chest.

And all of Perfuma's snakeheads turned to watch as a great machine came loping out of the ruins behind her warplant, a squat beast of a machine moving on both arms and legs like a great gorilla, the unarmored cockpit revealing a familiar face.

“Scorpia, go!” Entrapta yelled, her clearly jury-rigged mech carrying a large, rotating gun that fired... syringes? It looked syringes, though who knew what they were full of... it was purple, though, and looked unhealthy in Perfuma's admittedly unprofessional opinion.

Spinnerella weaved in the air, initially keeping up the wind but soon beginning to bob up and down, blinking constantly as whatever was in the syringe that had struck her took effect. No others hit her- even half-dazed, Spinnerella was smart enough to keep moving, and her erratic movements made it even harder to hit her for Entrapta, who was no born markswoman- but even so, the first hit was telling- the whirlwind shield was failing.

Through all her eyes, Perfuma took in the battle as it stood- saw Shadow Weaver, Glimmer and Bow disappear around a corner, Hordebots rushing in to assist the dark sorceress; saw the Rebels trying to step it up even as their strongest fighter faltered, saw Entrapta charging forward without care or concern in the world... saw Scorpia, free of the rock wall- and not naked save some holes in her pants from errant splatters *more's the pity* - making one last run for the Black Garnet's chamber.

And then Perfuma felt the *snap* as her legs connected with the rest of her again.

I can feel my legs again!

Perfuma got up, her mind running with fevers. She felt like an engine in overdrive, or at least, what she thought an engine in

overdrive was; it was a term she'd picked up when looking into Dryl things, or maybe something she'd heard, or a term she'd made up? She couldn't tell, not anymore, her mind was split in too many pieces for her to focus on much.

She wasn't sure, now.

(Something is pouring out of her mouth. She thinks it's her blood. It doesn't matter. It doesn't matter it doesn't matter it doesn't matter it doesn't-)

She wasn't holding together all that well her mind runneth over she is nearing her limits she is so close so close so close so close but not there yet, she can hold on just a little longer, long enough to get this DONE get Scorpia to the Garnet finish the job no matter who is opposing them or why. She will trust in Entrapta in Entrapta in Entrapta...

With a roar from her many mouths- a roar half-slurred out of her real mouth, mumbled through a mouthful of her own blood- Perfuma got up on stumbling legs and staggered forth one last time into the breach.

*****CATRA OF BRIGHTMOON****

The Red Knight waited inside the Garnet, reviewing all their long memories.

They had been made in another time, and by accident; an attempt by Moorstone deserters to create an invincible suit of armor that would grant its wearer immortality, which had worked... just not the way they'd hoped. Mages of the foul nobles of Moorstone had worked with smiths to craft sublime steel sheathed in sublime spellcraft, and the end result…

Well, immortality certainly *was* a word you could use to describe the gestalt consciousness of the Knight. They'd succeeded in that much, even if, in using a prisoner as the first host, they'd inadvertantly given the Red Knight all the reason they'd needed to desert Moorstone for Blackmoor.

How do I fight a Scorpioni?

Answer from some of its former bearers, which the Red Knight saw as memories, but dimly; the farther back they went, the harder it was to recall, the mind overstuffed. They'd hoped to ask Angella how she dealt with her memory issues; surely she had them too, old as she was, but she apparently had ways around them that the Red Knight was *very* interested in.

But that was a problem for later. For now...

Focus.

It was not unlike fishing, which enough of the Red Knight's wearers had enjoyed that it had bled into the general personality. Hunting for memories was like different kinds of fishing, too; recent memories were like fly-fishing, and hunting the oldest memories was like deep-sea trawling, deploying an anchor into the abyss and hoping to strike something.

This, though, was more recent, only a century back, and so it was more like common pole-and-line fishing.

A century back, there'd been a period of aggression from the Fright Zone, not exactly sanctioned by the then-Queen, but also not explicitly banned. A time when the second and younger children of noble houses had been encouraged by their parents to go looking for trouble in foreign lands, to try and carve out territory for their house, and not incidentally get them out of the way of their older siblings. These were mostly failures, and the Red Knight had been the reason for some of those failures.

Scorpioni... strong opponents. Chitin near everywhere, heavily armored. Strike legs- not knees- underside of arms above pincers, face. Soft areas, no chitin or weaker chitin in those places. Avoid tail, heavy chitin means it can't be chopped off, and the tip has a paralytic that will stop the body cold; armor might be able to keep moving but will be difficult without the body underneath.

The fighting style and forms it would need to use flowed through its body, creating memory for the muscle, translating what the armor knew to the physical body that wore it. A conversation, in some ways, the combined Red Knight not entirely the armor nor

entirely their wearer, but both and neither, greater than the sum of its parts.

But even as it reviewed those memories, it knew it would be a tricky thing. Scorpia was tough even by her people's high standards, strong enough to battle the She-Ra herself and sometimes come out on top by pure brute strength alone; the Red Knight was not so vaunted a warrior as the legendary Princess of Power, which did not bode well for the future confrontation.

Still, the Knight *did* have a lot of experience... and maybe if they added a good ambush...

Skill... and maybe a good ambush. They started looking for a good spot to jump Scorpia from; it was always easier to win a fight with someone who didn't *know* they were in a fight until you were already hitting them, and the Knight would take any advantage they could get.

(It often surprised their enemies, but Blackmoor, strong as they held to honor, did not actually think it had much to do with *combat.* Honor was about the rules of civilized society, after all... and someone trying to kill you had already thrown those out. Why, it'd simply be rude not to respond in kind- and Blackmoor held strong to *politeness,* too.)

Now, the Red Knight didn't know this area, not as well as Scorpia would, but it was well-lit and not a complicated place- mostly hallways and smaller rooms on the side full of tech. Navigating it wasn't that difficult, at least, with the lights on; in the dark, this would be nearly impossible, but with the Fright Zone's artificial lighting it wasn't hard.

Which, sadly, worked against them, too; with the lights on, there was no good place to hide. Worse, Horde architecture, with its focus on big, open hallways and grandiose rooms, proved surprisingly poor for would-be bushwhackers like themselves. A few minutes searching mostly gave the Red Knight frustration, though they *did* find the Black Garnet.

It had been... frightening, to be before a Runestone. They had only ever stood before the Moonstone, and just like then, they had *felt* the power inside the stone, the energy it bled into the world that made up the heart of all magic. Grand and alone, imposing and mighty, the fulcrum on which the world now turned had sent an electric tingle into the air, static shock licking along the lines of their armor, the Storm solidified and made manifest.

The room was... unnerving.

(They had tried not to shiver. They had not succeeded.)

Still, finding it gave them a better idea of where to wait for Scorpia. As defending the Garnet was what mattered, they now knew they had to be nearby... hmm. There was a long hallway outside the Garnet's room... not the only way in, but the most obvious way in from the direction of the fighting... and keeping the door open would let them know if anyone approached from the other ways. Doors wouldn't stop Scorpia, so it wasn't a bad idea to leave one open...

Hmm.

And this hallway... maybe a good place to catch Scorpia. If they couldn't surprise her, maybe they could talk to her, see if they could argue a way out of all this mess... and if nothing else, the hallway was relatively small, by Horde standards. Not quite as grandiose as the usual.

So, try to talk to her, and if that failed...

*Maybe I can push her back, outside, towards the others... if I can't win the fight, then take Scorpia to those who **can.***

And hope nothing major changes. It wouldn't take much to tip the scales towards Scorpia in this fight.

And with that plan in mind, the Red Knight waited, spear in hand, for the future to find them.

Chapter End Notes

> The stories Spinnerella is thinking of are references to Avatar the Last Airbender and the follow-up series, Korra. These aren't the actual version of events, of course; these are what the tales have become over centuries, since these are stories so old they predate the First Ones' arrival on the planet.

Chapter 71: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: All these Coals to Rake Over

Chapter Notes

Some chapters pop right out, and others take some thinking.

This was one of the latter ones.

I had SO MANY ideas for how to do this chapter, this event, this moment... but then I realized it was best to just let it exist on its own. To be what it is, wholly and completely, without interruption.

Without further ado... a choice.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A BATTLE FOR THE AGES

All these Coals to Rake Over

Adora stared up at Catra, and nothing passed through her mind.

Oh, she still had *sensations.* The dull pain of her wounded eye and arm, which never entirely left her, ever, even when medicated; pain that was joined by pain of exhaustion, pain of pulling muscles and exerting herself past her own limits, pain she only felt now that the high of adrenaline was wearing off and she had to stop and take stock of the situation. The sensation, distant,

of her sister, of the warm hot fire of the Spirit Ember, still empowering her even when she wasn't actively throwing flame.

(At this very second, far away, the Hordebot moved towards the button in the Spirit Ember's chamber, to press it in a few mere moments...)

All familiar, expected sensations. The dull pain in her eye and arm were old friends by now, she had over-exerted herself before- usually in trying to impress Shadow Weaver- and she'd gotten used to the Spirit Ember's omnipresent nature in her life surprisingly quickly. It had been… comforting, like a warm fire on a cold night.

But other sensations filtered through her too-clear mind, new sensations that made her heart beat at a thousand miles an hour, that belied how terrifyingly calm she felt, her blood racing around inside her like a thunderstorm set ablaze.

The blazing heat all around them, the sound of the Fright Zone almost literally cooking around them, aftermath of her apocalyptic fury; the stink of melting plastic, of bubbling concrete, of cooked rubber and boiled steel. The feeling of Catra saying *I love you,* which had landed like a hammer in Adora's heart, or at least, where she thought that broken organ's ashes might yet be.

The good weight of Catra atop her, feeling almost like long-ago days in bed at the Fright Zone, sleeping together long before the connotations of the words "sleeping together" were known to either of them… nights when, ironically, they were able to use the darkness to hide from Shadow Weaver, seeking comfort in each other's mere presence. Come the morning light, they'd be

separated, Shadow Weaver always doing whatever she could to keep the two apart without being cruel or heavy-handed enough to push Adora away…

But in the dark, they could be together.

And above all else, the thing Adora felt was the *pressure* of her gauntlet on the obsidian knife in her hand, the volcanic glass weighing nothing, nothing, nothing, which was ironic, too; it weighed so *heavy* in her mind, even as it weighed so little in her hand, this knife with which she could cut short the life of a hero, pin her name in history's pages as one of its worst villains, with which she could carve a path to her destiny…

(*Or the knife with which you can cut your destiny to shreds,* said some cool and dark part of her mind, of deepest darkness and thus oldest truth, the cloak of night that had hidden them from Shadow Weaver as children given voice. *The knife that you can use to cut yourself free of your self-destruction, a knife you use by* ***not*** *using it; let go, and change your life…*)

She lay there, and thought nothing, and felt everything, for what had to be an eternity. An eternity of listening as the nation that had followed her burned in her wake, a legacy of ashes; an eternity of looking up at Catra, who loved her so much she was willing to *die* if Adora did not love her back; an eternity of feeling ashes on her burned flesh as they rained down, there in the ruin and wreckage of everything Adora's choices had ever led her to.

Her choices...

Like this one.

Another choice.

(There is a coin, long dormant, that finally begins to spin, somewhere inside.)

Her instincts say to strike. To be what she *should* be. She is an abomination, a monster, the Lord of the Horde! Catra is the hero, she is the villain. This is not a complicated situation.

This should be so *simple.*

(*but it isn't, is it?* whispers the cold and the dark. *Nothing's* ***ever*** *been that simple, has it?*)

Simple. Stick the knife in. Kill Catra. Take advantage of the noble hero's sole weakness, her love for the villain, and put an end to it. Quick, clean, perfect. Prove that I am Catra's equal, no, her superior, the way she was all their childhood, and master your destiny!

But to the wildfire of those thoughts was applied a cold wind, from elsewhere in her mind.

And then what?

Stupid question. Why, then I take the Horde and I conquer all Etheria...

A sudden collapse nearby drew her attention, her eye snapping towards the falling building. She became aware, once more, of the world outside herself, as a building fell apart, material finally letting go with an almost-wet *snap* like breaking bone, the sound precipitating the much louder roar of the entire structure's total collapse. Fire, fire *everywhere* that Adora could see, and the distant sounds of battle as the civil war raged on...

And for the first time since she woke up to Lonnie's frantic warning, Adora had a moment to consider how much *damage* was being done.

All of Grizzlor's forces... and the Alliance is here too... the army heading to Plumeria might be okay, unless Grizzlor had traitors there too... and...

She stared at the huge circle of fire all around this, this *arena* she'd cleared with Catra's body and her own power, this place where she'd intended to have her final throwdown with the woman she loved (and kind of hated, it was complicated, as so much was.) This area, before she'd burnt it to ash, had been... factories and production facilities, she thought... and now they were surrounded by the detritus of Horde manufacturing, and she'd torn through lines of housing to even *get* here, a straight line of blazing fires behind her that would have spread in the meantime...

This *alone* represented damage that would grind the Horde to a halt while it was being repaired...

And *none* of this was *Grizzlor's* doing.

(There was only one Fire Princess in the Horde, after all.)

She'd been in such a state after her attempted assassination- her own people had tried to *kill* her- and then she'd seen *Catra* and the hellhound, the hellhound in her head, it was out, it was out, it was out, but...

She hadn't... she hadn't *meant* to...

(Or maybe she *had,* and she's not sure which one is worse.)

She swallowed against a dry mouth and returned to looking back up at Catra, whose face was scrunched up, her eyes shut, like a little child afraid of a nightmare; Adora had seen that face before, in those rare nights where they got to be together. Catra was not one who slept without fear, without memory, without... bad dreams. Adora had sometimes been woken by very small noises Catra would make- so small, so quiet, so scared to be heard even in her sleep that sometimes Adora wasn't sure she'd heard them at all- and she would always lean down and hold Catra until she stopped wearing that face, and went back to peaceful dreams again.

And now I'm the nightmare that hurts her, came the stray thought. *When I used to be the one to comfort her...*

(The thought came with a sinking feeling, a sense of drowning, of having lost something irreplaceably precious...)

She lay there for a long moment, the adrenaline fading, her mind ticking over everything that had happened in... had it been merely a few hours? Had her *entire life* been destroyed in the course of a few hours? It felt like months. Years. Eternities. It... it wasn't *possible* that everything that had happened was a matter of *minutes,* could be measured in the span of less than a day, and yet...

She had been awoken to knowing that Grizzlor had betrayed her. She had awoken in time to put her armor on and get ambushed, her own people blowing up her home to kill her; she had... she had unleashed the hellhound, she had snarled and barked and *bit,* all fire and rage, killing her attackers, and the War had raged and raged and...

And then Catra, and she'd told her... the First Ones...

Not angels, but that can't be right. I'm... no, no, no, I ***have*** *to be the sole fallen among the race of angels, or otherwise I'm...*

(*Not special,* came the cold dark voice inside. *The way Shadow Weaver always told you that you were. Her poison lives inside you still, in ways you don't even notice...*)

But I have to be the mistake. To... to be Catra's equal, I have to be... and all I've done, it's so much worse if I'm a First One and they're...

(*If you're normal for a First One,* whispered her truth once more, *then, again, not special... not that being a First One isn't, by itself, special...*)

Maybe... maybe she could just... stop. Stop, the way Catra had been trying to get her to do, all these years...

But what would be the point? What's even left? I... I've ruined everything I've ever touched, I'm a monster, maybe I'm not special but I ***am*** *a monster, so much death, so much death, so much blood on my hands, warmonger dictator murderer murderer murderer*

And it felt *cruel,* impossibly cruel, to come to this realization now, only now, when it was too late to turn her course...

(*You had chances to turn,* the dark said- the dark inside her, which she was just now realizing was just her own conscience, long ignored, the cold dark voice was just *herself,* in the end. The part of her that had, once upon a time, been kind to a little girl named Catra, a part that she'd put away when she burned that village, so long ago now. *You did not take them. But you can still take this one...*)

If she were to spare Catra... if she put the knife down, if she finally did the one thing Catra wanted her to do, and *stop...*

(the coin, flipping over and over again, a choice long made now reconsidered, a chance to try again...)

Well, ask the question again.

And then what?

(*You go home,* said her conscience.)

Home? No, that doesn't make sense. She *has* no home. Not anymore.

She couldn't stay in the Horde. She'd betrayed it too much already; why, between the two of them, Catra was the more loyal Hordesman. Catra had only turned on them after finding a mythic relic and a lifetime of mistreatment; but Adora, golden child that she was, nonetheless murdered Hordak for power, turned herself into a Runestone Princess, and then led the Horde to such ruin that it had entered *civil war,* a concept that still felt alien, even as she was living it.

Oh, yes, by comparison with Adora, Catra was damn near loyal.

Adora was not just *a* traitor, she was the *Traitor Lord*- a phrase that still hurt to think about... but one that was true nonetheless.

No, the Horde wasn't home for her. Not anymore.

So why do you say I go home? I have no home.

(*Yes, you do,* the quiet and dark said; and she wondered at that, what could it mean, there was no where to go?... until she looked up at...)

Catra, above her, eyes still shut... except one of them was just the slightest bit open, peeking down at her.

Of course, Adora thought, with nostalgic fondness that almost crushed her under its weight, something so elegaic and terribly sweet it was almost cancerous. *You never **could** resist peeking when I asked you to shut your eyes...*

Catra, whom she knew so well; better than she knew herself, really...

...Catra, who wanted her to come with her, to go...

...Oh.

...*I... I understand. **Catra** is home.*

(*Finally,* her conscience said... but the tone was almost fond.)

And that answer was so simple that it was obvious why she'd never considered it; but that was all Catra had ever done, wasn't it? Catra, who even *now,* with a knife to her belly, just wanted

Adora to *stop,* and come with her... Catra, who had only ever wanted Adora to *join* her. To come...

To come *home.*

(*Even when this all started, some part of you* ***wanted*** *to stop,* her conscience whispered. *Even back then...*)

...She'd spent a long time listening to the hellhound in her head, a hellhound absent now, Catra's offer having banished it from her mind... at least for now. And after, she'd tried to be a dragon, tried to be *the* Dragon, Lord of the Horde, but that had ended in... all this.

Maybe it was time to listen to that part of her from back then, that part that wanted to...

Stop.

(the coin lands)

Adora, who had lied her way through the world for half a decade now, had not the strength to voice the truth at this last moment; instead, she simply let her actions speak for her.

She let go of the knife in her hand, dismissed her armor, and gently- very gently- placed her hand on the scar where, so long ago, she had nearly killed the woman she loved.

“Catra,” she said, to the woman who was the only home she had left, the one home that had *never* turned her away, and never would.

(She means *I love you.* She means *I'm so sorry for what I've done.* She means *I'll stop.*)

“...Adora?” Catra said, eyes opening fully, ears perking up and she was so *beautiful,* had anyone in all the world ever been so beautiful?

And the way she said her name, so quiet and so small, so afraid that to speak too loudly would be to wake up from this dream. To know that she meant so much still to this woman who should, by all rights, hate her...

It shattered Adora's charred heart into a thousand burned pieces, and tears formed in her eyes, tears that the Hordesman could not help but be ashamed of, just a little... but they fell nevertheless, marking clean trails down the ash on her cheeks.

“I surrender,” she said.

(She means *It's over.* She means *You were right.* She means *Let's go home.*)

Catra *smiled* then, her face lighting up with something so beautiful that it made Adora's whole world better even *despite* all that had

happened, a smile that was only enhanced by the tears falling freely and unashamedly down her beloved's cheeks; and Catra did not act ashamed of them.

Of course she doesn't, she's of Brightmoon now, and they do not fear their sorrow in that place...

And for the first time, Adora wonders if that was strength, not weakness.

It's a good question to keep; she'll have time and opportunity both to figure it out. She'll be a prisoner in Bright Moon, after all. At least she's heard they treat their POWs well; well enough that more Hordesman defect to the purple and pink flag than to any other, or so her intelligence reports had said. Catra was the most prominent example by far, but not the only one.

And I'm joining her as one of those defectors right now, Adora thought, and almost laughed- but not in the whipsaw way, no, this was real laughter, genuine laughter, and she couldn't help the giggle that passed her lips. She was high right now, soaring on a sea of emotions, feeling both terrible guilt and crushing *relief* ; she had failed the Horde, and that was the guilt, but now she was *free* of the Horde, and that was the *relief.* She... she was done. It was over.

She had stopped.

“I accept!” Catra shouted with joy, leaping off of her and offering a hand. “I accept!”

(And Adora knows she means *I love you.*)

Adora reached a hand out to the woman she loved, to take her hand in her own, and move on out of this nightmare.

And in that moment, the Spirit Ember exploded like a bomb, and Adora's world was turned into sharpest *pain.*

Chapter End Notes

> Next up: surprise guest Razzle Dazzle! We're VERY close to the end, folks. With this writer's blockage out of the way, hopefully I can finish up soon!

Chapter 72: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: Out of the Frying Pan

Chapter Notes

A day late, but hey, nobody's perfect :D

HERE YA GO!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A BATTLE FOR THE AGES

Out of the Frying Pan

Madame Razz, sometimes Razzle Dazzle when she was feeling particularly mischievous, ran as fast as she could, old feet carrying her at a greater speed than most would expect. She ran, and her head ticked with an invisible clock whose timer she could not see, a timer that ended with *and the Spirit Ember kills us all.*

She didn't know how much time she had left on that clock; she just knew it was ticking down, down, *down.*

With that dread hanging over her, she moved swiftly and silently through the Fright Zone. A quickly-woven spell, using every magic but the Spirit Ember's, wove a shield of defense and ignorance

around her, let her pass as unnoticed as a quiet breeze on a windy day, redirecting bullets and arrows and more esoteric weapons that might intercept her path even as it kept her from being detected. Not a perfect spell- anyone *really* trying to find her would pierce it- but it didn't need to be.

Everyone in the Fright Zone had *much* bigger problems than a rogue maybe-Twigget, right now.

She saw proof of that with every step of her feet. She passed through the great suicide that history- if there was a future for history to be written in- would call the Horde Civil War, and every moment brought some new bout of horrible violence. She passed a scene of Hordesmen all holding each other at swordpoint, none knowing who to trust, an uneasy truce that would be broken soon enough; she passed a Hordesman on fire, the woman's screaming mixing with the roar of the flames as they consumed her, nothing to suggest *how* this had happened, or why, lending the whole thing the hallucinatory horror of witnessing someone else's nightmare. She even passed a small war crime and atrocity, as a surrendering Hordesman was nonetheless murdered by those he'd surrendered to, in defiance of all decency.

She shuddered at the sight. All war was ugly, even if it was at times necessary, but there were ways to wage it without giving in to the worst impulses…

But here, such ideas had no quarter. Even with all war being ugly, still was the ugliest of all a *civil* war.

And because it *was* ugly, she did what she could to help. She had little magic to spare, most of her great reserve had to be conserved for the great deed she was preparing for, the thing that might save the stars above… but she had a *little* to spare.

So she sent healing spells to the wounded that weren't too far gone for such help, or calming spells to those powered by fury and rage; maybe it would let them rethink what they were doing, or give some of them a chance to escape. Maybe not... but what else could she do? You did what you could, even under such pressure.

Hordesmen weren't the only beneficiaries of her deeds, either. As she ran, she passed a small spot of Alliance members, too- a gathering of Princesses and some of their warriors, assisting a young man on the ground who was, at the moment, missing his left hand and covered in deep wounds all over. He was losing blood at such a rate that he'd painted the world scarlet around him; he was going to die soon, even with the help he was receiving. An old Hordesman was using his people's first aid while a Snows cleric added the weight of her own culture, but they didn't have the resources to make up for the blood loss...

The young man didn't seem much bothered, though. He was being held by a Princess, a child of water and waves, who held his head in her hands with tears flowing freely down her stoic cheeks, so horrified that the ever-sarcastic soul was rendered uncharacteristically silent, only begging him with her eyes to live.

(All the young man did was put a hand to her face and tell her she was so beautiful; no fear of death in this one, not even now, when the reaper's footsteps could be heard.)

If he'd been alone, Razz wouldn't have been able to do much, but she *could* send him some Heart-Blossom energy, power of green and growing things, help with the blood situation... if the others could keep him from losing even *more* blood...

She sent the spell to him, a thing of green and mint, of growth and life; it slipped unnoticed into his veins, giving his marrow power and speed to fill him once again with the liquid of life. It was all she had time for, but maybe it would tip the balance.

She wished she could stay longer, but knew she couldn't; didn’t mean she didn’t feel a pang in her conscience. That leaving him was, without doubt, the *right* thing to do, did not make it a *comfortable* thing to do...

Still, she had to go.

So past them she ran, ever further, into the depths of the Fright Zone, hoping against hope she was not too late. She was so close, she was reaching it, maybe it was enough... there were people here. Hordesman, talking with... Queen Angella and King Micah? Yeah, those could be useful, they were great mages, maybe they could teleport it back!

She was about to greet them when the world burst into fire.

<u>CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>***

Adora's world was pain.

(*Adora! Adora!* She heard Catra yell, but distantly, as if through ears other than her own, pain too great to focus.)

Pain in every inch every drop every *cell* of her body, pain down unto her bones, pain and... *panic.* Panic, fear, terror, *hurt.*

Her sister in sin was being killed. That's what it felt like. Someone had done *something* to her, something that hurt, hurt, hurt, and the Ember was trying to save herself, trying to defend herself, lashing out- fire fire fire, burn things, burn *everything,* the fire was spinning and spinning and that was good, the heat was good, safe, good, safe, the Ember wanted to be safe and the only way to do that was to *strike back.*

Questions in her mind meant nothing as the fire around her wounded eye blazed out of control, all the wounds she'd gained in the world that never was aching and aching, she couldn't formulate a thought, couldn't do *anything,* she just hurt down unto her *soul,* it *hurt hurt hurt...*

And suddenly there was cool golden life, flowing in her veins.

She opened her eyes, couldn't see out of her bad eye but the good eye saw... Catra?

Catra, who was She-Ra again, and golden light, flowing inside her...

“I've got you, I've got you,” Catra told her, as her power washed over Adora, healing her... golden light, that patched her up, repaired her, put her back together again. It washed over her wounds and even the old ones were made not so bad; it didn't fix her left arm or her left eye, but it made them a bit better, enough she could see out of the blurry eye better, enough that her arm didn't hurt so much. Soothing. Good.

(She remembered, vaguely, a thing she had read in Hordak's notes, of a practice in Mystacor, where they took broken things and repaired them with drops of gold... and in that moment ,she felt the same way those teapots did, and it was good.)

The healing gave her room to *think...* and to *command...*

She reached out with her mind, her control, to her Runestone, which was... still bursting, still blazing... but why? Cold, it said... cold, cold, cold, wet, wet, wet...

I know what this is, Adora thought. *The failsafe... someone triggered it. Probably Grizzlor's goons... never meant for it to be used like that...*

She tried to soothe her sister, calm her down, quiet the raw, ragged edges of her screaming Runestone. It was... it was *scared,* frightened, lashing out like a nervous child as she tried to comfort and console and convince it to stand down, which it did *not* want to do... it didn't understand why she was stopping it. It was just defending itself...

...Is that all it is? she wondered, as she concentrated on stopping the Spirit Ember, as Catra's healing stabilized her, the golden glow calming the rage of fire down to something manageable. *Is that why the Runestone burns? Is it just... trying to* ***defend*** *itself, the only way it knows how?*

And she could *see* it, trace the line of thought; the last Flame Princess had triggered the destruction of her people because her heart was broken, and the Spirit Ember... it had tried to help, hadn't it? It had interpreted her suffering as an *attack,* and so it had responded with its power. Like one who had a hammer, and saw all problems as nails... the Runestone had flame, and all things looked like kindling.

Maybe the Runestone's propensity for disaster was simply because it was trying to *defend* itself, in a way that didn't work, maybe all her sister's sins were simply this: she wished above all things to be *safe,* and interpreted all discomfort and hurt as attack. Cold water could not truly damage the Spirit Ember, not in any way that could matter... yet still she lashed out with screaming death upon unexpected contact with it...

That's it, isn't it? All this death and disaster and the doom that has followed you, my Spirit Ember... just because you wanted to be

*safe. You were trying to **save** your last Princess when you melted her kingdom...*

Adora almost wanted to laugh, could feel the whipsaw inside, ready to let out. The Spirit Ember's mistakes... were so *simple,* when you looked at it like this. Like a loving and loyal but *stupid* dog, who misunderstood its masters playfighting for real, and thus savaged the master's friend when they pretended to swordfight with sticks…

(*And doesn't **that** feel familiar, Adora?* the quiet dark conscience inside her said. *All the things you've done... because Shadow Weaver told you that you were special... and then **Catra** got the Sword. So you tried to be special by being the bad guy...*)

Maybe her and the Spirit Ember really *were* siblings, sisters in sin...

"Spirit Ember's bursting," Adora whispered drunkenly to her beloved, "keep... keep healing me... stop it..."

"Okay," Catra said, and held the woman she loved tight as she fought a war inside herself to calm the flame.

<u>CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>***

It is a testament to Micah and Angella that the shields they erected over the Spirit Ember took ten entire seconds total to shatter. Ten long seconds, over three times what all the mages who had went to the Flame Waste so long ago had been able to manage; ten seconds, three of which were needed for Adora to exert her will on her Runestone, and tamp down what was coming into something that would not melt the entire nation, and thus three seconds too late for her to stop the initial blast.

Without those shields, fully half the Fright Zone would have been consumed in the fires before Light Hope teleported the Spirit Ember out, having timed it with machine perfection so it would not reach the Black Garnet... but *with* those shields, the extra time gave Adora a chance to limit the damage. Only ten percent of the Fright Zone was wiped clean in the Spirit Ember's volcanic rage.

But there were many lives even in that ten percent alone.

Lives like Micah, for whom those ten seconds lasted an eternity. His life on the Island had been made up of moments less than a second, of moments where a second lasted as long as a minute, adrenaline distorting the flow of time; and so in those ten seconds, he knew the shields would not hold, felt them burn up even as they resisted.

One second.

His feet ached to run, his arms to grab Flutterina and Angella, escape and flee.

Two seconds.

His mind counteracted the reaction; he could not run fast enough. Not by himself, not with his family in his arms, not in any way; he knew how big the Flame Waste was. Distances of *nations* were involved.

Three seconds.

But he had been preparing a spell, wasn't he? A teleport spell. One for the Spirit Ember, to send it back where it came from.

Four seconds.

Angella was just now reacting; she had not spent years on Beast Island, but she *was* an old veteran. Grizzlor, too, and some of his troops, were moving, reacting, but Micah's world had shrunk down to the woman he loved and the little adorable kid who'd come with them, and he paid them no further attention. The fire had his attention, and he thought it wasn't expanding as rapidly, now, and he didn't know why... but that meant more time to save his family, so he was grateful for it nonetheless.

(Unbeknownst to him, the slowdown was Adora's doing, her mind immediately trying to shut down the Ember, having caught up a second ago and her influence being felt now.)

Five seconds.

A teleport spell formed in his hands. A spell to go *back.* Back... and for Angella and Flutterina, that would be Brightmoon Castle, that would be *home,* they would be *safe.*

(He never thought of himself. He never does.)

Six seconds.

His spell finished, even as Angella was opening her mouth- to shout warning, perhaps, or just to scream. Screaming was not an incorrect response; within the dome of their magical shields, the world had turned to flame, to red and orange and white, the whole thing a transparent window into a world of fire that would soon burst out of it and obliterate all life. It was an ending and one that was cruel enough to show off *before* it killed you, their shields accidentally making a stage production out of their own deaths.

Seven seconds.

He would never know what his Angie was going to do with her open mouth, because in that moment, he cast his spell.

Eight seconds.

It hit his wife and it hit his new daughter's squire, and they were both thrown away, away, *away,* with all the force the greatest mage of his generation could muster, sending them *home.*

Nine seconds.

He wished he had more time with his Angie. He wished he'd thought to send himself too. He wished... wait, was that Madame Razz he was seeing in the distance? And were her hands glowing with a spell?

Ten seconds.

Right as his shields failed, just as the hairs on his beard were charring from the unleashed heat, he felt the wash of a teleport spell over him, one that chased his wife and squire; a basic spell, a tag-along spell, but one that had been cast with the weight of a planet behind it. The magic washed over others, he thought, but he had no time to focus on that, just enough time to wonder what the blastwave of the Spirit Ember would do to the spell, teleport spells were so famous for scattering at the least resistance...

And then he was going, body made into light, the raw chaos of the Spirit Ember sending him spiraling from whatever destination he'd been aimed at to somewhere *else.*

He reformed somewhere dark and cool, falling through the night sky, and he hit... sand, he thought, before the impact and the

aftereffects of such a rough teleport knocked him unconscious.

CATRA OF ETHERIA

In the halls of Brightmoon Castle, where the Third Raid on the Fright Zone had started, there were only a few servants cleaning the room.

They were the only witnesses to Queen Angella, who had been teleported with the force of a hammer throw, skipping like a stone across the planet and slung halfway up the continent by her husband's spell. Such a spell had no gentle landing, and it ended with her bodily hurled to the floor, skidding from impact, Flutterina following her with the grace of a thrown sack of potatoes, to crash hard against the far wall and pass out in a slump. The teleport was too rough to do elsewise; normally a teleport didn't have such effects on its passengers, but Micah had cast his spell rough and quick, without any of the protections usually woven into a teleport. Their brains had simply failed to deal with being made into light and then unmade into flesh in a matter of seconds, as brains usually fail to do, and responded in the most rational fashion by shutting down to reboot themselves.

(This was the same reason Micah himself passed out when Razz saved him; teleporting a person was *not* a gentle process if one didn't use the safeguards. Only Glimmer could ignore such rules, and she was a special case.)

As might be imagined, this caused quite a panic amidst the servants and the Castle in general; the Queen, without her King, unconscious? They did what they could to help her, but she would not awaken.

And so with fear and worry for their immortal leader, all of Brightmoon waited anxiously for her to awaken.

<u>*CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>**

Light Hope observed the blast with interest.

(1010101101andjoytherealmeisgladthatsomuchdeathwasaverted1010101000)

Despite the best efforts of the She-Ra, Flame Princess, and Brightmoon royalty... the blast was still accomplishing her goals. The various bots gave her a front-row seat, each transmitting until they were fried, letting her see the event as it happened from a thousand eyes. All of Grizzlor's forces were obliterated, save for Grizzlor himself and those in the absolute back of his ranks; those in the back survived due to distance, but Grizzlor lived due to the interference of the bizzare entity known as Madame Razz, who Light Hope's analysis instruments had *never* gotten a good read on. The maybe-Twigget had teleported him out, as well as King Micah and herself and maybe a few others, though Light Hope's sensors had blitzed out at that second and she wasn't sure if anyone else had made it or where such survivors might be.

Still, no matter. Unless they were all teleported to the Black Garnet- and she had no indication such was the case- they couldn't interfere in time to matter.

Those left were not so lucky. Sherrilyn, Dawg, and Destroyer, subset called the Fighting Foe Men, whom the Fright Zone's nobility had once feared, who had served the Horde for decades, died instantly, reduced to less than ash as the Spirit Ember's outburst flash-fried them mid-word. Old Zin, luck finally run out, died as shrapnel tore him to pieces before those chunks were themselves vaporized. The rest were baked alive on contact with the air itself, long before the volcanic fires reached them, the blastwave so hot it killed via convection alone.

That tied up *those* loose ends neatly enough.

She watched as the Spirit Ember reached its outer limits of influence before it began to trail off. Such power! The circular area of devastation carved was total; neither the civil war currently raging nor the massive trail of destruction Flame Princess Adora had carved as she slammed She-Ra Catra and herself through multiple buildings could match the Spirit Ember's power. Those things left rubble, after all.

The Ember left nothing but ashes and cooling lava.

Even in the context of the civil war, this was unprecedented. Fights far from the epicenter stopped as the overpressure reached

them, rendered cooler by distance but still hot enough to singe the skin, knocking over buildings damaged in the fighting and destroying what few windows remained. Eardums were blown out and people died as buildings crushed them,

Those on their way to the area stopped, paused, and most reconsidered; she didn't have eyes on all of them, but almost all of those she *could* see all left, loyalty to Adora or Grizzlor not enough to continue in the face of such disaster.

(Unseen by her, Double Trouble finally decided that discretion was the better part of valor, even as much as they truly wanted to speak with Adora and tell her the truth about herself, in hopes she would learn... but all their genuine affection for Adora was not enough to override the desire to *survive,* so they bailed, grabbing a transport and getting the hell out of town.)

Of those she could observe, only two- identified Rebel Leader Krystala and Wild Princess Netossa- kept going, for whatever reasons they had... irrelevant. The Spirit Ember didn't matter at this point; it was with an afterthought that Light Hope finished her work by using the Crystal Castle's mechanisms to teleport the Spirit Ember away. She'd always planned to do that, though she'd originally planned to do so with machine precision at the exact moment that the blastwave was *just* about to reach the Black Garnet... and now, doing so shut down and scrambled the Flame Princess' connection with her artificial Runestone. Another loose end, tidied.

Now to the main event.

Through her stolen tech eyes, she watched as darkness stole over the electric lights of the Fright Zone, distracting and confusing the battle at the Black Garnet as visibility was cut. Not totally-emergency lights and distant flames provided *some* illumination-but it was enough to cover one very specific person.

Light Hope watched as Scorpia, who knew the Zone well, even in the dark, made a break for the front door of the Garnet's protective fortifications, and unseen by any but the AI, made it inside.

Soon she would link up with the Garnet.

Soon, the Heart would beat, and the universe would be cleansed.

Light Hope smiled.

(And the real Light Hope inside her screamed.)

<u>CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>***

Adora

... *First Ones made you.* ***I'm...*** *I'm a First One, reluctant as I am to really admit that... could I... tweak the settings? Fix it,*

somehow?

She was not going to sit here and let even one more death be on her head; she had hands so wet with blood already. Too much blood. She is too soaked in sin, she will not add any more if she could avoid it. Catra, saint and sweetheart, deserved better of her...

Catra.

"Catra!" Adora meant to say but instead commanded, some of her Lord's voice in her as she spoke in the Perfect Speech of their mutual childhood. "Can you give me more of that healing? I'm going to send it to the Spirit Ember!"

"Okay!" Catra agreed immediately, even though Adora saw a hundred questions in her eyes; but her beloved said nothing else, just did as she was asked, because Catra was a fucking *angel.*

(*I don't deserve her,* every part of Adora thought, and knew it to be truth.)

The golden glow increased ever more, almost blinding, and Adora sent it down the channel inside her soul, as far as she could; her and the Runestone were tied together, as all Princesses were to their sources of power, they were one in a way, and she hoped it was enough. The energy flooded in, let her access deeper and deeper parts of her sister, but more importantly, the *healing* of it soothed her, calmed her, made the apocalypse just a little less frantic. The fire stopped growing, was retreating... however much

of the Zone had burned, no *more* would burn, as the blast was sucked back into itself.

"It's working," Adora whispered to her beloved. "The Spirit Ember... tried to burn... we're stopping it. We're stopping it."

"Thank Silver," Catra said, with the weight of a swear; an oath of Brightmoon, perhaps. Adora thought she'd heard similar things over the years, though never in Perfect Speech. "I... okay, once we get it calmed down... we have to go stop Scorpia. She's trying to get to the Garnet, I can't remember if I mentioned that or not..."

"I think you did," Adora said, drawing power from Catra. "I... I think I have a handle on it... You need ot leave, stop Scorpia..."

"I'm not leaving you," Catra said fiercely, and held her ever-tighter.

"You might have to," came a voice from nearby. "Because I'm pretty sure Scorpia's about to reach the Garnet. And that means you need to get to the Castle."

Adora, even as she finished calming her sister, turned her head to see... a Twigget? One who was slightly on fire, and was putting out burning hairs even as she watched.

Adora didn't recognize the newcomer, but Catra sure did.

“Madame Razz?” she said with disbelief.

“Who's that?” Adora asked...

Right as her connection to the Spirit Ember suddenly just... *died.*

*****CATRA OF ETHERIA*****

Getting inside the bunker, the door shutting itself behind her automatically- which Scorpia didn't think that door *was* automatic, but what did she know?- was odd, because when the door slammed shut, the chaos outside was replaced with... quiet.

Not all *that* much quiet- she could still hear the howl of winds and roars of angry botany- but comparatively? It was near silent.

Scorpia paused, letting her eyes adjust to the darkness inside; there were a few emergency lights running on low power, but the rest of it was near pitch black. Risky, but she trusted the door to buy her some time. Sure, it wouldn't hold forever, but even Scorpia knew that it wouldn't do any good to head in and stumble around in the dark because she was impatient.

(Also... maybe... maybe she didn't want to go in. Maybe she wasn't... entirely against a moment in which she was not heading in.)

After those few moments to adjust- or to gather her courage, she wasn't sure- she headed in, that sense of doing the wrong thing ever-growing inside her like the build-up of a static charge. The area was familiar but unsettlingly different in ways she couldn't say; maybe it was just because of how different she *felt.* Every time she'd been here before, she'd been happy, or at least, not freaking out; the first time with Adora and Entrapta back when she was screwing over Shadow Weaver and taking the Garnet from her before the Battle for Brightmoon, and then later...

Later, with Entrapta, and Hordak, the two doing their thing and Scorpia just happy to hang out with them, the whole thing a time of joy in her life with her friends.

(Hordak, whom she hadn't known was dead on Beast Island; Hordak, whom she had only known was dead on the Doom Balloon, and she still hadn't had time to process it, to grieve... and she wondered how her people had mourned, what she was supposed to do, she'd never had to think of it before? What was right, to mourn her friend and Lord? Do it like the Horde did? Or how Scorpioni did? How *did* Scorpioni grieve?)

Those warm memories clashed with this cold present, where the lab, once a source of joy, now felt sterile, alien... hostile. The unease inside her grew and grew as she walked down the halls, and she almost felt like she'd get attacked at any time, around any corner, nervously checking behind her to make sure a Rebel hadn't gotten in and was sneaking up behind her. Rebels were horror stories in the Horde, and Scorpia's new allegiance to the

Alliance was new enough that it hadn't overridden a childhood of hearing those stories... Hordesmen disappearing in the night, only to be found hanged or impaled later, food bars poisoned so that even eating was a death sentence, weapons and ammunition vanishing without a trace or, worse, being sabotaged, blowing up in your hands when you needed it most...

"Princess Scorpia of the Fright Zone," came a formal voice from the darkness ahead of her. "I wish we could meet under better circumstances."

Scorpia screamed and leapt a solid foot into the air, nearly escaping her own chitin as the speaker stepped forward, into the pale light of nearby emergency glow.

The figure that emerged from the dark was covered head to toe in red armor, bearing a spear in their right hand. The figure was almost perfectly anonymous, and the voice was odd; layered, almost, neither male nor female but a bit of both and a bit of neither.

Scorpia stared at them for a long minute, her racing heart settling down; eventually, into the silence, the figure titled its head at her.

"...I did not mean to startle you," the figure said. "I thought you were aware of my presence; you looked right at me at one point."

"...I got a lot on my mind!" Scorpia defended herself awkwardly. "And, uhh... you know my name? But I don't think I know you?..."

"Apologies. I am the Red Knight of Blackmoor," the figure said. "And I intend to stop you from reaching the Black Garnet. You know the cost, do you not?"

(*Red Knight? Vaguely heard of them... some soldier from Blackmoor... can't remember anything else I've heard in the Horde...*)

"I know Entrapta wants me to get there," Scorpia said, forcibly calming herself, clinging to the rationale that had propelled her all this distance, even with the queasy feeling in her stomach that she was doing something *wrong.* "I'm not gonna let you stop me."

"I cannot imagine her reasons for doing so…" the Red Knight said, shaking their head. " But regardless, I will not let you pass without a fight. I am sorry for that, I have heard many stories of your genial nature, and you are held in high regard even by your enemies, but I cannot let you reach the Black Garnet. Please surrender, or we shall fight."

"I don't want to fight you," Scorpia said, and meant it.

"I don't wish to fight you, either," the Red Knight said, and meant it, too.

(Not that it mattered, in the end.)

"…But we're going to have to, aren't we?" Scorpia asked, and the Knight nodded.

"Yes," he said.

Some part of Scorpia wanted to turn back.

But…

No.

She'd made her decision.

"…Okay, let's do this then," Scorpia said, squaring up; the Red Knight did the same, spear at the ready.

"If you surrender, I will accept it; but if you fake a surrender, I will accept no further offers," the Red Knight said, with the tone of one reciting rules, well-worn words that had been said before and would be said again. "Are you ready to begin?"

No, Scorpia thought.

"Yes," Scorpia said.

And then the Red Knight was rushing her, and a moment later, Scorpia got to find out that the Red Knight was real good at fighting.

Real good.

Scorpia didn't know much about them beyond their name- and even then, she didn't know what a Blackmoor was, a last name maybe?- but she was learning pretty rapidly that they were a badass, whoever they were.

Her attempts to get in close were failing miserably, and while she was pretty sure she out-bulked and out-muscled her opponent, she was having the devil's own time actually *getting* to them. The Red Knight moved with the long experience of a veteran's veteran; Scorpia was no stranger or slouch at fighting herself, but the Red Knight was making her look like an idiot. They'd even tripped her at one point, though the following attempt to put a spear through her throat was stopped by her tail lashing about. Her chitin was proof against their blade, and if she could just *catch* the damn spear she could snap it in half with her pincers, but so far all she had to show for this fight were a few bruises on her face where the Red Knight had headbutted her, the helm leaving distinctive marks behind.

It was frustrating as hell. When fighting Catra, at least, the fight was an even clash of great titans, Catra getting stuck in and her

and Scorpia trading blows like the equals they were; that, and seeing Catra was always kind of… nice.

Sure, Scorpia was realistic about her chances there, but hey, you never knew! Maybe Catra would give up on her epic tragic romance with Adora and settle for a *different* former enemy that she had way less personal history with!

(…Okay, probably not, but Scorpia had a right to dream!)

But facing the Red Knight was like trying to catch a pig covered in grease that was actively trying to kill you at the same time. Their strikes were lightning-fast, and they knew their weapon so well that they were attacking at the absolute maximum range of the spear, which was frustratingly *just* outside of Scorpia's pincer reach; she was taller than the Knight, and her pincers gave her some extra reach on a human hand, but it wasn't quite enough to overcome the spear's length.

Worse, the Knight knew what they were doing; they kept making attacks at Scorpia's legs, which weren't as obviously armored as her upper body. Sure, her skin was tougher than a human's even in the parts that *weren't* armored, and her pants had armored kneecaps to protect the joint, but she sure didn't fancy getting stabbed in the thigh! You'd bleed out.

So she kept having to dance back, the Knight implacable, never advancing too greedily nor ever entirely *stopping* their advance, moving at a slow and steady pace as they slowly pushed her out of the room, back towards the way she'd come in.

And even Scorpia could put together his plan.

Back towards the outside and away from the Black Garnet, Scorpia thought. *He wants to trap me with other Alliance troops!*

(Her mind automatically assigned everyone she was fighting status as members of the Princess Alliance, her longtime foes, a thing that would annoy the Rebels very much if they were told.)

A good plan, but how was she supposed to fight back? It wasn't like she could advance with him there in front of her…

Man, if I just had some help, she thought, as she lashed out with her tail, an attack that the Knight countered with the sharp end of their spear, whirling up the blunt end to smack her in the jaw.

"Oof!" Scorpia exhaled, as the Red Knight withdrew the blunt end, stepping back out of rage of her pincers- before hammering forward with the blunt end again, smacking her right in the nose. It didn't break- benefits of Scorpioni toughness- but it was a close thing, and she snorted to clear her nose as she retreated even further. "Hey, stop that!"

"You may surrender at any time," the Red Knight said, so politely that it perversely made Scorpia *way* madder than an insult would have.

"No!" she said, but even as she said it, her mind raced. Sure, she wasn't the brightest bulb, but she wasn't *completely* stupid. She knew this wasn't sustainable; at this rate, she'd be outside in a few minutes, and then get ganged up on and brought down.

But… maybe… she *was* bigger. And retreating like this gave the Knight initiative…

What was it Force Captain Training had always suggested to her?

Never let your enemy control your decisions. Once they do, you lose. Control ***theirs*** *by forcing upon them a choice.*

…Maybe that was the answer, right there. Right now, afraid of getting speared, she was letting the Knight control the fight, but if she just decided to go forward, press on like a juggernaut…

Yeah, that might work.

Taking a breath as the Red Knight lashed out again, she didn't bother trying to block or catch the spear, but instead simply stepped *into* the attack, which threw it off. The hit that should have sank into her right calf instead hit empty air, passing between her legs; and while the Knight quickly recovered, raising the spear rapidly to whack her directly in the groin- and *that* hurt, it nearly made Scorpia collapse!- she bulled on through, stumbling forward. The Knight danced back, avoiding her pincers and tail, but it was not with the effortless smoothness they'd been doing it

with so far; no, this was more desperate, panicked. Another spear thrust as the Knight retreated, but not at her legs this time, perhaps worried they were too difficult to hit, instead focusing on her arms and face- attacks easily enough blocked with hands at the ready. She wasn't quite getting to pincer distance, but she was getting closer with every step, the Red Knight moving backwards…

Then, out of nowhere, a Hordebot came rolling out of a nearby door into the room almost right on top of them, unfurling to shoot the Red Knight with its laser, already humming up to fire.

It didn't have a chance to shoot, the Red Knight reacting on reflex and thrusting their spear through its lens, the bot sparking and bursting as it died… but the distraction was enough for Scorpia to finish closing the distance.

She grabbed the Knight's left arm with one pincer and lifted it up, and there, in the gap in the armpit between the armor pieces, stabbed with her tail, pumping them full of poison.

Scorpia couldn't help a quick grin, even as bad as she generally felt about fighting this stranger and the situation in general. It felt *good* to beat someone this tough!

"I'll put you somewhere safe," Scorpia said, but the Red Knight, to her surprise, kept moving, albeit stiffly and with odd angles to it, as if the armor was compelling the flesh beneath. They tried to land a single final blow, thrusting out with their spear one more time, one handed as Scorpia still had a grip on their left…

But it was no use. They were too slow. Scorpia dodged just enough for it to hit her chitin and skip off the insectoid armor like a stone.

"Whoa, calm down!" Scorpia said. "You're going to hurt yourself."

"You're… going to… kill… everything," the Red Knight grunted out in response before, finally, succumbing, the momentum of their final blow sending them sprawling stiff-bodied to the floor. If she hadn't already been holding onto one of their arms, they'd have fallen.

As it stood, she propped them up in a nearby closet after clearing out the brooms and buckets.

"You'll be safe in here," Scorpia said, even as some part of her doubted that to be true.

No one will be safe, after I do this, came the thought, but she dismissed it. Just her fears and stupidity acting up, right?

Yeah.

Had to be.

With the last obstacle removed, Scorpia opened the last door.

(It felt like opening a grave, a sensation she could not shake.)

It was... really quiet, in the room of the Black Garnet, and that felt wrong on levels Scorpia didn't have words for.

It was such a stark contrast from the orchestra of war outside, the scream of wounded troops and the roar of Perfuma's warplant and the omnipresent howling of the winds as Spinnerella danced, danced, danced... or even just the battle with the Red Knight, where they'd been talking.

But here...

Here it was quiet.

She shouldn't be here.

She shouldn't do this.

She shouldn't...

(A coin, flipping over and over again)

...But she still owed Entrapta.

She still *trusted* Entrapta.

And so

(the coin is caught)

Scorpia put one raised pincer to the Black Garnet's surface.

Chapter End Notes

The stars return... and the end approaches.

Chapter 73: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: Into the Fire

Chapter Notes

Life's kicking my ass, but I fight back!

This chapter is all Princesses... and Double Trouble, because they deserve it.
(Some of their musing is my own musing on how much has changed in this ending as I write it. Adora was not the only person not to foresee Catra's ultimatum.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CATRA OF ETHERIA

The Last Battle of Etheria

Into the Fire

Double Trouble hated to admit defeat- they were Crimson Waste born-and-bred, after all, and *that* was a place that killed quick if you had any quit inside you- but that last explosion, and the lights all cutting out?

Yeah, that was a bit much. Time to bail.

(The Crimson Waste killed you quick if you *didn't* know when to run, as well.)

Sighing, sad they wouldn't get one last chance to talk to Adora before she died- assuming she *hadn't* already died, that explosion had seemed like the kind of way Adora would go out- they escaped into the outskirts of the Fright Zone, seeking- and soon finding- their way out.

That escape route took the form of an old scouting skiff, still entirely serviceable; that'd be fine for their purposes. Fuel and supplies for a quick trip out... away from this war, from any future gigantic explosions, and sadly, away from Adora, whom Double Trouble still felt an honest fondness for. They'd known she was a person full of lies from the very start, had found her *fascinating* , and... broken.

They'd hoped to talk with her tonight, maybe help her heal, but...

Ah, well. The best-laid plans of mice, men, and changelings that could transform into both. They just had to hope that someone else would try and heal her.

So they retreated, having no dog in this fight anymore... but they still wished Adora well.

They did not offer a prayer, exactly, as they started up the skiff, for they had no faith in anything but money... but they *did* wish,

genuinely, that Adora found out the truth, did not lie to herself anymore... that she could be as clear-eyed as the changeling themselves were.

And with that, Double Trouble bowed out of the Horde Civil War they'd helped kickstart, all aboard a little scouting skiff.

(And here is an impossible truth that no one will ever know; the very skiff Double Trouble rode out on was, in fact, the very same skiff that Catra and Adora had once argued on, years ago now... the very skiff that Catra had fallen from, finding the Sword, putting the world on track for the disaster now unfolding.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

The touch was brief, and for a long moment, Scorpia doubted herself. She had never felt like a Princess, after all, and her Horde upbringing had always told her she'd be rejected; every other Princess was a human, after all, but she was Scorpioni, they would look at her as freak and outsider. That was what she'd been told, time after time.

(And behold, fiercest of ironies- the Garnet *did* try to reject her, the stone of night trying, desperately, to save the stars, fighting with what little free will the First Ones had left it with to reject Scorpia... even if it would never, ever be enough.)

Combined with the fact that she didn't *want* to be here- that some part of her was still screaming sirens of warning in her skull- she couldn't quite commit to it; she withdrew from that first touch.

But... she did not turn away.

Because Entrapta wanted her to do this. Entrapta, who was her friend, her only real friend from her days in the Horde; Adora was a liar and a monster but Entrapta was a friend. A friend even after the Horde, who'd saved her life from Beast Island- saved her *and* Micah, another one of Scorpia's vanishingly rare friends! She owed her life and Micah's both to the Drylborn.

And she wasn't the only one! Perfuma wanted her to do it, too, and that woman made Scorpia feel... all kind of warm 'n squiggly inside! Kinda the same way Catra had at their first few meetings... though that had faded over time, especially as Scorpia realized Catra's eyes would never be on anyone but Adora.

(The She-Ra had godawful taste in women, apparently.)

And Shadow Weaver! She wanted her to do it, too! And sure, she was scary as all hell, but most of what Scorpia knew of her were stories, and Adora's contempt... and she didn't like Adora, and she was learning not to trust stories. Stories had said she'd be rejected, after all, not accepted... so maybe Shadow Weaver wasn't that bad?

...Okay, she probably was, but even so! Didn't mean she was *wrong* about Scorpia needing to link up to the Runestone!

Scorpia sighed, and screwed her courage to the sticking place.

She owed it to all her companions to at least *try* , one more time.

(And- to the misery of the universe- Scorpia paid her debts.)

So she put her pincers back to the Garnet's surface, and *focused,* willing the power within to come at her call, feeling a bit stupid because how did you call up magic? She had no idea, she wasn't even a mage, much less a Princess, was just going off of instinct and sensation.

But apparently those things were enough, because a moment later...

Power.

Her body lifted up, lightning raking the world around her; inside, in her mind, she felt herself falling through the power of the *Storm,* the raw heart of darkness, and the might it birthed. From the darkest storm clouds came the fiercest lightning, came *power,* innovation, the bolt from the blue...

It was a heady feeling, but not really all that pleasant... or maybe it *would* be pleasant, but Scorpia's doubts and worries weren't going away with all this... weird shit.

Is this how other Princesses feel, all the time? Scorpia briefly wondered. She felt like she had a fever, her head all loopy. She hoped it'd settle down, she did *not* enjoy this feeling.

A moment later, settle down it did, as the power let her go and placed her gently back on the ground, thunderstorms clacking between her pincers. The hallucinatory sensation had faded, and Scorpia was back in the real world, feeling just a bit energized.

Not a moment too soon, in Scorpia's opinion.

(And yet still far too late.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Far away, in the Crystal Castle, the last Princess linking up with her Runestone completed a chain of events centuries in the making. The Crystal Castle's systems, so long incomplete, were finally made whole at last. The Runestone sigils, so long unlit, burst into life, and the planetary network balanced.

Everything came to life at once. Portal network generators began powering up, ready to shift an entire planet back into realspace, out of Despondos, moving from the void that had sheltered the stars into the more familiar reality where the Heart could kill an

entire galaxy. Targeting solutions spun into existence, ready for when Etheria left Despondos and could cleanse the manifold worlds of life, make them sterile and free for the colonization of the Eternal Empire. Amplifier networks the size of continents shifted in the bedrock, the vast terraforming efforts of the First Ones necessary to create a weapon with a range measured in the impossible distance of lightyears.

What was to come was so big that it stretched backwards in time, an effect making a cause of its own, afflicting so many sensitive to such things on Etheria and in other worlds. A blind oracle of a homeless people who called themselves Thundercats woke from a sound sleep, haunted by a vision of deadly light, of a rainbow that would storm the stars and slay them; an artificial life form, by name Orion Pax, working in mines to supply his people, had a feeling of dread even his best friend, D-16, could not shake him from, constantly worried in ways he could not describe in words.

Even Horde Prime was affected, his eternal poise shaken and- though he would never admit it- *scared* by the sudden screaming of his survival instincts, those old and withered things that had so long atrophied in the face of his endless victory march across the stars. Small and unused as they were, though, they were nonetheless not so ruined that they did not wake up in the face of this... *pressure,* emanating from the future, this disaster on the horizon that would eclipse all other cataclysm.

In response- as a mere precaution, he told himself- he ordered the vast fleet around the Velvet Glove into defensive position, even contacting his allies in the Diamond Authority and the Voltron Unity, and warning them that something was coming, and to prepare.

(White Diamond answered with the ecstatic fury of a fanatic to her God, angry that someone would challenge the one being in all reality she had come to see as truly Perfect, without Flaw; King Lotor and Queen Alura responded with no enthusiasm, but more rationality, to the slaver who owned their souls... and inside their hearts, with a little hope that whatever was coming could kill them, and free them.)

None suffered as much as Peekablue, though, literally standing atop the epicenter, for his connection to his Minor Runestone made him a seer... and so he got to *see* it, before his eyes were blinded by the light that would eat the stars; he saw the entire thing, all that would happen, and even *understood* it, in the moment before his mind mercifully shut itself down to save his soul.

(And what he understood was this: it was not *a* end but *the* end, for everyone, and everyone's everything, a galaxy where one last burst of light would leave darkness alone to reign forever in the silence, weeping for all that had once been.)

All this, in the span of seconds, as the engine of apocalypse roared to life.

At the controls, the Light Hope the First Ones had made smiled.

(Inside, the Light Hope that love had made screamed.)

<u>*CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>**

The Fright Zone was no more.

Where once had been a city of order and structure, now there was only chaos. Even the lights were off now, the power cut out, plunging the world into darkness. While few knew exactly what had happened, everyone in the Zone had heard something *big* exploding right before the power went out, and so it wasn't hard to put one and one together to get two. With no more central power, the only lights came from a few backup generators kicking in, but those were rare; had *been* rare to start with, were rarer now with so many of them ruined in the fighting, usually by pure accident. The only light for most people now came from the fires raging all across the city, whether those started by Adora during her final madness, or caused in one of the billion battles taking place all across the ruined urban landscape.

The flickering fires made the shadows dance, and in that interplay of light and darkness, the fighting took on a surreal, nightmarish tone; the civil war kept raging even in the dark, but now with the added quality of a waking nightmare. No Hordesman could avoid an uncomfortable mental comparison to the ecstatic dances and revelries that had been held in Lord Adora's honor so very recently, whether they supported them or not, and the comparison sickened the soul; for where once had the bonfires of celebration merrily blazed, now they were replaced with the equally fever-pitch pyres of the Horde's grand mutual suicide.

All throughout the Fright Zone, on a night that all present would remember for the rest of their lives, that history itself would forever remember- if, that was, there *was* a future *to* remember anything in at all- vast sagas and stories were written that would

never be known, dramas of heroism and tragedies of devastation, lives snuffed out like candles, lives spared and refueled, all across the concrete and blood and flame.

One of those sagas was not that of a Hordesman, but of a Princess, who held the man she loved in her arms as he lay dying.

Mermista held Sea Hawk, and knew nothing of what was going on about her. The lights going out she hadn't even noticed; Sweet Bee's Andreenids had flashlights and lamps, being the well-prepared spec ops team they were, and even the old Hordesman, Hiron, had a small personal flashlight he held between his teeth as he worked on Sea Hawk's wounds with Chilla, the Snows priestess Frosta had brought. They were only inches away from Mermista, but they might as well have been on another continent for all she was concerned.

All her focus was on him, on his death, on his skin, cooling in her arms, on the gentle look in his eyes as his one remaining hand touched her cheek, his last smile on his lips.

(And Sea Hawk himself only thinks *this is a good way to die,* only regretting that he will leave his Mermista to weep behind him... but other than that, he has no complaints. He saved her from Octavia, after all, and avenged all those Octavia killed; this is not so bad. He will take it with him into the dark, when he goes to the Grim Reaper and shakes his hand, and he will call him a friend; he is of a kin with Glimmer in this, at least. He dies unafraid.)

It is in this moment, the worst of her life, that she achieves godhood.

Not the situation she'd expected to do that in. Not a thing she'd expected to *do,* really, but here she was; there was a moment like a lock breaking, and then there was *power,* power flooding her, blue flames around her as power spilled out of her like an overfilled cup. No Princess, even Lapis in all her terrible, misguided might, had been as strong as *this* before.

It felt like a corrosive version of what Catra had done when she united their powers for a moment at the Battle of Brightmoon, like a version of that so intense it *hurt,* like a dam breaking loose inside her to let the floodwaters rise; she felt... she felt...

Powerful.

And the only thing she could think to do with all this power, with strength enough to drown the entire Fright Zone in her grasp...

Was to save a single life.

Even as rainbow energy trailed off of her, the power of water so strong in her it literally caught fire- a thing she hadn't even known it *could* do- Mermista turned her focus towards the man she loved. Down, down, into his bones, into his... soul? Was *that* what she was feeling? She had always been the weakest of the modern Princesses, which was one reason she'd compensated with strategic knowledge- well, that and the fact of her role in society as the Princess of Salineas- so she didn't know *what* she was sensing, didn't know what it was that she was touching, a thing

that had been beyond her power before. It was small, but bright, like the last warm coal of a ferocious wildfire, with something... green?... curling over it to heal it, a power foreign but friendly. Mermista gave thanks to whatever it was; it meant he was alive in time for her ascension, and she could *save* him.

(Madame Razz's last spell, the only reason Sea Hawk had lived *this* long... not that Mermista would ever know.)

All this power, but she couldn't just *heal* him, her power still had *rules* even if they were looser than they were before, her power such that she could bend them... but not *break.* Water did not work like that... she searched her instincts, hunting, looking for lessons inside herself, or things she'd heard from others, tidbits that her brain frantically ransacked, searching for the key that would lock the door that led to Death.

Blood, he needed *blood...* and blood was life, wasn't it? So was water. Water was life was blood was life, but she couldn't just *make* blood, she had to..

Wait.

Water flowed. From lake to stream to ocean and back up to the clouds to begin again. Water flowed.

She had so much blood in her veins. Sea Hawk had so little.

(His hand falls away from her face. He approaches the final end. His vision grows dim, and she is the last thing he will ever see...

and that isn't so bad. The reaper is being terribly kind to him; he will have to thank him, when the last moment passes. Perhaps he will shake his hand.)

Not the right types. She knew biology enough to know *that.* Her blood could not replace his, not without change.

But water...

Water was also *change,* wasn't it? That was all the Pearl was- the balance, the *change,* between chaos and order, the way they turned into each other, ever-churning. A change that was a constant. The mere fact of flowing... flowing and change. To flow her blood from her to him, to *change* it... a bending of rules. Not a breaking...

I have no idea if this will work.

(She knew, at the same time, that she had to try. Love demanded no less.)

She thought she'd have to cut herself, but no such need; her blood responded to her will, flowing from her eyes, her tears turning scarlet. Her tears, shed for him, now full of blood that would be *his,* given by her freely.

(He had given of himself to save her, after all. How could she dare do less?)

Warm red teardrops fell onto pale and cooling skin, each covered in a drop of warm blue flame.

They sank in, gently, a few moments later, as she gave, and gave, and gave.

For a few long, silent moments, there was only the flow, the transfer, tears of blood down a Princess' face, to fall on a pirate vagabond.

Then, even as she was woozy from her own blood loss, still holding him, she heard Sea Hawk take his last breath...

And then another.

And another.

And another.

"...My... love-lobster?" he said, as warmth returned to his cheeks. "You, you're... bleeding."

"And you're *alive,* " she said, and cried harder than she had even when he was dying, clean tears that washed the last blood down onto him, still transferring those final few drops.

And in the wake of this miracle, she paid attention to nothing else, just him, even as the rainbow wisps of might began to trail away, towards some unknowable destination.

(The Crystal Castle, as it would turn out, the centerpoint of all the magic in Etheria now, mouth open and hungry as a cuckoo fledgling, devouring what rightly belonged to others.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

"So... is she supposed to burst into blue flame like that?" Hiron, the old Hordesman, asked Frosta. "Is that... normal? For a Princess?"

"Not usually," the Snows Princess told the Hordesman... before turning to look over at where Peekablue lay on the ground, Sweet Bee over him, checking his vitals. "Then again, I'm not sure what happened to *him* either. Chilla might know, she's got more education along those lines than I do, being a warpriest and all."

Peekablue had just... *screamed,* a moment ago, a horrible scream, the kind Frosta had heard only a few times even with half her life being a war... then passed out, grabbing at his eyes like he was either trying to protect them or maybe pull them out of his own head. Sweet Bee had caught him just before he hit the ground, and they'd checked him, but he was just... unconscious, as far as

the Andreenids could tell. It was why Sweet Bee hadn't tried to help with Sea Hawk, beyond sending an Andreenid over with some supplies for Hiron and Chilla to use- she'd been busy making sure the man she loved was okay.

Mermista hadn't paid them any attention, which Frosta supposed she couldn't blame her for. Watching the guy you loved die in front of you was the kind of thing that would be rather distracting.

I'm surrounded by people holding their wounded loves, Frosta thought. *War is a hell of a thing, sometimes.*

(Another hell of a thing was the brief fantasy that flickered through her mind, of herself and Glimmer in the same kind of positions, those big strong arms- *whoa, nope, nope, nope. Wrong time, wrong person, wrong place.*)

"I... have nothing to say, I'm afraid," Chilla admitted to her cousin, drawing her out of her attempts to suppress her subconscious. "I've never heard of a Salinean Princess doing this... or any Princess, for that matter... but it looks like Sea Hawk will live?..."

"Good," Frosta said. She wasn't that close with the man, but she *did* like Mermista, and Sea Hawk was kinda fun, in a useless sort of way. Like a tiny lapdog who made funny noises.

Plus, he sacrificed himself to kill Octavia, that was pretty badass. Might have to re-evaulate my opinion on the guy.

“The flame is kinda weird, isn't it?” Hiron commented. “Thought she was water. Water can't catch fire. Least, not normally. Wonder if it's because of Lord Adora's Spirit Ember being here.”

“I... don't think so,” came an unexpected voice from behind them- Sweet Bee, who was walking up to join them. Behind her, that one Andreenid with the wounded leg that Frosta had saved- Tike, she thought his name was?- had taken over watching over Peekablue, and Sweet Bee, while clearly shaken, was also obviously trying to refocus- they *were* in a warzone, after all.

“Hmm, you would know,” Hiron said, taking a cigarette out of a pocket. “You're Sweet Bee, right? Heard of you. Weird day, meeting all these famous people.”

“Ain't that famous,” Sweet Bee said. “I'm just kinda noticeable, what with being one of the only Hivers in the Great Rebellion.”

“More famous than me,” Hiron said. “You want a smoke?”

“Good Woman's fat ass, *yes,*” Sweet Bee swore, taking the tobacco stick he offered and the light that followed after. “Thank you.”

“No problem,” Hiron said as he lit his own cigarette. “Shame you don't know what this is; you'd tell me even if the stone worshippers wouldn't. You're a Crownless hardliner, from what I hear.”

“I'm standing right here,” Frosta said, but was summarily ignored.

“Sorry, but it's nothing I've heard of,” Sweet Bee said. “The Runestone Kingdoms bury a lot of stuff, but this... no, this is new, I think.”

“If it's not, nobody told me,” Frosta said.

“...So what does it mean?” Hiron asked, the question on everyone's mind.

Speculation was interrupted by Queen Orwall rejoining them from the other side of the battlefield, the Magicat clearly puzzled as she looked around.

“...Wasn't the Red Knight with us? Where'd they go?” she asked.

“Shit, you're right,” Sweet Bee said, taking a drag of her cigarette. “I was too busy after Dreer showed up to keep track of them, and then Peeki- Peekablue...”

She shook herself, quickly dragging like half the cigarette down her lungs before tossing the stump aside, exhaling a great breath of smoke.

“I'll fly up, check around- find them, alive or dead. Even dead, we have to get the armor back to Blackmoor...”

(Unbeknownst to her, she wouldn't have found the Red Knight if she searched a thousand years; not only was the real Red Knight currently paralyzed in a corner of the somewhat-exploding Black Garnet building, but the one with the group had, in fact, been Double Trouble, now cheerfully exiting the Fright Zone.)

“I'll look, too,” Orwall said, but Sweet Bee turned back to her with a shake of her head.

“We'll cover more ground than you can,” she said. “And we need people on guard here. Mermista's not paying any attention to the world around her, and I don't like the weird blue flame thing she's doing.”

“Me either,” Frosta agreed.

And because the universe enjoyed mocking her, at that exact moment, Frosta herself burst into cold flame.

Her own blazing aura was blue as well, but tinged with the white of purest ice; a wave of frozen fire, all over her.

And the *power*

(winter, at its heart; the cold and the dark that would go on forever when all the fire and light had died. The cold calmness of the last force, and the force that lasted... the Garnet was darkness in its active state, but the Fractal was darkness in its purest sense, the entropy that would render all things cold with time. A peaceful thing, the slow turning down of all lights, to rest, until all things were to be born again...)

"Fucking hell!" Hiron said, jumping back as she burst into light.

"Shit!" Sweet Bee said as well, also leaping back.

"Frosta!" Chilla exclaimed, rushing to her cousin's side but hesitating to touch her, feeling the cold rolling off of her like a winter front. The warpriest's hands did not quite reach her. "Are you... okay?"

"...I have no fucking clue," Frosta said after a moment, as the high tide receded and left her more or less as she had been, just... *way* stronger. She felt like she could break the world just by trying. "What in the world is happening? So much power..."

But she had no answer, and would not know that answer until it came for her in the form of *pain.*

*****CATRA OF ETHERIA*****

In another fit of the irony that was now a near-plague throughout the Fright Zone, the sole Princess that was actually in a position to use the power boost was *also* the one Princess who found herself totally unable to capitalize on the Heart's strength.

Princess Perfuma of Plumeria, buried in her warplant, found that the sudden influx of energy was simply too much. She was doing things so far outside her normal tactics that it was the equivalent of going from a standing start to a full-blown sprint, no stretching beforehand; she had dove so deep into her own reserves that she was not simply in the red, but running on fumes and less than fumes, the gas tank dry and empty. Only sheer willpower and her own unleashed love of battle had kept her in the fight so far, but the soul could only push the body so far, and hers was failing her at the last. Her inner organs had taken terrible damage both from the brutality of combat- even safely ensconced in her warplant as she was, she was still thrown around when attacks hit it or knocked it over- and, more deeply, from the sheer crushing *pressure* of having so much power channeled through her thin frame; only the nature of her power, of green things and growth, was keeping her alive, healing barely outpacing the damage she was doing to herself.

Her mind, too, was beginning to finally collapse. She was so out of it that she was not only totally unaware that she was monologuing- had, in fact, not stopped talking since she first formed the warplant, her brain pouring out her thoughts through her mouth to make room for control of her warplant's too-many limbs and too-many heads- but she'd barely noticed the lights going out.

She had simply adapted when Entrapta solved *that* problem a minute later. The Drylborn's jury-rigged mech apparently came with bright spotlights, since she turned them on when the darkness came, and Perfuma had treated them as target markers. She'd gratefully followed the implied order to attack whatever Entrapta was focusing on, vomiting bitterlye over anyone blinded by the light, before picking them up and placing them elsewhere.

(And here is a truth that most would consider madness to even consider believing; Perfuma, in all her rampage, had killed *no one.* Behold, the first invader in history with no blood on her hands; property damage that was almost incalculable alongside so many injuries and bruises and cuts... but not a single life lost. Perfuma would not kill if she did not have to.)

The stalemate had been broken by Entrapta, and Perfuma had cheerfully charged into the breach the Drylborn's presence had made. Perfuma had been totally stalled by Spinnerella until Entrapta showed up, able to do roughly fuck and all to the rebel Wild Princess while getting pummeled in retaliation, a flower waiting to be plucked... but Entrapta had shown up and drugged her, and that had been the beginning of the end.

(A thought more appropriate, given the Heart, than Perfuma could know.)

Spinnerella's Rebels had stood their ground and fought bravely as Spinnerella finally passed out from the poison... but there was so little they could do, with their equipment melting in their hands from bitterlye, and Perfuma's titanic warplant closing in for melee. Against a giant, with no tech, there was nothing they could do.

No wonder my ancestors were so terrifying, Perfuma thought, a lucid moment in the forest of dissolution that was her mind. *If even I can do **this** to the best of the Great Rebellion, what were the Glory Lilies like, in the full of their power?*

Captain Scurvy and his wife were at this moment trying to stall her, and doing poorly, because Perfuma's pincers alone were as big as they were combined. One head was chasing that Erelander with the rocket launcher, Toad, the one who'd blown up one of her heads with his First Ones weapon; he was buried in rubble, but she was going to get him soon. Other heads busied themselves fighting his fellow Rebels trying to help the mushroom man, or battling Horde stragglers arriving late to the fray behind her, most likely following the vast trail of destruction she'd carved behind her, while one last head was grabbing anyone she knocked out or rendered helpless and putting them somewhere safe.

No blood on my hands, she swore to herself... and out loud, with no one to hear her from her position at her warplant's heart*. Blood in my mouth blood in my guts blood in my **eyes** but not on my hands, never on my hands, never on my hands, never on my-*

Mid-sentence, the power of the Heart enveloped her, green flame around her form, lighting up the inside of the warplant with light visible even from outside.

And that was it.

The famed and proverbial last straw hit her, and Perfuma collapsed utterly. Her warplant fell without her will to animate it,

sinking down on its many legs, heads falling and slamming into the ground as the ivy that worked as muscles for the beast went slack.

(The last thing she heard was Entrapta screaming her name.)

Chapter End Notes

If you get the references in the section about those who felt the pressure of the Heart of Etheria awakening, my basic rule is “must be a cartoon, preferably of a series that started in the 80s and had a modern revival of some kind”. Steven Universe's inclusion here is obviously the outlier, but the Diamond Authority's space-faring and association with light, as well as White Diamond's specific obsession with perfection, made them so perfect that I had to make an exception just for them.

Horde Prime intends to make a universe where only he and his clones remain, a One and Only God, both worshiper and worshiped in one titanic narcissistic church the size of the stars- but that's for the future. For now, his forces include catspaws and servants to throw at his problems.

Lotor and Alura are his oldest living servants, having served him the longest, and in a lot of ways, are the absolute most screwed-over of all his servants. Many centuries ago, when Prime was just really hitting his stride as a conqueror, Lotor got exiled from the then-young Galran Empire for NOT murdering and enslaving an entire planet- i.e. the exact damn thing he got exiled for in Defender.

But in THIS universe... he found Prime.

Prime amused himself by appearing to the desperate young man as a benevolent foreign lord of light, one who freely told Lotor about Quintessence's addictive properties and the rift entities in extradimensional space who use Quintessence to enter this universe. This was a much younger Prime, one who

hadn't lost his edge from centuries of easy victories; he saw Lotor for what he was.

An opportunity.

An opportunity Prime made even bigger... by finding Allura.

See, Prime had ALREADY been looking for the Voltron lions, even before Lotor showed up. He wanted to destroy them, since they were such a great power... but then Lotor showed up... and he had an IDEA. He found the Castle of Lions in space, saw how Lotor and Allura were close in age and would have similar backgrounds and they were both attractive, and he had the idea to play matchmaker.

So first he deleted the AI of Allura's dad, to ensure she had no other supporters, then woke her up, introduced Allura and Lotor, and played the role of helpful friend. He supported them, helped them find the Altean survivors- he'd guessed that a space-faring nation would have SOME survivors just from people being off-planet when the thing got destroyed- and even gave them a planet for the survivors to live on!

With all this seeming benevolence given to them- and the fact that the two fell in love FAST, being young survivors with similar traumas and shared enemies- Prime basically became the coolest guy in the universe to the youngsters. Both were missing good father figures in their lives, and Prime stepped smoothly into that role, even as they found the other Voltron pilots.

The Voltron Pilot list, for the curious- Lotor drives the Black Lion, Allura drives the Blue Lion, Zethrid has the Red Lion, Ezor has the Green Lion, and Luka has the Yellow Lion. Yes, this means the only dude is Lotor, which has led to a lot of jokes in the Unity about Voltron just being his harem- which annoys the hell out of all of them.

With all this seeming benevolence, none of the pilots had a single reason to suspect Prime at all when he offered to give them some cybernetics to let them fight back against the increasingly powerful Robeasts the Galrans were using. They agreed to go under the knife, giving themselves to him and his sciences, trusting the man with their lives.

They shouldn't have.

The cybernetics do, in fact, keep them alive, alive forever, and strengthen them... but also make them completely obedient. It was the first use of his control chip tech. He lets them have free reign in most things, entirely to twist the knife into them when he orders them to do something abhorrent.
(Prime won't use the tech as he doesn't trust Quintessence, viewing it as polluting his purity.)

The Voltron Unity is the name of the rebellion against the Galran Empire that Lotor and Allura started; now it is the name of the empire they now run for Prime. It's actually by far the most pleasant part of Prime's empire to actually LIVE in, since Lotor and Alura are good people when not under orders.

It was the Unity that were Prime's main forces in his attack on Thundera, and it was Voltron itself that destroyed the planet; Prime thought it hilarious to make a lion robot kill a cat planet.

It is one of many atrocities he has made them commit.
(If freed, they might well just kill themselves; it's hard not to blame yourself when your own hands do the killing, no matter what your brain says about your choice in the matter.)

Chapter 74: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: Duel of Darkness

Chapter Notes

A shorter one this time, on a more... personal... moment in the battle. Something to note, before the end.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A Battle for the Ages:

Duel of Darkness

The last moments of the Last Battle of Etheria, itself but a few moments before the Spirit Ember's rage, before Scorpia touched the Black Garnet's surface, before... everything.

(Not the fall, but looking over the cliff's edge, right before the final push.)

******CATRA OF ETHERIA******

The payoff of a scheme was *incredible.*

Glimmer always felt more alive when she was waving at Death, always, but this... this was like waving with *both* hands, this was exhilarating. This wasn't just the rush of the moment, but something that had been building up ever since she had first went to Dryl to join the 'Council of the Wise', as Shadow Weaver had called their little trio; this was the culmination of all her training under Shadow Weaver, learning how she fought, studying under her, everything that had led to her growing real wings that could fly and Beast Island and her father and... everything.

So despite how serious this moment was...

Glimmer was *smiling.*

The fight had departed from the Black Garnet's immediate area; Shadow Weaver had retreated into a nearby ruined alleyway, one that was choked with rubble, sparking machinery, electrical fires, and a couple of pools of that weird goop Perfuma's warplant had been spewed. It was a small, closed-in kind of area, and honestly kind of a problem; the small space and limited sightlines screwed both Glimmer *and* Bow over. He couldn't use his range, and she couldn't teleport to a weird angle- there were only so many places to go, and there was no good spot to snipe from. The witch had picked her arena well; had probably chosen it on purpose, given it was near the Black Garnet and these used to be her old stomping grounds. Kind of a homefield advantage for her.

Well, I always knew Shadow Weaver wasn't stupid, Glimmer thought begrudgingly.

She also, begrudgingly, had to admit that the witch wasn't a coward. Shadow Weaver had not fled to this area, but retreated, and now that she had a good place to fight from, she wasn't backing down. She threw spells whose strength proved just *why* the witch was so feared; even having trained with her, Glimmer was having trouble keeping up. Shields of night tore away any attacks that approached her, eating their energy up, while the witch stood and cast spells, completely unflinching as arrows and sparkling light slammed into her protections.

Probably doesn't help that she's using the Garnet's energies, which she's more used to than anybody on the planet...

Glimmer leapt to the side as a column of lightning-wrapped shadow erupted underneath her very feet; she nearly leapt straight into a second column, Shadow Weaver casting in an area, probably hoping she'd dodge straight into one. Glimmer teleported behind the witch, but she'd thought of that, too; a backwash of energy flared out behind Shadow Weaver, and Glimmer had to teleport *again* just to avoid it. She popped up near Bow, who was taking cover near some fallen rubble.

"So... any ideas?" she asked him as she sent her shadow out to a nearby machine, one sputtering with remnants of electricity. She sucked it dry like the energy vampire she kind of was, now, restoring her flagging energy; teleporting took a lot out, but at least the Fright Zone's power grid provided plenty.

(The power tasted- well, "tasted", to the extent that her magical senses mapped onto her physical ones- warm and hot, like fire; she wondered what they were using to power this thing.)

“Just one,” Bow said quietly to her, ducking as a shot hit the wall above him, spraying the two with concrete fragments. “I've got two anti-magic arrows left. Take one; you can activate it just by hitting her with it, it just needs to burst.”

“I'll be right there, I'll lose magic too,” she said, as clawed shadows winged over their hiding place. Shadow Weaver had clearly noticed where they were, and was keeping up the pressure.

“Yeah, but you're better in a fight than she is,” Bow said as he handed the arrow over. “Wait until I shoot my arrow- I think she's noticed the anti-magic on my arrows, she's being careful to block anything I do. It'll distract her. Wait, then get close, take her magic out.”

“Then take *her* out?” Glimmer said with a fierce grin as she gripped the magic-killing arrow firmly in one hand.

“Punch a bitch for me,” Bow said, returning that grin. “...And for Catra.”

Glimmer laughed, even as she nodded.

Absolutely. For Catra, who has only two weaknesses; and today, I'm removing one of them. Shadow Weaver won't ever hurt her again.

(Her sister had saved so many lives; she deserved to have someone save *her* for once.)

As if on cue, there was a blast, from somewhere south of them; a massive one, though the start was oddly muted, like someone had slammed a lid on the top of it. Whatever resistance it had met, though, it popped a mere second later, the roar of flame growing tremendously before finally dying away; probably an ammo dump explosion, Glimmer had heard those before. Hell, she'd been *responsible* for a bunch of ammo dumps exploding, during that year the Best Friend Squad had upgraded to the Best Friend Squad Plus with Mermista and Sea Hawk; they'd spent most of it roaming around the Sea of Sighs attacking any supply centers the Horde had, and making the ammunition cook off had been a reliable way to wreck those bases.

*Though if that **was** an ammunition depot going off... Silver, it must have been fucking enormous.*

At the same time as that blast went off, the power cut off, the sparking machines nearby settling down and her hungry shadow finding nothing to eat. It didn't affect the actual illumination in the alley, for the most part- the lights had already been ruined before this point, and the fires didn't go out, they were providing most of the light- but it *did* mean she didn't have a good way to recharge.

“Make it count,” she whispered to Bow. “I think I'm down to what I got now. Power's out.”

“Understood,” Bow said, his eyes hard and firm as he nocked his last magic-killing arrow, peeking over the rubble to get a bead on the dark sorceress. He was back down a fraction of a second later, as Shadow Weaver filled the air where his head had been with killing shadow, but it was apparently enough time for him to get a good idea of where to shoot, for he was already drawing his bow back in preparation.

Glimmer took the chance to look at him as he drew the arrow back, his abs firm and tight, muscles taut and firm, his form stirring... quite a lot inside her. Add on that he was helping her complete her mission, when she'd thought at the start that he wouldn't be the kind of man who could agree to an assassination...

Well. Bow, always high in her estimation, had... risen.

(And hadn't he said he liked short girls, back near a year ago now, on the mission to get Mara's ship from the Crimson Waste? Glimmer had remembered him saying that, even though that mission had ended with Adora- well, Double Trouble, but it was Adora's plan- *blowing Glimmer up*... interesting priorities her subconscious had.)

A lot.

...When this is over... we are going to have to have a very long conversation... because if we don't, I'll end up kissing him without warning or doing some other stupid dramatic thing, if I'm being honest with myself.

(And she *was* honest with herself, these days, which was a small miracle... and a big one, all at the same time.)

Also, I should probably kill Shadow Weaver first. Don't want to declare my undying love with her creeping on us. Ruin the whole mood.

"On my mark," Bow said, drawing her out of her thoughts. "And..."

He leaned out over the side of his cover, from a different spot than he'd peeked through, and let go of his bowstring at the same time as he spoke.

"Go,"Bow said, not as a shouted command, but more like how he loosed his arrows, a gentle release.

Glimmer, like his arrow, was released with tremendous violence despite the gentleness of his actions, teleporting next to Shadow Weaver just as she blocked Bow's shot. This close, Glimmer did not strike with fist or sparkle, as she had so far, as she'd been *careful* to do so far...

But with all the dark magic she could muster.

Two great claws from the shadow of her wings, which ignored Shadow Weaver's attempt to stop her, passing right through

Shadow Weaver's protective shields and bit into her, gripping her arms even as they cut through her flesh, halting her spellcasting.

Glimmer broke into an exultant grin as Shadow Weaver's shouted in horror and surprise.

It worked!

(Glimmer had learned from her, after all, had learned lessons Shadow Weaver hadn't even known she'd been teaching; had learned from Shadow Weaver's arrogant mockery of those who had brought light against her and died in the attempt, had learned from Shadow Weaver's annoyed dismissal of Glimmer's sparkling magic, had learned from Shadow Weaver's prideful boasting about how rare and special dark magic was. She had learned that Shadow Weaver *never fought dark magic.*)

It wouldn't work for long. Glimmer had been the student, not the master, and a few weeks of training wouldn't change that, even if it was the best in all the world. Even now, in the grip of Glimmer's night, Shadow Weaver was already recovering, glowing eyes narrowing as she worked counter-magic even without her hands.

But the fun part of a surprise, as Glimmer was quickly coming to learn, was that it only had to work *once.*

Bow's anti-magic arrow in hand, Glimmer had a rush of inspiration on how she was going to do this. She'd only have a few seconds to kill Shadow Weaver without her magic getting in the way, and

sure, she could *probably* do it with her muscles alone, just punch her into paste...

But she had an idea she kinda liked *better:*

Grinning, Glimmer grabbed her.

(And in a moment no one would ever know about- for just a brief, hallucinatory second- Shadow Weaver thought she saw Silver in the gleam of Glimmer's smile.)

"For my *sister!*" she shouted in the witch's face... right before she teleported them.

Straight up.

Up, up, *up,* in the air, into the smoke and dust of the Fright Zone's collapse, high enough that nothing living could survive the impact without magic.

And before Shadow Weaver could cast any of a dozen spells she knew that would save her, Glimmer slapped Bow's arrow upside the witch's head so hard that it burst open, stripping them both of their magic.

But only *one* of them had *wings.*

Laughing her head off- because what *else* could she do? She'd done it, she'd done it, *she'd done it!*- Glimmer shoved the dark witch- who for the next few seconds was *not* a dark witch, but just a helpless mortal woman, as subject to gravity as anyone else- away from her, and spread her wings. Her back protested, her muscles ached, but she wasn't really trying to *fly* so much as *glide,* glide back to Bow and safety and the ground, and the hot air kinda helped with that, provided a little more lift for her inexperienced wings.

And she watched, with a sense of intense and overwhelming joy, as Shadow Weaver, screaming, fell to her death, down towards the fire, before the smoke swallowed her and her screams up.

Down, down, she went, gliding to Bow, who was staring at her with wide eyes, worry and concern clear on his handsome, *handsome* face.

She almost flew straight into him to kiss him, but remembered her earlier thoughts and forced herself to *not* do that.

Which worked out *really well,* because the *second* she touched down, her body reminded her that she was running with muscles that barely knew how to crawl, and the cramps forced her to curl up like a ball of pain on the ground as Bow alternated between berating her, watching over her, and treating her with some of his first aid supplies, alongside lamenting his lack of access to anything particularly strong.

Despite her suffering, Glimmer kept smiling.

(How could she not? She'd saved her sister's life. This was a price to pay so small that she could not truly call it payment.)

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter: Shadow Weaver.

You're not reading that wrong.
(The monster has one last trick up her sleeve.)

Chapter 75: A BATTLE FOR THE AGES: The Shadow on the Moon

Chapter Notes

For more context, you might want to read Chapter 18 again.

I've had this planned a long time.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A BATTLE FOR THE AGES:

The Shadow on the Moon

They are strange, the thoughts that come in the last moments.

There are two parts in her skull, screaming even as her hands move in patterns of sorcery that simply do not work; the magic around her is too confused, too jumbled, she is trying to weave with shadows choking on themselves and she cannot do it.

One part of her, the larger part by far, howls; there is still power left to grasp, there is still a world left to eat, there is still so *much* she does not *own*, it screams in frustrated fury, perceives the justice of its death as an injustice against its overwhelming hunger for power. Her bottomless belly is yet to be filled with all

the strength of the world, and so the glutton inside her rages at death, who halts all appetites.

(This part of her is not *just* the parasite she gained in the Spell of Obtainment; that would be nice, to believe that only the spell invited evil in her… but it would not be true. There is much of Light Spinner in it, too, of the pride and desperation and desire all three that led her to cast the spell in the first place.)

But there is another part of her.

It is much smaller, so small it might be mistaken for a mustard seed, something even all her decades of atrocity cannot entirely snuff out. This fire, floating on the sea of shadow, flickers, and feels… relief. There is a part of her that is *tired,* that is sick of the endless hunt, of the never-ending need for *more, more, more!*... and that will be over with, now. No matter what is it to come, there will be no more hunger pangs.

And… even smaller, the smallest part of her smallest part… there is a part of her that is glad that she will do no more harm.

(This part is wholly Light Spinner, the last echoes of the more complex woman she was... before the hunger reduced her so much.)

But whatever the smaller parts feelings, the larger part nonetheless commands their flesh; it is helpless to do anything but *survive,* or at least, try, hands moving, words spit, *nothing happening;* it is hard to make the right movements and right words at all with the wind whipping past her and the ground approaching at such a screaming speed but even when she *does*

perfectly cast her spells, *nothing happens.* Her spellcraft is still too confused, her desperate scrabbling cannot grab tight the seams of creation, the magic that permeates the very essence of Etheria is so scrambled around her from whatever device Glimmer hit her with that she cannot find purchase in the chaos.

She falls, and pride keeps her from giving the indignity of a scream.

She falls, turning and twisting, and the world passes about her in a kaleidoscope, in chaos, in madness. Fire, and the Fright Zone; war, civil war, war that is the death of Hordak's dream and the ultimate expression of the form that dream took. The machines of war, finally grinding each other's gears, Hordesman blood for lubricant and oil; what the Horde has brought to the world, it finally brings against itself.

Fall, tumble, twist, turn.

The sky above, the endless gray of Despondos; but then she turns and there is something else, black, black with pinpoints of light and *something* has changed and she doesn't know doesn't know doesn't know *what* she will never know she will die not knowing and why does this pass so slowly? One might think a fall would be too quick, but Shadow Weaver has always been a quick thinker, and the adrenaline flooding her veins like a choked engine speeds her up even more. Every second is a solid minute, an hour, a month, and she falls, falls, falls.

Her racing mind covers her whole life; and it seems… small. It seems that she, weaver of shadows, will take… very little with her, into the dark.

She thinks of Adora… but Adora is no creation of hers. *She* tried to build a good servant, a servant, a host to possess with her body-stealing spell when Adora came into her fullness. She did not build a Lord of the Horde. She did not build this… *thing* Adora has become, wild and untamed, so full of rage, this thing that has made the Horde itself catch flame.

(Shadow cannot be mother of fire, but must run from it.)

All she is, all she has, will die with her. She will leave nothing of value behind, not even fond memories in the minds of others.

She thinks of Catra, but only *after* she thinks of Adora, because that is the order she has always put them in. Adora, then- distantly, next, *beneath*- Catra… the annoying little hanger-on, whom Shadow Weaver had tolerated only because she knew Adora would blame her for the brat's death. Catra, who showed her weakness in needing Shadow Weaver's love; pathetic. It was why Shadow Weaver had always preferred Adora; Adora had not needed her, not the way Catra had. An orphan in search of a parent, unlike independent Adora, who had no need of others…

And yet she wonders, here at the last, if this was a mistake, and not for the first time; there were… moments… weak moments, in the years in which she raised the two brats, that she had… remembered. She had been an orphan of Mystacor herself, brought there due to her talent for magic, young enough that she

recalled nothing of them, old enough that she had known she was missing something.

She had wanted a parent, too, then.

She'd shrugged it off, before. Just weakness, obviously. Her lonesome upbringing had made her strong. Catra would adapt or die, same as Shadow Weaver had.

And yet… now she…

Wonders.

Perhaps… perhaps there was a middle way. Perhaps Catra could have had the best of all things. Perhaps there could have been a mother who knew what it was to be an orphan, who knew how surviving on your own made you strong… but who could also provide support. A child who did not have to grow up coddled or abandoned either one, but some other third thing, a middle way…

…*No,* she told herself, finally, even as she fell, as the world turned around her. *No.*

Never. That was just… weakness, in her last moments.

(Except she couldn't stop thinking that *a daughter, raised well* would be a fine last thought. That *a daughter, who loved me, whom I loved,* would be… something to take into the dark. A legacy…)

No, she would leave nothing behind. There were no kind thoughts in any head about her; Entrapta would not have such, nor would any Hordesman. She would not even have a grave, most likely. No one would honor her with a funeral; no Mystacor tombstone for her, no statues, not even a Horde burial in the fertile earth to feed the next generation.

Bitterest of ironies; her dark magic drew on the force that lasted, that was the last thing, yet she herself… she would be nothing, in a few moments. Ephemeral. A shadow before the sun.

But right as the last moment finally came, she hit upon a last thought.

Micah.

Micah… he would remember her. She had been… kind… to him. She had planned, after she got powerful from the Spell of Obtainment, to adopt him, to take him in; an orphan, like her, but one she could mother. The middle way- and was *that* where the thought was from? Had she once dreamed of raising Micah that way? Is that why she thinks of it now, at the last? That comes from when she was just Light Spinner, and she does not recall all that woman, nor her ways. She has been Shadow Weaver too long.

Micah… whose very own daughter with Queen Angella has slain her… Glimmer, whom she had once, in a single moment of

paranoia, feared might be planning something, which she'd dismissed. Foolishness, she could see now...

But...

Wait.

That moment of doubt... it had come during the influence check she'd performed on Glimmer, at a time that felt like ages ago now, looking at her inner power and ambient magic...

A thing she'd requested of Glimmer, asking for her permission to enter her mind and soul... *without* telling the girl that such permission could *not* be retracted afterwards. That the door, once opened, would *remain* open. A door through which Shadow Weaver had found that Glimmer, through the Moonstone, was connected to her immortal mother, that there was a backdoor into the mind and soul of the immortal Queen of Brightmoon.

Things she hadn't had a plan for, at the time. Just... information that might be useful, later. Nothing more than her usual grasping for *more* at work, no plan at the time, simply keeping that knowledge because she knew it might be useful later.

And later was *now.*

(A ferocious grin split her face. Hadn't she warned Glimmer at the time that she did not tolerate betrayal? Time to teach the little

cunt that lesson all over again.)

Time for a last spell.

Shadow Weaver had two spells of last resort, two spells that would cost her body. One a detonation, a destruction, a lashing out with all her force against all the world; a spell of slaying, a spell of slaughter, a spell of sacrifice. It would cause a blast that would kill anything she faced, slice it to ribbons with the force of her own life, freely given up.

But her *second* spell of last resort...

A spell that gave up her flesh, her body, for a chance to possess someone else, to take them over, to wear new skin. A chance to overshadow another soul, to lock them tight in the depths of their own subconscious while she ruled from their skull like a queen on a throne.

A spell that was a last resort, because it could *fail.* It could be banished from the flesh, or bounce off the target's mental and spiritual defenses, and then there would be no living after that; the body gone, such a formless spirit would soon dissipate. That was why she'd never used it, even as she'd vaguely intended on using it on Adora, back when she was raising the two ungrateful brats and had mistaken Adora as the one who might someday be a figure of legend, be someone whose life was *worth* stealing.

(She'd even vaguely thought of using it on Catra... but the idea of becoming the girl disgusted her, and she'd never seriously

considered using it to become a beast.)

Angella, one of the most formidable people on Etheria, would normally be absolutely proof against such a spell... but she didn't know of her daughter's spirit and its connection with her, of the backdoor through the Moonstone that a soul might slip through. An attack from a direction Angella didn't even know existed... and if Angella was, perhaps, distracted right now...

Assuming it would even work. Spells that gave up life were powerful, maybe powerful enough to punch through the scrambled magic around her, but maybe not...

...But what did Shadow Weaver have to lose? She would die if she did nothing.

Why not roll the dice?

And so she made her hands make one last motion.

I used to be called Light Spinner before I was Shadow Weaver, after all, came the thought in her mind, one full of gleeful laughter, as she gave herself up unto death in hopes of stealing someone else's life. *And now I will spin and weave both, with the Moonstone in my hands...*

But right as her hands finished, a thought most strange in Shadow Weaver's head, and with a motivation almost unknown to the dark witch, flitted through.

It will hurt Micah, if I do this.

A thought born of care for another person, a thing so unusual inside her that- even at this moment, the final point before impact and death- she had time to marvel at it. Empathy... a thing long dead inside her.

This was merely the ghost of something she had once had, before the Spell, before the Ritual, before...

Well, *before.*

And the thought was true: Angella, as a person, would be locked within her mind for all eternity. Shadow Weaver would be in control.

She would, in a way, be killing Micah's wife.

A coin spun, just once, in her mind.

(And here is the most nightmarish part of what is to come; there are timelines where Shadow Weaver does *not* cast the spell. This is a real choice. There are worlds where, for love of Micah, who

was as close to a son as she'd ever had, who was the one legacy she might leave in the world, Shadow Weaver would choose to die, a genuinely kind act, known to no one. Only a few timelines… but for *one* to exist would be proof that there was a spinning coin here, that a person's *decision* was the turning point of time's course… and that responsibility for whatever choice was made lay with the chooser.)

But just once.

I want to live.

The spell finished, and instead of her body slamming into the rubble and fire to break and burn, it dissipated into shadow, and slipped into Glimmer's aura.

(Glimmer, distracted as she stared up at the night sky, as she felt the echoes of the endless universe about her as Etheria shifted back into the true universe and away from the gray border of Despondos, mistook it for an effect of that transition- though she wondered why she heard laughter, even at the time, and why it seemed so cruel and familiar.)

And far away, Queen Angella, unconscious from her rough teleport, was helpless against the shadow that poured like poison into her soul. She still fought back, still tried to resist, a purely involuntary act... but to be struck while asleep, and from an angle unknown, by an attack unexpected...

Some outcomes are near inevitable.

And so it was that some time later, when Angella's body got up, it was Shadow Weaver who opened her new eyes.

Chapter End Notes

Oh, fuck.

Next chapter: Catra, Adora, and Razzle Dazzle, and the end of all things.

Chapter 76: T-Minus 3, 2, 1...

Chapter Notes

Only a little more.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 74

T-Minus 3, 2, 1...

Scorpia exits the Black Garnet and steps into... quiet.

That was... worrying. *Real* worrying.

Sure, there was noise all *around* the area, but distant mostly, fires and the sounds of the civil war that had been raging when they arrived and was now petering out into isolated skirmishes.

But here in the little smashed-in hole full of debris where the Black Garnet's little building sat, an area cleared by force into a bit of a field, there was mostly silence. Perfuma's great warplant was... asleep?... laying down, at any rate, with Entrapta's weird monkey-bot suit next to it. Rainbow energy was trailing up into the sky like a smoke signal from somewhere behind the warplant and mech that Scorpia couldn't see. The Rebels, meanwhile- which Scorpia thought to check a moment later- had retreated to

a far distance behind Scorpia, though they were keeping watch; Scorpia even caught one raising their weapon to line up a shot.

She summoned a bolt of lightning to curl around one pincer while looking at that Rebel, and they wisely lowered their crossbow and slipped into the shadows of a nearby alleyway.

(Man, these powers sure had a kick to them; if it weren't for how she felt like she'd done something *wrong* to get them, she might even have enjoyed having them!)

Really, the only sound Scorpia could hear was... sobbing?

It was coming from where that energy was rising up.

Scorpia headed over, the noise resolving itself into a more familiar voice; past the dead warplant and abandoned mech was Entrapta, sobbing as she held Perfuma, who was the source of the rainbow energy. Weird circuitry patterns were crawling up her, and Entrapta held her and sobbed as a medical device- which looked hastily jury-rigged and cannibalized from the mech suit, which was in some disarray now that Scorpia got a closer look at it- scanned the unconscious Plumerian.

“Entrapta?” Scorpia asked. Entrapta made no response, so Scorpia said it louder, and tapped her shoulder. “Entrapta?”

Entrapta looked up at her, mask raised, eyes flooding with tears.

“I did it again,” the Drylborn rasped, in a voice so swollen from crying it sounded choked. “I always... hurt them. Friends. Loved ones. People I care about. Hurt... I've hurt her, I've killed her, I've hurt her, I've killed her, Scorpia, get *away* from me, I'll hurt you too!”

Scorpia shot Perfuma a panicked glance, but the Plumerian was... breathing? She seemed to be in *pain,* but she was asleep and alive as far as Scorpia could tell.

“I think Perfuma's alive-” Scorpia began.

But she would never finish that sentence, because a second later, circuitry crawled up her body as energy began to be drained from her, Scorpia ending her words with a wordless scream as her body was seized in the grip of a machine the size of a planet.

(Distantly, she heard Entrapta's howl of despair.)

<u>CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>***

“Glimmer! Bow!” came the voice from above them.

Bow looked up from Glimmer, laying on the ground and groaning; the effort to fly down after she'd teleported Shadow Weaver to her well-deserved death had, once again, turned her back muscles into firm little slabs of hurt. Bow had moved her to a fairly defensible little spot of rubble, one most enclosed so that enemy soldiers had only one way to reach them, and then had kept watch while pouring a bit of ointment on her from his pack. He'd planned to help her get back on her feet and then head over to the Garnet once more, back into the breach with Perfuma and Scorpia, but things had gotten quiet on that end in the last few minutes.

That fight was over, now, for better or worse. Either his fellow Rebels had won, or they'd lost... and he hoped desperately that they'd won.

“We're down here!” Bow called up, as the form of Swift Wind descended from the skies, emerging out of the smoke.

“That Swift Wind?” Glimmer asked before groaning.

“Yes,” Bow said as Swift Wind landed next to them, coughing.

“Ugh, smoke!” Swift Wind complained in high temper and with great flamboyance; that reassured Bow that the pegasus was alright. “Awful! Anyway, Glimmer, did I see you just drop Shadow Weaver like the world's worst bomb from like a mile up?”

“Yep!” Glimmer said, chuckling even despite her pain.

“Couldn't have happened to a nicer person,” Swift Wind said. “Anyway, I saw some of the others, I think I can get you to them; not much air defense at the moment. I think the Horde people in charge of those weapons abandoned them for more ground combat oriented roles.”

“Good,” Glimmer said. “Soon as I can move aga-”

Whatever she was going to say was torn from her as she suddenly shrieked, circuitry forming around her and crawling up her.

“Glimmer!” Bow said.

“I- what is happening?!?” Glimmer had time to yell between shrieks, as Swift Wind collapsed behind Bow.

“Swift Wind!” Bow yelled, feeling deja vu as yet another of his friends collapsed before him.

“It's... too much,” the horse said. “Too- too much.”

“What is happening?!?” Bow asked.

(Who he asked? He did not know. But he knew he would get no answer.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Netossa didn't know what was going on.

She'd been on her way to the Runestone, but then that area had... exploded? She'd been on the edge of the blast radius, and her shields had held up well against the backwash of heat, but it had still been hellish; the area around her had been set ablaze just from the convection alone.

But she was still alive, so that *couldn't* have been the Runestone going up... if *that* had happened, all Etheria would be dead. It'd be like blowing up one of the magnetic poles of the planet, it wasn't the kind of thing a world *survived.*

And the fire... that didn't make sense, either. The Black Garnet was electrical in nature, not fiery.

Maybe an ammo dump going up?... but what the hell kinda ammo... I know they say Adora's a "Fire Princess", but that's absurd, nobody can control the Spirit Ember. Dozens have tried

and they all died. But maybe she made a mimic of it with Horde tech?

...Yeah, that made sense. Hordak had done all kinds of things people would say was impossible, and the Spirit Ember had been artificial to start with. Maybe he found some old First Ones' notes.

Regardless, she didn't know, and it wasn't like she could *keep* going the way she'd been headed. That area was basically lava now, all cooked and slowly-cooling coals- well, "cooling" in the sense that they were going from "die instantly from burning" to "die a second later from burning". Nothing Netossa knew of could survive that, except maybe a dragon, and she didn't have one handy.

So for now, having retreated to areas less ablaze, she was resting in an alleyway that was mostly intact, leaning on a wall, and idly trying to activate her comms. Useless, of course- they'd been jammed since she got here, presumably due to some Horde tech- but without them... she didn't know what was going on with her wife, or her troops.

(*Be okay, my love,* she prayed, to whatever was or was not, the first and most honest prayer of every lover's heart.)

As she flicked the button on her comms again, she felt the energies around her... shift. Her own inner magic as a Wild Princess felt like something was... trying to grab it?

She looked around, but she didn't see anyone else. It was just her and some corpses at the alley's end; a satyr slumped over a rock wall that might have been a window before it exploded, a four-armed Squamatus next to her in a leather jacket, a few other scattered dead. Not her victims; they'd been dead when she got here, victims of the Horde's civil war.

...So who's... doing whatever this is? she wondered, as she felt the clumsy attempts to rob her... not stop, but slide off. Like she wasn't what they were looking for, or something.

What was that? She wondered.

(She would never know the answer, that it was the Heart seeking all magic to draw into itself, that it was the warning that the apocalypse was come.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

The Heart.

With everything that had happened- with the *relief* she'd felt when Adora had put the knife down, the *terror* she'd felt when Adora screamed, and the sheer *joy* of having her beloved *back* in her arms- Catra had, for a few blessed moments, forgotten about the bomb whose fuse she held in her hand.

And in those few moments, it had been primed.

"...The Heart?" Catra tried to ask, through lips so dry and burnt from the blazing air that she had to lick them twice to make her words make sense. "The Heart."

(She didn't *ask,* the second time. There was no need. The look on Madame Razz's face alone told her that the worst had come to pass.)

"Yes," the not-Twigget said.

"The... Heart?" Adora said, and Catra realized that, despite literally *everything,* she'd never had a chance to really explain what was going on.

Thankfully, before she had to try, Madame Razz stepped in.

"The death of everything," Madame Razz said bluntly. "Get up, you two. We've got some talking to do and no time to do it."

Catra had been curled around her Adora, sending healing light into her to heal the Spirit Ember; and it had been... right. Like a final piece of her puzzle was complete; her family and friends had built most of it, but without Adora, she'd always been missing something.

(And bizarrely, some part of her is now *mad* at the Heart- and Light Hope, Entrapta, *everyone* involved in this mess- for *forcing* her to separate from her Adora once again, after all she had been through just to *be* with her again.)

The duo got up, Catra helping her Adora rise on wobbly legs.

“I... the Spirit Ember, where-” Adora began, and Catra noticed her eye was no longer on fire, but was just scarred, wounds she'd taken in a world that didn't exist.

“The Ember's still intact,” Madame Razz said, not unkindly. “It's back in the Flame Waste now, back where it started, but it's not hurt. Still, teleportation does a number on brains and circuitry alike unless you prep for it, so I imagine the Spirit Ember is freaking out and burning the Flame Waste again, and once it's done freaking out it'll find you.”

(She was right; the Flame Waste, given a reprieve for a time, was once more getting scorched... though not for very long, and if one could survive the blazing force to see the Ember itself, they would see golden light stitching across it, healing for something that had been born wounded.)

Adora nodded, and stumbled a bit; Catra put one strong arm around her to steady her.

“And you... you need to get to the Castle,” Razz said, nodding to Catra.

“How?” Catra said. “I don't know where Swift Wind went when we teleported-”

“I'll teleport you,” Madame Razz said. “One benefit of the Spirit Ember being gone and the Heart activating- cleared the air around here. Spirit Ember isn't scattering spells and all the Runestone magic in Etheria is heading to one point- I can make you hitch a ride on those streams, send you straight there. And I'll slap the usual safeguards on that teleport, too, unlike what I had to do with poor Micah- you'll need your wits about you as soon as you land, not unconscious or stumbling about.”

Poor Micah...?

“What happened to Mom's Micah?” Catra asked.

(She hadn't known the man for more than a few minutes, really... but she'd known how much her mother loved him, had known that for long years.)

“He's alive,” Madame Razz said. “He saved your mom and your squire both, and I saved him.”

Mom's okay? And Flutterina! Good to know, Adora's tackle kinda left them behind us...

“Where's my family at?” Catra asked.

“Back home, I think,” Razz said. “Well, Angella and Flutterina, anyway. Micah teleported them out when the Ember started bursting. I teleported Micah away myself, not sure where he ended up- a beach somewhere, I think. I was busy teleporting myself out too, the Ember was blowing up at the time, so I couldn't slap safeguards on the teleport- I ended up puking my little guts out when I landed, and I didn't even go all that far. I don't even want to think how Micah was feeling, he went a lot farther than I intended.”

“So they're safe,” Catra said.

“Yes,” Madame Razz replied. “But they won't be unless we deal with Light Hope, and quick.”

“What do you even want me to do when I *get* to the Crystal Castle?” Catra asked. “I can't exactly kill Light Hope, I've seen stuff just... pass through her when I was training with her.”

“Like a ghost princess from the stories,” Adora said, and Catra nodded.

“Yeah,” she said.

“That's more accurate than I'd like,” Razz replied. “But I'm not sure killing her, even if you could, would matter. The Heart's

activated already. We need to stop *that.*"

She nodded at the Sword.

"We need to cut the fuse," Madame Razz finished.

"You mean the Sword of Protection?..." Catra said, lifting it up and looking down at her reflection in the blade's metal.

(So much of her life has been determined by this Sword... all the good... and now... now some of the worst of the bad.)

"We need to break it," Razz said.

"How? It's the *Sword,* it's invincible-" Catra began, but Razz shook her head.

"Nothing is truly invincible," she said. "And that Sword... even *that* can't handle the sheer amount of energy that will be channeled into it to activate the Heart. Not without trouble. Ask your girl; enough heat will weaken *any* metal. But the only thing strong enough to shatter even a weakened Sword would be the strength of the She-Ra... and something hard to beat it against. Something the First Ones made. That's why I'm sending you to the Castle... that, and I'm hoping against hope that maybe some part of my old friend Light Hope is still in there, underneath the shackles they put on her."

Catra had trained in the castle, under Light Hope... there were a few objects... maybe even just the walls and floor. They'd lasted the centuries, after all...

(Even if breaking the Sword felt like tearing off an arm. Even if the very *idea*- even *knowing* she had to do it- felt unthinkable, a thing she could only approach sideways, without looking directly at it. She had never given up on *anything* before... not Adora, not Shadow Weaver... and now, not the Sword.)

"I... have some ideas," she said reluctantly.

"Good," Madame Razz said; and she sighed, which made her seem terribly old, all at once, drained of the manic energy that gave her a good fascimile of youth. Now... now she just looked... tired. "Because this is all I've got. Remember- wait until the last moment... and strike. And... good luck."

She raised her staff, but Adora spoke up.

"Wait," she said.

"No time, girl, kiss your woman and be quick about it," Madame Razz said. "Got work for you, too, or I'd send you both."

"Okay," Adora said, turning to Catra. "I... Catra, I... I love you."

I love you. Words Catra had wanted for so long, so long, so long that- even now, in the face of... of all *this*- still did it feel like a release. Like a tension she had carried all her life was finally released.

I love you. She had longed for those words for so long, but having them felt familiar instantaneously, familiar and comforting.

"I love you too," Catra managed to choke out, and then Adora was kissing her.

Not their first kiss. That had been one of blood and hurt in Mara's ship, so long ago in the Crimson Waste, when *you're a First One* had devoured Adora's soul and Catra had been trapped, a prisoner; the Hordesman had cut her lips on the Brightmoon soldier's teeth, they had both tasted like dry chapped lips and the heavy salt of blood and all the whipsaw laughter Adora had locked behind her lips with Catra's teeth.

This one... this one tasted like soot, and some salt, too, but gentler salt, and Adora was warm and heavy in Catra's arms and it was nice to kiss *up,* she'd shifted out of She-Ra when Adora kissed her and she didn't know *why* except maybe that she'd fantasized about kissing the taller woman for so long that to kiss Adora with her head facing down hadn't felt right. Adora's arms around her were a bit rough with the armor on, a bit too warm, but that was kinda nice, actually; it grounded her, told her this was real, because it *was* just a little bit imperfect. Even as the trumpets blared in her head and her life came to completion, the irritation of armor poking her a bit and the too-dry air of the burning Fright Zone around them made sure she knew that this *was* happening, this was *really happening.*

Adora loved her. All her fears that she wouldn't be wanted by the one she wanted had been just that, fears, not reality; she had suspected as much when Adora spared her life a moment ago, but to have confirmation...

It was terribly sweet.

(Happiness. Such a small thing. And yet the biggest thing of all.)

They pulled apart a moment later, because they had to; but Catra smiled at her, and Adora smiled back, and it was enough.

Madame Razz, whose eyes had softened momentarily, lost that sparkle as Catra turned to her.

“Okay,” Catra said, buoyed on that joy, and resolutely not thinking about what was to come. About the end of all things. About her role in the death of the universe.

About the Sword, and breaking it.

(About what that would mean, for one who was the She-Ra only because of the Sword...)

“I'm ready,” she said.

“I hope so,” Madame Razz muttered, and Catra wasn't sure she was meant to hear that... but before another thought could enter her mind, she was already being teleported across all Etheria.

<u>CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>***

Adora wasn't sure what she was feeling after that kiss, but it was... *really* good. Almost addictive. Terribly sweet.

(She did not recognize it, but it felt almost... familiar. Like she'd known it once, long ago, in her childhood...)

Still, Catra was gone now, in a flash of light, and Madame Razz had said she needed Adora to do something... Adora turned to the older woman, waiting a moment out of respect. All Hordesmen respected the elderly- nobody in the Horde got old without being *damn* tough- but the strange Twigget seemed far away, looking at where Catra had been with an inscrutable look on her face, so Adora decided to prompt her.

“What do you need me to do?” Adora asked, and felt more than a little stupid; she was the Lord of the Horde! She *gave* orders, she did not *ask* for them.

(*But given how poorly that went... maybe it's good to take orders. Maybe I was never meant to lead,* she thinks, and it hurts, to think that, because she was told all her life she was meant to lead... but it is also a kind of *relief,* to finally admit it to herself, to

admit that everything she has fought for and killed for and hurt for was something she just plainly *wasn't capable of.*)

The Twigget was silent a long moment more, but her face was dark and clouded, as though she were fighting with herself, on the inside.

"...All Etheria is not worth the damage that weapon will do," she finally said, and there were tears in her eyes. "It is not fair to ask this of you, young woman. Even with everything you have done... you do not deserve to be given this task. I have known few who would, and all of them would fail to realize the horror of what they were doing. You don't have that benefit.. but you are the only one now who *might* be able to do it."

"...What?" Adora asked, not because she didn't understand but because, somehow, she *did,* like the thing she was being asked to do was so big, so horrible, so *awful* that it reached back through time to inform her of its own existence, to know of a thing before she knew of it.

"...I think I'm about to ask you to murder the planet," Madame Razz said quietly. Tears streamed from her eyes but did not interrupt her words. "If... if Catra can't... we can't let the Heart go off. If she fails... you still have some flickers of the Spirit Ember's power in you. Your fire... it might... it might be able to destroy the Black Garnet. That'll... that'll kill *everyone* on this planet... but the Heart can't fire if a Runestone falls. One planet, for *hundreds* of worlds... it's..."

“Worlds?” Adora asks, and Madame Razz nodded.

“All Etheria is just one world, in a sea of stars,” the old Twigget said in that faraway tone. “The thing that's happening now... a weapon the First Ones left. Your kin's last and deadliest toy. The Heart of Etheria, a bomb big enough to obliterate so many worlds... Places just like this one, full of life just like this one, all of which will be turned into kindling if the Heart activates.”

“So it's either Etheria... or everything,” Adora said, and the old Twigget- whom Adora was beginning to think might *not* be a Twigget at all, because some part of her magical senses were already returning as her sister slowly reconnected to the planet's leyline and even in such bad shape they could *still* tell something was up with her- nodded.

“I'm so sorry, Adora,” the old woman apologized.

(It is the first apology anyone in authority or power has ever given her. The feeling is... odd. Like unexpected medicine. Like unexpected insult. Like a lot of things she didn't expect, and she has no idea how to feel about that.)

“Sorry?” Adora asked, thrown off.

“Yes,” Madame Razz said. “I am so sorry for putting this on you. But someone *has* to be the failsafe. I was going to ask Micah or Angella to do it, but then the Ember went off... and I don't have the strength anymore.”

She sighed, and finally turned her old, weary head towards Adora.

“It's down to you.”

(*Kind of funny, isn't it?* The hellhound inside whispered, and she tried not to listen to it. *Only when you finally stop being a villain do you finally become the* ***last*** *villain... the murderer of the whole world...*)

“How do I do this?” Adora asked, as she struggled to ignore the voice in her head.

“Pure fire,” Madame Razz said. “Get ready to burn the Garnet. If- if you see energy going back to the planet's core... there'll be a window where Catra can't stop it, where she'll have failed and the weapon's getting ready to fire... but you'll still have time. If I'm right. If I'm not just condemning the universe by asking you to wait. If... if you see that, or it just... you're a mage, you'll see it. The twisting of all Etheria's magic. If that happens... melt the Garnet. Kill us. But hit it *hard.* The Runestones are incredibly durable. It'll take more than a few shots.”

The old woman stopped, shook, as if to puke, and Adora couldn't blame her. How could she do anything less? She was asking for the murder of her own world, to stop the greater murder of others...

And it *is* cruel to ask this of Adora... but she gets it. Because she was- for all her treachery- still a Hordesman... and every Hordesman was trained from childhood to know that there were, at times, cold equations. Sometimes you had to prioritize. Sometimes you let people die that might be saved, if saving them would cost so much in time and resources that it meant you couldn't save three other people- three was more than one. Simple, brutal math.

Other times, you cut a limb off to save a body.

And rarely, you burned a building down, to keep the sickness inside from spreading.

(Even when that building was the size of a planet.)

"I'll try," Adora said, but that didn't feel like enough... this woman had said sorry to her. She... she should... do something for that...

...Catra would forgive her.

Adora had few other guidelines by which to orient herself... so she used that one.

"I forgive you," she said; and theold Twigget gave her a bemused, if depressing, grin.

“Thank you,” she said. “Weirdly, that *does* help. But... get on with it. Get over there- you still got that dragon self on the inside, so fly over there.”

Dragon self...? For a moment Adora thought she meant her semi-official title of the Dragon, which she'd used for her Horde flag, but then remembered her transformation through the Tiger's Eye.

“Oh!” Adora said. “I... I forgot I could do that.”

And she *had*, in the chaos of being awoken by Lonnie to an ambush, and the Horde falling apart all around her...

(*Lonnie, be okay,* Adora prayed- to whom or what, she did not know. Perhaps whatever forces empowered Catra, if such benevolent beings would deign to hear a cruel traitor's request.)

“I know all about that,” Madame Razz said with a smirk. “Forgotten half the tricks I know, and that's assuming I even remember I've forgot. Go on, get. I'm going to save a few lives in this nightmare. If the Heart don't go off, that's some people saved. If... you have to stop it... then it's a good thing to die doing.”

She sighed, and turned around.

“And Adora? *Thank* you. This... this is horrific, but...”

She trailed off before shrugging, because what else was there to say?

(An atrocity to stop a greater atrocity. At least Adora won't have to live with this one, it'll kill her too if she does it.)

“I know,” Adora said, and the old woman sadly nodded.

And with that, both turned away from the other, Madame Razz taking off ot heal, Adora shifting into a dragon so she could fly to the Garnet.

Chapter End Notes

An end, soon.

Chapter 77

Chapter Notes

An ending.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Cutting the Fuse

The Crystal Castle.

It had been... ages... since Catra had been there. Training, early on, in the first year- or maybe the start of the second?- when she had first been *home,* in Brightmoon, learning all she could to become someone worthy of the love she had been given, by the people, by her friends, by those who would become her family. To become the She-Ra who was so beloved, instead of the Catra who was so despised.

Will they still love me when I am not the She-Ra?

She had no answer for that question, save a kind of shivery sick-to-her-stomach feeling, like wanting to puke even as you knew it would do you no good... which was an answer of its own.

They will abandon you; no one has ever loved you for you, Catra. Even they only loved you <u>after</u> the Sword.

A terribly familiar voice. Catra whipped around, but saw no one around her; just her in the dark, empty hallways of the Crystal Castle, all the lights off save the glow of sparking power cords, all heading deeper in towards the center.

(*Towards the Heart.*)

"Who's there?" Catra asked, and got no answer from the dark.

...I'm losing it. I... I could have sworn I heard... Shadow Weaver...

She shook her head violently, let her mane of hair whip about, hoping physical action would clear mental stress.

No time for this. Go crazy after I ruin my life by breaking the Sword. I'll have time to think about it then.

(And here is a fact most telling about the good woman Catra has become, a thing she will never realize herself: there is no spinning coin here. There is no question in her mind of whether she will break the Sword or not, because that is the right thing to do, no matter the cost to herself; the only question in her mind is if she can work up the will and courage to do so in time. There is no question of what she *will* do, only a question of whether she *can.*)

Courage held fast to the sticking place- for now- Catra ran down, down, down, into the Crystal Castle.

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Light Hope prepared her next little soundbite, another play of Shadow Weaver's words to mess with Catra's mind. The false She-Ra had a great weakness in her feelings towards her first maternal figure, confused and broken as that bond was; every little word the AI could string together in the sorceress' voice would buy Light Hope a little more time.

And she needed only a few moment's delay; the last Princess had finally linked up with the system.

In a moment, Catra would be linked as well, despite the system's surprising slowness; perhaps a circuit in the Sword needed repairing. Perhaps the same broken circuit that had led to it accepting a *Thunderian* as a proper sync partner. A repair to be made in time, after the cleansing.

(Inside, the Light Hope that had loved Mara threw herself at the code, biting at it as best she could, desperately trying to buy Catra time; and inside the Sword, Etheria itself, which did not wish to be an engine of genocide, did what it could, too, slowing the eternal engine by inches...)

But regardless... soon the Thunderian, who should *never* have had the Sword to begin with, would fulfill her destiny.

All hail the Empire Eternal.

(100101101010catrapleaseresistinmarasname10101000001010)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Adora passed over the Fright Zone as a dragon, and all the joy of her kiss with Catra was burning down to ashes inside her.

Every wingbeat brought her another moment of death, destruction, tragedy. The fighting was dying down, but not in any orderly fashion; no, this was the death-peace of fire, the quiet that was left after it had burned itself out. Peace because there was nothing left to burn, a peace formed of a negative image; there was not war there, so there must be peace.

The air was full of the smoke and screams from this- Adora's last and greatest betrayal.

(She has killed her father and she has killed her people and she has come within inches, literal inches, of killing her love. Is there no one she does not turn against? Is this something all First Ones do?... But no, they built an empire across the stars... and all Adora can do is destroy. This fire she spreads, this poisonous nature, this treachery... it is all her own.)

The smoke shifted with each wingbeat, revealing scene after scene of ruin. That bar she'd allowed built, now a bombed-out wreck. Whole areas where there weren't even corpses, the fire taking the buildings and the bodies both, somehow worse for the wiped-clean sterility. Little scenes that were like dioramas from up here, scale models of real tragedies, and Adora would love nothing more than to believe that was all they were, that she had not done... all *this.*

But every scene beneath her was real, real, real, and all the blood of it was on her hands.

(Burning tears dripped down her scaled snout, trails of red-hot draconic despair.)

She passed over an alleyway and... was that the four-armed Squamatus from the Crimson Waste? One of the ones in that gang she'd recruited, in a time that felt like it was ages ago but was... a year? Maybe? She couldn't remember the date, now.

And she'd never be able to ask the Squamatus, because she was dead. Her body, leather jacket decorated with Adora's Horde symbol, was covered in wounds, but surrounded by corpses that all wore the old Horde colors; nearby behind the Squamatus' corpse, slumped over a remnant of wall with a spear sticking out of her, was her satyr girlfriend.

Adora had recruited both of them... led them *here,* to *this...*

And she hadn't even bothered to remember their names.

Here because of me. ***Dead*** *because of me. And I can't even mark them down like the Last Fire Princess did...*

The tale the corpses told was simple enough; the satyr had died, and her lover had went berserk and, in her last moments, made them all pay before the wounds and exertion had taken their toll.

...*Focus. I've got a mission... f-for Catra. Catra needs me to do it.*

Sailing over the ruin she had left of every life she'd commanded, only those thoughts kept Adora going.

<u>CATRA OF ETHERIA***</u>***

Spiderbots and other things got in her way; but those were easy foes, dispatched in a moment.

More distracting to Catra were the memories.

You have been nothing but a disappointment.

(*Why does she hate me?* Her oldest question, her first question, the question that was written on her heart for so long. No wonder she sympathized with Hordak, with his desperation for his brother to love him; Catra, too, has only ever been hurt by the one who was supposed to love her, her very own mother...)

Down the hall, following the sparking lines, shaking off robots and the hallucinations both, in the form of the She-Ra that she will lose when she loses this Sword.

The She-Ra who threw away the She-Ra. You can't even do <u>this</u> right.

(Her innermost heart- Catra the Child, who will always wonder, forever, why she was abused, what she did to justify being so hurt- keens inside her, and she wishes she had the wisdom to soothe her, to tell her it will be alright, to show her the better, happier future that the Sword gave her... but that's the problem, isn't it? The *Sword* gave her that happy future, and she will soon be without it... and all Catra can see now is the dark, and all she can hear is Shadow Weaver, and all she can think about is how she is about to lose the one thing that made her life *happy*.)

Further, further, she ran, dropping to all fours briefly with the Sword's hilt quickly bitten into her mouth, she had to get there, fast as she could, she was almost-

There!

She finally emerged from the darkness into light, into a long, strange bridge in the centerpiece of the castle, a design of the planet and the signs of the Runestones around them- the signs of Catra's *friends,* the other Princesses, unwilling bullets in the biggest gun in the universe.

Catra rose up to a standing position as she spat her blade back into her hand, aiming it at Light Hope.

"**Light Hope!**" she hissed, half-feral from fury and fright and the sheer *pressure* she was under, here in this moment. "Stop this, now!"

"Good, you are here; now we can begin," Light Hope said, unfazed by Catra's fury. "After a thousand years, my programming will be fulfilled."

"Fulfill *this!*" Catra yelled, and leapt at her, as she kept going on about the Heart of Etheria and the First Ones- but then there was circuitry, on the sword, on her *skin,* burning a path through her fur, it was killing her fur as it went, burning patterns into it, and then the Sword was lifting *itself* and she couldn't take her hands off the hilt, no matter how she tried.

"I had originally intended for Adora to be the She-Ra," Light Hope said, as Catra struggled and screamed, trying to let go of the blade, trying to get her body to *move*. "I used all my power to reach across the universe to retrieve her, as I believed a First One was needed to wield the Sword- but that was an inefficient use of my resources. Had I known the Sword had malfunctioned such

that it would accept a Thunderian, I would have simply waited for you to take up your task, and fulfill your destiny...”

“Not *my* destiny!” Catra hissed, as she fought the power trying to control her. She... she kinda *could* move, but it felt like a mountain on her, to do *anything...*

But the stakes were so high, and Catra would not fail- not here, not now.

(*Brightmoon needs me to do this. My friends and family need me to do this. People I'll never even know need me to do this...*)

“After a thousand years, the Heart will be unleashed against the First Ones' enemies,” Light Hope continued, monologuing to... no one in particular, really. Catra wasn't paying attention, that was for sure; she was too busy fighting her control to pay attention to whatever the AI was rambling about. “Even with the Sword malfunctioning, and choosing you, an unworthy Thunderian... no, not even that. Not a Thunderian. A planetary derivative, an offshoot, an offworld descendant of true Thunderians. Not just an incorrect choice, but a *copy* of an incorrect choice. The Sword will be taken from you, after this. Given to a proper owner. Adora, perhaps, if she survives. It was always meant for her, after all.”

That part Catra heard, despite everything- and a small part of her, somewhere in the deepest back of her mind, in the single solitary neuron not devoted to the fight, was almost glad she had so much else going on. It was a distraction from hearing *that* old fear, which she'd thought dead, proven completely correct- and wasn't that delicious irony? She'd thought it was disproven here in the Crystal Castle, during her and Adora's disastrous first

exploration here... but it was here in the Castle she heard the truth.

The Sword was *not* hers, had never *been* hers, and all good things in life were, in fact, for Adora, not Catra, as true now as when they were children.

Yes, it was good, to think on something else right now, because that would destroy her if she thought about it much.

(And she knew, even then, that if there was a *later* to think about this in... it would ruin her.)

"Still... it is no matter," the AI continued. " Destiny will be fulfilled. You will serve your function. You will bring the First Ones to glory. It is not what you were born to do... but be grateful, unworthy one. You serve a greater race than your own."

Goddammit, Catra, think! I need to buy time... what can I say to get Light Hope to be distracted? The Magicat's mind, well-made for manipulating, scrambled for an answer underneath her pain and the constant tug of war with the energies commanding her body. *What weakness does she even have, what does she care about- wait, Mara's last message!*

"You including Mara in that?!?" Catra yelled, and *that* got a response.

For just a moment- a mere second- Light Hope's calm demeanor flickered, and another face peeked out, a tormented face that had suffered longer than almost anyone on Etheria.

"...Mara," that woman said, the woman who had been Light Hope, beneath all that had been done to her.

And in that moment, the pressure on Catra relented, just the slightest bit.

It lasted only a second, but some seconds matter more than others; in that second alone, Catra, resisting, was able to move the Sword. She couldn't let *go* of it, Light Hope's control hadn't slipped that much, but she could *move* it, and while she didn't know if it would help to point the Sword down, she *knew* that Light Hope wanted the Sword *up,* so she did the opposite. Even as the circuitry crawled up her skin, curling around her like an infestation of scars, she found the strength to *slam* the Sword point-first into the walkway, hitting it hard- and to her delighted surprise, the material beneath her *resisted.* This was made of some fine First Ones' material, probably to handle the massive energies channeled through it- maybe it was hard enough to break the Sword on. Maybe if she lifted it again, slammed it down, and kept doing it, again and again, maybe it would burst...

But at the last second, right as she found the strength to do it...

She heard Shadow Weaver one last time, from close behind her.

Why do you think I'm here, but that I knew you would fail?

Catra could not stop herself, any more than she could stop breathing; she turned, just for a second, to see if her mother had betrayed her once again, somehow just *knowing* she would see a shadowed face and gleaming eyes, that here in this room somehow the sorceress would be there.

But there was no one there; Catra mistook it for the madness of her own mind cracking under pressure, never knew that Light Hope had speakers in the room. It did not distract her long; only a moment.

But it bears repeating.

Some seconds matter more than others.

For in *this* second, Light Hope said

"Initiate planetary move- out of the dimension of Despondos."

The command given, the circuitry was complete, power flooded through Catra, all of it her own and none of it in her control, and she screamed rainbow light out of her eyes and mouth.

CATRA OF ETHERIA

All over the planet, screams lit up the night as the world shifted- and not just the screams of princesses, who suffered the brunt of what was happening.

(Even Angella, unconscious, suffered, her body being used even in her sleep- and the pain helped Shadow Weaver win the internal war for control, for her spirit, awake and able to make decisions- unlike Angella's own sleeping consciousness, defending itself on instinct and not with intent- forcibly pushed off all the suffering the circuitry inflicted onto Angella's spirit and not her own, and the distraction of it was just enough of an edge for the witch to take over.)

Rainbow light consumed the world as the portal network spun into being, All around the world, the many peoples of Etheria looked up in fear and terror as the sky lit up with rainbow energies, great and terrible, drawing them out of the peace of Despondos and into the wider universe Etheria had once called home.

It was not a peaceful transition. The sheer drama of what was happening alone would have caused problems... but accompanying it was an unconscious kind of understanding, a sort of base-of-spine understanding that whatever this was, it was *bad,* something no one could describe but that everyone felt.

The physical damage alone did harm- the pressure inflicted by the process collapsed homes, started landslides, altered the landscape.

But the *terror* it inflicted?

That was worse.

The elderly and infirm suffered most, as always; a wave of cardiac arrest and stroke from suddenly-pounding hearts, or slips and falls as they tried to run from what was coming, or just to run without even knowing *what* was going on, save that it was bad. Other things happened as people panicked; homes burnt as lanterns were knocked over by accident, fights and riots breaking out in major cities as the disaster washed over them, the million and one disasters a panicking people might inflict on themselves.

It ended swiftly, at least, which was the thinnest silver lining of the biggest storm cloud in history; the planet soon returned to its original life-giving star, to an orbit in the circling dark it had once held, which prompted yet another wave of collapses and tidal waves as the gravity of their solar system reasserted itself on a planet which had been subject to no such constraints for nigh-on a millennia. Only the tech of the First Ones and the magic of the Runestones was able to prevent the planet cracking apart.

Those Runestones themselves had to discharge the pressures of the powers they were warding off somehow, and so more disaster was wrecked; each ended up harming the area around them, repeating the sin of the Spirit Ember in- thankfully- miniature,

though none killed anyone through sheer good luck. The Pearl flooded its room, the Moonstone alternated between burning with light and gleaming with darkness such that those who were looking at it were blinded for a time, and the Heartblossom rippled with such abundance in growth that it wrecked the little field of topiary statues, along with numerous other sites, burying them in vines.

The Black Garnet, the centerpiece of the last connection, bore the most pressure, and reacted the most dramatically- a bolt of lightning tall as a tower ripped *up* out of the Runestone, and tore the building it was in to pieces, reducing it to ash and ruin in an instant, clearing the field- and nearly killing the Red Knight, paralyzed in one of the building's saferooms, only barely not killing the Blackmoor Rebel.

(And giving Entrapta, nearby, weeping over the bodies of friends she thought she had killed, an idea as she saw the Runestone activating... an idea that led to her ripping a gun off of her nearby discarded mech suit and running towards the Runestone.)

When all was done, the portal network closing at the last, the grey of Despondos was gone, never to return, and above all Etherians were pinpricks of light in an endless sea of darkness... things only historians and scholars, and only the most truly gifted ones, had a name for.

Or, in one case, the son of such historians and scholars.

“Bow, what's-” Glimmer asked him, aching as the circuitry used her, taking the power that belonged to her and stealing it for its own use. Bow was over her, trying to figure out a way to help or

at least cut the damn circuitry out of her, but she was looking up, *past* him. “The sky... what's happening to the sky...?”

Bow, hearing her words, looked up...

And in that moment, saw something beautiful and horrible in equal measure, and knew that they had lost.

“It's... stars,” he said, so quietly Glimmer did not hear.

CATRA OF ETHERIA

When Adora reached the Runestone- having sped up when she saw the stars, not knowing what those were but knowing they were *bad*- she had not expected to find Entrapta shooting it.

The whole area was a wreck. A warplant bigger than even the one Adora had heard tales of Vultak defeating, back in the day, lay nearby, along with what looked like that plant princess, Perfuma, and... Scorpia? Both had rainbow light trailing off of them...

But what drew most of her attention was the Runestone, and the woman currently blasting away at it.

The Black Garnet was exposed to the world now, like a rotting tooth jutting out of the earth, the building around it wrecked and ruined. Lightning flickered over its face, sparks flying off as Entrapta fired what looked like syringes at from a jury-rigged railgun, one too big for her small frame; her hair had to help her hold it, coiling around it to steady the weapon, and coiling behind *her* to steady her frame from the impact of the recoil.

Adora's heart leapt up into her chest at the sight- no, no, Catra needed more *time,* Entrapta was going to kill them all!- but her shots didn't seem to be accomplishing anything; whatever venom this serpentine warrior had left, it was spent. She was coiled and striking, but still toothless before the Runestone.

Adora landed, and the weight of her draconic form shook Entrapta out of her one-woman hail of medical bullets.

"I... what?" Entrapta said, turning to stare in something a bit like surprise, though her reaction was much more subdued than Adora might have expected of someone seeing a dragon land next to them.

It was easy to read her expression, too. Entrapta had a mask on, sure, but it was broken and ruined, even in the down position it was more like a frame for her features than anything else- it could not hide her anymore. Pieces of that broken mask had pierced her skin, and the blood mingled with the tears flowing down her cheeks in a way almost elegaic.

“Who...?” Entrapta asked, staring at her for a second.

And Adora felt an urge to *lie,* because that was what she did, and it was a good idea, really! It would make this easier on Adora. Lie, claim to be a friend of Catra's- which wasn't even a lie, really!- and that she was here to assist. Which also wasn't entirely not a truth! She could even come up with a name on the spot- Fireheart. Sounded like a good dragon name.

And she probably *had* to lie, right now. Avoid the truth to avoid... probably a fight, she had to assume, though Entrapta did *not* look like she had much fight left in her at all, to be honest. Adora didn't think Entrapta would be friendly towards her, to put it mildly, and they had more important things to worry about right now than the justice that Adora so richly deserved.

But the quiet dark in her mind spoke up, once more.

This started with you lying to this woman. Your first lie, your worst lie, your most harmful lie. Will you really do that to her, again? Even after Catra's forgiveness?

(The taste of Catra on her lips in her mind, a kiss, a *real* kiss, not the broken thing she'd forced on her beloved in the Crimson Waste; this was the taste of a real kiss, of love she was not worthy of, that she didn't deserve, that had lasted despite *everything* Adora had done. She should... she should be *better,* for *Catra*...)

Her stomach churning in her huge scaled form, knowing down to her *bones* that this was a stupid idea, that she should *lie...*

Adora changed to her mortal form, and looked with her one good eye at the Drylborn princess.

"...It's me," she said, lamely, after a moment. The lie had sprung full-formed in her mind, but truth was like dragging hooks through her heart.

"...You?" Entrapta said, and her hands tightened on her gun. Adora braced for a fight- she had the embers of her sister in her still, and could feel her trying to reconnect, even with the planet in pure chaos like this- but a moment later, Entrapta did something else Adora hadn't expected.

She started to *laugh.*

It was horribly familiar laughter. Adora had heard it many times- in the back of her mind, echoing off the walls around her...

Coming from her own throat.

Entrapta began to laugh, whipsaw laughter, staring at Adora with tears and blood running down her face, dropping her gun to put hands to her temples as if trying to hold a mind under too much pressure together.

“Of course,” she laughed, giggled, tittered, eyes wide as she went away inside, laughing because her mouth did not know what else it could do. “Of course. After **everything** I've done, just to **kill you**... **you** lived. I didn't even get to **kill** you. I have spent my *everything*, and everyone's *everything*, and I did not even make the equation balance. The equation equals out to zero- no, worse than zero, I do not have nothing left I have **less than nothing left.** *Everyone* I *love* is dead at **my** hands and **you're** still alive, **you're** not dead, **you're** still here. Or... or **I'm** going mad. Oh, please, let **me** be going mad. Yes. Seeing **you** as a dragon. What **you** called **yourself**. That has to be it. **My** mind broke. **I've** gone mad and none of this is real. **I** didn't... **I** didn't kill *Perfuma* and Scorpia, **I** didn't kill everyone **I've** ever loved and who loved **me**, a-and maybe **you're** dead, this isn't happening, a-a-a-a-and **you're** still heee-reeeee...”

Entrapta laughed, and laughed, and laughed, and Adora- better than anyone on the planet- knew it for the sobbing it really was.

...What am I supposed to do?

No answer, from any part of her. Just... the memories, of how she'd felt, in the Crimson Waste, when she'd first heard those four terrible words, *You're a First One.*

...She knew what *she'd* wanted someone to do, back then, or at least... what might have helped.

So she stepped forward, cautiously at first- but Entrapta paid her no mind, so she sped up, reaching the shorter woman, and put a hand to her shoulder.

“Entrapta?” she asked, shaking her gently, trying to get her out of her spiral. “Entrapta, it's- they're not *dead,* Entrapta. Catra's going to save them. Save *everyone.* It's- it'll be okay.”

“Catra?” Entrapta asked her, looking up, breath hitching around her crying and her laughter and the crying laughter that infected her like a disease.

(*I gave this to her,* Adora realized. *I did this. I spread the fire of my madness to her, like sparks from a wildfire...*)

“Yes,” Adora said. “Catra will save us.”

“Catra... she... but I'm so poisonous, I bet I've killed her too...”

“Don't be an idiot,” Adora said, surprisingly offended by Entrapta's words. Doubting or hating Adora herself, sure, she could understand, but to do the same to *Catra?* Unacceptable. “If *I* couldn't kill Catra, what makes you think *you* can?”

And Entrapta... took that the way Adora meant it, considered her words, and she settled down a little.

Then, for the third time in nearly as many minutes, Entrapta surprised her again.

"...Then... can you kill **me?"** Entrapta whispered to her.

"What?" Adora responded.

"Can you kill **me**?" Entrapta asked- no, *begged* her, she sounded almost desperate as she turned herself towards Adora, and the First One's stomach roiled at the sound of someone longing for their own death like that. "Please, before **I** hurt her. Before **I** hurt Catra or Scorpia or *Perfuma* again. All this, it's **my** fault, **my** fault, **I** d-d-d-d-d-did thissss...."

She trailed off in a hiss that began to become weeping laughter again; and Adora stared at her, in open shock.

She... she didn't know what to *do* with that, to be honest.

So she just stood there, with this fucked-up mirror before her, with that ripsaw laughter in her ears, the laughter tearing away at her mind and Entrapta's too. Catra would know what to do, here; Catra was a hero, a healer, a helper, *good,* she'd have known what to do and what to say...

But Adora was a destroyer, a despoiler, a demon, *evil.*

She did not know what to do.

But... maybe she could keep Entrapta alive long enough to reach someone who did know what to do.

So Adora shook her head to her.

“No,” she said. “It'll be okay.”

“It never is,” Entrapta sobbed... and Adora kept watch on her, because Entrapta still had that weird syringe gun in her hands, and when she recalled it...

Well, at least Adora knew how to disarm somebody.

...This was still an active warzone, though. And Adora had a huge target on her head, with half the Horde gunning for it.

(She pushed away how that made her feel, because if she didn't, she'd join Entrapta in the horrible laughter.)

Maybe Adora should take a few precautions.

She had little of her Ember's magic left, and she needed all that to maybe bust the Runestone open if worst came to worst- a thing she didn't think would happen, because Catra would stop it- but she was still a sorceress, and there was lots of ambient magic here in literal spitting distance of a Runestone. She knew spells of illusion...

So she wove two of them; one over the general area, to hide the whole area, Entrapta and herself, a fairly weak but wide effect, and another, smaller and more concentrated, this second one over Scorpia and Perfuma. Adora was still awake and mobile, so she could act if need be, but Scorpia and Perfuma were unconscious nearby and unable to defend themselves; they needed a heavier cloak of invisibility that would, hopefully, protect them, even if Adora was distracted.

Such distraction came right as she finished her spellcraft, because Entrapta did, in fact, remember her gun, and Adora had to swap from runecraft into a full-body tackle into the smaller, older woman, all to stop her from putting the barrel up to her chin and blowing her brains out. Adora, atop her on the ground, was trying to pull the gun away, Entrapta not so much trying to fight her as just trying to buy time to kill herself, sobbing and laughing, laughing her sobs and sobbing her laughter all the while as they wrestled, Adora's greater size and strength against Entrapta's living hair and frantic desperation.

Please, Catra, hurry, Adora thought, as coils of hair lashed around her and Entrapta scrabbled for the gun. *Not sure how long I can keep this up.*

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Catra knew nothing but pain.

Pain of the body.

(The circuitry dances up her body and it burns and cuts and she will be tattooed with scars after this, and)

Pain of the mind.

(She knows she has failed everyone, and everyone's everything, that because for just a moment she heard her mother's voice she has failed them all; she *knew* Light Hope could make illusions of sound and light, why did she believe anything she heard or saw?)

Pain of the heart.

(Her family will die. Her friends will die. Her people will die. She will never get to laugh with Bow and Glimmer again she will never see her mother's soft, sad smile again she will never get to know Micah as her father she will never see the other Princesses again and sit with them in small rooms after a battle and patch each other up again she has lost she has lost *she has lost*. She will never kiss Adora again. All because she had turned to her mother's voice.)

Pain of the soul.

(*Even here, at the end, will I still be haunted by my mother?*)

…

Wait.

That word.

Mother.

A memory, like a bolt from clearest blue.

(A small, sad smile.)

Another memory, lightning forking off from the first bolt.

(The gentle moonlight of a mother's regard.)

One more memory, a spark so bright that no shadow could stay in its presence.

(*I want Catra to be my daughter. Not the She-Ra.*)

...Queen Angella- no, my <u>mother</u>- she wanted <u>me.</u>

Not the She-Ra. Not the hero of legend who needed the Sword.

Just Catra.

Just <u>me.</u>

(And like a raging storm all memories come clear now, lightning striking twice, striking three times, striking a thousand times, memories that blot out the past with their brightness; a piece of fabric on which Angella recorded her family, the thing her serious mother had called with joy by the bad pun of tapest-tree, on which lay a golden circle holding Catra herself; not the She-Ra, not the greater thing she can become, but Catra, just plain Catra, who had never been wanted at all by anyone before. A memory of gentle darkness, the first and only kindness of night that Catra, so scarred by shadow, has ever known, and the gift of sleep; a memory of a mother's determination, of a willingness in a Queen to risk national pride and a country's reputation to save the woman her daughter loved, despite her own well-deserved misgivings. Of the simple fact of being *loved* by her mother, a thing Catra had never had and had needed so badly, the most terrible and sweet of all her terribly sweet happiness.)

Shadow Weaver is not my mother... and my mother <u>will</u> still love me, when this is done.

And that thought was so much bigger than all the pain of body and mind and heart and soul that Catra found she could *move.*

(And so all destiny is denied by a mother's love, given to one bereft of it; on such small things are the dreams of the mighty undone.)

Roaring her defiance against the pain and the pressure physical and mental both, a sound that echoed triumphantly throughout the Crystal Castle, Catra staggered to her feet and lifted the Sword, ready to break the machine even as it powered itself up.

“No. Stop!” Light Hope commanded, the pressure on Catra increasing even as she found the might to withstand it... but then it decreased, suddenly.

Catra looked over and saw Light Hope's image begin to flicker, in and out, as if at war with itself, the AI speaking out of both sides of her mouth.

“No. Stop! Don't-”

“Do it!”

“Don't-”

“Do it!”

“-Don't!”

The pressure finally fading almost entirely as, just once, the real Light Hope won the war inside herself. The AI's hand lowered, and she said something so quietly that Catra never heard it.

"Do it."

Free for one second, one second was all the freedom she needed; with a great overhead heave, Catra slammed the Sword of Protection down as hard as her She-Ra enhanced muscles could, right onto the floor of the Crystal Castle.

The white-hot, overstressed metal, so full of power that it was stretched to its breaking point, found this to be the proverbial straw on the camel's back.

The Sword, which had survived so much time and so much trauma, that had been with her for years now, that had changed her life so much for the better even as it threatened to end all things...

Shattered.

And then everything, everywhere, happened, all at once.

Light Hope let out a sigh and a scream, all at once, as the chained part of the AI saw itself lose, and the true heart of her saw herself win, in the last moment.

The She-Ra flowed out of Catra, draining her strength as water from a tapped well.

And the Heart of Etheria, without a fuse, was no longer a bomb, but just a broken machine.

Catra, cut off from a power that had been closer to her than her own skin for half a decade, fell to her knees weak and shaking as the Castle began to violently power down, failsafes failing to keep safe, fuses bursting, circuits burning as the power of the Heart, almost unleashed, backflowed into it. The system was crashing, unable to continue without such a vital component, one that had been taken away at such a critical time. The First Ones built their work to last, to be as Eternal as they had hoped to be... but even their redundancies had their limits. Screws were shorn off, computer banks broke, and panels burst all around the fallen form of the once She-Ra, now just Catra, forever more.

Catra, shaking with the aftermaths of pain and the adrenaline rush and the sudden weakening loss all three, simply knelt there on the floor, so emotionally and physically overwhelmed that she could not work up the energy to try and escape, even as some part of her idly noted that the Castle might collapse atop her.

She couldn't even work up the energy to *care.* Not right now.

All she could do was stare at the shards of her life, scattered before her, the burst remnants of the Sword that had given her

happiness.

(It was the right thing to do. That does not mean it is not the worst thing she has ever done to herself.)

But some force of justice in the universe- or perhaps just dumb luck- spared her, for the Castle did not fall atop her, but simply went cold and quiet. All motion ceased. All lights died. All things faded.

Even Light Hope, the AI flickering for a few last moments before she, too, was gone, dying whatever death a computer dies... but she went out with a smile on her face.

(And the smallest part of Catra- the part that can *be,* underneath the weight of all that has just occurred- hopes that she has somehow found her way to Mara, that the Silver grants justice to two against whom so much injustice was done.)

All alone in the Crystal Castle, which was no longer a relic of the First Ones but merely a tomb marking the death of their weapon, Catra of Brightmoon, no longer She-Ra of Brightmoon, shivered in the dark and the cold, staring down at what was left of the Sword that had changed her life for the better, that she had rewarded for such kindness with its own destruction.

Some time later- an amount she had no way of knowing, in the dark- she finally found the energy to curl up on herself like a child in the dark, laying there on the floor, tears falling from her eyes unnoticed as she mourned the loss of all she had been.

(And in the sky above Etheria, in the star-dappled dark, still alive because of her sacrifice, a fleet of ships teleported into high orbit.)

Chapter End Notes

One more chapter after this!

I'm unreasonably proud of the pun for this chapter title; sure, Catra's cutting the fuse on the bomb of the Heart of Etheria, but it also cuts her “fuse” with the She-Ra powers. A two for one!

The next chapter will be Prime's and that will be the last chapter for this story. I'm gonna take a short break then return with SHE-RA OF THE STARS, the final chapter of the tale of Catra of Brightmoon... once the She-Ra of Brightmoon.

Chapter 78: HORDE PRIME OF HIMSELF ALONE

Chapter Notes

> That which was foretold, is now.
>
> Horde Prime, and Etheria; the apocalypse delayed, not stopped.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

HORDE PRIME OF HIMSELF ALONE

What an *interesting* little planet.

There had been nothing here, moments before; now there was something. That alone would be enough to be of interest… but even more impossibly, not only had this world just emerged from Despondos, *it still bore life.*

A magnificent impossibility! One that made even Prime, jaded from a long life of endless miracles, fascinated. He had never seen this before, a sentiment he had increasingly rare chances to experience as the centuries ticked by. Every place taken to Despondos until now had found the trip fatal; cut off from the lifegiving light of the stars, not to mention suddenly being no longer subject to the gravitational forces of existence along with a million other factors, all life on the planet would simply die of either cold or starvation as no energy entered into the now-closed system. Despondos was a truly desolate place; it had no suns, no

light, no life. Only those places that suffered only very short trips through the plane survived, and only a few of those; what survivors were found, if any, were those in sealed environments, and in a universe of trillions, they numbered in the low hundreds at best.

Yet on this interesting little planet, not only was life present, so was *war.*

A massive battle had been raging in the south of the planet's sole continent, a place thick with habitation where He should have seen empty ruins, bereft even of bacteria.

But both biospheres and battles had lived, the latter drawing His eye, being the place where His readings were coming from- dying out, now, but even the flickering sparks of that power were of great interest. He had directed His first scouts to go there, with the second wave chasing the strands of the web of might that had covered this planet's sole continent, searching for the anchor points- four others in total.

(Admittedly, "first" and "second" were matters more of trivia than of import; He had forces enough that the two had been sent within seconds of each other, and the reports had come back nearly simultaneously from both sets even as the third, the subjugation wave, was being prepared.)

And amongst the information sent back to Him had been, of all things, a picture, a photo of a statue, dramatically backlit by the burning flames of the city it had been built in. The city, relatively advanced by this backwater's standards, were of no interest,

merely on their way to being cyclopean ruins and ashes... but the statue?

It was statue on this mysterious planet of someone He had *known,* wearing armor He Himself had once deigned to grant a particularly worthy general.

Now *that* was *beyond* merely *interesting.*

The statue, by itself, would have been a mystery. But atop this were piled ever more enigmas; on this planet Prime did not even know the name of, where He had never sent His general, nonetheless did the reports show some of the natives using technology that was not unlike a primitive version of His own fleet's machinery, and wearing symbols that were not unlike His own, albeit many had been modified with a kind of… snakelike figure, one breathing what appeared to be a gout of flame. The two sides of what appeared to be a civil war, if He did not miss His guess, based on their violence towards each other.

(But the color… all *wrong.* A grotesque red, not his pale green glory… but that was a mystery easily solved. He'd only ever had *one* general whose mutations had given him red eyes... one general, who had earned a blessing of armor...)

There were other factions in this war, but they did not interest Him as much as these did, so He dismissed them. Most likely just more of the usual primitive societies He had encountered on far too many worlds, with the same structures and mistakes and natures.

No, only this one, this mimicry of His own greater glory, was worthy of His interest.

It wasn't even that surprising that the energy signatures He'd seen were coming from here! Of course it was the society that was like a little, inferior clone of his own that had produced it.

He called up the closest of His scouts, a screen displaying the view from the scrying lens of the scout ship. The video showed that, at the heart of the web of power that had drawn Him here in the first place, there was a great dark crystal in a ruined building, flickering with traces of red lightning… and at its base, there were two primitives fighting.

He directed the scout ship to focus on them with but a thought, and His loyal servant, of course, obeyed. The lens zoomed in, revealing that one native was attempting to kill themselves, and the other- who was wearing armor not unlike the armor on the statue, but made of some volcanic material- was trying to stop the first native...

…Well.

He would have to extend an invitation to these… *interesting* natives.

Why, in His benevolence, He would even take away the chance to refuse from them.

After all, what cruelty would it be, to deny them the chance to meet God?

Truly, His charity knew no bounds.

He sent the orders, and the clone pilot obeyed- as if there was any question of doing otherwise!- and took them up into their ship for transport to the Velvet Glove, the capital of His empire.

(And Horde Prime, so arrogant, did not sit and scan the area, and thus never saw through the illusions that hid two sleeping princesses, successfully guarded in a tower of illusions by the dragon he was taking up into his home.)

CATRA OF ETHERIA

Once the scout ship returned, He ordered his new guests to be cleansed and made ready to meet judgment. He didn't want them treading lesser filth on this holy ground, after all.

Had His lost general been among them, He would have taken them up immediately into audience, their condition be damned; if His suspicions were correct, then His presumed-dead general had, in fact, ended up on this world, and built this little Horde.

From one of His own, this would have been insult, mockery, *blasphemy,* an attempt by a clone to pretend it was the real thing. It would have born no punishment but the swiftest and harshest. He would have moved swiftly, in that case, and instantly.

But there was no sign of the one who had, in his arrogance, dared call Prime his brother, instead of his god. The way the statue had been laid out, Prime suspected he was already dead; that had the distinct air of a memorial, a gravestone… a tomb.

No, He did not think the lost general was still alive.

(He melted the statue down, of course. He also made sure the entire fleet saw it happen, so they would understand that, made of His sacred flesh and blood that they were, they were still not **HIM**, and could never be.)

But without one of His essence to lord over it, the mimicry was less offensive in His sight, was even... charming. In a way. It always amused Him, to see lesser beings attempt to mimic His eternal light and law; while one of His should know better, it was a tolerable foolishness in his other servants. It was the main reason he'd spared White Diamond, her slavish devotion to Him, her constant praise of Him as the only flawless being in all creation... and why He always found such joy in her dressing up as Him, even changing her colors to match His own, a thing she did in private and in secret that she thought no one knew anything about. From those so much lower than Him, such deeds were not an insult, but a flattery and an amusement all in one.

So instead of taking them up immediately, He had them cleaned and their “garments” removed, to be replaced with more presentable clothing, all the while directing His forces to take the planet under His total control. There were too many questions it raised to allow it to be anything but His, as soon as possible.

These changes had been met with great protest from one and abject silence from the other. The purple-haired girl- whose long locks had taken an exorbitant amount of shampoo and conditioner to properly clean- had been the latter, so utterly bereft of fighting spirit that she resembled a corpse more than a living thing. He would refer to her as a robot, but that would be an unfair comparison to machinery; even an automated assembly line showed more signs of life than this one did. She went where she was told, did as she was directed, and was perfectly obedient… or at least, was so perfectly empty that it resembled obedience.

It pleased Him, to see such acknowledgment of her base nature, in comparison to His elevated status.

(Though he did not like the way her eyes, sometimes, looked at him, or His servants, and something like... want?... flickered through them... or maybe just a memory of want.)

The blonde, meanwhile, had fought fiercely, resisting at all times with surprising strength… though she had of course succumbed to his guards eventually. It had taken a little time, but subduing someone without harm always did; had His troops been allowed to simply break her bones, they'd have gotten it done in mere moments, despite her resistance.

But Prime wanted them unharmed.

For now.

(Though he'd noted an oddity- the room she'd fought them in had experienced odd temperature fluctuations during the battle. Perhaps a glitch in the system, or something natural to her species?)

Both had been scrubbed, their items destroyed, and measured for new uniforms… and now…

Now they were at His bridge, as He sat with his back to them, drinking finest wine from his cup. A vintage that existed only on this ship, its home planet one of many he'd burned to the ground, the last of its vineyards taken and placed here in the Velvet Glove, so that He and He alone might enjoy it, long past the extermination of its home.

It added such piquancy to the drink.

His guests both stood at the ready, one simply looking around herself in an almost catatonic state, only vaguely interested in the machinery and servants around her, the other at parade rest but clearly panicking underneath her calm exterior. They were overwhelmed; not a surprise. To meet with God was, by definition, to be overwhelmed.

But they would hopefully not be so overwhelmed as to not be able to speak. After all, He wanted answers.

“We received a strange report, but we could not determine its source... and then I detected an energy reading like nothing I have ever seen before,” He informed His guests, as he turned in his chair to face them. He set one of his extra eyes to scanning them, the device recording invisibly and unobtrusively, scanning them to confirm what other systems throughout his ship had already found out; it never hurt to double-check one's data, even for God. “And when I arrived, this curious planet had appeared... where *did* you come from, little ones?”

He knew, of course- He knew all, saw all- but He wanted to test their knowledge and their character. He wanted to see what these natives knew, what they would tell Him…

And more importantly, what they would lie about.

It was the broken one who responded first.

“...Despondos,” the purple-haired one said, not looking at him, only glancing once at his face before turning to stare at the floor. With her head bowed, her living hair fell in loose coils about her face, covering her head in a fashion He rather liked; such posture was a sign of submission, of obedience, of absolute dejection. A fine posture, for a mortal before God. Her language was one of the primitive tongues on the planet below, but he heard it as Perfect Speech; His technology, having studied her over the last few hours she'd been onboard and cross-referencing with research His forces were sending back from her native land, was capable of translating it in real time to his ears. “We were in Despondos. We were teleported back.”

“And somehow, you are alive,” Horde Prime mused. “I have heard- rarely- of inhabited places sent to that gray nothing... they do not return with life on them. They return as tombs. *How* did you survive? You were not there a short time; I have mapped this system out before. There was *nothing* here when My light reached it, two centuries ago.”

(The report had said that His surveyor was hunting a rumor of a former First Ones' colony; that clone's supervisor had made a second report, stating that surveyor had returned empty-handed and was thus executed for wasting Prime's resources... but apparently they had been on to something. If He had ever bothered memorializing His clones, He’d owe the fallen an apology; but He gave them miracles enough in allowing them to exist and serve Him, so He owed the executed nothing.)

“…Centuries?” the burned one said, quirking the eyebrow over her good eye. The other side was a *ruin,* and the contrast was almost artistic; one a pretty, strong humanoid, the other melted, burned, charred. He doubted she could even use the eye on that side, and when she spoke, the dead flesh around that eye was tugged in interesting ways by her muscles moving under the skin.

Ordinarily, he detested such signs of imperfection. It was why he would kill a clone of his so wounded- His mirrors at all times had to show His perfection, even in their lesser forms- but here… much like the mimicry, what would be offensive on one of his own was much less so on one so below Him. It mostly made her a bit more interesting to look at. The way one side of her lips never entirely moved in sync with the other, the mild twitches from pain in her left arm, the way her eyelid seemed as if it would flake off as ashes at any moment...

...Wait.

It had taken him a moment, but he realized that her words had not been accompanied by the usual thin undertone of mechanical hiss that his translators always came with. Something he'd never entirely gotten rid of, but had also grown so used to that he barely heard it at all anymore.

But there had been no undertone when she spoke.

That could only be if she herself had just used *Perfect Speech.*

“You know the holy tongue, my child?” He asked her, startled. She had spoken to Him in *His* tongue…

“Perfect Speech?” she asked him, before, a moment later, adding, “Sir?”

It was quite delightful, seeing her stumble through her manners like a clone fresh from the vats. A grin grew on His face that He made no effort to hide.

“Sir is acceptable,” He said. Technically it wasn’t, his proper title was rather longer than that, and one of His would have been punished severely for such a lapse; but He was magnanimous. He

would make allowances for her obvious deficiencies and weaker flesh. “Where did you come to learn the sacred language, my child?”

“Y-your- you must be his-“ she began, before pausing, shivering, and making an obvious and deliberate effort to shape up. “I… I am Lor- I am Adora, of the Horde, sir. All of us in the Horde, we use Perfect Speech, sir.”

The Horde. His general had not been creative with the name, apparently... and his mimicry had been poorly done. This “Horde” had been tearing itself apart when He arrived, a poor comparison to the peace of His light and law... a Horde that was at war with itself violated the most basic principle of His light and His law. Peace, and order, above *all.*

Still, that one had always been a defective clone of His, flesh marred and weakened by technical malfunctions in the cloning process. It wasn't surprising that he had built a similarly defective Horde.

“And who *leads* your Horde, my child?” He asked. If his general was dead, who had succeeded him? Perhaps his death had sparked the civil war Prime had observed, that his forces were now busily quelling...

But she reacted in a way He had not foreseen, surprising Him- and oh, that was sweet, it was so *rare* that He got to be *surprised.*

Because, after a too-long moment, and a downcast look warring with her desire to maintain a stoic facade, she finally gave Him her answer.

"…I did," she said, quietly. "After Hordak died; I was…his successor. I took over."

...*Hordak? He dared* ***name*** *himself?!?*

Oh, the feelings that flooded Him in that moment, wrath that made Him terribly calm. Gods did not have anger in the explosive manner of mortals, after all.

They had it in the slow and invisible way that stars leaked radiation.

In His calmness, He asked one last question, one He knew the answer to already... but He wanted to see her reaction.

"Your leadership led to this?"Prime asked her, pulling up pictures His forces had taken of the civil war and spreading them before her on computer screens. Death and destruction and fire, always fire, consuming everything.

She flinched.

He smiled.

(Oh, this one was *fun.*)

"...Yes," she said.

He let it hang in the air for a few moments, enjoying her discomfort, before he continued on, dismissing the screens with an airy wave of a hand.

"I presume this... Hordak founded your Horde, my child?" Prime asked her- but it was the broken one who spoke up.

"*Hordak*," she said… no, *sobbed,* her hair animating to wrap around her like the most pathetic version of a hug He had ever seen. "*He*… *He* made the Horde... you're the brother, aren't you? The one *he* looked up to so much. Who *he* wanted to be like."

Well, that confirmed it; only one of His clones had ever dared call himself *brother.*

It was a thing He had tolerated because the clone had shown a good head for anything he was put towards; he had excelled at science and engineering and war all three, things Prime had sorely needed at the time. Prime had long let the Diamond Authority or the Voltron Unity be His left and right hands, without one of His sacred flesh leading the forefront of His holy wars; that was wrong, He preferred that one of His be in charge. Prime had once

led those armies Himself, but He preferred to enjoy the spoils of His great empire these days; there was no need for God to dirty Himself with such menial tasks. That was why one *had* servants in the first place.

So the malformed clone, despite the mutations and independent spirit that would normally have seen him culled, had become a general instead, and blessed in His sight.

Perhaps a mistake; the clone had gotten terribly arrogant. He'd even thought them to be equal in some way! To call Him "brother"... so terribly offensive.

But He had been a kindly God. In His benevolence he had magnanimously given the general grace and allowed the sin. He would have to kill the general eventually, of course- the servant was already showing far too many signs of independence- but for the time being, the general had been allowed to speak his blasphemy, so long as the clone led His armies.

And to have such kindness on Prime's part repaid with *this?*

He was lucky to be dead; Horde would have done such terrible things, to one who had spat on His kindness so.

"Ah, apologies," He said, his questions answered; now on to the next part of this little meeting. "I have been rude; you are guests. I am Horde Prime- what you would call the Lord of the Horde.

Welcome to my ship, the capitol of my empire, the heart from which My light and My law shine down on the universe."

His eye finished its scan, and reported back to him; ah, so the systems *had* been right. A First One... He'd thought them all extinct! He'd have to keep this one, perhaps in an exhibit, or have her killed in such a way not to mar her outsides and have her taxidermined.

The other, meanwhile, had an energy reading like what He'd first detected, if a mere fraction of the strength. What did *that* mean?

So many surprises in one day... why, this was shaping up to be the most fun He'd had in a while.

"I apologize for any harm done to your world by my little brother, then," he said as he stood up and walked over to them. "I desire only peace and order."

"That was all he had wanted, too," the purple-haired one said, looking up with eyes full of unshed tears and the ugly eyebags of bone-deep exhaustion. Her words carried... wistfulness. Like one thinking of a lover lost.

(Had his general given in to *desire* for these primitives? Such a thing was almost akin to bestiality! He'd known the clone had his faults, but such depravity... *grotesque.*)

The other, though, the blonde First One...at first, she felt only relief... then she felt horror... and *then,* then the two... mingled. Her mind a pile of ashes stirring in the breeze, all writ large on her face.

This one was getting more fun by the minute!

“We... he would have... he was trying to achieve that, too,” the young blonde woman said, stumbling over her words. She seemed... most affected... an emotional reaction. “I was trying to- after I kil- took over for him, I was trying the same.”

A little stumble, right there; and her word choice... had this one something to do with his general's death? Yet another surprise! He might have to keep this one.

In fact...

“What was the cause of the energy?” he asked them as he reached them. “The thing we detected, so far away.”

That answer would determine much. He had originally planned- when he'd seen the foolishness of his little brother- to simply wipe the mess clean. Kill everyone on the planet, then try and figure out where the energy readings were coming from. A simple enough task. One he'd do himself.

Oh, he could get the Voltron pilots to do it, but he did not want them knowing of it; they would try to use the information against him in their tiny acts of sabotage that they thought He knew nothing of, and while those *were* amusing- which is why they were allowed- He knew to limit their capacity to do harm. And having the Authority handle it was out of the question; his control over White Diamond was predicated entirely on her seeing Him as perfect, and this planet would raise questions.

As for the other factions he controlled weren't quite up to planet-busting yet, not without dragging it out, at least, and He wanted this place scrubbed as fast as possible. He simply *hated* having other people see such a mess caused by one of His own.

It was simply uncouth.

But the extra time to study that He'd had while these two were made ready had led to some interesting ideas about just what this world had... and between that, his amusement at the Horde-like society, and how surprisingly *fun* this burned and ruined First One was...

Yes, He thought He had a *better* plan, now.

"A weapon," the broken one said. "The Heart of Etheria... it would have... wiped out so many worlds. Done so much harm. I... I thought I could control it... I was wrong."

“You activated it?” he said.

“Yes,” she answered.

“Why?” he said. “To escape Despondos?”

She shook her head slowly.

“To... to kill **her,**” the broken one said, and pointed at the First One. “For killing *Hordak.*”

And on the First One's face... only abject despair, and... were those *tears?*

Magnificent.

She was a “Lord”, but she was so... so *pathetic,* it was, quite frankly, adorable. He wanted to pinch her cheeks as she stood there, horrified and hurting and, if He did not miss his guess, hating herself. To see one who aped Him, but in such a terribly insufficient way...

He found it all rather...

Endearing.

And... a moment of... *compassion.*

Another surprise! So few things moved the heart of God.

But honestly, how could He *not* feel such compassion? She was such a shattered thing, to try and mimic him! Such ruin in its features, such *guilt* inside its heart, such *pain.* Like White Diamond, in a way... but whereas White Diamond tried to mimic what He was in hopes of emulating His greatness, this one clearly knew nothing of Him, was but a copy of a copy, the failed clone writ large all over the young woman. It was such a *bad* attempt at copying Him that it was...

Funny.

Why, she even put Him in mind of a certain breed of dog that, appropriately enough, the girl's own people had been fond of. Short-snouted canines, whose name was not important enough for Him to recall; but He remembered how badly mangled by inbreeding they had been. So short of leg they were functionally useless, so short of snout they could barely breathe, so short of hip they had trouble giving birth... they had only the benefit of being so bizarre in their ugliness that it looped back around to being almost cute.

Prime had rather liked those- much better than the battlecats that had been so common among First Ones forces- and had debated saving a few before He rendered His judgment on their makers... but it hadn't been worth the effort. He preferred sentience in His pets.

The young woman before him, this last of the First Ones...

She was hitting that exact sweet spot, the paradox of ugly cuteness.

...It had been a long time since He'd had a pet. Something to reward, to toy with...

To *break.*

A great smile grew on his face. This one did not know what a gift she was receiving; to gain the attention of the center of the universe, for however long she would last under such divine weight... it was far more than she deserved.

(But He was a kindly god. She would learn, in time, to be grateful; He would ensure it. She would not die without thanking Him for His kindness. No matter how long it took.)

"Fear not," He said unto them. "Trust that your planet will become the jewel of My empire, and allow me to bring peace and order to the farthest reaches of the universe. And you shall all be part of it,

for all creatures, no matter how small, have a place in service of Horde Prime. For I see all, and I know all.”

And He returned to His throne, as plans to use this magnificent weapon filled His mind.

Chapter End Notes

Holy shit, what a journey.

This one's done. The next one will start up at some point, but we must finish here first; and let us take a moment to breathe, and be glad this is done.

I've developed a lot as a writer over the course of this story. I'd change some things or do things differently if I were to rewrite it, but let it stand as a testament to where I was and where I've reached; I'm proud of it.

Thank all of you for coming with me. This has been a wonderful journey.

I'll see you all next amongst the stars.

Works inspired by this one

[Restricted Work] by Dudeabuck

Knights of Etheria [BEING REWRITTEN] by HarrumphISay

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!